

STORIES OF MITHILA · VAJJI · ANGA

SELECTED STORIES

VOLUME I

THREE STREAMS OF STORIES

*Three hundred selected stories —
the first hundred.*



GAJENDRA THAKUR

TRANSLATED FROM THE MAITHILI BY THE AUTHOR

VIDEHA

THREE STREAMS OF STORIES

Volume I

Three Hundred Selected Stories by Gajendra Thakur

Stories 1–100

Gajendra Thakur

Translated from Original Maithili into English by the author himself

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Three Streams of Stories

Gajendra Thakur's three hundred selected stories offer a vivid mirror of life in Mithila, Vajji, and Anga: their folk worlds and human relationships, changing times, village and town, sorrow and joy, tradition and modernity, nature and society, women and men, the minds of children, old age, migration, memory, struggle, and hope.

Across these three volumes, the simplicity of the people's language, the depth of lived experience, and the cultural pulse of Mithila, Vajji, and Anga abide together.

Stories remain alive for as long as people and language remain alive.

— *Gajendra Thakur*

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The Bell That Never Rang

At the doorway of the old house in Laheriasarai was a round brass button. The wood around it had been polished smooth as yesterday by years of touch, but the button itself was always dull. In the rains, green moss crept out around its rim; in winter it was cold as ice; and in summer a touch made the fingertip flinch. Yet one thing about it had not changed in all those years: no matter how often it was pressed, it never rang.

When Madhavi was a child, she would press and press the button until she tired of it. Her mother would open the door from inside and say, "Leave the bell alone; call out your name and ring." Then Madhavi would rap on the door three times with her fist—knock, knock, knock—and her mother would come laughing from within. Time passed. Madhavi went away to study, found a job, married, had a daughter, was widowed, and finally settled in Pune. Her parents died, one after the other. The house remained—and, at its door, the same bell that never made a sound.

After the first anniversary of her mother's death, Madhavi decided to sell the house. It was not a mansion, but without care it was slowly growing weary. The roof gutter had broken, a fine crack ran through a pillar of the rear veranda, and the tulsi altar in a corner of the courtyard had begun to lean. Her daughter, Ira, had taken leave and come with her. The expense of higher studies lay ahead; Madhavi still had a loan on her own flat. "Memories don't pay taxes," Madhavi had told Ira while working through the figures on paper. Ira had replied, "But while paying taxes, don't sell every memory as well."

Madhavi had laughed. At the time it had seemed merely a clever line from her daughter.

The first prospective buyers came on Sunday. The broker, Diwakar Jha, led the way, followed by a couple and their college-going son. Reaching the door, Diwakar pressed the bell button from sheer habit.

There was no sound.

He pressed it again.

"Doesn't this work?" he asked, turning back.

Madhavi smiled. "It has hardly worked since I was born."

"We'll replace it. Such a big house, and the bell is mute!"

Everyone laughed at Diwakar's remark. Madhavi did not. She herself did not know why. The moment she saw Diwakar's finger pressing the button, something seemed to drop away inside her for an instant—as though a familiar name had risen to the tip of her tongue and turned back before it could be spoken.

While they were being shown around, the woman who was considering buying the house noticed a white tile set upside down on the western wall of the kitchen. "Why is this one tile upside down?" she asked.

Madhavi stopped still.

She had seen that tile since childhood: pale blue flowers around the edges, smooth white at the centre. It was inverted—the stems of the blue flowers pointed upward. There had surely been a reason for it once. Nothing in that house had survived so many years without a reason.

"This..." Madhavi began, and then stopped.

Ira looked at the tile. "Did Nani have it put in like that deliberately?"

"Yes," Madhavi said at once.

"Why?"

The question remained suspended there in the air.

After the buyers left, Madhavi went straight to Sukanya Kaki next door. Kaki was past eighty, yet her memory was astonishingly sharp. Madhavi brought up the tile.

Kaki burst out laughing. "You've forgotten even that?"

"What?"

"Your mother had a gas stove installed for the first time. The mason was setting the tiles. That day your father said every flower must be upright. Your mother deliberately had one fixed upside down. She said, 'If everything in a house is perfectly straight, people will begin to think themselves gods.'"

Madhavi fell silent.

Kaki went on laughing. "Your father glared at that tile for three days."

Madhavi could hear the sentence, but not see the scene. She remembered her mother in the kitchen, remembered her father, remembered the wall; but the incident of the inverted tile, which Sukanya Kaki narrated with such ease, stirred nothing inside her.

As soon as she returned home, she told Ira everything.

At first Ira thought it was fatigue. Then she looked at her mother's face and fell quiet.

"Diwakar pressed it twice," Madhavi said softly.

Ira looked towards the door. In the fading evening light, the dull button resembled a small eye.

"Twice," Ira repeated. "If one memory went, what was the other?"

They did not find the answer that night.

In the morning, the answer presented itself.

Ira went to bathe in the old bathroom. Five minutes later she called her mother. A thick iron grab bar was fixed to the wall at waist height. Its paint had worn away, and in the middle the metal shone where hands had rubbed it smooth.

“This was installed for Nanaji, wasn’t it?” Ira asked.

Madhavi answered immediately, “Yes.”

“When?”

The word caught somewhere inside Madhavi.

She remembered the last two years of her father’s life only in blurred fragments—medicines, hospital visits, his evening cough, the chair on the veranda. Ira had been in school then and spent several weeks each summer with her grandparents. But the day this bar was fixed in the bathroom, the first time her father used it to steady himself as he went in, her mother standing outside the door—nothing.

Ira stood holding the bar. “I remember this being here, but I don’t remember when it was put in.”

Madhavi called her aunt, who had stayed in the house for two months during her father’s illness.

“That bar?” her aunt said. “It was installed while I was there. That very day Ira went to the market and chose a pair of rubber slippers for her grandfather.”

Ira stood behind the phone, her face drained of colour.

Her aunt suddenly asked, “What has happened to you two?”

Madhavi made an excuse and ended the call.

Now it was no longer a coincidence.

Madhavi brought out a thick notebook. On the first page she wrote: “Memories of the House.” Under it she began listing, in order, the incidents she remembered clearly: her mother drying mango pickle, her father listening to cricket on the radio, a quarrel over a severed kite on the roof, her mother’s sewing machine in the hall, the brazier on winter nights, Grandmother’s low wooden seat beneath the tree at the back, and the year of the flood when a tub in the courtyard had been turned into something like a boat.

Ira added her own memories—potatoes and pointed gourd cooked by Nani, doing homework on the veranda, evening walks with Nana, the red dress Nani had made for a school play, climbing the mango tree for the first time. Some events belonged to Madhavi’s childhood, some to Ira’s, some to both of them.

Ira photographed every page and sent the images to her friend Tanvi, who had never been to the house. She wrote: "Keep these pages. If I ask, read them back to me."

Ira looked at the button. "Shall we test it once?"

Madhavi was afraid, but alongside the fear was a strange stubbornness. If this was true, it seemed necessary to understand the rule.

"I won't press it," she said. "Maybe it affects only those who have lived in this house. Let someone from outside press it."

At noon Vicky, the teenage milk boy, came. He belonged to a new generation and had no connection with the house's old stories. Madhavi stopped him at the door. "Press this button once."

Vicky laughed. "The bell doesn't ring."

"Press it anyway."

He pressed it once.

Nothing happened.

Vicky handed over the milk and left.

Madhavi and Ira went inside and began reading their lists.

First line—Mother's mango pickle. Clear.

Second—Father's radio. Clear.

Third—the kite on the roof. Clear.

Fourth—Mother's sewing machine in the hall.

Madhavi stopped.

The sewing machine stood in the room opposite—black iron, decorated with golden flowers, worked by a foot treadle. She knew her mother had sewn. Her frocks, pillowcases, curtains—everything had been made on it. But when she read the line "Mother's sewing machine in the hall," the scene that should have risen before her did not come.

Ira lifted the machine's cover. Inside lay a reel of red thread and an old pillowcase, half finished.

"Mumma," Ira said softly, "the red dress?"

Madhavi looked at her.

"No."

Ira's eyes filled. "Me neither."

Together they called Tanvi. Ira said, "Read that line from the list—the school play."

Tanvi read, "For Ira's school play, Nani made a red dress. She got the waist measurement wrong twice, and Ira spun around on the stage three times to try it out."

Ira held the red reel in her hand. "I can hear the words. I can't see the scene."

They ended the call.

Madhavi looked towards the doorbell as if it were not a button but someone's sealed mouth.

"One press—one memory," Ira said.

Madhavi corrected her. "One memory of the house. Nothing happened to Vicky."

"But it happened to both of us."

"Because both of us had lived that moment."

They decided that no one would press the button again. Madhavi taped a note outside: "BELL OUT OF ORDER. PLEASE KNOCK."

That night the rain began. Drops kept striking the wooden door. Madhavi could not sleep. How many memories did it take to make a house? Brick, timber, tiles, paint—those might be the body of a house; but what of the moments lived within it? If they were lifted away one by one, would the body left behind still be a house?

At about two in the morning, Ira came to the door of her mother's room.

"Mumma."

"Hmm?"

She came in and sat on the floor. In her hand was a photocopy of the list.

"Shall we test it once more?" she asked.

Madhavi shook her head at once. "No."

"We'll write everything down first. Tanvi will keep a copy. This time we'll learn whether the bell erases only things that happened in this house or things from outside it too."

"The price of finding out is a memory."

"If we don't understand the rule, how can we sell the house? Tomorrow some child may press it."

Madhavi looked at the line in the notebook—Mother's sewing machine in the hall. The words remained; the scene did not.

"Has the red dress come back to you?" she asked.

Ira was silent.

"Not to me either. Paper saved the event, not the lived moment."

Ira folded the photocopy. "Then we're not going to know everything?"

"We don't need to know everything."

"But what is this, why is it—"

"The more we press it out of the hunger to understand, the less of the house will remain."

For a long time Ira stared at the floor. Outside, the rain softened. At last she rose.

"All right. Tomorrow I'll cover the note with a transparent sheet."

Madhavi watched her leave. For the first time she understood that preserving a house did not mean preserving only its walls; sometimes it also meant refusing to hunt down the answer to a question.

More people came to see the house the next day. Madhavi warned everyone in advance: “Don’t press the bell. Knock on the door.” Some laughed; some obeyed without asking why.

In the afternoon a woman arrived with her small son. The child was tired after being taken through the house. As everyone stood outside discussing the price, he slipped a finger beneath the paper notice and pressed the button.

Madhavi saw him.

“No!”

It was already too late.

The bell did not ring.

The frightened boy ran to his mother. The woman kept apologising. Madhavi could say nothing. Which memory had vanished from within her was not immediately clear.

The prospective buyers left.

Madhavi and Ira sat down with the notebook. They read it line by line. Everything seemed intact. Then Ira’s finger stopped at one entry.

“First letter.”

Madhavi read it. “What?”

Ira said softly, “You wrote: ‘Madhavi’s first letter—Mother taught her to write it with rice in the courtyard.’ Nani told me this story too.”

Madhavi’s breath caught.

She knew her mother had taught her her letters. But the first letter? The courtyard? Rice? There was no scene.

Ira called Tanvi. “Read the line about the first letter.”

Tanvi read, “Mother drew the letter ‘M’ in a plate of rice. Madhavi traced it from the wrong side. Mother said, ‘A letter is not a road; it is like a house. Learn how to enter it.’”

Tears slipped from Madhavi’s eyes.

That might indeed have been her mother’s sentence—Tanvi was reading from the written page. Ira retained fragments of the story as something she had been told; but Madhavi had nothing: not her five-year-old hand, not the grains of rice, not her mother’s voice.

She began to cry—not loudly, but in silence. Ira sat beside her.

“Paper doesn’t bring a memory back,” Madhavi said.

Ira’s voice broke. “I know.”

“Words survive. Experience doesn’t.”

That evening they decided to remove the bell.

Ira brought a screwdriver. Two rusted screws held the round brass rim. The first came loose with difficulty. When she turned the second, the whole button slackened and came away into her hand.

They stared in astonishment.

There was no wire behind it.

There was not even a hole in the wall through which a wire could have passed.

There was only a round hollow in the wood, about a finger-joint deep. No dust inside it, no insect, no cobweb—as though that little portion had been cut out only yesterday.

“This is impossible,” Ira whispered. “The bell was real. Nani used to say the electrician came again and again.”

“His name?”

Ira shook her head. “I don’t remember.”

Madhavi searched for the name as well. Nothing.

Even the story of the bell’s installation had now grown indistinct in her mind. Whether the bell itself had eaten that memory, or time had, was impossible to say.

Madhavi took the button in her hand. It was surprisingly heavy. The brass at the back was perfectly flat: no maker’s name, no number. Only very fine scratches, visible when light struck at an angle. The marks resembled a count—one, a second, a third... but with breaks between them.

“Should we throw it away?” Ira asked.

Madhavi looked beyond the door towards the drain. Rainwater was moving slowly along it.

She could throw the button away. But fear stopped her. What if it still worked after being separated from the house? What if someone picked it up and pressed it? What if the cause was not the object at all, but simply that place on the door?

“Don’t press it,” she said. “We’ll decide the rest tomorrow.”

They put the button in an old steel box, packed cloth over it, and locked the box inside her mother’s trunk.

A round empty hollow remained in the door.

The next morning, the first thing Madhavi did after waking was go to the door.

The hollow was gone.

The wood was smooth, as though no button had ever been fixed there.

Madhavi called Ira. Ira came running. Both touched the wood. There was no mark.

“The box,” Ira said.

They opened her mother's trunk. The steel box was there. The cloth was inside.

The button was not.

They looked at each other.

Then came knock-knock-knock at the door.

Three times.

Sukanya Kaki stood outside with her walking stick. "Won't you have tea? You've been staring at the door since morning."

Madhavi invited her in. Kaki looked at the wood of the door.

"Oh! Where did the bell go?"

Madhavi and Ira turned towards her together.

"You remember the bell?" Madhavi asked.

"Why wouldn't I? Your father had it installed."

"When?"

Kaki narrowed her eyes. "When your grandmother's hearing had grown weak. He thought a louder bell would help. But once it was installed, it never rang at all. The electrician came five times. In the end your mother said, 'Leave it. Anyone who reaches this house can knock on the door.'"

"Who was the electrician?"

"Bisesar. He had a shop near the station."

The instant Madhavi heard the name, a faint light flickered in her mind—a thin man with a moustache, a coil of wire over his shoulder. The image appeared for a moment, then blurred again.

"Kaki," Madhavi asked, "when that bell was pressed... did anything happen?"

Kaki laughed. "No sound. That was all."

She drank her tea and left.

For a long time Madhavi and Ira said nothing.

Selling the house had become a question again. Ira said, "What if new people live here and the bell appears again?"

Madhavi said, "What am I supposed to tell them? That there is a bell at the door that eats memories?"

"The truth."

"Will they believe it?"

Ira did not answer.

They told Diwakar, the broker, that the old bell had been removed and a new one could be installed later. Nothing more. It was as much truth as the market could bear.

Three days later a family agreed to buy the house—a couple who were both teachers, their two children, and the husband's elderly father. They

liked the courtyard, liked the mango tree, and liked the fact that although the house stood in the middle of the city, it was quiet within.

The day for signing the papers drew near.

Madhavi began dividing the belongings. She decided to take her mother's sewing machine with her. Her father's radio was set aside for Ira. The inverted tile stayed in the wall—it would break if they tried to remove it. The iron bar in the bathroom stayed too. Some things are not sold; they are simply left behind.

The notebook now contained twenty-three filled pages. Whenever another memory surfaced, Madhavi wrote it down. But she had already understood that written words were no insurance against forgetting. Paper could draw a boundary around an empty place; it could not restore the scene within it.

On the last evening before they were to leave the house, Ira used her phone to show it to her aunt far away. Madhavi walked from room to room naming things. "This was my room... Grandmother used to sit here... this is the upside-down tile..."

Her aunt asked, "Why was it upside down?"

Madhavi paused. She now knew the reason from Sukanya Kaki's story, not from her own memory.

"Mother had it put in deliberately," she said.

"Why?"

Madhavi smiled. "Kaki says Mother used to say that if everything in a house were perfectly straight, people would start thinking themselves gods."

Ira looked at her mother. Their eyes met for a moment. They both now understood how great a distance lay between "Kaki says" and "I remember."

On the final day all the belongings were loaded onto the vehicle. The new owners would move in two days later. Once the house was empty, its sound changed—the thud of footsteps carried in long echoes. Where a picture frame had been removed, the wall was lighter. A strand of thread clung to a corner of her mother's room. On the veranda were four round marks where the feet of her father's chair had stood.

Ira stepped forward to close the main door.

At that moment Madhavi saw the round dull button again on the wood.

Exactly where it had always been.

Both of them froze.

"This..." Ira's voice would not come.

The button sat there with such naturalness that it was as though everything that had happened between—unscrewing it, locking it in the box, its disappearance—had never happened at all.

Madhavi moved slowly closer. A film of dust lay on the button. Green moss edged its rim. The brass was cold.

Behind her Ira said, "Don't touch it."

Madhavi stopped her hand.

Outside the door, the new owner's elderly father was standing near the gate. He had come to ask about something in the paperwork. When he reached the door, he lifted his hand towards the bell.

Madhavi immediately thrust her hand between them.

"Not this one," she said.

The old man looked startled. "Is it broken?"

"Yes," Madhavi said, "and let it stay broken."

He smiled, perhaps taking it for one of the eccentricities of an old house. Then he raised his fist and knocked three times on the door—knock, knock, knock.

A tremor went through Madhavi's body.

With those three sounds a scene returned with perfect clarity: she is five years old, rain outside, a paper boat in her hand; the door will not open; her mother calls from within, "Call your name and ring"; she knocks three times; the door opens; her mother wipes her wet hair.

Madhavi held her breath, trying to keep hold of the scene. This was not one of the memories erased by the bell; perhaps it was one that had survived. Perhaps the sound of knocking had opened some locked room inside her.

The old man said again, "There's one signature left on the papers."

Ira went outside.

Madhavi turned once and looked back at the house: the empty rooms, the inverted tile, the iron bar, the pale rectangles on the walls, and at the door, the bell that never rang.

She did not press it.

She laid her palm against the door, knocked softly three times—knock, knock, knock—and stepped outside.

STORY 2

The Road That Turned Back

Archana Jha worked at measuring roads, and for that reason she trusted them.

A map could be wrong, a milestone could be old, two villages could have bridges with the same name; but one quality of a road seemed beyond dispute to her—wherever you set out from, it would take you somewhere.

After the first heavy spell of monsoon rain, the district office assigned her to inspect three alternative roads. The waters of the Kamla and Bagmati were rising, one section of the main bridge was closed for repairs, and a new route sheet had to be prepared to show where ambulances, milk vans and school buses could pass in an emergency.

Archana's parents lived in an outlying neighbourhood of Benipur. The office had asked her to stay there that week and measure the roads in the surrounding area. For eight years her job had kept her moving between rented rooms in Patna and Darbhanga; now even five uninterrupted days in the old house felt almost like a holiday.

That afternoon, after lunch, her father said, "The clouds are gathering again. Measure it tomorrow."

Putting her survey notebook into her bag, Archana said, "The water will rise further tomorrow. Why waste today while it's still dry?"

From the veranda her mother called, "Be back before four."

Archana laughed. "I'm going to measure a road, not enter a jungle."

She reset the motorcycle's odometer to zero. On the first page of her survey notebook she had written: Route A: Benipur outer neighbourhood to Shivnagar turn, then along the old canal embankment; estimated total distance, 18.6 kilometres.

As soon as she left the gate, the road turned east. Two hundred metres farther stood a peepal tree, then the milk-collection centre, then a small culvert. Archana had known that sequence since childhood.

Nothing unusual happened during the first five kilometres.

At the sixth kilometre, water shone on both sides of the road. Archana slowed down. At the seventh she passed a new brick kiln. At the eighth, a thicket of bamboo. She entered everything in the survey notebook.

Near the tenth kilometre the road forked. To the right lay newly laid black asphalt; to the left, the old whitish-grey surface. According to the office map, the right-hand road led towards Shivnagar.

Archana turned right.

Three minutes later she felt that the air had suddenly brought her a familiar smell—not boiling makhana, not mud; it was the sharp pre-rain scent of leaves from the guava tree behind her house.

She laughed at herself. Smells had no maps.

The road curved once to the left, then to the right, and crossed a narrow bridge. A small red temple appeared ahead. Archana stopped the motorcycle.

That temple stood half a kilometre west of her house.

She looked in the rear-view mirror. The road behind her ran straight towards the milk-collection centre.

“Impossible,” she said softly.

The odometer showed 13.4 kilometres. The normal distance from the house to the temple was 0.6 kilometres.

When Archana reached the gate, her father was sitting on the veranda reading the newspaper.

“Back so soon?”

“I haven’t come back,” Archana said.

Her father peered at her over his spectacles. “Then what is this?”

Archana did not switch off the motorcycle. “I took the wrong road. I’m going again.”

This time she wrote in red ink on the survey page: First circuit, 13.4 km. End point: west gate of home.

The moment she wrote the word circuit, she struck it out. In its place she wrote: route error.

On the second attempt she left home and, at the first turn, went south instead of east. This road led to the market. From the middle of the market, a lane running north joined the canal embankment. It was a longer way, but there was less chance of a mistake.

Archana looked at her watch—3:47.

Fruit sellers, a tea stall, bicycle repair, the smell of vegetables, the cries of hawkers—everything in the market was ordinary. She stopped at one place and bought some lime. The shopkeeper asked, “Whitewashing a wall?”

“Remembering a road.”

The shopkeeper laughed. “Is the road going to run away?”

Archana laughed too, though her own laughter tasted faintly bitter.

As she left the market, she marked the first electric pole with a small white circle of lime. At the second turn she drew two lines. Near the canal,

three dots. If the route turned her around again, the marks would tell her where she had already been.

Four kilometres on, an old mustard-yellow granary stood by the roadside. At the fifth was a primary school. At the sixth, a broken culvert. The map was correct.

The sky had grown heavy now.

At the seventh kilometre Archana was riding parallel to the canal when a white circular mark flashed on a pole ahead.

She braked.

It was the first electric pole in the market—the one on which she had made the lime mark.

But why was that pole in front of her now?

Archana got down and touched it. The lime was still dry. On the wall of the shop beside it was the same soap advertisement in red letters. The shopkeeper came out and asked, “Come round again?”

“Did I leave from here?”

“Ten minutes ago.”

“Which way?”

“Towards the canal.”

“And which direction have I come from now?”

The shopkeeper looked down the road behind her. “From the canal.”

Archana stared at his face for a moment. There was no curiosity in it. To him, it seemed, both ends of the road simply led towards the canal.

“Where’s home?” the shopkeeper asked.

“The outer neighbourhood of Benipur.”

“Then keep straight on. You’ll be there in half an hour.”

“I don’t want to go home.”

The shopkeeper laughed again. “What can you tell a road?”

Archana did not answer.

She set off marking the road for a third time. This time, instead of a circle, two lines and three dots, she wrote the Maithili numerals १, २ and ३ in sequence. Distance, time, direction of each turn—she recorded everything in the survey notebook.

३:५९—१.

४:०४—२.

४:११—३.

At ४:१७ she found १ again—but this time on the other side of the pole.

She parked the motorcycle at the roadside and studied the map for a long while. On paper the line was straight. On the ground the line was catching its own tail.

She opened the map on her phone. The blue dot placed her north of Shivnagar, though the market shop stood directly in front of her. The phone compass pointed north behind her. Archana switched the phone off.

“A machine can go wrong,” she told herself. “The earth cannot.”

She did not believe that sentence immediately.

Jitan Mian was sitting at the market tea stall. He drove a small goods vehicle and knew every road in the surrounding area by heart. Archana had known him since childhood.

“Jitan Kaka, will you take me to Shivnagar?”

“What about your motorcycle?”

“It can stay here. Take me in your vehicle.”

Jitan Mian drained his cup and stood up. “Now?”

“Right now.”

Archana left the motorcycle with the shopkeeper and took her survey notebook and the lime with her.

Jitan Mian drove north out of the market. “By the old canal embankment?”

“Yes. But one thing—you choose the road. Don’t ask me.”

“That is a driver’s dream.”

He took the first turn to the right, the second to the left. Archana said nothing. Five minutes later the vehicle reached the grain warehouse at Shivnagar. Archana looked at her watch. Everything was right.

Her body relaxed. “All right. Now take the district road.”

At the next turn Jitan Mian swung the vehicle around. “Which district road? The eastern one or the station road?”

“The station road. Towards the main office.”

Whether anything changed after that answer, Archana could not say. The road was the same. The paddy fields were the same. The betel shop, the peepal beside the pond, the dog, the milk cans on a bicycle—everything was ordinary.

But ten minutes later Jitan Mian pressed the brake.

Ahead stood the west gate of Archana’s house.

On the veranda her father had folded his newspaper and risen to his feet.

Jitan Mian sat with both hands on the steering wheel and said nothing.

“Did you take a wrong turn?” Archana asked.

“Me?”

“Yes.”

“I took the station road from Shivnagar. I did not miss a single turn on the way.”

“Then?”

Jitan Mian looked at the gate and then into the rear-view mirror. "How did my vehicle come here?"

Her father came out onto the road. "What happened?"

Jitan Mian got out and looked around as though someone had lifted the house bodily and set it down in this place.

Archana opened the survey notebook. From Shivnagar to the house, the vehicle's odometer had advanced 11.2 kilometres. The normal distance was 7.8.

"Let's go again," Archana said.

Jitan Mian looked at her. "Where?"

"The station."

"No."

"Kaka—"

"If a vehicle breaks down, we repair it. If a road is damaged, people can be told. But when a thing cannot even be understood, testing it again as night is falling is not wisdom."

Irritation rose in Archana. "Are you frightened?"

"Yes," Jitan Mian said plainly. "I am frightened. If you are not, perhaps that is your special quality."

He turned the vehicle around. "I'm going to the market. Are you coming?"

Archana got in.

This time Jitan Mian himself named the destination—"The market." The vehicle went straight to the market. No loop. No detour.

Archana got down. "Now go to the station by yourself."

"Why?"

"Just go."

Jitan Mian shook his head, but he went. Twenty minutes later he phoned. "I've reached the station."

"The road was all right?"

"Perfectly."

Archana ended the call.

The shopkeeper asked, "Home now?"

"No."

"Then?"

Archana looked across the road at the paddy fields. From the market to the station there was an old footpath along the field embankments, not a motor road. In childhood people had used it to walk to the weekly market; now fewer people went that way.

She left the motorcycle with the shopkeeper and slung her bag over her shoulder.

"Where are you going?"

“To the station by the field path.”

“It’s going to rain.”

“Let it.”

Within the first five hundred metres, mud had climbed the sides of her shoes. The embankment was broad in places and no wider than two feet in others. Newly planted paddy trembled in the water. Lightning flashed in the distance.

Archana kept looking back. The market grew smaller. There was no sign of the house.

A kilometre later she crossed the canal. There was no bridge—only a bamboo footbridge. A motorcycle could not have crossed it.

Reaching the other side, she looked at her watch. In the survey notebook she wrote: 4:58, left the road; 5:23, crossed canal; direction stable.

Writing direction stable made her laugh.

The clouds broke open.

The rain came down so hard that she had to put the survey notebook inside her bag. She ran beneath a dry thatched shelter where two cowherd boys were already standing.

One of the boys asked, “Didi, why did you leave the road and come this way?”

Archana said, “Because the road won’t leave me.”

Both boys burst out laughing. Archana laughed too. This time the laughter came easily.

When the rain eased, she walked on. In the first darkness of evening she saw the station signboard. At five fifty-six she was standing on the platform.

By road, the station was nine kilometres from the house. Across the embankments and fields, it was roughly five.

Archana bought a ticket—to Darbhanga.

The ticket clerk asked, “Luggage?”

“Only this.”

“Motorcycle?”

“It will find its way home,” Archana said absently.

The passenger train arrived half an hour late. Archana sat by the window. When the train began to move, a strange relief came over her—as though the metal wheels had simply refused to acknowledge the road’s enchantment.

The train passed the edge of the village. Through the window Archana looked towards her neighbourhood in the distance. Behind the curtain of rain, nothing was clear.

On reaching Darbhanga she telephoned her colleague Rashmi.

“I’m near the office. Can I stay in your room tonight?”

Rashmi was startled. “Weren’t you in Benipur?”

“I was.”

“How are you here?”

“By train.”

“That doesn’t answer the question.”

“For now, that is the only answer I have.”

That night in Rashmi’s room, Archana spread out her survey notebook to dry. The wet pages had buckled into waves. The sequence of lime marks—1, 2, 3—was still legible. When she added up all the distances, the total came to 41.7 kilometres—and the result, three times, was home.

Rashmi laughed when she first heard the whole story, then stopped when Archana remained silent.

“You must have been tired,” she said.

“Ask Jitan Kaka.”

“Then both of you were tired.”

“The odometer?”

“A machine.”

“The lime marks?”

“The wrong pole.”

Archana smiled. “Those were all my answers too.”

Straightening a pillow, Rashmi asked, “So what will you do tomorrow?”

“Measure the road.”

“Which road?”

“I’ll go towards home. The road seems to behave properly in that direction.”

The next morning Archana reached the office. The maps in the file were checked again. The assistant engineer said that a vehicle had travelled all three routes only the previous week. There had been no loop.

Archana said nothing. She took an office vehicle and told the driver to go to Benipur by way of Shivrinar.

The journey was entirely ordinary.

At half past nine she stood at the gate of her house. Her father’s first question was, “Where is the motorcycle?”

“In the market.”

Her mother’s first question was, “Where were you last night?”

“At Rashmi’s.”

Their second question was the same—“Why?”

Archana said, “First, one test.”

The office vehicle stood outside the gate. The driver was drinking tea. Archana told him, “Now take me back to the office.”

The driver turned the vehicle around. Her father stood on the veranda watching.

The first kilometre was right. The second was right. At the third, Archana saw the peepal tree that stood near the temple west of the house.

She did not close her eyes.

At the fourth kilometre came the red temple. At the fifth, the gate.

The driver pressed the brake slowly. "Madam, isn't this your house again?"

Archana looked at her watch. Nine fifty-six.

Her father was still standing on the veranda. There was no curiosity on his face now.

Archana got out of the vehicle.

"Do you understand now?" she asked her father.

Her father looked at the road. "Understand what?"

"Wherever I try to go, the road turns me back here."

Her mother came as far as the doorway. "Since yesterday?"

"Yes."

Her mother asked simply, "On foot?"

"On foot I reached the station by the field embankment."

"Then the fault lies with the road, not with you."

Archana wanted to laugh at that sentence, but did not.

Her father said, "Leave vehicles alone for a few days."

"My work is to measure roads."

"Then measure from somewhere else."

The sentence was utterly simple. Archana had spent the whole night thinking in such complicated ways that the simple solution felt almost insulting.

Even so, she tried it.

From behind the house she followed the embankment between the fields for half a kos. There a dirt track joined the government road. Archana phoned the driver and called him to that spot.

The vehicle came. She got in.

"Office."

The vehicle went straight to the office.

All day Archana tested roads from different starting points. Shivnagar to the station, the station to the canal, the canal to the market—every route behaved normally. The problem arose only when the journey began at the gate of her house and the destination lay outside home.

That evening she defined the limits of the test.

She stepped from the gate onto the road and walked south for ten minutes—then found herself at the temple west of her house.

She walked south for ten minutes along the embankment behind the house—she was in the middle of the paddy fields, exactly where she ought to be.

She came out through the gate onto the road thinking only of going to the market—five minutes later she was home.

She came out through the gate intending to visit the neighbour's house—she reached it, because the neighbour lived only forty paces away on the other side of the road.

From there she set off towards the market—and returned home again.

Archana wrote in the survey notebook: The boundary is not distance. It is the act of 'going outside.'

She stared at the sentence for a long time after writing it. No survey notebook had any place for a statement like that.

For three days she worked alongside this private impossibility. In the morning she walked half a kos along the embankment behind the house, caught the office vehicle on the road, spent the day surveying, and returned home by vehicle in the evening. The return journey was normal every time.

On the fourth day the assistant engineer asked, "Why don't you have the vehicle come all the way to your house in the morning?"

Archana said, "I like walking on the dirt path."

It was not the whole truth, but neither was it a lie.

A week later the alternative-route sheet was ready. The distances of all three roads, the culverts, waterlogging, weak edges—everything had been recorded. Archana did not put the 41.7 kilometres of her first day into any official document.

Only on the last page of her survey notebook did she draw a separate figure: a small square house at the centre, three curved roads around it, every arrow pointing inward. Not one arrow pointed out.

The rains intensified. Twice the water rose over the road, then receded. Repairs to the main bridge were completed. The office work shifted to another area.

Archana decided to return to Darbhanga. She had only one bag of clothes and books. Her mother asked, "When will the vehicle come?"

"It won't come to the house."

Her mother no longer asked questions. She simply packed some fried tilkor leaves into a small box.

Her father reached for the bag to carry it. Archana did not hand it over. "It's only this much."

Outside the gate the road glittered in the sun. It had not rained for three days. There was no water anywhere on the surface. The road looked straight for a long distance—so straight that, for a moment, Archana considered trying once more.

Her motorcycle had been brought from the market and stood by the gate. She turned the key. The engine came alive.

Her mother waved from the veranda. Her father said, "If you go by the embankment, what about the motorcycle?"

Archana did not answer.

She wheeled the motorcycle onto the road, closed the gate, and set off towards Darbhanga.

Past the first turn.

Past the peepal tree.

Past the milk-collection centre.

Past the small culvert.

Archana's breathing slowly eased. For a moment she thought—the episode is over. Water, exhaustion, direction, machines—perhaps together they had created some confusion which three days of fear had merely prolonged.

Three kilometres on, the road curved left.

Archana saw the red temple ahead.

She did not stop the motorcycle.

She passed the temple. Half a minute later the west gate of the house stood in front of her.

Her mother and father were still standing on the veranda.

Archana switched off the motorcycle. For a few moments no one spoke.

Then she herself began to laugh—a laughter that made her mother laugh too, and then her father. None of them knew what exactly was funny, but the impossibility of the past three days had suddenly become familiar, like an old member of the household.

Archana put the motorcycle inside. She slung the bag over her shoulder.

"Now?" her father asked.

"Now I won't take the road."

She opened the small door at the back of the house. Ahead lay the paddy fields, a narrow embankment running through them, the canal in the distance, and beyond it the dirt track.

Her mother said, "Call when you reach, by evening."

Archana stepped down onto the embankment.

From that day it became her rule. The road was for coming home. The embankment was for leaving home. Half a kos away, the road she joined behaved again like any other road. Whenever she had to go out, she began leaving the motorcycle at the house of an acquaintance in the market.

People asked, "Why walk so far?"

Archana gave different answers. Sometimes exercise, sometimes the need to inspect mud, sometimes convenience with the motorcycle. If she told the real answer, people would laugh, or become frightened, or hunt for an explanation. All three reactions seemed useless to her.

Months passed. The paddy ripened. The embankment dried and turned yellow. The water in the canal fell. Fresh white lines were painted on the road.

One day a new employee from the district office came to Archana's house to get her signature on some papers. He rode his motorcycle straight to the gate, completed the work, and rode away again along the same road.

Archana watched from the veranda. For him, the road was straight.

That evening Archana had to return to Darbhanga. She lifted her bag, opened the back door, and stepped onto the embankment.

For a moment she turned and looked towards the front gate. Beyond it the road lay straight for a long distance in the last light of the sun. No bend was visible. No circle. No mark.

Even so, Archana knew that within that straight line, for her alone, a curve was hidden.

She walked on along the embankment.

Behind her, the road remained where it was, shining straight.

STORY 3

The Night's Second Sky

Kailash Mandal was the school's night watchman. Looking at the sky was nothing unusual in his work.

By day he rang the bell, swept the veranda, checked the latches on the classroom doors, and did whatever small tasks the headmaster asked of him. At night, once all the pupils had gone home, the school remained in his care.

Open fields surrounded the school. To the east lay a pond, to the north a thicket of bamboo, to the west the first houses of the village, and to the south the metalled road. The electricity failed often, so the sky was usually clearly visible.

Kailash was not in the habit of counting stars, but since childhood he had known enough constellations to find his bearings. Where the Pole Star was, where the Saptarshi lay, where the bright evening star appeared—that was enough for him.

One humid September night he had spread his cot on the school veranda. Sleeping without a mosquito net was difficult, but the room inside stayed hot from the whole day's heat.

It was nearly midnight. He rose and crossed the courtyard to drink water from the tap by the pond.

The sky was clear. There was not a scrap of cloud.

Kailash bent over the tap, drank two mouthfuls of water, then straightened.

At that moment his gaze caught and held on the sky.

He did not recognize what was there.

No Pole Star. No Saptarshi. No familiar slanting row of stars in the east.

There were no fewer stars. On the contrary, it seemed as though some unknown hand had arranged the heavens afresh. A cluster of stars curved like a bent sickle; beneath it three bright points stood in a straight line, and high in the west seven small stars formed a circle.

Kailash rubbed his eyes.

First he closed his right eye, then his left. The sight remained the same.

His first thought was that his eyes were deceiving him. His second, that clouds had hidden the familiar stars. His third, that he was looking in the wrong direction.

But the school veranda was where it had always been. The pond was where it had always been. The bamboo to the north stood motionless in the windless night.

The clock showed two minutes past twelve.

Kailash went back to the veranda and picked up his spectacles. He put them on and looked up again.

The same unknown sky.

He stood beside the cot and watched it for five minutes.

At five minutes past twelve, without any flash, sound, or passing cloud, the familiar sky returned.

The Saptarshi was there again. The Pole Star was there again. The bent sickle had vanished. The circle of seven stars had vanished.

Kailash had spent many nights alone. He had heard jackals, mistaken shadows for thieves, found cattle straying into the bushes, seen sheets of tin torn loose in storms. But he could fit what had happened that night into none of those familiar categories.

He sat on the cot with his watch held against his ear, as though the watch might tell him something.

At dawn he told no one.

As the day advanced, the school filled. The children said their prayers, the teachers taught their lessons, and the midday meal was cooked in the kitchen. In the brightness of afternoon, the night's event began to seem to Kailash like a joke he had played on himself.

Even so, at dusk he set the hands of his watch by the time announced on the radio news.

At eleven fifty-five that night, he was standing not on the veranda but in the school courtyard.

Eleven fifty-eight.

Eleven fifty-nine.

Twelve.

For the first instant, nothing happened.

Then it was as though a curtain turned over somewhere inside his eyes.

The familiar constellations vanished. The bent sickle returned. The three bright points were again beneath it. In the west, the circle of seven stars.

A shiver ran through Kailash's body.

He ran to the headmaster's room and fetched a piece of chalk left beside an old blackboard. On the veranda floor he began drawing the stars.

First the bent sickle. Then the three points. Then the circle.

Five minutes past twelve.

The familiar sky again.

This time Kailash did not erase the chalk drawings.

The next day his granddaughter Ragini, who was in Class Nine at the school, came in the evening to bring him his meal. Her home was half a kos from the school.

Seeing the chalk marks in the courtyard, Ragini asked, "What have you drawn here?"

Kailash tried to brush it aside. "Nothing. I was passing the time last night."

Ragini bent to study the drawing. "This looks like a sickle."

Kailash looked at her.

"When are you coming home?" Ragini asked.

Kailash said, "Can you stay here tonight?"

"Why?"

"There's something I want to show you."

Ragini smiled. "A ghost?"

"If it's a ghost, I'll leave you behind and run first."

That night grandfather and granddaughter sat on the veranda. Ragini had a book open, but Kailash kept looking at his watch.

Two minutes before midnight Kailash said, "Close the book. Look at the sky."

Ragini looked up. "What?"

"Just keep watching."

Midnight came.

At first Ragini said nothing. Then, softly, "Dada..."

Kailash's voice had gone dry. "Can you see it?"

"These... where did these stars come from?"

Kailash did not answer.

Pointing towards one part of the sky, Ragini said, "That one looks like a bent sickle."

Kailash's hand froze on his watch.

"Who told you that name?"

Ragini turned to him. "Name? I only said what it looks like."

"Last night I called it the same thing."

Ragini did not laugh.

For five minutes they studied the clusters one by one. Ragini marked dots on a sheet of paper. She named one cluster 'Three Staves'. Kailash stopped her.

"What is it?"

"Nothing."

The truth was that the previous night Kailash had silently called those three bright points 'Three Staves' in his own mind. He had told no one.

At five minutes past twelve, the sky changed again.

Ragini kept looking from the paper to the familiar sky.

“Shall we watch again tomorrow?”

Kailash said, “Don’t tell anyone yet.”

“Why?”

“Because I still don’t know myself what there is to tell.”

Ragini kept quiet for half an hour, but keeping a secret for more than one night was difficult for a girl in Class Nine.

The next day, around noon, her science teacher Shashibhushan Babu came to see Kailash.

“Ragini says the stars change at twelve.”

Kailash cursed Ragini in his mind, but all he said aloud was, “Come and see tonight.”

Shashibhushan Babu laughed. “For five minutes the stars follow the school timetable?”

“All I’m saying is: come and see.”

That night the teacher arrived with a small telescope, a mobile phone, and a tripod. The school’s mathematics teacher, Naseem Ansari, came with him.

At eleven fifty-five Shashibhushan aimed the telescope north. The familiar stars were perfectly clear.

Midnight came.

Kailash and Ragini looked up together. The second sky was there.

For a moment Shashibhushan Babu too fell silent.

“This is impossible,” escaped his lips.

Naseem Ansari said, “If it is impossible, then what is it that we are seeing?”

Shashibhushan immediately put his eye to the telescope.

“But the Saptarshi is here.”

Kailash started. “Where?”

“In the telescope. See for yourself.”

Kailash went to the telescope. Inside the round glass was the familiar sky. The Saptarshi stood exactly where it ought to be.

He lifted his eye. With the naked eye the bent sickle gleamed overhead.

The telescope again. The Saptarshi.

The naked eye again. The second sky.

Ragini took a photograph with the mobile. The screen showed the ordinary stars.

She lowered the phone. Before her own eyes were not the ordinary stars but the other constellations.

Naseem Ansari said quietly, “The instrument sees one sky; the eye sees another.”

Shashibhushan Babu said, “The instrument does not lie.”

Kailash asked, “Are all our eyes lying together?”

No one found an answer to that question before five minutes past twelve.

Over the next three nights the story spread through the whole village.

Seven people came the first night. Twenty-two the second. On the third, nearly fifty people gathered in the school field.

Someone brought a mat, someone a lantern, someone a mobile phone. For the children it became a festival. The elders grumbled that with such a crowd, who could see the stars at all.

Kailash did not like the crowd. What had first been five minutes of silence was now filling with whispers, guesses, and laughter.

Yet the moment midnight struck, the crowd fell silent by itself.

Now everyone could see the second sky.

On his first night, Bhola Sah, the village grocer, pointed to one cluster and said, “Look at that bent sickle.”

Ragini immediately gripped Kailash’s arm. No one had told Bhola Sah that name.

A little later Saguna Kaki, who rarely came even to school functions, pointed towards the three bright points and said, “The Three Staves are shining very brightly tonight.”

This time Shashibhushan Babu said nothing.

The next day he proposed an experiment.

Twenty-three people were chosen. Each was made to sit in a separate room. At midnight they were taken outside one at a time and allowed to look at the sky for one minute. No one was given a chance to hear what anyone else had said.

After five minutes past twelve, each person was asked to draw on paper the shape of the cluster they had seen and write the name that had come to mind.

Of the twenty-three, nineteen wrote ‘sickle’ or ‘bent sickle’ for the curved line of stars. Seventeen called the three bright points ‘Three Staves’. The seven stars in a circle drew different names—‘Seven Grains’ from some, ‘Round Bowl’ from others, ‘Seven Lamps’ from still others.

Shashibhushan Babu spread the papers across a table and sat looking at them for a long time.

“If the shape is the same, the names can resemble one another,” Naseem Ansari said.

“The sickle, yes,” Shashibhushan said, “but why should three points become staves? They could have said steps, posts, lamps, eyes—anything.”

Ragini asked, “Then where do the names come from?”

Instead of answering, Shashibhushan counted the papers again.

Gradually the rules of the second sky became clearer in the village, though not one cause did.

It began exactly at midnight. Five minutes. If it rained, the clouds hid everything, but on the next clear night after the clouds had gone, the same thing returned.

The telescope showed the ordinary sky. Mobile photographs showed the ordinary sky. Through a thick glass window, some people saw the familiar stars and some the second sky; no consistent rule emerged from that.

The school field, the pond steps, a rooftop, the road—wherever one looked from within the village boundary, the new constellations appeared for five minutes.

One night Shashibhushan Babu took Kailash on his motorcycle to the village's southern boundary. On one side of the road were the village fields; on the other began the land of the neighboring panchayat.

It was almost midnight. They stood beside the boundary marker.

When midnight struck, Kailash stepped two paces inside the village side. The second sky.

He crossed the road and went twenty paces into the neighboring panchayat. The familiar sky.

Back towards the village. The second sky.

Shashibhushan tried it himself. The result was the same.

"The boundary belongs to a map," Kailash said. "Why should the sky obey a map?"

Shashibhushan did not answer.

The following week four young men from the block science club arrived. They brought a large telescope, a compass, a thermometer, and an instrument for measuring brightness.

The villagers hoped that now something would finally be proved.

The young men set up their instruments and worked through the night. At twelve they too saw the second sky with their naked eyes. The telescope and the instruments continued to record the ordinary sky.

After five minutes one of them said, "I have no instrument with which to measure what the eye saw."

Another said, "It will be difficult to write this in the report."

Bhola Sah grew irritated. "You all saw it, and still it is difficult to write?"

The young man answered calmly, "Seeing and evidence are not the same thing."

Kailash did not like the sentence, but he did not argue.

The next day the science club left. The village's name did not appear in their public note. There was no news report.

Two days later Bhola Sah pasted a notice outside his shop: 'Tea for Watching the Second Sky—Until Eleven at Night.'

Naseem Ansari read it and laughed. “The sky lasts five minutes, the tea lasts an hour.”

Gradually the crowds thinned. The wonder that had drawn people in the first week began, by the second, to become part of ordinary routine.

Some people climbed to their roofs before midnight, watched for five minutes, then went to sleep. Some said, ‘I’m tired tonight. I’ll watch tomorrow.’

Kailash found this change strangest of all.

The sky that had driven sleep from him on the first night was becoming, in the village, another fixed time like the milkman’s hour, the electricity cut, or the closing of the market.

Only Ragini did not miss a single night.

She had begun keeping a thick notebook. Date, weather, temperature at midnight, the constellations seen, the ordinary constellations five minutes later—she wrote down everything.

Kailash asked, “What will you do by writing so much?”

“Someday it may be understood.”

“And if it never is?”

Ragini thought for a moment, then said, “Then at least it will remain known that I saw it.”

Kailash liked that answer.

One evening Ragini came to the school with an envelope in her hand. She had been admitted to a residential school in Darbhanga. She was to leave the following Monday.

Kailash showed his happiness. Ragini smiled, but her eyes were on the notebook.

“I’ll look at twelve there,” she said.

“Do.”

“What if it doesn’t appear there?”

“Then it doesn’t appear.”

“And what if it stops here after I leave?”

Kailash laughed. “Does the sky report for duty on your account?”

Ragini did not smile.

That week she measured the sky even more carefully. One night she said, “Dada, the circle of seven stars has shifted a little to the left.”

Kailash looked. He could make out no difference.

“Look at the drawing from the first night in the notebook.”

They compared the two drawings. The difference was tiny, but it was there.

The next night, again. The circle had moved a little farther left. The bent sickle too was a hair’s breadth higher.

When Shashibhushan Babu heard, he became excited again. He said that if there was movement in the second sky, then it must have a mathematics of its own time.

Ragini plotted the positions from three nights on a single page. The lines did not match the normal motion of stars.

“Perhaps our measurements are not accurate,” Shashibhushan Babu said.

Kailash laughed. “The instruments cannot even see this sky. What are we supposed to measure it accurately with?”

Ragini said, “With our eyes.”

For the first time, Shashibhushan Babu did not immediately contradict her.

On Sunday night, Ragini’s last night in the village, the school field was empty. The crowd no longer gathered as it once had.

Kailash and Ragini sat on the steps of the pond. The water was still. The ordinary stars trembled in its surface.

Ragini asked, “Can you see the second sky in the water?”

Kailash said, “We’ll test it tonight.”

Midnight came.

Above them, the second sky appeared.

They both leaned towards the water.

In the pond was the familiar sky.

Ragini watched without breathing. The Saptarshi in the water. The bent sickle overhead.

She stirred the water with her hand. The reflection shattered into little fragments of light, but when it gathered itself again, it was still the ordinary sky.

“Telescope, mobile, water,” Ragini counted. “All of them see the ordinary sky.”

“And we?”

“The second one.”

Kailash asked, “Then which one is true?”

Ragini began to answer, then fell silent.

At five minutes past twelve, the sky above once again matched the sky in the water.

Ragini wrote the last line for that night in her notebook: ‘The reflection does not change.’

The next morning she left for Darbhanga.

Kailash returned to keeping the night watch alone.

On the first night, at twelve, he stood in the courtyard as usual. The second sky came. Ragini was not there.

He took out his mobile and called her.

In the hostel Ragini was still awake. She immediately went up to the roof.

“There?” Kailash asked.

Ragini looked up. “The ordinary sky.”

“Here it’s the other one.”

For a few moments both were silent.

Ragini said, “Point the mobile upward.”

Kailash aimed the mobile camera at the sky. On the screen Ragini could see the Saptarshi.

“It’s the same here,” she said.

Kailash looked at the mobile screen. On the screen, the ordinary sky. Directly above the screen, before his own eyes, the bent sickle.

“Dada, are the Three Staves there?”

Kailash looked up. “Yes.”

“The circle of seven stars?”

“Yes. A little farther left than before now.”

Ragini searched her own ordinary sky in the direction her grandfather was describing. She could see nothing there.

On the mobile screen, the skies in both places looked exactly the same.

To their eyes, the skies were different.

Twelve oh four.

Ragini said, “Tell me when it changes.”

Kailash did not look at his watch. He kept looking up.

A moment later the bent sickle was gone. The Three Staves were gone. The circle of seven stars was gone. The familiar stars stood once more in their old places.

Kailash said softly, “Now they are one.”

At the other end of the phone Ragini said nothing.

She kept looking at the ordinary sky above her hostel.

Kailash kept looking at the ordinary sky above the school courtyard.

On the small mobile screen, the two skies had been the same all along.

The only difference was those five minutes—recorded by no instrument, yet present in full, the whole time, in the silence between the two of them.

STORY 4

The Woman Cutting Onions

Saroja Devi was not in the habit of crying while cutting onions.

If an onion was sharp, her eyes burned, water streamed from them, and her nose tingled; but she regarded all that as a natural part of the work. Just as a palm draws back of its own accord near a hot pan, just as the colour of the water changes while rice is being washed, so tears come from the eyes when onions are cut. There was no story in that water.

That day, too, there was no story at the beginning.

By nine in the morning, a long rectangle of sunlight had come through the kitchen window and fallen across the old wooden cutting board. The board was grey in the middle, dark brown around the edges, and its surface was crossed by countless knife marks cutting through one another.

Saroja placed the first onion on the board and cut it in two.

A hammer was sounding out on the veranda.

From the following week, the kitchen was to be rebuilt. The old limewash would be stripped from the walls, the sink moved to the other side, the wooden cupboard below replaced by metal drawers, and an extractor fitted above the stove. Her son had said, “Ma, have it done properly this once. The kitchen is thirty years old.”

Saroja had said, “Have it done.”

The mason had taken measurements the day before. Today the carpenter had come to inspect the old planks and decide which could be saved and which could not.

“Are we keeping this cutting board too?” her daughter-in-law Neelima asked, standing in the doorway.

Without stopping the knife, Saroja said, “It’s worn down this far. Throw it away.”

Neelima looked at the board. “I thought you would say—don’t throw this one away.”

“Why?”

“Because it’s old.”

“If every old thing is kept, there’ll be no room left to walk in the house.”

Neelima laughed and went outside.

Saroja returned to cutting onions.

Today's meal was not an ordinary one. That evening the family would gather for the first time since Yogendra Babu's retirement. He had been free of his job for three weeks, but their son had been away and their daughter caught up in examination work at her school; so everyone was coming today.

Yogendra Babu had said, "Don't make anything elaborate. Just what we normally eat at home."

For Saroja, 'what we normally eat at home' meant a list: arhar dal, fried potatoes and onions, pumpkin curry, rice, curd, papad, and a little kheer for Yogendra Babu.

Neelima had said, "Ma, cut three dishes from the menu."

Saroja cut two. Not three.

The work went on.

The carpenter's hammer on the veranda, granddaughter Anu's voice in the courtyard, the radio murmuring the news inside. Without needing thought, Saroja's hands peeled onions, cut away the roots, halved them, and sliced them thin.

"Nani!" Anu came running in.

"Have you washed your hands?"

"Yes."

"Then pick the bad leaves out of this coriander."

Anu pulled up a low stool and sat down. At school she had been given an assignment called 'Three Generations of My Family'. For the past two days she had been going around asking everyone questions.

"Nani, you still haven't answered me."

"Answered what?"

"Five major events in your life."

Saroja slid the onion pieces into a separate plate for the pan and said, "What major events have there been in my life?"

"Everyone has to write five."

"Your Nana got his job. Your mother was born. Your uncle was born. This house was built. Nana retired. There—five."

Anu shook her head. "Those aren't your events."

Saroja laughed. "I was there in all of them."

"Madam said that when we write about someone's life, we should ask about the things that person did."

"Then write—I was born, I got married, I had children..."

"That happens to everyone."

"Not everyone has children."

Anu thought for a moment, then repeated the question: "What did you do?"

The knife stopped for an instant.

Saroja looked at the child. Anu genuinely wanted an answer. There was no argument in her question, no accusation. She held a coriander leaf in her hand and was separating the yellowed part with her fingernail.

"Pick the coriander first," Saroja said. "I'll answer later."

Anu accepted that.

Saroja picked up the second onion.

This onion was smaller than the first, and a green shoot had emerged from its top. Ordinarily Saroja cut such shoots away. Sometimes they altered the taste.

She trimmed the root and halved the onion.

As the knife came down through the middle, Saroja's hand stopped of its own accord.

Inside the onion were rings of white and purple, but their centre was not in the middle. In the direction where the green shoot had grown, all the rings were slightly stretched, pressed, bent. The structure within was not nearly as even as the roundness visible from outside.

Saroja had cut onions like this many times before.

Today she saw it.

That was the only difference.

"What happened?" Anu asked.

"Nothing."

Saroja turned the half onion around on her palm.

The sprout had not asked for a path through the centre; it had risen wherever it found room. Because of it, the rings inside had shifted, little by little.

For some strange reason, Saroja felt the sight was worth looking at for a long while.

She put the half onion back on the board and raised the knife, but did not cut.

The rectangle of sunlight had now moved from the middle of the board towards its right edge. In that light, the old knife marks stood out clearly.

Some lines were straight. Some slanting. Some deep. Some so faint that they disappeared into the grain of the wood.

Without thinking, Saroja ran the fingers of her left hand over the board.

The board had not come with her when she married. Five years after she entered this house, when the old kitchen was first made, a carpenter had fashioned it from a leftover teak plank. The moment Saroja saw it she had said, "It's far too big."

The carpenter had said, "Big is better. The vegetables won't spill off."

At the time she had disliked the board. Heavy. Hard to wash. Slow to dry.

A few years later, working without it began to feel inconvenient.

Saroja noticed a long diagonal scar across the top of the board. She remembered—Meera had been in Class Eight when she first held a knife. While cutting cucumber, the knife had slipped and run all the way to the edge of the board. Frightened, Meera had dropped it.

Saroja had not scolded her. She had only said, “Curl your fingers inward when you hold it.”

How many times Meera had cut things on this board after that, Saroja could not remember.

There was a deep round burn on the board’s left corner. Once a hot pan had been set there by mistake. Who had put it down—Yogendra Babu, Meera, or Saroja herself—the memory was no longer clear.

The board had kept the scar; not the name of the culprit.

That made Saroja laugh.

“Nani?”

“Nothing. Pick the coriander.”

Now Anu was watching her.

Saroja began cutting the onion again, but her hands no longer moved at the old pace.

Somewhere inside her, Anu’s question rose again: What did you do?

The first answer came back unchanged: marriage, children, house, husband’s job, children’s education.

But now the subjects of the sentences began to change.

The house was built—that was one thing.

The kitchen window would face east—that was Saroja’s thing.

While the house was being built, the mason had set the window frame into the south wall. That was where the plan showed it. For three days Saroja kept saying that the neighbours would raise a high wall to the south and the kitchen would become dark. No one had time to listen. On the fourth day she had the bricks removed herself and made them shift the frame to the east wall.

Yogendra Babu came home that evening and said, “You changed the plan?”

“Yes.”

“What did the mason say?”

“He’ll get his wages. I am the one who has to look out of the window.”

Yogendra Babu had remained silent for a few moments, then said, “All right.”

For thirty years the morning sun had entered through that window.

Saroja picked up a slice of onion. Light gleamed along its edge.

Anu asked again, “Nani, did you make the window?”

Saroja started. She realised she must have spoken half a sentence aloud without noticing.

"The mason made it. I changed where it was put."

Anu sprang up and fetched her paper. "Shall I write that?"

"You'll write such a small thing?"

"You said it yourself, didn't you?"

Saroja did not answer.

As she cut the third piece of onion, another scene returned to her.

Meera was in Class Ten when Yogendra Babu was transferred to Supaul. Everyone in the family said the children should go with him. There would be government quarters.

Meera was not crying, but her board examinations were four months away. Changing schools would have been difficult.

Yogendra Babu had said, "What can we do? It's an order."

Saroja had said, "You go. I'll stay here with the children until the examinations are over."

"Alone?"

"What jungle is this?"

Four months later, the family moved to Supaul. For years the episode was remembered as 'Yogendra's transfer'. No one ever said, 'Saroja ran the house alone for four months.'

Saroja herself had never thought of it in those terms either.

Nothing extraordinary had happened in those four months. Children to school in the morning, market, kitchen, electricity bill, once a leaking roof, once a high fever at night, twice to the bank.

But inside 'nothing extraordinary' there had been so many decisions.

Saroja stopped the knife and looked at the board.

Its lines too had not been made by one great event. One cut, one day at a time.

The wood had slowly changed its colour.

"The second thing?" Anu was ready.

"Coriander first."

"The coriander is done."

Saroja looked. It really was.

"Then wash your hands again."

Anu made a face, but went.

Once Saroja was alone, the kitchen suddenly seemed very quiet. The hammer was still sounding outside, but the sound within had changed.

She thought—must the events of a life be large for the life itself to become large?

At once the question sounded contrived to her.

She did not want a philosophical answer. There were onions still to cut. The dal had to be put on. Milk had to be reduced for the kheer.

And yet, as she worked, memories no longer came to her as they had before.

Earlier, whenever a memory came, someone else's name was attached to it—Meera's examinations, Naveen's job, Yogendra's transfer, her mother-in-law's illness.

Now, within those memories, Saroja could see her own hands.

When her mother-in-law fell ill, Saroja spent fifteen days running between the kitchen and medicines. It had not been service alone; she had decided to change doctors when the first medicines made the condition worse. The men of the house had said, "We'll see tomorrow." Saroja had called a rickshaw that very night and taken her to hospital.

When Naveen got his first job, everyone said, "The boy has succeeded."

Saroja remembered that on the last day for submitting the form, one copy of his certificate had been missing. Naveen had sat down in despair. Saroja borrowed a neighbour's bicycle, rode to the market, and had the copy made before the shop closed.

All these things sounded small when spoken aloud.

Left unspoken, they vanished.

Saroja caught on that word.

Vanished.

Had her life truly remained invisible, or had she herself gone on storing it under other people's headings?

The pan on the stove had grown hot. Saroja poured in oil. Cumin seeds crackled. The moment she added the onions, a hiss rose from the pan.

There was still water in her eyes, but the cause was still the onions. Saroja understood that perfectly. No tragic revelation had come upon her. She was not crying over her life.

If anything, she felt a faint irritation—why, for so many years, had she kept such a poor answer to the question, "What did I do?"

Neelima came in again.

"Ma, the carpenter is asking whether this upper plank can be saved."

"It can. It's teak."

"The lower one?"

"That has rotted. Remove it."

"Will the window frame be changed?"

Saroja said at once, "No. The window will not be moved."

Neelima paused at the firmness in her voice. "No one was going to move it."

"Good. It will stay facing east."

“All right.”

Neelima left.

Saroja smiled as she stirred the onions in the pan.

She understood that she did not want to save the window because it was old. She wanted it kept because once it had been her decision, and it still served its purpose.

The wooden cutting board? That could be thrown away.

The distinction had never been this clear to her before.

An old object and one's own life were not the same thing.

By afternoon the house was full of people. Meera arrived with her husband and daughter. Naveen brought sweets from the market. Yogendra Babu bathed, put on a new kurta, and sat on the veranda, where the box containing the watch he had received as a retirement gift had remained unopened for three weeks.

Before the meal, everyone remembered Anu's school assignment.

Anu took her paper and sat down in front of her Nana.

“Nana, five major events.”

Without thinking, Yogendra Babu said, “Appointment, first transfer, promotion, the house being built, retirement.”

Anu wrote them down.

“That quickly?” Meera laughed.

“A government servant's life is like a register,” Yogendra Babu said. “You can find all the dates.”

Anu looked towards Saroja.

“Nani's five are still left.”

For a moment, everyone's eyes turned to Saroja.

Setting down a plate, Saroja said, “The food is getting cold.”

“Tell me one first,” Anu insisted.

Yogendra Babu laughed. “I'll count your Nani's events for you.”

Saroja looked at him.

No anger rose in her. What rose was curiosity—now she wanted to hear what Yogendra Babu would count.

“Marriage,” he said, “Meera was born, Naveen was born, the house was built...”

“Those four are on your list too,” Anu said at once.

Everyone burst out laughing.

Yogendra Babu laughed too. “You caught me.”

Saroja said, “Your Nana is running my life from his own list.”

The sentence was spoken in laughter, but even as she said it, Saroja heard the truth inside it.

Meera asked, “Then you tell us, Ma.”

Saroja put the plate down on the table and sat.

For the first time she began to make a list—not to look up a certificate, but to examine her own memory.

“One,” she said. “When this house was being built, I changed the position of the kitchen window.”

Yogendra Babu laughed immediately. “That is an event too?”

Saroja laughed as well. “It is mine, so I’ll decide whether it is large or small.”

Anu wrote with great care.

“Two?”

“During Meera’s Class Ten examinations, I lived here alone with the children for four months.”

Meera fell silent. “I remember.”

“I didn’t,” Naveen said.

“You were younger.”

“Three?” Anu asked.

Saroja paused.

Her mother-in-law’s night at the hospital? Naveen’s form? Her insistence on buying Meera her first bicycle? Starting a savings group with five women from the neighbourhood? Travelling back and forth between her parental home and her marital home during her mother’s last month? Opening the first bank account in her own name?

They all came to her.

Suddenly the number five seemed too small.

Saroja laughed. “I’ll tell you the other three this evening. Eat now.”

Anu was dissatisfied, but the sight of the plate persuaded her.

In the middle of the meal Yogendra Babu suddenly said, “I remember the window.”

Serving dal, Saroja said, “So do I.”

“I had thought the mason shifted it on his own.”

Saroja looked at him.

A small event from thirty years ago had survived in two people’s memories in two different forms.

“No,” she said. “I changed it.”

Yogendra Babu nodded. “Then you changed it well. The morning light comes in beautifully.”

That was all.

No apology. No grand acknowledgement. Nor was one needed.

Saroja moved the ladle of dal towards the plate.

By evening the house began to empty again. Meera went home. Anu forgot her paper, then ran back in through the door to fetch it. Naveen threw the empty sweets box into the rubbish.

Before leaving, the carpenter had piled the old things to one side: broken planks, a rotted drawer, rusted iron nails, and Saroja's cutting board.

The board was leaning against the wall.

Saroja saw it while putting the kitchen in order.

For a moment she wanted to keep it.

At once she asked herself—why?

The answer came: because the lines are there.

Then came another question—would keeping the lines bring the days back?

No.

She lifted the board. It was still heavy. There was an old stain of damp on the underside. The wood in the middle had grown thin. Neelima was right—it now rocked under the knife.

Saroja set it down again.

"This goes," she said, pushing it towards the separate pile for the carpenter.

After dinner, Anu came back with her paper. Her house was two lanes away; she could not sleep without finishing her school assignment.

"The remaining three."

This time Saroja was ready.

"Three—I opened my first bank account in my own name. I don't remember the date."

"Is the date necessary?"

"No. Did your teacher ask for it?"

"No."

"Then no."

"Four?"

"I started a savings group with the women in the neighbourhood. The first meeting was held in this kitchen."

Anu stared. "That group still exists, doesn't it?"

"It does. Now it runs even without me."

"Five?"

Saroja remained silent for a long time.

This time, many memories were not jostling one another for the fifth place. She was choosing.

"Staying here during Meera's examinations is already number two," Anu reminded her.

"Yes."

Saroja said, "Five—today I understood for the first time that all these things are events in my life."

Anu stopped her pen. "Should I write that?"

"Why not?"

"Madam will say—what kind of event is that?"

"Then tell her—Nani said so."

Anu laughed and wrote it down.

Yogendra Babu was listening to the news in the adjoining room. Whether he heard the sentence or not, Saroja did not try to find out.

After Anu left, Saroja went back into the kitchen and began looking over the preparations for the next day.

On the table lay the small piece of the sprouting onion from the morning that had been left uncut. The green tip had wilted slightly.

Saroja picked it up.

For a moment she thought of planting it in the soil.

Then she laughed. There was no need to turn every green thing into a symbol.

She cut off the sprout and put it in the rubbish bin, then placed the remaining onion in a container.

Neelima had bought a new cutting board—light, smooth, made of bamboo. Not a single mark had yet appeared on its surface.

Saroja unwrapped it, washed it under the tap, wiped it with a cloth, and set it in the old place beneath the window.

At night the east-facing window was only a black rectangle. In the morning, sunlight would come through it again.

Saroja took out two lemons for the next day. She placed one on the new board and brought the knife down.

The first cut was very light.

A fine line remained on the smooth bamboo.

Saroja did not touch it with her finger.

She began cutting the other half.

STORY 5

The Bus Window

That evening, at first, Madhav Jha could see only the road outside in the bus window.

The crowds of Laheriasarai were falling away behind him. Shop lights, bicycle bells, the yellow roofs of tempos, bulbs hanging above fruit vendors' carts—everything slipped past beyond the glass. The lights inside the bus had not yet been switched on, so the pane was still simply a clear window.

As soon as they crossed the railway gate, the darkness thickened a little. The driver switched on the two lights overhead.

Then the window changed.

The road remained where it was, but a face settled over it.

At first Madhav thought someone in the seat behind him had leaned forward and was looking into the glass.

He turned slightly. Two college students behind him were watching their phones with earphones in. An elderly man sat with his eyes closed.

Madhav looked back at the window.

The face was still there.

His first feeling was not fear. If it had been fear, his heart would have quickened, his body would have drawn back. This was only an awkward pause—as when, in a crowd, one sees someone familiar from a distance but cannot remember the name.

The face was familiar.

Very familiar.

And yet Madhav could not immediately accept it as his own.

The bus lurched. The reflection trembled. A red light from outside slid across his left cheek, then disappeared.

Madhav narrowed his eyes a little.

The hair at the front of his head was thinner than before. The right eyebrow sat slightly higher than the left. Deep shadows lay on either side of the nose. The skin beneath the chin had loosened. Fine lines gathered at the corners of the eyes.

He knew all this.

Every morning while shaving, he saw these things in the mirror.

But now the problem was not the lines or the hair.

The problem was that there was no familiar expression in the face.

It was neither smiling nor worried; it carried neither the gravity of the office nor the ease of home. It was simply the face of a tired man sitting in a bus, not prepared to answer anyone.

Madhav did not know what to do with this face.

At four that afternoon, a photograph had been taken at the office for his new identity card.

The three-year-old identity cards were being replaced. A white backdrop had been hung in the office conference room, with a small light in front and a chair in the middle. A young man was photographing all the employees on a mobile phone.

When Madhav's turn came, the young man said, "Sit a little straighter in the chair."

Madhav sat up straight.

"Chin a little lower."

He lowered his chin.

"Eyes here."

He looked at the small black dot above the phone.

"No smile."

The smile that had appeared on Madhav's face without thought vanished at once.

The first photograph was taken.

The young man looked at the screen and said, "Relax a little."

Madhav laughed inwardly. Sit straight, chin down, eyes here, no smile—and in the end, relax.

For the second photograph, he deliberately let the muscles of his face go slack.

The young man looked again.

"This one looks a little tired. Once more."

For the third attempt, Madhav assumed the expression that came automatically to his face whenever he entered the room of a senior officer—not too much of a smile, not sadness, not a question.

The young man immediately said, "Yes, this is right."

Madhav had not paid attention to the word "right" then.

Now, in the bus window, the word returned.

The right face.

Right for whom?

The bus was passing through a small market. In the hard light from a sweet shop, the reflection almost vanished. Madhav felt something like relief. Real people outside became clear again—a child holding his father's finger, a cyclist carrying a sack, a woman steadying a bag of vegetables.

Once the market fell behind and the darkness deepened again, the face returned to the glass.

This time Madhav was ready.

He made his mouth smile slightly.

At once familiarity returned.

This was the face he wore when posing for a photograph at a neighbour's wedding.

He removed the smile and drew his brows together a little.

This was the face he made at the office when the figures on two account sheets refused to match.

Corners of the mouth lowered, eyes softened.

This was the face that came of its own accord when he visited the home of someone who was ill.

Then he let all of it go again.

The stranger returned.

Madhav took his wallet from his pocket.

There was less money in the wallet than paper: a bank slip, a prescription, two or three old receipts, his current office identity card, and four small old photographs in a transparent sleeve.

He took the photographs out of the sleeve.

The oldest was from his undergraduate admission form.

Madhav had been twenty-two. His hair was thick, his cheeks lean, his moustache not yet fully grown. Yet the expression on his face was surprisingly solemn.

That day the photographer had said, "Don't smile. A smile doesn't look good on a certificate photograph."

Madhav still remembered the sentence.

The second photograph was from his first job application.

That time the photographer had run a comb through his hair and said, "Show your ears."

Both ears were plainly visible in the photograph.

The third photograph was from an older office identity card.

At the time, his daughter Ritu had been in Class Eight. Before he went to have the photograph taken, she had said, "Babu, don't look so serious. You look like a criminal."

Madhav had smiled. The photographer had immediately said, "That's enough. No teeth."

The fourth was from his current identity card, three years old.

Madhav held each photograph up in turn beside the face in the bus window.

The face had changed; that was natural.

But for the first time he realised that behind every one of those photographs some command or other was hidden.

Don't smile.

Show your ears.

No teeth.

Keep your chin straight.

Eyes here.

Relax.

Had he been recognising the instructions more readily than his own face?

At the front of the bus, near the driver, was a small rectangular mirror. It was not meant for the passengers but for the driver. In it, the faces inside the bus appeared small and reversed by distance.

Madhav tried to find his own face there.

Among so many people it was difficult to pick himself out.

Then, suddenly, he laughed at himself.

Because he could not recognise his face, he had gone looking for it in another mirror.

In the seat ahead, a child of six or seven slept in his mother's lap. His mouth was half open, one cheek pressed flat, a thin thread of saliva at the corner of his lips. Now and then his mother wiped it away with the end of her sari. The child did not wake.

Madhav thought: this child's face would never appear like this on his identity card.

And yet his mother probably knew him best in precisely this form.

The thought was so simple that Madhav did not immediately want to accept it.

He began looking out of the window.

His phone vibrated.

It was a message from Ritu.

"Babu, did you get the new photograph taken?"

Madhav smiled.

Two days earlier, Ritu had told him she was making a little family booklet for her five-year-old daughter. She wanted a recent photograph of every family member. Madhav had sent her the photograph from his old identity card.

Ritu had immediately sent it back. "Not this one. Send a photograph in which you look like you."

Madhav had replied jokingly, "Who else do I look like but myself?"

Ritu had answered, "Not in an identity-card photograph."

That day the exchange had ended in laughter.

Now, before the bus window, Ritu's sentence returned.

A photograph in which you look like you.

Madhav opened the front camera on his phone.

His face appeared clearly on the screen—far more clearly than in the window.

Without thinking, he straightened his head. Lifted his chin a little. Opened his eyes wider. Evened the two corners of his mouth.

At once a familiar man appeared on the screen.

Without pressing the button, Madhav switched off the camera.

The bus jolted through a pothole.

The seat beside him had been empty until then. At the next stop a thin young man got on and sat beside Madhav. A cloth bag hung from his shoulder; in one hand he carried a tin of blue paint. He looked as though he were returning from painting work.

As soon as he sat down, he glanced once at the window, then rested his head against the seat.

The words escaped Madhav before he had meant to say them: “Once it gets dark, this glass turns into a mirror, doesn’t it?”

At first the young man did not understand.

“What?”

“Nothing,” Madhav said.

After a couple of seconds the young man looked at the glass. “In the dark, you can see yourself.”

That was all.

He closed his eyes again.

Madhav found his own question ridiculous.

What he wanted to know was this: when other people saw their reflections, did they at once say, “That is me”? Or did a moment’s distance ever come between seeing and knowing?

But could such a question even be asked?

And if it were asked, would the answer be true? The very question would make a person conscious of his face.

Madhav looked at the window again.

This time he deliberately did nothing.

No smile. No tightening of the brows. No adjustment of the chin.

The face became uncertain again.

Electric wires outside ran across his forehead. Green letters from a shop fell across his cheek for a moment, then the red tail-light of a bus rested beside his eye. The reflection was never still. Perhaps this too was one reason for the lack of recognition—at home, in a mirror, the face stood alone; in the bus window it mingled with the road.

But Madhav knew it was not only a question of light.

He was never like this when he stood before the mirror at home.

In the morning, while shaving, the purpose was clear—where a patch of beard remained, where soap remained. While brushing, he looked at his teeth. Before leaving home, he fixed his hair. There was always some task.

The mirror was less an object for seeing his face than a tool for correcting it.

In the bus window there was nothing to correct.

Perhaps that too was why the face seemed unfamiliar.

Even the word “unfamiliar” did not seem quite right to Madhav.

An unfamiliar person is someone one has never seen before.

He had seen this face thousands of times.

Then what was this?

It was like a room in a familiar house that had remained locked for years, and when it was opened one day, every object inside was one’s own, yet their arrangement was unknown.

The bus slowed beneath a railway bridge. A train passed overhead with a roar. The window trembled. Madhav’s reflection seemed to break into many fine fragments, though the glass itself was unbroken.

He closed his eyes.

The moment he did, he remembered his father.

While shaving, his father used to hang a small round mirror from a nail by the window. The silvering had peeled away around its edges. As a child Madhav would stand behind his father and see only half his own face in it—sometimes one eye, sometimes the nose, sometimes the mouth. To see the whole face he had to tilt his head to one side.

One day his father had asked, “What are you looking at?”

Madhav had said, “Myself.”

“Half of yourself?”

“Half of me is still me.”

His father had laughed.

At the memory, Madhav opened his eyes.

He thought: as a child he had so easily accepted half a face as his own. Now the whole face was before him, and yet why was it difficult?

The young man beside him rose to get off. The paint tin knocked against Madhav’s knee.

“Sorry,” the young man said.

“It’s all right.”

The seat was empty again.

The conductor came from the rear and said, “Madhav Babu, you did take a ticket, didn’t you?”

Madhav started.

“Yes, I did.”

The conductor laughed. “You’re very quiet today.”

Madhav showed him the ticket.

The conductor moved on without even looking at it. He recognised Madhav every day.

That too seemed strange. The bus conductor did not even need to see his face—where he sat, the bag he carried, the stop where he got off, the way he asked for a ticket: all of it together was Madhav.

Then how much of Madhav was the face?

The moment the question arose, he felt irritated with himself.

After spending the whole day staring at columns of figures, to sit in a bus and philosophise about one’s own face—this was not his nature.

He closed the wallet and put it back in his pocket.

At that exact moment, the lights inside the bus went out for an instant.

The glass became a window again.

Madhav’s face disappeared.

Outside there was only the darkness of the fields, a bulb glowing at a distant house, and the beam of a motorcycle.

Madhav suddenly felt a faint sense of loss.

The face that had made him uncomfortable a moment earlier did not feel good to lose.

The lights came on again.

The face returned.

This time Madhav did not correct it.

He simply kept looking.

After a while he noticed that the face which seemed still was not truly still. The motion of the bus changed the eyelids; with each breath the nostrils widened slightly; at some thought the corner of the mouth moved; the light outside kept changing its colour.

None of this existed in a photograph.

On those little pieces of paper, the face had been stopped at a single moment of obeying instructions.

Here the face was obeying no instruction at all.

Madhav’s stop was drawing near.

From a distance the conductor called, “Next turn!”

Madhav lifted his bag.

As he stood, the whole shape of the reflection changed. The seated face lengthened, the shoulders rose, the roof of the bus moved into place behind his head.

For an instant it looked strange again.

Madhav did not smile.

He simply watched until the bus came to a stop.
When he reached home, Anita opened the door.
“Late today?”
“The bus got held up at the turn.”
Anita took his bag. “Why does your face look so fallen? Did something happen at the office?”
Madhav paused while taking off his shoes.
“My face looks fallen?”
Anita looked at him carefully once. “Not now. It did at the door.”
“It changed in two minutes?”
“What is wrong with you?”
Madhav laughed.
“Nothing.”
“Then wash your hands and face. I’m putting out the tea.”
There was a rectangular mirror in the washroom. Madhav turned on the tap but did not look at it.
Then his eyes rose of their own accord.
A clear face. Steady light. A familiar room.
Madhav immediately smoothed down the hair on the left side of his forehead with his hand.
Then he realised—he was correcting his face again.
His hand stopped in the air.
He left his hair as it was.
Jaw loose. Eyes ordinary.
Within two moments, the stranger from the bus had returned to the mirror.
This time Madhav was not startled.
The face was his. It was simply a face with no task to perform.
“Your tea will get cold!” Anita called.
“Coming.”
Madhav left the mirror and went out.
While they drank tea, Anita asked, “Did they take the photograph for the new identity card?”
“Yes.”
“Show me.”
“I don’t have it yet. They’ll make the card at the office.”
“Ritu was asking for a photograph too.”
Madhav remained silent.
Setting down her cup, Anita asked, “What are you thinking about?”
Madhav tried to ask a very simple question, but it did not come out simple.

“When does my face look most like mine to you?”

Anita laughed first. “What sort of question is that?”

“Just asking.”

She studied Madhav for a few moments.

“When you listen to someone and don’t interrupt halfway through.”

Madhav had not expected that. “I asked about my face.”

“That is when your face shows.”

“A smile? The eyes? Something?”

Anita looked again. “When you listen carefully, your right eyebrow lifts a little. But why do you want to know this?”

Madhav touched his right eyebrow.

“And when you say, ‘I’m not tired,’ your left eye closes halfway,” Anita added.

“Really?”

“Yes. Now tell me—what happened?”

Madhav could have told her about the bus window. But he felt that the moment he put it into words, the whole thing would become small or ridiculous.

He said, “Nothing. Today, while they were taking the photograph, I had to arrange my face so many times.”

Anita said easily, “Everyone arranges their face for a photograph.”

The matter ended there.

Madhav liked that answer.

That night Ritu sent another message: “Babu, don’t forget.”

Madhav opened his phone. Instead of opening the camera, he typed a reply: “I’ll send it tomorrow.”

The next morning, while shaving, he looked at the mirror very little. The shave turned out just as neat.

At the office, a preview of the new identity card arrived on his phone. It carried the third photograph from the previous day—the same “right” face.

A colleague said, “Madhav Babu, the photograph has come out well this time.”

Madhav looked at it.

The photograph was ordinary.

The man in it looked orderly, dependable, fit for the office.

Madhav said, “Yes, it’s good.”

He did not ask them to change the photograph.

That evening, on the way home, the bus was more crowded. There was no window seat. Madhav remained standing in the aisle.

He felt a little disappointed, and then laughed at his own disappointment. Until yesterday that pane had been a source of discomfort; today he wanted precisely that seat.

Two stops later, the window seat became free. Madhav sat down.

The sun had not fully set. For now, the glass showed more of the outside and less of the inside. His face was only a faint shadow.

The bus moved on.

Slowly the darkness deepened. The interior lights came on.

The face became clear again.

Madhav's first impulse was to straighten his chin a little.

He did not.

A lock of hair had fallen over his forehead. He did not brush it aside.

The man in the glass was still not entirely familiar.

But this time Madhav did not immediately declare him a stranger.

He kept looking.

Light from a shop passed over the glass. Half the face disappeared.

Then darkness. The face returned.

The corner of an eye shifted slightly, as though he were thinking something. At the edge of the mouth, without instruction, a faint smile appeared and went away.

Madhav did not try to hold it.

His phone vibrated again. It was a message from Ritu.

He took out the phone, but instead of opening the camera he opened Anita's name.

He wrote, "When I get home, take a photograph of me. Don't tell me beforehand."

The reply came at once: "Then you'll know that I'm taking it."

Madhav burst out laughing.

The man in the glass laughed too.

The laughter was familiar, but it had not been rehearsed.

Madhav put the phone back in his pocket.

The bus reached a brilliantly lit crossroads. The face slowly withdrew from the glass, and the road took its place.

This time Madhav did not try to stop it.

STORY 6

When It Was Time to Fetch Water

Manjari's phone showed 7:18 when she placed her yellow bucket in the queue at the tap.

Her bucket was ninth in line.

Ninth usually meant about fifteen minutes, but today the mouth of the tap was still dry, and all that could be heard was the faint rasp of air moving somewhere inside the pipe.

Manjari could wait for ten minutes.

At 7:28 she had to be back home. Father left for the shop at eight, her younger brother Anshu caught the school bus at five past eight, and Mother's medicine had to be given at twenty past eight.

And amid all this, she also had to send a reply by ten.

That reply had been lying half-written in her phone since the previous night.

"For personal reasons, I shall not be able to attend the training on the scheduled date..."

That was all she had written.

What remained was the final sentence: "Therefore, my place may be offered to a candidate on the waiting list."

Manjari had written and deleted that last sentence three times.

She had not deleted the message itself.

Only the final sentence refused to take shape.

She had gone to Darbhanga twice for that training—first for the written test, then for the interview.

It was a three-month programme at the district record repository, where she would learn to preserve old papers, registers, maps, and documents. There was no promise of a permanent job afterward, but there would be a certificate and experience.

Manjari liked the smell of old paper.

No one at home particularly understood that.

Father would say, "What is there in old paper? Look for a new job."

Mother would say, "If your heart is in it, learn."

Anshu would say, "Didi, so your job will be to dust old files?"

Manjari would laugh.

But when the letter of selection arrived, for the first time she did not laugh.

The training was to begin on Monday. She had to report at nine in the morning. By bus, Darbhanga was an hour and a half from home. In the evening, the return journey could sometimes take three hours.

And in that very week Mother sprained her right foot.

Not on the stairs.

At the tap.

Her foot had twisted while she was lifting a full bucket.

The doctor said—no heavy strain for ten or fifteen days.

So for the past ten days, Manjari had been fetching the water.

Mother had always fetched it before.

Manjari knew that, but she had not known that fetching water was not one task; it was a knot made of many tiny pieces of time.

What time the tap came alive in the morning, when the first burst of air escaped the pipe, which household's bucket reached the line first, whose vessel stood behind whose—each had its own arithmetic.

When Manjari received the selection letter, none of this queue for water had figured in the calculation she made.

She had written down only the bus timings.

6:45—leave home.

8:15—Darbhanga.

9:00—training.

5:00 in the evening—leave.

7:30—home.

On paper it was possible.

At home it was not.

It was 7:20.

The tap was still silent.

Manjari looked toward the front of the line.

In first place stood a blue container. Its owner was nowhere to be seen.

Second was an old brass water pot. No one stood beside that either.

Third was Rahima Chachi's red bucket. Rahima Chachi had said two minutes earlier, "The milk is on the stove. I'll check it and come back. Move the bucket forward for me."

Sushila Kaki, seated behind that bucket, said nothing; she simply nudged it slowly forward with her foot.

Manjari watched.

More than half the queue was made up of vessels; there were fewer people.

Someone had a stove to attend to at home, someone a child's tiffin, someone an elderly mother-in-law's medicine. People left their vessels in line and ran home in between.

The vessels remained standing in the queue.

Their places remained reserved.

Manjari had seen this arrangement before.

But today her attention stayed fixed on it.

"Whose blue container is that?" she asked Sushila Kaki.

"Kamala's. She has gone to put her grandson on the bus."

"And that pot?"

"Shobha's. Her rice is on the stove."

"Will they all come back?"

Sushila Kaki laughed. "If they don't, who will fill the water?"

Manjari laughed too.

But inside her, the question sounded differently.

If they don't come back, who will fill the water?

Mother had said almost the same thing the previous night.

"If you go away, who will fetch the water in the morning?"

Mother had not said it in the tone of someone stopping her.

She had merely asked for the arithmetic.

Manjari had given no answer.

Later that night, she had composed the half-written message declining the training.

It had seemed to her that there was only one answer to the question—"I won't go."

It was 7:22.

Suddenly the air inside the pipe stirred.

A "phuss" escaped from the mouth of the tap.

Everyone glanced at their own vessels.

Kamala came running back. Shobha had not yet returned. From a distance Rahima Chachi called out, "I'm coming!"

The queue suddenly came alive.

Sushila Kaki placed the first container beneath the tap.

Air came out first.

Then two or three heavy drops.

Then a thin, yellowish stream.

Kamala said, "Let the first water run. It will have been sitting in the pipe all night."

Sushila Kaki kept the container aside and let the water flow onto the ground.

Impatience rose in Manjari.

Water came with such difficulty, and these people were letting the first flow run away.

But no one filled it.

Within moments the stream turned muddy.

Then it grew a little stronger.

Then its colour lightened.

Kamala put the tip of a finger into the stream, smelled it, and said, "Now."

Only then did the first container begin to fill.

Without thinking, Manjari took out her phone.

7:23.

She opened the half-written message.

"For personal reasons..."

She read it.

Last night the sentence had seemed clear to her.

Today it seemed like that first flow from the pipe—what comes out the moment the pipe is opened need not be the water one finally keeps.

She did not delete the message at once.

She slipped the phone back into her pocket.

The first container filled.

Kamala hoisted it onto her head and walked away without looking back.

Shobha, the owner of the second pot, had still not returned.

Sushila Kaki placed the pot under the tap.

"She isn't here," Manjari said.

"So?"

"The water will overflow."

"I'll stop it."

When the pot was full, Sushila Kaki covered its mouth with her palm, moved it away from the tap, and set it to one side.

"When she comes back, she'll take it."

Manjari fell silent again.

Other people were filling water for those who were absent from the queue.

No meeting had been held to create this arrangement. No file had been opened. No signatures had been taken.

Everyone simply understood: if someone needed ten minutes elsewhere, that person's place did not disappear.

Manjari thought about her own home.

Could some rule like this be made there too?

At first the question seemed strange.

Then she began counting the tasks one by one.

Water.

Mother's morning medicine.

Anshu's tiffin.

Father's tea.

Rice for lunch.

The evening vegetables.

Small things from the market.

Until yesterday Manjari had put all these things inside one large word — "home."

"Home" was such a large word that beside it the training seemed small.

But when she broke home down into separate tasks, each one revealed its own time, its own hands, its own possible solution.

Father could fetch the water—if he opened the shop half an hour later.

Anshu could prepare his tiffin the night before—if all he had to do in the morning was warm it.

Mother's medicine could be given at seven, not at twenty past eight.

Until Mother's foot recovered, Reena from next door could come and put the rice on at noon—last month, in return for learning sewing from Mother, she had offered to help with something.

Manjari could cook the evening vegetables after she returned.

Some of these things would be inconvenient.

Not impossible.

"What are you thinking about?" Pinki asked from behind.

Manjari turned. Pinki had arrived in the queue carrying two small containers.

"Nothing."

"Where's your bucket?"

"There."

"Ninth?"

"Fifth now."

Pinki set her containers at the end of the line.

"I have to go turn off the gas at home. Keep an eye on my containers."

"All right."

Pinki ran off.

Manjari kept looking at her containers.

One was green, the other white. Both had a fine rim of soot around their mouths.

That someone's absence could be protected so simply—today this struck her as extraordinary.

7:25.

The third bucket was filling.

Manjari took out her phone again.

The cursor blinked beneath the message declining the training.

She selected the entire message.

Her finger paused over "Delete."

Then moved away.

She opened a new message instead.

"Namaskar. I have received the selection letter. I will attend on the scheduled date. During the first week, for family reasons, I will need to catch the evening bus; I will observe the training hours in full."

She read it.

This time too, she did not send it immediately.

First she looked at the water.

The stream was clear now.

But the water being clear did not make the message true.

The truth was that she wanted to go.

She had not admitted that the previous night.

She had thought: if she admitted that she wanted to go, she would also have to admit the guilt of leaving the work of the house behind.

So it had been easier to bury her desire inside the phrase "personal reasons."

The fourth bucket filled.

Now her yellow bucket was next.

She went up to the tap.

Sushila Kaki slid her bucket underneath.

"How is your mother's foot?"

"The pain is less now."

"Did the doctor say she can walk?"

"Not yet."

"You're going for the training from Monday, aren't you?"

Manjari started.

"Who told you?"

"Your mother."

"Mother?"

"Yesterday she was saying, 'Manjari will be away for three months. I'm thinking how I'll manage the water.'"

Inside Manjari, the sentence from the previous night rose again—"If you go away, who will fetch the water in the morning?"

It had been a question.

Manjari had turned it into an order.

"Your mother also said that if you don't go, she won't feel good about it," Sushila Kaki added casually.

Manjari said nothing.

The bucket was filling.

At first the stream struck the bottom with a hollow sound. As the water rose, the sound changed—deeper, fuller.

Suddenly Manjari understood that in making half a decision the previous night, she had heard only half of her mother's sentence.

Only the part that matched her fear.

"It's full," Sushila Kaki said.

Manjari turned off the tap.

7:28.

Exactly ten minutes.

Before lifting the bucket, she took out her phone.

She read the new message again.

She changed one sentence.

"I will attend on the scheduled date."

That was enough.

She deleted the rest of the explanation.

There was no need to send anyone an entire essay proving that her desire was justified.

She sent the message.

A small mark appeared on the phone screen.

The message had gone.

No instant sense of triumph rose inside her.

Her first thought was: now she would actually have to make the arrangements.

The bucket was very heavy.

She lifted it with both hands.

"Wait," Sushila Kaki said. "I'll take half the weight."

"No, I can carry it."

"Don't be heroic. Your mother has sprained her foot; now will you sprain your back?"

They both laughed.

Sushila Kaki took one handle of the bucket. Manjari took the other.

Together they carried it past two houses.

At Manjari's gate, Sushila Kaki let go.

"Send the empty container back in the evening. Tomorrow I'll teach your father how the queue works."

"Father?"

"Why not? Will the tap refuse water because a man's hand is holding the bucket?"

Manjari laughed.

Inside the house, Father was folding his newspaper.

“Why so late?”

“The water came late.”

“I told you to put two containers in the line last night itself.”

Manjari set down the bucket and went straight to the kitchen.

Mother was sitting on a low cot with her foot stretched out.

“You brought it?”

“Yes.”

“It didn’t hurt?”

“No.”

Mother looked at her face.

“What happened?”

“I’m going on Monday.”

Mother was silent for two moments.

“You sent the reply?”

“Yes.”

Mother looked at the bandage around her foot.

“Then the morning water?”

This time Manjari heard the question as a question.

“Father will fetch it.”

From outside, the rustle of the newspaper stopped.

“Me?” Father’s voice came from outside.

Manjari came and stood in the kitchen doorway.

“Yes. For the first week. Until Mother’s foot is better.”

Father pushed his glasses up onto his forehead.

“I don’t understand these queues and all.”

“You put the bucket down. When your turn comes, you fill it.”

“People will move it ahead and behind.”

“Sushila Kaki is there.”

At the sound of her name, Father fell silent. Few people in the neighbourhood had the courage to argue with Sushila Kaki about the queue.

Anshu came out from inside.

“What am I supposed to do?”

“Prepare your tiffin the night before.”

“Didi!”

“Just put the roti and vegetables in the box. Warm them in the morning.”

“I’ll miss my bus.”

“Wake up ten minutes earlier.”

Anshu pulled a face.

Mother kept looking at him.

“Practice from tomorrow,” Mother said.

Anshu immediately looked toward Father.

Father opened his newspaper again.

"I'll fetch the water, he'll do the tiffin," he said. "What else?"

In Manjari's mind, the huge word "home" she had made the previous day began opening again into small, separate tasks.

"I'll give Mother her medicine before I leave. I'll ask Reena if she can come and put the rice on for three or four days at noon. I'll be here in the evening."

Mother said softly, "Pay Reena."

"Yes."

"It is not good to make a habit of taking help without payment."

Manjari nodded.

From behind the newspaper Father said, "If I open the shop half an hour late, customers will go somewhere else."

Manjari remained silent.

This was a real difficulty.

She did not need an immediate answer to every question.

Mother said, "For the first fifteen days, one person can do two days—you two days, he two days, Anshu two days. On Sundays the tap comes late."

Anshu was about to protest, but one look at Mother's eyes silenced him.

Father lowered the newspaper.

"Anshu will fill buckets?"

"Why not?" Mother asked.

Father looked at Anshu.

Anshu looked at his own hands, as though for the first time checking whether these hands could lift water.

"I'll fill them halfway," he said.

"Who said you had to lift a completely full bucket?" Manjari said. "Make two trips."

Mother burst out laughing.

The air in the kitchen grew lighter.

Manjari understood that making arrangements was a second task that came after making a decision. A decision did not create the arrangements. It merely chose the direction in which arrangements could be made.

She looked at her phone.

There was still no reply from the record repository.

For a moment her chest grew heavy again.

What if they said her reply had not come in time?

What if her place had already been given to someone else?

What if nothing came of the training afterward?

What if, after three months, all the work of the house fell back upon her again?

A decision did not erase fear.
No one had told her that before, but today she understood it clearly.
She put the lid over the bucket full of water.
Then her phone vibrated.
The message read: "Attendance confirmation received. Please report by 8:45 a.m. on Monday."
That was all.
No congratulations. No assurance.
Manjari liked that.
She placed the phone in front of Mother.
Mother read it.
"Then check the bus timing again," she said.
"I have."
"There will be morning fog on the road."
"Where is the fog now?"
"You'll be there for three months, won't you? There will be by then."
Manjari laughed.
Mother had already carried the future three months ahead.
The previous night, Manjari's future had extended only as far as ten o'clock—whether or not she would send the reply.
Today it had suddenly reached all the way to the fog of December.
That afternoon Manjari went to Reena.
Reena was sewing a child's frock on the machine.
"Will you come and put the rice on at noon for three or four days?" Manjari asked.
"Will you pay me?" Reena asked.
"Yes."
"Then I'll do it."
They both laughed.
"Your mother has had plenty of work from me for free," Reena joked.
"That's why I'll pay."
"How much?"
The bargaining began.
Manjari found relief in the bargaining. The relationship would rest not on a favour, but on clearly defined work.
When Father came home that evening, he had a new, thin rope in his hand.
"The old bucket handle is weak," he said. "If it breaks tomorrow morning, the blame will fall on me."
He began replacing the bucket's handle.
Anshu moved the alarm on his phone five minutes earlier.

“Ten minutes earlier,” Manjari said.

“Let me start with five.”

Mother sat on the cot, watching everything.

That night Manjari opened her selection letter again.

She read her own name on the page.

Manjari Jha.

Three-month training programme.

Monday.

Until then she had seen only one problem on that page—her absence from home.

Today she saw something else: the page had a place written on it for her.

That place would remain hers only if she reached it on time.

No yellow bucket could be placed in a queue to hold that place for her.

She would have to go herself.

The next morning, at 7:17, Father opened the gate and stepped outside.

In one hand he carried the yellow bucket, in the other a small blue container.

“Why two?” Manjari asked.

“Anshu said he’ll fill only half, didn’t he? The small one is for him.”

From behind, Anshu called out, “I said I wouldn’t fill a full one!”

Father said, “First learn the queue.”

Manjari came out too.

“I’m going.”

“Where?” Father asked.

“The bus stand. I need to ask the exact time of Monday’s first bus.”

“Now?”

“Yes.”

Father placed the yellow bucket in the queue at the tap.

For a moment he shifted it left and right to find the exact position, as though straightening a bicycle wheel at his shop.

Sushila Kaki was watching from a distance.

“Not there,” she called. “Behind the red bucket!”

Without arguing, Father picked up the bucket and placed it behind the red one.

Smiling, Manjari started toward the road.

After ten steps she turned and looked back.

The yellow bucket was in the queue.

Father was not standing beside it—Sushila Kaki had taken him away to show him the pipe valve.

But the bucket’s place was safe.

Manjari turned back toward the road.

For the first time she understood that sometimes, to preserve one's place, it is not necessary to remain standing there.

But it is necessary to know which place one must return to.

STORY 7

The Blank Notebook

Govindkant Jha had never been afraid of a blank notebook.

For thirty-eight years he had been looking at blank notebooks.

One had no name on the first page, another no subject, another the wrong date.

He would make a small mark in the margin with his red pen and say, "You can tell how the work will go from the very first page."

Twelve years after his retirement, on that morning, a brand-new notebook of his own lay before him.

A blue cover, pale blue ruling inside, and a red margin on the left.

The shopkeeper had asked, "Master Sahib, is it for a child?"

He had replied, "No, for me."

The shopkeeper had not laughed.

He had merely dusted the notebook and slipped it into a paper bag.

Now the notebook lay open on the dining table.

Govindkant sat with his spectacles resting a little low on his nose.

A blue pen in his right hand.

The school's letter to his left.

Printed on it were the words: Centenary Year of the School's Foundation.

Former teachers had been asked to contribute a two-page reminiscence.

A suggested subject had been given: "The First Day of My Life as a Teacher."

Below it was the headmaster's signature.

After the date, in brackets, were the words: "Please send within seven days."

Govindkant had bought the notebook three days into those seven.

On the first day, he wrote his name on the cover.

On the second, he wrote the date at the top of the first page.

On the third, he drew a straight line parallel to the red margin.

Today was the fourth day.

The page was still blank.

He placed the point of the pen on the paper.

"The first day of my life as a teacher..."

That was all he said inwardly.

His hand did not move.
He lifted the pen.
Outside the window, two mynas were quarrelling in the guava tree.
Sudha's voice came from the kitchen: "The tea will get cold."
"I'm drinking it now."
"You said 'now' yesterday too."
Govindkant picked up the cup of tea.
The notebook remained open before him.
Sudha came and stood behind his chair.
"Not even one letter?"
"I'm thinking how to begin."
"Write about the first day."
"It is the first day itself that is not clear."
Sudha looked at his face.
"You taught for so many years and forgot the first day?"
Govindkant took off his spectacles and set them on the table.
"I have not forgotten the day. The question is which day was the first day."
Sudha did not understand.
She picked up the empty cup and went away.
Govindkant lifted the pen again.
This time he wrote, "Since childhood I had dreamed of becoming a teacher."
The moment the sentence was complete, his brow tightened.
He put down the blue pen and took out the red one.
Beside the sentence he wrote: "False."
The red word startled even him.
After many years, he was marking a sentence of his own.
He drew a short line beneath the red word.
Then he wrote a second sentence: "Circumstances made me a teacher."
The red pen rose.
"Incomplete."
A third sentence: "The school changed my life."
The red pen: "Easy to say; evidence?"
Govindkant pushed his chair back.
The first page was no longer blank.
Yet to him it seemed emptier than before.
Three blue sentences, three red judgments.
As though a student had copied out every question in an answer book and answered none of them.
He closed the notebook.

Until noon he busied himself with small household tasks.

He arranged the medicine box.

Folded the newspaper and put it away.

Hammered a loose nail into the veranda.

But the blank page kept moving about with him.

At lunch Sudha asked, "Will you go to the school?"

"Why?"

"To check the date. Who knows whether your appointment letter will turn up in the old trunk."

Govindkant stopped with a morsel in his hand.

"It will be in the school register."

"Then go and see."

"Is a reminiscence written by consulting a register?"

Sudha slid the bowl of dal toward him.

"If memory cannot be trusted, a register is not such a bad thing."

Govindkant did not answer.

After lunch he brought out his old cloth bag.

Inside it, the shawl given to him on the day of his retirement was still folded away.

Beneath the shawl he found an old diary.

The year on the first page was 1981.

His appointment had come two years before 1981.

Even so, he opened the diary.

Most of its pages were filled with students' names, examination dates, parent contacts, and household shopping accounts.

On one page he had written: "Mon—Class Seven—map. Wed—example of Mithila painting. Fri—essay again."

Govindkant smiled.

He remembered that lesson on maps.

But not his first day.

On a page near the back of the diary was Sudha's handwriting: "Bring oil in the evening."

He looked at that page for a long time.

How many days of a life remain preserved in such small instructions.

And how many great days pass without leaving behind a single word.

At three o'clock he set out for the school.

The road had changed.

There was now a chemist's shop at the old unpaved turning.

The peepal tree in front of the school was gone.

In its place stood an iron gate, with a cloth banner for the centenary year tied above it.

The watchman seated at the gate stood up at once on seeing him.

“Master Sahib! Pranam.”

Govindkant raised a hand in blessing.

The gesture still came from within him without thought.

The headmaster, Niranjan Chaudhary, had not been his student; he was much younger.

Even so, he called him “Sir.”

“We are waiting for your piece,” Niranjan said.

Govindkant tried to smile.

“Is the piece waiting, or am I?”

Niranjan did not understand the question.

He sent for tea and asked an assistant to open the cupboard containing the old records.

Registers were stacked inside the cupboard.

The edges of some bindings bore the marks of rats’ teeth.

Some were stained by damp.

The assistant placed three thick registers on the table.

“1979?”

“Yes.”

The pages were turned.

Govindkant’s name was found.

“Govindkant Jha—Assistant Teacher—assumed charge: 3 July 1979.”

Niranjan said with satisfaction, “See, the first day has been found.”

Govindkant kept looking at the date.

“No.”

“What?”

“On the third of July I came to the school only to sign the papers.”

“Then the fourth of July?”

Govindkant narrowed his eyes.

“Fourth of July... it was raining.”

A scene rose from somewhere within him.

A wet courtyard.

Slippers outside the classroom.

Rainwater dripping onto a wooden desk.

A child standing by the window.

But the scene was incomplete.

“It may have been the fourth of July,” he said, and at once felt dissatisfied with the sentence himself.

Niranjan turned more pages of the register.

“Attendance?”

In those days teachers’ attendance was kept in a separate register.

That register could not be found.

The assistant searched another cupboard.

Old files were opened.

Nothing.

Govindkant felt a strange relief.

As though, in the absence of proof, the question had returned to his own hands.

Niranjan said, "Write the third of July. It is the official record."

Govindkant closed the register.

"Does an official record tell you the first day of a teacher, or the first day of a job?"

Niranjan smiled.

"You can put that question in the piece."

Govindkant remained silent.

On his way out of the school he went toward his old classroom.

The room where he had once taught was now the computer room.

Through the glass in the door he could see machines arranged on small tables.

A student was typing his name on a screen.

When the name was entered incorrectly, a red line appeared beneath it.

Govindkant stopped without meaning to.

The red line.

He remembered the words in his notebook: "False." "Incomplete." "Evidence?"

He crossed the veranda slowly.

An electric bell had replaced the old bell.

But in one corner of the wall an old wooden board still remained.

No one's name could be read in the faded scratches upon it.

Govindkant did not touch it.

Outside the gate was a bicycle-repair shop.

The shopkeeper saw him and said, "Master Sahib, do you recognise me?"

Govindkant stopped short.

The face seemed familiar, but not the name.

"I recognise the face."

The shopkeeper laughed.

"So the name is gone—I understood that."

"Tell me."

"Devanand. I spent two years in Class Eight."

Something opened inside Govindkant.

"Devanand Mandal?"

"Yes, that same one—the one whose notebook was almost always blank."

They both laughed.

Pumping air into a bicycle tyre, Devanand said, "Do you still listen to every little thing so carefully?"

"It is a habit."

"A good habit."

Govindkant asked, "Do you remember why your notebook used to be blank?"

Devanand stopped pumping.

"I used to work."

"Where?"

"Here, with my father. At night I would be exhausted."

Govindkant did not remember this.

He remembered only the blank notebook.

He remembered the red zero.

"Did I ever ask?"

Devanand thought for a few moments.

"Once."

Govindkant's throat went dry.

"Then?"

"I told you I did not get the time."

"What did I say?"

Devanand pressed the tyre again to test it.

"You said, 'Bring three lines written. Not a whole page.'"

Govindkant held his breath.

"That was all?"

"That was all. For me, that much was a great deal."

A faint satisfaction appeared involuntarily on Govindkant's face.

Devanand noticed it.

"But I did not finish Class Nine," he said casually.

Govindkant's satisfaction stopped where it was.

"You left school?"

"My father fell ill. I had to look after the shop."

"I do not remember that."

"You came to our house twice."

Govindkant stared at Devanand's face.

"Did I try to stop you from leaving?"

"You did."

"Then?"

"The arithmetic at home was different, Master Sahib."

There was no complaint in Devanand's voice.

That made the words sink deeper into Govindkant.

Had he wished, he could have turned this meeting into proof that he had been a good teacher—the advice to write three lines, the journey to a student's house to look for him.

But Devanand stood before him—a school dropout, pumping air into bicycle tyres, managing his life well enough.

No story was giving clear testimony in Govindkant's favour.

Devanand began pumping again.

Govindkant heard no grand expression of gratitude.

No declaration that he had changed a life.

Only three lines.

Govindkant did not remember the incident.

Devanand did.

At that moment Govindkant understood that if he himself remembered every meaning of his life as a teacher, the life would become very small.

Some meanings lived in other people's memories.

Some in papers.

Some nowhere at all.

It was evening by the time he returned home.

Sudha was shelling peas on the veranda.

"Did you find the date?"

"Third of July."

"Then write it."

"That was the first day of the job."

"Of being a teacher?"

Govindkant looked at Sudha.

"You understood?"

"I understood from the beginning."

"Then why did you not say so?"

Sudha dropped an empty pea pod into the bowl.

"When you understand your own question yourself, the answer stays."

Govindkant wanted to take a red pen to that sentence.

But no comment formed in his mind.

After dinner he sat at the table again.

He opened the notebook.

The three blue sentences and three red judgments were still on the first page.

He did not tear the page out.

He capped the red pen and put it away in the drawer.

He took the blue pen in his hand.

He found the first blank line.

For a few moments he sat in silence.

Then he wrote: "On 3 July 1979 I joined this school as an employee."

He paused.

On the next line he wrote: "There is no date in the register for when I became a teacher."

His hand stopped again.

This time he did not look toward the red pen.

On the third line he wrote: "In my first year I knew many answers, but asked few questions."

After that he felt like writing Devanand's name.

Then he stopped himself.

This was not Devanand's story.

Nor was it an occasion for self-praise.

He wrote: "Many years later I understood that it is easy to give a zero when you see a blank notebook; to ask why it is blank is harder."

Govindkant read the sentence.

It seemed too clean to him as well.

Life had not been so clean.

With the blue pen he underlined the word "understood."

Then he added after it: "And I did not understand this all at once."

He leaned back in the chair.

His face was visible in the window glass.

White hair, thin cheeks, two shining frames of spectacles.

He tried to see himself not as Master Sahib, but simply as Govindkant.

It was difficult.

Over so many years, the title had endured more firmly than the name.

He began writing again.

The reason for taking the first appointment—household expenses.

He had accepted the job for three months.

Then he stayed until the next school term.

Then his father's illness.

Then his younger brother was studying.

Then marriage.

Then children.

Then the school's new building.

Then examinations.

Then the flood.

Then a student's admission.

Then another year.

Govindkant stopped in the middle of writing.

He could now see another form of the question.

If becoming a teacher had not been a decision made on the first day, did that mean all the days that followed had been mere compulsion?

He counted the years.

There was no single great moment at which he had declared, "Now I am a teacher."

But on thousands of mornings he had gone to school.

Many times while ill.

Many times in anger.

Many times when he did not feel like going.

Many times with enthusiasm.

On many days he taught well.

On many days badly.

He understood the words of many children.

And failed to understand many others.

He thought: some decisions in life do not happen on the day one signs a paper.

On the page he wrote: "Some decisions are not made on one day; they are made again and again."

For this sentence he felt no need of the red pen.

Sudha came and set down a glass of water.

"How much have you written?"

"They asked for two pages. It has become five."

"Then cut it."

Govindkant laughed.

"For the first time in my life, I do not feel like cutting."

Sudha laughed too.

"Master Sahib is improving."

Govindkant stopped his pen.

"Call me Govindkant."

Sudha looked at him.

"At this hour of the night?"

"Practise."

Sudha said softly, "Govindkant, go to sleep now."

Hearing his name felt strange.

As though the door of a very old room had opened.

He did not close the notebook.

He turned to the next page.

There was no separate box at the top for name, subject, or date.

There were only lines.

On the first line he wrote: "From today I will not give marks to my own answers."

Reading it, he found the sentence a little theatrical.

The red pen was in the drawer.

He did not take it out.

With the blue pen alone, he drew a line through the sentence and crossed it out.

Below it he wrote: "I will read it again tomorrow."

That was all.

In the morning Sudha found the notebook lying open on the table.

The first page was no longer blank.

But neither was it neat.

Blue, red, crossed out, added, halted—everything together.

Govindkant was sitting outside beneath the guava tree.

There was no newspaper in his hand.

Sudha took the notebook outside to him.

"Will you send this for the centenary volume?"

Govindkant took the pages.

He looked at them for a while.

"Not in this form."

"Then a clean copy?"

He looked at the red words on the first page—False. Incomplete. Evidence?

"No. In a clean copy all this will disappear."

"Then?"

Govindkant opened the notebook again.

He took out a small slip of paper and placed it on the first page.

The school's address was written on it.

"I'll give them this very notebook."

Sudha looked at him in surprise.

"The whole thing?"

"Yes. The headmaster asked for two pages. Let him print two pages. Whether he reads the rest or not is up to him."

"But the first page has been cut and corrected so much."

Govindkant touched the red margin with a finger.

"You can tell how the work will go from the very first page."

Sudha smiled.

Govindkant smiled too.

He closed the notebook, but this time his hand rested on its cover for a few moments.

His name was on the cover.

No class beneath it.

No subject.

Only the name.

For the first time, that blank space did not seem incomplete to him.

STORY 8

The Broken Comb

When Shailaja saw the comb, the first thing she noticed was not its colour but the empty space in it.

It was a black plastic comb, glossy as glass.

Three teeth were missing from the middle.

Two teeth were broken halfway.

There was a white scratch along one edge.

The moment she took it in her hand, Shailaja's finger settled of its own accord on that empty space.

As though her hand had always known that the comb's true identity lay in the broken part.

The comb had been lying at the bottom of an old tin box.

Her mother had sent the box three days earlier.

A slip of paper lay on top: "Keep whatever is useful. Get rid of the rest."

Her mother's handwriting was no longer as rounded as it used to be.

The letters had grown smaller, but the kh in "rakhi" still had the same long tail beneath it.

Shailaja had put off opening the box for three days.

The house was to be repainted.

The workman had said that the eastern room would have to be cleared by Monday.

So the cupboard, the old trunk and the paper bags had all come down onto the floor.

Shailaja was dividing things into three groups—keep, give away, discard.

Her mother's box had created a fourth group.

The moment she looked at anything inside it, the act of deciding came to a halt.

A yellowed measuring tape.

Two small spindles.

A wooden reel of blue thread.

Three needles wrapped in cloth.

An old thimble.

And then this broken comb.

A scene opened inside Shailaja so swiftly that she had no time to think.

She is eight or nine years old.
 After her bath she is sitting on a low stool in the courtyard.
 Her mother is sitting behind her.
 There is the smell of mustard oil in her hair.
 The comb is coming down from the centre of her head.
 At one place a tooth catches.
 Shailaja says, "Ah," and bends forward.
 Her mother pulls her head back toward herself.
 "Sit straight."
 Then the hair is parted in two.
 In that scene Shailaja could see the comb clearly—black, with broken teeth in the middle.
 She sat down on the floor in front of the box.
 She brought the comb close to her nose.
 There was no smell of oil.
 There was the faint smell of old cloth, dust and metal.
 She laughed at herself.
 Why would thirty- or thirty-five-year-old plastic still smell of oil?
 Yet the scene had been so clear that she could almost feel the greasiness of the comb.
 Before undoing the last knot in her hair, her mother used to tap the comb twice against her palm.
 She remembered that too.
 She tapped the comb twice against her palm.
 The sound was very faint.
 The blue reel inside the box shifted.
 Shailaja's phone rang on the table.
 It was Nilima.
 "Did the box arrive?"
 "Yes."
 "Have you opened it?"
 "Just now."
 "Ma keeps asking me whether you're going to put everything back in the cupboard again or actually sort it out."
 "I am sorting it out."
 "For three days?"
 Shailaja kept looking at the comb.
 "Do you remember a black comb?"
 "Which one?"
 "Ma's. Three teeth were broken in the middle."
 Nilima was silent for a moment.

“Black?”

“Yes. Ma used to comb my hair with that one, didn’t she?”

Nilima burst out laughing.

“Your hair? With that broken black comb?”

“Yes. Why?”

“Ma used to comb your hair with a red comb. The one with thick teeth. It had a flower on the back.”

Shailaja’s finger tightened over the broken teeth of the comb.

“The red comb came later.”

“No. I got hit with that same red comb too whenever my hair pulled.”

“Hit with a comb?”

“By hit I mean she’d tap us on the head with it. You make everything sound serious.”

Shailaja said nothing.

Nilima added, “The broken black comb used to stay in the sewing box.”

“Why would a comb be in the sewing box?”

“Ask Ma that.”

“You don’t know?”

“I remember she used it for something with thread. Tassels or edging. I can’t say exactly.”

After the call ended, Shailaja tried once more to see that same childhood scene.

There was the courtyard.

There was the low stool.

There was mustard oil.

Her back was between her mother’s knees.

But now the colour of the comb would not hold.

When she made it black, it turned red.

When she made it red, a flower appeared on its back.

She closed her eyes.

The scene changed again.

Her mother is sitting not in the courtyard but on the veranda.

There is cloth in her lap.

The black comb is moving along the edge of the cloth.

This scene was less distinct than the first, but it contained a different sound—the soft rasp of plastic teeth against thread.

Shailaja opened her eyes.

For the first time, she was angry with her own memory.

Not because it could be wrong.

Because it could be wrong with such confidence.

She reached to put the comb back in the box, then stopped.

A very fine blue thread was caught behind the comb.
It was so old that its colour had turned almost grey.
She tried to pull it out with her fingernail.
The thread was wedged at the root of one broken tooth.
Then Nilima's words came back to her—tassels or edging.
An old handwoven coverlet lay in the room that was to be painted.
Her mother had given Shailaja that coverlet a few years after her marriage.
The tassels along its edge were now tangled.
Shailaja brought the coverlet out.
She spread it on the floor.
She drew the comb slowly along its edge.
It did not move properly.
The teeth caught in the thread.
She laughed.
“Did she really work with this?”
On the second attempt she held the comb not straight but at an angle.
This time the threads separated.
The space left by the three missing teeth formed a broad gap.
Several fine threads came together into that gap.
Shailaja could catch them with her fingers and set them apart.
She straightened five or seven tassels.
Then she stopped.
This much proves nothing.
She said it silently to herself.
The sentence immediately reminded her of her father, who used to say at once whenever anyone told him something, “What you see and what you understand are two different things.”
Shailaja folded up the coverlet.
She felt like calling her mother.
Then she looked at the clock.
It was eleven.
At that hour her mother was usually sitting in the courtyard sun, sorting greens.
She took time to answer the phone.
Shailaja did not call.
She opened the second section of the cupboard.
She began sorting again.
But now every object looked like a question.
An old key—what lock had it opened?
A small brass box—had it held kohl or needles?
A blue ribbon—had it belonged to Shailaja or to Nilima?

She realised that an object does not itself give a memory.
It merely opens a door.
And the room behind that door is furnished by the mind according to its own convenience.
The thought unsettled her.
For there were many things about her mother that she believed she remembered "exactly."
Her mother always watered the tulsi first thing in the morning.
Her mother changed the water three times while washing rice.
When angry, her mother pronounced a person's full name.
When she laughed, her right eye narrowed first.
How much of this had Shailaja actually seen?
How much had been made afterward?
By noon the room was half empty.
The painter's boy came and measured the place where the paint tins would be kept.
Shailaja made tea.
She left the comb on the kitchen table.
As she drank her tea, her eyes kept returning to it.
The comb seemed to be pretending to be an ordinary object.
Three teeth were missing.
Everything else was there.
That was all.
In the afternoon her mother called on her own.
"Have you finished sorting?"
"Half of it."
"I told you, didn't I? If something is no use, get rid of it."
"Ma, this black comb?"
There was silence at the other end for a few moments.
"Which black comb?"
"The one in the sewing box. The one with broken teeth in the middle."
"Oh!"
Recognition came into her mother's voice at once.
"Is that still there?"
Shailaja felt unexpectedly pleased.
"Yes. You remember it?"
"Why wouldn't I?"
"Did you use it to comb my hair?"
Her mother laughed so loudly that the sound on the phone crackled.
"Your hair? With that comb?"
It was not like Nilima's laughter.

There was more astonishment in this one.

"Where did you invent such a thing?"

Shailaja fell silent.

"I remember it clearly."

"So what you remembered clearly became blurred the moment you asked me?"

Her mother laughed again.

Shailaja's irritation returned.

"Why are you laughing?"

"Not at you. At the comb. If I'd used that comb in your hair, it would have broken half of it off."

"Then what did you use it for with the sewing?"

"Not sewing. Edging."

"What edging?"

"In those days we used to leave loose threads along the edges of cotton wraps and make tassels. I used the comb to straighten the threads."

"With a broken comb?"

"It wasn't broken at first."

Shailaja sat upright in her chair.

"Then?"

"One tooth broke. I was going to throw it away. Then I saw that the broken space made it easier to separate a small bunch of thick threads. Later I broke two more teeth myself."

Shailaja picked up the comb.

"Yourself?"

"Yes. Look, the three teeth missing in the middle did not all break in one accident. The first broke on its own. I broke two."

Shailaja placed a finger in the empty space.

Suddenly one part of her childhood scene changed again.

Her mother is tapping the comb twice against her palm.

Not to shake loose knots of hair.

To dislodge thread caught in the comb.

"Did you use to tap the comb against your palm?"

"Perhaps. Thread used to get caught in it."

A fine shiver ran through Shailaja.

The memory had not been entirely wrong.

Its pieces had been joined in the wrong place.

The courtyard sunlight, her mother's hand, the tapping of the comb—all of them might have been true.

Just not in a single scene.

"Which comb did you use for my hair?"

"The red one. You hated that red comb."

"Why?"

"Your hair was thick. You didn't like having oil put in it. The comb would get stuck. You would run away."

Shailaja smiled.

This time the scene opened by itself.

She is running toward the courtyard door.

Her mother is standing behind her with the red comb in her hand.

There really is a flower on the back of the comb.

"And the black comb?"

"That stayed in the sewing box. Sometimes you would pick it up and draw lines in the dirt with it."

"Me?"

"Yes. Once you broke two more of its teeth."

"What?"

"You said, 'Now it's even.'"

Her mother laughed again.

Shailaja's hand went still.

"Did you break two teeth, or did I?"

"One I did, one you did. It's hard to keep count now."

After that sentence, both were quiet for a few moments.

Shailaja kept looking at the empty space in the comb.

What she had until now taken as her mother's mark had, in part, been made by her own hand.

The object had belonged to her mother.

The breakage had not belonged only to her mother.

"Ma, shall I send this comb back to you?"

"Why?"

"It's yours."

"I gave you the box. Keep whatever is useful."

"Is it still useful?"

"Try it on the edging of that coverlet."

Shailaja laughed.

"I already have."

"Did it work?"

"More or less."

"Then keep it. Otherwise get rid of it."

There was no worship of memory in her mother's voice.

That made Shailaja feel unexpectedly light.

She had imagined her mother would say, keep it safely, it's an old thing.

But for her mother, an object's importance was not separate from its use.

After ending the call, Shailaja did not spend long thinking about the difference between the black comb and the red one.

She got up.

She spread the coverlet out again.

She brought the tangled threads along the edge before her.

She drew the comb through them at an angle.

Eight or ten threads gathered together in the broken gap.

She caught them with her fingers and twisted them.

The tassel did not come out even.

Nor did the second.

The third was better than the first two.

Shailaja remembered her mother's hands—not quick, but patient.

This time no complete scene appeared before her.

Only the movement of two fingers.

She could not decide whether this was a memory she had truly seen or an image formed after hearing her mother's words.

Earlier that uncertainty would have troubled her.

Now it did not.

She went on straightening the threads.

By evening, the edging along one side of the coverlet had opened out.

Some tassels survived; some she tied again.

The black comb on the table became filled with threads.

Shailaja tapped it twice against her palm.

The threads fell away.

At the sound, she remembered her mother again.

This time not hair.

Not the veranda.

Not the courtyard.

No fixed scene at all.

Only the sense of a hand that knew how to give an object a second use after its first use had ended.

And beside that hand, the hand of a little girl who too had once broken one of its teeth.

By night the room being repainted was almost empty.

Shailaja looked again at the three piles.

Keep.

Give away.

Discard.

Her mother's tin still stood apart.

She opened the tin.

She picked up the blue reel.

She set the tape aside.

She discarded the rusted needles.

She kept the thimble.

After taking the black comb in her hand, she thought for a few moments.

Then she did not put it in the “keep” pile.

She placed it with the coverlet.

The workman came the next morning to clear the room.

Shailaja was folding the coverlet.

The three newly tied tassels along the edge looked slightly different from the others.

She thought of undoing them.

Then she did not.

The comb lay on the coverlet.

The empty gap left by three teeth was plainly visible.

Shailaja placed a finger in that gap, but this time she did not try to summon any single scene.

She simply picked up the comb and drew it once more along the edge of the coverlet.

The threads separated.

The teeth that remained did their work.

So did the empty space where the missing ones had been.

Hands Choosing Vegetables

Ramlochan Jha placed his hand on the heap of eggplants, then drew it back.

The eggplant was round.

Its skin was smooth.

Its stem was green.

It was difficult to find a fault in that heap.

Even so, his fingers kept moving from one eggplant to another.

“Babuji, they are all good.”

Bindeshwar, the vegetable seller, said it.

Ramlochan did not reply.

He picked up a third eggplant.

He turned it over to look at the underside.

There was a fine white line.

He put it back.

Bindeshwar laughed.

“Will you cut off that line and eat it, or hang it in a frame?”

Ramlochan looked at him over the top of his spectacles.

“The blemish may spread.”

“The eggplant will not grow old before it reaches your house.”

A faint smile touched Ramlochan’s lips, but his hand was still among the pile.

It was Saturday morning.

Water had been sprinkled over the old market in Laheriasarai.

Earth, coriander, green chillies and wet sacking mingled into a familiar smell.

For the last twenty-seven years, Ramlochan had bought vegetables at about this time.

Earlier, before leaving for work.

Now, after retirement, without any hurry.

Yet his method had not changed.

Potatoes of wildly different sizes did not go together.

Tomatoes must not be too soft.

The skin of pointed gourds must not be yellow.

Ridge gourds must be straight.

The leaves around a cauliflower must be fresh.
Mud might cling to the roots of coriander, but its leaves must not be wilted.

At home his wife, Malati, would say—

“Are you buying vegetables or choosing a bride?”

Ramlochan would reply—

“If I am paying money, I will bring home good produce.”

That sentence would end the argument.

Today too his shopping bag stood beside the counter.

Malati had made the list the night before.

Potatoes—one kilogram.

Eggplants—half a kilogram.

Pointed gourds—half a kilogram.

Tomatoes—four hundred grams.

Coriander—a small handful.

At the bottom, in smaller letters, she had written—

“No pumpkin. Half of the last one turned out bad.”

Ramlochan had read the list twice.

On reaching the market, he began with the potatoes.

Choosing potatoes required no thought.

Firm.

No sprouts.

No cuts.

Not too large.

His hand knew the rules.

It was as though those rules had settled into his palm.

The rules for eggplants were a little more difficult.

Meanwhile Bindeshwar called to his son, Raju.

“Put that crooked bottle gourd aside.”

Raju pulled a long bottle gourd from behind the heap.

It curved in the middle like a bow.

There was a fine scratch along one side.

Ramlochan’s eyes stopped there.

“Is it bad?”

he asked.

Bindeshwar took the bottle gourd in his hand.

He pressed beside the scratch with his thumbnail.

“Why would it be bad? It’s tender.”

“Then why put it aside?”

“This one will go home.”

“You won’t sell it?”

“Who will take it?”
Ramlochan looked again at the eggplants.
“If it is good, someone will take it.”
Bindeshwar laughed.
“Being good and being chosen are not the same thing, Babuji.”
The sentence was spoken in an ordinary tone.
There was no lesson in it.
Bindeshwar immediately turned to another customer.
But Ramlochan’s hand stopped on an eggplant.
Being good and being chosen.
Two different things.
Why had such a simple distinction never seemed obvious to him?
He put one gleaming eggplant into his bag.
He picked up another.
Then he looked again at the crooked bottle gourd.
It was now lying beside Raju.
Raju had set it on a sack and was sorting coriander.
Ramlochan opened his list.
No pumpkin.
Bottle gourd was not on the list at all.
He folded the list and put it in his pocket.
Half a kilogram of eggplants was weighed out.
The pointed gourds were sold at another stall.
As he moved that way, Bindeshwar’s sentence rose again in his mind.
Being good and being chosen.
He remembered his father.
The memory had nothing at all to do with vegetables.
Yet it came.
The day his matriculation results were announced.
Ramlochan was sixteen.
He liked drawing.
The steps beside the pond behind the school.
A horse at the fair.
Bamboo bending in the rain.
Again and again he drew lines in the margins of his notebooks.
On the evening the results came, his father had said—
“You are good at arithmetic. You will study commerce.”
Ramlochan had asked—
“Art?”
His father had replied—
“Will drawing pictures run a household?”

There had been no discussion after that.

For years Ramlochan had narrated the episode as though it had been his own decision.

“I chose commerce.”

How many times?

In job interviews.

At his son’s school.

Among friends.

Even at his retirement function.

“I was always interested in accounts.”

Today, standing before a heap of pointed gourds, Ramlochan saw a blank space inside that sentence for the first time.

Interest?

Or the road that had been available?

He picked up a pointed gourd.

He pressed it from both ends.

It was firm.

He put it into the bag.

The next pointed gourd had a yellow patch.

He left it.

The third was crooked.

He left that too.

His hand continued its work according to rule.

His mind went backward.

A job after college.

There had been an opportunity with a private company in Patna.

An acquaintance of his maternal uncle had sent word.

The salary was higher.

The work uncertain.

His father had said—

“Sit for the government examination.”

Ramlochan had done so.

He was selected.

He kept saying—

“I chose stability.”

Was that true?

Or had his father chosen stability, and had he accepted it?

The answer was not simple.

He had not disliked government service.

The salary came on time.

A house was built.

The children were educated.
 His mother received treatment.
 Many good things had come by that road.
 So the question was not whether the road had been wrong.
 The question was whose road it had been.
 Ramlochan's hand stopped with a pointed gourd half lifted.
 The seller asked —
 "How much?"
 "Half a kilogram."
 "Choose them."
 "Yes."
 He began choosing again.
 Voices were rising all around the market.
 "Ten rupees a quarter kilo!"
 "Fresh green peas!"
 "Coriander! Take coriander!"
 A child was holding his mother's bag.
 He pulled the most crooked okra from a heap and laughed.
 His mother took it from his hand and put it back.
 "Not this one. Choose a good one."
 Ramlochan's gaze settled on the child's hand.
 The small fingers went back into the pile.
 This time he picked up a straight okra.
 The mother nodded.
 The child put the straight okra into the bag.
 Ramlochan did not discover any profound secret.
 Only a small, familiar act.
 First learn the rule.
 Then the hand itself becomes the rule.
 He looked at his own hands.
 Trimmed nails.
 Fine lines of age over the knuckles.
 The right index finger slightly bent.
 With these hands he had signed so many files.
 On so many applications he had written, 'Approved.'
 On so many others, 'Not in accordance with rules.'
 People had thought of him as an officer who made decisions.
 So had he.
 But in his private life?
 Marriage.
 His maternal uncle had brought Malati's photograph.

The family had agreed.
Ramlochan had asked—
“Is the girl educated?”
The answer had come—
“Up to Class Twelve.”
He had said—
“All right.”
Later he had kept calling that “all right” his own choice.
Malati had not been a bad wife.
On the contrary, she had been the steadiest companionship of his life.
Then the same question again.
Does a good outcome prove that there was a choice?
Or only that there was an outcome?
Ramlochan suddenly laughed.
The pointed-gourd seller looked at him.
“What happened?”
“Nothing.”
“Found a bad one?”
“No.”
He paid.
The tomato stall was ahead.
Here he usually did not choose them himself.
The shopkeeper, Sushila, knew him.
“Babu, four hundred grams?”
“Yes.”
“Firm ones?”
Ramlochan asked, almost without meaning to—
“Do I always take only the firm ones?”
Sushila laughed.
“You send them back the moment you see they are soft.”
“For how many years?”
“Do I have time to keep accounts of that?”
“An estimate?”
“Since your moustache was black.”
Sushila picked up four tomatoes.
Two red.
One half red.
One small.
Ramlochan pointed to the small tomato.
“Why this one?”
“To make four hundred grams.”

“I used to leave those.”
 “That is why I put one in today.”
 “Why?”
 “Because it isn’t bad. It is only small.”
 Ramlochan took the tomato in his hand.
 Small.
 Round.
 A leaf-mark at the top.
 The old impulse to hand it back arose.
 His hand even lifted slightly.
 Then stopped.
 “Let it stay.”
 Sushila said nothing.
 The tomato went into the paper bag.
 Ramlochan moved on.
 His pace had slowed.
 The crowd streamed past him.
 A young man walked by speaking into his phone—
 “I have decided.”
 The four words reached his ears and Ramlochan went backward again.
 His son, Amresh.
 Class Twelve.
 He had said—
 “I want to study history.”
 Ramlochan had replied—
 “What will you do after studying history?”
 Amresh had fallen silent.
 Ramlochan had begun listing alternatives.
 Economics.
 Commerce.
 Bank examinations.
 “The final decision is yours,” he had said.
 But afterward he had given so many arguments that there was no space
 left for a ‘final decision.’
 Amresh studied commerce.
 He took a job in a bank.
 Now he lived in Pune.
 Ramlochan would tell everyone—
 “My son chose banking on his own.”
 Today the sentence sounded hollow inside.
 He remembered Amresh’s face.

Seventeen years old.
 The face from that time.
 His eyes bright when he said history.
 Then slowly becoming expressionless.
 Ramlochan pulled the strap of his bag higher onto his shoulder.
 The first impulse in his mind was—
 Call him.
 Say—
 “You wanted to study history, didn’t you?”
 Then that impulse too seemed hasty.
 A thirty-year-old question could not be answered by today’s remorse.
 Was Amresh unhappy in the bank, or content?
 Ramlochan did not really know.
 Had he ever asked?
 “How is work going?”
 He had asked that.
 “Do you like the work?”
 That was harder to say.
 He stopped at the coriander stall.
 A little girl was tying bunches of coriander with the roots still on.
 She asked—
 “How much?”
 Ramlochan said—
 “A small handful.”
 The girl closed her fist around a bunch.
 Ramlochan’s gaze fell on that fist.
 A small hand.
 About the size of a decision.
 Then he remembered his granddaughter, Ira.
 Two days earlier she had said on the phone screen—
 “Dadu, I can’t decide whether to study design or biology.”
 Ramlochan had immediately said—
 “There are more opportunities in biology.”
 Ira had said—
 “But—”
 The phone audio had broken off halfway.
 The conversation had ended there.
 At the time Ramlochan had thought—children need direction.
 Today, for the first time, he understood that direction and choice were
 not the same thing.
 The coriander girl put the handful on the scale.

“Too much?”

Ramlochan looked at the scale.

“Let it be.”

The girl wrapped the coriander in paper.

Ramlochan paid.

The list was complete.

Normally he would have gone straight home from there.

But today his feet took him back toward Bindeshwar’s stall.

The crooked bottle gourd was still lying on the sack.

Raju had placed two small pumpkins beside it.

Ramlochan stopped.

Bindeshwar was settling an account with a customer.

“What have you forgotten now, Babuji?”

“Nothing.”

“Then?”

Ramlochan looked at the bottle gourd.

“How much for this?”

Bindeshwar looked up.

“This one?”

“Yes.”

“This is the one I kept for home.”

“Sell it.”

“You will take it?”

Reasons immediately began forming inside Ramlochan.

It is tender.

It will be cheap.

It will make a vegetable dish.

Malati likes bottle gourd.

But bottle gourd was not on the list.

And whether Malati particularly liked bottle gourd—he was not even sure.

Again the reasons were being arranged for someone else’s convenience.

He remained silent.

Bindeshwar asked—

“Why do you want it?”

Ramlochan stopped at that simple question.

“Why?”

“Yes. It wasn’t on your list, was it?”

Bindeshwar had seen the paper in his hand.

Ramlochan looked at the curve of the bottle gourd.

The scratch across its middle.

The green stem at the top.
He did not find it especially beautiful.
There was no proof it would be especially tasty either.
He had simply stopped when he saw it.
That was all.
“I felt like taking it.”
He said it softly.
Bindeshwar looked at him for a few moments.
Then he laughed.
“That is reason enough.”
Raju weighed the bottle gourd.
Bindeshwar charged the ordinary price.
No discount.
No reward.
The bottle gourd would not fit inside the bag.
Half of it stuck out.
Ramlochan thought his bag looked ridiculous.
He set off.
On the road, two people noticed the gourd’s curve.
Neither cared.
Only one child said—
“Look, a bow!”
Ramlochan laughed.
When he reached home, Malati was sitting in the veranda shelling peas.
“So late?”
“There was a crowd.”
Ramlochan set down the bag.
Malati began taking things out one by one.
Potatoes.
Eggplants.
Pointed gourds.
Tomatoes.
Coriander.
Then the crooked bottle gourd.
Malati’s hand stopped.
“Was this on the list?”
“No.”
“Did Bindeshwar palm it off on you?”
The old answers tried to come out of Ramlochan’s mouth—
It was good.
It was cheap.

It was tender.
But he stopped them.
“I bought it.”
“I can see that. Why?”
At that question, the morning market opened again inside him.
The heap of eggplants.
The crooked bottle gourd.
Bindeshwar’s sentence.
The child’s straight okra.
The small tomato.
Amresh wanting to study history.
Ira’s unfinished ‘but.’
Ramlochan held the bottle gourd by its stem and placed it on the table.
“I felt like it.”
Malati kept looking at him.
“That’s all?”
“That’s all.”
Malati laughed.
“A new illness at fifty-seven?”
Ramlochan laughed too.
“Possibly.”
“How will I cut it? It bends in the middle.”
“Cut it in two at the bend.”
“Does that make a straight bottle gourd bad?”
“No.”
“Then?”
Ramlochan began searching for an answer.
Then stopped searching.
“A straight one is good too. So is this one.”
Malati shook her head.
“It seems a great deal of thinking went into today’s vegetables.”
“Too much.”
Malati picked up the bottle gourd and went toward the kitchen.
Ramlochan sat in the veranda.
He took out his phone.
Amresh’s name was on the screen.
His finger rested on the call icon.
He did not call at once.
First he thought—what will I say?
“Did I stop you from studying history?”
That sounded like an attempt to lighten his own guilt.

“Do you like your job?”
 That sounded like a question asked thirty years too late.
 In the end he wrote only a message—
 “If you have time this evening, call me. I want to ask you something.”
 He sent it.
 Then he opened Ira’s name.
 For a long time he did not write anything.
 Then he typed—
 “What is it in design and in biology that draws you toward each of them?
 We can look at the list of opportunities afterward. Write this to me first.”
 He read the message.
 He wanted to improve it.
 Should he remove “opportunities”?
 Was “draws you” right?
 Was the question too large?
 For the first time, he did not try to make the message perfect.
 He sent it.
 From the kitchen came the sound of a knife.
 Thock.
 Thock.
 Then a pause.
 Malati called—
 “Ramlochan!”
 “Yes?”
 “This bottle gourd is perfectly good inside.”
 From the veranda Ramlochan answered—
 “It turned out good. That’s fine.”
 Malati called again—
 “And if it hadn’t?”
 Ramlochan fell silent.
 The Ramlochan of that morning would have answered at once—
 Then it was a mistake.
 Money wasted.
 Be more careful next time.
 Now he went into the kitchen.
 Malati had cut the bottle gourd in two.
 The crooked place had been cut exactly through the middle.
 Inside, the flesh was white and tender.
 The seeds were small.
 Malati held one half toward him.
 “Look.”

Ramlochan looked.

Then said—

“If it had been bad, it would simply have been bad.”

“And the choice?”

“It would still have been mine.”

Malati stopped the knife and looked at him.

After a few moments she smiled.

“Who was selling philosophy in the market?”

“The bottle-gourd seller.”

“How much did he charge?”

“Full price.”

“Then the philosophy came free.”

They both laughed.

When the laughter ended, Ramlochan remained seated on the kitchen stool.

Malati went on cutting the bottle gourd.

The slices were not coming out round.

Sometimes a half-moon.

Sometimes a triangle.

Sometimes thick.

Malati said—

“Look at this. Not one slice is like the next.”

Ramlochan reached out and picked up a piece.

“Put it down, don’t eat it raw.”

He put it back.

The phone rang.

Amresh.

Ramlochan answered the phone.

“Yes, son.”

“I saw your message. Is everything all right?”

“Yes.”

“What did you want to ask?”

Ramlochan looked toward the veranda.

The small tomato was still in the bag.

“Do you like your work at the bank?”

He asked it directly.

There was silence at the other end.

Another sentence immediately rose inside Ramlochan—

“If you don’t like it, leave it.”

He did not say it.

Amresh said slowly—

"Some days I do. Some days I don't. Why?"

"That's all I wanted to know."

"Today?"

"Yes, today."

Amresh laughed.

"Have you started conducting surveys after retirement?"

Ramlochan laughed too.

"Possibly."

Then he said—

"One more thing. You wanted to study history, didn't you?"

There was silence again at the other end.

This time it lasted longer.

Ramlochan waited.

Amresh said—

"I did."

"And now?"

"I still read it. On Sundays."

Ramlochan was startled.

"What?"

"Whatever I find. Books. Lectures. Articles on old coins."

Ramlochan's eyes moved to the small tomato lying beside the bag.

"You never told me."

"You never asked."

The sentence was not spoken harshly.

That made it sound even clearer.

Ramlochan did not reply.

Amresh said on his own—

"Babu, I am not unhappy in my bank job."

"I didn't ask that."

"I know."

"I used to think..."

Ramlochan stopped.

To say 'I took away your choice' seemed too simple.

Life had not been that simple.

Amresh too had been seventeen then.

There had been family circumstances.

There had been money.

There had been fear.

And there had also been history.

He said—

“I used to think the decision was yours. Now I understand that I talked a great deal.”

Amresh did not laugh.

After a few moments he said—

“Yes. A great deal.”

Ramlochan laughed too.

“All right.”

“You called just to say that?”

“No. To listen.”

Silence again at the other end.

Then Amresh began telling him an ordinary story from the bank.

A customer’s signature had not matched.

An old account.

Two applications.

Ramlochan kept listening.

Earlier he would have suggested a solution.

Today he did not.

After he ended the call, the bottle gourd began sizzling in seasoning in the kitchen.

Its fragrance reached the veranda.

Ira’s reply arrived.

A long message.

In design, she liked form, lettering and the use of objects.

In biology, living systems.

She had written—

“Dadu, the problem is that I like both.”

Ramlochan smiled as he read it.

Earlier his mind would immediately have begun comparing—

Jobs.

Fees.

Cities.

Competition.

Those questions had not disappeared today either.

But he did not turn them immediately into an answer.

He wrote—

“If you like both, then the next question may be—which kind of difficulty are you willing to live with?”

He paused before sending the message.

This too was direction.

Advice.

His own influence.

Does choice ever happen without influence?
 That was difficult to say.
 He added one line to the message—
 “My question is only a question too; you must make the answer.”
 Then he sent it.
 In the evening Malati served the bottle-gourd curry.
 Ramlochan took the first bite.
 The taste was ordinary.
 Not especially sweet.
 Nothing remarkable.
 A little too much cumin.
 He laughed.
 Malati asked—
 “What?”
 “Nothing.”
 “Did the bottle gourd turn out magnificent?”
 “Ordinary.”
 “Then disappointed?”
 Ramlochan broke a piece on his plate with his spoon.
 “No.”
 “After so much thought, only ordinary?”
 “That is all right.”
 Malati kept looking at him.
 Ramlochan resumed eating.
 At night, while emptying the shopping bag, they found the small tomato.
 Malati picked it up.
 “Did you choose this?”
 Ramlochan remembered Sushila.
 “No.”
 “Then?”
 “She put it in. I didn’t take it out.”
 Malati laughed.
 “Where is the choice in that?”
 Ramlochan took the tomato.
 He rolled it in his palm.
 “Sometimes not removing something is a choice too.”
 “And sometimes it is laziness.”
 “That too.”
 Malati put the tomato back in the bag.
 “It will go into chutney tomorrow.”
 Ramlochan came and sat in the veranda.

The market list lay on the table.
Malati's handwriting at the top.
Below it, small ticks in his pencil.
A mark beside every item.

Potatoes.

Eggplants.

Pointed gourds.

Tomatoes.

Coriander.

At the bottom, "No pumpkin."

Ramlochan felt like writing in the empty margin of the list—

Bottle gourd.

Then he did not.

The list had completed its work for the day.

He turned it over.

On the blank side he wrote two words—

"My wish."

As soon as he wrote them, the phrase seemed ridiculous.

He picked up the pencil to strike it out.

Then set the pencil down.

He folded the paper.

He did not throw it away.

Nor did he put it in his pocket.

He left it on the table.

The next morning Malati picked up the paper and moved toward the wastebasket.

She saw the two words written on the back.

"What is this?"

Ramlochan had opened the newspaper.

"Nothing."

"My wish?"

Ramlochan looked over the top of the newspaper.

Malati was laughing.

"Shall I put that on the list next time too?"

Ramlochan said—

"No."

"Why?"

He folded the newspaper and set it aside.

"If it is written on the list, it will become another item on the list."

Malati was silent for two moments.

Then she did not throw the paper into the wastebasket.

She put it back on the table.
In the afternoon Ramlochan began putting away the market bag.
A small piece of the crooked bottle gourd's stem lay at the bottom.
He picked it up.
As before, his hand immediately moved to throw away what it had
recognized as useless.
Then he stopped.
There was no reason to keep the stem.
He looked at it.
And this time he threw it away for only one reason: its work was finished.
His hand reached the wastebasket.
The piece fell in.
Ramlochan's hand returned empty.
He was surprised—
Sometimes even an empty hand can feel like one's own.

Winter Sunlight

On winter mornings, sunlight entered the house late.

Janaki Devi knew this not by looking at the clock, but by looking at the floor.

Through the lattice of the south-facing window, a long bright strip fell inside.

At first the strip remained close to the wall.

Then it slowly slid toward the middle of the floor.

By noon it would touch the leg of the old low stool.

Janaki Devi would say, "The day has risen now."

The people of the house would laugh.

"There is a clock, Amma."

Janaki Devi would laugh too.

There was a clock.

A round clock hung on the wall, and its hands were always five minutes fast.

No one any longer asked why it was five minutes fast.

Years ago, Janaki Devi herself had set it five minutes ahead.

"It will save us from being late."

In those days there were four people in the house and four different times to keep.

Her husband's office time.

Her son's school time.

Her daughter's college time.

Her own kitchen time.

Keeping the clock five minutes fast was a way of gathering them all together.

Now everyone in the house had a clock on their phone.

No one looked at the wall clock.

Even so, it continued to run five minutes fast.

That day was Sunday.

Her granddaughter Kavya came into Janaki Devi's room carrying a box of chalk.

"Dadi, will you do something for me?"

Janaki Devi pushed her spectacles up her nose.

“At the very mention of work, one should first ask the wages.”

Kavya burst out laughing.

“The wages are two tilkuts.”

“Then tell me the work first.”

Kavya sat down on the floor.

With a piece of chalk, she drew a small line at one edge of the strip of sunlight falling through the window.

Beside the line she wrote—10:30.

“What is this?”

“School work.”

“Making the floor dirty has become school work now?”

“It is chalk. It will wipe off.”

Janaki Devi looked at the strip of sunlight.

“You want to see how far the sun moves?”

“Not the sun, Dadi.”

“You mean the earth rotates?”

Kavya brightened.

“You know everything.”

“My education did not stop in Class Five.”

“Then you can save my experiment.”

“Save it?”

Kavya looked at the clock.

“From ten-thirty until twelve, I have to mark this edge every fifteen minutes.”

“You do it.”

“I have to go upstairs and make the display chart for the project.”

“So the project will stay downstairs while its display chart gets made upstairs?”

“Dadi.”

“All right.”

Kavya handed her the chalk.

“10:45, 11:00, 11:15, 11:30, 11:45, 12:00.”

“So many times?”

“That is all.”

Janaki Devi took the chalk.

Kavya added, “Watch the edge exactly.”

“I have seen sunlight before.”

“But this time it has to be measured.”

Janaki Devi did not like that sentence.

One could look at sunlight.

One could sit and warm oneself in sunlight.

That sunlight could also be measured did not seem wrong to her; it merely seemed a little uncivilized.

Kavya went upstairs.

Janaki Devi placed the chalk on the low stool.

The 10:30 line had already moved inside the strip of sunlight.

She thought—this far in fifteen minutes?

She looked at the wall clock.

10:38.

“This clock is five minutes fast.”

She said it to herself.

So the real time was 10:33.

A faint discomfort stirred in her.

Kavya had written 10:30.

Which line was correct?

The chalk line?

The clock’s?

The phone’s?

The sun’s?

She got up and went into the sitting room.

Her daughter-in-law Manisha was shelling peas.

“What time is it on your phone?”

Manisha checked the phone.

“Ten thirty-three.”

“The clock is five minutes fast.”

“It has been for years.”

Janaki Devi returned to her room.

The strip of sunlight had shifted again.

It occurred to her that even while she went to fetch the answer to that small question, the sunlight had gone on doing its work.

At 10:45 she drew the second chalk line.

The line was farther from the first than she had expected.

“Can fifteen minutes be this long?”

The words slipped out of her mouth.

Then she laughed at her own sentence.

Fifteen minutes were not long.

Only their distance on the floor looked long.

She sat down on the low stool.

From the sitting room came the sound of peas dropping into a bowl.

Upstairs came the scrape of Kavya’s chair.

In the lane a vegetable seller called, “Cauliflower!”

Every sound inhabited its own time.
Janaki Devi placed the back of her hand in the sunlight.
The warmth did not come at once.
It came after a few moments.
She remembered—when her little boy was recovering from fever, she would place his hand in the sunlight just like this.
As soon as the memory came, she drew her hand back.
A child's fever had no place in Kavya's experiment.
She looked at the clock.

10:49.

Four minutes.
Four minutes are very short.
In four minutes milk can boil over on a stove.
In four minutes a bus can be missed.
In four minutes someone can say, "I'm coming," and step out of the house.

And four minutes spent sitting on a low stool can also become very large.
Janaki Devi got up and opened the cupboard.
From the upper shelf she took out some old woollen socks.
One pair had belonged to her husband.
The moment she saw them, she felt the urge to look at the clock again.
She shut the cupboard.
The socks remained inside.

10:56.

Four minutes still remained.
She went to the window.
On the neighbour's roof, a woman was spreading out a quilt.
The quilt's red border gleamed in the sunlight.
Janaki Devi wondered—did that woman need to know what time it was?
Perhaps she did not.
She would turn the quilt when one side grew warm.
She would know time not by a clock, but by the warmth of cloth.
At 11:00 Janaki Devi drew the third line.
This time she tried to write the numerals as neatly as Kavya would.
The first 1 came out crooked.
She rubbed it away and wrote it again.
In that much time the edge of the sunlight had moved forward once more.

Janaki Devi held the chalk suspended in the air.
"Then where is the exact place?"
Where the edge had been when she began to write?

Or where it was now?

First she made a small dot.

Then she wrote 11:00.

This method satisfied her.

The dot—the moment.

The number—the name.

She thought: by the time a moment is given a name, it has already moved on.

Was every date like this, then?

She remembered the date of her marriage.

She remembered her son's birth date.

She also remembered the day her husband died.

But who had written down all the time contained inside those dates?

Manisha came to the doorway of the room.

"Amma, shall I donate one of the old quilts?"

Janaki Devi turned.

"Which one?"

"The one with the green border."

"Not that one."

"Then the blue one?"

"Not that either."

Manisha smiled.

"Then which one are we donating?"

Before replying, Janaki Devi looked at the lines of sunlight.

"Keep them for now."

Manisha went away.

Janaki Devi felt a little ashamed of her own answer.

"Keep them for now."

For many days she had been saying those words about many things.

Old quilts.

An old brass plate from the family.

A broken low stool.

Her husband's socks.

Papers whose writing had now faded.

"Keep it for now" was as though there were a room inside time where objects could remain safe forever.

Meanwhile, the strip of sunlight had crossed all three chalk lines.

11:07.

Eight minutes.

Eight minutes suddenly felt heavy to Janaki Devi.

She went into the sitting room to shell peas.

Manisha pushed the bowl toward her.
 The two of them shelled peas without speaking.
 A pea-pod opened.
 The peas fell into a palm.
 The empty pod went into one basket.
 The full peas into another bowl.
 Manisha asked, "Why do you have to keep looking at the clock so much?"
 "Kavya's work."
 "She left you here as a watchman?"
 "My wages are two tilkuts."
 Manisha laughed.
 So did Janaki Devi.
 After a while, something suddenly occurred to her.
 "What time is it?"
 Manisha checked her phone.
 "Eleven seventeen."
 Janaki Devi dropped the peas and stood up.
 "Oh!"
 She hurried back to the room.
 11:15 had passed.
 The edge of the sunlight had already moved on.
 The chalk was in her hand.
 She stopped.
 "Should I write 11:15 here?"
 She asked herself.
 Where the sunlight stood now was the place for 11:17.
 Where was 11:15?
 Two minutes behind.
 The place where the earth had been turning two minutes ago no longer existed there.
 This small mistake troubled Janaki Devi far more than she had expected.
 While running a household, a mistake of two minutes had never troubled her this much.
 Nothing happens if food is served two minutes late.
 If a child reaches school two minutes late, he can run inside.
 If medicine is given two minutes late, the clock does not stop.
 But the thought of drawing the wrong line on Kavya's floor was unbearable to her.
 She put down the chalk.
 She left 11:15 blank.
 The blank place lay between two lines.

There was sunlight in that blank place.

Only the number was missing.

Janaki Devi sat on the low stool and kept looking at it.

From upstairs Kavya called, "Dadi, is everything all right?"

Janaki Devi called back loudly, "I missed one."

"What?"

"Fifteen minutes."

"What?"

"Nothing. Do your work."

Kavya fell silent.

Janaki Devi thought—if she estimated the place and drew the line in chalk, Kavya would never know.

The place in between could be worked out from the distance between the first three lines.

She picked up the chalk.

She measured the first distance.

She judged the second by eye.

Her hand moved forward to make a dot in the middle of the empty space.

Just then a thin cloud drifted past the window.

The strip of sunlight faded.

Within a breath it vanished.

On the floor there remained only three chalk lines and one empty interval.

Janaki Devi stopped her hand.

The room did not suddenly grow cold.

But her faith in the warmth diminished.

She looked out of the window.

A thin cloud lay across the sky.

The sun could still be seen, but milky and pale.

Janaki Devi looked at the wall clock.

11:23.

"What will I do about 11:30 now?"

She placed the chalk on the low stool.

At first she grew restless.

Kavya's work would remain incomplete.

Then she became annoyed—did Kavya have to do this experiment today of all days?

Then it seemed ridiculous to be angry at a cloud.

She rose, thinking she would shut the window.

Then she noticed—there was no sunlight, but time was still passing.

The second hand of the clock kept moving.

Upstairs, Kavya's chair scraped again.
 A bicycle bell rang in the lane.
 Manisha opened the tap to wash the peas.
 There was no strip of sunlight inside the room.
 Even so, it became 11:24.
 Janaki Devi sat down on the low stool.
 It seemed to her as though a teacher had wiped the board clean, but the lesson had not ended.
 She closed her eyes.
 Time passes in darkness too.
 Of course she had always known this.
 And yet knowing something and suddenly understanding it are not the same.
 She tried to remember a long stretch of her own life.
 Her son had gone away for work.
 During the first year after marriage, her daughter had not been able to visit often.
 Her husband had retired.
 She remembered all these events.
 But the years in between?
 In which year had she had the veranda wall painted?
 In which winter had she first sat in the sun with a blanket wrapped up to her knees?
 In which month had Manisha taken the kitchen keys into her own hands?
 There were no dates.
 Yet that time had not vanished.
 Just as 11:24 had not vanished merely because there was no line for it on the floor.
 Janaki Devi opened her eyes.
 Her own thought seemed too large to her.
 To make it smaller at once, she called to Manisha, "Will you make tea?"
 Manisha replied, "Now?"
 Janaki Devi looked at the clock.
 11:28.
 "Yes, now."
 "Before lunch?"
 "Since when did tea become the enemy of lunch?"
 Manisha laughed.
 The tea came.
 At 11:30 the cloud was still there.

Janaki Devi did not draw a line.
 She did not even try to write 11:30 on the floor.
 Steam kept rising from the cup.
 For a few moments it was visible.
 Then it disappeared.
 “Does this measure time too?” she wondered.
 She smiled.
 At 11:36 the sun became clear again.
 The strip of sunlight suddenly reappeared on the floor.
 Not where it had been before.
 It had gone far ahead.
 Something seemed to drop inside Janaki Devi.
 The interval during which the sunlight had disappeared had become a
 leap on the floor.
 She rose and went to the edge of the strip.
 The chalk line for 11:00 lay far behind.
 No 11:15.
 No 11:30.
 In front of her, only the present edge.
 She could have written 11:36 if she wished.
 11:36 was not on the experiment’s list.
 She did not write it.
 She simply sat there with the chalk in her hand.
 Until 11:45 the sunlight moved slowly once more.
 During those nine minutes she felt no impatience.
 She kept watching.
 The edge crossed a fine crack in the floor.
 Then it touched the shadow of the old low stool.
 Then it slipped past one of the stool’s legs.
 At 11:45 she drew the line.
 Beside it she wrote the time.
 This time her hand did not tremble.
 Between the two lines lay a long blank stretch.
 That blank stretch held the time of the cloud.
 On Kavya’s display chart it would look ugly.
 Janaki Devi had begun to like its ugliness.
 Kavya came downstairs.
 She had a ruler and a sheet of paper in her hand.
 “Dadi, let me see.”
 She sat down on the floor.
 10:30.

10:45.

11:00.

Then blankness.

Then 11:45.

Kavya raised her eyebrows.

"11:15 and 11:30?"

Janaki Devi said, "The first one I missed."

"And the second?"

"The cloud."

Kavya looked toward the sunlight.

"But it is there now."

"It wasn't then."

Kavya set down the ruler.

"I'll draw the missing lines in between from the distances."

Janaki Devi said at once, "No."

Kavya looked at her.

Janaki Devi softened her voice.

"If it is an experiment, write what was actually observed."

"But the graph will be incomplete."

"Why incomplete? There was a cloud. That is also a result."

Kavya thought for a moment.

"Teacher will say the observation was interrupted."

"Then write that the observation was interrupted."

"You have become a scientist."

"No. I simply do not want to hide my mistake."

Kavya looked at the floor again.

"You missed 11:15?"

"Yes."

"By how many minutes?"

"Two."

Kavya burst out laughing.

"So much worry over two minutes?"

Janaki Devi kept looking at her.

"Two minutes became large when I wanted them back."

Kavya stopped laughing.

It seemed she did not fully understand the sentence, but she did not make another joke.

"12:00 is still left," she said.

"I'll do that one."

Kavya did not go upstairs.

She sat beside her grandmother.

The two of them watched the strip of sunlight.
 After a little while Kavya grew restless.
 "It moves so slowly."
 Janaki Devi said, "It is slow because you are watching it."
 "And if I don't watch?"
 "Then you will discover that it has moved."
 Kavya thought.
 "Is that a riddle?"
 "No."
 "Then what?"
 Janaki Devi did not answer.
 Kavya began measuring the distances between the old lines with the ruler.
 "Dadi, from 10:30 to 10:45 it is seven centimetres."
 "Hmm."
 "From 10:45 to 11:00 it is eight."
 "Hmm."
 "Why aren't they the same?"
 "The window, the angle, the earth—ask your science."
 "You don't know?"
 "I don't know everything."
 Kavya looked up.
 "But you say you know everything."
 "I said my education did not stop in Class Five."
 "Isn't that the same as knowing everything?"
 "No."
 Kavya laughed again.
 So did Janaki Devi.
 Just before 12:00 Manisha came and stood in the doorway.
 "Why are both of you staring at the floor?"
 Kavya said, "We are catching time."
 Manisha said, "Did you catch it?"
 Janaki Devi replied, "It escaped from two places."
 Shaking her head, Manisha walked away.
 At 12:00 Kavya herself drew the line.
 She placed the chalk exactly at the edge of the sunlight.
 Janaki Devi saw that even while the line was being drawn, the edge was moving forward.
 Kavya wrote—12:00.
 "That's all."
 She stood up.
 "Shall I wipe it now?"

Janaki Devi said at once, "No."

Kavya paused.

"Why?"

Janaki Devi searched for the answer herself.

"Let it stay for now."

"Ma will scold me."

"I'll tell her."

Kavya gathered the chalk and went upstairs.

The room grew quiet again.

The strip of sunlight had already crossed the 12:00 line.

The experiment was over.

The sunlight had no work left to do.

Janaki Devi remained seated on the low stool.

She had imagined that the moment the experiment ended, the sunlight would somehow matter less.

But the sunlight went on moving without her permission.

12:07.

12:12.

12:19.

No one was drawing lines now.

Still the edge kept moving.

Janaki Devi found a strange relief in this.

For the day to be seen, it did not have to be recorded.

If she wished, she could simply sit.

She got up and went to the bundle of quilts.

The quilt with the green border lay on top.

The blue one beneath it.

She pulled out the green-bordered quilt.

The border was worn.

The cloth in the middle was still strong.

Her son had slept under this quilt when he was small—the memory came at once.

Then she stopped herself.

Was that reason alone enough to keep the quilt?

She spread it out.

There was an old patch in one corner.

She had sewn the patch herself.

She could not say when.

Had her son been small then, or already a teenager?

Had her husband still been working, or had he retired?

Nothing was clear.

The quilt nevertheless existed.

A blurred memory did not make the object false.

She called Manisha.

“Donate the green one.”

Manisha came to the doorway.

“Really?”

“Yes.”

“Not ‘keep it for now’?”

Janaki Devi laughed.

“Not for now.”

Manisha picked up the quilt.

“And the blue one?”

“Keep that one for now.”

“All right.”

Manisha went away.

Janaki Devi thought—giving away one quilt did not make a life lighter.

Even so, for the first time a small door seemed to open inside the words
“for now.”

The strip of sunlight had by then reached the leg of the low stool.

Every day at this hour Janaki Devi shifted the stool a little so that her feet
would stay warm.

Today she did not move it.

She watched the bright edge touch the front of her slipper.

Then her toes.

Then climb over the top of her foot.

Warmth came.

She did not look at the clock.

After a while the sunlight crossed her feet and moved on.

There was no reason to stop it.

Manisha called her to lunch.

Janaki Devi stood up.

At the doorway she turned and looked at the floor once more.

The chalk lines were still there.

So were the two blank places.

Suddenly she understood—the blank places were not truly empty.

There had been a cloud there.

There had been a mistake there.

There had been tea there.

There had been peas there.

There had been her sitting there.

Only the line had not been there. That was all.

After lunch Kavya came carrying her display chart.

"Dadi, what should I write as the title?"

"What does your subject say?"

"The position of sunlight with time."

"Then write that."

Kavya wrinkled her nose.

"Too dull."

"Science is not dull."

"A title can be dull."

Janaki Devi said, "Write 'Winter Sunlight.'"

Kavya smiled.

"That is a science title?"

"If your teacher asks, tell her your grandmother gave it to you."

Kavya wrote—"Winter Sunlight."

Then she paused.

"What do I write for the two blank times?"

Janaki Devi said, "For one, write—observation missed."

"And the other?"

"Cloud."

"That's all?"

"That's all."

Kavya wrote it down.

She made two points.

At one—11:15, observation missed.

At the other—11:30, cloud.

Janaki Devi watched from a distance.

On the paper, the blank places had now acquired names.

She felt a faint dissatisfaction.

What had been blank on the floor was filled on the paper.

Kavya seemed to notice the dissatisfaction.

"What happened?"

"Nothing."

"Should I change the title?"

"No."

Kavya took the display chart and went away.

Toward evening, Manisha came to wipe the floor.

"Shall I wipe off the lines?"

Janaki Devi looked toward the window.

There was no sunlight.

Only the shadow of the lattice.

She said, "Yes."

Manisha passed the wet cloth across the floor.
 10:30 disappeared.
 10:45 disappeared.
 11:00 disappeared.
 There was nothing to wipe across the empty interval.
 11:45 disappeared.
 12:00 disappeared.
 Within moments the floor was even again.
 Janaki Devi had expected to feel sad.
 She did not.
 She looked at the wall clock.
 Five minutes fast.
 Suddenly she remembered—it had been years since she had set that clock
 five minutes ahead.
 “Manisha.”
 “Yes?”
 “Take down this clock.”
 Manisha looked surprised.
 “Is it broken?”
 “No.”
 “Then?”
 “It is five minutes fast.”
 “But you set it that way.”
 “Yes.”
 “Shall I correct it?”
 Janaki Devi looked at the clock for a few moments.
 “No. Let it stay for now.”
 Smiling, Manisha said, “For now again?”
 Janaki Devi laughed too.
 “Yes. Everything does not have to end on the same day.”
 That night Kavya brought the display chart to her grandmother’s room
 once more.
 “Look.”
 The lines on the display chart had been drawn straight with a ruler.
 Between them, two points were marked in another colour.
 Janaki Devi read—
 “11:15—observation missed.”
 “11:30—cloud.”
 Below them Kavya had written one sentence—
 “The passage of time continued even while the sunlight was not visible.”
 Janaki Devi read the sentence twice.

“Did your teacher write this?”

“I did.”

“Because I told you?”

“No.”

“You wrote it well.”

Kavya did not fold the display chart.

She carried it carefully out of the room.

Janaki Devi turned off the light.

Outside the window was a winter night.

There was no strip on the floor.

In the dark, the wall clock only ticked.

Janaki Devi kept listening to it.

The clock running five minutes fast.

The phone showing the correct time.

The sunlight that would return in the morning.

And between them, the night, for which there was no chalk line.

She pulled the blanket up around herself.

For the first time, night did not feel like empty waiting.

It was night.

That was all.

The Milk Boiled Over

In the mornings, Pramila Devi could hear the milk.

Even when her eyes were occupied with something else, her ears stayed turned toward the stove.

First came a faint rustling from the bottom of the pot.

Then the thin skin on the surface of the milk trembled lightly.

After that, the sound changed altogether.

Once that small change came, even half a minute's delay was enough for the milk to reach the rim.

Pramila Devi never needed to look at the clock.

The family teased her about this skill.

Shashidhar Babu would say, "There are three clocks in this house, but Pramila is the milk clock."

Aniruddh would laugh and say, "Mother's milk never boils over."

Sometimes Meera would say, "Ma, why don't you set an alarm on the phone?"

Pramila Devi would refuse at once.

"You don't watch milk with an alarm."

There was a quiet pride in that answer.

Meera would smile and return to her work.

Pramila Devi took that smile for agreement.

There were many things in the house that were settled without anyone asking her.

She knew whether the rice tin was running empty.

She remembered whose medicine was about to run out.

She knew where Shashidhar Babu most often left his spectacles.

She knew where the spare copy of Aniruddh's office identity card was kept.

She even knew which drawer held the small scissors from Meera's sewing box.

Knowing so many things had slowly become part of who she was.

Whenever anyone failed to find something, the same cry went up—"Ma!"

Pramila Devi answered.

Often she was already on her feet before the call had fully come.

She liked being able to make things easy for everyone.

It exhausted her too.
Both things were true at once.
On that winter morning, everything in the house was ordinary.
A thin veil of fog hung beyond the window.
Dew rested on the tulsi plant in the courtyard.
The milkman had come half an hour late.
Even so, Pramila Devi did not allow the day's sequence to fall apart.
She strained the milk.
She set some aside for tea.
She put the rest on the stove in a large pot.
She turned the flame to medium.
Then she stood beside the stove and began picking over coriander leaves.
Meera came in.
She had washed clothes in her hands.
"Ma, there's no room on the line upstairs."
Pramila Devi left the coriander and looked toward the window.
"Take down the clothes from the back line."
"They're still damp."
"Then put these on the line inside the veranda."
Meera nodded.
She went back.
The first faint sound rose from the pot of milk.
Pramila Devi listened.
Just then Shashidhar Babu called from the sitting room, "Pramila!"
She did not answer.
Shashidhar Babu called again, "Where am I supposed to write the date on this form?"
Pramila Devi closed her eyes and stood still for a moment.
Only yesterday she had told Shashidhar Babu to have Aniruddh fill out the bank form.
Shashidhar Babu had said, "It's only this much. I can do it."
And now Pramila Devi was required even for that "only this much."
"Top right corner," she called from the kitchen.
"Where?"
Pramila Devi set the coriander stems on the table.
The sound of the milk was still quiet.
She went to the sitting room.
The form was in Shashidhar Babu's hands.
The blank space for the date was plainly visible.
Pramila Devi put a finger on it.
"Here."

“This one?”

“Yes.”

She turned back.

As she reached the kitchen doorway, Aniruddh came out of his room.

“Ma, have you seen my black belt?”

Before answering, Pramila Devi looked at his waist.

He was wearing a khaki belt.

“I need the black one.”

“Why?”

“I’m wearing blue trousers today.”

“Look in the upper cupboard.”

“It isn’t there.”

Pramila Devi remembered.

Three days earlier, she had brought the belt back from the cobbler after it was repaired.

She had put it in a cloth bag.

“There’s a bag on top of the trunk in the veranda.”

“Which bag?”

Pramila Devi said nothing.

She went into the kitchen.

The surface of the milk was swelling.

She immediately lowered the flame.

The foam sank back.

Pramila Devi drew a long breath.

“That’s enough,” she said to herself.

It seemed to her that even her ears were tired today.

She picked up the coriander again.

She separated two leaves.

Just then the doorbell rang.

Meera was upstairs hanging out the clothes.

Aniruddh was looking for the belt.

Shashidhar Babu was bent over the form.

The bell rang a second time.

Pramila Devi put the coriander on the table.

She went toward the door.

A delivery man was standing outside.

“Shashidhar Jha?”

“He is inside.”

“I need his signature.”

Pramila Devi turned and called, “Shashidhar!”

There was no answer.

The delivery man looked at his watch.

“Maaji, quickly, please.”

At that moment Pramila Devi did not like the word “Maaji.”

She could not say why.

She went inside.

Shashidhar Babu was on the phone asking someone about bank interest rates.

Pramila Devi gestured with her hand.

He said, “One minute.”

One minute.

Pramila Devi returned to the door.

The delivery man kept looking at something on his phone.

The sound of the milk was now coming clearly from the kitchen.

First the faint rustle.

Then a sound like heavy breathing.

Pramila Devi heard it.

Her body recognized the sound.

But she remained standing at the door.

Shashidhar Babu came out.

“Where do I sign?”

The delivery man held out the paper.

Pramila Devi moved away.

There were only five or seven steps between there and the kitchen.

But the milk was not going to wait five or seven steps.

By the time Pramila Devi crossed the doorway, the white foam had already risen above the mouth of the pot.

She stood still for a moment.

The foam crossed the rim.

A thick stream of milk fell onto the stove.

It made a hissing sound.

The smell changed at once.

Hot milk spread across the iron surface.

A few drops fell to the floor below.

Pramila Devi reached out and turned off the flame.

That was all.

The house did not shake.

Nothing happened to anyone.

The milk had boiled over.

Meera came down the stairs.

“Oh, the milk!”

Aniruddh arrived with the belt in his hand.

Shashidhar Babu came inside after setting down the parcel envelope.
All three saw the same scene.
Pramila Devi stood in front of the stove.
Even after turning off the flame, her hand was still gripping the stove knob.

Shashidhar Babu spoke first. "It happened with you?"

The sentence was short.

There was no rebuke in his voice.

Only surprise.

That surprise lodged somewhere deep inside Pramila Devi.

"Why shouldn't it happen with me?"

Shashidhar Babu fell silent.

Pramila Devi let go of the knob.

Meera began looking for a cloth to wipe up the spill.

"Leave it," Pramila Devi said.

Meera stopped.

"First the stove—" Aniruddh began.

"It's off."

"Then shall I wipe the milk?"

"Leave it."

Pramila Devi was startled by the sound of her own voice.

She was not speaking loudly.

But there was such hardness in it that everyone stopped.

The stream of milk on the stove was slowly thinning.

A drop hung from the edge.

Then it fell.

Pramila Devi kept watching that drop.

"Mother's milk never boils over," she said softly.

Aniruddh's expression changed.

He understood that his mother was repeating his old remark.

"I only said it as a joke—"

"I know."

Pramila Devi cut him off.

"As a joke."

She pulled a stool beside the stove and sat down.

No one in the house was accustomed to seeing this.

Pramila Devi never sat down in the middle of kitchen work.

To her, sitting meant that the work was finished.

The work was still spread out before her.

Yet she remained seated.

Shashidhar Babu said, "Let it be, it's only—"

“Only?”

Pramila Devi looked at him.

Shashidhar Babu did not finish the sentence.

Whether he remembered yesterday’s “only” about the form, Pramila Devi could not tell.

She remembered it herself.

“Where do I fill in the form?”

“Where is the belt?”

“Where do I hang the clothes?”

“Who will attend to the delivery man?”

Pramila Devi did not count the sentences one by one.

She wanted to count them.

Then the very desire to count made her angrier.

Why should she have to provide all the evidence?

Why should even anger have to become an account book?

She stayed silent.

Meera said softly, “Ma, I’ll clean it.”

“Leave it.”

“The milk will dry onto it.”

“Let it dry.”

As she said this, something trembled inside Pramila Devi.

For the first time in her life, she deliberately wanted to let spilled milk dry on the stove.

There was a childish stubbornness in the wish.

She did not like that stubbornness in herself.

Even so, she did not get up.

Aniruddh slowly left the kitchen.

Shashidhar Babu remained standing there with the parcel envelope in his hand.

Meera stayed.

After a few moments, she too sat down on the floor, leaning against the other side of the stool.

Pramila Devi looked at her.

“The clothes?”

“I hung them.”

“All of them?”

“Yes.”

Both were silent.

The smell of milk now carried a burnt sweetness.

Meera said quietly, “I’ve told you many times that I can watch the milk in the morning.”

The anger rose again inside Pramila Devi.

"So now it's my fault?"

"No."

Meera answered at once.

"I'm not talking about fault."

Pramila Devi tried to read Meera's face.

There was neither sarcasm nor triumph there.

Meera kept rubbing a hand over her knee.

"I'm only saying that you never let me do it."

Pramila Devi opened her mouth to answer.

No sentence came.

Many mornings returned to her memory.

In the first month after Meera's marriage, she had wanted to do a great deal of the kitchen work.

Pramila Devi would say, "Rest first."

Then, "You have your office."

Then, "The milk catches when you handle it."

Then, "I'm used to doing it."

Now the word "used to" sounded different.

Standing in the doorway, Shashidhar Babu said, "I should have learned a few things too."

Pramila Devi shot him a sharp look.

"Learn now?"

"If you teach me."

At that answer, the direction of Pramila Devi's anger shifted for a moment.

"So I have to teach you as well?"

Shashidhar Babu looked taken aback.

Meera pressed her lips together.

Pramila Devi felt laughter trying to rise.

It did not come.

No tears came to her eyes either.

There was only tiredness.

She stood up.

She took an old cloth.

Meera stood too.

"I'll do it."

"Take two cloths."

This time Pramila Devi did not refuse.

Together they began wiping the stove.

In places the milk had dried into a thin skin.

Elsewhere it had become sticky white patches.
Meera wet the cloth.
Pramila Devi brought a scraper.
“Gently here,” she said.
“The coating will come off.”
Meera lightened her hand.
There was no reconciliation in the middle of the work.
No apology was asked for.
No grand promise was made.
Only the stove became clean again.
But a thin black ring remained on the bottom of the milk pot.
Pramila Devi tried to scrub it away.
The mark did not come off completely.
“Let it stay,” Meera said.
Instinctively Pramila Devi wanted to say, “No, it won’t look good.”
The sentence formed halfway.
She stopped.
“Let it stay.”
By afternoon, the house looked ordinary again.
Aniruddh had gone to the office.
Meera had returned to her work.
Shashidhar Babu put the bank form into an envelope.
Pramila Devi cooked lunch.
She put the dal on the stove.
She took the rice off the flame.
She checked the salt in the vegetable dish.
All the work got done.
But something unfinished kept moving inside her.
Her anger had not risen once like milk and then settled back down.
It had divided itself into separate questions.
Was it really true that she had to do everything whenever others asked?
No.
She took up many tasks before anyone asked.
Why?
Because she could not bear disorder.
Because she noticed flaws in work done by others.
Because it saved time.
Because she liked being the one everyone came looking for.
The last reason made her uncomfortable.
After lunch she sat in the veranda.
Winter sunlight lay in one corner.

Unlike Janaki Devi the day before, she had no desire to measure time.
She simply stretched out her hand and placed it in the sunlight.
In the courtyard, Meera was speaking to someone on the phone.
Shashidhar Babu was folding the newspaper.

Pramila Devi remembered that five years earlier, Meera had once scorched the milk.

That day Pramila Devi had said three times, "If you had left it to me, it wouldn't have burnt."

Meera had said nothing.

It was a small memory.

But now it pricked like a thorn.

Pramila Devi heard the voice inside herself offering a defence.

"I said it so she would learn."

Then another voice came.

"Did you?"

She could not escape the question.

In the evening Shashidhar Babu asked for tea.

"Will there be tea?"

Pramila Devi was folding clothes in the veranda.

By old habit, her body began to rise.

She stopped her feet.

"Make it."

Shashidhar Babu lifted his head from the newspaper.

"Me?"

"Yes."

Two moments of silence.

A small spark of anger flared again inside Pramila Devi—see, this man doesn't even know how to make tea.

Then she remembered that in the early years of their marriage, Shashidhar Babu used to make tea.

At the time Pramila Devi had told him, "Leave it. You put in too much tea leaf."

Gradually Shashidhar Babu had stopped making tea.

That memory did not support her side.

Pramila Devi did not like it.

Even so, it was true.

"Two cups of water," she said.

"Then?"

"One cup of milk."

"Sugar?"

"As you like."

“Tea leaves?”

“As you like.”

Shashidhar Babu burst out laughing.

“Then the tea will go wrong according to my own calculations.”

For the first time, a faint smile came to Pramila Devi’s lips.

“Let it.”

The tea really did taste different.

There was too much tea leaf.

Pramila Devi drank it.

She did not praise it.

She did not complain either.

After dinner that night, Meera was putting the kitchen in order.

Pramila Devi came in.

The stove was clean.

The milk pot with the black ring was standing upside down.

“Ma,” Meera said, “shall I put the milk on tomorrow?”

Pramila Devi’s first response was already prepared inside her—“You have a meeting in the morning.”

The sentence reached her lips.

Then stopped.

“What time is the meeting?”

“Nine-thirty.”

“The milk comes at seven.”

“Then I’ll do it.”

Pramila Devi nodded.

That night she lay awake for a long time.

Shashidhar Babu was asleep.

His breathing was regular.

Pramila Devi kept wondering what anger’s true face had been.

Was it the delivery man’s hurry?

Was it Shashidhar Babu’s “It happened with you?”

Was it Aniruddh’s belt?

Was it Meera?

Was it Pramila herself?

There was no single answer.

Anger often appears to rest on one person.

But its roots draw water from many places.

At that thought Pramila Devi laughed at herself.

Thinking about milk and ending up with roots drinking water!

She turned over.

In the morning, the milkman came on time again.

Pramila Devi opened the door as usual.
She took the packet.
She strained the milk.
Meera was still upstairs.
Her old bodily habit, without asking permission, prepared to put the milk
pot on the stove.
Pramila Devi stopped her hand.
She set the pot on the table.
She did not light the stove.
Meera came down five minutes later.
“Has the milk come?”
“It’s on the table.”
Meera picked up the pot.
She lit the stove.
She set the flame to medium.
Pramila Devi stood by the doorway.
“Not so high,” she wanted to say.
The flame really was a little high.
She stayed silent.
Meera turned the knob herself.
“This much?”
Pramila Devi said only, “Yes.”
Then she started to go outside.
From behind, Meera asked, “Where are you going?”
Pramila Devi stopped.
Until yesterday, that question would have meant: where are you going,
leaving the milk?
Today it was an ordinary question.
“To the courtyard.”
She went outside.
The winter morning sunlight had not yet fully descended.
Dew lay on the tulsi leaves.
Pramila Devi sat on the first step.
From the kitchen came the first faint sound of the milk.
Her ears became alert at once.
Her body wanted to rise.
She did not get up.
The second sound came.
Then came the clink of Meera’s movements.
The sound of the knob being turned.
The sound grew softer.

The milk did not boil over.
Along with relief, a small disappointment arose inside Pramila Devi.
She laughed at herself when she noticed it.
Had she wanted Meera to fail?
Perhaps.
It was difficult to admit.
She rested her hands on her knees.
A little later Meera called, "Ma, shall I take some out for tea?"
Pramila Devi said, "Take as much as you need."
"The cream?"
"As you like."
"Will you have tea?"
"Yes."
Pramila Devi stood up.
She came into the kitchen.
The milk was quiet in the pot.
A fine white ring had formed around the edge.
The black mark from yesterday was still on the bottom of the pot.
Meera had used the same pot.
Pramila Devi did not run a finger over the stain.
She picked up her cup.
She poured in tea.
From the sitting room Shashidhar Babu asked, "Not too little sugar, is it?"
Pramila Devi opened her mouth to answer.
Then she looked at Meera.
"Ask her," she said.
Meera burst out laughing.
Shashidhar Babu laughed too.
Pramila Devi did not laugh.
She blew on her tea and began to drink.
There really was a little less sugar in it.
She still said nothing.
Sunlight was entering through the window in a thin line.
The stove was off.
The milk had not boiled over.
Yesterday it had.
The house had gone on through both days.
Pramila Devi set the cup on the table.
Her hands were empty.
No one had yet called out asking where something was.
In that small empty interval, she placed her hands in her lap.

And for the first time, she did not feel the need to give them work at once.

Before Opening the Envelope

The moment Sudha Jha saw the envelope, she knew it held the very answer she had been waiting for for three months.

The envelope was ordinary.

Off-white paper, dulled to a greyish cast.

The college's blue seal in the upper left corner.

Beneath it, in small letters: Records Section.

At the sight of it, her right hand stopped.

The postman was only just walking out through the gate.

"Signed?" he asked, turning back.

Sudha looked at the signature she had written beside her name.

"Yes."

The postman left.

As she closed the gate, she felt that the envelope resting in her palm was somehow heavier than paper ought to be.

She went inside.

She set the envelope on the table in the sitting room.

Then immediately picked it up again.

Left on the table, it seemed as though she had spread her answer open in the middle of the house.

She put the envelope on the kitchen cupboard instead.

There stood the sugar tin, the tea leaves, and two empty bottles.

Among them, the envelope looked like something someone had put there by mistake.

Sudha put water on the stove.

Tea could be made.

Making tea required no thought.

The water heated.

The leaves went in.

The milk went in.

Sugar according to taste.

That sequence reassured her.

There was no such sequence for opening an envelope.

She could slit the edge with a knife.

She could peel the gum apart with her fingers.

There were scissors in the drawer too.

The problem was not how to open it.

The real obstacle was that once it was opened, something would become definite.

Three months earlier, that prospect had not seemed so frightening.

Then, while writing to the Records Section, she had been almost excited.

"If a copy of the admission form for the 1988-89 session is available, kindly send it."

She had written in her neatest hand.

"Especially the section concerning choice of subjects."

At the bottom she had signed her old name—Sudha Mishra.

Not the name she had used after marriage.

Writing the old name had given her a strange pleasure.

As though she were opening a narrow path back toward her eighteen-year-old self.

That day her granddaughter Ira had asked, "Nani, why did you give up music?"

Without thinking, Sudha had answered, "I didn't give it up. Babuji said music would not run a household."

She had been saying that sentence for years.

She had said it so often that its beginning and end had hardened into place.

Babuji said it.

Music would not run a household.

I studied commerce.

Later I got a job in a bank.

That was all.

A great turn in a life could fit into two sentences.

Ira had not fallen silent that day.

"Why didn't you say no to Babuji?"

Sudha had laughed.

"Daughters did not argue so much in those days."

Then Ira had asked, "Did your form say music?"

At that question, Sudha's laughter had stopped.

"It must have."

"Must have?"

"I remember."

"Then look. The old papers must be somewhere."

The old papers were not in the house.

That was when Sudha had written to the college.

She wanted to prove that her memory was right.
At least, that was what she had believed then.
Before the tea could boil over, she lowered the flame.
The envelope was still on the cupboard.
Its blue seal faced the wall, not her.
Sudha poured tea into a cup.
One cup.
Her husband Arvind had gone to the market.
He would be back by noon.
For now, the house held only Sudha and the envelope.
She carried the cup into the sitting room.
After two sips, she got up again.
She returned to the kitchen and picked up the envelope once more.
She ran her thumb along its back.
The strip of gum was smooth.
One corner had come slightly loose.
A simple pull from there would open it.
Sudha placed a finger on that corner.
She did not pull.
She brought the envelope close to her nose.
There was no smell of old paper.
Only the dry scent of newly posted paper.
She laughed.
What she had been treating as a truth thirty-five years old was sealed
inside freshly printed paper.
Sudha set the envelope beside the cup.
As she drank her tea, she turned the question around for the first time.
What if the form did say music?
Then Babuji would stand guilty.
At the thought, something inside her suddenly hardened.
She did not like the word "guilty."
Babuji had been dead for twelve years.
In his final months, he had been confined to bed.
Sudha had managed his medicines, his doctors, and the calculations for
his bank pension.
Once Babuji had said, "You're good with accounts, Sudha."
Sudha had joked, "You're the one who made me so."
Whether Babuji had laughed, she could no longer remember clearly.
Perhaps he had.
Perhaps he had only closed his eyes.
Memory was already beginning to loosen.

Sudha set the cup on the table.
 What if the form said commerce?
 That was the second question.
 It was harder than the first.
 What if her own signature stood beside the subject choice?
 What if music was not mentioned anywhere?
 What if Babuji had really only asked, "Commerce will make it easier to
 get a job, won't it?"
 And Sudha herself had turned that question into an order?
 A cold emptiness descended into her stomach.
 She picked up the envelope again.
 She ought to open it now.
 The longer she delayed, the more foolish the delay became.
 She took out the scissors.
 She opened the two blades.
 She placed them against the top of the envelope.
 At that exact moment, the phone rang.
 Sudha felt almost relieved.
 It was her younger sister, Anjana.
 "What are you doing?"
 "Nothing."
 The answer came too quickly.
 Anjana said, "Why does your voice sound like that?"
 "Like what?"
 "Like you're hiding something."
 Sudha sat down on the chair.
 The scissors lay on the table.
 The envelope rested in her lap.
 "The reply from the college has come."
 "Which reply?"
 "The old admission record."
 Anjana was silent for two moments.
 Then she laughed.
 "You really sent for it?"
 "Yes."
 "They kept papers that old?"
 "They said they would look if anything was available."
 Anjana went quiet again.
 Sudha said, "I haven't opened it."
 "Why?"
 The word was so small that it made Sudha angry.

"I just haven't."

"Then open it."

"You remember, don't you? Babuji told me to give up music."

She heard Anjana breathe at the other end of the line.

"Did he?"

Sudha sat up straight.

"What do you mean?"

"I don't remember exactly."

"You were there."

"Was I present for every conversation?"

"You were at home when I took admission."

"I was at home. Whether I was there when that conversation happened is another matter."

Sudha pressed the edge of the envelope with her nail.

"Do you remember anything?"

Anjana said slowly, "I remember this much: you had brought forms from two places. One for music, and the other wasn't exactly commerce—perhaps arts and commerce. Babuji talked about expenses."

"He didn't say, 'Music will not run a household?'"

"I have heard that sentence more often from you."

Sudha did not reply.

Anjana added at once, "That doesn't mean he never said it. I just don't remember."

"You don't remember anything."

"That is possible too."

Sudha ended the call.

She did not immediately feel ashamed of her anger.

At first, she simply felt angry.

Why had Anjana not remembered?

Some things change one member of a family's life, while another member does not remember them at all.

It felt unjust.

Then Sudha thought: perhaps, for Anjana, that event had never happened at all.

Perhaps the event had taken shape later inside Sudha.

She picked up the scissors and put them back in the drawer.

Her desire to open the envelope had not diminished.

Her fear had grown.

Holding the envelope, she went to her room.

Two old music notebooks were kept in the lower compartment of the old trunk.

One was labelled Introduction to Ragas.
 The other bore only her name.
 Sudha took them both out.
 She brushed off the dust.
 Inside the first notebook was Guruji's handwriting.
 "Yaman—ascending scale, descending scale."
 Below it, Sudha's own hand.
 For a moment she wanted to find Babuji's signature somewhere in it.
 Why?
 She herself did not know.
 As though finding one mark made by her father would allow her to hand
 the burden of the decision over to him.
 The last written page of the notebook bore the date—17 June 1988.
 Four pages after that were blank.
 That was all.
 Sudha kept looking at the date.
 College admissions had taken place in July.
 Had she stopped her music lessons before taking admission, or afterward?
 She had always believed—afterward.
 The notebook suggested—perhaps before.
 But four blank pages were not proof.
 Guruji might have been ill for a few days.
 She might have changed notebooks.
 The date might simply not have been written.
 Memory immediately found its routes of defence.
 Sudha saw it happening.
 She did not like what she saw.
 She closed the notebook.
 She laid the envelope on top of it.
 Now there were two objects before her—one that said nothing, and one
 that might say something.
 Arvind returned around noon.
 He put his shopping bag on the table.
 "Peas have become expensive."
 Sudha said, "Hmm."
 Arvind looked at her face.
 "What happened?"
 "Nothing."
 "That is not a 'nothing happened' face."
 Sudha showed him the envelope.
 Arvind read the seal.

"It came?"

"Yes."

"Did you open it?"

"No."

Arvind said casually, "Then open it."

Sudha felt the same anger she had felt with Anjana.

Why did everyone speak of opening the envelope as though they were talking about opening a gate?

She said, "Do you know what is inside?"

Taking peas out of the bag, Arvind said, "No."

"Then why is 'open it' so easy to say?"

Arvind stopped his hand.

"Because not opening it will not change what is inside."

Sudha replied at once, "I'm not afraid of what is inside."

After saying it, she realised it was true.

At least half true.

Arvind sat down on a chair.

"Then?"

Sudha took the envelope in her hand.

The answer did not come immediately.

After a while she said, "Once I open it, one of the stories I tell about myself may change."

Arvind looked at her questioningly.

Sudha repeated the sentence about Babuji.

Music will not run a household.

Arvind had heard the sentence before.

He said softly, "Yes, you say that."

"What if it didn't happen that way?"

Arvind split open a pea pod.

There were five peas inside.

"Then it didn't happen that way."

Sudha stared at him.

"You think this is a small thing?"

"No."

"Then?"

"I'm thinking."

Sudha was silent.

Arvind said, "If you have been angry with Babuji for years, and then discover that the decision was yours, that would be difficult."

Sudha looked away.

"And if the decision was Babuji's?"

“Then?”

“Then at least my memory was not wrong.”

The moment the sentence came out, Sudha startled herself.

“At least.”

What exactly was she trying to save—her music, her memory, or her anger?

Arvind went on shelling peas.

He did not offer advice.

That was one of his qualities Sudha had learned to recognise only after many years.

Sometimes he simply did not advise.

Sudha carried the envelope back to her room.

Afternoon sunlight was entering through the window.

The envelope looked white.

She thought: if there is a copy of the form inside, what will I look at first?

My signature?

The choice of subjects?

The date?

My father’s signature?

Perhaps her father’s signature would not be on the form at all.

An eighteen-year-old student would have signed for herself.

Sudha could not remember what her own signature had looked like at eighteen.

Suddenly this seemed enormously important.

The girl whose decision Sudha had described to everyone for years—Sudha could not even remember that girl’s handwriting.

She remembered the face.

Not two plaits—by then she wore one plait.

A blue salwar.

The veranda of Guruji’s house.

The black-and-white keys of the harmonium.

Babuji’s bicycle.

But the moment of decision?

Where had it happened?

In the sitting room?

In the courtyard?

In the admission queue at the college?

Whose hand had held the pen?

Sudha closed her eyes.

A scene appeared.

Babuji was folding the newspaper.

He was saying, "Music and singing are fine as a hobby."

Sudha stopped the scene.

Was that truly a memory, or an image made from a story repeated for years?

She closed her eyes again.

Another scene appeared.

Her mother was polishing a brass plate.

She was saying, "Your Babuji says choose a subject that will lead to a job."

Why had she never remembered this scene before?

Perhaps it had never happened at all.

Sudha opened her eyes.

The envelope was still closed.

For a while now, its being closed felt useful.

As long as it remained closed, both possibilities stayed alive.

Babuji could still be guilty.

Sudha could still have chosen for herself.

The two possibilities did not cancel each other; they simply stood outside the sealed paper.

For the first time Sudha understood that for three months she had not been waiting for an answer; she had been waiting for uncertainty to end.

And now that the end stood before her, she was postponing it.

At four in the afternoon Ira returned from school.

She went straight to the kitchen.

"Anything to eat?"

Sudha gave her flattened rice with curd.

As Ira sat at the table, she noticed the envelope.

"What's this?"

For a moment Sudha wanted to say—nothing.

Then she said, "It came from the college."

Ira's eyes brightened.

"That form?"

"I don't know."

"You haven't opened it?"

"No."

Ira laughed.

"Nani!"

Sudha wanted to laugh too, but no laughter came.

Ira reached out her hand.

"Shall I open it?"

Sudha pulled the envelope toward herself at once.

The movement was so quick that both of them fell silent.

Ira drew her hand back.

"All right."

Sudha said, "I have to open this myself."

"Then open it."

"Not yet."

Ira went on mixing the flattened rice into the curd.

After a while she asked, "Are you afraid?"

Sudha was ready to say "no."

Then she stopped.

"Yes."

Ira looked up.

"Of what?"

Sudha looked at the envelope.

"That something I have believed about myself for years may be wrong."

Ira thought for a moment.

"If it is wrong?"

Sudha did not answer.

Ira asked again, "You can start music again, can't you?"

"This is not about music."

"Then what?"

Sudha understood that whatever answer she gave now could become the next version of the story.

She grew careful.

"It is about whom I gave responsibility for one of my decisions."

Ira stopped her spoon.

"To Babuji?"

"Perhaps."

"And if Babuji really did stop you?"

"Then to him."

"In either case, you should open the envelope."

Sudha smiled.

"At your age, everything looks straight."

Ira immediately said, "At your age, does everything become crooked?"

This time Sudha truly laughed.

The laugh was brief, but it lasted a little while.

Ira finished eating and went to her room.

The envelope remained on the table.

Sudha did not move it.

At five o'clock, the sunlight moved off the table.

The envelope looked greyish again.

Sudha weighed it in her hand once more.

There could not be more than two or three sheets inside.
She did not hold it up to the light.
That felt like stealing.
If she was going to open it, she would open it.
If not, then not.
There was no middle way.
The thought startled her again.
Perhaps years ago she had thought in exactly the same way—music or commerce.

As though there were nothing in between.
As though studying commerce meant music had to end.
As though choosing music meant household responsibility had to end.
Perhaps the decision had never been that absolute.
Perhaps she herself had made it absolute later, so that regret would remain clean.

Clean regret is easier than muddied responsibility.
The sentence formed inside her, but she did not say it aloud.
At half past five Arvind asked for tea.
Sudha made tea.
The envelope was on the table.
This time Arvind did not even look at it.
That gave Sudha a strange relief.
She wanted no one's gaze to compel her to open it.
As she drank her tea, she placed the envelope in front of herself.
From her room, Ira could be heard humming something as she studied.
Sudha did not recognise the tune.
Suddenly she remembered the smell of Guruji's harmonium—wood, old cloth, and incense.

Was that smell truly a memory, or was it being made now?
By now she trusted her memory less.
And strangely, that mistrust was reducing her fear.
If memory was not complete evidence, why should a document be a complete judge?

The form could only show what had been written in one box on one day.
Where could that one box contain all the fear, advice, desire, hesitation, convenience, and stubbornness of that day?

Sudha caught the loosened corner of the envelope again.
This time her hand did not tremble.
She pulled gently.
The strip of gum came apart.
The paper made a small sound.

That was all.
The house did not change.
Nor did the evening.
Nor did her age.
The envelope was open.
Sudha did not immediately take out the papers inside.
She kept looking at its open mouth.
What she had kept sealed all day was now only an ordinary hollow made of paper.
Arvind said nothing.
Sudha drew out two sheets.
The first was a letter from the Records Section.
She read it.
“The individual admission forms for the 1988–89 session were damaged by damp and are not available in full.”
Sudha stopped.
She read on.
“On the basis of the available admission register, it can be certified that Ms Sudha Mishra was admitted to the Faculty of Commerce.”
The second sheet was a certified copy of the register.
Name.
Father’s name.
Date of birth.
Commerce.
That was all.
No subject-choice form.
No signature.
The word music nowhere.
No sentence spoken by Babuji.
After three months of waiting and a full day of fear, the letter said only what Sudha had already known.
She had studied commerce.
For the first time, Sudha did not laugh.
Nor did she cry.
First, an intense relief rose inside her.
So intense that the moment she noticed it, she felt ashamed.
She had wanted the form not to be found.
She had wanted the decision to remain uncertain.
That desire was itself an answer.
Arvind asked, “Did you find it?”
Sudha handed him the letter.

He read it.
“It wasn’t found.”
Sudha said, “Yes.”
Arvind gave the letter back.
“Are you disappointed?”
Sudha thought for a while.
“Relieved.”
The word was difficult to say.
Arvind only said, “Hmm.”
Sudha looked again at the certified copy.
Her name was there on the line.
Sudha Mishra.
Commerce.
That much was fact.
Everything else was story.
But calling it a “story” did not make it a lie.
Stories take shape in the empty spaces where documents do not reach.
The problem comes only when a story begins calling itself proof.
After dinner, Ira asked again, “What was in it?”
Sudha showed her the letter.
Ira read it quickly.
“So you still don’t know?”
“No.”
“Whether Babuji stopped you or not?”
Sudha opened her mouth.
The old sentence was ready.
Babuji said music would not run a household.
For years the sentence had come out without resistance.
This time it did not.
Sudha said, “I don’t remember exactly.”
Ira looked a little disappointed.
Young minds like clear answers.
Sudha added, “I remember that there was a great deal of talk about jobs at home. Babuji worried about it. I was afraid too. But whose words became whose decision—I can no longer say.”
Ira reached out to fold the letter.
Sudha said, “No, not like that.”
She folded the letter herself.
She took out the old Introduction to Ragas notebook.
For a moment she wanted to place the letter inside it.
Then she did not.

The record office letter would stay with the records.
The music notebook would stay with the music.
She put the letter back into the envelope, but did not seal it.
The envelope was open now.
What it contained was no longer a mystery.
The mystery remained outside it—Sudha's own eighteen-year-old mind.
That night, when she went to bed, Babuji's sentence returned to her.
"Music will not run a household."
This time the voice was not clear.
Sometimes it sounded like Babuji's.
Sometimes like her mother's.
Sometimes like Sudha's own.
She did not try to give the voice a face.
The next morning Ira was humming before leaving for school.
Sudha was straining tea in the kitchen.
One of Ira's notes went off-key.
Out of old habit, Sudha opened her mouth to give her the correct note.
Then she stopped.
Ira found the note again herself.
Sudha poured the tea into the cup.
The open envelope lay on the table in the sitting room.
Its mouth was still open.
Sudha did not close it.

White Hair in the Mirror

Madhavi Jha noticed her first white hair on a day when she was not looking at her face at all, but straightening the parting in her hair.

It was half past seven in the morning.

Tea was brewing in the kitchen.

On the veranda, the washed clothes were half dry, half still heavy with water.

From the room upstairs came the sound of Kavya dropping a book, while from inside Arun had called, "Where did you put my black pen?"

Madhavi stood before the mirror for two minutes.

Those two minutes could, perhaps, be called her own.

She drew the comb through her parting.

She wet the small flyaway hairs near her ears and pressed them down.

Then she saw a thin line of white gleam.

At first she thought it was a thread of sunlight falling through the window.

She turned her head a little to the right.

The line did not move.

She turned to the left.

The line was still there.

With her fingers she separated the other strands.

One hair.

White from root to tip.

A little stiffer, a little different.

"Oh," escaped Madhavi's lips on its own.

There was less fear than surprise in that "oh."

She was forty-six years old.

Whether the white hair had come late or on time was a question without much meaning.

Even so, for a moment she thought of pulling it out.

A small pair of tweezers lay beside the mirror.

She reached out her hand.

Just then a voice came from the courtyard: "Chhotki! Is the tea ready?"

It was Urmila, her elder sister-in-law.

Madhavi's hand reached the tweezers and stopped.

"It's nearly ready," she answered.

Then she looked at her face in the mirror again.

The white hair was still there.

"Chhotki."

The word had not come from inside the mirror, but from the courtyard.

Yet for the first time it struck Madhavi as strange that a forty-six-year-old woman, on whose head the first white hair had now appeared, was still "Chhotki" in this house.

She did not pick up the tweezers.

She went towards the kitchen.

Urmila was waiting for her tea.

"Chhotki, less sugar in mine," she said.

"Yes."

From inside, Arun asked again, "Listen, did you find the black pen?"

Madhavi said, "In the right-hand drawer of the table."

From upstairs Kavya called, "Ma, has my white dupatta been ironed?"

"It's on the chair."

Three voices.

Three forms of address.

Chhotki.

Listen.

Ma.

No one's mouth had formed the word "Madhavi."

It was not that the people in the house had forgotten her name.

Everyone knew it.

Whenever it had to be written on paper, it was written correctly.

On the bank account.

On the insurance papers.

In the school's register of parents.

On the application for the new electricity connection.

Madhavi Jha.

Not Madhavi Arun Jha.

Only Madhavi Jha.

On paper, the name was whole.

In speech, only now and then.

While straining the tea, she tried to remember when Arun had last called her "Madhavi."

In the first year of their marriage?

Before Kavya was born?

While introducing her to someone?

“This is my wife, Madhavi.”
She remembered that sentence.
But inside the house?
Madhavi could not remember.
She held the cup out to Urmila.
Urmila took a sip and said, “It’s just right.”
Madhavi smiled.
That small approval made her feel a little lighter.
Why, she could not tell.
In the work of the morning, she forgot the white hair.
Kavya left for college.
Arun for the office.
Urmila went to her room.
Madhavi folded the clothes, sifted flour, and answered two phone calls.
The first call was from her mother’s house.
Her sister-in-law asked, “Chhoti, are you coming on Saturday?”
Madhavi answered, “I’ll see.”
The second call was from a neighbour.
“Kavya’s mother, will I get that book I asked for yesterday?”
“Yes, I’ll send it.”
After putting down the phone, Madhavi sat for a few moments with it still in her hand.
Chhoti.
Kavya’s mother.
In her mind she said her own name: Madhavi.
The word was familiar.
Yet it felt like the opening line of an old song whose tune one remembers but has lost the practice of bringing into voice.
That afternoon she had to go to the market.
A small rubber washer for the household tap, a blue file for Kavya, and a little box for Urmila’s medicines—three things.
She changed into another cotton sari.
She stood before the mirror again.
The white hair was still there.
The sun was now at a different angle, so its shine was less visible.
Madhavi could press it down with a finger and hide it among the black strands.
She tried.
Two moments later the white hair sprang out again.
She laughed.
“You’re in an awful hurry,” she said softly.

Whether she said it to the hair or to herself, she did not decide.

At the hardware shop in the market, the shopkeeper saw her and said, "Chhotki Bhauji, what do you need?"

He was an old customer of the family.

Madhavi asked for a rubber washer.

"The size Arun Babu uses?"

"No, I unscrewed the tap and brought the old one. See."

She took the worn washer out of her bag.

The shopkeeper measured it and handed her a new one.

Madhavi paid him.

Next was the stationery shop.

The shopkeeper's young son was sitting at the counter.

He did not know Madhavi.

"Whose name is the account under?" the boy asked.

Madhavi did not understand.

"What?"

"We need a name for the old credit ledger. Babuji has told me to write down all the old customers' names again."

Madhavi opened her mouth.

The first answer was almost ready: Arun Jha.

The household credit usually ran under his name.

Then she stopped.

"Madhavi Jha," she said.

The boy wrote in the ledger: Madhavi Jha.

"Phone number?"

Madhavi gave him her number.

"That's all."

That was all.

Nothing rang out like a fanfare.

No announcement was made.

On the other side of the counter, the boy kept slipping the blue file into a paper bag.

Yet something small stirred inside Madhavi.

She thought: Why did I hear my own name so loudly?

The name is mine.

As she was leaving the shop, the boy called from behind, "Madhavi ji, your change!"

Madhavi turned at once.

She held out her hand and took the coins.

"Thank you."

Outside, for no reason, she walked slowly for a little while.

Why should hearing her own name from the mouth of a stranger feel so strange?

She tried to remember the first day of her marriage.

How many people had asked her name when she arrived at her husband's home?

Very few.

"The new bride."

"The younger daughter-in-law."

"Chhotki."

Then Kavya was born, and she became "Kavya's mother."

Time passed, forms of address changed, but where had Madhavi herself been among them?

The thought did not make her sad.

None of those forms of address was loveless.

Many times her heart had filled at the word "Ma."

There was affection in Urmila's "Chhotki."

There was the easy intimacy of married life in Arun's "Listen."

The problem was not in the words.

Perhaps the problem was only that, among all those words, the sound of the original name had become rare.

For a moment Madhavi wondered how often she herself called Arun by name.

Very rarely.

In front of Kavya: "Papa."

In front of Urmila: "He."

On the phone: "Listen."

When introducing him to someone: "Arun ji."

Inside the house, almost never "Arun."

She laughed.

So this was not her story alone.

Together, they had slowly turned one another's names into names of relationships.

The names had not vanished.

They were simply used less often.

On her way home, Madhavi passed a shop with a mirrored glass front.

For a moment she saw her reflection in the pane.

The white hair was not visible.

She did not stop.

When she reached home, Urmila looked at the medicine box and said, "Oh, Chhotki, this is very nice."

"Yes."

“How much did it cost?”

Madhavi told her the price.

Urmila took the box away.

Madhavi put the blue file on Kavya’s table.

She left the rubber washer beside the tap.

Three tasks completed.

After lunch the house grew quiet.

Urmila went to sleep.

Madhavi sat in the drawing room with a book, but her mind would not stay on the page.

“Madhavi Jha.”

The stationery-shop boy’s voice kept returning to her memory.

She closed the book.

Once more, in her mind, she said her name.

Madhavi.

Her mother had given her that name.

Her mother used to say that when Madhavi was born, the madhavi creeper behind the house had been covered in flowers.

Madhavi had loved that story as a child.

Even after her marriage, her mother would sometimes say on the phone, “Madhavi, listen.”

Her mother had been dead for seven years.

It suddenly struck Madhavi that after her mother’s death, there was almost no one left who regularly spoke her name aloud.

She closed her eyes.

Her mother’s voice was no longer very clear in memory.

But the three syllables of the name were clear.

Ma-dha-vi.

She did not become emotional at once.

No tears came to her eyes.

Instead, she felt a faint urge to laugh.

A name is such an ordinary thing.

And yet how long it can take a person to notice when it has stopped being used.

Kavya returned in the evening.

Seeing the file, she said, “Ma, this is exactly the one I needed.”

Madhavi asked, “Do you like my name?”

Kavya stopped in the middle of taking off her shoes.

“What?”

“My name. Madhavi.”

Kavya burst out laughing.

“Why are you asking like this all of a sudden?”

“I just asked.”

Kavya thought for a moment.

“It’s nice. A little old-fashioned, but nice.”

“Old-fashioned?”

“I mean... it’s not a name from my generation.”

“Oh.”

Kavya started upstairs, then turned back and asked, “Ma, did you have a pet name at home?”

Madhavi thought.

“At my mother’s house they called me ‘Madhu.’”

“Wow. Madhu!”

Kavya deliberately drew it out: “Ma-dhu!”

Madhavi laughed.

“Go on, do your work.”

Kavya went upstairs.

Madhavi thought again: after how many years had she heard the name “Madhu”?

There was no way to count.

Arun came home in the evening.

Taking off his shoes, he said, “Listen, will you give me some water?”

Madhavi gave him water.

After one sip Arun asked, “What happened? Why are you looking at me like that?”

“Nothing.”

“There is something.”

Madhavi smiled.

“What is my name?”

Arun lowered the glass from his mouth.

“What?”

“My name.”

“What kind of question is that?”

“Answer it.”

Arun laughed.

“Madhavi Jha.”

“When was the last time you called me by my name?”

Arun’s laughter faded a little.

He began to think.

“I... I do call you by name.”

“When?”

“Oh, I do.”

“Remember one time.”

Arun put the glass on the table.

“Is this some kind of test?”

“No.”

“Then?”

Madhavi said, “I found my first white hair.”

Arun’s face took on an expression as though the question had now become even harder to answer.

“Oh. What does that have to do with your name?”

“I don’t know either.”

A brief silence settled between them.

Arun tried to look at Madhavi’s head.

“Where?”

Madhavi made no immediate attempt to hide it.

“Here.”

With a finger she pointed to the right edge of her parting.

Arun came closer.

“Only one?”

“Only one so far.”

“Shall I pull it out?”

Madhavi laughed.

“No.”

Arun laughed again.

“All right. Let it stay.”

He began to turn away.

Madhavi called, “Arun.”

Arun stopped.

For a moment their eyes rested on each other.

First surprise, then laughter appeared on Arun’s face.

“Had you forgotten my name too?”

Madhavi said, “No. I had stopped using it.”

Arun pulled a low stool towards him and sat down.

“True.”

“I usually call you Kavya’s papa.”

“And I call you ‘Listen.’”

“Urmila Didi calls me Chhotki.”

“Kavya calls you Ma.”

Arun said, “So now what?”

Madhavi thought before answering.

She did not want to make a rule out of it.

“Nothing. Just say my name sometimes.”

Putting on a solemn expression, Arun said, "Very well, Madhavi ji."
 Madhavi glared at him.
 "Drop the ji."
 "All right, Madhavi."
 The word sounded slightly unnatural inside the house.
 Like a new object placed in an old room.
 Madhavi laughed.
 Arun laughed too.
 "And you?" he asked.
 Madhavi said, "Arun."
 This time the word sounded less unnatural.
 At dinner Urmila asked, "Chhotki, what will you cook tomorrow?"
 Madhavi answered naturally, "There's ridge gourd."
 She did not say, "Call me Madhavi."
 She had understood that freedom did not mean erasing every old form of address.
 In "Chhotki" there was one of her lives.
 In "Ma," another.
 In "Bhauji," a third.
 She only needed to know that beneath them all, the original name was still alive.
 After dinner Kavya suddenly looked towards her head.
 "Ma!"
 "What?"
 "Your white hair!"
 Madhavi laughed.
 "Yes, I saw it."
 Kavya got up and came closer.
 "There's only one. Shall I pull it out?"
 Madhavi's hand went involuntarily towards her head.
 She remembered the tweezers from the morning.
 "No."
 "Why?"
 "Let it stay."
 "Will you colour it?"
 "Not yet."
 Kavya shrugged and went away.
 The question was over.
 Madhavi liked that no grand declaration had been necessary.
 At night she stood before the mirror again.
 The white hair was clearly visible now.

As before, she could have read it as information about her age.
 Forty-six.
 Forty-seven a year from now.
 Then forty-eight.
 The calculation was easy.
 But now the hair seemed to her less like a number than like a voice.
 Not a voice calling anyone.
 A small sign saying: your body is not older than all your relationships, but
 it is certainly separate from them.
 You are not only Chhotki.
 Not only Ma.
 Not only someone's wife.
 Not only someone's sister.
 Madhavi.
 She did not turn the thought into a sentence aloud.
 To say it would have made it too large.
 She simply picked up the comb.
 She straightened her parting.
 The white hair remained where it was.
 She did not try to press it down among the black strands.
 The next morning, nothing in life looked visibly different.
 Tea was made.
 Kavya woke late.
 Urmila said, "Chhotki, has the newspaper come?"
 Madhavi said, "It's by the gate."
 Arun could not find the black pen again.
 Madhavi smiled.
 "Look in the drawer."
 Arun opened the drawer.
 The pen was there.
 Just then his phone rang.
 He looked at the screen.
 "Unknown number," he said.
 He answered the phone.
 "Hello?"
 The voice at the other end asked something.
 Arun looked towards Madhavi.
 For a moment the old form of address rose to his lips—"Listen..."
 He stopped.
 Then he said, "Madhavi, the phone is for you."
 Madhavi turned in from the veranda.

The morning sunlight fell across her head.

The white hair gleamed for a moment.

She reached out to take the phone.

This time, hearing her own name did not make her feel that someone else was being called.

The Empty Bowl

Anshu was nine years old, and he was very fond of his steel bowl with the blue rim.

There were four bowls in the house of almost the same size, but he could recognize his own from a distance.

A thin blue ring ran around its rim, chipped away in three places.

Anshu said those three white patches were his bowl's "teeth."

His mother, Sarita, would laugh.

"Bowls don't have teeth."

"Then what are these?"

"The paint has chipped off."

Anshu could never quite accept that.

He liked giving things names in his own way.

On Friday evening, that bowl held his rice, red-lentil dal, and fried potatoes.

He had come back from playing and was ravenously hungry.

When his mother served him dal the first time, he ate quickly.

The second time, he pushed the bowl forward himself.

"More dal?"

"A little."

"Rice?"

Anshu placed a hand on his stomach and considered.

"One spoonful."

Sarita gave him one spoonful of rice.

Grandmother Janaki Devi said, "He says one spoonful, then he'll finish all the potatoes."

Anshu smiled.

He did, in fact, pick up two more pieces of potato.

His father Naresh sat opposite him.

He had returned after working all day with a mason, but instead of the usual tiredness on his face there was a look of waiting.

Again and again he checked his phone.

Sarita asked, "Did it come?"

Naresh shook his head.

Anshu understood that some message had probably not arrived.
He went back to mixing dal into his rice.
Such exchanges happened many times a day among the grown-ups.

“Did it come?”

“No.”

“What did he say?”

“By Monday.”

“We’ll see.”

To Anshu, these sentences carried no particular meaning.

In his world, many things happened later.

His school shoes would be bought next month.

New coloured pencils on Sunday.

The fair next week.

His father’s wages on Monday.

“Later” seemed to him like a large room in time where all unfinished things lay safely stored.

By the time he finished eating, his stomach was full.

At the bottom of the bowl he saw a thin yellow trail of dal.

A single grain of rice clung to the rim.

He picked it up with his finger and ate it.

Grandmother was finishing her meal slowly.

Naresh got up to wash his hands.

Sarita sat beside the stove eating the last two mouthfuls from her plate.

Anshu turned the bowl upside down and tapped it on the table—tak, tak.

The blue rim rang against the metal table.

“Don’t play the drum,” Sarita said.

Anshu tapped it once more, more softly.

Then he picked up the bowl.

“Shall I wash it?”

“Yes.”

He liked this chore because a small bowl was easy to wash.

At the tap outside the kitchen, he filled the bowl with water.

The pale yellow tint of the dal swirled through the water and disappeared.

He scrubbed the bowl with ash until it shone.

Then he turned it upside down and set it on the ledge by the tap.

He thought he would now go outside and finish the remaining round of marbles with Sumit.

Just then Sarita called, “Anshu, bring that bowl here.”

“I’ve just washed it.”

“It needs to be washed.”

Anshu carried the bowl inside.

Sarita had pulled the rice tin towards her.
The tin was old.
There was a small round dent in the middle of its lid.
Anshu had often tried to sit on that lid, but his mother had stopped him.
Today the lid lay on the floor.
Inside the tin, the rice lay very low.
Sarita took Anshu's bowl.
"What for?"
"To measure."
"What?"
"Rice."
Anshu became curious.
Sarita lowered the bowl into the tin.
The grains rasped against the metal.
She brought the bowl up full.
With her palm she levelled the rice.
Then she emptied it into an old plate.
"One," she said.
Until then, Anshu thought this was a game.
Sarita filled the bowl again.
"Two."
A third time.
"Three."
The fourth time, the bowl would not fill completely.
To gather the rice from the bottom, Sarita tilted the tin slightly.
The grains collected on one side.
The bowl filled a little more than halfway.
Sarita kept looking at it.
Grandmother had come over too.
"How much?"
"Three bowls and a little more than half."
Naresh came in, wiping his hands.
"Is there maize flour?"
"Enough for two meals."
"Flattened rice?"
"Enough for one meal."
"Dal?"
"There's masoor. Not much arhar."
Anshu listened to this inventory.
A moment ago his bowl had simply been his bowl.
Now it was measuring something that belonged to the whole household.

Sarita poured the rice from all three full bowls back into the tin.
 Then the half bowl too.
 One or two grains remained on the plate.
 Anshu began picking them up.
 Sarita did not stop him.
 He dropped the grains back into the tin.
 "Is this all the rice there is?" he asked.
 "Yes."
 "Where is the rest?"
 "This is all."
 Anshu peered into the tin.
 The empty part was much larger than the rice.
 He must have seen it before as well.
 But earlier he had thought of the empty part simply as part of the tin.
 Today, for the first time, it looked like an emptiness.
 Naresh said, "I'll speak to the contractor again tomorrow."
 "He said Monday," Sarita said.
 "Tomorrow is Saturday. It would help if he gave something."
 Grandmother said, "I don't need rice at night. Roti will do."
 "Not like that," Sarita said at once.
 "I'm saying it will do for me."
 "Whatever is cooked will be for everyone."
 Anshu looked at Naresh's face.
 "Will the money come on Monday?"
 Naresh looked at him.
 "That's what we've been told now."
 "Then will we buy rice tomorrow?"
 Before Naresh could answer, Sarita said, "Tomorrow we'll manage with what we have."
 "There's rice at the shop, isn't there?"
 "There is."
 "Then why don't we buy it?"
 To Anshu, the question was perfectly straightforward.
 If the thing was in the shop, why was it not in the house?
 Naresh smiled faintly.
 "You have to pay money to buy it."
 "Don't you have money?"
 This time a small silence settled over the room.
 The smile did not leave Naresh's face, but it grew smaller.
 "Not as much as we need just now."
 Anshu placed a hand on his stomach.

His stomach was full.
He was not hungry.
He could still taste the dal in his mouth.
Even so, for the first time the word “not” touched something beyond his stomach.

He looked at the bowl again.
The empty bowl was in Sarita’s hand.
Only a little while ago it had held rice.
Anshu had taken dal twice.
He had taken one more spoonful of rice.
Now it was empty.
But looking at the empty bowl did not remind him of the meal he had eaten.

It reminded him of the bottom of the tin.
“How much cooked rice does one bowl of raw rice make?” he asked.
Sarita said, “A lot.”
“One bowl this size?”
“Measuring raw rice is a different matter.”
“How many people can eat from it?”
Grandmother laughed.
“Now the calculations begin.”
Sarita thought for a moment.
“It depends on what is cooked, how much water is used, and how much each person eats.”

Such an answer did not satisfy Anshu’s curiosity.
At school, answers did not slide away like this.
Take three mangoes away from ten and seven remained.
Divide twelve sweets among four children and each got three.
One bowl of rice fed how many people?
Why could that not have a single-number answer?
“How many bowls will we cook tomorrow?”
Sarita picked up the lid of the tin.
“We’ll see tomorrow.”
“Why not now?”
“Because tomorrow we won’t eat only rice.”
Grandmother said, “There’ll be maize roti.”
Sarita added, “And a little rice at noon.”
“Milk?”
“No milk until Sunday.”
Anshu stared.
“Tea?”

Naresh laughed.

"I'll survive without tea."

"I drink milk."

Sarita looked at him.

"Tomorrow you can eat roti with jaggery-water."

Anshu opened his mouth.

He wanted to say that he did not like roti with jaggery-water.

He wanted milk.

His mouth remained open.

Then his eyes fell on the bowl.

Sarita was wiping that empty bowl.

Anshu closed his mouth.

He himself was surprised by his silence.

He had not decided to make a sacrifice.

Nor had he said, "I don't want milk."

Only the next part of the question did not come out.

It was a new experience for him.

When he was smaller, hearing "no" would only make him ask again.

Why not?

When?

Where else?

Who has it?

Now, for the first time, it seemed that the answer to the question was already lying before him.

The answer was the empty part of the tin.

The answer was three bowls and a little more than half.

The answer was the distance between Saturday, Sunday, and Monday.

Anshu remembered that day's mathematics lesson at school.

The teacher had written on the blackboard—

" $9 - 4 = 5$ "

Anshu had answered at once.

Five remained.

The teacher had asked, "Is five a little or a lot?"

The class had burst out laughing.

"Compared with what?" the teacher had said.

Then everyone had fallen silent.

At the time, Anshu had thought the question was one of the teacher's games.

Now three and a half bowls stood before him.

Was that little or a lot?

The tin was not empty.

The food in the house had not run out.

Grandmother was not hungry.

Father had eaten too.

Mother had finished her plate.

Anshu's stomach was the fullest of all.

And yet something was scarce.

What was scarce was not inside the stomach; it spread across the days ahead.

Anshu placed a hand on his stomach again.

His stomach was full.

The rice in the tin was low.

Both things could be true at the same time—never before had he understood it quite this way.

It seemed to him that scarcity could begin even before the stomach was empty.

Sarita closed the rice tin.

"Where shall I put this bowl?" Anshu asked.

"Where it always goes."

Anshu carried the bowl towards the utensil shelf.

Three other bowls lay there upside down.

He began to turn his bowl upside down too.

Then he stopped.

It seemed to him that an upturned bowl showed only its shining back.

Not the empty space inside.

He set the bowl upright.

Grandmother saw him from a distance.

"Is there water left in it?"

"No."

"Then why upright?"

Anshu did not answer.

He did not fully understand the reason himself.

That night he sat at his study table.

He opened his mathematics notebook.

There were five subtraction problems in the day's exercise.

He worked out all the answers.

The fourth problem was—

"A shopkeeper had 18 kilograms of rice. He sold 7 kilograms. How much remained?"

Anshu wrote—11 kilograms.

Usually he would have thought the problem ended there.

Today he paused over the 11 for a while.

Eleven kilograms for how many days?
For how many people?
Was there more rice somewhere or not?
Had the shopkeeper received his money or not?
The problem said none of these things.

Then Anshu understood that the “remaining” in mathematics and the “remaining” at home could be the same word and yet not the same experience.

He closed the notebook.

Outside, he could hear Naresh speaking softly on the phone.

“Yes, I understand.”

A short silence.

“No, I’m not complaining.”

Then—

“If you can give even five thousand on Saturday, we’ll manage.”

For the first time, Anshu listened carefully to the phrase “we’ll manage.”

It was said often in the house.

If a strap was fixed to an old slipper, they would manage.

If one fewer bulb was fitted, they would manage.

If there were fewer vegetables, add potatoes and they would manage.

If there was no money until Monday?

They would manage.

Anshu wondered—where, exactly, did this “managing” go on?

Who had to keep pushing it forward?

He wanted to laugh.

But the question felt deep.

Sarita came to check his notebook.

“All done?”

“Yes.”

“Pack your schoolbag.”

Anshu put the notebook into his bag.

Sarita began to turn away.

“Ma.”

“Yes?”

“I don’t want milk tomorrow.”

Sarita stopped.

Anshu added quickly, “I mean... jaggery-water will do.”

Sarita looked at him and remained silent for a moment.

“You like milk.”

“I won’t drink it for one day.”

“It isn’t about one day.”

Anshu did not understand.

Sarita came closer and rested a hand on the back of his chair.

"When something is short in a household, it is not necessary that the child be the first to give up his share."

Anshu was silent.

"We are doing the calculations. We won't give you less food."

"But the rice is low."

"The rice is low. Food is not."

Anshu thought about the difference.

Sarita said again, "It is good to understand scarcity. Being frightened by it is something else."

"I'm not frightened."

"All right."

"It's just... the bowl feels smaller."

A faint smile came to Sarita's face.

"The bowl is the same size."

"But before, it was mine."

"And now?"

Anshu searched for an answer.

"Now it's a measure too."

Sarita laughed.

"Yes, a measure too."

She went away.

For a long time Anshu kept straightening the strap of his schoolbag.

Before going to sleep, he went to the kitchen to drink water.

His bowl stood upright on the utensil shelf.

The yellow bulb left a round pool of light inside it.

The bowl was empty.

Anshu picked it up.

In his palm it felt very light.

He tried to imagine—how heavy would it be filled with raw rice?

Filled with cooked rice?

Filled with dal?

He understood that emptiness was not only a matter of weight.

The same empty bowl, after a meal, had meant an ending.

Beside the tin, used as a measure, it had become a question about the next day.

He put the bowl back on the shelf.

This time he did not turn it upside down.

In the morning, when Sarita lit the stove, Anshu woke earlier than usual.

He came into the kitchen.

“So early?”

“I woke up.”

Sarita was kneading flour.

Anshu looked at the bowl on the shelf.

“Shall we measure the rice?”

“Not now.”

“When?”

“At noon.”

Anshu nodded.

He did not insist on picking up the bowl.

Naresh was getting ready to go out.

“To the contractor?” Anshu asked.

“Yes.”

“Will he give the money?”

Putting on his shoes, Naresh said, “We’ll see.”

Earlier, after hearing “we’ll see,” Anshu would have asked the next question.

Today he did not.

He had learned that some answers become clear like a bowl filled to the brim, some like a half-filled bowl, and some like grains scattered across the bottom of a tin.

Naresh went out.

Grandmother went to water the tulsi plant.

Sarita set the griddle on the stove.

Anshu looked at the empty bowl standing upright on the shelf.

His stomach was empty now.

But today hunger and scarcity no longer seemed to him the same thing.

Hunger was inside him.

Scarcity was the three days spread around that bowl.

Sarita lifted the first roti from the griddle.

“Anshu, bring your plate.”

Anshu went to get his plate.

The bowl stayed where it was.

At noon it would measure the rice again.

The Bird at the Window

Prabha Jha's day ran less by the clock than by sequence.

She rose at five forty-five in the morning, but she knew the hour not from an alarm, but from the growl of the first passenger vehicle in the courtyard lane.

By six, the rice had been washed, the lentils picked over, the stove cleaned, and water set to boil for tea.

At half past six, Shailesh opened the newspaper.

At seven, Naina got ready for school.

By seven twenty, in that small house, three cups of tea, two plates of breakfast, and one lunch box had each set off in its own direction.

Prabha had never written down this list.

Yet her body remembered it.

Which utensil would be lifted first, which clothes would dry where, on which day spices would be ground, on which day the window mesh would be wiped—everything moved in an order like an unwritten rule.

Thursday was the day for cleaning the window mesh.

That kitchen window did not open toward the road, but toward the neighbour's back courtyard.

Between the two houses lay a narrow strip of open ground where rainwater collected in the monsoon and sunlight barely descended in winter.

The window had an old iron frame, three bars on the outside, and a fine mesh within.

One corner of the mesh had come slightly loose during the previous monsoon.

Prabha kept noticing it.

Each time she thought—I'll sew it on Sunday.

Sunday came, another task appeared.

The mesh remained as it was.

That Thursday morning, while leaving, Shailesh said, "Mishraji may come this evening. Keep something savoury with the tea."

Prabha nodded.

As Naina put on her shoes, she said, "Ma, wash my white shirt today. Tomorrow is laboratory day."

“Leave it there.”
Naina left the shirt on the chair.
The door closed.
The house did not suddenly become silent.
The fan kept turning, the tap kept dripping, a chair scraped in the flat upstairs, and the milkman’s bell sounded on the road.
For Prabha, these were all sounds inside silence.
She gathered the plates.
She wiped the stove.
She put the lentils on to cook.
At eight ten, she soaked Naina’s shirt in soapy water.
At eight twenty, she checked the storage tins.
The gram was half full.
There was enough flattened rice.
There was gram flour for making something savoury.
In her mind, she completed the accounting for the evening tea.
At eight forty, she stood before the window mesh.
First she dusted the grime settled on the bars.
Then she ran a dry cloth over the mesh.
The loose corner caught her eye again.
“I’ll sew it today itself,” she said to herself.
The needle and thread were not in the kitchen.
She put the cloth down.
She thought she would cut the vegetables first, then bring the sewing box.
She cut two small pieces of cauliflower.
Just then something fluttered outside the window.
Prabha thought it must be a dry leaf.
Then came a faint “tick”—as though something like a fingernail had struck the iron bar.
She looked up.
A small brown bird was perched on the outer bar of the window.
It was so close that Prabha could see the fine pale ring around its eye.
The bird reached its beak toward the loosened corner of the mesh.
A fine wire protruding like a loose thread from the mesh caught in its beak.
It pulled.
The mesh tightened.
The bird pulled again.
The knife remained still in Prabha’s hand.
A third time the bird fluttered its wings and tugged hard at the wire.
The wire did not come free.

The bird stopped.
Its chest rose and fell very quickly.
Its body was still, its breathing within it so swift.
It was the first time Prabha had seen one so closely.
The bird let go of the mesh.
It turned its neck and looked toward Prabha.
For two moments their eyes met.
Prabha understood that she was not seeing any “sign.”
Nothing auspicious, nothing inauspicious.
Only a living creature that had pulled at one thing three times and had now let it go.
The bird dropped to the outer sill below.
Two dry straws lay there.
It picked up one slender straw in its beak and flew away.
Prabha kept looking at the empty bar for a long time.
Not really “a long time.”
She looked at the clock—nine oh two.
Perhaps not even a minute had passed.
Yet the half-cut piece of cauliflower in her hand felt as though some long pause had entered the middle of her work.
She put the knife down.
The loose wire of the mesh stirred slightly in the air.
“It didn’t come out at all,” Prabha said softly.
Then her own voice struck her as ridiculous.
Whom was she telling?
The bird had already gone.
She began cutting the vegetables again.
But the sequence did not return to where it had been.
After the cauliflower, she was supposed to cut the potatoes.
She picked up a potato, then put it back.
She felt like having tea first.
Tea at nine?
Prabha usually had her second cup of morning tea at ten fifteen.
Inside her there was a fixed hour for that cup.
If she drank tea at nine, what would she do at ten?
The question arose so naturally that Prabha herself was startled.
As though ten o’clock depended for its existence on her cup of tea.
She did not make tea.
She cut the potatoes.
She checked the lentils.
She wrung out the clothes.

She rinsed Naina's white shirt separately.
Then she went to the room to fetch the sewing box.
The sewing box was beneath the bed.
She bent down.
She pulled out the box.
When she opened the lid, she saw three buttons lying on top, two partly cut strips of elastic, and an old spool of green thread.
She needed black thread for the mesh.
The black spool was underneath.
She kept moving things aside.
Then she found a slip of paper.
Naina had made it when she was in Class Five—a list titled “Mother’s Day.”
Prabha read it.
“Mother gets up.”
“Mother makes tea.”
“Mother cooks food.”
“Mother washes clothes.”
“Mother checks my work.”
Below it was a smiling face drawn with coloured pencils.
Prabha had seen this paper long ago.
She had laughed then.
Today the list made something different visible to her.
“Mother” appeared five times in the list.
Not one sentence contained “Prabha.”
She put the paper back in the box.
She took out the black thread.
She returned to the kitchen.
She stood before the mesh.
She threaded the needle.
She took the loose corner in her hand.
Before making the first stitch, she remembered the bird pulling three times.
She did not freeze.
Only a question came—was it necessary to sew this mesh today?
The answer should have been simple.
Yes, mosquitoes would get in.
Dust would come in.
The mesh would tear further.
But the opening was so small that even a fine finger could scarcely pass through it.

It had been like this since the previous monsoon.
Prabha pushed the needle back into the spool.
“In the evening,” she said.
Then she immediately laughed.
Not Sunday now, but evening.
She did not close the box.
She left it in a corner of the kitchen.
It was ten fifteen.
Tea time.
Prabha set water on the stove.
She took out a cup.
The tea was ready.
Usually she picked coriander while drinking tea.
Today the coriander lay before her.
She did not reach for it.
Cup in hand, she stood by the window.
The bird was not there.
A scrap of red paper lay in the narrow strip outside.
A cloth hung halfway down from the neighbour’s terrace.
A few ants were climbing an old wooden post.
Prabha had always thought there was nothing outside the window worth looking at.
Today she understood that “nothing” too is made of many things.
She finished her tea.
She picked the coriander.
The day moved on again.
At eleven, she was supposed to wipe the upper shelf.
She took a cloth.
Three brass vessels sat on the shelf, used only once or twice a month.
Prabha wiped them every Thursday.
She lifted one vessel.
A fine ring of dust lay beneath it.
She wiped the place.
She lifted the second.
Then it occurred to her—Mishraji was coming in the evening to drink tea, not to inspect the brass vessels.
She did not lift the third vessel.
Her hand stopped.
Was this laziness?
Prabha asked herself.
The first phrase came at once—“leaving work undone.”

Then another—"choosing the work."
 The two were not the same thing.
 She left the third vessel where it was.
 She folded the cloth and put it away.
 Eleven oh five.
 Five minutes saved.
 The word "saved" felt slightly strange to her.
 Saved from what had those five minutes been?
 She did not fill them with some other task.
 She sat down on a chair.
 As soon as she sat, her eyes fell on a dry lentil lying on the floor.
 Usually she would have picked it up at once.
 Today she kept looking at it.
 The lentil remained where it was.
 The house did not fall apart.
 At eleven oh seven, she picked up the lentil.
 She did not smile.
 She did not frame any lesson in her mind.
 Only this settled lightly into her body: a lentil could remain on the floor
 for two minutes.
 Lunch was ready on time.
 Shailesh ate at the office.
 Naina was at school.
 Prabha ate alone.
 Earlier she used to turn on the radio, but it had been broken for two
 months.
 She ate without sound.
 She washed her plate.
 At half past twelve, she normally checked the vegetable box for the next
 day.
 Today she forgot.
 She remembered that she had forgotten at one o'clock.
 At one, she was straightening the bed-sheet.
 Her hand suddenly stopped.
 "The box!"
 She got up.
 She went to the kitchen.
 She opened the box.
 Enough potatoes, four tomatoes, not much okra.
 Everything was fine.
 No disaster.

She closed the box.
 Then she thought—what if there had been no okra?
 Then some other vegetable would have been cooked.
 The answer was exceedingly ordinary.
 So ordinary that many of the fears in her day began to seem exaggerated.
 But she did not immediately pass judgment on her life.
 She knew that a house is difficult to run without order.
 Doing things on time creates ease.
 Sequence is not the enemy.
 The question was when sequence had turned from a means into a rule, and
 when the rule had forgotten its reason.
 At half past one she lay down to rest for ten minutes.
 Ten minutes was her rule.
 She woke twelve minutes later.
 On seeing the clock, her first feeling was not guilt but surprise.
 “Twelve minutes?”
 Two extra minutes of sleep had made no particular change in her body.
 She got up.
 Naina’s shirt had dried.
 She took out the iron.
 While ironing the shirt, she noticed a small stain near the shoulder.
 The stain had not come out with soap.
 Earlier, for such a stain, she would have soaked the shirt again.
 Today she thought—the stain would not even show beneath the
 laboratory coat.
 She folded the shirt and put it away.
 Naina returned at three.
 As soon as the door opened she said, “Ma, I’m hungry.”
 Prabha cut some fruit for her.
 While eating, Naina saw the shirt.
 “You washed it?”
 “Yes.”
 Naina noticed the stain on the shoulder.
 “This didn’t come out?”
 Prabha looked at her face for a moment.
 “No.”
 “Then?”
 “Then nothing. It will be under the coat.”
 Naina was quiet for a little while.
 Then she ate another piece of apple.
 Prabha felt like laughing, but she did not.

All this time she had feared Naina's possible objection more than the stain itself.

Naina objected, then ate her apple.

At four, Shailesh called.

"Mishraji isn't coming. His meeting has run long."

Prabha said, "All right."

She ended the call.

She had already taken out the gram flour for the savoury snack.

Normally she would have thought—I've taken it out now, I might as well make it. It will keep till tomorrow.

Today she put the gram flour back in its tin.

Naina was studying.

Evening was settling slowly over the house.

Prabha went to the window.

The loose wire of the mesh was still exposed.

The sewing box lay open in the corner of the kitchen.

She looked at it.

She had said she would sew it in the evening.

Now evening had come.

She picked up the needle.

Then a faint sound came again from the outer bar.

Whether it was the same bird or another, Prabha could not tell.

A small brown body, bright eyes—to her, birds of that kind looked almost alike.

This time its beak was empty.

It sat on the bar.

It did not look toward the loosened corner of the mesh.

It kept watch somewhere above the road.

Inside, Prabha stood holding the needle in her hand.

The bird looked toward her for a moment.

Then it fluttered its wings and flew away.

That was all.

Prabha threaded the needle.

She took the loose corner of the mesh.

She made two stitches.

Before making a third, she stopped.

The corner was already completely closed.

More stitches were needed only to make it look neat.

She cut the thread.

She closed the sewing box.

That night dinner was served at nine oh five.

Usually it was served at nine.

Shailesh said nothing about the five minutes.

Neither did Naina.

After dinner Shailesh asked, "You look tired today?"

Prabha thought.

"No."

"Then why are you so quiet?"

Prabha looked toward the window.

"Nothing. A bird came today."

Shailesh laughed.

"What is new about a bird coming to this house?"

Prabha smiled too.

"Perhaps the bird was not the new thing."

"Then what?"

Prabha did not answer.

Because she herself did not yet have a complete answer.

At night, while washing the dishes, she left one bowl in the washing area.

Her habit was to dry every utensil, put it in its place, and only then leave the kitchen.

The bowl was clean; water was merely dripping from it.

She left it there.

She switched off the light.

She walked to the door.

Then she turned and looked once more.

The window was dark.

There was no bird outside.

The sewn corner of the mesh was still.

A drop of water fell from the bowl in the washing area.

Prabha did not switch the light on again.

The bowl would still be there in the morning.

There would still be time to lift it.

The night had no duty to stand guard over the bowl.

Prabha closed the door.

Next Thursday, the day for wiping the window would come again.

She had not changed that rule.

But inside the rule there was now a small empty space—a space that did not have to be filled.

Something fluttered its wings outside the window.

Prabha did not turn around.

One Wrong Word

Vasudha Jha heard the wrong word leave her elder sister's mouth first; its meaning arrived afterward.

Lunch was over.

Saroj Didi was sitting on the chair by the window.

It had been five days since the cataract operation on her right eye.

The doctor had said—do not let direct sunlight fall on the eye, do not lift anything heavy, and do not stay alone for a few days.

So Saroj had left her own home in Madhubani and come to Vasudha's house in Darbhanga.

Vasudha did not think of this arrangement as an arrangement.

To her, Didi had come; that was all.

When Vasudha had been thirteen, Didi had taken her into her home then too.

There had been no doctor's prescription at that time.

There had been no particular day of which one could say—from this day onward, Saroj Didi became like a mother.

Their father died.

Their mother died two years later.

In the years between, Saroj Didi was twenty, but the household accepted her as the grown-up.

Vasudha was the younger one.

Being younger was a kind of right—the right to cry, sulk, study, and fail to understand a question.

For Saroj, being the elder one was not a right but a task.

Vasudha had thought about this many times.

But until today, her thinking had always ended at the same conclusion—
Didi did a great deal for me.

There had been no thorn in that conclusion.

It was clean.

Like the steel bowl that shines after being scrubbed clean at the end of a meal.

That day too, Vasudha came out of the kitchen after washing two bowls.

Saroj Didi sat in the chair with her eyes half closed.

She had no kajal on her eyes.

The doctor had forbidden it after the operation.

Without kajal, her face looked to Vasudha like a photograph from childhood.

"Is it time for the medicine?" Saroj asked.

Vasudha looked at the clock.

"Ten minutes to go."

"Not now, just now," Saroj said, laughing.

Vasudha laughed too.

"Ten minutes to go."

"Half your Maithili still lives in the office."

"And half your Hindi still lives in the marketplace."

They both laughed.

This kind of teasing between them was old.

Saroj had married into a family in Samastipur.

After living there for years, many Hindi words had entered her everyday speech.

Vasudha, after spending half her life working in a bank, had spent years listening to the language of forms, branches, accounts, and customers.

Each corrected the other's language, but neither felt insulted.

Words were a game between them.

At least that was what Vasudha had believed until then.

Vasudha placed the small medicine bottle on the table.

"Didi, the doctor says you can go home after seven days, but I say stay for two weeks."

Saroj turned her face toward her.

"If I stay, your work will increase."

"What work?"

"Medicine, meals, drops in my eye, getting up at night to check on me—aren't these all work?"

"These are household things."

Saroj was silent for a few moments.

A vegetable seller's call came from the road outside.

A gate closed at someone's house.

The fan turned slowly.

Saroj stroked the arm of the chair with her fingers.

"For a long time, I have been living on your..."

She stopped.

Vasudha looked at her.

"What?"

Saroj began again.

“For a long time, I have been living on your debt.”

The sentence came out naturally.

So naturally that it took Vasudha a moment to understand that it was wrong.

Saroj herself immediately frowned.

“Not debt—support.”

She laughed.

“See what my mouth said! I meant support.”

Vasudha tried to smile too.

“Yes.”

Saroj moved on.

“Support. Now with my eyes, my knees, all this—I have to depend on you.”

But Vasudha remained caught inside the first sentence.

Debt.

The word was small.

Only four letters in Maithili.

Not even very far from support.

Change the first vowel and the meaning changed.

Vasudha thought—it was a slip of the tongue.

That was all.

It would be foolish to search for meaning in it.

The ten minutes until the medicine had by then become seven.

She picked up the bottle.

She put the drops into Saroj’s eye.

Saroj closed her eyelids.

“Don’t open your eye for two minutes,” Vasudha said.

“Did the doctor say that, or you?”

“The doctor.”

“Then I’ll obey.”

Vasudha smiled again.

But the word ‘debt’ did not close its eyes inside her mind.

That night, while cooking dinner, she thought for the first time—when Didi paid my school fees, was that a debt?

The question seemed so indecent that she immediately grew angry with herself.

Didi had paid the fees because there had been no one else in the house.

That was all.

At the time, Saroj had sold two of her glass bangles.

Vasudha had learned this much later, not from her mother but from a neighbour auntie.

Saroj herself had never mentioned it.

Would someone who keeps accounts of debts hide the story of selling her bangles?

Vasudha added salt to the lentils.

The answer seemed clear.

No.

But in the next moment another memory came.

In the month of Vasudha's first salary, Saroj had asked for a sari.

Jokingly she had said, "Now the little one earns; my account will be settled."

Everyone had laughed.

Vasudha too.

Had that been only a joke?

The lentils began to boil over.

Vasudha lowered the flame.

She felt ashamed of her question.

It was not right to change the meaning of thirty-year-old laughter because of one wrong word.

She decided—tonight I will not think about this again.

Ten minutes later she was thinking about it again.

When Saroj's son Raghav had studied engineering in Darbhanga, he had lived in Vasudha's house for two years.

Vasudha had kept him like her own son.

His food, clothes, fee dates, fever—she had attended to everything.

Saroj would often say, "You have taken half my work upon yourself."

At the time Vasudha had felt proud.

Today an invisible account opened behind that sentence.

Two years of meals in exchange for two bangles?

Raghav's room in exchange for school fees?

Drops in Saroj's eye in exchange for the nights Saroj stayed awake during their mother's final illness?

Vasudha stopped while serving the plates.

The arithmetic was repulsive.

And, though repulsive, very simple.

That simplicity frightened her.

"What happened?" her husband Naresh asked.

"Nothing."

"Too much salt?"

"No."

Naresh tasted the lentils.

"They're fine."

Saroj was eating slowly.
 Since the operation, bright light troubled her.
 Vasudha switched off the main light and lit the smaller lamp.
 Saroj said, "You remember everything."
 Vasudha's hand stopped for a moment.
 Everything?
 Even the debt?
 She said nothing.
 After dinner Vasudha opened her household expense book.
 The habit came from her bank job.
 Milk, vegetables, electricity, medicines, domestic help—everything was
 written down.
 After Saroj's operation she had opened a new page.
 At the top she had written—"Didi—medicines/check-ups."
 Below were five entries.
 Medicine 1,280.
 Dark glasses for the eye 350.
 Car 600.
 Two consultation fees.
 Until then those amounts had meant only expenses.
 Today the heading 'Didi' looked like an account.
 Vasudha closed the book.
 That night she did not fall asleep for a long time.
 Naresh asked, "Didi's eye is all right, isn't it?"
 "Yes."
 "Then?"
 "Nothing."
 Naresh turned over.
 Vasudha kept looking at the ceiling in the dark.
 It seemed to her that after a wrong word, silence too becomes a word.
 The next morning, while drinking tea, Saroj said, "There's less sugar
 today."
 Vasudha started.
 "Less?"
 "Yes, but it's fine."
 Saroj's voice was ordinary.
 Vasudha wanted to laugh at herself.
 In a single day she had begun weighing every sentence Didi spoke.
 "Where is the medicine kept?"
 Was that dependence?
 "You've grown tired?"

Was that guilt?

“Did Raghav call?”

Was that accounting?

Once language falls under suspicion, even ordinary questions begin to look like documents.

Vasudha was troubled by this.

She left the kitchen work and went to the veranda.

Saroj was sitting there in the shade, out of the sunlight.

An old woollen shawl lay in her lap.

She was pushing a loose thread at its corner back in with her finger.

Vasudha remembered—Saroj had given her this shawl at her wedding.

She had said then, “It isn’t expensive, but it will keep you warm.”

Vasudha had said, “Why such a large shawl for me?”

Saroj had answered, “In your husband’s home, your own covering should never be too small.”

The sentence had been humorous then.

Today Vasudha wondered—had Didi known the price of the things she gave?

At once she thought—of course she had.

Whoever buys a thing knows its price.

Knowing a price is not the same as keeping an account.

It took Vasudha half a day to arrive at that small distinction.

In the afternoon Raghav called.

Saroj put the phone on speaker so everyone could hear.

“Ma, are you taking your medicines on time?” Raghav asked.

“Your aunt has turned me into a child.”

“Be one. For a few days.”

“Yes, now I am a burden on everyone...”

Saroj stopped.

Vasudha’s ears sharpened slightly.

“Not a burden,” Saroj corrected herself, “I meant dependent.”

Raghav laughed.

“Ma, your tongue slips a lot these days.”

Saroj laughed too.

“Effect of age.”

Vasudha did not laugh.

After the call ended she asked, “Didi, do your words really slip this much?”

Saroj looked over her glasses.

“What?”

"Yesterday you said debt instead of support. Today you almost said burden."

Saroj said casually, "It's a mouth. It makes mistakes."

"Yes."

Vasudha wanted the question to end there.

It did not.

Saroj kept looking at her face.

"You've been stuck on this since yesterday?"

Vasudha was silent.

The smile left Saroj's face.

"Oh, I meant support."

"I know."

"Then?"

Suddenly Vasudha felt thirteen years old again.

At that age too she used to fall silent like this before asking Didi a difficult question.

"Didi, did you ever feel that I owed you a great deal?"

Saroj's fingers became still on the loose thread of the shawl.

She did not answer at once.

At that delay, something sank inside Vasudha.

Saroj asked, "What do you mean by 'owe'?"

"That you did so much for me. Later I kept Raghav with me, I run around for your treatment... as though all of it were an account."

Saroj slowly folded the shawl.

"You made this account?"

The question came back at her.

Vasudha was startled.

"Me?"

"Yes. Yesterday I only said one wrong word. You spent the whole night making a ledger out of it?"

Vasudha grew irritated.

"Don't make fun of me."

"I'm not making fun of you."

Saroj's voice was gentle.

"You remembered the school fees?"

Vasudha did not answer.

"The bangles?"

Vasudha looked at her.

"How did you know?"

"Auntie told you. I knew she had."

At those few words, the old story changed again for Vasudha.

Didi had known that Vasudha knew about the bangles.

Then Didi's silence was not necessarily the silence of sacrifice; it could have been a decision not to repeat the story again and again.

Saroj said, "What I did then was what the house needed then."

Vasudha said, "But you left your studies."

"Yes."

"For me."

Saroj lowered her eyes.

"For you too. For the house too. And because of my own fear too."

"Fear?"

"I myself didn't know what I would do by going to college. After Babuji died, I lost the courage to leave the house."

Vasudha sat stunned.

The story she had carried all her life was—Didi gave up her studies for her younger sister.

Saroj was now saying—the reason had not been one thing.

This answer did not make the sacrifice smaller.

But the clean line blurred.

Vasudha was uncomfortable with such blurring.

In a bank, money is either a deposit or a withdrawal.

At home, the same amount can carry many names.

Saroj said, "You kept Raghav for two years. Was that to repay what you owed me?"

"No."

The answer came at once.

"Then?"

"He was a child. He was studying. It was convenient for him to stay with me."

"That's all."

Saroj pushed the loose thread of the shawl in again.

"For me too, at that time, there was what was convenient, what was responsibility, what was love—it was all mixed together."

Vasudha said nothing.

Saroj added, "Some love is not pure. Work, fear, habit, responsibility—everything stays mixed into it."

The sentence felt heavy to Vasudha.

She wanted Didi to say—'No, there is no debt at all.'

A clean answer.

Saroj did not give that answer.

The afternoon passed.

In the evening Vasudha opened the expense book again.

At the top it said—"Didi—medicines/check-ups."

She picked up her pen.

For a few moments the nib rested on the word 'Didi.'

She did not cross it out.

Below it she wrote a new entry—"Eye drops—480."

Then she closed the book.

She understood that crossing out a heading would not erase the accounting inside it.

Even acting against accounting can become another form of accounting.

Over the next two days Saroj's eye improved.

She began walking from the veranda to the courtyard without support.

Vasudha watched from a distance.

As before, she felt the urge to hurry over and take her hand.

Twice she restrained herself.

The third time Saroj herself said, "Give me your hand."

Vasudha gave it.

That small incident made something new visible to her.

It seemed to Vasudha that when Saroj asked for her hand, the meaning of the hand she held was different from the hand Vasudha had stopped herself from offering the first two times.

She did not feel the need to name that difference.

She simply kept the difference in mind.

After that she continued watching Saroj's steps, but did not immediately extend a hand.

On the seventh day the doctor said, "The wound is healing well. She can go home after two more days."

Saroj was pleased.

Vasudha said, "After two days?"

"Yes."

A small emptiness rose inside her.

She did not again insist that Saroj stay two weeks.

On the morning of her return, Saroj packed her clothes.

She folded the shawl.

She put the medicine bottle in a separate bag.

She put on the dark glasses.

Vasudha was in the kitchen wrapping parathas for the journey.

From inside Saroj called, "Little one, this medicine is three times a day, right?"

"Yes."

"And the one with the red cap at night?"

"Yes."

“Write it down.”

Vasudha wrote it on a piece of paper.

Saroj folded the paper and put it in the bag.

Then she said, “You are so much my...”

Vasudha looked toward her instinctively.

Saroj smiled.

“Don’t worry. This time I’ll think before I choose the word.”

Vasudha laughed too.

Saroj said slowly, “You are my support.”

The word was correct.

The pronunciation was clear.

The meaning too ought to have been clear.

Yet strangely, to Vasudha that sentence felt smaller than yesterday’s ‘debt.’

Perhaps the wrong word had opened more rooms than the right one.

She said, “Didi, a house rests on support. But a house is not only its support.”

Saroj raised an eyebrow.

“Is that bank language or philosophy?”

Vasudha laughed.

“I don’t know.”

“Then leave it.”

They both laughed again.

The car arrived.

Naresh loaded the luggage.

Saroj sat inside.

Vasudha stood at the gate.

The car turned away.

The house suddenly became quiet.

Vasudha went inside.

The chair was empty.

There was half a glass of water on the table.

One of Saroj’s hairs was caught on the back of the chair like a thread from the shawl.

Vasudha removed it.

In the afternoon she opened the expense book.

The page headed ‘Didi—medicines/check-ups’ was before her again.

She could have totalled it.

Adding five amounts was not difficult for a bank employee.

She did not add them.

Nor did she tear out the page.

She closed the book and put it in the cupboard.

Three days later Saroj called.

"Little one, I can see clearly now."

"Very good."

"I'm taking the medicine on time."

"Good."

"And listen."

"Yes?"

"Yesterday Raghav was saying—Ma, when will we repay what we owe Mausi?"

Vasudha's body tightened slightly.

Saroj laughed.

"I scolded him. I told him, from now on think before using that word in this house."

Vasudha was silent.

Saroj's laughter slowly faded.

"You've started thinking again?"

Vasudha looked toward the window.

Clothes were drying outside.

"Yes, but not as before."

"What are you thinking?"

Vasudha searched for an answer.

A week earlier she would have said—nothing.

Today she said, "I think a wrong word sometimes opens the wrong place."

Saroj was silent.

"And the right word?"

Vasudha said, "It may sometimes close the door."

At the other end of the phone Saroj laughed softly.

"You've begun thinking too much."

"You said one wrong word."

"My fault."

"No."

Vasudha said this 'no' slowly.

She understood that to search for fault would be to open the ledger again.

"Didi?"

"Yes?"

"When you paid my school fees, were you afraid then?"

There was silence on the phone for a few moments.

"Very," Saroj said.

"Of what?"

"That the next month I wouldn't know where the money would come from."

For the first time Vasudha imagined that answer.
In memory she kept looking at the bangles.
Earlier, the bangles had been a sign of sacrifice.
Now fear existed inside them too.
Adding fear did not reduce the love.
It made it more human.
Vasudha said, "I understood nothing then."
"You were a child."
"And now?"
Saroj laughed.
"Even now, you understand a great many things only partly."
Vasudha laughed too.
After ending the call she stood by the window.
She remembered yesterday's correct word—support.
Then the wrong word—debt.
The two words no longer cancelled each other out.
There was some open space between them.
In that space were school fees, bangles, Raghav's two years, eye medicine,
fear, convenience, habit, love.
So many things could not fit into a single word.
Vasudha went to the kitchen.
The expense book lay on the table.
She opened it.
It was time to begin the page for a new month.
She wrote the date at the top.
Then the first item—milk.
The second—vegetables.
The third—medicine.
She did not create a separate heading called 'Didi.'
Nor did she alter the old page.
She let both remain truths of their own time.
She capped the pen.
The phone rang again from outside.
Vasudha paused for a moment before getting up.
She did not know whether Didi was on the other end or someone else.
This time she did not guess.
She answered the phone.
"Yes, tell me."

New Slippers

Urmila Jha had no desire to buy new slippers.

The left strap of the old pair could be stitched once more.

At least, that was what she thought.

Before going to the market, she picked up the old slippers and examined them.

The heel of the right slipper was almost level.

The outer edge of the left slipper had become very thin.

The knot of the strap had been stitched twice.

Even the colour of the dust on the soles was different on the two.

Urmila understood all this as wear.

Wear belonged to things, not to people—until now, that was all she had believed.

She put on the old slippers and went to the market.

On the way, the left strap loosened once again.

She stopped and bent down.

With a finger she pushed the knot of the strap inward.

“One last time now,” she said, not to the slipper but to herself.

The shoe-and-slipper shop stood at the turn of the lane.

The shopkeeper, Kamlesh, had known her for many years.

“Stitch them again?” he asked with a laugh.

“If they can be stitched.”

Kamlesh took the slipper in his hand and turned it over and over.

“The strap can be stitched.”

Urmila breathed in relief.

“But the sole?”

“What is wrong with the sole?”

Kamlesh placed both slippers evenly on the table.

“Look.”

Urmila looked.

One stood straight.

The other leaned a little outward.

“They are old.”

“They both became old on the same day.”

Urmila remained silent.
Kamlesh ran a finger along the outer edge of the left slipper.
"It is more worn here."
"The road is uneven."
Kamlesh did not laugh.
He showed her the right slipper.
"Is the road kinder to the right foot?"
Urmila looked at his face.
Kamlesh said at once, "I am not saying anything is wrong."
"Then?"
"Your gait may have changed."
Urmila did not like that sentence.
"Why would my gait change?"
"I am not a doctor."
Kamlesh put the slippers back on the table.
"I only look at soles."
Urmila felt he was stretching the matter unnecessarily.
"Show me a new pair."
Kamlesh brought out three pairs.
The first pair seemed much too bright in colour to Urmila.
The second had thin straps.
The third was plain black.
"This one."
Kamlesh asked her size.
Urmila held out her old slipper.
"Like this."
Kamlesh did not measure her foot.
He looked at the number written inside the old pair and handed her the new one.
Urmila sat on the edge of the bench.
She took off the old slippers.
She put on the new ones.
Her first sensation was not comfort.
It seemed to her that the floor was slightly tilted.
She pressed down with her right foot.
Then the left.
Both soles were even.
"This is not right," Urmila said.
Kamlesh bent down and looked.
"The size is right."
"One foot feels lower."

Kamlesh removed the slippers and matched the two soles together.
“They are equal.”
“It does not feel so to me.”
Kamlesh paused for a moment.
“Put on the old pair.”
Urmila put the old slippers on again.
At once everything felt right.
She rose and took two steps.
The floor was level.
“See?”
Kamlesh said, “I see.”
“Then the new pair is not right.”
Kamlesh placed the old slippers on the table again.
“Your old pair has worn itself to match your gait.”
Urmila grew irritated.
“Slippers wear according to the way one walks. What is new about that?”
“The new pair has not yet worn itself to your gait.”
Kamlesh’s voice was matter-of-fact.
That very matter-of-factness made Urmila more uneasy.
She put the new slippers on again.
“Walk and see,” Kamlesh said.
Urmila took four steps inside the shop.
The first step with the right foot.
The second with the left.
On the third, she became aware that she set her left foot a little outward.
She deliberately tried to place it straight.
At once her right knee tightened.
There was no pain.
Only something like an old caution awakened inside.
Urmila stopped at once.
“What happened?”
“Nothing.”
She walked again.
This time she watched not her feet but her shoulders.
Her left shoulder moved a little forward.
The right a little back.
She had never noticed this before.
A small mirror stood in front of the shop.
It was not there for looking at one’s hair.
It was there so customers could see their whole bodies while trying on shoes.

Urmila walked in front of the mirror.
Her eyes fixed on the straps of the new slippers.
The distance between her two feet was not equal.
“It is because of these slippers,” she said.
Kamlesh only said, “It may be.”
Urmila did not like that answer either.
“Give me the old pair.”
“For stitching?”
“No.”
She thought for a moment.
“Keep them.”
Kamlesh put the old pair into a bag.
Wearing the new slippers, Urmila stepped out of the shop.
For the first ten steps she felt everyone was watching her walk.
No such thing was happening.
Everyone was busy with their own work.
The vegetable seller was watching his scales.
A cyclist passed, ringing his bell.
Two children ran by with schoolbags hanging from their shoulders.
No one had any interest in Urmila’s left foot.
That gave her relief and disappointment at once.
The road home was about half a kos.
Ordinarily, Urmila stopped at two places on her way back from the market.
First at the spice shop.
Then at the milk booth.
That day she bought no spices.
Nor did she buy milk.
She only wanted to walk.
She wanted to listen to her own gait.
The soles of the new slippers made a faint sound on the dry road.
Right—tap.
Left—a slight scrape.
Right—tap.
Left—a slight scrape.
Urmila slowed down.
She listened again.
The right foot lifted cleanly.
Before leaving the ground, the left foot slid a little.
“It was not like this before,” she said in her mind.
Then the question came at once—

Before when?
Twenty years ago?
Ten years ago?
Last month?
She could not answer.
At the gate of the house she stopped.
There was a small raised brick beneath the gate.
She always lifted her right foot first to cross it.
This time she deliberately lifted the left.
Her body faltered for a moment.
The left foot crossed the rise.
Her right knee trembled slightly.
Urmila caught hold of the gate.
“Ma:”
Neha called from inside.
Urmila released her grip.
“Yes.”
Neha came as far as the veranda.
“New slippers?”
“Yes.”
“They’re nice.”
Urmila waited.
Neha said nothing more.
“Did you notice how I walk?”
Neha looked startled.
“What?”
“How do I walk?”
Neha burst out laughing.
“With your feet.”
Urmila did not laugh.
Neha looked at her face.
“What happened?”
“Nothing.”
She went inside.
The passage leading to the kitchen was narrow.
On one side stood the grain bin.
On the other, the basket of utensils.
Urmila passed between them dozens of times a day.
She went through by drawing her right shoulder slightly back.
This time she became distinctly aware of that movement of her body.
She stopped.

Then she tried to pass through normally.
 Her shoulder brushed the basket of utensils.
 A steel bowl clattered.
 "What fell?" Neha asked.
 "Nothing."
 Urmila straightened the basket.
 She looked at the width of the passage.
 "How long has this been here?"
 Neha came over.
 "What?"
 "This basket."
 "For a long time."
 "How long?"
 Neha did not laugh.
 "Ma, I don't know."
 Urmila looked at the grain bin.
 The bin had not always stood in that corner.
 She remembered—the bin had been moved there after the new rack for
 utensils was installed.
 When had that rack come?
 Seven years ago?
 Eight?
 From that day the passage had become narrower.
 From that day she had been drawing her right shoulder back as she passed.
 "Push the basket a little farther in," Urmila said.
 "It is convenient here."
 "Convenient for whom?"
 Neha did not answer.
 Urmila herself lifted the basket and placed it elsewhere inside the kitchen.
 The passage became two fingers wider.
 What could so little change?
 She walked through once again.
 Her shoulders could remain straight.
 But the gait of her feet was the same.
 Right—straight.
 Left—a little outward.
 Urmila was not disappointed.
 What surprised her was that she wanted an immediate correction.
 As though the body had written a wrong answer.
 She sat down in the sitting room.
 She took off the new slippers.

She brought the old pair out of the bag.
She placed both pairs in front of her.
The new pair—the two soles even.
The old pair—one edge thin.
She took the old left slipper in her hand.
She ran a finger over the worn place.
The rubber had become smooth.
Here and there the threads showed through.
The wear had happened day by day.
Not on any one day.
Not because of any one event.
That thought drew her attention to her right knee.
Seventeen years earlier, in the monsoon, she had fallen on the stairs.
She had been carrying a bucket full of water.
Her right knee had remained swollen for two days.
She had not gone to a doctor.
There had been a wedding in the family.
“The pain has gone down,” everyone had said.
The pain truly had gone down.
But had her gait changed then?
Urmila was not certain.
She got up and put on the old slippers.
She walked from the sitting room to the kitchen.
In the old pair she did not feel the sliding of the left foot.
The sole had accepted that sliding.
Like an old seat that learns the pressure of a body.
Urmila put on the new slippers again.
The difference returned at once.
“Ma, if the old ones are more comfortable, wear those,” Neha said.
Urmila looked at her.
There was nothing wrong with the advice.
Urmila herself would have said the same.
Why replace something that is comfortable?
But now the word comfort had changed a little.
“They are comfortable,” she said.
“Then?”
“I’m seeing.”
After lunch Urmila usually lay down for half an hour.
That day she did not.
She sat in the courtyard with the two pairs of slippers.
A small strip of sunlight lay on the wall.

She turned the old slippers upside down.
On the right sole, the wear was in the middle of the heel.
On the left, it ran along the outer edge toward the front.
With her fingernail she tried to connect the two marks.
No straight line emerged.
Neha came with tea.
“Is an examination going on?”
This time Urmila laughed.
“Yes.”
“What have you discovered?”
“I walk crooked.”
“Who told you?”
“The slippers.”
Neha sat down.
“You look normal to me.”
“What is normal?”
Neha thought.
“The way you walk every day.”
The answer struck Urmila deep inside.
Every day’s gait was normal.
Every day’s tilt was normal.
Every day’s path was normal.
“How long have you been watching me?”
“Since I became aware of things.”
“Then how would you know my old gait?”
Neha blew on her tea.
“Do you know your old gait?”
Urmila fell silent.
There was no answer to that question.
In the evening Pradeep Babu returned.
As soon as he came through the gate he noticed the new slippers.
“They’re nice.”
Urmila asked, “How do I walk?”
Pradeep Babu stopped while taking off his bag.
“What sort of question is that?”
“Look.”
Urmila walked from one end of the sitting room to the other.
Pradeep Babu watched carefully.
“Fine.”
“Are both feet equal?”
“I’m not measuring.”

“Just look.”

She walked again.

Pradeep Babu said, “The left foot goes a little outward.”

Urmila stopped at once.

“Since before?”

“What?”

“Was it like this before too?”

Pradeep Babu scratched his head.

“Perhaps.”

“Since when?”

“Who remembers that?”

Urmila did not become angry.

Her own question seemed impossible to her.

Who keeps a date for a change that happens slowly?

Who writes down—today the gait shifted by two degrees?

Who says—today the shoulder went a little farther back?

Who notes—starting today, the right foot goes first on the stairs?

Pradeep Babu went to wash his hands and face.

Urmila remained alone on the veranda.

She looked at the rise beneath the gate.

Then the passage.

Then the high shelf in the kitchen.

The spice boxes on that shelf were in the right-hand corner.

She always raised her right hand to take them down.

The rice drum was on the left.

She lifted the bucket with her right hand.

The stair railing was on the left, yet she climbed with her right foot first.

Were these all causes, or only habits?

Urmila did not know.

She did not want to make a list of causes.

At dinner she remained quiet.

In the middle of the meal Neha asked, “Are the slippers comfortable?”

“They are new.”

“That does not make things clear.”

“For now, that is all I can say.”

Pradeep Babu laughed.

“Wear them for two days. They’ll mould themselves.”

Urmila stopped her spoon.

“To whose shape?”

“What?”

“Will the slippers mould themselves to me, or will I mould myself to the slippers?”

Pradeep Babu laughed again.

“A little of both.”

Urmila liked that ordinary answer.

At night she did not throw away the old slippers.

Nor did she put the new pair into the cupboard.

Both remained beside the door.

The next morning the milkman rang his bell.

Urmila rose sleepily.

Without thinking, her feet went into the old slippers.

She had already taken two steps when she stopped.

She looked down.

The old pair.

She turned back.

She took them off.

She put on the new ones.

It was a very small decision.

So small there was no need to tell anyone about it.

By the time she reached the gate, her left foot had again turned a little outward.

She did not force it straight.

She took the milk.

On the way back, she did not try to lift the left foot first over the raised brick.

Whichever foot her body lifted, she crossed with that one.

It seemed to her that today was not a day for experiments.

The routine continued.

But her attention had changed.

While washing lentils in the kitchen, she noticed that she always held the bowl in her left hand.

She lifted the heavy pot with her right.

While sweeping, her left foot stayed forward.

While folding the bedding, she bent her right knee less.

She did not immediately change any of these things.

She only noticed them.

Three days later, a faint line of dust appeared on the soles of the new slippers.

Before washing them, Urmila turned them over and looked.

A little more dust had gathered along the left edge.

Not wear yet.

Only a sign.
 Urmila felt like laughing.
 “Now you are learning too,” she said to the slipper.
 Neha heard her.
 “Who are you talking to?”
 “No one.”
 “To the slippers?”
 Urmila laughed.
 “Yes.”
 Neha laughed too.
 On the fourth day Urmila went to the market.
 Kamlesh’s shop lay on the way.
 She did not go inside.
 Kamlesh was outside measuring a customer’s shoe.
 He saw Urmila.
 “Are they all right?”
 Urmila stopped.
 “The slippers?”
 “Yes.”
 “They’re fine.”
 “And the gait?”
 Urmila thought for a moment.
 “That is fine too.”
 Kamlesh smiled.
 Urmila added, “Only not the way it used to be.”
 She walked on.
 In the market crowd it was difficult to observe her own gait.
 People jostled her.
 She had to avoid rickshaws.
 There were potholes.
 Sometimes she turned right, sometimes left.
 Urmila realised that a straight gait could be seen only on an empty
 veranda.
 On the roads of life, a gait is always in conversation with the road.
 The thought seemed a little too philosophical to her.
 She dropped it at once and began choosing vegetables.
 On the way back she carried a bag in one hand.
 She always carried the bag in her right hand.
 This time she took it in the left.
 After ten steps it became uncomfortable.
 She changed hands.

Freedom did not mean doing the opposite—she understood this without turning it into a sentence.

On reaching home she placed the bag on the table.

Neha said, “You came back early today.”

“There was less crowd.”

“The slippers?”

“Leave the slippers alone.”

Both of them laughed.

While cleaning in the afternoon, Urmila saw that the basket of utensils had again been placed in the passage.

Neha had probably put it there for convenience.

Urmila lifted the basket.

She did not return it to its old place inside the kitchen.

She measured—with her eyes.

How much space was needed in the middle of the passage?

She pushed the basket a little closer to the wall.

Then she moved the grain bin two fingers farther inward as well.

There was now enough space in the middle for two feet to pass at equal width.

Wearing the new slippers, Urmila walked through once.

The left foot still went a little outward.

But she did not need to twist her shoulder.

She passed through again.

This time her body turned a little less.

She did not go through a third time.

Walking through three times would turn it into an examination again.

She went back to her work.

A week later Pradeep Babu said, “Your gait seems to have changed a little.”

Urmila asked at once, “How?”

“I don’t know.”

“Straighter?”

“No.”

“Then?”

Pradeep Babu thought.

“Slower.”

The answer surprised Urmila.

“Did I use to walk fast?”

“Not fast. You just... used to walk in the middle of doing things.”

“And now?”

“Now, when you walk, you are walking.”

Urmila did not laugh.

The sentence stayed inside her for a while.
Walking in the middle of work.
Walking while walking.
The two were not the same.
She did not ask Pradeep Babu whether that was good or bad.
She no longer needed an immediate verdict on every change.
On the tenth day she picked up the old slippers.
The stitching on the strap had opened.
Kamlesh could have stitched it again if she had wanted.
Urmila did not take them outside to throw them away.
She washed and dried them.
Then she placed them beside the back door of the house.
They would be useful for work involving mud and water.
The new slippers remained beside the main door.
The two pairs now had different uses.
And different meanings as well.
One day, in a hurry to leave for college, Neha put on Urmila's new slippers.
After two steps she stopped.
"Ma, these feel a little crooked."
Urmila looked at her.
"Crooked?"
Neha took off the slippers.
"The left one feels slightly tilted."
Urmila took the slipper in her hand.
She looked at the sole.
A very faint wear had begun along the outer edge of the left one.
She did not suddenly feel sad.
Nor did she feel that every effort had failed.
She only understood—the new slippers too were now learning her gait.
Neha put on her own slippers and went out.
Urmila held the new pair in her hands for a while.
Then she put them on the floor.
She slipped her feet into them.
She walked.
On reaching the passage, she looked at the basket of utensils.
During the night it had again shifted outward.
This time Urmila did not twist her body to get past it.
She bent down.
She lifted the basket and moved it six inches to the left.
The passage opened up.

Urmila stood straight.
Then she placed one foot forward.
This time she did not notice which foot went first.

The Silence of the Afternoon

Saumya was not in the habit of sleeping in the afternoon.

Everyone else in the house was.

At least, that was how it seemed after Sunday lunch.

That day there had been rice, masoor dal, potato curry, and mango chutney.

By the time the meal ended, it was half past one.

As Mother gathered the plates, she said, "Now sleep for a while. Study in the evening."

Grandmother added on her way to her room, "The eyes need rest too."

Uncle folded the newspaper.

Aunt took little Rinku by the arm and led her inside.

Father turned the fan a little faster.

Her younger brother Piyush protested at first, but five minutes later he too was stretched out on his bed.

Saumya watched everyone.

In the house, preparing to sleep was itself almost a collective task.

Pillows were shaken out.

Curtains were drawn halfway.

Phone ringers were switched off.

Glasses of water were placed beside pillows.

And in the end, everyone gathered up their own voices.

Saumya went to her room.

Her bed was right beside Piyush's.

Piyush lay facing the wall.

His feet stuck out from under the sheet.

Saumya opened her book.

The history chapter was about cities, trade, and routes.

She read the first paragraph.

By the time she reached the second, her attention had drifted to the sound of the fan.

The fan revolved evenly.

There was no rise or fall in its sound.

She tried to read again.

Three lines later, she realized that the words were passing before her eyes without sinking inside.

She laid the book on her chest.

Closed her eyes.

Sleep did not come.

Two minutes later she opened them.

Piyush was in front of her.

Now, when he breathed, he made a faint whistling sound.

Saumya smiled.

“Asleep?”

The question came as far as her lips, but she did not say it.

The answer was obvious.

She sat up.

On an ordinary day, that alone might have prompted Mother to ask from outside, “Finished studying?”

Aunt might have said, “If you’re awake, bring these clothes inside.”

Grandmother might have called, “Saumya, where did I put my glasses?”

Without opening his eyes, Piyush might have said, “Turn the fan up a little.”

This time nothing happened.

Saumya sat there for a while.

For the first time she understood that the silence of a house was not merely the absence of sound.

No one needing her was another form of silence.

She put her feet on the floor.

She did not put on her slippers.

The floor was cool.

She went out quietly.

In the passage, the curtain hung half drawn.

Light from outside entered in a thin strip.

Looking at that strip, she remembered no winter sunlight; she saw only motes of dust.

Even with no wind, the dust motes moved ever so slightly.

Saumya reached out and tried to catch one.

Nothing came into her hand.

She drew her hand back.

In the sitting room, Father was half-reclining on the divan.

The newspaper lay across his stomach.

His glasses had slipped a little down his nose.

Saumya stopped at the doorway.

If Father had been awake, his first sentence would have been certain:
“Studying at this hour?”

The answer to that question would have been certain too: “Yes, I’m going now.”

Today there was no question.

So there was no answer either.

It was a small thing, yet Saumya found it strange.

She went toward Uncle’s room.

The door was not fully closed.

Inside, Uncle and Aunt were both asleep.

Rinku lay diagonally between them.

One of her hands rested on Aunt’s cheek.

Saumya did not go inside.

She looked for only a moment and moved on.

The fan in Grandmother’s room was turning slowly.

Grandmother lay on her side.

Her tulsi beads lay beside the pillow.

Saumya felt that if Grandmother woke and saw her standing there, she would ask, “What do you need?”

Saumya asked herself: What do I need?

No answer came.

She went toward the kitchen.

The smell of the meal still lingered.

The utensils had been washed and put away.

A small bowl lay upside down, with a drop of water clinging to its rim.

Ordinarily Saumya would never have noticed such a drop.

Today she kept watching it.

The drop slowly grew heavier.

Then it fell.

A small round mark appeared beneath the bowl.

Saumya felt like laughing.

The sight served no purpose.

It was not even something worth telling anyone.

Yet she watched the whole thing.

In one corner of the kitchen sat the mango chutney.

Saumya loved mango chutney.

Mother usually said, “Don’t eat it again and again; it will burn your stomach.”

For a moment Saumya thought: no one is awake now.

If she wanted, she could take out one spoonful.

Then two.

No one would know.
She placed her hand on the lid of the container.
Her hand stopped at once.
She wondered whether she truly wanted chutney just then, or whether the desire had risen only because Mother forbade it.
The question was ridiculous.
She smiled at herself.
She did not open the lid.
Then it suddenly occurred to her that not opening it was also obedience to Mother's instruction.
So where was her own desire?
She took her hand away.
She came out of the kitchen.
She stood in the middle of the sitting room.
Everyone in the house was asleep.
The door was bolted from inside.
Now and then the bell of a passing bicycle sounded from the road.
From somewhere far off came the creak of a handcart being pushed.
Then everything was quiet again.
Saumya did not feel that the house was empty.
In an empty house, one feels the absence of those who are not there.
Here everyone was present.
Only their gazes, questions, and needs were asleep.
It was a different kind of solitude.
Saumya realized that she had never experienced it before.
At school, it was impossible to be alone.
There were people on the bus.
Even if she went to the roof, someone called from below.
At night everyone slept, but then she too was expected to sleep.
This afternoon was the first time no fixed task had been assigned to her.
She could read if she wished.
She could sleep.
She could draw.
She could listen to music.
She could talk to someone, if she made a call.
There was no compulsion to do anything at all.
Inside that "nothing at all" she found a small fear.
She had imagined that when free time came, she would immediately know what she wanted to do.
Now she did not know.
She returned to her room.

The book was still lying open.
The history chapter did not seem to be waiting for her.
The book was only a book.
She opened the cupboard.
Her drawing notebook was on the upper shelf.
Saumya used to draw a great deal.
For the past two years, she had drawn less and less.
She took out the notebook.
On the first page was an old tree.
On the second, the unfinished face of a woman.
On the third page, there were only two faint lines.
Saumya picked up a pencil.
She wanted to draw something.
The pencil did not touch the page.
She wondered: if I draw, what should I draw?
The window?
The fan?
The sleeping house?
Her own hand?
None of these seemed important enough to be put down on paper.
Saumya set the pencil aside.
She closed the notebook.
She felt a little irritated.
“I wanted so much time,” she said to herself, “and now that I have it, I can’t think of anything.”
She could not tell whether the voice inside that sentence was Mother’s or her own.
She went out again.
The floor in front of the divan in the sitting room was empty.
People crossed that spot all day long.
Sometimes Rinku spread her toys there and Aunt gathered them up.
Sometimes Piyush left his schoolbag there and Father said, “You’re blocking the way.”
It was not considered a place to sit.
Saumya stood there.
Then, for no reason at all, she sat down on the floor.
She stretched her legs out in front of her.
She braced her hands behind her.
She looked up at the ceiling.
From this angle, the fan looked different.
The dust beneath the blades was clearly visible.

Under the divan lay an old blue button.
Saumya realized that the button might have been there for months.
She could pick it up.
She did not.
After a while she lay down fully on the floor.
Her back against the smooth floor.
Both arms beside her body.
Her braid spread to one side.
The first sensation was coolness.
The second was the certainty that if anyone saw her lying like this, they would ask, "What happened?"
At once she prepared an answer in her mind: "My back was hurting."
Then she laughed at her own answer.
Her back was not hurting.
So another answer came: "I was looking for something."
That too was a lie.
A third: "Rinku's button had fallen."
Her gaze returned to the blue button.
That answer could become half true if she picked the button up.
Saumya began to reach for it.
Then she stopped.
It suddenly struck her that no one was even awake, yet she was preparing an explanation for what she was doing.
As if gazes could sleep, but questions could not.
The questions were awake inside her.
Why here?
Why like this?
What are you doing?
What use is it?
For how long?
She closed her eyes.
She decided in her mind: I will not make up any answer.
She was lying on the floor simply because, at that moment, she felt like lying there.
Was "I felt like it" reason enough?
Some old teacher-like voice inside her said: Make the reason clear.
Another voice said: Clear to whom?
Saumya opened her eyes.
The fan was turning.
The blue button was still there.
Father's breathing came faintly from inside the room.

No one sneezed.
No door opened.
Saumya became sharply aware of the weight of her body against the floor.
All these years, even this simple fact had never occurred to her: one did not need a pillow in order to lie down.
The floor was holding her back.
She felt no one helping her.
Nor did she feel heroic.
Only weight and coolness.
She turned her right palm over.
She placed it on the floor.
The floor was smooth.
In one corner there was a hairline crack.
She touched the crack with her fingernail.
Then she put her hand back.
She felt that in silence, things revealed their shapes more distinctly.
In conversation, every object became a function.
A glass—to give water.
A chair—to sit on.
A book—to read.
A broom—to clean.
A door—to open or close.
In silence, for a few moments, they could remain merely things.
Saumya wondered: then what about a person?
When no one called her “sister,” “daughter,” “granddaughter,” “student,” or “hey, listen,” what was she?
The question felt heavy.
She did not want to look for its answer.
She felt that the moment she searched for an answer, she would be sitting another examination.
The right answer.
The wrong answer.
Full marks.
Half marks.
She left the question where it was.
There was a slight relief in leaving it there.
From Piyush’s room came the sound of him turning over.
Saumya stiffened a little.
She thought: now he will wake.
Then he will say, “Didi.”
Piyush did not wake.

The silence spread again.

Saumya realized that she had been waiting for this silence to end.

As though something abnormal were taking place.

She thought: what if no one wakes until evening?

The thought did not frighten her.

But it made her remember the time for hunger, the time for tea, the time for studying.

The house took its cues for time from people's voices.

Grandmother's "Is the tea ready?"

Father's "It's time for the news."

Mother's "Evening has come; bring the clothes in."

Aunt's "Rinku, homework."

Piyush's "I'm going out to play."

Now, without looking at the clock, Saumya could not tell how far the afternoon had advanced.

She deliberately did not look at the clock.

This time she did not want an answer from time either.

She remained lying on the floor.

Sometimes with her eyes closed.

Sometimes open.

She was not asleep.

But neither was she performing the task of staying awake.

She was somewhere in between.

For a moment, children's voices came from the distant road.

Then a motorbike passed.

Then a dog barked somewhere.

Inside the house, the silence no longer felt as heavy as before.

A little space had opened within it.

Saumya remembered an incident from school.

One day in Class Eight, the teacher had arrived late.

For five minutes the whole class had been without a teacher.

All the children had made a racket.

Saumya too.

At the time, she had thought that the moment supervision disappeared, freedom turned into noise.

Today supervision was asleep.

She was quiet.

Yet she felt freer than before.

Why?

Again she left the question unanswered.

After a while her left arm began to go numb.

She rolled onto her side.
Her cheek touched the floor.
The coolness was stronger.
The blue button was now directly in front of her eyes.
It had four small holes.
A tiny shred of thread was caught in one hole.
Saumya wondered whose garment the button had belonged to.
There were possible answers.
Father's kurta.
Uncle's kurta.
Piyush's old pyjamas.
Rinku's clothes.
If she wanted, she could get up and inspect all their clothes.
She was curious.
Then she also understood that not every curiosity needed an answer.
A button could remain a button.
She smiled.
Just then Grandmother coughed.
Once.
Twice.
Saumya immediately planted an elbow to get up.
Her body rose halfway.
Then she stopped.
Grandmother did not cough again.
Saumya slowly lay down once more.
Her own reaction surprised her.
Grandmother coughed—she should get up.
Mother called—she should go.
The door knocked—she should open it.
The phone rang—she should check.
These had become such practiced responses that her body rose before the task had even begun.
Now, for the first time, she asked her body: Is it necessary?
The answer was: not yet.
A few moments later Grandmother really did wake.
First the cot creaked.
Then came the soft scrape of slippers.
Saumya again felt the urge to sit up.
She did not.
Grandmother came out of the room.
She looked toward the sitting room.

On seeing Saumya lying on the floor, she stopped.
“What happened?”
That was the very question Saumya had been waiting for all afternoon.
All the prepared lies came back at once.
My back was hurting.
I was looking for the button.
I was feeling hot.
My head was spinning.
Saumya looked at Grandmother’s face.
Then she said, “Nothing.”
Grandmother came two steps closer.
“Then why are you lying on the floor?”
Saumya opened her mouth.
For a moment she felt she needed a proper reason.
Then she said, “I felt like lying here.”
Grandmother kept looking at her.
Saumya thought the next question would come: Why did you feel like it?
The question did not come.
Grandmother touched the floor with her foot.
“It’s cold. Don’t lie there too long, or your body will stiffen.”
With that, she went toward the kitchen.
Saumya remained lying where she was.
Nothing very great had happened inside her.
She did not feel victorious.
Nor rebellious.
She only understood that the world had not stopped because it heard “I felt like it.”
Grandmother had not become angry.
The rules of the house had not broken.
The roof had not fallen.
The floor had remained merely the floor.
Saumya slowly sat up.
She looked at the blue button again.
This time she picked it up.
She placed it in her palm.
Then she put it on the corner of the divan.
She did not try to discover whose it was.
Grandmother had opened the tap in the kitchen.
The sound of water clearly broke the silence for the first time.
A few moments later came the light clink of utensils.

Saumya understood: that complete solitude of the afternoon was beginning to end.

Mother turned over.

Aunt moved Rinku aside and got up.

Father woke as the newspaper slipped from his stomach.

From the room Piyush shouted, "Didi, water!"

Saumya automatically prepared to get up.

Then she laughed.

"Get up and take it," she called back.

Piyush answered, "Oh, it's so far away!"

"Closer to you than to me."

Muttering, Piyush got up.

Saumya remained seated.

Mother came out and looked at her.

"Didn't sleep?"

"No."

"Did you study?"

Saumya paused for a moment.

Earlier she would have said: yes, a little.

Or: I'm going to study now.

This time she said, "No."

Mother looked at her in surprise.

"Then what were you doing?"

The whole afternoon returned to Saumya at once.

The lid of the chutney container.

Those two faint lines in the drawing notebook.

The coolness of the floor.

The blue button.

Grandmother's question.

The even sound of the fan.

She did not feel any need to decide whether all these things amounted to "something."

"Nothing," she said.

Mother looked at her for a little while.

Then she only said, "All right. Study in the evening."

She went toward the kitchen.

Saumya returned to her room.

The history book was still open to the same page.

Piyush, drinking water, looked at her.

"Nothing the whole afternoon?"

"Yes."

“Weren’t you bored?”
Saumya thought.
“At first.”
“Then?”
“Then I wasn’t.”
Piyush found the answer pointless.
He shrugged and went outside.
Saumya picked up the book.
She read the first paragraph again.
This time the words sank inside.
Cities, trade, routes.
She read three pages.
Then she closed the book.
By evening the house had returned to its familiar voice.
Doors opened and closed.
Teacups clinked.
Uncle commented on the news.
Aunt made Rinku do her homework.
Grandmother went to the tulsi altar.
Father asked Saumya a question.
Piyush called her name twice.
Mother gave her three tasks.
Saumya did them all.
She did not feel that from now on she would stop listening to anyone.
The silence of the afternoon had not made her rebellious.
Only one small thing had changed.
She felt a little less need to answer every question immediately.
After dinner Mother asked, “Tomorrow when you come back from school, you’ll study straightaway, won’t you?”
Saumya opened her mouth.
“Yes” almost came out.
Then she thought.
“I’ll rest for a while first, then I’ll study.”
Mother said, “All right.”
That was all.
No argument.
Saumya remembered the afternoon floor again.
Before going to sleep that night, Piyush asked, “Didi, whose blue button was it?”
Saumya was startled.
“Where did you find it?”

“On the corner of the divan.”

“It was there.”

“Whose?”

Saumya thought for a moment.

Then she said, “I don’t know.”

“Shall we find out?”

Saumya smiled.

“We’ll see tomorrow.”

Piyush turned off the light.

The room went dark.

Now the house was slowly moving again toward the silence of sleep.

But this silence was not like the silence of the afternoon.

In the silence of night, tomorrow’s tasks were already present.

School.

Homework.

Getting up in the morning.

Catching the bus.

That afternoon silence had been different because, for a few moments within it, even the next task had been absent.

Saumya closed her eyes.

She remembered the coolness of the floor again.

“Nothing”—Mother had asked, and that was what she had said.

This time the answer did not feel to her like laziness, guilt, or concealment.

Only a small empty space.

In which she was not an answer to anyone’s question, but simply present herself.

A Splitting Nail

Vibha's right index fingernail did not break all at once that morning.

At first, only a hairline crack appeared.

It was so fine that Vibha barely noticed it.

As she lifted the lid of the grain tin, the corner of the nail caught on the metal rim.

There was a faint sting.

Vibha pulled her hand back.

Nothing was visible from above the nail.

She closed the tin again.

The work in the kitchen went on.

Tea was set to boil.

Rotis were rolled out.

Her daughter Pragya kept looking for her schoolbag.

Her husband Mukund kept looking for his spectacles.

Vibha moved among them all in her familiar way.

No one realised that a fine crack had begun to travel through the nail of her right index finger.

Vibha did not realise it either.

When she wiped the griddle with a cloth, the corner of the nail snagged on a cotton thread.

This time she stopped.

She brought the finger up before her eyes.

A small split showed at the left corner of the nail.

"Hmm."

That was all she said.

Mukund asked, "What happened?"

"Nothing."

Vibha was about to bite the nail off, then stopped.

The split was too low.

If she cut it, she would reach almost to the skin.

She took a small strip of cloth and wrapped it around the tip of the finger.

"For that little thing?" Pragya said with a laugh.

"It catches on threads."

“It’ll be fine in two days.”

Vibha did not reply.

That day she had to complete the monthly attendance register in the school office.

Vibha had been a clerk at that school for twenty years.

Everyone said her handwriting was neat.

The spacing between names was even.

The dates stood in one straight line.

The loops of her numerals were clear.

Even her signature was almost the same size every time.

Vibha did not react much to this praise.

She would say, “If one is going to write, one should write neatly.”

She had said the sentence so often that it no longer seemed like an opinion, but part of her nature.

On reaching school, she opened the register.

She picked up the pen in her right hand.

As her index finger settled against the barrel, the nail pressed inside the bandage.

It stung.

Vibha loosened her grip.

Then she tried to write again.

The ‘r’ in the first name came out a little thicker than usual.

She did not like it.

In the second line, the ‘7’ leaned crookedly.

Vibha put the pen down.

She opened the bandage and looked at the finger.

The crack had opened a little more than before.

“Madam, do you need anything?” Ramesh, the assistant sitting opposite, asked.

“No.”

Vibha tied the bandage again.

She laid her right hand on the desk.

For a few moments the register remained open.

Her left hand was already resting on the left-hand page.

Without thinking, Vibha picked up the pen in her left hand.

All she had to do was put a small tick beside a name.

The pen touched the paper.

A tick appeared.

Vibha stopped.

It was not a beautiful tick.

But it was not unfamiliar either.

It did not look as though the hand had held a pen for the first time.
Vibha turned the pen and made another tick.
The second was cleaner than the first.
With the third, her wrist moved easily.
Vibha's gaze settled on her left hand.
"What?" Ramesh asked again.
"Nothing."
Vibha took the pen back into her right hand.
Until noon she worked slowly.
Where there was more writing to do, she used the right hand.
Where a page had to be turned, the left.
Where a stamp had to be lifted, the left.
When she picked up her cup of tea, the left hand.
When she turned a key, the left hand.
Had she always done all this, or only today?
The question was so small that at first Vibha did not even want to call it a question.
At lunchtime she opened her tiffin box.
She lifted the spoon in her right hand.
Her index finger hurt again.
She shifted the spoon to her left hand.
The first mouthful reached her mouth without any difficulty.
So did the second.
Vibha held the spoon a little away and looked at it.
The grip of her left hand was ordinary.
It did not seem to be learning.
It felt as though some old task had simply begun again.
A very old scene came back to her.
A slate.
A small wooden stool.
White chalk.
A woman's hand holding her wrist and saying—
"Not this hand. The right one."
The scene was so brief that it had neither a beginning nor an end.
Vibha closed her eyes.
Then opened them.
The spoon was still in her left hand.
"Was I left-handed?"
She whispered the question to herself.
No one could hear it.
On the bus home, Vibha rested both hands in her lap.

There was a cloth bandage around her right index finger.
 Her left hand lay open.
 She kept looking at the two as if comparing them for the first time.
 The middle of her right palm was slightly harder from holding a pen.
 There was thickened skin at the base of her left thumb too.
 "Where did this come from?"
 She could not remember.
 When she reached home, she telephoned her mother.
 Her mother lived in Madhubani with Vibha's younger brother.
 Vibha did not usually call in the evening.
 Her mother answered, "Everything all right?"
 "Yes."
 "Then?"
 Vibha was silent for a few moments.
 Then she asked, "Ma, which hand did I write with when I was little?"
 There was silence at the other end.
 Then she heard her mother laugh.
 "Why this question after so many years?"
 "Tell me first."
 "With your left."
 Vibha sat upright in the chair.
 "Really?"
 "Yes. You ate with your left hand too. Made mud houses with the left.
 Held your doll with the left."
 "Then?"
 "At school the teacher said you should be taught to write with the right.
 Everyone said that in those days."
 "You taught me?"
 "Me, your Babuji, the teacher—all of us."
 There was neither guilt nor self-defence in her mother's voice.
 The fact came out like ordinary information.
 "At first you used to get terribly annoyed."
 Vibha remembered nothing.
 "For how long?"
 "Not days. Months. I don't remember exactly, but for a long time."
 Her mother paused over the words.
 "A long time."
 Vibha said nothing even to this uncertain answer.
 "Then you began writing so well with your right hand that everyone forgot."
 "You too?"

“Yes. I hadn’t remembered it for years either.”

After the call ended, Vibha remained sitting in the chair for a long time.

Pragya was studying in her room.

Mukund had not yet returned.

The pressure cooker whistled in the kitchen.

Vibha got up.

She reached out to turn off the stove.

Her left hand went forward.

She stopped.

Her right hand was behind it.

Which hand was natural?

Why had this question never existed in her life until today?

Vibha turned off the stove with her left hand.

Then, deliberately, she touched the lid with her right.

The nail stung.

She drew the hand back again.

Mukund returned in the evening.

At the doorway Pragya told him, “Ma’s nail has broken.”

Taking off his shoes, Mukund asked, “How much?”

“This much,” Pragya said, laughing as she showed her own nail.

From the kitchen Vibha called, “Is it necessary to announce it to everyone?”

Mukund laughed.

“Everyone has been informed.”

Normally Vibha would have laughed too.

This time she did not.

Mukund looked at her face.

“Does it hurt?”

“A little.”

“Shall I put some medicine on it?”

“No.”

At dinner Vibha held the spoon in her left hand.

Mukund noticed after two mouthfuls.

“With the left today?”

Vibha stopped the spoon.

“I was left-handed as a child.”

Mukund’s hand stopped in mid-air.

“You?”

“Yes.”

“I never knew.”

“Neither did I.”

Pragya grew excited.

“So, Ma, are you actually left-handed?”

The word ‘actually’ caught somewhere inside Vibha.

She took a moment before answering.

Pragya asked again, “You are, aren’t you?”

Vibha looked at her right hand.

Every register from twenty years of work had been filled by this hand.

Thousands of signatures.

Pragya’s first school application.

The household accounts.

The names of her mother’s medicines.

Little notes for Mukund.

All with the right hand.

Then she looked at the left.

She had very few memories about that hand.

Only a few movements the body performed without thought.

“I don’t know,” Vibha said.

Pragya looked disappointed.

“Such a simple question!”

Vibha smiled.

“It doesn’t seem simple anymore.”

That night she did not go looking for old papers.

She did not try to inspect anyone’s photographs for which hand she had used.

For a moment she had wanted some proof, but in that desire too she recognised her old way of doing things.

A question arose: find proof.

Find proof: reach a conclusion.

Reach a conclusion: straighten the line.

That night the line did not straighten.

Lying in bed, Vibha wrote her name in her mind.

‘Vibha.’

She could clearly see the letters formed by her right hand.

What the letters of her left hand had been like—she could not remember.

The next morning the crack in the nail had widened a little more.

As she opened the bandage, one edge caught in the cloth.

Vibha felt irritated.

She picked up the nail clippers.

She cut the nail back as far as it was safe to cut.

The index fingernail was now shorter than the others.

Vibha spread her hand and looked at it.

The unevenness was obvious.
But her attention did not remain on the nail for long.
She picked up the tumbler used for brushing her teeth.
Left hand.
She opened the cupboard.
Right hand.
She tied her braid.
Both hands.
She strained the tea.
The left hand held the strainer; the right held the spoon.
“What have I been looking at all these years?” she thought.
There was no answer.
At school that day she conducted a small experiment.
She took out a blank sheet of paper.
She held the pen in her left hand.
She tried to write her name.
As she formed ‘Vi’, the line trembled.
The vowel mark in ‘bha’ went crooked.
The whole name looked like a child’s first attempt at writing.
Vibha kept looking at it.
No miracle occurred.
She did not feel some old beautiful handwriting returning from inside her body.
The left hand had forgotten how to write.
Or perhaps the left hand had never been allowed to learn writing in the first place?
Vibha wrote it a second time.
This time the letters were a little clearer.
She did not write it a third time.
She folded the paper and put it in the drawer.
Ramesh came in.
“Madam, a signature is needed.”
Vibha took the paper.
She picked up the pen in her right hand.
Because the index fingernail was short, her grip shifted slightly.
The signature came out a little broader than usual.
Ramesh took the paper and left.
He did not pause over the signature even once.
Vibha felt a small laugh rise in her.
Until yesterday she had thought of her neat handwriting as almost a natural extension of her personality.

Today it seemed to her that it too was practice.

Twenty years of practice.

Why should that make it less valuable?

But if something made by practice can come to feel like nature, then how does one measure nature?

In the afternoon the headmistress, Shashi Devi, came into the office.

Glancing at one register, she said, "Vibhaji, looking at your handwriting gives me peace of mind. Everything is in order."

Vibha was about to say, as she usually did, "The work itself demands it."

Then she stopped.

"I've had a great deal of practice."

Shashi Devi said matter-of-factly, "Practice is what becomes skill."

She left.

Vibha thought about that ordinary sentence for a long time.

Practice is what becomes skill.

Then why should practice be the opposite of nature?

And why should nature be the opposite of practice?

When Vibha returned home that evening, her mother called again.

"Did yesterday's conversation upset you?"

"No."

"I was thinking—would it have been better if we had let you write with your left hand?"

Vibha searched for an answer.

"I don't know."

"In those days, that was what all of us believed."

"I'm not angry with you."

"Then?"

Vibha looked towards the window.

Outside, a child from the neighbourhood was throwing a ball.

The child threw with the right hand and caught with the left.

"I'm thinking, Ma, about how many things I have accepted about myself without ever thinking about them."

Her mother was silent.

"Everyone does," she said at last.

"Yes."

"What will you do now? Write with your left?"

Vibha laughed.

"No. It's easier to write with the right."

"Then what is the problem?"

Vibha laughed again.

"That is exactly what I'm trying to understand."

After the call, Pragya came with her homework.

“Ma, look at this problem.”

Vibha took the notebook.

Pragya was holding the pen in her right hand.

For the first time Vibha asked her daughter, “Which hand feels natural to you?”

Pragya looked surprised.

“The right.”

“Do you ever do anything with the left?”

“On the playground I pick up the ball with my left.”

“That is a hand too.”

Pragya laughed.

“Ma, are you going to research every hand now?”

“No.”

“Then explain the problem.”

Vibha explained it.

That night, while folding clothes, Vibha noticed that her left hand caught the first corner of a dupatta while the right made the fold.

While rolling rotis, the left hand turned the dough ball and the right moved the rolling pin.

When opening the door, the key was in the right, the latch in the left.

When tying her hair, both were equal.

Life did not belong to one hand alone.

Then why had the sentence “I am right-handed” always seemed so complete?

Because she wrote with her right hand?

Or because society identifies a person’s hand by the hand with which they write?

Vibha smiled at her own question.

She was not writing a treatise on society.

Only one fingernail had split.

Yet the small split in that nail had opened so much space inside her that she was beginning to feel irritated with herself as well.

“How many days are you going to think about this?” Mukund asked.

“As long as I feel like it.”

“And when the nail heals?”

“We’ll see.”

Mukund took her right hand in his.

“Does it still hurt?”

“Very little.”

“Then it’s fine.”

Vibha did not pull her hand away.
Mukund's hand held her right hand.
Vibha's left hand lay open on the table.
Two days later she no longer needed the bandage.
The nail was short, but the crack was no longer spreading.
Vibha began writing again at her usual pace.
Her right hand recovered its old speed.
What surprised her was that the left hand did not disappear again.
The teacup often rose in that hand.
She pushed the heavy door panel with it.
While cutting vegetables, the knife was in her right hand and the bowl in her left.
Nothing had changed.
But Vibha noticed now.
One Sunday, while cleaning an old drawer, she found the sheet on which she had written her name with her left hand.
She opened it.
The first 'Vibha' trembled.
The second was a little clearer.
The third had never been written.
An empty space remained.
Vibha picked up a pen.
She held it in her left hand.
Then stopped.
Did she need to write the third name and complete the experiment?
The old Vibha would have said at once—yes, complete the sequence of three.
Now she laughed.
She folded the paper and put it away again.
The third space remained empty.
A few days later a new student was admitted to the school.
The small child wanted to write his own name on the form.
He held the pen in his left hand.
The child's father casually reached to shift the pen into the right hand.
Vibha's eyes went there.
For a moment she held her breath.
Then the father himself stopped.
"You write with your left hand?"
The child nodded.
"Then write."
That was all that happened.

Vibha said nothing.
There was no need for her to say anything.
Slowly, the child wrote his name.
The letters were crooked.
A vowel mark landed in the wrong place.
Smiling, the father straightened the paper.
“You’ll learn to write it properly.”
Vibha looked at her right index finger.
The broken part of the nail was slowly moving forward.
New nail was growing from behind.
The old crack had almost reached the edge now.
In two or three days it could be clipped away.
There was no mystery in that small growing nail.
The body grew at its own pace.
Practice formed at its own pace.
Some natural ease remained.
Some natural ease changed.
Vibha opened the register.
She held the pen in her right hand.
With her left, she straightened the page.
She wrote the new student’s name.
The letters were as neat as before.
Looking at them, this time she did not think, “This is me.”
Nor did she think, “This is only something learned.”
She understood only this much—it was the work of one of her hands.
The other hand was holding the page.
And on the paper lying between the two hands, it was not her name but a
child’s name that was being written.
Vibha smiled.
The short nail of her right index finger touched the edge of the page.
There was no sting.

The Smell of Cut Fruit

Aniruddh Jha had not learned how to cut a pineapple in his village.

He had learned it in Doha.

It was only much later that he remembered this fact.

That evening, in the small kitchen of the workers' accommodation, a knife was in his hand.

The green leaves crowning the pineapple were still stiff.

Outside, June's heat remained trapped in the walls even after nightfall.

The kitchen exhaust fan rattled on.

A fine layer of dust lay over the floor.

And the shoes of four men lay piled over one another by the door.

Suresh Mahato said, "Cut off the crown first."

Aniruddh laughed.

"I know that much too."

"If you know it, then cut it."

"The peel?"

"Cut that too."

"How thick?"

Suresh almost snatched the knife from his hand.

"Are you cutting fruit or timber?"

Everyone in the kitchen burst out laughing.

Aniruddh was forty-two then.

He lived more than four thousand kilometres from home.

He worked on a warehouse maintenance team.

All day he moved among lists, tools, screws, pipes, dust and heat.

Cutting fruit was not on his list of duties.

When he lived at home, someone else usually cut the fruit.

First his mother.

Later his wife, Nilima.

When their child was small, Nilima cut fruit for him as well.

Aniruddh's share usually arrived as ready-cut pieces on a plate.

During his first months in Doha, he rarely bought fruit at all.

It seemed expensive.

And keeping things in a shared kitchen was difficult besides.

Whose bananas someone had eaten, whose milk had diminished, whose container someone had knocked over and put back—small quarrels kept arising over such things.

One day Suresh brought home a pineapple.

The only reason was that it had been cheap in the market that day.

Suresh was from Siraha.

Ravindra was from Samastipur.

Yusuf was from Kerala.

Aniruddh was from Madhubani district.

The four men slept two to a cot in the same room.

Their languages were different.

Their food was different.

But the language of exhaustion at night was not so very different.

Suresh pared the pineapple.

Thinly.

So thinly that the round eyes of the peel remained in the fruit.

Then he turned the knife on a slant.

One row of eyes came out.

Then another.

Then a third.

A spiral line appeared around the fruit.

Aniruddh watched closely.

“All this work?”

“If you don’t do it, half the fruit gets thrown away.”

Aniruddh took that sentence simply as a rule for cutting fruit.

Years later he understood that it might also have been a rule for living in Doha.

Do not be quick to throw away what can still be saved.

The first time the pineapple was cut, a sweet-sour smell filled the kitchen.

There was something green in the smell.

Something sticky-sweet.

Something that seemed to reach all the way behind the nose.

At the time, Aniruddh connected it with no home at all.

Pineapple had scarcely been cut even once a year in the house of his childhood.

There were mangoes.

Jackfruit.

Bananas.

Guavas.

Wood apples.

Jamun.

Pineapple was a market fruit.
 Not a household fruit.
 So that night the smell of pineapple was merely the smell of pineapple.
 The four men sat around the plate.
 Suresh counted the pieces.
 "Twelve."
 Ravindra said, "Four people—three each."
 Yusuf ate two pieces and left the third.
 "Too sweet for me."
 Aniruddh said, "But it's sour too."
 "Too sweet for me."
 Suresh put the remaining piece in a container for the next day.
 That was how pineapple entered their shared kitchen.
 Gradually, cutting fruit became Aniruddh's responsibility.
 Because he learned quickly.
 And because whatever a person learns, other people are quick to turn into that person's responsibility.
 Aniruddh used to laugh about it.
 "I came here fixing pipes and turned into a fruit seller."
 Suresh would say, "Not a fruit seller. A divider of shares."
 "How so?"
 "You cut equal pieces."
 It was true.
 Aniruddh cut the pieces almost the same size.
 Unequal shares displeased him.
 Pineapple, melon, watermelon—whatever it was, he cut and arranged it on the plate so that no one would feel his share had come out smaller.
 Some months later, Yusuf returned from the night shift and asked, "Any fruit today?"
 Aniruddh said, "No."
 Yusuf drank water and went to sleep without showing disappointment.
 But the next day Aniruddh bought fruit and brought it back.
 Why, he himself did not know.
 Perhaps because, for the first time, someone had waited for fruit he had cut.
 The years passed.
 The room changed.
 Roommates changed.
 The employer changed.
 Even the colour of the city's roads kept changing.
 But the way Aniruddh used the knife scarcely changed.

A thin peel.
 A spiral cut.
 The hard core removed.
 Equal pieces.
 First the plate in the middle.
 Then each person his share.
 Sometimes at midnight.
 Sometimes at five in the morning.
 Sometimes on a holiday afternoon.
 Meanwhile, the word home was used often in his life.
 His mother would say on the phone, "When are you coming home?"
 Nilima would say, "The damp on the roof at home has spread again."
 His son Ishan would say, "Babu, if you were here, we could all go out
 somewhere."
 At the warehouse the manager would ask, "When are you taking home
 leave?"
 His companions would say, "Going home in December?"
 The meaning of the word home changed with the context.
 For his mother, home was the old house in the village.
 For Nilima, it was the rented flat in Darbhanga.
 For Ishan, it was the small room on the second floor of that flat.
 For Aniruddh?
 He did not think about the question.
 The answer seemed simple enough—the village.
 Where he had been born.
 Where there was a neem tree in the courtyard.
 Where his father's old trunk still stood.
 Where the family deity was.
 Where the papers for the land were kept.
 That was home.
 Everywhere else was merely a place to stay.
 He carried that sentence within him without ever writing it down.
 One year, during the rains, he got leave and went to the village.
 Nilima and Ishan had arrived earlier from Darbhanga.
 His mother had stopped plastering the courtyard with mud, but she still
 swept it herself.
 Everyone was delighted when Aniruddh arrived.
 For the first two days he was fed like a guest.
 From the third day onward, he was treated as a man of the house and
 given work.
 Look at the drain on the roof.

Tighten the door latch.
Go to the bank.
Pay the electricity bill.
Look over Ishan's school papers.
Aniruddh grew tired, but there was a sense of belonging in that tiredness.
One evening he saw a pineapple in the market.
Whole, not cut.
He bought it without thinking.
His mother asked as soon as she saw it, "Why this?"
"It's fruit."
"I can see that much myself."
Nilima burst out laughing.
Ishan grew excited.
"Will Babu cut it?"
Aniruddh asked for a knife.
The pineapple was set on a low wooden seat in the courtyard.
He cut off the crown.
He pared the peel thinly.
He cut out the rows of eyes on a slant.
His hands moved in their own rhythm.
His mother kept watching.
"Where did you learn to do it that way?"
"In Doha."
"This fruit was never cut like that in our house."
Aniruddh's hand stopped for a moment.
Only for a moment.
Then it moved again.
The knife turned through the fruit.
A sweet-sour smell rose.
And the smell did not bring back his childhood in the village.
Not the neem tree.
Not his mother's kitchen.
Not the earth after rain.
Not his father's voice.
It brought back the small kitchen in Doha.
The rattle of the exhaust fan.
Four pairs of shoes.
Suresh saying, "Don't cut it so thick."
Yusuf leaving his third piece.
Ravindra's night shift.
The small steel plate.

And a kind of exhaustion after which cutting fruit had become a form of rest.

Aniruddh was startled.

The smell was in the village.

The memory belonged to Doha.

The fact felt almost improper to him.

As though a foreign place had entered the old courtyard.

He worked the knife more briskly.

Nilima asked, "What happened?"

"Nothing."

The pieces were cut.

His mother took one.

"It's sour."

Ishan said, "I like it."

Nilima said, "So do I."

Aniruddh picked up a piece for himself.

The taste was all right.

The smell was more familiar.

That night he sat on the veranda for a long time.

His mother had gone inside to sleep.

Nilima was in the room with Ishan.

A small discomfort kept circling in Aniruddh's mind.

If home was only the village, why had a smell rising in home's courtyard reminded him of a foreign country?

The question was simple.

There was no answer.

The next day he asked his mother, "Did I eat pineapple when I was a child?"

His mother laughed.

"Since when have you become so concerned about pineapple?"

"I just asked."

"No. Very rarely. I remember your maternal uncle brought one once."

"Who cut it?"

His mother thought for a while.

"Perhaps your father. Or me. Who knows now?"

Aniruddh did not get the answer he had expected.

In truth, there had been no expected answer.

He only wanted to make sure his memory was not mistaken.

Pineapple belonged to Doha.

Not to the village.

That much was confirmed.

But the discomfort did not go away.
In the final week of his leave, Aniruddh went to the flat in Darbhanga.
Nilima lived there because of Ishan's school.
The small kitchen window of the flat opened toward the road.
Outside the window was a web of wires.
Below, passenger vehicles stopped and moved on.
Aniruddh usually called that place "Nilima's flat."
Sometimes, "the place in Darbhanga."
Very rarely, "home."
That night, as Nilima cooked rotis, she said, "Does this leave feel as though it's ending too quickly?"
Aniruddh said, "Yes."
"Had enough of the village?"
"Can one ever have enough of home?"
Nilima turned the roti.
"Of your home?"
The question was ordinary.
Aniruddh got caught inside it.
"What do you mean?"
"Nothing. When you're in the village, you're in a hurry to return to Darbhanga. When you're in Darbhanga, you remember work in the village. When you reach Doha, we keep asking—when are you coming home?"
Nilima laughed.
"Your home travels around a great deal."
Aniruddh laughed too.
But the sentence stayed inside him.
The next day Ishan said, "Babu, cut a pineapple, please."
There was no pineapple in the house.
Nilima said, "Go buy one."
Aniruddh went to the market.
He bought the fruit.
He cut it in the flat's kitchen.
The smell rose.
This time he remembered the room in Doha.
And the village courtyard as well.
Because now the village courtyard too had acquired an incident attached to that smell.
He understood that smell does not carry memory only back to old places.
A smell also becomes attached to new places.
The thought was very ordinary.
But it was new to Aniruddh.

As he cut the fruit, he made four small piles.
One for Ishan.
One for Nilima.
One for himself.
His hand made the fourth pile out of habit.
Aniruddh stopped.
There were three people in the kitchen.
Nilima asked, "Who is this fourth one for?"
Aniruddh looked at the plate.
Then he laughed.
"Habit."
"Whose share were you making?"
"Everyone's."
When Ishan reached for the fourth pile, Aniruddh did not stop him.
Ishan left his own pile and took a piece from the fourth.
Something inside Aniruddh grew lighter.
A share that had not been named for anyone could be shared.
The leave ended.
Aniruddh returned to Doha.
Suresh no longer lived in that room.
He had returned to Nepal and then gone on to another country.
Yusuf lived in different accommodation.
Ravindra had returned to India and started a small business.
There were new roommates—Faizal, Manoj and Dilbahadur.
The kitchen had changed.
The exhaust fan was new.
The old steel plate was gone.
Aniruddh did not buy fruit during his first week back.
There was too much work.
One night Manoj brought a pineapple from the market.
"Jha ji, will you cut it?"
Aniruddh's hand rose of its own accord.
"Give it here."
The knife moved.
The smell rose.
This time the smell did not take him to any one place.
The low seat in the village courtyard.
The narrow kitchen in Darbhanga.
The old room in Doha.
The new room in Doha.

Everything was present in a single instant, without any one place displacing another.

This time Aniruddh felt no discomfort.

He made the pieces equal.

Manoj asked, "How do you manage to cut them so evenly?"

Aniruddh said, "Many years of practice."

"Learned it at home?"

Aniruddh fell silent at the question.

Then he said, "In homes."

Manoj did not understand.

"What?"

"Nothing."

The fruit was shared.

Before going to sleep that night, Aniruddh called Nilima.

Ishan was studying.

Nilima asked, "Have you eaten?"

"Yes."

"What did you eat?"

Aniruddh gave her the list.

Dal.

Rice.

Vegetables.

Then he said, "Pineapple too."

Nilima laughed.

"Now this has become your fruit."

"Mine?"

"Wherever you go, you keep cutting it."

Aniruddh was silent on the phone.

Nilima moved on to another subject.

The school fees.

His mother's medicine in the village.

The drainage problem.

Aniruddh listened.

After the call ended, he stared for a long time at the dark screen of the phone.

For so many years he had tied the meaning of home to place.

Land.

Walls.

Courtyard.

Address.

Papers.

Birth.

None of those things was false.

But they were incomplete.

That night, for the first time, he understood that some homes are made of memory.

Some are made of responsibility.

Some are made of waiting.

Some are made of small habits repeated so long that a person does not realize he is making a place his own.

Cutting fruit was one such habit.

But Aniruddh did not turn the thought into a theory.

He was tired.

He wanted to sleep.

The following week, Faizal was preparing to return to his country.

The room was full of piles of belongings.

Shoes apart.

Clothes apart.

Gifts apart.

There was no plan for fruit.

That night Faizal said, "Tomorrow is my last night. Shall we make something?"

Dilbahadur said meat.

Manoj said kheer.

Aniruddh said, "I'll cut the fruit."

Faizal laughed.

"That's already decided."

The next night they brought pineapple, melon and oranges.

Aniruddh kept cutting.

The smell of pineapple rose again.

Faizal kept talking about his home.

His mother.

His wife.

Two children.

A half-built room.

A debt.

A small field.

Manoj began talking about his home.

Dilbahadur did too.

After a while, everyone's "home" had become a different map.

Aniruddh listened.

It no longer seemed to him that one home was real and the others less real.

Someone owned his house on paper but lived there only twenty days a year.

Someone's home was rented, but his children had been born there.

Someone's home was still being built.

Someone's home had been sold, but in conversation it still existed in the present tense.

The fruit was cut.

The plate was set in the middle.

Aniruddh had made the pieces equal.

Faizal left his third piece of pineapple.

"Too sweet."

Aniruddh burst out laughing.

He remembered Yusuf.

Yusuf too used to leave his third piece.

For the same reason.

The memory came with the smell.

But this time the memory did not pull him backward.

It was simply like an empty place on the plate.

Where someone had once sat.

And someone else sat now.

Two months later his mother fell ill.

Aniruddh could not return immediately.

Nilima went to the village.

Medicine, tests, doctors, expenses—everything was discussed over the phone.

The old guilt rose inside Aniruddh.

Far from home.

The weight of that sentence grew heavier again.

One night he asked himself—if there are many homes, does that lessen the guilt of living far away?

The answer came at once—no.

Changing the meaning of home does not reduce responsibility.

Sometimes it increases it.

He sent money for his mother's medicine.

He submitted an application for leave.

He kept asking Nilima for updates again and again.

And amid all this, at night, he kept cutting fruit for the people in his room.

One day Manoj said, "You're worried. Leave it, I'll cut it."

Aniruddh handed him the knife.
 Earlier he would have said—no, I'll do it.
 This time he handed it over.
 Manoj cut the pineapple peel far too thickly.
 The words escaped Aniruddh's mouth on their own: "Not that thick."
 Both of them laughed.
 Aniruddh did not take the knife back.
 He kept watching the thick peel.
 Some fruit came away with it.
 The world did not end.
 There was less fruit.
 The shares were smaller.
 Even so, everyone ate.
 His mother's health improved gradually.
 His leave was approved.
 Aniruddh reached the village again.
 This time he had brought no pineapple with him.
 On the first day he simply sat in his mother's room.
 She was weak, but she talked a great deal.
 "Why do you have to live so far away?"
 Aniruddh knew the answer.
 Earnings.
 Debt.
 Ishan's education.
 Repairs to the house.
 His mother's medicine.
 But he did not give her the list.
 He only said, "It's the work."
 His mother fell silent.
 After a while she said, "You've come home. That much is enough."
 Aniruddh looked at his mother's face.
 "Ma, which one is home?"
 His mother frowned.
 "What sort of question is that?"
 "Just asking."
 His mother gestured toward the courtyard.
 "This."
 Then, after a few moments, he asked, "Not Darbhanga?"
 His mother said, "That too."
 "Doha?"
 His mother laughed.

“Is your bed there? Your utensils? Do people look for you there?”

“Yes.”

“Then you decide.”

His mother turned over.

For her, the philosophical importance of Aniruddh’s question had ended.

That afternoon Nilima brought fruit.

Mangoes.

Bananas.

A small pineapple.

“Ishan said Babu would cut it.”

Aniruddh picked up the fruit.

He took a knife and sat in the courtyard.

His mother watched from the window of her room.

Ishan sat in front of him.

Nilima beside him.

Aniruddh cut off the crown.

The peel came away thinly.

The rows of eyes came out on a slant.

The sweet-sour smell filled the air.

This time no single place came to his mind.

The memories came, certainly.

But not in sequence.

Not old first, new later.

All at once.

Suresh.

Yusuf.

Manoj.

The low seat in the village courtyard.

The window in Darbhanga.

The exhaust fan in Doha.

His mother’s room.

Ishan’s eager eyes.

Aniruddh cut the pieces.

He made three piles.

Then his hand moved to make a fourth.

He did not stop.

He made the fourth pile too.

Ishan asked, “Who is this for?”

Aniruddh said, “Whoever comes.”

No visitor was expected.

The fourth share on the plate waited, empty of any name.

A little later, a small child from the neighborhood came into the courtyard.

Ishan pointed toward the fourth pile.

“Eat.”

The child picked up a piece.

Aniruddh watched him.

The smell of pineapple was still in the air.

This time, within that smell, the word “home” did not take on any one face for him.

There was only a plate.

There were a few people.

And there was one share that had not been named in advance for anyone.

Beneath the Fan

After four days of fever, lying in bed, the ceiling had begun to seem to Jaynarayan Mishra the most familiar part of the house.

The wall clock was to his right.

The window to his left.

But his eyes stayed fixed above for most of the time.

An old fan turned on the ceiling.

Three blades.

Grey in colour.

A faded blue stain near the end of one blade.

The stain was so small that on healthy days he would never have noticed it.

Now that stain was the most regular visitor in his day.

The blue stain came.

Went.

Came again.

Went again.

Jaynarayan counted silently—one, two, three.

Then one again.

Then two.

Then three.

After a while he would lose the count.

He would begin again.

“One.”

“Two.”

“Three.”

Sharda came in through the doorway.

She had a glass of water in her hand.

“Counting again?”

Jaynarayan kept his eyes raised.

“No.”

Sharda smiled.

“I can tell just from the sound.”

“I count aloud?”

“Your lips keep moving.”

Jaynarayan stilled his lips.

The fan went on turning.

The blue stain came round again.

Sharda placed the glass on the table.

“Drink some water.”

Jaynarayan tried to sit up.

Sharda raised the pillow a little.

He drank two sips of water and lay back down.

“What day is it today?”

“Thursday.”

“Yesterday?”

“Wednesday.”

“And the day before?”

“Tuesday.”

Jaynarayan closed his eyes.

He could feel no difference among the three days.

In the morning his temperature had been taken.

He had been given something to eat.

He had been given medicine.

He slept.

He woke.

He was given water to drink.

Someone phoned.

Someone asked how he was.

Evening came.

Night came.

Then morning again.

For three days the sequence had been such that the days seemed not to change at all; only the blue stain on the fan kept returning to the same place again and again.

“Why Thursday?” slipped from his mouth.

Sharda did not understand.

“What?”

“Why Thursday after Wednesday? To me it feels like the same day.”

Sharda drew the window curtain aside a little.

The afternoon light fell in a square on the floor.

“The day has changed.”

“Proof?”

“Yesterday the sunlight was here.”

She pointed to the floor near one leg of the bed.

“Today it is over there.”
Jaynarayan tried to turn his neck.
His temple felt heavy.
He looked back at the fan.
“But this is the same.”
“The fan?”
“Yes.”
Sharda said, “Its very job is to turn.”
Jaynarayan did not answer.
The blue stain came again.
It struck him that turning was not merely a task; it was also a kind of
proof.
What keeps moving comes back to the same place.
Then to the same place again.
And again.
In illness, time did not seem like a line to him.
It seemed like a circle.
He tried to remember his healthy days.
Getting up in the morning.
Bathing.
Tea.
The newspaper.
Walking to the shop.
Lunch.
A little rest.
The evening market.
Dinner.
Sleep.
That too was a circle.
The only difference was that on healthy days he moved along the circle.
Now the circle turned above him.
Sharda began wiping the window frame.
“Shall I change your clothes?”
“Later.”
“By the time you keep saying later, you’ll be soaked in sweat again.”
“Everything here happens again.”
Sharda stopped.
“What?”
“Water. Medicine. Clothes. Food. The fan. Everything again.”
Sharda looked at him.
“So?”

“Nothing moves forward.”

Instead of answering, Sharda removed the pillowcase.

It took her two minutes to put on a fresh one.

There was a pale yellow stain on one corner of the old case.

The new case was clean.

“This did not happen again,” Sharda said.

“What?”

“The pillowcase.”

Jaynarayan tried to smile.

“It will be changed again tomorrow.”

“But tomorrow’s pillowcase will not be this one.”

Sharda carried the old case outside.

Jaynarayan kept looking at the fan.

The blue stain came round.

He thought—the stain itself is exactly the same.

The stain does not change.

There was a fine layer of dust on the rest of the blade.

From below he could not tell whether dust had collected around the edge of the blue stain as well.

He narrowed his eyes and looked.

Each time the stain seemed exactly the same.

He wished he could stop the fan and look at it closely.

But if the fan stopped, he would feel hot.

He let the wish go.

In the afternoon his son Nachiketa phoned.

Sharda held the phone to his ear.

“Babu, how are you?”

“Fine.”

“Has the fever come down?”

“If you say so.”

“Shall I come this evening?”

“Why leave your work?”

“Work can wait.”

“There is nothing new here.”

For a little while there was no sound from the other end of the phone.

“I don’t want to see something new. I want to see you.”

Jaynarayan’s gaze remained on the fan.

The blue stain was circling.

“I’m right here.”

Nachiketa said softly, “That isn’t what I mean.”

Jaynarayan did not understand what exactly he meant.

Sharda took the phone.
She went outside and spoke for a while.
Jaynarayan counted one revolution.
Then a second.
Then a third.

It dawned on him not suddenly but gradually that what he felt inside before those three turns during the phone call was not the same as what he felt after three more turns.

Before, Nachiketa's coming had seemed unnecessary.

Now there was a little expectation.

The fan kept turning at the same speed.

Then where had expectation entered the circle from?

He liked that question.

More than the answer.

Nachiketa had not come by evening.

Rain began.

Water started striking the windowpane.

Outside, the peepal leaves flipped and flashed.

The fan's air and the outside wind collided with one another.

The curtain sometimes billowed inward, sometimes outward.

Jaynarayan watched that back-and-forth movement.

The curtain too seemed to be circling.

But each time its fold was different.

Sometimes one corner lifted high.

Sometimes the middle of the cloth swelled.

Sometimes only the edge trembled.

He looked back at the fan.

The blue stain came.

This time the shape of the curtain behind it had changed.

The blue stain came again.

This time a thick stream of water was sliding down the pane.

It came again.

The light outside had dimmed a little.

"The same place," Jaynarayan said to himself.

Then he corrected his sentence.

"The same place—but not the same time."

The sentence seemed a little too neat to him.

He let it go.

Nachiketa came at night.

After changing his wet kurta, he sat beside his father.

He had two small guavas in his hand.

“Found them in the market.”

“Did the doctor say fruit is allowed?” Sharda asked.

“Not now,” Nachiketa said. “I’ll keep these for tomorrow.”

Jaynarayan looked at the guavas.

For tomorrow.

The words were small.

But for the first time that day, tomorrow seemed to him like a separate thing.

The guavas were placed on the table.

Not now.

Tomorrow.

The fan kept turning.

The blue stain came.

Went.

The guavas remained where they were.

That night Jaynarayan did not sleep for a long time.

Nachiketa had gone home.

Sharda sat leaning against the small cot beside him, dozing.

The room light was off.

A thin line of light from the veranda entered beneath the door.

The fan blades were not clear in the darkness.

The blue stain had disappeared.

Even so, from the sound of the fan he could tell it was turning.

Air fell across his head.

An even rhythm.

He thought—when the stain cannot be seen, where does the circle go?

The turning still continues.

To see a circle, one needs a mark.

Without the mark, only the air remains.

He tried to turn onto his side.

His right shoulder hurt.

Sharda woke.

“What do you need?”

“Nothing.”

“To turn over?”

“Yes.”

Sharda shifted the pillow a little.

Jaynarayan lay on his left side.

Now the fan was no longer directly above his eyes.

He could see the wall.

A thin strip of light beneath the door.

Two round shadows of the guavas on the table.
 Sleep came to him.
 When he opened his eyes in the morning, the fan was still.
 At first he was startled.
 Then he understood that the power had gone out.
 The room was hot.
 All three blades of the fan were motionless.
 The blue stain was clearly visible.
 The stain was not at the very tip of the blade but a little inward from it.
 Its shape was not round.
 Narrow on one side, broad on the other.
 Jaynarayan wondered why, while it was turning overhead, the stain had seemed so uniform.
 A still object was more complicated.
 A moving object was simple.
 Sharda came with a hand fan.
 "Where has the electricity gone?"
 "The whole lane is without it."
 "For how long?"
 "Who knows."
 Sharda began fanning him by hand.
 The air was uneven.
 Strong once.
 Weak the next time.
 In between, her hand grew tired.
 Then she changed the rhythm.
 Jaynarayan kept looking at the motionless ceiling fan.
 The blue stain no longer turned away and returned.
 It was stuck in one place.
 Yet time had not stopped.
 Outside, the milkman passed.
 The voices of children going to school came from the lane.
 Utensils clinked in the neighbouring house.
 The square of window-light shifted across the floor.
 Sharda's hand tired.
 She took the hand fan in her left hand.
 Sweat appeared on Jaynarayan's forehead.
 The smell of the guavas on the table grew a little stronger.
 The minute hand of the clock moved forward.
 The still fan remained silent amid all of it.
 A small laugh came to Jaynarayan.

“What happened?” Sharda asked.

“Nothing.”

“This is the first time in four days you have laughed on your own.”

“You count that too?”

“I count many things.”

Jaynarayan looked at her.

“What things?”

Sharda said while moving the hand fan, “Medicine times. How much water you drink. When the temperature was taken. How many times you woke at night. How often your clothes were changed. Who phoned. How much you ate.”

She paused.

“And?”

“And when you say, ‘I’m fine,’ while your face says you aren’t.”

Jaynarayan smiled.

“You are in a circle too.”

Sharda stopped her hand.

“Me?”

“The same tasks again and again.”

Sharda thought for a few moments.

Then said, “Perhaps.”

“Then does time feel the same to you?”

“No.”

“Why?”

Sharda did not answer at once.

The hand fan began moving again.

“Yesterday you ate two bowls of porridge.”

“And today?”

“Today you were full after half a bowl.”

“That is not good.”

“But yesterday, when you sat up, you had to hold my hand. Today you sat up without holding it.”

Jaynarayan was silent.

“Last night you asked for water five times. Tonight, twice.”

Sharda said.

“The tasks repeat, but the account is not the same.”

Jaynarayan looked at the ceiling.

The motionless fan.

The blue stain.

“Do you write all this down?”

“No.”

"Then how do you remember?"
 "Because I am the one doing the work."
 The answer did not seem pleasing to him; it seemed true.
 After a while the electricity returned.
 The fan started with a jerk.
 Slowly at first.
 Then a little faster.
 The blue stain came round once.
 A long time later, a second time.
 Then the interval shortened.
 Then the speed became even.
 Jaynarayan began to count once.
 "One..."
 He stopped.
 The blue stain came again.
 He did not say the number.
 Sharda came after washing the guavas.
 "Shall we eat yesterday's fruit today?"
 Jaynarayan said, "Today."
 Sharda cut off a small piece for him.
 Jaynarayan chewed slowly.
 The taste was mildly sour.
 After that Sharda opened the window.
 There was wind outside.
 Mingling with the fan's air, it made the curtain tremble slightly.
 The blue stain kept circling.
 In the afternoon his temperature was taken.
 Sharda looked at the number.
 She said nothing.
 Jaynarayan asked, "Compared with yesterday?"
 "A little lower."
 "How much?"
 Sharda told him the number.
 Jaynarayan looked at the clock.
 Then at the fan.
 "What was I doing at this time yesterday?"
 "Sleeping."
 "And today?"
 "Asking questions."
 Jaynarayan laughed.
 The laugh was small.

But it caused a slight pull in his chest.
He fell quiet.
Later in the afternoon Nachiketa came again.
This time empty-handed.
“The guavas?”
“We ate them.”
“Good.”
He sat at the foot of the bed.
“Babu, do you feel like going outside?”
Jaynarayan considered his answer.
For the previous four days, the question of outside had seemed meaningless to him.
Now he wanted to see the peepal leaves beyond the window.
“Up to the veranda.”
Nachiketa and Sharda looked at one another.
“Now?”
“Yes.”
Together they slowly helped him up.
His legs trembled a little as soon as his feet touched the floor.
Jaynarayan gripped the edge of the bed.
He looked up at the fan.
The blue stain was turning.
Rising from beneath it and going outside felt to him as though a line were emerging from the middle of a circle.
The metaphor seemed too contrived to him.
He threw it away in his mind.
Nachiketa held his arm and led him to the veranda.
The air on the veranda was different.
Not direct.
Sometimes on the cheek.
Sometimes on the neck.
Sometimes nowhere at all.
A bicycle passed on the road in front.
A dog changed its patch of shade.
On the clothesline hung Sharda’s washed pillowcase.
Jaynarayan recognised it.
It was the same old case with the yellow stain, washed and now hanging in the sun.
The stain had faded.
It had not vanished completely.
He thought—the blue stain too would fade one day.

Whether the fan would still be turning then, who could know.
There was no fear in the thought.
Only an ordinary uncertainty.
A few minutes later he returned to the bed.
He was tired.
Sharda straightened the sheet.
“That is enough.”
“Yes.”
“Again tomorrow.”
This time Jaynarayan smiled at the word “again.”
Again did not have to mean the same thing.
Again could also mean another time.
Evening fell.
The light on the wall slowly climbed upward.
The shadow of the fan blades on the ceiling was sometimes sharp,
sometimes blurred.
Jaynarayan was not waiting for the blue stain.
Even so, it came.
His eyes caught it.
It went.
Came again.
This time the light in the room behind the blue stain was a little more
yellow.
It came again.
Sharda sat on the small cot untangling thread.
It came again.
A child laughed somewhere outside.
It came again.
A minute advanced on the clock.
It came again.
Sharda loosened the knot in the thread.
It came again.
Jaynarayan’s eyelids grew heavy.
He wanted to count.
One.
Two.
Three.
In the old sequence.
But after the third, the next number did not come automatically.
His attention moved to Sharda’s hands.
The small knot in the thread had opened.

Sharda was winding it up.
The fan kept turning above.
The blue stain came again.
This time Jaynarayan did not say the number.

The Half-Written Name

Renuka Mishra stepped inside the municipal library while waiting for the rain to stop.

It was hard to count how many times in the past seven years she had passed in front of that library.

On her way to the vegetable market.

On her way to the bank.

On her way to the post office.

While going to catch a bus.

While returning with someone.

She had always seen the name painted on the blue board above the door, but she had never had a reason to go inside.

That day, the reason was rain.

The Bhadon rain broke so suddenly that the dust on the road turned to mud within two minutes.

Renuka gathered her sari a little and climbed onto the library veranda.

Inside, a fan was turning slowly.

Five men sat at four tables reading newspapers.

In one corner, two students sat with books open before them.

Old magazines stood in glass-fronted cupboards along the wall.

Instead of remaining on the veranda, Renuka went inside.

The young man seated behind the service desk pushed his glasses up his nose.

“Please sit. The rain is heavy.”

Renuka smiled.

There were three empty chairs in front of the service desk.

She sat down on one of them.

For some time, only the sound of the rain could be heard.

Water struck the tin awning as though a thousand tiny grains were falling all at once.

Renuka's eyes went to the magazines lying in front of her.

She picked one up.

As soon as she turned the first page, an old familiar smell rose from it—a mingling of paper, dampness, and dust.

She used to go to the library at school.
At college too.
And after that?
After that, there had been books at home.
The child's textbooks.
Thin recipe booklets.
A novel borrowed from someone now and then.
Sometimes a story collection from Aditi's syllabus.
The thought of sitting in a library and choosing a book for herself came to her after a very long time.
The rain showed no sign of easing.
Renuka placed the magazine back on the service desk.
"Can books be taken home from here?"
The young man said, "Yes, if you have a membership."
"How much does it cost?"
He told her the amount.
It was not a sum that required thought.
"Make me a member."
The young man pulled a yellow application form from beneath the service desk.
"Fill this in. The two photographs can be given later as well. We need a copy of an identity document. You can submit the application now."
Renuka took a pen out of her bag.
The first line of the application form read—
Name:
Without thinking, she began to write.
A
Di
The pen stopped after she had written "Adi."
Renuka kept looking at the paper.
Three letters.
Adi.
"Ti" wanted to come next.
Her hand was ready.
But the name was not hers.
Aditi was her daughter.
Renuka lifted the pen.
The young man at the service desk was entering someone else's book in the register.
He did not notice.
Renuka kept her eyes fixed on the three letters.

Her first impulse was to laugh.

What had happened?

She laughed inwardly.

She had read "Name" and begun writing her daughter's name.

Aditi was in Pune now.

She had started her job three months earlier.

Her own rented room, her own bank, her own identity card, her own office.

And Renuka, in a library in Darbhanga, had begun writing Aditi's name on an application for her own membership.

She drew a straight line through "Adi."

The line came out slightly crooked.

Beneath it, she wrote clearly—

Renuka Mishra.

Even after the name was complete, her hand remained there for a moment.

The next line—Age.

She wrote it.

Address.

She wrote it.

Phone.

She wrote it.

Occupation.

At this line she paused again.

She did sewing and embroidery from home, but should that be called an "occupation"?

Over the past twenty years, blouses, kurtas, curtains, pillowcases, and children's clothes for so many people in the neighbourhood had been made by her hands.

She was paid too.

Sometimes little.

Sometimes reasonably well.

She wrote—

Sewing work.

This time her hand did not pause.

She filled in the application and handed it to the service desk.

The young man glanced over it.

"There is a correction in the name."

"Yes."

"Shall I give you a new application?"

Renuka looked again at the three letters.

Adi.
A crooked line across them.
Renuka Mishra beneath.
“No. It can be read, can’t it?”
The young man looked a little surprised.
“Yes, it can be read.”
“Then it is fine.”
He said nothing.
He placed the application to one side.
The rain had eased a little.
Renuka stood up.
As soon as she stepped outside, she laughed again at her mistake.
Aditi’s name.
Why?
The answer seemed very simple to her.
For years, she had been filling in application forms.
The first school.
“Student’s Name”—Aditi Mishra.
“Date of Birth”—16 July.
“Mother’s Name”—Renuka Mishra.
“Father’s Name”—Manohar Mishra.
Aditi had been five years old then.
She did not yet know how to write properly.
Renuka had filled everything in.
Then the admission form for the second school.
Then the scholarship.
Then the science exhibition.
Then the sports competition.
Then the library membership card.
Then examinations.
Then college.
Then the hostel.
Some applications Aditi filled in herself.
But after filling them in, she would bring them to her mother.
“Just check it once.”
Renuka would check the date.
She would check the name.
She would check the spelling.
She would check the date of birth.
She would see whether the photograph had been pasted in the right place.
She would see where the signature was required.

So often Aditi would say impatiently,
“Ma, it’s fine.”
Renuka would say,
“Checking that something is correct is also part of making sure it is correct.”

Aditi would roll her eyes.
Now she filled out her applications herself.
She did not show them to Renuka.
That was a good thing.
Renuka had always wanted her daughter to manage her own papers herself.

But her hand?
The hand knew only the practice of years.
It saw “Name.”
And Aditi began.
When she reached home, she took off her wet slippers outside.
Manohar was sitting in the drawing room reading the newspaper.
“You got this wet?”
“The rain caught me.”
“Umbrella?”

Renuka opened her bag and looked inside.
The umbrella was there.
She burst out laughing.
“I had an umbrella and still went into the library.”
Manohar lowered the newspaper.
“The library?”
“Yes. I’m becoming a member.”
“Good.”

Renuka paused slightly at the word “Good.”
There was neither enthusiasm nor objection in it.
Only ordinary acceptance.
“I filled in the application.”
“All right.”
She wanted Manohar to ask—What book will you borrow?
He did not ask.
Renuka did not volunteer the answer either.
She went to the kitchen and changed her sari.
She put water on the stove.
While making tea, her eyes fell on an old magnetic strip stuck to the metal cupboard in the kitchen.
Aditi’s Class Twelve timetable had once been fixed there.

Now only the strip remained.

Renuka strained the tea.

One cup for Manohar.

One for herself.

She brought the cups into the drawing room and set them down.

"Did you speak to Aditi today?" Manohar asked.

"Last night."

"Is work going well?"

"Yes."

"Is the room all right?"

"Yes."

"Food?"

"She cooks."

Manohar smiled.

"She couldn't even make tea before."

Renuka ran a finger along the rim of her cup.

"She could. You wouldn't drink it."

"Me?"

"Yes. She made it once. There was too much sugar. You said, 'Her mother makes it better than this.'"

Manohar thought for a moment.

"I don't remember."

"She will."

Having said this, Renuka herself fell silent.

Who remembers what?

Who forgets what?

And what does the hand remember?

In the evening she sat down at the sewing machine.

She had to finish a blouse for a neighbour.

As she folded the cloth, she noticed that she still picked up the measuring tape exactly the way her mother had taught her in the first year of her marriage.

Before cutting thread, she held it lightly between her teeth.

Her mother used to say—when the scissors are in your hand, why hold the thread in your teeth?

But the habit had never gone.

Are habits a form of identity?

If her hand wrote Aditi first, did that mean Renuka had somehow become less herself?

No.

The answer was so obvious that her own question seemed a little theatrical to her.

She started the machine.

Tak-tak-tak.

The seam ran straight.

Without thought, her foot increased and decreased the pressure.

This was the practice of her hands and feet.

Writing Aditi's name was practice too.

And yet something inside her remained caught.

If it was merely habit, why had seeing "Adi" made her so uneasy?

After dinner, Renuka opened the old metal cupboard.

On the upper shelf were three bundles of papers.

One for household papers.

One for bank papers.

One for Aditi's education.

She took out the third bundle.

Manohar asked,

"What are you looking for?"

"Nothing."

She sat on the floor and opened the bundle.

On the first application, Aditi's name was in her handwriting.

Rounded letters.

Aditi Mishra.

Beneath it, "Mother's Name"—Renuka Mishra.

Renuka's own name was in smaller letters, slightly slanted.

She opened the second paper.

Aditi Mishra.

The third.

Aditi Mishra.

On papers from a few years later, the handwriting had changed.

Aditi's own hand.

A little faster.

The lines straighter.

Renuka's signature beneath.

All at once, something became visible to her—

Where there was "Name," for many years the daughter had been written.

Where there was "Parent's Signature," there was Renuka.

Her name had not disappeared.

It had simply lived in a different place.

Not in the first line.

In the lower corner.

In that corner was responsibility.
 Renuka sat holding the papers in her hand.
 She did not like the idea of tying everything in life into a single sentence.
 "I was always in the lower corner."
 That would be untrue.
 So many decisions in the household had begun with her in the first line.
 Without anyone's permission.
 She had made the decision to change Aditi's school.
 Manohar had not agreed at the time.
 She had also decided to buy the sewing machine.
 And during her mother's treatment, she had chosen the hospital.
 So the problem was not that she had always been "second."
 The problem was that different tasks taught the hand different sequences.
 When one spends years caring for someone, whose face appears first
 behind the word "Name" is not the final truth of identity.
 Renuka tied the bundle again.
 One old paper remained in her hand.
 Aditi's Class Eight science exhibition application.
 Her daughter's name at the top.
 The subject below.
 Then "Supervising Teacher."
 At the very bottom, "Parent's Consent."
 There was Renuka's signature.
 Seeing the signature reminded her of another habit of her hand.
 When signing any paper, she had never once written Aditi's name.
 The movement of a signature was different.
 Renuka Mishra.
 Like a single breath.
 She did not even need to write out the whole signature consciously; the
 practice of years had turned it into a shape.
 Writing a name and signing it were not the same thing.
 In one place she was filling in someone else's identity.
 In the other she was giving her own consent.
 Her hand remembered both.
 She placed the old application back in the bundle and closed the
 cupboard.
 That night Aditi called.
 "Ma, what are you doing?"
 "I was looking at some papers."
 "Whose?"
 "Your old ones."

“Why again?”
 “Just like that.”
 Aditi laughed.
 “Do you still have the science-exhibition one from Class Eight?”
 “Yes.”
 “Throw it away.”
 “Why?”
 “It is of no use.”
 Renuka smiled faintly.
 “Not every paper is kept because it is useful.”
 “Ma, you’re being very sentimental now.”
 “Say it.”
 “No, say it in Maithili now and it will sound right.”
 Both of them laughed.
 Renuka said,
 “Today I filled in an application for myself.”
 “For what?”
 “The library.”
 “Really?”
 “Yes.”
 “That’s good. What book will you take?”
 Renuka paused at the question.
 Manohar had not asked it.
 Aditi did.
 “I don’t know yet.”
 “Choose whatever you feel like.”
 “Whose wishes have I been choosing by until now?”
 Aditi fell silent.
 “Mine?”
 Renuka laughed.
 “Sometimes.”
 “All right. Now choose for yourself.”
 The sentence made Renuka slightly uncomfortable as soon as she heard it.
 “Now for yourself”—as though everything until now had belonged to
 someone else.
 “Aditi,” she said, “it isn’t quite that simple.”
 “What happened?”
 “Nothing. I’ll choose a book and call you.”
 “All right.”
 The call ended.
 Renuka remained holding the phone for some time.

“Now for yourself.”

Such sentences sound good.

But life is rarely divided into such clean sections.

Had the applications she filled out for her daughter not been part of her own life?

Was the practice of writing Aditi's name again and again not part of the history of her own hand?

If she said, “I had forgotten my own name,” that would be untrue.

She had not forgotten her name.

She had only changed the first answer to the word “Name.”

And now perhaps that answer would change again.

Two days later there was no rain.

Renuka went to the library carrying a copy of her identity document and two photographs.

The same young man was at the service desk.

“Application?”

He searched through a file and took out the yellow sheet.

From a distance, Renuka recognised the three letters she had crossed out.

Adi.

The line.

Renuka Mishra beneath.

The young man pasted the photograph.

He attached the copy.

He wrote something in the register.

Then he turned the application form towards her.

“Sign here.”

Renuka signed without thinking.

The pen did not pause even once.

The young man picked up the application.

Renuka looked at it.

On the first line at the top was a crossed-out, half-written name.

Beneath it was her full name.

At the very bottom was her signature.

All three were made by the same hand.

The application did not look ruined to her.

It was not neat and spotless.

But it was legible.

“Your membership card will be ready next week,” the young man said.

“You may take one book now.”

Renuka went towards the shelves.

For five minutes she read the names.

Some familiar.
Some unfamiliar.
At first she wanted to pick up a book by one of Aditi's favourite authors.
Her hand moved towards one book.
She stopped.
This time, stopping was not a crisis.
She left the book where it was.
She opened another cupboard.
She took out a thin book of stories by an author whose name she did not recognise.
She opened it and read two lines.
She could not yet decide whether she would like it.
That was precisely why she took the book.
At the service desk, the young man wrote the book number in the register.
"Member's name?"
Renuka opened her mouth.
This time it was not the hand's turn, but the voice's.
She did not think.
"Renuka Mishra."
The young man wrote it down.
Renuka put the book in her bag.
Outside, there was sunshine.
As soon as she stepped onto the road, she remembered the yellow application.
Aditi, half-written.
Renuka, complete.
The signature below.
She did not wish to make the application clean again.
The line would remain on the paper.
So would the three letters.
They were not merely evidence of a mistake.
They were the old movement of her hand.
And the full name written beneath them was not a new birth.
It was simply the correct applicant for that day.

Before the Lamp Went Out

The first day, the white line drawn across the middle of the courtyard seemed very thin to Kusum Jha.

The mason had dipped a string in limewash, stretched it taut between two ends, and snapped it against the ground.

For an instant, the string trembled.

Then a straight white mark appeared on the red-brick floor.

“From here?” Kusum had asked.

Rolling up his measuring tape, the mason had said, “This is where it is on the papers.”

This is where it is on the papers.

After those five words, the courtyard had split into two parts.

The portion on the left belonged to Kusum’s husband, Naresh.

The portion on the right belonged to his younger brother, Mahesh.

The house was old.

The walls were thick.

The veranda was long.

The courtyard in the middle was square.

Naresh and Mahesh’s father had inherited this house from his own father.

For years, the shares had been recorded on paper, but there had been no line on the ground.

As long as Babuji was alive, no one had even raised the matter of drawing one.

For two years after his death, too, everything went on as before.

Then the two brothers sat down to calculate the education of their sons and daughters, loans, repairs, taxes, and the future.

The matter had not begun with a quarrel.

It had begun with clarity.

“What belongs to whom should remain clear,” Naresh had said.

Mahesh had agreed.

Kusum, too, had agreed.

Meenakshi—Mahesh’s wife—had been the first to say, “If everything stays clear, there will be no questions among the children later.”

The papers were taken out.

The old measurements were checked again.
 For two days, the record-keeper came.
 One day, the mason came.
 Then came the lime line.
 After the line was drawn, Kusum's first surprise was how quickly the places
 in the house that had seemed to her like one thing could become two.
 Before, there had been "the tap."
 Now there were "our tap" and "their tap."
 Before, there had been "the veranda."
 Now there were "this side of the veranda" and "that side of the veranda."
 Before, there had been "the clothesline."
 Now there were two clotheslines.
 Before, the pickle jars were placed wherever the sunlight was best.
 Now, before setting down a jar, one looked at the line.
 The line was very thin.
 But the language of the house kept making it thicker.
 In the first week, Kusum left her slippers on the wrong side three times.
 "Auntie, these are your slippers!" Mahesh's daughter Tanvi had said,
 laughing.
 Kusum had laughed too.
 After that, she began leaving her slippers beside the pillar of her own
 veranda.
 Once, Meenakshi's brass lota wandered over to this side of the line.
 Kusum picked it up and placed it back on the other side.
 Meenakshi said, "Let it stay there. What harm does it do?"
 Kusum had replied, "Now that things have been decided this way, let
 them remain this way."
 There was no anger in that answer.
 There was order.
 Kusum liked order.
 She liked clothes folded neatly.
 She liked the grain tins labeled by name.
 She liked keys on their own hooks.
 Spices in their own containers.
 Money in its own purse.
 Work at its proper time.
 The line did not oppose this temperament; it seemed almost an extension
 of it.
 And yet, in some places, the line snagged against daily life.
 The courtyard drain ran diagonally.

Rainwater flowed from the right-hand corner toward the drain by the left gate.

The old tap stood a hand and a half on the other side of the line.

The tulsi altar stood on this side.

But the little brass bowl used for filling water at the altar had for years remained beside the tap.

“Whose is this?” Tanvi once asked jokingly.

Kusum had tapped her lightly on the head.

“Whose can water for tulsi be?”

Tanvi burst out laughing.

“Look at the papers.”

Everyone laughed.

Some things could still make a joke of the papers.

But gradually the jokes became fewer.

There had already been two separate kitchens, because Naresh’s work hours and Mahesh’s shop hours were different.

Now even the movement between the two kitchens diminished.

Before, if Meenakshi ran out of salt, she would take a pinch from Kusum’s jar without asking.

Now she stood at the doorway and asked.

Before, if Kusum saw the lentils boiling on Meenakshi’s stove, she would lower the flame.

Now she stopped her hand.

“That is her work.”

With that sentence, many small hands began to stop.

Whether Kusum liked this or not, she herself could not say clearly.

Often, she felt relief.

Why should every task be hers?

At other times, an emptiness.

If a task was not hers, why should her eyes go there either?

Eight months passed.

The lime line was wiped away many times.

Then drawn again.

In the rains, half of it vanished.

Naresh mixed lime and straightened it himself.

“Once the wall is built, we won’t have to keep drawing the line again and again,” he had said.

The wall had been part of the plan from the beginning.

It was to be built when enough money had been saved.

A wall three hands high.

Low enough for air and light to pass across the courtyard, but high enough to keep the division clear.

Kusum agreed with this too.

“A low wall is fine,” she had said.

Meenakshi said, “Should there be a small gate in the middle?”

Naresh had immediately replied, “Why a gate? Then it will become the same coming and going again.”

Mahesh had remained silent.

Kusum too had said nothing.

Meenakshi changed the subject.

The day for building the wall was fixed—the last Monday of Kartik.

Two evenings before that, the electricity had begun going off repeatedly.

Whenever the power failed in the old house, a brass lamp was brought out.

It was not a ritual lamp.

It was simply the house’s old source of light.

When Kusum’s mother-in-law had first come to this house as a new bride, the lamp had already been there.

A thick, round belly.

A broad rim.

On one side, a spout-like groove for holding the wick.

A cotton wick in mustard oil.

When the electricity went, the lamp was placed beside the pillar between the veranda and the courtyard.

From there, a little light reached both sides.

Once battery lamps arrived, the brass lamp was needed less often.

Even so, during long cuts, Kusum still took it out.

The battery ran the fan.

And a small bulb.

But Naresh would say, “It is good to keep the old lamp. You cannot trust the electricity.”

Kusum kept the lamp clean.

It had no glass, so there was little soot.

She trimmed the wick.

The oil tin was kept separately.

And the little lid used for putting the lamp out had its own place.

She never blew out the flame.

She simply lowered the small round brass lid over it.

Within two breaths, the flame shrank.

Then darkness.

That Saturday evening, the electricity went out at seven.

Within half an hour, the battery began giving its warning beep.

"The battery has grown weak," Naresh said.
 Mahesh lit a small battery lamp on his side.
 Kusum brought out the brass lamp.
 She set it on the little platform beside the old pillar near the line.
 The pillar stood on this side.
 So did the lamp.
 But its light did not obey the line.
 The yellow circle fell over both portions.
 Tanvi brought her book to the light.
 "Auntie, may I study here for five minutes?"
 Kusum said, "Sit."
 Tanvi placed her low stool on her own side of the line and sat down.
 The lamp was in the middle.
 Her brother Neel came too.
 "I have writing to do."
 From the doorway, Meenakshi said, "You have your own light, don't you!"
 Neel replied, "That light hurts my eyes."
 Kusum laughed.
 Naresh arrived with the newspaper.
 "The letters are still clearer in the light of this lamp," he said.
 "Then why are you wearing spectacles?" Kusum asked.
 Naresh laughed.
 Mahesh arrived a little later as well.
 Four people were sitting on both sides of the line.
 The lamp was making a pool of light in the middle.
 For a moment, the scene looked to Kusum as it had in the old days.
 Then her eyes dropped.
 In the yellow light, the lime line looked even whiter.
 As though the lamp were not erasing it but bringing it into sharper relief.
 Tanvi closed her book.
 "Auntie, the wall will start going up on Monday, won't it?"
 "Yes."
 "Then I won't be able to sit here and study?"
 Kusum replied naturally, "You'll sit on your own side."
 Tanvi said nothing.
 Neel said, "Then there will be separate light on each side."
 Mahesh gave him a light tap on the head.
 "You understand too much."
 Kusum did not laugh at that sentence.
 She began watching the lamp's wick.

At nine, the electricity had still not returned.
Dinner was cooked separately in the two kitchens.
Even so, the lamp in the courtyard kept burning.
At ten, Tanvi went back to her side.
Neel had already gone to sleep.
Mahesh went to his room with the shop accounts.
Meenakshi began washing the dishes.
Kusum put her own kitchen in order.
She gave Naresh his medicine.
She checked the doors.
She closed the oil tin.
Now only the lamp remained in the courtyard.
Power-cut darkness altered the old architecture of the house.
The veranda pillars looked thicker.
The doorways deeper.
The corners of the courtyard farther away.
The lime line shone in one place in the yellow light and disappeared into shadow in another.
Kusum pulled over a low stool and sat beside the lamp.
She wanted to think about Monday's wall.
But her thoughts did not move in a straight line.
She remembered that on the first day after the line was drawn, Meenakshi had forgotten her broom on this side.
The broom had lain in Kusum's veranda for three days.
No one noticed.
Then one day Kusum had picked it up and placed it on the other side.
She remembered that last Phagun, Tanvi had fallen ill.
In the middle of the night Meenakshi had knocked at Kusum's door looking for medicine.
The line had been there that night.
But Kusum, running over with the medicine, had not even looked at it.
Then she remembered that two months earlier Meenakshi had placed a pickle jar on this side to turn it into the sun.
That day Kusum had stopped her.
"Look at the line."
Meenakshi had picked up the jar.
Kusum wondered: why was the line invisible on the night of a sick child?
And why was it visible on an afternoon with a pickle jar?
No answer came at once.
The lamp flame leaned slightly.
Kusum looked at the wick.

The oil was low.
She thought, I won't add any more now.
Everyone is going to bed.
I'll put the lamp out.
She stood up.
The brass lid was kept in the niche in the pillar.
She reached for it.
Just then she heard the tap dripping on the other side.
It seemed Meenakshi had not shut it completely.
Drip.
Drip.
Drip.
At first Kusum thought, "It is their tap."
Then she thought, if it drips all night, water will collect and keep the drain wet.
She thought of calling Meenakshi.
"Meenakshi!"
The call had risen only halfway up her throat.
Just then the lamp flame became very small.
Kusum was about to reach for the lid.
The flame turned blue once.
Then thin and yellow.
Then, without wind and without breath, it went out on its own.
Darkness came so quickly that Kusum's raised hand remained suspended in the air.
For an instant she could not even see her own palm.
The smell of hot lamp oil remained.
The drip of the tap sounded clearer.
Kusum stood still.
She knew where the matches were.
On the kitchen wall, above the small box.
The phone was inside too.
She could call Naresh.
But Kusum did nothing.
Drip.
Drip.
Drip.
She began walking toward the tap.
Her first step avoided the edge of the pillar's little platform.
Her second fell on the crack where, years earlier, one brick had sunk slightly.

Her third crossed the narrow run of the drain.
Kusum was not thinking.
Her body was walking.
Her hand stretched forward.
It found the cold iron mouth of the tap.
She turned it shut.
The dripping stopped.
In the darkness, the silence suddenly became enormous.
Kusum's hand was still on the tap.
Then she realized—she was standing on the other side of the line.
Even after that thought came, the line itself was invisible on the ground.
Kusum did not try to find it with her foot.
She simply stood there.
She realized that on the way to the tap, her body had not hesitated even once.

The line existed in memory.
But not in the map of her feet.
Her feet were still walking through the courtyard they had known before the lime line.

One pillar.

One sunken brick.

One drain.

One tap.

One path.

The papers said there were two shares.

The body was still reading a single courtyard.

Something became clear to Kusum not all at once, but very slowly.

She was not against the wall.

She liked the shares to be clear.

She understood that for the future of Naresh's and Mahesh's children, the papers needed to be unambiguous.

But for the last eight months she had also been doing something else—trying to carry the paper's line fully into her memory, her hands, her voice, and her gaze.

Even where the papers said nothing.

The tap was "theirs."

The jar was "theirs."

The flame under the lentils was "theirs."

The child's book was "theirs."

The sunlight on the veranda was "ours."

The pillar's shadow was "ours."

She understood that creating order and cutting through history were not the same act.

She had mistaken them for one.

The darkness had made that distinction clearer than light.

Kusum removed her hand from the tap.

At that moment, the door to Meenakshi's kitchen opened.

"Who is it?"

Meenakshi's voice was heavy with sleep.

Kusum said, "It's me. The tap was dripping."

"You're over there?"

Kusum paused for two moments before answering.

"Yes."

Meenakshi switched on the small light of her phone.

A faint white glow spread across the courtyard.

The lime line became visible again.

Kusum really was standing on the other side.

Her right foot was nearly two hands inside the line.

Meenakshi looked at her.

Kusum looked at the line.

Neither of them said "the wrong side."

Meenakshi only asked, "Did the lamp go out?"

"The oil ran out."

"Shall I give you a light?"

Kusum said, "No. I know the way."

With that she turned.

The phone light remained in Meenakshi's hand.

Kusum deliberately did not look toward it.

She returned in the same three steps.

The drain.

The sunken brick.

The pillar.

This time the line was visible, but Kusum did not pause her foot while crossing it.

Back on her side, she touched the brass body of the lamp.

It was still warm.

The lid was no longer needed.

She left it where it was.

From inside, Naresh asked, "Did you put the lamp out?"

Kusum said, "It went out by itself."

"You should have checked the oil."

Ordinarily Kusum would have replied, "I'll fill it tomorrow."

But she only said, "Yes."

That night, as he was falling asleep, Naresh said, "The mason will come at seven on Monday."

"Yes."

"We'll have to mark the line clearly again. Half of it has faded."

Kusum lay looking at the ceiling in the dark.

"Won't he understand the line from the papers?"

"He will, but having the mark on the ground will make it easier."

Kusum said nothing.

Soon Naresh fell asleep.

Kusum had no grand decision in mind.

She was not thinking of stopping the wall.

Nor of erasing the line.

Nor of once again borrowing salt from Meenakshi as in the old days.

She understood only that in eight months she had given a thin line far too many additional meanings.

A boundary of ownership.

A boundary of work.

A boundary of memory.

A boundary of sympathy.

A boundary of sight.

She had laid them all on the same line.

In the darkness, her body had refused to carry that burden.

The next morning, Kusum cleaned the lamp.

She trimmed the charred end of the wick.

She filled it with oil.

She wiped its brass belly with a cloth.

Then she put the lamp back in its old niche.

In the morning light, the lime line looked pale.

While drinking tea, Naresh said, "We'll have to bring lime today."

Kusum said, "Bring it."

At that moment Meenakshi was filling a bucket at the tap.

When the bucket was full, she shut the tap completely.

Without thinking, Kusum looked toward the tap.

Meenakshi looked toward her too.

Whether either of them smiled was difficult to say.

Their eyes simply met.

On Monday, the mason arrived.

Sand.

Mortar.

Bricks.

Measuring tape.

Naresh and Mahesh both stood in the courtyard.

The mason looked at the old line.

"The wall goes on this?"

Naresh said, "Yes."

The mason took out his string.

Kusum stood at the doorway of her kitchen.

Meenakshi stood on her side.

The string was pulled taut.

Straight from the tap to the gate.

Then the mason stopped.

"There's one thing," he said.

"What?" Mahesh asked.

"This drain runs diagonally through here. If the wall is closed all the way down, it will be hard to clean. We'll have to leave an opening at the bottom."

Naresh said, "Put in a small pipe."

The mason looked at the ground.

"Rubbish will get stuck in a pipe. Better to leave it wide enough for a hand to go through."

Mahesh said, "Then leave it."

Naresh thought for a moment.

"How much?"

The mason showed the measure with his hand.

"This much. We'll leave out two bricks."

Kusum came out of the kitchen.

"Leave a little more," she said.

Everyone looked at her.

Kusum pointed toward the drain.

"So a broom can go through by hand. The drain fills up often."

Naresh said, "Four bricks?"

"Three are enough."

The mason nodded.

"All right."

That was all.

No one called it a symbol.

No one said the house had become one again.

By afternoon, half the wall had risen.

Three hands high.

Near the drain, an opening three bricks wide.

A person could not pass through that opening.

A hand could.

A broom could.
 Water could.
 After the mason left in the evening, Kusum stood beside the wall.
 The courtyard now truly looked like two parts.
 The line had become a wall.
 Whether she felt sorrow, she could not tell at once.
 But one thing was clear—the words on the papers had now acquired a
 body of brick.
 Tanvi peered over from the other side.
 “Auntie!”
 The three-hand-high wall came just below her chin.
 “What?”
 “Can I sit here and study?”
 Kusum looked at the top of the wall.
 “You can put your book on it.”
 Tanvi tried setting the book there.
 It was thick enough.
 “It has made a good table.”
 Kusum laughed.
 That night the electricity went out again.
 Kusum brought out the brass lamp.
 The old pillar’s platform now lay on this side of the wall.
 She placed the lamp there as before.
 The flame caught.
 The yellow light climbed to the top of the wall.
 On the other side, the edge of Tanvi’s book gleamed.
 The sound of Meenakshi’s dishes came across.
 Naresh was searching for the newspaper.
 Mahesh was speaking to a customer on the phone.
 The house went on doing its separate work in its two halves.
 Kusum checked the oil in the lamp.
 This time there was enough.
 At ten, the house grew quiet.
 Kusum lifted the lid to put the lamp out.
 Before lowering it over the flame, her eyes went to the three-brick
 opening at the bottom of the wall.
 Through it, a thin piece of darkness from the other side was visible on this
 side.
 A little water shone in the drain.
 Kusum slowly lowered the lid over the lamp.
 The flame grew small.

The wall's shadow deepened.
The yellow light contracted.
Then the lamp went out.
This time the darkness was not unexpected.
Kusum stood still.
She could not see the tap.
Nor the drain.
The line had now become a wall.
But she knew where everything was.
She turned toward her own side.
Her feet found the right path.
Behind her, through the three-brick opening, came the faintest sound of
water.
Kusum did not feel any need to stop it.

Red Dust

The afternoon air was dry.

Nayan was flying a kite on the roof.

The kite was blue.

A narrow yellow strip ran through the middle of the blue paper.

While making it, Nayan had torn the paper twice.

So the third time his mother had held the paper while Nayan applied the glue.

The kite's bamboo bow was slightly crooked.

Nayan said that was why it caught the wind.

His mother said that was why it kept veering to the right.

Both were partly right.

That day the kite really did veer to the right.

Toward the empty field in front of the roof.

The field had not been empty for three days.

People had been coming and going there since morning.

The surveyor had come.

Two bamboo stakes had been driven into the ground.

A long measuring cord had been stretched across the field.

Nayan watched everything from above.

The wind carrying his kite had no concern with that cord.

Once the kite passed over it.

Then dipped low.

Then rose again.

Below, Nayan's father, Nandkishore, shouted—

“Mind the cord!”

At first Nayan thought he meant the kite string.

But his father was looking at the surveyor.

“The line will not pass through here.”

On the other side stood Ramanand Kaka.

He was not really Nayan's uncle.

By village reckoning, he was a kaka.

By the reckoning of the land, there was now nothing certain between him and Nayan's father.

Ramanand said—
“The old boundary ridge was right here.”
Nandkishore said—
“The old ridge was over there.”
The surveyor had his measurement register open.
He read out a few numbers.
The wind does not understand numbers.
The kite veered right again.
Nayan let out a little more string from the reel.
The blue paper flashed.
Then, below, one of the stakes was uprooted.
Nayan did not see who pulled it out.
His eyes were on the kite.
One voice rose.
Then five voices behind it.
The measuring cord went slack.
One man picked it up and began stretching it again.
Another pushed his hand away.
Someone's foot came down on the dry boundary ridge.
The soil was cracked.
Red dust rose.
First ankle-high.
Then knee-high.
Then so high that the feet of the people in the field vanished.
Nayan's kite was coming down.
He pulled the reel toward himself.
The string drew taut.
For a few moments the kite climbed again.
Then the wind changed direction.
The blue paper disappeared behind a curtain of red dust.
Nayan could see only the string.
A thin string.
Glinting in the sunlight.
Then that too disappeared from sight.
The reel suddenly grew light.
Nayan's hand jerked backward on its own.
The string had snapped.
Below, the quarrel had now shed clear words and become only sound.
“Mine—”
“Yours—”
“Measurement—”

“Papers—”

“Boundary—”

The dust swallowed the rest of the words.

His mother came up to the roof.

“Come downstairs.”

Nayan showed her the reel.

The broken end of the string trembled on it.

“The kite fell.”

“Come down first.”

“It went into the field.”

His mother caught him by the arm.

“No one is going to look for a kite in that field now.”

Nayan went downstairs.

Water was drawn from the earthen pot in the courtyard.

His father came home a little later.

The edge of his dhoti was red.

There was soil on his elbow.

His mother asked—

“Are you hurt?”

“No.”

Nayan looked at his father's elbow.

The skin there was scraped.

There was no blood.

Only dust stuck to it.

His father washed his hands.

Red water ran into the drain.

There was no boundary of the field in that water.

His father went inside.

People came into the courtyard.

Then others came.

No one asked Nayan about the kite.

Everyone talked about the field.

“Who pulled out the stake?”

“What did the surveyor say?”

“How many cubits does the paper show?”

“Where did the old mango tree stand?”

Nayan remembered where the old mango tree had stood.

Two years earlier his red kite had got caught in that tree.

The tree was gone now.

Its trunk had been cut down.

Whether the roots still lay beneath the soil, Nayan did not know.

The afternoon began to decline.
The number of people in the courtyard dwindled.
His mother went into the kitchen.
His father was in the front room looking at papers with two men.
Nayan picked up the reel.
Four finger-widths of the broken string protruded from it.
He did not tie a knot in it.
Holding the reel, he slipped out through the back gate.
At the turn in the lane, dust still hung in the air.
The sun looked not yellow but pale red.
On the path leading to the field there were so many footprints that it was impossible to find the old ones.
Nayan walked slowly.
His mother had told him that the kite was not to be searched for in the field now.
She had not said how long “now” lasted.
By his own reckoning, Nayan decided that now was over.
At the edge of the field, the first bamboo stake lay tilted.
The second was missing.
The measuring cord lay on the ground.
It was white.
But half of it had turned red.
Nayan stopped beside the white cord.
From a distance he thought it was his kite string.
He bent down.
The moment he saw its thickness, he knew—it was not his.
It was the surveyor’s cord.
Nayan did not touch it.
Dust rose again.
This time not from a quarrel.
The wind brushed its hand over the dry surface of the field.
A thin red layer lifted and reached as high as Nayan’s shins.
He half closed his eyes.
When he opened them, the edges of everything before him were blurred.
The boundary ridge.
Thorns.
Uprooted grass.
The strap of a torn slipper.
A scrap of yellow cloth.
Nayan ran and picked up the yellow scrap.
It was not the strip from his kite.

It was the edge of someone's gamchha.
He let it fall.
A little farther away, a thin shard of glass glinted in the soil.
Nayan did not touch that either.
He was looking for the kite.
In the dust, things changed their names quickly.
Paper looked like cloth.
String looked like a dry grass root.
A shadow looked like a pit.
Nayan did not trust his eyes completely.
He moved forward watching where he placed his feet.
Where the old boundary ridge had stood, the earth had been dug up.
There were marks where two stakes were to be driven for the new line.
Red dust had collected inside one of the marks.
Nayan tucked the reel under his arm.
He searched the ground for something.
A thin fibre of string.
His kite string was not glass-coated.
His mother had bought ordinary cotton string.
"It won't cut your hands," she had said.
Nayan's string felt soft to the touch.
He picked up the first fibre.
It turned out to be dry grass.
A second.
A spiderweb.
The third time his fingers truly found the string.
He pulled.
The string emerged from beneath the soil.
Nayan's chest lightened.
He began pulling the string slowly.
One handspan.
Two handspans.
Three handspans.
Then the string caught.
Nayan followed it.
He crossed the surveyor's white measuring cord.
The measuring cord lay on the ground.
There was no one there to forbid him.
His kite string passed beneath it.
Without lifting the white cord, Nayan worked his thin string out from under it.

One cord was measuring land.
The other had gone after something that had fallen from the sky.
For a moment both lay between his fingers.
Nayan released the thick cord.
He kept hold of his own thin string.
Ahead was a thorn bush.
Beyond it lay the part of the field that Ramanand called "mine."
Nayan thought of that.
Then he pulled the string.
It was caught in the bush.
He bent down and looked inside.
There was no blue paper.
Only a very small piece of the yellow strip was caught on a thorn.
Nayan took it out.
It was from his kite.
Along one glued edge, the little crease made by his mother's finger pressure was still there.
Nayan closed the scrap in his fist.
The string ran beyond the bush.
He moved on again.
This time the earth beneath his feet was a little softer.
Someone had recently cut through the boundary ridge there.
Nayan slipped.
His hand struck the ground.
His palm turned red.
The reel rolled into the dirt.
He got up and brushed it off.
The red dust on the reel did not come away.
It had worked into the fine grain of the wood.
Nayan caught the string again.
Ahead lay an uprooted bamboo stake.
The string had looped once around its pointed end.
Nayan stopped.
He did not know whether the stake belonged to the surveyor or to the old boundary ridge.
The string did not know either.
It was simply caught.
Nayan began undoing the knot.
The knot was tight.
Soil packed beneath his nails.
He used his teeth.

The knot loosened.
The string came free.
Then a voice came from far away—
“Nayan!”
It was his father’s voice.
Nayan did not answer.
He looked along the string.
It was now leading toward the third edge of the field.
There stood the dry stubble of an old pigeon-pea crop.
The dust thickened again.
His father’s voice came closer.
“Nayan!”
“I’m here!”
“What are you doing?”
“Looking for my kite.”
His father emerged from the dust.
His face looked tired.
The first thing he looked at was Nayan’s hand.
“Cut?”
“No.”
“Come home.”
“I found the string.”
Nayan showed it to him.
His father looked for a moment in the direction it ran.
“Don’t go that way.”
“The kite is over there.”
“The land on that side—”
His father left the sentence unfinished.
Nayan looked at his face.
His father tried again—
“There was a fight there. There are thorns and stones lying around.
Come.”
That was a second sentence.
Nayan obeyed the second sentence.
But he did not let go of the string.
He began winding the thin string back onto the reel.
As he retraced his steps, the string came free from different parts of the field.
From thorns.
From the boundary ridge.
From beneath the measuring cord.

From the uprooted stake.
His father stood silently watching.
The reel filled.
Then the far end of the string moved.
Near the pigeon-pea stubble, something blue glinted in the soil.
Nayan started to run.
His father caught him by the shoulder.
“Slowly.”
Together they went over.
The kite was no longer whole.
More than half of the blue paper had torn away.
The yellow strip was stuck to the soil.
One thin bamboo spar lay apart from the rest.
The bow had broken in the middle.
Nayan knelt down.
First he picked up the bamboo spar.
Then the blue paper.
There were two blurred footprints on the paper.
Whose feet had made them was impossible to tell.
Nayan blew the dust off with his mouth.
The blue colour appeared again.
But not completely.
The fine fibres of the paper remained red.
From behind him his father asked—
“Where did you find it?”
Nayan turned and looked at him.
It was an ordinary question.
But that day the word “where” was no longer ordinary.
Ramanand called this part of the field his own.
His father said something else.
The surveyor’s measuring cord had drawn a third line.
The kite string had wandered across all of them and reached this place.
Nayan picked up the blue paper.
“At the end of the string.”
His father said nothing.
He looked once at the soil.
Then at Nayan’s reel.
“Come.”
The two walked home.
Behind them the wind rose.
Red dust spread across the field again.

It covered the whiteness of the measuring cord.
The uprooted boundary ridge too.
The footprints too.
But the string wound around Nayan's reel was in his hand.
When they reached home, his mother looked at the kite.
"It won't fly now."
Nayan spread the blue paper on the table.
"It can be made smaller."
His mother examined the broken bow.
"You'll need new bamboo."
"This one spar is still good."
Nayan picked up the kite's straight bamboo spar.
It was stained with red dust.
His mother started to bring a cloth.
Nayan said—
"Leave it."
His mother stopped.
"The dust?"
"Yes."
He turned the bamboo spar in his hand.
Red dust came off on his fingers.
Nothing in that dust showed whose share of the field it belonged to.
Nayan opened the reel.
He laid the two broken ends of the string before him.
For the new kite, the string would have to be knotted together.
He tied the knot.
The knot was very small.
But plainly visible.
From the direction of the field, a sound rose again outside.
This time it was not people.
It was the wind.
Nayan held the bamboo spar to his ear.
There was no sound in it.
He set it down on the table.
Tomorrow the kite would be made again.
Over whose field it would fly was not something he needed to think about yet.

A Three-Minute Procession

At seventeen minutes past three in the afternoon, the mouth of the lane filled with noise for the first time.

Before that, the lane had been going about its ordinary day.

The tak-tak of a sewing machine.

The clang of brass being hammered.

The faint hiss of oil in a wok.

And, every now and then, the thud of the hand-pump handle dropping.

On paper, the lane was called Shivmath Lane.

People called it Carpenter's Lane.

That was because Ramsevak the carpenter had his shop at the entrance, and fine wood dust floated in the air there all day.

At that moment Ramsevak was running a plane over a doorframe.

His granddaughter Jhilmil was gathering the shavings on the ground into a little heap.

"Not there," Ramsevak said. "If the wind rises, it will get into your eyes."

Jhilmil pushed the heap into a corner by the wall.

At the other end of the lane, Sakina Chachi was arranging guavas on her cart.

Ten ripe fruits in a separate pile.

The half-ripe ones apart.

The bruised fruit at the very bottom.

She used to say that a buyer's eyes tasted the colour first; the tongue came later.

At that moment Naseem was coming in with two milk cans tied behind his bicycle.

The lane was so narrow that if two bicycles met head-on, one had to flatten itself against the wall.

Naseem had given up ringing his bell and was advancing with cries of "Move aside, move aside."

Jhilmil laughed when she saw him.

"Has your bell died?"

"The bell may survive; I won't," Naseem replied.

Just then the first beat of a drum came from the main road.

One heavy stroke.
Then two quick ones.
Ramsevak stopped his plane.
Sakina Chachi raised her head.
Naseem stopped his bicycle and listened.
First, a small scrap of red-and-yellow paper blew into the mouth of the lane.

Behind it, two boys appeared running.
“A procession is coming,” one of them said.
The other ran off toward the main road without stopping.
Ramsevak pulled the doorframe inside the shop.
“Jhilmil, come in here.”
Jhilmil left the heap of wood shavings and went inside the shop.
Sakina Chachi gripped the bamboo handle of her cart.
She wanted to pull the cart back, but an empty tin from the sweet shop lay behind it.

Naseem remained trapped in the middle of the lane.

“Should I get out?”

“Not now,” Ramsevak said.

The main road suddenly became sound.

The slogans were no longer words.

They came like a wave.

Struck the walls and poured into the lane.

The first rank passed the entrance.

The flags were above.

Below, only feet could be seen.

Slippers.

Shoes.

Bare heels.

Dust.

At the mouth of the lane, a policeman stood with his arms spread, trying to stop people from spilling inside.

But the pressure from behind moved the bodies in front farther than they meant to go.

A young man was flung out of the line and into the lane.

He did not fall.

He caught the wall and steadied himself.

He had a bundle of leaflets in his hand.

Half the bundle fell to the ground.

Another shove came from behind.

Two women, a boy and an old man were pushed into the lane.

The policeman kept shouting at the entrance.
His voice drowned in the procession.
Sakina Chachi tried to turn her cart.
At that instant a man's foot caught against one of its wheels.
He saved himself.
The cart did not.
The right wheel climbed onto the platform of the hand pump.
The left wheel sank into a pothole.
The guavas rolled away all at once.
Green, yellow, blemished.
Running in circles through the lane.
Jhilmil watched from inside the shop.
Naseem seized the bicycle handlebar to steady it.
The rear milk can struck the wall.
Its lid came off.
A white stream of milk ran over the brick pavement.
No one noticed it.
The drum sounded again.
At that stroke, a guava struck the pump platform and split open.
Its pink flesh showed.
Three eighteen.
There were more people in the lane now.
Many times more on the main road.
A little boy slipped out of the crowd and crawled under Sakina Chachi's cart.
He had both hands clamped over his ears.
"Come out," Sakina Chachi said.
The boy shook his head.
"Who are you with?"
The boy did not answer.
A black streak of dust crossed his cheek.
The next section of the procession kept passing the mouth of the lane.
Some people were singing.
Some were simply walking.
Some took each step looking only at the shoulder in front of them.
Then a long bamboo pole brushed the electric wire strung above the lane.
The wire did not break.
But the old bulb beside it swung loose.
Jhilmil looked up with her mouth open.
Ramsevak pulled her back.
"Inside."

A leaflet flew into the shop.
 Jhilmil stopped it with her foot.
 It had large letters on it, but mud from a shoe had smeared the middle.
 She could not read it.
 Without picking it up, Ramsevak said, "Leave it for now."
 Three nineteen.
 The last flag of the procession passed the mouth of the lane.
 The drumbeats turned right and began to recede.
 The slogans withdrew first from the walls.
 Then from the air.
 Then from the ears.
 Dust remained on the main road.
 In the lane there were five extra people, twelve fewer guavas, half a can less milk, and one child still under a cart.
 The three minutes were over.
 No clock announced it.
 Ramsevak was the first to come outside.
 He did not go toward the mouth of the lane.
 First he looked at the swinging bulb.
 Then at the hand-pump platform.
 The cart wheel was still jammed there at an angle.
 "Lift it," he said to Naseem.
 Each of them took one corner of the cart.
 Sakina Chachi pulled the handle.
 The wheel came free of the pothole.
 With it, one brick of the platform came loose.
 A thin stream of water sprang out from beneath the brick.
 "Oh, God," Sakina Chachi said.
 Naseem bent to look.
 "The joint of the pump has shifted."
 The water first mixed with the milk.
 The white colour thinned across the ground.
 Then dust mixed into it.
 The colour turned muddy.
 Sakina Chachi began gathering the guavas.
 Three had been crushed.
 Two were stuck in the drain.
 One had fallen into Ramsevak's wood shavings.
 Jhilmil came out of the shop.
 She picked up a guava from the drain.
 "Not that one," Sakina Chachi said. "Leave it."

Jhilmil put the guava down again beside the drain.
Then the boy under the cart stirred.
“Arre,” Sakina Chachi said, bending down, “are you still in there?”
The boy slowly crawled out.
He looked seven or eight years old.
One button was missing from his kurta.
There was no slipper on his left foot.
“What’s your name?” Ramsevak asked.
The boy was silent.
“Where is your home?”
Silence.
As Naseem straightened the milk can, he said, “He’s frightened.”
Sakina Chachi tried to wipe the boy’s face with her scarf.
He drew back.
“All right, I won’t touch you,” she said.
People now began emerging at the mouth of the lane.
Some talking about what they had seen of the procession.
Some about being shoved.
Some repeating a slogan.
Ramsevak heard them, but his eyes remained on the stream of water.
“First we have to stop the water.”
He brought two thin wooden wedges from his shop.
Naseem brought an old piece of cloth.
Together they began stuffing them into the crack in the platform.
The water slowed, but did not stop.
The boy stood by the wall watching everything.
Jhilmil looked at his bare foot.
“Your slipper?”
The boy looked toward the main road.
“Out there?”
The boy nodded.
Jhilmil went as far as the mouth of the lane.
Ramsevak called out, “Don’t go far.”
On the main road lay paper, dust, a broken flower garland and one black slipper.
The slipper was in the middle of the road.
Two rickshaws passed beside it.
Jhilmil was about to step down.
Ramsevak called again, “Wait.”
Naseem left his bicycle and went onto the road.
He picked up the slipper and brought it back.

He put it on the boy's left foot.
 It was not his.
 The heel stuck out by two fingers' breadth.
 The boy spoke for the first time.
 "Mine was blue."
 Sakina Chachi did not laugh.
 "This must belong to someone else."
 Naseem stood holding the slipper.
 "Keep it?"
 Ramsevak said, "Stand it by the entrance. Whoever owns it may see it."
 Naseem propped the slipper against the wall.
 The water grew stronger again.
 The wooden wedge had shifted.
 Ramsevak did not curse.
 He pushed the wedge back into place.
 Sakina Chachi took an empty basket from her cart and set it in front of
 the stream.
 "At least it won't fill the drain."
 The basket could not hold water.
 Everyone laughed.
 Sakina Chachi laughed too.
 "My brains work only as far as guavas," she said.
 A small smile appeared on the boy's face.
 "Name?" Jhilmil asked again.
 "Chhotu."
 "Home?"
 "Behind the big mosque."
 Sakina Chachi said, "That's half a mile from here."
 "Who did you come to the procession with?"
 Chhotu lowered his eyes.
 "Abba sells roasted gram by the road. I was near his cart."
 "You weren't in the procession?"
 "No."
 "Then?"
 "People ran. I ran too."
 That was all he said.
 For him, the story of those three minutes was only that much.
 For Ramsevak, it was the broken pump joint.
 For Naseem, half a can of milk.
 For Sakina Chachi, the crushed guavas.
 For Jhilmil, the leaflet smeared with mud.

The procession had already gone far down the main road.

But the lane had begun its own accounting.

Naseem measured the milk.

"Four litres gone."

He scratched his head.

"Who do I tell?"

Sakina Chachi cut open one of the crushed guavas and looked inside.

"If we argue about it, the milk will only turn sourer."

Naseem did not laugh.

He had taken the milk on credit.

He had to settle the account that evening.

Ramsevak knew this.

He went into his shop and brought out some money from an old brass box.

Naseem drew his hand back.

"No."

"Take it as a loan."

"The milk was mine."

"The pump joint broke in front of my shop."

"Did you bring out the procession?"

Ramsevak smiled for the first time.

"No."

"Then keep your money."

They left the matter there.

Jhilmil looked at Sakina Chachi, asking with her eyes for a guava for Chhotu.

Sakina Chachi picked one from the half-ripe pile, not the ripe one.

Then she thought for a moment and exchanged it for a ripe guava.

"Eat."

Chhotu took the guava but did not bite into it.

"For Abba."

Sakina Chachi gave him another.

"This one's yours."

This time he bit into it.

A woman came running to the mouth of the lane.

She was carrying a child's blue slipper.

"Whose is this?"

Chhotu dropped the guava and stepped forward.

"Mine!"

The slipper really was his.

The woman said, "It was lying by the side of the road. I picked it up thinking it was my child's. He has both of his on."

She handed the slipper to Chhotu.

Naseem showed her the black slipper standing by the wall.

"Is this yours?"

The woman looked at the slipper and laughed.

"My foot isn't that big."

She went away.

The black slipper remained where it was.

Chhotu put on his blue slipper.

Then he remembered his worry about Abba again.

"I should go."

"Not alone," Sakina Chachi said.

"I'll take him," Naseem said.

His bicycle was still fit to ride.

There was less milk, but the wheels were sound.

Chhotu sat on the rear carrier.

The cans swung on either side.

Jhilmil waved.

Naseem rode out of the lane.

Normal traffic was now returning to the main road.

Two handcarts, three bicycles, one bullock cart.

The dust still had not settled.

Ramsevak remained bent over the pump joint.

Sakina Chachi began arranging the fruit again.

The crushed fruit apart.

The dusty fruit apart.

The surviving ripe guavas on top.

Jhilmil picked up the leaflet that had blown into the shop.

The mud had begun to dry.

Half the large lettering could now be read.

She went to Ramsevak.

"Baba, what does this say?"

Ramsevak wiped his hands and looked at the paper.

Some of the words had been erased.

What remained did not make a complete sentence.

"What will you do with half a message?"

"Half a message is still a message."

Ramsevak handed the paper back to her.

"You read it."

Jhilmil began joining the letters together.

Then an old voice came from farther inside the lane—

“Why has the water stopped?”

Ramsevak answered, “It hasn’t stopped; the pipe has burst.”

“When?”

Ramsevak looked at his watch.

Three twenty-seven.

He thought for a few moments.

“Ten minutes ago.”

Jhilmil immediately said, “In three minutes.”

“What?”

“The procession passed in three minutes. We’ve spent the other seven trying to fix things.”

Ramsevak looked at her.

Then at the pump joint.

“Fixed? Where is it fixed yet?”

By evening the joint had been replaced.

The municipal plumber arrived at five.

He removed the old iron ring and fitted a new rubber one.

The work took twelve minutes.

The labour charge was quoted for fifteen.

Sakina Chachi took seven crushed guavas home.

They would become chutney that night.

After taking Chhotu to his Abba, Naseem went to settle the milk account.

The four-litre shortage was entered in his ledger.

The stain of milk, water and dust in front of Ramsevak’s shop remained until evening.

Jhilmil wanted to throw water over it.

Ramsevak stopped her.

“Not now. Let it dry.”

“The stain will remain.”

“We’ll scrub it tomorrow.”

The black slipper stood at the mouth of the lane until evening.

People came and went.

Twice a dog sniffed it.

One child tried it on, looked at his foot, and left it again.

As darkness fell, Ramsevak picked it up and placed it beside the doorframe.

“Why?” Jhilmil asked.

“Someone may come looking for it tomorrow.”

“And if no one comes?”

“Then until the day after.”

“And then?”

Ramsevak did not answer.

Night settled over the main road.

No one in the lane knew how far the procession had gone.

One leaflet lay pressed between the pages of Jhilmil's notebook.

The black slipper rested by the doorframe.

A guava seed was caught in the heap of wood shavings.

The pump joint was new, but the old bricks around it were still wet.

The three minutes had passed on the city's clock.

In the lane, those three minutes were still lodged in separate things.

The Torn Drum

At Sonbarsa village's annual spring festival, the drum sounded first; the song rose afterward.

No one knew exactly why the order was so.

The elders said that when the steps of the pond were built, the hand that first cut the earth and the hand that first struck the drum had eaten at the same feast that evening.

The young men took the tale for an amusement of old people.

Yet on the morning of the festival, before the sun rose, every ear waited for the drum's first beat.

This year the drum hung in the veranda of Ganeshi Paswan's house.

Ganeshi was past seventy, but when he tightened a hide his fingers were still as nimble as a young man's.

His son Mohan had been working with a band in Darbhanga for three years.

He had returned to the village two days earlier for the festival.

The drum lay overturned in the middle of the veranda.

The hide on one side was dark brown, on the other a pale yellow.

Five old smears of vermilion marked the wooden shell between them.

Pulling at the rope, Mohan said, "Babu, we should replace the drum this time."

Ganeshi ran his fingers over the hide.

"Why?"

"Look, it has dried along the edge. The sound has grown heavy too."

"Is a heavy sound a bad sound?"

"Not bad, but there will be loudspeakers on the stage."

Ganeshi looked at him.

"Will the microphone ask the drum its age?"

Mohan did not laugh.

"I'm saying, what if it tears?"

"If it tears, it tears. It will give its voice first."

Just then two bicycle bells sounded from the square.

On the first bicycle was Ramakant Jha, a member of the panchayat.

On the second was Chandan, son of Bisesar Yadav.

Both had come to the veranda over the same matter, though not in the same language.

Ramakant said that this year the procession should set out first from the North Hamlet.

Chandan said that the South Hamlet had played first the previous year, so this time it was their turn.

Ganeshi let go of the rope.

“Why are you asking me where the drum will be played?”

Ramakant said, “The drum is at your house.”

“The drum belongs to the village.”

Chandan immediately said, “Then the village will decide.”

Ganeshi smiled.

“Who is the village?”

The veranda fell silent for a moment.

Ramakant hitched his gamchha higher on his shoulder.

“It will be settled at the meeting.”

“Settle it. The drum will stay here until the player comes.”

Chandan looked toward Mohan.

“The player is right here.”

Mohan kept tightening the rope.

“I’ll play the instrument. I won’t lead the procession.”

Chandan seemed about to say something, but Ramakant turned his bicycle around.

“We’ll see in the evening.”

By noon the color of the festival had spread through the village.

Yellow pennants were tied along the pond steps.

The children’s drawings were hung in the school courtyard.

In front of the shops were arranged jaggery, sugar drops, flattened rice, toys, and colored whistles.

An old potter who had come to sell clay horses kept shaking the dust from his sheet.

Three loudspeakers were tied behind the stage.

The largest loudspeaker pointed exactly toward the direction from which the drum procession was to arrive.

A meeting was held after noon.

The meeting was on the school veranda, but more people stood in the courtyard than under the veranda.

The program sheet said—procession at four, group song at five, play at seven.

It did not say where the procession would begin.

Because that one line had not been written, all the other lines became useless.

The North Hamlet said—the main temple is on our side, so the beginning should be there.

The South Hamlet said—the old drum has always gone to the ghat by our road, so the tradition should not be changed.

The Middle Hamlet said—because of this quarrel, start directly from the pond.

Then the question arose—who would carry the drum to the pond?

One voice grew louder.

Someone remembered an old dispute at a wedding.

Someone the panchayat election five years earlier.

Someone a field boundary.

Someone the seating line at a wedding procession.

Slowly, the matter of the festival became a bundle of all those matters that had no direct connection with the festival.

Mohan stood by a veranda pillar and listened.

Ganeshi had not come.

His name, however, was called three times.

Mohan was asked, “What does your father say?”

Mohan replied, “He looks at the drumskin, not at hamlets.”

Some people laughed.

Some took the laughter as a taunt.

The matter worsened again.

At last the mukhiya announced that the drum would be played from the school gate to the pond, and the procession from every hamlet would join there together.

The decision was simple on paper.

Not on the village road.

Fifteen minutes before four, Ganeshi and Mohan reached the school with the drum.

The drum was on Mohan’s shoulder.

Ganeshi carried two beaters.

One thick, one thin.

Two groups were already standing near the school gate.

The North Hamlet with its young men wearing green gamchhas.

The South Hamlet with yellow strips edged in red.

None of those colors had any old meaning.

Two days earlier, whatever cloth had been cheapest in the market had become their markers.

But once a color was tied on the head of a group, meaning arose by itself.

Mohan lowered the drum just inside the gate.

Ganeshi placed his palm on the hide and listened.

"Loosen it."

"Now?" Mohan asked.

"It has tightened in the sun."

Mohan began loosening the knot.

Just then Chandan arrived.

"It's time. Let our people play first."

From behind, Ramakant said, "The decision has been made. Everyone will go together."

"Everyone will go together, but who will give the first beat?"

It was a small question, but people immediately formed a circle around it.

Ganeshi took the rope from Mohan's hand.

"The drum will give the first beat."

Chandan said, "Will the drum play itself?"

"When people talk too much in front of a drum, the drum keeps quiet."

This time no one laughed.

The announcer's voice burst from the loudspeaker—"All guests, please take your respective places."

No one's place was fixed.

The bamboo barrier at the gate was opened halfway.

People began pushing in from two directions.

One young man caught the left strap of the drum and said, "Turn it this way."

Another pulled the right strap. "This line will go first."

Mohan pushed into the middle.

"Let go. The hide is tightening."

No one listened to him.

Two or four hands fell on the rope.

For a moment the drum tilted in the air.

Ganeshi slammed the thick beater on the ground.

"Let go!"

His voice was so hard that the two young men in front removed their hands.

But the pressure from behind did not stop.

Mohan pulled the drum against his chest.

The rope tightened again.

Along the rim of the hide, a thin line that had already dried suddenly turned white.

A sound came—not a beat, not a blast.

Only a coarse "crack," like cloth tearing.

Every hand stopped.

The hide on the right side of the drum had split for nearly two spans from the edge.

Through the torn opening, the dark wood inside was visible.

Mohan's mouth stayed open.

Ganeshi put the beater down.

He cursed no one.

He named no one.

He merely ran a finger along the torn edge of the hide.

The announcer's voice was still coming from the loudspeaker—"The procession will begin shortly."

At the head of the procession, the drum was silent.

The first accusation came from Chandan's side.

"It was pulled from that side."

Ramakant immediately said, "Everyone saw it. Your people grabbed it first."

Within ten seconds the torn hide became evidence.

Within twenty seconds, a side.

Within half a minute, guilt.

Someone said the split had already been there.

Someone said a deliberately weak hide had been left on the drum.

Someone said the proposal to replace the drum this year had been suppressed.

Mohan listened.

He knew that in the morning he himself had said to Babu, "What if it tears?"

But saying that now would clarify nothing.

It would only give birth to another suspicion.

Ganeshi lifted the drum.

"Take it home."

Chandan blocked the way.

"What about the procession now?"

Ganeshi looked at him.

"Do you want a procession or a sound?"

"Both."

"With this drum, neither now."

Ramakant looked toward the mukhiya.

The mukhiya signaled to the people on the stage to wait five minutes.

Saying five minutes was easy.

In a festival crowd, if five minutes remain empty, rumor fills them.

Someone said a fight had broken out.

Someone said the drum had been smashed.
Someone said Ganeshi had refused to play.
The woman selling sweets by the pond heard that two hamlets had clashed.

She made her child sit behind the stall.
The old toy seller moved his clay horses farther inside.
Three policemen set out from the square toward the school.
The sky was clear, but suspicion settled over the festival like a cloud.
Ganeshi carried the drum beneath the neem tree behind the school.
Mohan went with him.
Twelve-year-old Binod came running behind them.
Binod was not Ganeshi's grandson.
He was the grandson of Ramudit, a craftsman from the North Hamlet, and he often came to Ganeshi's house to watch drums being made.

He looked at the torn hide.
"Baba, can it be joined?"
Ganeshi said, "The hide can be stitched together. The sound will not be as it was."

"Today?"
"There isn't time today."
Mohan was silent.
Ganeshi asked him, "Where are the other instruments?"
"The brass band will arrive at five."
"The kettledrum?"
"There is a small kettledrum at the temple."
"Cymbals?"
"Plenty."
"Then why has the procession stopped?"
Mohan looked at his father's face.
"Everyone wants the drum."
"Everyone does not want the drum. Everyone wants the first beat to be theirs."

Binod plucked a neem leaf and began crushing it in his hand.
Raised voices rose again from the school gate.
Ganeshi shook his head.
"Go tell the mukhiya—take out the procession without the drum."
Mohan remained standing.
"And you?"
"I'll remove the hide."
"Now?"
"Looking at a broken thing does not mend it."

Mohan walked toward the gate.
 Binod stayed behind.
 Ganeshi began undoing the knots.
 Slowly the torn hide loosened from the mouth of the wooden shell.
 In the shade of the neem, the drum without its hide looked like a house
 with one wall removed.
 There were old scratches inside on the sal wood.
 At one place, 1987 had been written in charcoal.
 At another, only the letter "M."
 Binod asked, "Who wrote this?"
 "Who knows."
 "Not you?"
 "The drum was made before I was born."
 "Then is it the village's drum?"
 "It stays in my house, so people call it my drum."
 Binod was holding the torn hide.
 The tear had begun exactly where the pressure of the strap fell hardest.
 He measured it with his finger.
 "Did it tear because it was pulled from both sides?"
 Ganeshi did not answer.
 "Baba?"
 "The hide has already said it."
 "What?"
 "That it could not bear so much pulling."
 At the school gate, Mohan delivered Ganeshi's message to the mukhiya.
 At first the mukhiya was not ready to agree.
 "A procession without a drum? What will people say?"
 Mohan said, "People are already saying plenty."
 Chandan cut in, "Bring the temple kettledrum."
 Ramakant said, "The kettledrum is in that hamlet. Then it becomes the
 same issue again."
 Mohan's patience was wearing out.
 "Then clap your hands."
 "What?"
 "Everyone has their own hands. No hamlet's name is written on a clap."
 Some people laughed again at that.
 But this time the laughter was light.
 Chandan said, "Are you joking?"
 Mohan replied, "No. Take out the procession. The band will arrive at
 five."
 The mukhiya looked at his watch.

Four twenty-four.
The festival was running twenty-three minutes late.
The children on the stage were waiting.
The women arranging lamps by the pond kept asking where the crowd was.

At last the gate opened.
The procession set out without the drum.
For the first twenty steps there was such silence that everyone could hear the sound of their own slippers.

Then the small schoolchildren began clapping.

There was no rhythm.

No even tempo.

One child clapped fast, another late, a third stopped midway.

But the walking continued.

Behind them, someone found a pair of cymbals.

Someone else a brass plate.

An old woman began striking the knob of her walking stick on the ground in rhythm.

The sound was not beautiful.

Nor was it orderly.

But the procession moved.

Chandan and Ramakant walked on opposite edges.

Neither spoke to the other.

When the procession reached the pond, the announcer on the stage called the incident a "technical difficulty."

Hearing the phrase, Mohan smiled from a distance.

The drumskin had torn, but over the loudspeaker its name became "technical difficulty."

At five in the evening the brass band arrived.

The festival filled with noise again.

Prizes were given for the children's drawings.

The group song took place.

The play too began only half an hour behind schedule.

Many visitors from outside never knew how many things had already torn inside the village that afternoon.

But the villagers' eyes kept returning to Ganeshi's empty place.

Ganeshi did not return to the festival.

When Mohan reached home at night, a lantern was burning in the veranda.

The wooden body of the drum lay on the ground.

The torn hide had been dampened with water and pressed between cloths.

Ganeshi was spinning thread.
 Mohan sat down.
 "Will we buy a new hide?"
 "We will."
 "Will we throw the old one away?"
 Ganeshi did not lift his head.
 "What is the hurry to throw it away?"
 Mohan was silent.
 After a while he said, "What happened today..."
 Ganeshi broke the thread and joined it again.
 "What happened?"
 "The drum tore in front of everyone."
 "The drum has torn at home before too."
 "But not like this."
 "How, then?"
 Mohan searched for an answer.
 "It was pulled from both sides."
 For the first time Ganeshi looked at him.
 "Then remember that."
 "Whom should I tell?"
 "No one. Yourself."
 At nine that night Chandan came.
 He had brought a coil of new rope.
 "Kaka, keep this."
 Ganeshi asked, "Why?"
 "The old rope tightened too much."
 Mohan looked at him.
 Chandan averted his eyes.
 "It was our people's fault..."
 Ganeshi stopped him.
 "Leave the rope."
 Chandan left it and went away.
 Half an hour later Ramakant came.
 He carried not goatskin but thick thread bought from the market.
 "It may be useful for the stitching."
 Ganeshi took the thread in his hand.
 "It will be useful."
 Ramakant stood there for a while.
 "Today... the children clapped well."
 "Yes."
 "Will the drum be repaired?"

Ganeshi looked at the torn hide.

"This hide will never be fit to play again."

Ramakant's face fell.

"Then?"

"A new hide will be fitted."

"The old one?"

"We'll keep it."

Ramakant left.

Mohan laughed softly.

"They both came at different times."

Ganeshi said, "If they had come together, the argument would have begun again."

The next morning Binod came again.

He kept bringing the two edges of the torn hide together and looking at them.

"Stitch it, Baba."

"It won't play."

"Not for playing."

"Then?"

Binod had his answer ready.

"We'll hang it in the school. People will see it."

Ganeshi placed a hand on his head.

"People will see it, but what will they understand?"

"That the drum had torn."

"Only that?"

Binod slipped a finger into the torn part and touched the wood inside.

"That it had been pulled too much."

Ganeshi took out thread and needle.

The torn hide began to be stitched.

The seam would not run straight.

The two edges of the damp hide sometimes met, sometimes one rode over the other.

Ganeshi did not force them into perfect alignment.

"The scar will stay crooked," Binod said.

"Let it."

By noon the torn hide had once again been bound into a round shape, but not on the drum.

Ganeshi made a frame for it from two thin strips of bamboo.

The white stitching in the middle was clearly visible.

In the evening Mohan took it to the school.

At first the headmaster hesitated.

“Why should we hang this torn hide?”

Mohan said, “Beside the children’s drawings.”

“What name should we write?”

Mohan said nothing.

Binod, who had gone with him, spoke up. “Don’t write a name.”

The headmaster laughed.

“An exhibit without a name?”

“Everyone knows the drum.”

In the end the hide was hung on the school veranda.

There was no label beneath it.

No culprit’s name.

No hamlet.

Only the seam through the middle.

For the next few days children looked at it and asked questions.

Some were told—it tore at the festival.

Some—the rope had tightened.

Some—too many hands had grabbed it at once.

Some—the hide was old.

No single answer remained fixed.

A month later the drum, fitted with a new hide, sounded again.

The first beat was given not by Ganeshi but by Mohan.

The place was the school courtyard.

There was no procession.

It was the children’s sports day.

The beat was deep and clear.

The old hide hanging on the veranda moved gently in the breeze.

The sound of the new drum reached as far as its seam.

The seam gave no answer.

But whenever a beat fell very hard, the white thread tightened for a moment.

In that tension, what returned was not the whole uproar of the day the drum tore, only one rough sound.

A sound that was not a beat.

After which, for the first time, the village had understood that before a drumskin tears, it often remains silently stretched for a long while.

The Night Truck

By the time evening settled, the rain had thickened again.

Water lay on both sides of the main road; only a raised strip in the middle, black as a ribbon, remained above it.

Along that strip the relief truck moved slowly forward.

Two yellow lamps blinked at the front of the truck; behind them, under a tarpaulin, were sacks, medicines, candles, salt, and dry flattened rice.

Seven people sat on top of the sacks.

They were all looking at the same flood, but the flood inside each of them was different.

The driver, Saroj, held the steering wheel in a rigid grip.

He was not watching the road so much as the earth beneath it.

Earlier in the day, a young man from the panchayat had said that one edge of the road near the Barhampur bend had been eaten away.

No one knew exactly how deep the washout was.

Saroj feared that if the truck's front wheel caught the soft edge even once, the whole weight of the vehicle might tilt toward the water.

He had not told the people sitting behind him this.

At the front of the group in the back sat Dhanouti Kaki.

A small cloth bundle rested in her lap.

The bundle held no clothes: only three papers, an old brass key, and a skein of red thread.

Her fear was for her house.

The house stood half-submerged, but inside the courtyard her old she-goat had been left tied to a bamboo peg.

There had been no time to untie the goat.

The boat for the camp had already pushed off, and all she had managed to take was the key.

After distributing relief, the truck would drop her at the bend from which her hamlet lay half a kos away.

Everyone had told her, "Do not go home now."

Dhanouti Kaki had given no answer.

Only the goat's thin bleating remained lodged in her ears.

Beside her sat seventeen-year-old Ranjana.

Ranjana held a tin box in her hands.

There were no books inside it, only four surviving pages from water-soaked notebooks.

The roof of the school had blown away.

No one knew when her examination would now be held.

But Ranjana was not afraid about the examination.

She was afraid the ink would spread before the pages could dry.

On those pages were two mathematical formulae written in the hand of her dead father.

Her father had died the previous year.

Ranjana was not saving pages; she was saving his handwriting.

Again and again she touched the lid of the box, then drew her hand away.

If she opened it, splashes of water might get inside.

If she did not, the dampness trapped within would increase.

Her whole night was caught between those two small fears.

Behind Ranjana sat Mahendra.

He was a volunteer with the relief team.

A cloth pouch hung from his neck; inside it was a list of names.

The list recorded three hamlets, fifty-seven families, and the distribution account.

Mahendra was not afraid of the sacks getting wet.

He was afraid the numbers would go wrong.

If one sack went missing, who would answer for it?

If one family was entered twice, who would know?

If one name was left out, people might remain hungry until the next consignment.

He held the list tight against his chest, as though it were not paper but the breath of all those families kept inside the pouch.

Opposite Mahendra sat Navkeen.

He was a labourer who had returned from the city.

Inside his kurta, wrapped in plastic, were five thousand three hundred rupees.

They were his savings from three months.

He had told no one at the camp.

He feared suspicion more than theft.

If anyone's money disappeared, the first glance would fall on Navkeen, the man returned from elsewhere—this was the assumption lodged inside him.

So he did not keep touching his money.

If he reached for it, people would notice.

If he did not, he could not trust that it was still there.

He sat upright, as though guarding the pocket beneath his clothes were his only duty.

In the right-hand corner of the truck sat Phoolo Devi.

Four-year-old Sonu slept in her lap.

Sonu's forehead was hot.

At the medicine-distribution point in the camp she had been given two packets of medicine.

She had been told, "If his fever rises at night, give him one packet with water."

Phoolo Devi's fear was where she would find water.

There was water on every side, but none to drink.

Sonu had drunk half the water in her lota that evening.

Only two mouthfuls remained.

She had wrapped the lota in cloth and placed it between her feet.

To her, those two mouthfuls were worth more than all the sacks, tins, and lists in the truck.

At the very back sat old Budhan Mallah.

Budhan's hands were empty.

His fear too looked empty.

He was a boatman, but in this flood his boat had been swept away.

People asked him about the route, the current, the depth.

He answered every question.

But inside, he was afraid of the question no one asked: what is a boatman without a boat?

The truck kept jolting forward.

Rain rattled against the tarpaulin.

At times the sound of the drops grew so dense that it drowned the growl of the engine.

Beside the road appeared the crown of the first submerged mango tree.

Seeing it, Budhan said, "The current is strong on the left here."

Saroj looked at his face in the mirror.

"But the road is straight."

"On the surface."

At that one phrase, Saroj's hands tightened further.

The truck slowed.

Mahendra looked at his watch.

"We were supposed to reach Barhampur in half an hour."

Saroj replied, "The road on a clock is always dry."

No one laughed.

Ahead, two bamboo poles had been planted on either side of the road.

Someone had put them there during the day as a warning.

One of the poles now leaned halfway into the water.
 Saroj pressed the brake.
 The truck stopped.
 As it halted, everyone sitting in the back lurched forward once.
 Sonu woke and began to cry.
 Phoolo Devi touched his forehead.
 "He's hot," Ranjana said softly.
 Phoolo Devi said nothing.
 Saroj climbed down.
 The water reached his knees.
 He went to the bamboo pole and began feeling for the road's edge with his foot.
 At one spot, as soon as he pressed the ground, his leg sank above the knee.
 He stepped back at once.
 The people in the truck could see only his shoulder.
 Saroj climbed back up.
 "The edge ahead has been washed away."
 "How much?" Mahendra asked.
 "Too much for the truck."
 "Can we turn back?"
 Saroj looked behind them.
 Five kos back, the water had begun rising over the small bridge as well.
 "There's no certainty in turning back either."
 The rain grew harder again.
 From one corner of the tarpaulin, water began falling in a stream.
 Mahendra stood at once and pulled the rope.
 With the tug, the cloth pouch around his neck slipped free.
 It fell onto the floor of the truck.
 Navkeen snatched it up immediately.
 For one moment their eyes met.
 Mahendra took the pouch, but the word of thanks reached his lips and stopped.
 Navkeen saw that halted word.
 He said nothing.
 They began discussing how to lighten the truck.
 Saroj said, "If we unload twenty or twenty-five sacks here, the wheels will carry less weight."
 "Unload them here?" Mahendra burst out. "The water is rising."
 "We'll spread a tarpaulin."
 "It's relief rice."
 "If the truck overturns, where will the rice go then?"

This time Mahendra fell silent.

Everyone's fear was colliding with everyone else's.

Dhanouti Kaki felt that if the delay grew, the goat's rope would pull tight in the rising water.

Ranjana felt there was no air inside the tin box.

As she kept touching Sonu's forehead, Phoolo Devi counted her two mouthfuls of water.

Navkeen felt that as the darkness deepened, people's eyes would linger more on small things.

Mahendra felt that once the sacks came down, his accounting would scatter.

Saroj felt that if they delayed the decision, the road would grow softer still.

Budhan listened only to the sound of the water.

"First straighten the truck," he said.

Saroj looked at him.

"It is straight."

"No. The rear right wheel is on soft ground."

Every eye dropped.

The wheel had indeed sunk half an inch farther than the other.

Saroj did not curse; he simply started the engine at once.

The truck was taken one cubit backward.

For that one cubit, everyone held their breath.

The wheel came back onto firm ground.

Budhan climbed down, took a bamboo pole, and began sounding the water ahead.

"Not here," he said at one point.

"Two cubits to the left."

"There's more water on the left," Saroj said.

"More water, firmer ground."

Saroj looked at Budhan's face for a while after hearing this.

In the boatless boatman's voice lived the old assurance of someone who knew a current.

Twenty sacks were unloaded.

Everyone climbed down and went to work.

Dhanouti Kaki too shifted a small sack of salt.

Ranjana put her tin box beneath the tarpaulin and gripped a sack with both hands.

Navkeen unloaded the heaviest sacks of rice.

Mahendra kept counting—one, two, three...

When Navkeen set down the fourteenth sack, Mahendra counted again.

"Thirteen."

"Fourteen," Navkeen said.

Mahendra frowned.

Without speaking, Navkeen pointed toward the sacks.

Two had been placed one behind the other so that they looked like one.

Mahendra counted again.

"Fourteen."

With that single word, his gaze on Navkeen changed for the first time.

As the nineteenth sack was being unloaded, Phoolo Devi's lota rolled away.

Ranjana lunged and caught it.

The lota was in her hands before the lid could come off.

Phoolo Devi's face had gone completely pale.

"Is the water still there?"

Ranjana righted the lota and listened.

A faint slosh sounded inside.

"It's there."

At that sound Phoolo Devi let out a breath as if someone had risen above the surface of the water.

The twentieth sack came down.

The tarpaulin was tied tightly over them.

Saroj told everyone to climb back onto the truck.

Budhan did not get on.

"I'll walk ahead."

"Why?"

"I'll see where the wheels should go."

Saroj wanted to refuse, but Budhan was already in the water.

Probing the ground with the bamboo pole, he moved ahead.

The truck began crawling behind him.

The first ten cubits passed easily.

On the eleventh, the right wheel slipped.

Several voices rose together from the back.

Saroj turned the steering wheel left, but did not touch the brake.

Budhan raised a hand and shouted, "Keep moving—don't stop!"

The truck tilted slightly.

Dhanouti Kaki seized the rope around the sacks.

Ranjana clutched her tin box to her chest.

Mahendra's pouch pressed against his stomach.

Navkeen grabbed not his own pocket, but Sonu's shoulder.

Phoolo Devi clenched the lota between her teeth and wrapped both arms around Sonu.

Two moments later, the wheel climbed back onto hard ground.
 The truck straightened.
 No cheer rose from anyone.
 Only the growl of the engine sounded normal again.
 Budhan did not turn back to smile.
 He drove the bamboo pole into the water again.
 It took five minutes to cross the washed-out stretch.
 To everyone, those five minutes felt enormous.
 Once across, Saroj stopped the truck.
 Budhan climbed back aboard.
 His dhoti was wet up to his thighs.
 Dhanouti Kaki opened her bundle and tore off a piece of red thread.
 She tied it to the top of Budhan's bamboo pole.
 "Why?" Budhan asked.
 "So the next truck coming this way can see it from a distance."
 The red thread darkened in the rain until it looked nearly black, but it kept fluttering.
 From there to Barhampur hamlet, the road was firm.
 The silence inside the truck slowly loosened.
 Mahendra took out his list and checked the count again.
 This time Navkeen himself helped count the sacks.
 Phoolo Devi found time to give Sonu his medicine.
 Ranjana opened the tin box for a moment to let air in.
 The ink had not spread.
 Dhanouti Kaki kept looking through the darkness toward her hamlet.
 When they reached Barhampur, the first sack of relief supplies was unloaded.
 People came running.
 Some needed flattened rice, some salt, some candles.
 Mahendra read out the names.
 This time his voice was not as hard as before.
 Navkeen kept unloading sacks.
 No one discovered the money hidden inside his kurta.
 Phoolo Devi's lota became empty, but Sonu's fever came down a little.
 Ranjana's tin box closed again, but her fear did not close as tightly.
 When they reached the bend where Dhanouti Kaki was to get down, Saroj said, "Don't go alone now."
 Kaki replied, "Where am I alone?"
 She looked at Budhan.
 Budhan lifted his bamboo pole.
 "I'll see her to the hamlet."

The two walked away along the narrow path through the water.

The truck moved forward again.

Behind them, the twenty sacks they had unloaded still lay under the tarpaulin on this side of the washout.

Saroj was already worrying about collecting them on the next trip.

On his list, Mahendra made a small mark beside those twenty sacks.

"What is that?" Ranjana asked.

"Relief supplies lying on the road for now."

"No name?"

Mahendra thought for a moment.

"I'll write the name later."

The truck's yellow lamps moved forward, drawing two long, trembling lines on the water.

All night the flood looked like one colour.

But the people sitting on the truck now understood that fear did not have a single colour.

For one person, fear was a goat's rope.

For another, wet ink.

For another, a name left out of a list.

For another, wages wrapped inside clothing.

For another, two mouthfuls of water.

For another, an identity without a boat.

And for Saroj, that stretch of road which was a road on the surface, but not underneath.

The truck kept moving.

Behind them at the washout, the red thread could no longer be seen in the darkness.

Even so, the rain-wind kept it fluttering.

It was no flag.

Only a small marker—on a road at night where the fears were different, but every wheel was searching for the same firm ground.

Flowers on Ash

Three days after the fire, in the last week of Phagun, that courtyard in Dharampur looked as though some black hand had erased all its colours in a single night.

The part of the wall that remained was streaked black with smoke. The bamboo screen had crumbled into ash. Half the thatched roof had fallen in, and in the middle of the courtyard the red bricks of the earthen hearth lay half-buried in soot.

The owner of the house, Rambabu Sah, stayed awake night after night. How the fire had started was a question whose answer changed every day. Some said a spark from the hearth, some dry leaves, some a fault in the old wiring.

Rambabu himself could settle on no answer. For him, the question larger than the cause was what remained now.

What remained was the rear wall of one room, an old iron chest, two brass plates, and a red earthen flowerpot belonging to his seven-year-old grandson Neeraj, half its rim broken away.

On the night of the fire Neeraj had been at a neighbour's house with his mother. When he was brought back at dawn, the first thing he looked for was not the house but the flowerpot.

Nothing remained in it. The tulsi leaves had blackened and fallen, and a thin layer of ash lay over the soil.

From that day onward Neeraj would repeatedly come to the middle of the courtyard and sit in silence. The adults would move him away, saying there were nails in the ash, bits of glass, perhaps hot embers still buried underneath.

Neeraj would step away, but after a while he would return and stand in the same place.

On the morning of the fourth day he took the broken flowerpot in his hands and followed his mother.

His mother, Sarita, was wringing wet clothes in a neighbour's courtyard. Neeraj asked, "Can anything grow in this soil again?"

Without turning, Sarita said, "Let the house stand again first."

"Can't there be flowers before the house?"

Sarita stopped her hands. Water kept dripping from the cloth.

“Will you eat flowers?”

Neeraj did not laugh. “No. But can they grow or not?”

Sarita’s eyes went once toward the burnt courtyard. She gave no answer.

That afternoon some relief workers came. They gave the family a plastic sheet, rice, lentils, salt, and two blankets. On the form Rambabu did not put a thumbprint; he signed his name, for he had run a shop for years.

A young man raised a camera and asked the family to stand in front of the burnt house. Rambabu stood stiff for a few moments, then pushed the surviving lid of the chest behind him.

Neeraj did not stand for the photograph. He was searching at one edge of the heap of ash, where his grandmother had once grown marigolds.

His grandmother had died two years earlier. The marigolds she had planted had spread so widely that in Phagun the courtyard used to look yellow. On the night of the fire every plant had turned to ash.

When Neeraj began pushing his hand into the ash, Sarita ran over and caught his wrist.

“How many times have I told you? Don’t put your hand in there.”

Neeraj opened his fist. Inside lay the dry round fragment of a half-burnt seed.

“Has this survived?”

Sarita looked at his palm. “Hard to say.”

Neeraj placed the fragment in the flowerpot.

By evening he had picked out five such seeds. Some were completely black, some half-brown.

When Rambabu saw him, he became irritated. “Stop sifting through the ash. This is no time for games.”

Neeraj asked, “When will the courtyard be cleaned?”

“When we find labourers.”

“Where will the ash be thrown?”

“Behind the pond.”

Neeraj thought about that answer all night.

At dawn he came into the courtyard carrying an old aluminium bowl, half the handle of a broom, and a broken sieve.

He began dividing the ash into three piles—brick and stone, iron and glass, and fine ash.

When Sarita saw him, she first wanted to stop him. Then she put an old pair of thick shoes on his feet and said, “The moment you see glass, stop using your hands.”

Neeraj nodded.

The first person to join him in this work was eight-year-old Rani from next door. Her house had escaped the fire, though the outside of one wall had been blackened by smoke.

Rani asked, "What will you do with the ash?"

"Flowers."

"Flowers in ash?"

"Grandmother used to plant them."

Rani brought a small hand hoe from her house.

By noon the two children had cleared a corner of the burnt courtyard about a cubit long. The old soil underneath was black, but not hard.

At that moment Tejnath, the village gardener, happened to pass by. A basket of vegetable seedlings was strapped to his back.

Seeing the children, he stopped. "What sort of farming is going on here?"

In a serious voice Neeraj said, "Flowers."

Tejnath picked up some ash, smelled it, and rubbed it between his fingers. "Not in ash alone. You'll have to turn the soil underneath. The pieces of burnt plastic and wire must be removed."

Rambabu came over. "Kaka, let the children play. Right now we have to think about rebuilding the house."

Tejnath looked at him. "The house will be built. But the soil too needs to breathe again."

Rambabu said nothing.

Tejnath took two handfuls of composted leaves from his basket and mixed them into the soil the children had cleared. Then he said, "No seeds yet. Let the ash cool first."

Neeraj asked, "How many days?"

"What has burned keeps its heat longer than the heat you can see outside. Give it seven days."

Neeraj began counting the seven days.

Meanwhile, talk of rebuilding the house began. Masons came, bamboo came, bricks came. No insurance representative came, because the house had no insurance. Relatives kept offering advice—make the courtyard smaller and add an extra room, extend the shop in front, don't waste space on flowers and plants.

Rambabu thought this made sense. The fire had eaten up his savings; an extra room could be rented and bring in some income.

On the seventh day he asked the mason to measure the courtyard.

At that very moment Neeraj was loosening the soil in the corner he had cleared.

The mason's measuring line ran straight through his little flower bed.

Neeraj lifted the line and placed it to one side.

The mason laughed. "If you move that line, the wall will come out crooked."

"Flowers will grow here."

From a distance Rambabu called, "Neeraj, move."

Neeraj did not move.

Sarita came over. She understood that if the dispute grew now, the child would cry, and Rambabu might as well. She picked up the line and returned it to the mason, but she did not lift Neeraj into her arms.

"Babuji," she said softly, "leaving one cubit of space won't make the room small."

In an irritated voice Rambabu said, "Everyone wants flowers. Who is looking at the expense?"

Sarita fell silent.

Neeraj only said, "I'm not asking for money."

For a few moments after that sentence, no one spoke.

Rambabu looked at the mason's line, then at the burnt wall, then at the child's hoe. At last he said, "Leave not one cubit, but one and a half. Only make sure the water doesn't run toward the room."

The mason shifted the line.

No smile appeared on Neeraj's face. He simply began digging the soil again.

The next day Tejnath brought four kinds of seed—marigold, sunflower, aparajita, and a small local red flower whose name Neeraj had never heard before.

"Not all of them will sprout," Tejnath said, "and those that do won't all survive equally well."

Neeraj asked, "Then how many should we plant?"

"As many as the soil can carry."

The children made three rows. Rani marked them with pieces of leaves. In a separate corner Neeraj buried the surviving burnt seeds from his grandmother's plants.

He was certain his grandmother's seeds would sprout. Tejnath gave him no assurance.

Nothing happened for the first two days. Nothing happened on the third day either.

On the morning of the fourth day Rani came running—"Green! Green!"

From the black soil mixed with ash, a thin crooked shoot had emerged. Beside it was another, then a third.

Neeraj lay flat on his stomach and looked at them from so close that soil touched his nose.

When Rambabu came outside, he saw the children gathered there.

“What happened?”

Rani pointed.

Rambabu bent down. The shoot was so small that for a moment he could not see it at all.

Once he saw it, he straightened up. “All this noise for that?”

Neeraj said, “It’s the first one.”

Rambabu said nothing, but later that day, when the mason began unloading sand, Rambabu himself said, “Don’t let it fall on the flower bed.”

Slowly the walls of the house rose, and leaves rose in the flower bed. Both kinds of building went on together, but at different speeds.

A brick wall could climb three cubits in a day. A flower plant did not grow even a finger’s breadth in the same time.

Every evening Neeraj measured both.

One day a strong wind blew. The plastic over the new roof flapped wildly, and two shoots in the bed bent over. That night Neeraj planted two thin bamboo sticks and tied thread around them for support.

The next day Rambabu cut an old plank from the shop and made a border around the flower bed. He told no one why.

Sarita saw it and merely smiled once.

On the fifteenth day the first marigold bud appeared.

Neeraj ran to call Rambabu. Rambabu had a bowl of limewash in his hand.

“Has it become a flower?”

“Only a bud so far.”

Rambabu said, “Then call me when it becomes a flower.”

But five minutes later he came into the courtyard on his own and looked at the bud.

The corner where Grandmother’s burnt seeds had been planted was still empty.

Neeraj looked at it every day, gave it little water, and did not disturb the soil.

One night he asked Sarita, “If these don’t sprout, will Grandmother’s flowers be finished?”

Sarita stroked his head. “Flowers and the memory of a person are not the same thing.”

“But these were her seeds.”

“Yes. If the seeds do not sprout, they were still hers. If they do sprout, they are still hers.”

Neeraj remained silent for a long time over that answer.

A month later the new roof of the house was complete. Not all the black marks of the fire had been erased; Rambabu deliberately left one patch of the rear wall without limewash.

When anyone asked, he would say, "There wasn't time earlier."

In truth, the flower bed lay directly in front of that mark.

The first flower to bloom was not a marigold but the unfamiliar red flower whose seeds Tejnath had brought. It was small, with five petals, growing very close to the earth.

Neeraj did not pluck it.

The next day three marigolds bloomed. Rani wanted to pluck one and take it to school, but Neeraj stopped her. Then he himself carefully plucked one flower and gave it to her.

"One can go," he said, "not all of them."

Gradually people began coming to see the new house instead of the burnt one. Those who had earlier asked about the cause of the fire now began asking about the flower bed.

Some people said the ash had become fertilizer. Tejnath corrected them again and again: "Not the ash alone; the ash was removed, the soil was turned, compost was mixed in, and time was given."

Neeraj listened carefully to that correction. He liked the phrase—time was given.

One dawn a tiny green point appeared in the corner where Grandmother's seeds had been buried.

Neeraj called no one.

He sat on the ground and watched it for a long time.

He was not certain whether it had come from one of those burnt seeds or from some other seed already lying in the soil.

Tejnath saw it too and said, "Don't give it a name yet. Let it grow first."

This time Neeraj did not ask for an answer.

Two weeks later leaves had appeared on the plant. It was not a marigold. It may have been some wild seed that had already been in the soil.

Even so, Neeraj did not pull it out.

Rambabu asked, "It doesn't look as though this will even flower. Shall we keep it?"

Neeraj said, "There is room for it for now."

Rambabu nodded.

Before the rains arrived, the courtyard flower bed was full. Red, yellow, blue, green—the black ash survived only in a few places beneath the soil.

The window of the new room opened toward it. When a tenant moved in, the first thing he asked was, "Was there a fire here?"

Rambabu looked toward the blackened rear wall.

“Yes,” he said, “here.”

The tenant looked at the flower bed. “And these flowers?”

Before Rambabu could answer, Neeraj came over watering them.

“After the fire,” Rambabu said.

That was all.

Neeraj kept pouring water slowly from the lota into the soil, so that the ash would not rise into the air again.

The Blacksmith's Hammer

Phagun was drawing to a close, but the seasons made no difference to the forge in the blacksmiths' quarter. Dawn or dusk, Jagdish Lohar's hammer sounded at its appointed hour—thak, thak, thann.

The neighbours set their clocks by that sound. After the first blow the milkman crossed the lane; by the second, the schoolchildren had gone past; and when the iron on the anvil began to throw sparks, the first shop in the market opened.

Jagdish spoke little. People in the village called him hard. He had no son; only one daughter, Madhavi, who had grown up amid the heat of the forge, coal dust, and the roughness of a blacksmith's hands.

Madhavi was five when she first tried to lift the hammer. It did not rise even an inch from the ground. Jagdish did not laugh. He merely said, "Straighten your grip first."

For a long time that sentence of her father's stayed in Madhavi's memory—straighten your grip first.

By twelve she had learned to work the bellows. By fifteen she could look at the colour of hot iron and know when it needed a blow and when it had to go back into the fire. Jagdish said nothing, but whenever her judgment was right, his next stroke fell a little lighter.

That lighter stroke was praise enough for Madhavi.

This time the house was preparing for a wedding. Madhavi was to marry Raghav of Basantpur, three kos away. Raghav was an accounts assistant in a primary school and repaired bicycles in his spare time. At their first meeting he had noticed soot on Madhavi's palm and asked, "Do you work at the forge?"

Madhavi had replied, "It is work of the house."

Raghav had said, "Good if hands know work."

Jagdish had said nothing to that answer, but while leaving he silently tightened the loose pedal on Raghav's bicycle.

Ten days before the wedding, bamboo arrived in the courtyard, then straw, leaf plates, sacks of makhana. The women began rehearsing songs. Curd began setting on the veranda.

Even so, the forge did not close.

“Still working?” Mama asked. “Your daughter is getting married. Let the forge go cold for two days.”

Jagdish laid a hot sickle on the anvil and gave it three blows. “It is an implement for cutting paddy. People are waiting.”

“People can wait.”

Jagdish gave no answer.

Madhavi was listening from inside. She understood the meaning of her father’s silence. If something was not made in time, wedding songs could not make up for the loss.

Seven days before the wedding Jagdish removed the old handle from his hammer. The handle was of sheesham wood, and in its middle there were still two slanting cuts Madhavi had made with a little knife in childhood.

Madhavi asked, “Why are you changing the handle?”

“It has come loose.”

“I’ll tighten it.”

“In a wedding house you have other work.”

“This too is work of my house.”

Jagdish looked at her. Then he placed the old handle in her hand.

Madhavi pared a wooden wedge thin and hammered it in, tightening the iron head again. She lifted the hammer and struck the anvil once. The sound rang clean.

Jagdish said, “Not too hard. Listen to the iron.”

Madhavi smiled. “You should listen to people too.”

Jagdish’s eyes rested on her for a moment. Then he picked up the half-finished hoe.

Five days before the wedding, Raghav’s uncle arrived with two men. The talk began with the number of people to be fed, moved to separate seating for the wedding party, and then reached the question of transport.

“Raghav himself says nothing,” the uncle said, “but a family has its standing to maintain. It would look good if there were a motorcycle at the vidai.”

The air on the veranda went still.

Madhavi was inside. Her mother, Shanti, closed the betel box. Mama cleared his throat.

At that moment Jagdish was straightening a horseshoe beside the forge. The words reached his ears. The hammer rose once, but the blow did not fall.

The uncle said again, “I am not calling it a demand. Only a matter of honour.”

Jagdish set the hammer down and came into the courtyard. There was soot on the sleeve of his kurta.

“Did Raghav say this?”

“No, but the family—”

“Did Raghav say this?”

The uncle fell silent.

Jagdish looked toward Shanti. “Give them tea.”

With that he returned to the forge.

That night Madhavi asked her father nothing. The forge kept sounding until late. In place of the usual three blows, long pauses began to fall between the strokes.

The next day Raghav came himself. He left his bicycle outside the courtyard and went straight to the forge.

“What Kaka said was not from me,” he said.

Jagdish did not stop working the bellows.

“I do not want a motorcycle.”

Jagdish drew the hot iron from the fire. “Whatever you do not want, say it clearly in your own house.”

Raghav lowered his head. “I will.”

“Now hold these tongs.”

Raghav took the tongs. Jagdish began striking the iron. After the first two blows, Raghav’s grip trembled.

“Firm,” Jagdish said.

Madhavi watched from the veranda. She understood that her father’s approval was not a pat on the groom’s shoulder; it was placing hot-iron tongs in his hand.

Two days before the wedding, Jagdish began heating a small strip of iron in one corner of the forge. It did not look like any customer’s tool. He bent the strip, hammered it, then plunged it into water.

Madhavi asked, “What are you making?”

“Something useful.”

“For whom?”

“Let it be made first.”

That night the women sang wedding songs in a sohar-like cadence. Behind the sweet voices, the forge kept going—thak, thak. A few guests complained that the smoke would settle into their clothes.

Shanti said, “Without this smoke, where would this house be?”

On the morning of the wedding, for the first time Jagdish lit the forge late. He bathed and put on a clean dhoti and kurta, but the soot at the edges of his nails would not come off completely.

Madhavi’s friends were admiring the colour of the henna on her hands. Madhavi looked at the tips of her fingers; a fine black line remained even through the henna.

“That won’t come off,” one friend said.

Madhavi replied, "There is no reason it should."

By afternoon the courtyard was full. Music, voices, laughter, the sounds of rows of people being seated. Those who called Jagdish hard were also curious to watch his silence.

"When the daughter leaves, we'll see whether the blacksmith cries or not," one neighbour whispered into another's ear.

Madhavi heard him. She did not feel angry. It only seemed strange that people looked for proof of a father's grief in his eyes, not in his palms.

The wedding party arrived before evening. Raghav walked to the gate; there was no motorcycle. His uncle was there too, but this time his voice was subdued.

The rituals began. The priest continued reciting mantras. Jagdish sat where required, rose where required, offered water, offered grain. He spoke unnecessarily to no one.

At the time of kanyadaan the priest said, "Bring your hand forward."

Jagdish's hand came over Madhavi's. For the first time Madhavi felt that her father's fingers were trembling.

The tremor was very slight—less even than the movement with which he placed hot iron on the anvil.

Madhavi looked up. Jagdish's eyes were dry.

In that moment her father's silence did not feel heavy. It felt familiar.

During the night meal a problem arose. The handle came off the large iron ladle made for serving the rows of guests. The cook panicked.

"Another one?"

"Too short. It won't reach into this cauldron."

People began looking for Jagdish. He was sitting in one corner of the wedding pavilion. The moment he heard, he stood up. He took off his clean kurta and placed an old gamchha over his shoulder.

The forge was lit again.

From the pavilion Madhavi saw smoke rising. Before long the familiar sound of the hammer cut through the wedding music—thak, thak, thann.

The cook carried the ladle away. The meal resumed.

Jagdish did not return to the pavilion without washing his hands. When he did return, there was once again a black stain on the sleeve of his clean kurta.

Madhavi's vidai was set for near dawn. As the night waned, the guests grew tired. The songs thinned. One by one, the lamps in the courtyard went out.

When Madhavi entered her room, she saw the old hammer handle lying on the cot—the same sheesham handle with the two slanting cuts.

Beside it lay a small new hammer. Not the heavy hammer of a blacksmith; one that fit in the palm, meant for driving nails and small repairs. Its handle was new, but the place meant for the grip had been smoothed as though lightly worn.

Madhavi lifted the hammer. The weight was right.

Jagdish stood at the doorway.

"Is this mine?" Madhavi asked.

"Nails keep coming loose in a house."

Madhavi laughed. "Only nails?"

Jagdish gave no answer.

"You made the handle?"

"Measured to your grip."

Saying this, he came inside and picked up the old handle. His thumb passed over its two slanting cuts.

"Will you keep this?" Madhavi asked.

"This is mine."

"And the new one?"

"Yours."

Someone called from outside—the time for the vidai had come.

People gathered in the courtyard. Shanti held her daughter and wept. Madhavi's friends were crying too. Raghav stood a little distance away.

Jagdish remained standing near the gate. Someone said to him, "Give your daughter your blessing."

He placed his hand on Madhavi's head. No words came.

People kept waiting.

Madhavi did not.

She opened her trunk and placed the small hammer on top so it would not be pressed beneath the clothes. Then she closed the trunk.

Before the vehicle moved, she said to her father, "Keep your grip straight."

The corner of Jagdish's mouth moved slightly.

The vehicle went on. The gate, the bamboo, the women singing, the forge blackened with smoke—all fell behind.

Jagdish stood looking down the road for a long time. One by one, the others went back inside.

As dawn brightened, Shanti saw Jagdish sitting beside the forge. The fire was out. The old hammer lay on the anvil, but he was not lifting it.

"Rest," Shanti said.

Jagdish looked at the two slanting cuts on the old handle. "Customers will come late today."

He lit the fire.

The first blow was lighter than usual. So was the second.

On the third, a clear metallic note rang from the anvil.

At that same hour in Basantpur, Madhavi was opening the window of her new home. One nail in the window was indeed loose.

Raghav said, "I'll call the carpenter."

Madhavi opened her trunk.

"Let me look first," she said.

She took the small hammer in her hand, set it against the head of the nail, and before striking, paused for a moment to listen to the iron.

The Lantern Glass

In Basahia market, just as the colour of evening changes, so too does the voice of the shopkeeper. The person who is called a customer by day becomes familiar by dusk—someone is heading home, someone is talking about credit, someone stops for tea.

That evening was not ordinary. The electricity had been gone since late afternoon, and a thin layer of cloud was spread across the sky. Shops on both sides of the main road had lit their own lanterns.

Right beside Suresh Sahu's grocery shop stood Rahim Ansari's tailoring shop. Between them ran only a drain a handspan wide, with two bricks laid across it. For twenty years the two men had stepped on those bricks to pass from one shop to the other.

It was difficult to call Suresh and Rahim friends. Just as difficult to call them quarrelsome. They argued regularly over which way the drain water should slope, whose sacks spread as far as whose threshold, and in whose account the tea had been entered. Yet when a customer asked for needle and thread, Suresh pointed next door; when one of Rahim's customers asked for soap or oil, Rahim indicated Suresh's shop.

Rahim's lantern was old. Its brass colour had worn to a dull grey, black thread was wound around the handle, and there was a fine crack in the lower corner of the glass. Rahim would say, "That is not a crack. It is a line of age."

Suresh would laugh. "One day it will break, and then you will understand age."

That evening Rahim had hung the lantern from a bamboo peg outside the shop. Its light fell on the iron of the sewing machine, making a small bright streak. Inside, his son Sameer was writing something in a school notebook.

Shortly before seven, a motorcycle came racing from the northern end of the main road. Without stopping, the rider shouted, "Shut the shops! Fighting has started up ahead!"

He said it in a single breath and sped away. No one asked where, between whom, or who had seen it.

Within ten breaths the first shutter came down. Then another. The clang of metal ran from one shop to the next.

Messages began arriving on mobile phones. One said there was a crowd near the bridge. Another said people were moving toward the market. A third showed an old photograph, but no one checked the date.

Rahim came outside with the phone to his ear. His face was taut. "Sameer, pack up your notebook. We are going home."

As he closed his cash box, Suresh asked, "What happened?"

"I cannot make sense of anything. They called from home to say the little one's fever has risen. I am going there first."

Rahim covered the sewing machine with cloth. He reached out to put out the lantern, but just then the phone rang again. Still talking, he took Sameer by the hand and crossed the road. The lantern remained burning.

Suresh thought of calling out to him, but the jeweller opposite said, "Bring the shutter down. Do not delay."

Suresh lowered his shutter halfway. Inside, his wife Kamala called on the mobile. "Come home quickly. The children are frightened."

"I am closing the shop and coming," he said.

Meanwhile, a small group of people appeared running from the south. No one had a stick in hand, but at the sight of them running, the people in the market supplied a meaning from their own fears.

Someone shouted, "They are coming!"

Iron shutters crashed down together. In the blink of an eye the lane went dark. Only Rahim's lantern kept burning outside.

Suresh had almost closed his shutter. A gap two palms high remained at the bottom. He bent and looked out. The running people were in fact heading toward the bus stand. From far away came a sound like a police whistle.

Then, in the panic, a bicycle struck the bricks over the drain. The cyclist recovered, but the handlebar brushed the bamboo peg.

The lantern swung. First one way, then the other.

Without thinking, Suresh raised the shutter.

When the lantern slipped free of the peg, he ran and caught it by the handle. The hot body of the lantern touched the side of his palm. He hissed in pain, but did not let go.

Two drops of kerosene fell from the lower part. Had the lantern struck the stone, the glass might have shattered and the oil spread. Inside Rahim's shop, cloth, thread, paper—everything was dry.

Suresh carried the lantern into his own shop and blew out the wick. The glass survived, though the tip of the old crack had lengthened slightly.

"Have you gone mad?" the jeweller opposite called from behind his half-closed shutter. "Is this a time to go outside?"

Blowing on his palm, Suresh said, "There could have been a fire."

“Whose shop?”

Suresh gave no answer.

He placed the lantern on the floor away from the sacks of rice. Then he pulled Rahim’s shutter fully down. There was no padlock. In his haste Rahim had only fastened the hasp. Suresh put his own spare small padlock on it.

Meanwhile another commotion rose. This time, at the bend in the lane, five or seven young men were stopping motorcycles and telling people to go home. Whether their words were meant to reduce fear or increase it, no one was sure.

Suresh closed his own shutter and sat inside. Going out now seemed almost impossible.

The shop was dark. Only the glow of the mobile fell on his palm. The skin had turned red.

Kamala had already called five times. Suresh called her.

“Where are you?” Kamala’s voice was trembling.

“At the shop. I am safe.”

“Come home.”

“Let the road clear a little first.”

“Someone said they set fire to the market.”

Suresh sniffed the air around him. Spices, soap, a faint smell of kerosene. No smoke.

“There is no fire here,” he said.

“Then the messages?”

“There are plenty of messages.”

He put the phone down.

In the dark his foot touched the lantern’s handle. He bent and set it upright. In the light of the mobile, the crack in the glass shone like a white line.

From outside came the sound of something heavy being dragged. Suresh held his breath. Then he understood—two young men were moving a cart lying in the middle of the road so that an ambulance could pass.

After a while a police jeep arrived. A voice came through the loudspeaker: “Do not pay attention to rumours. Everyone remain in your homes. No riot has taken place in the market area.”

For the first time the word “riot” was heard clearly. What until then had been a shapeless fear now received a name from an official voice.

Suresh looked out through the gap in the shutter. The jeep passed. On the road lay a shoe, a vegetable basket, a half-crushed water bottle, and an overturned bicycle.

He unlocked the shutter and stepped outside. Two policemen stood as far as the bend. After taking their permission to go home, he closed his shop.

Rahim's lantern was in his hand.

One policeman asked, "What is that?"

"It belongs to my neighbour."

"Why are you taking it now?"

Suresh paused for a moment. "If I leave it outside, it will break."

The policeman looked at his palm. "Is that from the same lantern too?"

"Yes."

"Get your hand looked at first."

Suresh did not laugh. Carrying the lantern, he started home.

He was stopped three times on the way. Each time he heard a different version. Somewhere they said a crowd had come from across the river. Somewhere they said two shops in the market had been burned. Somewhere they said nothing had happened at all and the rumour had been spread only to facilitate theft.

Suresh argued with no one. In his hand was a lantern whose glass was intact. For him, that fact was enough.

When he reached home, Kamala first took hold of his hand, then noticed the lantern.

"Whose is this?"

"Rahim's."

"In the middle of closing your own shop, you brought this home?"

"It was falling."

Kamala looked at him for a moment. Then she warmed water and washed his palm.

"Where is Rahim?"

"He went home. The little one had a fever."

"Did you call him?"

Suresh fell silent. He had saved the lantern, yet it had not occurred to him to let Rahim know.

He called at once. The signal kept breaking. At last Sameer answered.

"Babu has gone to the hospital," he said. "The little one has a high fever."

"The shop is safe. The lantern is with me."

Sameer was silent for a few moments. "The lantern?"

"Yes. It was about to fall."

"Babu keeps saying the glass should never be replaced."

"The glass survived," Suresh said. "The crack has grown a little."

Sameer let out a faint breath. "Then it is all right."

All night different stories about the market formed and dissolved on mobile phones. One video showed smoke, but it was from another town. In one voice message someone said three people had been injured; by morning it was known that they had been hurt in a road accident.

Suresh placed the phone face down. The lantern stood on the cot. Its wick was out, but the light of the bulb in the house remained caught in the glass.

At dawn he was the first to reach the market.

Some shutters bore marks from police batons—the police had knocked on them while telling people to remain inside. Two carts were overturned. An elderly man had fallen while running. The glass of one grocery shop had broken in the pressure of the crowd.

But nowhere had there been a fire.

The market committee opened a register to record losses. Name, shop, damage.

“Suresh Sahu?” the secretary asked.

“Nothing.”

“Your hand?”

“No damage to the shop.”

“Rahim Ansari?”

“He has not come yet.”

“His shop?”

“Safe.”

The secretary moved on to the next name.

At ten o’clock Rahim arrived. The night’s wakefulness showed beneath his eyes. The little one’s fever had come down.

Without saying anything, Suresh brought out the lantern.

Rahim looked first at the glass, then at Suresh’s bandaged palm.

“It fell?”

“It was about to.”

Rahim turned the lantern and examined the crack. “The line has grown.”

“Put in a new glass. I will pay for it.”

Rahim shook his head. “Not yet.”

“Why?”

“This line is no longer only a line of age.”

Suresh looked at him. Rahim did not smile. He simply placed the lantern inside the shop.

By afternoon the market was almost normal again. People bought and sold as usual, but the stories of the night kept circling in conversation. Some told what they had heard as though they had seen it; others added what they had heard to what they had actually seen.

Twice Suresh thought of saying that nothing had happened. Then he remembered the old man fallen in the road, the overturned cart, the broken glass, and his own burned palm. “Nothing happened” was not the whole truth either.

That evening the electricity went out again.

Rahim filled the lantern with oil, straightened the wick, and lit it. Because of the crack, a fine white line appeared in the glass. One part of the light fell on his sewing machine; the other crossed the drain and fell on Suresh's sacks of rice.

Suresh kept watching.

Rahim said, "If I replace the glass, the light will be clear."

Suresh raised his bandaged hand. "Clear light does not always tell the whole story."

Rahim said nothing.

People began moving through the lane again. Children came laughing home from school. A bicycle climbed onto the same brick over the drain and jolted, but this time the bamboo peg was empty.

The lantern was kept inside the shop.

The light passing through its crack lay like a thin line between the two thresholds.

Under the Bridge

On the morning of the inauguration, coloured flags were being tied along the bridge. Below, in the shadow of the seventh pillar, Vimla was sweeping ash from the hearth.

From above came the tapping of hammers, the clatter of bamboo being shifted, and the announcer's voice, all descending together. Below, the children continued their own work amid those sounds.

Vimla's son Chhotu straightened two bricks and placed a brass bowl on them. Her daughter Kajal put a small stone on the pages of her notebook to keep the wind from turning them.

"You'll study here?" Vimla asked.

"The exam is tomorrow," Kajal said. "However much noise there is above, the lesson will not stop."

Vimla reached out to stroke her head, then lowered her hand. Her palm was full of ash.

Bisesar had not been home since the night before. Home—if it could be called that. Four bamboo poles, a blue tarpaulin, the frame of an old door, and the concrete roof of the bridge: together, that was their house.

Two years earlier, when the old settlement was demolished, the officials had said, "A place for rehabilitation will be found soon."

The word "soon" was now two years old.

Bisesar worked as a labourer on the construction of the bridge. First he carried iron rods, then mixed cement, and finally lifted the moulds for the railings. The bridge for which his old home had disappeared had also taken the sweat of his hands into its body.

Vimla called this neither pride nor irony. To her it was the ordinary arithmetic of life—wherever wages were available, one worked.

At seven o'clock a jeep came and stopped beneath the bridge.

Two men got out. One carried a file; an identity card hung around the other's neck.

"Who lives here?"

Vimla rose from beside the hearth. "We do."

"There is an inauguration today. This place has to be vacated."

Kajal lifted her head from her notebook.

Vimla asked, "For how long?"

"Until the programme is over. There will be cameras, guests. No one should be visible underneath."

Vimla looked at him for a moment. "Where are we supposed to go?"

The man pointed toward the empty sandbank across the road. "Sit there. You can come back in the evening."

"The tarpaulin?"

"You can leave it here, but no people should remain."

Vimla did not laugh. "If the tarpaulin is visible, will the camera not see it?"

The man with the identity card became slightly uncomfortable. "I am only telling you what I was told."

They left.

Chhotu asked softly, "Ma, is the camera afraid of us?"

Kajal immediately said, "Be quiet."

Vimla did not answer. She separated the two pieces of wood still left in the hearth, washed the bowl, opened an old sack, and began packing clothes.

Just then Bisesar arrived. A red gamchha was tied around his head, white cement dust covered his feet, and in his hand was a piece of paper wrapped around half a roti.

"Why are you packing everything?"

Vimla told him.

Bisesar looked up. Yellow and red cloth fluttered along the bridge. A banner bore large letters: "Bridge of New Development."

He said nothing.

"Have you nothing to say?" Vimla asked.

"What would saying it do?"

"You worked on this bridge."

"For wages."

"And the house?"

Bisesar fell silent again.

Kajal closed her notebook. Her father's silence angered her. When their old house had been demolished, Bisesar had stood silently in the line for paperwork then too. When his name appeared as "Bisheshwar" in the compensation papers and as "Bisesar" in the land papers, he had done nothing but scratch his head.

Kajal thought: if Babu spoke loudly just once, something might change.

Bisesar picked up a sack. "Let's go."

"How far?" Chhotu asked.

"As far as the camera cannot reach," Kajal said.

Vimla glared at her, but for an instant the corner of Bisesar's mouth moved.

Together they carried three sacks, a bucket, two plates, Kajal's books and notebooks, Chhotu's tin car, and the essential things from beneath the tarpaulin toward the sandbank. The doorframe, the hearth, and the heavy chest were left beneath the bridge.

There was no shade on the sandbank. The Bhadon sun was not yet at full strength, but the sand had begun to heat.

Bisesar spread an old mat. Vimla sat down. Chhotu began making roads in the sand with his tin car. Kajal opened her notebook.

Above them, preparations for the programme intensified. The same sentence kept coming through the loudspeaker: "The honourable guest will arrive at ten o'clock."

Kajal began reading her lesson—"Because of river erosion..."

She stopped.

Her textbook had a chapter on floods, erosion, rehabilitation, and development. The words were neat and clean. In the picture there was a bridge, a bus passing over it, and a blue river below. There was no tarpaulin, no sack.

Kajal closed the book.

"Why aren't you reading?" Bisesar asked.

"The picture is wrong."

"Can a picture be wrong too?"

"It can."

Bisesar took the book in his hand. He looked at it for a few moments. "It shows the space under the bridge as empty."

Kajal said, "Place."

"What?"

"Not space—place."

Bisesar laughed. "All right. It shows the place under the bridge as empty."

Vimla smiled for the first time.

At half past nine people began gathering on the bridge. Motorcycles, bicycles, groups on foot. Schoolchildren dressed in red and yellow. A beat of the drum travelled as far as the sandbank.

Chhotu stood up. "Can I go and see?"

"No," Vimla said.

"From far away?"

"Stay here."

Chhotu puffed out his cheeks.

Kajal said to him, "Drive your car. You see the bridge every day."

"Today it has flowers on it."

“Has the bridge changed because of flowers?”

Chhotu thought. “The top has changed.”

Hearing this, Bisesar began scratching at the sand.

At ten o’clock the loudspeaker made the formal announcement. The guest had arrived. Cheers rose. A red ribbon was stretched across the top of the bridge.

From the sandbank the four members of the family could see only heads and flags at a distance.

Vimla asked, “They didn’t call you?”

“Who?”

“The labourers.”

Bisesar did not raise his head. “The contractor said two or four people would be there. I was on the night shift. My name is not on the list.”

Kajal said, “Where is your name written on the bridge?”

This time Bisesar looked directly at her.

“Name?”

“Of the people who built it.”

“The engineer’s name will be on the plaque.”

“The labourers?”

Bisesar searched for an answer, then said, “My name is in my hands.”

Kajal was not satisfied. “After you wash your hands?”

Vimla laughed, saying, “Oh God.” Bisesar laughed too.

At that moment loud applause broke out above. The ribbon had been cut.

Suddenly the wind grew strong. The flags fluttered. The voice in the loudspeaker trembled.

The guest began the speech: “This bridge will not merely connect two banks...”

The rest of the sentence broke apart in the wind and the cheering.

Kajal tried to listen carefully. She might have to write an essay on the subject at school.

“...the economic progress of the region... transportation... new opportunities...”

Chhotu raced his tin car across the sand, making the shadow of the bridge into its road.

Kajal wrote in her notebook: “A bridge connects two banks.”

Then she stopped.

Below it she wrote a second line: “Sometimes people are left behind beneath a bridge.”

Bisesar saw the line but said nothing.

Before noon the sky suddenly darkened. Clouds gathered in the distant east.

Vimla said, "It will rain."

The programme was still going on. Food packets were being distributed on the bridge. The crowd spread as far as the railing.

The first drop left a large round mark on the sand.

"Pick up the things," Vimla said.

Bisesar looked up toward their tarpaulin beneath the bridge. It was only two hundred feet away, but a bamboo police barricade stood between them and it.

"Let's go there," Chhotu said.

Bisesar picked up the bucket and reached the barricade. A policeman extended a hand and stopped him.

"The programme is not over."

"It is raining. Our things are there."

"Not yet."

"There are children."

The policeman looked up. The rain was growing heavier. He too needed shelter.

"Wait five minutes."

For the first time Bisesar raised his voice. "In five minutes the books will be soaked."

Kajal heard him from a distance. She was surprised.

The policeman was about to say something when one of the programme organisers came running. "No one is to go underneath. The cameras are still moving around."

Bisesar looked at him. "Does the rain ask the camera before it falls?"

The young man became irritated. "Don't make an issue of it."

Just then lightning flashed. With a strong gust of wind, rain crashed down all at once. The crowd on the bridge scattered. People ran toward the stage, vehicles, and tents.

On the sandbank the mat was soaked in an instant. Vimla put a sack over her head. Kajal pressed her notebook against her stomach. Chhotu began to cry.

Bisesar lifted the barricade and led his family through.

The policeman did not stop them. The organiser said something, but his voice drowned in the rain.

Reaching the seventh pillar, Kajal first opened her notebook. The edges were wet, but the pages inside had survived.

Vimla straightened the bricks of the hearth. Chhotu crawled under the tarpaulin.

Bisesar saw that the doorframe had been pushed to one side. Mud from a large shoe was smeared across the chest. Someone clearing the way for the inauguration decorations must have shoved their things aside.

He lifted the doorframe.

At that moment the first official line of vehicles began crossing the bridge. The growl of tyres travelled down through the concrete body and became a vibration in the pillar.

Chhotu startled. "The bridge is shaking!"

Bisesar placed his hand on the pillar. "This much shaking is all right."

"How do you know?"

"I listened to it while we were building it."

Chhotu too placed his palm on the pillar. His face became serious.

Above, one final wave of applause rose.

The rain lasted fifteen minutes. It eased as quickly as it had arrived.

The programme on the bridge began putting itself together again. Wet chairs were wiped, the loudspeaker sounded once more, and people began looking for food packets.

Below, Vimla searched for dry wood in the hearth.

Kajal saw a small piece of the red ribbon wash down from the edge of the bridge with the rainwater. It caught near her foot.

Chhotu ran and picked it up. "Is this the same ribbon?"

Kajal said, "Probably."

Chhotu tried to tie it around his neck. Vimla stopped him. "It's wet. Throw it away."

Chhotu did not throw it away. He tied it behind his tin car. As the car moved, the red strip dragged over the sand.

Kajal laughed.

Bisesar did not laugh, but his eyes remained fixed on Chhotu's car.

The programme ended in the afternoon. The vehicles left. A few flower petals remained stuck to the bridge, and paper cups stayed caught in the drain.

The man with the identity card came down again.

"You can stay here now," he said.

Vimla kept blowing on the hearth. "We are staying here now."

The man could not tell whether it was an answer or a statement. He left.

By evening the river water had turned deep brown. Traffic on the new bridge became ordinary—motorcycles, tractors, buses, small vehicles. The sound of each vehicle came down below as a different wave.

Chhotu had turned it into a game.

"This is a motorcycle."

Rrrr-rrrr.

"This is a tractor."

Dham-dham-dham.

"This is a bus!"

The whole roof thundered once.

Bisesar kept correcting his guesses.

Kajal sat down to study, but again and again the noise from above broke her concentration. Irritated, she closed the notebook.

"Isn't your exam tomorrow?" Bisesar asked.

"It is."

"Then study."

"There is too much noise."

Bisesar thought for a moment. He opened the chest and took out an old sack. He hung the sack on one side of the doorframe and doubled the tarpaulin on the other. The noise did not stop, but it grew softer.

"Will this do?"

Kajal opened her notebook. "This will do."

Vimla put rice on to cook. Smoke rose beside the pillar and merged into the darkness under the bridge.

After dinner Bisesar took out his file. Inside a plastic bag were papers for compensation, rehabilitation, identity, and wages.

He placed one paper before Kajal.

"Read this for me."

Kajal read, "Applicant's name—Bisheshwar Paswan."

"I am Bisesar."

"That I know."

"Look below."

Kajal continued reading. Old settlement, acquired area, temporary rehabilitation, verification pending.

"You will sit your exam tomorrow. The day after, I will take this file to the office."

Kajal looked at her father. "And stay silent again?"

Before Bisesar could answer, a heavy truck crossed above. The pillar shuddered. Water trembled in the bowl.

He watched until the water grew still.

"No," he said. "This time I will say my name correctly."

Kajal wanted to ask—only the name? What about the house? What about the place? But she stopped herself. For the first time, her father had said "no" on his own.

Night deepened. Half the decorative lights fixed above the bridge were switched off, but two lights in the middle remained lit. Their glow broke along the edge of the pillar and came down below.

Vimla stood the old doorframe upright again. Its wood had survived from their old house. When the house was demolished, Bisesar had refused to throw it away.

“Why here?” Kajal asked.

“The mouth of the tarpaulin hangs crooked,” Vimla said. “With the frame here, the curtain sits properly.”

“A house without a door?”

“Which comes first—the house or the door?” Vimla returned the question.

Kajal did not answer.

Chhotu brought his tin car through the frame. The red inauguration ribbon was still tied behind it, now dry and stiff.

He stopped the car beside the chest. “My bridge has opened.”

“Your bridge?” Kajal teased.

“Babu built it.”

Bisesar heard from a distance. “Many people built it.”

Chhotu thought, then said, “Then it is everyone’s bridge.”

No answer came.

At night the first bus crossed the bridge. Its heavy sound slowly receded into the distance.

Below, Kajal bent over her notebook beside the lamp. She crossed out the first line of her essay and wrote it again—

“A bridge is built to connect two banks.”

Before writing the second line, she looked up. Beyond the doorframe, the pillar, the tarpaulin, the smoke, the tin car with the red ribbon tied to it, and the file beside her father were all held in the same view.

Kajal left the second line blank.

Outside, Bisesar kept his palm against the pillar. Again and again, the vibration of vehicles travelled down through the new bridge.

He knew that vibration.

Now he also had to say his own name clearly.

Paper and Stick

The rains had receded, but the smell of earth still rose from the western hamlet of Sonbarsa village. Along the narrow ridge running through the transplanted paddy, two bamboo poles had been driven into the ground and red cloth tied to them.

Since early morning people had kept gathering around those poles. Some carried old papers, some bamboo sticks, some only questions.

Harinarayan Yadav stood at the corner of his field. His right foot was on the ridge, his left sunk in the wet mud of the paddy. Again and again he said the same thing—"From this marker eastward, six kathas are mine."

In front of him, Rambabu, the surveyor from the circle office, was unrolling the measuring line. With him were two employees, a revenue clerk, and four policemen.

At the very front stood the clerk Manoj, holding the Circle Officer's file. The file had a green cover, and in bold letters on top was written: "Order for Delivery of Possession."

Manoj opened the file and took out a sheet. "The order is that possession of the southern portion of plot number two hundred sixty-nine be delivered to the family of Ramvilas Paswan."

A murmur ran through the whole hamlet.

Ramvilas's widow, Sarita, stood a little distance away with her son Sonu. In her hand was a basgit parcha kept inside a waterproof cover. The corners of the paper were worn, but the red seal was still clear.

Harinarayan looked at her. "I have no enmity with Ramvilas. But how does land my grandfather tilled become someone else's because of one line on a piece of paper?"

Sarita said softly, "I too received this land on paper. For eight years I have been running to the office. Now will you say paper means nothing?"

No answer came at once.

The surveyor stretched the line from the first bamboo marker. It ran straight across the paddy plants.

Harinarayan's younger brother Mahesh stepped forward. He had a stick in his hand, but its end was resting on the ground. "The line will not run from here. It will run from that old ridge."

Without lifting his head, Rambabu said, "We will follow the map."

"A map does not till a ridge," Mahesh replied.

The policemen became a little more alert.

The Circle Officer, Navalkishore, got out of the vehicle and came over. Flecks of dust marked his white kurta. He took the file first, then looked around.

"Has the order been read out?"

Manoj nodded.

"Then begin the measurement."

From the crowd, old Dukhan Mahto called out, "Babu, look at the old map once as well. After the river cut the bank, this ridge shifted twice."

Navalkishore did not know him. "The old map that is in the file has been examined."

Pointing with his walking stick toward the stump of a mango tree in the east, Dukhan said, "That tree was alive in the year I was married. The boundary ran from that tree."

Manoj suppressed a smile. "Government measurement is not done from trees."

Dukhan fell silent, but his stick remained raised toward the stump.

Rambabu carried the other end of the line to the planted bamboo. The measurement placed the land described in Sarita's parcha inside the paddy Harinarayan had planted.

Harinarayan went completely still. His eyes were on the paddy. "This crop is from my seed."

Sarita said, "Harvest the crop. I need a place to build a house, not paddy."

Mahesh broke in, "Today we give the land; tomorrow she will say the crop is hers too."

Sarita turned and looked at him. "I have not asked for anyone's crop. For eight years I have been placing a basin on the roof to keep the rain out."

The crowd began to separate as though into two pieces. On one side was the Yadav hamlet, on the other people who had come from the Dalit settlement. Between them the measuring line was stretched taut.

Navalkishore read the order again. The words were clear—"After demarcation, lawful possession shall be ensured."

He asked Manoj, "When was the earlier demarcation done?"

"Three months ago."

"In whose presence?"

Manoj turned the papers. "The report itself says—in the presence of local witnesses."

"Names?"

Manoj kept turning pages. In the space for names were two illegible signatures.

Dukhan Mahto slowly came closer. "No one called me."

Harinarayan said, "Nor me."

Sarita gripped her parcha tightly. Worry showed on her face. "Then does that make my order false?"

Navalkishore looked at her. "I did not say the order is false. We will see whether the measurement is correct."

Mahesh's stick still rested on the ground, but his fingers had tightened around it. The policeman Ramsevak kept watching his hand.

Rambabu opened a copy of the old map. A thin blue line ran across it—a former channel. In the present field that channel was nowhere visible.

Navalkishore asked, "This blue line?"

"An old watercourse, sir."

Dukhan immediately said, "Not a watercourse. A seasonal stream. It filled with earth twenty-four years ago."

Harinarayan's father, Kailash, who until then had stood behind the crowd, stepped forward for the first time. His hands were empty. "When the channel filled, the panchayat fixed the ridge again. The paper for it was in the old cupboard at the school."

Manoj did not laugh, but disbelief was plain on his face. "Land papers in the school?"

Kailash said, "At that time there was no panchayat building. All the files were kept in the school."

Sarita looked toward Sonu. The child was making a small groove in the wet mud with the tip of his slipper.

Navalkishore signalled for the measurement to stop. A murmur immediately rose through the crowd.

Mahesh said, "This is a game to delay things. Even with an order, they will not give the land."

From Sarita's settlement, Geeta Devi answered, "It has been delayed for eight years. Delay it again?"

Voices rose from both sides.

Ramsevak raised his hand and said, "Keep the sticks down. No one will cross the line."

Mahesh flared up. "I cannot cross a line in my own field?"

Ramsevak replied calmly, "No one will, for now."

At that moment the wind strengthened. One sheet of the order slipped from Manoj's hand and fell among the paddy. Sonu ran toward it. He bent to pick up the page, but his foot caught in the measuring line.

One of the bamboo markers was pulled loose. Instinctively, Mahesh thrust his stick forward and kept Sonu from falling.

For a moment everyone was silent.

Sonu steadied himself by holding the stick. The wet sheet of the order was in his hand.

Mahesh rested the stick on the ground again. "Save the paper."

Sarita reached her son. Mud stained his knee. She said nothing.

Navalkishore looked toward the old school building in the distance. "We need to see the cupboard."

Manoj looked at his watch. "Office hours—"

"Today the office is here," Navalkishore cut him off.

Everyone went together to the school. The headmaster was startled at first, then opened the lock of an old room. Inside were dust, broken chairs, an old election box, and an iron cupboard.

The cupboard lock had rusted. It opened after the key was turned three times.

Among the tied files inside they found the panchayat proceedings register from 2002. The pages had turned yellow.

Kailash's eyes brightened. "It will be in this."

Manoj kept turning the pages. At last they found an entry—a panchayat decision redefining the access path to the fields and the ridge after the seasonal stream had filled in.

Rambabu placed the entry beside the map and read it. Three markers were recorded: the old mango tree, the northern corner of the pond, and the earthen ridge.

Leaning on his stick, Dukhan Mahto said, "Those are the three markers I was talking about."

Navalkishore became serious. "But why was this panchayat decision never entered in the revenue records?"

No one had an answer.

Manoj said softly, "Perhaps the change was never recorded."

Harinarayan's face hardened. "If it was not recorded, is that my fault?"

Sarita immediately said, "And mine?"

This time the question from both sides was the same.

Navalkishore closed the register. "No. If the record is incomplete, the fault is neither yours nor hers."

Mahesh asked sharply, "Then what of the order?"

"The order will stand. But possession will not be delivered by force on the basis of a wrong demarcation. First there will be a fresh measurement."

Geeta Devi was dissatisfied. "Another month or two?"

“No. The measurement will be done today itself, using the three old markers.”

Everyone returned to the field. This time the line was stretched from the mango stump to the northern corner of the pond. The measurement changed.

Under the new line, Sarita’s six kathas did not fall inside Harinarayan’s planted paddy but on the fallow strip to its south—though one corner of the bamboo cowshed Mahesh had built stood on it.

Mahesh stopped short.

Rambabu said, “About three cubits of the cowshed will have to be removed.”

Mahesh ran his hand over the handle of his stick. “I built this cowshed five years ago.”

Harinarayan looked at him. “We built it thinking the land was fallow.”

Sarita said nothing.

Navalkishore asked, “How much time do you need?”

Mahesh did not answer.

Kailash said softly, “It is a bamboo cowshed. Half a day.”

Mahesh looked at his father. “And the paddy?”

“The paddy has been saved,” Kailash said.

For the first time Sarita looked as though she had released a breath.

On the back of the order Navalkishore wrote a new note—“Previous demarcation revised due to an error in the records. Fresh measurement conducted on site. Boundary marked in the presence of the parties.”

Manoj asked, “Possession now?”

Navalkishore looked toward Sarita. “If she is ready.”

Sarita looked at the new bamboo marker driven into the soil. “I am ready. But I will not remain here while the cowshed is taken down.”

For the first time Mahesh looked directly at her.

“Why?”

“You remove your own cowshed. I came to receive my land, not to watch your humiliation.”

Mahesh’s grip on the stick loosened.

The next morning Mahesh and Harinarayan began unfastening the bamboo. Sonu stood at a distance. After a while he ran forward to lift one pole.

Mahesh said, “This is heavy.”

Sonu replied, “I’ll hold one end.”

Together they lifted the two ends of the same bamboo pole.

Sarita took her parcha out of its waterproof cover and looked at it again. The new measurement was now written on the paper.

Harinarayan stood on the paddy ridge. His feet were sunk in the mud as they had been the day before, but this time the measuring line did not cut through the paddy.

Leaning on his stick beside the mango stump, Dukhan Mahto smiled. "The tree died, but the marker survived."

Manoj, who had come again to write the report, said, "Markers survive if someone writes them down."

Dukhan replied, "And what is written survives if someone reads it."

By noon the cowshed had been removed. Small bamboo poles were planted at all four corners of Sarita's land.

Sonu began tying a red cloth to the first corner. Mahesh did not take the cloth from his hand; he only showed him how to tighten the knot.

By evening the policemen had left. The order file had returned to the office. The sticks had been put against the walls of the houses.

In the field there remained only four bamboo poles, one old mango stump, and the green rows of paddy.

On his way home Harinarayan stopped beside Sarita's new marker. The soil there had been pressed down slightly. He levelled it with his foot.

Sarita watched from a distance. She said nothing.

That day the administrative order was completed on paper, but on the land its final line was written not by anyone's pen, but by the footprints of two families.

The Smell of Jackfruit

As evening fell, doors in the western quarter of Sonbarsa market began closing again and again.

Nothing major had happened all day. In the afternoon two young men had quarrelled near the bus stand—someone said over the fare, someone said over a motorcycle being touched, someone said over caste. By evening, the story of the incident had spread farther than the incident itself.

The shopkeepers who kept their shutters open kept looking at one another's faces. No one clearly knew what there was to fear, yet fear was already present.

Mahendra Sah's grocery shop stood at the bend where the quarter began. He left the day's accounts half-finished and began tying the mouths of the sacks. From inside, his wife Sudha asked, "So early?"

Mahendra said, "People are saying the night will not be good."

"Which people?"

Mahendra did not answer.

At that moment, across the road, Nasim Mian could be seen fastening the gate of his courtyard. Behind his house stood an old jackfruit tree. Three days earlier a large ripe jackfruit had fallen. Half had been shared at home; Nasim Mian had been thinking of sending the other half to his sister's house.

The thick smell of jackfruit reached Mahendra's nose—sweet, warm, touched faintly by rot.

The smell reminded him of rainy seasons in childhood. His mother would cut jackfruit and separate the seeds, and Mahendra would wrinkle his nose and run away. Later he would eat those same seeds boiled in salted water.

Sudha said, "Tell Nasim Bhai to move the jackfruit. The smell will grow stronger at night."

Mahendra looked toward the gate. Nasim Mian was looking at him too. Until two days ago the two men had spoken over evening tea; now it felt as though not a few cubits but an entire road lay between their gates.

Mahendra said, "I'll tell him in the morning."

At seven the electricity went out.

As darkness fell, rumours began moving faster. First it was said that one young man had been injured in the bus-stand quarrel. Then it was said he had died. Then someone said outsiders were coming toward the quarter.

No one had seen anything, but someone's uncle, someone's maternal uncle, someone's brother-in-law, an acquaintance, or a 'reliable' policeman was cited as though he had seen everything.

Mahendra kept his son Anuj inside the door. Anuj was twelve, and his curiosity was greater than his fear.

"Babu, is someone coming?"

"No."

"Then why is the door shut?"

"It is night."

Anuj began looking at the road through the slit in the window.

There was no light in Nasim Mian's house either. Only a candle flickered toward the kitchen. In the darkness the smell of jackfruit grew denser.

By eight o'clock four young men were standing in the road holding bamboo sticks. They were boys from the same quarter, yet the hardness on their faces made Mahendra's own familiar boys seem unfamiliar.

One of them, Binod, came to Mahendra's door.

"Kaka, stay inside. The news is not good."

"What sort of news?"

Lowering his voice, Binod said, "People are gathering from that side."

"Which side?"

Binod waved toward one direction, but that direction contained half the market, the hospital, the mosque, the pond, and the railway crossing.

Mahendra asked, "Did you see them?"

Binod remained silent for a few moments. "People told us."

Mahendra closed the door.

Inside, Sudha lit the small lamp in the prayer corner. Anuj sat before it and opened a book, but he was not reading.

At nine a sound rose somewhere in the distance. At first it seemed like a crowd shouting. Then, listening carefully, they realised that dogs were barking together.

After that something fell on a tin roof.

Anuj shuddered.

Mahendra ran toward the door. Sudha caught his arm.

"Don't open it."

Mahendra looked through the slit in the window. There was no one on the road. From Nasim Mian's courtyard came repeated thudding sounds.

Then the sound of a child crying could be heard.

Anuj said, "That is Sameena."

Sameena was Nasim Mian's eight-year-old granddaughter.

Sudha said again, "Do not open the door."

Mahendra listened again for the child. This time, along with the crying, came someone's frightened voice.

"Ammi, a branch of the tree has fallen on the roof!"

Mahendra thought of going outside, but at that moment he heard running footsteps at the other end of the road. Four or five shadows were moving toward the bend.

He went back inside.

The smell of jackfruit was now so strong that Sudha covered her nose with the end of her sari.

Anuj whispered, "Babu, the tree must have broken."

Mahendra understood—the smell was not coming only from ripe fruit. A falling branch must have split two or three jackfruits open.

In the midst of fear, that smell was such an ordinary fact that something inside Mahendra straightened.

He remembered that Nasim Mian had an old pain in his knee. His son worked in Saudi Arabia. At home were Nasim Mian, his wife Halima, their daughter-in-law Rukhsana, and two children.

The shadows on the road came closer.

Binod's voice called out, "Kaka, don't come outside!"

Mahendra looked through the window. Binod had three young men with him. All carried sticks.

"What happened?" Mahendra asked from inside.

"There was some sound from Nasim's house. We are going to see."

There was caution in Binod's voice, but one of the young men with him said, "First find out who all are inside."

A tremor ran through Mahendra's body.

He opened the door and stepped outside.

Behind him Sudha said only once, "Mahendra!"

Mahendra's hands were empty. Binod looked surprised.

"Kaka, stay inside."

Mahendra said, "A jackfruit branch has fallen there."

One of the young men laughed. "You can see jackfruit in this darkness?"

Mahendra replied, "I didn't see it. I can smell it."

No one quite understood.

Mahendra began crossing the road.

Nasim Mian's gate was bolted from inside. Mahendra knocked three times.

"Nasim Bhai!"

At first there was silence inside. Then Halima's voice came, "Who is it?"

“It is Mahendra.”

The wait before the bolt opened felt very long. In truth it was only a few moments.

As soon as the gate opened, the smell of jackfruit seemed to spill out. A thick branch lay slantwise across the courtyard. Two jackfruits had split with it; yellow bulbs were stuck to mud, leaves, and old rainwater.

One corner of the thatch had been crushed. Sameena was crying at the edge of the courtyard. Nasim Mian was trying unsuccessfully to move the branch.

Mahendra stepped inside.

Nasim Mian stopped when he saw him. Relief did not come first to his face; hesitation did.

“You, now?”

Mahendra said only, “This branch will not move with one pair of hands.”

Binod stood outside the gate.

Mahendra called to him, “We need four hands.”

Binod came in. Two young men followed him, but the third remained outside.

Nasim Mian brought an old saw. Its teeth were blunt. Mahendra thought of fetching the axe from his own house.

The young man standing outside said, “Kaka, it is not right to leave your house so often tonight.”

Mahendra replied, “The axe is in my house. The branch is in his. The road will clear only when the two meet.”

Anuj was already standing at the door holding the axe. Sudha was behind him.

“I came to give it,” Anuj said.

Sudha was holding him. She extended the axe toward Mahendra but did not cross the road.

Mahendra returned to Nasim’s courtyard.

The first blow struck the branch. The sound of metal against green wood rang clearly in the darkness.

With that sound, the sticks in the hands of the young men standing on the road lowered slightly.

A window in another house opened. Someone asked, “What happened?”

Binod replied, “A tree branch has fallen.”

Someone inside asked, “And that sound?”

“The axe.”

Two minutes later old Ramcharitra Jha from another house came out carrying a lantern.

“Need light?”

Halima said, "Bring it."

The lantern was set in the courtyard. In its glow the split bulbs of jackfruit gleamed.

Rukhsana brought a sack from inside. She began separating the ripe bulbs because someone might step on them and slip. Sameena stopped crying and began holding the sack.

Binod began cutting the thinner part of the branch. Mahendra stripped leaves from the thicker section. Nasim Mian could not bend his knee, so he kept shifting the pieces that had been cut.

The tension of the night had not ended. At the other end of the road people were still moving about with sticks. Somewhere a rumour would rise again, then subside.

But in that small courtyard everyone's attention was now on a single branch.

Wrinkling his nose, Ramcharitra Jha said, "This jackfruit smell will keep the whole quarter awake."

Halima smiled for the first time. "Tomorrow I'll send half to your house."

Ramcharitra said, "Then I won't complain."

Binod laughed. In his hand was not a stick but a saw.

Half an hour later the way was clear. The bamboo of the crushed roof was still bent, but there was no longer any danger of it falling.

Mahendra asked for water to wash the axe. Halima gave him a lota. Jackfruit latex had dried on the blade like a white film.

Nasim Mian said softly, "Mahendra Babu, is the storeroom behind your shop open?"

Mahendra was startled.

"Why?"

"I saw it while fastening the gate. I thought I would tell you, but..."

He left the sentence unfinished.

Mahendra understood that the distance which had become a road between their gates had existed inside Nasim too.

He said, "Come, let's see."

The two crossed the road.

The rear door of the storeroom was indeed half open. The wind was moving the panel in and out. The sacks were safe.

Mahendra closed the door and fastened the bolt.

Nasim Mian said, "In this darkness, if anyone saw it, they would say there had been a theft."

Mahendra said, "And by tomorrow the thief's name would be decided too."

The two remained silent for a few moments.

From the far end of the road came the light of a police jeep. It approached slowly. Two policemen kept urging people to go inside their homes.

One policeman saw the saw in Binod's hand. "What is that for?"

Binod pointed toward the jackfruit branch.

The policeman wrinkled his nose. "The smell reaches a long way."

Ramcharitra Jha said, "The smell is how we knew the tree had fallen."

The policeman said nothing. He moved on.

The night was not over yet. Mahendra returned home and bolted the door, but this time he left the small upper slit open.

Sudha asked, "Everything all right?"

"The roof was crushed. The people are fine."

Anuj asked, "Are people coming from outside?"

Mahendra said, "No one at the moment."

Anuj asked again, "Then is the fear over?"

Before Mahendra answered, the outside air came in. The smell of jackfruit was weaker now, but still distinct.

"Fear will remain," he said, "but not every sound is a crowd."

Sudha lowered the lamp wick.

After midnight rain began to fall. At first the sound of water on the roof startled everyone again; then, slowly, it became ordinary.

When the market opened in the morning, all of the previous night's rumours had taken different forms. Someone said five hundred people had been coming; someone said the police had stopped them in time; someone said nothing at all had happened.

As Mahendra opened his shop, he looked toward Nasim Mian's courtyard. The cut branch lay to one side. Flies buzzed over the scraps left from the split jackfruits.

Sameena crossed the road carrying a plate.

"Grandmother sent this."

The plate held clean jackfruit bulbs.

Sudha came outside. "Why so much?"

Sameena said, "These were the good ones left from what broke yesterday."

Sudha took the plate. She gave one bulb to Anuj. He brought it to his nose, smelled it, and laughed.

By afternoon the truth about the bus-stand quarrel came out. The injured young man had gone home from the hospital. He had not died. The dispute had begun over fare and jostling; there was no evidence for the caste, religion, or outside crowd that had been added to it through the night.

Binod came to Mahendra's shop in the evening.

"Kaka, yesterday we went outside for nothing."

Mahendra said, "Not for nothing. You helped remove the branch."

Binod fell silent.

Mahendra gave him two packets of salt. "Take these to Nasim Bhai."

Binod took the packets but asked, "Won't you give them yourself?"

Mahendra laughed. "You go. Yesterday you held a saw; today hold salt."

Binod crossed the road.

That evening the electricity went out again.

This time the doors did not close at once.

From Nasim Mian's courtyard came the smell of jackfruit seeds boiling. In her kitchen Sudha tempered spices. The two smells met in the middle of the road.

Anuj sat by the window doing his homework. Once he lifted his nose and said, "Jackfruit again today."

Writing the accounts, Mahendra said, "Yes."

"Like yesterday?"

Mahendra looked outside. Nasim Mian sat on a cot with his gate half open. Ramcharitra Jha was walking slowly along the road. Binod rode past, ringing his bicycle bell.

Mahendra said, "The smell is the same. The night is different."

The Rumour of Five Bullets

The evening market seemed to tire early that day. The damp heat of Bhadon had clung to the body all day, and as the sun went down, the yellow lights of the shops in the old post-office lane came on one by one.

Ramsevak Sahu was putting away the weights of the scale in his spice shop. Across from him, Shafiq the tailor stopped his sewing machine and bit off the thread with his teeth. At the medicine shop, Sushila Devi was reading a prescription for fever medicine.

The first sharp sound came and vanished so quickly that before anyone understood it, all the pigeons in the lane rose at once.

Immediately after it came a second sound.

Some heard a third; some did not.

Holding a scale weight in his hand, Ramsevak looked outside. Shafiq caught the half-lowered shutter of his shop. Sushila dropped the prescription and turned toward the door.

Chhotu came running from the bend in the lane. His breath was breaking.

"Shots were fired!" was all he said.

"How many?" Ramsevak asked.

Without stopping, Chhotu answered, "Five."

He ran on.

Ramsevak had not heard five. He remembered two clear sounds. But the word "five" ran through the lane faster than Chhotu.

Shafiq pulled his shutter all the way down. When the metal sheet struck the ground, there was another loud bang. Karim, his assistant sitting inside, started and said, "Now it has become six."

Shafiq scolded him, "That was my shutter."

Karim did not answer, but in his eyes the number was still six.

At the medicine shop, the mother of a child burning with fever stood before Sushila Devi. She wanted to take the medicine and reach home quickly. As soon as she heard what people were saying outside, her hand began to tremble.

"I heard three," Sushila said.

The child's mother whispered, "Outside they are saying five."

Wrapping the bottle in paper, Sushila said, "What people are saying is not what I saw."

Meanwhile, at the western end of the lane, Kailash the tea seller had set water on his stove. He had not heard the first sound at all. When the second came, he was washing a brass tumbler.

Two customers sitting at Kailash's shop stood up at the same instant. One said, "Four shots." The other said, "Seven."

"Did you count them?" Kailash asked.

"My brother told me on the phone," the first customer replied.

"Where is he?"

"At the bus stand."

The bus stand was half a kos from the old post office.

Kailash lowered the flame under the stove. The tea kept boiling, but the customers left their tumblers half-finished and went away.

Within ten minutes, half the shutters in the market were down. Every loose shutter that fell with a bang was becoming another new shot. When a motorcycle exhaust popped somewhere in the distance, the people sitting in the lane looked at one another.

Harinarayan Mishra stood near the veranda of the old post office. He was a retired postal worker and came walking as far as that veranda every evening. At the time of the sounds, he had been behind the building, where wires near the electrical transformer had flashed.

He saw one sharp flash, then a little later heard two separate sounds.

When he came around to the front, the first question put to him was, "Kaka, five shots were fired, weren't they?"

Harinarayan said, "I did not see any shot being fired."

"The sounds?"

"I heard sounds."

"How many?"

He paused. The eyes of the questioner already wanted an answer before he gave one.

"Two or three. There was also a flash near the transformer."

As the questioner turned away, he whispered into someone else's ear, "Harinarayan Kaka saw three shots and a flash too."

Harinarayan heard him. He wanted to call out, but the scraping rush of running feet from ahead cut off his words.

A bicycle lay fallen in the middle of the lane. Its owner was twelve-year-old Pawan, who had been taking two bottles of milk home. Hearing the commotion, he had abandoned the bicycle and run into a nearby grain shop.

One bottle had broken. Milk was flowing toward the drain.

From inside his shutter, Ramsevak recognised Pawan and called him over.

“Where is your home?”

“East hamlet.”

“Who were you with?”

“No one.”

Pawan’s lips were trembling. He did not know how many shots there had been; he knew only that one bottle of milk had broken and his mother would scold him.

Ramsevak took an empty bottle kept inside the shop and poured the remaining milk into it. Then he knocked on the closed shutter of the neighbouring milk shop. A voice from inside said, “Not today.”

Ramsevak said, “The boy’s bottle has broken.”

After a few moments the shutter rose four fingers high. A hand came out, gave half a bottle of milk, and the shutter dropped again.

For Pawan, at that moment it no longer mattered whether there had been five shots in the market or seven. His two bottles were full again.

At the other end of the lane, Sarju, the ward night-watchman, arrived blowing his whistle. A bamboo stick was in his hand. People surrounded him.

“Where were the shots fired?”

“Who fired them?”

“How many were injured?”

Sarju knew the answer to none of the three questions. The police station had told him only that there was a commotion in the market and that he should see the situation and report back.

But the crowd could not bear an empty answer.

“At least five,” someone said.

“I heard seven,” another voice said.

“No, three,” Sushila Devi said from inside her shop.

“Could have been two as well,” Harinarayan added.

Sarju rested the tip of his stick on the ground. “Whoever saw it, raise your hand.”

No hand went up.

“Who only heard sounds?”

Almost every hand went up.

“Who heard the number from someone else?”

Some hands slowly went down; some remained raised.

This small test did not calm the crowd, but for one moment everyone did look at their own palms.

Two policemen came from the station. They examined the lane, looked for fresh holes in shop walls, searched the ground for cartridge cases, and asked whether anyone had been injured. They found nothing.

Behind the old post office, one fuse in the transformer had burned. There was a small soot mark near it.

How many sounds that had caused was uncertain.

At the same time, a teenager from a nearby wedding house admitted that in the evening he and a friend had lit some sparklers and two loud firecrackers from two leftover strings of fireworks. But whether the timing was exactly the same or a few minutes earlier, the two friends gave different accounts.

The policeman wrote: no direct evidence of gunfire.

By the time that sentence reached the market, it had changed again.

Someone said, "The police picked up five cartridge cases and took them away."

Someone said, "The evidence is being hidden."

Someone said, "Actually, they were firecrackers."

All three statements were made at the same tea shop within five minutes.

Kailash raised the stove flame again. When boiling water hit the tea leaves left from the day, steam rose. He took no side. He simply began washing the empty tumblers again.

By nine at night the market was almost deserted. Pawan had reached home. Instead of scolding him for the broken bottle, his mother touched his forehead to see if he had a fever. He did not. She quietly put the milk away.

Sushila Devi gave out the last medicine and closed her shutter. Harinarayan went once more to the veranda of the old post office and looked at the soot mark. Ramsevak put the scale weights back in their box.

When the market opened at dawn, the numbers from the night were still on the wall. Someone had written "5" in charcoal. Beside it someone had added "7." Below them, in smaller writing, was "3."

Sweeping the shopfront, Kailash looked at the wall and did not laugh. He took a wet cloth and erased seven first, then five, then three.

Harinarayan came for tea. He said, "Couldn't you have left one number?"

Kailash asked, "Which one?"

Harinarayan replied, "The one somebody actually saw."

Kailash ran the cloth over the wall again. All the charcoal numerals blurred into a single black smudge.

Just then Pawan rode past on his bicycle. Two full bottles of milk clinked on the front bar. At the place where he had fallen the day before, he slowed for a moment, then pressed the pedals and rode on.

Ordinary sounds were returning to the lane again—the weights of a scale, a sewing machine, tea glasses, a bicycle bell.

In one person's memory there had been five shots, in another's three, in another's seven.

No number remained on the wall.

The Torn Flag

In the old market of the town, Shanti Devi's tailoring shop stood two steps in from the road. There was no gate, only a half-raised sheet of tin and, inside, a foot-operated sewing machine.

The shop sign had faded so much in rain and wind that of "Shanti Tailoring House," only "Shanti" could still be read clearly.

At dawn she would first sweep, then run her hand twice over the machine's treadle, as though dust had held its breath all night.

There was to be a rally in the market that day. Word had spread that processions of two different parties would pass at different times, so the shopkeepers had pulled inside anything hanging from their awnings.

What worried Shanti Devi most was not the processions, but the clothes promised for Wednesday.

A schoolgirl's blue kurti, a hospital nurse's white wrap, the sweetmaker's torn apron, and Ramlochan's paddy sack—all lay in turn beside the machine.

"Ma, will we close early today?" her daughter Rekha asked.

"Work does not close early," Shanti Devi said as she threaded the needle. "A shop can close."

Rekha was in Class Twelve and, in her spare time, was learning to sew on buttons, turn hems, and cut thread.

At ten o'clock the first procession appeared from the eastern end of the market. The sound of the drum arrived before the flags.

Shanti Devi did not stop the machine. The sleeve of the blue kurti had to be shortened.

The procession passed. The slogans struck the tin roof, entered the shop, then slid away toward the west.

Rekha peered outside. On the road remained two scraps of paper, a broken bamboo pole, and dust.

"Come inside," Shanti Devi said. "Measure the other sleeve of the kurti."

By noon the market had become ordinary again. The vegetable seller brought his wooden platform back outside. The tea seller began washing glasses.

Then three young men came running. In their hands was a long bamboo pole, and from its tip hung a large red-and-green flag, half torn.

The edge of the flag had split almost to the middle. The stitching had come undone at one corner, and the knot at the bamboo pole was loose as well.

"Auntie, stitch it at once," one young man said. "There is another rally in half an hour."

Shanti Devi stopped the machine. Without yet taking the flag in her hands, she asked, "Where is the cloth torn?"

"There was some pulling and tugging at the bend," the second young man said. "Whose fault it was can wait. First fix this."

Shanti Devi opened the flag and spread it on the table. The cloth was thin, but the torn section had already been patched twice before.

"This is not new," she said.

The young man laughed. "The flag is old. The rally is new."

Shanti Devi did not laugh. She brought the torn edges together with her fingers. "If I give it only a straight seam, it will tear here again. It needs a backing strip inside."

"However you do it, just do it quickly."

"Cloth tears quickly when work is done in a hurry."

The young men looked at one another. The youngest asked, "How much will it cost?"

"Let me first see how much work there is."

Shanti Devi began searching for cloth matching the colours of the flag. She found red, she found green, but not the faded yellow in the middle.

Rekha opened a bundle of old cloth. "Ma, this one?"

"Too bright."

"This?"

"Too thick."

In the third bundle they found a strip from an old curtain. The colour was almost right.

Shanti Devi placed the strip behind the flag and cut it with half a finger's extra margin on all sides.

"Will it show from the front?" the young man asked.

"If the work is done properly, very little. The cloth will still know it had been torn."

Rekha smiled. Her mother spoke to cloth like this often, as though cloth understood more than half the truths told by customers.

The machine began to run. The large flag hung down from the table, so Rekha kept it from touching the floor.

Someone shouted a slogan outside. The young men peered out of the half-open shop, but Shanti Devi kept her eyes on the needle.

First she matched the torn edges, then held the backing strip in place, then ran a double seam.

“Shall we give it one more line?” Rekha asked.

“Too much stitching also makes cloth stiff. Only as much as it needs.”

Meanwhile an elderly woman arrived carrying a blouse. Seeing the shop crowded, she stopped.

“My sleeve by tomorrow?”

“This evening.”

The woman looked at the flag, looked at the young men, then placed her blouse at one corner of the table. “Don’t forget my work.”

“Do I forget anyone’s work?” Shanti Devi asked.

The woman went away laughing.

The tear in the middle of the flag was stitched, but when the corner near the bamboo pole was pulled, it rasped again.

Shanti Devi shook her head. “This has to be opened too.”

“Auntie, there is no time.”

“Then it will tear again on the road.”

The young man looked at his watch. “Do it.”

She cut away the old thread at the corner. From inside came a small rusted wire that someone had inserted during an earlier repair to fasten the cloth tightly to the bamboo.

“This wire is cutting the cloth,” Shanti Devi said.

Rekha placed the wire on a piece of paper. “Because of this?”

“One reason. The pulling is another.”

Shanti Devi made a small strong loop of cloth around the tip of the bamboo. In place of the wire she used thick cotton cord.

When she stopped the machine this time, she spread the whole flag out and examined it. The scar of the tear had not disappeared, but the cloth was one piece again.

The youngest young man said, “It has become like new.”

“Not new,” Shanti Devi replied. “Fit to be carried again.”

“How much?”

She told him the charge. The young man searched his pocket. Two notes and some coins came out.

The second young man whispered, “We’ll get it from the party office later.”

Shanti Devi did not fold the flag for them. “Whoever has the work done settles the account here.”

The three of them together paid the full amount. Shanti Devi counted it, put it in the drawer, and wrote on a small slip: “Torn edge, backing strip, bamboo loop.”

“What is this?”

“The account of the work.”

The young men left carrying the flag.

As soon as the flag went outside, two men from the road peered into the shop. One asked, “You stitched their flag?”

Putting the blue kurta back under the machine, Shanti Devi said, “I stitched torn cloth.”

“But you saw the colours, didn’t you?”

“I saw the colours to choose the thread.”

The man stood there for a few moments as though searching her answer for some hidden meaning. Finding none, he left.

Rekha asked softly, “What if the other party’s flag comes?”

“If it is torn, I will stitch it.”

“What will people say?”

“People’s clothes tear too.”

After noon the second procession arrived, this time from the western end of the market.

The beat of the drum was different, the colours different, the slogans different.

Shanti Devi was cutting around an old oil stain on the sweetmaker’s apron and attaching a new pocket.

Among the procession, Rekha spotted the flag they had stitched earlier. When the wind rose, the line of the patch flashed for a moment, then the cloth spread wide again.

“Ma, look,” Rekha said.

“Has the seam opened?”

“No.”

“Then it is all right.”

Ten minutes after the procession had passed, a middle-aged woman entered the shop in a hurry. In her hand was a small flag of another colour, its edge torn.

“Sister, can you stitch this? The children took it for the school cultural programme. It got caught in the crowd and tore.”

Rekha looked at her mother’s face.

Shanti Devi spread out the flag. “Only the edge has come undone here. Five minutes.”

The woman remained seated on the chair. She said, “People in the market will ask whose flag I am carrying around. It is a prop from the school play.”

Changing the thread, Shanti Devi said, “Cloth comes with its own story, but the needle looks first at where it is torn.”

Rekha laughed at this, but the woman’s face relaxed.

As evening fell, the sounds of the processions diminished. The market returned to prices, weights, bus timings, and the worry of reaching home.

Shanti Devi kept finishing one job after another: the elderly woman's blouse, the sweetmaker's apron, the schoolgirl's blue kurti.

Ramlochan arrived carrying his paddy sack. The bottom of the sack was torn.

"Will the machine work on this?" he asked.

"It will, but it needs a thick needle."

Rekha took out the thick needle.

Ramlochan noticed small leftover pieces of red and green thread at the corner of the table. "So politics got stitched today too?"

Turning the sack inside out, Shanti Devi said, "A lot of cloth was torn today."

Ramlochan laughed. "Even your answers are like stitching—you join two edges and keep the middle part inside."

"If too much is left outside, the thread gets tangled."

At closing time, the youngest man from the first procession came back. He had no flag with him.

"Auntie, the stitching held," he said.

"So?"

"We were five rupees short." He placed a coin on the table.

Shanti Devi opened the drawer and took out the slip. She checked the account. "You were not short."

The young man looked surprised. "I thought the three of us paid less in the hurry."

"You paid in full."

"Then keep this."

"No money without work."

She returned the coin to his hand. The young man seemed about to say something, then put it back in his pocket.

He turned toward the entrance, then stopped again. "The patch shows in our photographs."

Shanti Devi asked, "Has the seam opened?"

"No."

"Then the patch is doing its work."

The young man left.

Before closing the shop for the night, Rekha began cleaning the table. Small pieces of thread of many colours lay scattered there.

Red, green, yellow, blue, white, black.

Rekha asked, "What should we do with all these threads?"

"Throw away the ones too short to use. Put the useful ones in the box."

Instead of separating them by colour, Rekha put all the usable threads into the same box.

Shanti Devi lifted the blue kurti. The schoolgirl would come for it in the morning. One sleeve had been shorter before; now both were equal.

She folded the kurti and attached the slip bearing the girl's name.

Outside, two paper flags from the day remained tangled on an electricity pole. Whenever the wind blew, they fluttered in different directions.

Shanti Devi pulled the tin sheet down. The machine fell silent in the dark.

Rekha asked, "What is the first job tomorrow?"

From inside the doorway Shanti Devi called out, "Give that girl her kurti. Then Ramlochan's other sack."

"And flags?"

"If one comes torn again, we'll see then."

The shop closed. Inside remained the wages in the drawer, the box of thread beneath the table, and a half-cut length of white thread still in the machine needle.

Whether the market would remember the colours of the day's flags was uncertain. But at dawn Shanti Devi would thread the needle again—and whichever cloth arrived first, she would stitch its torn place first.

Boot Marks

At the eastern hamlet of Sonapur, the paved road ended and mud began. On the edge of that mud stood Harinath Sah's small bicycle-repair shop—bamboo posts, a tin roof, and two rows of bricks at the front.

It was the last week of Bhadon. Clouds hung low all day, but no rain fell. The earth was soft and took the shape of every foot that stepped on it.

In the evening Harinath was fitting the chain back onto an old bicycle. His twelve-year-old daughter Revati sat beside him doing mathematics exercises for school.

The house stood behind the shop. Between them was a courtyard two cubits wide, where Lalita Devi had planted four marigolds beside the tulsī altar. New leaves were coming in.

A little after sunset, the growl of engines came from the west. Motor vehicles rarely entered the hamlet; as soon as the sound was heard, the dogs began barking all at once.

Three vehicles stopped at the last bend in the road. Five policemen got out of the first. Two carried torches; one held a folded sheet of paper.

Harinath wiped his chain-oiled hands on a cloth and stood up. "Whom are you looking for?"

The policeman in front unfolded the sheet. "Copper wire was stolen from the market warehouse last night. A few names have come up during questioning."

"My name?" Harinath's voice did not rise; it merely became smaller.

A finger moved down the page. "Harinath Sah. You repair bicycles?"

"Yes."

"We will look at wire, tools, scrap—everything."

Harinath glanced once at Lalita. She stood half-hidden by the doorway. Revati did not close her notebook; only her pencil stopped moving.

The policemen entered the shop. The ground had not dried. Heavy boot soles crossed the bricks and carried mud all the way inside.

The first mark appeared just inside the entrance—a broad heel, a slanted cut in the middle, five grooves at the front. Revati's eyes fixed on it.

One policeman overturned the pile of tyres. Another picked up a piece of old wire. "What is this?"

Harinath said, "Brake wire. Every piece you see is entered with its account in this register."

He opened a wooden drawer and took out the ledger containing customers' names. Its pages had yellowed with oil stains.

The policeman turned the pages, but he looked less at the words than at Harinath's hands—soot under the nails, an old cut on the thumb, chain oil across the palm.

"We will see the house."

Lalita opened the door fully. "Look."

The first boot in the courtyard sank into the soft earth near the marigolds. The second step went past the tulsi altar. The third boot came down squarely on a new marigold.

Lalita said nothing. She only bent, lifted the broken stem, then let it fall.

Revati went inside carrying her notebook. It seemed to her that she was seeing everything, yet the clearest things of all were the footprints.

The sack of paddy was opened. A torch was shone beneath the bed. Clothes from the old chest were pulled out. The beam climbed as high as the bamboo rafters.

One policeman picked up Revati's schoolbag and turned it upside down. Two textbooks, a geometry box, a small pencil pouch, and a half-eaten guava fell out.

Revati bent to pick up the guava, and a boot pressed down on the corner of her mathematics notebook.

"Move," she said softly.

Whether the policeman heard her was unclear. He moved toward the next room. A crescent-shaped print of mud remained on the corner of the notebook.

In the last room of the house, Harinath's elderly mother was asleep. She sat up. "Who are all these people?"

"It is a search, Ma," Harinath said.

Looking for her spectacles, the old woman said, "Let them search, but there is medicine in that box. Don't turn it upside down."

The policeman did not overturn the box. He opened it, looked from above, and put it back.

In twenty minutes the whole house had changed. The things were the same, but no longer in their places. The bedsheet was left unfolded, the paddy sack half open, clothes outside the chest, and seven or eight deep boot prints marked the courtyard.

Nothing was recovered.

Folding the sheet of paper, the leading policeman said, "Come to the station tomorrow and give a statement."

Harinath asked, "Why did my name come up?"

"It came up during questioning. You'll understand there."

The vehicles drove away. The dogs' barking receded slowly into the distance, but the mud in the courtyard kept glistening.

Lalita went first to the marigolds. There was no way to straighten the broken stem. She pressed the soil around its root and packed it firm.

Harinath went to the shop. He stood the overturned tyres up again, counted the tools, and put the ledger back in the drawer.

Revati opened her notebook and looked at the page bearing the crescent of mud. The exercise question read: "Find the perimeter of the given figure."

With her pencil, she drew a line around the mud print.

Lalita asked, "What are you doing?"

"I am not going to erase this mark."

"It is mud. It will dirty the notebook."

Revati did not answer.

Harinath did not sleep until late that night. More than the fear of being accused of theft, what hurt him was the thought that everyone in the hamlet who had seen the vehicles would have made up a different story by morning.

At dawn he went to the police station. After sitting on a bench for two hours, an officer asked where he had been the previous night, which customers had come, and where he sold old wire.

Harinath showed the names in the ledger. Three customers' bicycles had been in his shop that night. One had been fitted with a new brake wire.

The officer copied the entries onto a sheet. "Go. If necessary, we will call you again."

"Who gave you my name?"

Without looking up, the officer said, "The investigation is continuing."

When Harinath returned, he found that the hamlet already knew he had been to the police station.

At the tea shop two men stopped talking. A third said, "I had believed from the start that Harinath was not that kind of man."

Harinath did not try to smile. "If you already believed it, why did you need to say it?"

The man fell silent.

In the afternoon the clouds broke open. The first heavy drop struck the tin, then rain began so fiercely that the road and the courtyard became the same colour.

Revati stood in the doorway watching the marks.

First the edge of the heel dissolved. Then the grooves in the middle filled. After a few moments, water gathered in the deepest print, the one beside the broken marigold.

From inside, Lalita called, "You'll get wet."

Revati took one step back, but did not take her eyes away.

Within half an hour the courtyard was level again. Where the boots had been, only a thin sheet of water shone.

Revati opened the notebook page once more. The mud print had dried to a pale brown. The rain could not reach it.

For the next two days fewer customers came to the shop. Those who did asked more about the theft than about their bicycles.

"How much wire was stolen?"

"How many people were caught?"

"How did your name come up?"

Harinath gave the same answer to every question: "The investigation is continuing."

On the third day the stolen copper wire was found at a scrap dealer's shop in the market. Two young men were arrested with the dealer; both were from another block. By evening the news had reached Sonapur.

At the tea shop the same people said, "See? Harinath's name came up for nothing."

Harinath was not there. He was in his shop straightening the bent wheel of a child's bicycle.

In the evening a policeman came again. This time he was alone and on foot. He said, "The matter has been cleared up. Your statement is no longer needed."

Harinath kept turning the wheel. "All right."

The policeman stood there for a while. "That day the house must have been badly disturbed."

Harinath stopped the wheel. "We put everything back in its place."

The policeman's eyes moved toward the courtyard. After the rain, the earth was level again, almost new. Near the marigolds, one broken stem had dried black.

"All the marks have washed away," the policeman said.

Revati had been listening from inside. She came out carrying the notebook.

"This one did not wash away," she said, opening the page.

A pencil line ran around the crescent of dried mud. Beside it she had drawn five small grooves with her own hand, the ones she had seen in the first boot mark by the doorway that night.

The policeman looked at the page. "Why have you kept this?"

Revati thought for a few moments. "What if someone later says nothing happened?"

An answer came to the policeman's face and stopped there. He did not reach out to touch the page.

Harinath said quietly, "What children see, grown people forget quickly."

The policeman lowered his head and left. This time there was no mud on his shoes; after the rain, the road had hardened.

A few weeks passed. The marigolds flowered again, but the plant whose stem had broken did not survive. Lalita planted another one in its place.

The number of customers at the shop returned to what it had been. The people at the tea shop found a new subject to discuss. No further summons came from the police station.

Revati's mathematics notebook kept filling. After the page with the mud print came triangles, fractions, perimeter, area.

One day, while checking the notebook, the teacher noticed the stain. "Why is this page so dirty?"

Revati said, "Sir, this is a measurement."

"Of what?"

Revati wondered whether to answer. Then she said only, "A foot."

The teacher lifted his red pen but made no mark on the stain. He put a tick beside the answer to the exercise.

Before winter began, Lalita levelled the courtyard soil again. New marigolds bloomed in a row.

Harinath extended the two rows of bricks in front of the shop so that less mud would be carried inside during the rains.

As Revati put the old notebook into a trunk, she ran her finger once over the page with the mud mark. The stain had faded, but the pencil line remained clear.

Outside, fresh rain began to fall. In front of the bricks, the prints of two customers' slippers appeared and dissolved at once.

Revati watched from the window, closed the notebook, and sat down with a new exercise book.

In the courtyard, water kept levelling every mark. Inside the house, the measure of the night that had entered without permission remained—on someone's page, in a broken plant, in someone's silence.

The Night Boat

After evening fell, the colour of the water could no longer be made out. After a day of rain, the Kamla River had merged fields, footpaths, and courtyard boundaries into a single muddy sheet. From the high bamboo platform in Mahua Tola, people could see only two or four lamps flickering in the distance, marking where houses stood amid the water.

Jagnath Mallah ran his hand along the belly of his small boat. Made from old bamboo planks, it had already carried people in three trips to the high road that day. A strip of cloth had been stuffed into one split, where water kept seeping in. His son Deepak continued bailing it out with a bowl.

"We are not going again," Jagnath said. "It is getting darker. The current is stronger too."

Deepak nodded in agreement. The exhaustion of the day trembled in his arms. Fifteen or twenty people were on the platform. Some had houses completely submerged, some half; someone had left a cow tied behind, someone sacks of paddy. But by evening everyone had understood that taking a boat out at night was not merely taking out a boat—it was weighing lives.

Just then a voice came from the east—unclear at first, then again.

"Hey, Jagnath!"

Someone raised a lamp below the bamboo platform. The voice came again. "The elder daughter-in-law's labour pains have started!"

Whispers began through the hamlet. The voice was coming from Ramcharan's house. His home stood below the embankment, near the river's old channel. Ramcharan had come to the platform during the day, but his pregnant daughter-in-law Sunita had refused to leave the house. She had said, "The water will go down in two days."

Jagnath closed his eyes and listened for a few moments. The voice broke apart in the wind. Then a woman's groan came through clearly.

Deepak said softly, "Babu, we have to go."

Jagnath did not answer at once. His eyes went to the boat. "No more than four people. And not through the middle of the current—we'll take the side route."

Suresh Mandal, the mukhiya's representative sitting on the platform, stood up. "I'll go. There's an old date palm near Ramcharan's house. We can hold the boat there."

Harinarayan Sahu rose as well. His shop was at the bend in the road, and his wife and two children were stranded on the roof of their house. All day he had kept saying that his family should be brought first on the next trip. Now he came to Jagrnath and said, "I'll go too, but first to my house. It's on the same way. The children are on the roof."

Suresh looked at him. "Sunita's labour pains have started."

Harinarayan's voice hardened. "Are my children not lives? They've been sitting on the roof for three hours."

Silence spread across the platform.

Untying the boat, Jagrnath said, "The boat will decide the route. We'll go where the current allows. But at one time this boat can hold only one crisis."

Deepak picked up the oar. Suresh put in a lantern, a blanket, and a long bamboo pole. Harinarayan took two empty sacks and a rope. The boat pushed off.

For the first fifty cubits the water was calm. The boat slid over submerged paddy fields. Here and there the tops of plants broke through the surface. Jagrnath kept sounding the depth with the end of the oar.

Ahead, the water spun in circles at one spot. By day there had been an unpaved road there. Now the road had been cut away, and the river's main current was forcing itself through the breach.

"Straight ahead will be faster," Harinarayan said. "You can see the roof of my house on the other side."

Jagrnath lowered the lantern light toward the water. Small pieces of debris were racing in one direction. "Straight ahead will get us to the river faster," he said. "We turn right."

Harinarayan said nothing. The boat turned right. On that curve, Ramcharan's house came first.

A little farther on, they found a bamboo thicket half-bent into the water. Its branches blocked the way. Deepak pushed them aside one by one with the pole. One branch brushed the lantern glass. Suresh caught it at once.

"If the light goes out, we'll all be guessing in the dark," he said.

The parapet of Ramcharan's house came into view. He stood on the roof in water up to his knees. His wife was by an inside window. Sunita's groans were now clear.

"It's late," Ramcharan said. "Even lifting her is difficult."

The boat could not reach the doorway; a thick neem branch had fallen in front of it. Jagrnath tried to bring the boat alongside a window. Deepak held onto bamboo to keep the boat steady. Suresh and Ramcharan went inside.

Harinarayan sat in the boat staring toward his own house. Far away, a small light flickered into view now and then, then vanished behind the bamboo.

“My younger boy has a fever,” he said quietly.

Jagnath heard him but did not answer.

After a while Suresh came out and said, “Sunita can’t walk. Even the cot won’t come out.”

Jagnath measured the width of the window. “Leave the cot. Make a sling from the blanket.”

Ropes were tied to the four corners of the blanket. Sunita was slowly brought to the window. Her mother-in-law was gathering a small bottle of oil, a cloth, and an old piece of dhoti kept for the newborn.

“Ma, nothing else,” Sunita groaned. “Just hold me.”

At last Sunita was laid in the boat. Her mother-in-law climbed in too. Ramcharan tried to board, but Jagnath stopped him with a hand. “The boat is full now. You stay here. We’ll come back.”

Ramcharan’s face fell. “My daughter-in-law...”

“Suresh is with her. Deepak is here. I am here. Stay on the roof and keep the lamp high.”

The boat turned.

Harinarayan suddenly said, “My house?”

Jagnath looked at the water rising in the bottom of the boat. Sunita groaned. Her mother-in-law stroked her head.

“The platform first,” Jagnath said.

Harinarayan sprang up. The boat rocked. “No! My house is only two bends away now. Will the children stay on the roof all night?”

Deepak said sharply, “Sit down! The boat will overturn.”

Harinarayan sat, but his breathing was rapid. “To all of you she is one daughter-in-law. To me there are three people on that roof.”

Suresh opened his mouth to say something, then fell silent.

Jagnath kept the boat straight. The water was now striking the left side hard. Turning right toward the platform was safe; Harinarayan’s house lay to the left, but the fierce current at the breach stood between them.

Sunita opened her eyes and looked at Harinarayan. Her voice was barely audible. “Sahuji, you go. They’ll get me to the platform.”

Harinarayan did not understand her. “Where am I supposed to go after leaving the boat?”

“I’m saying... drop me there, then go.”

At that moment Sunita’s mother-in-law caught her hand. “Child, keep quiet.”

Harinarayan's face changed again. He looked at the wet blanket spread near Sunita's feet. Then at the tiny light of his house far away.

"How long to the platform?" he asked.

"Fifteen minutes, if the current doesn't rise," Jagrnath said.

"And then my house?"

"In this boat?" Jagrnath paused for a moment. "If the water rises farther, coming back may be difficult."

After that answer, only the sound of the oars remained in the boat.

Ahead, the crown of a submerged mango tree appeared. Someone had tied a red gamchha to one thick branch—a marker for the safe route made during the day. Jagrnath turned the boat toward it.

Just then a sharp cry came from behind—from the direction of Harinarayan's house.

"Babu!"

Harinarayan sprang up like lightning. "That's my daughter!"

Jagrnath heard it too. No second cry came.

"Turn the boat!" Harinarayan said.

Deepak looked at his father. Suresh looked at Sunita's mother-in-law. No one had an answer on his face.

Jagrnath stopped rowing. The boat began drifting slowly in the current. He knew: the platform was to the right, Harinarayan's house to the left. On one side a woman in labour; on the other a feverish child and a family stranded on a roof. The small boat had no room to take everyone at once. Whatever decision was made, some part of it could later seem wrong.

He asked Harinarayan, "Can you swim?"

"Yes, but not in this current."

"As far as the mango tree?"

Harinarayan looked at the water. The distance was not more than twenty cubits, but no one knew where the ridges of the fields lay below.

Jagrnath opened his spare rope. "I'll hold the boat beside the tree. You climb onto it. I'll get Sunita to the platform and come back at once. From there you can hear your house and keep watching the light. If anything changes, untie the red gamchha and wave it."

Harinarayan stared at him in disbelief. "Alone here?"

"If we turn left, everyone is at risk. If we go all the way to the platform, your mind will not rest. This is the middle course."

Suresh said, "I'll stay on the tree with him."

Jagrnath shook his head. "Then we'll be short two hands for getting Sunita onto the platform."

Harinarayan looked once more toward the distant roof. He looked once at Sunita's face. Then without another word he tied the rope around his waist.

The boat reached the mango tree. Deepak caught a branch. Harinarayan carefully climbed onto it. Jagrnath tied the other end of the rope to the tree so he could find the place in the dark when he returned.

"I'll come back," Jagrnath said.

Harinarayan said only, "Quickly."

The boat moved again.

The platform was no longer far, but Sunita's pain intensified. Her mother-in-law placed Sunita's head in her lap. Suresh kept probing the water with the bamboo pole. Deepak's hands were trembling, but he did not let go of the oar.

As soon as they reached the platform, the women climbed down to meet them. Two men held the boat steady with ropes. Sunita was lifted up in the blanket sling.

Asha Didi, who was there, immediately took her into a corner enclosed with bamboo.

Jagrnath picked up the bowl to bail the water that had collected in the boat.

Deepak said, "Babu, sit for two minutes."

"Harinarayan is on the tree."

Someone on the platform said, "Don't go out again tonight. The water is rising."

Jagrnath did not answer. He remembered his own words—We are not going again. Only half an hour earlier.

He tightened the cloth stuffed into the split in the boat. Suresh began climbing in.

"You stay," Jagrnath said.

"He is sitting on that tree partly because of me too," Suresh replied.

Deepak was already in the boat. The three set out.

On the return journey the wind was against them. The lantern flame kept shrinking. The red gamchha on the mango tree could not be seen.

"It hasn't washed away, has it?" Deepak asked.

Jagrnath's oar stopped for a moment. "The tree won't have washed away."

A little farther on, a dark shape moved on a branch. It was Harinarayan. He was not waving the gamchha.

"Why not?" Suresh asked when the boat came close.

Climbing down, Harinarayan said, "The light at the house is still there. No one called again."

He sat in the boat, but this time he did not immediately insist on going to the house. He only said, "You know how strong the current is at the breach."

Jagrnath answered, "I know."

For a few moments all four remained still beside the tree.

Then the light at Harinarayan's house swung rapidly three times.

"That is a signal," Harinarayan said. "My wife swings the lamp three times like that when she needs help."

Jagrnath turned the boat left.

This time no one argued over the decision. Sunita had reached the platform safely. The boat was lighter. The danger remained, but its meaning had changed.

At the breach Jagrnath used the bamboo pole instead of the oar. Deepak kept the rope ready. Suresh leaned forward watching for submerged shrubs. Twice the current tried to spin the boat. The roof of Harinarayan's house was now close.

On the roof were his wife Kamla, his daughter Rani, and eight-year-old Sonu. Sonu was wrapped in a blanket, burning with fever.

"Why did you wave the lamp three times?" Harinarayan asked as they reached the roof.

Kamla replied, "The rear wall behind the thatch has fallen. Water is coming inside."

Sonu was taken down first. Then Rani. Kamla climbed in last. For five adults, two children, and their belongings, the boat was too small.

Jagrnath said, "Harinarayan, you stay here. I'll take the family to the platform and come back."

This time Harinarayan did not protest. He sat down on the roof. "Leave the rope."

Jagrnath left the rope with him.

As Rani sat in the boat, she asked, "Babu isn't coming?"

Kamla pulled her into her lap. "Babu will come later."

Jagrnath heard her. The word "will" floated across the night water.

The second journey to the platform was harder than the first, but no one raised their voice. Sonu kept whimpering with fever. Deepak dipped his wet gamchha in the water and placed it on the boy's forehead. Kamla kept looking back.

As soon as they reached the platform, people surrounded the child. Someone looked for warm water, someone for dry clothes, someone for medicine.

Jagrnath turned the boat for the third time. Now only he, Deepak, and Suresh were aboard.

"Tonight it isn't a boat moving—it's decisions," Suresh said softly.

Jagrnath stopped him. "Don't say that. A boat has wood, rope, water, and weight. Calling it a decision does not make the current weaker."

Suresh fell silent.

Harinarayan was found on the roof exactly where they had left him. One section of the wall had indeed collapsed. He had brought out a small iron box from inside the house.

“Not that,” Jagrnath said. “No extra weight in the boat.”

Harinarayan placed a hand on the box. “The shop accounts, land papers, the children’s certificates—everything is in this.”

Deepak looked down into the belly of the boat.

For a few moments Harinarayan held the box. Then he opened it, took out the papers on top, put them into an old oilskin pouch, and left the box on the roof.

“If the house remains, I’ll find the box,” he said. “If the house doesn’t remain, what will I do with the box?”

The boat moved toward the platform again.

After midnight the rain eased. On the platform Sunita gave birth to a daughter. In the light of an old lantern, Asha Didi wrapped the baby in cloth. No one felt like celebrating loudly; the exhausted people simply looked at one another. Far away, Ramcharan kept a lamp burning on his roof. There was still no way to send him the news.

Harinarayan sat beside his family. Sonu’s fever had come down a little. Rani had fallen asleep. Kamla was drying her wet hair.

Jagrnath tightened the boat rope around a bamboo post of the platform. Deepak sat beside him.

“Babu,” Deepak asked, “was it right to bring Sunita first, or should we have gone to Sahuji’s house?”

Jagrnath did not answer for a long time.

“People see right and wrong clearly afterward,” he said at last. “In night water, all you can see is who is in the boat at that moment, where the current is strongest, and whether another trip is possible.”

Deepak remained silent.

At dawn the water became steadier. The boat went again to Ramcharan’s roof. He was found alive, exhausted, and silent. When he was told he had a granddaughter, he said nothing at first. Only after sitting in the boat did he ask, “Is Sunita all right?”

“She is all right,” Jagrnath said.

The iron box from Harinarayan’s house was found on the roof two days later. Water had got inside. The ink in the account books had run, but the papers he had removed into the oilskin pouch had survived.

A week later, when the flood receded, the people of Mahua Tola returned to their homes. Some called Jagrnath a hero, some asked why he had not gone to Harinarayan’s house on the first trip, some said the boat should never have been taken out at night at all. Everyone had the light of hindsight.

Jagnath spoke little in those discussions. He turned the boat upside down and let it dry in the sun. He removed the cloth stuffed into the split and fitted a new strip.

Deepak found a small piece of red thread inside the boat. It had probably torn from the edge of the gamchha tied to the mango tree and caught in the boat.

He showed the thread to Jagnath.

Jagnath did not throw it away. He tied it to the front bamboo peg of the boat.

“As a marker?” Deepak asked.

“No,” Jagnath said, “not for memory. So that next time, in the dark, we can find the end of the rope quickly.”

Deepak smiled.

By evening the boat was ready again. The river was returning to its channel. The platform was empty. In the distance a new lamp burned near Ramcharan’s house. Harinarayan was lowering the wet iron box from his roof.

Jagnath left the boat at the bank and walked home. The short journey through the night had ended, but no decision inside him had been carved into stone. There remained only a few faces, the sound of water, the mango tree, the red gamchha, and the weight of a boat—a weight that had kept changing again and again through that night.

A Shard of Glass

Morning sunlight was slowly descending over the awnings on the eastern side of the market. The night's rain had stopped, but water was still rushing swiftly through the drains. In front of the cloth shop, the oil shop, the blacksmith's shed—everywhere people were sweeping, turning over wet sacks, and setting wooden boards out to dry.

At the bend in the square, the front glass of "Mithila Optical" was split through the middle. The lower corner had broken away and fallen outside, while the larger part remained wedged in the wooden frame. Cracks had spread through it like a spider's web. On the table inside, empty spectacle frames, a small screwdriver, scraps of cloth, and the eye-test letter chart trembled in the damp air.

The shop owner, Harinath, had been there since the night before. His eyes were red; he had not slept. At about two in the morning, a small vehicle carrying grain had skidded while taking the bend, its front wheel sinking into the drain. A bamboo pole projecting from the rear had swung around and struck the shop glass. The vehicle had escaped serious damage, the driver had suffered a small injury to his head, but the glass had shattered.

Harinath had spent the hours until morning securing the frame. He had swept together the pieces that had fallen to the ground and wrapped them in thick paper. The part still caught in the frame he was afraid to touch. Its edges were sharp.

His eight-year-old daughter Meera arrived from home carrying his lunchbox. Her mother had told her, "Feed Babu, then go to school."

Meera stopped in front of the shop. She had heard about the night's accident, but this was the first time she had seen the broken glass.

"Why is this still here?" she asked.

Leaning the broom against the wall, Harinath said, "The glazier will come by noon. Don't touch it now."

Meera placed the lunchbox on the table. She stepped inside the doorway, but her eyes remained fixed on the glass. Morning sunlight had now crossed the square and was filtering through the leaves of the peepal tree opposite.

A thin ray fell on the thick edge of the broken pane. Perhaps water was trapped somewhere inside the glass, or a drop from the night's rain was still

caught along the edge. On the wall, beside the eye-test chart, thin lines of red, yellow, green, and blue appeared.

Meera fell silent.

"Babu," she said softly, "look at the wall."

Harinath did not look at first. He was opening the lunchbox.

"What?"

"Colours."

Harinath raised his eyes. A small band of colours lay on the wall. It trembled as the leaves shifted in the sunlight.

"It's the edge of the glass," Harinath said. "The sunlight has broken."

Meera laughed. "Does sunlight break?"

"No," Harinath said. "I said it wrongly. The sunlight is appearing in different colours."

He paused over his own sentence. All night he had been telling everyone, "The glass is broken; everything is ruined." Now, seeing the colours on the wall, he realised that even the language in which one looks at something broken keeps changing. But he did not place that thought upon his daughter.

Meera went near the wall, but kept away from the glass. She put her palm against the band of colour. Red and blue lines fell across her hand.

"It looks like the rainbow we made at school," she said.

Harinath took his first mouthful of rice. "A rainbow is best up in the sky. If you are looking at one through glass, keep your distance."

Meera drew her hand back.

The market was slowly opening. Nandu, the betel-shop owner opposite, came over. He looked at the pane and shook his head.

"A big loss?"

Harinath said, "New glass, labour, straightening the frame—we'll see when it is all added up."

Nandu looked over the cracks. "Last night people were saying a truck had driven straight into the shop."

"Not a truck. A small goods vehicle. It did not enter the shop. A bamboo pole struck the glass."

"Rumour is bigger than the market," Nandu said with a laugh, and went away.

Meera looked again at the colours on the wall. "Do rumours break too?"

This time Harinath smiled. "They spread first. They break later."

At half past eight the school bell sounded in the distance. Meera gathered up the lunchbox. As she left, she said again, "Babu, when the glazier comes, don't throw away this corner that makes the colours."

Harinath did not become irritated. "It's sharp. You are not taking it home."

“I won’t take it home. I only want to see it.”

Meera left.

By ten o’clock three customers had come. An old man wanted the arm of his spectacles straightened, a student had lost a screw from his glasses, and a woman left an old frame to have new lenses fitted. Harinath worked as on an ordinary day, but the broken pane outside kept drawing his eyes.

Before noon, Subhash the glazier arrived. Under his arm were a measuring tape, rope, and thick gloves. The moment he saw the crack, he said, “The whole thing has to come out. The frame has been pushed slightly inward.”

Harinath asked the cost. Subhash wrote a figure on a sheet of paper. Harinath frowned.

“That much?”

“It is thick glass, and this is a shopfront. If you put in a thin pane, it will break again quickly.”

Harinath fell silent. The previous month he had paid his son’s college fees. The roof at home leaked too. The shop’s savings were small.

Subhash said, “For the time being I can nail up wooden boards. You can put in the glass two weeks later.”

Harinath looked out at the road. Dust, water, children, bicycles—the open shop would remain unsafe.

“Put it in today,” he said.

Subhash put on his gloves. First he pasted thick paper along the cracks, then began loosening the nails in the frame.

Harinath moved the things on the table farther back. A sack was spread on the ground.

Subhash said, “Keep the children away.”

“She has gone to school,” Harinath said.

Removing the broken pane from the frame was not easy. One corner was jammed. Subhash slowly lifted the wooden strip. Harinath held the other side. The glass grated once, but the entire section came out in one piece.

Sunlight fell again on its thick edge. This time a thin arc of colour appeared not on the wall but on the ground. Red and green shone in front of Subhash’s shoes.

Subhash looked for a moment. “The old glass was thick,” he said. “That is why the colours show more strongly along the edge.”

Harinath remembered Meera’s words: “Don’t throw away the corner that makes the colours.”

“One minute,” he said.

He brought a piece of chalk from inside and made a small mark on the ground where the colours had fallen.

Subhash laughed. “When the glass goes, the colours will go too.”

"I know," Harinath said.

"Then why mark the place?"

"My daughter will ask when she comes back from school."

Subhash said nothing. He laid the pane on the sack. With a light tap of the hammer he separated the sharp corner. A safe thick piece with a clean edge was placed to one side; the rest of the broken glass went into a box.

Harinath asked, "Can anything be made from this small thick piece?"

"Nothing useful for the shop," Subhash said. "If I grind the edges, you can keep it as a sample. But keep it away from a child's hands."

Harinath said, "Grind it."

Subhash picked up the piece. It was about the size of a palm, not triangular but like a rough quadrilateral. One edge was smooth from the original factory grinding; the others were freshly broken and sharp. Subhash kept wetting a stone and grinding down the sharp sides. Then he wrapped the piece in thick cloth and put it on the table.

"Don't let her touch it yet," he said. "I'll check the edges once more."

The new pane was installed before evening. The frame was straightened. Market dust was kept outside once again. The new glass was clear and uncracked. Harinath felt relieved when he looked at it, yet also sensed an unfamiliar emptiness. The cracks in the old pane had been the mark of the night's accident; the new glass had almost erased the event from the outside.

Subhash took his labour charge and left.

At three o'clock Meera returned from school. Her bag was wet; a light rain had fallen again on the way. She stopped in front of the shop and looked at the new pane.

"Where did the colours go?" was her first question.

Harinath showed her the chalk mark. "They fell here."

"And the glass?"

Harinath took out the piece wrapped in cloth, but did not put it into Meera's hand. He laid it on the table and unwrapped it.

"Here it is. The edges have been ground. Just look."

Meera bent over it. There seemed to be nothing special about the piece. The sun was behind clouds now. The glass looked grey.

"There is no rainbow," she said, disappointed.

Harinath said, "The colours were not locked inside the glass."

"Then where were they?"

"Sunlight, glass, and the angle of looking—when all three came together, they appeared."

Meera thought about this. "Will it happen again tomorrow?"

"It may. In this piece, in the new pane, in a drop of water—anywhere."

Meera did not ask to touch the fragment. She took out her notebook, placed it on the table, and began drawing the shape of the broken pane. Through the middle she drew thin lines in seven colours.

Harinath kept polishing a customer's spectacles.

In the evening the driver whose bamboo pole had broken the glass came to the shop. His name was Shambhu. A bandage was tied around his head. He came inside and stood silently.

"We couldn't talk properly last night," he said. "I will pay half the cost."

Harinath looked at him. He had been very angry during the night. The driver had gone to hospital, so the matter had remained unfinished. People in the market had given different advice—take the full amount, file a police complaint, stop the vehicle.

"Why half?" Harinath asked.

Shambhu said, "The vehicle skidded. The drain cover had shifted. It was my mistake that I did not slow down at the bend. But I cannot pay the whole cost now."

Harinath looked at the new pane.

"Pay whatever you can now. I'll write down the balance," he said.

Shambhu took folded notes from his pocket. Harinath counted them. It was less than he had expected, but he said nothing. He entered the amount in the register.

Meera sat in a corner drawing. Shambhu noticed the colours in her notebook.

"A rainbow?"

Meera said, "It was in the broken glass."

Shambhu lowered his face. "It broke because of me."

Meera immediately said, "The colours were not because of you."

Harinath looked at his daughter. So did Shambhu.

Straightening the yellow line in her notebook, Meera said, "Babu says sunlight, glass, and the angle are all needed."

Shambhu gave a faint laugh. "So my only job was to break the glass?"

An unwilling smile came to Harinath's face. "Don't do that job again."

None of the three laughed, but some of the stiffness inside the shop loosened.

After Shambhu left, Meera asked, "What if he doesn't pay the rest?"

Closing the register, Harinath said, "Then I'll ask again. The account has not been erased."

"And the colours?"

"There is no accounting for colours."

Before closing the shop that night, Harinath did not leave the ground piece of glass on the table. He placed it on a high little shelf on the wall, beyond a child's reach. Behind it he stood a sheet of white paper upright.

The next morning the sunlight was clear. Peepal leaves kept moving. At about ten past eight, one ray reached the shelf. Passing through the thick, smooth edge of the glass, it raised a thin spread of colour on the white paper.

This time Harinath saw it first.

Meera had not yet arrived.

He looked at the clock, then went back to work. The colours remained for a few minutes, shifted, thinned, and disappeared.

When Meera arrived with the lunchbox, Harinath said, "It came again today."

"I didn't see it!" Meera said unhappily.

Harinath had made a small chalk mark beneath the shelf.

"Come a little early tomorrow at ten past eight."

Meera said, "School?"

"You are not missing school. Come five minutes early, then go."

The next day was cloudy; no colours came. On the third day the sun appeared, but the angle of the ray had changed. The colours fell on the wall behind the paper. On the fourth day Meera had a holiday; she sat and waited patiently.

At eight-oh-seven, nothing. At eight-oh-nine, a white gleam. At eight-eleven, a thin red edge. Then yellow, green, blue.

Meera watched without breathing.

Harinath was repairing an old pair of spectacles for a customer. He kept his eyes not on his daughter but on the screwdriver.

"Has it come?" he asked.

"Yes."

"Then look."

This time Meera did not put her palm on the wall. She simply watched from a distance. The colours moved slowly. Five minutes later only a white patch remained.

"Babu," she said, "does that mean broken things should not always be thrown away?"

Harinath stopped the screwdriver.

"Not all of them," he said. "Some have to be thrown away. Some can be repaired. Some change their use. Some remain only as memory. First you have to see what is safe and what is useful."

Meera looked at the glass on the shelf.

"Is this useful?"

Harinath thought before answering.

“Not in the way a shop window is,” he said. “But it teaches you about sunlight, reminds me of the expense, and perhaps reminds Shambhu to slow down at the bend. That is not very little work.”

Meera laughed.

Outside, the market had fully awakened. Bicycle bells, vegetable sellers’ calls, the blacksmith’s hammer, the feet of children running toward school—all the sounds were mingling together. Through the new front pane the square was clearly visible. The small piece of old glass lay still on the shelf.

When the sunlight shifted away, its colours disappeared.

Harinath did not cover it again with cloth. The fragment remained where it was—not a prize from an accident, not a miracle. Only a safely ground piece of glass that, at the right moment, revealed the divisions within light.

The Field Turned to Ash

The light of dawn had not yet fully broken, but the southern sky looked not grey but sooty. During the night the smoke had risen very high; now only its smell remained caught close to the earth.

Ramlochan Yadav stood on the ridge of his field. Until yesterday, where the wheat ears had swayed together in one direction with the wind, there now remained black stalks, ash, and twisted metal wire. The night's fire had run from one field to the next. Some said an electric wire had fallen; some said smouldering straw in the fallow land; some said the stub of a bidi. Ramlochan trusted none of the explanations. Before him lay the consequence more plainly than any cause.

He bent and lifted a handful of ash. It was so fine that the moment it settled on his palm, it flew away. The earth beneath was no longer hot, but it was loose and crumbly.

From behind, his son Arun called, "Babu, shall I bring sacks first? Let's gather whatever is left."

Ramlochan did not answer. He walked toward the eastern corner of the field. Two old kans-grass stakes had once stood there. One had burned completely; the other leaned halfway down. Ramlochan brushed away the ash of the burned stake with his hand, scraped at the soil, and found a small hollow.

"Arun," he called, "bring four small bamboo splints."

Arun was startled. "The boundary now?"

"Yes."

"The whole crop has turned to ash. Why the boundary first?"

Ramlochan said only, "When everything becomes one colour, the boundaries have to be marked first."

Arun ran toward the house.

The night's fire had touched the fields of five farmers. Ramlochan's wheat had suffered the most. To the west was Joginder Sahu's field, where half the lentils had survived. To the north lay Rita Devi's small strip, where the mustard had already been harvested and only stubble remained. After the fire, the rise and fall of the ridges had disappeared. In places the ash lay so level that the old lines of the fields could no longer be seen.

Ramlochan walked while repeating in his mind measurements from his father's time—not one hundred and thirty-six paces from the eastern corner to the west, but one hundred and thirty-two as far as the bend of the drain; seven paces south from the old jujube stump on the north. He was not counting steps as he walked; he was recognising places. But the fire had changed the shape of those places.

Arun returned with bamboo splints, a hammer, and a bundle of red thread.

“Why red thread?”

“It will show from a distance against the ash.”

Ramlochan drove the first splint into the hollow where the old stake had stood. He moved north to place the second. Joginder Sahu was already standing there. The sleeve of his kurta had been blackened by smoke.

“Ramlochan,” Joginder said, “the boundary wasn't here. It was two hands that way.”

Ramlochan stopped.

“You remember?”

“Would I not know the ridge of my own field?”

Arun tightened his grip on the hammer. His face grew tense.

Ramlochan sat down on the ground. He began clearing away ash. Joginder bent down too. After a while they found a hard strip of earth beneath the burned grass—the old ridge, whose upper part had dissolved in the fire and the night's water.

Joginder touched its edge with his toe. “It's in the middle.”

Ramlochan said, “Then we'll put the bamboo in the middle.”

Joginder said nothing. He turned back toward his field.

Arun said quietly, “He was asking for two hands.”

Driving the splint down with the hammer, Ramlochan said, “Quarrels rise quickly over ash. Once the ridge is found, the matter is over.”

The sun climbed higher. The dew dried from the ash. Ramlochan's footprints appeared and disappeared across the blackened earth. He kept marking the four corners. Small knots of red thread trembled in the wind.

People from the village began coming to the fields one by one. Some crushed burned ears between their fingers, some estimated losses, some asked when the government people would come.

“We should take photographs first,” said Mahesh, the ward member. “Everything that burned should be visible.”

Ramlochan replied, “We will. But if the boundary is clear, the meaning of the photographs will be clear too.”

Mahesh looked at the red thread. “Your crop has burned, and you are measuring the land.”

Ramlochan did not smile. "The crop belonged to this year. The boundary will remain next year too."

By noon all four corners had been marked. But one problem remained on the western side. The bend of the drain had not been destroyed by the fire but by the wheel of a tractor that had raced in during the night to help extinguish it. The earth had caved in and water had left the drain and spread into the field. The old marker was gone.

Ramlochan had an old tin box brought from home. Inside were papers, old packets of seed, fertiliser slips, loan receipts, and a yellowed map. His father, Bhola Yadav, had made some marks on it in red ink.

Arun spread the map out. "This is hard to read."

"We won't read the map alone," Ramlochan said. "We'll match it with the ground."

Rita Devi came too. The boundary of her field met the same drain. Pulling her sari tightly over her head, she said, "If my husband were alive, he would remember. All I remember is that in the rains the water used to leave first from this corner."

Ramlochan put a finger on the map. "Here is the drain, here the jujube tree, here your ridge."

Rita Devi looked toward a burned stump in the distance. "Could that be the jujube tree?"

Arun ran over. The stump was half burned, but the roots had survived. When he scraped the earth near them, he found a round stone. Old lime still clung to it.

Ramlochan let out a breath. "This is the marker."

Rita Devi said, "Then the drain turned from here."

The three of them marked the western boundary again. Ramlochan did not put bamboo there; he replanted the stone. Red thread was tied to it, though the thread looked small against the stone.

In the afternoon a government field employee arrived. A young man with a camera accompanied him. They photographed the fields, asked names, and wrote down estimates of the burned area.

"How many bighas?"

"Two bighas and eight kathas of wheat," Ramlochan said.

"Complete loss?"

"Almost."

The employee wrote on the form, then looked at the red thread. "Did you put all these markers yourselves?"

"We re-marked the old boundaries."

"Why?"

Ramlochan answered plainly, "When you measure, you should see one boundary. If someone else comes tomorrow, he should see the same boundary. Names should not change on ridges that have turned to ash."

The employee looked at him for a few moments, then wrote a note on the slip: "Boundary markers re-established by local agreement."

Joginder had been listening from a distance. He came forward and said, "Write down my western boundary too. I checked it with Ramlochan."

The employee asked his name.

By evening the crowd in the fields had thinned. People returned to their own homes and losses. Ramlochan, Arun, and Ramlochan's wife Kamla began gathering the half-burned ears that remained in the ash. A few grains inside had survived, but they smelled of smoke. Kamla broke one ear and examined it.

"Will it do for seed?"

Ramlochan shook his head. "I don't know."

Arun said, "Babu, whatever survives could be feed for the chickens."

Kamla looked at him. "And where are the chickens that survived?"

The three were silent for a moment. The night's fire had not reached the house, but the outer thatch of the cowshed had been scorched. Two chickens were missing.

Ramlochan kept putting ears into the sack.

A little distance away, Joginder was turning over a smouldering heap in his field while his son poured water on it. Rita Devi was separating burned stubble. Across the black earth, small tasks belonging to different families continued—no announcements, no meeting.

That night little food was cooked at home. The smell of smoke had settled into clothes, hair, and walls. Kamla had put lentils on the stove, while Ramlochan sat on the outer veranda untangling the leftover bundle of red thread.

Arun asked, "Babu, are you grieving more for the crop or for the erased boundary?"

Ramlochan kept untangling the thread.

"The grief of the crop strikes the stomach," he said. "The grief of an erased boundary strikes the head. The stomach's grief can be understood—how much less grain, how much more debt. The head's grief grows silently. Tomorrow someone will say two hands are mine; the day after someone will say the drain was never here. Five years from now no one may even remember where the ridge lay on the night of the fire."

Arun said, "You don't trust Joginder?"

"I do. That's why I marked it in front of him. Trust needs markers; then quarrels are fewer."

From inside Kamla said, "People also enlarge boundaries while they are making them."

Ramlochan did not laugh, but his voice softened. "That is why it was done in front of everyone."

The next morning it rained—a small, fine rain. The ash turned wet and became a black paste. The red thread tied the night before shone brightly. Some splints leaned, but remained planted.

When Ramlochan reached the field, his first task was not to straighten the splints. He began opening the western drain because water was standing in the field. Arun came with a spade. Without being asked, Joginder joined them with his own spade. Rita Devi sent an old basket from home for carrying away mud.

In three hours the waterway was open. The drain began to flow again. One knot of red thread had blackened with splashed water, but it was still visible from a distance.

After the rain stopped, Ramlochan picked up a burned wheat stalk. Beneath it, in the soil, a small green shoot was visible. It might have been some grass that had survived the fire, or some seed already lying there. He did not touch it.

Arun saw it. "Wheat?"

"I don't know."

"Will it live?"

"We'll see."

Just then the field employee came again. This time he had a measuring pole with him. In front of the three farmers, he measured the boundary. Three of the four markers Ramlochan had placed were correct. The western stone was half a hand to the south.

Arun's face fell. "Did we mark it wrong?"

Ramlochan immediately pulled up the stone. "If it is wrong, we correct it."

Joginder said, "Leave half a hand. What does it matter?"

Planting the stone in the new place, Ramlochan said, "Half a hand is small now. Five years later it can become an entire story."

The employee completed the measurement. Everyone signed. Rita Devi gave her thumbprint, then looked closely at the new boundary line on the paper.

"Is my drain still there?"

"It is," the employee said.

Rita Devi smiled. "Then it is all right."

Later in the day two village boys came to photograph the burned field. One said, "This scene looks very serious."

Ramlochan did not stop them. They photographed the red thread, the black earth, the leaning splints, the burned stalks.

"Kaka, stand here," one said. "The whole field will come behind you."

Lifting a sack, Ramlochan said, "I have work to do. Take a picture of the field."

The boy laughed, but Ramlochan had already gone back to gathering burned ears.

Three days later the colour of the ash began to change. Brown patches of soil showed through the black surface. After five days the red thread faded. On the seventh day, Ramlochan pulled out one splint and planted a small brick in its place.

Arun asked, "Shall we remove the red thread?"

"When the ridge rises again."

Rebuilding the ridge was not only about remaking the boundary. The ash had to be gathered in one place, burned wire removed, earth put back along the drain, and ash washed in from neighbouring fields separated out. Slowly the line began to appear again on the land.

A few weeks later the first compensation list was posted on the panchayat building. Ramlochan's name was there, but the area was written as two bighas. Eight kathas had disappeared.

Arun became agitated. "See? We marked the boundary for this very reason, and still the paper is wrong."

Ramlochan did not tear down the notice. He made a copy, attached the measurement slip, and added a copy of the employee's note.

"Marking the boundary was not wasted work," he said. "Now there is a basis for correcting it."

Two days later the revised list showed two bighas and eight kathas. The compensation was not enough to clear the debt, but it could cover the initial cost of seed and fertiliser.

Counting the money, Kamla said, "The fire ate the field; the paper was eating eight kathas."

Ramlochan said, "That is why you have to watch both sides—the soil and the paper."

On the day of the new sowing, the ridges were clear again. Most of the red-thread knots were removed. Ramlochan left one small piece tied to the bamboo at the eastern corner. Arun asked, "Why this?"

Ramlochan said, "Until the next rains."

"For memory?"

"No. The bamboo is new; this will keep it visible from a distance."

Arun laughed.

When the plough moved, the ash mixed into the soil. The black layer turned under and moist brown earth came up. Burned stalks broke apart and were buried. The field began to look like a field again, but Ramlochan knew that for one season, each time a spade cut the soil, somewhere or other a thin line of soot would still appear.

By evening the sowing was complete. Joginder sat on his ridge. Looking toward Ramlochan, he said, "The morning after the fire you were rebuilding the boundary. I thought you did not care that the crop was gone."

Shaking out the empty seed sack, Ramlochan said, "I was doing it because I cared."

"I don't understand."

"When many things are destroyed at once, the place of whatever remains has to be fixed first."

Joginder was silent for a few moments. Then he pressed the earth of his ridge down with his foot.

"This ridge was half a hand on my side," he said jokingly.

Ramlochan looked at him.

Both of them burst out laughing.

Before night fell, Ramlochan looked once more at the red thread in the eastern corner. The wind was light. The small end of the thread trembled. Behind it lay the newly ploughed field, level and bare—no wheat, no black sheet of ash, no flame. Only soil, with new seed pressed beneath it.

He turned toward home. The boundary remained where it was.

A Guard Without a Gun

It was the last week of Asadh. After a day of oppressive heat, the night wind had risen from the south. The tin roof of the cooperative seed warehouse creaked at intervals, and dry neem leaves in the courtyard scraped along the wall.

Near the warehouse gate, Jagat Sahu sat on his cane stool. He was past seventy-two, yet night watch remained the main support of his livelihood. In his shirt pocket he kept a brass whistle, a small bunch of keys, and a folded paper slip. No gun. Even the only stick was an old bamboo pole propped in a corner by the gate.

Three months earlier, at a committee meeting, some members had said that the seed season required an armed guard. Inside the warehouse were sacks of certified paddy, maize, and arhar seed; outside, farmers' demand was rising.

The chairman had asked, "Jagat Kaka, do you know how to fire a gun?"

Jagat had replied, "At my age, before lifting a gun I would first have to find my spectacles."

The meeting had laughed. But no gun was arranged. The committee decided that until some temporary arrangement was made, Jagat would remain at night and the warehouse keeper by day.

Jagat took neither pride nor insult from this. His work was to check the lock on the gate, make a round along the rear wall, see whether the roof drains were clear, and blow his whistle once at eight, ten, midnight, and two. Hearing the whistle, the watchman at the milk collection centre opposite knew that Jagat was awake.

That night, after blowing the ten o'clock whistle, Jagat went around the back. The earth beside the western wall of the warehouse was damp. There had been a light shower during the day, so two sets of footprints were clear. One pair belonged to the warehouse keeper's slippers; the other to heavy shoes.

Jagat bent to look. The heavy-shoe prints were fresh. They ran along the outside of the wall and then turned toward the unpaved road.

"Whose?" he said to himself.

At ten-twenty at night, the growl of a motor came from far away. Usually even tractors rarely travelled this road after ten. The sound drew closer and stopped in front of the gate.

It was a small goods vehicle. Sudhir, the warehouse keeper, got down from the front seat. Two young men were with him, both wearing heavy shoes.

Jagat rose from the stool. "At this hour?"

Sudhir took out a paper and said, "Orders from above. Fifty sacks of paddy seed have to be sent to another centre. The vehicle must reach by dawn."

"Why wasn't I told during the day?"

"The order came in the evening."

Sudhir handed the paper to Jagat. Jagat could read, but small print strained his eyes. He switched on the bulb at the gate and put on his spectacles. The paper carried a seal, a signature, and the name of a centre.

"Where is the dispatch register?" Jagat asked.

"Inside."

"And the chairman's telephone confirmation for a night dispatch?"

Sudhir's voice hardened. "Kaka, I am the warehouse keeper. My signature is enough."

Jagat looked at the paper again. The date was today's. But the last two digits of the serial number written at the top looked familiar. In the evening he kept the day's dispatch slips with the keys. The folded slip in his pocket bore the same number—but that slip had been issued four days earlier for twenty sacks of maize seed.

He remained silent.

One of the young men opened the rear panel of the vehicle. Inside was empty space, two thick ropes, and a tarpaulin.

Sudhir said, "Open the lock. We're getting late."

Jagat put a hand into his pocket. The bunch of keys came out, and with it the cord of the whistle hung loose.

"First I'll see the dispatch register," he said.

"You don't trust me?"

"Trust is one thing. The register is another."

Sudhir watched him for a moment, then said, "All right. Open it."

The gate opened. The veranda inside was dark. Sudhir switched on his hand torch. Jagat unlocked the main door, but before stepping inside he blew the whistle once.

Sudhir started. "Why now?"

"My first round after ten is complete."

"Ten has already passed."

"My watch is slow."

That was a lie. Jagat's watch was correct. The sound of the whistle travelled through the quiet night to the milk collection centre, the veranda of the roadside betel shop, and two houses. Across the way, the watchman Ramvriksh turned on his cot and sat up.

Inside the warehouse, sacks of paddy seed stood in three rows. Jagat asked Sudhir for the register. Sudhir opened a cupboard and brought out a thick ledger. Two dispatches made during the day were recorded on today's page; there was no mention of anything at night.

"I'll write it now," Sudhir said.

"The order number?"

Sudhir looked toward the paper. "Whatever is written there."

Jagat opened the slip from his own pocket and compared the two numbers.

"This number was used four days ago," he said.

The two young men looked at each other.

Sudhir laughed, but the laugh was brief. "A clerical mistake. Such things happen in the higher office."

"Then wait until morning. When the office opens, we'll ask."

"The seed leaves now."

His tone had changed. Outside, the wind tapped the tin roof. Jagat closed the register.

One of the young men stepped forward to move a sack. Jagat did not seize his hand. He stood at the doorframe and blew the whistle twice—first short, then long.

It was not his regular signal.

Sudhir whispered, "Kaka, why make a spectacle?"

Jagat did not answer. Outside, Ramvriksh rose from his cot and came to the gate. Mahesh, the owner of the betel shop, who had been sleeping on the veranda, also came out at the sound. Dogs in two houses began barking.

"What happened?" Ramvriksh called from outside.

Jagat said loudly, "There is a night dispatch of seed. Note the time—ten thirty-eight."

Sudhir's face tightened. "No theft is taking place here. Government goods are going to a government centre."

"Then why object to having the time heard?" Jagat said.

Mahesh came and stood by the gate. A half-burned lantern was in his hand. "How many sacks?"

"Fifty," Jagat answered.

"Whose order?"

Sudhir extended the paper toward him, then immediately drew his hand back. "You have no right to see the paper."

Mahesh shrugged. "Fine. I am standing here not to see, but to hear."

The two young men left the sacks and came outside. One quietly said something in Sudhir's ear. Irritated, Sudhir replied, "Keep quiet."

Jagat put the key into the peg-lock on the inside of the gate, but did not close it. He wanted the goods not to leave just then, but he also did not want anyone later to say that the watchman had forcibly stopped official work.

"Write it in the dispatch register," he said. "The time, the number of sacks, the vehicle number, the order number, and your signature in front of me."

Sudhir's eyes narrowed. "You've learned a lot of rules, haven't you?"

Jagat remained calm. "The night is long. There is time to write."

For a few moments only the roof could be heard. Then lightning flashed far away. Rain was coming.

Sudhir opened the register again and began to write. First he wrote "50" for the sacks, then the vehicle number. At the order number he stopped.

"Write it," Jagat said.

Sudhir copied the number from the paper.

Jagat placed his old slip beside the register. The two numbers were identical. Mahesh watched from outside the doorway; Ramvriksh too had come closer.

Sudhir abruptly closed the page. "Order cancelled. We'll see in the morning."

One young man let out a breath of relief. The other began closing the rear panel of the vehicle.

Jagat said, "Don't cut out what you've written. Write 'cancelled' and sign it."

"You'll teach me?"

"No. I won't leave the page blank."

The rain began with the first heavy drops. The sound on the tin roof grew louder. With a red pen, Sudhir drew a line across the entry, wrote "Cancelled," and signed it.

The vehicle drove out. Before climbing in, Sudhir looked at Jagat and said, "This whistle won't save every night."

Jagat did not answer. He closed the gate and locked it. The vehicle turned into the darkness.

Ramvriksh asked, "Kaka, should we tell the police?"

"Not now. In the morning the register will be opened before the chairman and the committee."

Mahesh said, "What if the paper turns out to be genuine?"

"Then I blew the whistle too much, that's all."

"And if it is fake?"

Straightening his stool, Jagat said, "Then the sound came out in time."

It was eleven at night. The rain grew heavier. Ramvriksh returned to his centre; Mahesh to the veranda. Jagat made a round of the western wall. The prints of the heavy shoes were dissolving in the water. In a little while the earth would be level again.

He did not step on the prints. He only looked at them, then moved on.

At midnight he blew his regular whistle—a single long note. This time the sound did not travel very far through the curtain of rain, but from Ramvriksh's centre opposite came a brief answering whistle.

Jagat did not smile. He sat on the veranda and wrung out his wet gamchha.

At five in the morning Sudhir, the warehouse keeper, did not arrive. At seven the chairman, the secretary, and two members came. Jagat placed before them the night register, the old slip, and the cancelled dispatch entry.

The secretary first checked the number, then opened the office file. The number did indeed belong to the maize dispatch from four days earlier. No order had been issued for transferring paddy seed.

The chairman's face hardened. "Whose vehicle was it?"

Jagat showed the number in the register.

"Witnesses?"

"Ramvriksh and Mahesh. Both heard the time."

The chairman looked at Jagat. "Did you stop the vehicle?"

Jagat shook his head. "I made them write the record. The vehicle turned back on its own."

By noon an inquiry had begun. Sudhir's phone was switched off. One of the two young men came to the committee office and said he had been called for paid loading work; he knew nothing about the paper.

Three days later Sudhir was suspended. The matter did not end there; inquiry, statements, files, the vehicle owner's reply—everything continued. Jagat received no citation for bravery. His monthly wage also remained exactly the same.

The committee met again. This time one member said, "Now at least he should be given a gun."

Jagat sat outside on the veranda listening. The chairman called him in. "Kaka, what do you want?"

Jagat thought for a moment. "Have the bulb at the gate repaired. Water collects beside the western wall; have a drain made there. And write a rule requiring two signatures for any night dispatch."

"A gun?"

"Give it to someone who knows how to use one. My whistle is fine."

Laughter rose again, but this time it died quickly.

The following week a new bulb was installed at the gate. A drain was cut beside the western wall. For night dispatches, two authorised signatures and telephone confirmation were made compulsory.

Jagat's brass whistle remained the old one. Its cord had worn through, so his grandson tied on a new cotton cord.

One night the grandson asked, "Baba, aren't you afraid?"

Testing the gate lock with a tug, Jagat said, "Of course there is fear."

"Then why not a gun?"

Jagat turned the whistle in his hand. "A gun makes its sound once. When people hear a whistle, they ask—what happened? On my watch, that question is necessary."

The grandson remained silent for a while, then went home.

At ten at night Jagat walked as far as the western wall. Rainwater was flowing through the drain. The old heavy-shoe prints were gone. On the soil there were only two new blades of grass.

He returned to the gate, looked at his watch, and blew the whistle.

From the milk collection centre in the distance, a small whistle answered.

Jagat sat down on his stool. A great deal of the night still remained.

A Song Amid the Smoke

It was the last evening of Sawan. Clouds had hung overhead all day, but no rain had fallen. At eight that night, smoke began rising from the eastern hamlet. At first people thought someone was burning straw or dry leaves. Five minutes later the smoke had turned black, and an orange glow showed within it.

The old paddy warehouse in the village was on fire. The warehouse belonged to the panchayat, but in this season half of it held sacks of seed belonging to farmers, while the other half was filled with dry straw.

The wind was blowing from the south. The flames were not very visible outside, but smoke was spreading through the lane.

Sabita Devi was taking rice off the stove in her courtyard. As soon as she smelled the smoke, she covered the hearth and went outside. People were running along the road—some carrying buckets, some ropes, some empty-handed.

When Sabita reached the warehouse, she saw that the main gate was half open. A few people inside were dragging sacks out. The smoke was so dense that figures ten cubits away had become blurred.

“Don’t go inside!” the mukhiya was shouting. “The roof has become hot.”

But voices were breaking apart in the smoke and coughing.

Behind the warehouse was a small landing by a pond. People had formed a line and were filling water there. Buckets passed from hand to hand, and empty ones came back. No one seemed able to make out an order. People kept colliding with one another.

Sabita stood in the middle of the line. Her eyes were streaming because of the smoke.

She saw twelve-year-old Guddu run twice in the same direction with an empty bucket. Old Ramvilas was trembling as he lifted a full one. Two women were calling each other’s names, but the replies were disappearing in the smoke.

Sabita first caught Guddu by the shoulder. “You take the empty buckets toward the pond. Pass the full ones forward through this line.”

Guddu nodded, but five cubits later he was lost again in the crowd.

Then Sabita began humming a slow folk tune. It was an old paddy-transplanting melody, the kind women sang in the fields to keep their rows straight. She sang no words, only the rise and fall of the tune.

Ramvilas looked toward her.

On the first rise of the melody, Sabita passed a full bucket forward; on its fall, she sent an empty one back. Then she repeated it.

Three women nearby understood. They picked up the tune too.

There was no complete line of song yet. Only a small wave of shared voices—hands forward on the rise, hands back on the fall.

The line that had been breaking apart ten minutes earlier slowly found a rhythm.

The mukhiya stopped shouting and began signalling with his hands. Two young men arranged a row of filled buckets at the pond landing. Guddu began counting the empty ones.

“Seven!” he said.

“Eight!” came a voice from behind.

The smoke thickened. The song did not grow louder; it only needed to continue.

At the left corner of the warehouse, the tiled roof was sagging downward. Someone could be heard coughing inside.

“Who is inside?” Sabita asked.

No answer came. Only twice came the sound of something metal falling.

A young man named Dinesh tried to go in. The mukhiya stopped him. “No. The roof will fall.”

Sabita stopped singing. For a moment the bucket line also lost its order.

Then a thin voice came from inside—“Here!”

It was Chhotan, Bindeshwar’s grandson. He had gone near the rear window of the warehouse to count sacks and had been trapped inside when the smoke rose.

The window was barred from outside with thick bamboo slats. The fire was stronger near the main gate and the straw in the middle.

Dinesh and Javed ran around the back. Sabita went too.

The window frame was hot. Javed soaked a gamchha and used it to grip the bamboo. Dinesh ran to fetch an axe.

Standing outside the window, Sabita called, “Chhotan, sit low near the ground. Hold a cloth over your nose.”

From inside, between coughs, came a “Yes.”

She began humming the tune again. This time it was not for the bucket line, but so that Chhotan would keep hearing a voice from outside.

She did not add words to the melody. She was afraid that if she began to speak, her own fear would come out.

Dinesh returned with the axe. The first bamboo split after three blows. On the fourth, one panel of the window opened. A black mass of smoke poured out.

Chhotan was crouched near the floor. Javed caught his hand and pulled him outside.

As soon as he came out, Chhotan vomited, then washed his face with pond water.

Sabita stopped singing.

“Why did you stop?” Guddu asked. He had come around to the back as well.

“The work here is done,” Sabita said. “The line is still moving in front.”

Guddu listened carefully. Sure enough, the same tune was still coming from the direction of the main gate.

The women of the village had taken up the melody in their own voices. Some voices were high, some cracked, some little more than humming.

The government fire vehicle arrived three quarters of an hour later. By then one part of the warehouse had burned, but the fire had not reached the houses behind it.

The crew who got down from the vehicle moved people away. A thick hose was run to the pond. A strong stream of water struck inside the warehouse.

The bucket line broke up. The song too slowly faded away.

At eleven that night the middle section of the roof collapsed. At the sound, everyone fell silent for a moment. Sparks rose into the smoke and then disappeared into the darkness.

Chhotan was laid down in the panchayat building. A health worker listened to his breathing and said there was no immediate danger, but he should be watched through the night.

Sabita placed a wet cloth on his forehead.

Chhotan opened his eyes and asked, “Kaki, that song inside—was it coming from outside?”

“Yes.”

“I thought someone was singing inside the warehouse.”

Sabita said nothing.

By dawn the fire was completely out. Many sacks of paddy seed had been soaked; some had burned. Almost all the straw had turned to ash.

At sunrise people gathered in front of the warehouse. The black smoke of the night now rose like a light grey vapour.

Farmers began identifying their sacks. On some, the ink of the names had run; some sacks were half burned. The panchayat clerk opened the records and began matching the numbers.

Guddu was counting the buckets scattered near the pond landing. "Three are missing," he said.

Ramvilas laughed. "You're accounting for three buckets after a night like that?"

Guddu was serious. "If they went to someone's house, they'll bring them back."

Sabita kept looking at the burned wall of the warehouse. Her throat had gone hoarse.

One woman asked her, "What song were you singing yesterday?"

Sabita said, "It wasn't a complete song."

"It was a transplanting tune."

"It was a tune. There were no words."

"Why?"

Sabita thought for a while. "People hear different things in words. Yesterday I only needed one rhythm."

By afternoon a preliminary list of losses had been prepared. Most of the discussion was about the cause of the fire—an electric wire, a bidi, a wire gnawed by rats. No one was certain.

But when people spoke of the night's events, they mentioned the song again and again. Some said Sabita had given everyone courage. Some said the fire had seemed smaller once the singing began.

Sabita felt uneasy hearing this.

"The fire did not become smaller," she said clearly once. "The water from the hose and the buckets made it smaller. The song only gave the hands one rhythm."

Three days later the surviving part of the warehouse was emptied. The broken bamboo bars at the rear window were removed. Chhotan came too.

He stood by the window and looked inside. "It was very dark here."

Sabita said, "It is light now."

"Because it is daytime."

"Yes, because it is daytime."

The panchayat decided that until a new warehouse was built, the seed would be kept in an empty room at the school. Two of the buckets used against the fire were turned upside down on the veranda of the panchayat building.

The handle of one bucket had burned black.

In the evening Sabita went toward the fields. In the distance the paddy transplanting had already finished; the fields were green, but a few women were weeding. One of them raised an old tune.

Sabita stopped and listened. It was the same tune, but here its rhythm was natural—among earth, water, and bodies bent over the field.

This time she added words to the song.
No one spoke of the fire.
Only the line across the field kept moving forward.

One Minute of Electricity

By half past ten at night, the rain was striking the hospital's tin awning so hard that the people sitting inside had to raise their voices simply to hear one another.

It was the district's old hospital. The main building had a long veranda, with the medicine room in the middle, the maternity room on one side, and the general ward on the other. Rainwater had risen as far as the first step of the staircase.

At exactly half past ten, the electricity went out. First the fans stopped, then the tube light went dark, and at last the veranda light flickered once and disappeared into darkness.

Two moments after the darkness fell, different voices rose—"Sister!", "A lamp here!", "Where is Babu's bed?", "Keep the door open!"

Nurse Malti Devi had anticipated the possibility and kept two rechargeable lamps ready. The first lamp came on, but its yellow light reached only the corners of four beds.

"Everyone remain where you are," Malti said. "Those who can walk must not get up without telling us."

At the far end of the veranda, the electrician Raghuvir ran toward the generator room. The slap-slap of his slippers over the water could be heard from far away.

The general ward had twenty-six beds. On the night shift there was one nurse, Malti; one assistant, Lalita; one pharmacy worker, Naveen; and the guard, Bindeshwar. The doctor was in the emergency room.

In the darkness everything seemed to have changed shape. The rails of beds looked like walls, curtains like doors, and the rain outside the windows like people moving about.

On Bed 12 lay the elderly Shivnath Jha. He had difficulty breathing, but that night he was stable. His grandson Ashish was searching the bag under the bed for a medicine prescription.

"Sit down," Malti told him. "The lamp is here."

Ashish sat down, but his eyes kept going toward the door.

On Bed 7, ten-year-old Neha was holding her mother's hand. She had a fever. The moment the power failed she had asked, "Ma, will the night now stay here?"

Her mother had not answered. She had only stroked the child's palm.

Five minutes passed. The generator did not start. The rain grew heavier.

Lalita brought a hand lamp from the medicine room. Its light was clearer, but after five minutes that too began to weaken.

"Raghuvir!" the guard called from the veranda.

From far away came the reply: "There is fuel, but water has got inside! I'm drying the main strip!"

Malti tried to look at the clock. Its hands were not visible. She began estimating time by counting her pulse, then smiled at herself.

"How long has it been?" Neha's mother asked.

"Not very long," Malti said, though she herself was not certain.

In darkness, time expands. Ten minutes can feel like half an hour, and one minute like an entire night.

From outside, the lights of an ambulance swept across the window. For an instant every face became bright, then there was darkness again.

Naveen moved from bed to bed carrying a paper list. "Whose medicine is due at eleven?"

Malti called out the names. In the darkness she repeated them all because reading the list was difficult.

"Listen to the names," she told Lalita. "Even if the lamp goes out, the order must not be lost."

Meanwhile the first cry of a newborn came from the maternity room. Some of the people sitting on the veranda fell silent without meaning to.

No one clapped. Only Neha asked, "Was that baby born in the dark?"

Her mother said softly, "A baby does not ask whether it is darkness or light."

Fifteen minutes later Raghuvir came into the ward in a wet kurta. A small piece of wire was in his hand.

"The water on the main-wire side has been cut off," he said. "The generator can run now, but first it will give a one-minute test. If the sound is right, then we'll put it under full load."

"One minute?" Ashish asked at once.

"Yes. Only for testing."

The news spread through the ward. "There will be electricity for one minute."

Those who had been silent sat up. Those who had been conserving small hand lamps switched them off. Someone looked toward the fan, someone toward the clock, someone toward the door.

Malti's mind was occupied less by excitement than by calculation—what had to be seen in one minute? The medicine chart, the oxygen meter, the wall clock, the bed numbers, the maternity-room signal, the sound of the generator.

"When the electricity comes, no one will get out of bed," she said loudly. "Whatever you need to see, see it from where you are."

Raghuvir went outside again.

A few moments later the generator began to rumble. First one veranda light came on, then two lights in the ward, and then the fans started turning together.

The light seemed so bright that some people closed their eyes.

The wall clock showed 10:57.

Neha immediately looked at her mother's face and laughed. "You are still here."

Ashish read the chart hanging over Bed 12. Shivnath Jha opened his eyes and watched the fan make its first turn.

Naveen marked three names on the medicine chart. Lalita saw that the water bottle at Bed 18 was almost empty; she immediately went to replace it.

Malti read the oxygen-meter figure, checked the temperature chart at Bed 7, and saw the green signal light glowing at the maternity-room door.

The light was reassuring. For one moment the hospital looked like the familiar hospital again—white walls, blue sheets, numbered beds, a clock, fans, charts.

But at that exact moment Malti's eyes went to Bed 5.

Bed 5 was empty.

"Where is the patient from Five?" Her voice changed.

Lalita stopped short. "The toilet?"

"He cannot walk."

In a single instant the reassurance of light turned into fear.

Malti looked under the bed. There were no slippers. The walking stick kept beside it was also gone.

"Name?" Naveen asked, looking at the list.

"Ramcharit Mandal."

The guard Bindeshwar started to run toward the door, but Malti stopped him. "Slowly. Don't create a crowd."

At that same moment the fans began to slow. The lights trembled once.

"Time's up!" Raghuvir called from outside.

The light went out.

The ward sank into darkness again, but the darkness was no longer the same. In everyone's mind the empty rectangular space of Bed 5 remained clearly visible.

“Ramcharit Babu!” Bindeshwar called along the veranda.

No answer.

Malti took the hand lamp and went to the doorway. “Everyone stay in bed. Bindeshwar, you take the veranda. Lalita, not toward the maternity room—check the water room first.”

Ashish said, “Shall I help search?”

“No. Stay with your grandfather.”

The darkness of the hospital had now acquired direction. One empty bed had divided the work among everyone.

Three minutes later Lalita’s voice came from behind the water room —“He is here!”

Ramcharit Mandal was sitting on the floor. He had climbed down from the bed by himself, taken his walking stick, and gone toward the veranda; in the darkness he had slipped where water had spilled and had been unable to get up.

“Any injury?” Malti asked.

“My knee hurts,” he said. “I thought I would drink some water.”

Lalita and Bindeshwar together lifted him. The doctor was called at once. His knee was examined; no serious injury was apparent, but he was carefully settled back on the bed.

“Why did you need to walk in the dark?” Malti’s voice was stern.

Embarrassed, Ramcharit said, “I didn’t want to wake anyone.”

Malti was about to answer, then stopped. “Wake us now. That is what people are here for.”

Outside, the generator started again. This time Raghuvir first put only the essential electrical lines under load for five minutes. The emergency room, the maternity room, and two rows of ward lights came on.

No one made a sound of happiness. Everyone first looked toward Bed 5.

Ramcharit was there.

Neha let go of her mother’s hand and asked for water for the first time. Ashish folded his grandfather’s prescription and put it back in the bag. Naveen wrote down the next round of medicines.

By midnight the main electricity had still not returned. The generator was stopped and checked from time to time, then started again.

Malti made a new rule for counting beds—whether there was electricity or not, names would be called every half hour.

“Wasn’t this rule already there?” Lalita asked.

“Many rules exist on paper,” Malti said. “Today I saw one rule with my own eyes.”

At three in the morning the main electricity returned. This time the light slowly became steady. The fans began to run at an even speed. The wall clock showed 3:04.

Outside, the rain had eased.

Neha was asleep. So was Shivnath Jha. Ramcharit Mandal's walking stick had been tied to the head of the bed so that he could not get down without telling anyone.

Malti went out to the veranda and gave Raghuvir tea. His kurta was still wet.

"Was that one minute all right?" Raghuvir asked.

Malti looked toward the lit veranda. "It was all right. But it wasn't very short either."

Raghuvir laughed. "One minute is one minute."

"For a clock," Malti said.

She went back inside.

All the lights in the ward were on, but her eyes went once more to the small number plate above Bed 5.

In that one minute the hospital had received light.

And in that same one minute, one deficiency in the darkness had become visible.

Not Blood, but Vermilion

It was an evening in Bhadon. Before the market closed, the shops along the temple road were crowded with the last buyers of the day. In front of Malti Devi's cosmetics shop, small paper packets of red vermillion, bangles, and boxes of bindis were neatly displayed.

Malti's fourteen-year-old son Ratan was gathering up the display outside the shop. Across the road, the sweetmaker was putting out his stove, and the vegetable seller was packing the remaining vegetables into sacks.

Just then a bicycle took the bend at speed. Its bell rang, a heifer in front slipped its rope loose and came onto the road, and the cyclist, startled, swerved to the left.

The bicycle struck Malti's small bamboo rack head-on. The rack toppled. Two boxes of bangles sprang open, and seven or eight packets of vermillion tore apart, spreading over the pavement like red dust.

While trying to catch the rack, Ratan slipped and fell. His elbow scraped against a stone, but the wound was not deep. He tried to get up.

At that moment the betel-shop owner opposite shouted, "What is all that red?"

Before anyone could answer, a voice from the row behind cried, "It's blood!"

After that single word, the movement of the crowd changed. Those farther away began pushing forward; those already in front began stepping back. Some eyes were on Ratan, others on the red pavement.

Malti took Ratan's elbow and examined it. Two drops of blood had come from the scrape, but the redness spread across the pavement was hundreds of times greater.

"It's vermillion," Malti said. But her voice was drowned in the noise of the crowd.

Someone asked, "Who hit whom?" Another said, "The cyclist ran away." A third immediately added, "A knife was used."

The cyclist had not run away. He was sitting at the roadside rubbing his knee. His name was Bablu Sah, and the front wheel of his bicycle had bent.

"I'm right here," he said. But before anyone's attention could reach him, the story had moved ahead.

Within two minutes the news had reached the northern gate of the market that a fight had taken place near the cosmetics shop. Within five minutes it had changed—one young man was injured.

The temple bell rang. For a moment the people fell silent again, but even within that silence the guessing continued.

Ratan poured water over his elbow. The water mixed with the red dust and began flowing down the slope of the pavement. From a distance, the scene now looked even more alarming.

This time old Harinath, the bangle maker, came forward. Without saying anything, he bent over the pavement, picked up a grain of the red dust on the tip of his finger, smelled it, and pointed to one of Malti's torn packets.

"This is vermilion," he said clearly. "Blood does not fly about like dry powder."

Some people heard him. But the word "vermilion" did not reach those near the gate; there "blood" was still circulating.

Malti brought a brass plate from inside the shop. She began brushing the vermilion left in the torn packets into it. Ratan started separating the broken bangles.

"Look at his wound first," one woman said.

Malti examined Ratan's elbow again. The scrape was small. Ramesh from the nearby pharmacy arrived carrying clean water and a bandage.

While cleaning the scrape, Ramesh asked, "You're not feeling dizzy, are you?"

"No," Ratan said. "See whether my rack survived."

At that answer, Malti smiled for the first time.

By then Suresh Jha of the market committee had arrived. At the gate he had been told that a serious assault had taken place. He pushed through the crowd, saw Ratan sitting there, saw Bablu beside the bent wheel, and saw red water running over the pavement.

"Who saw the incident?" he asked.

Many hands went up.

"Who saw the bicycle strike the rack?"

Four hands went up.

"Who saw a knife?"

One hand rose halfway and then dropped.

"Who saw a stream of blood?"

This time people began looking at one another's faces.

Malti held out the brass plate. "Look—these are the torn packets. I counted seven. Half of the eighth is still left."

Harinath pointed to the edge of the pavement, where one intact packet lay soaked in water. Malti's shop stamp in blue ink was still visible on the paper.

Suresh Jha sent two boys toward the gate. "Tell them—there was no fight. A bicycle hit the rack. The boy has a small scrape. The red colour is vermilion."

The two boys ran off.

Ten minutes later the news reached the southern lane, but there it took another form—"It wasn't blood; it was vermilion." People began repeating the sentence as though it were a relief.

Some people returned to the shop. The man who had earlier said "knife" quietly began gathering up broken bangles. The one who had said "assault" started trying to straighten Bablu's bicycle.

Bablu apologised to Malti. "The heifer came in front of me. Whatever damage happened to the rack, I'll pay for it."

Malti looked at his bent wheel. "First get that repaired. I'll have the bamboo worker tie the rack back together."

Ratan said, "I'll be short in the account by one packet."

Malti lightly placed a hand on his head. "Today the shortage is not in the account of vermilion. It is in the account of words."

Harinath heard her, but said nothing. He kept cleaning his spectacles.

Evening deepened. The market began to empty. Water was poured over the pavement and the red dust washed away, but a little vermilion remained lodged in a fine crack in the stone.

The next morning, when Ratan opened the shop, the red line was still there in the crack. He bent with the broom, then paused for a moment.

The betel-shop owner opposite asked, "A lot of blood flowed here yesterday, didn't it?"

Ratan looked at him. The man's voice held half a question and half a certainty.

Ratan stopped the broom and showed him the empty packets in the brass plate. "Two drops of blood. Seven packets of vermilion."

The betel-shop owner fell silent.

Ratan poured water over the crack. The red line slowly faded.

That day Malti set the bamboo rack upright again. Instead of keeping the packets of vermilion on the top, she placed them on the lower shelf so that wind or a jolt would not knock them down.

The market began running as before. People bought things, bargained, and laughed.

But when the evening crowd thickened again, Ratan's eyes kept returning to the stretch of pavement where the day before people had seen one red colour and each made a story of his own.

The colour had been one.

There had been many witnesses.

The incident had been one.

The meaning belonged to each person separately.

My Great Business

If you are going to hear the history of my business, first understand one thing—profit is not the greatest thing in business. Profit is what ordinary traders earn; fame is earned by the man who suffers a loss and still leaves people talking about him. By that measure, my business was extremely successful.

This happened at the Wednesday market in Pachrukhi. The market met once a week and, in my eyes, it was not merely a market but an ocean of opportunity. People bought vegetables, sold grain, weighed goats, pressed oil, stitched shoes—but no one seemed to notice one enormous problem.

The problem was that everyone's hands were full. A sack of paddy in one hand, a bag of vegetables in the other, a child tucked under one arm, a gamchha over the shoulder. How was anyone supposed to bargain in such a condition? I understood at once—where there is a problem, there is business.

I came home and told my wife Saroja, "From tomorrow, I am going to change the market."

Saroja was sifting flour. She said, "First change your old debts."

I said, "Debt is the shadow of business capital."

She stopped the sieve and looked at me. "Where is your capital?"

"In the idea."

"Then keep your customers in the idea too."

I accepted this sarcasm as a blessing. Great businesses are often not understood first by the people at home.

The next Wednesday I planted two bamboo poles near the southern gate of the market and stretched an old tarpaulin between them. Under it I placed one long plank, a small hoe, a piece of chalk, and fifty little tokens cut from date-palm leaves. On the plank I wrote in charcoal: "Baggage Deposit. One bundle—one rupee. Safe. Numbered."

My first customer was Ramdin Sahu. He had two sacks of makhana, one bag of aubergines, and a small brass box. He read the board and asked, "What does 'safe' mean?"

I puffed out my chest and said, "As long as I breathe, nothing will happen to your bundle."

Ramdin Sahu said, "I want my sack, not your breath."

Even so, he left one sack with me. I wrote '1' on the sack in chalk and gave him a date-palm token also marked '1'. One rupee came in.

Inside my head I immediately made the calculation—fifty customers meant fifty rupees. Four Wednesdays meant two hundred. Deduct the tarpaulin expense, bamboo was my own, the plank belonged to the neighbour, and a child had brought the chalk from school. The profit was almost pure.

By ten o'clock I had reached number 17. Someone left a sack of potatoes, someone a bundle of clothes, someone even an empty basket. Why an empty basket? The customer said, "After walking around for a while, even this feels heavy." I accepted it in the spirit of service. A trader's job is not to ask questions; it is to collect the fee.

By noon I had accumulated twenty-three rupees. Saroja appeared in the market from a distance. I opened my fist and showed her the coins.

She asked, "Will you be able to count so many things?"

I said, "Look at the system. Everything has a number."

She looked at the tokens, then at the goats tied behind my tarpaulin in the market. "Why are the numbers on date-palm leaves?"

I said, "Paper was expensive."

She said nothing. If a wife leaves a question alone, understand that the question is not yet dead.

At three o'clock the first accident occurred. 'Accident' is not the right word; call it a business test. A black goat loosened its rope and reached the corner of my plank. At that moment I was writing a number in chalk on customer number 24's bundle. I heard a rustling behind me. I turned—and token 19 was in the goat's mouth.

I ran. The goat had already chewed half of token 19. Opening its mouth was not easy. In the end three pieces survived in my hand—one with '1' on it, one with a chalk smudge, and the third completely soaked in saliva.

I thought—no matter. The customer has his token; the bundle on my plank has its number. The system works from both sides. A great business does not depend on one token.

Just then clouds gathered. Within five minutes such rain fell that everyone in the market squeezed under tarpaulins, shop awnings, trees—wherever they found shelter. The prestige of my baggage house suddenly increased, because people wanted to place not only their bundles but also their heads under my tarpaulin.

I kept shouting, "This is a storehouse, not a dharamshala!"

No one listened. In the crowd someone's elbow landed on a sack of potatoes, someone's foot on the empty basket. The chalk got wet. The numbers written on the bundles slowly began to wash away.

I looked at the plank. Number 8 remained only half visible. 12 had become a white smudge. 17 had vanished completely.

At that moment I remembered Saroja's question—"Will you be able to count so many things?"

I immediately applied business intelligence. I began giving each bundle a different identifying feature. "This one with the red string—possibly 6. This one smelling of mustard—11. This one with the torn corner—14."

The rain stopped. The real test began when the customers returned carrying their tokens.

Ramdin Sahu showed token 1. His sack was clearly identified. I handed it over with pride.

Number 2 went too. So did 3. At 4 there was a problem—two bundles were almost the same colour. One contained lentils, the other old clothes. I tried to decide by smelling the bundles. The customer said, "Those are my clothes. There is no need to smell them."

I replied, "Security inspection."

Somehow things continued from 5 through 10. Number 11 brought his token back soaked by the rain, but his sack was found by the smell of mustard. My faith in my system returned.

The problem came with number 19. An old woman arrived holding token 19. She said, "Give me my small bundle."

I looked toward the goat. The goat looked back at me with exceedingly innocent eyes.

"What is inside the bundle?" I asked.

The old woman said, "Why didn't you ask that before?"

"Security inspection."

"Two children's kurtas, one old dhoti, and four papads."

I began feeling the bundles. The moment I heard 'four papads', I pressed one bundle—there came a crisp cracking sound. The old woman cried, "Not that one!"

I removed my hand at once. Later the correct bundle was found. The papads were intact. The old woman did not bless me, but she did not abuse me either. In business, this counts as moderate success.

By evening most of the goods had been returned. In the end three things remained—a brass lota, a green bag, and an earthen pot. Three customers also remained. The problem was that the numbers on all three tokens had washed away in the rain.

I said, "One by one, identify your property."

The first man said, "Mine is round."

I looked at the lota and the earthen pot. "Two things are round."

The second customer, a woman, said, "Mine is green."

The bag was settled at once. My confidence increased.

The third young man said, "Mine is the earthen pot."

Now the mathematics was easy. The lota remained for the first man. I handed all three objects to the proper people. The crowd applauded. That applause was the first public honour of my business career.

I counted the coins—thirty-seven rupees in all. Expenses? The tarpaulin had been bought earlier, the tokens cost almost nothing, the chalk was borrowed. In my mind I entered thirty-seven rupees as pure profit.

Then a boy came running. "Kaka, where is my mother's earthen water pitcher?"

I was startled. "Number?"

"There was a token, but the number washed away in the rain."

I looked all around. There was no pitcher.

The boy said, "I left it at ten o'clock. It had blue flowers painted on it."

I remembered—a blue-flowered pitcher had been under the plank during the noon crowd. Then someone's foot had struck it and it had rolled with a clunk. Whether it broke or someone picked it up, I could not remember exactly.

The boy's mother arrived too. In a calm voice she said, "The pitcher cost eight rupees. It was new."

Now the reputation of a businessman was at stake. I took eight rupees out of the thirty-seven and gave them to her.

Saroja, who had somehow appeared again from I knew not where, quietly asked, "Pure profit?"

I said, "Investment in customer trust."

She did not laugh. This was an even worse sign.

On the way home I discovered that one corner of the tarpaulin had torn. The bamboo owner said, "Your bamboo came from my field. Give me two rupees." The owner of the plank said, "The plank swelled in the rain. Give me three rupees." The child who had brought the chalk said, "The teacher will ask about it. Buy a new piece of chalk."

That night I did the accounts. Thirty-seven income. Eight for the pitcher. Two for bamboo. Three for the plank. Two for chalk. Five for stitching the tarpaulin. Seventeen remained.

Saroja said, "What about the twenty-five rupees you had already spent on the tarpaulin?"

I said, "That was capital expenditure, not a one-day expense."

"So you will continue the business?"

I became serious. "Great experiments are not repeated every day."

The next Wednesday I went to the market, but I did not open the baggage deposit. The tea seller had extended his bench into my place. People saw me and asked, “No numbers today?”

I said, “The first phase is complete. Now the market will learn by itself.”

And to tell the truth, the market did learn. Two weeks later I saw people bringing their bags with red or blue strings tied to them. Some had the first letter of their names on sacks, some had scraps of cloth on their baskets. One shopkeeper had even fixed bamboo pegs and, instead of leaf tokens, stamped numbers onto little tin discs.

I showed Saroja. “See? My innovation has spread.”

She said, “Your business has shut down.”

I said, “The business has shut down; the idea is still running.”

She said, “You earned seventeen and invested twenty-five.”

I said, “History is not written from cash accounts.”

Even now, when I go to the Wednesday market, the old-timers smile as soon as they see me. Ramdin Sahu says, “Here comes the founder of the Bundle Bank.” The goat owner tightens his goat’s rope when he sees me. The old woman whose papads I nearly broke calls from a distance, “Still doing security inspections?”

I listen to all of them with pride.

Why shouldn’t I? The business stall did not survive, but the customers still recognise me. Where in any ledger can you enter the fame earned in exchange for eight rupees of loss, a torn tarpaulin, and a chewed-up token?

I say my business did not fail.

The market simply turned out to be cleverer than I was.

And a great businessman is the man who learns that truth by taking a loss—and still says he made a profit.

The Three-Time Wedding Guest

My name is not Bauku Jha, but ever since this incident happened in the village, some people call me by that name. I do not object. After all, how long can a man who has landed in the wrong wedding party three times defend his real name?

It was the wedding season in Phagun. On the same evening there were three weddings in three villages—Belahi, Amahi, and Sonbarsa. My cousin sister's wedding was in Amahi. As I left home, my mother told me clearly, "Amahi. East of the pond. Red canopy." I tied all three details securely in my mind.

When I reached the bus stand, I saw wedding parties leaving in three directions. Everywhere there were drums, cymbals, flower garlands, and red cloth. It seemed to me that in wedding season the sound of drums was more reliable than signs of direction. That was my first mistake.

I saw a paper marked "Amahi" on a minibus. I ran and climbed in. The people seated inside made room the moment they saw me and said, "Come, come, we're getting late." I was delighted. How warmly one's own people receive one!

Ten minutes later the young man beside me asked, "How are you related to the groom?" I said, "The groom's maternal uncle's paternal aunt's cousin." The young man nodded. It did not occur to me that I myself could not possibly have become my sister's groom's maternal uncle's paternal aunt's cousin. The mathematics of relationships at a wedding differs from ordinary mathematics—I accepted that immediately.

The minibus reached Belahi. There was a pond. The canopy was to the east. It was red too. All three signs matched. I got down without a worry.

During the welcoming ritual, an old man put a flower in my hand. I stood there holding it. The women were singing. The groom dismounted from the horse. I looked at his face and something stirred uneasily inside me. I had once seen a photograph of my sister's groom; this young man was at least five noses away from that photograph.

I thought—photographs deceive. Perhaps cameras make noses look smaller or bigger.

Just then a child asked me, "Kaka, which side are you from?"

With confidence I said, "The bride's."

The child burst out laughing. "Then why did you come in the groom's bus?"

I had no answer to that question.

Somehow I asked a young man, "This is Amahi, isn't it?"

He said, "No, Belahi. The bus used to run to Amahi, so the paper is still stuck on it."

Thus my first wrong wedding party was officially established.

I slipped out at once. But leaving a village wedding quietly is not easy. The man serving betel at the entrance stopped me—"Eat before you go." I said, "There is an urgent matter at home." He thrust two betel leaves, one areca nut, and four sugar drops into my hand. My first profit from the wrong wedding.

There was no transport from Belahi to Amahi. On the road four young men were travelling on a tractor trolley with musical instruments. I asked, "Amahi?" They all said together, "Yes, get on."

This time I was cautious. I asked the groom's name. One young man said, "Rajesh." My sister's groom was also named Rajesh. I felt that God was compensating me for my first mistake.

The tractor moved off. On the way the young men sang and played cymbals. I too began clapping. One of them put a hand on my shoulder and said, "If every wedding party had enthusiastic people like you, it would really come alive!"

I thought to myself—this time I have found the right group.

Half a kos later the tractor turned toward Sonbarsa. I was startled. "Isn't Amahi straight ahead?"

The driver said, "Sonbarsa first, then Amahi. The musicians have contracts for two weddings."

I was just thinking of getting down when the groom's car appeared from the front. The musicians became alert at once. "First take this party in, then Amahi."

Before I could say anything, a pair of cymbals was pushed into my hands. "Play for two minutes. My hands are tired."

Here occurred my second mistake—I played the cymbals.

At the gate in Sonbarsa I arrived in the middle of the musicians. The wedding guests thought I was one of the musicians, and the musicians thought I was one of the guests. I have never again enjoyed such an intermediate social status.

A gentleman placed ten rupees in my hand. "You played well." Alarmed, I said, "I'm not a musician."

He said, "Such modesty is not good."

I tried to return the money, but the drums suddenly thundered. The ten rupees remained in my fist. My second profit from the wrong wedding.

Just then the groom's father saw me and said, "You are Rajesh Babu's college friend?"

I said, "Rajesh?"

"Yes, my son."

I understood—trusting the name Rajesh was no more useful than asking directions.

I returned the cymbals to the musician and ran. Someone called from behind, "At least keep the ten rupees!" I kept them. I considered them wages for all the running around.

By the time I reached the Sonbarsa crossroads, evening had deepened. Red canopies were visible far and wide. The three signs my mother had given me now seemed useless—pond, east, red. In Mithila during wedding season, all three are practically public property.

This time I decided I would not follow anyone's party. I would ask directly for the road to Amahi.

A tea seller gave me exact directions: "Two kilometres along this paved road, left after the peepal tree, then the pond."

I set out on foot. Halfway there, a jeep stopped behind me. Someone inside asked, "Amahi wedding?"

I said, "Yes."

"Get in."

Before sitting inside, I asked five questions—the bride's name? The groom's name? The bride's father? Which hamlet? On which side of the pond? All five answers were correct. I felt proud. Experience makes a man learned.

The jeep reached Amahi. Red canopy. Pond to the east. At the gate stood my own maternal uncle. I breathed with relief.

The moment he saw me, Mama said, "Where on earth did you go? The groom's party arrived half an hour ago."

I said, "I was conducting social research on the way."

Mama did not understand. Good.

I went inside. My mother's first question when she saw me was, "Why so late?"

I took two betel leaves, four sugar drops, and ten rupees from my pocket and placed them on the table. "Travel allowance."

My mother looked at me with an expression containing more questions than patience.

I did not have the courage to tell the whole story. I only said, "I lost the way in two places."

My sister sitting nearby had heard everything. She whispered, "Two?"
I glared at her.

The main wedding rituals began. This time I did not leave my place at all. At mealtime I sat in the row. Vegetables were served on the leaf plate, then dal, then puris. An unfamiliar old man seated beside me asked, "Are you from the groom's side?"

I remained silent for three moments.

All the mistakes of the day spun through my head.

Then, with great care, I said, "I am the bride's cousin. Name—Shivnath Jha. Village—Bardaha. If necessary, rather than Aadhaar, I can call my maternal uncle as proof."

The old man burst out laughing. "Who asked for such a complete introduction?"

I said, "Today I have learned that at a wedding one should never give half an introduction."

Just then a young voice called from behind, "Hey, Belahi Kaka!"

I turned around—the same child from the first wrong wedding party! He had come to this wedding too, with his mother.

The entire row burst into laughter. Proudly, the child told everyone, "Earlier he became one of the bride's people at our wedding."

I protested, "I did not become one. I merely thought I was one."

At that moment, from the other direction, the young musician waved. "Hey, Cymbal Babu!"

There was no longer any point in defending myself.

My sister began counting. "One—Belahi. Two—Sonbarsa. Three—?"

I said, "The third is the correct wedding."

She said, "But you arrived among wedding parties three times, didn't you? The title is settled—The Three-Time Wedding Guest."

I said, "The third time I am not a wedding guest; I belong to the bride's family."

She replied, "Proof?"

From a distance Mama called, "He is my nephew."

My sister folded her hands and said, "All right. Identity confirmed this time."

By the time the wedding ended that night, my story had reached the groom. Before the bride's departure he looked at me and laughed. "Brother, don't sit in my car, or you'll become a wedding guest all over again."

I said, "From now on I'll walk to every wedding for the rest of my life."

A few months later there was another wedding in the village. Along with the invitation, people drew me a map. One person even pasted photographs of the bride and groom onto it.

I did not mind.

Because in that one evening I had learned something—at weddings everyone is dressed up, every party looks cheerful, every canopy is red, and there can be three grooms named Rajesh in the same area.

So the best way to identify a wedding party is not by drums, bus, canopy, or name.

Ask directly: “What is the bride’s name?”

And if no one knows the answer, eat a betel leaf and go home. At least you will not become the wrong wedding guest for a fourth time.

The Philosopher on Credit

At Parsauni Chowk, a wooden board hung in front of Gopal Sah's shop: "NO CREDIT." The board was so old that half the final letter of "NO CREDIT" had worn away, but Gopal Sah's voice was still entirely intact.

Whenever a customer spoke of paying five rupees later, Gopal Sah would clear his throat at once.

"The first rule of business," he would say, "is that the moment goods leave the hand, their price must enter it."

The customer would ask, "Then why is my name written in this ledger?"

Gopal Sah would close the ledger. "That is not business. That is a social circumstance."

No one in the village except Gopal Sah understood the difference.

The truth was that three years earlier, during Sawan, his outstanding credit had grown so large that the wholesaler refused to send a second sack of rice. That night Gopal Sah came home and announced, "The age of credit is over."

His daughter Kusum was then in Class Nine. She asked, "How will it end?"

"By principles."

"How many principles?"

Gopal Sah considered the number. A small number seemed beneath his dignity. He said, "One hundred."

Kusum brought out an old thick exercise book and wrote on the cover: "One Hundred Principles Against Credit."

Gopal Sah himself wrote the first principle: "Cash is the foot of business."

The second: "Credit takes away not the customer's sleep, but the shopkeeper's."

The third: "The person who has no money today should buy the goods tomorrow."

While he was writing the fourth, Kusum asked, "What if the goods are needed today?"

Gopal Sah glared at her. "Questions are not asked while principles are being written."

In one month thirty-seven principles were ready. In two months, fifty-four. By the sixth month, eighty-nine. The remaining principles were

difficult because nearly every possible sentence for stopping credit had already been said.

But credit did not stop.

Budhni Kaki would be the first customer in the morning. She needed half a seer of rice. Her old-age pension would arrive three days later.

Gopal Sah would recite the first principle. Budhni Kaki would listen silently. When the speech ended, she would say, "All right, weigh me half a seer."

Gopal Sah would weigh it. While writing her name in the ledger, he would say, "This is not credit. It is an old-age-payment interval."

At ten o'clock Nandu the mechanic would buy oil and soap. His money depended on his evening wages. Gopal Sah would recite the seventh, twelfth, and sixteenth principles all together.

Nandu would laugh and ask, "After three principles, does the price of the oil go down or up?"

Gopal Sah would give him the oil. "I owe you two rupees from the gate repair last time. This is not credit. It is labour adjustment."

At noon, Chhotu, a schoolboy, would ask for two pencils and an exercise book. His teacher had said the homework must be submitted by the next day. Chhotu was three rupees short.

Gopal Sah would begin the twenty-eighth principle. Chhotu would interrupt, "Kaka, should I listen to the whole thing, or may I take the exercise book?"

"Both."

The speech would be completed, and the exercise book would leave too. In the ledger Gopal Sah would write: "Educational item; payment awaited."

By evening, seven new lines would have been added to the ledger beneath the "NO CREDIT" board.

Kusum would return from school, look at the ledger, and smile.

"Babu, your principles are working."

Gopal Sah would brighten. "See?"

"Yes. Earlier people took credit without a speech. Now they take it after listening to one."

Gopal Sah regarded this remark as disrespect, but could not find an answer.

By Kartik that year, the principles had stalled at ninety-four. Gopal Sah became anxious to complete the number. Whenever the shop was empty, he thought of new sentences.

Ninety-five: "The shopkeeper remembers credit longer than the customer does."

Ninety-six: "If an account has to be written, the price must first be asked."

As soon as he wrote ninety-seven, Kusum interrupted him. "This is a repetition of an earlier one."

Gopal Sah said, "In philosophy, repetition is called depth."

Kusum crossed it out.

Then something happened.

At noon an assistant from the wholesaler Mohanlal arrived with the account. Payment for Gopal Sah's three sacks of rice, two boxes of soap, and sugar had been overdue for five days. The assistant said plainly, "If the account is not settled by tomorrow, no new goods will be sent."

For the first time, Gopal Sah's face showed not principles but arithmetic. He opened the ledger. On seeing the total outstanding amount, he scratched his head.

Kusum was sitting beside him. She turned the pages of the ledger. Budhni Kaki, Nandu the mechanic, Chhotu, Ramvati, Shivdhari, Kalavati, Madan, Tara, Jhagaru—the lines of names went on.

"Babu," Kusum said, "did you stop giving credit, or did you only change its name?"

Gopal Sah replied at once, "Changing the name clarifies the nature of the transaction."

"The nature of the transaction is that the wholesaler must be paid in five days."

Gopal Sah closed the ledger. That evening, in front of the shop, he announced, "From tomorrow, strict rules will apply."

Someone sitting at the chowk asked, "So what we had until now were gentle rules?"

Gopal Sah pretended not to hear.

The next morning he hung a second paper beneath the board, written in red ink: "PLEASE DO NOT ASK FOR CREDIT."

The first customer was Ramvati. She needed salt. Her son would send the money two days later.

Gopal Sah straightened his chest. "Strict rules from now on."

Ramvati read the paper. "All right."

She turned to leave. After she had taken three steps, Gopal Sah called, "Wait. Will you eat rice without salt?"

"Whatever happens."

Gopal Sah weighed out a quarter seer of salt. In the ledger he wrote: "Food balance; not credit."

Kusum sat down holding her head.

The second customer was Jhagaru the barber. He needed soap. Gopal Sah refused in a stern voice. Jhagaru said, "All right. Next week when I shave you, we'll settle the account."

Gopal Sah immediately handed over the soap. "That is service exchange."

The third customer was Tara Devi. She needed matches and mustard oil. There were guests at home. The money would come by evening.

Gopal Sah recited the sixty-fourth principle, then gave her the goods. "A guest situation is not counted as ordinary business."

The fourth customer was an unfamiliar young man. His bicycle chain had broken and only his fare home remained in his pocket. He asked for one bottle of water and two packets of puffed rice, saying he would return along the same road the following week.

Kusum was curious—this time Babu would surely refuse. No acquaintance, no account, no village.

Gopal Sah studied the young man for five minutes. Then he asked, "Name?"

"Ramesh Yadav."

"Village?"

"Sonapur."

"Whom have you come to see?"

The young man gave a name. Gopal Sah wrote it in the ledger and handed over the goods.

Kusum whispered, "Which category is this?"

Gopal Sah said, "Emergency supply arising from travel obstruction."

By noon the paper announcing the strict rule was fluttering in the wind, and five new names had been added to the ledger.

Kusum decided that the principles had to be completed. She picked up her father's old exercise book and said, "Now write the remaining rules today itself."

Gopal Sah was surprised. "This is business time."

"The business is running anyway. Why should the philosophy remain incomplete?"

The people sitting at the chowk became interested. Everyone knew that completing one hundred principles could become a small village celebration.

Gopal Sah wrote ninety-eight: "Before giving credit, ask the date of repayment."

Kusum said, "That one is good."

Ninety-nine: "Tell the customer the same amount that you enter in the ledger."

Kusum nodded again. "That one is good too."

Now only the hundredth rule remained. Gopal Sah put the pen against his teeth and thought. Five minutes. Ten minutes. In between, two customers came; both took goods, and both their names were added to the ledger.

At last Gopal Sah wrote: "If you must give credit, do not hide it; write the account clearly."

Kusum pulled the exercise book toward herself. "That is not an anti-credit principle."

"Why?"

"It accepts credit."

Gopal Sah became solemn. "A philosopher does not run away from truth."

Laughter broke out across the chowk.

That evening Kusum prepared a new ledger. It had four columns—name, item, amount, payment date. At first Gopal Sah objected. He felt this arrangement would reduce his great philosophy to ordinary bookkeeping.

But the moment he remembered Mohanlal's five-day deadline, he agreed.

For the next three days, Gopal Sah began asking everyone who sought credit the same question: "When will you pay?"

The answers varied. "Friday." "After the paddy is sold." "When I receive my wages." "When the old-age pension comes." "My son will send it."

Gopal Sah wrote down the date. Those who could not name a date received fewer goods. But very few people went away empty-handed.

On the fourth day Budhni Kaki came with her old-age pension. She paid for the half seer of rice. Along with it she placed two lemons on the counter.

Gopal Sah said, "The lemons were not in the account."

"Then add them to the philosophy."

Nandu the mechanic deducted the old two rupees for the gate repair and paid the balance. Jhagaru the barber adjusted the cost against a shave. Chhotu came with three rupees and said proudly, "The homework has been submitted."

The entire outstanding amount did not come in within three days, but enough money was collected for Gopal Sah to make the wholesaler's essential payment. New stock arrived.

That day Kusum took down the old "NO CREDIT" board from the shop.

Gopal Sah protested. "That was the symbol of my principles."

Showing him the worn letters on the back, Kusum said, "Keep the symbol, but write the truth too."

A new board was made: "KEEP CREDIT ACCOUNTS CLEAR."

Gopal Sah stared at it for a long time. The sentence seemed insufficiently philosophical to him. But underneath, in small letters, Kusum wrote: "One Hundred Principles Available Inside the Shop."

That line made Gopal Sah happy.

Now, when customers ask for goods, he still gives speeches. He starts with the first principle, quotes the seventh, nineteenth, or fifty-third according to the situation, then writes the amount and date in the ledger.

The people of the village have also learned his ways. Someone will say, “Kaka, give me half a kilo of sugar, and tell me whichever principle applies with it.”

Gopal Sah weighs the sugar. “Principles are not free.”

The customer laughs and asks, “Do I pay for that now, or later?”

Gopal Sah thinks for a moment, then opens the ledger.

“Payment for principles may come later.”

From inside, Kusum calls, “Babu, that is credit again!”

Without being disturbed, Gopal Sah answers, “No. A knowledge-payment interval.”

And at Parsauni Chowk everyone understands that the philosophy of credit is still alive—only its accounts have become clearer than before.

The Panchayat Expert

For three nights in a row, the first heavy spell of the rains fell over Bardaha village. On the fourth morning, the road in front of the school was under knee-deep water. Children crossed carrying their shoes in their hands, cyclists got down and pushed, and the sacks kept in front of the shops had been raised onto bricks.

Water itself was nothing new. What was new was that this time the panchayat had received funds to build a drain. On paper, its length, width, and depth were all specified; what had not been decided in the village was where the drain would begin and end, and how much slope it should have.

To settle the question, a meeting was held beneath the peepal tree. The secretary sat with the file open. The mukhiya said, "First let the masons inspect the route. Then we will decide."

Batesar Jha was already seated there. Batesar Kaka was the kind of man in the village who did not consider it necessary to know a subject before speaking on it. In his view, knowledge was of two kinds—one written in books, and another that could be understood without reading books. He claimed complete authority over the second kind.

The secretary said, "To measure the drain's slope, we'll need a water tube and string."

Batesar Kaka immediately asked, "Measure the slope? The slope is toward the east."

The mason Raghunandan smiled. "Kaka, the sun rises in the east. We're measuring where the water will go downward."

"That much I know too," Batesar said. "Water always goes down. Why measure something so obvious?"

The first laughter rose in the meeting. Batesar Kaka took the laughter as support for his position. "See? Everyone agrees."

Raghunandan lifted the two ends of a transparent tube. Coloured water was inside. He placed one end near the school gate and the other fifty cubits ahead. The water stood at the same level in both ends.

Batesar Kaka peered into the tube and said, "This contraption has stopped the water in one place. When the drain is built, will the water flow, or stand like this?"

“This is only a way of measuring,” Raghunandan explained.

“A method that stops water first, and then needs another method to make it flow. This is science designed to increase expenses.”

Everyone laughed again. The secretary stopped writing. He feared that if every sentence Batesar uttered had to go into the proceedings register, the paper would run out before the drain was built.

Raghunandan drove stakes into the ground at three places and marked them. He said, “From the school to the square, the ground falls gradually. After the square it rises again. So the drain cannot run straight to the pond.”

Batesar Kaka said at once, “Why straight? Make a crooked drain. Does a snake move in a straight line?”

“A snake is not a drain,” someone called from behind.

“Exactly why a snake’s drain never gets clogged,” Batesar replied.

This time the laughter was louder. But laughter did not remove the meeting’s real problem. If the drain turned west from the square, it would touch the corner of Harikishun Sahu’s courtyard. If it turned south, only a cubit and a half would remain between the old peepal tree and the temple platform. The northern route was too high.

Harikishun Sahu stood up. “No drain will be cut beside my wall. The last flood already softened the foundation.”

Two people immediately spoke against him. A third began recalling the old boundary. The secretary held his head.

Batesar Kaka raised a hand for silence. “First listen to everyone. I know the history of the roads in this village.”

Raghunandan whispered into the secretary’s ear, “If the history begins, it will be evening before it ends.”

Batesar began, “Where Harikishun’s wall now stands, there used to be a post for tying cattle. Behind it ran an old earthen drain. When I was a boy, I used to float paper boats in it.”

Harikishun Sahu said, “Will the panchayat build a drain on the basis of paper boats?”

“Not the boat—the direction,” Batesar said. “The boat floated away; the direction remained.”

For the first time Raghunandan looked at him carefully. “Where did the old drain come out?”

“Not behind Sahu’s wall. Three cubits east of the wall, where the dung heap is now. There should be an old earthen pipe underneath.”

“A pipe?”

“Yes. The panchayat installed it ten years before the Durga Puja fair. It worked for two years; in the third, its mouth silted up. Then everyone forgot it.”

Harikishun Sahu immediately objected. "I don't remember any such thing."

Batesar Kaka brightened. "When it was installed, you weren't even married. How would you remember?"

The gathering laughed again, but this time Raghunandan asked for a spade. The dung heap was removed. About a cubit and a half down, a rounded piece of red earthenware appeared. With the second spadeful, the mouth of the old pipe came into view.

For the first time the secretary wrote one of Batesar's statements in the register. Batesar Kaka looked at his pen and said, "Write the whole thing—"The expert's prediction proved true."

"I am writing: 'Old drainage outlet found,'" the secretary said.

"Government language is terribly stingy."

The old pipe was not fully usable. It was broken in several places and clogged with soil in others. But its direction was important. It passed clear of Harikishun Sahu's wall and ran toward the outer edge of the old pond.

Raghunandan measured the level again. The slope in this direction was sufficient. "If we use half of the old route and join the rest with a new drain, we can do the work with less cutting."

Batesar Kaka puffed out his chest. "I told you from the beginning—make a crooked drain."

"You gave the example of a snake," the secretary reminded him.

"A snake is a natural engineer," Batesar said.

Measurements continued until afternoon. In the meantime Batesar Kaka began sentences with "It seems to me" at least twenty-seven times. He offered opinions on the width of the drain, the thickness of the bricks, the quantity of sand, labour costs, the direction of rain, school holidays, and even the psychology of mosquitoes inside drains.

None of his suggestions was accepted immediately. Yet in between them, bits of information kept emerging that were not on the map.

"Don't bring the drain too far out at this bend," he said. "On Friday market days, bullock carts turn here."

Raghunandan altered the measurement. There really would have been too little room for bullock carts.

"The cover here must be strong," Batesar said at another spot. "The children's Saraswati Puja procession passes this way."

"That isn't technical, but it is useful," the secretary admitted.

"Everything I say is useful. Technology arrives later at its own pace."

By evening a preliminary line had been drawn. Raghunandan marked the ground with red chalk. Harikishun Sahu's wall was spared, the peepal tree was

spared, and the water in front of the school gate had found a route toward the old outlet.

The meeting was about to end when Batesar Kaka said, "One important question remains."

Everyone fell silent. The secretary looked exhausted.

"The drain water will reach the pond—but where will the pond water go?"

Raghunandan replied, "The pond has an outer outlet. We'll measure that tomorrow."

Batesar sat down again at once. "Good. Tomorrow I will speak on that subject in detail."

Work began the next day. Batesar Kaka had been present since seven in the morning. In his hand were an old umbrella and a small exercise book.

Raghunandan asked, "Why the notebook?"

"An expert should write observations."

On the first page Batesar had written: "Drain Science—Part One." Under it: "Water flows from higher ground to lower ground."

Raghunandan read it and said, "Preserve this conclusion carefully. It will be useful to future generations."

Batesar could not decide whether it was sarcasm or praise. Even so, he remained pleased.

On the third day of work a problem arose. One section of the old drain ran beneath the school's old kitchen. Digging there was impossible. Raghunandan was considering a new turn. Batesar Kaka had already suggested five solutions—four impossible, and the fifth a repetition of something he had said earlier.

At that moment Malti Devi, the school cook, said, "There used to be an old ash pit behind the kitchen. The soil is soft there."

Raghunandan measured that route. The slope turned out to be right.

Batesar Kaka immediately opened his notebook.

Malti asked, "Will you write down what I said?"

"Certainly," Batesar said. "It is an expert's duty to gather evidence from local sources."

"Am I the local source, or is the ash pit?"

"Both. Evidence is multilayered."

Malti Devi laughed so loudly that two labourers stopped working and looked at her.

Within a week the main part of the drain was built. The next rain came at night. In the morning, water no longer collected in front of the school gate as before. A small stream slipped through the holes in the cover and flowed toward the old pond.

Batesar Kaka stood leaning on his umbrella. Raghunandan asked him, “Kaka, now tell me—is the slope toward the east, or toward the water?”

Batesar Kaka watched the flow in the drain. “I said from the start that water goes by its own intelligence. Our job is merely to keep it free from debate.”

“From debate?”

“Yes. If water had listened to the panchayat meeting, it would still be standing in front of the gate.”

At that, Raghunandan laughed too.

Two days later there was another panchayat meeting—this time the subject was vaccination of goats. The livestock worker was expected. The secretary was arranging the papers when Batesar Kaka arrived before anyone else.

In his hand was the same exercise book. He had crossed out “Drain Science” on the first page and written above it: “General Expertise.”

The secretary saw him from a distance and said, “Kaka, have you ever kept goats?”

“Never.”

“Then remain silent on this subject.”

Batesar Kaka became serious. “That is precisely why my opinion is impartial.”

The secretary closed the register. The livestock worker had not even arrived, but the panchayat expert had already begun his introduction.

My Rich Uncle

In our family, no audit was required to identify a wealthy man. Whoever arrived first at a wedding, ordered a second box of sweets, had two sacks of rice lifted at the market without asking the price, and did not waste time in conversation on figures below a thousand—that man was rich. By this standard, Uncle Nandkishor was the family's undisputed rich man.

He had a grain shop in the Parsauni market. Above the shop hung a tin sign: "Nandkishor Bhandar." The word "Bhandar" was painted in letters so large that from a distance one could not see the empty corners inside.

Uncle always kept two ledgers. One was thick, the other thicker still. If someone bought five kilos of rice, Uncle would open a page and write with such gravity that one might think the fate of the district's entire paddy crop was being decided.

When I was a child, I thought that a thick, filled ledger was proof of wealth. Much later I learned that one way for a ledger to grow thick is for accounts never to be settled.

But that knowledge came to me much later. Until then, in the family, Uncle remained rich.

That year, after two spells of rain in Sawan, the rear roof of Grandmother's old house began leaking in three places. One night a plate had to be placed upside down on the tin of stored paddy to stop the drops. The aunts said that if the roof was not repaired before Dashami, the next rain would turn the inside of the house into a courtyard.

On Sunday all the uncles, aunts, brothers, and sisters gathered in Grandmother's courtyard. Tea, puffed rice, and the estimate of expenses were placed on an old wooden cot in the middle.

Eldest Aunt said, "Bamboo, tin sheets, labour—altogether it will cost about thirty thousand."

Younger Uncle, lowering his head, said he would give five thousand. Aunt offered three thousand. My father said he would bear half the labour cost.

Everyone's eyes turned toward Uncle Nandkishor.

Uncle slowly set down his clay cup of tea. "You are all counting money. I am looking after the arrangements."

The moment he said this, everyone relaxed. In our family, the word ‘arrangements’ meant that whatever amount remained would be paid by Uncle Nandkishor.

Eldest Aunt said happily, “Then Uncle will take care of the balance.”

Uncle smiled. “Not the balance. I will look after the whole job.”

The effect of this sentence was such that even the tea seemed sweeter.

The meeting ended. Uncle said to me, “Come to the market tomorrow. We’ll speak to the tin-sheet man, the bamboo man, the carpenter—all at once. You should learn some business too.”

I was studying in town then. I had little desire to learn business, but a great desire to discover the secret of my rich uncle. So I reached the market early the next morning.

Uncle was opening his shop. First the lock opened, then Ramsevak, the tea seller next door, arrived.

He greeted him and said, “Uncle, thirteen days of old tea are due.”

Uncle looked at me and introduced him. “Ramsevak is an old associate of mine.”

Ramsevak laughed. “Associate is the right word. I provide the assistance; he provides the payment—when he finds the time.”

Uncle opened the ledger. “Not thirteen days. Twelve. I was away one day.”

Ramsevak said, “Your clerk drank tea that day.”

Uncle immediately added a line to the page. “Then thirteen. Justice is essential in accounts.”

I thought—rich people keep even such tiny accounts. It was inspiring.

Then Habib, who stitched sacks, arrived carrying three empty sacks. “Uncle, last month’s stitching?”

Uncle introduced him too. “This is my sack manager.”

Habib said, “My position has gone up. The amount has not.”

Uncle turned a page of the ledger. “You have four hundred and twenty due. I’ll pay you on Wednesday.”

“Which Wednesday?”

“Whichever Wednesday becomes suitable for payment.”

Habib looked at me and said, “Baua, you are educated. Find such a Wednesday for me in the almanac.”

Uncle laughed, and so did I. I still suspected nothing. Perhaps even a rich man’s debts were simply part of business—that was all I understood.

Ten minutes later Bholan, the cart driver, arrived. Seven trips of his freight charges were unpaid. After him came the oil seller—half the payment for two drums of mustard oil. Then a small truck came from the grain market; the driver got down and said at once, “I’ll unload the goods, but first give me the receipt for the previous trip.”

Uncle knew everyone by name, remembered almost every amount, and spoke to each person with such warmth that one might think they had come not to ask for their money but to offer him birthday blessings.

Slowly I began noticing the red marks in the ledger. The pages that in childhood had looked to me like proof of prosperity now looked like a long queue in which people stood waiting for their own money.

I asked, "Uncle, are all these red marks liabilities?"

Uncle tucked the pen behind his ear. "Not liabilities. Ongoing relationships."

"And the blue ones?"

"Those are people who owe me."

There were fewer blue marks.

I asked again, "Then why are there more red ones?"

Uncle looked at me as though I had asked an extremely childish question in arithmetic. "Business needs circulation. If money sits in one place, it catches a fever."

Meanwhile Ghanshyam Sahu, the tin-sheet dealer, arrived. Uncle gave him the roof measurements and asked the price of twenty sheets.

Ghanshyam Sahu quoted the price. Then Uncle said, "Give me fifteen days."

Ghanshyam Sahu shook his head. "First the old eight thousand."

Uncle smiled. "That is a business account. This is family work."

"My shop does not have two separate cashboxes—one for family and one for business."

Uncle leaned toward me and whispered, "These people reconcile accounts too often. That is why their businesses remain small."

Ghanshyam Sahu heard him. "And you do not reconcile accounts. That is why your credit remains large."

For the first time I laughed aloud. Uncle laughed too, though for one moment fewer teeth showed in his smile.

No deal was made for the tin sheets that day. We went to the bamboo seller. There too an old account surfaced. We went to the carpenter—his wages for two doors were still due. The hardware man said Uncle had not yet fully paid for a box of supplies used in last year's roof repairs.

By noon an astonishing truth had become clear to me—the family's rich uncle was in fact the most indebted person in the family.

I asked quietly, "Uncle, how much do you owe in total?"

He did not answer at once. He opened the thick ledger, then the other ledger. He added two or three pages, crossed out one page, and scratched his head.

"Speaking of the total is against business practice."

“Why?”

“The moment you hear the total, the mind panics. Hear the instalment, and the mind remains calm.”

“Even so?”

Very softly, Uncle named a figure.

I asked again, “And how much do people owe you?”

That figure was roughly half the first.

I did not feel like laughing. Uncle read my face. “Don’t become so serious. Everything is running. I have not swallowed anyone’s money. There are delays, but there are accounts.”

That was true. Uncle was not a fugitive debtor. He sat in the market every day; he knew the names of those he owed; if the date he promised was not met, he spoke to them again. His problem was less dishonesty than optimism. To him, every coming week looked larger than the week before it.

I raised Grandmother’s roof again. “Then how will you manage the whole arrangement?”

Uncle became alert at once. “Arrangements are not made with money alone.”

I had heard this sentence before. Now its meaning had changed.

Uncle took me back to Ghanshyam Sahu. This time he said, “Not twenty sheets. Twelve. Only the back room. The rest next year.”

Ghanshyam Sahu said, “Cash?”

Uncle looked at me. “The family contributions have been collected. Half now, half when the goods arrive.”

It was the first time I had seen Uncle on the side of the word ‘cash’.

With the bamboo seller he adjusted the account for four old bamboos against sacks of paddy Uncle had sent him. He told the carpenter he would pay half today toward the old wages for the two doors, while the roof work would be a separate cash job.

I asked, “Where will the money come from?”

“From what all of you said you would contribute. I am only going to make sure it reaches the right place first.”

After noon we reached Grandmother’s house. Everyone had expected Uncle to arrive with twenty sheets of tin, ten bamboos, and an army of five labourers. Behind him came only one bullock cart—twelve tin sheets, six bamboos, nails, rope, and two labourers.

Eldest Aunt asked, “Only this much?”

Uncle sat on the cot and opened the ledger. “Not the whole house. First the part that leaks. Half a roof in cash is better than a whole roof on credit.”

Younger Uncle stared. “You are saying that?”

Uncle became solemn. "Experience is an expensive teacher. I have paid a great deal in fees."

Everyone laughed. Uncle did too.

The work began. Uncle did not lift the tin sheets himself, but he watched the measurements, prices, labour, and reuse of old timber. Strangely, once the facility of borrowing disappeared, his bargaining intelligence became remarkably sharp.

He managed the job with one fewer tin sheet. He had the sound portions of two old bamboos cut and reused. He had the nails separated by size. He told the carpenter, "If the wood has not rotted, don't throw it away merely to look rich."

Eldest Aunt whispered in my ear, "He isn't rich, but he knows business."

By evening the roof over the back room was complete. When the first rain came, not a drop fell inside. Grandmother sat on her cot looking up at the roof.

The following Sunday there was another accounting meeting. This time Uncle brought the thick ledger himself.

First he read out all the expenses—cash payment for tin sheets, bamboo, labour, nails, bullock cart. Then on a separate page he wrote his old liabilities—Ghanshyam Sahu, Habib, Bholan, the tea seller, the carpenter.

Younger Uncle widened his eyes. "Are all these expenses for Grandmother's house?"

"No," Uncle Nandkishor said. "This is my personal splendour."

The courtyard filled with laughter.

Eldest Aunt said, "We all thought you were rich."

Without embarrassment, Uncle replied, "You were not entirely wrong. So many people trust me enough to give me credit. Trust is capital too."

Habib, who happened to have come into the courtyard at that moment for some stitching work, immediately said, "Capital is fine. When do I get my four hundred and twenty?"

Uncle opened the ledger. "Wednesday."

Habib asked, "Which Wednesday?"

Everyone laughed again.

This time Uncle laughed so hard that he had to close the ledger. Then, from the money left over in the roof account—not four hundred and twenty, but two hundred from his own pocket—he paid Habib.

"The rest on Wednesday," he said.

Counting the money, Habib said, "Now my search through the almanac has been cut in half."

After that day the family did not stop calling Uncle rich. If anything, the nickname became firmer. The only difference was that now, whenever

someone said “Rich Uncle,” he himself would pat the ledger and ask, “Shall we count assets, or relationships?”

And before answering, all of us would remember the faces of the tea seller, the sack-stitcher, and the cart driver.

The Missing Goat's Statement

In our village, a missing goat becomes less a problem for the owner than a test of everyone's intelligence. If someone's cow slips its tether, two or four people go looking for it; but the moment a goat disappears, half the village becomes a search party and the other half becomes scholars of causes and explanations.

In the last week of Sawan that year, Budhni Kaki's Dhauri disappeared. Dhauri was not completely white; the front of her left ear was black, and there was a small tuft of grey hair at the tip of her tail. Budhni Kaki said those two marks would make Dhauri recognisable even among a thousand goats.

At dawn Kaki got up, swept the courtyard first, then went to the tethering post. The post was empty. The rope was gone too. There were circular scrape marks in the earth, as though the post had gradually loosened and come out.

Kaki's first call was for Dhauri. Her second was for the neighbour. Her third was so loud that even two dogs in the lane looked at each other.

"Dhauri is gone!" Kaki said.

Within five minutes Lalan Sahu arrived. He never needed to inspect an event; he already knew what had happened before he came.

"This is theft," he said. "She has gone with the rope. A goat cannot untie its own rope and simply walk away, can it?"

Rasida Khala came from behind and immediately disagreed. "A thief would untie the rope. This one has uprooted the post. It must have been a pack of jackals."

Gangaram the blacksmith laughed. "Jackals have started dragging goats away by their ropes now? Next year they'll be reading government files too."

At that remark, instead of the search beginning, the debate began.

Master Harinarayan bent toward the ground. Around the post were two or three faint hoof marks. He adjusted his spectacles and said, "She went east."

"Where are the marks toward the east?" Lalan Sahu asked.

Master pointed at the earth with his stick. "Look at this curved line."

Rasida Khala said, "That is my granddaughter's slipper mark from yesterday."

Master stood up. "I know the difference between a slipper and a hoof."

Just then Ramsevak the barber arrived. His view was that a goat disappearing the night before market day was no ordinary matter. "Traders' people go around the village beforehand," he said gravely.

"Which trader?"

"Traders."

"Whom did you see?"

"Seeing is not necessary. You have to understand trade."

Budhni Kaki sat down holding her head. A small kid of hers was bleating continuously inside beside the bamboo screen. Kaki gave it leaves, but it sniffed them and left them untouched.

For five minutes the bleating lowered everyone's voices. Then a new round of opinions began.

Nago Paswan said Dhauri must have gone toward the northern fields. At night he had heard leaves breaking there.

"At what time?"

"I didn't look at the clock."

"Then when in the night?"

"When I woke up."

On the strength of this evidence, two people set off north.

Mangli Devi believed some child must have untied the goat while playing. At this, all the children in the lane began declaring their innocence at once, each in a different voice.

"I was at home all evening."

"I was at the pond."

"I'm afraid of goats."

"I don't even touch Dhauri."

After these four statements, the adults became even more suspicious of the children.

I too had reached the place by then. I had no theory. Admitting this is not very good for one's reputation in a village, but that was the truth. I saw only that the post had been uprooted, the rope had gone with it, and there were two or three tiny heaps of fine brown powder on the dusty ground outside the courtyard.

I thought it might be husk. But so many people had stepped over it that it was difficult to make out any trail.

Malti was also in the crowd. She was Mangli Devi's eleven-year-old daughter. She had her school jute bag in her hand because she intended to help find Dhauri and then go straight to school.

Malti said quietly to me, "Kaka, the husk is not only here."

"Where else?"

She pointed toward the bend in the lane. "There too. In between."

I walked two paces ahead and looked. Sure enough, there were tiny grains of bran beside the wall in the shade. Nothing showed on the sunlit patches, but where the dew had left the ground damp, the grains had stuck.

I told everyone.

Lalan Sahu immediately said, "The thief must have led the goat away by showing it bran."

Rasida Khala replied, "Do jackals keep bran now too?"

Master said, "The line of husk may have been made by the wind. The hoof direction is the main evidence."

Malti said nothing. She went as far as the bend in the lane and then beckoned to me with her hand.

I followed her. There was more bran at the bend. In the earth there, old bullock-cart wheel marks, bicycle tracks, and footprints overlapped one another. Among them, here and there, a thin mark of a rope dragging along the ground could also be seen.

Now I became interested.

I said, "Let us follow this line first. If we find nothing, we'll search elsewhere."

Five people agreed to come—Malti, Budhni Kaki, Gangaram the blacksmith, Ramsevak the barber, and I. The rest scattered in different directions to prove the importance of their own theories.

The grains of bran led first to the bend by the pond. There the trail broke. Ramsevak said at once, "See? A trader's cart passed from here."

Malti bent under the shade of the pond's masonry wall. "Here it is again."

After that small discovery I understood that the bran had not been blown by the wind; it had been leaking from a torn sack. The grains were not in the middle of the road but mostly near the edge, where a wheel must have jolted along.

Gangaram said, "Who carried bran last night?"

I remembered—Chhotelal Teli had loaded two sacks of bran from the mill onto his handcart in the evening. When the rain began, he had also stopped for ten or fifteen minutes beside the old oil house.

The old oil house was no longer in use. Inside stood an old wooden oil press, two broken low stools, and some empty sacks. One leaf of the door had swollen at the bottom, so it was difficult to close completely.

We reached the place. The door was not locked from outside, but both leaves were wedged against each other.

Ramsevak reached out his hand.

Budhni Kaki said, "Wait."

For the first time since the search had begun, everyone fell silent.

From inside came a very faint "Maa-a."

Kaki rushed to push the door. Gangaram stopped her. "Slowly. The rope may be caught somewhere."

The door leaf was lifted and opened. A thin shaft of sunlight entered. Dhauri stood beside the wooden oil press. Her rope had wound twice around the press's old bamboo handle. At the other end of the rope, Kaki's uprooted bamboo post was still tied.

In front of Dhauri was a small heap of bran spilled from a torn sack. She had eaten half of it; the rest had been trampled underfoot.

Budhni Kaki first untangled the rope, then caught Dhauri by the black ear and gently scolded her. "Because of you the whole village has become learned."

Dhauri did not reply. The moment she came outside, she stretched her mouth toward the grass by the pond.

Meanwhile the search parties that had gone in different directions began returning. The northern party brought a broken slipper. The eastern party had a cracked bicycle bell. The party that had gone toward the market announced that no goat trader had left the village that morning.

When they were told that Dhauri had been found inside the oil house, the first thing to return after their surprise was everyone's defence of his own theory.

Lalan Sahu said, "Didn't I say it was theft? It is still possible that the thief left her here and ran away."

Rasida Khala said, "The jackals must have chased her as far as the oil house. She escaped by getting inside."

Looking at the ground with his stick, Master said, "The eastern hoof marks must have been old. But it was necessary to raise the question of direction."

Ramsevak announced, "I brought up the traders so that the market direction would be checked immediately. It was checked—that itself was useful."

Malti said nothing about any of this. She merely dusted her jute school bag because dust from the oil house had settled on its lower corner.

Chhotelal Teli was called. The moment he saw the torn sack of bran, he slapped his forehead. "Yesterday bran kept spilling from this sack all along the road. When the rain became heavy, I stopped the cart here. I didn't see the goat in the dark. The wind must have jammed the door leaves."

"Your sack lured my goat away," Budhni Kaki said.

Chhotelal laughed. "The sack is guilty; I am only the witness."

The incident could have ended by noon. But in our village, an incident ending and its statement ending are two different things.

Rahman Mian from the market, whose name had twice been mentioned without evidence during the discussion of traders, came to the panchayat outpost that evening and said, "If my name has been taken, then write down that the goat was found in the oil house. Tomorrow someone will say I took her."

Budhni Kaki agreed. "Write it. Today people searched for Dhauri; tomorrow the story may grow larger than my house."

So the panchayat assistant opened the register. I remained seated there because, after hearing the story this far, going home now seemed an injustice to myself.

The assistant wrote the first line: "Budhni Devi's goat was found absent from its tethering post at dawn."

Lalan Sahu immediately interrupted. "Write that theft was suspected."

Rasida Khala said, "And the possibility of jackals."

Master said, "Inspection of hoof marks in the eastern direction."

Ramsevak cleared his throat. "Market-related investigation."

The assistant stopped his pen and looked at me. "Is this the goat's statement, or the experts'?"

Laughter rose at the outpost.

Budhni Kaki said, "If the goat could speak, half the village's work would have been saved."

In the end a short account was written in the register: post uprooted; marks of rope dragging; scattered grains of bran; old oil house; rope caught in the oil press; animal found safe. Beside Rahman Mian's name it was written clearly that there was no evidence against him.

Before writing the last line, the assistant asked, "The goat's statement?"

For the first time Malti spoke loudly. "The statement was on the road. We were slow to read it."

At this, Master took off his spectacles and began cleaning them. Lalan Sahu quietly stared at the page of the register. Rasida Khala smiled.

After thinking for a few moments, the assistant wrote: "No direct statement from the animal available; sequence of events clear from physical signs."

Budhni Kaki could not read. She asked, "It says here that Dhauri has been found, doesn't it?"

"Yes."

"Then that is enough."

On the way back, Malti held Dhauri's rope. Dhauri kept pulling her hand toward the grass growing along the roadside.

From behind, Lalan Sahu called, "I knew from the beginning that the matter concerned the stomach."

Ramsevak asked, “Whose stomach? The goat’s, or your theory’s?”

Everyone laughed again.

The next day the panchayat outpost register acquired the heading: “The Missing Goat’s Statement.” Beneath it were seven lines of facts. After that, there was no theory.

But theories continued in the village. There was only one change: whenever someone spoke with great confidence about something he had not seen, Malti would look at the ground and ask, “Where did the bran fall?”

The Mobile-Phone Guru

Every Wednesday at four in the afternoon, a different kind of school assembled on the panchayat veranda in Baraila village. Most of the students had white hair, thick spectacle frames, and no fewer questions than children.

The teacher of this school was Raghunath Babu. After forty years of delivering letters, he knew almost by heart the route to nearly every house in the village, every family name, and whose son lived where. Now, after retirement, people had given him a new name—the Mobile-Phone Guru.

At first Raghunath Babu protested when he heard the name. He would say, “I am no guru. I only know as much as I have not forgotten since yesterday.” But once the name caught on, he too accepted it with a smile.

A small wooden board always stood before him. On it, in large letters, were written five things: read first, then press; do not trust an unfamiliar message; never tell anyone your passcode; do not keep guessing again and again; and if you do not understand something, ask.

On the first day Rasida Khala brought her phone simply because whenever it rang, she kept confusing which symbol to press. Raghunath Babu made her do it three times. The fourth time he said, “Now I will not tell you.” Rasida Khala did it herself and smiled as if she had passed a difficult examination.

Shivnarayan Kaka had been thinking of giving up the device because the letters looked too small. Raghunath Babu enlarged the text on the screen. Kaka immediately asked, “Was this already inside it?”

“A great many things are already inside,” the guru said. “The difficulty is that the device stays silent, and people do not ask.”

Laughter rose on the veranda.

Kamala Devi liked sending voice messages, but in a single breath she would send one so long that the listener could make tea halfway through it. The guru trained her to speak in short sentences.

Murtuza Mian, while looking for his grandson’s photograph, would keep opening the clock screen instead. Within two weeks he could open and view the photographs by himself. Then he began showing them to everyone. In the third week Raghunath Babu said, “The proof that you have learned is not that you show it to everyone. Show it to the person who wants to see it.”

The hardest subject in the school was the passcode. Many people in the village used their birth year, their house number, or four identical digits. Raghunath Babu gave special lectures on this.

“A passcode is like knowing which peg in the house holds the key,” he would say. “If you tell everyone, what is the point of keeping a key?”

One day Rasida Khala asked him directly, “Guruji, what is your passcode?”

Raghunath Babu folded both hands and said, “If I answer that question, stop calling me guru.”

From that day the students stopped asking one another for passcodes. In fact, if someone began saying one aloud, five people would cry “Quiet!” at once.

On one Wednesday in Bhadon, Raghunath Babu reached the veranda half an hour earlier than usual. His phone had switched off during the night; when he turned it on in the morning, it asked for the passcode.

Raghunath Babu pressed the first digit, the second, the third, the fourth. The screen showed that it was wrong. He frowned. Then he tried another sequence. Wrong again.

A third time his finger went toward the screen, but he stopped midway. He remembered the fourth sentence on his board—do not keep guessing again and again.

He turned the phone face down on the table. For five minutes he kept cleaning the wooden board, although it was already clean.

‘First of all’—Raghunath Babu smiled inwardly at the phrase; it was what he trained his students to do. And indeed, Rasida Khala was the first to arrive.

“Early class today?” she asked him.

“An oral lesson today,” the guru said.

“Where is the device?”

“Resting.”

Rasida Khala looked at the phone lying face down on the table. “Is the device resting, or the guru?”

Raghunath Babu did not answer.

A little later Shivnarayan Kaka, Kamala Devi, Murtuza Mian, and the others arrived. Everyone opened his or her own device. The guru only began reading the five sentences from the wooden board.

Kamala Devi interrupted him. “Won’t you teach by showing us today?”

“Understanding is more important than seeing.”

Murtuza Mian said softly, “That sentence comes out when no example is available.”

Laughter rose again. Raghunath Babu’s ears turned red. At last he turned the phone face up. Four empty spaces were visible on the screen, asking for the passcode.

“I have forgotten it,” he said in a low voice.

For a moment the veranda fell silent. No one laughed.

Rasida Khala looked toward the wooden board. “First rule—do not panic.”

Shivnarayan Kaka said, “Another useful rule—do not keep guessing again and again.”

Kamala Devi said, “And the third—never tell anyone the passcode. So none of us will ask either.”

This time Raghunath Babu himself burst out laughing.

“All right,” he said. “The guru’s examination begins.”

He explained that a few months earlier he had replaced his old, easy number with a new passcode. That day he himself had given the example that recovery information should not be kept with the device.

“Then where did I keep it?” Raghunath Babu scratched his head.

Rasida Khala said at once, “You yourself said, ‘I’ll keep it in the inner pocket of my old postman’s bag.’”

Raghunath Babu looked at her as though a student had defeated the teacher in the answer book.

The old postman’s bag hung on the wall of his house. The house was a five-minute walk from the veranda. Raghunath Babu wanted to go alone, but Kamala Devi said, “Today is the practical lesson. We will keep our distance, but we will not abandon the class.”

The small group went as far as his house. Seeing the crowd on the veranda, Sumitra Devi asked, “Whose device has broken down this time?”

Rasida Khala said, “Guruji’s today.”

Sumitra Devi smiled without surprise. “I have been waiting a long time for this day.”

The old brown postman’s bag hung from a nail in the wall. Raghunath Babu opened its inner pocket. Out came old postage stamps, two torn receipts, a dry neem leaf, and a small sealed envelope. On the envelope, in his own handwriting, were the words: ‘Recovery details; separate from device.’

“I wrote this, but I did not remember that I had written it,” he muttered.

Shivnarayan Kaka said, “That is why it was written down.”

The envelope did not contain the passcode. It contained only the details with which he could prove his identity at the service centre and regain access. Raghunath Babu was pleased to see this. “At least the old me left a complete arrangement for the new me.”

The authorised service centre in the village market was small but familiar. Raghunath Babu went inside alone; the students stood outside near the tea shop. Half an hour later he emerged. The phone was open again in his hand.

Murtuza Mian asked, “What is the new passcode?”

Raghunath Babu replied at once, "Class dismissed."

Everyone burst out laughing.

The next Wednesday there were six sentences on the wooden board, not five. Raghunath Babu had added a new final line: 'If you forget, do not be ashamed; do not keep making wrong guesses.'

He first told them what had happened to him, but not the new passcode. No one asked for it either.

Then he told the students to check their own recovery arrangements—without telling anyone a secret number, without writing down anyone's private information. This time the students did not give one another orders; they asked one another questions.

Rasida Khala opened her device and held it toward the guru. "Look, I have set a new passcode."

Raghunath Babu began to look toward the screen. Rasida Khala immediately pulled the phone back. "Guruji, you yourself told us—not to show it to anyone."

Raghunath Babu raised his hands. "Right. That lesson I remember very well now."

In small chalk letters at the corner of the table, Shivnarayan Kaka wrote: 'Today the guru is also a student.'

Raghunath Babu read it. He picked up a cloth to erase it, then put the cloth down again.

Evening descended. The veranda began to empty. Everyone packed away his or her device. As Rasida Khala was leaving, she turned back and asked, "Guruji, another passcode lesson next Wednesday?"

Raghunath Babu said, "No. Next Wednesday we will learn how to ask a guru a question in such a way that the guru cannot escape."

Laughter rose once more on the veranda. The six rules shone on the wooden board, and in the corner the small chalk sentence had not been erased.

The Wedding Budget

Before the evening meeting began in Navalkishor Jha's courtyard in Sarisab, one thing had already been settled—Kumud's wedding would be simple, the expenses would remain limited, and no money would be thrown away merely to imitate others.

Navalkishor had announced this decision so many times that even the small children in the house began imitating his voice whenever they heard the words "simple wedding." But the distance between a declaration and an account became clear at the very first meeting.

On an old wooden cot in the veranda lay a red-bound expense ledger. Kumud's maternal uncle Govind tucked his pencil behind his ear. Beside him sat Phulo Kaki, neighbour Jagdish Kaka, the village's well-known cook Nathuni Maharaj, and Kumud's mother Shailaja.

Govind opened the ledger and said, "First write the total limit. An account without a limit is like a river without banks."

Navalkishor said, "Not above seventy thousand."

Phulo Kaki immediately asked, "How many from the groom's party?"

"They have said eighty-five. With our own village and household, one hundred and twenty."

Jagdish Kaka added, "Count those who have not been invited too. On a wedding day, people follow the sound of the drums more readily than the invitation card."

Govind wrote: "Total diners: two hundred and fifty; for safety, two hundred and seventy." Navalkishor held his head. In five minutes the meeting had added twenty people.

The first item was the wedding pavilion. Bamboo would come from the neighbour's grove, rope from home, and village children would gather the leaves. The cost was small. For flower decoration Shailaja said, "There are marigolds in the courtyard." A small figure was entered under that item too.

For music, Kumud's younger brother Pawan proposed that the village youth group could play the kettledrum and cymbals. Govind wrote: "Music: honorarium only."

When photography was discussed, Kumud called from inside, "Two hours are enough. Not the whole night." Navalkishor was pleased. So far even half a page of the expense ledger had not been filled.

Then Govind wrote the next heading: "Food."

Nathuni Maharaj had remained silent until then. Spreading his gamchha across his knees, he said, "Before discussing food, first decide what 'simple' means."

Without delay Navalkishor answered, "Rice, dal, one vegetable dish, pickle, curd, and one sweet."

Phulo Kaki made a face as though three fingers out of five had gone missing. "Only one vegetable dish for the groom's party?"

"One is enough."

"Will there be jackfruit?"

"If there is, that itself is the one vegetable dish."

"Jackfruit needs potatoes with it. Do potatoes count separately or not?"

Nathuni Maharaj burst out laughing. "The potatoes will sit inside the vegetable dish, not in a separate row."

Phulo Kaki did not surrender. "Then pointed gourd? The elderly men in the groom's party do not eat jackfruit."

For the first time Govind's pencil crossed into a second line beneath the food heading.

Jagdish Kaka said, "In my view there should be leafy greens. It is a winter wedding; without fresh greens the meal will look dull."

Shailaja said softly, "If we cook greens, we will need another large cauldron."

Nathuni Maharaj began counting: "One cauldron for rice, one for dal, one for jackfruit and potatoes, one for greens. Four fires. Four people to supervise. Oil and spices separately."

Navalkishor said, "Cut the greens."

Jagdish Kaka replied, "I accept that they are cut, but history will record that in our time leafy greens were removed from a wedding feast."

Laughter rose in the veranda. Govind put a question mark beside the greens.

Then they considered curd. They had milk from two cows of their own, but two cows could not supply curd for two hundred and seventy people. The cost of buying milk from neighbours was added. Earthen pots would be needed to set the curd. Phulo Kaki said curd tasted better in earthen pots. Nathuni Maharaj said that for two hundred and seventy people, seventy little pots would become not flavour but transportation. In the end, three large earthen vessels were agreed upon.

The meeting truly grew heated over sweets. Navalkishor had said one sweet. Shailaja wanted kheer. Phulo Kaki would not agree to drop pua. Pawan said his friends were expecting rasgullas.

Navalkishor looked at Pawan. "Are your friends coming to attend a wedding or to inspect the sweets?"

Pawan fell silent, but five minutes later asked, "Then will the bowl of kheer be large?"

In a corner of the ledger Govind wrote: "Special watch on Pawan's friends."

By the time the first meeting ended, out of the total seventy-thousand-rupee ceiling, the estimate for food alone had reached thirty-four thousand. The pavilion, music, photography, honoraria, and transport together did not amount to that much.

Closing the red-bound ledger, Navalkishor said, "In a low-cost wedding, the stomach has turned out to be the most expensive department."

The next day Kumud looked through the expense ledger. Under the food heading there were so many crossed-out, added, and circled words that it seemed to her as though someone had written a story.

She asked her mother, "Do we need this much food?"

Shailaja said, "I would prefer less. But if we remove something, someone's feelings get hurt. Phulo Kaki has her pua, Jagdish Kaka his greens, your brother his rasgullas, and your father his spending limit."

Kumud laughed. "And what do I have?"

"It is your wedding. Your chance to have an opinion on the food list will come later."

Kumud opened a new page in the ledger and wrote: "First use whatever can be made from things available at home or in the village; buy from outside only afterward."

At the second evening meeting she placed that page on the cot. Nathuni Maharaj read it and said, "If the cook had said this first, people would think I was trying to save labour. When the bride says it, it sounds like wisdom."

Two village families offered rice from their own fields. Jagdish Kaka would provide potatoes from his kitchen garden. Phulo Kaki took responsibility for supplying jaggery from her house for the pua, but laid down one condition: "Pua stays on the list."

Navalkishor said, "The jaggery is yours; the decision is mine."

"Then the jaggery is mine too."

Laughter rose again. In the end the pua stayed, but the rasgullas were cut. Pawan protested, then was given the right to taste the first batch of pua. The protest ended.

The question of greens returned at the next meeting. This time Jagdish Kaka arrived carrying a basket of fresh greens. "The thing struck off the list has come back on its own feet."

Nathuni Maharaj looked at the basket and said, "What will this amount do for two hundred and seventy people?"

Jagdish Kaka said, "Flavour."

In the end the greens were assigned not to the main meal but to the first meal for the cooks and household members. Jagdish Kaka looked as pleased as though he had won a policy decision.

The purpose of the third meeting was merely to settle quantities, but deciding quantities turned out to be the hardest task of all. Nathuni Maharaj gave the measure for rice. Govind calculated. Phulo Kaki said, "The groom's party will take second helpings." Pawan added, "My friends will take third helpings."

Navalkishor said, "Shall we keep your friends after the wedding to plough the fields?"

After listening to everyone, Nathuni Maharaj finally said, "Respect people's appetites, but do not invent them. Measure for the number we actually have; keep ten percent extra. Not double."

By this rule the amount of rice fell, the amount of oil fell, and the ingredients for sweets fell. The food estimate came down from thirty-four thousand to twenty-seven thousand. For the first time Navalkishor looked victorious.

Then Phulo Kaki asked, "Won't there be tea at the meeting?"

Everyone looked at one another. At the previous two meetings there had been tea, puffed rice, roasted gram, and jalebis twice, but none of it appeared anywhere in the ledger.

Govind immediately wrote a new heading: "Expenses of Wedding-Planning Meetings."

Navalkishor said, "Remove that heading."

Govind replied, "The heading can be removed. The expense cannot."

On the wedding day, the plan ran almost exactly as it had finally been written in the ledger. Bamboo came from the neighbours, marigolds from the courtyard, rice from village fields, potatoes from Jagdish Kaka's garden. Nathuni Maharaj's cauldrons were hot before evening.

The groom's party did not number eighty-five; one hundred and seven arrived. From a distance Jagdish Kaka looked at Navalkishor as though returning his prediction from the first meeting with interest added.

But because they had kept ten percent extra, some village people ate later, and the cooks divided the serving into rows, there was no shortage. The trays

of pua emptied faster than expected. Pawan went about telling his friends proudly that the rasgullas had been removed deliberately.

Taking three puas at once, Phulo Kaki said, "This is not an expense. It is tradition."

Navalkishor heard her but did not argue on the wedding day. He merely signalled to Govind with his eyes. Govind wrote nothing in the ledger; peace on a wedding day was also a kind of saving.

After the night had deepened, Nathuni Maharaj gave the account of the remaining food. A little rice, dal covering the bottom of one pot, two buckets of jackfruit and potatoes, and only twenty-seven puas. Compared with the estimate, very little had been wasted.

The next morning Govind opened the red-bound ledger again. The final expenses were added. The pavilion cost less than estimated, the music almost nothing, the photography stayed within the agreed limit, and food was still the largest item. Yet the total expenditure remained within seventy thousand.

Navalkishor said with satisfaction, "See? A low-cost wedding is possible."

Govind turned the page. "One account is still left."

"What?"

"Tea, puffed rice, roasted gram, jalebis, samosas on two occasions, and what Phulo Kaki called the special pua-testing for four meetings."

From the other end of the veranda Phulo Kaki said, "How would we have known the quality without testing?"

Govind added the amount. Everyone laughed until they gradually fell silent. Food had been the largest item at the wedding, but the meetings held to reduce the food budget had themselves become small feasts.

Kumud, who came to look at the ledger before leaving for her husband's home, wrote a line in pencil in the corner of the last page: "At the next wedding, do not hold meetings on an empty stomach—eat first."

Navalkishor read it, closed the ledger, and for the first time did not make another declaration about a "simple wedding." He only said, "Keep this ledger safe. Next time, before we begin the accounts, we will eat breakfast at home."

The Great Poet's Neighbour

Batuknath Jha lives immediately to the west of my house. The wall of his house leaves just enough distance between us that when he recites poetry on his veranda, I may not understand the meaning from my courtyard, but I certainly hear the rhyme. People in the village call him "Poet Batuk"; Batuknath himself has added the word "Great" to the name.

I have no objection to this. People may add whatever they like before their names. The only difficulty is that his sole method of proving his greatness is to recite poetry to his neighbour, and unfortunately I am his nearest neighbour.

At first I was polite. In the evenings he would come and say, "Just listen to two lines." I would shift the wooden stool for him. Two lines became four, four became twelve, and by the time twelve became "the last poem in this section," my rice would be cold.

Once my wife Kamla asked, "Shall I heat your rice again?" I said, "No, I'll eat when the poem ends." Laughing, she said, "Then I'll save tomorrow's rice too."

That was how I learned that loving poetry is one thing, and being a poet's neighbour quite another. It was necessary to save my evenings without dishonouring literature.

I devised my first method of escape—whenever I saw the red-bound book in Batuknath's hand, I immediately went toward the cowshed. I believed no one would recite poetry beside a man lifting cow dung. Batuknath proved more determined than I was. Standing at the cowshed gate, he said, "This poem contains soil, smell, and labour—all three. Hearing it here will give it the proper atmosphere."

That day I carried out two baskets of dung and listened to seventeen lines. The only advantage was that the cow occasionally swished its tail between verses, so some words never reached me.

For my second method, I began pretending to be hard of hearing. He said, "I have written a new poem." Cupping a hand to my ear, I asked, "What? You bought a new hoe?"

Batuknath was delighted. "Hoe! Wonderful. A whole poem could be written on that word." He sat down on the veranda at once and began

composing "The Lament of the Hoe." My deafness had not saved me from poetry; it had helped produce a new poem.

The third method was planned with the family's cooperation. I told Kamla—when the poet comes, wait five minutes, then shout from inside, "The milk is boiling over." That would give me an excuse to get up.

The plan might have worked, but on the very first day Kamla forgot that there was no milk in the house that evening. Batuknath looked inside and asked, "Where is the milk?" Kamla thought for a moment and answered, "It finished before it could boil over."

Batuknath looked at me. I looked at him. He said nothing, but titled his next poem "The Milk That Never Boiled Over."

After that I began arranging all my defensive measures in my head. Red book—toward the well. Blue book—to the market. Open sheet of paper—"I have accounts to write." Paper in his pocket—a greeting from a safe distance.

The trouble was that Batuknath's poetic material was everywhere. One day he came without a book. Reassured, I sat on the stool. He slapped his forehead and said, "I forgot the book today." I breathed with relief. Then he added, "But I know it all by heart."

Other people in the village were not unfamiliar with this crisis either. Harimohan the betel seller began pounding areca nuts the moment he saw Batuknath, so half the lines disappeared in the clatter. Mahesh the tailor ran his sewing machine faster. The schoolmaster, the moment he spotted Batuknath coming from a distance, began giving the children extra lessons.

But there was no unity among us. One day Harimohan blamed me. "You are the neighbour. You listen. What am I supposed to tell my customers?" I said, "The poet's throat opens after chewing your betel. You are the root cause."

In the middle of this argument Batuknath himself arrived. "What are you discussing?" he asked. Harimohan immediately said, "Your poetry." I have not considered him a friend since that day.

Batuknath caught hold of me. "I have found you at just the right time. Shall I recite 'The Seven Colours of Evening'?"

I replied at once, "I'll listen, but I have one rule. While listening to poetry, my hands will not remain empty."

He looked surprised. "Meaning?"

"Meaning that I have to repair the bamboo fence behind the house. You recite; I'll listen while tying the bamboo."

I had thought the sight of the repair work would make him turn back. Instead, he gathered up his dhoti and said, "Poetry and labour ought to meet." Five minutes later he was holding the rope, I was setting the bamboo upright, and "The Seven Colours of Evening" had reached an eighth colour.

The poem ended, but half the fence had been repaired too. A new thought came to me—if I could not escape listening, why not get some work done while I listened?

The next time he arrived with a poem, I was shelling peas. I placed a bowl before him. He read the first couplet and shelled three peas. On the second, five. By the third couplet, his hands had found the rhythm. The poem was long, but all the peas were shelled.

When Kamla saw this, her eyes lit up with the particular glow that appears when an expense has been saved. The next day she herself said, “Poet Babu, if you have a new poem, recite it while picking the stones out of these pigeon peas.”

Batuknath looked at the tray of pigeon peas, remained silent for a moment, then said, “If the listener is industrious, it is the poet’s duty to help.”

From that day my method spread through the village. Harimohan began listening while counting betel leaves. Mahesh the tailor sorted buttons. The schoolmaster listened while binding old exercise books. No one escaped Batuknath’s poetry, but at least the time spent listening was no longer wasted.

At first Batuknath was proud of the change. He would say, “See? My poetry is making people industrious.” I would nod in agreement, because the moment I disagreed he would begin another poem as evidence.

After a month the situation became strange. Whenever Batuknath came down the lane carrying a book, people immediately brought out little jobs of their own—shelling peas, untangling jute cord, folding old newspaper sheets. The poet moved from one house to another reciting, and everywhere did some small task alongside it.

One day he said to me, “I suspect people are listening less to the poetry and more to the work.”

I said, “Poetry is heard; work is seen. Together they strengthen memory.”

He stared at me for a long time. I was afraid my answer would give birth to another poem. But he only smiled.

The real test came one evening in Sawan. Batuknath arrived with a new poem—twelve pages long. Clouds hung outside; inside, Kamla was sorting lentils. I had no job large enough to survive twelve pages. In alarm, I looked around the courtyard.

Beside the wall lay a pile of old bricks that had to be moved under the veranda before the rains. I said, “I shall certainly hear the poem. I only need to move these bricks inside.”

Batuknath tucked the book under his arm and lifted the first brick. I took the second. He read one line, we moved two bricks. By the third page the rain

had begun. On the fifth, Kamla opened the door and set down tea. By the eighth, half the brick pile was gone.

On the tenth page Batuknath suddenly stopped reading. I thought he was tired. Looking at the page, he said, "This line is wrong."

I was astonished. For the first time in all those days, he had stopped his own poem midway.

He set down two bricks, took out a pencil, crossed out one line, and wrote another. Then he asked me, "Was the first version better, or this one?"

I had always avoided this question. But that evening I had a brick in my hand, the rain was heavy, and I had crossed ten of the poem's twelve pages. I said, "The second is shorter, so it is better."

He burst out laughing. "Your criticism always saves time."

I laughed too. For the first time that day I understood that Batuknath was not unaware of all my escape tactics. He knew everything—the milk, the cowshed, the deafness, the market, the fence—but seemed content to keep the game going.

Before the twelfth page was finished, all the bricks were under the veranda. Batuknath closed the book and said, "Now you have escaped."

I said, "The poem is over?"

"No. The last two lines tomorrow. You still have to lift the bamboo onto the roof, don't you?"

I began to suspect the plan had slipped out of my hands.

A few days later the village library announced a monsoon literary evening. Everyone feared that if Batuknath gave the main reading, the programme would continue until night. Naresh, the librarian, told me secretly, "You are the neighbour. Do something."

I said, "Where will I find peas on a stage?"

In the end I went to Batuknath. It was difficult to speak directly, but years of neighbourhood give a man some courage. I said, "People do not run from your poetry. They run from its length."

He asked calmly, "How many pages can you listen to?"

"Sitting still? Two."

"While working?"

"Six."

He laughed. "Then shall we give everyone work at the literary evening?"

I said, "No. Keep it to two pages."

On the day of the programme Batuknath went up on the stage. In his hand was the red-bound book, containing at least twenty visible pages. Every listener grew uneasy. Harimohan began searching his pocket for areca nuts; Mahesh assumed the posture of sorting imaginary buttons.

Batuknath opened the book and said, "My neighbour's order—two pages."

Every eye turned toward me. I tried to become smaller in my chair.

He really did read only two pages. The poem was short, about a village evening, the shadow of the bamboo fence, peas, a pile of bricks, and a neighbour's habit of repeatedly getting up to leave. I feared everyone would recognise me; everyone did.

At the last line people laughed, then applauded. Batuknath closed the book and stepped down from the stage. Naresh looked as relieved as though not a programme but a flood embankment had been saved.

On the way back I walked beside Batuknath. He asked, "Were two pages all right?"

I said, "Fine. But what happened to the poem about the fence?"

He narrowed his eyes at me. "I thought you never listened."

I began searching for an answer. The truth was that many lines from the poems I had tried so hard to escape had settled inside me without my consent.

Batuknath said, "Don't worry. The fence poem is seven pages long. I'll recite it tomorrow."

I said immediately, "Tomorrow morning I have to dig potatoes."

He replied happily, "Excellent. The poem is about soil."

That is why I no longer devise new escape plans. Whenever Batuknath arrives with a book, I simply look around the courtyard to see what task has been postponed for too long. I have still not achieved complete escape from poetry, but my fence, bricks, lentils, peas, potatoes, and even the library have all benefited from this neighbourhood.

And Batuknath? He still adds "Great" before his name. I do not object. One advantage of being the neighbour of a great poet is that work in the village never comes to a complete halt.

The Scholar for Hire

In an old lane near the university in Darbhanga stood Gopikant Jha's two-storey house. He himself lived downstairs with his family, while upstairs he had rented three small rooms to students. A tin sign hung on the gate: 'Quiet Residence for Students.' At some point, someone had added 'Very' in red chalk before the word 'Quiet', but Gopikant Babu had never erased it.

Gopikant Babu was a retired clerk. He believed that after thirty years of reading files in an office, no subject in the world could remain entirely unfamiliar to him. If history came up, he cited the archives; if the conversation turned to botany, he pointed to the tulsi plant in his courtyard; if there was a question of economics, he opened the rent ledger.

A new tenant, Nilambar Jha, came to live in the house. He was a final-year postgraduate student, writing a short dissertation on 'The Memory of Domestic Labour in the Wedding Songs of Northern Mithila'. All he wanted was one room, one table, an earthen pot for water, and enough quiet to study at night.

On the first day Gopikant Babu read out the terms of tenancy: rent by the fifth of the month, shoes kept straight on the veranda, no loud music after ten at night, and no plucking mangoes from the tree on the roof without asking.

Nilambar said, 'I don't have a musical instrument.'

Gopikant Babu was pleased. 'Then you seem to be a man of study. What is your subject?'

Nilambar told him the subject.

Gopikant Babu's eyes lit up. 'Wedding songs? That is my special field.'

Nilambar thought that landlords generally regarded their roof, drain, water supply, or electricity as their special field. Wedding songs were a first.

The very next morning Gopikant Babu came upstairs carrying an old exercise book. On its cover was written: 'Miscellaneous Knowledge'. Inside were half a page of rent accounts, half a page of proverbs, names of medicines here and there, two pages of materials for worship, and, at the end, five lines from wedding songs.

'I heard all these from my mother,' he said. 'Use them. Put my name among your sources.'

Nilambar examined the notebook respectfully. Some of the lines were genuinely useful. He said, 'Certainly. I'll put your name in the acknowledgements.'

Gopikant Babu raised an eyebrow. 'Only the acknowledgements?'

Nilambar laughed. He could not tell whether the question was a joke or a proposal.

A week later the first chapter of Nilambar's dissertation lay ready on his table. That evening Gopikant Babu came upstairs on the pretext of collecting the rent. He spent five minutes taking the rent, fifteen minutes reading the chapter, and then drew circles in three places with a red pencil.

'Here you have written "the women of the household". That is too broad. Write "the experienced women of the household".'

Nilambar said, 'But not all the songs are sung only by experienced women.'

'Very well. Then let "the women of the household" remain. I merely offered an alternative.'

The second circle was around a punctuation mark. The third was in an empty part of the page.

Nilambar asked, 'What is wrong here?'

Gopikant Babu said, 'Nothing. The space was empty, so I drew a circle. If there is a red pencil in my hand and I draw no circles, my mind remains dissatisfied.'

Nilambar laughed. From that day Gopikant Babu began his evening 'research darshan'.

He would read a page and say midway, 'This line meant something different at my wedding.' Then he would begin the story of his own wedding. Instead of writing, Nilambar would be left listening.

One night Gopikant Babu said, 'My contribution to your subject has become quite sufficient now. How will the name appear?'

Nilambar asked, 'Which name?'

'On the dissertation. Nilambar Jha—and Gopikant Jha. Smaller type will do.'

The pen in Nilambar's hand stopped. 'This is a university dissertation. The author is the candidate alone.'

Gopikant Babu grew serious. 'Why should there be only one author? The house is mine, the table is mine, the electric wiring is mine, the wedding songs are my mother's, the red pencil is mine. Only the sentences are yours?'

'I pay the rent too.'

'That is financial support in reverse.'

Nilambar remained silent for a few moments before this argument. He understood that the university regulations would contain no answer to a sentence like that.

From the next day Gopikant Babu began to formalise his role. He put a small sign at the corner of the upstairs staircase: 'Research Room'. He had the old chair from the veranda sent into Nilambar's room and said, 'A co-author needs support for his back.'

Nilambar objected. 'Drop the word co-author.'

'Fine. For now, "collaborator". The final decision after the degree is awarded.'

The house's other tenant, Ashok, a mathematics student, took great delight in these discussions. Every day he asked, 'Gopikant Babu, will you become a co-candidate in my examination too?'

Gopikant Babu would say, 'Mathematics is not my field.'

Ashok would immediately reply, 'But only yesterday you were teaching me how to calculate interest.'

'That was life-mathematics.'

Gradually word spread through the lane that Gopikant Babu wanted his name added to his tenant's degree. At the tea stall people began addressing him as 'Professor'. At first he protested; from the third day onward he merely smiled.

Nilambar's difficulty was that not everything Gopikant Babu said was meaningless. One wedding song mentioned 'the seventh post of the veranda'. Nilambar had interpreted it as an architectural symbol. Gopikant Babu said, 'My mother used to say that in old houses sacks of grain were kept beside that post. In the song it may be a memory of the bride taking leave of the grain store.'

To verify this clue, Nilambar spoke to two elderly women. Both remembered the old practice of storing grain in that way. An important paragraph in his chapter was corrected as a result.

After this success, Gopikant Babu's confidence grew by two full armspans. On the first page of his 'Miscellaneous Knowledge' notebook he wrote a new title: 'Assistant Research Ledger'.

Nilambar saw it and clutched his head.

The problem became serious when the submission date drew near. Nilambar had a sample of the university cover page printed. The university's name appeared at the top, the subject in the middle, and below it: 'Submitted by: Nilambar Jha'.

The moment Gopikant Babu saw the page, he asked, 'Where is my name?' 'In the acknowledgements.'

‘Acknowledgements are given even to the man who serves paan at a wedding. Mine is an intellectual contribution.’

‘Then I’ll state it clearly in the acknowledgements—assistance with folk memory and regional interpretation.’

Gopikant Babu was not satisfied. He took out his red pencil and, in faint letters beneath ‘Submitted by’, wrote: ‘Local Co-Thinker: Gopikant Jha’.

Nilambar looked at the page and said, ‘This is the printed copy!’

‘Red is temporary. If the university wants, it can have it printed in black.’

That night Nilambar seriously considered looking for another house. But it was the end of the month, the submission date was five days away, and finding a new room seemed as difficult as writing the dissertation all over again.

Ashok advised, ‘Run away after you get the degree.’

Nilambar said, ‘By then he will come along to the oral examination.’

Ashok laughed. ‘Just answer his questions by saying, “This is not my field; it is life-research.”’

One day before the submission, Gopikant Babu called Nilambar downstairs. On the table lay the rent ledger, the Assistant Research Ledger, and a sheet of white paper.

‘I have been thinking,’ he said. ‘It would not be proper to break the university’s rules. But there ought to be some proof of the contribution.’

Nilambar became wary. ‘What proof?’

‘Write down that my contribution to this dissertation is forty percent.’

‘Forty!’

‘All right, thirty-five. I won’t count the table’s contribution separately.’

Nilambar burst out laughing. Gopikant Babu did not take offence; he began laughing too. After a while the percentage became twenty, then ten, then finally ‘important’. In the end Nilambar wrote one sentence: ‘I received assistance from Shri Gopikant Jha in understanding local memory, the meanings of old songs, and regional practices.’

Gopikant Babu read the sentence three times. ‘Could we add “important” here?’

‘No.’

‘“Special”?’

‘No.’

‘Then “Scholar” before my name?’

‘Certainly not.’

Gopikant Babu folded the paper and placed it in his ledger. ‘Students are ungrateful,’ he said, though there was a smile on his face.

The dissertation was submitted. Two weeks later came the oral examination. Nilambar was about to leave the house early in the morning

when he found Gopikant Babu standing at the gate in a freshly washed dhoti-kurta.

Nilambar was startled. 'Where are you going?'

'To the university. Not as co-author—as listener.'

'The oral examination will be held inside. Listeners are not allowed.'

'Then I'll wait on the veranda. The outcome of knowledge can be heard outside as well.'

Nilambar did not argue. The two left together. On reaching the university, Gopikant Babu sat beneath a banyan tree and Nilambar went inside.

The examiners asked their questions one by one: the division of labour in wedding songs, the metaphor of crossing the river, the household veranda, grain storage. The third examiner asked, 'What is the basis for this interpretation of the "seventh post"?'

Nilambar answered, 'Regional oral memory. I found the clue in an old memory preserved by the mother of the landlord at my residence, and then verified it with two independent elderly women.'

The examiner asked, 'What is the landlord's name?'

'Gopikant Jha.'

'Is he in the acknowledgements?'

'Yes.'

For a moment Nilambar saw, in his mind, the white kurta seated beneath the banyan tree. He had to suppress a laugh.

The oral examination ended. The moment Nilambar came out, Gopikant Babu rose to his feet. 'Was there a question on my subject?'

Nilambar said, 'The seventh post.'

Gopikant Babu's face lit up. 'You see? If not forty percent, then at least a seventh-post percentage.'

A few months later Nilambar's degree certificate arrived. Naturally, it bore only Nilambar's name. When he brought the certificate home, Gopikant Babu put on his spectacles and studied it for a long time.

'My name isn't here,' he said.

Nilambar remained silent.

Gopikant Babu spoke again. 'The university writes very concisely.'

That evening Nilambar gave him a copy of his dissertation. He opened the acknowledgements page, where one sentence had been underlined in pencil: 'I received assistance from Shri Gopikant Jha in understanding local memory, the meanings of old songs, and regional practices.'

Gopikant Babu kept looking at the page. Then he went inside, emptied an old photograph frame, and placed a copy of the acknowledgements page in it.

The next morning a new sign hung beside the gate: 'Quiet Residence for Students. Research Consultation Free. Co-authorship According to University Rules.'

Ashok read it and asked, 'Will the rent come down?'

Gopikant Babu said, 'Knowledge is free. The room is not.'

A few months after receiving his degree, Nilambar left the town. But students continued to come to Gopikant Babu's house. Now, on the first day, along with the terms of rent, he added one more thing: 'Tell me your subject. If it isn't my field, I'll only collect the rent.'

They say no such subject has yet been found.

The Village Meteorologist

In Sonbarsa village, people called Harinarayan Kaka “the meteorologist.” No university had conferred this title on him; years ago, the men sitting in front of the paan shop at the crossroads had bestowed it in jest, and little by little the name had stuck so firmly that his original identity had receded into the background.

Harinarayan Kaka was seventy-two. Sparse white hair covered his head, an old gamchha rested on his shoulder, and he carried a slender bamboo stick. At dawn he looked first not at the sky but at the roof of the cowshed; only after that did he study the ants, the egrets, the leaves, the dust, and the movement of the wind.

He had many theories.

If ants carried grain upward, there would be rain.

If an egret sat in the middle of the pond, there would be sunshine.

If the neem leaves turned over, a storm was coming.

If a cow sat facing east in the evening, it would rain at night.

There was one difficulty with all these theories—the weather usually refused to obey him.

On days when he declared, “There will be a downpour by afternoon,” the women who had put clothes out to dry would not have to clear the washing line even by evening. On days when he said, “Leave your umbrella at home today,” the schoolchildren returned with their books soaked through.

Even so, the first question of the morning was always put to him.

“Kaka, what will happen today?”

He would plant his stick on the ground, narrow his eyes, look toward the sky, and say, “The wind says there will be rain after two.”

The shopkeeper would immediately ask, “Should I bring the sacks inside before two?”

Kaka would reply, “Why are the sacks outside in the first place? Whatever the weather does, sacks of grain ought to stay under the veranda.”

In this way, practical advice emerged even before the forecast had finished.

When a new teacher named Aniruddha came to the village, he found all this peculiar. He taught science and explained wind, temperature, clouds, and

humidity to the children. In his very first week he heard that Harinarayan Kaka had predicted “three watches of rain” the day before, and all three watches had remained bright with sunshine.

Aniruddha laughed.

“Then why do people ask him?”

The pupil Malti said, “We do ask him, Master Sahib.”

“Why?”

Malti thought for a moment. “You will understand later.”

Aniruddha found the answer incomplete. In one corner of the school blackboard he made a new chart—“Harinarayan Kaka’s Weather Talk.”
Date, Kaka’s statement, actual weather.

First day—“Rain in the evening.” Reality—sunshine.

Second day—“Sunshine.” Reality—a light drizzle.

Third day—“Strong wind.” Reality—a still evening.

The children laughed whenever they looked at the chart. When Harinarayan Kaka passed near the school, Aniruddha would call him inside.

“Kaka, we need today’s statement.”

Kaka looked at the blackboard and said, “Have I been given a job?”

“Not a job. An examination.”

“Then who will pay the salary?”

“If you are right, you will get respect.”

Kaka grew solemn. “Respect does not buy rice. Still, write this down—no rain tonight.”

That night it rained for half an hour. The next morning the children wrote “wrong.”

A month passed. Aniruddha added up the figures. Out of thirty statements, five were correct, seven half-correct, and eighteen wrong.

He announced the result of the chart at the crossroads.

Everyone laughed. Harinarayan Kaka laughed too.

“You see,” Aniruddha said, “these figures prove that Kaka’s forecast cannot be relied upon.”

Harinarayan Kaka asked, “Who relies on it?”

Aniruddha stopped short.

The shopkeeper, Bhola Sahu, said, “I ask him.”

“Do you rely on him?”

Bhola Sahu scratched his head. “That is another matter.”

This answer only deepened Aniruddha’s curiosity.

In the last week of Jeth, paddy seed was being dried in the courtyard of the village cooperative. For weddings in three households, sacks of makhana, rice, and spices had also been stacked along one side of the same courtyard.

The sky was clear. The official weather bulletin said the chance of rain during the next twenty-four hours was low.

Even so, Bhola Sahu went to Harinarayan Kaka.

“Kaka, shall we leave the seed outside today?”

Kaka looked toward the west. “No rain tonight.”

Bhola Sahu immediately called two boys. “Where is the tarpaulin?”

Aniruddha was standing there. He burst out laughing. “Kaka says there will be no rain, and you are asking for a tarpaulin?”

Bhola Sahu said, “If the tarpaulin is ready and it does not rain, what do we lose?”

Kaka asked, “And which sacks are for the weddings?”

“These five.”

“Do not leave them directly on the ground. Last time they caught damp from below.”

Two bricks were set beneath a plank, and the wedding sacks were lifted onto it.

Aniruddha noticed that once again a question about weather had turned into a meeting about storage.

There was no rain that evening. This time Kaka’s statement proved correct. Kaka himself came to the crossroads with an announcement: “Draw a red flower on the blackboard.”

Malti said, “One correct answer does not erase eighteen wrong ones.”

Kaka laughed. “You study science; do not forget arithmetic.”

The next week Ashadh began. Near the western hamlet, an old drain was choked with silt. The panchayat had already postponed its cleaning twice. Harinarayan Kaka announced at the crossroads, “No rain for three days. The drain can be cleaned later.”

This time Phulo Devi was the first to speak. “Then let us clean it today.”

Kaka looked startled. “I am telling you there will be no rain for three days.”

Phulo Devi said, “We all understand what your three days mean.”

By afternoon ten people had reached the drain with spades. Aniruddha went too. Kaka stood on the bank with his bamboo stick.

“You will not use a spade yourself?” Aniruddha asked.

“I will supervise.”

“The weather?”

“The work.”

People kept shovelling out the silt. By evening half the drain had been cleared. In the second watch of the night, heavy rain began. Kaka’s promised three days had not survived even half the night.

By morning, however, water had not collected near the western hamlet; it ran away through the cleared drain.

The moment Phulo Devi saw Kaka, she said, "Wrong again."

Kaka asked, "Is the drain all right?"

"It is."

"Then half the respect belongs to me."

"You did not lift a spade."

"I gave advice."

"And even the advice was backwards."

Everyone burst out laughing.

That day Aniruddha added a new column to his chart—"What did the village do after the statement?"

In this column, the story began to change.

"After rain was predicted—the torn thatch on the roof was replaced."

"After sunshine was predicted—the school's damp books were brought inside."

"After a storm was predicted—a heavy mango branch was tied securely."

"After no rain was predicted—the drain was cleaned."

Aniruddha began to understand that the village was not listening to Kaka's weather; using him as a pretext, it was listening to its own need for preparedness.

But before this understanding could become complete, a larger test arrived.

On the first Monday of Sawan, a health camp was to be held beside the panchayat building. Elderly people, children, and women would come from far-flung hamlets. A bamboo canopy was erected in the courtyard. Medicine chests, registers, drinking water, and benches were assembled.

The sky was grey in the morning. The official bulletin said moderate rain was possible after noon.

The panchayat secretary asked Harinarayan Kaka, "What do you say?"

Kaka studied the sky for a long time. He took a neem leaf in his hand and turned it this way and that. He made two rounds toward the pond and came back.

Then, in a decisive voice, he said, "Not a single drop before noon."

Aniruddha made a note of it.

Phulo Devi said, "Then put the medicine chests inside the building."

The secretary said, "But there is a canopy."

"Didn't you hear Kaka?"

Everyone laughed, but the chests went inside. The registration table was shifted nearer the veranda. Two bamboo poles were tightened again. The earthen water pots were moved away from the edge of the canopy.

Harinarayan Kaka put on a show of being offended. "Such an insult to my forecast!"

Aniruddha said, "Kaka, your forecast has tremendous influence."

At half past eleven, rain began. First came large, heavy drops, and then a fierce downpour.

One corner of the canopy sagged, but because the bamboo poles had been tightened, it did not collapse. The medicines remained safe inside the building. The register stayed dry. People pressed together under the veranda.

Kaka himself was stranded without an umbrella.

Phulo Devi gave him half the shelter of her own umbrella and said, "Not a single drop?"

Kaka replied, "These are not drops; this is a full downpour. Technically, my sentence—"

"Quiet."

Laughter erupted under the veranda.

After the camp ended, Aniruddha brought the blackboard chart to the panchayat building. It now had three columns—statement, actual weather, and action taken after the statement.

He read it aloud to everyone.

Harinarayan Kaka had been wrong—that fact had not changed.

But after the questions and answers with Kaka, people usually inspected roofs, lifted sacks, cleared drains, tightened ropes, brought animals inside, and covered seed.

Aniruddha said, "You are less a meteorologist than a bell that rings for preparedness."

Kaka said, "Will the bell get a salary?"

Bhola Sahu said, "Tea on credit at the crossroads."

"I already have credit there."

"Then respect."

"Again that same thing that will not buy rice!"

The blackboard remained in use throughout Sawan. The children no longer wrote only "right" or "wrong"; they recorded which signs had been observed and which preparations had proved useful. Aniruddha also wrote the official weather bulletin alongside Kaka's predictions, so that the difference between conjecture and evidence could be understood.

Harinarayan Kaka did not abandon his theories. On the contrary, he added a new one: "If Malti sneezes three times, the wind will change."

Malti protested, "Dust makes me sneeze."

Kaka said, "And dust too is carried by the wind."

Aniruddha clutched his head.

One evening in Bhadra, the sky was perfectly clear. The radio announced a chance of rain during the night. At the crossroads Bhola Sahu asked, “Kaka, what about tonight?”

Harinarayan Kaka examined the neem leaves, adjusted the gamchha on his shoulder, and declared, “Absolutely no rain.”

For one moment there was silence.

Then the entire crossroads sprang into motion at once.

Bhola Sahu began carrying the rice sacks indoors.

Phulo Devi ran toward home—chillies were drying on her veranda.

Two children went to close the school windows.

The herdsman set off to inspect the bamboo latch on the cowshed.

Laughing, Aniruddha asked, “Kaka, did you see that?”

Harinarayan Kaka looked around. “None of them believes me.”

Aniruddha said, “They do believe you—they simply understand the meaning of what you say in their own way.”

Kaka grew serious. “Then am I science, or am I a sign?”

Malti, who was standing nearby, said, “You are a question, Kaka. We are the ones who have to find the answer.”

Kaka looked at her for a few moments. Then he said, “Write that on the blackboard. But put my name in large letters.”

That night, rain began at nine.

Harinarayan Kaka went inside to look for his umbrella. He could not find it for a long time. At last he remembered—he had left it at the panchayat building on the day of the health camp.

He put the gamchha over his head and set off through the rain. As he crossed the crossroads, Bhola Sahu called out, “Kaka, no rain, eh?”

Without stopping, Harinarayan Kaka replied, “I forecast the weather. I do not forecast where I have left my umbrella.”

The next morning a new line had been written on the blackboard: “Statement: no rain. Reality: rain. Result: the entire village was ready in time.”

Below it, Malti had added in small letters: “A meteorologist is useful for more than the weather.”

Harinarayan Kaka read it and smiled. He picked up the red chalk and drew a line beneath his own name.

Free Advice

At Belahi crossroads, beside Bhola Sahu's tea stall, stood an old wooden bench. Behind it, on a strip of tin, someone had written in charcoal: "Maheshwar Jha: Free Advice. You are responsible for the consequences."

Maheshwar Kaka had added that last line himself. He liked to say, "The remedy is free, but the courage to follow it has to come out of your own pocket."

He held no official position in the village. Once he had run a seed shop. After the shop closed, the wooden bench became his office. From the first tea of the morning until the first darkness of evening, someone or other would invariably arrive there with a question.

Someone's goat had eaten a neighbour's greens; someone's son wanted to skip an examination and go to the fair; someone's roof-water was falling into another person's courtyard; at someone's wedding the number of guests in the groom's party kept increasing day by day. Whatever the subject, Maheshwar Kaka would scratch his chin and ask three questions.

First: "What are the facts?"

Second: "What is the guess?"

Third: "What is the smallest useful thing that can be done right now?"

Bhola Sahu would say, "Kaka, the entire panchayat fits inside those three questions."

Maheshwar Kaka would reply, "Running the panchayat is not my subject. I never get a chance to speak there, so I practise here."

One day Phulo Devi came to him. Her two hens were laying eggs in her neighbour's courtyard. The question was: whose eggs were they?

Maheshwar Kaka asked, "Whose hens?"

"Mine."

"Whose courtyard?"

"Hers."

"Who feeds them?"

Phulo Devi fell silent. From a distance the neighbour called out, "Half the time I do."

Maheshwar Kaka gave no verdict. He said, "For seven days, divide the eggs equally. On the eighth day, give the hens equal feed in both courtyards. Wherever they settle, take that as nature's vote."

Bhola Sahu burst out laughing. "Nature gets a vote too?"

"The oldest member of all."

That was how Kaka's reputation spread. The teenagers called him "Advice Guru," the elders "Maheshwar Babu," and Bhola Sahu simply "Kaka," because adding honorifics to an unpaid tea bill did not reduce the amount owed.

But there was one thing the village did not know: for a month, a problem had been standing in Maheshwar Kaka's own house, and he had not said a word about it to anyone.

In the rear courtyard, a wall ran beside the kitchen as far as the courtyard of their neighbour Kalavati. It was an old brick wall: mud mortar below, lime plaster in patches above, and here and there the cracks of time.

After the last rains, the middle section of the wall had begun to lean slightly outward. To support it, Maheshwar Kaka had propped two bamboo poles against it at an angle.

The previous month, a third bamboo prop had been added.

Saraswati Devi had asked, "Why don't you call a mason?"

Maheshwar Kaka had said, "Let the rains pass. One does not make decisions about a wet wall."

"Did you invent that, or is it written in some book?"

"In experience."

Saraswati Devi looked at the bamboo poles. "Experience has increased for the third time."

Kaka changed the subject.

The real difficulty was that twelve years earlier Maheshwar Kaka himself had proposed the method used to repair this wall. For the rainwater running off the kitchen roof, he had made a narrow earthen channel along the foot of the wall and led it round toward the lane. Everyone had praised his ingenuity then.

Now, if the wall was leaning from that very foundation, the question concerned not only bricks but prestige as well.

At the crossroads Kaka told other people, "Do not fall in love with your old remedies; if one does not work, change it."

At home, he tightened the knots on the bamboo props.

One evening Kalavati called from her courtyard, "Kaka, is the wall leaning more toward my side or yours?"

Kaka looked at the top of the wall. "An optical illusion."

Kalavati said, "Then are the bamboo poles an optical illusion too?"

"A precaution."

“The third bamboo pole?”

“Extra precaution.”

Kalavati laughed, but the next day she moved her two earthen water pots away from the wall.

Two days later Ramkripal came to the crossroads. One post in his cowshed was rotting. He asked, “Should I replace it after the rains?”

Maheshwar Kaka replied at once, “If the weakness is visible to the eye, why wait for the weather? First remove the load, give it temporary support, then look for the cause.”

Bhola Sahu looked at him while pouring tea.

Maheshwar Kaka looked away.

Ramkripal said, “It is difficult to understand the cause.”

“Look at the facts. Is the earth wet? Are there termites? Is there too much weight above? Do not begin with assumptions.”

This time Bhola Sahu cleared his throat.

“Have you got a cough?” Kaka asked.

“No. I was looking at the facts.”

That night it rained hard. Water drummed on the kitchen roof. Around midnight, Saraswati Devi woke to a faint rustling scrape.

In the rear courtyard, the foot of one bamboo pole had sunk into the earth. The wall had not fallen, but the soil at its base had become soft as a marsh.

Maheshwar Kaka came out carrying a lantern. He set the bamboo upright again, placed two bricks beneath it, and moved some old sacks of paddy away from the veranda.

Saraswati Devi said, “Shall I call Bhola Sahu?”

“At night?”

“In the daytime you do not call anyone either.”

Kaka remained silent.

By dawn the rain had stopped. On her way to school through the lane, Ranjana noticed the bamboo poles jutting beyond the wall. The moment she reached the crossroads she told Bhola Sahu, “There are three bamboo poles holding up the wall behind Kaka’s house.”

Bhola Sahu asked, “Three?”

“And one is half sunk into the ground.”

By ten o’clock, the news had reached the bench.

Ramkripal offered the first piece of advice: “Tear down the whole wall and build a new one.”

Phulo Devi gave the second: “Put a broad stone footing underneath.”

Pappu the mason gave the third: “Stop the water first.”

Bhola Sahu supplied the fourth: “Deposit the consultation fee with me.”

Maheshwar Kaka frowned. "Did I ask anyone for advice?"

Bhola Sahu pointed at the strip of tin. "It says 'free' here. It does not specify the customer's name."

Laughter rose at the crossroads.

Maheshwar Kaka got up and walked away. But Ramkripal, Pappu the mason, Bhola Sahu, and Ranjana followed him. Kalavati opened the gate to her courtyard.

"Facts first," Pappu the mason said. "Your rule, Kaka."

Reluctantly, Maheshwar Kaka showed them the foot of the wall.

Pappu took some soil in his hand. The earth near the middle of the wall was much wetter, while the soil in Kalavati's courtyard was almost dry.

Maheshwar Kaka said, "Her courtyard is higher, so the water must be coming toward our side."

Kalavati answered at once, "My water drains into the channel in front. Have you seen it?"

Kaka said nothing.

Ranjana looked toward the edge of the kitchen roof. "Where does the water come down?"

Maheshwar Kaka showed her the old narrow channel. Its mouth was almost completely blocked with earth, leaves, and roots.

Pappu pushed a bamboo rod into it. After half a cubit it stopped. When they dug from the other side, they found the channel packed with fine neem roots.

Bhola Sahu said, "Fact one."

Pappu measured the slope along the channel. In places the earth had subsided; instead of flowing from the roof toward the lane, the water was collecting at the foot of the wall.

Ranjana said, "Fact two."

Kalavati picked up a dry brick from her courtyard and set it near the base of the wall. "And fact three: the water is not coming from my side."

Maheshwar Kaka looked in turn at the wall, the channel, and the three bamboo props.

Bhola Sahu said softly, "What was the guess?"

Kaka replied distractedly, "The neighbour's higher courtyard."

"The smallest useful thing?"

This time Maheshwar Kaka could not help smiling. "First, open the drain."

The whole wall was not demolished that day. For the water from the kitchen roof, a length of split bamboo was temporarily extended to the open drain in the lane. The old blocked earthen channel was dug out and cleaned. The wet soil at the foot of the wall was removed and replaced with dry gravel.

Pappu the mason said, "Let it dry for three days. Then we will reset two courses of brick beneath the leaning section. The upper part of the wall can still be saved."

Maheshwar Kaka asked, "There is no need to tear down the whole thing?"

Ramkripal said at once, "I withdraw my first piece of advice."

Phulo Devi said, "And keep my stone footing on hold for now."

Bhola Sahu announced, "The market for free advice has collapsed."

Three days later, the foot of the wall had dried. Holding the leaning section steady with ropes, Pappu reset two courses of brick beneath it. A small drainage opening was also left so that rainwater would not remain trapped at the base.

Kalavati put her water pots back in their old place. Watching the three bamboo props being removed, Saraswati Devi said, "Has the optical illusion been cured?"

Maheshwar Kaka replied, "The precautions have been reduced."

"And the prestige?"

Kaka ran a hand over the wall. "That has been given fresh mortar."

The next morning, beneath the strip of tin at the crossroads, Maheshwar Kaka himself added a new line: "New rule: hiding your own problem does not change the facts."

Bhola Sahu read it and asked, "And advice for the man who gives advice?"

Maheshwar Kaka handed him the charcoal. "The day you give tea away for free, you may write that line yourself."

Bhola Sahu immediately returned the charcoal. "Reform on such a large scale is not healthy all in one day."

At noon Ramkripal came again. This time his question was not about the cowshed post but the ridge around his field. He began to explain.

Maheshwar Kaka did not interrupt. He listened to the whole thing. Then he repeated his three old questions: "What are the facts? What is the guess? What is the smallest useful thing that can be done right now?"

Before answering, Ramkripal laughed and asked, "Kaka, were these rules tested on the wall?"

Maheshwar Kaka looked toward his house. The upper part of the wall was still old—some bricks crooked, some of the lime flaking away—but the base was dry, and where the three bamboo props had stood there was now an open courtyard.

He said, "Yes. Advice used to be made on the bench. Now, once in a while, it goes home and sits an examination too."

Election Tea

From the second day after the election was announced, the busiest place at Haripur crossroads was no longer the panchayat building but Kailash Sahu's tea stall.

Calling it a stall hardly did it justice. Four bamboo posts, a tin roof, three benches in front, a coal stove inside, two brass kettles, and an old wooden drawer—that was the whole of Kailash's kingdom. Yet during election season those three benches hosted so much discussion that people said, "The polling station will open later; the decisions are made here first."

Kailash would smile at that. He counted cups, not decisions.

Inside the drawer lay his principal election document—a blue-bound credit ledger. On its first page he had written: "Drink tea, have your name entered, and do not forget the date."

Before the election, most entries in the ledger were individual names: a schoolteacher for three cups, a cart driver for five, a farmer for seven. The moment the election was announced, party groups began appearing beside the names.

On the first evening, ten supporters of Rameshwar Jha arrived. "Kailash, ten teas. Quickly."

Kailash set out ten cups. Before he could ask for payment, the leader of the group said, "We'll settle after the election. We're your own people."

Kailash opened the ledger. "And what name shall I write for my own people?"

"Rameshwar Babu's group."

He wrote: "Rameshwar group—ten cups."

The next morning, twelve supporters of Sunaina Devi arrived. They were tired from a meeting that had gone on late into the night. As one of them drank his tea, he asked, "Were those people sitting here yesterday?"

Kailash said, "They were."

"Are you on their side?"

"I'm on the side of their ten cups."

Everyone laughed. Kailash entered twelve cups under the name "Sunaina group."

At noon, Naseem Ansari's people arrived. They had already heard that Kailash had served tea to both the other camps.

Naseem's younger brother Javed asked, "How much respect do our people get?"

Lifting the kettle, Kailash said, "As many cups as you drink, that much respect will be entered in the ledger."

From that day onward, Kailash's reputation rose in a curious fashion. Rameshwar's people said, "Kailash has always been one of ours." Sunaina's people said, "He gives everyone tea, but he smiles more in our direction." Naseem's people said, "Look at the veranda of his shop—when our people sit there, he wipes the bench himself."

The truth was that Kailash wiped the benches after every group, because tea got spilled.

Within a week, three pages of the credit ledger were full. Every evening Kailash added up the totals. By the end of the first week: Rameshwar group—one hundred and thirty-two cups. Sunaina group—one hundred and eighteen. Naseem group—one hundred and twenty-nine. Independent candidate Harinandan's circle of friends—eighty-six.

Kailash showed the account to his wife, Malati.

Malati asked, "And the money?"

Under all four totals, Kailash wrote the same word: "Outstanding."

Malati said, "Is your shop contesting the election, or distributing charity?"

Kailash grew serious. "Business has increased."

"Where is the money?"

"In the ledger."

Malati shut the ledger. "Boil the ledger and make tea with it."

The next day Kailash made a new rule. If a group ordered more than ten cups, the name of one responsible person had to be entered.

When Rameshwar's group arrived, he asked, "Who is responsible today?"

Everyone looked at everyone else. At last Shambhu said, "Write the name Shambhu Yadav."

When Sunaina's group came, Nirmala Devi gave her name. Javed gave his for Naseem's group. Harinandan's friends decided that the responsible person would change every day, so that the whole burden would not fall on any one of them.

Kailash said, "The burden is the cups of tea; changing the name does not change the total."

One day Harinandan himself came by. Drinking his tea, he asked, "Kailash, tell me honestly—where does your heart lie?"

Kailash placed a hand on his chest. "Here."

Harinandan laughed. "I mean your vote."

"That is a matter behind the curtain. The matter outside the curtain is that your group still owes for one hundred and seven cups."

Harinandan's laughter stopped for half a moment, then returned twice as loudly. "You really are an impartial officer."

After that remark, a rumour spread that Kailash was impartial. By evening came another rumour: his impartiality was only for show, and inwardly he supported a certain candidate. By night came a third: Kailash was taking money from every party.

When Malati heard this, she asked, "You're taking money?"

Kailash showed her the ledger. "If I were taking it, why would 'Outstanding' be written here?"

The election fever rose. Meetings filled the crossroads; groups moved from place to place; drums beat; flags and banners went up. Amid it all, Kailash's stall was one place where opponents drank tea from the same kettle, though they insisted on separate cups.

One day two young men from Rameshwar's group began tying up a campaign banner in front of the stall. Kailash stopped them.

"Not here."

"Why not? You're one of us."

"Tomorrow the others will say the same thing. If the tin roof has to carry everyone's banners, where will the rain go?"

One of the young men said, "Then nobody's?"

"Nobody's. The only sign that stays is the price board—tea four rupees, milk tea five."

At noon, Sunaina's people praised the decision. In the evening, Naseem's group said, "You did right." The next morning Rameshwar's group said, "See? It was because we told him that he made everyone remove their banners."

Adding up that day's total in the ledger, Kailash thought that politics and tea had one thing in common: both heated up quickly, but the account became clear only after things had cooled down.

Two days later Malati opened the sack of sugar and looked inside. Less than half remained. The tea leaves, too, had come down to the last tin.

"No more credit now," she said.

Kailash did not object. He hung a new sign in front of the shop: "Credit for election groups today only until evening."

Rameshwar's group gave the first response. "You don't trust us?"

"Complete trust. Half the sugar."

Nirmala Devi of Sunaina's group paid five hundred rupees. "Put this toward today's and some of the old amount."

Naseem's Javed cleared two days' account. Four of Harinandan's friends pooled their money and paid half the outstanding amount.

Kailash's new rule had an unexpected effect. Now, before ordering tea, each group would first ask among itself, "Who has money today?" For five minutes the discussion would leave politics and turn to purses, pockets, and accounts.

One evening two rival groups arrived at the same time. There were three benches and twenty people. Voices began to rise over who would sit first.

Kailash put the kettle on the stove and said, "Whichever group has the larger old debt will stand."

Everyone fell silent.

Nirmala Devi laughed. "Then half our group will sit and half will stand."

Javed said, "Our account came down yesterday."

Kailash opened the ledger. "Shall we verify it?"

The argument dissolved into laughter. In the end, the benches were given to the older people, and everyone else drank tea standing.

On the eve of polling, the crossroads was relatively quiet. Campaigning had stopped. For the first time, Kailash totalled the entire ledger. The outstanding amount was greater than he had expected. On four separate sheets he wrote each group's amount, but no election symbol appeared at the top—only the name and the number of cups.

Malati said, "Tomorrow everyone will be busy voting. The results are the day after. When will you ask for the money?"

Kailash thought for a moment. "After the results everyone will be in a different mood. The winners will forget in their happiness. The losers will forget in their sorrow."

"Then?"

"The credit count before the vote count."

On polling morning Kailash opened the stall at the usual hour. People came and drank tea, but there was less political argument that day. Someone asked him, "Have you voted?"

Kailash said, "I have."

"For whom?"

Kailash lifted the ledger and put it away in the drawer. "This ledger is public. My vote is not."

After that answer, no one asked again.

By evening the voting was over. All four groups began returning to the stall. This time Kailash entered no credit. With every cup he set down a small earthen bowl, and coins and notes dropped into it as the tea was served.

Shambhu from Rameshwar's group asked, "Why so strict today?"

"The votes have been cast. Don't ask for votes on tea now."

From morning on result day, the crossroads was crowded. Alongside the kettles, Kailash had placed the four sheets of paper. When the first result came in, one group shouted with joy. The second fell silent. The third said they would see next time. The fourth began adding up its number of votes.

Kailash placed the ledger in front of everyone.

"I have a count of my own."

Shambhu asked, "What?"

Kailash read from the first sheet: "Rameshwar group—two hundred and thirty-six rupees outstanding."

Nirmala Devi laughed. "Forget victory and defeat. Listen to this result first."

Kailash read the second: "Sunaina group—one hundred and forty-two." The third: "Naseem group—one hundred and fifty-eight." The fourth: "Harinandan friends' circle—one hundred and twenty-one."

Such laughter rose at the crossroads that for a while it drowned out the victory slogans.

Rameshwar himself stepped forward. "Kailash, you were my supporter. Any discount?"

Kailash said, "If support earns a discount, the ballot box may give it. My ledger does not."

Sunaina Devi took the money from her bag. "Strike out my name."

Naseem Ansari said, "Half of mine now, half this evening."

Laughing, Harinandan said, "I lost the election, but I placed fourth in debt—that is an achievement."

Kailash replied at once, "There will be no certificate for this achievement."

By noon most of the outstanding money had been collected. A little remained, but the names of the responsible people were clear. Malati bought a new sack of sugar. Kailash replenished the tea leaves.

By evening the crossroads had grown quiet. The campaign banners were coming down. For the first time, only five regular customers sat on the benches.

An elderly schoolteacher asked, "Kailash, during the election you called people from every side 'our people.' Whose side were you really on?"

Kailash lifted the lid of the kettle. Steam rose.

"The side of the people who drink tea."

The teacher laughed. "And their ideas?"

"Everyone keeps his own ideas. The cups are mine."

From inside, Malati called out, "And the credit?"

Kailash added at once, "I am against credit."

Everyone burst out laughing.

A week later, beneath the old price board in front of the stall, Kailash wrote a new line: "Whether the meeting is political or family—above ten cups, name the responsible person first."

Shambhu read it and said, "Will this rule last until the next election?"

Closing the ledger, Kailash said, "An election may come after five years; credit arrives by evening. I understand nearby accounts better than distant politics."

From that day onward, no one in Haripur could say for certain whom Kailash had voted for. But everyone knew one thing for certain: while drinking his tea, it was important to give one's name correctly.

Uncle with the Microphone

The day Bhelahi Primary School completed fifty years, the village prepared as though it were not merely the school but the whole village celebrating its birthday.

Between the two mango trees in the courtyard, a bamboo platform was built. A sheet was stretched over it to make a small stage. Mats were spread in front for the children, chairs were set behind them for the elderly, and a table for tea and puffed rice stood to one side.

The headmistress, Nirmala Devi, was most anxious about the sound system. The previous year it had failed halfway through the programme, and the names of the prize-winners could not be heard. This time she had brought a battery-powered set from town.

The set came with a wire, two loudspeaker horns, and a handheld microphone. The iron stand meant to hold the microphone, however, was bent in the middle.

“Someone will have to hold this,” said the young man who had brought the equipment.

Just then, near the school gate, Bhuwaneshwar Kaka was looking for a pump to put air into his bicycle tyre. His house stood two doors away from the school. He was sixty-two; sometimes he farmed, sometimes he repaired bicycles; and by temperament, wherever four people gathered, he became the fifth and stood among them.

Nirmala Devi said, “Kaka, could you hold this for five minutes?”

Bhuwaneshwar Kaka took the microphone in his hand. The young man connected the wire and said, “Test it—one, two.”

Kaka brought it to his mouth and said, “One, two.”

His voice travelled from the loudspeakers across the school courtyard all the way to the steps of the pond.

Bhuwaneshwar Kaka started at the sound of his own voice. Then he smiled.

“Three, four,” he added.

The young man laughed. “That is enough.”

But from that moment onward, the word enough became a very small word for Kaka.

The first item was the children's prayer. Nirmala Devi came onto the stage and held out her hand to take the microphone for the introduction. Kaka could have handed it over, but first he said, "And now we shall hear the sweet collective voices of the children of our school, expressing education, discipline, punctuality, and—"

Nirmala Devi said softly, "Kaka, just say the name."

Kaka said at once, "Yes, in brief—the prayer."

The children sitting on the mats burst out laughing.

After the prayer, a student was to recite a poem. Kaka asked her name.

"Mamata."

"Father's name?"

"Why?"

"The introduction ought to be complete."

From a distance, Nirmala Devi waved her hand. "Only the name."

Kaka announced, "Now Mamata will recite a poem."

Mamata climbed onto the stage. Kaka stood in front of her holding the microphone. When the poem ended, he brought it back to his mouth. "Very beautiful. Especially the third line—"

Mamata whispered, "Kaka, I recited five lines."

"Then all five were beautiful."

Laughter rose again.

By ten o'clock, the village had given him a new name—"Microphone Kaka."

People who had once called him Bhuwaneshwar now shouted to him from a distance, "Microphone Kaka, say my name once too."

Kaka did not merely say people's names. He made announcements.

"A pair of slippers with red borders has been found to the left of the stage."

"Rambabu's calf has gone into the field behind the school; the owner is requested to take note."

"The tea is hot at present; after five minutes, do not blame the tea seller."

With every announcement, his voice grew more solemn.

Harimohan, a former student of the school, had come with his two children. He approached Kaka and said, "I have come from the city. Introduce me."

Kaka asked, "What do you do?"

"I work in an insurance office."

Kaka raised the microphone to his mouth. "Harimohan Babu, a former student of Bhelahi School, has graciously come from a distant city. He now safeguards people's future in the field of insurance."

Harimohan's wife said quietly, "The tap at home has been leaking for three months. Let him safeguard the present first."

The microphone was so close that this sentence too went out through the loudspeakers and spread across the whole courtyard.

Everyone laughed. Harimohan was embarrassed at first, then laughed himself.

Kaka said, "That domestic notice was not part of the programme."

Nirmala Devi sat down holding her head.

By midday, the sound system's battery indicator had fallen below half. The young man who had brought the equipment grew worried.

"Madam, at this rate the battery will not last until evening."

Nirmala Devi immediately went to Kaka. "From now on, keep the announcements short. Very short."

Kaka asked, "How short?"

"Twelve words."

Kaka became serious. "A dignified introduction is difficult in twelve words."

"Then eight."

Kaka understood that the bargaining was moving in the wrong direction. He agreed to twelve.

Nirmala Devi now placed a sheet of paper in front of him. Across the top she had written: "One announcement = maximum 12 words."

Kaka made his first attempt: "Now former student Rekha Devi will share her experiences with everyone."

Nirmala Devi counted the words. "Ten. Fine."

Kaka was pleased.

Then came the second announcement: "Someone has lost a blue bag."

Kaka began, "A beautiful blue cloth bag, possibly containing useful belongings—"

Nirmala Devi put a finger on the paper.

Kaka stopped. "Blue bag found. Owner, come to the stage."

Eight words.

Gradually, Kaka began practising how to fit an entire world inside twelve words.

But the problem was not words. It was opportunity.

Once people understood that Kaka was making announcements, everyone began bringing him some small task of their own.

"Kaka, say that Ramdulari's son must not go near the pond."

"Kaka, if anyone has taken my tin box, tell them to return it."

"Kaka, announce that the meal queue will form from the left."

"Kaka, say that the teachers should not eat first."

At this last request, all the teachers protested.

Kaka immediately announced, "The meal queue will follow the same rule for everyone."

Nirmala Devi asked, "Is that within twelve words?"

"Nine."

Kaka had begun speaking with a word-count in his head.

The main programme was after lunch—a meeting with former pupils, prizes for three children, and finally a children's play. The children had been rehearsing the play for two months.

The battery indicator was now close to the red mark.

The young man warned again, "If there is too much talking, there will be no sound left for the play."

For the first time, Kaka looked at the microphone as though it were not an instrument for speaking but oil that had to be spent drop by measured drop.

He asked Nirmala Devi, "How much is left?"

"Hard to tell. But not much."

Kaka lowered the microphone.

He introduced the next student without the sound system. Those seated in front heard him; those at the back craned their necks.

Kaka switched the system on again. "Prize: Rekha Kumari, Class Five."

That was all.

Rekha came onto the stage. There was applause.

The second: "Prize: Mohan Paswan, Class Four."

The third: "Prize: Shabnam Khatoon, Class Five."

Kaka had reduced even his twelve-word rule to three or four words.

There was less joking now, but the work moved faster.

Then a new problem arose. An old woman came along the road behind the school. She carried an old cloth bag and was looking for someone.

Kaka saw her. "Whom are you looking for?"

"My grandson Sonu. I told him to come to me after the prizes. I have brought his medicine."

No one knew where Sonu was. Children were moving about behind the stage, near the mango tree, around the meal queue, and among the costumes for the play.

Kaka lifted the microphone, but the battery's red light was blinking.

Nirmala Devi said, "Make one announcement."

This time Kaka did not arrange his words for effect.

"Sonu, your grandmother is by the stage with your medicine."

Nine words.

The announcement carried across the whole field. Two minutes later, Sonu came running.

His grandmother caught him by the ear and made him sit beside her.

Kaka lowered the microphone. He understood that the pleasure of a public voice did not lie in everyone hearing him; its real purpose was that the right thing should reach the person who needed to hear it, at the right time.

Toward evening, the children's play began. The first scene went smoothly. Halfway through the second, the sound system gave a long "hummm" and fell silent. The battery was dead.

The children froze. From the back, someone in the audience shouted, "We can't hear!"

Nirmala Devi panicked. The young man checked the wires, then the battery. "Nothing can be done immediately."

Everyone looked at Microphone Kaka.

Kaka stood holding the dead microphone. For a moment, the old expression of a public speaker returned to his face. Then he put the microphone down on the table.

"Move the chairs ten handspans forward," he said in his ordinary voice.

A few young men moved the chairs forward. Those standing at the back came closer to the platform. The children sat in a circle on the mats.

Kaka went over to the children in the play. "Don't shout. Speak clearly. Don't talk over one another."

The play began again.

The surprising thing was that after ten minutes everyone had fallen quiet. The voices were softer, but there was no crackle from a loudspeaker. The children spoke every word distinctly. People leaned forward to listen.

In the middle of the play, one child forgot a line. Had the sound system been working, the silence might have seemed enormous. Without it, the child whispered to the one behind, asked for the line, and the story moved on. The audience smiled.

When the play ended, the applause sounded louder than the loudspeakers ever had.

Bhuwaneshwar Kaka applauded too.

Harimohan teased him, "Kaka, a closing speech now?"

Kaka picked up the microphone, then remembered it was dead.

In his ordinary voice he said, "Closing in three words: get home safely."

Harimohan counted. "Exactly three."

Everyone laughed again.

The next day, when Bhuwaneshwar Kaka reached the tea stall, people gathered around him.

"Microphone Kaka, give us a speech."

Kaka took his tea. "Who will charge the battery?"

"There is no battery here."

"Then there is no speech either."

A few days later there was a meeting at the panchayat building about drainage. The secretary said to Kaka, "You know how to make announcements. Handle the sound system."

Kaka first asked for a sheet of paper. At the top he wrote: "Whose message? How many words? Who needs to hear it?"

The secretary laughed. "So many rules?"

Kaka said, "Earlier I thought I was holding a sound system in my hand. Now I understand that this machine takes hold of people's ears. One should not seize ears for no reason."

At the meeting, Kaka announced only the names and the subjects. Four times he had an opportunity to add an opinion of his own, but all four times he made a dot on the paper and kept quiet.

After the meeting, the secretary asked, "Kaka, how did you manage to remain so quiet?"

Kaka showed him the four dots. "Those were speeches. They were spared."

The name, however, did not change in the village.

Bhuaneshwar Kaka went back to being the ordinary Kaka who pumped air into bicycles, inspected the ridges of fields, and drank tea. But whenever there was a public event, people said, "Call Microphone Kaka."

And when Kaka arrived, his first question was, "Where is the sound system?"

His second: "How much battery is left?"

His third: "Does this really need to be said?"

The moment the organisers heard that third question, they usually began shortening their papers for the first time.

A Kilo of Prestige

Madhav Sah's lentil-and-spice shop in Bhathahi market was neither the largest, nor the brightest, nor did it have the lowest prices.

Yet on the Wednesday market day, anyone who came to buy lentils, chickpeas, peas, or cumin would invariably stop once by his bamboo platform.

The reason was his balance.

The balance was old, but when empty its pointer stood exactly in the middle. Madhav Sah wiped every weight with a cloth and kept it in a box. The one-kilo yellow-metal weight was wrapped separately in cloth.

In the market, people called it "Madhav's kilo."

Whenever there was a dispute over someone's balance, the shopkeeper would say, "Come, let us check it against Madhav's kilo."

People bargained over Madhav Sah's prices, but rarely over his weights.

He liked that.

He often said, "Argue about the price, not the weight."

One Wednesday morning, his granddaughter Gauri opened the box and asked, "Grandfather, why does this one-kilo weight shine so much?"

"Because everyone's eyes are on this one."

"There are other weights too."

"There are. People will accept two five-hundred-gram weights as one kilo, but the moment there is a dispute, everyone looks for this single one."

Before Gauri could pick up the weight, her grandfather stopped her.

"Your hands are wet. Wipe them first."

Gauri laughed. "Is this a weight or a deity?"

"A weight. But in a market, whatever people place their trust in has to be cared for like a deity."

The first customer that day was Budhni Devi.

"How much for the lentils?"

"Eighty-six."

"Eighty-two."

"Eighty-five."

"Eighty-three."

"Eighty-four."

“Weigh them.”

Madhav Sah smiled. “The four-rupee war is over?”

Budhni Devi said, “Not a war. A market.”

Madhav Sah placed the one-kilo weight on one pan and lentils on the other.

The pointer balanced.

Budhni Devi took her bag, then said, “Four minutes over the price, four seconds over the weight.”

“That is prestige.”

Nathuni Sah, selling vegetables beside them, overheard.

“Not prestige—the magic of the yellow weight.”

Madhav Sah said, “If it were magic, the price would fall by itself too.”

The market burst into laughter.

By noon, the one-kilo weight had been borrowed three times.

First Nathuni Sah took it to check the balance he used for potatoes.

Then the oil seller, Maqsood, took it to compare against his own weight.

The third time, Devkinandan, who sold flattened rice, said, “A customer says my kilo is light. Lend me your weight for five minutes.”

Madhav Sah lent it every time, but told Gauri, “Write down who takes it.”

Gauri wrote three names in the ledger.

Nathuni—returned.

Maqsood—returned.

Devkinandan—returned.

“See?” Madhav Sah said. “The account is clear.”

As they packed up the shop that evening, Gauri asked, “Grandfather, if everyone trusts your weights, why do you not simply write down your prices?”

“Prices change every day.”

“The weights?”

“Weights should not change.”

The following Wednesday, that very principle was turned upside down.

Madhav Sah opened the box.

The half-kilo weight was there.

The two-hundred-gram weight was there.

The hundred, fifty, twenty, and ten were all there.

The one-kilo weight was missing.

First he turned the box over.

Then he looked behind the sacks.

Then under the platform.

Gauri said, “Against every name from last time, it says returned.”

Madhav Sah looked at the ledger.

“Then where did the weight go?”

From a distance Nathuni Sah called out, "Lost your prestige?"

"Lost the weight."

"I returned it."

"I know."

Maqsood came over too.

Devkinandan left his shop and hurried across.

Within five minutes, the news had spread through the whole market—
Madhav's kilo was missing.

Someone said, "Children were playing here yesterday."

Someone else said, "Perhaps a cat knocked it away."

Gauri asked, "Where would a cat go carrying a one-kilo weight?"

They fell silent.

An elderly man said, "Check with the blacksmith. It is metal."

Madhav Sah grew annoyed. "Do not assume theft and start naming
people."

Meanwhile, the first customer arrived.

"One kilo of chickpeas."

Madhav Sah took out two five-hundred-gram weights.

The customer asked, "Not with that old kilo?"

"It is not here today."

"Then use the two halves."

Madhav Sah weighed the chickpeas.

The customer took the bag, then asked again, "A full kilo?"

Gauri said, "Five hundred plus five hundred."

"The arithmetic is right, child, but that old weight inspired a different
kind of trust."

Madhav Sah's brow tightened.

"Why should two certified half-kilo weights inspire less trust?"

The customer laughed. "Habit."

A second customer arrived.

He too asked for a kilo of lentils.

The moment he saw the two half-kilo weights, the bargaining began.

"Take two rupees off."

"Why?"

"The one-kilo weight is not here."

"What has the weight to do with the price?"

"If it has nothing to do with it, why does your face look so serious?"

Madhav Sah was still thinking of an answer when the customer walked
toward the neighbouring shop.

Nathuni Sah roared with laughter.

"See, Madhav! The weight is missing, and now the price is light too."

Madhav Sah said, "Shall I weigh your potatoes or your jokes?"

"Both are heavy."

By noon, the situation had become peculiar.

People who had earlier bargained with Madhav Sah only over price now began adding the question of weight as well.

"On two kilos, add a handful extra."

"Two half-kilo weights can introduce an error."

"Show me the pointer once more."

Each time Madhav Sah tried to remain calm, but his ears grew redder and redder.

Gauri said softly, "Grandfather, it really does seem as if it is not the weight but the prestige that has gone missing."

"Prestige does not live in a box."

"But people are looking for it in the box."

Madhav Sah said nothing to that.

In the afternoon, Chandreshwar, secretary of the market committee, arrived.

He was carrying a paper envelope.

"Madhavji, do not worry."

Madhav Sah immediately asked, "Do you have the weight?"

Chandreshwar stopped short.

"Yes."

The entire market turned toward him at once.

Madhav Sah's voice dropped.

"You took it without telling me?"

Chandreshwar said, "Yesterday evening, while you were packing up, I said we needed one reliable one-kilo weight from the market for the weights-and-measures inspection camp. You were talking to Nathuni. You said, 'Take it.'"

Madhav Sah put a hand to his head.

Nathuni Sah said at once, "I heard that. But I thought you were telling him to take an old sack."

Gauri opened the ledger. "This time no name was written down."

Madhav Sah looked at the envelope in Chandreshwar's hand.

"So it was inspected?"

"Yes."

"Is it correct?"

A smile appeared on Chandreshwar's face that immediately made Madhav Sah suspicious.

"What?"

"The weight is one kilo."

Madhav Sah breathed a sigh of relief.
 Chandreshwar added, "One kilo and twelve grams."
 For a moment the market was silent.
 Then Nathuni Sah laughed so hard that his basket of potatoes shook.
 "Madhav! Your prestige is twelve grams heavy!"
 Madhav Sah did not snatch the envelope, but he took it quickly.
 The inspection figure was written on the paper—1012 grams.
 He picked up the weight.
 On its underside, a small patch of old yellow metal could be seen.
 Chandreshwar said, "It looks as though years ago, when the bottom wore away, someone repaired it by adding metal."
 Madhav Sah turned the weight over and over in his hands.
 Then he remembered.
 Nearly twenty years earlier, one corner of the weight had broken. His father had had a market craftsman fill it in.
 No one had checked its weight again after that.
 Gauri asked, "So whenever we sold one kilo, we were actually giving twelve grams extra?"
 Chandreshwar said, "Approximately."
 Nathuni Sah began calculating.
 "On a hundred kilos, that is one kilo two hundred grams!"
 Madhav Sah stopped him. "Count your potatoes."
 Maqsood laughed. "Now I understand why people never bargained over your weight."
 "Why?"
 "The pointer balanced, but the prestige went into the bag on top."
 Everyone laughed again.
 Madhav Sah did not find it funny.
 He felt that twenty years of honesty had suddenly been turned into a twelve-gram joke.
 He asked Chandreshwar, "Where can I get a new weight?"
 "Certified weights are being sold at the inspection camp."
 Leaving Gauri in charge of the shop, Madhav Sah went there at once.
 An hour later he returned carrying a new one-kilo weight. It was made of dark metal, less shiny, with a clear official stamp.
 He did not put the old yellow weight back inside the box.
 He set it on the shelf behind the platform.
 Gauri wrote on a piece of paper: "Old weight—not for trade."
 Nathuni Sah added, "For prestige only."
 Madhav Sah glared at him.
 The next customer was Budhni Devi.

"How much for the lentils?"

"Eighty-six."

"Eighty-two."

"Eighty-five."

"Eighty-three."

"Eighty-four."

"Weigh them."

Madhav Sah put the new one-kilo weight on the balance.

Budhni Devi saw the old yellow weight on the shelf.

"Weigh with that one."

"That one is twelve grams heavy."

"Then use that one."

"In trade, only the certified weight will be used."

Budhni Devi made a face. "Earlier, for eighty-four, I got one kilo and twelve grams. Now for eighty-four, I get one kilo. Then take two rupees off."

Madhav Sah was speechless.

From behind, Nathuni Sah said, "That is what is called metrology."

Laughter rose around the entire platform.

Madhav Sah said, "The price is for the lentils, not for an old mistake."

Budhni Devi replied, "And my bargaining is over the lentils too."

In the end, the deal stayed at eighty-four; the price did not fall.

But as Budhni Devi took her bag, she said, "The weight has become correct, and the bargaining has become difficult."

From that day, a new game began in the market.

Some people asked Madhav Sah, "How much will you sell the old kilo for?"

He would say, "It is not for sale."

Some said, "Put it in a museum."

Gauri asked, "May I take it to school for Mathematics Day?"

At first Madhav Sah was going to refuse, then said, "Take it, but write clearly that it is not a trading weight."

At school, Gauri made a small display with the two weights.

One new and certified—1000 grams.

One old—1012 grams.

Above them she wrote: "How much is the thing called one kilo?"

The mathematics teacher asked the children to guess.

One said, "The old one is better. It gives you more goods."

Another said, "But the shopkeeper loses."

Another said, "Without inspection, trust is incomplete."

When Gauri came home, she repeated all the answers to her grandfather.

Madhav Sah asked only, "Did you write my name?"

“No.”

“Good.”

“But everyone understood.”

Madhav Sah nodded. “In this village, leaving out a name does not hide the name.”

Two weeks later, the market returned to normal.

People went back to bargaining over prices.

Madhav Sah once again said, “Argue about the price, not the weight.”

The only difference was that now, if someone questioned the weight, he did not become annoyed.

He would lift the new weight and say, “Look, the stamp is here.”

Sometimes he would even compare it against two five-hundred-gram weights.

And sometimes Gauri would take down the old yellow weight from the shelf and show it to the children. “This is the famous twelve grams.”

One day Nathuni Sah said, “Madhav, your prestige used to be yellow. Now it has turned black.”

Madhav Sah replied, “The colour changed, not the price.”

“The bargaining?”

“That will continue as long as you are around.”

One evening, as the market was packing up, a new customer arrived. He was from another village and knew nothing of the old story.

“Give me one kilo of chickpeas.”

Madhav Sah quoted the price.

The man immediately offered two rupees less.

The two haggled briefly.

The price was settled.

Madhav Sah placed the new dark weight on the balance.

The newcomer’s eyes went to the yellow weight on the shelf.

“Why have you displayed that weight so carefully?”

Nathuni Sah had opened his mouth to answer, but Madhav Sah spoke first. “That is a kilo of prestige.”

The newcomer looked startled.

“One kilo?”

Gauri suppressed a laugh.

Madhav Sah said, “Its name is one kilo; its weight is one kilo and twelve grams. For years people accepted it without question.”

“And now?”

Madhav Sah pointed toward the new weight. “Now the weight is one kilo.”

The newcomer asked, “And the prestige?”

Madhav Sah handed him the bag of chickpeas.

“That is bargained over every day.”

Nathuni Sah said, “And the price?”

Madhav Sah laughed. “The chickpeas have a separate price.”

The newcomer took the bag, walked two steps, then turned back and asked, “If you had weighed it with the old weight, I would have got twelve grams extra?”

“Yes.”

“Then next time I shall bargain for two rupees less.”

As Madhav Sah packed up the platform, he said, “See, Gauri? The moment prestige lost twelve grams, bargaining gained two rupees.”

Gauri opened the ledger and wrote: “A Kilo of Prestige: weight decreased, talk increased.”

Madhav Sah looked at the ledger and, this time, did not cross out the heading.

Not a Leader Who Forgets Names, but a Teacher

After rainwater seeped into the old records room at Belahi Middle School, eighteen files had become soaked.

The papers were dried, but the ink had run in several student registers from 1990 to 1994.

In some places half a letter of a name remained, in others a father's name, and elsewhere only a roll number.

Headmaster Arun Kumar had said, "Reconstruct verified copies as far as possible. Do not fill in names by guesswork."

The task was assigned to Neelam, a newly appointed teacher.

Neelam gathered the old examination forms, fee receipts, library lending register, and prize lists in one place.

Even then, many entries would not match.

At that point someone suggested, "Call Shivnarayan Jha. He taught here in those years."

Shivnarayan Jha was eighty-five years old.

He had taught at the school for thirty-two years.

When he arrived, he carried an old cloth bag, a walking stick, and a pen tucked behind his ear.

Neelam placed the first register before him.

"Guruji, Class Seven, 1991. The name here has been half washed away."

Shivnarayan Jha narrowed his eyes at the page.

"This... Ramesh?"

The assistant sitting by the door laughed. "Ramesh runs a seed shop now. This was Mahesh."

"Mahesh?"

"Yes."

Shivnarayan Jha shook his head.

"All right. But was he the one who once hung the geography map upside down?"

The assistant laughed again. "That was Ramesh."

Neelam stopped her pen.

“Then, Guruji, we cannot rely on you for the names.”

Shivnarayan Jha said without a trace of offence, “That is precisely what I came to tell you.”

Just then Ramesh himself came to the school to deliver a sack of seed.

Hearing the conversation, he joked, “Guruji has become a leader now—he has forgotten everyone’s name.”

Shivnarayan Jha answered at once, “Not a leader, a teacher. Let the register be trusted for names; I shall give you clues.”

Neelam’s interest was stirred.

“What kind of clues?”

“The kind that help you find the paper.”

On the first blurred line, only ‘...resh Ku...’ remained.

At the end of the father’s name, ‘...dev’ could still be seen.

Neelam said, “Could it be Suresh Kumar?”

Shivnarayan Jha said, “There were two Sureshes in this class. One had tied a bamboo pen-holder to the window frame. The other carried two spare nibs on examination days.”

Neelam asked, “How will that help us find the name?”

“The father of the boy who made the pen-holder worked with bamboo. His occupation should be written on the fee receipt.”

They searched the old fee receipts.

On one receipt was written: ‘Father: Ramdev Paswan; occupation: bamboo work.’

The roll number matched the number on the washed-out line in the old register.

Neelam recorded the first match.

“Memory cue—bamboo pen-holder. Documentary match—fee receipt.”

Shivnarayan Jha said, “Work this way. What I tell you is not proof; it is a path.”

Ramesh put down the sack and sat there himself.

“Let us see how many names our Guruji gets wrong.”

On the second line the name was clear—‘Meera Devi.’

The father’s name had been washed away.

Shivnarayan Jha said, “This is the same Meera who used to bring her exercise book wrapped in a reed mat on rainy days.”

Neelam looked through an old prize list.

‘Cleanest Notebook Prize—Meera Devi, father Harinandan Mandal.’

She completed the name.

Ramesh said, “That could still be a coincidence.”

Neelam agreed. “We need another document.”

In the library register, Meera Devi's name appeared with the same father's name.

Neelam did not put a tick; she wrote, "Two sources matched."

Shivnarayan Jha laughed.

"I would not be able to get away with copying in this teacher's class either."

The third line was difficult.

The beginning of the name looked like 'Di', the end like 'sh'.

Shivnarayan Jha said at once, "Ganesh."

Ramesh said, "Guruji, it must be Dinesh."

Shivnarayan Jha looked up at the ceiling.

"The boy who never plucked mangoes, but counted the fallen ones and divided them equally?"

"Dinesh," Ramesh said. "He runs a fruit shop now."

Neelam said, "What Rameshji says is not proof either."

They opened the old examination forms.

The roll number matched—Dinesh Sah.

Neelam laughed. "Guruji, you missed the name again, but the mango clue was right."

Shivnarayan Jha twirled the pen between his fingers. "That is why I am not filling in the names."

By noon, seven lines had been restored.

The same rule was followed in every case.

First, Shivnarayan Jha gave only a memory cue.

Then Neelam searched for at least two documentary sources.

Without two sources, the name was left blank.

Ramesh, after mocking the rule for a while, began searching old files himself.

On one line only 'Ku...' remained.

Shivnarayan Jha described the student almost as if painting a picture. "Quick with answers in mathematics, but never wrote out the steps in between."

Ramesh said at once, "Kusum!"

Neelam asked, "The document?"

The prize list contained the name Kusum Jha, but no roll number.

The library register contained three Kusums.

Neelam left the line blank.

Ramesh grew impatient. "Everyone remembers that it was Kusum."

"Remembering and verifying are two different things," Neelam said.

Shivnarayan Jha said softly, "She is right."

Toward evening Kusum herself arrived at the school.

Having heard about the old records, she had brought her Class Eight certificate from home.

The roll number matched.

Only then did Neelam fill in the name.

Kusum laughed and asked, "Guruji, did you remember my name?"

Shivnarayan Jha told the truth. "No. But you never wrote the working in between."

Kusum said, "Now I keep accounts. If I leave out even one line, the owner asks about it."

Ramesh said, "Guruji's teaching took effect rather late."

The work began again the next day.

This time Shivnarayan Jha was wrong even about one of his clues.

He said, "This student did not do his homework for three days because the calf at home was ill."

Headmaster Arun Kumar smiled.

"Guruji, that was me."

Shivnarayan Jha said, "Yes, Arun."

But when the old daily register was opened, it turned out that it was Arun's younger brother Anil who had been absent for three days because of the calf.

Shivnarayan Jha fell silent.

For the first time, Ramesh made no joke.

Neelam wrote against the line: "Memory cue unverified; not used."

Shivnarayan Jha himself said, "Draw a red line through it."

Neelam drew the red line.

"Guruji, did that hurt?"

"Why should it? Memory is not a register. If an error is not caught, tomorrow it becomes a lie."

From that day, a third rule was added: "A teacher's memory may also be struck out."

Ramesh wrote the three rules on the board.

"One—no name by guesswork."

"Two—memory is only a clue for the search."

"Three—no line is complete without two independent documentary matches."

Shivnarayan Jha read them and said, "Add a fourth."

"What?"

"Even if Guruji says it, check it."

Everyone burst out laughing.

On the third day of the work, they found a curious line.

The name had vanished completely, but one remark remained: ‘School play: Gatekeeper.’

Shivnarayan Jha looked straight at Ramesh.

“This is you.”

Ramesh was startled. “You forgot the name, but remembered the gatekeeper?”

“The king had four pages of dialogue. You chose the gatekeeper’s role with two lines.”

“And?”

“You forgot one of the two lines.”

Ramesh folded his hands. “It would be better if no documentary proof of that survived.”

Neelam searched for the old expense sheet for the play.

It contained the names of the performers.

‘Gatekeeper—Ramesh Yadav.’

The second source was the annual report, which also listed the cast of the play.

The name matched.

Neelam filled in the line.

Ramesh said, “Now I understand. Guruji does not recognise me by my name, but by my laziness.”

Shivnarayan Jha corrected him. “Not laziness—a talent for the shortest route.”

By the fourth day, eighteen of the twenty-two blurred lines had been verified.

Four lines remained blank.

The headmaster asked, “Guruji, does anything come back to you?”

Shivnarayan Jha studied all four lines.

“There are a few hazy memories, but I cannot see a path to any document.”

“Then?”

“Leave them blank.”

The headmaster said, “The copy will remain incomplete.”

Neelam replied, “An incomplete true copy is better than a completed lie.”

Shivnarayan Jha smiled.

Under the fourth rule on the board, Ramesh wrote a fifth: “A blank space is also information.”

When the work was finished, Neelam added a note at the end of the new copy.

“In reconstructing illegible entries, oral memory was used only as a search cue; final names are based on independent archival corroboration.”

Ramesh read it and said, "Will Guruji understand that sentence?"

Shivnarayan Jha replied, "I do not need to understand it. The person who opens the register next time should."

Neelam also made a separate little notebook.

On the cover she wrote: "Memory Cues: Not Evidence."

In that notebook they recorded such clues as the bamboo pen-holder, two spare nibs, the reed mat, fallen mangoes, omitted workings, and the gatekeeper's two lines.

In red ink they also recorded the mistake involving Anil and Arun.

Shivnarayan Jha looked at that red line.

"Why keep this?"

Neelam said, "So that the next person understands that your memory was useful, not infallible."

"You did well."

Ramesh asked, "Guruji, do you remember Neelamji's name now?"

Shivnarayan Jha looked at Neelam.

He remained silent for a few moments.

"The name... Neelam."

Neelam clapped.

Shivnarayan Jha immediately added, "But I may forget the name again."

"Then how will you remember me?"

"The two-witness teacher."

Everyone roared with laughter.

Ramesh said, "The title still has to be the same—Not a Leader Who Forgets Names, but a Teacher."

Shivnarayan Jha asked, "Why 'leader' again?"

Ramesh said, "The joke from the first day."

Shivnarayan Jha scratched his head.

"I have forgotten that joke."

Neelam opened the little notebook and showed him the first page.

It read: "First day: Guruji got five names wrong; he himself said—let the register be trusted for names, I shall give the clues."

Shivnarayan Jha read it and laughed.

"See? That is the virtue of the written word—it remembers better than I do."

As he was leaving, Ramesh called from behind, "Guruji, who am I?"

Without turning around, Shivnarayan Jha replied, "The gatekeeper. You forgot one of your two lines."

Ramesh said, "My name?"

Shivnarayan Jha stopped.

"That is why we made the register."

The Donation Expert

The roof of Belahi village's old reading room had been leaking for three years.

In the first year, a single drop fell from one corner.

In the second year, buckets had to be placed in five different spots.

By the third year, even after shifting the books, there were not enough buckets.

A village meeting was called.

The mukhiya said, "This time there is no remedy except replacing the tin sheets."

Master Shashikant opened the ledger.

"Let us form a committee to collect donations."

The moment they heard this, everyone seated on the veranda lowered their eyes.

Anyone who dared look up feared that his name would be written down.

Master asked, "Who will be the head?"

No one answered.

From the back, Ramauti Kaki said, "Make Gangaram Sah the head."

Every neck turned towards Gangaram at once.

Gangaram Sah was sitting at the corner of the wooden cot, cutting betel nut.

He started.

"Me?"

The veranda erupted in laughter.

Everyone knew why.

In the village, Gangaram Sah was famous—or rather notorious—for never contributing to any collection.

The school was whitewashed—zero.

Steps were built at the ghat—zero.

New cymbals were bought for the kirtan—zero.

A collection was raised to buy a community canopy for weddings—zero there too.

But when it came to getting money out of other people, no one was his equal.

Gangaram shut his betel-nut box.

"I am telling you beforehand—I shall not donate."

The mukhiya said, "That is precisely why we are making you the head."

Another burst of laughter.

Gangaram's face tightened.

"What sort of arithmetic is that?"

Ramauti Kaki said, "A man who guards his own pocket so well will guard the community's pocket well too."

Gangaram thought for a few moments.

"Very well. But there will be three rules."

Everyone fell silent.

"First—whoever makes a pledge will have it entered in the ledger."

"Second—cash, bamboo, tin sheets, nails and labour will all be accounted for separately."

"Third—my name will be at the very top."

Master smiled.

"How much shall I write?"

Gangaram said, "Zero."

This time the laughter rose so loudly that the broken tin sheets on the reading room trembled.

The next morning, Gangaram set out carrying a new ledger divided into four columns.

Name.

Pledged.

Received.

Outstanding.

On the first line was written: "Gangaram Sah—o."

Master's grandson Neeraj went with him.

Neeraj had been given the job of writing down the figures.

The first house belonged to Anant Chaudhary.

Eight sacks of paddy were stacked in Anant's courtyard.

Gangaram said, "The reading room roof is being replaced."

Anant said, "A very good undertaking."

"So, how much?"

"Look, expenses are very heavy this month."

Gangaram opened the ledger.

"If not money, then materials."

"Materials?"

"You have twelve bamboos lying in your storehouse. Will you give two?"

Anant was startled.

"How did you know there were twelve?"

"Yesterday I saw your bullock cart going out. Counting bamboo is the work of the eyes, not the pocket."

Anant laughed.

"Write three, not two."

Neeraj wrote three.

Gangaram immediately said, "Leave the Received column blank. It gets a tick only when the bamboo reaches the reading room."

Anant said, "You do not trust even me?"

"I have not put a tick even against my own zero."

The second house belonged to Chedi the blacksmith.

Chedi said, "I have no money."

Gangaram said, "I never asked for money."

"Then?"

"Nails."

"How many?"

"As many as the roofing mason writes down."

Chedi shook his head.

"This sounds less like a donation and more like a contract."

"If it were a contract, I would have received my wages first."

Neeraj burst out laughing.

The third house belonged to Sita Devi.

Sita was a widow.

She came out with twenty rupees and said, "This is all I have."

Gangaram did not take the money.

"You sweep the reading-room veranda every day. Keep these twenty rupees."

Sita became angry.

"Have you come to ask for donations or to stop them?"

Gangaram was taken aback.

Sita placed the money on the ledger.

"What I wish to give is not for you to decide."

Gangaram silently wrote down twenty.

As soon as they stepped outside, Neeraj asked, "Did the rules change?"

Gangaram said, "The rules need a fifth column—for people one must not argue with."

By noon, the ledger had filled up with more materials than money.

Three bamboos.

Two days of carpentry.

One cartload of sand.

A pledge of nails.

Four labourers to remove the old tin sheets.

Fourteen hundred rupees.

One sack of cement—whose purpose no one later understood.

Gangaram put a question mark beside that entry.

In the evening, the committee met.

The mukhiya asked, “What is the total?”

Gangaram said, “That is the wrong question.”

“Why?”

“What number do you get by adding three bamboos to fourteen hundred rupees?”

Master laughed.

“Then how much is still needed?”

“First we need the mason’s list.”

The mason came the next day.

He counted the tin sheets.

He measured the bamboo.

He listed the nails.

He counted the days of labour.

Gangaram pasted the list into the ledger.

Then the real game began.

Those who had tin sheets were asked for tin.

Those who had bullock carts were asked for transport.

Those who had money were asked for money.

Those who had nothing were asked for one three-hour shift of labour.

But Gangaram’s own entry still remained—zero.

On the third day, Chhotelal Sah said, “You give your share first. Then I shall give mine.”

Gangaram opened the ledger and showed him the first line.

“My share is public knowledge.”

“Zero?”

“Yes.”

“Aren’t you ashamed?”

“There is no separate column for shame.”

The people standing nearby laughed.

Chhotelal laughed too.

“All right, write five hundred.”

Gangaram said, “Five hundred goes under Pledged. It goes under Received only when the money reaches my hand.”

Chhotelal took out five hundred rupees and handed it over.

“Now?”

“Now both columns are filled.”

In four days, the ledger had grown thick.

But along with donations, complaints accumulated too.
Someone said, "Gangaram asked more from me than from others."
Someone said, "He valued my bamboo too low."
Someone said, "I sent two labourers, but the ledger shows only one day."
On Sunday, Gangaram opened the ledger on the reading-room veranda for anyone who wished to complain.

"Anyone with an objection may mark it in red pencil."

Ten marks appeared.

Seven were beside entries where people had forgotten their own pledges.

Two were genuinely Gangaram's mistakes.

One mark had been placed by Neeraj beside Gangaram's own zero.

Gangaram asked, "Why this?"

Neeraj said, "This is the biggest objection of all."

The veranda once again filled with laughter.

The work began.

The old tin sheets were removed.

Two of the bamboos proved usable; the third was hollow inside.

Gangaram wrote two beside the three in the ledger and struck out one.

Anant Chaudhary said, "I shall send a fourth bamboo."

"I shall write it down when it arrives."

"Your trust still has not increased?"

"My trust has increased. The rules of the ledger have not changed."

Clouds gathered in the afternoon.

The mason said, "If the tin is not laid by this evening, the books inside will get wet again."

They calculated what remained.

Eight tin sheets were short.

They were also short of twelve hundred rupees.

Everyone's eyes turned to Gangaram again.

Chhotelal Sah said, "This time, turn that zero into something."

Gangaram put a hand on his pocket.

"The zero will remain zero."

"Then what about the roof?"

Gangaram closed the ledger.

"The job of the head of a donation drive is not to give the money himself, but to raise what is still needed."

He took Neeraj with him and set off for the market.

At the warehouse of Ganesh, the tin-sheet dealer, he asked the price of eight sheets.

He heard the price and shook his head.

"Don't you have a couple of sheets that are not quite good?"

Ganesh was surprised.

“Which ones?”

“The ones with dented corners. They cannot go in the middle of the roof, but they will do along the edge.”

Ganesh said, “Those are not fit for sale.”

“I am not asking for a donation. Sell them to me for less.”

They bargained for half an hour.

In the end, he got six sheets at full price and two dented ones at half price.

Even then, they were three hundred rupees short.

Gangaram said, “Could your cart take them there?”

Ganesh laughed.

“Is this a donation drive or a business deal?”

“When you cannot get a donation from someone, save the freight instead.”

Ganesh agreed to provide the cart.

When they reached the village, Neeraj opened the ledger.

“Ganesh Sah—donation?”

Gangaram said, “Zero.”

“Cart?”

“Transport—free of charge. Write it separately.”

Neeraj looked at Gangaram.

“And all your running around?”

“That is no one’s donation.”

“Then what is it?”

“My misfortune.”

By evening, the roof was in place.

When the first drops of rain fell, they pattered on the new tin.

No bucket had to be placed inside.

The books remained dry.

On Sunday, the accounts were read aloud.

Total cash.

Total materials.

Total labour-days.

Total transport.

Cancelled pledges.

Price reductions.

Balance—zero.

Master Shashikant said, “One thing has been left out.”

“What?”

“Gangaram Sah’s contribution.”

Everyone applauded.

Gangaram raised his hand and stopped them.

“Read the ledger.”

Neeraj read the first line: “Gangaram Sah—o.”

More laughter.

The mukhiya said, “Remove that zero.”

Gangaram said, “Why?”

“You have been running about for so many days.”

“I did, because all of you made me the head. A donation is a different matter.”

Ramauti Kaki said, “Then let that zero remain.”

Gangaram closed the ledger.

“Let it remain. When people see it, they will understand that one need not first be a great philanthropist in order to raise donations.”

Neeraj said softly, “But does one have to be a miser?”

Everyone roared with laughter.

Gangaram laughed too.

Two weeks later, a crack appeared in the masonry platform around the village’s old well.

Another meeting was called.

Master brought a new ledger.

Gangaram was sitting on a cot at some distance.

He said at once, “This time, leave my name out.”

Neeraj opened the ledger.

On the first line he wrote: “Gangaram Sah—o.”

Gangaram clutched his head.

The veranda erupted in laughter once again.

The Free Photograph

Belahi Panchayat had announced that a 'Family Gathering' would be held on Sunday in the grounds of the old middle school. The programme would include folk songs, games for children, health check-ups, an exhibition of old photographs, and one free family photograph for every family.

Of all the words in that announcement, the one I heard most clearly was —'free.'

Nirmala said, "Your ears are less alert to talk of social service than to anything free."

I protested, "I am going to take part in a community programme. The photograph is only a small part of it."

My daughter Gauri promptly asked, "Then why did you take out your new kurta?"

My son Naval added, "And why have you been trimming your beard since yesterday?"

In a family, children usually assume responsibility for telling the truth; the adults are left with the task of explaining it.

We had no proper photograph of the whole family together. In our old wedding photograph, Nirmala and I were there, but Gauri and Naval had not yet entered the world. The children had separate school photographs. Once, all four of us had been photographed together, but Naval's eyes were closed that day and half my head lay outside the frame. Nirmala had put that photograph at the back of the cupboard.

For that reason, on Sunday we were ready much earlier than usual.

Nirmala wore a pale yellow sari. Gauri undid her braid twice and tied it again. Naval put on his new shoes and got dust on them within five minutes. I checked the buttons of my kurta three times.

"All this only for social service?" Nirmala asked.

"There is no crime in looking neat while doing social service," I said.

When we reached the school grounds, there were still twenty minutes to nine. I thought that by arriving early we would get the first place in the photograph queue.

The organizers were still stretching ropes across the ground. On one side old photographs were being hung up; on the other, medicine boxes were

being arranged on the health-check table. In the middle, a green cloth had been hung to make a photography stage. Above it, paper letters read: 'My Family, My Village.'

The photographer had arrived, but his assistant had gone to fetch fuel for the generator. The young man who was supposed to distribute the numbered slips was nowhere to be seen.

The moment the programme coordinator, Shambhunath, saw me, he said, "Gajendra Babu, sit at this table for five minutes. As people arrive, write down each family's name and give them a numbered slip. Just five minutes."

I wanted to say that I myself had come so early precisely in order to stand first in the queue. But Nirmala looked at me with an expression in which the entire account of the word 'social service' was written out.

I sat down on the chair.

On the table lay a register, two pencils, slips cut and numbered from 1 to 100, and a small red cord. The rule was simple—write down the family's name, give one slip to the family, and enter the same number in the register. The slip had to be held while the photograph was taken; later, the printed photograph would be matched by that number.

I entered my own family's name first.

Number 1.

I was pleased. Social service and practical intelligence could proceed side by side—I had become living proof of the fact.

Then the first unfamiliar family arrived.

"Name?" I asked.

"Ramnath Jha."

I wrote it down. At that very moment a voice came from behind: "I am Ramnath Jha too."

A second family stepped forward.

I realized that making a register was a more difficult science than the human imagination allowed for.

Gauri immediately said, "Baba, write the hamlet too."

Thus 'Ramnath Jha, East Hamlet' and 'Ramnath Jha, Beyond the Pond' became two distinct entries.

Naval was put in charge of handing out the slips. He gave each family its slip with such gravity that one might have thought he was distributing land deeds issued by the panchayat.

Nirmala opened the next page of the register and began writing the names clearly. Looking at the two names I had written, she said, "With handwriting like yours, the photographer will have to match people by destiny, not by their faces."

"That was only preliminary handwriting," I replied.

Five minutes passed.
Shambhunath did not return.
Ten minutes passed.
The queue reached all the way to the school veranda.
At number 17, an elderly woman came and stood before us alone.
I asked, "Family name?"
She said, "Write my own name—Janaki Devi."
I paused for a moment. At the top of the register was written 'Family.'
Janaki Devi understood my hesitation.
"Is one person not a family?" she asked.
Without even looking at me, Nirmala wrote: 'Janaki Devi, Back Hamlet.'
I handed her number 17.
Janaki Devi folded the slip and tied it into the knot of her sari's end.
At number 23 came a joint family of thirteen people. The head of the family wanted four separate photographs—one with one son, one with the other son, one with the grandchildren, and one with everyone together.
I read the rule aloud—one family, one free photograph.
He said, "We are four families."
From behind him, his wife said, "When household expenses are being paid, we are only one family."
Laughter rose from the queue. The head of the family himself gave a sheepish smile.
Gauri said, "Have one taken with everyone together. If thirteen people fit into a single frame, that will be the photograph's real miracle."
The photographer, hearing this from a distance, said, "And a test of my equipment as well."
Meanwhile, one corner of the green backdrop came loose. The wind had strengthened. Naval ran and caught the rope. I began to rise from the table, but Nirmala said, "Don't get up; the names will get mixed up."
Naval held the cloth for five minutes. Then the assistant returned with the fuel and tied the rope again.
The generator started. The photographer's flash fired.
Number 1 was announced.
That was our family.
I prepared to get up.
Just then, three families reached the table at once for their slips, and a child dropped his slip in the mud.
Nirmala said, "Set this right first. Our photograph can be taken at number two."
I agreed. After all, a difference of one number could not alter our faces.
Number 1 was skipped and number 2 was called.

Then numbers 3, 4, and 5.

I kept writing names.

By ten o'clock the grounds were full. The health check-up had begun, rehearsals for the folk songs had started, and the children were busy with the running competition. At my table, not only slips but questions too began to pile up.

"My sister's family couldn't come. Can you keep a slip aside for them?"

"My son-in-law will be here in half an hour. Can the photography be stopped until then?"

"If a child is crying, does a crying photograph count?"

"Should I wear my spectacles for the photograph or take them off?"

I answered three of the questions and sent the fourth to the photographer. Thus I learned the first rule of becoming an expert—when you do not know something, put the answer on someone else's head.

By noon we had reached number 64.

Then clouds gathered overhead.

Shambhunath came running and said, "It's going to rain. Take the register and the slips inside."

The photography stage was shifted to the school veranda. The green cloth was taken down and hung on an inside wall. Table, chairs, register, slips—everything went indoors.

In the rush, the photographer's assistant put eight envelopes containing the printed photographs from numbers 41 to 48 in the wrong order.

Gauri looked at the numbers written on the backs of the envelopes and arranged them again one by one.

"Your social service has now become a family business," Nirmala said to me.

I replied, "Family participation is essential in organization."

"And the photograph?"

"There is time."

The rain began. Water drummed so loudly on the school's tin roof that the voices calling out names were drowned. The photographer said the little printing machine would not work properly in the damp. He would keep taking photographs, but the printed copies could not be handed out until evening.

Shambhunath looked at the register in my hands.

I did not like that look.

"Do one thing," he said. "The photographs will be printed in town tomorrow. The numbered register is with you. You take care of the distribution."

"Me?"

“You have come to know all the families.”

This was entirely untrue. I knew the names, not the families. But when someone has spent the whole day sitting at a table, society gradually begins to assume that he understands everything.

Nirmala said, “Take it. After doing so much, there is no point leaving the work half-finished now.”

I picked up the register.

By evening, 82 families had been photographed. After the last family left, the grounds began to empty.

All at once, a question rose in my mind.

“What about our number 1?”

Gauri looked at the register.

Our family’s name was written beside number 1. The box marked ‘Photograph Taken’ was empty.

The four of us looked at one another.

The family that had spent the whole day arranging the world by the order of photographs had forgotten to have its own photograph taken.

Naval said, “Baba, the social service was a success.”

Nirmala burst out laughing.

I went over to the photographer. He was packing away his equipment.

“There is one problem,” I said.

He asked, “Did some family get left out?”

“Ours.”

He looked first at me, then at Nirmala, Gauri, and Naval.

“But all of you were more visible than anyone else the whole day.”

“Being visible and being in a photograph are two different things.”

He began looking through the images stored in the camera. After a few moments, he smiled.

“There is one.”

He showed us on the small display screen.

It was an image taken just before the rain began. The green cloth was flying loose on one side. Naval was holding the rope, Gauri was gathering the slips, Nirmala had one hand on the register to keep the papers from blowing away, and I stood gripping a corner of the table. All four of us were in the same frame, but not one of us was looking at the camera.

I said, “That is hardly a family photograph!”

Nirmala said, “Are all four of us there?”

“Yes.”

“Are we together?”

“Yes.”

“Then the rest is a problem of your prestige.”

The photographer kept that image as number 1.

At noon the next day, a large box containing 82 envelopes arrived at our house.

It was then that the true value of a free photograph became clear.

Distributing the envelopes was harder than taking the photographs.

The family at number 6 said that in their photograph everyone's eyes looked fine, but their younger son had stuck out his tongue; they wanted another copy.

I showed them the rule—one family, one copy.

Janaki Devi at number 17 opened her envelope and remained silent for a long time. Then she said, "Is this me?"

Nirmala said, "Yes."

"Do I look good alone?"

Gauri said, "Very."

Janaki Devi did not tuck the photograph into her sari; she carried it away openly in her hand.

When the photograph of the thirteen-member family at number 23 was handed over, everyone first counted to make sure all thirteen were visible. They were. The head of the family said, "One copy will not be enough."

His wife said again, "One family when expenses have to be paid, thirteen when the photograph has to be shared?"

I wrote 'Received' in the register.

By evening, 71 envelopes had been distributed. Five families were in the fields, three had gone to town, two envelopes had reached the wrong hamlet and come back, and Naval had put one envelope under his pillow and forgotten it there.

Within three days, every photograph had reached its own home.

The last envelope was ours.

Nirmala put the photograph in a frame.

I said, "My new kurta is hardly visible at all."

Gauri said, "Neither are Naval's new shoes."

Naval said, "Ma's sari is half hidden behind the register."

Straightening the frame on the wall, Nirmala said, "That is why it is good. We went there to show our clothes, and the work ended up showing instead."

Let me make one thing clear here: I did not go to the programme merely for the free photograph.

I went there for social service.

Yes, it is another matter that my name stood at number 1 in the register of social service, while we remembered to have our photograph taken only in the evening.

Not on Time, but on His Word

There is no single time in our village of Belahi. It is best to explain this to outsiders beforehand; otherwise they may insult someone by saying he has arrived late, and then imagine the fault was his.

The wall clock in Mangal Sah's shop runs ahead of all the others. Mangal Sah says, "In business, time ought to stay ahead." Ask him how far ahead his clock is, and he looks at it and says, "Far enough to keep me out of loss."

The clock at the middle school is seven minutes fast. The headmaster has deliberately kept it that way, because if a pupil is seven minutes late, the school clock still gets him there on time.

The clock at the panchayat house is five minutes slow. The mukhiya's reasoning is that panchayat decisions should never be rushed; the clock, too, ought to move after due thought.

The pocket watch Harinarayan Kaka carries belonged to his father. He says, "I shall live in the time in which Babuji left me."

I have complete faith in my own watch. I do not consider it proper for another man's clock to interfere in my private time.

With all these arrangements, the village carried on for years. Weddings took place, funerary rites were performed, the weekly market met, examinations were held. People kept arriving late and producing their own watches as evidence.

The trouble came that year in Ashadh, when the time for transplanting the rice seedlings in Phulo Devi's field was slipping away.

Phulo Devi's husband had died of illness away from home two years earlier. The household consisted of her, her mother-in-law, and her twelve-year-old son. Their one and a half bighas of land were their chief support. The seedlings were ready, but continuous rain had kept postponing the transplanting.

One day the sky cleared. The women of the village said, "Tomorrow we shall finish the transplanting." The men agreed as well.

It was decided on the veranda of the panchayat house that every household would send at least one person to give two hours of labour. The work would begin at seven in the morning.

I asked, "Seven o'clock by whose clock?"

Everyone looked at me as though I were being needlessly clever.

The mukhiya said, "Seven o'clock means seven o'clock."

I fell silent. In our village, many disputes begin with precisely such an answer.

The next morning I reached the field. My watch showed two minutes past seven.

The field was empty.

Phulo Devi was sitting on the ridge, loosening the bundles of seedlings. She said, "You are the first to arrive."

I said, "I am two minutes late."

She said nothing.

A little later Sushila Devi, the headmaster's wife, arrived. Her watch showed five minutes past seven.

Behind her came Shambhu, Mangal Sah's son. He said, "Babu told me to be here exactly at seven. Look—by my watch it is six fifty-six."

I looked at his watch. It was four minutes behind the clock in Mangal Sah's shop. There were two times in the same household.

Eight or ten people gathered. The transplanting began.

Feet sank into the mud, seedlings passed from hand to hand, and the rows slowly advanced. For the first time, some of the anxiety left Phulo Devi's face.

Then Harinarayan Kaka appeared on the ridge. Taking out his pocket watch, he said, "I have arrived at exactly seven."

My watch showed seven thirty-seven.

Mangal Sah himself arrived at seven forty-five—according to my watch. By the reckoning of his wall clock, he was on time.

By eight o'clock there were thirty people in the field.

There was no trouble until nine, because everyone's hands were busy. The trouble began when those who had arrived first decided that their two hours were complete and started to leave.

Pulling his feet out of the mud, Shambhu said, "My two hours are done."

Harinarayan Kaka looked at his pocket watch. "You have worked only an hour and a half."

Shambhu said, "By my watch, it has been two hours."

Kaka said, "Your watch runs fast."

Shambhu replied, "Your watch got left behind with Babuji."

The moment I heard that sentence, I knew the rice transplanting was about to turn into a clock-repair workshop.

Sushila Devi said, "Whoever came first may leave first. End of the matter."

Mangal Sah said, "Came first by which clock?"

The seedlings slipped from someone's hand and fell into the mud.

Within five minutes the transplanting stopped. Such an argument broke out over the accounting of two hours' labour that Phulo Devi quietly bent down and began planting a row by herself.

Trying to act as a mediator, I said, "Let everyone write down the starting and finishing time by his own watch."

The headmaster's wife asked, "Who is going to keep a sheet of paper in this mud?"

Mangal Sah said, "I shall keep it, but the times must be written by my clock."

That proposal died on the spot.

Then Phulo Devi's mother-in-law, whom everyone called Dadi, spoke from the ridge. "Are you people planting clocks or rice?"

No one answered.

Dadi said again, "Was the agreement for two hours, or for finishing the field?"

The mukhiya, who had arrived late and had only just begun working, said, "The decision was for two hours."

Dadi said, "Then if the field remains unfinished, will you eat those two hours?"

Everyone laughed, but Phulo Devi did not.

Jyoti, who was in Class Eight, was also transplanting with her mother. She washed the mud from her hands, climbed onto the ridge, and looked across the field.

She said, "Instead of dividing the hours, divide the field."

Mangal Sah asked, "How do we divide a field?"

Jyoti said, "Count the rows from one ridge to the other. Give rows to each household. Whoever finishes his rows has finished his share of the work."

I liked the idea, but I did not support it immediately. In a village, if you endorse an idea too quickly, people assume you had agreed upon it beforehand.

The headmaster's wife counted the width of the field. Phulo Devi told us how many bundles of seedlings there were.

It was settled: four rows to each household. Two rows for a household whose member was elderly or weak. Six rows if a household had sent two young adults.

Harinarayan Kaka objected. "That is not equality."

Dadi said, "Is equality to be counted by feet, or by work?"

Kaka looked at his pocket watch again, but the answer to that question was not in it.

A rope was fetched. It was stretched from one end of the field to the other, and a small knot was tied at every four rows.

Mangal Sah inspected his share. "There is more mud in my part."

Shambhu said, "Babu, you have received mud in proportion to your prestige."

Everyone laughed. Mangal Sah did too.

The transplanting began again.

Now, if anyone looked at a watch, it was only for his own satisfaction. The right to leave came when one's allotted rows were finished.

Harinarayan Kaka planted slowly. He had two rows. Shambhu had six.

After finishing his first three rows, Shambhu looked towards Kaka. Kaka was still halfway through his first.

Without saying anything, Shambhu took over Kaka's second row.

Kaka said, "I do not want your pity."

Shambhu said, "This is not pity. It is saving my sixth row from the mud."

Kaka laughed. "Your watch may run fast, but now and then your mind keeps proper time."

By noon, more than half the field was filled with green rows.

When Mangal Sah finished his four rows, more than two hours had passed by his own watch. He said nothing. He merely climbed onto the ridge and began washing his feet.

I asked, "What time is it?"

He said, "The work is finished."

I thought that answer deserved a place in history.

From time to time Phulo Devi opened another bundle of seedlings. Her twelve-year-old son carried them to the planters. Earlier, while the argument was going on, his face had fallen. Now he counted the knots and called out, "These rows belong to that household; those rows to the other one."

After noon, some people left the field to eat. Some went home after completing their share. Two households' portions remained unfinished; their people had gone to town on business.

The mukhiya said, "Leave those two households' rows. Let them come in the evening and do them."

Dadi said, "Will the seedlings wait until evening?"

Then every family saved a handful of seedlings from its completed share and began planting those eight rows. There was no new decision. No one made a proposal. Hands simply reached out of their own accord.

Before the sun went down, the entire field had been transplanted.

Phulo Devi stood on the ridge and looked at the field for a long time. She tried to say something, but her voice caught.

Dadi said to her, "One does not offer thanks at transplanting time. Next year, take up a row in someone else's field."

Phulo Devi nodded.

As we were leaving, the subject of clocks came up again. That was natural; in Belahi, no day is complete without a discussion of clocks.

Harinarayan Kaka said, "My watch says four twenty-two."

Mangal Sah said, "Mine says four thirty-seven."

The headmaster's wife said, "If the school clock were here, it would say four thirty-two."

I looked at my own watch, but this time I did not announce the time.

Shambhu asked, "What does yours say?"

I said, "My four rows are done."

The next day, the rope was being dried on the veranda of the panchayat house. Jyoti was undoing the knots.

The mukhiya said, "Write this method down as a rule: in community work, divide the work itself instead of the hours."

The headmaster said, "Not every kind of work can be divided into rows."

Jyoti said, "Then divide what can be divided. And where it cannot be divided, make the terms clear beforehand."

Mangal Sah said, "Do not write down any proposal to change the clocks."

Harinarayan Kaka said at once, "Passed unanimously."

On this one decision, there was no disagreement in the village.

A few days later, fresh green shoots rose in Phulo Devi's field. Four rows, six rows, two rows—there was no longer any sign of which part had been planted by whom. The entire field was one colour.

Standing on the ridge, Dadi said, "See? The rice does not care whose clock was right."

Mangal Sah said, "Rice knows nothing of business."

I said, "Does it understand time?"

After thinking for a moment, he replied, "It understands the season."

I liked that answer, though I did not tell him so.

The clocks in Belahi still tell different times. The school clock is fast, the panchayat clock is slow, the clock in Mangal Sah's shop hurries everyone along, and Harinarayan Kaka's pocket watch still moves in his father's time.

An outsider asks, "What is the correct time here?"

I say, "Look at your own watch."

He asks again, "Then how do all of you manage to work together?"

The answer to that question is simple now.

I say, "Not on time, but on our word."

Where Am I to Blame?

My name is Bhola Jha. In the village, people call me Bhola Babu, but do not draw the wrong conclusion from the name. Bhola is the name I was born with, not a description of my nature.

I understand accounts, I know people, and most important of all—I have complete faith in my own memory.

It was because of that confidence that, last Ashadh, responsibility for the village tree-distribution committee came to me. Whether the committee entrusted it to me or I took it upon myself is a small matter we shall come to later.

Sixty-eight saplings had arrived from the block nursery—mango, guava, lemon, neem, and drumstick. The agricultural extension worker, Jyoti Devi, had also supplied a small slip with every sapling explaining what kind of soil, sunlight, and water suited it best.

The moment I looked at the slips, I understood that the work was not difficult. After all, why should one need to study agricultural science in order to know a mango for a mango?

Jyoti Devi said, “Bhola Babu, write the full names. Put the house numbers too. The saplings are small; you cannot always identify them easily by their leaves.”

I said, “Why waste paper? I’ll make short signs.”

“What kind of signs?”

“Aa—for mango, A—for guava, Nee—for lemon, N—for neem, S—for drumstick.”

Jyoti Devi kept looking at me. Then she said, “And if Nee and N blur in the rain?”

I laughed. “Does rain wash away judgment, or only written letters?”

The headmaster praised me greatly for that sentence. Later I realised he had been laughing, not praising me. But at the time, I took it as praise.

The first job was to prepare the list of families. Every household stated its preference. Some wanted mango, some lemon, and some said they would take whatever was left.

Beside Malti Devi’s name I wrote “M,” because she wanted a mango near the manjara in her courtyard.

Jyoti Devi asked, "What variety is this M?"

I said, "Malti."

"Why is a person's name in the sapling list?"

"If there are no people, who will plant the saplings?"

Do you see any fault of mine here? I certainly do not.

The next day all the saplings were arranged in rows on the school veranda. I was tying on my little paper labels with their coded signs. A boy asked, "Bhola Kaka, is this 'A' guava or mango?"

I said, "Aa is for mango. A is for guava."

He said, "What if the extra a gets washed away?"

I put a hand on his head and said, "Pay attention to your studies. I'll worry about the rain."

Just then the wind rose. Two labels blew away. Four became tangled together. I tied them back on. Naturally, one might ask which label belonged to which sapling; but all the saplings were still right there. None of them had gone abroad.

I retied the labels from memory.

From a distance, Jyoti Devi called, "On the right saplings?"

I said, "Trust me."

That sentence acquired much greater importance later.

Ramautar's bullock cart came for the distribution. Mango and guava were placed on one side, neem and lemon on the other. To balance the load, I slipped the drumstick saplings into the middle.

Ramautar asked, "Won't the order get mixed up?"

I said, "Order belongs on paper, not on a cart."

He scratched his head.

By the time we reached the first hamlet, clouds had gathered. It began to rain. The paper labels got wet. In some places the long ee of "Nee" survived; elsewhere it washed away. On some of the "Aa" labels, the second a remained only half-visible.

I remembered what Jyoti Devi had said, but suppose her prediction happened to prove correct. That did not prove my system wrong; it merely proved the rain uncooperative.

At Malti Devi's house I unloaded a sapling. She asked, "Mango, isn't it?"

I looked at the label. It had "M" written on it.

With full confidence I said, "Yours."

"Mango?"

"You are Malti Devi, aren't you?"

She burst out laughing. "I am."

"Then this is your sapling."

Thus the first distribution was a success.

The second house belonged to Parmeshwar Mandal. He wanted lemon. The label still showed an “N.” I handed him the sapling.

He asked, “Is this lemon?”

I said, “When they are small, lemon and neem look like siblings. Once the leaves open out, the truth will reveal itself.”

He said, “Then until the truth reveals itself, where should I dig the pit?”

I said, “Somewhere sunny. Both like sunlight.”

How accurate that answer was from the standpoint of agricultural science is a question for Jyoti Devi. At the time, however, she had gone to another hamlet.

By noon, thirty-eight saplings had been distributed. The cart grew emptier; my confidence grew fuller.

When we reached the third hamlet, the problem was that the list had two men named Ramvilas—Ramvilas Mahato and Ramvilas Paswan. I had not written their fathers’ names, because in a village people know one another.

They both arrived at the same time. One wanted mango, the other neem.

I looked at the list. “Ramvilas—M.”

Both said, “Me.”

I said, “It goes to whoever raises his hand first.”

Ramvilas Mahato immediately raised his hand.

Ramvilas Paswan said, “Is this some kind of examination?”

I said, “Promptness is essential in village work.”

Mahato-ji took the mango. Paswan-ji was given the neem. Later it turned out that the list had been the other way round.

Where was my fault in that? Both households had given their sons the same name. No one had consulted me at the time of their births.

By evening all the saplings had been distributed. Only three remained—a drumstick, a neem, and a guava. Three names remained on the list—mine, the mukhiya’s, and the school kitchen.

I had asked for guava for my house. The mukhiya wanted neem; the school wanted drumstick.

All three labels were soaked. One had something resembling an “A,” another a straight line, and the third nothing at all.

I said, “Now it is easy. Three things, three places.”

Ramautar asked, “Which one goes where?”

I said, “Whichever comes off the cart first is mine.”

He unloaded a sapling that looked like guava. I planted it in my courtyard.

My wife Kamla asked, “Guava, isn’t it?”

I said, “Certainly.”

She said, “Then why do the leaves look like neem?”

I said, "One does not judge a young plant by its appearance. When a child is born, does anyone announce at once that he will study mathematics?"

Kamla fell silent. I took that to mean the argument had been effective.

Three days later the first complaint arrived. Malti Devi said, "Bhola Babu, the leaves of my mango smell like lemon."

I said, "The effect of the soil."

On the fifth day Parmeshwar Mandal came carrying a twig. "My lemon is turning out to be a thornless neem."

I said, "Be patient. Give the sapling time to declare its identity."

On the seventh day Jyoti Devi made a round of the village. She had the original list in her hand—full names, varieties of sapling, advice on soil, everything clearly written.

She first went to Malti Devi's courtyard. One look at the sapling and she said, "This is lemon."

Malti Devi looked at me.

I said, "Lemon is useful too."

She smiled. "Instead of mango pickle, we'll make lemon pickle."

I said, "See? No real loss at all."

Jyoti Devi went to the next house. Parmeshwar Mandal's sapling turned out to be neem. His pit was small, but the spot was good. He said, "Let it stay. It will give shade."

I said, "I told you from the beginning that both like sunlight."

Jyoti Devi stared at me.

The homes of Ramvilas Mahato and Ramvilas Paswan were checked. There was a neem in Mahato-ji's courtyard and a mango at the corner of Paswan-ji's field. Both men burst out laughing.

Mahato-ji said, "So the prize for raising my hand first turned out to be neem."

Paswan-ji said, "And the benefit of being late was mango."

I said, "Life restores its own balance."

Jyoti Devi said, "Not life. A wrong list."

I registered my disagreement.

The mukhiya's house had got the drumstick. The school kitchen had the guava. My courtyard had the neem.

Kamla kept looking at me. She said nothing. This kind of silence is a very powerful language in a married woman.

I said, "Neem is good for health."

She said, "So is guava."

I said, "Neem lives long."

She said, "Guava bears fruit."

I said, "Shade too is a kind of fruit."

She went inside.

At this point people say my plan failed. That conclusion is not supported by the facts. Of the sixty-eight saplings, fifty-seven reached suitable places. Nine had their varieties exchanged, and two had to be moved to different spots.

Work out the percentage and the success rate is very high.

Jyoti Devi said, "Forget the percentage. Think of a way to improve the system."

I immediately said, "Tie coloured thread to them. Red for mango, yellow for guava, green for lemon, blue for neem, white for drumstick."

She said, "That is what I told you on the first day—variety label, house number, and the list, all three."

I said, "You said labels. I added coloured thread."

The committee agreed that the next distribution would use three marks—the full name of the variety, the house number, and coloured thread.

To me, this improvement was extremely scientific.

Two weeks later, as the saplings opened out their leaves, their identities became clear. Two that had been planted in unsuitable places were carefully replanted. The people accepted all the rest.

Malti Devi built a small bamboo guard around the lemon plant. She said, "I didn't get a mango, but this is mine now."

Parmeshwar Mandal marked out the place for a future bench beneath the neem.

Ramvilas Mahato went from time to time to look at Paswan-ji's mango. He would say, "The mango I raised my hand for is over here."

Paswan-ji would reply, "You raised the hand; I'm the one watering the mango."

The neem in my courtyard grew fastest of all. Kamla watered it, but never praised it in front of me.

One evening I said, "See? If it had been guava, it would not have grown this straight."

Kamla said, "Where are you to blame?"

Her voice was very sweet. For a moment I suspected she was making fun of me. Then I thought—life becomes difficult when there is distrust at home. I let the suspicion go.

The following year the saplings came again. A committee was formed. I arrived at the meeting fully prepared. In my bag I had red, yellow, green, blue, and white thread.

The mukhiya read out the names: "Distribution in charge: Jyoti Devi. Assistants: two school students. Register in charge: the headmaster."

I asked, "And me?"

The mukhiya said, "You are the adviser."

I sat up straight with pride.

Ramvilas Paswan quietly said to Mahato-ji, "A promotion."

I heard him.

He was right. The post of the person who advises is above the post of the person who does the work.

Before the meeting ended, I offered three suggestions—write the labels in full, add the house number, tie coloured thread.

Jyoti Devi smiled and said, "Where did these three rules come from?"

I said, "Experience."

That was entirely true.

The experience was mine.

And the fault?

Where the fault lay is for you to decide.

The Devout Thief

In the village, people regarded Devkinandan Jha as a devout man. At dawn the sound of a conch would rise from his courtyard; at noon a small lamp burned in a corner of his shop; and in the evening he supervised the washing of the temple steps.

He possessed another quality as well, one to which he himself had given a very handsome name.

He did not call it stealing. His phrase was: "temporary redistribution of goods."

The phrase was born in the first year of the Harinam week. The temple courtyard had run short of bamboo poles for the pavilion. Devkinandan Jha had four bamboos lifted from Nandlal Sah's backyard.

That evening Nandlal Sah asked, "Who took the bamboos?"

Devkinandan Jha said, "They haven't been taken. They've been temporarily redistributed for a community religious purpose."

"Why didn't you ask?"

"If I had asked, you would have given them anyway. It saved time."

Nandlal Sah made no reply. When the week ended, three of the four bamboos came back. The fourth came back as half a bamboo, because it had been cut to make a prop for the stage.

Returning the half bamboo, Devkinandan Jha said, "In the service of religion, its length has diminished, not its value."

From that day Nandlal Sah began calling him "Redistribution Babu."

Devkinandan Jha was not offended by the name. To him it was almost a title.

The following year a large brass lota was needed for the ritual feast. Phoolmati Kaki had a gleaming one at home. Kaki had gone to the market. Devkinandan Jha had the lota fetched.

That evening Kaki saw her lota in the temple, measuring out kheer.

She said, "If you had asked me, I would have given it."

Devkinandan Jha replied cheerfully, "That is exactly what I am saying—you would have given it. So what separate need was there to ask beforehand?"

Kaki looked at him for a long while. Then she said, "My need for my own things comes first."

Devkinandan Jha reflected on this sentence, but concluded that Kaki had grown old and her attachment to possessions had increased.

Gradually the list of redistributions grew longer. Two long benches from the school went to a religious discourse. Ramsevak the mason's hammer went to the repair of the temple gate. Basanti Devi's thick cloth went to cover sacks of prasad on a rainy day. Kishori Chaudhary's bamboo ladder went to fasten the flag rope.

Devkinandan Jha claimed that he remembered every object.

There was also a slim ledger in the drawer of his shop. Across the top, in red pencil, he had written: "Religious Debt."

Open the ledger and the entries ran like this: "One hammer—public good." "Two benches—discourse." "One thick cloth—protection of prasad."

Very often the owner's name was not written at all.

Devkinandan Jha's reasoning was, "If the object has been identified, why write the owner's name?"

One day Ramsevak the mason came to his shop looking for his hammer.

"Where is my hammer?"

Devkinandan Jha opened the ledger.

"It is in the service of the public good."

"Where does the public good live?"

"Near the temple gate."

Ramsevak went there. The hammer was not there. The gate had already been repaired. He was told the hammer had been by a pavilion stake. The stake had already been removed. At last the hammer was found in the rear storeroom of the temple, beneath an old jhaal.

Ramsevak returned and said, "If you had written the owner's name, the hammer would not have travelled through three places."

Devkinandan Jha replied, "A thing in the service of religion must keep moving. If it sits still, it gathers rust."

Ramsevak oiled his hammer and said nothing.

Meanwhile, it was decided that the temple's old veranda should be repaired. Devkinandan Jha was put in charge of the materials.

He began running about day and night. In his view, delay in religious work was itself a kind of loss.

Kishori Chaudhary's ladder arrived again. Two bamboos belonging to Nandlal Sah arrived. Basanti Devi's thick cloth arrived. Ramsevak's hammer also arrived again; this time Ramsevak himself was not present.

Devkinandan Jha said, "He must know by now that the hammer is used for religious work."

On the third night of that week, clouds gathered overhead.

There was already a crack in the rear wall of Phoolmati Kaki's house. With heavy rain threatening, Kaki had told Ramsevak during the day to brace it with bamboo by evening.

Ramsevak arrived with his tools, but the hammer was missing.

He understood at once.

He went towards the temple. Work on the veranda had stopped, but the hammer was not beside the pile of new bricks.

Devkinandan Jha said, "It must have gone into someone's hands. It is here somewhere."

The rain began.

Ramsevak, Kaki's grandson Sudhir, and Nandlal Sah all began looking for the hammer. Half an hour later they found it beneath a bucket. By then a section of the outer plaster on Kaki's wall had fallen away.

The wall did not collapse. No one in the house was hurt. But two sacks of Kaki's paddy were soaked because water had entered through that corner.

Ramsevak braced the wall with bamboo that very night.

Devkinandan Jha stood there drenched by the rain.

He said, "The hammer was found in time. A great disaster was averted."

From inside the house Phoolmati Kaki replied, "If the hammer had been at home in time, the question of disaster would never have arisen."

Devkinandan Jha had no immediate answer to that.

The next day the temple committee met. No one wanted to remove Devkinandan Jha. Without him, the work really was difficult. But everyone wanted an account of their belongings.

Nandlal Sah said, "First count them—whose things are in the service of religion at this moment?"

Devkinandan Jha opened the Religious Debt ledger.

The counting began.

Two benches belonging to the school. One ladder belonging to Kishori Chaudhary. Three bamboos belonging to Nandlal Sah. One thick cloth belonging to Basanti Devi. Ramsevak's hammer. The owners of two spades unclear. The owner of one bucket unknown. Two families claiming the same rope.

The total came to twenty-seven objects.

Devkinandan Jha said, "You see? Not a single object is for private use. Every one of them is in the service of religion."

Ramsevak asked, "Where is the permission?"

Devkinandan Jha turned the pages of the ledger.

"The permission is in the mind. People would not obstruct religious work."

Phoolmati Kaki said, "The mind is yours; the property is mine. The two are not the same."

A few people at the meeting laughed. Devkinandan Jha did not.

Just then, a small incident occurred.

Devkinandan Jha began looking for his new black umbrella. He had bought it in town the previous week and would not let anyone touch it.

Not in the shop. Not in the temple office. Not on the veranda.

Then Sudhir pointed towards the temple roof and said, "Look there."

The black umbrella was open in one corner of the roof. The masons had propped it upside down so that rain would not fall on the fresh lime mortar.

Devkinandan Jha's face changed.

"Who took my umbrella?"

Wiping his hammer, Ramsevak said, "Temporary redistribution of goods."

For a moment the meeting fell silent. Then Nandlal Sah burst out laughing.

Devkinandan Jha kept looking towards the roof. White splashes of lime had marked one edge of the umbrella.

He asked quietly, "If they had asked, I would have given it."

Phoolmati Kaki said, "That is exactly what I used to say."

This time Devkinandan Jha did not blame Kaki's attachment on old age.

The meeting did not end there. That day a new register was drawn up. It had four columns—object, owner, purpose, date of return. In a fifth column they wrote: "Permission."

Devkinandan Jha himself said, "Without permission, an entry shall be considered incomplete."

Nandlal Sah asked, "Permission given in the mind?"

Wiping lime from his black umbrella, Devkinandan Jha said, "No. From the owner's own mouth."

Over the next two days all twenty-seven objects were traced and returned. The two spades turned out to belong to two different households. The bucket belonged to the school kitchen. The dispute between the two families over the rope ended when a red thread was found inside one of its knots, the kind Basanti Devi tied to her belongings.

Devkinandan Jha went about returning everything. If an object had been damaged, he had it repaired. This time, in place of Nandlal Sah's old bamboo that had been reduced to half, he gave him a whole new bamboo.

Surprised, Nandlal Sah asked, "A new rule of redistribution?"

Devkinandan Jha said, "This is accounting."

The temple veranda was finally completed. On the day of its inauguration, Devkinandan Jha was as busy as ever. The only difference was that a pencil was tucked behind his ear and the new register was in his hand.

Ramsevak needed a rope. Devkinandan Jha went to Basanti Devi.

"Will you lend us the rope for one day?"

Basanti Devi said, "I will. Write it in the register."

He wrote: "Rope. Owner: Basanti Devi. Purpose: tying the veranda jhaal. Return date: tomorrow. Permission: given orally."

In the space for a signature, Basanti Devi put her thumb impression.

Devkinandan Jha closed the register.

From a distance Nandlal Sah called out, "Redistribution Babu, the rules have multiplied!"

Devkinandan Jha replied, "The name has changed."

"Changed to what?"

Lifting the rope, he said, "A loan."

Nandlal Sah asked, "Even for religious work?"

Devkinandan Jha paused for a moment.

"Even for religious work."

That evening a sheet of paper bearing the rules of the new register was pasted on the veranda wall. Devkinandan Jha himself had written the first line: "Whether an object is sacred or ordinary, the owner's name comes first."

In smaller letters below, he had added: "So does the date of return."

The Committee for Good Conduct

One day a new notice was pasted on the wall of Barhi Tola's old reading room: "Committee for Good Conduct: Complaints will be heard on Saturdays."

Beneath the notice were five names: Chairman Harimohan Mishra, Secretary Shashibhushan Jha, treasurer Ramvachan Sah, schoolteacher Devavrat Babu, and Kamla Kaki. All five were regarded as respected people in the village. It was not that they had no faults; respect merely meant that people spoke of their faults in lowered voices.

The reason for forming the committee was not very grand. Someone's goat would eat the flowers at the reading room, someone's sand would lie scattered in the lane, public chairs borrowed for a wedding would come back three days late, or a household drain would empty toward a neighbour's courtyard. Small matters led to quarrels every day. The village head said it was difficult to abandon all the panchayat's work to hear such things. So the committee was formed at the reading room.

Shashibhushan Jha devised the system. There would be a blue book of complaint slips. A slip would be torn out, but its small stub would remain attached to the book. The same serial number would be written on both. The complaint would go above, a brief subject below. The complaint slip would be dropped into a wooden box; the stub would remain in the book.

"This way no slip can ever disappear," Shashibhushan Jha said proudly.

Harimohan Mishra added, "And the committee will apply the same rule to everyone."

On the first Saturday eight slips came out of the box: dung in front of someone's doorway, music played late into the night, the rope from the public well taken home. The committee heard them all, summoned both sides, and wrote brief decisions in the register.

For three weeks the system worked so well that people began to enjoy filing complaints. Some weighed their words while filling out a slip; others made a point of remembering the serial number. As Ganesh, the reading-room attendant, tore off a slip, he would say, "Keep the number. Otherwise later you'll say the complaint was never born at all."

On the fourth Saturday, slip number 18 came out of the box. The complaint read: "Twelve chairs from the reading room went to the chairman's house. Four days have passed. Only six have returned."

Harimohan Mishra read the slip and took off his spectacles.

"This is not a complaint; it is an account of a household function," he said. "The chairs will come back."

Devavrat Babu said, "The chairman himself has taken responsibility. What purpose would a public discussion serve?"

Ramvachan Sah agreed. Instead of entering the slip in the main register, Shashibhushan Jha put it into a grey envelope. On the envelope was written: "Personal consultation."

The following week came number 23: "The secretary's son is building a house, and the sand has blocked half the lane."

Shashibhushan Jha cleared his throat. "It is a matter of two days. The work crew will come and remove it."

Taking the slip in his hand, Harimohan Mishra said, "Some inconvenience is inevitable while a house is being built. There is no need for a public ruling on this."

Number 23 also went into the grey envelope.

Number 29 concerned Ramvachan Sah. He had sent five sacks of paddy to the market on the public handcart but had not entered the cart's use in the register.

"The cart was standing empty," Ramvachan Sah said. "If a village thing cannot serve a villager, what use is it?"

Kamla Kaki smiled. "Quite right. It is hardly theft."

Number 29 went into the grey envelope.

Number 34 concerned Kamla Kaki's cow, which had been tied near the post by the public well and had turned the ground all around into mud.

Reading the slip, Kamla Kaki said, "The cow had gone there to drink water. Every living creature needs water."

Devavrat Babu said, "Where is the question of good conduct in this?"

Number 34 also went into the grey envelope.

Number 41 concerned Devavrat Babu. Two students from the school had gone to his house to carry old books to the reading room, but along with the books they had also carried bags of oil and salt. The person who filed the complaint asked whether it was proper to have schoolchildren carry household goods.

Devavrat Babu frowned. "The children helped of their own accord. I gave no order."

Harimohan Mishra said, "The bond between teacher and pupil cannot be measured in the language of complaints."

Number 41 went into the grey envelope.

Meanwhile the committee continued to hear other people's complaints in the usual way. If someone's sand remained in the lane for seven days, a date was fixed for its removal. If someone returned public chairs late, the name went into the register. If someone's cow made mud by the well, an order was given to put up a separate post. If someone sent a teenager on a private errand, that person was warned.

People in the village began to regard the committee as powerful.

Only the blue complaint-slip book in the hands of Ganesh the attendant told a slightly different story. On the attached stubs the serial numbers ran without a break - 1, 2, 3, 4... - but the main decision register had gaps here and there.

Ganesh had no particular concern with this. His job was to tear off the slips, give the secretary the key to the box, and sweep the veranda after the meeting. But at the end of the year, the task of preparing the reading room's statement of expenses and work fell to his nephew Niranjan. Niranjan was a college student and quick with figures.

On the first day Niranjan asked, "How many complaints in all?"

Shashibhushan Jha said, "Count the register."

There were fifty-two decisions in the register. The last serial number in the blue complaint-slip book was eighty-four.

Niranjan counted again. Fifty-two. Then eighty-four.

"Where did thirty-two slips go?" he asked.

Without looking up, Shashibhushan Jha said, "Some cancelled, some duplicates, some private."

"Where are the cancellation marks?"

Shashibhushan Jha looked at him over his spectacles. "You make the accounts. You are not a court."

Niranjan fell silent, but on the account sheet he left one line blank: "Complaints received: 84. Decision register: 52. Other: ____."

The following Saturday was the annual open meeting. Donors to the reading room, old members, the women's group, and students had all come. Harimohan Mishra read a brief account of the committee's successful year. "We heard every dispute peacefully, applied the same rules to all, and remained above personal animosity."

Then Niranjan read out the accounts. At the end he stopped at the blank line.

"Complaints received: eighty-four. Decisions: fifty-two. Other: thirty-two - I found no details."

There was a stir on the veranda.

Harimohan Mishra said, "Some matters may have been settled by consultation within the committee."

From the back, Phoolmati Kaki untied the knot in the end of her sari and took out a small blue stub. "Mine was number 23. About the sand in the lane. Was that settled?"

For a moment Shashibhushan Jha's face went still.

Phoolmati Kaki continued, "The sand stayed there until the third rain. My grandson slipped twice."

Ganesh quietly took the grey envelope from the cupboard and placed it on the table. A layer of dust lay on it.

Niranjan asked, "Is this the 'other'?"

No member answered at once.

Harimohan Mishra opened the envelope. The first slip was number 18 - the chairs. The second, 23 - the sand. The third, 29 - the handcart. Then 34 - the cow. Then 41 - the students. Among them were other slips involving the members' families and people close to them.

For the first time Kamla Kaki did not laugh. Looking at the slips, she said, "We kept dismissing one another's matters as 'small.'"

Ramvachan Sah immediately said, "They were all small matters."

Niranjan opened the main register and turned its pages. "At number 12 there is a decision ordering a separate post for Haricharan's cow. At number 34 Kamla Kaki's cow became 'personal.' At number 9 there is a warning for using the public handcart without making an entry. At number 29 Ramvachan Kaka's cart became 'village business.'"

No one on the veranda burst out laughing, but smiles appeared on many faces.

Holding his own slip, Devavrat Babu said quietly, "The comparison is fair."

Shashibhushan Jha said, "The committee wished to settle matters involving its members among ourselves first. There was no ill intent in it."

Phoolmati Kaki replied, "The intention may have been good. The sand was still in the lane."

This time the sentence drew laughter. Even Shashibhushan Jha smiled.

Harimohan Mishra looked at the slip about the chairs. "My six chairs?"

Ganesh said, "Two are still on your veranda."

"Not four?"

"Two had already been returned. Two still have slips with your granddaughter's name stuck on them."

Harimohan Mishra put his spectacles back on. "Then first write down that the chairs are to be returned."

Niranjan asked, "In the main register?"

For a few moments the chairman kept looking at the grey envelope. "Yes. In the main register."

After that, the thirty-two slips were read one by one. Not every complaint led to a penalty. Some complaints really were duplicates, some incomplete, some no more than personal friction. But now the reason was written in the register. When a slip concerned a committee member, that member did not decide it; the others and two invited villagers heard the matter.

On Ramvachan Sah's handcart slip it was written: "Next time the name will be entered." For Kamla Kaki's cow, a bamboo post would be set up ten cubits from the well. Devavrat Babu said he would no longer have students carry household goods. Shashibhushan Jha himself wrote down a date within three days for the sand to be removed.

In the matter of Harimohan Mishra's chairs, Ganesh was sent at once. Half an hour later he came back carrying two chairs on his head. On the back of one chair a piece of paper really was stuck: "Naina."

Kamla Kaki said, "So even a chair can have a private name?"

This time Harimohan Mishra laughed louder than anyone.

The meeting went on into the night. At the end, a new rule was written in the blue complaint-slip book: "Whoever a slip is against, that name will be entered in the register in the ordinary sequence. A member's slip will come neither first nor last; wherever its number falls, there it will stand."

"The 'personal consultation' envelope?" Ganesh asked.

Shashibhushan Jha folded the envelope and moved toward the wastebasket, then stopped.

"Don't throw it away," Niranjan said. "It is part of the reading room's history."

A new label was pasted on the envelope: "Slips omitted in the first year."

When the box was opened the following Saturday, there was only one slip. Number 85.

Shashibhushan Jha read it aloud: "The secretary's goat ate the reading room's new marigolds."

Every eye on the veranda turned toward him.

Out of habit he began, "The goat is a household matter..."

He stopped in the middle of the sentence. Harimohan Mishra uncapped his pen and pushed the main register toward him.

Shashibhushan Jha read the slip again, nodded, and wrote: "Number 85. Complaint received. The goat is private; the flowers are public."

Kamla Kaki asked, "The decision?"

Shashibhushan Jha said, "First I will pay for the flowers. Then I will shorten the goat's rope."

Niranjan made a small tick in the margin of the register. This time no grey envelope was opened.

Sacred Parking

This year the annual festival at Pipra Shiva Temple had become a subject of discussion in advance because of a new arrangement. Near the mango grove behind the temple, the committee had marked out eighteen car bays with lime. Down the middle it had left a footpath two cubits wide, two spaces on the left for elderly people, and an open strip on the right for bullock carts and handcarts.

Raghunandan Jha took full credit for the arrangement himself. For three days he had been going about with a chalk line, bamboo stakes, and signboards. A new board hung by the temple gate: "Sacred Parking." Beneath it, in smaller letters, was written: "Keep vehicles within the lines. Keep the footpath clear."

Raghunandan Jha was the committee secretary, but he generally introduced himself as "the man who looks after arrangements." He believed that most quarrels in a village arose from the absence of rules, and that if the rules were written clearly enough, people would become better of their own accord.

The main sermon at the festival that year was also on "self-restraint and the rights of others." Raghunandan Jha was delighted by the coincidence. He told all the volunteers, "The sermon is inside; its practice is outside. Even parking a vehicle is a test of character."

Niranjan, who was studying at college, smiled as he went over the lime lines once more. "Uncle, who will award the marks in this examination?"

Raghunandan Jha said, "The lines will."

Until eight in the morning, everything went well. The first four cars stood neatly inside their bays. Two motorcycles were placed separately behind a bamboo barrier. The two spaces reserved for elderly people remained empty. Every now and then Raghunandan Jha wiped the signboard and made its lettering shine.

At half past eight, his elder brother Harihar Jha arrived in a white car. It was not new, but it had been washed and polished until the mango leaves could be seen clearly reflected in it. Harihar Jha noticed a patch of shade near the gate and stopped the car squarely across half the footpath.

Niranjan came running. "Babuji, this path is supposed to be kept clear."

As he got out of the car, Harihar Jha said, "I'll go inside for ten minutes and then move it. The car will heat up in the sun."

Niranjan looked toward Raghunandan Jha.

Raghunandan Jha looked for a moment at the signboard, then at his brother. "All right, but make sure the wheels do not stand too far outside the line."

"And the path?" Niranjan asked.

"Ten minutes," Raghunandan Jha said. "Rules also require the intelligence to understand circumstances."

Ten minutes passed, and the car remained where it was. Harihar Jha had gone inside and become occupied with the temple's guest list. Then Mahendra Sah, a wealthy trader from the market, arrived. He stopped his car between two bays, occupying half of each.

Niranjan pointed out the lines to him. Mahendra Sah said, "I gave fifty thousand rupees for the bell. What if my car gets scratched?"

Raghunandan Jha wanted to make the rule clear here, but Mahendra Sah added first, "It is only a matter of two hours."

Raghunandan Jha said, "Straighten the car a little."

Mahendra Sah moved it half a cubit straighter. Both bays were still half blocked.

By nine o'clock, the number of "circumstances" had multiplied. A motorcycle appeared in one of the spaces reserved for the elderly on the ground that its rider was a guest of the priest. Two bicycles leaned against the edge of the footpath because the bhajan group needed somewhere to put down its dholak. Raghunandan Jha kept explaining one small exception after another.

Meanwhile, Binda Kaki arrived with three earthen water pots, two brass lotas, and a sack of sattu on a handcart. Serving drinking water at the festival had been her work for years. She had to take the handcart to the water stand behind the temple.

Near the gate, Harihar Jha's car blocked half the path. On the other side stood bicycles and a bamboo stake. The handcart could not get through.

Binda Kaki said, "Is this a footpath, or a resting platform for cars?"

Niranjan went inside to look for Harihar Jha. The sermon was about to begin. Harihar Jha was already seated in the front row. When asked to get up, he said, "The conch has sounded now. It would be improper to rise in the middle of the sermon."

Niranjan came back outside and told Raghunandan Jha.

In a low voice Raghunandan Jha said, "Kaki, unload two pots first. Then the cart will squeeze through along the side."

Binda Kaki looked at him. "I should lift three pots myself, when the sign says this footpath is to be kept clear?"

Before Raghunandan Jha could answer, a voice from inside came over the loudspeaker: "Make your own convenience smaller, and another person's path will grow wider."

The three people standing by the gate looked at one another. Nirnanjan could not suppress his smile.

In the end Binda Kaki unloaded the pots. Nirnanjan, two teenage girls, and a boy carried them inside. The handcart was left outside by a mango tree. Binda Kaki sat down at the water stand, sweat on her forehead and silence on her face.

Inside, the sermon went on—patience, humility, the rights of others, control over anger. Outside, the number of vehicles kept growing. Once the marked bays were full, people began finding new places according to their own ingenuity. One motorcycle was parked beside the water pots, another on the strip meant for unloading grain for the prasad, and a third directly outside the gate.

Raghunandan Jha tried to stop everyone, but his sentences now seemed to contain less rule than relationship: "He is Mukhiyaji's guest," "He is the priest's brother-in-law," "He has come from outside," "He is elderly," "He will be leaving soon."

Once Nirnanjan asked, "Uncle, who are the marked bays left for now?"

Raghunandan Jha said, "Don't make jokes. Manage the crowd."

At noon the sermon ended. People came out from inside. For the first five minutes everyone had to find his own shoes; for the next five, his own vehicle. After that, the main assembly began at the gate.

A bicycle was trapped behind Mahendra Sah's car. A handcart now stood in front of Harihar Jha's car, because Binda Kaki had dragged it back to take the empty pots home. The dholak player from the bhajan group was looking for his bicycle. One motorcycle owner was insisting that someone had twisted his rear-view mirror.

"My car will come out first," Mahendra Sah said. "I have other work."

Harihar Jha said, "My car is on the path. If this one comes out first, the way will open for everyone."

Nirnanjan said softly, "The way has been blocked since then."

Raghunandan Jha glared at him. "This is no time for argument. Put things in order."

"From what moment does the order begin?" Binda Kaki asked. "From when the path was blocked, or from when the sermon ended?"

A few people laughed. Raghunandan Jha did not.

He said loudly, "Everyone be patient. That is what we have just heard inside."

Mahendra Sah answered at once, "I have been patient. My car has been standing here for two hours."

The laughter grew louder at that. Mahendra Sah himself did not understand at first why everyone was laughing; then he too smiled.

Meanwhile, two young men from the temple kitchen wanted to carry a large cauldron of hot dal toward the community dining area. The strip on the right, which had been kept clear for exactly this purpose, was filled by one motorcycle and two bicycles. The young men lifted the cauldron and began trying to thread their way between the vehicles.

Binda Kaki stood up at once. "Not with a pot of hot dal between the vehicles. Open the way first."

Her voice was not very loud, but this time no one objected. Niranjana went looking for the owner of the motorcycle. The owner was sitting in the dining line. Waving from a distance, he called, "Just move it a little, will you?"

Niranjana asked for the key. The owner said, "The key is in my pocket."

Raghunandan Jha went to the line himself. He had to go inside and make people rise in the middle of their meal. Within five minutes, three vehicles had been moved. The cauldron passed through safely.

On his way back, Raghunandan Jha's eyes fell on the ground. The white lime of the footpath disappeared beneath Harihar Jha's car, but two thin muddy wheel tracks curved around it in a semicircle. They were the marks left by Binda Kaki's handcart when, unable to find a clear path, she had turned the cart around and left it outside.

Raghunandan Jha stood looking at those marks for a few moments. Just then the preacher, Shambhunath Babu, came out from inside. People moved toward him, wanting to praise the sermon, but seeing the crowd at the gate he merely asked, "Which vehicle is to be moved first here?"

No one asked him to repeat his sermon. Shambhunath Babu pointed toward Harihar Jha's car. "The one blocking the path goes first."

A little uncomfortable, Harihar Jha said, "The secretary gave me permission."

Every eye turned toward Raghunandan Jha.

At first Raghunandan Jha wanted to say, "For ten minutes." The words came to his lips, but he looked again at the semicircular tracks on the ground.

He said, "Yes, I gave permission. I was wrong to give it."

Niranjana was holding a small tin of lime. He said nothing.

Harihar Jha took out the key. "Then I'll move it."

The moment the car moved, the footpath opened. Binda Kaki pushed the empty handcart straight inside. It went through without turning, without unloading a single pot. Raghunandan Jha kept looking at the width of the path, as though measuring it for the first time.

After the midday meal, the committee sat again for five minutes. Mahendra Sah said that some respect ought to be shown for his donation of fifty thousand rupees for the bell.

Niranjan asked, "A separate parking space?"

Mahendra Sah said, "All I am saying is that the donor should be recognised."

Raghunandan Jha replied, "Your name is on the bell, not on the lines painted on the ground."

Mahendra Sah was silent at first, then said, "All right. But next time no one should lean a bicycle against my car."

"That rule applies to everyone," Raghunandan Jha said.

When the crowd thinned in the evening, Raghunandan Jha took down the signboard. The words "Sacred Parking" now seemed a little too grand to him. On the back of the board he painted new lettering: "Vehicle Parking. Keep the Footpath Clear."

Niranjan asked, "Why did you remove the word 'sacred'?"

Washing his brush, Raghunandan Jha said, "A vehicle is not sacred. It is enough for the path to remain clear."

The next day the new signboard hung by the gate. When Harihar Jha arrived, he left the shade of the mango tree and parked in the third bay. Mahendra Sah's car was not between two bays but inside a single one. The priest's guest kept his motorcycle away from the spaces reserved for the elderly.

Raghunandan Jha parked his own motorcycle farthest back of all. Niranjan smiled.

"What?" Raghunandan Jha asked.

"Nothing. I'm watching the arrangements."

Raghunandan Jha straightened the signboard. "An arrangement works only when the man who looks after it stays inside the lines first."

Niranjan said nothing. He simply joined a broken lime line on the footpath once more. This time, there was no wheel standing on it.

The Donation Photograph

When a new hand pump was installed in the southern hamlet of Belahi, the first discussion was not about the water but about the photograph. Mahendra Sah, who ran a cloth and hardware shop, had paid for the work in memory of his father, and for three days he had been saying that everything ought to look good on inauguration day.

The hand pump had been installed beside the village's old dirt road, a little way from the peepal tree. Until then, people from that hamlet had fetched water from an old well beside the pond half a kos away. The new hand pump was already working, but the earth around it was still raw and unpaved.

Mahendra Sah's chief concern was not the raw earth but the name plaque. On a metal plate gleaming like brass were the words: 'In memory of the late Badrinarayan Sah, by his son Mahendra Sah.' The plaque had been fixed to the lower part of the platform, directly in front of the hand pump.

Mahendra Sah had already told the photographer, Prabhakar, 'The plaque must be clearly visible, my face must be above it, and the water must come out in a stream. I want all three in the same photograph.'

Prabhakar asked, 'Which way will the water flow?'

Mahendra Sah replied, 'Down.'

Buchchi Devi, who was sitting nearby, heard him. She was past seventy, yet she still carried her own water pot. She said, 'The plaque is down there. Will the water flow over it or through it?'

Mahendra Sah laughed. 'Auntie, today is the inauguration. The drain will be built tomorrow.'

Buchchi Devi placed her palm over the mouth of her empty pot and said, 'If the water starts flowing today, why should the drain wait until tomorrow?'

Mahendra Sah answered the question by explaining the order of the inauguration. First, five families would stand by the hand pump with empty pots. Then he would cut the red ribbon. After that Buchchi Devi would fill the first pot. Third would come the group photograph. Only then could everyone else fill water.

Lalita Devi from the hamlet committee asked him, 'What if someone needs water before that?'

'It is a matter of ten minutes,' Mahendra Sah said. 'A deed of donation ought to leave behind a memory.'

Lalita Devi folded the list and put it away. She had no objection to ten minutes, but she was looking at the way water would collect beside the platform. Bhola, the mason who had tested the hand pump, had said twice the day before, 'Make an outlet, otherwise there will be mud here.'

The cost of drainage had not been included in the original work. Mahendra Sah had said that the hand pump should first be put into use; the rest could be seen to later.

By ten o'clock a cloth banner had been stretched between two branches of the peepal tree. It read: 'The Gift of Water: Service Above All.' Prabhakar set his camera on a tripod. Mahendra Sah wore a white kurta and polished shoes.

Buchchi Devi arrived in an ordinary blue sari. Her water pot was not new. Brass still shone at two spots around its rim; the rest had gone grey. Mahendra Sah said softly to Lalita Devi, 'Wipe Auntie's pot a little. It looks very old in the photograph.'

Buchchi Devi heard him. 'The pot has grown old carrying water. There is no need to make it look new today.'

Prabhakar lowered the eye of the camera, as though hiding a smile.

The inauguration began. Mahendra Sah cut the red ribbon. Two children clapped. Prabhakar took the first photograph. Then Mahendra Sah gripped the handle of the hand pump and worked it up and down three times.

The first stream was thin; then the water came out strongly. Buchchi Devi held her pot forward. Water fell into it, but what spilled outside followed the slope of the platform and began to run straight towards the name plaque.

Mahendra Sah said at once, 'Move the pot a little to the right!'

Buchchi Devi moved it to the right. The water flowed right as well, but curved around the edge of the platform and once again began collecting below the name plaque.

Prabhakar stepped back and changed his angle. 'The glint of water on the plaque is coming out nicely.'

'I don't want a glint. I want the letters clear,' Mahendra Sah said.

Buchchi Devi's pot filled. Behind her, four women stood with their own vessels. Taking the inauguration to be over, they stepped forward to fill water. Mahendra Sah raised a hand and said, 'One minute. The group photograph is still left.'

'My pot is full,' Buchchi Devi said. 'Now I am going home.'

'Just stand here. You are the first beneficiary.'

Buchchi Devi replied, 'Is the benefit in the pot or in the photograph?'

A light laugh rose from the people standing behind them. Mahendra Sah took it as a joke and smiled. 'In both.'

While everyone was being arranged in a line, water kept dripping from the hand pump. The earth in front of the platform began to turn dark. Two children tried to catch the water in an empty tin, but half went into the tin and half beneath their feet.

Prabhakar said, 'Move back a little. You're covering the plaque.'

Mahendra Sah took two steps back. His right shoe sank halfway into the soft earth. He pulled his foot out at once. A thick layer of mud clung to the side of the shoe.

'Wait,' he said. 'Clean this first.'

Lalita Devi brought an old sack. Mahendra Sah began rubbing his shoe clean. Meanwhile two women, who had left lentils cooking on their hearths at home, filled their water and went back.

'Why didn't you stop them?' Mahendra Sah asked.

Lalita Devi said, 'The water has started. The inauguration is over.'

'The photograph?'

'That is your business. The water is theirs.'

Mahendra Sah said nothing. Prabhakar began gathering everyone again. This time only three families remained instead of five. Buchchi Devi too set down her pot and came back, because she had developed an interest in watching the spectacle.

Prabhakar gave the signal. Mahendra Sah arranged a smile and took hold of the pump handle. At that very moment a boy named Chhotu came running along the platform with a lota full of water. His foot slipped in the mud.

Buchchi Devi caught him by the arm. Chhotu did not fall, but the water from the lota splashed over the lower part of Mahendra Sah's kurta. Prabhakar's finger was on the shutter at that very instant.

'Don't keep that one,' Mahendra Sah said immediately.

Prabhakar looked at the picture. 'Auntie is holding the child, you're holding the handle, and water is flying through the air. The photograph has life.'

'Look at the kurta.'

'The kurta has life too.'

This time the laughter was louder. Mahendra Sah did not laugh. His eyes went to Chhotu's feet. Mud had climbed to his ankles. Buchchi Devi lifted him onto the platform and washed his feet. The wash water ran back into the same mud.

Bhola, the mason, who had been watching everything from a distance, came forward. 'Babu, shall I build the drain now?'

Mahendra Sah said, 'Let the photograph be finished today. Build it tomorrow.'

Bhola pointed to the lower part of the platform. 'By tomorrow this earth will have softened even more. And the mouth of the drain will have to come out from here itself.'

'What do you mean, from here itself?'

Bhola placed his palm on the name plaque. 'This plaque will have to come off. The drain has to run exactly through this spot. The platform already slopes this way.'

For a moment the smile on Mahendra Sah's face stopped. 'The plaque was fixed only yesterday.'

'If the drain had been made first, the plaque would have gone on the right,' Bhola said. 'Now the water isn't going to ask where the name is written.'

Buchchi Devi said, 'Water isn't literate.'

Prabhakar did not take a photograph of that sentence. He lowered the camera.

Mahendra Sah looked at the flecks of mud on the lettering of the name plaque. For a moment he wanted to say that the drain should be made to curve around it. Bhola laid a cord on the ground and showed him. If the drain were curved, the water would have to climb two cubits uphill before coming down again.

'Water won't climb uphill,' Bhola said.

'I understand,' Mahendra Sah replied.

A little later the four screws around the brass-like plaque were opened. Mahendra Sah himself stood holding the plaque in his hands. Behind it, the new cement showed white. Prabhakar asked, 'A photograph now?'

'Not now,' Mahendra Sah said. 'The drain first.'

Bhola gave two boys the job of choosing bricks. Lalita Devi brought old broken roof tiles and pieces of brick. Buchchi Devi sent a spade from her house. Mahendra Sah sent someone to his shop for two sacks of sand and one sack of cement.

By midday a drain four cubits long had been made in front of the platform. At its end a small soak pit was dug and filled with pieces of brick, sand, and gravel. The name plaque was fixed higher up beside the right-hand post of the hand pump, where the stream of water could not touch it.

Mahendra Sah's white kurta was no longer white. There was a grey mark of cement on its sleeve and flecks of earth near the knee. Prabhakar asked twice whether he wanted to go home, change his clothes, and come back.

'People are filling water now,' Mahendra Sah said. 'Am I to stop everyone again?'

Prabhakar said, 'There is no need to stop them for a photograph.'

This time he stood a little way from the hand pump. Buchchi Devi was filling a second pot. Chhotu was watching the water disappear at the end of the drain. Lalita Devi was explaining the turn to the next household. Mahendra Sah stood to one side, not directly beneath the name plaque.

Prabhakar took three photographs. In one, the water ran along the drain in a thin, shining stream. In another, Buchchi Devi was working the handle. In the third, Mahendra Sah was folding an empty cement sack in his hands.

'In which one is my face clear?' Mahendra Sah asked.

Prabhakar showed him the third photograph. 'A little in this one.'

'The name plaque?'

'Half of it.'

Mahendra Sah looked at the first photograph. His face was at the edge, and the name plaque looked small, but the drain was clearly visible and two water pots stood beside the platform without sinking into mud.

'I am at the side in this photograph,' he said.

Lifting the water pot onto her head, Buchchi Devi said, 'The water is in the middle. That's right.'

Prabhakar smiled. This time Mahendra Sah laughed in reply.

Two days later two photographs hung on the wall of the shop. The first was small: Mahendra Sah cutting the red ribbon. The second was large: the hand pump, the drain, the water pots, the people, and Mahendra Sah at one side in his earth-stained kurta.

A customer looking at the large photograph asked, 'Which one is the donation photograph?'

Mahendra Sah first looked towards the photograph with the red ribbon. Then he looked towards the large one.

'The one from the day the work was completed,' he said.

The customer searched for the name plaque. 'The name looks very small.'

Opening his account book, Mahendra Sah said, 'Water doesn't read.'

The Great Renunciate

In Belwa village of Madhubani district, the room of the "Shared Seed Bank" stood behind the panchayat building. The room was small, but Jagdish Chaudhary kept its key tied into a knot of his sacred thread. He used to say, "The key to the seed is the key to the village's next harvest."

He had repeated this sentence so many times that even a new volunteer at the seed bank knew what would come next: "And what have I not given up for this seed bank!"

Then the list would begin. The first year he had skipped the agricultural fair. The second year he had reached a feast at his brother's in-laws' home half an hour late. Once he had lent his bullock cart to carry seed without charging any hire. Twice his midday meal had gone cold. And one rainy night, when the roof was leaking, instead of sleeping at home he had spent the night shifting sacks in the seed bank.

In Jagdish Chaudhary's telling, every incident was a "sacrifice." Even in jest he would say, "If an account were kept of my sacrifices, it would need a separate book."

He did, in fact, have a book. It was an old red-bound ledger, and on its first page, in thick letters, was written: "Shared Seed Bank: Expenditure and Service." Rupees went in the expenditure column, hours in the service column. But when recording service, Jagdish Chaudhary never wrote merely "three hours." He wrote: "Three hours, leaving my own work."

Manjari Devi, who kept the seed bank's accounts, understood what this language meant. From time to time she would say, "Uncle, just write the hours. Whether you left your own work or not, let the historian decide."

Jagdish Chaudhary would laugh. "A historian needs the whole story, daughter."

That year the seed bank's chief concern was an indigenous rice variety called Kanakjir. At the mere sound of its name, the village elders remembered the fragrance of rice from long ago, but it was difficult to grow. Seed was scarce, the yield moderate, and the newer market varieties matured quickly.

Five years earlier, Jagdish Chaudhary had begun multiplying Kanakjir again from two handfuls of seed kept in his father's bamboo chest. The first

year he planted one kaththa, the second three kaththas, then half a bigha. He had also given some seed to the village's shared bank.

This time, eighteen kilos of selected Kanakjir lay separately in his private storeroom. The grains were uniform in size, properly dried in the sun, and sealed with neem leaves in a large earthen jar. A red cloth was tied over the mouth of the jar.

For two months Jagdish Chaudhary had been thinking of sending a sample to the district agricultural fair for the "Best Preserved Indigenous Rice" category. The agricultural extension worker had said that if, in the next season, he planted a full half-bigha of pure Kanakjir, his name could be submitted for seed-purity testing.

Jagdish Chaudhary placed this not on his list of sacrifices but on his list of achievements. "This is my father's seed," he would say. "I will give it a name again."

In the first week of Ashadh, three days of proper rain fell. Preparations for transplanting began. Different rice seeds were issued from the shared bank. Manjari Devi wrote down the names in the register, weighed the seed, and marked each sack.

On the fourth night, torrential rain swept in from the north. It did not last very long, but a small channel of the Kamla River rose suddenly. Water entered the courtyards of several houses in the lower hamlet. The worst losses were in the rooms where farmers had kept rice seed soaking for transplanting.

When the water receded, it became clear that the seed of nine families had been ruined. Some sacks had been soaked through; in other homes the swollen seed had been swept away with the mud. If transplanting was delayed, the fields would remain empty; if fresh seed was to be gathered, it was needed within two or three days.

At dawn the room of the shared seed bank was opened. Manjari Devi counted what remained: there was not enough ordinary rice seed. The stock left in the bank would not even cover half the fields of seven families.

Jagdish Chaudhary said at once, "Order it from the market."

Manjari Devi asked, "From where?"

"It will be available in Jhanyharpur."

Arun, the agricultural extension worker, who was there at the time, shook his head. "Seed for transplanting is scarce in the market now. Hybrid seed may be available, but for the present stage of these fields and this water, it may already be late."

Jagdish Chaudhary said, "Then Sakri?"

"Even bringing it from Sakri will take two days. Then it has to be soaked, sprouted, and only after that transplanted. Time is slipping away from the people with the low-lying fields."

In the empty margin of the register, Manjari Devi added up the figures. "We need seventeen kilos in all. With a little less, each family could at least transplant half its field."

For a few moments the room was silent. Outside, wet sacks were being spread in the sun. Arun's eyes were on the register, not on Jagdish Chaudhary. But Jagdish Chaudhary understood what the next thought would be.

He said it himself. "Do not look towards my Kanakjir. That is not property of the shared seed bank."

Manjari Devi said evenly, "No one said it was shared property."

"Then?"

"I am adding up the figures."

Jagdish Chaudhary picked up the red ledger. "For all these years I have given private seed to the shared bank. Eight kilos last time. Five kilos before that. These eighteen kilos are my foundation seed for next year."

Arun said, "That is true. It is your private seed."

Jagdish Chaudhary found the agreement slightly uncomfortable. Had there been opposition, he would have laid out his reasons one by one. Once everyone agreed with him, those reasons remained in his hands like papers for which there was no use.

Rampyari Devi came from the lower hamlet. A wet gamchha lay over her head. Standing at the door of the seed bank, she asked, "Has any solution been found?"

Manjari Devi said, "We are still counting."

Rampyari Devi bowed to Jagdish Chaudhary. "Whatever you all decide, we will do. It is hard to leave the field empty."

Jagdish Chaudhary asked, "How much seed did you lose?"

"Three kilos. My daughter went to lift the sack higher in the night, but by then the water was up to her knees."

"Ordinary rice seed will be brought," Jagdish Chaudhary said.

Rampyari Devi nodded. "Whatever can be found. I have no craving for the name. Let the field survive." She turned and left.

"No craving for the name" was an ordinary sentence. Yet in Jagdish Chaudhary's mind appeared the jar tied with red cloth. That jar had a name, a history, and the possibility of the agricultural fair.

By noon, two cyclists had returned after visiting three nearby villages. One farmer had five kilos of seed, another two, but everyone had kept it for his own transplanting. One farmer agreed to spare a single kilo.

At the evening meeting, all nine families came. No one came to make a demand; each came only to state the extent of the loss. The rule of the shared seed bank was that in a disaster, whatever was available would be divided equally.

As he opened the meeting, Jagdish Chaudhary told one of his old stories. "This seed bank was made for days like this. When I first gave the room, the family asked where we would keep our grain. But I said: the village's work comes first."

Manjari Devi sat with the ledger open. Her eyes rose for a moment, then lowered again.

Jagdish Chaudhary continued, "I have never been attached to my private comfort."

The elderly Naresh Mahato, sitting in the meeting, asked, "Then what is the remedy now?"

Jagdish Chaudhary's sentence stopped there.

Arun said quietly, "There is one remedy, but the decision belongs to Chaudharyji. He has eighteen kilos of Kanakjir safely stored. It is private seed. The shared bank has no claim on it."

Everyone fell silent. For the first time Jagdish Chaudhary understood that silence too could become a question when no one actually asked one.

He said, "Kanakjir will not suit every field. It needs care."

Arun replied, "The soil in the lower hamlet suits it. If it is transplanted now, a crop is possible."

"And will the seed remain pure?"

"We will mark the borders of the separate fields. At harvest time, any family that wishes can return seed to the bank."

Naresh Mahato said, "Our people will plant whatever they receive. There is no pressure on Chaudharyji's seed."

Jagdish Chaudhary said at once, "Why speak of pressure?"

"There is no pressure," Naresh Mahato said. "That is why I said so."

Once again, agreement proved uncomfortable.

The meeting ended. No one asked for the Kanakjir. It was decided that people would be sent to the surrounding markets again the next morning.

After dinner that night, Jagdish Chaudhary opened his private storeroom. The jar tied with red cloth stood in a corner. He did not need to lift it; he merely placed his hand on the lid.

His wife Vimla came up behind him. "What are you looking at?"

"The seed."

"That much is obvious."

Jagdish Chaudhary said, "Everyone thinks I should distribute it."

Vimla asked, "Did everyone say so?"

"No one said it directly."

"Then how did you learn that everyone thinks so?"

Jagdish Chaudhary remained silent.

Vimla looked at the red knot on the jar. "You have been multiplying this seed for five years. Your heart is in it. If you do not give it, no one will call you a thief."

"This is not about being a thief."

"Then what is it about?"

Jagdish Chaudhary did not answer. He remembered his red ledger: three hours leaving my own work, one day leaving the fair, two sacks carried without hire. Every line now seemed very small beside the eighteen kilos in the jar.

Vimla said, "A sacrifice is written down when giving something up is difficult. What was lying useless and you gave away may count as service; whether it was a sacrifice, I do not know."

Jagdish Chaudhary said, a little annoyed, "Have you started keeping accounts too?"

Vimla laughed. "You taught me how."

The jar remained where it was that night.

At dawn, preparations began again to send out the bicycles. Manjari Devi had opened the register. Arun was repairing an old balance scale. Jagdish Chaudhary arrived as on any ordinary day, except that the key was no longer tied to his sacred thread.

Manjari Devi did not notice.

A little later, Vimla Devi came from behind. On her head was a bamboo basket, and in the basket was the jar tied with red cloth.

Jagdish Chaudhary stepped forward at once and lowered the jar. "Careful. The seal at the mouth has not been broken."

Manjari Devi understood. "All of it?"

Jagdish Chaudhary looked at the jar. "Weigh it first."

The seed was poured onto the scale. It came to a little more than eighteen kilos. Arun said, "If seventeen kilos are distributed, a little can still be saved. Keep enough for one kaththa."

The suggestion fell on Jagdish Chaudhary's ears like relief. One kaththa could preserve the variety; next year he could multiply it again. He wanted to say at once, "All right."

Just then Gudia, Rampyari Devi's daughter, arrived carrying two empty bags. She said, "Mother says that whatever falls short, we will leave half our field empty. We will not reduce anyone else's share."

Jagdish Chaudhary kept looking at the pan of the scale. Then he said, "Distribute the seed that remains as well. I will plant another rice variety in my field this year."

Arun asked, "The agricultural fair?"

Jagdish Chaudhary's hand rested for a moment on the red cloth. "The fair will be held next year too."

No one applauded. Manjari Devi simply began writing the weight beside each of the nine names in the register. Strangely, Jagdish Chaudhary liked that. The sentences he had prepared--his father's seed, five years of labour, the fair--did not need to be spoken.

The seed was distributed. It was agreed that after the harvest, any family whose crop did well would return some seed to the shared bank according to its means. No fixed burden was placed on anyone.

Jagdish Chaudhary looked into the empty jar. Only dried neem leaves remained inside. He folded the red cloth and put it into his pocket.

Manjari Devi pushed the red ledger towards him. "Write down today's service."

Jagdish Chaudhary picked up the pen. At the top of the page stood an old entry: "Rainy night: four hours, leaving my sleep." Below it was an empty space.

He wrote: "Kanakjir seed: 18 kilos 350 grams, distributed among nine families."

Manjari Devi asked, "You won't write 'leaving my own work'?"

Jagdish Chaudhary looked at her. Manjari Devi's face was serious, but laughter was held back in her eyes.

"No," he said. "The weight is enough."

Three weeks later, the fields of the lower hamlet were green. Kanakjir plants were a slightly different shade from ordinary rice, so the separate strips could be distinguished even from a distance. Jagdish Chaudhary had planted another market variety in his own field. For the first two days he looked towards that field with a sense of loss; from the third day onward, the pace of work occupied his attention.

At the end of Sawan, the agricultural extension worker came again. He asked, "No sample for the fair?"

Jagdish Chaudhary pointed towards the lower hamlet. "The sample is in nine fields now. If it is to be tested, go there."

At harvest time, the nine families returned Kanakjir seed in separate small bags. Some brought half a kilo, some one kilo; Rampyari Devi brought two kilos. The shared bank's jar filled again, but this time it did not go back to Jagdish Chaudhary's private storeroom.

Manjari Devi opened a new page and wrote: "Kanakjir: shared foundation seed."

Jagdish Chaudhary looked at the page. He ran a finger over the old red cover of the ledger, where the words "Expenditure and Service" were written.

Naresh Mahato asked with a laugh, "Chaudharyji, how much does the account of sacrifice come to this time?"

Jagdish Chaudhary almost gave his old answer--"My account is separate." But he stopped himself.

He opened the red ledger and showed the page. "Eighteen kilos three hundred and fifty grams. The rest is in the register."

Manjari Devi laughed and asked, "But that is the account of the seed."

Tying a new cloth over the mouth of the jar, Jagdish Chaudhary said, "Yes. For now, let that be enough."

Manjari Devi closed the register. Outside, rice from the nine fields was going to nine different homes, while in the shared jar the seed for the next season was gathering in one place.

The Truthful Merchant

In the old market of Madhubani town, Banshidhar Sah's shop was called "Mithila Cloth Emporium." Above the name, another line was painted in blue letters: "Whatever a thing is, that is what we shall call it."

Banshidhar Sah was prouder of that line than of the name of his shop. He used to say, "Prices may be higher or lower, but there should never be two versions of the truth."

The shop sold cloth, shawls, small panels of Mithila painting, bags, and coloured fabric for worship. Some articles were entirely handmade, some had been coloured by hand over printed outlines, and some were wholly machine-printed.

In Banshidhar Sah's own reckoning, he understood these distinctions, so they presented him with no difficulty. The difficulty began where the customer did not understand them.

At such moments Banshidhar Sah used a particular art of his own: he never said anything untrue, but neither did he answer a question that had not been asked.

For example, someone might ask, "Is this Mithila art?"

He would reply at once, "Certainly. Fish, lotus, sun, vines - all are motifs of Mithila."

If someone asked, "Is it handwork?"

He would say, "It has been coloured by hand."

Both statements were true, and Banshidhar Sah did not consider the empty space between those two statements to be a lie.

The shop's paper bags also bore a small stamp: "A Deal in Truth." Kamlesh, who had worked in the shop for five years, once asked with a laugh, "Master, does the stamp of truth go on the paper or on the goods?"

Banshidhar Sah said, "On both. But on the paper it can be seen."

In the first week of Bhadon, a new bundle arrived from Patna. The shawls were white, green, ochre, and pale yellow. Along the borders were paired fish, in the middle lotuses, and on the ends designs of the sun and moon. From a distance they looked very much like handwork.

Inside the bundle was a small slip from the supplier: "Printed outline; hand-coloured finish." Kamlesh read the slip and looked at Banshidhar Sah.

"Which section shall I put these in?"

Banshidhar Sah had made three sections. The first: "Entirely Handmade"; the second: "Hand-Finished"; the third: "Machine Print."

He had the new shawls placed in the second section.

Kamlesh opened one of the shawls and examined it. "The outlines are from a machine, the colour by hand?"

"Yes."

"Then should we write that on the label too?"

Banshidhar Sah said, "It says 'Hand-Finished.' Where is the lie?"

Kamlesh said nothing. He tied the label on.

Two days later, around noon, Pramod Jha came into the shop with his twelve-year-old daughter, Maitreyi. It was the tenth anniversary of his sister's wedding, and he wanted to send her a gift. He needed a shawl that looked beautiful but was not excessively expensive.

The moment Maitreyi entered the shop, she read the board above: "Whatever a thing is, that is what we shall call it."

She said to her father, "Babu, this looks like a shop where one has to sit an examination."

Pramod Jha laughed. "Look at the goods first. You can examine them later."

Banshidhar Sah laughed as well. He liked the child's remark. "I am ready for the examination. Questions are not forbidden in this shop."

Pramod Jha said, "I want Mithila work made by hand. My budget is not very large."

Banshidhar Sah took out two shawls from the first section. When Pramod Jha heard the prices, he fell a little silent.

Then Banshidhar Sah moved towards the second section. "Look at this. It has hand-applied colour, the motifs are beautiful, and the price is only a little more than half as much."

Maitreyi took a green shawl in her hands. The eye of the fish was round, and just to the left of it was a tiny black dot. She opened a second, yellow shawl. There too, beside the fish's eye, the same kind of dot appeared in exactly the same place.

She opened a third shawl. Again, the same dot.

Maitreyi asked, "Uncle, were all three shawls made by the same woman?"

Banshidhar Sah said, "They were worked on from the same design."

"What is her name?"

Banshidhar Sah paused for a moment. "The people who filled in the colours may be different. The supplier did not send their names."

Maitreyi looked again at the fish's eye. "This little dot is at exactly the same distance in all three. Does a hand never tremble?"

Pramod Jha looked at his daughter. "Do you learn all this at the art school?"

"Didi says hand-drawn lines may resemble one another, but they cannot be twins."

Banshidhar Sah tried to laugh. "Children look at things very closely."

Maitreyi turned the shawl over. In a few places the colour had bled through to the reverse, but the black outline was hardly visible there at all.

She asked, "Was the outline drawn by hand?"

The smile remained on Banshidhar Sah's face, but his answer came a little late. "The outline was printed first."

"And the colour?"

"The colour was filled in by hand."

"Then it is not entirely handmade?"

"I never said it was entirely handmade."

Maitreyi looked up at the board, then read the label on the shawl: "Hand-Finished."

"I did not understand what 'Hand-Finished' meant," she said. "Babu did not understand it either. You do. Then what does that line - 'Whatever a thing is, that is what we shall call it' - mean?"

Pramod Jha immediately stopped his daughter. "Speak properly."

"I am asking properly," Maitreyi said. "Uncle said he was ready for the examination."

There were two other people in the shop at that moment. For the first time, Banshidhar Sah felt that the board was not hanging high above him at all, but directly over his head.

He said, "Daughter, in business every detail cannot be written on a small label. Whoever asks, I tell them."

Maitreyi asked, "And whoever does not ask?"

"Whatever they hear from me will be true."

"But if they do not know the important thing, how will they know what question to ask?"

Before answering, Banshidhar Sah cleared his throat. "A buyer should understand a little for himself too."

Handing the shawl to her father, Maitreyi said, "Babu, I like this one. If the outline is printed and the colour filled in by hand, then it should say exactly that. I would still buy it."

Pramod Jha looked at his daughter. "What about the price?"

"The price later. First the name."

Kamlesh, who was folding cloth, lowered his face to hide a smile.

Banshidhar Sah did not like the smile. He untied the label, picked up a pen, crossed out "Hand-Finished," and wrote: "Machine-printed outline; colour filled in by hand."

The line he wrote was slightly wider than the slip of paper, so the final word dropped onto the line below.

Maitreyi read it. "Now I understand."

Pramod Jha asked the price. Banshidhar Sah quoted the same price as before. Pramod Jha bargained a little, got two hundred rupees knocked off, and bought the shawl.

The sale was complete, yet Banshidhar Sah felt nothing that resembled victory. To him it was an ordinary sale, but something remained lodged inside him.

Maitreyi took the paper bag. It bore the stamp: "A Deal in Truth." She ran a finger over the stamp and smiled, but said nothing.

That silence made Banshidhar Sah more uncomfortable than all the questions she had asked before.

After Pramod Jha and Maitreyi had left, Banshidhar Sah said to Kamlesh, "Children ask a great many questions these days."

Kamlesh replied, "There were not many questions. The label was too small."

Banshidhar Sah gave him a hard look. Kamlesh immediately began counting cloth.

A little later, a woman came in. She wanted a gift for her niece. Picking up a red shawl from the second section, she asked, "This is handmade, isn't it?"

Banshidhar Sah's old answer was ready on his tongue: "It has been coloured by hand."

He even began to say it - "It has been coloured by hand..." - but stopped halfway through the sentence.

The woman kept looking at his face.

Banshidhar Sah opened the shawl. "The outer outline is machine-printed. The colour inside has been filled in by hand. If you want something entirely hand-painted, it is in that other section; it will cost more."

The woman looked at two pieces. In the end she chose the one with the printed outline. "My niece will wear it every day. This will do perfectly."

Banshidhar Sah was surprised. Telling the whole truth had not lost him the sale. But then he felt ashamed of the surprise itself - as though he had been weighing the value of truth only on the scale of whether a sale survived it.

When the market grew quiet in the evening, he took down the labels from all three sections and laid them on the table. "Entirely Handmade" was

clear. "Machine Print" was clear too. The middle label, "Hand-Finished," suddenly seemed to him like smoke.

He read the supplier's original slip again: "Printed outline; hand-coloured finish."

Kamlesh asked, "Shall we change them all?"

"All of them."

"There will be a lot of labels to write."

"We will write them."

"It will take until tomorrow."

Banshidhar Sah said, "The old wording will also remain until tomorrow. That is why we shall write them today."

The two of them sat down. On the label for the first section they wrote in black letters: "Entirely hand-painted; artist's name included." Wherever a name was available, it was added to the back of each article.

On the second section: "Outline printed; colour filled in by hand."

On the third: "Entirely machine-printed."

The labels became longer, and the shop's display looked a little less elegant. For the first time, Banshidhar Sah liked that lack of elegance.

Then his eyes went to the board above: "Whatever a thing is, that is what we shall call it."

He pulled over a chair, climbed onto it, and took the board down. Kamlesh was startled. "Is this going too?"

"It is not going."

Banshidhar Sah fixed an empty strip beneath the board. After thinking for a long while, he wrote: "What you need to know before buying, we will tell you without waiting to be asked."

Kamlesh read it and said, "This line is longer than the first one."

"Truth does not have to fit into a short sentence."

Kamlesh did not laugh at that answer. He hung the board back up.

The first customer the next morning was a young man from Darbhanga. He wanted a Mithila-work shawl for his sister. He was in a hurry and said, "Show me handwork. I have a train to catch."

Banshidhar Sah reached towards a shawl in the second section. His old habit said: show the beautiful article first; if questions come, explain the details afterward.

His hand stopped halfway.

He opened an article from the first section. "This is entirely hand-painted; the artist's name is written on the back. It is expensive."

Then he opened one from the second. "Here the outline is printed and the colour filled in by hand. It costs less."

And then the third. "This is entirely printed. It is cheaper for everyday use."

The young man looked at all three, chose the second, and said, "Yes, this is exactly the kind I wanted."

As Banshidhar Sah made out the bill, he raised his eyes. The letters on the new strip had not yet dried completely; at one spot a tiny gleam of wet ink remained.

On the bill he wrote the description of the article: "Outline printed, colour filled in by hand." Then he wrote the price.

A paper bag lay beside the table. Its old stamp still said: "A Deal in Truth."

Banshidhar Sah picked up the bag, looked at the stamp for a moment, and this time felt no need either to cover it or to explain it.

A Receipt for Merit

Even after retiring from the cooperative store, Ramanand Chaudhary could not give up the habit of keeping accounts. The sacks of rice, tins of oil, and credit ledgers had passed out of his hands, but a red-bound register had now taken their place on his table.

On the cover of the register, in his own handwriting, were the words: "Account of Merit."

The first time his wife Saroj saw it, she burst out laughing. "What new business is this?"

Pushing his spectacles higher on his nose, Ramanand said, "Keeping accounts of money is prudence; keeping accounts of good deeds is memory. People do good and then forget it."

Saroj said, "And what is lost if a good deed is forgotten?"

"Nothing is lost, but the account remains incomplete."

The register had five columns: date, deed, expenditure, witness, and merit-points.

Ramanand had also devised rules for awarding points. Helping an old person cross the road earned two points; taking medicine to a sick neighbour's house, five; lifting chairs at a wedding without being asked, three; and giving food to a poor family, anywhere from ten to fifty points according to the expense.

Saroj had once asked, "Who decided these points?"

"Experience."

"Whose experience?"

Ramanand thought for a moment and said, "Mine."

The family regarded the register as a game, but to Ramanand it was no game. At the end of every month he added up the points. At the end of the year he turned back through the old pages. If a deed had no witness's name beside it, he grew uneasy.

That was why he had small receipts printed. Each slip said, "Assistance received." Below it were spaces for name, date, and a signature or thumb impression.

When Saroj saw the bundle of receipts, she clutched her head. "People will be in distress, and you will take their thumb impressions?"

"Not a thumb impression. Proof."

"Proof for whom?"

"For the future."

"Whose future?"

Ramanand closed the register. "You find a joke in everything."

Behind Ramanand's house ran a narrow lane. Across it stood Basanti Devi's mud-and-brick house. Her husband had died long ago. She lived with her grandson Niranjan, who was in the eighth class.

Basanti Devi's courtyard lay low. Rainwater entered it in the monsoon, but an old drain along the side of the lane used to carry the water away towards the pond.

Two rooms at the front of Ramanand's house were rented out. After retirement he thought that if the veranda were extended a little, a third small shop could be made. A mason was called, and a brick platform was extended for seven cubits.

The old drain ran along the edge of that platform. The mason said, "Babu, the drain will narrow here."

Ramanand replied, "Put a pipe through it. The water will pass."

The pipe was laid, the platform built, and an advance for the third room was received as well. Ramanand entered no merit-points for this successful arrangement, because this was business.

The first two rains of Sawan passed without trouble. On the third night, clouds closed in. Until midnight, rain drummed in one unbroken note on thatch, tin, and leaves.

At dawn, Niranjan came and stood at Ramanand's gate. His feet were caked with mud.

"Grandfather, Grandmother is calling you."

Ramanand took an umbrella and went over. The water in Basanti Devi's courtyard was not knee-deep, but it reached the ankles. Paddy stored along one side of the room was soaked, two bedrolls were wet, and the earthen stove had softened and caved in.

Basanti Devi said nothing. She was lifting the soaked sacks to higher ground.

Ramanand sprang into action at once. He had two plastic sheets brought from his house, sent over a sack of rice, and asked two young men from the neighbourhood to spread the bedding out in the sun.

By noon, the water had receded.

A familiar warmth of satisfaction rose in Ramanand's heart. He returned home and opened the register.

He entered the date. In the deed column he wrote: "Food and sheet assistance to Basanti Devi during the rain emergency." He added up the

expense. In the witness column he wrote Nirnanjan's name. Beside merit-points he first wrote forty, then paused and changed it to fifty.

He filled out one of the receipt slips as well.

Saroj watched him. "Will you take her thumb impression now?"

"The water has gone down. What difficulty is there now?"

"There is this difficulty too--" Saroj stopped, then changed her words. "The difficulty is that her paddy is still wet."

Ramanand put the slip in his pocket.

In the evening he went to Basanti Devi's house. A piece of the plastic sheet had been tied over a leak in the roof. Nirnanjan had spread his wet books separately to dry.

Ramanand took out the slip. "This is only for my accounts. Put your thumb impression here."

Basanti Devi looked at the slip. "Does it say I owe you money?"

"No, no. Assistance. Nothing has to be returned."

"Then why the thumb impression?"

"I keep an account of what I do."

Basanti Devi looked at Nirnanjan. "I cannot read. You read it."

Nirnanjan read the slip. Then he asked, "Grandfather, will you also write where this water came from?"

Ramanand's hand stopped. "From the rain. Where else?"

"The water could not get out through the drain."

"That happens in the rains."

"It never happened like this before."

Ramanand folded the slip and put it back in his pocket. "Would children remember how the rains used to be?"

Nirnanjan said nothing. He led him to the mouth of the lane. In front of the pipe running beneath the new platform, leaves, plastic, and silt were jammed together. The mouth of the pipe sat half a level higher than the drain. Water from the lane had backed up there and turned towards Basanti Devi's courtyard.

Ramanand tried to clear the silt with a stick. A little water flowed out, then stopped again.

"This is the mason's mistake," he said.

Nirnanjan asked, "Whose platform is it?"

Ramanand looked at him. There was no taunt in the boy's voice. He was only asking a question.

The mason was called the next day. After examining the pipe, he said, "I told you then that the drain would become too narrow. The pipe does not have enough fall. It cannot carry a large volume of water all at once."

Ramanand frowned. "Then what is the remedy?"

"Restore the old width. This side of the platform will have to be broken."

"How much of it?"

The mason indicated a line seven cubits long. Half the wall of the new shop stood on that stretch.

Ramanand fell silent.

Gopal Mandal was to rent the new shop. Ramanand had already used Gopal's advance to replace the roof of his house. If the shop were demolished, the question of returning the advance would arise. Then there would be the separate cost of the platform and the wall.

Ramanand asked the mason, "What if we put in a wider pipe?"

"Its mouth needs to be lower. Without removing the bricks, the slope cannot be made."

"Can we turn it the other way?"

"The other way is Sharmaji's courtyard."

For the first time Ramanand understood that water takes no one's side; block one path, and it looks for another.

Even so, he could not bring himself to decide.

That afternoon he opened the register. The fifty merit-points seemed to gleam at him. It occurred to him that the number now looked slightly crooked.

In pencil, he wrote in the margin: "Drain under examination."

Saroj read it. "Who is examining it?"

"The mason."

"The mason has already told you."

"One mason's word is not final."

Saroj said nothing. She slid the bundle of receipts farther under the register.

The next day Ramanand brought a second mason. The second mason said the same thing: restore the old drain.

On the third day, Harinarayan Paswan, an elderly man who had long overseen the village's drainage work, was called. Leaning on his stick, he measured the lane, studied the slope, and traced the old line towards the pond.

"I dug this drain when I was a young man," he said. "The water used to run straight through here. That platform is sitting on its chest."

Ramanand did not like the word "chest." "Is this a government drain or a private one?"

Harinarayan laughed. "Water does not read government papers before it flows."

By evening the matter had spread through the neighbourhood. There was no quarrel, but people kept coming to look at the lane. One poked a stick

into the pipe, another recalled how wide the old drain had been, and another simply stared at the new wall.

Ramanand disliked this silence. An open accusation could be answered; silence was harder to answer.

He went to Basanti Devi again. "If you wish, I will also pay for the paddy that was spoiled."

Basanti Devi said, "We can settle the paddy later. Open the water's path first."

"But I am helping you."

"Thank you for the help. But it will rain again."

The word "thank you" gave Ramanand a little comfort, but the last sentence took that comfort away.

That night he sat for a long time with the register open. He turned back through the old pages.

At one place he had written: "Bamboo for Ramphal Kaka's roof--twenty points." He remembered that the bamboo had fallen while the boundary ridge of his field was being cut, and Ramphal Kaka had simply carried it away.

Elsewhere: "Examination fee for Dulari's son--thirty points." He remembered that Dulari had worked in his house for three months and had still not received half her wages; the examination fee had been paid out of that very money.

A third entry read: "Meal for labourer in the rain--ten points." The labourer had been building Ramanand's own wall.

Sweat appeared on Ramanand's forehead, although the night was cool.

For the first time he began to see his own debts beside the good deeds in the register.

At dawn, Nirnanjan was sweeping water out of the lane. There had been a light rain in the night, and the pipe had clogged again.

Ramanand called to him. "How much of your grandmother's paddy was soaked?"

"About one sack."

"I will pay for it."

Nirnanjan stopped sweeping. "Grandmother said: the drain first."

"If I open the drain, my shop will have to be broken."

The boy remained silent.

Ramanand himself added, "Gopal's advance will have to be returned too."

Nirnanjan was silent again.

"Do you think all this is easy?"

"No."

"Then?"

"I did not say anything."

That answer stung Ramanand more than he had expected. He needed an opponent for his argument; the boy refused to become one.

That afternoon Gopal Mandal was called. Ramanand told him everything. Gopal was disappointed at first, then asked, "So the shop will not be built?"

"Not in this form."

"And the advance I gave you?"

"You will get all of it back. I used the advance to replace the roof, so give me some time, but I will return the money."

Gopal was silent for a long while. "I will find another room. But when you break the wall, give me the bricks. One side at the back of my house is unfinished."

The words slipped out of Ramanand's mouth: "The price of the bricks--"

He stopped.

"Take them," he said.

The mason came. When the first hammer blow landed on the fresh plaster, Ramanand closed his eyes without meaning to. The platform had been built with his money, the plan had been his, and the pride in it had been his too.

A section of the wall came down. The bricks were stacked separately. The pipe was removed. Beneath it, the black earth of the old drain appeared.

Harinarayan Paswan stood there leaning on his stick. He said, "Now the path can be seen."

Ramanand did not answer him.

Within three days, the drain had been restored to its old width. A low barrier was built along the edge of the platform so that no one would fall in. The plan for the new shop was abandoned.

For those three days Ramanand did not open the register.

On the evening of the fourth day, dark clouds gathered again. Ramanand set a chair on the veranda and sat down. Saroj said, "You never used to be this eager to watch the rain."

Ramanand did not reply.

The rain grew heavy. The lane filled, then a stream rushed through the open mouth of the drain towards the pond. Spray reached the edge of Basanti Devi's courtyard, but no water collected there. Niranjan waved from the veranda.

Ramanand raised his hand without thinking.

That night he opened the register. He placed his pen on the line that carried the fifty merit-points. First he struck out "50." Then beside the deed he wrote: "Food and sheets--the beginning of compensation for damage."

Below it he made a new entry: "Old drain reopened; platform removed; Gopal's advance returned."

He left the merit-points column blank.

After a while, Niranjan's name came to mind for the witness column. The pen did not move.

He was about to close the register when Saroj asked, "Did you forget the points?"

Ramanand said, "This was not a matter for points."

"Then what kind of matter was it?"

He opened the register again. At the end of the deed he added two more words: "My debt."

Saroj read them and said nothing.

The bundle of receipts lay in a corner of the table. On the top slip, Basanti Devi's name had been filled in halfway; the space for the thumb impression was blank. Ramanand picked up the slip, looked at it for a while, and did not tear it up.

He placed the blank receipt between the pages of the register at the very place where the merit-points column had been left empty.

The next morning, the night's rain still ran as a thin stream through the drain. The receipt between the pages was dry paper; it bore no one's thumb impression, no one's thanks, and for the first time in Ramanand's accounts, that empty space seemed clearer than anything else.

The Respectable Family

For many years a framed notice had hung in the sitting room of Vinaykant Jha's house. Inside it were seven lines: Speak softly; do not interrupt; remember a guest's name; wait your turn at mealtimes; keep things in their proper place; say thank you; and never insult anyone.

Beneath the frame stood Vinaykant's old chair. Even after retiring from school, whenever he sat in it, the voice of a headmaster came out of him almost by itself.

"Civility is no grand thing," he would say again and again. "It is the sum of small acts of conduct."

His wife, Manorama Devi, had heard this sentence so many times that sometimes, before Vinaykant had finished half of it, she would complete the rest for him.

Their son Anshuman would laugh and say, "Father's eighth rule: read the seven rules every day."

Vinaykant would glare at him, but the smile would escape despite his efforts.

That year Vinaykant and Manorama were about to complete forty years of marriage. The family decided there would be a small gathering at home.

Everyone agreed on the word "small," but the guest list reached thirty-seven names.

Manorama said, "And you call this small?"

Vinaykant replied, "Where our own people are concerned, numbers are not counted."

Anshuman glanced quietly at Richa. Richa suppressed a laugh.

Their granddaughter Ira was given charge of making the name cards. Her handwriting was beautiful, and she liked cutting paper and giving it coloured borders.

Vinaykant gave special instructions. "Do not shorten anyone's name. 'Bablu' and 'Guddu' are household nicknames; the cards must carry full names. A person's name is a matter of respect."

Ira began copying the list into a blue notebook.

"Kaushalya Kaki -- full name?"

"Kaushalya Mishra," Manorama answered at once.

"Anant Mama?"

"Anantkumar Jha," Anshuman said.

"Mithilesh Dada?"

"Mithileshchandra Chaudhary. Do not drop the 'Chandra,'" Vinaykant added.

For two hours they discussed names, relationships, ages, and the order of seating. Of the thirty-seven people, Vinaykant remembered the full names of thirty-five. For the other two he pulled out old invitation cards and checked.

Ira finished the list and turned the page.

"There will be one more card."

Richa asked, "Who is left?"

Ira looked towards the kitchen. "Kaki."

For a few moments silence spread through the room.

Manorama spoke first. "Yes, make one for her too. If she is in the house, her name should be there."

Ira held her pen ready. "Full name?"

Manorama looked at Vinaykant.

Vinaykant looked at Anshuman.

Anshuman looked at Richa.

Richa put a hand to her forehead and tried to think. "I... I call her Kaki."

Ira said, "So do I. What is her name?"

Manorama said with some hesitation, "I think it may be Malti."

Anshuman said, "Malti was the woman who used to come before her."

"Then Shanti?"

"Shanti Mausi comes to sew clothes."

Vinaykant's brows tightened. "Didn't we call her Dulari's mother?"

Richa burst out laughing. "Dulari is her daughter. That still does not give us her name."

Ira left a blank line in the blue notebook.

Vinaykant raised his eyes towards the third rule in the frame: "Remember a guest's name."

"She isn't a guest," Anshuman said.

The sentence sounded wrong even to his own ears as soon as he had said it.

Trying to move the conversation on, Manorama said, "Look in the monthly accounts notebook. Richa writes it."

Richa brought a brown-bound notebook from the cupboard. They turned the pages one by one.

Rice, milk, vegetables, laundry, gas, puja supplies -- everything had a name.

On the line for monthly household work was written: "Kaki -- full month."

The next month: "Kaki -- two days' leave."

The month after that: "Kaki -- advance, five hundred."

In six years of notebooks, her name did not appear even once.

Ira asked, "You all pay her wages, but you don't write down her name?"

Richa closed the notebook. "We will from now on."

Vinaykant said, "First we must learn the name."

The list of thirty-seven names lay on the table. One blank line was more conspicuous than all the rest.

By noon, guessing the name had become a little game in the house. Manorama vaguely remembered something like 'Chandra.' Anshuman thought it might be 'Kamla.' Richa said she had once seen something on a bank slip, but could not remember it.

Ira put a question mark beside every guess.

"Such a respectable family," she said with a smile, "and four opinions about one name."

Vinaykant said, "No mockery. We have understood the mistake. That is enough."

Just then the courtyard gate opened.

Carrying a basket of greens at her hip and an old cloth bag in one hand, the woman entered whom the five members of the household called in five different ways.

Manorama called out, "Kaki, come here."

Ira pressed her lips together.

The woman stood at the threshold of the sitting room. "What happened?"

Vinaykant sat up straight in his chair. The question was so simple that its very formality struck him as strange.

"What is your full name?"

The woman looked first at Ira and then at the name cards spread across the table.

"Today? After all these years?"

Manorama laughed in embarrassment. "We are making name cards."

"Chandrakala Mandal."

Ira wrote at once: Chandrakala Mandal.

Vinaykant repeated it. "Chandrakala Mandal."

Chandrakala said, "I told you on the very first day."

Vinaykant fell silent.

"Then you said, 'Fine, we'll call you Kaki.' I thought the matter of my name had been settled there and then."

Anshuman pretended to cough. Richa began straightening the cards on the table.

Ira asked, "Do you know all our full names?"

Chandrakala set the basket down. "Why wouldn't I?"

One by one she recited them: "Vinaykant Jha, Manorama Devi, Anshuman Jha, Richa Jha, Ira Jha."

Anshuman laughed and asked, "In my 'Anshuman,' is the 'sh' written with sha or ṣa?"

"Sha. I have carried your medicine prescriptions, insurance papers, and post inside so many times."

Vinaykant's eyes went once more to the framed rules.

Chandrakala picked up the basket. "Shall I wash the greens now?"

Manorama said, "Yes, Chandrakala Devi."

Chandrakala stopped at the threshold and laughed. "It is good that you know my name now, but you do not have to say 'Devi' five times in a single breath."

Ira burst into laughter. Even Vinaykant could not suppress a smile.

From that day, a few awkward changes began in the house. Manorama would pause before saying "Kaki" and then say "Chandrakala." Twice Richa slipped and called her "Chandra," then corrected herself.

One day Anshuman called from a distance, "Hey, listen," and Ira shouted from the sitting room, "Eighth rule!"

"Which eighth rule?"

"Now that you know someone's name, call them by it."

Vinaykant took Ira's side. "That is a good rule."

From the veranda Chandrakala called back, "Make fewer rules. Remember more."

Five days before the gathering Chandrakala told Richa, "That day I can stay only until twelve. At one there is a parents' meeting at my grandson's school."

Richa was measuring flour. "Yes, all right."

Chandrakala said again, "The meal is at one, isn't it?"

"Yes, but I'll see to it."

The matter ended there.

On the night before the gathering, the sitting room was full of coloured name cards. Ira was arranging them not alphabetically but in seating order. Chandrakala's card was placed beside Manorama's.

When Manorama saw it, she asked, "Why is this here?"

Ira said, "There are name cards for everyone."

Manorama replied, "But she'll be serving."

Ira said nothing. She did not move the card.

The bustle began early in the morning: rugs in the courtyard, chairs on the veranda, three stoves in the kitchen, and a tray of flowers in the sitting room.

Chandrakala had arrived before time. She rolled balls of dough for the puris, arranged bowls of yoghurt, washed betel leaves, and, at Manorama's request, checked the salt twice.

Vinaykant welcomed each guest by name.

"Come in, Mithileshchandra Babu."

"Kaushalya Didi, your chair is here."

"Anantkumar, after such a long time."

There was satisfaction in his voice at the order he had created.

At half past eleven Ira showed Chandrakala her name card near the kitchen door. "Your seat is ready."

Chandrakala laughed. "If I sit down, who will take out the puris?"

"I will."

"You'll be tired after taking out two puris."

"Try me."

At twelve Chandrakala washed her hands, picked up her cloth bag, and went to Richa. "I'm leaving."

Richa was startled. "Now? Serving is just about to begin."

Chandrakala looked at her. "I told you five days ago."

Richa was holding the serving spoon. The conversation came back to her.

"Yes... you did say so. But I thought perhaps a little later --"

"The school meeting is at one. My grandson said, 'Nani, if you don't come, I'll have to sit there alone.'"

Manorama too came over. "On a day like today, couldn't you stay a little longer..."

Before she could finish, Ira said, "Dadi, you remembered her name but forgot what she told you?"

Manorama glared at Ira but did not answer.

From a distance Vinaykant understood that something was happening and came over. Richa explained quietly.

He asked Chandrakala, "When will you be back?"

"Not today. After the meeting I am going to my daughter's."

"All right."

Manorama looked at him. "Then who will serve?"

Rolling up the sleeves of his kurta, Vinaykant said, "Whoever has a free pair of hands."

Ira immediately picked up two plates. Anshuman was called in. Richa took charge of the kitchen.

Chandrakala had reached the gate when Vinaykant called out, "Chandrakala!"

She turned.

"What is your grandson's name?"

Chandrakala smiled a little. "Nishant."

"I hope the meeting goes well."

"It will."

She left.

Once the meal began, the household's well-mannered order was thoroughly tested during the first half hour. Anshuman spilled dal into one guest's plate. Twice Ira had to run when the puris ran short. With a water lota in one hand and a bowl in the other, Vinaykant went on calling people by name until he forgot his own chair altogether.

Mithileshchandra Chaudhary laughed and asked, "Where has the serving squad gone today?"

The old answer came to Vinaykant's lips: "Our Kaki is on leave..."

He stopped.

"Chandrakala Mandal has gone to her grandson's school," he said. "Today it is our own hands that are being tested."

Mithileshchandra said, "So on your fortieth wedding anniversary you are learning self-reliance as well."

Laughter rose. The conversation moved on.

By late afternoon the meal was over. Ira began gathering the name cards from the table. A drop of yoghurt stained Kaushalya Mishra's card. Anantkumar's was bent. Vinaykant's had a splash of dal on it.

Chandrakala Mandal's card lay clean. No one had sat in her chair.

Ira put the card aside.

When Chandrakala came the next morning, the house was quiet like any ordinary day. Two chairs from the day before were still lying overturned on the veranda.

Manorama asked, "Did Nishant's meeting go well?"

"Yes. The teacher said he is doing well in his studies; his handwriting needs improvement."

Vinaykant came out of the sitting room. He had the brown accounts notebook in his hand.

"Chandrakala, one minute."

He opened the notebook and showed her the new line for the month's household work. The old lines all said "Kaki." The new line was blank.

"Write your name yourself. I don't want to get the spelling wrong again."

Chandrakala took the pen and slowly wrote: "Chandrakala Mandal."

Vinaykant looked at the handwriting. "You write beautifully."

"I studied up to Class Five. I still haven't forgotten how to write my own name."

She handed the pen back.

Ira came running in from inside. In her hand was the clean name card from the day before.

"This is yours."

Chandrakala read the card. "You're giving it to me?"

"Yes."

"I'll show it to Nishant. He'll say, 'Nani's name has been written as beautifully as if it were printed.'"

She carefully slipped the card into her bag.

Ira put the other thirty-seven cards into a small wooden box that would stay in the cupboard until the next family gathering.

The brown accounts notebook remained open on the table. Through six years of entries, the same word appeared again and again: "Kaki." Beneath them, on the line for the new month, a full name appeared for the first time: "Chandrakala Mandal."

Vinaykant wrote the wage amount in the next box. Then for a few moments he kept looking at the empty space, as though even after writing down a name there was still a great deal left to ask.

The Preaching Traveller

At Laheriasarai bus stand, the morning sunlight had not yet fully settled. Steam from tea, bus exhaust, and the voices of travellers mingled with one another.

Shashibhushan Pathak stood a little apart from the crowd. In one hand he carried a cloth bag, under his arm an old umbrella, and in the upper pocket of his kurta a blue pen.

He was going to Madhubani.

As soon as the bus arrived, people surged toward the door all at once.

Shashibhushan raised a hand. "Let those getting off alight first. Those boarding can come after."

Two passengers stopped. Three ignored him and pushed ahead.

Shashibhushan raised his voice a little. "If we keep a queue, we'll save five minutes."

Ramlochan Sah, standing behind him, laughed. "Babuji, the bus will leave, but the queue will survive."

"It would only leave us behind if it ran on time," Shashibhushan replied.

The conductor stood by the door, fanning himself with his ticket book. "Come, come. There's room inside."

Shashibhushan said, "If there's room, people will board on their own. What's the need to shove them?"

The conductor looked him up and down. "You get in first, Babuji. Everyone else will improve behind you."

Inside the bus, Shashibhushan sat in one of the two seats by the window. He placed his bag on the other seat, then immediately picked it up and put it on his lap.

Ramlochan came in and noticed. "So the rule has already been applied to yourself first?"

"A rule begins with oneself," Shashibhushan said.

Ramlochan sat in the adjoining seat. In his hand was a small bundle tied in cloth.

The bus kept filling. An elderly woman set her bamboo basket beside the aisle.

Shashibhushan immediately said, "Mother, if the basket stays here, someone may trip over it."

The old woman said, "If I put it down below, the greens inside will get crushed."

"Then keep it to the side under the seat. The aisle should remain clear."

Ramlochan said softly, "Did you board the bus, or have you come to run it?"

Shashibhushan suppressed a smile. "If people do their own part properly, no one gets the chance to tell them what to do."

The engine roared. The conductor slapped the side by the door to signal the driver.

"Tickets first," Shashibhushan said. "Once the bus starts, people will stand up to take out money, then there'll be pushing and shoving."

The conductor raised his ticket book. "I'll begin with you."

"One for Madhubani."

Shashibhushan had already kept the exact fare separate. The conductor counted the money and tore off a ticket.

Shashibhushan checked the printed number, checked the date, then folded the ticket twice and tucked it into the upper pocket of his kurta behind the blue pen.

"See?" he said to Ramlochan. "Keep the ticket safe until the journey ends. It may seem a small thing, but it prevents disputes."

Ramlochan shoved his ticket into the lower pocket of his kurta. "I don't know so much procedure."

The bus set off.

At the first bend, a young man got up and tried to make his way toward the driver.

Shashibhushan said, "Don't move back and forth while the bus is in motion. What do you need?"

The young man said, "The window glass is stuck. I wanted to tell the conductor."

"Tell him from where you're sitting."

The young man stared at Shashibhushan for a moment, then called out, "Brother, the window won't slide."

From a distance the conductor replied, "I'll look at it at the next stop."

Satisfied, Shashibhushan leaned back against his seat.

A little farther on, loud music rose from the back of the bus. Two young men were listening to songs on a small audio device.

Shashibhushan turned and said, "It isn't reasonable to assume that every passenger likes the same song."

One of the young men lowered the volume a little. "Now?"

"Still too loud."

The volume went down further.

Looking out of the window, Ramlochan said, "By the time we reach Madhubani, you'll have turned the bus into a meditation room."

"What's wrong with peace?"

"Nothing. But this is a bus."

Shashibhushan did not answer.

Before Sakri, a stretch of road was broken up. The bus lurched forward. The old woman's basket slid out from under the seat and into the aisle again.

Shashibhushan bent down and picked it up. "I told you, keep it somewhere it won't slide."

The old woman held out her hands. "Give it to me. I'll keep it on my lap."

"It'll be heavy on your lap. Ramlochanji, move your bundle a little to the side."

Ramlochan lifted his bundle. Shashibhushan wedged the basket into the empty space between two seats and put Ramlochan's bundle up on the mesh luggage rack.

As he did so, his kurta brushed against the edge of the seat. The blue pen slipped slightly outward. He pushed it back into the pocket.

"Now the aisle is clear," he said.

The old woman silently checked her greens.

At Sakri Chowk the bus stopped. Three passengers got off and five boarded.

The moment Shashibhushan saw the crowd at the door, he called out again, "One at a time!"

The conductor laughed. "Babuji, I'll pay half your fare. You're doing half my job."

Laughter spread through the bus.

Shashibhushan said, "Make your jokes, but order is for everyone's convenience."

A newly boarded woman was carrying a bag of medicines. She was looking for an empty place by the window.

Ramlochan stood up. "You sit here."

The woman sat down. Ramlochan stood beside Shashibhushan's seat.

Shashibhushan said, "If you're standing, hold the rail. You could fall on a bend."

Ramlochan took hold of the rail. "The command has been obeyed."

Laughter broke out in the bus again.

A trace of displeasure crossed Shashibhushan's face, but he remained silent.

After Sakri the bus picked up speed. Fields, ponds, and small markets fell behind.

After a while, the conductor began checking everyone's tickets once more. He had received word that a transport inspection team was stationed ahead on the road.

"Keep your tickets in hand," he called out.

Shashibhushan immediately looked at Ramlochan. "Heard that? That's why you keep the ticket safe until the journey ends."

He put his hand into his upper pocket.

The blue pen was there. The ticket was not.

He reached in again, running his fingers into every corner of the pocket.

Nothing.

Ramlochan watched carefully. "What happened?"

"Nothing."

Shashibhushan felt through his lower pocket. A handkerchief came out. A small key came out. No ticket.

He opened his bag. Inside were a tin of betel nut, two papers, a gamchha, and the invitation card he was to deliver in Madhubani.

No ticket.

The conductor reached him. "Show me your ticket."

Shashibhushan said, "One moment."

The conductor paused.

It seemed as though every eye in the bus had lifted toward him at once.

Ramlochan suppressed a cough and turned toward the window.

Shashibhushan emptied and searched the bag again. He looked under the seat.

"Your ticket?" the conductor asked.

"I had kept it."

"Where?"

"In this pocket."

The conductor looked at the blue pen. "The pen is there. The ticket isn't."

From the back, one of the young men said softly, "Lower the volume."

His friend burst out laughing.

Shashibhushan turned to look. The young man immediately sealed his lips.

The conductor said, "I gave you the ticket. I remember. You even checked the date."

Shashibhushan's ears grew hot. "Memory is one thing; proof is another."

"Then look for it."

Meanwhile the bus pulled over at the roadside. An inspector climbed aboard.

The conductor followed behind him with the ticket book in hand.

"Everyone show your ticket."

The inspection proceeded row by row.

Shashibhushan was still running his hand beneath the seat.

The old woman lifted her basket. "Look under here."

There were a few dry leaves, but no ticket.

Ramlochan took his bundle down from the luggage rack. "Could it have fallen here?"

"Why are you taking the bundle down? Let everything stay in its proper place," Shashibhushan said.

Ramlochan looked at him. "I'm looking for your ticket."

Shashibhushan fell silent.

The inspector reached him. "Ticket?"

Shashibhushan sat upright. "It's lost."

The bus went so quiet that the vibration of the engine could be clearly heard.

The inspector looked at the conductor.

The conductor said, "I gave him a ticket. He paid the exact fare. The number... the number will be in the book."

The inspector examined the counterfoil in the ticket book. "All right. Next."

Shashibhushan looked startled. "That's all?"

The inspector turned back. "The conductor confirms it. There's a counterfoil as well."

"But I don't have the ticket with me."

"It's lost. The fare was paid."

"What does the rule say?"

The inspector raised an eyebrow. "Do you want to read the rules, or do you want to reach Madhubani?"

A few passengers laughed.

Shashibhushan did not. "If showing the ticket is compulsory, then I ought to pay the fare again."

The conductor said, "Why? I remember you."

"A system cannot run on memory."

Ramlochan said softly, "And for the sake of the system, the bus is standing here."

Shashibhushan glared at him.

The woman with the medicine bag checked her watch. "I have an appointment for a test in Madhubani."

At that sentence, Shashibhushan's eyes moved to her.

The inspector said, "There is a counterfoil, the conductor recognizes you, and a fellow passenger saw it. In this situation, no second fare is due. Now let the bus move."

Shashibhushan looked uncertain. The strictness he was insisting on was now consuming other people's time.

The conductor signalled the driver. The bus moved again.

The inspector got off at the next stop.

For a few moments, no one said anything to Shashibhushan.

He closed his bag, put the handkerchief back inside, and put the key back. The blue pen went once more into the upper pocket.

Ramlochan lifted his bundle to put it back overhead.

A thin piece of paper was caught in the bundle's cord.

"What's this?" Ramlochan asked as he loosened the cord.

The moment he pulled the paper free, Shashibhushan's eyes fell on it.

The same colour, the same folds, the same printed number.

The ticket.

Ramlochan straightened it. "Madhubani."

From a distance the conductor shouted, "Found Babuji's official gazette?"

Laughter rose again.

Shashibhushan took the ticket. One corner had been bent where the cord had pressed against it.

He remembered: while moving the old woman's basket, he had put Ramlochan's bundle on the rack. That was when his kurta had rubbed against the edge of the seat.

The ticket must have slipped out of his pocket and become caught in the bundle's cord.

Ramlochan said, "Now you have both proof and memory."

Shashibhushan kept looking at the ticket.

The young man at the back switched on the audio device again, but the volume was very low.

Shashibhushan turned. The young man's finger rested on the volume dial, ready to turn it up.

Their eyes met.

The young man asked, "Is this much all right?"

After a moment Shashibhushan said, "As long as it reaches only your ears."

The young man smiled.

Ramlochan said, "So the meditation room is closed now?"

For the first time, Shashibhushan laughed openly. "Let a little air in."

The old woman noticed two green chillies falling from her basket. She began to bend down.

Shashibhushan bent down too, but this time the word "aisle" did not leave his mouth. He picked up the chillies and put them back in the basket.

The old woman said, "Thank you."

"It's nothing."

As they approached Madhubani, the road became crowded again. The conductor told those getting off to be ready in advance.

Shashibhushan placed his bag on his lap. This time he did not put the ticket in his upper pocket; he slipped it inside the bag between the folds of the invitation card.

Ramlochan noticed. "A new rule?"

Shashibhushan said, "No. Only that the old place proved unreliable."

The moment the bus stopped at the bus stand, people outside surged toward the door. The way out was blocked again for those trying to get off.

Shashibhushan's lips parted. The old sentence was ready: "Let those getting off alight first."

He did not say it.

He slung the bag over his shoulder and reached the door. A young man outside, trying to board, was carrying a heavy sack.

Shashibhushan did not shove him back. He simply turned his body sideways and made space for the old woman.

The old woman got off with her basket. The woman with the medicine bag came out as well. Ramlochan followed behind, steadying his bundle.

Then Shashibhushan got off.

The moment his feet touched the ground, the conductor called down from above, "Babuji, you still have the ticket, don't you?"

Shashibhushan patted his bag.

"I do."

The conductor laughed. "Then I can relax now."

Shashibhushan looked up. "You can relax. But if I lose it again, don't stop the bus on my account."

The conductor looked at him for a moment, then burst out laughing.

The bus moved on.

Shashibhushan remained standing by the roadside. Inside his bag, the ticket lay safe between the folds of the invitation card. Its bent corner had not straightened.

He made no further attempt to take it out and smooth it flat.

Pure Food

In Laheriasarai, Darbhanga, the kitchen in Shashidhar Jha's house stood apart from the other rooms. Above the doorway hung a small wooden plaque: "Pure Food, Peaceful Mind."

Shashidhar had made the plaque himself. The letters were painted red, with two green leaves drawn beneath them.

He would say, "The mind becomes what the body eats. If the food is pure, the thoughts will be pure as well."

At first, the people in the house agreed with this sentence. Later, they merely listened to it.

Shashidhar Jha had many rules about food. Which field the rice came from, how old the lentils were, which oil press the oil came from, how many days old the spices were—everything was recorded in a thick ledger.

The first page of the ledger had four columns—item, source, date brought in, last date for use.

A fifth column was added later: "Doubt."

Once he wrote "doubt" against an item, that item was never allowed into the kitchen again.

Malati, his wife, had initially been pleased with this system. It protected them from adulterated market goods, reduced stale food, and cut down on waste.

But gradually the rules moved beyond food and began to reach people.

"Don't touch the pickle jar with this ladle," Shashidhar would say.

"Wash your hands again before rinsing the rice."

"Don't put the leafy greens on that stool; the market bag was kept there yesterday."

Sometimes Malati would laugh and say, "These days your eyes are on the kitchen more than mine are."

Shashidhar would reply, "If one does not keep watch, purity can collapse in a single day."

His younger brother's daughter, Neelima, lived with them. She studied at a college in town and, after returning from class, often helped Malati in the kitchen.

Once, on a blank page at the back of the ledger, Neelima wrote in pencil: "Salt—one pinch; rules—twenty-seven pinches."

Malati saw it and smiled.

When Shashidhar discovered the line, he erased it.

"Food accounts are not a place for jokes," he said.

Neelima did not reply.

Shashidhar did not confine his concern for pure food to his own home. If neighbours asked his opinion about oil, ghee, rice, or spices, he advised them with great enthusiasm.

Quite often, people benefited from his advice.

That only strengthened his belief that his vigilance about food was not merely a habit but a kind of service.

He spoke of this service himself as well.

"People run after taste," he would say. "I look for the truth of the thing."

The coming Sunday, eight or ten old acquaintances were expected at his house for a meal.

Malati began preparing two days in advance.

Shashidhar opened the ledger and made a list—arwa rice, moong dal, pumpkin, pointed gourd, lemons, homemade curd, ghani-pressed oil.

"Sweets?" Malati asked.

"Nothing from outside."

"Then kheer?"

"The milk must be fresh from that morning."

"And if the morning milk arrives late?"

"Let it be late, but not old."

Malati folded the list.

On Saturday evening, a problem arose. The family in the village that supplied the moong dal sent word that, because of the rain, no vehicle had been able to leave. No one could say for certain whether the dal would arrive by Sunday morning.

Malati said, "The dal we have at home is only two weeks old. It is perfectly good."

Shashidhar looked at the ledger.

"Its source is not recorded."

"It came from my mother's home."

"The date?"

"I don't remember the exact day."

Shashidhar shook his head. "Then not for guests."

Neelima had been listening. She said, "Are the guests going to ask for the dal's horoscope?"

Shashidhar looked at her. "You are making light of it. Purity is not a light matter."

Neelima fell silent.

At five on Sunday morning, the rain began again.

The milk arrived on time, but the moong dal did not.

Shashidhar kept pacing up and down the veranda.

At half past six Malati said, "I'll make masoor dal now. Everything is being held up."

"When was the bag of masoor opened?"

"Four days ago."

"Who filled it?"

Malati stared at him.

"I did."

"I asked because there is a different knot at the mouth of the bag."

Malati picked up the bag and looked at it. "I opened it yesterday and tied it again."

"Then why didn't you say so before?"

"Because it is not a crime."

Shashidhar's voice hardened slightly. "In a kitchen, whether a lapse is small or large, a lapse is still a lapse."

Malati's hand went still on the bag.

She remained silent for a few moments, then said, "All right. You decide."

Neelima heard the exchange from inside and came out.

"Kaki, I'll cut the vegetables."

Shashidhar immediately said, "Wash your hands first. You touched the veranda railing."

Neelima went to wash her hands. When she returned, there was nothing on her face—neither a smile nor annoyance.

At twenty past seven, Kishor Sah arrived with the dal. His clothes were soaked by the rain, and the wheels of his bicycle were caked with mud.

"There was a lot of water on the road," he said. "That's why I'm late."

Shashidhar first examined the sack.

"It hasn't got wet, has it?"

"The outer sack is a little wet, but the bag inside is dry."

Shashidhar opened the bag, took out a handful of dal, smelled it, and bit two grains between his teeth.

"It's fine."

Kishor Sah breathed a sigh of relief.

"The money?" he asked softly.

Shashidhar said, "We'll settle the account after the meal."

"I need to pick up medicine from the market on my way back now."

"I'm not leaving the work for the guests midway to settle accounts."

Kishor Sah opened his mouth to say something, then closed it again.

Neelima was standing on the veranda. She went inside, brought her purse, and put the money into Kishor Sah's hand.

"Take this. Kaka will pay me back later."

Shashidhar's brows drew together.

"It is not proper to pay without settling the account."

Neelima said, "You have already inspected the dal. The account is about the price, not its purity."

Kishor Sah took the money and left quickly.

For a few moments Shashidhar kept looking at Neelima.

"Guests are coming today," he said. "This is not a day to prolong an argument."

Neelima replied, "I didn't prolong anything. I simply didn't hold a person back."

At the word "person," Shashidhar seemed about to say something, but Malati began washing the dal and the matter ended there.

By ten o'clock the kitchen was full of aromas. The kheer was simmering, the dal carried a light scent of ginger, and the pointed gourd was cooking over a low flame.

Every time before lifting a lid, Shashidhar would ask, "The ladle is clean, isn't it?"

The first two times Malati answered him. The third time she simply held up the ladle for him to see.

The guests began arriving around eleven.

With pride Shashidhar told everyone, "The source of every item in today's meal is recorded. Nothing has been prepared outside."

An elderly acquaintance laughed and said, "Are we here to eat or sit an examination?"

Everyone laughed. Shashidhar laughed too, but immediately added, "Let the food be examined, not your stomachs."

The meal was served.

Everyone praised the dal.

"The moong is excellent," one guest said.

Shashidhar immediately began explaining its source—which village it came from, which family's field it came from, and how many days earlier the dal had been milled.

Neelima silently went around filling glasses with water.

In the middle of the meal, one guest asked, "Malati Bhauji, how did you manage so much work all by yourself?"

Malati said, "Neelima was here, so it got done."

Shashidhar added, "If the system is clear from the beginning, the work is not difficult."

Malati looked at him for a moment, then moved on to the next row of guests.

The meal ended.

The guests left pleased.

Shashidhar opened the ledger and wrote on Sunday's page: "Moong dal: satisfactory. Milk: fresh. Oil: pure. Vegetables: fine."

Then he remembered that Neelima had paid Kishor Sah.

He called Neelima.

"How much did you give him?"

Neelima told him the amount.

Shashidhar noted it in the margin of the ledger, counted out the money, and handed it to her.

"From now on, don't make a payment without asking me," he said.

Neelima took the money but did not get up.

"Kaka, may I ask you something?"

"Ask."

"Was today's meal pure?"

Shashidhar's voice relaxed. "Certainly."

"The dal?"

"Very good."

"The milk?"

"Fresh."

"The oil?"

"Fine."

For a few moments Neelima kept looking at the ledger.

"Then everything went well today."

Shashidhar thought she was going to say something more, but she stood up.

"That's all?"

Neelima turned back and said, "Yes. There is no column in the ledger for the rest."

She walked away.

Shashidhar reached out to close the ledger, but the page did not fall shut at once like a lid.

He did not like the words "the rest."

He began going over the day again in his mind.

The rain. The dal. Malati's bag. Neelima's washed hands. Kishor Sah's rain-soaked clothes. The medicine.

First he remembered the smell of the dal, and then Kishor Sah's face.

He had not thanked him for bringing the dal on time.

Nor had he asked whom the medicine was for.

He had doubted the knot Malati had tied on the bag of masoor, yet not once had he spoken a word of trust about all the labour she had put in throughout the day.

Amid these thoughts Shashidhar tried to reassure himself: "The system is one thing; behaviour is another."

But as soon as the sentence was complete, it struck him that this was a defence, not an answer.

In the evening Malati was putting the kitchen in order.

Shashidhar went inside.

The stove had gone cold. Two bowls of kheer were left in one corner.

"This kheer?" he asked.

Malati said, "Neelima and I will eat it later."

"Why didn't you eat with the guests?"

Wringing out the cloth in her hands, Malati said, "There was no time."

"I could have told you."

"You didn't."

Shashidhar searched for an answer.

Malati added, "Your attention was on the food."

The sentence was ordinary, but it brought to Shashidhar's mind the ledger lying on the table.

He said, "Eat the kheer now."

Malati did not smile. "The kitchen still has to be washed."

For the first time Shashidhar looked around as though the room were not his own. Since morning, how many hands had worked here, how many times water had been carried, how many times someone had bent to lift a vessel—there was no column for any of it in the ledger.

Silently he went to the tap and filled a bucket.

Malati looked startled. "What are you doing?"

"I'll help with the washing."

"Leave it. I'll do it."

The old sentence rose to Shashidhar's tongue: "The utensils must be washed properly."

The words did not come out.

He only said, "It has already become very late."

For a while the two of them worked in silence.

That night Shashidhar opened the ledger again.

Four remarks were already written on Sunday's page—dal, milk, oil, vegetables.

He looked at the heading of the fifth column: "Doubt."

The word he had written there so long ago seemed, that night, to be looking back at him.

He picked up his pen.

At first he thought of writing: "Behaviour."

Then he stopped.

Adding a new column would not settle the matter.

At the bottom of the page he wrote only one line: "Kishor Sah's payment was delayed when it should have been made; the reason was my stubbornness."

Once written, the line looked ugly. The rest of the writing in the ledger was straight and neat; this line leaned slightly askew.

Shashidhar did not cross it out.

The next morning Kishor Sah was again on his way toward the market. Shashidhar saw him from the doorway and called out.

Kishor stopped his bicycle.

Shashidhar came outside.

"Did you get the medicine yesterday?"

Kishor said, "Yes, I did."

"Who was it for?"

"For my mother. She had a fever."

Shashidhar nodded.

"I held you up yesterday. That was not right."

Kishor Sah looked slightly taken aback. "Let it go, Babu. I got the money."

"Neelima gave you the money. The fault was mine."

Kishor said nothing.

Shashidhar added, "The dal was good. Thank you."

This time Kishor smiled. "Next time, if it doesn't rain, I'll bring it on time."

Shashidhar said, "If it rains, then bring it on the rain's timetable."

Kishor laughed.

Shashidhar laughed too.

Back home, he looked at the wooden plaque hanging above the kitchen door: "Pure Food, Peaceful Mind."

He did not take the plaque down.

He merely wiped away the dust that had gathered beneath it with a cloth.

Inside, Malati was washing rice.

Shashidhar stopped at the doorway and, before stepping in, asked, "Is there anything I can help with?"

Malati looked at him.

"How many rules today?"

Shashidhar smiled faintly.

“Rules for food are necessary; so are rules for how we speak.”

Malati did not reply. She placed an empty bowl in his hand.

“Put the washed rice in this.”

Shashidhar took the bowl.

He did not, as he once would have, begin inspecting its rim.

The Ceremony of Forgiveness

Near Sakri in Madhubani district there was a small dairy cooperative—"Sajha Dhar Dairy Cooperative." By five in the morning, brass and steel milk cans would begin clanking in the courtyard.

Saroja Devi had been supplying milk there for five years. There were three cows in her household, though only two were in milk at any one time.

She kept the milk accounts in a red-bound notebook. How many litres went on which day, how much money it came to, how much remained unpaid—everything was entered with the date.

The cooperative's secretary, Gaurishankar Mishra, took great pride in the fact that his centre "ran by the rules."

He often said, "In the milk trade, trust is the greatest capital."

The courtyard wall, too, bore the words: "Purity and Trust."

One Monday Saroja delivered her milk. Ramesh, an employee, took a sample, fastened a paper label around the vial, and wrote down its serial number.

The crowd was larger than usual that day. Two employees were absent. It had been raining since the night before, and everyone was in a hurry.

That afternoon, a boy from the cooperative reached Saroja's house.

He said, "From today your milk will not be accepted. The test showed too much water."

At first Saroja could not understand what he meant.

"My milk?"

"Yes. The secretary said the supply is to remain stopped until it is tested again."

Saroja looked at the milk can. The morning's milk had already gone; where was the evening's milk to go now?

She asked, "What was the serial number on the sample?"

The boy had brought no paper with him.

"I don't know."

Saroja opened her red notebook. She also copied into it the serial number written on the receipt each morning. That day she had written: 72.

That evening she went to the cooperative.

Gaurishankar Babu was seated at a table inside. Two members and the test papers were before him.

Saroja asked, "Show me my sample."

Gaurishankar said, "Don't worry. It will be tested again."

"Show me the vial."

"The vial has gone to the laboratory."

"The serial number?"

Gaurishankar looked at the paper.

"Twenty-seven."

Saroja held out her receipt.

"It says seventy-two here."

A brief silence fell over the room.

Ramesh was called in. He opened the old register. The entry for the sample, too, showed 72.

Gaurishankar looked again at the test sheet. It showed 27.

"This could be a copying error," he said.

Saroja asked, "Then why was my milk stopped?"

Gaurishankar's voice softened a little.

"As a precaution."

Saroja said, "Who will pay the price of that precaution?"

She had had to sell eight litres of the evening's milk to a sweet-maker at half price. The next morning she distributed five litres among neighbouring households.

The cooperative did not accept her milk through the following day.

Then the test was done. The retained second sample bearing number 72 was found to be normal.

Number 27 belonged to another supplier, but that supplier, too, was not held at fault; it emerged that rinse water may have been left in the bottle used to hold the sample.

A meeting of the cooperative was held.

Gaurishankar Babu proposed, "A public apology should be made to Saroja Devi."

No one opposed the proposal.

One member said, "This is necessary. People should see that the cooperative admits its mistake."

Another said, "The annual meeting is only two days away. We can apologise from the stage there."

Gaurishankar liked the proposal very much.

"Where dignity has been wounded, dignity should be restored."

Saroja was informed.

She said, "I don't need a stage. Correct what is written in the register, and add the payment for those two days."

The members of the cooperative explained that a public apology was a way of restoring her honour.

Saroja said again, "Why tell people who don't know anything about it?"

Gaurishankar laughed.

"The humiliation was public."

Saroja fell silent.

In truth, the accusation had been confined to a notice on the centre's wall for a single day. Thirty or thirty-five milk suppliers had seen it. Most people in the village knew nothing about it.

Because her milk had not gone to the centre for two days, Saroja had changed her routine. In the morning she first measured the milk, delivered some to two households, and set the rest as curd. Amid all this work, the worry kept returning: would the cooperative begin accepting her milk again or not?

On the third day, when the centre's boy told her that supply would resume the next morning, Saroja asked only, "Has the register been corrected?"

The boy said, "Secretaryji says everything will be done at the meeting."

Saroja understood that her milk would be accepted again, but the matter on paper was still unresolved.

Inside the cooperative, preparations for the event proceeded with a different kind of enthusiasm. Someone suggested that two lines be written on the notice board—"Previous notice withdrawn; error in sample serial number." But Gaurishankar said that this would not make the cooperative's responsibility sufficiently clear.

One member asked, "Does Saroja Devi want to come on stage?"

Gaurishankar replied, "Shyness is natural in a matter of honour."

After that sentence, no one felt it necessary to ask her wishes again.

Preparations for the annual meeting began.

A large cloth banner was hung at the gate: "Restoration of Trust and Public Apology Ceremony."

Below it, in smaller letters, was written: "Administrative error concerning suspicion of adulteration in Saroja Devi's milk."

When Saroja arrived on the day of the programme, she stopped at the gate.

She could read her own name from a distance.

Her sister-in-law Shyama was with her. Shyama said softly, "Was it necessary to write all this?"

Saroja did not answer.

Inside, chairs had been arranged. The stage had a green cloth, a loudspeaker, two flower vases, and a frame placed in the middle.

Inside the frame was a certificate.

Saroja went closer. She read: "On the occasion of being proved completely innocent of the charge of adulterating milk..."

She did not read the rest of the line.

Gaurishankar Babu was pleased.

"Look, we are restoring your honour."

Saroja asked, "Must the word 'accusation' remain on this paper?"

"How will the apology be understood without the context?"

The programme began.

First the cooperative's accounts of income and expenditure were read out. Then came an announcement about a veterinary camp. After that the secretary said over the loudspeaker, "And now, a special moral responsibility."

Saroja was seated in the third row.

Gaurishankar stood on the stage.

He explained in detail the date on which suspicion had fallen on Saroja's milk, how the supply had been stopped, how the serial numbers had been reversed in the testing, and how the cooperative regretted the error.

People who had known nothing about the matter before now began looking at Saroja.

Two women seated at the back asked each other, "What had happened?"

The other whispered, "Something about the milk."

Gaurishankar continued, "I wish to make it clear that Saroja Devi is not at fault."

Saroja's hand tightened around her red notebook.

The sentence brought her no relief. It seemed to her that the stage first placed her inside the circle of guilt and then announced that she was being taken out of it.

The master of ceremonies called her name.

Saroja rose.

There were only five or seven steps to the stage, but all those eyes made the distance feel longer.

Gaurishankar tried to place a flower garland on her.

Saroja folded her hands and said, "No garland."

He held out the certificate.

Saroja accepted it, because refusing the paper on the stage would only create another spectacle.

The young photographer said, "Hold the paper a little higher so the words can be seen."

Saroja did not raise it.

The young man said again, "Both of you, a little closer."

Gaurishankar came and stood beside Saroja.

Then someone at the back asked, "Is she the same milk woman?"

Saroja heard the question clearly.

Gaurishankar heard it too, but said into the loudspeaker, "This incident proves that our cooperative is transparent."

There was applause.

Before moving to the next item, the master of ceremonies said once more, "Saroja Devi will now continue supplying milk to the cooperative with full honour."

An elderly man seated at the back, who had known nothing about the incident before, asked his neighbour, "For how many days had her milk been stopped?"

The other man said, "How would I know? I heard about it only today."

Saroja understood that something which could have ended in two days was now being born anew in people's memories.

Saroja came down from the stage.

Shyama came to her side.

"Shall we go home?"

Saroja said, "First, the office."

In the office, Ramesh was putting away the register.

Saroja said, "Open the page from that day."

Ramesh opened the page.

In red ink it said: "Supply stopped—suspected adulteration."

Below it, a short line had been added in blue ink: "No fault found in testing."

Saroja looked at the page for a long time.

"This is not complete."

Ramesh asked, "What should I write?"

Saroja took out her receipt.

"Write: 'Error on the cooperative's side in recording the sample serial number; supplier not at fault.'"

Ramesh looked at Gaurishankar. He had come to the office doorway.

Gaurishankar looked slightly uncomfortable.

"So much detail in the register?"

Saroja said, "There was detail on the stage."

The room fell silent again.

Gaurishankar pulled out a chair and sat down.

"Write it," he told Ramesh.

Ramesh added the line.

Saroja said again, "And the loss from those two days?"

The accounts were checked. The cooperative's rules contained no clear provision for such an error.

Gaurishankar said, "I will put it before the meeting."

Saroja opened her red notebook. She had written down the quantity for those two days and the lower price she had received.

"Put it before the meeting. Keep this copy."

She handed him the paper.

Gaurishankar took it.

His apology on the stage had lasted five minutes. This conversation in the office lasted fifteen.

Outside, the programme had begun again. A speech about animal feed was coming over the loudspeaker.

Saroja began to fold the certificate, then stopped.

Shyama asked, "Will you keep it?"

Saroja said, "Not on the wall at home."

She placed the certificate on the office table.

Gaurishankar said, "This is your certificate of honour."

Saroja looked at him.

"My honour runs on the price of my milk, not on this paper."

She did not raise her voice.

Then she walked out.

At the gate she had to pass once more beneath the same banner. Some new people were now standing there, reading her name.

One young man asked his companion, "What was the matter?"

Before answering, the other young man looked at Saroja. He knew nothing about it, yet he had already begun to guess.

Saroja did not quicken her steps.

On the road Shyama said, "They apologised, but my heart still doesn't feel lighter."

Saroja kept her red notebook tucked under her arm.

"Because the apology was less for me and more for themselves."

Having said only that, she fell silent.

The next morning she arrived at the centre with her milk as before.

Ramesh was getting the scale ready.

Gaurishankar, too, had arrived early.

The banner at the gate had been taken down.

The cloth lay folded in one corner of the office.

The small notice from the previous day was no longer on the wall either.

Ramesh turned the register toward Saroja.

The line added the day before was clearly visible: "Error on the cooperative's side in recording the sample serial number; supplier not at fault."

Below it, the amount of the two-day loss had been entered as a provisional payment due.

Saroja read the page and signed it.

Gaurishankar stood a little distance away.

He said, "About yesterday's programme..."

Saroja did not interrupt him.

Gaurishankar could not finish the sentence.

Saroja placed the milk can on the scale.

Ramesh entered the quantity.

Until the day before, the nearby notice board had been filled with the name of the ceremony. Today it had been turned around and hung with its other side facing out.

On the blank reverse side, today's milk rate had been written in chalk.

Saroja read the rate once.

Today, her name was not on that board.

The Kindhearted Master

An old mango tree stood in front of Vachaspati Jha's house.

From the right side of the tree one could see the veranda, where Vachaspati Babu often sat in the evenings drinking tea.

Whenever someone came to that veranda for the first time, Vachaspati Babu made a point of telling them the history of the house.

Which room had been built how many years ago, at whose wedding the rear veranda had been extended, and after which flood a wall had been raised again—he knew it all by heart.

There was one thing he said with particular pride.

"In my house, even the people who work here are treated like members of the family."

After saying this, his voice would soften a little.

"Look at Sumitra. It has been fifteen years now. I gave her money for medicine when she was ill, a sari for her daughter's wedding, and at my grandson's naming ceremony she stayed beside us without even being asked. There is no distinction here between one's own and an outsider."

At such moments Sumitra was usually at work in the kitchen or the courtyard.

Whether she could hear him or not was something Vachaspati Babu never bothered to find out.

Sumitra was around fifty.

She came before daybreak and, after putting away the evening meal, sometimes stayed there for the night.

Her village had once been two kos from the house.

After river erosion, she had gone to live with her daughter in the neighbourhood behind the market.

Vachaspati Babu told everyone that the doors of his house were open to Sumitra day and night.

There was, however, one thing inside the house that visitors rarely saw.

Under the back staircase, between an old grain drum and two broken wooden cots, stood Sumitra's iron trunk.

Whenever she stayed the night, she spread a mat in that corner.

Vachaspati Babu's wife, Shailaja, did not regard this as an inconvenience.

"The house is full," she would say, "and Sumitra is one of our own. She fits in wherever there is room."

After one monsoon, a large crack appeared in a wall of the old house.

The mason said a fresh coat of plaster would not be enough.

The rear portion would have to be demolished and rebuilt.

Vachaspati Babu grew excited.

For years he had wanted to preserve the old appearance of the house while modernising its interior arrangement.

His niece Neelima took charge of the architectural design.

Neelima had returned after studying in Darbhanga and now worked in Madhubani.

On the first day she arrived with a measuring tape, blank sheets of paper, and a pencil.

Vachaspati Babu took her around and showed her every room.

"This is mine, this is Shailaja's prayer room, this one is for my son and daughter-in-law, and this is my grandson's study. Two rooms upstairs for guests. The veranda should be wide."

Neelima kept moving her pencil across the page.

"The kitchen?"

"Here. It should get plenty of light."

"Storage for rice and lentils?"

"Next to the kitchen."

"And Sumitra Kaki's room?"

Vachaspati Babu fell silent for a moment.

"Hers?"

Neelima looked up.

"She does sometimes stay here at night, doesn't she?"

"She does. But why would she need a separate room? She is family. She sleeps wherever it is convenient."

Neelima's pencil stopped on the paper.

"Then what about the corner she uses now, under the stairs?"

"That will become part of the storeroom."

"And the trunk?"

"That can go into the storeroom too."

At that moment Sumitra was crossing the courtyard, washing brass utensils as she went about her work.

Her step slowed for an instant, then returned to its usual pace.

Neelima asked again, "And if she stays the night?"

Vachaspati Babu laughed.

"Oh, the house will be so large. She can sleep anywhere. Do you count rooms for your own people?"

From a distance Shailaja called out, "There will be a small veranda outside the kitchen, won't there? It will have plenty of air too."

Neelima said nothing.

On the plan she drew a small rectangle and wrote above it: "Utility Room."

That evening Sumitra opened her trunk.

Inside were two saris, an old blanket, a photograph from her daughter's wedding, packets of medicine, and a small brass box.

She folded everything neatly and put it back.

Then she measured the length of the trunk with the span of her hand.

The demolition of the rear portion of the house was fixed for the following week.

The family temporarily rented a house in a nearby lane.

It had three rooms, a small kitchen, and a narrow veranda in front.

Vachaspati Babu said, "It is only for a few months. We will all manage."

The household belongings began to be moved.

Beds, trunks, the bookcase, prayer articles, the grandson's study table—everything was accounted for separately.

Sumitra's trunk remained under the staircase until the very end.

Two labourers asked, "Where is this going?"

Vachaspati Babu said, "Leave it for now. Sumitra will decide where to keep it."

Sumitra was standing a little distance away.

She said, "I'll take it with me."

"Where?" Shailaja asked.

"I've seen a room near my daughter's neighbourhood."

Vachaspati Babu was surprised.

"You mean you'll pay rent? You already stay here."

Sumitra looked at him.

"Where will I sleep at night in the new rented house?"

Vachaspati Babu answered at once, "There is a veranda beside the kitchen."

Sumitra shook her head.

"The utensils will be kept there after the evening meal."

"Then spread a mat inside. Think of it as your own home."

Sumitra said nothing more.

By evening her trunk had been loaded onto a handcart.

For the first time that day, Vachaspati Babu noticed that the trunk was heavier than he had expected.

"What have you packed in there to make it so heavy?"

Sumitra smiled.

"A little of this and that from fifteen years."

Life settled into a routine in the temporary house.

Sumitra still came in the mornings as before, but after clearing away the evening meal she went home.

Earlier, when guests stayed over, she would sometimes keep working until midnight.

Now, as soon as it was half past eight, she washed her hands.

"I'll be going."

For the first two days Shailaja was surprised.

"The milk pot hasn't been washed yet."

"I'll do it in the morning."

"But my grandson's friends are coming tomorrow."

"I'll come early in the morning."

One evening Vachaspati Babu said, "I don't understand this hurry to rent a room. You are one of the family."

Dusting the flour from her hands, Sumitra replied, "A member of the family knows beforehand where she will sleep at night."

She said it very softly.

Vachaspati Babu heard her, but did not reply.

Work on the house continued.

Neelima came from time to time to inspect the plan and the construction.

One day, while measuring the utility room, she asked, "Kaka, shall we put a window here?"

"What use is a window in a storeroom?"

"What if Sumitra Kaki ever stays here?"

Vachaspati Babu looked slightly uncomfortable.

"She has taken a separate room now. Her own choice."

Neelima drew a line with her pencil.

"Then shall I label it simply 'Storeroom'?"

"Yes."

That day Sumitra too came to see the new house.

The mason knew her.

He asked, "Kaki, which one is your room?"

Sumitra looked around.

In front of her, walls coated in white lime were rising.

To the right, the grandson's study had two windows.

Upstairs, a bathing space was being built into the guest room.

Behind the kitchen was a small storeroom with no window.

Sumitra said, "My room isn't here."

The mason could not tell whether she was joking or merely stating a fact.

He went back to his work.

Vachaspati Babu mentioned her answer to Shailaja.

"Sumitra has changed a little lately."

Shailaja said, "A person does not change after getting a room of her own. She simply begins to stand upright."

Vachaspati Babu looked at her.

Shailaja went back to cutting vegetables.

"So now you are on her side too?"

"What side is there to take? I am only saying that a place to spend the night and a lock on one's own belongings are two things quite separate from speeches about being family."

Vachaspati Babu got up and walked toward the veranda.

By the time the construction was finished, four months had passed.

The new house did not look very different from the old one, but inside everything was more open and filled with light.

Relatives gathered on the day of the housewarming ceremony.

Vachaspati Babu took pride in showing everyone the rooms.

"We have preserved the soul of the old house," he kept saying.

Sumitra had been at work since four in the morning.

Prasad, water, leaf plates, the kitchen—everything was under her supervision.

At one point Neelima, while showing the house to a friend, reached the back of the kitchen.

The storeroom door was open.

Inside were sacks of rice, tins of spices, two empty boxes, and the old wooden cot.

Neelima stood on the threshold for a moment.

Sumitra was passing that way carrying leaf plates.

Their eyes met.

Neither of them needed to say anything.

At the midday meal Vachaspati Babu introduced Sumitra to the guests.

"This is our Sumitra. Think of her as a member of the family. She has stood with us through every joy and sorrow in this house."

Everyone smiled.

Sumitra moved on, serving vegetables onto the leaf plates.

An elderly relative said, "Loyal people like her are a matter of good fortune."

Vachaspati Babu was pleased.

By evening the number of guests had thinned.

Shailaja was exhausted.

Neelima had gone home.

Sumitra put the kitchen in order, covered the leftover food, and wiped the water from beside the stove.

Then she picked up her bag.
 In the new sitting room, Vachaspati Babu was sorting out a bunch of keys.
 He said, "Stay here tonight. It is already so late. This is the new house—think of it as your own."
 Sumitra stopped.
 "Where?"
 Vachaspati Babu's hand froze over the keys.
 For a moment his eyes went toward the closed door behind the kitchen.
 The storeroom was full.
 Relatives in the guest rooms were preparing to sleep.
 In the grandson's room, his books, desk, and toys had all been arranged in their places.
 Vachaspati Babu said, "A bed can be laid out in the sitting room."
 Sumitra smiled.
 "No. It isn't too late yet."
 She put a hand into her bag.
 A small brass key came out.
 "This is the key to my room."
 Vachaspati Babu looked at his own bunch of keys.
 It held the keys to the main gate, the kitchen, the storeroom, the upstairs rooms, the cupboards—everything.
 He separated one key from the bunch and held it out to Sumitra.
 "Keep the spare key to the kitchen. After all, you are family."
 Sumitra took the key.
 Two keys lay in her palm—one for her work, the other for her own room.
 She looked at them for a while.
 Then she put the kitchen key into her bag and closed her fist around the key to her own room.
 "I'll be here in the morning," she said.
 She did not look back as she walked to the gate.
 Vachaspati Babu remained standing in the sitting room.
 On the wall in front of him, the plan of the new house had been set in a frame.
 His son's room, his grandson's study, the guest room, the prayer room, the kitchen, the storeroom—everything was clearly labelled.
 On the small rectangle marked as the storeroom, the faint trace of Neelima's first pencil line still seemed visible beneath the whitewash, like a memory.
 Vachaspati Babu stepped closer to look.
 A word that had once been written there had been erased.
 Only the last two letters of the word 'room' remained faintly visible.

The Poster of Truth

From early Monday morning, the tap-tap of hammer and nails could be heard along the veranda of the Kamalpur Block Office.

A new poster was being hung on the wall.

Across the top, in bold letters, it read: 'Public Funds, Public Accounts.'

Below it were five short lines.

State the budget head.

State the rate.

State the quantity.

State the authorization.

Show the full trail of the expenditure.

Shashinath Chaudhary stood in the veranda, looking at the poster from a distance.

He was the coordinator of Anti-Corruption Week.

For this work, he had spent three weeks running from branch to branch of the office.

Meetings, announcements, pledge forms, posters, leaflets—each had its own list in his notebook.

Shashinath was pleased with his preparations.

He had a favourite saying: 'The first rule of clean work is this—do everything in full view of everyone.'

Manjula Karn, the accounts assistant, had heard that sentence many times.

That morning she sat at her desk with the expenditure register open before her.

Shashinath came in.

'Manjulaji, have all the posters arrived?'

'Three hundred.'

'The leaflets?'

'One thousand.'

'Is the payment voucher ready?'

Manjula stopped writing.

'We need to talk about that again.'

Shashinath pulled up a chair and sat down.

‘What is it now?’

Manjula turned a page of the register towards him.

‘The funds under the awareness head have still not arrived.’

‘We knew that from the very first day.’

‘Then under which head are we to book this expenditure?’

Shashinath looked at the line.

‘There is money left under office maintenance.’

Manjula looked at him.

‘That head is meant for things like the roof, drains, doors and electrical connections.’

‘It is only a matter of two weeks. Once the funds arrive, we will regularize it.’

‘Prior approval is required.’

Shashinath laughed.

‘Are we to hold up the entire block’s work over three hundred posters?’

Manjula remained silent.

Shashinath leaned forward and said softly, ‘Not a single paisa is going towards anyone’s private benefit.’

‘I am not talking about benefit.’

‘Then what?’

‘The budget head.’

Shashinath closed the register.

‘A budget head is a box on paper; purpose is the soul of the work.’

Manjula opened the register again.

‘In accounts, no one looks for the soul. They look at the entry.’

Shashinath got up and left.

A second poster was being hung in the veranda.

He liked its white surface and bold lettering.

He had designed the format of the campaign as well.

The district office had sent only the theme.

The wording, the lines, the size, even the thickness of the paper—Shashinath had decided them all.

Nayan Mishra, the printer, had quoted his price on the first day.

The total cost was coming out slightly above the prescribed ceiling.

The moment that ceiling was crossed, three quotations and a separate approval would be required.

Shashinath had said, ‘There is no time.’

Nayan Mishra had asked, ‘Then shall I reduce the quantity?’

‘No. With fewer than three hundred, we will not reach every panchayat.’

‘Then the approval?’

Shashinath had thought for a moment.

Then he had said, 'Treat the posters and the leaflets as separate jobs.'
 Nayan Mishra had said nothing.
 The next day, two invoices arrived.
 One was for the posters.
 The other was for the leaflets.
 Together they came to exactly the same total amount.
 Manjula understood the moment she saw the invoices.
 'Why has this been split?'
 Shashinath had answered, 'The items are different.'
 'The printer is the same, the order is the same, the date is the same.'
 'The jobs are different.'
 That day Manjula had withheld the payment.
 And so, by Monday, Nayan Mishra's money was still stuck.
 Nayan Mishra had arrived early that morning.
 He stood in a corner of the veranda.
 Shashinath saw him and called him over.
 'Do not worry. We will get it released today.'
 Nayan Mishra folded his hands.
 'I bought the paper on credit.'
 'I understand.'
 'And I still have to pay the workers their wages.'
 Shashinath grew a little uncomfortable.
 'It will be done by noon.'
 Manjula could hear the conversation from inside.
 She said nothing.
 At ten o'clock, Anti-Corruption Week was inaugurated.
 Employees of the block, panchayat representatives and members of several local organizations gathered in the meeting hall.
 Standing before the dais, Shashinath said, 'Truth is not merely a speech; it is a process.'
 Manjula's eyes went involuntarily to the expenditure register.
 Shashinath continued, 'Where the accounts are clear, suspicion diminishes.'
 There was applause.
 The poster hanging on the veranda wall trembled slightly in the breeze.
 As soon as the inauguration ended, Kiran Jha arrived from the district accounts branch.
 Her visit had been scheduled in advance.
 She had not come to see Anti-Corruption Week; she had come for the quarterly audit.
 Shashinath was pleased.

'You have come on just the right day. You can see the campaign as well.'
 Kiran read the first poster in the veranda.
 'The language is good.'
 Shashinath smiled.
 'I drafted it.'
 Kiran read the fifth line again: 'Show the full trail of the expenditure.'
 She asked, 'How much did this printing cost?'
 Shashinath gave the amount in an easy tone.
 'Under which head?'
 It was a small question.
 For a moment, Shashinath looked towards Manjula.
 Manjula had already opened the register.
 Kiran sat down.
 She examined the entry.
 Then she asked for the invoices.
 The two invoices were placed before her.
 She checked the date on both.
 'The order letter?'
 Manjula took out the file.
 A single order listed both the posters and the leaflets.
 Kiran looked at the register again.
 'The maintenance head?'
 Shashinath said, 'The awareness funds are delayed. We could not change the campaign date.'
 Kiran asked, 'Approval to change the head?'
 'It would have been adjusted later.'
 'As of now?'
 'As of now, no.'
 Kiran picked up the second invoice.
 'Two invoices?'
 'The items are different.'
 'The order is one.'
 Shashinath fell silent.
 Kiran called Nayan Mishra in.
 'Did you receive separate orders?'
 Nayan Mishra looked towards Shashinath.
 Then he said, 'I received a single list.'
 'Then why two invoices?'
 Nayan Mishra's voice dropped.
 'I was told to make them separately.'

The chairs left from the inauguration were still arranged in straight rows in the meeting hall.

The pledge sheet hung on the wall.

Shashinath seemed to hear his own words again in his ears: 'Truth is not merely a speech; it is a process.'

He spoke at once. 'No one has gained anything privately from this.'

Kiran put down her pen.

'Did I write that there was private gain?'

'No.'

'Then?'

'The point is that the work is in the public interest.'

Kiran said, 'I will not comment on the purpose. I will record the trail of the expenditure.'

For the first time, Manjula looked directly at Shashinath.

Shashinath sat holding the arm of his chair.

The audit continued until noon.

Kiran recorded three points in the file.

The approved budget head was not available.

No prior approval had been obtained before spending from another head.

Expenditure under a single order had been shown through two invoices so as to remain below the prescribed ceiling.

Shashinath objected to the third line.

'Writing "so as to remain below the ceiling" is an inference.'

Kiran said, 'Then have the reason recorded.'

Shashinath pulled the paper towards himself.

He picked up a pen.

For a while, he stared at the blank space.

He could have written: 'The items were different.'

He had already said those words before.

But the order letter lay in front of him.

One list.

One day.

One printer.

He put the pen down.

'I have already stated the reason orally.'

Kiran turned the page back.

'Then the record will contain the facts available on file.'

Nayan Mishra was still waiting for his payment.

Because of the audit, the payment was held up again.

By evening, his impatience had grown.

He came to Manjula and asked, 'What mistake have I made?'

Manjula said, 'Your work is complete.'

'Then my money?'

'It is difficult to release it until the expenditure entry is corrected.'

Nayan Mishra looked at the poster on the wall.

'My job was to print these words. The rules belong to all of you.'

Manjula did not reply.

At the other end of the veranda, Shashinath heard the exchange.

He called Nayan Mishra over.

'How much do you owe on credit?'

Nayan Mishra told him the amount.

Shashinath did not reach for his pocket.

He merely nodded.

Paying from his own pocket would not solve the problem.

The problem lay in the public accounts.

The next morning, Shashinath was the first to reach the office.

The posters had curled slightly in the dampness of the dew.

He went into his room and wrote a one-page note for Manjula.

The first line read: 'Proposal for correction of the previous entry.'

On the second line he wrote the amount booked under the maintenance head.

On the third he wrote: 'Budget head used without prior approval.'

On the fourth, he recorded the matter of the two invoices.

He began to write the word 'inadvertently.'

His hand stopped.

The two invoices had not been made inadvertently.

He struck out the word.

Then he wrote: 'Although the order was one, the expenditure was presented through two invoices.'

Manjula arrived and read the page.

'Will you sign this?'

Shashinath said, 'I will.'

'Then the correction proposal will go to the district office.'

'Let it go.'

'And Nayan Mishra's payment?'

'Record whatever route the rules provide. His money should not remain blocked much longer.'

Manjula placed the paper in the file.

Shashinath signed it.

At noon, another small meeting was held.

It was nothing like the inauguration.

There was no decorated dais.

No pledge was read aloud.

The audit observations were read out to the branch heads.

Shashinath kept his remarks brief.

‘The expenditure entry for the campaign will be corrected.’

No one applauded.

Kiran had said that after the correction, the observation could be treated as closed, provided approval and payment were processed according to the rules.

Nayan Mishra received his payment three days later.

He took the money and went straight to the printing press.

The posters in the veranda remained where they were.

Shashinath did not ask for them to be taken down.

A week later, Manjula pasted a small sheet of paper beneath the first poster.

That sheet was not part of the campaign.

It was a certified copy of the corrective expenditure entry.

It listed the budget head, the amount, the original entry, the date of correction and the authorization number.

Shashinath came into the veranda and stopped.

The fifth line of the large poster above read: ‘Show the full trail of the expenditure.’

Directly beneath it, on the small sheet of paper, was the trail of expenditure for that very poster.

Two panchayat representatives stood reading the small sheet.

One of them asked, ‘Why has this paper been put up?’

Manjula said, ‘It is the account behind what the poster says.’

Shashinath said nothing.

He straightened one corner of the poster.

The wind was lifting one edge of the small sheet.

Shashinath took a pin from his pocket.

He fixed the loose edge with it.

Now the large poster and the small account sheet were both held firm on the same wall.

A Gentleman's Testimony

In the village, Bhaveshwar Mishra's name was invoked with a trust greater than any office could command.

He was a retired headmaster.

For years he had taught children at the school to write, to read, and to understand the meaning of what was said.

Whenever a witness's signature was needed on a document, people first looked toward his house.

Bhaveshwar did not take pride in this trust - at least, that was what he told himself.

He used to say, "Say what you saw. Keep silent about what you did not see."

Even his former pupils remembered that sentence.

In the last week of Sawan, it rained for three nights without a break.

By the fourth night, the water of the Kamala channel had eaten through the fields and reached the village's rear hamlet.

By dawn, water stood in many courtyards.

Some mud walls leaned; some tiled roofs came crashing down.

The school's high veranda became a temporary shelter.

Bhaveshwar had been there since evening.

He had helped spread mats.

All night, the cries of children, wet clothes, lantern smoke, and the slap of water continued together.

The eastern hamlet could not be seen from that veranda.

An old mango grove and two brick houses stood in between.

Bhaveshwar knew this very well.

Two days later, the water began to recede.

A temporary register for damage relief was opened at the panchayat building.

Only eighteen households were to receive repair materials in the first allotment.

The officials' forms had three categories - total damage, severe damage, and ordinary damage.

A claim for total damage required statements from two local witnesses.

One line on the statement was printed with two choices: mark either "I personally witnessed the incident" or "I saw the damage after the incident."

The accountant, Rekha Jha, explained to people that the two lines meant different things.

The first carried greater weight in the immediate priority list.

The second required a site inspection.

On the first day, Bhaveshwar examined five applications.

Where he had personally witnessed the incident, he marked the first line.

Where he had seen only the damage the next morning, he chose the second.

Rekha Jha smiled and said, "Master Sahib, your statements make the work easier."

Bhaveshwar said, "So long as the facts are clear."

That afternoon, Ramsevak Yadav came in.

He had once been Bhaveshwar's pupil.

He now ran a small fertilizer and seed shop.

At every village event he was the one rushing about - putting up platforms, lifting sacks, arranging places for visiting guests to sit.

When there had been a wedding in Bhaveshwar's family, Ramsevak had managed the work for three days.

He opened the file and placed it before Bhaveshwar.

"Guruji, only your signature is left."

Bhaveshwar read the page.

It said that the mud wall of Ramsevak's back room had collapsed on the night of the flood.

Damage category - total.

The first line already bore a faint mark beside it - "I personally witnessed the incident."

Bhaveshwar looked up.

"I was at the school all night."

Ramsevak said at once, "Yes, Guruji, but you saw the house the next day, didn't you?"

"I saw it the next day."

"Then what difference does it make?"

Bhaveshwar placed a finger on the page.

"It says here: I personally witnessed the incident."

Ramsevak laughed.

"The incident happened, the wall fell, and you saw the fallen wall. Where is the lie?"

Bhaveshwar said nothing.

Ramsevak went on, "If the site inspection takes seven or ten days, the first allotment will be gone. My old mother is at home. It is hard to get through the night without that back room."

That was true.

Ramsevak's mother was close to eighty.

Bhaveswar knew her well.

Ramsevak said softly, "If you will not sign, I will find another witness. But in this village, whose word carries more trust than yours?"

A slight uneasiness stirred inside Bhaveswar when he heard this.

The uneasiness came less from Ramsevak's pleading than from the weight of his own name.

He did not want someone's relief to be delayed because of him.

He did not want Ramsevak to think that Guruji would not trust him over such a small matter.

He wanted the paperwork completed then and there.

All three wishes seemed perfectly reasonable at the same time.

Bhaveswar uncapped his pen.

He darkened the faint mark beside the first line.

Below it he wrote, "Signed, accepting the statement as true."

Then he signed his name.

Ramsevak folded his hands.

"When Guruji is here, work never gets stuck."

Bhaveswar said, "Now go and look after your mother."

The file was closed.

Two days passed.

A list was posted on the veranda of the panchayat building.

It contained eighteen names.

Ramsevak's name was thirteenth.

Nasima Khatun's was nineteenth, written in red ink with the note: "Site inspection pending."

Nasima's house was not on the riverward side, but it stood in a low-lying lane.

The water entered there late and drained away late.

One wall of her house had tilted inward.

Bhaveswar had passed through that lane the next morning.

He had seen the leaning wall.

He had not seen the incident happen.

Nasima came to him with her application.

"Master Sahib, you came into my courtyard the next morning."

Bhaveswar said, "Yes, I saw the damage."

"Then please witness this."

Bhaveshwar read the paper.
 The first line had been marked.
 He stopped his pen.
 "Not this line. I did not see the wall fall."
 Nasima said, "It has not fallen. It has leaned."
 "Then the second line is right - I saw the damage after the incident."
 Nasima said at once, "Write what is true."
 Bhaveshwar marked the second line.
 He signed it.
 Nasima folded up the paper.
 She made no complaint.
 She asked only, "Will this put my name in the first allotment?"
 Bhaveshwar said, "That will be decided after the site inspection."
 Nasima nodded.
 "All right."
 She left.
 Bhaveshwar remained seated on the veranda for a while.
 Ramsevak's paper came back to his mind.
 He had not shown the same caution there.
 He told himself that Ramsevak's wall truly had collapsed.
 Then he told himself that Ramsevak's mother was old.
 Then again - everyone in the village knew what had happened.
 All three things were true.
 But the printed line too had asked for the truth: had you personally seen
 it?
 Bhaveshwar rose and went home.
 That evening, Ramsevak's younger brother was carrying bamboo for the
 repairs.
 From a distance, he bowed in greeting.
 Bhaveshwar raised a hand.
 His mind settled again.
 Three days later, a verification meeting was held at the panchayat office.
 Two employees had come from the district office.
 Rekha Jha took out the applications one by one.
 For statements marked as eyewitness accounts, the time and place were
 being asked.
 Bhaveshwar's name appeared on three applications.
 He answered easily on the first two.
 "Around seven in the evening, near the school's south gate."
 "Before eight at night, on the pond embankment."
 Then Ramsevak's paper came up.

The district employee asked, "From where did you see the wall collapse?"
For a moment, Bhaveshwar's throat went dry.
He could have said, "I was with the villagers."
He could have said, "I do not remember the exact time."
He could have said, "It was raining heavily."
Any one of those answers might have carried the matter forward.
It seemed to him that the paper itself had already prepared an answer for him.

Just then the school veranda rose before his eyes.
The wet mats.
The lantern smoke.
The crying children.
And the mango grove hiding the eastern hamlet from view.
Bhaveshwar said slowly, "I did not see it fall."
The employee looked up from the page.
"The eyewitness option is marked here."
Bhaveshwar looked at his signature.
The ink was his.
The handwriting was his.
Beneath those letters there was no Ramsevak, no rain, no old mother.
There was only his name.
Rekha Jha remained silent.
Bhaveshwar said, "I made that mark. I marked it incorrectly."
Two or three people sitting on the veranda looked toward him.
The employee asked, "Then what did you see?"
"I saw the collapsed wall the next morning."
"Who told you it had fallen?"
Bhaveshwar looked toward Ramsevak.
Ramsevak was seated at the back.
His eyes were lowered.
Bhaveshwar said, "I heard people in the village talking about it. Ramsevak told me too."

The employee marked the second line.
He struck out the first mark.
Beside it he wrote, "Not an eyewitness; saw damage after the incident."
Ramsevak did not get up at once.
The meeting moved on.
Inside Bhaveshwar, the meeting did not move on.
He kept thinking that Ramsevak had not forced him to lie.
Ramsevak had only asked for a convenience.
Bhaveshwar himself had chosen the rest of the road.

And while walking that road, not once had his own step seemed wrong to him.

Because he had taken no money.

Because he had intended no harm to anyone.

Because he had thought of an old mother's hardship.

Because he trusted his own name.

Those very reasons had kept the lie from looking like a lie in his own mind.

The meeting ended.

Rekha Jha stopped him.

"Master Sahib, there is one thing."

Bhaveswar said, "Tell me."

"Ramsevak's place will now be decided after the site inspection. The first-allotment list will be recalculated."

"And Nasima's?"

"Her house was inspected yesterday. Severe damage has been recorded. The order may change."

Bhaveswar asked, "Did my incorrect statement push her name down the list?"

Rekha Jha did not answer directly.

She said, "Eyewitness testimony carries greater weight in the priority calculation. It can move a name up or down by one place."

Bhaveswar understood.

It was no great conspiracy.

It was one small mark.

One signature.

One line whose meaning he knew.

And one convenience - not having to say no to anyone.

That evening, Bhaveswar went to Ramsevak's house.

A temporary bamboo enclosure stood where the wall had fallen.

Ramsevak was digging earth.

Seeing Bhaveswar, he stopped his spade.

"Guruji, did I say something wrong?"

Bhaveswar said, "You told me what had happened. I was the one who wrote that I had seen it."

Ramsevak fell silent.

"You did say you would find another witness, but the pen was in my hand."

Ramsevak said softly, "I needed the relief quickly."

"I understand that."

"Mother talks about that room at night."

"I understand that too."

Ramsevak raised his head.

"Then?"

Bhaveswar looked toward the fallen wall.

"Then this: I said I had seen what I had not seen, and in my own mind I called it compassion."

Ramsevak said nothing.

Bhaveswar did not preach either.

He said only, "There will be a site inspection. Whatever the damage is, that is what will be recorded."

As Bhaveswar turned to leave, Ramsevak stopped him.

"Guruji."

Bhaveswar looked back.

"Did you testify against me?"

Bhaveswar thought for a moment.

"No. Today, for the first time, I testified against myself."

No smile came to Ramsevak's face.

Nor to Bhaveswar's.

Two days later, the revised list was posted.

Ramsevak's name had not been removed.

After his status changed to "site inspection complete," his case was placed in the severe-damage category.

Nasima's name too entered the first allotment.

Bhaveswar did not stand with the crowd before the list.

He read it from a distance and walked away.

A week later, another application came to his house.

This time it was Harinarayan Mahato.

Water had entered his paddy store.

He held out the paper.

"Master Sahib, you saw it the next morning."

Bhaveswar read the page.

The same two lines stood before him again.

"I personally witnessed the incident."

"I saw the damage after the incident."

Harinarayan said, "It is all true. Write whatever you think is proper."

Bhaveswar marked the second line.

In the blank space below, he added a line in his own hand: "I did not see the water entering; the next morning I saw wet paddy and marks left by the water."

Harinarayan read it and said, "Was it necessary to write that much?"

Bhaveswar capped his pen.

"It was necessary for me."

He signed it.

He returned the paper to Harinarayan.

The cord of Bhaveshwar's spectacles had caught on an old nail in the veranda pillar.

He gently freed the cord.

His name stood on the paper in fresh ink.

This time, not a single word in the line above his name went beyond what he himself had seen.

The Coin in the Donation Box

At the beginning of Jeth, the masonry platform around the old well in the middle of Pipra village cracked on two sides.

The water was still sweet, but the pulley had begun to lean and, year after year in the rains, bricks had fallen from the platform.

The villagers thought that if they kept waiting for government approval, the monsoon would arrive first.

So it was decided at the village meeting that the well would be repaired from their own common fund.

A wooden box was made.

On top was a narrow slot for coins and notes; across the front, in bold letters: "Common Well Repair Fund."

Two locks were fitted to the box.

One key would remain with the treasurer, Kiran Jha; the other with Devkinandan Paswan, who kept the expenditure ledger.

The rule was simple: the box would not be opened midway; when it was opened, it would be in everyone's presence, and the money inside would be entered in the ledger as a single total.

On the first day, the box was placed on the veranda of the meeting place.

Even before the morning meeting began, two women who had come to collect milk dropped in a few coins.

Kishun the herdsman, too, felt in his pocket and put in a coin.

No one's name was written down.

The box had already given three or four little jingles from within.

Then Ratinath Chaudhary arrived.

Ratinath's grain shop in the market was an old establishment, and in the village his voice was better known than the shop itself.

A meeting, a wedding, the cleaning of the pond—whatever the occasion, he was sure to have something to say.

He came up to the box and first looked around at everyone on the veranda.

Then he took a one-rupee coin from the pocket of his kurta.

The coin was wrapped in a small piece of paper.

In his own handwriting the paper said, "First contribution—Ratinath Chaudhary."

He showed the paper to everyone.

"Do not look at the value of the money; look at the sentiment," he said.

Then he folded the paper again and dropped it into the box with the coin inside.

There was a sharp clink from within.

Ratinath smiled.

"Now the fund has been formally inaugurated."

Kiran Jha was writing down the date.

She looked up. "The box was already making sounds before you arrived."

Ratinath laughed. "Those were loose coins. Mine is the first contribution with a name."

A few people on the veranda smiled.

Kiran said, "The box does not preserve an order of names."

"But my paper is in there."

"The paper will tell us the name. The box will not tell us whether it was first or fifth."

Ratinath took the remark as a joke and let it pass.

That evening, whoever mentioned the well at his shop heard Ratinath add one thing without fail.

"The first named donation was mine."

Someone asked, "How much?"

What matters is not the amount, but the beginning.

Old Gangaram, sitting in front of the shop, said, "It must have begun with the first jingle in the box."

Ratinath replied, "Who keeps accounts of nameless things?"

Gangaram fell silent.

The next day, the money in the box grew.

Sufal Paswan, who dug earth for a living, offered three days of labour without wages.

Phulkumari Devi gave an old but sturdy rope.

Nasim Ansari sent two thick bamboo poles for the pulley.

Some people dropped in five or ten rupees.

Some did not even give their names.

Kiran kept entering cash totals, the estimated value of materials, and labour-days in separate columns.

On the third day, Ratinath came to the meeting place again.

He had a small slip of paper in his hand.

"I need a receipt."

Kiran asked, "For which money?"

“For one rupee. It should be receipt number one.”

Kiran closed the ledger.

“Individual receipts are not issued for money put into the donation box. When the box is opened, the total amount will be entered.”

“I wrote my name on it.”

“That paper is inside the box.”

“Then issue me a receipt when it is opened.”

“When it is opened, whatever is found will be counted. We will not issue an individual receipt backdated to an earlier day.”

Ratinath’s brows drew together slightly.

“Then what proof is there that mine was the first donation?”

Devkinandan, who was noting the measurements of the bricks, said, “Did the thought of proof come before the donation, or afterward?”

Ratinath looked at him.

“The arrangement ought to be transparent.”

Devkinandan replied, “That is why the box has two locks.”

The matter ended there.

But it did not end in Ratinath’s mind.

He went home and wrote on a notebook page: “First named donor to the Common Well Repair Fund: Ratinath Chaudhary—one rupee.”

Below it, he wrote the date.

He folded the page and put it in his pocket.

At the next meeting, he took it out.

“Just add this much to the minutes of the committee.”

Kiran read it.

“Only decisions taken at the meeting go into the minutes.”

“This is a fact.”

“The first half of that fact cannot be verified without opening the box.”

“But I am the named donor.”

Kiran said, “I saw you put in a folded paper with your name on it. I also saw that there was money in the box before you came.”

Ratinath folded the page again.

“Then write ‘first named donor.’”

Kiran smiled. “When did the committee decide there was a competition for that?”

Laughter rose again on the veranda.

This time Ratinath did not laugh.

He put the page back in his pocket and left.

Work in the village kept moving ahead.

A day was fixed for dismantling the old well-platform.

The mason gave a list of materials.

They needed to know how much money had been collected.
 So a day was announced for opening the box.
 That day more people than before gathered on the veranda.
 The two keys were put into the locks at the same time.
 The box was opened.
 Kiran gently turned it upside down over the table.
 Notes, coins, and little folded pieces of paper spread across the surface.
 Ratinath pulled a chair forward and sat down.
 His eyes searched for his own folded paper.
 The counting procedure had been agreed in advance.
 Notes separately, coins separately, written slips separately.
 If a folded slip bearing a name was found, it would be assigned a supporting-slip number, but that number would not be treated as the chronological order of donations.
 Ratinath immediately asked, "Why not chronological order?"
 Kiran showed him the inside of the box.
 Coins lay at the bottom, notes in the middle, papers wedged along the sides.
 "The box has been moved, lifted, and set down. Whatever order there was inside has not survived."
 Ratinath said nothing.
 The first written fold was opened—fifty rupees.
 The name was "Manju Devi, Back Hamlet Ward."
 It was assigned supporting-slip number one.
 Ratinath sat a little straighter in his chair.
 "That is not the first donation."
 Kiran said, "It is the first written fold we have found."
 The second fold contained twenty rupees and no name.
 The third held five rupees and two letters, but not a complete name.
 The papers without names were set aside separately.
 The counting continued.
 At the seventh written fold Ratinath's eyes lit up, but it was not his.
 Nor was the twelfth.
 Every now and then Ratinath asked, "Where has my paper gone?"
 Devkinandan kept saying, "If it is in the box, we will find it."
 The sixteenth written fold was opened.
 There was no money inside—only a line that read, "I will dig earth for two days."
 Kiran placed it not with the cash but in the labour column.
 The seventeenth fold was small.
 As soon as the paper was opened, a one-rupee coin rolled across the table.

Ratinath immediately reached out his hand.

"That one is mine."

On the paper was written, "First contribution—Ratinath Chaudhary."

Kiran wrote on the supporting slip: "No. 17; one rupee; name written."

Ratinath said, "Why number seventeen?"

"This is the seventeenth written fold we have opened."

"But the paper itself says 'First.'"

"That is a line written by you."

"You all saw me put it in."

"Yes, we saw you put in a folded paper with your name on it."

"Then write one."

Kiran stopped her pen and looked at Ratinath.

"Shall I change the counting order?"

Ratinath did not answer.

Devkinandan said quietly, "None of us remembers the order of the coins that jingled before yours. The box will not tell us either."

Ratinath looked at the heap on the table.

There were many one-rupee coins in it.

Some were older than his, some newer.

There was now no way to say which coin belonged to whom.

His coin had been distinguishable only because it had come wrapped in his own written paper.

Kiran mixed the coin into the cash pile.

The paper was filed with supporting slip 17.

Ratinath's eyes kept searching for the coin, but after five moments he could no longer tell which one it was.

The counting resumed.

The total came to three thousand eight hundred and forty-two rupees.

In addition, bamboo, rope, bricks, and labour-days were entered in separate columns.

Kiran read out all the entries.

"Donation box—total, three thousand eight hundred and forty-two rupees."

Ratinath waited.

His name was not read out.

He asked, "What about the named slips?"

"They will be kept with the supporting records."

"A public list?"

"There is no list in the rules we agreed."

Ratinath put a hand into his pocket as though to take out the page he had written at home.

His hand went in, then came out empty.
He did not take out the page.
The following week, work on the well began.
The old loose bricks were removed.
The masonry platform was rebuilt.
The pulley was replaced.
Silt was cleared out.
Ratinath came twice to watch the work.
The first time he asked the mason, "How much has the total cost come to?"

The second time he asked nothing.
On the day the well was completed, no stage was erected.
On one side of the platform a small accounting board was put up: "Money received, materials received, labour-days, total expenditure, balance."
Below it was written: "Balance reserved for the next repair."
No one's name appeared.
Ratinath stood in the crowd.
Gangaram saw him and said, "Chaudharyji, you were the first donor, weren't you?"

Once, Ratinath's answer would have been ready on his tongue.
This time he looked at the accounting board.
"I gave one rupee," was all he said.
Gangaram laughed. "A great many people gave that."
Ratinath, too, smiled a little.
"Yes. They did."
The bucket was lowered for the first time.
The pulley turned without a creak.
Water came up.
People began filling their own lotas.
Kiran was gathering the ledger file.
The supporting slips were tied together with string.
Number one lay on top, below it number two, number three, and so on through the rest.

Ratinath's paper, in his own hand, saying "First contribution," lay seventeenth in that bundle.

He caught sight of its edge once.

Then the file was closed.

Beside the well, only the accounting board remained, where his coin had merged with all the other coins into the total sum.

The Decent Driver

Nagendra Jha, driver of the passenger vehicle that ran from Kamalpur Chowk to Haripur market, often spoke of his own courtesy.

He would say, "No foul word ever leaves my tongue."

He said this perhaps two or three times a day.

Sometimes at the tea stall, sometimes while passengers were boarding, sometimes after stopping the vehicle to explain some trouble on the road.

His conductor, Vijay, had heard the sentence so many times that he had stopped replying to it.

Nagendra had a simple definition of his own.

If a harsh remark ended with "ji," then it was not an insult.

"Look," he would explain to Vijay, "I say, 'Ox-ji, keep to the left.' Where is the insult in that?"

Vijay once asked, "The person you called Ox-ji is a human being, isn't he?"

Nagendra merely laughed.

"It is a metaphor. Metaphor is literature."

His vehicle was better known for its horn than for its literature.

At Kamalpur's narrow bend the horn would sound first, and Nagendra's voice would follow.

"King-ji, the road isn't your father's property!"

A little farther on, someone's bicycle would wobble.

"Great Man-ji, keep your eyes in front!"

An ox-cart would be moving a little too slowly.

"Maharaj-ji, are you carrying a wedding procession or a load of goods?"

And after each such remark he would look at Vijay and say, "See? I said it with respect."

Vijay would go on issuing tickets.

He did not argue.

Three passenger vehicles on this route were run by the same cooperative association.

The association had a rule that at the end of every month the drivers would submit a brief account of delays, quarrels, and passenger complaints.

At first the entries were only a few words long—"road blocked," "passenger dispute," "fare matter."

No one could make much sense of them.

Then, in one month, five complaints came in from the same day.

Sarojini Mishra, who looked after the association's accounts, said, "If you are recording an incident, record the words too. Writing only 'quarrel' does not tell us what the quarrel was."

A new rule was made.

If a complaint concerned language, the sentence spoken was to be written in the complaint register as nearly word for word as possible.

Nagendra was pleased when he heard the rule.

"Very good," he said. "Now there will be proof that I never abuse anyone."

Vijay looked at him but said nothing.

The rule was put to the test the very next week.

On Monday, just beyond Haripur, a cyclist carrying a sack of paddy was shifting from one side of the road to the other.

Nagendra sounded the horn.

Startled, the cyclist veered into the middle of the road.

Nagendra stopped the vehicle.

"Scholar-ji, do you have one body or four? Decide first which side you intend to keep it on!"

The cyclist said nothing.

He moved to the left.

The vehicle went on.

On the delay sheet Vijay wrote: "Cyclist carrying sack of paddy; vehicle stopped; driver's words—'Scholar-ji...'"

Nagendra looked at the paper.

"You wrote it correctly?"

"Exactly as you said it."

"Don't leave out the 'ji.'"

"I haven't."

On Tuesday, an elderly pedestrian stepped into the middle of the road while avoiding a pothole left by the rain.

Nagendra sounded the horn from a distance.

The old man did not hear it.

As the vehicle came near, Nagendra leaned toward the window.

"Uncle-ji, have you sent your ears on leave?"

The old man turned and looked back.

Vijay raised a hand and signalled for him to move to the left.

The vehicle passed.

A second sentence was added to the delay sheet.

On Wednesday, near the market, a woman was crossing the road with two baskets.

The cord of one basket came loose.

She stopped in the middle.

Nagendra brought the vehicle to a halt.

“Mother-ji, are you planning to set up the whole market right here?”

The woman gathered up her basket and moved aside.

An elderly woman seated in the back said, “Son, speak more gently.”

Nagendra replied at once, “Mother, I called her Mother-ji.”

The elderly woman turned to look out of the window.

Vijay wrote down the third sentence.

Nothing happened on Thursday.

That evening Nagendra said proudly, “See? When people follow the rules, even my mouth turns to honey.”

On Friday, an ox-cart ahead took a little time to give way.

Nagendra sounded the horn twice.

“Emperor-ji, kindly clear the royal road.”

The cart driver looked back.

Smiling, he moved the cart aside.

Vijay wrote down that sentence too.

This time Nagendra himself said, “That was a joke. Write ‘joke’ in the register.”

Vijay wrote: “Driver’s words: ‘Emperor-ji...’ Driver’s comment: joke.”

On Saturday morning a message came from the association office.

A passenger had submitted a written complaint saying that Nagendra “talks down to everyone.”

Nagendra bristled as he read the paper.

“Me? Talk down to people?”

He pushed up the sleeves of his kurta, then immediately pulled them down again.

“I call everyone ‘ji.’”

Vijay was silent.

“You hear me, don’t you?” Nagendra asked.

“I do.”

“Tell me, have I ever said anything to anyone without a ‘ji?’”

Vijay thought for a moment.

“Very rarely.”

“There you are! I’ll give them a written reply.”

The association’s meeting room was in the old dharamshala in the market.

All three vehicles remained off the road on Sundays, so the meeting was fixed for that day.

In front of Sarojini Mishra lay the complaint register, the delay sheets, and the fare register, all three open.

Nagendra had brought his reply in writing.

The first line read: "I always use respectful language with passengers and with people on the road."

The second: "My sentences contain respectful forms of address."

The third: "Even in difficult moments I do not use foul language."

He handed the paper to Sarojini.

"Here is my reply."

Sarojini read it.

Then she picked up Vijay's sheet for the week.

"Under the new rule, this week's language-related incidents have also been recorded."

Nagendra smiled.

"Read them. Every bit of evidence will go in my favour."

Sarojini read the first sentence.

"Scholar-ji, do you have one body or four? Decide first which side you intend to keep it on!"

Nagendra nodded.

"See—Scholar-ji."

Sarojini read the second.

"Uncle-ji, have you sent your ears on leave?"

Nagendra said, "Uncle-ji—respectful."

The third sentence was read aloud.

"Mother-ji, are you planning to set up the whole market right here?"

Nagendra still wore an expression of confidence.

"Mother-ji."

Then came the fourth sentence.

"Emperor-ji, kindly clear the royal road.' Comment—joke."

The other driver at the meeting, Parmeshwar Yadav, burst out laughing.

Nagendra turned toward him.

"Why are you laughing?"

Parmeshwar pressed his lips together.

Sarojini said, "I am not giving a decision yet. I have one question."

Nagendra sat up straight in his chair.

"Ask."

Of these four sentences, what useful road instruction is actually there?

Nagendra immediately looked toward the first sheet.

"In the first one I told him to choose a side."

“Which side?”

Nagendra paused.

“The left.”

“Does the sentence contain the word ‘left’?”

Nagendra read it again.

It did not.

Sarojini placed a finger on the second sentence.

“Here, what was the old man told to do?”

Nagendra answered, “To move aside.”

“Where are those words?”

Nagendra looked at the sentence again.

It mentioned only the ears being on leave.

The question then moved to the third line.

“What instruction did you give the woman with the baskets so she could cross safely?”

Nagendra’s answer came more slowly.

“She understood.”

Sarojini said, “Yes, she understood that you were annoyed. But the sentence does not say what you wanted her to do.”

Nagendra grew a little uncomfortable.

“There isn’t much time on the road.”

“Then you need fewer words.”

Sarojini placed a blank sheet of paper before Nagendra.

“For each of these four incidents, write only the useful instruction. No comment on the person.”

Nagendra picked up the pen.

For the first he wrote: “Keep to the left; there is a vehicle behind you.”

For the second: “Uncle-ji, move to the left.”

For the third: “Gather your basket and move aside; I have stopped.”

For the fourth: “Move the ox-cart to the left; I will pass.”

He put down the pen.

All four lines were short.

Sarojini placed his earlier written reply beside them.

“Now compare them yourself.”

Nagendra kept looking at the sheet.

“These are only instructions.”

“At that moment on the road, instructions were all that was needed.”

“Where did the humour go?”

Parmeshwar Yadav again made as if to laugh, but the moment Sarojini looked at him he fell silent.

Nagendra said, “People understand my way of speaking.”

For the first time in the meeting, Vijay spoke.

"Some understand it. Some endure it."

The room fell silent.

Nagendra looked at Vijay.

"Why didn't you ever say anything all these days?"

Vijay replied, "You always said that because there was a 'ji,' it couldn't be abuse."

Nagendra's hand rested on the paper with the four new lines he had written.

He asked, "In your view, the 'ji' changes nothing?"

Vijay said, "'Ji' after a name is an honorific. Put it after mockery, and the mockery does not become respect."

Sarojini stopped Vijay.

"Let the register give the decision, not a sermon."

At that, an unwilling smile appeared on Nagendra's face.

"See? Your sermon has been stopped too."

Vijay smiled as well.

The tension eased a little.

The association imposed no penalty.

In reply to the complaint it merely recorded: "The driver has been instructed to keep road-related directions separate from remarks about individuals."

Nagendra read that line three times.

"Does it say I am decent or not?"

Closing the register, Sarojini said, "The register does not measure decency; it only records incidents."

Nagendra did not answer.

On Monday the vehicle went out again.

The first passenger boarded at Kamalpur Chowk.

Vijay issued the ticket.

Nagendra sounded the horn once and pulled away.

Half a kos down the road, a boy carrying a sack on his bicycle was wobbling.

Nagendra opened his mouth.

"Great Ma—"

The words stopped halfway.

Vijay looked at him.

Nagendra gave a short tap on the horn.

"Brother, keep to the left; there is a vehicle behind you."

The boy moved to the left.

The vehicle passed without stopping.

Vijay opened his delay sheet.
 Nagendra asked at once, "What are you writing?"
 "Nothing. There was no delay."
 Nagendra cleared his throat slightly.
 "No need to write down my sentence?"
 "There was no complaint."
 Nagendra kept his eyes on the road.
 A little farther on, two goats were crossing.
 He slowed the vehicle.
 "Goat-ji—" The word came to his tongue.
 Nagendra himself burst out laughing.
 "It isn't even a person."
 Vijay said, "Then save the 'ji.'"
 Nagendra did not sound the horn.
 The goats crossed.
 By the time they were nearing Haripur, they came upon an ox-cart ahead.
 The cart driver took a little time to move aside.
 Nagendra's finger went to the horn.
 He sounded it once.
 "Move to the left; I'll pass."
 The ox-cart moved aside.
 Nagendra drove past.
 A few moments later he asked Vijay, "That wasn't too rude, was it?"
 Vijay said, "It was clear."
 "There was no 'ji.'"
 "It was still clear."
 Nagendra was silent for a few moments.
 Then he said, "So where was I spending all those 'jis' all these years?"
 Vijay replied, "On the words."
 Nagendra laughed.
 "And the meaning?"
 Gathering up the tickets, Vijay said, "The listener had to supply that."
 Haripur market came into view.
 Nagendra slowed the vehicle.
 There was a crowd along the roadside.
 He rested his hand on the horn, but this time he looked at the spot before
 calling out.
 "Keep to the left—the vehicle is coming."
 People moved aside.
 The vehicle reached its place and stopped.
 Vijay closed the delay sheet.

That day the column for language complaints remained blank.

Nagendra glanced once at that blank column.

He said nothing.

He merely used a finger to wipe the dust from the old words written across the front windscreen—"Courteous Service"—until they stood clear again.

The Character Certificate

Two blank certificates lay before Madhav Mandal.

The day after tomorrow was the deadline to apply for the temporary post of accounts assistant at the district grain depot.

All the other papers were ready.

Only two character certificates from persons of standing were required.

Across the top of the form, in bold letters, was written: "The applicant is personally known to me."

The second line below read: "To the best of my knowledge, his conduct is excellent."

The third line: "He is not related to me."

Madhav read all three lines three times.

His mother called from the kitchen, "Go to Bhuvaneshwar Master first."

Madhav said, "How well does he know me?"

His mother replied, "He is the best-known man in the village."

Madhav did not fold the form.

He placed it between clean clothes and put it in his bag.

Bhuvaneshwar Babu was a retired headmaster.

On his veranda, old report cards, certificates of honour, and photographs of students hung in frames.

The moment he saw Madhav, he said, "Well, have you got the appointment?"

Madhav bowed and placed the form before him.

"It is only the application for now."

Bhuvaneshwar Babu put on his spectacles.

"Is that all?"

"I need two certificates."

"Then I shall give you one."

He took out his pen, but instead of reading the form, pushed it toward Madhav.

"Fill in the name and address and all that."

Madhav filled in his name.

He filled in his father's name.

He wrote the village, post office, and police station.

When he came to the line, "The applicant is personally known to me," his pen stopped.

Bhuvaneshwar Babu asked, "Why have you stopped?"

Madhav said, "That is your statement."

"What do you mean?"

"You should write that."

Bhuvaneshwar Babu laughed.

"You insist on rules even in things like this?"

Madhav remained silent.

Bhuvaneshwar Babu pulled the form back toward himself.

"How long have I known you?"

Madhav said, "I cannot say exactly."

"I'll write ten years."

Madhav said softly, "Ten years ago I was studying away from the village."

Bhuvaneshwar Babu frowned.

"Then five years?"

"It has been four years since I returned to the village."

"Shall I write four?"

"Whatever you think is right."

Bhuvaneshwar Babu wrote four.

Then he read the next line.

"Conduct excellent."

Without pausing, he wrote: "Extremely good, courteous, obedient, and wholly trustworthy."

Madhav kept looking at the form.

"What is it?"

"Nothing yet."

"Why are you making that face?"

Madhav said, "Have you observed me that closely?"

Bhuvaneshwar Babu leaned back against his chair.

"Have I ever heard anything against you?"

"Nothing of that sort."

"Then that is why I wrote it."

Madhav asked, "Just because you have heard nothing, how does that make me 'wholly' trustworthy?"

For two moments the veranda fell silent.

Bhuvaneshwar Babu looked over the form again.

"You argue too much."

Madhav said, "It is your certificate."

"Who wants the appointment—you or me?"

"I do."

“Then take the simple road.”

Madhav reached out to pick up the form.

Bhuvaneshwar Babu stopped him.

“Wait. I’ll cross out ‘wholly.’”

He drew a line through the word.

“Shall I leave ‘trustworthy?’”

Madhav smiled.

“That is for you to know.”

For the first time, Bhuvaneshwar Babu gave the task of filling the form some attention.

At the end, he signed it.

He stamped it with his seal.

He said, “The form is spoiled now; one word has been crossed out.”

Madhav said, “The crossed-out word is visible.”

“Shall I write it again on a fresh form?”

“This one is fine.”

Bhuvaneshwar Babu looked at him.

“You will submit a form with a crossed-out line in an appointment application?”

Madhav replied, “A crossed-out statement is better than a hidden one.”

Bhuvaneshwar Babu said nothing.

Madhav put the certificate into his bag and rose to leave.

The second name was Ramakant Sah.

He was secretary of the Public Welfare Committee.

At every village meeting and function, his chair stood at the front.

The committee’s papers were kept in a small room behind Ramakant Sah’s shop.

When Madhav reached there, Ramakant Sah was sitting with the accounts ledger open before him.

“So, you have come?”

“I need a certificate.”

“Give it here.”

Ramakant Sah did not even read the whole form.

He signed at the bottom.

Madhav was astonished.

“The lines above are blank.”

“Fill them in when you get home.”

“How can I fill in your statement?”

Ramakant Sah laughed.

“You are coming from Bhuvaneshwar Master’s house, aren’t you?”

“I have just come from there.”

“He must have had you fill his too.”

“He wrote it himself.”

Ramakant Sah paused a little.

“Then I’ll fill it in later.”

With that, he bent over the ledger.

“First do one small thing.”

Madhav remained seated.

Ramakant Sah opened a page.

It contained the accounts for the repair of the public tap the previous month.

The date on one receipt belonged to the following month.

Ramakant Sah said, “The date should have been written one month earlier.”

Madhav asked, “Why should the date be put back?”

“The grant was only valid through last month.”

“Was the work done the following month?”

“The work had begun then itself.”

“But the receipt is from the following month.”

“Changing the date alone won’t change the work, will it?”

Madhav remained silent.

Ramakant Sah held the pen out to him.

“Your handwriting is neat.”

Madhav did not take the pen.

“This is not my ledger.”

“It belongs to the committee.”

“Then the committee should write in it.”

Ramakant Sah’s voice hardened.

“I am the secretary.”

“Then you should write it.”

“Everyone knows my handwriting.”

Madhav did not close the ledger, but neither did he pick up the pen.

“I can write the date on which it actually happened.”

Ramakant Sah stared at him.

“You have started understanding too many rules.”

Madhav said, “I understand this much: if the date is changed, what the receipt says will change too.”

Ramakant Sah picked up the form.

He looked at his signature on it.

Then he looked at the blank lines above.

“So what am I supposed to write on this?”

Madhav replied, “Whatever you know.”

Ramakant Sah drew two crooked lines through his signature.

“Now I know nothing.”

Madhav’s throat went dry.

The application deadline was close.

Even so, he picked up the form.

“I understand.”

Ramakant Sah said, “Get another one made somewhere else.”

Madhav bowed.

As he was leaving, his eyes fell on the ledger.

Ramakant Sah had set his pen to the date on the receipt.

Madhav stepped outside.

Until evening, the household discussed whom else they might approach as the second person of standing.

His mother listed five names.

Madhav listened to every one of them.

He knew some of them only slightly.

With others, his entire relationship consisted of exchanging greetings.

That night he opened the application papers again.

On the first certificate, the word “wholly” stood visibly crossed out.

On the second form was Ramakant Sah’s crossed-out signature.

Madhav did not throw that form away.

He placed it in a separate compartment of his bag.

Early the next morning, he went to the library.

The village public library was looked after by Satyanarayan Karna, a retired postal employee.

For four years, Madhav had been helping there in the evenings, shelving and taking down books.

There was no salary.

There was no post.

Satyanarayan Karna usually called him “Madhav” when giving him work, not “volunteer.”

Madhav placed the form before him.

Satyanarayan Karna read it.

He said, “Whether I am a person of standing or not, the people who drafted this form may know.”

For the first time, Madhav laughed.

“You know me.”

“That much is true.”

“Then write whatever else you know.”

Satyanarayan Karna picked up his pen.

On the first line he wrote, “Known to me for four years.”

On the second line, the words “conduct excellent” were already printed.
He added nothing after them.

In the blank space below, he wrote: “In the conduct I have personally observed, I have found nothing improper.”

Madhav read it.

“Will you write only this much?”

“This is as much as I have seen.”

“Not ‘extremely’?”

Satyanarayan Karna raised his spectacles and looked at him.

“Do you need ‘extremely’?”

Madhav shook his head.

“There is no need for ‘extremely.’”

“Then I do not need it either.”

Satyanarayan Karna signed at the bottom.

Instead of a seal, he had only a small stamp bearing the library’s name.

Madhav asked, “Will this be accepted?”

Satyanarayan Karna said, “Whether it will be accepted, the office will know. Whether a lie would be accepted, I do not know.”

Madhav put two certificates into his bag.

The first—Bhuvaneshwar Babu’s.

The second—Satyanarayan Karna’s.

The third form, with the crossed-out signature, remained separate.

The next day, the district grain depot office was crowded.

Madhav waited for his turn.

The clerk receiving the papers examined each form one by one.

He paused at Bhuvaneshwar Babu’s certificate.

“Why is something crossed out here?”

Madhav said, “At first, ‘wholly’ had been written.”

“Then why was it crossed out?”

“The person who wrote it changed his mind.”

The clerk looked at Madhav’s face.

“Did you ask him to cross it out?”

“I only asked whether he knew me that well.”

The clerk said nothing.

He looked at the second certificate.

“Why is there an additional remark here?”

“He wrote what he had seen.”

Again, the clerk said nothing.

He counted the rest of the application papers.

Then one form slipped out of Madhav’s bag.

The one bearing Ramakant Sah’s crossed-out signature.

The clerk picked it up.

“What is this?”

Madhav was silent for a moment.

“An incomplete certificate.”

“The signature is crossed out.”

“The signature was there first.”

“Then how did it get crossed out?”

Madhav felt like saying, “He thought poorly of me.”

But he stopped himself.

He said, “I refused to change a date when he asked me to.”

The clerk’s hand paused over the form.

“What date?”

Madhav told him what had happened, in a few words.

The clerk listened carefully.

Then he returned the crossed-out form to Madhav.

“This will not be attached to the application.”

“I understand.”

The clerk set the two valid certificates aside.

His eyes went to the crossed-out word on Bhuvaneshwar Babu’s form.

Then to Satyanarayan Karna’s three-line remark.

Then he looked at Madhav’s name on the application.

He offered no praise.

He gave no advice.

He simply stamped the receipt slip.

Madhav took the slip.

As he stepped outside, he remembered Bhuvaneshwar Babu’s words: “Who wants the appointment—you or me?”

He opened his bag and looked at the crossed-out form.

Ramakant Sah’s signature had been struck through with two lines.

The entire certificate above it was blank.

Only the name-and-address section had been filled in by Madhav.

He looked at the back of the form.

The pressure of Ramakant Sah’s pen had left faint impressions through the paper.

Like the imprint of that sentence from the ledger: “The date one month earlier...”

The words were not fully legible.

Madhav did not fold the paper.

He kept it flat and clean.

When he reached home, his mother asked, “Did two decent men give you certificates?”

Taking off his bag, Madhav said, "I got two certificates."

His mother asked, "What is the difference?"

Madhav did not answer.

He placed the first two papers in the compartment containing the appointment file.

He kept the third, crossed-out form separately.

No one had written on it that Madhav's character was excellent.

And yet, of all three, that paper seemed to him the clearest statement about who he was.

The Fasting Feast

At four in the morning, the first bamboo basket was unloaded in the courtyard of the dharmashala.

The basket held bananas.

Behind it came a sack of makhana.

Then came cucumbers, coconuts, curd, and sugar candy.

Ramkripal Mishra kept count of every item.

He himself was observing a nirjala fast, without even water.

Yet since dawn his mouth had been full of nothing but the names of food.

"Twenty-four dozen bananas?"

"Twenty-four."

"Twelve seers of makhana?"

"Twelve."

"Six pots of curd?"

"Six."

Ramkripal kept ticking the entries in the register.

This time the Govind Dharmashala was holding a collective fast for Nirjala Ekadashi, followed by an evening recitation.

In the old way, people observed the fast in their own homes.

In the evening they came to the dharmashala to listen to the recitation and broke their fast together.

Earlier, the fasting fare had been simple.

Bananas, curd, makhana—that was all.

But in three years the scale of the event had changed.

The eastern hamlet had served five kinds of fasting fare the previous time.

The southern hamlet had served seven kinds the following month.

Ramkripal would say, "What have we to do with competition?"

Then, at once, he would add, "But the arrangements must not be slack."

This time nine kinds had been decided upon.

By Ramkripal's reckoning, this was not a question of taste.

It was a question of discipline.

What would be placed on whose plate first, what would follow, who would sit in which row—everything had been written down.

On the right side of the courtyard, yellow wooden markers were set aside for those observing the nirjala fast.

On the left, white markers were for those who took water during the fast.

In the middle, green markers were for those taking fruit during the fast.

Ramkripal inspected the three piles in turn.

“No colour must get mixed into another.”

The volunteer Navalkishore laughed.

“Are people coming here to fast, or to identify colours?”

Ramkripal looked at him.

Navalkishore fell silent at once.

By seven o’clock, a large board had been hung on the wall of the dharmashala.

On it was written—

“THE FASTING FEAST—NINE KINDS OF FASTING FARE.”

Below, in smaller letters, were the names of the donor families.

Ramkripal measured the height of the board.

“Half a cubit higher.”

Two young men loosened the bamboo again and raised the board.

At half past seven, Sita Devi arrived with her granddaughter Kusum to enter her name in the register.

Sita Devi was seventy-two years old.

She had observed Ekadashi for years.

This time Kusum did not want to leave her alone.

The young man keeping the register asked, “Nirjala?”

Sita Devi said, “No water from dawn till evening. But at a quarter past six I have to take medicine with food.”

The young man paused.

There was no separate field for medicine in the register.

Kusum said, “She only needs one banana or a boiled potato.”

The young man wrote in the margin—“6:15—medicine.”

Then he handed Sita Devi a yellow marker.

Ramkripal saw this from a distance.

“What did you write in the margin?”

The young man told him.

Ramkripal pulled the register towards himself.

“Food will be served to everyone at the same time.”

Kusum said politely, “Her medicine has to be taken at a fixed time.”

Ramkripal said, “All right. I’ll see to it.”

He turned the register back.

The day climbed higher.

There was less talk of fasting and more of arranging the plates.

The team roasting the makhana said the curd station should not be beside them.

The curd servers said dust from the makhana would blow over.

The young man cutting coconuts wanted his place near the entrance, because people would see his platter first.

Ramkripal kept shifting everyone's places.

At eleven, an acquaintance from the eastern hamlet arrived.

He cast his eyes all around.

"You've arranged nine kinds?"

Ramkripal said casually, "It isn't about the number. It's for people's convenience."

The acquaintance said, "Next time we'll have eleven."

Ramkripal smiled.

As soon as the acquaintance left, Ramkripal called Navalkishore over.

"Could we add a small cake made from water-chestnut flour?"

Navalkishore's eyes widened.

"Then it'll become ten kinds."

Ramkripal said, "Not for the number. For people's convenience."

Navalkishore said nothing.

At noon, the volunteers met in the back room of the dharmashala.

Ramkripal spread out the seating plan.

The first row was for the elderly.

The second was for women.

The third was for men.

The fourth row was for the special donor families.

Looking at the plan, Kusum asked, "Where will the people who have medicines at fixed times sit?"

Ramkripal raised his head.

"How many are there?"

"My grandmother is one."

"Then she'll sit in the first row."

"But she needs food at a quarter past six."

Ramkripal looked at the clock.

"The recitation is supposed to end at six. The conch will sound, then the prasad distribution will begin."

Kusum said, "What if the recitation runs long?"

Ramkripal had his answer ready.

"We'll make sure it ends on time."

Kusum fell silent.

At three o'clock, the rehearsal for cutting the fruit began.

The bananas did not need to be cut.

Even so, the decision about which way the bananas should face on the plates was changed twice.

Five minutes went into deciding whether the cucumbers should be cut in rounds or lengthwise.

Ten minutes went into deciding whether the bowl of makhana should sit at the top of the plate or on the right.

Ramkripal's fast continued.

He was hungry, but had no time to mention hunger.

At half past four, the recitation began.

The dharmashala filled up.

People sat quietly.

Ramkripal stood by the doorway, counting the rows.

One hundred and fourteen.

The register contained one hundred and sixteen names.

Two people had not come.

Even that discrepancy bothered him.

At five fifty-five, the final portion of the recitation began.

Ramkripal's eyes went to the clock.

Everything was in order.

At six-oh-five, the principal speaker requested everyone to remain seated for two more minutes.

Those two minutes became eight.

Then an elderly member of one of the donor families arrived.

The volunteers began making room for him in front.

The rows shifted again.

It was six sixteen.

Kusum quietly came over to Ramkripal.

"It's time for Grandmother's medicine."

Ramkripal looked at the clock.

"Just a moment. The conch is about to sound."

"She needs the medicine first."

"If we open the rows now, everyone will get up."

Kusum said, "I'll take just one banana."

Ramkripal's eyes fell on the pile of yellow markers.

"If we give something separately, other people will ask too."

Kusum looked at him for a few moments.

Then she turned away.

At six twenty, the photographer arrived.

The donor families wanted a photograph of all nine platters of fasting fare together.

Ramkripal himself began straightening the platters.

One platter was half an inch too far back.
 He moved it forward.
 The cloth over one of the curd pots was crooked.
 It was straightened.
 The photograph was taken at six twenty-seven.
 The conch sounded at six twenty-nine.
 People rose slowly.
 Ramkripal breathed a sigh of relief.
 The rows had indeed formed beautifully.
 The elderly people with yellow markers sat down first.
 Ramkripal counted the first row.
 One seat was empty.
 Sita Devi's yellow marker lay on it.
 Kusum was nowhere to be seen either.
 Ramkripal asked Navalkishore, "Where did that elderly lady go?"
 Navalkishore said, "She left by the back of the kitchen."
 "Why did she go back?"
 "For her medicine."
 "Was she given a banana?"
 Navalkishore said, "Champa Kaki gave her half from her own share."
 Ramkripal frowned.
 "Why from her own share?"
 "Because there was no permission to open the plates prepared for distribution."
 Ramkripal said nothing.
 Meanwhile, nine little bowls began to be set out in the first row.
 People took the curd first.
 Then the makhana.
 Then the bananas.
 Then the cucumber.
 Then the coconut.
 Then the sugar candy.
 Then the water-chestnut cakes that had been added after noon.
 Some people laughed.
 "All this just to break a fast?"
 Ramkripal heard them, but only smiled.
 At an event, laughter was considered a good sign.
 By the time the serving reached the second row, two or three items were being left untouched on many plates.
 Some did not want curd.
 Some found the sugar candy too sweet.

Some found the water-chestnut cakes hard.
 The volunteers kept collecting the leftover food in separate vessels.
 Again and again, Ramkripal's eyes went to the empty seat.
 Sita Devi's yellow marker was still there.
 By the time the feast ended, it was eight at night.
 The donors were pleased.
 The principal speaker praised the arrangements.
 The acquaintance from the eastern hamlet also said, "I have to admit, the rows were very neat."
 Ramkripal thanked him.
 Navalkishore said softly, "It did become ten kinds after all."
 Ramkripal pretended not to hear him.
 When the people had gone, three large vessels in the courtyard were full of leftover fasting fare.
 Champa Kaki asked, "May we take these leftover potatoes and bananas home?"
 Ramkripal said, "Divide it all among yourselves."
 Picking out potatoes, Champa Kaki said, "It was a good thing I gave that elderly woman half a banana."
 Ramkripal said, "Yes."
 A little later, he sat down to put away the register.
 One hundred and sixteen names.
 One hundred and fourteen present.
 One hundred and thirteen meals served.
 His pen stopped.
 He found Sita Devi's name.
 In small letters in the margin beside it was written—"6:15—medicine."
 For the first time all day, he read that little note in full.
 Beside it was his own red mark.
 The red mark meant—"first row."
 The time of the medicine had disappeared into that red mark.
 Ramkripal did not close the register.
 He left it open for a long time.
 Navalkishore came over and said, "Come on. It's late."
 Ramkripal asked, "Did Champa Kaki eat?"
 "Last of all."
 "What time did Champa Kaki eat?"
 "Around half past eight."
 Ramkripal did not look at the clock.
 The next morning, he went to Sita Devi's house.
 He was not carrying a box of leftover fasting fare.

He carried only the yellow wooden marker that had been left on her seat.
 Sita Devi was sitting on the veranda.
 Kusum was inside.
 Ramkripal handed her the marker.
 "This was left behind."
 Sita Devi laughed.
 "What use is it to me now?"
 Ramkripal had no answer.
 Sita Devi herself said, "I broke my fast, but I left the gathering."
 There was neither anger nor sarcasm in her voice.
 That was why the sentence lingered all the longer.
 Ramkripal asked, "Did you manage to take your medicine on time?"
 "A little late, but I took it."
 From inside, Kusum said, "Champa Kaki's half banana did the job."
 Ramkripal turned the yellow marker over in his palm.
 In small letters on it was written—"Nirjala."
 That was all.
 No age.
 No medicine time.
 No distance from home.
 Nothing about how long someone working in the kitchen might
 themselves have been fasting before getting to eat.
 Ramkripal rose.
 Sita Devi asked, "Did the event go well?"
 Ramkripal said, "The rows were good."
 As he walked away, his own sentence sounded incomplete to him.
 When he reached the dharmashala, the courtyard was empty.
 The large board still hung on the wall—"THE FASTING FEAST—NINE
 KINDS OF FASTING FARE."
 The names were underneath.
 Navalkishore was approaching with a ladder to take the board down.
 Ramkripal said, "Leave it."
 Navalkishore stopped.
 "Until the next event?"
 "No. Turn it over first."
 Together they took down the board and laid it on the ground.
 The back was blank.
 Ramkripal took a piece of charcoal and wrote four lines—
 "How many people?"
 "Whose medicine has to be taken at a fixed time?"
 "Who has far to travel home?"

“Who will eat late because they are serving others?”

Navalkishore read them and said, “Where do we write how many kinds of fasting fare there are?”

Handing him the charcoal, Ramkripal said, “If there’s room left, write it.”

The board remained propped against the wall, turned around.

Its bright lettering on the front faced the wall.

Its blank-backed side, now bearing the new questions, faced the courtyard.

The Prize for Humility

On the third day after the notice for “The Prize for Humility” was posted in the small auditorium behind the municipal library, people’s manner of walking began to change.

The notice read: “An annual Prize for Humility will be awarded to one person as an example of selfless service, renunciation of credit, and modest conduct in society.”

Below it appeared not the word “application,” but “nomination.”

That word itself was the first thing to reassure everyone.

Putting forward one’s own name seemed contrary to humility.

Having someone else put forward one’s name seemed proper.

The next day, teacher Navalkishore Mishra came to the library.

He carried a two-page letter in his hand.

The letter had been written by a former student of his.

Handing the letter to the secretary, Mridula, Navalkishore said, “I have no attachment to any of this.”

Mridula opened the letter.

The first line read: “Guruji has never taken credit for anything in his life.”

The second line was followed by seven examples.

Mridula asked, “Did you ask him to write this letter?”

Navalkishore laughed.

“No. I merely told him that the committee does not make decisions without facts.”

Mridula placed the letter in the nomination register.

By evening, five nominations had arrived.

In every letter, one sentence said nearly the same thing: the nominee had no desire for the prize.

The following day, cloth merchant Devkinandan came in.

He said, “Strike out my name.”

Mridula asked, “On which page is your nomination?”

“The third.”

“Who told you?”

Devkinandan fell silent for a moment.

“If my name had to be struck out, I had to see where it was.”

Mridula opened the register.
 His younger brother had nominated him.
 Devkinandan said, "I will not accept the prize."
 "You have not even been selected yet."
 "Even so, write down that I refused it in advance."
 Mridula stopped her pen.
 "Where am I to write that you refused?"
 Devkinandan placed a finger on the right-hand margin of the register.
 "Here. Then there will be no confusion later."
 Mridula wrote: "The nominee has expressed no wish to accept the prize."
 Devkinandan read it.
 "Add 'in advance.'"
 Mridula added it.
 He left satisfied.
 Within three days, the nominations had risen to nine.
 The committee chair, Surendra Babu, grew concerned.
 "The criteria must be clear."
 Mridula asked, "How do we measure humility?"
 Surendra Babu said, "By conduct."
 "Evidence of conduct?"
 That question gave birth to a new form.
 The form had three boxes.
 "An occasion on which you gave credit for your work to someone else."
 "An occasion on which you remained calm after being insulted."
 "An occasion on which you rendered service without your name being known."
 The nominator was to fill in the form.
 The nominee's signature was not required.
 But once the forms had been distributed, the nominees themselves began improving the wording of the completed forms.
 Navalkishore's student had written: "The school library was built through his efforts."
 With a red pen, Navalkishore struck out "through his efforts" and wrote "through the collective efforts of all the teachers."
 Below that, in brackets, he added: "Correction by nominee."
 Mridula read it and smiled.
 Navalkishore immediately said, "Do not count that smile in my favour."
 Two days later, Ramakant Jha, who ran a social organisation, arrived with three witnesses.
 All three said separately that Ramakant never sat in the front.
 Mridula asked, "At every programme?"

The first witness said, "Usually."

Ramakant cut in, "Not usually—unless it is absolutely necessary."

The second witness looked at him.

Mridula wrote: "Clarification provided by the nominee."

Ramakant said, "Remove 'clarification.' I do not like speaking about myself."

Mridula capped her pen.

Little by little, the nomination register turned into a ledger of humility.

Someone brought proof that his name appeared in small letters on a plaque.

Someone brought a photograph from a programme in which he was seated in the back row.

Someone brought a letter in which he had written, "I did nothing."

The nominee's name was clearly written on every piece of evidence; otherwise, how was the committee to identify it?

A new file appeared on Mridula's desk: "Humility—Evidence."

The file grew thicker.

One day, Kamli Devi, who did the cleaning, picked up the file and asked, "Whose are all these papers?"

Mridula said, "Humble people's."

Kamli shifted the file from one hand to the other, as though weighing it.

"Humility must be a heavy thing."

Mridula burst out laughing.

Just then the chair came in.

"What happened here?"

Mridula repeated the exchange.

The chair did not laugh.

"Kamli Devi's name could be considered too."

Kamli immediately said, "Leave me out of it. I have another house to go to at four."

The chair looked at Mridula.

Mridula understood that this sentence, too, could become evidence.

She wrote nothing down.

On the day of the decision, five members sat around a circular table.

A score sheet had been prepared for each nominee.

Giving up credit—ten.

Gentle speech—ten.

Keeping oneself in the background—ten.

Anonymous service—ten.

The first file was opened.

There were three pieces of evidence for Navalkishore's "anonymous service."

His name appeared on all three.

One member asked, "How was anonymous service verified?"

Surendra Babu said, "The beneficiary told us."

"Then how did it remain anonymous?"

The first ten points became five.

The second file was Devkinandan's.

He had already refused the prize in advance.

One member said, "That is strong evidence of humility."

Mridula showed them the margin of the register.

It was Devkinandan himself who had insisted that the refusal be recorded.

Ten points became six.

Ramakant's file contained fourteen photographs of him sitting at the back.

One member noticed that in all fourteen he was looking towards the camera.

Another member said, "What does that prove?"

The first replied, "Nothing. But by now I am measuring photographs, not humility."

The room fell silent.

Mridula laid her pen on top of the score sheet.

"May I ask a question?"

The chair nodded.

"If proof is required to show that someone deserves the prize, then the nominee must leave traces of his humility."

No one answered.

Mridula continued, "And if he leaves no trace, how are we to know?"

The members looked at one another.

From the veranda outside came the scrape of chairs being moved.

Kamli Devi was arranging chairs for the evening programme.

The chair said, "Then should we discontinue the prize?"

The treasurer was startled.

"The funds have already been approved."

"For the prize."

"Yes."

"Must they necessarily be given to an individual?"

The treasurer looked at the papers.

The sanction letter read: "Annual prize to encourage humble conduct."

It did not name an individual.

The discussion began again.

Someone proposed that the money be spent on a water pot for the library.
Someone suggested reading materials for students.

Someone said the prize should remain, but the recipient's name should not be announced.

Mridula asked of this proposal, "Then who will receive the money?"

Silence again.

At last Surendra Babu said, "This year we will not award points."

"Then what do we do?"

"Put the money into something everyone needs and to which no single person can keep the credit attached."

Behind the auditorium stood the library's old veranda.

Whenever it rained, water came inside.

The children's books had already been soaked twice.

The money would be enough for a drain and a small awning.

The decision was made.

But the problem was not yet over.

How should the notice be worded?

Navalkishore, Devkinandan, Ramakant, and the other nominators would all ask for the result.

Mridula took out a blank sheet of paper.

She wrote: "This year, no ranking of individual humility has been made."

Surendra Babu read it.

"The reason?"

Mridula wrote a second line: "The committee found that the evidence required by the competition was itself changing people's behaviour."

The treasurer said, "That line is too harsh."

Mridula struck it out.

She wrote a new line: "The prize money will be used for work to protect the library veranda."

Everyone agreed.

The notice went up the next day.

By noon, three nominees had come to the library.

Devkinandan said, "I had already said I would not accept the prize."

Navalkishore said, "The committee's decision is proper. My name should appear nowhere."

Ramakant asked, "When the veranda is finished, who will inaugurate it?"

Mridula said, "That has not been decided yet."

The three stood there for a while.

Then each went his own way.

A week later, the mason began work.

The old drain was dug out.

Bricks were unloaded.
The children's books were shifted inside.
The thick nomination file remained on top of the cupboard.
Kamli Devi dusted it every day.
On the day the awning was completed, the chair said, "We could put up a small plaque here."
Mridula asked, "What would it say?"
"Built with the prize money."
"The name of the prize?"
The chair paused.
Kamli, standing at the foot of the ladder, had been listening.
She said, "Rain is coming. Put the books inside first."
Everyone looked up.
Clouds were gathering in the east.
The matter of the plaque was left there.
People began moving the books inside together.
Navalkishore happened to be there; he picked up two bundles.
Devkinandan, returning from the market, saw them and stood holding the door.
Ramakant stopped his vehicle and carried three boxes inside.
No individual name became attached to that work.
No one announced it.
The rain grew heavy.
Water began drumming on the new awning.
Inside, the children's books remained dry.
On top of the cupboard, the "Humility—Evidence" file lay quietly.
Every name was safely preserved inside it.
Outside on the veranda, there was no name at all.

The Last Line

Decorations for the municipal library's twenty-fifth anniversary meeting began in the hall three days in advance.

A cloth banner behind the stage bore the library's old name and the new year.

A book exhibition was being arranged on the right.

On the left stood water-filled earthen pitchers and glasses.

Eight rows of seats had been laid out in the middle.

At the head of every row was a small paper slip.

The first two rows were reserved for founding members, honoured guests, and readers over eighty years of age.

From the third row onward, the general invitees were to sit.

Ramanand Jha read the notice and smiled.

He ran an old shop selling paper and books in the town.

When the library was being established, he had donated five thousand rupees.

Later, on two occasions, he had donated cupboards as well.

Many people in the town knew this.

Ramanand also knew that many people knew it.

This second fact was no less dear to him than the first.

He had received the invitation card five days earlier.

Before his name on the card there was only 'Shri'.

Ever since, the absence of some word such as 'Patron', 'Senior Contributor', or 'Distinguished Member' had continued to bother him.

He said to the secretary, Sudhakar, 'The card has been made very beautifully.'

Sudhakar thanked him.

Ramanand added, 'They have kept the designation beside the name brief. That is good too.'

Sudhakar thanked him again.

Ramanand waited for him to say something more.

Sudhakar did not raise his head from the file.

On the day of the meeting, Ramanand arrived forty-five minutes early.

The hall still smelled of dust and cloth.

Three men laying out the seats were measuring the spacing of the last row.
The moment Ramanand entered, he looked at the first row.
Names were written on the slips there.
Dr Ila Chaudhary.
Jagdish Babu—Founding Member.
Sharda Devi—First Woman Reader.
Prof. Ratneshwar Mishra.
Ramanand's name was in the middle of the third row.
He looked once toward the stage.
Then at his own slip.
Then toward the first row.
Sudhakar was standing beside the steps to the stage.
Ramanand said, 'My knees are not what they used to be.'
Sudhakar immediately replied, 'If you like, we can give you a seat at the end of the row.'

'The end will be fine.'

Sudhakar told a volunteer to place his slip at the end of the third row.
Ramanand was silent for a moment.
'Will the sound reach the back clearly?'

'Yes, it was tested yesterday.'

'My hearing has become a little weak.'

Sudhakar looked at him.
'In that case, I'll keep the end seat in the second row for you.'

A very faint line of satisfaction appeared on Ramanand's face.
The volunteer picked up his slip from the third row and placed it at the end of the second.

Just then Sharda Devi's granddaughter came in.
She said, 'Grandmother does not hear well, and getting up and sitting down is difficult for her.'

Sudhakar showed her the end seat in the first row for Sharda Devi.
Ramanand recognized Sharda Devi's name.
In the library's early years, she had come every evening to read stories aloud to the children.

Ramanand said, 'It is only right that she should sit in front.'

After saying this, his own second row seemed to him a little less far forward.

One of the men laying out the seats was Ramjatan.
For fifteen years he had been arranging seats, tables, and cloth in the hall.
He was not a committee member.
His name was not on the invitation card.

His job was to keep the rows straight, replace wobbly seats, and pack everything away at the end.

Ramjatan had already seen Ramanand's slip moved twice.

He said nothing.

The guests began to arrive.

The third row filled up.

Teachers, traders, and old readers of the town sat in the fourth row.

Teenage readers sat in the fifth.

The last three rows were still half empty.

Ramanand sat down at the end of the second row.

He could see the stage clearly.

He could hear clearly as well.

Even so, his attention kept drifting less toward the stage and more toward the slips in the first row.

One elderly founding member did not come.

A seat in the first row remained empty.

Ramanand looked at the empty seat.

Then he looked at his watch.

There were twenty minutes before the meeting was to begin.

He signalled to Sudhakar.

Sudhakar came over.

Ramanand said softly, 'If that member is not coming, an empty seat will not look good.'

Sudhakar said, 'Let us wait another ten minutes.'

'Of course.'

Ramanand straightened the edge of his gamchha.

Ten minutes later, the seat was still empty.

But in the meantime Sharda Devi, the first woman reader, arrived.

Two people supported her and slowly brought her inside.

The entire hall rose when they saw her.

Ramanand stood as well.

Sharda Devi sat in her seat.

Her granddaughter wanted to remain standing behind her.

Ramanand spoke up, 'Give her a seat nearby too.'

The empty seat in the first row was given to the granddaughter.

There was a smile on Ramanand's face.

But somewhere inside him, a very small calculation changed again.

There was no longer an empty place in the first row.

At that moment a young man came in carrying a camera.

He began checking the light from the right-hand corner of the stage.

Ramanand watched him.

The young man turned the camera toward the second row.
 Ramanand sat a little straighter.
 The young man then moved farther back.
 Ramanand asked Sudhakar, 'Where will the group photograph be taken?'
 'At the end, in front of the stage.'
 'All the members?'
 'First the honoured guests, then the founding members. If there is time, the contributing members too.'
 'All right.'
 Ramanand said 'all right' in a tone that made it clear the question was not yet finished.
 A cable from the sound system ran in front of his seat in the second row.
 A volunteer said, 'Uncle, mind your feet.'
 Ramanand drew his feet back.
 Because of the cable, this corner might prove awkward when photographs were taken.
 He understood that at once.
 He got up.
 At that moment Ramjatan was replacing a wobbly seat in the last row.
 Ramanand called him over.
 'Ramjatan, can you move this seat a little farther forward?'
 Ramjatan looked toward the second row.
 'How far?'
 'Just in front of that pillar.'
 'That would break the row.'
 'What difference can one seat make?'
 Ramjatan put a hand on the back of the seat but did not lift it.
 'Can't you see the stage from here?'
 Ramanand said, 'I can see it.'
 'Can't you hear?'
 'I can hear too.'
 'Then why move forward?'
 Ramanand laughed.
 'Oh, you wouldn't understand.'
 Ramjatan laughed too.
 'I lay out rows, Babu. I understand a little about rows.'
 Before grasping the meaning of the words, Ramanand weighed the tone in which they had been spoken.
 There was no mockery in it.
 Ramjatan said, 'You are not moving forward so that you can see the people on the stage.'

He paused for a moment.
 'You want the people sitting on the stage to see you.'
 No noise rose in the hall.
 No one else paid any attention to the remark.
 But Ramanand felt that after that sentence all the rows of seats looked a little straighter.
 His hand was still on the back of the seat.
 He looked at Ramjatan.
 Ramjatan's attention had already returned to the wobbly leg.
 Bending down, he was slipping a thin piece of wood beneath it.
 Ramanand wanted to say, 'I have done a great deal for this library.'
 The sentence came as far as his lips.
 He did not speak it.
 He wanted to say, 'I have no craving for recognition.'
 That sentence too remained inside him.
 Because neither sentence answered what Ramjatan had said.
 Sudhakar called from a distance, 'We are starting the meeting.'
 Without moving his seat, Ramanand returned to his place in the second row.
 The first speaker began reading the history of the library.
 The years, donations, repairs, number of books, and membership figures were recited.
 Ramanand's name came up once as well.
 By habit, he lifted his head.
 At once he remembered Ramjatan's sentence.
 Instead of looking at the stage, he began looking at the white hair of Sharda Devi seated in front of him.
 Even when her name was mentioned, Sharda Devi did not look back.
 It was as though she were not accustomed to hearing her own name.
 When it was time for the young-reader award, a girl rose from the fifth row.
 She went to the stage and received a book.
 As she returned, she waved directly toward the last row.
 Ramanand looked back.
 Her father was standing there.
 Although seats were available, he stood against the wall because his little son was asleep in his arms.
 It was almost certain that he would not appear in the stage photographs.
 Yet his face showed no sense of having missed out.
 During the interval, Sudhakar came to Ramanand.

‘Ramanand Babu, one of the founding members has gone home. There is a place free in the first row. Come and sit there.’

Ramanand looked toward the first row.

Then toward Ramjatan.

Ramjatan was carrying two extra seats in from outside.

Ramanand said, ‘Leave it. I can see the stage clearly from here.’

Sudhakar paused for a moment.

‘If your hearing—’

‘I can hear clearly too.’

Sudhakar nodded and moved on.

Ramanand gave a slightly awkward laugh at hearing his own answer.

It was the exact reverse of all the excuses he had made earlier.

After the interval came the presentation of honours.

Names were called for the group photographs.

First the honoured guests.

Then the founding members.

Then the committee members.

Time ran short.

No separate photograph was taken of the contributing members.

For a moment, the old bitterness stirred inside Ramanand.

He looked at his watch.

Then he gripped the arm of his seat.

He did not get up.

The meeting ended.

People gathered in front of the stage and began greeting acquaintances.

Ramanand slowly started toward the exit.

By the door, Ramjatan was counting the seats.

Ramanand stopped.

‘How many seats were used today?’

‘One hundred and thirty-two.’

‘And how many people?’

‘I didn’t count them.’

Ramanand laughed.

‘You count rows, not people?’

Ramjatan said, ‘People are hard to count. The same person keeps changing places again and again.’

This time Ramanand laughed openly.

Ramjatan laughed too.

A week later, the small anniversary souvenir reached the shop.

The group photograph was printed on the inside front cover.

At first glance Ramanand looked for his own face.

He was not in the photograph.

His thumb paused at the edge of the page.

The shop assistant asked, 'Babu, your photograph hasn't been printed?'

Ramanand turned the page.

Inside, his name appeared in the list of donors.

In small type, as before.

He did not let his thumb linger on the list.

His eyes went to the photograph of the girl who had received the young-reader award.

Behind her in the photograph, a small portion of the wall by the last row could be seen.

Ramanand remembered her father standing there.

The assistant asked again, 'Next time, you should sit in the first row.'

Ramanand closed the souvenir.

'From the last row, you can see the stage clearly.'

He placed the souvenir on the stack of books.

A customer came in from outside.

Ramanand walked toward him.

The River's Paper

The Kamla River flowed a little east of Garhiya Tola.

Twenty years earlier, it had not been here.

Back then the river ran farther east, and a settlement called Garhiya Tola existed only on people's lips, not on paper.

Ramcharit Sahni had built the first house.

His old home had been washed away in a flood.

He had driven bamboo poles into the sand and raised a hut.

After him came two families.

Then five.

Then the river's old channel kept retreating, and houses kept multiplying along the bank.

Now Garhiya Tola had thirty-seven households.

Some houses were thatched, some made of mud and brick, some half-pucca.

There were two wells.

There was one community hand pump.

In a small courtyard, children studied in the evenings.

Whenever the river rose, sacks of grain were the first things carried up into that courtyard.

To the people, Garhiya Tola was a settlement.

On the revenue map, it was a blue-and-white strip.

Beside that strip were the words: "River zone, zero habitation."

Champa Sahni first saw that sentence at the block office.

She had gone there to have her address certified on her daughter Poonam's scholarship papers.

The clerk opened the map and asked, "What is the plot number of your house?"

Champa said, "My house has no plot number. The tola is written there."

"Where is the tola?"

"On the western riverbank."

The clerk moved a finger over the map.

"There's nothing here."

Champa thought: it was easy to see an empty place on a map.

The map did not know how many hearths burned there each night.

The clerk handed back the scholarship papers.

“Get the address certified by the panchayat.”

Champa gathered up the papers.

As she was leaving, she looked once more at the map.

On that blue strip, her entire settlement did not amount to a single dot.

Two weeks later, four corners were marked with white lime along the riverbank.

The first corner lay in front of Champa’s house.

The second was inside Bhola Mukhiya’s bamboo enclosure.

The third was near the community hand pump.

The fourth touched the edge of the courtyard where the children studied.

A member of the construction team said, “Stone will be stored here.”

“How much stone?” Champa asked.

“It’s embankment work. A lot.”

“In front of the houses?”

“On the map, this is vacant land designated for storing materials.”

Again Champa caught on that one word—vacant.

Ramcharit was no longer alive.

But if the first bamboo stake he had driven into the ground still survived somewhere beneath the soil, the papers would have called that place vacant too.

The next day, the construction team painted red numbers on twelve houses.

They were not house numbers.

They marked the order in which the houses were to be removed.

A 1 appeared on one wall.

A 2 on another.

Champa’s house was marked 7.

Poonam returned from school and saw the 7 on the wall.

“What does this number mean?”

Champa said, “They say there is no house here.”

Poonam did not laugh.

She opened her schoolbag.

She took out her school identity card.

The address read: Garhiya Tola, western riverbank.

“If there is no house, where will this address go?”

Champa had no answer.

That evening, people from the whole tola gathered.

Some said, what harm would it do if stones were stored there; they could put up with it for a few days.

Others said, first the stones, then the machines, and then the houses would go.

An old woman said, "My name is in the ration register. Why is my house not on the papers?"

Bhola said, "Ration papers are not land papers."

"Then I am not asking about the land. I am asking whether I exist," the old woman said.

The meeting fell silent at that.

The next day Champa went to the panchayat office.

There she found an old flood-relief register.

The names of twenty-four families from Garhiya Tola had been entered in it during a flood three years earlier.

At the top of the register were the words: "Riverbank settlement."

Champa asked for a copy.

The clerk said, "This is a relief register, not a land record."

Champa said, "I am not asking you to declare us owners of the land. First write down that people live there."

The clerk kept looking at her.

Then he gave her the copy.

That evening Poonam opened an old tin trunk.

The family's papers were kept inside.

A vaccination slip.

A school certificate.

A ration-distribution receipt.

A list of families taken aboard the flood-rescue boat.

A copy of an application for repairing the hand pump.

And an electricity-bill receipt where, beneath the address, the same words appeared again—Garhiya Tola.

Poonam said, "One office says we exist. Another says we do not."

Champa said, "Keep all the papers together."

For the next three days, the whole tola searched for papers.

Someone had a maternity-assistance slip.

Someone had a notice of an old-age payment.

Someone had a child's school-enrolment paper.

Someone had a receipt from a livestock vaccination camp.

Someone had the serial number under which the family had been entered on the river-crossing rescue-boat list.

Some papers were torn.

On some, the ink had run.

Of some, only half remained.

But every one bore some government stamp or another.

Poonam did not sort the papers by household.

She arranged them by year.

The oldest slip was fourteen years old.

It was in Ramcharit's name.

Place—Garhiya Tola.

Champa stared at that slip for a long time.

When Ramcharit had driven in the first bamboo stake, how could he have known that one day the ink on a slip would have to survive in order to prove that he had existed there?

Poonam made a list of the houses in a thick notebook.

Not House 1, House 2.

By name.

Jamuna Devi.

Bhola Sahni.

Rahim Mian.

Champa Sahni.

Saryu Khatun.

Devnarayan Mallah.

Against each name she wrote which office's document was available.

From which year.

What address it carried.

Of the thirty-seven households, thirty-two had some government paper or another.

Five households had none.

Those five were new.

Champa said, "Do not strike out their names."

Poonam said, "I won't. I'll write beside them—seen on site."

The tola decided that the notebook would make no claim to ownership of the land.

It would record only how many people lived there, how long they had lived there, and which offices had used that address.

Champa said, "Do not add anything that is not true."

Bhola laughed and said, "So now we have become more careful than government papers."

No one laughed.

On the fourth day, the construction team fastened a notice to a stake giving the date when the stones would arrive.

Materials would begin to be stored there in six days.

Champa went to the panchayat secretary.

"Come and inspect the site."

The secretary said, "This is a revenue matter."

The revenue clerk said, "This is a construction-department matter."

The construction official said, "We work according to the map."

Three offices.

Three answers.

The same vacant strip.

Poonam said, "Call all of them on the same day."

"Who will call them?" Champa asked.

"The office whose papers all of them use—the panchayat."

At first the secretary would not agree.

Then Champa placed the copy of the relief register in front of him.

"Is this your office's stamp?"

"Yes, it belongs to our office."

"Where do the people under this stamp live on the map?"

The secretary said nothing.

At last, a date was fixed for a joint site inspection.

On the day of the inspection, there was no procession through the tola.

No slogans were raised.

Poonam drove a small bamboo stake in front of every house and tied a strip of paper to each one.

The strips carried no household names, only the year and office of a government document.

"2014—Vaccination Camp."

"2016—Flood Relief."

"2018—School Enrolment."

"2021—Hand-Pump Repair Application."

"2023—Ration Distribution."

From a distance, the entire settlement looked filled with little paper flags.

The revenue clerk arrived carrying the map.

The construction engineer was with him.

So was the panchayat secretary.

The engineer looked at the first square outlined in white lime.

It was Champa's courtyard.

"On the map, this is open land."

Champa said, "On the ground, this is my courtyard."

"Do you have ownership papers?"

"No."

"Then what you are saying—"

Champa did not interrupt him.

Poonam opened the notebook.

"We have made no claim of ownership. Your plan says zero habitation. Check that claim."

For the first time, the revenue clerk took the notebook.

He turned the pages.

He looked at documents from different government offices carrying the same address.

“None of these documents establishes ownership.”

Poonam said, “Our notebook does not say that either.”

The engineer moved on.

The second white square covered half of the hand pump.

The third lay in the middle of the courtyard where the children studied in the evenings.

The fourth lay across the narrow path leading to the river.

That was the path where the boat came in during floods.

The engineer asked his assistant, “If materials are stored here, will this path be blocked?”

“Yes.”

“An alternative path?”

The assistant looked at the map.

The path was not on the map either.

In Poonam’s notebook, an entire page was devoted to it.

The flood-relief boat list.

Boarding point—Garhiya Tola western path.

The engineer read the list.

Champa said nothing.

She only kept looking toward the river.

The inspection continued past noon.

Thirty-seven households were counted.

Government papers were examined for thirty-two households.

Five newer households were recorded on site.

Two wells.

One hand pump.

One community courtyard.

One boat path.

The revenue clerk added a new page to his file.

At the top he wrote: “Site Verification.”

Below it he wrote: “Map records zero habitation; thirty-seven households found on site.”

He paused.

Then he added: “Ownership status to be examined separately.”

Champa read the page.

This time she did not ask for a single word to be changed.

The engineer shifted the material-storage site a little farther north on the construction map.

There lay an old sandy stretch of the riverbed, with no houses on it.

"Suspend the numbering of houses for removal until the boundary survey is completed," he told his assistant.

The red 7 was still on Champa's wall.

No one erased it that day.

Three days later, it rained.

The red paint ran a little.

One edge of the 7 blurred.

Poonam did not whitewash over it.

She said, "Leave it. This too is evidence, like a paper."

Champa laughed.

"A wall is not a paper."

Poonam said, "And if a paper cannot see the place, what makes it so much better than a wall?"

This time Champa did not try to silence her.

A month later, two surveyors from the revenue department arrived.

They carried a newly printed map.

The blue strip was still empty.

But along its edge, in small letters, were the words: "Habitation—site verification pending."

The first surveyor asked, "Where should we start counting the households?"

Champa looked toward the river.

Then toward the place where the old map had shown nothing.

"Start where the paper is blank."

The surveyor drove in the first stake.

It stood in front of where Ramcharit's old house had been.

The Number on the Brick

On Ramdev's first day at the kiln gate, no one asked his name.

The clerk placed a small round tin token in his hand.

Painted on it in white was the number 31.

"This is your number."

Ramdev turned the token over.

There was nothing on the back.

"Where do I write my name?"

The clerk laughed.

"I'll remember the name. We use numbers for the work."

Ramdev tied the token into the corner of his gamchha.

From that day on, many people at the kiln called him Ramdev, but in the ledger he was 31.

On the rows of unbaked bricks: 31.

On the day's count: 31.

On the margin of the advance account: 31.

On the list of broken bricks: 31.

Ramdev had no objection to being a number.

When the work was counting bricks, numbers were convenient.

Five hundred bricks in one row.

Seven hundred and twenty in the next.

How many had been made by noon, how many by evening—the clerk could tell at once from the figures.

Little by little, Ramdev too grew used to his number.

A voice would come from far away: "Thirty-one!"

He would turn his head.

Sometimes someone joked, "Not Ramdev—Thirty-one Babu."

He would laugh.

The kiln stood on the outskirts of Sonbarsa village.

On winter mornings the smoke hung low.

The long rows of unbaked bricks disappeared into the fog.

Those who kneaded the clay worked in one place.

Those who filled the moulds in another.

Those who carried the unbaked bricks in another.

Those who tended the kiln in another.
 Everyone had a number of his own.
 Nandu worked with Ramdev.
 Nandu was 32.
 Salim was 33.
 Bhuwan was 34.
 When they spoke to one another, they used names.
 When the accounts were opened, the numbers came to the front.
 Until then, Ramdev had never thought to question such a system.
 He had come to work on the twelfth day of Poush.
 That day, he received a three-thousand-rupee advance.
 His name was written on the advance receipt—Ramdev Mandal.
 The date was written too.
 He had put his thumbprint on it.
 His half of the receipt was given to him.
 He put that piece of paper in his old iron trunk.
 The trunk stayed beneath his cot in a thatched hut at the kiln.
 Ramdev kept a separate little notebook for the daily count.
 He could not write full sentences, but he knew his numerals well.
 He wrote the date.
 Beside it, the number of bricks.
 Sometimes his count was twenty or twenty-five off the clerk's.
 Then the two of them counted again.
 Most of the time, the difference disappeared.
 In the last week of Phagun came the kiln's first major settlement of accounts.
 The workers were called one by one.
 A thick ledger lay open before the clerk.
 For each number he read out the bricks made, the advance, small expenses, and deductions.
 The account for 32 was settled.
 Then 33.
 After that the clerk called, "Thirty-one."
 Ramdev came and sat in front of him.
 The clerk pressed his thumb to the page.
 "The total count is correct. Advance: three thousand. Two grain receipts. And damage—one thousand eight hundred bricks."
 Ramdev lifted his head.
 "What damage?"
 "The unbaked bricks that broke in the first firing."
 "Mine?"

"It says ३१ here."
Ramdev leaned toward the ledger.
There, in red ink, really was ३१.
Beside it—१८००.
"What day was this?"
The clerk turned the page.
"The seventh of Poush."
At first Ramdev said nothing.
Then he said, "I came on the twelfth of Poush."
The clerk looked at him.
"The number was ३१."
"But I wasn't here."
"There's no name in the ledger."
"Then how can the ledger say I'm the one at fault?"
The people sitting nearby fell silent.
The clerk looked at the page again.
To him, ३१ was one continuous line.
३१ on the seventh of Poush.
३१ on the twelfth of Poush.
३१ all the way through Phagun.
The person had changed in between; the ledger had not.
Ramdev went back to his hut.
He opened the iron trunk.
He took out his half of the advance receipt.
The paper had gone slightly soft with the damp of sweat.
The date was clear.
Poush १२.
The name was clear too.
Ramdev Mandal.
He placed the receipt before the clerk.
"This is the day you gave me the advance."
The clerk read the receipt.
"Yes. This very day."
"Then who was ३१ on the seventh of Poush?"
The clerk's thumb stopped on the ledger.
He turned back through the pages.
There was no arrival entry for the old ३१.
There were only counts.
Nandu said, "There was someone here before Ramdev."
"His name?"
Nandu scratched his head.

“Suresh... or Surjan...”

Salim said, “He used to tie a red gamchha around his head.”

Bhuwan added, “They said his home was somewhere toward Supaul.”

The clerk did not become angry.

He simply grew uneasy.

“No one remembers his name properly?”

The three men looked at one another.

All of them had worked beside that man.

Not one of them could recall his full name.

The kiln owner, Madhusudan Babu, arrived just then.

The clerk explained the matter to him.

Madhusudan looked at the receipt.

He checked the date.

“Ramdev wasn’t here on the seventh of Poush.”

He drew a line through the 1800 written in red ink.

“Remove this deduction from Ramdev’s account.”

Ramdev breathed a sigh of relief.

But Madhusudan asked the next question.

“Then where is the old 31’s account?”

The clerk said, “He left midway.”

“How many bricks had he made?”

“It’s on this page.”

“How much was he still owed?”

The clerk fell silent.

“His name?”

The silence grew heavier.

Madhusudan did not close the ledger.

He reopened every old page for number 31.

The figures were very clear.

There was not a single name.

Ramdev thought that without that half-receipt, the burden of those 1,800 bricks would have remained on him.

And if some wages were still due to the old 31, under whose name would they be paid?

Work began again that evening.

Ramdev went on slapping clay into the mould.

His tin 31 was tied into his gamchha.

Until then, the number had seemed like a light little thing.

That day he understood that sometimes a number lasts longer than a person.

The next morning, the clerk brought out the box of workers' tin number tags.

There were spare numbers in the box too.

47.

52.

61.

On some of the old numbers, the paint had worn away.

The clerk said, "The trouble came from reusing the numbers."

Nandu asked, "Then should we stop using numbers?"

The clerk answered at once, "No. Without numbers the counting would be chaos."

Ramdev said, "Keep the numbers."

Everyone looked at him.

"But when a number is given to someone, write the name as well."

The clerk said, "If we write names too, the ledger will get longer."

Ramdev did not laugh.

"By one line."

Madhusudan Babu was standing nearby.

He said, "Let it grow by one line."

A new page was drawn up that day.

There were four columns at the top.

Number.

Full name.

Village.

Date work began.

The clerk said, "We need the end date too."

A fifth column was added.

Ramdev's row was filled in first.

31.

Ramdev Mandal.

Belahi.

Poush 12.

End date—blank.

Ramdev kept looking at the page.

For the first time, he saw his name and 31 on the same line.

Nandu said, "And the old 31?"

The clerk made a separate row above for him.

In the space for the name, he wrote: "Unknown; red gamchha, somewhere toward Supaul."

Madhusudan said, "Don't leave it as 'unknown.' Ask around. Someone may know his name."

Two days later, Bhuwan remembered the name.
He had once gone to the market with that former worker.
His name was Surjan Yadav.
Nandu remembered the name of the village.
The clerk corrected the ledger.
A week later, someone from the kiln cycled to that village.
Surjan was not there.
He had gone to Punjab.
But his family was there.
The account showed that two days' wages were still due to him.
It was not a very large amount.
But before, the owner of that money had been only ३१.
Now its owner had a name.
The heat of Chaitra grew stronger.
Work at the kiln quickened.
New workers arrived.
One morning, a thin young man came to the gate.
The clerk opened the box to give him a tin token.
"Number 47."
The young man held out his hand.
Before giving him the token, the clerk opened the ledger.
"Name?"
"Ikram Ansari."
"Village?"
"Parsa."
"Starting work today?"
"Yes, from today."
The clerk wrote down the date.
Only then did he place the tin 47 in the young man's hand.
Ramdev was kneading clay a little distance away.
He heard the whole exchange.
He said nothing.
At noon, the count was taken.
The clerk called, "Thirty-one—Ramdev Mandal."
Ramdev stood up.
Nandu joked, "Now the name comes with it too."
Ramdev untied the tin token and looked at it.
३१ was still the same.
The paint had chipped a little.
He tied the token back into his gamchha.
That evening, only ३१ was chalked on the new row of unbaked bricks.

There, no name was needed.

But in the ledger, beside ३१, the ink read: Ramdev Mandal, Belahi, from Poush १२.

The ink was not yet completely dry.

The Forest Road

West of Belsar village lay a sal grove.

The forest was not very large, but for the people of three hamlets, the path through that green strip was part of daily life.

Belsar lay on one side of the path, the paved road on the other.

Along that road were the milk collection centre, the high school, the post office, and the weekly market.

The path through the sal grove was a little under one and a half kos long.

Going around by the embankment made the distance nearly four kos.

Every morning Saroja Devi came along that path carrying two cans of milk.

Her bicycle was old; its bell rang half the time and merely trembled the other half.

At the first bend, she would meet the children from Mahuatol.

Some were going to school; others were headed for the road to catch a vehicle to the market.

At the second bend, people bound for Ramphal Sah's flour mill in Dumri would join the path.

No motor vehicle had ever travelled along this path.

It was just wide enough for two bicycles to squeeze past each other with difficulty.

One Monday morning in Bhadau, Saroja saw a red cloth tied across the mouth of the path.

Behind the cloth, two bamboo poles had been driven into the ground.

In thick letters made with lime on the earth were the words: ENTRY CLOSED.

Saroja stopped her bicycle.

Forest guard Bateshwar Jha stood there with three labourers.

The labourers had spades in their hands.

To one side lay bundles of young sal saplings.

The rain expected over the next three days was said to be crucial for the forest planting.

That was why the labourers had been ordered to cut the first trench across the path that very day.

Once the trench was dug, it would be impossible to get a bicycle through with milk cans.

Saroja asked, "What has happened here?"

Bateshwar opened the map tucked under his arm.

On the map, the line through the forest had been struck through with a red cross.

"Under the new forest plan, this route is closed."

"Route?" Saroja bent over the map.

"Is my path shown here?"

Bateshwar put his finger on it.

"On this line."

"Then how is it closed?"

"The map says it is closed."

Saroja looked back at the ground.

Just then three children arrived with schoolbags hanging from their shoulders.

They stopped when they saw the red barrier.

Behind them came Gону Rai with milk cans hanging from his bicycle.

After him came two women carrying baskets for the market.

Within ten minutes, a small crowd had gathered at the mouth of the path.

Someone said they should pull out the bamboo poles.

Someone else said they would make another footpath across the forest.

Saroja did not even touch the bamboo.

"If we pull it out in the night, tomorrow the papers will say we forced our way in."

Bateshwar looked at her.

"Then what will you do?"

"First, let us understand what exactly the map is closing."

Bateshwar had a thick file with him.

In that file they found a brief note from an old survey.

An inspection had been carried out three years earlier, in Sawan.

The note read: "Unpaved motor road; culvert damaged; vehicular traffic closed."

Saroja read it once, then again.

"It says vehicles here."

Bateshwar remained silent.

The legend on the new map said only: "Route closed."

The old word "motor" had disappeared.

Bateshwar said, "I cannot ignore what is written in the papers and open the path on my own authority."

Saroja replied, "I am not asking you to do that either."
 She had the blank back of a red milk slip with her.
 She took out a pencil.
 "Let us count how many people use this path in a single day."
 A few people in the crowd laughed.
 Bateshwar did not.
 "What will counting prove?"
 "At the very least, it will show whether the thing being closed is actually in use."
 Bateshwar told the labourers to stop digging.
 "Until noon."
 Saroja did not go to the milk collection centre.
 The centre stopped weighing milk at seven forty-five.
 Saroja knew that if her milk arrived late that day, it would be entered in the evening account.
 Even so, she did not leave the mouth of the path.
 Gonu Rai took her two cans along with his own.
 Saroja sat down at the entrance to the path.
 Bateshwar brought an old board from the forest outpost.
 He drew four columns on it: on foot, bicycle, animal, other.
 The first row recorded seven schoolchildren.
 Then came five people taking milk to the collection centre.
 Then Lakshmikant Mishra, an elderly man on his way to the post office.
 He needed to have his monthly pension form verified.
 When he heard about the route along the embankment, he said, "My knees do not understand a four-kos map."
 Saroja smiled, but drew only a single mark on the board.
 By eight o'clock, forty-eight people had passed.
 Of those forty-eight, twelve were schoolchildren, nine were taking milk, five carried market baskets, and the rest were headed for the road.
 Bateshwar recorded this breakdown in a separate row.
 Saroja said, "Let the count be kept in such a way that tomorrow no one can say it was only a market-day crowd."
 By ten o'clock, the number had reached eighty-six.
 Someone was going to sell greens.
 Someone else to have a ploughshare sharpened.
 Someone empty-handed to catch a vehicle on the road.
 Someone to bring back salt and oil from the market.
 From time to time, Bateshwar kept asking their purpose.
 Saroja said, "Count the path, not the purpose."
 "Why not ask the purpose?"

"The work they have today will keep changing. The path will remain."
At eleven o'clock, the Forest Department's area assistant arrived by jeep.
The jeep did not enter the forest.
It was stopped by the roadside.

The area assistant looked at the map, then the board, then the line of people beyond the bamboo poles.

"Were all these people specially called here today?"

Saroja said, "No. We are counting whoever happens to come."

The area assistant looked at Bateshwar.

Bateshwar nodded.

"I have been here since morning."

By noon, one hundred and thirty-two people had passed.

By then the sun was high.

The people sitting at the path entrance kept changing, but the counting did not stop.

No one who passed was made to stop and listen to a speech; only a tally mark was drawn.

That simplicity caught the area assistant's attention more than anything else.

Not a single motor vehicle was among them.

There were twenty-seven bicycles.

The rest were on foot.

The area assistant placed his pencil on the red cross on the map.

"This survey concerned a route fit for motor traffic."

Saroja asked, "Then is there no separate symbol for a footpath?"

"Not on this map."

"Then how can something that has no symbol here be declared closed?"

The area assistant did not answer at once.

The labourers were sitting on the bundles of saplings.

By two o'clock, the count had reached one hundred and sixty-nine.

Bateshwar himself set off once to measure the alternative route along the embankment.

He went on foot.

By the time he returned, his sandals were packed with slick mud.

"Not quite four kos," he said, "but more than three."

Saroja did not write that on the board.

"Measuring distance is your job."

That evening, a meeting was held at the forest outpost.

Some young men wanted the entire old route opened to motor vehicles as well.

Their argument was that since the department was already giving ground, they might as well take the full benefit.

One young man said that if motor vehicles were allowed, loads from the market could be brought in more easily.

Saroja showed them the day's tally on the board.

The column for motor vehicles stood at zero.

Saroja objected.

"Let us ask for no more than what we actually need."

"If the path is being opened anyway, why not allow motor vehicles too?" one young man asked.

"Because once motor vehicles begin using it, the forest path will become a road."

For the first time, Bateshwar spoke in Saroja's support. "And then the map will start saying something else again."

The area assistant wrote out a proposal: the old strip used for local pedestrian and bicycle traffic would be preserved; narrow posts would be installed at both entrances to stop motor vehicles; and the plantation would be shifted to either side of the path.

That night, no bamboo pole was pulled out.

The next day, the ENTRY CLOSED strip was not removed; it was merely moved aside.

The measuring began.

The path was four cubits wide in some places, five in others.

Where rainwater had cut into it, packed earth was used instead of gravel.

At two points inside the forest, the rows of saplings were shifted half a cubit.

A week later, two sturdy posts were planted at each entrance.

A bicycle could pass between them.

A motor vehicle could not.

A new sign was put up: "LOCAL PEDESTRIAN-BICYCLE PATH. MOTOR VEHICLES PROHIBITED."

Saroja read the sign.

"Is it right now?" Bateshwar asked.

"The sign is right. What about the map?"

Bateshwar laughed.

"That is being corrected too."

A month later, a new map arrived at the forest outpost.

During that month, the planting had also been completed.

The saplings that had first been placed in the middle of the path now stood in rows along both sides.

Bateshwar said that saving the path had not reduced the number of saplings; only the line had changed.

The red cross was gone.

In place of the thick line, a thin dotted line ran through the sal grove.

In the legend beside it were the words: local pedestrian-bicycle path.

Bateshwar showed the map to Saroja.

She did not look at it for long.

It was almost time for the morning milk run.

She lifted her bicycle.

She carefully guided the milk cans through the gap between the two posts.

Behind her, the schoolchildren were coming along.

The young sal saplings stood in straight rows on both sides of the path.

The path between them was as narrow as it had always been.

The only difference was that now, even on the map, it looked like a path rather than a road.

The Labourer's Signature

The desilting of Belahi Pond began in the second week of Phagun.

The pond's water had already fallen very low.

A thick layer of black silt lay exposed along the banks.

The villagers said that if the silt could be removed before the rains arrived, the pond would breathe again.

Twenty-six women and nine men were engaged in the work.

Dhanwanti Paswan was among them.

She was about forty-five years old.

She could not read, but she kept a careful account of each day's work in her memory.

How many baskets of silt had been lifted, which day it had rained, which day a spade had broken—she remembered it all.

In the evening Jagdish, who kept the work records, would open a register.

Against each name were columns for days, measurement, rate, and amount due.

Dhanwanti could not read her own name.

She simply watched Jagdish's finger.

"Here."

At that spot she pressed down her inked thumb.

During the first week, the procedure caused her no difficulty.

The first wage payment came on time.

At the end of the second week, it rained one day.

Silt was dug in the morning, but by noon the pond bed had turned slippery.

Instead of stopping work, the supervisor told the group to fill sacks with the silt already taken out and move them to higher ground along the bank.

Dhanwanti and the other women spent two hours lifting sacks.

After that, a temporary bamboo barrier was put up beside the pond.

Everyone remained at the site until evening that day.

Three days later the same thing happened again.

This time no silt was dug.

The whole day was spent clearing weeds and debris from the mouth of the old drainage channel.

Dhanwanti remembered that day especially because a small blister had formed in the middle of her right palm.

On payment day, Jagdish called out the names one by one.

When Dhanwanti's turn came, she received less money than she had expected.

She counted the notes, then counted them again.

"Why are two days missing?" she blurted out.

Jagdish looked at the register.

"Not two days. One and a half."

"Was I at home for a day and a half?"

"Not at home. The measurement was short."

Dhanwanti did not understand.

"A full day, but less measurement—what kind of account is that?"

Jagdish placed a fingernail on one of the columns in the register.

"Look here. Half measurement on the rainy day. Half on the drainage day too."

Dhanwanti stared at the page.

Black lines, small figures, and the mark of her thumb.

Jagdish's words—"Look here"—lodged inside her.

She could not read what he was asking her to see.

She could only stare at the page.

That night Dhanwanti did not keep thinking about the bundle of notes; she kept thinking about the columns in the register.

The next morning she went to work.

She lifted silt.

At noon, while stopping for water, she paused by Jagdish's table.

"Say those four words again."

"Which four?"

"Name, day, measurement, rate."

Jagdish laughed.

"And amount due."

"Yes, that makes five."

With her finger, Dhanwanti drew five boxes in the earth.

Jagdish wrote the first letter in each box.

Dhanwanti did not learn the letters that day.

She learned the order of the boxes.

Name first.

Day second.

Measurement third.

Rate fourth.

Amount due fifth.

That evening, with a piece of charcoal, she drew five lines on the wall of her house.

Her daughter-in-law Sunita asked, "What's that?"

Dhanwanti said, "The five houses of a wage."

Sunita had studied through the seventh class.

She did not laugh.

She brought a scrap of paper.

"Learn the numbers first. The letters can come later."

That made sense to Dhanwanti.

Numbers were not entirely unfamiliar to her.

She heard prices at the market.

She counted bus fares.

But connecting written numerals with the spoken numbers was new to her.

Sunita wrote the digits from zero to nine.

Beside each digit, Dhanwanti placed that many grains of rice.

Within three days she had begun to recognize single-digit numbers.

On the fifth day she joined two digits and read them together.

"Twelve days."

Sunita said, "Correct."

Dhanwanti smiled.

"Now I'll be able to see on the paper whether I've worked twelve days or not."

Sunita wrote the five words again.

First box—name.

Day.

Measurement.

Rate.

Amount due.

Dhanwanti could not yet read each whole word at a glance.

She began by recognizing their shapes.

"Day" was short.

"Measurement" had a distinctive shape in the middle.

"Amount due" stretched longer at the end.

Ten days later, when Jagdish opened the register, Dhanwanti did not wait for his finger this time.

She found the first box herself.

Sunita had first taught her the opening "Dh" of her own name.

She could not read the whole of "Dhanwanti," but she recognized the "Dh" and the position of her row.

In the days column was "12."

She read it.
 "Twelve days."
 Jagdish's finger stopped.
 Dhanwanti moved to the third column.
 There it said "10½."
 She did not understand the half sign.
 "What is this crooked mark?"
 Jagdish said, "Half."
 Dhanwanti looked at the page again.
 "Twelve days. Measurement ten and a half."
 "Yes, that's right."
 "Then where did the other day and a half go?"
 "I told you—the measurement was short on the rainy day."
 This time Dhanwanti did not let the page go.
 "That day I carried sacks. On the other day I cleaned the drainage channel."
 "That wasn't measured work."
 "Then which box is it in?"
 Jagdish fell silent.
 Dhanwanti looked at the heading row at the top of the register.
 After the five familiar words there was another small box.
 She did not know that word.
 "What does this word say?"
 Jagdish read it slowly: "Other work."
 Dhanwanti repeated the words.
 "Other work."
 The box was blank.
 "Was carrying sacks and cleaning the drainage channel not other work?"
 Jagdish turned the page.
 "The supervisor told you to do it. I didn't enter it on the measurement sheet."
 "Why not?"
 "Because there was no measurement."
 For the first time Dhanwanti understood that wages could be cut not because the work was absent, but because a column for it was.
 She asked to see the rows for the other women.
 At first Jagdish hesitated.
 Then he turned the register around on the table.
 Dhanwanti could not read all the names.
 But she could recognize "12."
 One row, then another, then a third.

Eleven people who had worked twelve days had been entered as ten and a half in the measurement column.

For three men, all twelve had been entered.

Dhanwanti asked, "What did these three do on those days?"

Jagdish said, "They put up the bamboo posts."

"They didn't dig silt either."

"No, they didn't."

"Then where is their other work written?"

Jagdish turned the page back again.

In the "Other work" column of all three rows, "1½" had been entered.

Dhanwanti's face did not harden.

She simply looked at the page for a long time.

"Did our sacks and drainage work happen in the air?"

Jagdish said, "No."

"Then why is there only empty space on the paper?"

That evening the payment was not held back.

Jagdish called the supervisor.

At first the supervisor said that remaking the measurement sheet would take time.

From the fold of her sari, Dhanwanti took out her paper with the five boxes.

In a sixth box Sunita had written a new phrase—"Other work."

Dhanwanti read the words slowly.

The supervisor looked at her.

"Do you know how to read?"

Dhanwanti said, "Not everything. Just enough for my wages."

At that answer Kusuma, Rampari, and Phulkali laughed.

The supervisor checked the register again.

Jagdish confirmed that it was the supervisor himself who had given the verbal instructions for those two days' work.

The "Other work" done by the three men who had put up the bamboo posts had been recorded.

But the column was blank for the eleven women who had carried sacks and cleared the drainage channel.

The supervisor said, "This is an entry error."

Dhanwanti corrected him: "That error costs a day and a half."

The following week a correction sheet was prepared.

A day and a half was added against each of the eleven rows.

This time Dhanwanti checked the figures herself.

Twelve days.

Twelve measured workdays.

Rate.

Amount due.

Everything matched.

Jagdish slid the inkpot toward her.

“Thumbprint?”

Dhanwanti held out her hand, then stopped.

“I’ve learned to write my name.”

Writing her whole name in one continuous flow was still difficult.

Night after night, Sunita had made her practise its five letters.

Dhanwanti took hold of the pen.

The first “Dh” came out a little crooked.

The “n” in the middle was too small.

The final vowel mark climbed too high.

But on the page, instead of the round inked mark of her thumb, stood her written name.

Jagdish said, “Now you have a signature.”

Dhanwanti turned the page back toward herself.

“The signature comes later. First the account.”

She read each box once more.

First box—name.

Day.

Measurement.

Rate.

Other work.

Amount due.

Only after everything matched did she put the pen down on the table.

On the next payment day, Rampari moved forward to press down her thumb.

Dhanwanti did not stop her hand.

She turned the register toward her instead.

“First look at the days column.”

Rampari said, “I don’t know how to read.”

Dhanwanti replied, “I don’t know all of it either.”

She placed a finger on the word “Day.”

“Start here.”

By the third week, the desilting of the pond was almost complete.

The soil along the bank was gradually levelled.

Something new had appeared in the register too.

The “Other work” column was no longer left blank for anyone.

Dhanwanti’s signature was not very beautiful.

Sometimes the “Dh” grew too large; sometimes the final vowel mark slipped down.

But she kept reading the figures written directly above it.

For her, a labourer’s signature was no longer merely a name in ink.

The road to that name now passed through five or six columns.

The Erosion Zone

Behind Kushaha Tola stood a small hillock.

In the rains, scrub grew over its slope; in winter, the red earth gleamed.

On the other side of the hillock, a lease for stone quarrying had been granted five years earlier.

At first, the villagers regarded it as work taking place far away.

Two or three times a day came a dull thud; the ground trembled slightly, and then everyone returned to what they had been doing.

Sugiya Devi's field lay below the hillock.

A little less than one bigha.

Pigeon pea on the upper part, maize in the middle, and a small patch of paddy lower down.

At one corner of the field stood an old culvert belonging to the irrigation department.

The number "4" was painted in white on its side.

Sugiya's father used to say, "As long as that number remains, the corner of the field will never be lost."

Until then, Sugiya had understood those words only in relation to the boundary ridge.

One morning she saw a bamboo pole tied with a red cloth standing among the pigeon pea.

The pole had not been there the day before.

It stood halfway into the field.

Sugiya went up to it and touched the soil.

The bamboo had been newly planted.

Beside it was written: "Safety."

At noon, a guard from the quarry came.

"There will be blasting today," he said. "Don't remain inside this marker."

Sugiya asked, "Is this the lease boundary?"

"No, only a safety line."

"Then why is it in my field?"

"Stones may fly this way."

That day Sugiya left the pigeon pea and went home.

When she returned in the evening, the bamboo pole was still there.

It was there the next day too.

And the third day.

A week later the red cloth had faded, but the bamboo pole had not been removed.

When Sugiya went in to pick pigeon pea, the guard said, "From now on, don't come too far this way."

"There's no blasting today."

"It is better to be careful."

Sugiya said nothing.

She picked the pigeon pea and carried it home.

Fifteen days later, a second bamboo pole was planted.

Twelve or fifteen cubits farther into the field than the first.

This time the cloth was yellow.

Beside it again was written: "Safety."

Sugiya looked at the first red bamboo pole.

It was still there too.

There were now two lines.

The old line and the new one.

The quarry workers said, "A crack has been found farther ahead, so the distance has been increased."

"For how many days?"

"As long as necessary."

From that day, Sugiya began counting the distance from the corner of her field.

She counted her steps from Culvert Number Four to the first red bamboo pole.

One hundred and fourteen steps.

To the yellow bamboo pole, ninety-six.

Back home, she wrote on the last page of an old notebook:

"Red—114. Yellow—96."

Sugiya could read numbers perfectly well.

When it came to land, numbers had never felt burdensome to her.

The following month, the mining company distributed small slips to four houses beside the field.

The slip read: "Temporary safety restriction."

Sugiya's field-plot number was on it as well.

It said not to enter the field for two days.

A small payment was made for those two days.

Sugiya kept the slip.

She did not go to the field that day.

On the third day, she went.

Beyond the yellow bamboo pole, small pieces of stone lay scattered on the ground.

She picked them up and put them outside the boundary ridge.

By Kartik, the pigeon pea had been harvested.

Sugiyā wanted to sow lentils in that same patch.

The guard said, "Don't sow in this strip."

"The slip said two days."

"There is still a risk."

"Then give me another slip."

The guard did not answer.

Sugiyā sowed the lentils.

The whistle sounded twice.

She left the field.

The blasting took place.

In the evening she returned to the field.

This time the lentils came up.

But in the middle of winter, a new blue flag was planted even farther inside than the yellow bamboo pole.

Sugiyā counted her steps again.

From Culvert Number Four to the blue flag: seventy-two steps.

In the notebook she wrote:

"Blue—72."

In three months, the line had moved from 114 steps to 72.

The quarried section was still some distance away.

But the field seemed smaller.

In Phagun, an employee from the circle office came for an inspection.

Standing beside the field, he asked, "Why is there less crop in this strip?"

The mining company's clerk said, "People no longer sow on this part."

Sugiyā heard him.

"I sow here."

The clerk smiled. "A little."

Sugiyā pointed to the rows of lentils.

On this side of the blue flag the lentils were thick.

On the other side they were sparse.

Whenever the whistle sounded, people had to leave that part of the field; they kept their animals away, and irrigation was delayed.

The employee wrote on his paper: "Mining-affected fallow strip."

Sugiyā immediately asked, "How is it fallow?"

"It is not being fully cultivated."

"Cultivation has decreased because your people told us to leave the field."

“Not our people,” the employee said.
 Sugiya took out all three slips.
 The first, the two-day notice.
 The second, a safety notice.
 The third, a one-week restriction.
 “If the restriction exists on your paper, how did the land become fallow by my choice?”
 The employee looked at the papers again.
 “These restrictions are temporary.”
 “Then ‘fallow’ should also be written as temporary.”
 The employee remained silent for a few moments.
 The clerk intervened. “The line is only for safety.”
 Sugiya opened her notebook.
 “Then why did the safety line move from 114 steps to 72 in three months?”
 The clerk laughed. “Steps are not an official measurement.”
 “Fine,” Sugiya said. “Have it measured officially.”
 The inspection ended there that day.
 For two weeks, nothing happened.
 The blue flag remained where it was.
 One morning Sugiya saw a thin line being drawn with white lime beyond the blue flag.
 She asked, “What is this?”
 The young man doing the work said, “So that the excavation zone can be seen clearly.”
 “Will the quarrying come this far?”
 “I was told only to draw the line.”
 Sugiya did not stop the lime from being laid.
 She walked to Culvert Number Four.
 She opened her notebook.
 She counted her steps.
 The lime line was sixty-eight steps from the culvert.
 She wrote: “Lime—68.”
 Then she went to the circle office.
 This time she did not say, “Save my field.”
 She said, “Show me the lease boundary, the safety line, and the excavation line separately.”
 The surveyor sitting in the room looked up.
 “All three?”
 Sugiya placed her notebook before him.
 “Red 114. Yellow 96. Blue 72. Lime 68. Culvert Number Four is still where it was.”

The surveyor asked, "Is the culvert an officially recorded marker?"

"It has a number painted on it."

The old survey map was brought out.

On the map, the mining-lease boundary was marked with a thick black line.

No safety line was marked within it.

It could change, because the manner of quarrying changed.

But it was not a boundary of land ownership.

The surveyor said, "We need a joint measurement on site."

Three days later, the measurement was carried out.

A representative of the mining company came.

The circle surveyor came.

An irrigation-department employee brought the record for Culvert Number Four.

Five farmers from the village also stood there.

Sugiya stood quietly on the boundary ridge.

The measuring chain was stretched out from the culvert.

The first permanent lease marker was half buried in the earth.

When the scrub was cut away, its top became visible.

An old serial number was marked on it.

The black boundary on the map matched that marker.

The red bamboo pole stood outside it.

So did the yellow bamboo pole.

The blue flag and the lime line lay even farther inside the field.

The mining-company representative said, "All these were for safety, not to extend the lease."

The surveyor said, "Then once the safety restriction ends, the markers must be removed."

"Because of the cracks, we need to keep a distance."

"Keep the distance," the surveyor said, "but do not call it the lease boundary or a permanent excavation zone."

For the first time, Sugiya spoke: "And when the field remains empty because of it, don't call it fallow."

The circle-office employee remembered his earlier remark.

He added a new sentence to the file:

"Cultivation partly obstructed by safety restrictions."

That sentence did not immediately make the field any larger.

Nor did it stop the sound of stone blasting.

But all three temporary markers were removed.

On blasting days, a red flag was now put up only alongside a slip stating the time, and was removed in the evening.

At the lease boundary, the two permanent stone markers were raised above the ground again.

Their serial numbers were repainted.

The next season, Sugiya sowed peas where the blue flag had stood.

At the first irrigation, the water crossed the old lime line and flowed beyond it.

The lime mark disappeared even before the rains.

One day her granddaughter asked, "Where is the boundary of this field?"

Sugiya pointed out the distant stone marker.

Then she pointed to Culvert Number Four.

"Remember these two."

"What about the red and yellow flags?"

"Those only tell you what is happening that day," Sugiya said. "They are not the boundary of the land."

Her granddaughter went on ahead, counting the rows of peas.

Sugiya stood on the boundary ridge.

The dull thud from the quarry came again.

The ground trembled slightly.

The pea leaves quivered, then grew still.

Culvert Number Four remained where it was.

Ration Day

In Sonbarsa village, the seventh day of every month was set aside for ration distribution.

From early morning, people began gathering in front of the shop with sacks, bags, and brass or plastic containers.

Sonmati Devi arrived at seven o'clock.

She was seventy-two years old.

Her body was frail, her gait slow, but her memory remained sharp.

She kept her old ration slip folded inside a red cloth.

The corners of the slip had worn thin.

Inside were small marks showing that she had received grain through the previous month.

Sonmati now lived alone in her house.

One son lived in Punjab; the other worked as a labourer near Janakpur.

Both names had been removed from the household list long ago.

She collected her five kilos of rice and her wheat ration herself.

The dealer, Brijmohan, opened the register.

"Tell me your name."

"Sonmati Devi, wife of the late Harinarayan Sah."

Brijmohan ran a finger down the register.

Then he checked another page.

"Your name isn't here this time."

Sonmati thought she had heard him wrong.

"Look again."

Brijmohan looked again.

"I can't find the name."

"It was there last month."

"Last month's register was different."

Sonmati unfolded the red cloth.

"Look at this. You made the mark here yourself."

Brijmohan examined the slip.

"I'm not denying that. But your name isn't on today's list."

The people standing behind her began to shift impatiently.

Someone said, "Give us ours first. This can be sorted out later."

Sonmati moved aside.
 She sat quietly against the shop's mud wall.
 Brijmohan went on reading out the names one by one.
 Sacks kept opening.
 The scale kept tipping.
 Sonmati's bag remained empty.
 At nine, Brijmohan came over to her.
 "Go to the block office. The list came from there."
 "Was my name sent away from here, or from there?"
 Brijmohan paused for a moment.
 "It didn't come from there."
 Sonmati tucked the bag under her arm and set off for the office.
 The block office was about two kos from the village.
 By the time she arrived, it was noon.
 Seven people were waiting outside the food-distribution room.
 When Sonmati's turn came, the clerk entered the number from her old slip.
 He looked at the screen.
 "Your status here shows 'transferred.'"
 Sonmati stared straight at him.
 "Where to?"
 "What did you say?"
 "Where have I been transferred to?"
 The clerk looked at the screen again.
 "The destination field is blank."
 "Then how did I go?"
 Another employee sitting in the room almost laughed, but Sonmati did not.
 The clerk said, "Bring proof of residence. From the panchayat."
 "Isn't my body proof enough?"
 "The rules require paper."
 Sonmati set off again.
 The panchayat office was half a kos back along the same road.
 The assistant there, Chandreshwar, knew her.
 "Auntie, what happened?"
 Sonmati said, "I've left the village, but I don't know where I've gone."
 At first Chandreshwar did not understand.
 Then he looked at the papers.
 "Oh, this has been entered incorrectly."
 "Do I have to correct the incorrect paper myself?"
 Chandreshwar lowered his eyes.

He wrote out a residence certificate: Sonmati Devi, Ward Five, Sonbarsa, continuous resident for the past thirty-eight years.

The mukhiya's seal was affixed.

Sonmati did not fold the paper.

Holding it flat in her hand, she returned to the block office.

This time the first clerk had gone out for lunch.

The other clerk examined the certificate.

"This proves residence. But the number of family members must also be verified."

"There's only one name in the family."

"It still has to be verified."

"Who will do that?"

"The village-level worker."

"Where will I find him?"

"He's out in the field today."

"What time will he return?"

"Hard to say."

Sonmati sat down outside on the veranda.

Her bag held only an empty container.

Whenever the wind stirred, the lid of the container clinked again and again.

At three, the village-level worker arrived.

The moment he saw Sonmati, he said, "You're from Sonbarsa, aren't you?"

"The paper says I belong somewhere else."

The village-level worker looked at her certificate.

"I'll submit a report after checking your house tomorrow."

"Not today?"

"I'm not going out again today."

Sonmati returned home.

Less rice went onto the stove that day.

Her neighbour Chameli offered her half a seer of rice.

Sonmati would not take it.

"There's enough at home for two days."

That night she unfolded the red cloth and kept looking at the old ration slip.

The certificate stating that she had lived there for thirty-eight years was new.

The ration slip, however, was old.

Both papers belonged to the same woman.

One paper said: she is here.

The other list said: she has gone away.
 The village-level worker came the next morning.
 He inspected the courtyard.
 The earthen stove, the tulsi altar, the old bamboo lattice, the faded
 photograph of Harinarayan on the wall.
 "You live here?"
 Sonmati looked at him.
 "Do you have to write that question down?"
 The village-level worker looked embarrassed.
 "It's on the form."
 "Write: she lives here."
 He wrote it.
 Sonmati asked for a photocopy.
 The village-level worker looked startled at first.
 "What for?"
 "Tomorrow someone else may ask where I am."
 At noon, Sonmati reached the block office for the third time.
 This time the first clerk was at his desk.
 He placed the residence certificate and the verification report together.
 Then he opened the old list.
 "I'll register an application."
 "When will my name come back?"
 "In the next revision."
 "And this month's grain?"
 The clerk fell silent.
 "The shop won't give it without your name on the list."
 Sonmati unfolded the red ration slip.
 "Who took last month's grain?"
 "You did."
 "Where is that register?"
 The clerk said, "At the shop."
 "Does that register have my thumbprint?"
 "It should."
 "Then one paper says I left, and another says I collected grain last month."
 This time the clerk had no answer.
 Sonmati asked, "How did 'transferred' get written there?"
 The clerk called for the old survey file.
 A dust-covered sheet arrived.
 Sonmati's name was on one line.
 Below it was the name of her younger son, Mahesh.
 Mahesh had settled elsewhere five years earlier.

On the original survey sheet, 'away' was written against Mahesh's name.
Against Sonmati's, it said 'present.'

But when the fair copy was prepared, the line between the two rows had gone slightly crooked.

The mark for 'away' had become attached to the row above.

The clerk pulled the paper closer.

"There's been an error here."

Sonmati asked, "Mahesh went away, so why did the paper send me?"

No one laughed.

The clerk wrote a correction note.

The old distribution register was called for as well.

On the page from Brijmohan's shop, Sonmati's thumbprint stood beside the previous month's date.

The quantity was written below the date.

Five kilos of rice.

Two kilos of wheat.

The clerk laid three papers together.

The residence certificate.

The village verification report.

The distribution register.

Then the original survey sheet.

"A provisional approval can be issued today," he said.

Sonmati asked, "Am I provisional, or is the approval?"

A faint smile appeared on the clerk's face.

"The approval."

He stamped it.

By the time evening fell, Sonmati had reached the ration shop again.

Brijmohan was closing up.

He looked at the stamp.

"You want it now?"

"Today is ration day, isn't it?"

Brijmohan opened the sacks again.

The scale came back out.

Sonmati held open her bag.

First the rice was weighed.

Then the wheat.

Brijmohan pushed the register toward her for a thumbprint.

Sonmati held back her hand.

"Read it first."

"What did you say?"

"The name."

Brijmohan looked at the register.

“Sonmati Devi.”

“Husband?”

“Late Harinarayan Sah.”

“Village?”

“Sonbarsa.”

“Quantity?”

Brijmohan read out both quantities.

Only then did Sonmati put down her thumbprint.

On the seventh of the next month, she again reached the shop early in the morning.

A new list had been posted.

She could not read her own name.

Brijmohan’s daughter Rashmi was sitting there.

Sonmati said, “See if my name is there.”

Rashmi ran a finger down the list until she found the line.

“The name is there.”

“Anything else written?”

“Status—present.”

For a moment Sonmati kept looking at that word.

Then she placed the old ration slip, the residence certificate, the photocopy of the verification report, and the stamped correction paper together inside the red cloth.

Rashmi asked, “Auntie, why do you still keep so many papers?”

Sonmati said, “When your name lives on paper, you have to preserve the paper’s memory too.”

A sack slipped behind the shop.

Brijmohan straightened the scale.

Sonmati opened her bag.

This time, her row was already there in the register.

The Distance to School

When Class Eight at Kamalpur Middle School ended, Kanchan's results were good.

She stood third in her class.

For further study, she had to go to Belahi High School.

It was ten kilometres and two hundred metres from Kamalpur.

On the very first day, Kanchan's father, Shambhu Mandal, said, 'I won't send you that far on foot every day.'

Kanchan did not argue.

She knew the distance.

Heavy trucks loaded with sand ran along the main paved road.

In the rains, the roadside became slippery.

There was one old bicycle at home, but it was Shambhu's only means of getting to the market and the fields.

Its rear wheel kept coming loose.

One day Kanchan said, 'I'll walk for the first week.'

Parvati, her mother, asked only, 'Ten kilometres there, ten kilometres back—and then again the next day?'

Kanchan did not answer.

On the day of admission, she went to Madhavi Jha, the headmistress of the middle school.

Madhavi looked over her certificate.

'Shall I enrol you at Belahi?'

Kanchan said, 'Please do. I don't yet have a way to get there.'

Madhavi paused at that answer.

From the school cupboard she took out a register.

On it was written: 'Bicycle Assistance for Girls Living Far Away.'

The rule was brief.

A girl entering Class Nine who lived more than five kilometres away was eligible for assistance.

Kanchan's eyes lit up.

Then Madhavi read the next line.

'Distribution after at least twenty days' attendance at school.'

Kanchan fell silent again.

Madhavi did not close the register.
 She read the line once more.
 She needed a bicycle because of the distance.
 To receive the bicycle, she had to reach school for twenty days.
 To reach school for those twenty days, she needed a bicycle.
 Kanchan said softly, 'Then how do I manage the first twenty days?'
 Madhavi had no answer.
 The admission was completed that day, but Kanchan did not go to Belahi the following Monday.
 Nor on Tuesday.
 On Wednesday, Madhavi came to her house.
 Kanchan was on the veranda, writing her name on a notebook she had bought for Class Nine.
 'Why didn't you go?'
 'The road to the twentieth day begins with the first.'
 Madhavi did not smile.
 She said, 'I'm looking for an answer to that very thing.'
 Behind Kamalpur Middle School was a small storeroom.
 It held bamboo poles used for games, old planks, torn maps, and two iron chests.
 In one corner stood a bicycle covered in dust.
 Kanchan had seen it before.
 Two years earlier it had been bought to carry a travelling book-box from village to village.
 When the mobile service stopped, the bicycle was put into storage.
 In the asset register it was listed as: 'Property No. 14—Bicycle—Not in Working Order.'
 Madhavi and the watchman, Nandu, wheeled it outside.
 There was no air in the tyres.
 The chain was rusty.
 The bell was missing.
 The saddle was torn.
 But the frame was straight.
 Nandu said, 'We can get it running again.'
 Bhola Sah, the village repairman, was called.
 He spun the wheel.
 'Two inner tubes, clean the chain, one pedal, a brake cable. That's all.'
 Madhavi asked, 'How much?'
 Bhola gave her the figure.
 There was enough money in the school development fund.
 But there was another obstacle.

School property could not be given to a student.

Madhavi called a short meeting of the School Management Committee. Shambhu attended as well.

Madhavi placed the rules in front of them.

‘I’m not asking anyone to change the assistance scheme.’

Committee member Jagdish asked, ‘Then what are you asking?’

‘Let us create a way across the first twenty days.’

She opened the page of the asset register.

‘The bicycle will remain the school’s property, not the student’s.’

‘Who will use it?’

‘A girl who lives more than five kilometres away and is waiting for the assistance bicycle.’

Jagdish asked again, ‘And after one girl rides it for twenty days?’

‘When her assistance bicycle arrives, this one will go to the next new student.’

Nandu laughed. ‘Call it the Twenty-Day Bicycle.’

Madhavi said, ‘Let the register give it a clear name: Entry Bicycle.’

The meeting agreed on that name.

A separate section was created.

Student’s name.

Distance from home.

Date taken.

Date returned.

Condition of bicycle when taken.

Condition of bicycle when returned.

Kanchan’s name was entered in the first row.

Distance—10.2 kilometres.

Bhola had the bicycle running in two days.

He did not repaint it.

The old blue paint remained.

A thick cloth cover was fitted over the saddle.

A new bell was attached.

The chain still made a little noise as it turned, though much less than before.

The first time Kanchan brought the bicycle home, Parvati walked around it, looking it over from every side.

‘Is it yours now?’

‘No. It belongs to the school. I have it for twenty days.’

Shambhu asked, ‘And after twenty days?’

‘When I get the assistance bicycle, I’ll return this one.’

Shambhu looked at the copy of the register entry.

It said: 'Return date—after receipt of new bicycle.'

Shambhu read that line twice.

Kanchan did not set out alone on the first day.

Rekha and Sarita from the neighbourhood already cycled to Belahi on their own bicycles.

The three met under the peepal tree at Kamalpur at five past seven in the morning.

Madhavi had told them, 'For the first week, leave together at the same time.'

Kanchan's bicycle had a new bell, but old brakes.

She went slowly down the first slope.

Rekha in front.

Kanchan in the middle.

Sarita behind.

The ten kilometres did not become any shorter.

When Kanchan returned on the first day, her legs ached.

They ached on the second day too.

By the third day, she had identified two shady places along the road.

By the fifth, she realised that cycling to school took less than half the time it would have taken to walk.

It rained on the seventh day.

The three girls waited for ten minutes beneath a roadside shelter.

They reached school late, but they reached it.

A seventh attendance mark appeared beside Kanchan's name in the register.

On the tenth day, she had the bicycle's brakes tightened at Bhola's shop.

Kanchan herself wrote in the register: 'Brakes tightened.'

Madhavi said, 'Using something that belongs to the school also means recording its condition.'

Kanchan nodded.

On the twelfth day, a teacher at Belahi School filled out the assistance form.

The distance field was already clear.

The attendance field was blank.

'We'll sign it when you complete twenty days.'

Kanchan did not fold the form away.

She left it in the school file.

On the seventeenth day, Sarita's bicycle tyre went flat.

Kanchan stopped the Entry Bicycle.

The two girls walked for a kilometre and a half, pushing their bicycles.

Rekha rode ahead to the repair shop in the next village.

All three reached school late that day.
 Their attendance was marked, with the time entered separately.
 Kanchan understood that the twenty-day count was not about making twenty flawless journeys.
 It was about reaching school.
 On the nineteenth day Shambhu asked, 'Tomorrow makes twenty?'
 'Yes.'
 'So you return the bicycle the day after?'
 Kanchan said, 'After the new bicycle is in my hands.'
 She remembered the line in the register.
 On the twentieth day, Madhavi came to Belahi.
 She checked the attendance register.
 Twenty days.
 The required stamp was placed on the assistance form.
 Kanchan was delighted, but she did not receive the new bicycle that day.
 Distribution was three days later.
 One committee member said, 'The twenty days are complete. Take back the school bicycle now.'
 Madhavi opened the asset register.
 In the return field it said: 'After receipt of new bicycle.'
 She said, 'Let us not create another three-day gap between eligibility and the means to reach school.'
 The Entry Bicycle remained with Kanchan for three more days.
 On the twenty-third day, the assistance bicycles were distributed in the courtyard of Belahi School.
 Kanchan's name was called.
 She took hold of the new bicycle.
 There was no garland of flowers.
 She first rode the new bicycle once around the courtyard.
 Then she rode the old blue Entry Bicycle back to Kamalpur.
 Madhavi was sitting with the register open.
 Kanchan showed her the condition of the bicycle.
 'Both brakes work.'
 'Tyres?'
 'Filled with air.'
 'Bell?'
 Kanchan rang it.
 Tin-tin.
 Madhavi entered the return date.
 Kanchan signed.
 She had thought the bicycle would now go back into the storeroom.

But the storeroom door did not open.

That evening, Poonam came with her mother from neighbouring Barahi village.

Poonam had enrolled in Class Nine.

Her home was seven kilometres and eight hundred metres from Belahi.

Her own twenty-day qualifying period for assistance had not even begun.

Madhavi brought the Entry Bicycle out in front of her.

The second row of the register was opened.

Poonam's name.

Distance—7.8 kilometres.

Date taken.

Kanchan stood a little way off.

Poonam looked at the height of the saddle.

'I need it a little lower.'

Bhola was called again.

The saddle was lowered.

Kanchan rode home on her new bicycle.

When she reached the peepal tree, she looked back once.

Poonam was now walking away, pushing the old blue bicycle beside her.

The following month, when Kanchan came to the middle school, she wanted to see the asset register.

Beside Property No. 14, 'Not in Working Order' had been crossed out.

In its place were new words: 'Entry Bicycle—In Use.'

Below them were two names.

Kanchan.

Poonam.

Beside Kanchan's name, the return date had been filled in.

Poonam's row was still open.

Madhavi asked, 'Did you come to see your name again?'

Kanchan said, 'No. I came to see the next name.'

That day, a twenty-seventh attendance mark was placed beside Kanchan's name in the Belahi School register.

In the distance field, the number was still the same—10.2 kilometres.

The number had not grown smaller.

Only the gap between the first day and the twentieth now had an old blue bicycle moving through it.

A Song While Breaking Stones

Beside the Sonbarsa road there was a stone-breaking site.

There was no hill there, but heaps of large stones brought down from the hills lay there all day.

Twelve women from the village broke those stones into small pieces of gravel.

The hammer never struck just once.

One strike, then another, then a third.

If the rhythm broke, the palm soon tired.

That was why Jamuna Devi would start a song.

The song was not the same every day.

Sometimes the first line was about the water pot.

Sometimes it was about the yellow truck arriving late.

Sometimes it was about a cracked hammer handle.

Sometimes about rain stopping the work for half a day.

The other women repeated the line.

And then the hammers moved again.

Three heaps of stone, two pots of water...

Jamuna would begin.

All of them answered, "Two pots of water, work till evening."

The next day, the line would change.

The yellow truck is stuck, half a wheel in mud...

The answer rose, "The wheel came free, and the work went on."

There was no written book of these songs.

Nor was there any single fixed version.

Jamuna would say, "When the day changes, the song's opening changes too."

One day Anupama, a teacher at the village middle school, came there.

She had been given the task of writing down labour songs for a block-level cultural booklet.

She was delighted when she heard Jamuna and the others singing.

"This is very good," she said. "I will write it down neatly."

Jamuna laughed.

"What will you make neat?"

Anupama did not understand.

"The song."

Jamuna asked again, "Which day's?"

Anupama wrote down that day's song.

Its first line was, "The driver in the red gamchha arrived late."

Anupama stopped as she wrote.

"Shall I leave this line out?"

"Why?" Basanti asked.

"Why should the driver's gamchha be in the song?"

Basanti put down her hammer.

"Why shouldn't it?"

Anupama smiled.

"The booklet will contain folk songs. A few beautiful lines will look better there."

Jamuna said quietly, "The red gamchha is the mark of that day."

Anupama wrote it down, but later, while making a fair copy, she struck out the line.

In its place she wrote, "The hammer rang in the evening's cadence."

The line sounded beautiful.

But the red gamchha of that day disappeared.

Another line said, "Fourteen baskets were measured."

Anupama struck that out too.

She felt that counting would turn the song into a register.

A third line said, "On Tuesday market day, half a pot of water."

"Tuesday market" disappeared from that line.

The song became better suited to the booklet.

Short, graceful, uniform.

Anupama showed the copy to Jamuna.

Jamuna could not read.

She listened.

Then she said, "It is a good song, but it is not ours."

Anupama's hand stopped.

"The meaning is still there."

"The meaning stayed," Jamuna said, "but the day went away."

At the time, Anupama did not fully understand that sentence.

Two months later, the stone-breaking work was nearing its end.

The main gravel supply for the road was complete.

On the day the final accounts were prepared, the women were told that they would be paid for eighteen days of work.

Jamuna immediately said, "We worked twenty-two days."

Kailash, who kept the accounts, opened the register.

"It says eighteen days here."

"Where did the other four days go?" Basanti asked.

Kailash turned the pages.

"Stone-breaking was stopped for four days."

"Not the stone-breaking," Jamuna said. "The arrival of new stone was stopped."

Kailash looked up.

"Same thing."

"No," Sukhni said. "There were old heaps."

During those four days, the women had sorted the old heaps.

The larger pieces had been broken again.

The smaller gravel had been separated out.

Three truckloads had gone out for the road work.

But against those dates the register said, "No new supply."

Kailash had taken that to mean, "Work stopped."

Jamuna said, "On the first day, the yellow truck got stuck."

Kailash laughed.

"A stuck truck is not proof of wages."

Basanti said, "That day we dug the wheel out twice."

Sukhni added, "And the gravel from the third heap was loaded onto the truck."

Kailash kept his thumb pressed on the register.

"Show me the paper."

The women looked at one another.

They had no slip for those four days.

Jamuna slowly struck one palm against the other.

Tap.

Then tap again.

"The yellow truck is stuck, half a wheel in mud..."

Basanti answered, "The wheel came free, and the work went on."

Sukhni raised another line: "On Tuesday market day, half a pot of water..."

They all answered, "The pot was filled, and the work went on."

Kailash grew irritated.

"Accounts are not made from songs."

Jamuna stopped the song.

"The account is not made from the song; it is made from the days. The song is telling you which days."

Just then Anupama was passing on her way to school.

Seeing the crowd, she stopped.

The moment Kailash saw her, he said, "You are a teacher. Explain it to them. The register says eighteen days; they say twenty-two."

Anupama looked at Jamuna.
Jamuna said, "You wrote it down, didn't you?"
Anupama's expression changed.
She remembered the red gamchha.
She remembered the fourteen baskets.
She remembered the Tuesday market.
And she remembered that she had cut all of them out while making the fair copy.

"My first notebook is at home," Anupama said.
"Some of the lines are still there."
Kailash said, "A notebook will not change the accounts."
"No," Anupama replied, "but those lines will help us find the dates."
She did not go to school.
She brought the first notebook from home.
There were no dates in the notebook.
But the lines were there.
The red gamchha.
Fourteen baskets.
Tuesday market.
The yellow truck.
The broken handle.
Half a day's sunshine after the rain.
Anupama asked, "What date did the Tuesday market fall on?"
Basanti could not give the date immediately.
But she said, "That was the day my daughter brought salt from the market."

The market was held once a week.
They worked out the date.
The truck driven by the man in the red gamchha had arrived the day before.

The next day, the broken handle had been replaced.
Little by little, the sequence of the four days took shape.
Kailash was still not satisfied.
"You have a sequence. Where is the proof?"
Anupama asked, "Where is the dispatch register?"
Kailash fell silent.
There was another register at the stone-breaking site.
It recorded the outgoing trucks, the identifying mark of the heap, and the quantity.
That register was kept separately from the payment register.
Kailash brought it out.

Three trucks were entered on the date of the Tuesday market.
 Their colours were not recorded.
 But their vehicle numbers were.
 Ramsevak, the driver of the yellow truck, was called.
 The moment he saw the number, he said, "That's my truck."
 "Did it get stuck that day?" Anupama asked.
 Ramsevak smiled.
 "Half the wheel sank in. These women dug it out."
 He pointed towards Jamuna and the others.
 Kailash looked at the next date.
 Two trucks had gone out.
 On the third date, one truck.
 On the fourth, two again.
 No new stone had arrived.
 But old stone had gone out.
 Without being sorted and broken, it could not have gone out.
 Kailash added the four dates to the payment register.
 He looked at Jamuna.
 "Did the song contain the vehicle numbers too?"
 Jamuna said, "Not the numbers. The colour."
 "Then it was only half the proof."
 "A song is not sung to become complete proof," Jamuna said.
 "A song keeps the day from being forgotten."
 Kailash said nothing.
 He added the wages for the four days.
 Anupama opened her notebook.
 The fair copy and the first copy lay side by side.
 In the fair copy, the song was beautiful.
 In the first copy, the song was scattered.
 One line said there had been too little water.
 One said a truck had got stuck.
 One said a hammer handle had broken.
 One held the market day.
 One held fourteen baskets.
 That night, Anupama opened the booklet copy again.
 She struck out the line, "The hammer rang in the evening's cadence."
 The red gamchha returned.
 So did the fourteen baskets.
 So did the Tuesday market.
 Above the song, she did not write the title, "Folk Song."
 She wrote, "Work Lines - The Twenty-Two-Day Version."

The following week, a man came from the block office to collect folk songs.

He asked, "Which is the original version of this song?"

Anupama read the notebook aloud to Jamuna.

Jamuna stopped her midway.

"Here it wasn't 'two pots'; it was 'half a pot.'"

Anupama corrected it.

Then she read on.

Basanti stopped another line.

"That day it wasn't fourteen baskets. The fourteen baskets were the next day."

Anupama corrected it again.

The lines kept changing on the paper.

The song never settled into a fixed form.

But the twenty-two days remained distinct, one from another.

A few months later, the Sonbarsa road was finished.

The stone-breaking site stood empty.

The sound of the hammers stopped.

Jamuna and the others took up other work.

Anupama's notebook remained in a cupboard at the school.

One day a new teacher opened it and asked, "Why are there so many versions of the same song?"

Anupama replied, "It isn't the same song."

She turned the pages.

In one place it said, "The yellow truck got stuck."

In another, "On Tuesday market day, half a pot of water."

In a third, "The handle broke; another hammer till evening."

Anupama did not close the notebook.

Outside the window, vehicles were moving along the new road.

Beneath that road lay the gravel of those twenty-two days.

And inside the cupboard, the sound of those twenty-two days.

The Right to the Forest

West of Simarbanni village lies a belt of sal and sakhua forest.

Right beside the forest stood Dhanmaya Devi's bamboo grove.

Beyond the bamboo lay two kathas of field, and beyond the field the Kachhua nala, which flowed during the rains.

Dhanmaya used to say that the nala was small, but there was no better landmark in the village for understanding the boundary.

One morning in Jeth, three Forest Department employees arrived carrying tins of red paint.

They moved ahead, painting red bands on tree stumps, stones, and bamboo.

Dhanmaya was sorting paddy in the courtyard.

The red band ran straight through the middle of her bamboo grove.

She rose to her feet.

"Where is this line going?"

The forest guard said, "It is the new demarcation."

"Where did the old boundary go?"

"Wherever it is on the map."

Dhanmaya came out of the grove.

The new red line cut across the Kachhua nala and ran straight north.

A part of her bamboo grove and field fell inside it.

The forest guard handed her a paper.

It said that private use within the boundary was to be removed.

Dhanmaya read the words slowly.

Her eyes stopped at the word "within."

Her granddaughter Kusum was at home then.

Kusum was learning survey work at the block headquarters, but she held no government post.

She read the paper.

"Amma, this is based on the new map."

Dhanmaya said, "Has the new map straightened the old nala?"

Kusum remained silent.

Dhanmaya was seventy years old.

Her husband, Ramapati, had died long ago.

Ramapati had not been a forest watchman.

He had been a farmer.

But after the rains he would often join the community work of clearing the forest firebreak.

Dhanmaya had gone with him two or three times.

In those days the boundary was visible on the ground, not on paper.

From one post to the nala.

A turn following the nala.

Then a stone pillar.

After that, the dense stand of sal.

Dhanmaya said, "The line used to turn with the nala."

Kusum asked, "What marker do you remember?"

"Post number twenty-six."

"And after that?"

"The nala."

"And twenty-seven?"

Dhanmaya thought.

"Post twenty-seven climbed uphill after leaving the nala."

Kusum said, "Remembering something is not evidence."

Dhanmaya looked at her.

"I am not calling it evidence. I am saying the nala is where you should look."

The next day Kusum came with a long measuring cord, a notebook, and chalk.

She said to Dhanmaya, "Show me the old boundary as far as you remember it. Let us walk it."

Dhanmaya took her walking stick.

The two of them reached post number twenty-six.

The post gleamed with fresh red paint.

From there, the department's new line ran straight toward post number twenty-seven.

Dhanmaya did not go straight.

She turned to the right.

Beneath the dry leaves ran a shallow depression.

"The nala was like this," she said.

Kusum bent down.

The soil was harder than elsewhere, but round pebbles lay in that narrow channel.

There had been no rain, so there was no water.

Dhanmaya moved on.

Halfway along stood an old karanj tree.

Dhanmaya stopped by its roots.

"The firebreak used to turn here."

Kusum measured the distance with the cord.

She wrote in her notebook: from twenty-six to the karanj, one hundred and eighteen metres.

From the karanj, following the nala to the next bend, eighty-seven metres.

Dhanmaya said, "Now we should find the stone."

They did not find the stone at once.

For half an hour they brushed leaves aside.

At one spot Kusum's chalk struck something hard.

They cleared away the soil.

The top of a square stone appeared.

It was not a boundary post.

It was only an ordinary old stone.

Dhanmaya laughed.

"Memory too can sometimes be in a hurry."

They moved on.

They eventually found post number twenty-seven, but it stood on higher ground along the forest edge.

The old narrow channel leading to it matched the bend Dhanmaya had described.

Kusum did not close her notebook.

She kept writing down the distances.

That evening she examined a photocopy of the new map.

On the map, a perfectly straight line ran between twenty-six and twenty-seven.

There was no sign of the Kachhua nala.

The next day Kusum went to the forest range office.

She said, "I have not come to get the boundary changed. I want to see the record from which the boundary was drawn."

The clerk first showed her the new map.

Kusum asked, "Is there an earlier description of the boundary?"

The clerk searched for the old file.

Many of its pages had gone grey with age.

One page had a torn corner.

On that page, between post numbers 26 and 27, were the words: "along the seasonal watercourse."

Kusum read the line again.

A distance was recorded there as well.

Not the straight-line distance.

The distance measured along the watercourse.

Kusum compared the figure with the numbers in her notebook.

They were not exactly the same, but the difference was very small.

She asked for a copy.

The clerk said, "Submit an application."

Kusum submitted one.

Three days later she received a certified copy.

Meanwhile, a second mark had been painted on the bamboo inside the red line.

People in the village began saying, "Dhanmaya's bamboo grove has turned out to be forest land."

Someone said, "Is the government supposed to run on old people's memories?"

Dhanmaya did not answer.

Nor did she begin cutting the bamboo.

She simply waited for the paper to come.

Kusum took the certified copy to the forest officer.

"It says here, 'along the seasonal watercourse,'" she said.

The officer opened the new map.

"In the digital version, the two old posts have been joined."

"And the description of what lay between them was left out?"

The officer did not answer at once.

He looked again at the old page.

Then he said, "There will be a field inspection."

On the day of the field inspection, Dhanmaya did not walk at the head of the group.

She stood beside the Kachhua nala.

A Forest Department surveyor, the circle amin, and two local witnesses arrived.

Measurement began from post number twenty-six.

The straight line shown on the new map was marked separately.

The seasonal channel mentioned in the old description was also traced.

They found the round pebbles in the dry nala, the narrow line of erosion, and remnants of the old firebreak.

Kusum did not offer her notebook.

She said, "You measure first."

The official measurement was completed.

The distance along the channel matched the distance in the old record.

The straight line cut off a triangle in between.

That triangle contained part of Dhanmaya's bamboo grove and field.

The amin also opened the old khasra map.

It showed the western edge of the field touching the watercourse.

The forest officer looked at the newly painted red band.

"This line is to be suspended for now," he said.

Dhanmaya said nothing.

Three separate points were entered in the inspection record.

First: the new digital line joins the two posts directly.

Second: the old boundary description states that the boundary follows the seasonal watercourse.

Third: the watercourse was identified on the ground, and its measured distance matches the old description.

Kusum read the record aloud to Dhanmaya.

Dhanmaya asked, "Was what I said written down?"

"As local oral information."

"That is enough."

For a week, the red band remained as it was.

Then the Forest Department team came again.

The old straight marking was painted over with a muddy colour.

A new boundary was drawn, turning with the nala.

Most of Dhanmaya's bamboo grove remained outside the boundary.

But seven bamboo plants stood on the far side of the nala.

The forest guard said, "These seven are inside the forest boundary."

Harikant, Dhanmaya's son, wanted to say that the bamboo belonged to the old homestead.

Dhanmaya stopped him.

"What lies inside, let it remain inside."

The family made no claim to any of the seven bamboo plants.

That made the final line of the inspection record brief.

"The family accepts the revised demarcation."

When the rains came, water flowed again through the Kachhua nala.

A revised copy of the new map arrived at the panchayat building.

Kusum took it to Dhanmaya.

Dhanmaya placed a finger on the thin blue line on the map.

"Is this the Kachhua nala?"

"Yes. This is the nala."

"And the red boundary?"

"Now it turns with the nala."

Dhanmaya did not look at the map for long.

She went outside and looked toward the actual nala.

The water was carrying bamboo leaves as it slowly rounded the bend.

Kusum opened the first page of her old notebook.

Dhanmaya's first sentence was written there: "The nala is where you should look."

Kusum added nothing beneath that line.

Now the nala itself was written into the map.

Compensation for the Bridge

For many years there had been talk in Basahi village of building a bridge over the Kamla River.

In the monsoon, once the boats stopped running, the market, the hospital, the weekly bazaar—everything lay stranded on the far side.

When approval finally came for a permanent bridge, sweets were distributed at the village crossroads.

Jhumri Devi took a peda too.

She said, “It will be good when the bridge is built.”

A few days later, the survey team arrived.

The western approach to the bridge ran straight through the outer row of Basahi.

Eleven houses fell along that line.

Jhumri’s was the seventh.

It was not a very large house.

Two brick rooms, a tiled veranda, a small kitchen, and the shade of a neem tree in front.

The government surveyor measured the walls.

An assistant recorded the structure of the house in a thick register.

“Two brick rooms?” Jhumri asked.

“Yes, it is written down.”

“The veranda?”

“That too.”

“The kitchen?”

“That too is written down.”

Jhumri asked again, “What will come of all this writing?”

The assistant said, “The valuation will be done next.”

Jhumri looked toward the page of the register.

Reading was difficult for her.

But she could see the measurements of her house in numbers.

Two weeks later, a notice arrived.

It stated the date by which the house had to be vacated.

It also carried one line: anyone wishing to reuse materials should obtain permission and remove them before handover.

Jhumri's son Naresh said, "We'll save the timber."

Jhumri said, "Save whatever can be saved."

Leaving the house hurt, but the timber, roof tiles, and latch could all be used in the new house.

The next morning, Naresh went to the bridge-work camp to seek permission.

The assistant checked the house number and pulled out a slip.

He counted the materials.

Two door shutters.

Three window shutters.

Four wooden beams.

Seventy-six roof tiles.

One old latch made by a blacksmith.

The assistant wrote everything down and signed it.

At the bottom was written: "Permission for removal by owner for reuse."

Naresh was given one copy of the slip.

For three days, the work of dismantling the timber continued at the house.

Shambhu the carpenter removed the doors.

The window shutters were taken down.

The roof tiles were lifted off one by one.

The beams were laid in the courtyard.

Jhumri removed the old latch with her own hands.

Its iron links had been worn smooth with use.

She wrapped it in cloth and set it aside.

The walls still stood, but there were no tiles on the roof.

The doorframes stood open and bare.

Half the veranda had been stripped.

Jhumri thought that now only the government demolition remained.

But on the fifth day, another team arrived.

This team had come to carry out the valuation.

There was an engineer, two employees, and the local revenue clerk.

The engineer looked at the house.

"A lot of this has already been dismantled."

Naresh said, "We removed the materials as instructed in the notice."

The engineer wrote something on his paper.

He tapped the wall to inspect it.

He went over to the veranda.

He counted the empty frames.

He saw no roof tiles.

He saw no beams.

He saw no latch.

By evening, the valuation slip was ready.

Naresh asked for a copy.

The house had been classified there as “partially dismantled.”

The value assigned to the veranda roof was zero.

The value assigned to the wood from the doors and windows was zero.

Jhumri asked, “Why zero?”

An employee said, “The materials were not there on the day of inspection.”

Naresh took out the permission slip.

“These materials were removed because your people told us to remove them.”

The employee looked at the slip.

“This slip is from a different branch.”

“Did the house belong to a different branch too?” Jhumri asked.

No one answered at once.

Two days later, a slip arrived stating the preliminary compensation amount.

The other ten families in the village began checking their respective amounts.

One had more land, another a fully brick-built house, another a larger veranda.

Jhumri’s amount was lower than expected.

Her neighbour Ramcharit said, “Take it. Don’t hold up the bridge work.”

Jhumri said, “Am I stopping the bridge?”

“No, but your signature on the paper is still pending.”

Jhumri folded the permission slip and opened it again.

“They ordered us to dismantle the house. Now they say the house was already half dismantled.”

Ramcharit fell silent.

Jhumri’s objection was not about every last rupee of the amount.

One line kept troubling her: “Partially dismantled beforehand by owner.”

She said, “Not beforehand. After the order.”

Naresh went to the block office.

There he was told to submit a written objection.

Naresh wrote down the sequence: first inspection, notice to remove materials, permission slip, then valuation.

All four dates were written separately.

Before giving her thumbprint, Jhumri had the page read aloud to her.

She stopped them midway.

“Write that I am not opposing the bridge.”

Naresh added it.

“And write that the condition of the house had already been seen on the day of the first survey.”

That too was added.

The objection was submitted.

Meanwhile, the bridge piers began rising from the river.

People from the village went every day to watch the work.

Jhumri too went twice.

Looking at the new pier standing in midstream, she said, “Once this is done, we won’t have to depend on boats every monsoon.”

Naresh looked at his mother’s face.

“Then shall we let the paperwork go?”

Jhumri said, “The bridge and the paperwork are two different things.”

Ten days later, a date was fixed for a joint inspection.

This time, the valuation engineer, an employee from the land branch, and the assistant who had issued the material-removal permission came together.

Jhumri stood beside the open doorway of the house.

The engineer called for the old measurement register.

The page from the first inspection was opened.

It recorded two brick rooms, a tiled veranda, and a kitchen.

The date was earlier than the notice permitting removal of materials.

Then the permission slip was examined.

Two door shutters.

Three window shutters.

Four beams.

Seventy-six roof tiles.

One latch.

The engineer asked, “How could all these have appeared on the permission slip if they had not been in the house?”

The assistant said quietly, “They were counted after the first survey.”

“So the materials were there?”

“Yes, the materials were there.”

Jhumri said nothing.

The revenue clerk took out another page.

It carried the line: “Partially dismantled beforehand by owner.”

During the joint inspection, that line was not struck out.

Beside it, a new note was added: “Reusable materials removed in compliance with departmental notice.”

Jhumri asked, “Will both lines remain?”

The engineer said, "The first line will remain, but the correction will be made explicit."

"Then what about the amount?"

"It will be recalculated on the basis of the condition recorded during the first inspection."

Naresh let out a long breath.

Jhumri asked again, "And the other houses?"

The owners of the other village houses were listening too.

The engineer looked toward the assistant.

"From now on, permission to remove materials will be given only after the valuation is complete."

The employee from the land branch added, "A copy of the valuation slip will be given to the owner beforehand."

No one applauded.

People simply began looking at their own slips.

Three days later, Jhumri's revised amount arrived.

It was higher than the first amount.

Naresh said, "Shall we sign now?"

Jhumri had the entire slip read aloud.

On that page, the condition of the house was recorded as "according to the first technical inspection."

She gave her thumbprint.

On the day the house was to be demolished, Jhumri woke very early.

Wind was coming through the empty frames into the courtyard.

Neem leaves had blown all the way inside.

She touched the wall and stepped out.

By noon, the house had become a heap of earth and bricks.

Naresh stood at a distance.

Jhumri did not go searching through the heap for anything.

Whatever could be reused had already been taken out.

Work on a small new house elsewhere in the village began with the first instalment of compensation.

Two of the old beams proved usable.

Many roof tiles had broken, but some went onto the kitchen roof.

One shutter from the old door was too small for the new house.

Shambhu the carpenter cut it down to fit.

Jhumri had the old latch fixed onto it.

A few months later, the bridge opened.

The time needed to reach the market from Basahi was cut in half.

People went onto the bridge just to look at the river.

On inauguration day, Naresh had kept a place for his mother too.

Jhumri went.

She did not walk all the way to the middle of the bridge.

She stood for a few moments at the beginning of the approach.

From there, it was hard to identify the place where the old house had stood.

The new road now ran over it.

Ramcharit said, "Look, the bridge has been built."

Jhumri said, "Yes, it has."

That night, as she closed the door of the new house, Jhumri fastened the latch.

The iron links sounded with their old familiar clink.

Two papers lay together in the trunk.

One was the permission slip for removing materials.

The other was the revised compensation slip.

Both bore the same house number.

Outside, the first night traffic was crossing the new bridge.

Jhumri tugged the latch once to test it.

It held firm.

The Labourer's Photograph

East of Shivpur there was an old drain that carried away the monsoon water.

Year after year, silt had built up, and earth from the banks kept collapsing into it.

Whenever the rains were heavy, water stood knee-deep on the road.

This year the block sanctioned work to deepen the drain and build masonry outlets at two points.

The work was divided into three sections.

The first was near the culvert, the second near the middle hamlet, and the third near the paddy fields.

Budhan Mandal was in the labour team assigned to the third section.

He dug earth, spread stone chips, and compacted the layers with a hand rammer.

There was a separate register at the site for issuing tools.

Every tool had a number painted on it in white.

Budhan was usually given hand rammer 12.

Its bamboo handle had once come loose.

Budhan had bound it with wire and made it firm again.

So he could recognize the rammer even from a distance.

On the morning of the seventeenth day of Sawan, one worker from the team did not turn up.

Five workers were already on the middle section that day.

The mate, Harilal, told Budhan, "Today leave the third section and work in the middle section until noon."

Budhan had the change of section entered in the tool register.

The line in the register read: Rammer 12, Budhan Mandal, Section 2.

That day the engineer's assistant came to inspect the work.

He had a camera in his hand.

He went first towards the culvert.

Then he stopped at the middle section.

The third layer of stone chips was being laid there.

On a small blackboard, the section, date, and name of the layer had been written in chalk.

The assistant said, "Do not stop the work. I need the photographs while the work is in progress."

Budhan and the other labourers went on with their work.

Two or three photographs were taken.

Budhan paid little attention to them.

After noon he returned to the third section.

The day ended.

A few weeks later, the first payment was made.

The labourers stood in a line near the panchayat building, checking the amounts they had received.

Budhan's account was short by one day.

At first he doubted his own memory.

When he returned home, he opened his small notebook.

He did not write a complete account every day.

But he did note the number of whichever tool he had taken.

Against the seventeenth of Sawan he had written: 12, middle.

The next morning he went to Harilal.

Harilal opened the daily attendance register.

On the page for the third section, the space beside Budhan's name was blank.

"You were in the middle section," Budhan said.

Harilal opened the page for the middle section.

The names of five regular labourers were there.

At the bottom margin, in small letters, was written: one additional.

There was no name.

Harilal scratched his head.

"Was that you?"

"You yourself had sent me."

Harilal remembered.

"Yes, but I forgot to write your name."

When the payment register was prepared, the line marked "one additional" had not been counted.

Harilal said he would enter a correction.

But the accounts room replied that no payment could be added for an attendance entry without a name.

"We need proof of the name," the accounts assistant said.

Budhan laughed.

"I am standing right here."

The accounts assistant smiled too.

"Your standing here proves that you are Budhan. We need separate proof that you worked in the middle section that day."

Budhan fell silent.

Harilal said, "Let us look at the tool register."

The entry for the seventeenth of Sawan was clear in the tool register.

Rammer 12 — Budhan Mandal — Section 2.

The accounts assistant read the line.

"This may serve as supporting evidence, but it is not an attendance record for the work."

Budhan asked, "Did the rammer go there for a walk?"

Two or three people in the room burst out laughing.

The accounts assistant did not laugh.

"I understand what you mean. But the rules of paper have to be satisfied with paper."

That week the block's progress report arrived at the panchayat.

The mukhiya had left a copy on a table in the building.

The colour pages contained photographs of the drain before and after the work.

Budhan's son Nandu saw the pages lying on the table and called his father over.

"Babu, that is you."

Budhan bent over the page.

In a photograph of the middle section, he was lifting the hand rammer.

His face could be seen clearly.

Beside him stood the blackboard: Section 2, seventeenth of Sawan, third layer.

Underneath was written: "Compacting gravel by local labour."

There was no name.

Budhan looked at the page for a few moments.

Harilal came over as well.

"This is the photograph from that day," Budhan said.

Harilal picked up the page.

"The date is clear too."

The two of them took the report to the accounts room.

The accounts assistant looked at the photograph.

Then he looked again at the tool register.

"On what basis am I to write that the person in this photograph is Budhan Mandal?"

Harilal said, "I recognize him."

The accounts assistant said, "Your statement will be recorded too. But is there another link?"

Budhan looked at the photograph.

The white number on the rammer was half in shadow.

He carried the page over to the window.

The number 12 could be seen.

The tool register showed that on that day rammer 12 had been issued in Budhan's name for Section 2.

Harilal's daily register recorded "one additional" in that section.

The photograph in the progress report was from the same day, the same section, and the same layer.

Three separate papers had come together.

The accounts assistant wrote a short note on each of the three copies.

"Combined evidence for verification of attendance where the name was omitted."

A written confirmation was taken from Harilal.

Budhan was also asked how much of that day he had worked in the middle section.

He said, "From morning until noon."

The page for the third section already carried an attendance mark for the afternoon.

In this way, the account for the full day was established.

A correction slip was added to the next payment.

Budhan received the wages still due for one day.

The amount was not large.

But after that, the page in the progress report became a subject of discussion at the panchayat.

The mukhiya said, "Photographs are kept as proof of the work. But if the worker in a photograph is not linked by name anywhere, the proof remains only half complete."

When the engineer's assistant came for the next inspection, Harilal told him what had happened.

At first the assistant thought the labourers wanted their names printed beneath the photographs.

Budhan said, "Having my name printed will not get me anything."

"Then what do you want?"

"If a photograph shows the day recorded in a register, there should be a path from the photograph to that register."

The assistant thought for a while.

The progress report was a public document.

It would not be proper to print every labourer's full name and private details in it.

What the accounts room needed was a way to find whose attendance was connected with the work shown in a photograph on a given day.

From the following month, a small rule was introduced.

Under each photograph, instead of a person's name, the photograph number, section, date, and page of the attendance register would be written.

A list kept at the site would link each photograph number to the labour team's register reference.

The tool register too would be kept section-wise for that day.

At first everyone thought it was more paperwork.

For two days Harilal forgot to write the page numbers.

The accounts assistant sent the register back.

"Without the number, the same problem will happen again."

Harilal began keeping a small pencil in his pocket.

The matter of Budhan's payment gradually came to an end.

The drain was deepened.

During the second spell of rain, water no longer stood on the road as it had before.

The earth from the third section was piled along the side and levelled.

One day a new progress report arrived at the panchayat building.

Nandu was turning its pages again.

This time he did not call his father.

Budhan himself stopped by the table.

In one photograph, four labourers were setting stones along the side of the drain.

Underneath was written: "Photograph 27; Section 1; Attendance Register, page 31."

There was no name.

Budhan turned the page.

In the list at the back, the team reference appeared beside Photograph 27.

He did not start searching the list for his own name.

He only saw that there was now a path to the register.

Nandu asked, "Why have they not printed the names this time?"

Budhan said, "Printing the name is not necessary."

He closed the report.

"What matters is that there is a path to the name."

The Red Card

In the western hamlet of Barail, Phulmati Devi had what could be called a home, but on paper it had no place of its own.

She lived with her husband, Harikishun, and their three children in the rear part of the old courtyard belonging to Harikishun's uncle, Bhuvaneshwar.

A thin bamboo partition stood between the two families.

Their hearths were separate.

Their rice stores were separate.

Their earnings were separate.

But the main gate was the same.

And so was the official house number—Barail West, 47.

Bhuvaneshwar's family already had a red food-assistance card.

Phulmati's family had no card at all.

For seven or eight months of the year, Harikishun stayed away from the village, carrying bricks for a living.

Between the rains and winter, he remained in the village and worked as an agricultural labourer.

Phulmati transplanted paddy, weeded fields, and harvested crops for others.

Two years earlier, her youngest son, Deepak, had fallen ill.

The debt from grain bought on credit at that time had taken three months to clear.

Then the anganwadi worker had asked Phulmati, "Why don't you apply for a separate red card for your family?"

Phulmati had said, "Uncle has a card. None of our names are on it."

The worker asked, "Then how do you get your grain?"

"From the market."

"And when there isn't enough?"

Phulmati did not laugh.

"Then we buy on credit."

The following Monday she went to the panchayat office.

She took an application form.

She had the names entered—Phulmati Devi, Harikishun Paswan, Reena, Gudiya, Deepak.

The address was written as—House No. 47.

The employee checked the list.

“There is already a red card against 47.”

Phulmati said, “That belongs to my uncle’s family.”

“Same house number?”

“Yes, the number is the same.”

“Then verification will be required.”

The application was submitted.

Phulmati received an acknowledgement slip.

She wrote the date from the slip on the wall in charcoal.

Fifteen days later, a verification team came.

That day Phulmati had gone to transplant paddy.

Bhuvaneshwar’s wife was in the courtyard.

The team entered through the main gate.

They saw one courtyard.

They saw one hand pump.

They saw one neem tree.

The bamboo partition ran all the way to the rear, but the little doorway in it happened to be open that day.

Bhuvaneshwar’s wife said, “Harikishun’s family lives separately at the back.”

The employee asked, “Separate house number?”

“No, the number is not separate.”

“Separate gate?”

“No, there is only one gate.”

The register was marked: “Status as a separate family unclear.”

Phulmati understood what had happened when she returned that evening.

The next day she reached the panchayat office.

The employee said, “There will be another site inspection.”

“When?”

“You will be informed.”

The notice came three weeks later.

This time Phulmati stayed at home.

She showed them her own hearth.

She showed them her separate earthen pots.

She showed them her separate sacks of rice.

She showed them the trunk where she kept the children’s clothes.

The verification staff saw everything.

Then one of them asked, "Do you have papers showing a division of the land?"

Phulmati said, "The land is in Uncle's name. The family has given us this part to live in."

"Any rent receipt?"

"There is no rent receipt."

"A separate tax receipt?"

"No separate tax receipt either."

The employee wrote again: "Single premises; no proof of separate ownership available."

Phulmati asked, "Do you have to own the house to get a card?"

The employee paused.

"No, but a separate household has to be established."

"You saw the separate hearth."

"I did."

"And our earnings are separate?"

"That will have to be shown on paper."

From that day began Phulmati's month-by-month rounds of the office.

The first month, she took a copy of Harikishun's labour register.

Harikishun's name appeared there as a worker in his own right.

The employee said, "This proves employment, not a separate family."

The second month, she took certificates from the anganwadi register showing Deepak's and Gudiya's names.

Phulmati was listed as their mother.

"This proves the children," came the reply, "not a separate household."

The third month, she brought a school slip.

Harikishun's name appeared as Reena's guardian.

"We accept that you are a family," the employee said, "but another card is already active against House No. 47."

For the first time, Phulmati raised her voice. "If two families enter through one gate, do they become one family in the government's count?"

The employee said nothing.

The people standing behind her in the queue began to edge forward.

"Come next Tuesday," the employee said.

Phulmati went the following Tuesday.

Harikishun had left again for work outside the village.

For now, the household depended mainly on Phulmati's earnings.

A new assistant was seated in the office—Shashikant.

He looked through everything from the first acknowledgement slip to the fourth.

"Why was the application submitted again and again?"

Phulmati said, "Sometimes it was verification, sometimes a separate-family certificate, sometimes house papers."

Shashikant read the earlier remarks.

"Whose name is on the card against 47?"

"Bhuvaneshwar Paswan."

"Who are the members on that card?"

Phulmati listed five names—Bhuvaneshwar, his wife, two sons, one daughter.

"Is anyone from your family on that card?"

"Not one person from my family is on it."

Shashikant said, "Then the first thing to check is how many people's grain is being drawn on the existing card for No. 47."

He called for the distribution register.

Five members were recorded against Bhuvaneshwar's card.

Month after month, the quantity issued was for five people.

Not one of the five members of Phulmati's family appeared there.

Shashikant asked, "If your family is being treated as part of this card's household, where is the ration for these five additional people?"

No one in the room had an answer.

Phulmati said nothing either.

For the first time, the question had arisen from within the paperwork on her side.

Shashikant added a small note to the application file.

"Check the provision for multiple households within one premises."

He sent the note to the senior officer.

Three days later the reply came: once a separate household was verified, a family sub-number could be assigned under the same house number.

Shashikant called Phulmati.

"There will be another verification now."

Phulmati's face fell.

"Again?"

"This time the questions will be different."

A third verification date was fixed.

This time the employee did not count the main gate.

He asked—was food cooked separately?

Were rice and other grain stored separately?

Were earnings and expenses separate?

Who was responsible for bringing up the children?

Bhuvaneshwar was called as well.

He said clearly, "Harikishun's family is not part of my card. They have kept a separate hearth for five years."

Phulmati said, "Not five. Six years."

Bhuvaneshwar laughed.

"All right, six."

For the first time the verification register recorded: "Single premises, separate household."

Beneath it was the proposed designation—47-A.

Phulmati asked, "What is this 'A'?"

The employee said, "The house number will not change. Your family will have a separate designation."

"And Uncle's?"

"47-original."

Phulmati returned home and looked at the date of the first acknowledgement slip on the wall.

Rain splashes had half-erased the figures.

Four months had passed.

The following week she went to the office.

The file had gone upstairs for approval.

She went again the next week.

Her name had been written as "Phoolmati."

She said, "My name is Phulmati."

The employee asked, "What difference does that make?"

Phulmati showed her anganwadi slip.

"For four months I have learnt that one letter can send you around every doorway later. Correct it now."

The name was corrected.

In the third week she was called for a photograph.

Phulmati went with all three children.

Harikishun was away.

The employee said, "Your husband isn't here?"

Phulmati's heart lurched again.

"He is away for work. His name is on the application."

Shashikant checked the earlier verification.

"Phulmati Devi is recorded as head of household. Take the photograph of the members present. The absent member's earlier identity verification is attached."

This time the application was not held up.

On the first Wednesday of the fifth month, Phulmati received word from the panchayat office.

The card had arrived.

It was red.

Phulmati had never seen that colour before.

She read the name.

Phulmati Devi.

Then she read the household designation—47-A.

Then she read the members.

Harikishun.

Reena.

Gudiya.

Deepak.

Every name was there.

Shashikant said, "Sign once here."

Before signing, Phulmati asked, "None of our names has been added to Bhuvaneshwar's card, has it?"

Shashikant opened both records and showed her.

The records confirmed that none of Phulmati's family had been added to Bhuvaneshwar's card.

"And the quantity?"

"Your five members' entitlement will be added separately against your card."

Only then did Phulmati sign.

On the first distribution day, she did not go at dawn.

The old fear of having to run from door to door was gone.

She reached the distribution centre before noon.

Bhuvaneshwar's wife was there with her card.

The two women stood in the same queue.

Bhuvaneshwar's family's ration was weighed first.

Then Phulmati's card was taken.

The dealer looked at the household designation.

"47-A?"

Phulmati said, "Yes."

He opened the register.

There was a new line.

Phulmati Devi—five members.

The grain was weighed.

Phulmati tied the sack.

Bhuvaneshwar's wife said, "Two cards for one house—look at that."

Phulmati smiled.

"For one house number."

She lifted the sack onto her head.

"There were always two homes."

That evening the children gathered around the red card.

Deepak asked, "Why is it red?"

Phulmati said, "The colour belongs to the government."
Reena asked, "What does 47-A mean?"
Phulmati looked towards the main gate of the courtyard.
Bhuvaneshwar's family entered through that gate, and so did hers.
The little doorway in the bamboo partition was closed now.
Smoke rose separately from the two hearths.
Phulmati put the card away in the trunk.
The half-erased date of the first slip was still visible on the wall.
She did not rub it out.
Beneath that date, she wrote only this in charcoal—47-A.

The Sand Ghat

At this bend of the Kamla River lay a village called Sonbarsa, but the villagers simply called the pale strip across the river the Sand Ghat.

In winter the river grew gentle. A long tongue of sand emerged in the middle, while thin streams of water ran along both sides.

Sonbarsa's three old wells lived by the rhythm of this river. As the rains receded, the water level fell, then stayed steady from Kartik through Paush.

The oldest well stood behind the school. Its water was used for the midday meal, people from five nearby houses drew from it, and every morning Haripriya, who sold tea, filled two pitchers there.

Haripriya did not measure the depth of the water, but her hands knew the length of the rope.

'If it reaches this knot, the bucket will come up full,' she would tell her daughter Manju.

There were seven knots in the rope.

The first five were old, the sixth had been tied by Haripriya's husband, and Manju had added the seventh the previous monsoon.

In the first week of Phagun, three heavy trucks arrived at the Sand Ghat.

Two days later, a yellow machine arrived.

A notice was posted on the panchayat building stating that sand would be lifted from a designated strip of the river. The permit was for three months.

The villagers read the notice. Some spoke of a bridge, some of a road, some of work.

For Haripriya, the first change was dust.

Whenever the trucks left the ghat and took the main road, pale dust settled over the benches at her tea stall.

She swept them twice a day.

'It is business,' people said. 'A little dust has to be endured.'

Haripriya kept enduring it.

A week later, the rope at the well dropped as far as the sixth knot.

She filled the bucket and drew it up.

The water was clear.

Two days later, the rope went down to the seventh knot.

Manju laughed. 'We need an eighth knot.'

Haripriya did not laugh.

That evening she went toward the river.

Where a thin stream had once hugged the village side of the Sand Ghat, there was now a broad track for the trucks to descend. Sand had been cut away to lower the track.

Four deep pits gleamed in the middle of the riverbed.

The excavated sand lay heaped to one side.

Haripriya did not know how to read a river, but one thing was immediately plain to her.

The water no longer curved around the old bend.

A thin stream had been drawn from the lower part of the truck track straight toward the pits.

She returned home.

The next morning Vimla Devi, the school cook, said, 'The bucket is touching the bottom of the well.'

That day, water for the children's meal was brought from another hamlet.

A panchayat meeting was held.

Manoj Sah, the sand contractor, said, 'The water in the river has fallen. It would not be right to say our work is the cause.'

The mukhiya also said, 'There was less rain this winter.'

Haripriya listened in silence.

At the end of the meeting she asked, 'How far are you permitted to dig the track for the trucks to descend?'

Manoj Sah showed her the papers.

The paper marked the four corners of the sand-lifting area. There was no separate mention of a track for the trucks.

'How will the trucks get there without a track?' he said.

Haripriya said nothing more.

That night Manju began tying an eighth knot in the rope.

Haripriya stopped her.

'Do not add another knot.'

'Then how will we draw water?'

'First we will see where the water has gone.'

The next day Haripriya called Ramji, the boatman.

Ramji had been rowing boats on the river for forty years.

He looked at the river and then said, 'The mouth of the channel has shifted.'

'Because of the sand lifting?'

Ramji did not say yes at once.

He went to the truck track and planted his staff in the sand. Then he walked toward the bend of the old channel.

'It is not only the pits,' he said. 'This track has been cut lower. Water takes the lower path.'

Haripriya asked, 'How can that be shown on paper?'

Ramji smiled.

'Write the water into a register.'

For the next seven days, a small exercise began.

Three schoolchildren went to the river at six each morning.

Ramji showed them three places.

The first was the old channel on the village side.

The second was the cut made for the trucks to descend.

The third was the mouth of the sand-extraction pit.

The water depth was measured with bamboo rods of the same length.

Manju wrote down the figures.

Haripriya counted the knots on the school well's rope.

Before cooking the meal, Vimla Devi recorded the well's water level.

The pages filled with seven days of entries.

In the old channel, the water fell day by day.

In the cut track, it rose day by day.

At the well, the rope had to go past the eighth knot.

On the eighth night, there was a light rain.

Haripriya thought the water in the well would rise now.

But by morning there was very little difference.

Ramji said, 'The soil does not hold water by itself. Where the river's current exerts pressure matters too.'

Haripriya understood it in her own way: a river does not flow only over the surface; its water also breathes through the earth along its banks.

On the ninth day, the water in another village well turned grey.

Fine sand from the bottom began coming up in the bucket.

This time the panchayat met again.

Haripriya placed the seven days of records on the table.

Manoj Sah did not laugh.

He looked through the pages.

'This is not an official survey,' he said.

'No,' Haripriya replied. 'That is why you should have an official survey done.'

After that one sentence, the meeting fell silent for a while.

The mukhiya sent word to the block office.

Two days later, Junior Engineer Navalkishore arrived.

He examined the permit, the map of the mining area, and the ghat.

First, the distances between the four marked corners were measured.

The main sand-extraction pits were within the permitted area.

Manoj Sah's face relaxed a little.

Then Haripriya showed him the truck track.

Navalkishore measured its bed.

The cut track crossed the boundary of the designated sand strip and ran as far as the bend of the old channel.

'This is not part of the mining area,' he said.

Manoj Sah replied at once, 'It is only an access track.'

Navalkishore said, 'But the riverbed was cut while making it. Its effect is like mining.'

Ramji showed him the bamboo-rod measurements from the three places.

The engineer measured again with his own instrument.

The figures were not identical, but they pointed in the same direction.

The old channel was shallower.

The cut made for the trucks was deeper.

Small cuts linked the pits to one another.

Navalkishore drew a line on the map with a pencil.

'These are no longer three separate pits,' he said. 'They are becoming a new course for the water.'

Manoj Sah fell silent.

Sand extraction was not halted that day.

Haripriya had not demanded that either.

It was decided that the lowered truck track would be filled back in, an unbroken strip of sand would be left at the bend of the old channel, and the cuts connecting the pits would be closed.

No trucks ran for three days.

The workers filled the cut track with sand again.

Manju watched from a distance.

She asked, 'They are filling it again with the same sand they lifted?'

Haripriya said, 'Sometimes filling in the wrong path is work too.'

On the fourth day, water began flowing close to the old bend again.

There was no instant miracle.

At the school well, the rope still went down to the eighth knot.

On the sixth day, the bucket touched water between the seventh and eighth knots.

On the tenth day, it touched at the seventh knot.

Vimla Devi wrote in the register: 'Water clear again.'

Haripriya read that page and did not put it away separately.

She tied it together with the records from the first seven days.

Manoj Sah resumed sand extraction.

This time the truck track ran over the higher sandbar, where the riverbed had not been cut.

Stakes were driven into the ground at the four corners.

Manju saw that one stake bore the words in red: 'Not beyond this point.'

She told Haripriya, 'Now the boundary can be seen.'

Haripriya replied, 'The boundary was there before. It just could not be seen.'

A month passed.

Trucks still came and went at the Sand Ghat.

Dust still rose.

Haripriya still swept the benches twice a day.

But the rope at the school well kept stopping around the seventh knot.

On the day the permit expired, a final survey was conducted at the panchayat.

Navalkishore looked again at the old records.

He said, 'Keep all of these.'

Haripriya asked, 'Will they become official papers?'

'They are not official papers,' he said, 'but at the next survey they will show where the question first arose.'

Haripriya liked that answer.

She went home and looked at the rope.

Manju had not cut off the eighth knot.

'Shall I remove it?' Manju asked.

Haripriya shook her head.

'Let it stay.'

'Why keep the eighth knot then?'

Rolling up the rope, Haripriya said, 'The river may change again. One knot should remain for memory.'

By evening, the Sand Ghat lay white.

There were no trucks.

The old channel flowed beside the village with a faint sound.

Haripriya filled the bucket at the well.

The rope went taut at the seventh knot.

She drew it up.

The water in the bucket was clear.

She looked at the water, then at the eighth knot in the rope.

For her, the two were no longer separate things.

The Temporary Settlement

The official name of the hamlet that had settled east of the Dharharwa embankment had remained the same for thirty years—"Temporary Relief Settlement."

The villagers simply called it Relief Tola.

The relief in that name had ended long ago; the word temporary had survived.

Thirty years earlier, a flood of the Kamla had washed away the old settlement.

At the time, eighteen families had been given bamboo posts and tarpaulins on barren government land away from the embankment.

The first camp slip had said: "Temporary settlement until the river channel stabilizes."

Below it was another line: "The situation will be reviewed after three years."

Three years passed.

There was no review.

The people stayed.

Thatch replaced the tarpaulins.

Tiles replaced the thatch.

Some houses acquired tin roofs.

Eighteen families became forty-six households.

The first children born in the settlement were now sending their own children to school.

Electric poles went up.

Two rooms were built for the anganwadi.

Yet on the panchayat map, the place was still marked in small red letters: "Temporary Relief Settlement."

The weight of those words was felt most heavily when it came to water.

Water from the main village pipeline did not reach Relief Tola.

Twenty years earlier, the panchayat had laid a black flexible pipe.

It ran above the ground, winding along field ridges, through scrub, and past two courtyards.

At its end stood a public tap.

In summer the pipe softened.
In winter it hardened and cracked.
If a vehicle ran over it, it was crushed.
If a goat got its teeth into it, water sprayed from a small puncture.
Again and again, the people of Relief Tola bandaged the pipe's wounds with thin slivers of bamboo, cloth, and wire.
The panchayat too replaced the pipe several times.
This time, at the end of Chait, it split in three places at once.
For five days people carried filled water pots from the main village tap.
On the sixth day, Malati Devi went to the panchayat office.
She was the daughter of one of the eighteen families that had come to this place thirty years earlier.
She had been nine then.
Now her granddaughter was nine.
"Not another pipe laid on top of the ground this time," she said.
"Connect us with a permanent underground water line."
Panchayat assistant Vijay Jha opened the water-scheme file.
He looked at the survey sheet, then at the map.
"A proposal can be made," he said, "but there is one obstacle."
"What obstacle?"
Vijay placed a finger on the red lettering on the map.
"Temporary Relief Settlement."
Malati Devi was silent for a moment.
"How many years has the black pipe been temporary?" she asked.
Vijay did not answer.
"And the settlement?"
Vijay looked at the map again.
"I do not look at time. I look at the record."
That evening Malati Devi opened her old tin trunk.
Not much from the time of the flood had survived inside it.
There was a torn photograph.
There were two coins tied in a red cloth.
And there was a thin yellow slip with its right-hand corner torn away.
Her father's name was written on the slip—Bholanath Sah.
Below it: Family No. 12.
The line saying "review after three years" was still legible on that slip.
The next day she took the slip to the panchayat office.
Vijay turned it over and examined it several times.
"This is a settlement slip," he said. "It is not a deed of ownership."
Malati Devi said, "I am not asking for ownership."
"Then what are you asking for?"

“When was the review that was supposed to take place after three years actually done?”

Vijay sent for the old files.

Nothing was found on the first day.

On the second day, an inspection sheet from 1999 turned up.

At the top it said: “Relief Tola—temporary.”

Review—blank.

A sheet from 2004 was found.

Status—temporary.

The review field was blank again.

A sheet from 2010 was found.

Status—temporary.

Nothing had been entered under review.

A sheet from 2018 was found.

Status—temporary.

The review line was still blank.

Vijay laid the sheets out in order on the table.

Then he opened the water-expenditure register.

2002—“Temporary water pipe in Relief Tola replaced.”

2006—“Temporary water pipe repaired.”

2011—“New flexible pipe.”

2015—“Water pipe replaced.”

2020—“Relief Tola water pipe repaired.”

2024—“Temporary water pipe replaced.”

Malati Devi read every line.

“The settlement remained temporary,” she said, “and so did the pipe. But the spending remained permanent.”

Vijay wanted to laugh, but he did not.

Malati Devi could have demanded at once that the settlement now be recognized as permanent.

She did not.

“Write down my request,” she said. “First conduct the review that was promised on the original slip.”

Vijay wrote the application.

Malati Devi could read.

She stopped him at the first sentence.

Vijay had written: “Permanently settled here for thirty years...”

Malati Devi said, “I will not use the word permanent myself yet.”

“Then what should I write?”

“Continuously settled here for thirty years.”

Vijay changed the sentence.

The application asked for five things.
A copy of the original relief order.
A current survey of the settlement area.
An assessment of the present distance from the river channel.
The reason for continuing the temporary status.
And the basis for withholding a permanent water line.
Thirty-four households signed or gave thumb impressions.
Twelve households had members away earning a living; their names were listed separately.

Ten days later, two people came from the Circle Office.
One was a surveyor; the other was a revenue official.
The junior engineer responsible for the water works and Vijay Jha came with them.

The first question was: "How old is the settlement?"

Everyone began speaking at once.

"Thirty years."

"My son was born here."

"I was married here."

"This tap has been here for twenty years."

The surveyor raised a hand and stopped them.

"We will record memories, but the survey will be separate."

Malati Devi said, "That is right."

This time she did not want memory to be made into proof.

The first survey was made from the map attached to the old relief slip.

Two of the four old corner markers could not be found.

Near the third corner, a rusted iron stake was found among the roots of a peepal tree.

The fourth corner matched the line of the old tap.

The surveyor measured the distances.

Then everyone went as far as the river's present channel.

Between the settlement and the channel there were now two fields, an unpaved path, and a raised sandbar.

The revenue official asked, "Does floodwater reach this far?"

Malati Devi said, "Water does come, but in thirty years the old channel has not returned here."

"Is there a government record of that?"

Vijay produced the flood-inspection sheets for five years.

No earlier sheets were available.

Malati Devi showed them the old construction year of the anganwadi.

"This shows how long the settlement has existed," she said, "not how the river has moved."

The surveyor nodded.

“Record that distinction.”

That day Malati Devi understood that asking for the right document was more important than trying to make the wrong document prove the right thing.

It took three weeks.

A copy of the original 1996 relief order was found in the Circle Office file.

It stated clearly that the settlement was to remain “until the old river channel stabilizes.”

Below that was a field for the date of review.

It was blank.

Old channel maps were requested from the district water records.

The lines from 1996, 2001, 2011, and 2021 were laid side by side.

The old channel had gradually shifted westward, but it had never returned to the site of Relief Tola.

That fact did not determine ownership of the land.

But it did require a review of the temporary condition stated in the original order.

The Water Department’s records told a different story.

Expenditure was recorded for replacing the black pipe six times.

The junior engineer added up the figures.

“By treating this pipe as temporary, we kept buying a new one again and again,” he said.

Malati Devi asked, “And what would it cost to lay one underground once?”

The engineer wrote down the estimate.

It was less than the total cost of the six rounds of repair and replacement.

No one said anything.

The next meeting was held in the panchayat building.

Many people from Relief Tola stood outside.

Inside were five chairs and one long table.

The Circle Officer read the old order.

Then he looked at the four inspection sheets.

“For thirty years, the word ‘temporary’ was repeated,” he said, “but no review of the original condition was recorded.”

He also examined the water-expenditure register.

“The temporary arrangement was replaced six times.”

No one applauded.

People waited to hear the answer.

The Circle Officer said, “This meeting will not decide ownership.”

Malati Devi said, “My application did not ask for ownership either.”

The officer looked at her.

“That will be made clear in the record.”

He dictated an order directing that the status of Relief Tola be formally reviewed, with the present settlement, water risk, public facilities, and land records entered separately.

Then another sentence was added: “A safe basic water supply shall not be withheld solely on the basis of the unreviewed 1996 notation ‘temporary relief.’”

Vijay Jha read the sentence again.

Malati Devi asked, “Will the underground pipe be laid now?”

“Yes,” the junior engineer said. “The scheme will move forward.”

“And permanent settlement status?”

Vijay paused before answering.

“That is a separate decision.”

Malati Devi said, “Let it remain separate. At least the question has finally been asked.”

A month later, the labourers arrived.

A trench was dug from the main pipeline to Relief Tola.

The black flexible pipe was removed.

A thick water pipe was laid underground.

Three public taps were installed.

At the old single-tap spot, children no longer had to quarrel with one another again and again.

When the water was turned on for the first time, Malati Devi filled her water pot.

She did not place her hand over the mouth of the tap.

She looked down at the ground where the pipe had been buried.

Vijay was holding a piece of the old black pipe.

“Shall I throw it away?” he asked.

Malati Devi said, “No. Let it stay.”

“Why keep it?”

“Keep it in the anganwadi.”

A length of the black pipe, about a cubit long, was washed and hung on the wall.

Below it Vijay wrote a small label: “Old water pipe.”

Malati Devi read the label.

“One word is missing,” she said.

Vijay picked up his pen.

The label was changed to: “Old temporary water pipe.”

Outside, water flowed from all three taps.

On the anganwadi wall, the old pipe hung silently.

Malati Devi lifted her water pot and walked home.

For the first time, she understood that for something temporary to end, it need not always break; sometimes it is enough for it finally to be reviewed.

The Forest School

In the midst of the sal forest stood the settlement of Beljharia.

The paved road lay four kos from the settlement.

Between them were two small streams, an earthen embankment, and a dense thicket of sal.

At the edge of that thicket stood a one-room primary school.

The limewash on the wall had grown old, but the name in blue letters could still be read.

Phulkumari of Class Five was the first to arrive every day.

Behind her came Raghu of Class Three, Chanda of Class Two, and the younger children.

The school key stayed with Sugni Kaki, who cooked the midday meal.

Naresh Babu, the teacher, had the other key.

In the first month Naresh Babu came for eight days.

In the second month, five.

In the first ten days of the third month, two.

When the teacher did not come, Sugni Kaki opened the room.

The children would talk for a while at first.

Then some went home, while others stayed and played in the courtyard.

One day, standing by the gate, Phulkumari said, "What will we do if we go back home?"

Raghu said, "Let's look at the maths we were given yesterday."

"Who will explain it?"

Raghu shrugged.

Phulkumari went into the room.

The addition and subtraction from the previous week were still written on the blackboard.

She opened her book.

"Let's first study what we do understand."

Four children sat down in front.

Phulkumari read the lesson aloud.

Halfway through, she stumbled over a word.

Raghu pronounced it.

"Meaning?" Chanda asked.

No one knew.

Phulkumari wrote the word on the blackboard.

By noon, eleven questions had accumulated on the board.

As she served the meal, Sugni Kaki asked, "Who will wipe all this off?"

Phulkumari said, "The day Guruji comes, we'll ask him."

The next day Guruji did not come.

There was no room left on the board for a new lesson.

Raghu tore a page from an old notebook.

Phulkumari stopped him.

"Why are you tearing your notebook?"

Sugni Kaki brought out some old slips kept near an empty rice sack.

They were the backs of old food-stock account sheets, with one side still blank.

Phulkumari cut those sheets into small pieces.

They also found an old piece of red cloth.

Chanda stitched a small pouch from it.

On the mouth of the pouch Phulkumari wrote: "NOT UNDERSTOOD."

Any question no one could answer was written on a slip and dropped into the pouch.

If they found the answer in a book, the slip came out.

By the end of the first week there were twenty-seven slips in the pouch.

Some questions were about mathematics.

Some were from the language lessons.

Some were questions the children could work out among themselves by reading the books.

"Which is greater, a quarter or a half?"

That question came out on the third day.

"Why is north shown at the top of a map?"

That slip stayed inside.

"When water boils, where does the steam go?"

Raghu and Chanda gave two different answers.

The slip stayed inside.

One day Naresh Babu came.

Phulkumari placed the red pouch before him.

"What is this?"

"Not understood."

Naresh Babu laughed.

"All of it?"

"All of ours."

He opened the slips.

He explained the first five questions.

The bell rang while he was on the sixth.
 Then someone from the office sent for him.
 He said, "The rest tomorrow."
 The next day he did not come.
 The remaining slips stayed in the pouch.
 Then Phulkumari began another task.
 She opened the last blank page of an old, half-filled register.
 Across the top she drew four columns.
 Date.
 Who opened the room.
 What was studied.
 How many questions remained unanswered.
 Raghu added a fifth column: "Did Guruji come or not?"
 Phulkumari looked at him for a moment.
 Then she left the column there.
 "We won't write anything false," she said.
 "If he comes, we'll write 'came.' If he doesn't, we'll write 'did not come.'"
 No complaint against anyone was entered in this register.
 Only the account of the day.
 Monday — Sugni Kaki opened the room.
 Language lesson three.
 Two questions resolved.
 Thirty-one slips left.
 Guruji did not come.
 Tuesday — Raghu led the multiplication tables.
 Four children checked one another.
 Two slips resolved.
 Twenty-nine left.
 Guruji did not come.
 Wednesday — Guruji came.
 He explained the answers to seven slips.
 Twenty-two left.
 And so the register continued to fill.
 For some days the children were very enthusiastic.
 They took turns ringing the bell, reading lessons, and cleaning the blackboard.
 But little by little the difficulties began to show.
 Phulkumari could explain Class Five mathematics to the younger children, but she herself got stuck on her new chapter.
 Raghu could read, but he was not confident enough to correct written answers.

Chanda could memorize words, but fell silent when asked their meanings.

The red pouch grew thicker.

One day the number of slips crossed fifty.

Phulkumari lifted the pouch.

“We can keep the school open,” she said softly, “but we cannot teach every lesson.”

Sugni Kaki heard her from a distance.

She said nothing.

That week there was a meeting of the School Management Committee at the panchayat building.

Naresh Babu came too.

He said the forest path became difficult after the rains.

The bus came only as far as the road; from there he had to walk.

On some days he also had work at the block office.

The committee members listened.

Phulkumari and Raghu were not at the meeting.

The next day they went on filling their register.

At the end of the month, Sudhanshu Jha, the education coordinator from the block, came for an inspection.

Naresh Babu was with him.

Sudhanshu Jha looked around the room.

The blackboard was clean.

The children were seated.

He asked Phulkumari, “What did you study today?”

Phulkumari showed him the page in the book.

“This lesson.”

“Who taught it?”

Phulkumari looked toward Raghu.

Raghu said, “I read the first two paragraphs. She read the third.”

“And Guruji?”

Naresh Babu was standing right there.

Instead of answering, Phulkumari brought out the register.

Sudhanshu Jha turned the pages.

One day, two days, three days.

In some places it said “came,” in others “did not come.”

He asked about the red pouch.

Chanda took the pouch down.

“Are these all complaints?”

“No,” Phulkumari said, “these are questions.”

Sudhanshu Jha opened one slip.

“Rainwater goes into the river, but where does the water in a well come from?”

A second slip.

“Why is one point five called one and a half?”

A third.

“In history, is it more important to remember the date or the event?”

He spread the slips across the table.

“How many are there?”

Raghu said, “Fifty-eight.”

For the first time, Naresh Babu looked carefully at the pouch.

“On the days I come, I can’t get through all the questions at once,” he said.

Sudhanshu Jha pointed to the register.

“Then on the days you do not come, they keep increasing.”

The room was silent for a few moments.

Phulkumari said at once, “We have not taken Guruji’s place.”

“Then what do you do?”

“We do not let the school close.”

Raghu added, “What we do not understand, we save for later.”

Sudhanshu Jha reached the last page of the register.

He counted the days.

The room had been opened on twenty-two days that month.

Naresh Babu had come on seven days.

For fifteen days the children had kept the lessons going on their own.

“On those fifteen days, did the school run or not?” Sudhanshu Jha asked.

Naresh Babu did not answer.

Phulkumari said, “The door was open.”

“And the teaching?”

She looked at the red pouch.

“As much as we could manage.”

After that answer, another meeting was held at the panchayat building.

This time the children’s register lay on the table.

It was decided that the Beljharia school would no longer be left to depend on a single teacher.

A teacher from a nearby school would come here two days a week.

The days when Naresh Babu had non-teaching work at the block office would be recorded in advance.

If he had to be away on such a day, the name of the substitute teacher would be entered in the register.

The key would continue to stay with Sugni Kaki.

The children’s daily register would continue as well.

Someone said that it was not an official register.

Sudhanshu Jha replied, "No, but it shows that opening the room is not the same as completing the teaching."

The new arrangement began the following Monday.

Naresh Babu arrived on time.

He cleaned the blackboard.

Then he took down the red pouch.

"Books later today," he said.

"This first."

He began opening the slips one by one.

The first question was about well water.

On the ground he drew a circle.

He began explaining the layers of sand, soil, and water.

In the middle of it Chanda raised her hand.

Naresh Babu stopped.

"Yes? What do you want to ask?"

Chanda asked her question.

Raghu added another.

Phulkumari wrote the date in the register.

In the column "Who opened the room," she wrote Sugni Kaki's name.

Under "What was studied," she wrote layers of water and soil.

Under "How many questions remained unanswered," she wrote fifty-six instead of fifty-eight.

The last column was: "Did Guruji come or not?"

Phulkumari held her pen still for a moment.

Then she wrote: "Came."

The bell rang.

This time Phulkumari did not sit in the teacher's chair.

She went back to her place and opened her book.

The red pouch still hung on the wall.

She was not waiting for it to become empty.

She only made sure that whatever the children did not understand did not quietly disappear.

The Power of a Signature

The meeting of the 'Anjor Women's Savings Group' in Sonbarsa village was held on the second Tuesday of every month.

There were twelve women.

Some had been able to write their names for years; some, until two years earlier, had still been putting down thumbprints.

Now all of them wrote their names.

They were proud of that.

But one day Chandrakala Devi said, 'We have learned to write our names. Now let us learn to read what is written above them.'

Everyone laughed.

Phulo Devi asked, 'Is it necessary to read everything above?'

Chandrakala said, 'The signature goes below. The responsibility is written above.'

After that sentence, the manner of their meetings changed.

Along with the additions and subtractions in the savings ledger, they began practising how to read a document.

Sometimes it was a bank receipt, sometimes the quantity printed on a sack of seed, sometimes a notice from the panchayat.

They did not understand every word.

Whatever they did not understand, they circled.

At the next meeting, they looked for its meaning.

Meanwhile, four community paddy-drying platforms were built behind the panchayat building.

The idea was that when the rains ended and paddy began coming in from the fields, the village women could spread it there to dry.

Earlier, paddy had been dried wherever space could be found—in courtyards, beside the road, under thatched roofs.

The sight of the new platforms pleased everyone.

All four were paved.

They stood raised above the ground.

A small drain was to run along the edge so that rainwater would not remain standing.

For the first month, two of the platforms worked well.

A thin crack appeared across the middle of the third.

On one side of the fourth, the outlet for the water had never been made at all.

When it rained, water stood in a corner of the platform.

Sweeping the water away, Phulo Devi said, 'Before we can dry anything here, we have to dry the drying platform itself.'

Everyone laughed, but the water remained in that corner for three days.

A month later, word came from the panchayat that the members of the Anjor Women's Savings Group had to sign a form.

Madan Babu brought the form to their meeting.

He had a single sheet in his hand.

Across the top, in bold letters, were the words: 'User Group Satisfaction Certificate.'

Below were twelve lines.

Madan Babu said, 'Each of you write your name here. The work is complete. This is the paper for the final payment.'

Neelam Devi picked up the pen.

Chandrakala drew the page towards herself.

'Read the line at the top first.'

Madan Babu smiled.

'What is there to read? You have seen the work yourselves.'

Chandrakala read the first line slowly.

'We... the users... certify...'

She stopped.

Phulo read the next word: 'work...'

Neelam added, 'complete...'

Then all three were held up by one word.

Madan Babu said, 'Defect-free.'

Chandrakala read the whole line again.

'The work has been found complete and defect-free.'

The room fell silent.

Phulo said, 'Is the crack in the third platform not a defect?'

'That is a small matter,' Madan Babu said.

'And the water on the fourth?'

'That depends on how it is used.'

Chandrakala turned the sheet over.

The back was blank.

She asked, 'Where are the rest of the papers?'

'What rest?'

'The work order. The measurements. What exactly was to be built. How long the responsibility for repairs lasts.'

Madan Babu stared at her.

‘What do you need with all that?’

Neelam said quietly, ‘Our signatures are being asked for at the end of all that.’

This time Madan Babu had no answer.

He said the complete file was at the panchayat office.

Chandrakala pushed the sheet back to him.

‘Then we will sign after we have seen the complete file.’

Madan Babu went away with the blank sheet.

The next day two women went to the panchayat building.

Then four.

In the end, eight women arrived.

The panchayat secretary said, ‘The file is bulky. It will be difficult for everyone to understand it.’

Chandrakala said, ‘We do not need to understand everything. We will understand as much as our signatures are meant to stand behind.’

The file was placed on the table.

It contained seventeen pages.

The first page gave the name of the work.

The second gave the cost.

From the third onward came the measurements and details of the materials.

On a separate sheet, the women wrote five words: ‘work, measurement, period, defect, responsibility.’

They began looking for those five words in the file.

Many lines went over their heads.

Whenever they did not understand a word, they asked the secretary again.

The sixth page contained the measurements of the four platforms.

The eighth described the drainage along their edges.

For the fourth platform, it said clearly that the slope was to run towards the drain at the back.

Phulo said, ‘There is not even an outlet to the drain there.’

The secretary put his finger on the line.

‘This was supposed to have been built.’

On the eleventh page, one line was circled in red ink.

‘Defect-correction period—twelve months.’

Neelam read it three times.

‘Twelve months.’

Chandrakala asked, ‘How many days has it been since the work was declared complete?’

The secretary checked the date.

‘Fifty-six days.’

Phulo did not laugh.

She only said, ‘So in fifty-six days the defect became ours. And who is responsible for the twelve months?’

The secretary sat straighter in his chair.

The file also contained a column for the security deposit.

That amount was not to be released in full before the defect-correction period ended.

The women did not argue about the amount.

Their question was something else.

‘If the correction period is still running, why is there already a sheet saying “defect-free”?’

The secretary said this was the normal procedure.

Chandrakala asked, ‘Does the file say anywhere that this is the normal procedure?’

The secretary fell silent.

Two days later, Nandkishore Sah, the contractor for the work, came to the village himself.

He inspected the platforms.

He bent over the crack in the third.

‘This is only a fine surface line,’ he said.

Phulo replied, ‘That may be so. The file says that if a defect is seen, it should be reported.’

‘Are you an engineer?’

‘I am not an engineer.’

‘Then who will judge how deep the crack is?’

‘The engineer will. I will only write that a crack can be seen.’

Nandkishore Sah went over to the fourth platform.

There was no water standing there then, but a thin green strip of moss was visible.

Chandrakala said, ‘Water collects here. The outlet is shown in the file, but it is not here.’

Nandkishore Sah said, ‘That can be fixed easily.’

‘Then we will write “defect-free” after it is fixed,’ Neelam said.

Nandkishore Sah’s voice hardened.

‘The final payment is being held up.’

Chandrakala replied, ‘My signature is not meant to hold up a payment. But if I sign against what I have just read, the lie will be in my own writing.’

At that, Madan Babu looked at Chandrakala.

Until then he had thought the women’s group signatures were only a formality.

Now the page lay on the table without a single name on it.
The following Monday, the junior engineer came.
He examined the crack.
He took measurements.
He checked the slope of the fourth platform.
He measured the unfinished drainage outlet.
He wrote that the upper layer of the third platform should be filled again and levelled.
The outlet of the fourth should be completed.
The work continued for five days.
The crack in the third platform was cut open and filled.
The drainage outlet behind the fourth was opened.
Not once during those days did the women ask to sign anything.
On the sixth day it rained.
The next morning, Chandrakala deliberately went to inspect the platforms.
There was no water in the corner of the fourth.
With her big toe, Phulo nudged a little water towards the slope.
The water ran into the drain.
The repaired strip on the third platform was still a different colour.
The women did not spread paddy on it.
The engineer had said it should be left unused for three days.
Three days later, the group met again.
This time Madan Babu opened the seventeen-page file at the final form.
The sheet was not separate.
The file lay open above it.
The signature lines were below.
Chandrakala read the first line.
'Joint inspection by the user group...'
Phulo read the next line.
Neelam read the date.
Madan Babu said, 'If you want to add anything, write it here.'
Chandrakala looked at the secretary.
'Was this line here before?'
The secretary said, 'No. It has been added now.'
Phulo smiled.
She could write, but not long sentences.
Chandrakala asked her what they should write.
Phulo spoke slowly.

‘We saw that the crack in the third platform had been repaired. We saw that the drainage outlet of the fourth had been opened. We will begin using them after three days.’

Chandrakala wrote exactly that.

Below it, all twelve women wrote their names.

Nandkishore Sah was there as well.

He looked carefully at the page.

He said nothing.

Madan Babu put the form back into the file.

That day’s meeting did not end with the savings ledger.

Neelam took out an old bank receipt of her own.

She asked, ‘My signature is on this, but I never read the line above it.’

Phulo said, ‘We cannot change an old signature.’

Chandrakala replied, ‘We can change the next one.’

After that, the group made a small rule.

No member would sign a blank sheet.

No one would sign a detached final page if the meaning of what came before it was not visible.

Any line they did not understand would be read aloud and explained.

They would not certify anything they had not seen.

The rule was written on the last page of the ledger.

The twelve names were written beneath it again.

This time no one was in a hurry.

Two months later, a form arrived for renewing the group’s savings account.

Madan Babu was not there.

Nandkishore Sah was not there.

There was no contract involved.

It was only an ordinary bank form.

Neelam picked up the pen.

The signature line was in front of her.

First she turned the top part of the page towards herself.

Then she began to read.

The other eleven women waited in silence.

Half a Day's Wages

Two days before the rains were due to begin, a truckload of new seed sacks was expected at the Belwara Cooperative Paddy Store.

The rear wall of the storehouse was damp with seepage.

So preparations were made to keep the new sacks in the front room.

Six labourers were called in.

Bachchan Mandal was the oldest among them.

With him were Ramlochan, Rahim, Mahesh, Pachiyaa, and Suresh.

Early that morning, storekeeper Dayanand Jha read out the work slip.

The goods truck carried four hundred and eighty sacks.

The day's assignment for the six labourers was to unload every sack and stack them in order inside the room.

That came to an average of eighty sacks per labourer.

The wage had been fixed for a full day.

Dayanand Jha's signature appeared at the bottom of the work slip.

Bachchan was not highly educated, but he understood the count of eighty perfectly well.

While carrying sacks, he kept count not aloud but on the joints of his fingers.

At the storehouse gate, attendance was marked with slips of two colours.

A white slip in the morning.

A yellow slip after noon.

When both slips were present, a full day was recorded.

With only one slip, half a day.

The labourers all knew this rule.

At eight o'clock that morning, black clouds massed across the sky.

Looking up, Dayanand Jha said, "If it rains, the goods truck will get stuck outside."

The unpaved approach road to the storehouse turned to mud as soon as rain fell.

He said, "No sitting down midway today. Get all the sacks inside first."

Rahim asked, "What about food?"

"Once the work is finished, all of you can go home," Dayanand replied.

"And the wages?" Bachchan asked.

Dayanand laughed. "Work complete, day complete."
 Everyone heard him say it.
 So did the accounts clerk at the gate.
 The six men were given their white morning slips.
 Then the unloading began.
 The body of the goods truck was hot.
 For the first twenty sacks, everyone moved slowly.
 After that, they found a rhythm.
 Two men on the truck.
 Two carrying sacks as far as the gate.
 Two stacking them in rows inside the room.
 After every twenty sacks, they changed places.
 Bachchan did not keep his eighty sacks separate.
 The work of all six was becoming one single stack.
 After every forty sacks, the storekeeper drew a stroke in the receipt register.
 There were four strokes.
 Then six.
 Then eight.
 Then ten.
 Before noon, the wind strengthened.
 Dust rose at the gate.
 The truck driver kept looking at his watch.
 He wanted to leave before the rain came.
 Dayanand Jha said, "No break now."
 Pachiyaa wiped her head with her gamchha.
 Suresh stopped for two minutes to drink water.
 Bachchan kept counting the sacks.
 Four hundred.
 Four hundred and twenty.
 Four hundred and forty.
 Four hundred and sixty.
 The final twenty sacks remained on the truck.
 Just then, the first heavy drop fell.
 All six labourers quickened their pace at once.
 Bachchan and Rahim lifted the last sack together.
 As soon as they set it down inside the room, Dayanand Jha called out,
 "Four hundred and eighty."
 The storekeeper drew the final stroke in the receipt register.
 The goods truck was empty.
 The driver signed the slip and turned the truck around.

The clock showed one ten.
 The rain came down hard.
 Dayanand Jha ordered the gate shut.
 The yellow slips were normally distributed at two o'clock.
 That day, the storehouse remained closed through two.
 The accounts clerk had already gone home.
 The labourers sat beneath the awning at the gate, wringing rainwater from their gamchhas.
 Bachchan asked, "The yellow slips?"
 Dayanand Jha said, "Today the work itself is your slip."
 Ramlochan laughed.
 Everyone understood that the matter was settled.
 Wages were to be distributed three days later.
 The six labourers returned to the storehouse.
 The payment register lay open in front of the accounts clerk.
 Against Ramlochan's name: half a day.
 Against Rahim's: half a day.
 Against Mahesh's: half a day.
 Against Pachiyaa's: half a day.
 Against Suresh's: half a day.
 Against Bachchan's: half a day.
 The amount was exactly half a full day's wage.
 Bachchan looked at the paper.
 Then at the accounts clerk.
 "Why is this half?"
 The clerk showed him the bundle of white slips.
 "Morning attendance is here."
 "The yellow one?"
 "It isn't here."
 "The storehouse was closed."
 "The rule requires both slips."
 Dayanand Jha was not there.
 He had gone to the grain committee office.
 Ramlochan said, "Come on. We'll ask tomorrow."
 Bachchan did not take the payment.
 The other five remained standing too.
 The accounts clerk said, "Take it for now. We can discuss it later."
 Bachchan said quietly, "If we had done half the work, we would take half the wage."
 "You people left at one ten."
 "We were sent away."

“You worked only half the time.”

Bachchan was silent for a few moments.

Then he asked, “How many sacks came that day?”

The clerk replied, “Four hundred and eighty.”

“How many went inside?”

“Four hundred and eighty.”

“Did any other labourers come later?”

“Not one.”

Bachchan asked again, “How many sacks were written on the work slip?”

The clerk turned the pages.

He found the work slip.

Four hundred and eighty sacks.

Six labourers.

One day’s work.

The clerk’s finger stopped on the page.

Bachchan said, “If we worked only half a day, then who did the other half of the work?”

The room fell silent.

The accounts clerk searched for an answer.

There was no answer in the register.

The storekeeper brought the receipt register.

That day’s page carried twelve strokes.

Each stroke stood for forty sacks.

At the bottom was written: Total received—four hundred and eighty.

The goods-truck slip also showed four hundred and eighty.

On its final line, the time was written: one ten.

Bachchan put his finger on the time.

“That is not the time we left,” he said. “That is the time the work was completed.”

Just then Dayanand Jha returned from the office.

Seeing the crowd inside, he asked, “What happened?”

The accounts clerk turned the register toward him.

Dayanand Jha looked at the half-day entries.

Then at the work slip.

Then at the receipt register.

His expression did not change, but his voice grew quieter.

“The yellow slips were not distributed,” he said.

Bachchan replied, “The gate had been closed.”

“The rule requires two slips.”

“Then on a rainy day, does the rule say we should leave the work unfinished?”

Dayanand Jha said nothing.

Pachiyaa spoke for the first time. "We skipped our meal to unload those sacks."

Rahim added, "So the truck wouldn't get stuck."

Suresh said, "If we had sat there until two, we would have received the yellow slips."

"But the truck had already been emptied," Mahesh said.

Dayanand Jha called for the gate daybook.

On that day's page, one line read: Storehouse closed at one fifteen because of rain.

His own signature stood beneath that line.

Bachchan kept looking not at the paper, but at Dayanand Jha.

Dayanand Jha sat down on the chair.

For a while, three pages lay spread out before him.

One page recorded the time.

One recorded the work.

One recorded the goods received.

All three belonged to the same day.

Only the payment page called it half a day.

Dayanand Jha told the accounts clerk, "Don't strike out the entry."

The clerk looked surprised.

"Then what should I do?"

"Write the correction beside it."

He dictated: "The second attendance slip was not distributed because the office was closed; the assigned work was completed."

Beside "half day" against each of the six names, "full day" was entered.

Dayanand Jha added the date.

The storekeeper signed as witness.

The remaining half of the wage was added.

Only then did Bachchan take the money.

He counted the notes again.

There was no smile of victory.

Only the count was complete.

As they stepped outside, Ramlochan said, "Four hundred and eighty sacks turned out to be heavy."

Bachchan said, "Not the sacks. The word 'half' was heavy."

The following week, another goods truck arrived.

This time it carried five hundred and forty sacks.

A new team was called in.

The white morning slips were distributed.

Before noon, the sky clouded over again.

Dayanand Jha had a new line added beneath the work slip.

“If the assigned work is completed before the office closes, a full day will be recorded.”

The accounts clerk read the line.

The storekeeper read it.

The labourers heard it.

Bachchan was not part of the team that day.

He was uprooting paddy seedlings in a nearby field.

At noon, he heard the storehouse bell.

He raised his head.

The goods truck was pulling out through the gate.

It had not yet begun to rain.

Inside the storehouse, all five hundred and forty sacks had already been counted.

The accounts clerk opened the bundle of yellow slips ahead of time.

First the sacks were counted.

Then the day.

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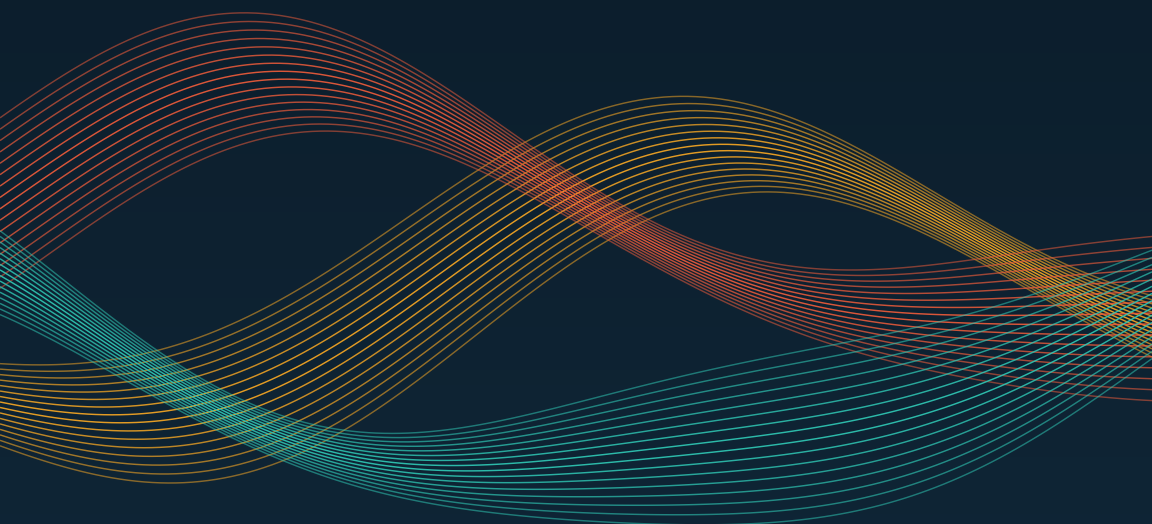
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(Three Hundred Selected Stories by Gajendra Thakur)

STORIES 101–200

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STORY 101

FOUR HANDFULS OF SEED

It was the last week of Aghan. After three days of sunshine, the colour of the paddy heaps in the threshing ground on the southern side of Majhaul village had begun to change—the fresh-cut gold was slowly turning grey-gold.

Sunaina was the first to arrive through the morning mist. A small red thread was tied to the corner of her sari. It was not meant for anyone to notice; she intended to use it to mark the sack of paddy selected for seed.

Only two oxen were tethered in the threshing ground so far, and Gopal was levelling the earth with a broom.

“Was the dew heavy last night?” Sunaina asked.

Gopal picked up a fistful of paddy and brought it to his nose.

“A little on the surface. Inside it is fine. If we turn it till ten o’clock, it will do.”

Sunaina bit a grain between her teeth.

“We will keep the seed heap separate, won’t we?”

Gopal stopped sweeping and looked at her.

“Let the division be done first. The question will come up today.”

“Will good grain be left after the division?”

“Whether it will be left or not is not the point. The point is, I do not know whether this field will remain in my hands next year.”

Sunaina did not answer. She tucked the red thread back into the fold of her sari.

The three bighas on the southern side belonged to Baldev Babu. For five years Gopal had cultivated them on a half-share basis. Gopal supplied the seed, farmyard manure, and part of the labour; Baldev Babu paid half the diesel for the pump and half the chemical fertiliser. After harvesting and threshing, the expenses were deducted and the remaining paddy divided equally.

Nothing was on paper.

Between the two households lay five years of memory—who had bought how many sacks of urea, who had repaired the pump pipe the previous year, in which year the paddy had stood under floodwater for three days, in which year mice had eaten the seed.

Within that memory, a small practice had continued since the days of Sunaina’s mother-in-law.

While the sacks were being filled, four handfuls of good paddy were taken from every sack and set aside.

That grain went into the seed sack.

Before the division.

It belonged neither to the landlord’s share nor to the cultivator’s share.

It was the cost of the next sowing.

At first Sunaina had found the practice rough and pointless. What could four handfuls amount to? But by the time thirty or thirty-five sacks had been filled, those four handfuls had grown into nearly a full sack.

For the past five years, the southern fields had begun again each season from that seed.

This year was different.

Baldev Babu's younger son, Naresh, had returned from the city. He had said that next year the field would not be given to Gopal; he would farm it himself with his maternal cousin and a tractor.

Gopal had not heard this from Baldev Babu's own mouth, but the village had begun saying it.

And once a thing begins to circulate in a village, it is hard to know when it becomes the owner's decision and when it remains merely the people's guess.

Baldev Babu arrived at half past eight.

He carried an old walking stick, a cloth bag tucked under his arm, and a white gamchha on his head. Naresh came with him.

Naresh wore an old pair of city shoes, but once his feet sank into the earth of the threshing ground, his gait became that of a villager.

Baldev Babu looked at the heaps.

"The yield has not been bad this year."

Gopal said, "By God's grace. It would have been better still if the pump had not stopped during the last irrigation."

Naresh spoke at once. "And diesel had to be fetched three times in two days then."

Gopal looked at him but said nothing.

Sunaina went on turning the paddy.

By ten o'clock two more labourers had arrived. Instead of the old brass weights, this time a small iron balance and a fifty-kilo scale had been brought. Naresh had said that if all the sacks were of equal weight, selling them later would be easier.

Gopal liked the idea.

"The measurement will be clear," he said.

Baldev Babu laughed.

"Whether clear measurement reduces quarrels or begins a new kind of quarrel—we shall learn that today."

For the first time, Sunaina smiled.

The first sack was lifted onto the scale.

A little under fifty kilos.

Gopal added paddy from the top.

The needle came level.

Sunaina stepped forward. With her right hand she took out four handfuls of paddy and dropped them into a small bamboo basket kept nearby.

Naresh asked, "What is that?"

"Seed," Sunaina said simply.

"Whose seed?"

At the four words of that question, Gopal's hand stopped.

Sunaina looked at Naresh's face.

"The field's."

Naresh did not laugh.

"Will you open a granary in the field's name?"

Baldev Babu kept scratching the earth with the tip of his stick.

Gopal said, "It is the custom. It has always been kept aside first."

Naresh rested a hand on the sack. "When you are not even going to cultivate this field next year, why should your house keep the seed?"

Sunaina said, "Why should my house keep it? Let the sack remain in Baldev Babu's store room."

"Then take it from our share. After the halves have been divided."

"Seed is not selected after division. The good grain is here before us now."

A crease appeared on Naresh's forehead.

"If all the good grain goes into seed, will only bad grain remain to sell?"

This time Sunaina laughed softly.

"Not all the good grain. Four handfuls."

"Four handfuls from every sack."

"Yes."

"If there are thirty sacks?"

"Almost one sack."

Naresh turned to Gopal.

"One sack of paddy is not a small matter."

Gopal said quietly, "It is not a small matter. That is why for five years it has been kept aside before the division."

Baldev Babu had remained silent until then.

He looked at the first sack, then at the basket.

"How much was kept last year?"

Sunaina answered at once. "Forty-two kilos."

"How much seed was used?"

"About thirty-seven kilos. Five kilos remained. Mice ate two kilos of that. I dried the remaining three and kept them. This year those were the first to go into the nursery bed."

Naresh asked, "Where is all that accounting written?"

Sunaina slipped a hand into the fold of her sari. She did not take out the red thread. Instead, she drew out a small old notebook she had brought from home.

On one page, in pencil, was written: Southern Tract, Lalmania, 42 kilos.

Below it: after Rohini nakshatra, 37 kilos.

Naresh looked at the notebook.

"This is not an official register."

Sunaina said, "Neither is the paddy government property."

The two labourers burst out laughing.

Baldev Babu did not laugh.

He said, "Dry the paddy first. We will discuss the matter later."

But the matter did not wait for later.

When the second sack was filled, Sunaina again took out four handfuls. Naresh reached out and stopped the basket.

"Wait. Let the decision be made first."

Gopal's face hardened.

"Are you stopping the sack or the seed?"

"I am stopping nothing. I only want a clear account."

"Then count five years of custom in your clear account as well."

"You cultivated for five years. In the sixth year someone else will cultivate."

"The field will still be the same."

"But who did the labour of preparing the seed?"

At that question, Sunaina turned fully toward Naresh for the first time.

"That is a good question."

She set the basket down.

"Who sorts the paddy, dries it, puts neem leaves in it, and turns the sack three times?"

Before Naresh could speak, Gopal said, "Sunaina."

"Then," Sunaina said, "if someone else cultivates next year, give the seed to him. But let the work of preparing the seed this year also enter the account."

Baldev Babu raised his head for the first time.

"How much is that account?"

Sunaina fell silent.

She had never thought of a separate price for that work.

For five years the work had lived inside farming itself—like untying the cattle at dawn, turning sacks in the sun, watching the first water in the nursery bed.

The moment a price was put on it, the work seemed to change its shape.

Gopal said, "It is not about price. It is about the rule."

Naresh answered at once, "A rule exists only when it is clear. Otherwise the same dispute will return next year."

Baldev Babu walked to the edge of the threshing ground and sat down, leaning on his stick.

"All right. Do not stop filling the sacks. Let the weighing continue. The seed basket will remain here. We will decide by evening."

The work began again.

But now, whenever the four handfuls came out, every eye fell on the basket.

Third sack.

Four handfuls.

Fourth sack.

Four handfuls.

While filling the fifth sack, Chhotu, one of the labourers, asked, "Would it be good to keep seed this way in my field too?"

Gopal said, "Your field is your own."

Chhotu replied, "In one's own field, seed is the first thing people sell. Cash is always needed."

No one answered.

By noon fourteen sacks had been filled. The basket was half full.

From time to time Sunaina sorted the grains, separating diseased ones, black-spotted ones, and the half-ripe.

Naresh watched her twice.

The third time, he picked up a handful himself and asked, “Are these good?”

Sunaina spread the grains on her palm and looked.

“Two are light. Blow on them.”

Naresh blew. Two grains fell to the edge.

“These are not seed?”

“You can eat them. Why put them in the seed?”

Naresh returned the handful to the basket.

Lunch came from Baldev Babu’s house—flattened rice, curd, and jaggery.

Everyone sat along one side of the threshing ground.

Gopal had grown quiet.

Sunaina knew that he needed cash. The fertiliser bought on credit the previous month was still unpaid. Their daughter Rani’s annual school fee was due the following week. Even half the value of a sack of paddy was not a small amount for them.

Sunaina asked softly, “What do you think?”

Gopal set down his bowl of curd.

“Let the old custom remain.”

“If the field leaves our hands?”

“Then the seed belongs to Baldev Babu.”

“And what I sort?”

Gopal was silent for a while.

“That was part of the farm work.”

“Whose farm work?”

Gopal looked at her.

Sunaina did not smile.

“I am not asking for money. But if a rule is being made, let the work have a name.”

Gopal let out a breath.

“You want a name for everything.”

“If it has no name, next time people will say—it simply happened by itself.”

At that moment Baldev Babu came near.

“What happened by itself?”

Sunaina did not hesitate.

“The seed.”

Baldev Babu took a handful of flattened rice.

“In my father’s time, seed used to be set aside separately. But in those days sharecroppers changed less often.”

Gopal said, “Will it change now?”

Baldev Babu did not answer directly.

“Naresh wants to farm.”

“Let him.”

“You are not upset?”

Gopal kept breaking off bits of jaggery.

“The field is yours. I have cultivated it for five years. Let the accounts be settled properly.”

“That is all?”

Gopal lifted his head.

“Does saying ‘that is all’ make it any smaller?”

Baldev Babu looked at him for a few moments.

“No.”

After noon, Mohan Sah, a trader from the market, arrived.

He left his motorcycle outside the threshing ground and immediately began counting the sacks.

“The price is good today,” he said. “It may fall tomorrow.”

Naresh’s eyes brightened.

“How much?”

Mohan Sah named the price.

Gopal calculated at once in his head.

At that rate, if he sold his half, he could clear the fertiliser debt, pay the school fee, and still save something.

Mohan Sah looked at the paddy in the basket.

“Why has that been kept separately?”

Naresh said, “There is a dispute over the seed.”

Mohan Sah laughed.

“Sell the paddy and buy seed from the market. Certified seed. Higher yield.”

Sunaina asked, “The last certified seed you brought—how much of it germinated?”

Mohan Sah’s smile faded a little.

“Every year is not the same.”

Baldev Babu said, “Market seed is not bad. But one’s own seed is not useless either.”

Mohan Sah patted a sack.

“The price is here today. If you keep one sack as seed, you are holding back one sack’s cash.”

Everyone understood that.

Naresh understood it.

Gopal understood it.

So did Sunaina.

The custom of four handfuls had suddenly ceased to be merely tradition. It had become a question of cash.

Mohan Sah left.

Naresh said, “You heard him? One sack means this much money at today’s price.”

Sunaina replied, “And when seed has to be bought next Jeth, what will the price be then?”

“Who knows?”

“That is why seed is a cost.”

“But what if I sow a new variety?”

“Then sell this one.”

“Whose money?”

The same question again.

This time Sunaina did not answer.

Baldev Babu said, “We will weigh it in the evening. First let us see how much it comes to.”

The work continued until dusk.

There were thirty-two full sacks and another containing twenty-seven kilos.

The seed basket was emptied three times into one separate sack.

It weighed thirty-eight kilos and six hundred grams.

Sunaina wrote it in her notebook.

Naresh watched carefully.

“How much will be needed for the next sowing?”

“Thirty-five to thirty-seven kilos will be enough for this field.”

“Then one and a half or two kilos will remain.”

“Some will be lost in the germination test. And there are mice.”

Baldev Babu said, “Good. Now the accounts.”

They all sat in the middle of the threshing ground.

Gopal brought his notebook. Baldev Babu took fertiliser and diesel receipts from his bag. Naresh used a calculator.

First the expenses.

Then the total weight.

Then the half shares.

When the thirty-eight kilos and six hundred grams of seed were kept outside the total before division, Naresh stopped again.

“Write ‘seed’ here. But who is the owner?”

Gopal was silent.

Sunaina held her pencil motionless over the notebook.

Baldev Babu said, “Write my name as owner.”

Sunaina did not move the pencil.

Naresh looked at her.

“Why?”

“If you are the owner, then this becomes your share. Why should it be taken out before the division?”

Baldev Babu grew slightly irritated.

“Then whose name?”

Sunaina said softly, “The Southern Tract.”

Naresh burst out laughing.

“Will the field sign its name?”

Gopal laughed too.

The tension loosened a little.

Smiling, Baldev Babu said, "The field will not sign, but the field will not change."

Sunaina said, "The cultivator will."

"Yes."

"Then let the field's name remain."

Naresh stopped smiling and became serious.

"All right. But what will be the rule for using it?"

This time everyone was silent.

With his stick, Baldev Babu drew four lines on the earth.

First line—how much seed.

Second—who receives it.

Third—what happens if it is not used.

Fourth—whose work it is to sort and dry it.

"These four things must be clear," he said.

Gopal said, "Whoever cultivates the field next year will receive the seed."

Naresh asked, "Free?"

"It has already been taken out of this year's produce before division."

"But the person who cultivates next year has given nothing this year."

Sunaina said, "At the next harvest, he will set aside the same amount of seed again."

Naresh paused.

"What if the crop fails?"

"As much as possible. If less can be kept, let it be written down how much less."

Baldev Babu said, "Good. The seed is like the field's revolving capital."

Sunaina smiled a little at the word 'capital'.

"I do not know such grand words. Seed is simply seed."

Gopal said, "Third question—what if new seed is bought?"

Naresh replied immediately, "Then sell the old seed."

"The money?" Baldev Babu asked.

Gopal said, "Half to the owner and half to the cultivator of the year in which this seed was produced."

Sunaina interrupted, "First, the cost of preparing the seed?"

Naresh smiled.

"Now there is a cost again."

"Sorting, drying, neem leaves, the sack—does the air do all that?"

Baldev Babu said, "How much will you take?"

Sunaina faltered again.

She did not want to put a price on the work; she only did not want the work to remain invisible.

After thinking a little, she said, "No money. The household where the seed is stored must be responsible for drying it twice and protecting it from mice. If there is any loss, it must be written down. That is all."

Naresh asked, "And the labour?"

"This year I sorted it. Next year the household of whoever cultivates will sort it. Write that into the rule."

Baldev Babu nodded.

"That is fair."

The fourth point was settled.

Only one question remained—where the seed would be kept.

Baldev Babu's masonry store room was secure, but damp had entered it the previous year. The raised platform in Gopal's house was dry, but if his connection with the field ended, coming to ask for the seed next year would be awkward.

Naresh said, "Let it stay at our house."

Gopal did not object at once.

Sunaina pressed the sack with her hand.

"Let it stay there. But write the field's name, the variety, the date, and the weight on the sack. And let both households seal it."

Naresh was startled.

"Seal it?"

"With thread."

Sunaina opened the fold of her sari and took out the red thread.

"I will tie red. You tie your colour. If the sack is opened, both threads will have to be cut."

Gopal laughed.

"A register on top of a register."

Sunaina said, "Paper gets lost. Thread can be seen."

Naresh felt in his pocket. He had a thin green plastic cord, the kind he used to tie his motorcycle papers.

"This is my colour."

Baldev Babu said, "For the first time in this threshing ground, there has been more discussion of thread than of paddy."

Evening was falling.

The accounts were completed. Gopal's sacks stood to one side, Baldev Babu's to the other.

The seed sack stood in the middle.

Mohan Sah came back again.

"Will you sell?"

Gopal looked at his sacks.

"I will sell ten sacks from my half."

Baldev Babu said, "I will sell twelve."

Mohan Sah looked at the seed sack.

"And this?"

Naresh answered, "Not this one."

Mohan Sah shrugged.

"If the price falls tomorrow, do not blame me."

Gopal said, "Tomorrow's market will not decide the price of seed."

Laughing, Mohan Sah left.

Before nightfall, the seed sack was carried to Baldev Babu's house.

On a piece of white paper Sunaina wrote:

Southern Tract.

Lalmania paddy.

Aghan.

Thirty-eight kilos, six hundred grams.

For the next cultivator.

After use, seed to be set aside again at the next harvest.

If not used, the sale proceeds to be divided equally between the two parties of this year.

Sorting and drying the seed to be the responsibility of the next cultivator.

Below, Baldev Babu and Gopal affixed their thumbprints/signatures. Sunaina wrote her name beside the words 'seed sorted by'. Naresh signed as witness.

The paper was stitched onto the sack.

Red and green threads were tied across its mouth.

Gopal said little on the way home.

Sunaina asked, "Are you upset?"

Gopal said, "Because the field will leave us."

"Is it certain yet?"

"Baldev Babu will not brush aside Naresh's wish."

"Then we will look for another field."

"Will we find one?"

"Are fields scarce, or hands?"

Gopal smiled.

"Hands are more plentiful."

They walked some distance in silence.

Behind them, chaff was blowing across the threshing ground.

For the next three months, Gopal's life kept its usual course. The money from the paddy paid the fertiliser debt, the school fee was deposited, and two sacks were kept for the household to eat.

In Magh, Baldev Babu said plainly that the following year Naresh and his maternal cousin would cultivate the Southern Tract.

Gopal merely said, "All right."

Sunaina heard it and raised no quarrel.

In Phagun, Gopal settled on two bighas of land on a half-share arrangement along the boundary of another village.

At the end of Baisakh, Naresh came to Gopal's house one day.

The same white paper was in his hand.

"We have to open the seed sack."

Gopal was sitting under the eaves.

"Why do you need me?"

Naresh showed him the paper.

"There were two threads, remember? Sunaina had said the red thread was yours."

Sunaina came out from inside.

"The red thread was not mine. It belonged to the cultivator's side for that year."

"That was you."

"Now you will cultivate the field. The old side only has to be present when the sack is opened."

The three of them went to Baldev Babu's house.

The sack was brought out of the store room.

The green thread had turned dull. The red had faded too.

The writing on the paper was still clear.

Sunaina pressed the sack.

"Open it in the sun first. I can feel dampness inside now."

Naresh said, "We will sun it tomorrow."

Gopal asked, "Have you tested the germination?"

"No."

Sunaina said, "Soak a hundred grains. You will know in two days."

Naresh nodded.

The sack was not opened that day.

The next day, in the sun, both threads were cut.

A hundred grains were wrapped in a wet cloth.

On the third day, eighty-six had sprouted.

Naresh said, "That will do."

Sunaina said, "Keep a little more seed. Germination is eighty-six per cent."

Naresh laughed.

"Is the seed mine now?"

Sunaina looked at the paper.

"It is still the field's. Once it goes into your nursery bed, it becomes your responsibility."

Without a word, Gopal helped lift the seed sack.

Naresh did not stop him.

Two men carried the sack outside.

Baldev Babu stood at the doorway.

"Gopal, do you have seed for your new field?"

"The owner's household will provide it."

"On paper?"

Gopal looked at Sunaina.

Sunaina laughed.

"This time we will ask first."

Naresh could not load the sack onto his motorcycle, so a handcart was sent for. When the cart moved away, the paper label faced outward.

Southern Tract.

No man's name above it.

Gopal read it once.

Then he took the road that led toward his new field.

THE PLOUGH'S ROAD

It was the second Monday of Ashadh. After a light rain through the night, the unmetalled road in Majhau village was soft with mud, but not so soft that the oxen's hooves would sink into it.

At dawn, Jagesar opened the door of the cattle shed and first ran a hand over Moti's back. The other ox, Karia, had his muzzle in the trough and was eating chaff.

The two oxen were the joint property of two brothers. Jagesar was the elder, Nandu the younger. While their father was still alive, he had said, "Divide the fields if you must, but the oxen cannot be divided into two."

After their father died, the fields were indeed divided, and even a thin wall rose through the middle of the courtyard; but Moti and Karia, the plough, the yoke, and the old bullock cart remained in the joint possession of the two brothers.

On days when the oxen were free from work in their own fields, the brothers hired out the plough and oxen to the village's small farmers.

The rule was very old.

From morning till noon—a half-day.

From noon till evening—a half-day.

The rate was the same.

Whether the field was near or far.

Whether the soil was hard or soft—none of this was asked when the rate was fixed.

Nandu strongly favoured this simple rule.

"The account stays clear," he would say. "A half-day means a half-day. Look at the clock, pay the money, and the matter is finished."

Jagesar would usually laugh.

"The cleaner the account, the fewer the complications."

That Monday morning's half-day had been entered in Mohan's name.

Mohan's field lay east of the village, beyond the old mango grove, on the far side of a small stream. It was about half a kos from the cattle shed.

Lifting the yoke, Nandu asked, "Will the road there be muddy now?"

Mohan, who was already standing by the cattle shed, said, "The main road is all right. It may be a little soft near the stream. I will take a spade."

Jagesar looked not at a clock but at the sky.

"The morning is good. If you reach there before the sun climbs, the oxen will have an easier time."

Mohan said, "That is why I came while it was still dark."

Nandu took the plough on his shoulder. Jagesar untethered the oxen.

The custom was that with each hire, one of the two brothers went along to handle the plough. If the customer wished, he could handle it himself, but the

rate remained the same, because the oxen and the plough were considered the principal part of the hire.

Today it was Nandu's turn to go.

Mohan walked ahead carrying the spade. Nandu came behind with the plough, with Moti and Karia between them.

The road through the middle of the village was easy. Someone was sweeping a doorstep, someone turning cow-dung cakes, someone walking towards the pond with a lota in hand.

Beyond the grove, the road narrowed.

At one place, water had collected in an old bullock-cart wheel rut. Mohan cut a channel at the edge with his spade and let the water drain away.

Nandu stood waiting.

"Five minutes went here," he said.

Mohan smiled.

"From my field's time?"

Nandu laughed too.

"The half-day clock started the moment we left the cattle shed."

Mohan gave no answer.

Near the stream the road was softer still. Moti's right hoof slipped twice. Nandu put the plough down and loosened the yoke a little.

"Wait a little," he said.

Mohan sat down on the grassy edge.

The oxen spent five or seven minutes catching their breath.

By the time they reached the field, the sun was emerging from behind the clouds.

Mohan pointed out the bund of his field.

"The northern patch first. The soil there is a little heavy."

Nandu took hold of the plough.

With the very first furrow, he understood that the night's rain had softened the topsoil, but the earth beneath was still hard.

Moti and Karia leaned into the yoke.

After two furrows Nandu stopped.

"Do you want it deep?"

"It is the first ploughing," Mohan said. "As deep as the oxen can go comfortably."

The work settled into its rhythm.

Mohan kept cutting grass from the bund. From time to time he took the plough handle himself and gave Nandu a rest.

After about an hour, Karia began panting with his mouth open.

Nandu stopped the plough.

"Water."

Mohan ran towards the bucket kept in a corner of the field.

The oxen were not given too much water at once. Their mouths were washed, they were allowed to drink a little, and then they were made to stand in the shade.

Mohan asked, "How long a rest?"

“Ten or fifteen minutes.”

“Does that count in the half-day too?”

This time Nandu did not laugh.

“If the oxen do not rest, how will they work the second shift?”

Mohan nodded.

“That is true.”

A little later, the ploughing began again.

Before noon, Nandu looked up at the sky.

“We have to turn back now.”

Mohan was startled.

“Only this much?”

The northern patch was finished, but two rows in the south were still untouched.

Nandu said, “The second half-day belongs to Shivrath. His field is on the western side of the village. We have to reach the shed, give the oxen chaff and water, and then set out again. That will take time.”

Mohan brushed the soil from his hands.

“I will pay for a half-day, but the ploughing I received was barely an hour and a half or two hours.”

“The oxen were walking on the road too.”

“The road did not plough my field.”

“Is the road not work for the oxen?”

Mohan was silent for a moment.

“It is work. But then say that I am hiring the oxen for half a day, not buying a half-day of ploughing.”

Nandu let go of the plough handle.

“That is exactly what we hire out.”

“Then a man whose field is close by gets three hours of ploughing in the oxen’s half-day, while I get an hour and a half. Yet the money is the same.”

“I did not create the distance.”

“Nor did I take a distant field for the pleasure of the road.”

Neither man raised his voice.

Moti had turned his muzzle towards the shade. Karia was swishing flies away with his tail.

At last Nandu said, “For today, the work has been done according to the rule as it stands. Speak to my elder brother.”

Mohan paid the full amount.

Nandu did not count it. He put it into the pouch at his waist.

They spoke little on the way back.

When they reached the cattle shed, Jagesar asked, “Did the work go well?”

Leaning the plough against the wall, Nandu said, “The field was good. The account was bad.”

Mohan remained standing there.

Nandu told the whole story.

After listening, Jagesar looked first at Mohan and then at the oxen.

“Did you pay the full amount?”

Mohan said, "I did. I am not asking you to break the rule. I am asking you to understand the rule."

Just then Shivnath arrived. His western field was not even ten minutes from the cattle shed.

He heard the last part of the conversation.

"What fault is mine?" he said with a laugh. "I bought a field close by, so I get more ploughing."

Mohan smiled as well.

"It is not your fault. Nor is my question addressed to you."

Jagesar went on putting chaff into the trough.

"The half-day rate has been there since our father's time," he said. "The village was not spread out so far then. Few fields beyond the eastern stream were cultivated."

Nandu said at once, "If we change the rule, the account will become a headache. Measure the road, measure the rest, measure the field—spend the whole day writing."

Jagesar looked at him.

"What do we lose by writing it down for three days and seeing?"

Nandu frowned.

"For whom?"

"For ourselves."

Shivnath laughed.

"Write down my shift today as well. Let us see how much advantage I am getting."

Jagesar went into the house and brought out his son's old school notebook. Half a page still carried arithmetic sums. On a blank page he ruled four lines.

Name.

Time of departure from the cattle shed.

Ploughing in the field—start and finish.

Rest for the oxen.

Nandu said, "Where is the time of return?"

Jagesar added a fifth line.

Time of return to the cattle shed.

"All right now?"

Nandu twisted his mouth.

In the afternoon Nandu went to Shivnath's field.

Left the cattle shed—1:05 p.m.

Ploughing began—1:17 p.m.

First rest—2:56 p.m. to 3:08 p.m.

Ploughing ended—4:05 p.m.

Returned to the cattle shed—4:16 p.m.

Jagesar added up the time.

Road—twenty-three minutes, outward and return together.

Ploughing—two hours and thirty-six minutes.

Rest—twelve minutes.

Nandu wrote down Mohan's morning figures from memory.

Road—one hour and five minutes.

Ploughing—one hour and forty minutes.

Rest—about twenty minutes.

Jagesar did not suggest sending the notebook to Mohan's house. He simply kept looking at the page.

Two days later, records for four more customers had accumulated.

One field was close, but the soil was so slick that the oxen slipped again and again. There was less ploughing and more rest.

One field was far away, but the road was dry and straight. The oxen reached it quickly.

One farmer handled the plough himself, so Nandu merely took the oxen there.

At one place they had to wait half an hour because a field bund had broken.

By the end of three days, the "half-day" had separated itself into four different things.

Road.

Ploughing.

Waiting.

Rest.

Looking at the notebook, Nandu said, "What rate are we supposed to produce by writing all this?"

Jagesar said, "Not the rate yet. First let us understand what we are taking money for."

"For the oxen."

"The oxen walk on the road, plough in the field, and rest in between. All three are the oxen's time. But the work done in the customer's field is not equal in all three."

Nandu fell silent.

On the fourth day a new complication appeared.

The morning shift belonged to Ratneshwar. His field lay by the eastern grove, halfway along the road to Mohan's field. The afternoon shift again belonged to Mohan, because he wanted the untouched southern patch ploughed.

Nandu ploughed Ratneshwar's field in the morning.

Around noon the oxen were given chaff and water there, under the shade of a mango tree.

Jagesar arrived from home with food.

Mohan too came over from his field.

Jagesar said, "Do we now return to the cattle shed and then come back this way?"

Nandu laughed.

"This time the notebook will save me. We will go straight to Mohan's field."

Ratneshwar asked, "Then who pays for the road time from the cattle shed to my field?"

Mohan said, "And there was no road journey at all from the cattle shed to my field."

The three men looked at one another.

Jagesar opened the notebook.

Here the old half-day rule came to a complete halt.

If the whole road journey from the cattle shed to the fields were charged to Mohan, then that day the journey had not even been made for Mohan.

If it were charged entirely to Ratneshwar, then the oxen would not return to the cattle shed until after Mohan's work was over.

Nandu said, "The road is not only the customer's. It is part of the oxen's day as well."

Jagesar looked at him.

"If you had said that three days ago, you would have laughed at yourself."

"Three days ago there was no notebook."

Everyone laughed.

That day Mohan was given a full two hours of ploughing.

When the work ended, he asked, "How much do I pay?"

Jagesar said, "For now, the old rate. We will not set a new one without speaking to everyone."

Mohan said, "I do not want a concession."

"I am not giving you one."

"Then?"

"We are learning the account."

That evening Jagesar and Nandu sat on the low platform outside the cattle shed, the notebook between them.

Nandu wrote down three possibilities.

First—the old half-day.

Second—only the hours of ploughing.

Third—ploughing separately, road separately.

Jagesar asked, "Rest?"

"Why should that fall on the customer?"

"The oxen get tired while ploughing his field."

"But if we do not rest them, the oxen will suffer. That is also part of our cost of keeping animals."

Jagesar smiled.

"Now you are the one changing the rule."

Nandu closed the notebook.

The following Sunday, people gathered beneath the village peepal tree. It was not a formal panchayat. Because the rain had stopped for the previous two days, farmers had come there to talk about their fields.

Jagesar brought the notebook.

He read out the accounts of five days.

Someone immediately said, "If you calculate by the hour, people will quarrel over the clock."

Another said, "If the soil is hard, the plough will move slowly. The customer will say you deliberately stretched the time."

Shivnath said, "My field is close. Why should I pay for the road to a distant field?"

Mohan was there too.

Before he could answer, Jagesar spoke.

"You will not pay for the whole road to a distant field. But some share of the oxen's upkeep is present in every hire. At present that expense is hidden inside the half-day."

An elderly farmer, Phuleshwar, said, "In the old days, when we said half a day, we read the sun, not a morning clock. And all the fields were close. Now new strips to the east and south are being cultivated. The old word has grown longer, but its measure has stayed the same."

Nandu opened the notebook.

"I can see one way."

Everyone looked at him.

"The hire should not be for a 'half-day'. It should be for 'ploughing time'. If someone wants two hours of ploughing, he takes two hours. If he wants three, he takes three."

Shivnath asked, "And the road is free?"

"No. The road is separate. But its rate is lower than the field rate."

"Rest?"

"Rest will be recorded, but its full duration will not be counted as the customer's ploughing time. A small equal share for the upkeep of the oxen will remain in every hired shift."

Phuleshwar asked, "And a distant field?"

Jagesar said, "The first twenty minutes after leaving the cattle shed and the last twenty minutes on the return will count as our own business travel. It will not be charged separately to any customer. Any additional road time beyond that will be added at a lower rate."

Mohan listened carefully.

Nandu added, "If there are two customers in the same direction, the shared stretch of road will not be entered twice. As far as their route is common, that part will be divided between them."

Shivnath laughed.

"Now we will need a calculator."

Nandu said, "No. Fifteen-minute blocks. Four marks in the notebook."

Someone said, "Too much trouble."

Jagesar replied, "The trouble exists in the half-day too. It simply is not written down."

They talked for a long time.

In the end, no permanent rule was made.

They agreed on a one-month trial.

New lines were ruled in the notebook—

Ploughing.

Road.

Rest.

Waiting.

Ploughing time at the full rate.

Separate road time at less than half that rate.

The first and last common approach time to belong to the owners.

Compulsory rest not to count as the customer's ploughing time.

If waiting was caused by the customer, it would be entered separately; if it was caused by the oxen or the plough, it would belong to the owners.

Nandu said, "People will run away the moment they see all these lines."

Jagesar said, "We will see after a month."

The first week was difficult.

Someone would forget to note the time.

Someone would insist that the oxen had entered the field five minutes earlier.

Someone would call a ten-minute rest eight minutes.

Jagesar found a new method.

On reaching the field, when the first furrow began, the customer himself made—not a thumb impression, merely a small slanting mark—in the notebook. At the end of the work he made a second mark. Nandu wrote the time.

"I will write it; you can see it," Nandu would say.

Mohan's next shift was again in the eastern field.

This time the departure from the cattle shed was recorded.

Twenty minutes—the owners' common initial road time.

The next thirty-five minutes—separate road time.

On reaching the field, the oxen spent ten minutes catching their breath—rest.

Then a full two hours of ploughing.

Twelve minutes for water in between—rest.

On the return journey, the road as far as the grove was Mohan's separate road time; after that came the common initial stretch.

The account was made up in the evening.

Compared with the old half-day rate, Mohan's payment came out neither much lower nor much higher—because he had received the full two hours of ploughing and there was additional road time as well.

Hearing the amount, Mohan smiled.

"It costs about what it used to?"

Nandu said, "About the same."

"Then what is the difference?"

Nandu turned the notebook towards him.

"Today you know what the money is for. And the full two hours of ploughing are there."

Mohan looked at the notebook.

"That is not a small difference."

In the second week, Shivnath's nearby field had its turn.

He paid less than under the old half-day system, because his road time fell within the ordinary allowance and he had taken only two hours of ploughing.

He said at once, "I have gained by this."

Nandu said, "If you had taken three hours of ploughing, you would have paid more."

Shivnath laughed.

"I took only as much as I needed. Earlier there was no option except to take half a day."

In the third week the problem was reversed.

One farmer booked three hours of ploughing, but on reaching the field they discovered that half of it was still too wet. The work had to stop after an hour.

He said, "I booked three hours. Do I have to pay the full amount?"

Jagesar said, "One hour of ploughing. But the time left idle because of the condition of your field comes under the waiting or cancellation rule."

There was an argument.

At last a new note was added to the notebook: if the condition of the field had not been disclosed beforehand and the oxen had already arrived, the minimum charge would be one hour.

That evening Nandu said, "The rules are not shrinking. They keep growing."

Jagesar replied, "Life is larger than half a day."

The month came to an end.

People gathered beneath the peepal tree again.

On the last page of the notebook, Jagesar had added up the totals.

The oxen had gone out on almost as many days as before.

Farmers with distant fields had received more actual ploughing time.

Among those with nearby fields, some had saved money by taking less time; others had paid more because they took more ploughing.

There was very little change in the two brothers' total income.

But one difference was clear.

The oxen's rest was now less often a cause of quarrel as "time eaten out of the customer's share."

The time spent on the road was no longer hidden.

Looking over the page, Phuleshwar said, "The old half-day was not bad. It was right for the old village."

Mohan said, "The roads of the new village have grown longer."

Shivnath added, "And some fields are near, some far."

Nandu closed the notebook.

"Then shall we keep the rule we tried for a month?"

No one supported it loudly. No one opposed it either.

Many village rules endure in just this way—not because a meeting applauds them, but because, the next time the need arises, people use the same method again.

By the time the rains were passing, half the notebook had filled up.

One morning Mohan came again.

“The last southern patch has to be ploughed. Two hours.”

Nandu opened the notebook.

“The same road?”

“They have filled in new earth near the stream. It will take a little less time.”

As Jagesar laid the yoke across Moti’s back, he said, “On the way back you will pass Ratneshwar’s field. Enter the common road time accordingly.”

Mohan nodded naturally.

Nandu wrote the name on the page.

Mohan.

Ploughing—two hours.

Road—to be entered once they were under way.

Rest—as much as the oxen needed.

He did not close the notebook. He left the page open, because the first time still had to be entered.

As they moved out from the cattle shed, Moti went slightly ahead and Karia slightly behind, skewing the pair. Nandu straightened the yoke.

Mohan took the spade onto his shoulder.

Jagesar stood at the doorway.

Nandu asked, “What time is it?”

Jagesar looked at the clock hanging inside the house.

“Five fifty-eight.”

Nandu wrote the time in the notebook.

Then he lifted the plough.

This time, a half-day had not begun.

Only the road had begun.

STORY 103

HALF A BAMBOO

It was the first week of Sawan. Clouds wandered across the sky all day, yet the rain came only twice, for five minutes each time. The earth was wet on the surface and still warm underneath.

Near the market at Majhaul village, Ramcharit's pile of bamboo lay slantwise along the roadside: fifteen long poles, five somewhat shorter ones, and two that tapered so much toward the top that they were almost like staffs.

Ramcharit always kept the thick ends of the bamboos pointing the same way. He would say, "Look at the thick end first. It tells you the age of the bamboo."

That morning Binti Devi arrived carrying a length of old rope in her hand. Three knots had been tied in it.

Ramcharit asked, "What measure is this?"

Binti uncoiled the rope. "The crossbeam of the thatch has broken. The carpenter said I need eight hands and a little more. I measured it at home and tied the knots."

Ramcharit stretched the rope out. "What does 'eight hands and a little more' mean?"

"That is what the third knot is for. The old crossbeam reached up to here."

Ramcharit looked toward the bamboo pile. "Take a whole bamboo."

Binti laughed. "What would I do with a whole bamboo?"

"Cut it."

"And the part left over?"

Ramcharit said easily, "Keep it at home. Bamboo is never wasted."

The smile faded from Binti's face. "It may not be wasted, but I would have to pay for the whole thing today."

Ramcharit fell silent.

A whole bamboo cost one hundred and sixty rupees. Cutting was another ten rupees. Binti had expected to pay somewhere between eighty-five and a hundred rupees for a piece eight or ten hands long.

There was no custom in the market of selling bamboo by halves. Ramcharit explained the reason: the thick end was strong, the slender end light; the joints in the middle might be straight or crooked. Two equal lengths cut from the same bamboo were not necessarily equal in usefulness.

Binti said again, "Give me half for half the price."

Ramcharit shook his head. "It is easy to say 'half.' Which half?"

"The half that is useful to me."

"And will the remaining half be useful to me?"

Binti wound up the rope. "Is that all there is to it?"

Before Ramcharit could answer, the bell of a bicycle sounded from the direction of the market.

Kamli Devi came pushing a bicycle. It was not hers but her son's. A small old wooden doorframe was tied to the rear carrier. She untied it and set it down in front of Ramcharit.

"Look at this. The beam above the cattle-shed door has rotted. I need seven hands of bamboo—not very thick."

Ramcharit looked at Binti. Binti looked at Kamli.

Kamli asked, "What happened?"

Binti said, "I need a little more than eight hands, and he sells only a whole bamboo."

Kamli replied at once, "Then let the two of us divide one bamboo."

Ramcharit laughed. "So now both of you will teach me how to account for my bamboo?"

Kamli ran a hand over the wood of the doorframe. "Not teach you. Save ourselves some money."

Ramcharit pulled out a bamboo about sixteen hands long.

"Very well. Look at this. I cut eight hands from the thick end for your thatch. The remaining slender part—about eight hands—goes to Kamli Devi. Equal halves. Eighty rupees each. Five each for cutting."

Binti's eyes brightened.

Kamli lifted the slender end of the bamboo and examined it. "Will this hold the beam of my cattle shed?"

Ramcharit said, "It is bamboo."

Kamli lifted it again. The slender section was slightly flattened in the middle, and two joints lay very close together.

"These two joints will fall exactly where I have to tie the rope."

Binti said, "My part is thick."

Kamli looked at her. "Yours is thick, so eighty? Mine is thin, and still eighty?"

Ramcharit's face hardened a little. "That is why I do not sell halves."

All three fell silent.

Just then Harinath the carpenter came from the market side, a saw on his shoulder, a hammer at his waist, and a thin strip of bamboo in one hand.

Binti called from a distance, "Harinath bhaiya, come here."

Harinath came over. "What has broken?"

"Not the roof—the arithmetic," Ramcharit said.

Harinath laughed. "If the arithmetic is broken, what am I supposed to hammer back into place?"

Binti opened her rope and showed him the measurement. Kamli showed him the doorframe. Ramcharit explained the difficulty with half-price bamboo.

Harinath said nothing at first. He laid the sixteen-hand bamboo straight on the ground, planted a foot on the thick end, and raised the slender end.

"This would do for the roof crossbeam, but the first hand and a half at the thick end is too thick. The notch for the old crossbeam is not that wide."

Binti asked, "Then?"

"We shave the first half-hand thinner, or choose another bamboo."

Harinath walked toward the slender end. "Kamli didi can get her seven hands from this bamboo, but where it would be tied to the frame there is a hairline split. It is small now; once the bamboo dries, it may widen."

Ramcharit said, "So this bamboo is bad for both of them?"

"Not bad. Different parts of the same bamboo are good for different jobs."

Harinath pulled another bamboo from the pile. It was a hand and a half longer than the first. Its thick end was somewhat less bulky, the middle was straight, and the slender end was not excessively light.

He measured Binti's rope from the thick end. "Eight hands and three fingers—up to here."

He asked for charcoal. Ramcharit brought a small piece from inside the shop. Harinath drew a line across the bamboo.

Then he laid Kamli's doorframe on the ground and measured seven hands. "This much from the slender end." He drew a second line.

Between the two lines, about two hands and three fingers of bamboo remained.

Ramcharit said, "Now who owns this middle piece?"

Kamli said, "You do."

Ramcharit laughed. "The two of you take the useful parts, I keep the little piece in the middle, and you still pay half and half? Is that how my business is supposed to run?"

Binti said, "Then why should the two of us pay for the middle piece?"

Harinath rolled the charcoal between his fingers. "First tell us this—how do you arrive at one hundred and sixty rupees for a whole bamboo?"

Ramcharit said, "Length, thickness, straightness. The market rate."

"Then why should this two-hand middle section be worth nothing?"

"It is not worth nothing. But when will I find a buyer for it?"

"A peg in a cattle shed, a prop under a thatch, a small gate, a rack above a hearth—there are plenty of uses."

Ramcharit shook his head. "There may be uses, but there is no buyer for it now."

The discussion stopped at that one sentence.

Binti's need was now. Kamli's need was now as well. The buyer for Ramcharit's leftover piece did not exist now.

None of the three truly wanted 'half a bamboo'; each simply did not want to push his or her own risk onto someone else.

Harinath drew three lines on the ground. Beside the first he wrote: thick section. Beside the second: middle section. Beside the third: slender section.

Ramcharit laughed. "Are we opening a school for bamboo now?"

Harinath said, "No. We are only looking at where the money goes."

He asked Ramcharit, "This whole bamboo is one hundred and sixty. You value the thick section highest?"

"Yes."

"The middle?"

"Medium."

"The slender end?"

“Less.”

“Then why should equal lengths carry equal prices?”

Ramcharit did not answer.

He pulled three old offcuts from the pile: a thick piece two hands long, a medium piece three hands long, and a slender piece five hands long.

“These are from last month. Look. The thick piece would have sold in two days, but a joint has split. No one has asked for the medium piece. The slender one will sell when the children come looking for a bamboo pole for their kite string.”

Kamli asked, “So you keep no register of the pieces you cut?”

“A register?”

“How long, how thick, how much money?”

Ramcharit laughed. “I sell bamboo. I do not run an accounts office.”

Binti said quietly, “But if I go home empty-handed because I cannot buy a whole bamboo, then your bamboo does not sell either.”

Ramcharit was silent at that.

The market was slowly filling. Vegetable sellers were spreading their cloths, the oilman was unloading tins of mustard oil, and the tea seller had set down his first kettle, smoke curling upward.

Ramcharit sat on the bamboo pile.

“I did not buy the bamboo for one hundred and sixty,” he said. “My own money is in it, transport, the cutter’s wage, the place where it is dried—all of that is included. If I charge only for the useful pieces, the leftover may lie here for a month. Who pays for that?”

Kamli said, “Whoever wants the leftover piece.”

“And if nobody wants it?”

Harinath said, “Then the leftover remains Ramcharit’s stock. But do not value it by simply deducting something afterward. Decide its value first.”

Ramcharit frowned. “How much?”

Harinath picked up the old thick two-hand offcut. “If you sold this, what would you charge?”

Ramcharit looked at it. “Twenty.”

“The medium three-hand piece?”

“Twenty-five.”

“The slender five-hand piece?”

“Thirty, if it is straight.”

Harinath wrote the figures beside the lines on the ground.

“Then from the bamboo we cut for Binti didi and Kamli didi, the middle piece—two hands and three fingers—will remain yours. Tell us what you would value it at, right now, as your own stock.”

Ramcharit tapped the middle of the bamboo. “Twenty.”

Binti said at once, “Then subtract twenty from one hundred and sixty. That leaves one hundred and forty.”

Kamli said, “But mine is the slender section and Binti didi’s is the thick one.”

Harinath said, “Exactly. Length alone cannot decide the price.”

Ramcharit began doing the arithmetic with his finger on the ground. "The thick section, eight hands and three fingers—eighty?"

Binti asked, "Why eighty? Because that is half the price of the whole bamboo?"

Ramcharit did not get annoyed. This time he thought about it.

"The thick section is worth more. Eighty-five."

Kamli said, "And my seven hands?"

"Fifty-five."

"Fifty-five and eighty-five make one hundred and forty," Harinath said. "Ramcharit keeps the middle twenty as his own stock. Cutting: five rupees each for the two pieces."

Binti was quiet for a moment at the figure of eighty-five. "I had expected to spend up to a hundred. All right."

Kamli said, "If I had had to buy a whole bamboo, it would have cost me one hundred and seventy. My work will be done for sixty."

Ramcharit said, "For today, perhaps. But if this becomes the rule, everyone will ask for the thick section. Who will take the slender one?"

Harinath said, "Whoever has a job suited to the slender section. If no such need exists, do not cut the bamboo."

Ramcharit looked at him. "So the customer gives me a measurement and I hunt for a bamboo to fit it?"

"Until now you have been pressing a whole bamboo on the customer. Now match the customer's measurement to the bamboo."

Ramcharit laughed. "You have put the carpenter's work on my head."

Binti said, "We will bring the measurements. You only have to look before you cut."

Kamli lifted the doorframe. "And look at where the joints will fall."

Ramcharit laid the bamboo straight on the ground again.

Harinath placed Binti's rope along it. "If we cut here, the thick piece is eight hands and three fingers. But when it is set into the thatch, one joint must remain outside. The cut should be two fingers behind this line."

Binti's required length grew a little.

Ramcharit said, "Then the slender piece will shrink."

Kamli immediately laid the doorframe down again. Harinath measured it.

"Seven hands still comes out. The middle piece left over will be a little less than two hands."

Ramcharit said, "Then the middle cannot be valued at twenty."

"How much?"

"Fifteen."

The arithmetic changed again.

Binti's portion: eighty-seven. Kamli's: fifty-eight. The middle: fifteen. Total: one hundred and sixty. Cutting: ten rupees extra.

Binti burst out laughing. "I came looking for half a bamboo, and the arithmetic has turned out harder than buying a whole one."

Ramcharit said, "That is why I used to sell the whole thing."

Harinath took out his saw.

"Wait," Ramcharit said.

Everyone looked at him.

Ramcharit went inside the shop and tore two pages from an old school notebook.

"Let us write it down first. Later someone will say the thick part was not this long, or the slender part was crooked."

Harinath laughed. "You do not run an accounts office?"

Ramcharit smiled. "Not an office. My memory is small."

On the page he wrote:

Bamboo No. 7.

Full price—160.

Binti—thick section, 8 hands 5 fingers, 87.

Kamli—slender section, 7 hands, 58.

Leftover—1 hand 11 fingers, Ramcharit, 15.

Cutting—5 + 5.

Harinath said, "Write about the joints too."

Ramcharit glared at him. "How many joints?"

"Not that. Write: 'Customer saw the cutting line.'"

Ramcharit wrote it.

Binti did not put a thumbprint. She could write her name. Slowly, she wrote "Binti." Kamli signed her name as well.

Harinath darkened both cutting lines with charcoal once more.

The saw began to move.

At the first cut, the scent of bamboo rose out—a moist green smell still sealed beneath the dry outer skin.

The thick section came free.

Binti tried to lift it. "It is heavy."

Harinath said, "Heavy is good for the thatch. But one thing: when you get home, dry both ends in the shade, not in direct sun."

The second cut was made.

Kamli lifted her section. "This is right."

The small middle piece lay beside Ramcharit's foot.

He was about to toss it into a corner of the pile, then stopped. He looked at the notebook page, picked up the piece, and placed it apart from the rest of the bamboo. With charcoal he wrote on it: 15.

Binti asked, "You are writing a price even on such a little piece?"

Ramcharit said, "It is now fifteen rupees' worth of stock, not something to throw away."

Three days later the rain truly came down hard.

Harinath removed the old crossbeam from Binti's thatch. Half of it had been eaten hollow from within. The new bamboo was set in place.

Binti's son climbed up and held the rope.

From below Harinath said, "We needed two fingers more than the measurement you had tied into the rope. Good thing we shifted the cut."

Binti stood below, smiling. "And for those two fingers I should have bought a whole bamboo?"

Harinath did not answer.

That evening the slender bamboo was tied above the doorway of Kamli's cattle shed. A thick bamboo would, in fact, have been too heavy there.

As Kamli tightened the rope she said, "Not half for half the price. The part that suits my work."

Her daughter-in-law asked, "Who took the rest?"

Kamli said, "Whoever had a use for it."

On the fifth day, for the first time, someone came to Ramcharit's shop asking for the small middle piece.

Nandu the bullock-cart driver needed a short, sturdy pole at the back of his cart to stop sacks from sliding off.

Ramcharit brought out the piece. "One hand and eleven fingers. Fifteen rupees."

Nandu said, "Ten."

Ramcharit looked at the notebook page. "Give twelve and take it."

Nandu paid twelve.

Ramcharit's account was now three rupees short. Beside the fifteen on the page he wrote in small letters: "Sold 12."

That evening he looked over the full account once more.

From a bamboo priced at 160: $87 + 58 + 12 = 157$.

Three rupees short. The ten rupees for cutting had been received separately.

Ramcharit wondered: a three-rupee loss, or two new customers? He did not reach a conclusion.

At the next market an old farmer came asking for five hands of slender bamboo.

Ramcharit was about to say what he always used to say: "Take a whole one." The sentence reached his lips but did not come out.

On an old piece of sacking hanging behind the pile, he wrote four lines in charcoal:

Thick piece—how many hands?

Medium—how many hands?

Slender—how many hands?

Leftover piece—how much?

The farmer could not read.

He asked, "What is that?"

Ramcharit said, "Tell me your measurement first."

The farmer stretched out his hand. "Five of these."

Ramcharit picked up the rope. "Everyone's hand is not the same. Measure it on the rope and give me that."

The farmer laughed. "Now I must sit an examination to buy bamboo?"

Ramcharit laughed too. "No. An examination in how not to pay for a whole bamboo."

Two market days later, more lines had appeared on the sacking.

Someone wanted four hands of thick bamboo. Someone wanted six hands of slender bamboo. Someone wanted only a strong two-hand piece.

Ramcharit could not meet every need.

Sometimes he would say, “There is no match for it yet. If I cut a whole bamboo, there will be no one for the part left over.”

Earlier such an answer would have annoyed customers. Now some of them left their measurements behind.

Ramcharit made small loops of rope and hung them on the sacking. Beside each loop he wrote a name and a measurement:

“Sita—6 hands, slender.”

“Mahendra—4 hands, thick.”

“Suresh—2 hands, medium.”

Whenever three sections of one bamboo happened to match three separate needs, Ramcharit first sent word to all three customers.

Sometimes it took two weeks. Sometimes it happened the same day.

One day Binti came to the market and saw the sacking. Her old sheet of paper was pinned under a nail.

She asked, “Why is my name still here?”

Ramcharit said, “It was the first account.”

“The one with the three-rupee loss?”

“Yes.”

“Then take it down. It was a bad beginning.”

Ramcharit shook his head. “Not bad. It was an account that taught me something for three rupees.”

Binti read the names written across the sacking. Nowhere did the words “half a bamboo” appear.

She said, “It ought to be called ‘Half a Bamboo.’”

Ramcharit asked, “Why?”

“People will understand.”

Ramcharit picked up the charcoal. At the top of the sacking he wrote: “Half a Bamboo?”

Then, beneath the question mark in smaller letters, he wrote: “Measure First.”

Binti laughed.

That evening the rain began again.

The market packed up earlier than usual. Ramcharit was covering the bamboo pile with the sacking when a boy came running toward him.

“Uncle, do you have three hands of thick bamboo?”

Without uncovering the pile Ramcharit asked, “What is it for?”

“To lay across the drain behind the house.”

“Exactly three hands?”

“About that.”

Ramcharit pulled the measuring rope from beneath the sacking.

“Not ‘about.’ Take this. Measure it and come tomorrow.”

The boy ran off with the rope.

Ramcharit tied the sacking down again.

At the top, the charcoal words “Half a Bamboo?” had blurred a little in the spray of rain.

Beneath them, “Measure First” was still clear.

STORY 104

THE COWSHED'S FIRST MILK

Kartik was drawing to its close. In the mornings drops of dew fell from the cowshed roof, though once the day advanced the sun was still warm.

For two months Sudama Chaudhary's cow, Surti, had stood tethered in Gauri Devi's cowshed, her belly swollen with pregnancy.

Surti was not white. There was a grey patch near her neck, a small white mark on her forehead, and the edge of her right ear was slightly torn.

Gauri could recognise her by her voice.

When Gauri opened the cowshed gate at dawn, Surti would look first not at the manger but at her hand.

For there was usually a handful of bran in Gauri's palm.

Surti was not a cow from Gauri's own household.

Two years earlier, after Sudama Chaudhary's knee had grown bad, he had reduced the work of keeping cattle.

His son was away in another place, and his daughter-in-law was managing the house with two small children.

Sudama's cowshed was not empty, but cutting grass every day, clearing dung, washing the manger, and milking had become difficult for him.

So, not in a formal village council but simply before four people, an oral arrangement had been made.

The cow would stay in Gauri's cowshed.

Grass, chaff, water, and the daily care would be the responsibility of Gauri's household.

Half the milk would belong to Sudama, half to Gauri.

The cow would remain Sudama's.

If a calf was born, male or female, it too would belong to Sudama.

That was all that had been settled.

The first year everything went smoothly.

Surti gave about five and a half to six seers of milk a day.

In the morning Gauri measured the milk and divided it equally between two brass lotas.

Sudama's grandson came and carried one lota away.

From her own share Gauri kept half for the household and sold half at the market.

The evening followed more or less the same pattern.

If there was half a seer more or less on some day, neither household treated it as illness or theft.

A cow is not a machine—on that point both sides agreed.

But when Surti became pregnant again, her milk slowly diminished.

At last it stopped altogether.

During the first week Gauri thought little of it.

No milk, no division.

But the manger still had to be filled.

Evening chaff was still needed.

Oilcake was still needed.

Water was still needed twice a day.

And because of her swollen belly, Surti could no longer be taken far out to graze.

One day Gauri's husband, Makhan, added up the expenses and said, "The milk has stopped. The expense has not."

Gauri said, "She is a cow. She will calve. Then there will be milk again."

Makhan said, "I am not saying we should stop the expense. I am only trying to understand the account."

On an old sack he wrote in charcoal: twenty-seven days.

By then Surti had been dry for twenty-seven days.

Gauri folded the sack over.

"What will come of writing this?"

"Nothing yet. But we will not forget."

Sudama Chaudhary had asked nothing about those twenty-seven days.

Now and then he came to see the cow, stroked her forehead, looked at her belly and said, "It will not be many more days now."

Once he brought five kilos of oilcake.

Gauri accepted it.

That day, beside the twenty-seven on the sack, Makhan wrote: oilcake, five kilos, owner.

Gauri looked at him again.

"That register of yours will start a quarrel one day."

Makhan said, "A register does not start quarrels. Forgetting does."

On the first Monday of Aghan, Surti became restless during the night.

Again and again she rose and sat down.

She lifted her tail, then looked toward the manger.

Gauri understood that the time was near.

She woke Makhan.

"Fill the lantern."

Half asleep, Makhan asked, "Now?"

"Yes. Surti's gait has changed."

Their daughter Rekha woke as well.

She was in Class Seven, but what she knew about cows and calves she had learned not from books but by staying beside Gauri.

Gauri told her to remain inside the house.

Five minutes later Rekha came into the cowshed wrapped in a shawl.

"You are here alone."

Gauri did not send her back.

At about half past one in the night, the calf was born.

Small, wet, trembling.

Surti turned at once and began licking it.

Gauri spread out a dry sack.

Rekha brought straw.

Makhan ran to Sudama's house with the news.

Sudama did not come himself this time.

The pain in his knee had worsened.

His daughter-in-law Nirmala came with Deepak, a boy from the neighbourhood.

As soon as Nirmala entered the cowshed and saw the calf, she smiled.

"A bull calf?"

Gauri said, "Yes, a bull calf."

Nirmala touched Surti's forehead.

"Babuji will be pleased."

The calf tried twice to stand, then fell back onto the straw.

Gauri straightened its forelegs.

"It must drink the colostrum first."

Nirmala asked, "Has the milk come down already?"

"It is coming."

By dawn the calf had managed to stand.

Gauri guided its mouth to the udder.

The first time it only sniffed.

The second time it pulled its mouth away.

The third time Gauri held its lips against the teat.

The calf began to suck.

Rekha watched in silence.

Nirmala asked, "How long will it drink?"

Gauri replied, "As much as it needs now."

Nirmala said nothing.

After sunrise, Dinesh, Sudama's son-in-law, arrived on a motorcycle.

He collected milk from the village and carried it to the market.

He had heard that Surti had calved.

Stopping the motorcycle outside the cowshed, Dinesh said, "If there is first milk today, it will fetch a good price at the market."

Gauri was inside the cowshed.

Nirmala stepped outside and asked, "How much?"

"More than ordinary milk. People who make pithar have been asking for colostrum."

Gauri heard him.

She kept looking at Surti's udder.

Dinesh said again, "Whatever price we get today, tomorrow it will be back to the ordinary rate."

Nirmala looked toward Gauri.

"Sister, milk out a little. The calf has already drunk."

Gauri felt the udder with her hand.

"It has drunk, but I do not know whether it has drunk its fill."

Dinesh said, "Half the milk belongs to the owner, doesn't it?"

The sentence was short.

But inside the cowshed its sound became long.

Gauri rose to her feet.

"Half the milk belongs to the owner. That is true."

Dinesh said, "Then the owner's half should be given."

Gauri looked at the calf.

"From what point does the division begin?"

Nirmala asked, "What do you mean?"

"Before the calf drinks, or after?"

No one answered at once.

Dinesh glanced at his watch.

"The market will be over."

In a calm voice Gauri said, "The market will be held again. The calf's first morning will not."

Dinesh grew slightly uncomfortable.

"I am not saying the calf should be denied its milk."

"Nor am I saying the owner should be denied his milk. I am asking—whose share comes first?"

Nirmala said, "The calf belongs to the owner too."

Gauri looked at her.

"Then will whatever the calf drinks be deducted from the owner's half?"

Nirmala fell silent.

Dinesh said, "If we begin accounting like this, there will be no end to it."

Rekha stopped in the middle of gathering the straw.

Makhan had come to stand at the cowshed door.

He had barely slept since the night before.

He said, "The account was not made this way during the dry days either."

Dinesh asked, "What dry days?"

Makhan pulled out the sack kept behind a post of the cowshed.

The charcoal figures had faded.

After twenty-seven, many small strokes had been added.

The final number was forty-six.

"Forty-six days without milk. The fodder continued."

Nirmala looked at the sack.

"Why did you not tell us?"

Gauri said at once, "At the time it did not seem necessary to say anything."

Makhan said, "Now it does."

Dinesh turned the motorcycle key, then switched it off again.

"So now you will deduct the fodder for the first forty-six days before dividing the milk?"

Makhan said, "I did not say that."

"Then?"

"At the moment I do not understand it either."

That answer loosened the quarrel a little.

No one had come with his or her position fully prepared.

Gauri guided the calf to the udder again.

Dinesh stood there for another five minutes.

At last he said, "I will not take any today. But speak to Babuji."

Then he left.

Nirmala remained a little longer.

As she was leaving, she said to Gauri, "Sister, please do not let Babuji think we came to snatch away the milk."

Gauri said, "I do not want him to think that either."

At noon Sudama came himself, leaning on his walking stick.

Makhan placed a low stool outside the cowshed for him.

Sudama looked at the calf.

"Is it well?"

Gauri said, "For now. It is drinking."

Sudama stretched out his hand and touched the calf's back.

"My father used to say the first milk is the calf's share."

Gauri said nothing.

Sudama himself continued.

"But we had an agreement too—half the milk."

"Yes."

"Dinesh says no milk was given today."

"Yes."

"Why?"

Gauri answered directly.

"I could not understand whether the calf's share should be taken before the milk was halved or after."

Sudama placed both hands on the knob of his walking stick.

"The calf is mine."

"Yes."

"Then its share is mine."

Gauri was silent for a moment.

"Then whatever the calf drinks will be deducted from your half?"

Sudama raised his eyes and looked at her.

Dinesh had tried to answer that question.

Sudama did not.

Makhan set the sack before him.

"And these forty-six days?"

Sudama looked at the figures on the sack.

"What is this?"

"The dry days."

"A cow goes dry. Is that something new?"

"No."

"Then?"

Makhan said slowly, "The milk is half and half. Whose are all the dry days?"

Sudama folded the sack over.

"You should have said this earlier."

Gauri said, "Earlier I did not understand it either."

Sudama said, "And now that the milk is coming, you understand?"

His voice was not harsh, only tired.

Gauri replied, "Now the division is beginning, so what was left outside it earlier has become visible."

Sudama watched the calf for a while.

Then he said, "I do not want any milk today. We will see tomorrow."

He rose.

As he left, the tip of his stick struck the sack.

Two charcoal strokes were rubbed away.

The next morning the calf drank first.

After that Gauri milked a little.

Less than two seers.

She did not measure and divide it.

She kept one lota at home and left the rest in Surti's udder.

Rekha asked, "None for the owner today either?"

Gauri said, "The division has not begun today either."

"When will it?"

"When the rule is clear."

"The cow does not understand rules."

Gauri laughed.

"That is why people must."

Two days later Surti's appetite declined a little.

She sniffed the oilcake and left it.

Gauri grew worried.

Ramesh, the village livestock worker, was called.

After examining her, Ramesh prescribed some medicine.

"She is weak after calving. Watch her water, rest, and feed. If the fever rises, let me know."

The medicine cost three hundred and sixty rupees.

Gauri paid at the shop.

Makhan pinned the prescription to a post in the cowshed.

Sudama came that evening.

He saw the prescription.

"Why did you not tell me?"

Gauri said, "The medicine was needed during the day. No one was at your house."

"I will pay."

Makhan asked, "All of it?"

Sudama looked at him.

"The cow is mine."

Makhan said, "The milk is half and half."

Sudama remained holding the prescription.

Gauri spoke between them. "This is why we need a rule."

This time Sudama did not object.

"Sit down tomorrow evening."

The following evening four people sat on the veranda of the cowshed.

Sudama, Gauri, Makhan, and Nirmala.

Rekha was studying inside, but her ears were outside.

Sudama spoke first. "I do not want a long document."

Makhan said, "Nor do I."

Gauri said, "Four things should be clear."

Nirmala brought an old exercise book.

Half of the first page was torn away.

She wrote: Surti.

Below it, the date.

Sudama said, "Milk first."

Gauri said, "The calf first."

Both fell silent again.

Nirmala stopped her pen.

Makhan asked, "Shall we call whatever milk comes into our hands after the calf has drunk the milk?"

Sudama said, "Then who will know how much the calf has drunk?"

Gauri said, "No one knows that now either. If we pull its mouth away merely so that the half can be measured, the account will be clean and the calf weak."

Nirmala said quietly, "Let the calf drink first. Whatever is milked afterward will be divided."

Sudama looked at her.

"You belong to the owner's household."

Nirmala said, "That is why I am saying it. The calf belongs to the owner's household too."

Makhan did not laugh.

Nor did Gauri.

Sudama rubbed his thumb over the knob of his stick.

Then he said, "All right. First line—the milk after the calf has drunk."

Nirmala wrote it down.

The second matter was medicine.

Sudama said, "I will pay for medicine in a serious illness."

Gauri asked, "Who will decide what is serious and what is minor?"

Sudama was silent.

Makhan said, "Prescription medicines, half and half? The cow is yours, the milk belongs to both of us."

Sudama nodded.

"Any sudden large expense should be discussed first."

Gauri added, "If medicine is urgently needed and you cannot be found, the prescription will be kept."

Nirmala wrote it down.

The third matter was the dry days.

This took the longest.

Sudama said, "When the cow is dry, where will there be milk to divide?"

Makhan said, "There will be no milk to divide. But that I must provide all the fodder—that was never made clear in the agreement."

Gauri said, "I will provide the ordinary grass and chaff. But if the milk is zero for two months, all the oilcake and purchased fodder fall on me."

Nirmala asked, "Then during the dry period should Babuji provide half the fodder?"

Gauri did not answer at once.

"If that is the agreement, it will work. But I am not asking now for all the money for the previous forty-six days."

Sudama asked, "Then what do you want?"

Gauri looked toward the old figures on the sack.

"Let it be recognised that dry days are days of care too. Next time the cow goes dry, the extra purchased oilcake and fodder will be half and half. Household grass, labour, and water will remain my responsibility."

Sudama said at once, "That is fair."

Makhan asked, "And the previous forty-six?"

Gauri stopped him.

"It was not written down last time. Babuji supplied half the oilcake once. Let the old account close there."

Makhan wanted to say something, but did not.

Sudama looked at Gauri.

"You are letting it go?"

"Not letting it go. I am not pushing an old unclear matter into a new clear one."

Sudama nodded slowly.

The fourth matter was the half share of the milk.

That was the simplest of all.

Whatever was milked after the calf had drunk would be measured and divided in half.

If, for household need, either side took more on some day, it would be written in the register.

The adjustment would be made at the next division.

Nirmala wrote the four lines and turned the page toward Gauri.

Gauri read them.

From inside Rekha called, "Ma, have you written 'dry days'?"

Everyone laughed.

Gauri said, "Do your studying."

From inside Rekha replied, "I can hear everything."

At the bottom of the page all four wrote their names.

Gauri could write.

Makhan signed.

Nirmala wrote her name in clear letters.

With a trembling hand Sudama made a small signature.

No witness was appointed.

No seal was affixed.

The page was hung from a post in the cowshed.

The next morning the new account was used for the first time.

The calf went to Surti.

Gauri did not pull it away.

After a while the calf stepped back on its own.

Gauri milked the cow.

Three seers, twelve chhataks.

Makhan measured it and wrote it down.

Rekha asked, "How much is half?"

Makhan said, "No calculator needed. One and a half seers and six chhataks."

Gauri smiled.

Nirmala carried away one share.

Gauri kept the other.

At noon Sudama came to look at the register.

The first line read: after the calf drank, 3 seers 12 chhataks.

Below it were the two equal shares.

Sudama asked, "How much did the calf drink?"

Gauri said, "We did not measure it."

Sudama looked at the register again.

"Then the account is incomplete."

Gauri said, "The account begins from the point where the division begins."

Sudama was silent for a few moments.

Then he hung the page back up.

For three days everything went well.

On the fourth morning the milk was less.

The calf had already drunk twice during the night.

When Gauri milked Surti, there were only two seers and eight chhataks.

When Nirmala came for the share, she stopped short at the measurement.

"So little?"

Gauri said, "That is all today."

The old question appeared on Nirmala's face—how much had the calf drunk?

But she did not ask it.

She wrote the figure in the register.

The next day the milk increased again.

Looking at the register, Sudama said, "A cow is not a machine."

Gauri smiled.

It was an old sentence, but now it had a different place.

A week later Surti's course of medicine ended.

The two prescriptions together came to four hundred and twenty rupees.

Sudama paid two hundred and ten.

Gauri paid two hundred and ten.

Nirmala wrote in the register: medicine equally shared.

One evening Dinesh came again to collect milk.

"The market rate is good today. Shall I take the owner's whole share?"

Sudama said, "Take only as much as the register says is the owner's."

Dinesh laughed.

"So now the register will run everything?"

Sudama said, “The cow stays in Gauri’s cowshed more days than she stays with me. The register belongs to both sides.”

Dinesh said nothing.

He took away the measured milk.

Two weeks later a new question arose.

Surti’s milk had increased.

Gauri’s share was more than her household needed.

She began selling part of her half at the market.

Sudama’s household sometimes did not use its entire share.

One day Nirmala said, “Sell half a seer from our half as well. I will take the money later.”

Gauri said, “I will write it in the register.”

Nirmala laughed.

“Now even the milk will not move without the register.”

Gauri said, “The milk will move. What comes afterward—the memory—will not.”

Rekha heard the sentence and wrote it into her exercise book.

A few days later the calf had begun running about the cowshed.

It pushed its muzzle into the manger, chewed at the rope, and tugged at Rekha’s shawl.

Surti kept sniffing it.

The morning division had now become regular.

First the calf.

Then the milking.

Then the measuring.

Then the two shares.

Some days the milk was less, some days more.

The figures on the page changed.

The order did not.

On a cold morning in Paush, Sudama arrived very early.

Gauri was still cleaning the cowshed.

The calf was drinking from Surti.

Sudama remained standing at the doorway.

Gauri said, “The stool is inside.”

Sudama said, “I am fine standing.”

He watched the calf.

After a while the calf moved away on its own and began licking the straw.

Gauri sat down with the bucket to milk.

Sudama looked at the register hanging from the post.

The old page was full.

Nirmala had added a new page.

At the top it again said: Surti.

Below it, the first line: milk after the calf has drunk.

Then: medicine.

Then: extra fodder during dry days.

Sudama straightened the edge of the page.

The wind had curled it.

As she milked, Gauri asked, "How much do you need at home today?"

Sudama said, "Whatever my share is."

Then, after a brief pause, he added, "After the calf."

Gauri said nothing.

The milk kept falling into the bucket, drop by drop.

The register hanging from the post stirred in the wind.

The old oral agreement had contained only two words: "half the milk."

The word "half" was still there on the new page.

But now three lines stood above it.

STORY 105

NIGHT ON THE WATCH PLATFORM

By the time Aghan was well underway, the paddy in the eastern tract of Majhaul village had turned yellow.

Four fields lay so close to one another that, seen from a distance, the ridges between them looked like little more than thin lines.

At one corner near the middle stood a bamboo watch platform.

The platform belonged to no single field.

Two bamboos had come from Ramlochan, four old planks from Kishori Mandal, the tiles from Jagdish, and two days of labour from Budhan.

Once it was built, the villagers began calling it the 'four-field platform.'

The last twenty days before the paddy ripened were considered the hardest time for those four fields.

Birds descended by day, stray cattle wandered in at dusk, and at night nilgai or wild boar prowled along the field edges.

The four households had divided the night watches among themselves.

One night was Ramlochan's, the next Kishori's, the third Jagdish's, the fourth Budhan's.

Then the same order began again.

A piece cut from an old fertiliser sack hung from one post of the platform.

Dates and names were written on it in charcoal.

Beside the name of whoever had the watch that night, a circle was drawn.

At dawn, a tick was placed inside the circle.

The arrangement was so simple that for three weeks no one had called it a rule.

It was merely a custom.

Budhan was the only one of the four whose field was not his own.

He cultivated one and a half bighas belonging to Ramdas Chaudhary on a sharecropping arrangement.

On the watch roster, Budhan's name was written instead of the landowner's, because Budhan was the one who spent the night there.

Ramdas Chaudhary lived in town with his son.

He invariably came at harvest time for his half of the paddy, but the night watch on the platform was not part of his share.

Budhan had never questioned this.

The land was not his, but his labour was in the crop.

If the crop survived, half of it would reach his household too.

That was why the watch was his as well.

Budhan's house stood about half a kos behind the fields.

He lived there with his wife, Phulo, their twelve-year-old daughter Chandni, and his elderly mother, Sukni Devi.

Sukni Devi's knees had troubled her for years, but she was not a woman who would stop working and sit idle.

On days when paddy was dried, she could still turn the grain in a basket.
But for the past month, her breathing had grown a little heavy after dusk.
Twice Budhan had brought tablets from the village medicine shop.
Sukni would say, 'It is old age. How many medicines can I go on taking?'

Phulo would answer, 'Old age is one thing, breathlessness another.'

That Wednesday was Budhan's turn on watch.

He had remembered it since morning.

In the afternoon he went to the platform and inspected the southern corner of the thorn fence.

Three days earlier, a dry karil branch had fallen in the wind.

Budhan raised two branches and propped them upright again, but the soil underneath was loose.

He told Ramlochan, 'This corner ought to be tied up today.'

Ramlochan, rubbing a paddy ear between his fingers, said, 'We'll see to it by evening.'

Kishori was there too.

He said, 'First open the northern drain, otherwise the water will stand.'

The small jobs of the four fields kept pushing one another to the back of the queue all day long.

Budhan drove two stakes into the ridge of his field and returned home.

He intended to eat early and go to the platform.

After sunset, Phulo was taking the rice off the hearth.

Chandni brought water.

Sukni Devi sat by the courtyard wall, rubbing mustard oil into her knees.

Suddenly she began to cough.

Twice at first.

Then without stopping.

Phulo held out a lota of water.

Sukni tried to drink, but after half a sip she set the lota down.

Her breaths had become short and shallow.

Budhan left the morsel in his hand on his plate and sprang up.

'Ma?'

Sukni raised a hand as if to say it was nothing.

But her chest was rising and falling rapidly.

Phulo stopped what she was doing and rubbed her back.

'Not the medicine shop this time,' she said. 'Take her to the health centre.'

The primary health centre was three kos from the village.

Transport was hard to find after dusk.

Budhan ran to borrow a neighbour's bicycle.

Only then did he remember his turn on the platform.

He went towards Ramlochan's house.

Ramlochan was not there.

His daughter-in-law said, 'Kaka has gone to the market. He hasn't returned yet.'

Budhan said, 'When he comes, tell him that tonight is my watch, but I am taking my mother to the health centre.'

‘All right.’

Budhan then turned towards Kishori’s house.

Kishori’s door was closed.

His younger brother opened it.

‘Kishori bhaiya?’

‘He has gone to our maternal uncle’s house. He’ll be back by nine.’

Budhan said, ‘As soon as he comes, tell him someone must reach the platform. My mother is ill.’

The boy nodded.

Budhan thought of going to Jagdish’s house as well, but from home came Phulo’s voice.

‘Don’t waste time!’

He ran back.

It was not easy to seat Sukni Devi on a bicycle.

In the end Ramsevak lent them his old handcart.

They spread a sack over it and seated Sukni there.

Budhan and Phulo pulled the cart together as far as the main road.

Chandni stayed with a neighbour.

After half an hour on the road they found an empty milk van.

The driver took Sukni to the health centre.

Budhan’s mobile phone had very little charge left.

He dialled Ramlochan’s number.

It rang once, then the phone died.

Budhan put it back in his pocket.

The health centre was not crowded, but the doctor was seeing another patient.

It took time before Sukni was taken inside.

It was eight o’clock at night.

The watch platform kept entering and leaving Budhan’s thoughts.

He said to Phulo, ‘Should I go back?’

Phulo looked at him as though the answer to the question had already been obvious.

‘Leaving Ma here?’

Budhan fell silent.

The doctor said phlegm had accumulated in her chest; they would give her medicine and steam, and watch her breathing through the night.

There was no great danger at present, but sending her straight home would not be wise.

Budhan sat down in the veranda.

There, the first watch of his night passed.

Meanwhile, the fertiliser sack on the platform flapped in the wind.

The circle beside Budhan’s name was empty.

Ramlochan returned from the market at about half past eight.

When he reached home, his daughter-in-law gave him Budhan’s message.

Ramlochan was tired.

As he untied his gamchha, he asked, ‘Does Kishori know?’

'Budhan said he had told them there too.'
Ramlochan assumed Kishori must already have gone.
Kishori returned from his maternal uncle's house a little after nine.
His younger brother was asleep by then.
Budhan's message never reached him.
Jagdish was stitching up sacks of paddy in his courtyard.
His watch was the following night.
A little after ten, he put the sack aside and washed his hands.
From the direction of the distant fields came the sound of a metal plate
being struck once.
Then silence.
Jagdish paused.
Whoever stayed on the four-field platform would strike the plate now and
then to make his presence known.
Tonight it had sounded only once.
He thought Budhan must have arrived.
A little later his dog began barking towards the fields.
Jagdish stepped out to the doorway and stared into the darkness.
Nothing could be made out from that distance.
He took a torch and walked towards the fields.
The platform was empty.
The sack hanging from the post moved in the wind.
The metal plate lay on the ground.
Jagdish climbed up and swept his torchlight across all four fields.
At the southern corner, the karil fence looked pressed down.
He climbed down and went there.
There were fresh hoofprints in the soil.
Two nilgai had forced their way in through the gap in the fence.
One still stood near the ridge of Ramlochan's field.
The other was two or three paces inside the paddy field Budhan cultivated.
Jagdish shouted at the top of his voice.
'Hut! Haa!'
He picked up the metal plate and beat it with a stick.
The sound carried as far as Ramlochan's house.
Kishori heard it too.
Within ten minutes all three were in the fields.
The nilgai fled.
Some paddy plants had been flattened.
The gap in the southern fence had opened still wider.
Ramlochan's first question was, 'Where is Budhan?'
Jagdish said, 'The platform is empty.'
Only then did Kishori remember what his younger brother had been
trying to tell him.
He went home and woke the boy.
Rubbing his eyes, the boy said, 'Budhan Kaka said his mother was ill.'
Kishori slapped a hand to his forehead.

'Why didn't you tell me earlier?'

'You weren't at home.'

'And when I came back?'

The boy said nothing.

Ramlochan said, 'Leave the blame there for now. First close the gap.'

Together the three men stood the karil branches up again.

Jagdish brought a slender bamboo from his field.

Kishori brought rope.

By about eleven the fence was closed again.

Ramlochan said, 'Someone will have to stay now.'

Jagdish climbed onto the platform.

'I'll stay. Tomorrow was my turn anyway. Count this as one day early.'

Kishori said, 'Then tomorrow?'

'We'll see tomorrow.'

Ramlochan stayed with him until midnight, then went home.

No animal came again that night.

At dawn, Jagdish did not put a tick inside Budhan's circle on the fertiliser sack.

He drew only a short line beside it.

After sunrise, the four cultivators gathered again.

Kishori began counting the flattened plants.

'Twenty-two here.'

Ramlochan looked at another row.

'Eleven here.'

Jagdish said, 'Some of them will stand up again.'

Ramlochan said, 'The paddy is ripe. What is broken is broken.'

The discussion moved at once from plants to money.

Kishori estimated, 'As much as one paseri lost.'

Jagdish laughed.

'One paseri from twenty-two plants?'

Kishori was not offended.

'I said it was an estimate.'

Ramlochan said, 'And who will compensate on the basis of an estimate?'

Both men looked towards Budhan's field.

Jagdish said, 'First let Budhan come back.'

Budhan returned from the health centre at about nine.

Sukni Devi had been advised two days of medicine and steam inhalation.

Phulo took her home.

Budhan went straight to the field.

Seeing the platform empty, he first read the fertiliser sack.

He saw the line beside his name.

Then he saw the newly tied rope at the southern corner.

Ramlochan said, 'Animals got in last night.'

Budhan's face tightened.

'How many?'

'Two were seen.'

‘The paddy?’

Kishori showed him the flattened rows.

Budhan bent down and began lifting the plants.

Some ears were pressed into the soil; some stalks were merely bent.

He straightened them one by one.

Kishori said, ‘The question for all of us is that the watch was missed.’

Budhan stood up.

‘It was missed - I accept that.’

Ramlochan said, ‘Then there must also be some accounting for the loss.’

Budhan did not answer at once.

He went to the southern fence.

He scraped the soil beneath the newly tied bamboo.

‘This gap was there yesterday afternoon too.’

Ramlochan said, ‘A little. The animals pushed it down at night.’

‘I had said it should be tied.’

‘You did. I went to the market.’

‘Kishori bhaiya was busy with the northern drain.’

Kishori remained silent.

Budhan looked again at the hoofprints.

‘The animals did not come by way of the platform. They came through the gap.’

Ramlochan’s voice hardened.

‘If a watchman had been here, he would have driven them off as soon as they entered.’

‘That is also true.’

Budhan’s reply was brief.

‘Then?’

Budhan said, ‘I did not complete the work of my watch. Whatever work is decided in its place, I will do. But why should the price of twenty-two or thirty-three plants be put on my head by guesswork?’

Kishori said, ‘Because it was your night.’

Budhan looked towards the platform.

‘The night was mine. Whose fence was it?’

No one answered immediately.

The southern fence of the four-field platform actually began along the outer edge of Ramlochan’s field and ran to the corner of the field Budhan cultivated on shares.

When the fence was first made, Ramlochan had supplied the bamboo, Jagdish had cut the karil, and Budhan had done the work of driving it into the ground.

On paper, it belonged to no one.

By custom, it belonged to all.

Jagdish said, ‘The fence belongs to all, the watch belongs to all.’

Kishori said, ‘But the turns belong to one person at a time.’

Budhan nodded.

‘All right. Then let me make good my turn.’

Ramlochan asked, 'How?'

'I will spend the whole day today finishing this southern fence. And on one of the next seven nights, whichever watch is weakest, I will stay from two in the morning until dawn as an extra man.'

Kishori said at once, 'How can a day's fence work equal a night's watch?'

'I am not saying it is equal. I will do both.'

'And the loss?'

Budhan looked at the flattened plants.

'Count the ones that are broken. After harvest, see how many ears actually fail to fill. To call it one paseri now is not an account.'

Ramlochan fell silent.

Whether he fully liked Budhan's answer or not was hard to tell.

But the words 'one paseri' had begun to feel heavy even to him.

Jagdish took the old fertiliser sack down from the platform and spread it on the ground.

'Come, first let us look at the previous watches.'

They all sat around it.

It was hardly worthy of being called a register, but the dates and names were all there.

Jagdish asked, 'Ramlochan Kaka, last Monday night was your watch?'

'Yes.'

'Until what time?'

Ramlochan thought.

'The pump men came at two. I went home, then returned at dawn.'

Kishori laughed.

'Then from two till dawn?'

'No animal came.'

Jagdish said, 'Is that an answer?'

Ramlochan's face changed.

'I am saying there were circumstances.'

Budhan said nothing.

Jagdish looked at the next date.

'Kishori, it rained on your watch.'

'I was on the platform.'

'You went home after midnight.'

'It was raining heavily. Where would animals have come from?'

'Then you too had circumstances.'

Kishori began folding the fertiliser sack.

The matter was no longer about Budhan's night alone.

All four were beginning to see that the old custom recorded only presence with a tick; it had no language for a lapse.

One man stayed the whole night, another half; someone sent a brother in his place; someone arrived late because of work at home.

As long as there had been no damage, no one had asked for an accounting.

The moment damage appeared, the old ticks suddenly became a rigid rule.

Ramlochan said, 'Then make a rule. Otherwise we will quarrel until harvest.'

Kishori drew three lines in the soil with a stick.

First - night watch.

Second - fence/ridge.

Third - emergency.

Jagdish asked, 'What happens in an emergency?'

Budhan said, 'If before evening you know you cannot go, exchange the watch with another household and write it down.'

Ramlochan said, 'And if it is sudden?'

Thinking of his mother, Budhan paused for a moment.

'Then whatever the reason, say so in the morning. That night will be marked vacant. In return for a vacant night: one day's work on the shared ridge or fence, and one extra late watch.'

Kishori asked, 'How late a watch?'

'From two until dawn.'

Jagdish said, 'That is the difficult watch too.'

Ramlochan nodded.

'Fine. But what if someone is only making excuses?'

Budhan said, 'Everyone can hear the reason and decide. On the paper, write only "emergency," not the whole story of the illness.'

Jagdish looked at him.

'Why?'

'Why should the platform register record how many times my mother coughed?'

This time Kishori nodded silently.

Ramlochan ran the stick once more along the third line in the earth.

'And the damage?'

Jagdish said, 'If an animal came through a gap in the fence, inspect the gap first. If the watchman was found asleep, that is different.'

Kishori added, 'If a field was left open, its loss should not fall on everyone.'

Budhan said, 'Write down what can actually be seen. No sacks of guesswork.'

Ramlochan laughed.

'That one paseri has really offended you.'

Budhan laughed too.

'I have nothing against a paseri of paddy. I object to a paseri that was never weighed.'

The tension eased a little.

That day, though he had returned exhausted from the health centre, Budhan worked on the southern fence until afternoon.

Jagdish joined him for an hour.

Two new bamboos were driven into the ground.

The karil branches were tied not only at the top but also at the bottom.

Where the soil was loose, mud was packed onto the ridge.

Kishori came in the evening to inspect it.

He said, 'If this work had been done four days ago, there would have been no meeting today.'

Ramlochan replied, 'There would have been no meeting, and no rule either.'

Kishori smiled.

Jagdish replaced the old fertiliser sack on the platform with a sheet of stout paper.

At the top he wrote: 'Watch Register.'

Below it he drew four columns - date, name, night, shared work.

Kishori said, 'Emergency?'

Jagdish added a fifth column.

'Do we write the reason?'

Budhan said, 'If necessary, only "emergency."'

Ramlochan said, 'Agreed by all?'

All four nodded.

That night was supposed to be Jagdish's first regular turn, but he had already stayed the previous night in Budhan's place.

The first test of the new rule arrived immediately.

Kishori said, 'I will stay tonight. Jagdish can take my next turn.'

Jagdish said, 'All right.'

For the first time, an exchange of watches was written in the register.

No merely spoken assurance.

An arrow between two names.

Three days passed quietly.

Sukni Devi's breathing gradually returned to normal.

She began sitting in the courtyard sunshine again.

When Budhan left for the fields she would ask, 'Did the paddy survive?'

Budhan would say, 'The paddy and the platform both.'

Sukni would laugh.

'There was a quarrel because of me, wasn't there?'

'Not because of you. Because of an empty watch.'

'I don't understand.'

'Don't. That is better.'

On the fifth night it was Ramlochan's turn.

At dusk his small grandson developed a high fever.

There was only one bicycle in the house, and Ramlochan had to go to the market for medicine.

He went to the platform and said to Jagdish, 'Can we exchange watches tonight?'

Jagdish had no work at home.

He agreed.

Another arrow was drawn in the register.

Kishori sat on the platform watching this.

He said softly, 'The rule was made because of Budhan, and Kaka is the first to use it.'

Ramlochan laughed.

‘If a rule is for only one man, what kind of rule is it?’

Budhan was not there that night, but when he saw the register the next morning, he smiled.

His extra late watch was fixed for the seventh night.

It was Kishori’s turn.

At two in the morning Budhan left home.

Sukni Devi was awake.

‘The platform again?’

‘Half the night.’

‘Is it your turn tonight?’

‘The part left over from the old turn.’

Whether Sukni understood or not, she said nothing.

She only brought out an old shawl from inside and gave it to him.

Budhan draped the shawl over his shoulders and left.

Kishori was waiting for him on the platform.

He climbed down.

‘I’m not sleepy. If you want, shall I stay with you?’

Budhan said, ‘The turn has to be made good, not shared.’

Kishori laughed.

‘All right, owner.’

‘The word “owner” does not suit me.’

Both laughed.

Kishori went home.

Budhan was alone on the platform, but this solitude was not like the solitude planned for his original watch.

He knew now that if a watch stood empty, the register had a name for that condition.

The night was somewhat cold, though the wind was not strong.

Wrapping the shawl around himself, he looked over the four fields.

The paddy ears did not shine alike in the faint moonlight.

One field lay a little lower, another higher.

One ridge was thick, another thin.

The platform was one.

At about three there was a rustling at the southern fence.

Budhan climbed down at once.

He swept the torchlight there.

Two goats outside were eating the karil leaves.

He drove them away.

This time the fence did not bend.

He tested the bamboo knot with his hand.

It was firm.

Towards dawn the sky began to whiten.

Budhan untied the register from the post of the platform.

He found the old date beside his name.

There the word ‘emergency’ had been written.

In the shared-work column opposite it was written: ‘southern fence.’

The space for the date of the extra watch was still blank.

Budhan picked up the charcoal.

He wrote the date.

Then he put a small tick beside it.

He did not fill in the empty circle from the old night.

The circle remained empty.

Beside it now stood two marks - one for a day's work, one for a night's watch.

By sunrise Ramlochan reached the field.

He looked at the register.

'Account settled?'

Climbing down from the platform, Budhan said, 'The account for the work I missed is settled. Not the account of my mother falling ill.'

Ramlochan was silent for a moment.

Then he looked towards the southern fence.

'The rope hasn't loosened?'

'No.'

The two walked along the ridge.

Most of the paddy plants that had been flattened were standing upright again.

Where the stalks had broken, the ears were beginning to dry.

Ramlochan took one ear in his hand.

'Not one paseri.'

Budhan smiled.

'We'll say after it is weighed.'

Ramlochan laughed too.

Behind them, the register on the platform post moved in the wind.

One night on that page was still empty.

But opposite that empty night, both the daytime fence work and the late-night watch were now recorded.

THE SHARE OF CHAFF

It was the second week of Chait.

In the rear threshing ground of Majhaul village, the sheaves of wheat had been lying in the sun for three days.

Whenever the morning wind rose, the dry leaves rubbed against one another with a crisp crackle.

Ramjeevan Yadav stood in the middle of the threshing ground, looking towards the old heap of chaff.

Some of last year's chaff was still left in the lower storeroom.

But by now it had turned grey, and dampness had entered its smell.

This year he had thought that if threshing did not take too long, he would sift the chaff and store it in the cowshed in good time.

In his mind, "saving time" had become linked with the machine.

For the first time that year, two mobile threshing machines had come to the village.

A belt from the tractor drove the machine; wheat sheaves went in from one side, and grain and chaff came out separately from the other.

People said: two days' work in half a day.

Ramjeevan liked the sound of that.

But Parvati Devi had reached the threshing ground before him.

For the past seven years, Parvati had worked at this household during the harvesting and threshing season.

With her were her husband's younger brother's wife, Phoolkumari, and their neighbour Mangali.

All three women held short bamboo forks and were turning the sheaves.

Parvati broke open a dry sheaf and examined the grain inside.

"Will the threshing be done today?"

Ramjeevan said, "Yes. The machine should be here by ten."

Mangali's hand stopped.

"A machine?"

"Yes. With bullocks the threshing would take two days."

Parvati said nothing.

She began turning the sheaves again.

Ramjeevan noticed her silence.

"There won't be any reduction in your wages."

Parvati raised her head.

"Did I say anything about wages?"

Ramjeevan tried to laugh.

"No, but I thought you would ask."

Phoolkumari said, "We certainly will. The machine is coming into the middle of the work our hands used to do."

The old arrangement for harvesting and threshing in that village was simple, though it had never been written down.

Cash on the day of harvesting.

Some grain on the day of threshing.

And once all the chaff had been made, a customary share for the labouring group.

Who had first said exactly how much that share was?

No one could say with certainty.

Sometimes one heap out of twelve.

Sometimes two cartloads, depending on the size of the field.

Sometimes more, if the owner needed less for his cattle.

But in this household one thing had remained steady for the past four years.

The group that stayed for the entire threshing would receive chaff as well as grain.

Parvati had two cows at home.

Mangali had a heifer.

Phoolkumari had no animal, but she sold half her chaff and bought salt and oil with the money.

To them, chaff was not refuse.

It was one form of wages.

A little before ten, the sound of a tractor came from a distance.

A green threshing machine was hitched behind a red tractor.

In white paint on the machine were the words: "Jai Kisan Mobile Threshing Service."

Shambhu Mahato was driving the tractor.

He was from the neighbouring village of Parsahi.

His younger brother Naresh and two helpers were with him.

The tractor stopped at one side of the threshing ground.

Shambhu climbed down and first examined the ground.

"Will the belt run straight here?"

Ramjeevan said, "It will."

Shambhu looked over the heap of sheaves and measured the open space with his eye.

"The chaff will fall on this side."

Parvati immediately asked, "How much chaff?"

Shambhu looked at her.

"Whatever comes out."

Parvati smiled.

"That much is obvious. I'm asking—which heap will it belong to?"

Ramjeevan intervened.

"Let the machine be set up first."

Shambhu looked again at Ramjeevan.

There was a small question in that glance.

Ramjeevan understood it.

"What we agreed yesterday will stand."

Parvati heard him.

“What agreement?”

Ramjeevan’s face tightened slightly.

“The machine-hire agreement.”

Parvati laid her fork on the sheaves and stood upright.

“Does the hire include chaff too?”

Shambhu decided it was no longer proper to remain silent.

“I offer two kinds of arrangement.”

“One: full payment in cash.”

“The other: a little less cash, and a share of the chaff.”

Mangali asked, “Which one for this field?”

Shambhu answered matter-of-factly, “Less cash and two cartloads of chaff.”

Parvati looked at Ramjeevan.

The air of the threshing ground suddenly felt heavy.

Ramjeevan said, “Two cartloads as part of the machine charge.”

“And ours?”

“You will still get the grain portion of your wages.”

“The chaff?”

Ramjeevan paused before replying.

“The machine has come now. The old threshing work is no longer the same.”

Phoolkumari thrust the point of her fork into the ground.

“Was the harvesting not still the old work?”

“Was tying the sheaves not still the old work?”

“Who will feed the sheaves into the machine?”

“Who will fill the grain into sacks?”

Mangali said softly, “Don’t ask everything at once.”

Phoolkumari fell silent.

Shambhu kept opening the machine belt.

He said, “I have come according to the arrangement made with me.”

Parvati said, “I am not blaming you.”

“But the same chaff is being divided twice.”

Shambhu stopped.

“How?”

“Earlier, there was a workers’ share in it.”

“Now that same chaff has become the machine charge.”

Ramjeevan said, “The amount of labour has gone down.”

Parvati asked, “By how much?”

Ramjeevan had no answer to that.

He could have said—a lot.

But “a lot” was not an account.

Shambhu turned the iron wheel of the machine to test it.

“Look, my machine doesn’t run for free either. Diesel, two men, belts, repairs.”

Parvati said, “I don’t run for free either.”

Shambhu did not laugh.

"That is fair."

Ramjeevan felt the dispute might grow before the threshing had even begun.

He raised his hand.

"Run one heap first."

"Then we will sit and settle the account."

Parvati asked, "Once one heap has run through, whose heap will its chaff fall into?"

This time Ramjeevan did not answer at once.

Shambhu said, "We can let it fall separately."

"Keep the chaff from the first heap separate."

That one sentence allowed the work to begin.

The mouth of the machine began swallowing sheaves.

Naresh lifted the sheaves from one side.

Phoolkumari loosened them and fed them towards the mouth of the machine.

Mangali gathered the dry stalks.

Parvati held the sack on the side where the grain fell.

Ramjeevan changed the empty sacks.

Shambhu watched the belt and listened to the machine.

It was difficult to talk over the roar.

In half an hour, work equal to many hours of the old hand-threshing was done.

Sweat stood on Parvati's forehead.

Dry stalks had scratched Phoolkumari's palms.

Chaff had gone into Mangali's eyes.

She went to wash them with water.

When the machine stopped, the threshing ground suddenly seemed very quiet.

Shambhu looked at the time.

"Thirty-two minutes."

Ramjeevan examined the heap.

The grain had come out clean.

The chaff was light and even.

He could not help being pleased.

"With bullocks this would have taken half a day."

Parvati took some chaff in her hand and rubbed it between her fingers.

"The machine is good."

Ramjeevan looked at her.

Parvati continued, "The question is not whether the machine is good or bad."

"The question is: when the machine arrived, where did the share that had already been agreed upon go?"

Shambhu sat in the shade of the tractor.

"I'll state my two arrangements again."

With his finger he drew two lines on the ground.

"Full cash payment—the chaff belongs to the farmer."

"Reduced cash payment—two cartloads of chaff are mine."

Ramjeevan said, "I chose the second arrangement."

Parvati asked, "When you chose it, did you also count our share of chaff?"

Ramjeevan was silent.

The silence made the answer clear.

No.

The labourers' share had never been counted as a separate thing in the bargain with the machine owner.

It had simply been treated as the field's chaff.

Phoolkumari said quietly, "Our name was never in the bargain at all."

Ramjeevan's voice became a little sharper.

"You will get your full cash wages."

Parvati said, "Cash is one thing; chaff is another."

"If you had told us beforehand that once the machine came we would get no chaff, we would have asked for wages accordingly."

Shambhu nodded.

"That is fair."

Ramjeevan looked at him.

"You have come to take your chaff."

"I will take what was agreed with me," Shambhu said.

"But I did not know beforehand what arrangement existed between you and the labourers."

Mangali came back, wiping her eyes.

"Shall we stop work?"

Parvati said, "No."

Ramjeevan looked at her in surprise.

"No?"

"The wheat is dry. Clouds may come again. If we stop, everyone loses."

"But we will not run the second heap without settling the account."

This time Ramjeevan did not object.

An old wooden cot was brought to the corner of the threshing ground.

Ramjeevan's son Chhotu was returning from school.

He was told to bring the old ledger and a piece of charcoal from the house.

Chhotu asked, "Which ledger?"

Ramjeevan said, "The one with the fertiliser accounts."

The ledger came.

On its earlier pages were entries for urea, diesel, seed, and pump expenses.

The word chaff did not appear even once.

Parvati turned the pages.

"Chaff was never on paper at all."

Ramjeevan said, "It was custom."

"The day a custom changes, that is the day paper is needed."

Shambhu took the charcoal and wrote three headings on the narrow edge of the cot.

“MACHINE.”

“PEOPLE.”

“CHAFF.”

Chhotu burst out laughing.

“There is a ledger right here. Why write on the cot?”

Shambhu said, “First let it remain where everyone can see it.”

Under MACHINE, Ramjeevan said, “Lower cash rate per hour.”

Shambhu corrected him.

“Lower rate, plus two cartloads of chaff.”

Under PEOPLE, Parvati said, “Harvesting is already done.”

“Today: carrying the sheaves to the machine.”

“Changing the sacks.”

“Gathering the chaff.”

“Making the heaps.”

Mangali added, “Picking up the grain left behind after the machine stops.”

Phoolkumari said, “And finding water when chaff gets into our eyes.”

Everyone laughed.

The tension eased a little.

Under CHAFF, Ramjeevan asked, “How much was the old share?”

That question created another difficulty.

Someone said one-twelfth.

Someone said “two cartloads.”

Parvati said, “Last year the three households together received four loads.”

Ramjeevan said, “Four loads do not make a cartload.”

“I am not saying they do.”

“Then what measure?”

No one had an answer.

Shambhu said, “That is why first decide the measure.”

He looked towards his cart.

“How much chaff my cart carries is a separate matter.”

“The workers’ share does not have to be measured by the same unit.”

Ramjeevan opened the ledger.

“Then what about today’s work?”

Parvati said, “First point: the old chaff share does not suddenly become zero.”

“Second: it must be clear whether the machine’s chaff charge comes from the farmer’s share or from everyone’s total chaff.”

Ramjeevan asked, “Why from the farmer’s share?”

Parvati replied, “Because you made the machine bargain.”

“It is not right to pay that charge out of our wages without asking us.”

Shambhu listened quietly.

Ramjeevan ran a finger along the edge of the ledger.

The argument felt severe to him.

But it was not unfair.

He could say—the machine had reduced everyone’s work.

But reduced it by how much?

And what part of the work had the chaff share originally paid for?

No one had ever written down the answer to that.

Ramjeevan's wife Janki came from the house carrying water.

She looked at the three words on the cot.

"Has a village council assembled here?"

Ramjeevan said, "A council of chaff."

Janki did not laugh.

She kept watch over the household cattle.

She understood better than Ramjeevan how many days the chaff would last.

"If two cartloads go to the machine, how much will remain for our own cow?"

Ramjeevan said, "How can we weigh it yet?"

Janki looked at Parvati.

"You people had a separate share, didn't you?"

"Yes."

Janki said to Ramjeevan, "Then why did you not count that when you made the machine bargain?"

Ramjeevan grew irritated.

"Must every single thing fall on my head at once?"

Janki replied calmly, "You made the bargain."

Shambhu, drinking water, said, "There is one way."

Everyone looked at him.

"Today I can take one cartload of chaff instead of two, and the rest of my payment after the wheat is sold."

Ramjeevan said, "Then my cash payment goes up."

"Yes."

"How much?"

Shambhu stated the rate.

Ramjeevan began calculating in his head.

Parvati intervened.

"We do not want Shambhu-bhai's charity."

Shambhu smiled.

"I am not offering charity. I am offering the other arrangement."

"The remaining cash later, and one cartload of chaff now."

Ramjeevan's difficulty was cash.

That was why he had chosen the lower cash payment plus chaff.

Now everyone understood the problem.

The machine owner was not greedy for chaff.

The farmer was not deliberately trying to cut the labourers' share.

The labourers were not against the machine.

The difficulty was that there were three separate accounts, but all three bargains had landed on one thing—chaff.

Parvati opened a blank page of the ledger.

"Write this down first for today."

Chhotu brought a pen.

Ramjeevan said, "Machine—one cartload of chaff, the remaining cash after the wheat is sold."

Shambhu said, "Agreed."

Parvati said, "People's work—today's agreed cash wage, in full."

Phoolkumari added, "And the harvesting cash, as before."

Ramjeevan wrote it down.

"Chaff?"

Parvati did not rush.

She said, "Once today's total chaff has been heaped, first mark three portions: one for the household cattle, one for the machine cart, and one for the labourers' share."

Ramjeevan said, "How much for the labourers?"

Parvati said, "Whatever reached the three households last year—measure that today and write it down."

"And if no one remembers?"

Mangali said, "There are old marks in the bamboo bin at my house."

Phoolkumari laughed.

"You have marks on everything."

Mangali said, "Without marks, a poor person's account blows away."

For a few moments no one spoke.

Shambhu brought two ropes from his cart.

"Chaff is harder to measure than grain."

"Make loads of roughly the same size."

"We can count ten loads as one small heap."

Ramjeevan asked, "Is that science?"

Shambhu laughed.

"No. But it is better than judging by the eye."

Work began again.

This time the machine's chaff did not fall into one undivided heap.

Mangali and Phoolkumari used the rope to tie loads of roughly equal size.

At every tenth load, Parvati drew one line in the ledger.

Chhotu counted the lines.

While watching the machine, Shambhu would occasionally say, "Tie them loosely, otherwise dampness will remain inside."

Janki had the filled grain sacks placed near the veranda of the house.

By noon, more than half the wheat had been threshed.

Ramjeevan was still pleased with the machine.

The work truly was fast.

But he now understood that "the work is faster" and "the wages have fallen" were not the same sentence.

At lunchtime everyone switched off the machine.

Chaff drifted in the air over the threshing ground.

Shaking out the end of her sari, Parvati said, "In the old days, on threshing day the body would be broken by night."

Shambhu said, "Then the machine is good, isn't it?"

"It is good."

"Then why the quarrel?"

"The arrival of a good thing does not mean an old share should disappear without a word."

Shambhu nodded in agreement.

Breaking a morsel of rice, Ramjeevan said, "Then next year, if the work is done by machine, will the chaff share stay the same?"

Parvati said, "Not necessarily."

Ramjeevan looked at her in surprise.

"Then?"

"Next year, settle it beforehand."

"How much work the machine does, how much the labourers do, and what labour the chaff share pays for—settle all of that before the work begins."

"If the rate has to change, let it change."

"But not after the work has started."

Janki said, "I like that."

After noon, a thin line of cloud appeared in the north.

Everyone returned quickly to work.

The machine ran without interruption.

Before four in the afternoon, the last sheaf too had gone through.

Shambhu shut down the machine.

Suddenly a humming seemed to remain inside everyone's ears.

Fourteen sacks full of grain stood in a row in the threshing ground.

Five separate heaps of chaff had been made.

Chhotu looked at the ledger.

"Forty-eight loads in all."

Mangali said, "Two loads are loose."

Parvati said, "Tie them again."

They counted once more.

Forty-seven equal loads, with some loose chaff left over.

Shambhu said, "The loose chaff can go on top when the cart is filled."

Ramjeevan looked at the ledger.

"One cartload for the machine—how many loads?"

Shambhu measured his cart and said, "With this tying, about fourteen."

Ramjeevan drew a line after fourteen.

"For the cowshed?"

Janki said, "We need twenty loads for now."

"And the rest?"

Parvati said, "See how much the old share used to come to."

Mangali ran home.

After a while she returned with a thin bamboo strip.

There were three old charcoal marks on it.

"Last year I received five loads."

Phoolkumari said, "I received four. I had sold half and kept half."

Parvati said, "I received six."

Ramjeevan added them.

"Fifteen in all."

Shambhu said, "Then forty-eight minus fourteen for the machine, twenty for the house, fifteen for the labourers—makes forty-nine."

Chhotu immediately said, "The total is forty-seven."

Everyone laughed.

The account had snagged again.

Janki said, "Twenty for the cowshed was only an estimate. We can manage with eighteen."

Ramjeevan looked at her.

"Can we?"

"If it is kept dry."

Parvati said, "Let the workers' share remain fifteen."

Ramjeevan wrote in the ledger:

Machine—chaff equal to fourteen loads.

Labouring group—fifteen loads.

Household—eighteen loads.

Loose chaff—to go on top when the cart is filled.

Shambhu began loading his cart.

Parvati, Mangali and Phoolkumari helped him too.

Shambhu said, "Why are you filling my chaff?"

Parvati said, "Gathering chaff is written under today's people's work."

Shambhu laughed.

"That ledger will become a burden."

Parvati replied, "A ledger makes the burden lighter."

As evening fell, the tractor drove away.

Three heaps remained in the threshing ground.

One for the household.

One for the labouring group.

And one small loose portion.

Ramjeevan looked towards the labourers' heap.

"Who will divide this?"

Parvati said, "We will."

"According to who has animals at home and who needs to sell."

Ramjeevan asked, "Then there will be another dispute?"

Parvati smiled.

"If there is, it will stay within the fifteen loads."

"Your machine charge will not enter it."

Ramjeevan laughed too.

The next day Parvati's group went to work in a field in another village.

A machine was to be used there as well.

The field owner stated the wages.

Parvati's first question was not about cash.

She asked, "In what form is the machine being paid?"

The field owner said, "Entirely in cash."

"The chaff?"

“Belongs to the household.”

“The labourers’ share?”

The field owner paused.

“The old custom is different here.”

Parvati said, “Then write it down before the work begins.”

From that day onward, ledgers did not become compulsory in every threshing ground.

Some people wrote things down.

Some did not.

Some continued exactly under the old custom.

But at Ramjeevan’s house the following year, three lines were written down one day before threshing began.

Machine payment.

People’s work.

Share of chaff.

That year Shambhu came again.

He looked at the ledger.

“No chaff for me?”

Ramjeevan said, “Full cash payment this year.”

Shambhu looked at the rate.

“Fine.”

When Parvati arrived, her name had already been written in the line for people’s work.

She looked at the line for chaff.

The quantity was written there too.

Parvati put a small tick beside it with the pen.

No one made a speech.

No one reopened the old dispute.

The machine started.

The chaff was not divided three times.

First the three accounts remained separate.

Only then did the work begin.

STORY 107

THE TWO GHATS OF THE POND

It was the second week of Jeth.

From a distance, the pond at Majhaul still looked full, but the moment one descended to the ghats it became clear how far the water had receded since the previous month.

The seventh step of the northern ghat had dried out.

At the southern ghat, one now had to cross mud from the brick edge to reach the water.

People in the village still spoke of “the two ghats.”

The water, however, was slowly joining both ghats into the same shallow crescent.

At first light, Malati Devi reached the northern ghat with a bundle of clothes on her head.

Subhadra and Pano were with her.

The three women descended the steps, and when they reached the last stone, Malati stopped.

Two thin bamboo poles had been planted obliquely in the water.

A red cord was tied between them.

From the cord hung a small wooden board.

Written on it in charcoal were the words: “Do not cross beyond this point.”

Subhadra frowned.

“Who put this here?”

Malati touched one end of the cord.

“It wasn’t here last night.”

Just then a narrow dugout, almost like a little boat, came gliding across the water.

Bhola Sahni was in it.

That year the pond had been leased to him for fish farming.

Bhola brought the dugout to the ghat.

“I tied the cord.”

Pano asked, “Why?”

Bhola pointed towards the green growth beneath the water.

“Yesterday evening there was a shoal of small fish here. As the water falls, they are all coming into the shallows. When clothes are washed, the soap foam flows straight here.”

Malati lowered her bundle.

“But this is the ghat.”

“I haven’t closed the ghat.”

“Then what is the cord saying?”

Bhola remained silent for a moment.

“It is saying: leave this side for the fish.”

Malati looked towards the water.

Where the cord now stood, two months earlier the water had reached to the waist.

Now it came only to the knees.

Beyond it began the deeper green water.

Subhadra said, "Are we supposed to wash clothes in the air?"

Before Bhola could answer, Pano burst out laughing.

"The soap foam belongs to the fish, and the mud belongs to us?"

Bhola stepped out of the dugout and came onto the ghat.

His legs were wet to the knees.

"I'm saying—don't stop washing clothes. Just do it a little higher up."

Malati looked at the dry steps.

"Where is the water higher up?"

Bhola did not answer.

That day the matter ended there.

The three women washed their clothes on the near side of the cord.

But the space was so narrow that when one wrung out a sheet, another woman's bucket overturned.

The wind carried the foam around and back beneath the cord.

Malati said nothing.

Bhola too was watching.

By noon, the red cord had become a subject of discussion throughout the village.

Some said Bhola was fencing off the pond.

Some said that since he had taken the lease, he had to protect the fish.

Some said that if clothes could no longer be washed there, a new quarrel would begin in every household.

That evening another problem arose at the southern ghat.

Ramcharit brought his two cows and a heifer to drink.

There was no water now on the old slope of the southern ghat.

The animals came down through the mud and reached the same shallow stretch where Bhola had tied the cord that morning.

One cow stepped two paces farther in to drink.

Mud churned up.

The water turned cloudy.

Bhola came running from a distance.

"Kaka, keep them a little to this side."

Holding the cow's rope, Ramcharit said, "Where exactly is 'this side'?"

Bhola pointed south.

"The old ghat."

Ramcharit laughed.

"The old ghat is on dry land now. Shall I teach the cow to read a map?"

Bhola fell silent.

The cow continued drinking.

The heifer sank a hoof into the mud.

Ramcharit quickly caught it by the neck and pulled it out.

At that moment Sarita Devi, the ward member, was passing by.
She stopped.

“What happened?”

Ramcharit said, “The pond has two ghats, but the water has become one-ghat water.”

Sarita laughed at first, then looked towards the pond.

It was true.

The next morning Sarita came to the pond carrying two old bamboo poles, a rope, and a hand-span measure.

Bhola was already there.

Malati, Subhadra, Pano and Ramcharit also arrived.

Sarita said, “First let us see where the quarrel actually lies.”

Malati said, “The quarrel lies in the red cord.”

Bhola said, “The quarrel lies in the falling water.”

Ramcharit said, “In both.”

Sarita planted a bamboo pole in the water.

The first mark was made where the old stone steps of the pond ended.

The second where the water now reached the knee.

The third where Bhola said the shoals of fish were circling.

Three charcoal lines were drawn on the bamboo.

Pano asked, “And what will these lines do?”

Sarita said, “Nothing yet. We will watch for two days.”

In two days, the water fell one finger below the first mark.

In four days, three fingers.

On the seventh day, the cord at the northern ghat hung half over mud.

Bhola untied it himself.

Malati watched from a distance.

She said, “Has the cord lost?”

Bhola smiled.

“The water has won.”

For the first time, Malati laughed.

But the inconvenience remained.

Those washing clothes now had to keep searching for stones as they moved lower.

The animals too were drinking from the same side.

One morning Subhadra’s sari was stepped on by a cow.

Ramcharit immediately lifted the cloth.

“My fault.”

Brushing off the sari, Subhadra said, “Not yours. There is only one path.”

That evening a small meeting was held beneath the peepal tree beside the pond.

There was no platform.

Sarita placed a register on an old wooden stool.

Bhola did not bring his lease papers.

Malati did not bring any petition either.

Ramcharit had a rope in his hand, because it was nearly time to take the cows home.

Sarita asked the first question.

“How does it work when the pond is full?”

Malati said, “The northern ghat is for washing clothes.”

Ramcharit said, “The southern ghat is for the animals.”

Bhola said, “The deep middle is for fish.”

“And when the water falls?”

All three fell silent.

From a little distance Pano called out, “Then all three become the same place.”

Sarita drew three lines in the register.

“Then the rule cannot be about fixed places. It has to be about the water level.”

Bhola said, “The level will change every day.”

“That is why there will not be a new village council every day. There will be marks.”

Sarita copied the three bamboo marks into the register.

Upper water line.

Middle water line.

Lower water line.

Malati asked, “At the upper line?”

“As with the old two ghats.”

“The middle?”

Instead of answering, Sarita said, “That is what we now have to work out.”

Here the meeting became difficult.

Bhola wanted the soap foam not to flow directly into the pond.

Malati said that carrying water twenty hand-spans uphill to wash clothes was impossible for an elderly woman.

Ramcharit wanted the animals to reach the water but not sink into deep mud.

Sarita asked, “What is actually needed for washing clothes?”

Subhadra said, “A level stone, water, and a place to wring them.”

“Is it necessary to stand inside the pond?”

“No. The water only has to come within reach of the hand.”

“For the animals?”

Ramcharit said, “A slope. Water at mouth level. That is all.”

Bhola said, “I need the shallow green growth in the middle to survive.”

Sarita wrote three more lines in the register.

Washing.

Water for animals.

Shallow refuge for fish.

No solution was reached that day.

But the next morning Malati brought an old square stone from her house. She placed it beside the fourth step of the northern ghat.

Pano brought two bricks.

Subhadra brought an old tin basin.
 Bhola watched from a distance.
 He asked, "What are you making?"
 Malati said, "First we are seeing whether clothes can be washed by drawing water upward."
 Bhola said nothing.
 From his dugout he brought out an old thick rope.
 "For lowering the bucket."
 The first trial was not easy.
 Half the bucket spilled while it was being pulled up.
 The stone was too small.
 The tin basin rocked unsteadily.
 After bending twice, Malati's back began to ache.
 She said, "This rule will make old people sit at home."
 Bhola nodded.
 "Then it is not right."
 At noon Sarita brought out two discarded stone slabs from the rear room of the panchayat building.
 They had once belonged to a broken platform.
 Four young men carried the slabs to the ghat.
 Malati said, "Why is everyone working for us?"
 Sarita replied, "Not for you. To keep the pond water from receiving soap directly."
 Bhola said, "The expense will not fall only on the women."
 He agreed to provide sand and two sacks of gravel the next day.
 Ramcharit said, "I will give labour to make the slope at the animal ghat."
 Sarita wrote it down.
 No one became a benefactor.
 It was written whose work brought benefit to whom.
 Within three days, a small level washing platform was made above the northern ghat.
 The platform stood eight hand-spans above the pond.
 Water was pulled up with rope and bucket.
 A narrow channel was made along one side of the platform.
 Water from the channel did not run towards the pond, but towards a soak pit in the earth beside two banana plants.
 On the first day Pano said laughingly, "So the fish no longer drink our soap?"
 Bhola said, "The banana plants do."
 Subhadra interrupted, "The banana plants should not drink too much soap either."
 Everyone laughed.
 Sarita wrote: "Use less soap; foamy water towards the soak pit."
 Malati said, "Write a rule, but I don't want a policeman measuring soap."
 Sarita did not underline the word "less."
 She wrote only: "Foam must not flow directly into the pond."

Ramcharit's work at the southern ghat was harder.

The animals' hooves sank into the mud.

He laid broken bricks and roof tiles.

Bhola said, "The edges of the bricks may cut their hooves."

Ramcharit removed them again.

In the end a slope was made by pressing three pieces of old thick bamboo into the mud.

Two flat stones were placed over them.

The animals could descend to the water, but to prevent them from going into the deeper part, two bamboo poles were tied horizontally across the way.

The bamboo was low enough for a cow to stretch its head forward and drink.

It was high enough to keep the whole body from moving through.

On the first day Ramcharit's cow was frightened by the bamboo.

It backed away.

Ramcharit stroked its forehead.

When it saw the second cow, the first one came forward again.

Both drank.

Ramcharit said, "This can work."

Bhola looked at the colour of the water.

Less mud had been stirred up than before.

But seven days later the inconvenience changed again.

The water fell below the middle line.

The rope at the northern washing platform was now becoming too short.

The end of the southern slope was once again on dry ground.

Opening the register beneath the peepal tree, Malati said, "We are back where we began."

Sarita looked at the marks on the bamboo.

"No. Now we know that building a fixed ghat will not work."

Bhola asked, "Then?"

With a thin stick Sarita drew the shape of the pond on the ground.

"The ghat stays above. Access moves."

Ramcharit said, "Explain."

Sarita pointed towards the bamboo at the southern slope.

"The horizontal bamboo should not be fixed. The stakes must be movable."

Bhola understood at once.

"As the water falls, the stakes move lower. But the deep-water boundary moves with them."

Malati said, "And my rope?"

Pano said, "Longer."

This time the laughter was brief, but the answer was right.

Bhola cut two long pieces from an old strong net rope.

Malati objected.

"Don't cut up your fishing gear."

Bhola said, "It is old. Knotted. It is good for this."

The stakes at the southern ghat were pulled out and planted again.

A rule was made: when the water passed below the middle mark, the stakes would be moved one stone lower.

When it passed below the lower mark, only a narrow place for animals to drink would remain open; the rest of the shallow green stretch would be left as refuge for the fish.

Malati asked, "And clothes at the lower mark?"

Sarita said, "On the platform. With the long rope."

"And anyone who cannot pull it?"

The matter stuck again.

It would have been easy to say: a young person in the household will pull it.

Malati rejected that immediately.

"What of a household with no young person?"

Bhola thought.

"I can leave a filled drum every morning."

Malati said, "That will increase your work."

"If the fish survive, I benefit too."

Sarita said, "It must not depend on one man."

In the end two medium-sized drums were placed beside the northern platform.

The first person able to draw water in the morning would fill them with two or three buckets.

Those washing clothes would refill them in turn.

Leaving a drum empty was not declared an offence.

The register merely said: "As much as you take, refill as much as you reasonably can."

Pano said, "This rule has no punishment."

Sarita replied, "Not every rule exists for punishment."

Bhola said nothing.

He remembered the sentence.

On the eighth morning the drums were found empty.

Malati was alone.

She pulled the first bucket.

Then the second.

On the third pull, her hands began to hurt.

She sat down.

At that moment Bhola was setting out with his boat.

He came to the ghat and half-filled both drums.

Malati said, "Your name won't go into the register for this."

Bhola laughed.

"Then write the fish's name."

Malati laughed too.

At noon Pano filled the drums again.

In the evening Ramcharit's son left two buckets of water.

Slowly, the work began to become habit more than rule.

Then, on the last Monday of Jeth, a strong wind rose.

That night the first proper rain came.

Not much, but it continued for two hours.

By morning the pond had risen by half a hand-span.

The moved stakes at the southern ghat now stood too far inside the water.

Ramcharit said, "So now we move them back up?"

Bhola looked at the water-level marks on the bamboo.

The water was touching the middle line.

Sarita said, "A rule that moves downward must also return upward."

The stakes were moved one stone higher.

The washing platform at the northern ghat remained where it was.

Some of the women washing clothes wanted to return to the old steps now that the water had risen.

Malati said, "The water has risen. The path of the soap has not changed."

Bhola looked at her.

He said nothing.

That week the fishing net was lifted.

Bhola released the small fish and separated the larger ones.

Ramcharit stood at the edge.

He asked, "Did all this trouble truly save the fish?"

Bhola showed him a small fish in his palm.

"How many were saved, I cannot say."

"Then?"

"Less mud is being churned up. Foam is not coming straight here. That much I can see."

Ramcharit said, "And my cows no longer sink in the mud."

Both statements were separately true.

No one tried to combine them into a single benefit.

A month later, at an ordinary meeting of the panchayat, Sarita read out the pond register.

Someone asked, "Does the pond now belong to the fish or to the village?"

Before Sarita could answer, Bhola said, "The water is used by everyone; the fish are my responsibility."

Malati said, "And the ghats move with the water."

A few people at the meeting laughed.

But Sarita did not write that sentence in the register.

She wrote only the three water-level rules.

Upper line—the old two ghats remain open; the washing platform may be used; animals use the southern slope.

Middle line—washing on the platform; the animal stakes move one stone lower; the shallow green area remains clear.

Lower line—long rope; movable animal stakes; no one steps inside the fish-refuge strip.

Below that she added one more line.

"Foamy water must not flow directly into the pond."

No one added a "penalty."

No one wrote the word "owner."

No one wrote “only” either, except in the prohibition against stepping into the refuge strip.

In the first week of Asadh, the rains became regular.

The pond began to fill.

The dry steps of the northern ghat became wet again.

The bamboo pressed into the lower part of the southern slope was half submerged.

The first stake that had once carried the red cord had been removed long before.

Malati had tied its cord into her clothesline.

One morning Bhola saw the red cord fluttering in the wind.

He laughed.

Malati asked, “What happened?”

“Nothing.”

“Then why did you laugh?”

Bhola said, “Once this cord tried to stop the pond.”

Wringing out a cloth, Malati said, “Did the cord ever stop the pond?”

Bhola did not answer.

The water had now risen to the upper mark.

The two ghats once again appeared clearly separate.

Clothes were being washed at the northern ghat.

Ramcharit’s cows were drinking at the southern ghat.

In the deep middle, Bhola was checking his net.

From a distance the scene looked as it had before.

The only difference was that beneath the peepal tree, three water lines were now written in the register.

And they were marked on the bamboo at the ghat as well.

When the water rose, the lines disappeared beneath it.

When the water fell, they appeared again.

No one erased them.

THE CREDIT LEDGER

Sawan was drawing to a close.

After three days of rain, the mud on the main road of Majhaul village had dried a little, though water still stood in the potholes along the edges.

For the first time, Devaki went alone to Mahendra Sahu's shop.

It had been eight months since her marriage had brought her to this village.

During those eight months she had gone to the shop many times, but usually with her mother-in-law or sister-in-law.

Today her mother-in-law's knee was aching, her father-in-law had gone to inspect the field bunds, and the household had run out of salt.

Besides, her young brother-in-law Naval had had a fever since the previous day.

The ordinary fever tablets prescribed at the village health room were kept at the shop.

Devaki tied two hundred rupees into a knot at the end of her sari.

She thought she would buy salt, soap, the tablets and a little mustard oil; if the money fell short, she would have thirty or forty rupees entered on credit.

Mahendra Sahu's shop stood at the village crossroads beside an old peepal tree.

One half held rice, lentils, oil, salt, soap and matches; the other held seed, rope, umbrellas, cheap notebooks and pencils, and a few common medicines.

Behind the counter lay three thick ledgers, one on top of another.

The red ledger was for cash sales.

The green ledger was for wholesale goods.

The blue ledger was for credit.

Everyone in the village knew the blue ledger by name.

Mahendra Sahu did not announce in front of outsiders how much any household owed.

But he himself knew almost every account by heart.

When Devaki arrived, there were two customers in the shop.

An elderly man was buying tobacco; a child was buying half a kilo of sugar.

Devaki stood at one side of the counter.

Mahendra Sahu returned the child's change, wrapped the old man's purchase in paper, and then asked, "Tell me, bahuria, what do you need?"

Devaki recited her list.

Mahendra Sahu took out the items one after another.

"One kilo of salt?"

"Yes."

"Half a kilo of oil?"

"Yes."

"One bar of soap?"

"Two."

"How many tablets?"

Devaki held out the prescription.

Mahendra Sahu read it and took out two strips.

He placed everything on the counter and added it on the calculator.

The total was thirty-seven rupees more than two hundred.

Devaki untied the knot of her sari and gave him two hundred rupees.

"Write thirty-seven on credit. If Madhav comes by evening, he will pay it."

Mahendra Sahu casually opened the blue ledger.

The ledger was not arranged alphabetically but according to an old sequence of households.

He turned the pages.

"Harinayaran Jha..."

Devaki became attentive on hearing her father-in-law's name.

At the top of the page, in thick letters, was written: "Harinayaran Jha Household."

Below it ran entries from many years.

Sometimes "flour," sometimes "oil," sometimes only an amount of money.

Nowhere was the name of the person who had taken the goods.

Nowhere was the full list of items.

Mahendra Sahu drew a new line.

"Today—thirty-seven."

Then he looked at the previous total.

"With the old balance, that makes one thousand seven hundred and forty-two."

Devaki thought she had misheard him.

"How much?"

"One thousand seven hundred and forty-two."

"I only asked you to write thirty-seven."

"I wrote thirty-seven as the new credit. I told you the total including the old balance."

"How much was the old balance?"

Mahendra Sahu looked at the last addition above.

"One thousand seven hundred and five."

Devaki's hand stopped on the bag of soap.

"When is that from?"

"It has been running for a long time. Money has been paid into it from time to time, then more goods have been taken."

"From before I came here?"

Mahendra Sahu turned the page and checked the dates.

"The first balance here is from five years ago. Since then it has gone down and up."

Devaki remained silent for a few moments.

“Then why is what I bought today being joined to something from five years ago?”

Mahendra Sahu looked at her.

“I have not put it on your head. It is the household ledger.”

“My father-in-law’s name is at the top of the page.”

“Yes. That was the name under which the household account was kept.”

“Then whose thirty-seven is what I took?”

“The household’s.”

Devaki’s question came again.

“And the one thousand seven hundred and five from five years ago?”

“That too belongs to the household.”

Mahendra Sahu said it in a manner that suggested the answer was self-evident.

To Devaki it was not.

She had entered this household only eight months ago.

Five years earlier she had been a student in her parents’ home.

Who had taken oil from this ledger then, who had taken rice, who had paid money—none of it was written down.

She did not suspect the shopkeeper of theft.

The problem was not in the shopkeeper’s eyes. It was in the lines on the page.

The ledger knew the “household.”

It did not know the people inside it.

Devaki said, “I gave you two hundred rupees. Against which debt did those two hundred go?”

Mahendra Sahu looked at the ledger again.

“They were deducted from the total.”

“From today’s goods?”

“From the total.”

“Then if Madhav gives you thirty-seven tomorrow, which line will that reduce?”

“The total.”

For the first time Devaki smiled slightly.

“So the ledger adds everything together, but separates nothing.”

Mahendra Sahu smiled too.

“Old shop accounts are like that.”

“If they are old, isn’t there even more need for them to be clear?”

Before Mahendra Sahu could answer, another customer came into the shop.

He closed the ledger.

He handed Devaki her bag of goods.

“When Madhav comes this evening, we will talk.”

Devaki returned home.

All along the road, the number one thousand seven hundred and five revolved in her mind.

At home she first gave Naval's prescription and medicine to her mother-in-law.

Then she filled the salt jar.

She put away the oil.

She placed the soap in the box on the veranda.

Her mother-in-law asked, "How much did it come to?"

"Two hundred and thirty-seven."

"You ran short of money?"

"Thirty-seven on credit."

Her mother-in-law said casually, "He must have written it in the account."

Devaki looked at her face.

"There is already one thousand seven hundred and five in the account."

Her mother-in-law's hand stopped.

"Still?"

That "still" startled Devaki.

"You knew?"

"Not how much. There was an old account."

"Whose account?"

Before answering, her mother-in-law lifted the lota to drink water.

"The household's."

Devaki heard the shopkeeper's answer again.

"Who inside the household took it?"

"Sometimes I did, sometimes your father-in-law, sometimes Madhav, sometimes Naval. Sugar and tea for the field labourers also came from there. At your sister-in-law's wedding, half the price of two sacks of rice was paid later."

"None of that under separate names?"

"Who used to write all that in those days?"

Devaki fell silent.

Her mother-in-law, now a little uneasy, said, "Don't think that the old debt has been put on your head."

"I am not saying that."

"Then?"

"I want to understand why what I took today must remain tied in the same knot as entries from five years ago."

Her mother-in-law did not answer.

Madhav returned in the evening.

Devaki told him everything.

At first Madhav laughed.

"You are thinking this much over thirty-seven rupees?"

"Not over thirty-seven."

"Then?"

"Today I paid two hundred. The shopkeeper says it was deducted from the total. If you pay five hundred tomorrow, that too will come off the total. If Naval takes a notebook on credit, that too will increase the total. Five years

from now someone will ask—who took what?—and the answer will again be ‘the household.’”

Madhav’s laughter slowly faded.

“This is an old custom.”

“Does an old custom mean the account itself must remain old?”

Madhav looked towards his father’s room.

“Babuji will not like this. He will think you want to separate the household accounts.”

“I do not want to separate the household. I want to separate the lines.”

Madhav said nothing.

The next morning Harinayaran Jha raised the matter himself.

“I hear there was an argument over the account?”

Devaki was sitting near the hearth.

“Not an argument.”

“Mahendra said you asked questions after looking at the page.”

Devaki understood that even when a village shop kept accounts private, words still travelled like air.

“I only asked why old and new credit were not kept separately.”

Harinayaran Jha coughed and said, “A household account belongs to the household. Are we going to count how much salt went into each mouth inside it?”

Devaki replied calmly, “The salt is shared. The medicine was for Naval. The rice from five years ago was for sister-in-law’s wedding. The reasons are different.”

“The money will still go from the household’s pocket.”

“Every time?”

Harinayaran Jha paused.

Madhav stood silently by the doorway.

Devaki continued, “Yesterday I paid two hundred rupees saved from my sewing. Did that money reduce the old wedding rice or today’s oil? The ledger does not say.”

Harinayaran Jha’s face grew a little stern.

“Are you trying to say your money is separate?”

Devaki did not answer at once.

She looked at the fire in the hearth.

“I am saying that it should be written who paid the money. It should be written for whom the goods were taken. If something is shared by the household, let it be written as shared. That is all.”

Harinayaran Jha went out onto the veranda.

The matter stopped there, but did not end.

Three days later Naval came home with a notebook and pen bought on credit.

That evening Devaki asked, “Did you pay?”

“No. I had it written in the account.”

“Under whose name?”

Naval laughed.

“Our household’s.”

Devaki said nothing.

That same week sugar, tea leaves and jaggery for the field labourers were again brought on credit.

Harinayaran Jha said, “That is a field expense.”

Devaki asked, “Is that written in the ledger?”

There was no answer.

The problem was no longer merely Devaki’s question.

Madhav himself began to think about it.

He did brick-and-mortar work in town.

When the contractor paid the weekly wages, days, hours, advances and deductions were written separately.

Many times there were quarrels over those accounts, but at least one could look at the lines.

The household credit had only one total.

The following Sunday Madhav went to Mahendra Sahu’s shop.

Devaki did not go with him.

Madhav placed five hundred rupees on the counter.

“Deposit this.”

Mahendra Sahu opened the blue ledger.

Madhav said, “First, one thing.”

“Tell me.”

“Against which balance will these five hundred be deducted?”

Mahendra Sahu laughed.

“Now everyone in your household asks the same question.”

“The answer?”

“From the old total.”

“What if I say three hundred should go against the sugar and tea for the field, and two hundred against the household’s everyday goods?”

Mahendra Sahu looked at the ledger.

“The old ledger has no columns like that.”

“Can you make them?”

Mahendra Sahu remained silent for a while.

“I can. But if I make them only for your household, others will ask why not for theirs.”

“Then make them for everyone.”

Mahendra Sahu scratched his neck.

“Writing the name of every customer will not be easy. A child will come, a daughter-in-law will come, a labourer will come. One person will say, ‘write it to the household,’ another, ‘put it under the master’s name.’ How much can I ask when the shop is crowded?”

Madhav said, “Ask three things—who is taking it, whether it is shared by the household or for some specific purpose, and when money is paid, which balance it is meant to reduce.”

“Three questions are too many in a crowd.”

“Fewer than the quarrels caused by one vague total.”

Mahendra Sahu did not agree immediately.

He thought about it throughout the day.

Credit in his shop was not merely a convenience.

In many village households, cash ran out in the middle of the month.

One family would pay after the crop was sold, another after wages arrived, another when money came from the city.

For him, keeping accounts under a household name was simple.

One household, one page, one total.

But simple for whom?

For the shopkeeper.

Not always for the customer.

That evening something happened.

Lalita Devi's son Ramesh took five kilos of rice on credit.

Two hours later Lalita Devi came and said, "I had told him we were not to buy on credit today. His wages come tomorrow; he will pay for it himself."

Mahendra Sahu said, "But the page is under the household name."

Lalita Devi replied, "The household name may be there, but his earnings are separate. He took the rice for himself, not for the family kitchen."

For the first time Mahendra Sahu understood that Devaki's question was not merely an argument inside one household.

The next day he brought a new blue ledger from the market.

He did not throw away the old ledger.

On it he pasted a white sheet and wrote: "Old Balance—Where the Purpose Is Unclear."

On the first page of the new ledger he made four columns.

Date.

Name of person taking the goods.

Purpose—"Household Shared" or "Personal/Special."

Amount.

Then he added a fifth column—"Payment credited against which balance."

His son Chhotu said, "If you write this much, customers will run away."

Mahendra Sahu said, "We will watch for seven days first."

On the first day the arrangement slowed the shop down.

An elderly woman buying oil said, "Why do you need the name of the person taking it? Don't you know my name?"

Mahendra Sahu smiled.

"I know it. Let the ledger know it too."

A child asked for biscuits on credit.

Mahendra Sahu asked, "For the household or for you?"

The child laughed.

"How can biscuits be shared?"

People in the shop laughed.

Mahendra Sahu wrote: "Personal—Ravi."

On the second day the problem was reversed.

A farmer bought jaggery and tea leaves for labourers.

He said, "Household shared."

Mahendra Sahu asked, "Household, or field work?"

The farmer scratched his head.

"Field."

In the ledger was written: "Special—Transplanting."

On the third day Devaki herself went to the shop.

She bought salt, turmeric and soap.

Mahendra Sahu opened the new ledger.

"Person taking—Devaki."

Devaki smiled.

"Salt and turmeric are household shared."

"The soap?"

Mahendra Sahu asked.

"That too is for the household."

"All of it?"

"All of it today."

Mahendra Sahu wrote it down.

Devaki asked, "And the old one thousand seven hundred and five?"

Mahendra Sahu showed her the old ledger.

"It has not disappeared. The old balance remains exactly as it is. As much as the family can clarify about the old entries, they can tell me and I will add notes. What cannot be clarified, I will not give a made-up name."

Devaki nodded.

"That is better."

"And the payment?"

"I'll pay cash today."

"Then there is no new credit."

"Yes."

When the seven-day trial was over, Mahendra Sahu placed the blue ledger before him after closing the shop.

Chhotu kept adding the figures.

There was more writing than under the old method.

But two kinds of quarrel had already diminished.

Once, Ramesh's personal rice had not been charged to his mother.

Once, goods taken for field labourers had not been merged into the household's monthly kitchen total.

And once, a woman paying two hundred rupees from her own savings had been able to say clearly, "Deduct this from my previous personal medicine debt."

For the first time Mahendra Sahu wrote a name in the payment column.

On the eighth day Harinayaran Jha himself came to the shop.

He had five hundred rupees in his hand.

Mahendra Sahu opened the old ledger.

"Against which balance?"

Harinayaran Jha raised his eyebrows.

"Our household's."

Mahendra Sahu said, "Against the old unclear balance?"

Harinayaran Jha thought for a few moments.

"Yes. Against the one that has been running for five years."

Mahendra Sahu deducted five hundred.

Then in the payment line he wrote: "Harinayaran Jha—Old Unclear Balance."

Harinayaran Jha looked at the words.

"Why 'unclear'?"

"Because the old page does not say what was taken, or for whom."

Harinayaran Jha opened his mouth to answer, then closed it.

After a while he said, "Fine. Better 'unclear' than falsely clear."

Mahendra Sahu smiled.

The new ledger did not fill up in a month, but its method became understood in the village.

Not every household separated all its internal accounts.

Not all credit became personal either.

Rice, salt, oil and matches were still usually entered as "Household Shared."

A school notebook went under a child's name.

Jaggery and tea for farm work became "Special—Field."

Medicine was entered under the name of the person for whom it had been bought.

And whenever someone paid money, Mahendra Sahu now always asked one sentence:

"Against which balance?"

Many people were irritated at first.

Then they thought and answered.

Sometimes the answer was, "The oldest one."

Sometimes, "Today's goods."

Sometimes, "My own line."

By Dussehra, Harinayaran Jha's old unclear balance had fallen to less than half.

Meanwhile, twice medicine was entered under Devaki's name, and once sewing thread.

Oil, lentils and salt continued under the Household Shared line.

One evening Devaki arrived at the shop and found Mahendra Sahu with both the old blue ledger and the new blue ledger open together.

On the old page, in thick letters, was still written: "Harinayaran Jha Household."

At the top of the new page was the same household name.

But in the lines below were separate names, dates and purposes.

Devaki looked at both pages.

Mahendra Sahu asked, "Has the household broken apart now?"

Devaki laughed.

"No."

"Then?"

Devaki placed a finger on the page of the new ledger.
“Now the account lets us see the people inside the household.”
Mahendra Sahu closed the ledger.
Naval was standing at the door.
He asked for a notebook.
Mahendra Sahu opened the ledger again.
“Household shared or Naval’s?”
Without laughing, Naval replied, “Naval’s.”
Mahendra Sahu wrote the date.
Then the name.
Then: “Personal—Notebook.”
The old household name remained at the top.
Below it, for the first time, the people too remained visible.

STORY 109

THE MANGO TREE AT THE EDGE OF THE FIELD

It was the last week of Chait. The scent of mango blossom had begun to fade, and tiny young fruits were appearing on the trees.

At the eastern edge of the village, an old mango tree stood on the last bund of Raghunath Chaudhary's field.

The trunk of the tree stood inside Raghunath's field.

No one disputed that.

The fruit of the tree was also considered Raghunath's.

No one disputed that either.

The dispute lay elsewhere.

It concerned the path by which the tree could be reached.

On the southern side of Raghunath's field, Ramsakhi Devi had two katthas of mung.

The rows of mung were new.

The soil was still soft.

The heaviest branch of the mango tree leaned towards Ramsakhi's field, but the ground beneath it was now full of mung plants.

Raghunath owned the tree.

Ramsakhi owned the mung.

And once mango season arrived, the men who climbed the tree to pick the fruit became a third party.

For many years Raghunath had sold the entire crop on contract before the mangoes ripened.

The trader would inspect the tree.

Estimate the fruit.

Name a lump-sum price.

Raghunath would accept.

After that, the risks of ripening, storms, insects, picking and transport belonged to the trader.

That year the trader was Shambhu Sahu.

He had already inspected the tree three times.

On the fourth visit he came carrying a thin notebook.

"There is more fruit than last year," he said.

Raghunath looked up.

"If there is more fruit, there should be more money too."

The bargaining went on for a long time.

In the end they settled at six thousand four hundred rupees.

Shambhu wrote in his notebook: "One tree, entire crop, picking by trader."

Raghunath did not use a thumb impression; he could write his name.

He signed.

At that time Ramsakhi was working with a hand hoe in her field.
 She had nothing to do with the bargaining.
 But when Shambhu, on his way back, stepped straight through her mung
 to reach the bund, Ramsakhi called out.
 "Not this way."
 Shambhu stopped.
 "What?"
 "There is mung here."
 "I'm only passing through."
 "Even empty feet crush plants."
 Shambhu took two steps back.
 Then he made the longer turn along the bund and went out.
 The matter might have ended there.
 But in the first week of Jeth, five men came on the day the mangoes were
 to be picked.
 Two bamboo poles.
 One rope.
 Three baskets.
 One long fruit-picking pole.
 And a sack full of cord.
 Shambhu was with them.
 The morning dew still lay on the mung leaves.
 Ramsakhi was pulling weeds at the far end of her field.
 The first picker stepped down from the road and walked straight through
 her mung.
 The second followed.
 The third carried a bamboo pole.
 Ramsakhi dropped her hoe and ran.
 "Stop!"
 The first man stopped.
 "The path is over there."
 Ramsakhi pointed towards the northern bund of Raghunath's field.
 Shambhu said, "Going around that way is much farther."
 "If it is farther, that does not make my mung any smaller."
 Shambhu did not laugh.
 He looked at the rows of mung.
 Broad footprints had already appeared in three places.
 "It is only two trips there and back," he said.
 Ramsakhi replied, "Five men going twice makes ten passages."
 "The mangoes will be heavy."
 "The mung is light, so it is easier to crush?"
 By then Raghunath had reached the field.
 Word had reached him that something had come to a halt.
 The moment he saw him, Shambhu said, "The tree is yours, the fruit is
 mine, but the path is closed."

Ramsakhi answered immediately, "Did you also give him a path on contract?"

Raghunath remained silent for a moment.

Shambhu took out his notebook.

He opened the page.

"One tree, entire crop, picking by trader."

Ramsakhi looked at the page.

"Where is my field written here?"

It was not.

Raghunath said, "Last year everyone went by this same way."

"Last year this patch was fallow."

That was true.

The previous year Ramsakhi had grown nothing on this strip.

The year before that there had been mustard, but it had already been harvested by mango-picking time.

This was the first year that the mung season and the mango season overlapped.

Shambhu looked up at the branch.

Most of the mangoes were on the southern side.

"The bamboo has to be set from that side," he said.

Ramsakhi replied, "Set the bamboo, but where will the feet stand?"

Shambhu did not answer.

The pickers remained standing.

One man asked quietly, "Shall we take down the mangoes from the northern side first?"

Shambhu nodded.

"Come."

The men went around along the bund of Raghunath's field.

The path was long.

There was an irrigation channel in the middle.

The soil in the channel was wet.

Carrying the bamboo across it was difficult.

On the first round, only two baskets of mangoes came down.

Shambhu checked the time.

"At this pace it will take the whole day."

Raghunath said, "Let it take the day."

Shambhu looked at him.

"The labour for the extra time comes out of my contract price."

Ramsakhi was listening from a distance.

She said, "And whose account carries the labour of my mung?"

Raghunath's face tightened.

He was irritated not with Ramsakhi, but with the situation.

The contract had been made by him.

He had never thought about the path.

By noon, much of the fruit from the northern side had been picked.

The heavy southern branch was still full.

Ramdev, one of the pickers, had climbed the tree.

From above he said, "If the rope stays below on the southern side, the baskets will come straight down."

Shambhu looked at Ramsakhi.

Ramsakhi said, "The rope goes through the air, not feet. Lower them."

A bamboo pole was planted on the bund.

The rope was turned over its top.

Ramdev filled the baskets from the tree.

Below, two men standing in Raghunath's field pulled the rope.

The basket swung from the southern branch and then came down into Raghunath's field.

In the first basket, some mangoes struck against one another.

Shambhu picked one up and examined it.

"It will bruise."

Ramdev called from above, "Give the rope a little more slack."

The second basket came down better.

The third better still.

Ramsakhi stood at the edge of her field and watched.

No one stepped into the mung.

But the work was slow.

By evening, even half the tree had not been cleared.

Shambhu said, "We will have to come again tomorrow."

Raghunath asked, "How much extra has this cost?"

"One day."

"In money?"

Shambhu named the four labourers.

Ramsakhi said, "Why did that money become necessary—because my field exists, or because the contract never mentioned a path?"

No one answered immediately.

Shambhu closed his notebook.

"We will talk tomorrow."

The next morning Raghunath first went to Ramsakhi's field.

He carried a short bamboo stick.

He stopped beside the footprints.

Of the three marks from the previous day, the plants had risen again in two.

In one place four or five plants were still flattened.

Ramsakhi said, "I am not asking money for these five plants."

"Then?"

"Next time it will not be only five."

Raghunath understood.

The issue was not merely the damage of the previous day.

The issue was that the next contract must not again rest on the same incomplete sentence.

He sent for Shambhu.

When Shambhu arrived, he had brought a thin bamboo and red cord.

“Let us measure the path,” he said.

The three of them walked around the edges of the fields.

From the road to the tree along Raghunath’s northern bund was one hundred and twenty-two paces.

Cutting straight across Ramsakhi’s field was fifty-six paces.

The difference was sixty-six paces.

Shambhu said, “That difference enters the labour cost.”

Ramsakhi said, “And the shorter path enters the mung.”

Raghunath did not bring out a map of the fields.

He drew three lines on the ground with the stick.

First—from the road along the northern bund.

Second—the place where the irrigation channel had to be crossed.

Third—the open circle beneath the tree.

“Where is the difficult part on this route?” he asked.

Ramdev, the picker, said, “The channel.”

The channel was not wide.

But when it was wet, crossing it while carrying bamboo was difficult.

Ramsakhi said, “There are two old planks at my house.”

Shambhu looked at her.

“Will you lend them?”

“For two days. I want them back unbroken.”

The planks were brought.

They were laid across the channel.

Carrying the bamboo became easy.

Now the difficulty was the baskets.

It took time to carry heavy baskets along the long bund.

Raghunath brought his old handcart.

The cart could run on the bund, but grass had to be cut in two places.

Within half an hour the route was cleared.

Shambhu checked the time again.

“Now it will not be as slow as yesterday.”

Ramsakhi smiled.

“And my field is not any smaller than yesterday either.”

By noon that day the remaining mangoes had been brought down.

Once, a basket swung towards Ramsakhi’s field.

The man holding the rope stopped it at once.

The basket remained hanging in the air.

Ramsakhi called from below, “The mangoes have not become mine.”

Everyone laughed.

So did Shambhu.

But after the laughter he took out his notebook.

“What should I write in the contract?”

Raghunath said, “Next year’s matter belongs to next year.”

Ramsakhi said, “No. Write now what we learned this year.”

Shambhu rested the notebook on his knee.

Raghunath said, “Fruit—one tree.”

Shambhu wrote it.

Ramsakhi said, "Access path—the owner's northern bund."

Shambhu wrote it.

Ramdev said, "Planks over the wet channel."

Shambhu laughed.

"Shall I write that in the contract?"

Raghunath said, "Do not write 'planks.' Write who must keep the route usable."

Shambhu wrote: "On picking day, keeping the access route usable is the tree-owner's responsibility."

Ramsakhi thought for a moment.

"If for some reason it becomes necessary to step into another field?"

Shambhu said, "Ask first."

"And if plants are crushed?"

Raghunath said, "Count the rows where they are crushed."

Ramsakhi said, "Not individual plants. Rows. Counting each plant is difficult."

Shambhu wrote: "If entry is unavoidable, prior permission; record the length of the row that is flattened."

Ramdev said, "And if mangoes fall in a storm?"

The matter halted again.

A storm does not ask permission.

Ramsakhi said, "If mangoes from the tree fall wherever the storm throws them, you may come to collect them. But if the field is wet, stay on the bund."

Shambhu wrote that down.

"If we write this much, will a mango contract become a book of land?" Raghunath joked.

Ramsakhi replied, "The tree stands on land."

That evening the heap of mangoes was weighed beside the road.

Shambhu received slightly less fruit than he had estimated.

Some young fruits had already fallen.

Some mangoes were damaged by insects.

Even so, he did not speak of breaking the contract.

Nor did Raghunath take the full cost of the extra day's labour upon himself.

They agreed to split the additional labour cost equally.

Ramsakhi paid nothing towards it.

Her two planks had been used.

On the way back, Shambhu cleaned the planks and left them at her door.

Three days later a strong wind came.

At noon five or seven unripe mangoes fell into Ramsakhi's mung.

Shambhu's young son came to collect them.

He stopped at the edge of the field.

Ramsakhi saw him from a distance.

"Come along the bund," she said.

The boy came along the bund.

Ramsakhi herself stepped down among the mung.

She picked up the mangoes one by one and placed them on the bund.

The boy said, "Kaki, keep two for yourself."

Ramsakhi shook her head.

"The contract belongs to your father."

The boy said, "But they fell in your field."

Ramsakhi laughed.

"Falling in a field does not change a name."

She put the mangoes in his hands.

When the rains came, the mung grew.

The three old footprints disappeared beneath green leaves.

In one place the plants remained sparse.

Ramsakhi loosened the soil there and pulled out the weeds.

Raghunath's mango tree became dense again.

The wounds on the branches where fruit had been picked were drying.

One day in Sawan, Shambhu met Raghunath at the shop.

He said, "Next year, before I inspect the fruit, I will inspect the path."

Raghunath said, "First inspect the tree."

Shambhu smiled.

"The price of the tree will come from the tree. The cost of the path will come from the path."

Phagun returned.

The tree blossomed again.

One day Shambhu reached the field with his notebook.

This time he did not go straight to the tree.

He stopped first by the roadside.

He looked towards Raghunath's northern bund.

The planks from the previous year were not lying over the channel.

He asked Raghunath, "Will this path be ready by picking time?"

Raghunath said, "It will."

That year Ramsakhi was harvesting lentils in her field.

From a distance she called, "Bargain over the mangoes later. Write the path first."

Shambhu opened his notebook.

The first line read: "Fruit of the tree."

The second: "Access path."

The third: "Accounting for unavoidable damage."

Then he looked up at the mango blossom.

Shambhu turned to the previous year's page.

The extra half-share of labour cost was written there too.

"If the path is ready beforehand this year, that cost will come down," he said.

Raghunath replied, "If it comes down, count that into the price."

Shambhu nodded.

Meanwhile another trader, Tejnarayan Sahu, arrived at the field.

He had heard that the flowering on Raghunath's tree was good.

Seeing Shambhu's notebook, he smiled.

"Are you buying mangoes or a path?"

Shambhu replied, "They are two different things."

Tejnarayan looked at the southern branch.

"If we unload straight through that field, half the time will be saved."

Ramsakhi stopped her sickle.

"This year there are lentils in that field."

Tejnarayan said, "By harvesting time it may perhaps be empty."

Ramsakhi replied, "A contract cannot run on 'perhaps.'"

Raghunath said nothing.

The previous year had taught him that when fruit was sold, it was not only the tree that entered the work.

The pickers' feet, bamboo poles, baskets, handcart and path all formed part of it.

Tejnarayan named a price.

It was two hundred rupees higher than Shambhu's.

Raghunath did not agree at once.

He asked, "Which way will you enter?"

Tejnarayan replied, "Whichever is easiest."

Raghunath said, "Easiest for whom?"

The conversation stopped there.

Tejnarayan looked at the tree again.

"You decide the route."

Raghunath pointed to the northern bund.

"This way."

Tejnarayan measured it for a while.

"One extra labourer may be needed."

"Then quote your price accordingly."

Tejnarayan reduced the price he had first named.

Shambhu raised his own price a little.

The two prices were now almost equal.

Ramsakhi resumed cutting her lentils.

She did not care who received the contract.

What mattered was only that her field should not become an unspoken part of someone else's bargain.

In the end Shambhu got the contract.

This time the first line in the notebook was not the fruit.

The first line was: "Access path: northern bund."

Second: "Keeping the path usable: tree-owner."

Third: "Picking and transport: trader."

Fourth: "Entry into another field: prior permission."

Only on the fifth line was the price of the fruit written.

Raghunath signed his name.

Shambhu signed his.

Ramsakhi did not sign.

Her field was not inside the contract at all.

She merely looked towards the bund.

This time Raghunath had already placed two sturdy planks across the channel.

Shambhu closed his notebook.

The bargaining had not even begun yet.

STORY 110

TWO DAYS OF TRANSPLANTING

It was the third Monday of Asadh, the first spell of rice transplanting.

By daybreak, dark clouds had risen from the direction of the Kamla River, but such clouds were nothing unusual in Asadh.

The sun was nowhere to be seen, yet people from the southern quarter of the village were already heading towards the fields.

A team of twelve women transplanting rice had been called on a two-day contract to work seven bighas belonging to Ramcharit Yadav.

Phoolmati Devi led the team.

With her were Saraswati, Malati, Bindiya, Reena, Chandrakala, Jasoda, Sugni, Kusum, Pano, Devaki and Phoolkumari.

They lived in different hamlets, but for five years, during the transplanting season, this team had worked together.

The agreement with Ramcharit had been made the previous Saturday.

They were to transplant twenty-four katthas on the eastern side in two days.

Payment would be by the kattha, but the whole team would remain reserved for Ramcharit's fields for both days.

That second sentence had never been entered in any register.

It had been spoken.

And everyone remembered a spoken agreement in a slightly different way.

On the first day the soil was good.

The water stood below the knee, the seedlings were of the right age, and bundles uprooted from the nursery had been placed beside the field.

The twelve women stepped into the field in a line.

By noon they had finished eight katthas.

By evening, fourteen.

Ramcharit was pleased.

"Only ten katthas will remain for tomorrow," he said.

Washing her hands, Phoolmati said, "If the water stays like this, we will be free just after noon."

Ramcharit laughed.

"My gain, then."

Phoolmati laughed too.

"Ours as well. We can take another field."

Ramcharit said nothing to that one sentence.

At the time, no one understood that the seed of the next day's quarrel lay in it too.

It rained lightly during the first watch of the night.

During the second, heavily.

Until four in the morning, rain hammered the thatch so hard that Phoolmati got up three times to clear the drain in the courtyard.

Around half past five the rain eased a little.

She opened her mobile phone.

There was no message from Ramcharit.

Only three women in the team had mobile phones; the others received news through them.

Phoolmati called Ramcharit.

The phone rang.

No answer.

She called again.

This time Ramcharit picked up.

“Babu, will we be able to enter the field?”

“There is too much water just now,” Ramcharit said, “but the seedlings have been uprooted. Everyone come. Once the clouds clear, we will begin.”

Phoolmati asked, “And if they do not clear?”

“How long do Asadh clouds ever remain? Come.”

The call ended.

Phoolmati sent word through the team.

By six, everyone had set out.

Some walked half a kos, some a kos and a half.

Pano left her small son at a neighbour's house.

Devaki wrapped the morning rotis in cloth and brought them with her.

Mud from the previous day was still dried into the corners of Jasoda's toenails.

At half past six, all twelve reached the bund of Ramcharit's field.

The rain grew heavy again.

The field held water two hand-spans higher than on the first day.

The bundles of seedlings lay on the bund, half soaked.

Ramcharit's younger son Nandu was pulling a sack over them.

Phoolmati looked at the field.

“It is difficult to enter now.”

Ramcharit said, “Let us watch for half an hour.”

Everyone sat on the higher part of the bund.

Half an hour passed.

The rain weakened, but water continued to enter the field through the northern drain.

Chandrakala got up and went towards it.

“Unless this is closed, the water will not fall.”

Ramcharit and Nandu went with hoes.

The mouth of the drain was diverted slightly.

“Now it will go down,” Ramcharit said.

The team sat again.

Seven forty-five.

Saraswati asked, “How long?”

Ramcharit looked at the sky.

“By eight or half past eight we will know.”

Eight o'clock came.

Clouds closed in again.
 This time with wind.
 Everyone had to move into Ramcharit's empty cowshed.
 Inside were three old tethering posts, some chaff and one broken plank.
 The twelve women kept changing places to sit.
 Some leaned against the wall; some remained standing.
 Malati thought of opening her rotis, then folded the bundle shut again.
 "We will eat once work begins."
 Phoolkumari said, "And if work never begins?"
 No one answered.
 At half past eight, Phoolmati asked Ramcharit again.
 "Babu, if today is to be cancelled, tell us now. We can ask elsewhere."
 Ramcharit replied at once, "Where will you go? Every field is flooded. The seedlings here have already been uprooted. Wait until nine."
 "All right."
 Phoolmati sat down again.
 At nine, the rain stopped.
 Everyone came out of the cowshed.
 The sky had not brightened, but the rain had ceased.
 Ramcharit planted a bamboo on the bund to check the depth of the water.
 Above the knee.
 "Let it fall a little more."
 At twenty past nine, two men in a field to the east set up a pump to drain water.
 Phoolmati looked over.
 "They have started."
 Ramcharit said, "Their field is higher."
 At half past nine Devaki's phone rang.
 The call was from home: it was time to give her mother-in-law her medicine.
 Devaki said, "I left the medicine ready. My daughter will give it."
 Phoolmati asked, "If we had gone home by now?"
 Devaki laughed, but it was a small laugh.
 "Then I would have given it myself."
 At ten Ramcharit said, "We can enter now. The water has gone down."
 Everyone gathered up their saris and clothes and went towards the field.
 Phoolmati placed the first foot in.
 The soil was not merely soft; it was flowing.
 When she lifted her foot, two seedlings floated away together.
 She came out.
 "The rows will not hold yet."
 Ramcharit stepped in himself.
 He walked three paces, then came back out.
 "Another half hour."
 Now no one had laughter left on her face.
 At ten fifteen Pano said, "Are we at work today, or merely sitting?"

Ramcharit replied, "You are here for the work."

"Then will the day count?"

Ramcharit fell silent for a moment.

"The transplanting was agreed by the kattha."

Pano said nothing.

Phoolmati looked at her.

The matter stopped there, but did not end.

By eleven the water had dropped somewhat.

Ramcharit said, "Come, let us try."

All twelve entered.

The first row advanced slowly.

Seedlings were being planted, but at barely half the normal pace.

Sometimes a foot sank deep; sometimes a seedling floated up again.

Twenty minutes later the rain began once more.

This time the drops were heavy.

Ramcharit kept saying, "Work a little. The cloud will pass."

After five minutes Phoolmati stopped the line.

"Are we planting seedlings or setting them afloat?"

Everyone came out.

In those twenty or twenty-five minutes, they had not completed even half a kattha.

Noon was near.

Malati now opened her rotis.

Everyone sat in the cowshed and ate.

Ramcharit had beaten rice and curd sent from his house and ate with Nandu.

No one raised the question of wages while eating.

Outside, the rain gradually weakened again.

At twelve forty-five it stopped.

At one, Phoolmati stepped into the field and tested the soil.

"Now it can be done."

This time the work truly began.

At one ten the line started moving.

For the first half hour, slowly.

Then the hands found their old rhythm.

In the afternoon the clouds tore open and light came through.

By three o'clock four katthas were complete.

Ramcharit's face opened with relief.

"See? The day was not wasted."

Phoolmati said nothing.

By half past four a total of six katthas had been transplanted.

The sky began darkening again.

Four katthas remained for a third day.

Everyone came out.

Feet were washed.

Clothes were wrung out.

The remaining seedling bundles were lifted to a higher part of the bund.

Ramcharit took out not a register, but his small notebook.

Opposite the first day he had written: "14 katthas."

For the second day he wrote: "6 katthas."

Phoolmati watched.

Ramcharit calculated.

"Twenty in all. Four katthas remain. Tomorrow morning they will be finished in two or three hours."

Phoolmati said, "All right."

Ramcharit continued, "Today's payment will be for six katthas."

This time Phoolmati did not answer immediately.

Pano did.

"Did we come here at half past six this morning for six katthas?"

Ramcharit said, "The contract was by the kattha."

"And the team was also reserved for two days."

"If the work could not be done, what am I supposed to do? Did I make the rain fall?"

Pano fell silent.

Phoolmati said quietly, "You did not cause the rain. Neither did we."

Ramcharit said, "Then?"

"Then it was never made clear beforehand who would carry the cost caused by it."

Nandu stood holding the notebook.

Ramcharit took it back from him.

"If I pay a full day's wage, the cost of six katthas becomes twice as much."

Phoolmati said, "We are not asking for a full day's transplanting wage."

Ramcharit looked slightly surprised.

"Then what?"

Phoolmati pointed towards the cowshed.

"From half past six in the morning until one, we remained here because you told us to wait. During those hours we could not take another field. That was not transplanting time, but it was still our time."

Ramcharit said, "The other fields in the village were closed too."

Chandrakala replied at once, "Mahato's field to the east started at ten."

"That field is higher."

"True. But if you had released us at nine, five of us could have taken half a day there."

Ramcharit's face tightened.

"So now it is my fault that I wanted to save the uprooted seedlings?"

Phoolmati shook her head.

"Again we have come to the word fault. I am not counting fault."

"Then what are you counting?"

"Time."

For a few moments there was silence.

Water dripped steadily beside the bund.

Nandu asked softly, "How much time?"

Phoolmati looked at him.

"Waiting from half past six until one ten. There was a twenty- or twenty-five-minute attempt at work in between. After that, four hours of transplanting."

Ramcharit said, "Will we count by the clock now?"

"No. I am saying it only so that we understand today."

Saraswati said, "If in the morning you had said, 'Today is cancelled,' we would have gone home. We would not have asked for money."

Devaki added, "If you had said, 'Let us watch until nine,' then a decision would have been made at nine."

Pano said, "But every time it was extended by another half hour."

Ramcharit opened the notebook.

He kept looking at the first day's "14" and the second day's "6."

"So you are saying there should be separate payment for waiting?"

Phoolmati said, "We are saying it needs a separate name. How much money it should carry can be decided by sitting together."

Ramcharit sat down on the ground.

Everyone formed a circle again beside the bund.

Nandu opened the notebook and held his pencil ready.

Ramcharit asked, "Three kinds?"

Phoolmati said, "Three."

"First?"

"Work done—the agreed rate per kattha."

"Second?"

"After we arrive, if you say stay and wait—compulsory waiting."

"Third?"

"Work cancelled. But write when cancellation has to be declared too."

Ramcharit laughed. "A rate for a cancelled day as well?"

Malati said, "Why, if we receive word before leaving home?"

Pano said, "But if cancellation comes after we have reached the field, both travel and time have gone."

Ramcharit looked at Phoolmati.

"Does everyone in your team agree on one thing?"

Phoolmati replied, "No. We are making it now."

At that answer, some of the tension went out of Ramcharit's face.

He said, "All right. First let us settle today's account."

Nandu drew three lines in the notebook.

Work.

Waiting.

Cancellation.

Ramcharit said, "Six katthas of work. Full rate for that."

No one disputed it.

"You are saying six and a half hours of waiting?"

Phoolmati said, "We were told to remain until one ten. Leave out the attempt at work in between. Count six hours."

Ramcharit asked, "A full day's rate for six hours?"

“No.”

“Half?”

There was a murmur among the team.

Saraswati said, “Half a day’s rate seems fair.”

Pano said, “But we sat for six hours.”

Phoolmati turned towards her.

“We sat; we did not transplant. The body tired less, the time was lost more.

Those are not the same thing.”

Pano fell silent.

Ramcharit said, “Then the waiting rate is half a day?”

Phoolmati said, “For today. Going forward, there also needs to be a time limit.”

“What limit?”

“Say beforehand whether we will wait more than two hours or not.

Otherwise the wait will keep growing by half-hour pieces.”

Nandu wrote: “Two hours.”

Ramcharit stopped him at once.

“I do not agree to that yet.”

Phoolmati said, “Then do not write it. Tomorrow, while we finish the remaining four katthas, we can discuss it again.”

This time no one quarrelled.

Today’s account was settled: full transplanting rate for six katthas, plus a fixed half-day amount for waiting, to be divided equally among the twelve.

Ramcharit paid.

Pano counted the money.

Phoolmati did not give a thumb impression in the notebook; she merely said, “Today’s arrangement is for today.”

Ramcharit also said, “Tomorrow for the rule going forward.”

Everyone went home.

There was no rain that night.

The next morning the sky was clear.

The water level in the field was right.

The remaining four katthas were transplanted by half past nine.

When the work ended, Phoolmati did not hurry home.

She sat down on the bund.

Ramcharit understood.

Nandu brought the notebook.

This time it was not only Ramcharit and the team. Two farmers from the eastern side also came and sat down.

They had heard about the previous day’s dispute.

One farmer, Ganesh Mahato, said, “If such a rule is made, then in the rains labourers will demand money the moment they reach a field.”

Phoolmati said, “Arriving and being made to wait are two different things.”

Ganesh said, “If they have already come, what can the farmer do?”

“Tell us immediately—cancelled. We will go home.”

“And the journey?”

Pano interrupted, “Write something for the journey too.”

Phoolmati raised a hand to stop her.

“First make three things clear.”

Ramcharit said, “Work—the agreed rate. That is clear.”

Nandu wrote it down.

“Cancellation before arrival?”

Phoolmati said, “If we receive word before setting out in the morning—no payment.”

Pano looked somewhat dissatisfied, but said nothing.

Ramcharit asked, “Immediate cancellation after reaching the field?”

Devaki said, “A small arrival amount. Not a full day.”

Ganesh Mahato laughed.

“Payment merely for travelling?”

Devaki looked at him.

“When you call a tractor from the market, if it returns without working, do you refuse to pay for its fuel?”

Ganesh stopped laughing.

Ramcharit said, “Fine. A small fixed arrival amount.”

Nandu wrote: “Full cancellation after arrival—arrival amount.”

Phoolmati said, “And waiting?”

Ramcharit asked, “For how long?”

That led to another discussion.

One hour seemed too little.

Three hours too much.

In the end a limit of two hours was agreed.

After the workers arrived, the farmer could say: wait for two hours.

Those two hours would carry a fixed waiting rate.

At the end of two hours there had to be a clear decision again—work begins, or the day is cancelled.

No “another two hours.”

If work began, the waiting rate would remain separate and the transplanting rate separate.

If the day was cancelled after two hours, the waiting rate would apply; the arrival amount would not be added on top of it.

Pano asked, “And if rain stops us again in the middle of work?”

Ramcharit laughed.

“Will this rule grow another twenty lines?”

Phoolmati laughed too.

“No. A short stoppage after work begins stays within the transplanting day. But if the farmer himself tells everyone to come out and sit, and the stoppage becomes long, then we discuss it again.”

Ganesh Mahato said, “Is this paper being made for a court or for a field?”

Phoolmati replied, “For the field. That is why keep it short.”

In the end Nandu wrote only four lines.

Work—agreed measure/rate.

Cancellation before arrival—no payment.

Waiting after arrival—not more than two hours; fixed waiting rate.

After two hours—work or full cancellation; clear decision.

Ramcharit himself added a fifth line.

“Extraordinary stoppage after work begins—to be settled separately that day.”

Phoolmati read it.

“This is right.”

Nandu wrote the date.

The names of all twelve women were not written individually.

The team was entered as: “Phoolmati Team, 12.”

Ramcharit wrote his name.

Phoolmati did not sign; she put her thumb impression.

Ganesh Mahato signed as a witness, although he did not fully like the rule.

He said, “Next time labourers in my field will mention this paper.”

Ramcharit replied, “If they do, set your own rate. At least the word ‘wait’ will no longer be free.”

Everyone fell silent at that sentence.

Because the quarrel had begun over money, but the real issue had turned out to be a single word—wait.

It was easy to tell someone to wait.

Waiting occupied part of someone else’s day.

The rule was first used the following week of Asadh in Ganesh Mahato’s field.

It was raining at dawn.

At five he sent word to the team: “Do not come today.”

No one reached the field.

No one asked for money.

By noon the sky cleared.

Ganesh regretted it.

He lost a day.

Phoolmati’s team found half a day’s work in another village.

That evening Ganesh said to Ramcharit, “See? I cancelled too early. I suffered the loss.”

Ramcharit laughed.

“That loss came from your decision, not from the workers’ waiting.”

Ganesh said nothing.

By the end of Asadh, the four lines from the notebook had been copied into three fields.

The rates differed from place to place.

In one place the waiting limit was one hour.

In another there was no arrival amount.

The rule did not become identical everywhere.

But one thing changed.

No one made transplanting workers sit from morning until evening and then counted only the katthas actually planted.

Nor did anyone place every risk of rain entirely upon the farmer.

Work had its own accounting.

A cancelled day had the accounting of a cancelled day.

And the stretch of time between them, which until then had belonged to no one's account, finally received a name—

Waiting.

STORY III

CARE OF THE HEIFER

On mornings in Bhadon, calves and heifers began coming out one by one from the rear hamlet of Barahi village.

Some had hemp ropes around their necks, some thin bamboo cords, some only an old bell.

The village's grown animals grazed separately, but eight calves and heifers were kept under one shared herding arrangement.

Every morning they were gathered beneath the large peepal tree.

From there Phoolkali Devi took them towards the eastern fallow ground, the canal embankment and the strip of green beside the bamboo grove.

At dusk she brought them back beneath the same peepal tree.

The eight households paid Phoolkali a monthly amount in grain and a little cash.

On paper, the arrangement was very simple.

Who owned the animal.

How much was due for the month.

How many days the calf or heifer had gone with the herd.

That was all.

The register had been made from unused pages left in an old notebook from Ramphal Sahu's grocery shop.

At the top, in red pen, was written: "Calf-Heifer Herding."

Phoolkali could read, but she wrote slowly.

So on the first Sunday of each month Ramphal filled in the register.

One line for the owner's name.

Another for the colour or identifying mark of the animal.

A third for the payment due.

Phoolkali's name appeared nowhere at the top of the page.

Everyone assumed that since Phoolkali did the work anyway, what was the need to write her separately?

Among the eight animals was a reddish-brown heifer.

There was a small white patch in the middle of her forehead.

Her owner, Chandrika Yadav, called her "Lali."

Phoolkali called her the same.

But Lali turned more quickly at Phoolkali's voice than at Chandrika's.

Phoolkali never said this aloud.

The animal belonged to the person who owned it.

Caregiving was work, not a claim.

Phoolkali understood that distinction very well.

For six months of the year Chandrika went towards Punjab for labouring work.

At home lived his wife Sunaina, two children and his elderly mother.

Sunaina looked after the grown cow.

Lali spent the day with Phoolkali.

One Tuesday in Bhadon, the bushes had grown thick along the far embankment of the canal.

The soil was slippery from the previous night's rain.

Phoolkali was getting all eight animals across one after another.

The first two crossed.

The third calf jumped.

Lali slipped behind it.

As she fell, her right hind leg scraped against a thick thorn-stump.

The heifer snorted loudly once.

Phoolkali immediately caught the rope.

The wound was not deep, but the skin had split and blood began to flow.

Phoolkali tied the other seven animals in the open strip beside the canal.

She tore the corner of her sari and tied it over the wound.

The village was half a kos away.

There was no mobile phone nearby with which to inform Sunaina.

Phoolkali slowly turned the heifer back towards the village.

The other animals came along too.

By the time they reached the peepal tree it was nine in the morning.

Sunaina was shaping cow-dung cakes in the courtyard.

Phoolkali called out, "Look at Lali's leg."

Sunaina came running.

"Is it badly cut?"

"The bleeding is stopping. But it would be better to wash it and put medicine on it."

The village livestock worker had gone that day to another panchayat for vaccination.

Phoolkali said, "Shall I bring wound wash and a dressing from the medicine shop in the market?"

Sunaina looked at Lali's leg.

"Bring it. Chandrika will settle the account when he comes."

Phoolkali went home.

From a bamboo box she took one two-hundred-rupee note and three fifty-rupee notes.

She had kept that money to buy rice at Saturday's market.

At noon her son Munna went to the market on a bicycle.

He brought wound-cleaning solution, ointment, bandages and two days' worth of dry bran.

The shopkeeper gave a receipt: three hundred and twenty rupees.

Phoolkali folded the receipt and put it into her box.

That evening Sunaina said, "I have spoken to Chandrika. He will return next week."

Lali did not go with the herd for three days.

Every morning Phoolkali went to the house to inspect the wound.

On the fourth day the heifer rejoined the group.

She still limped slightly while walking.

Phoolkali kept her in the middle of the herd rather than at the rear.

Where there were thorns, she removed them first by hand.

None of this work entered the register.

The register showed only a small mark for three days' absence.

Seven days later Chandrika returned.

In the evening the animals were coming back beneath the peepal tree.

He lifted Lali's leg and looked at it.

"The wound has healed."

Phoolkali said, "Yes, it is fine now."

She took out the receipt.

"Medicine and dressing cost three hundred and twenty."

Chandrika read the receipt.

Then he looked at Phoolkali.

"Don't we pay you the monthly herding fee?"

At first Phoolkali thought he was joking.

But his face was serious.

"You pay the herding fee."

"Then why is this medicine separate?"

Phoolkali paused before answering.

"The herding fee is for taking them to graze. The medicine came from my pocket."

Chandrika said, "The animal was in your care during the day. It was injured there."

Five households were still standing beneath the peepal tree, waiting to take their animals home.

Hearing the exchange, everyone looked that way.

Phoolkali kept her voice low.

"It was in my care, which is why I did not leave the wound untreated. But had medicine expenses already been included in the herding payment?"

Chandrika pointed towards the register.

"What is written there?"

Ramphal opened it.

Beside Chandrika's name was written: reddish-brown, white patch on forehead.

The monthly payment was written.

Nothing about medicine.

Phoolkali's name was not there either.

Ramphal said, "This was never written at all."

Chandrika immediately said, "Then how am I to accept that every expense that happened is mine?"

Phoolkali placed the receipt in his hand.

"If you do not accept it, keep the receipt. But next time settle the matter beforehand."

Sunaina arrived.

She said, "I told her to bring the medicine."

Chandrika looked at her.

“How much did you authorise?”

Sunaina fell silent.

She had only said, “Bring it.”

She had given no limit.

Ramphal closed the register.

“We will not settle the money today. First let us understand what exactly is included in the herding.”

People took their animals away from beneath the peepal tree.

Phoolkali left the receipt in Chandrika’s hand.

“Lali will go tomorrow too. The dispute will not keep her back.”

She went home.

That night there was not enough rice in Phoolkali’s house.

Munna asked, “Why didn’t you bring rice today?”

“The money went on medicine.”

“Will it come back?”

“When the account is settled.”

Munna said nothing.

The next morning Lali came beneath the peepal tree again.

Chandrika himself brought her by the rope.

Phoolkali looked at the heifer’s leg.

“Do not make her run hard today.”

Chandrika said, “I am not going to swallow the medicine money.”

Phoolkali replied evenly, “Nor am I saying that you are.”

The conversation stopped there.

Three days later an animal-vaccination camp was held in the village.

A large tarpaulin was stretched beneath the peepal tree.

Two employees from the block office had come with the livestock worker.

They checked the number on each animal’s ear, asked the owner’s name, and recorded the vaccination date.

When Lali’s turn came, the employee asked, “When was the previous vaccination?”

Chandrika thought for a moment.

“Perhaps in Phagun.”

From behind him Phoolkali said, “Not Phagun. The first Tuesday of Chait. It rained that day.”

The employee looked at her.

“Are you the owner?”

“No. I herd her during the day.”

The employee looked again at Chandrika.

Chandrika said, “She looks after her all day.”

“Any problem after the previous vaccination?”

Chandrika shook his head.

Phoolkali said, “She had a slight fever that night. It was gone by morning.”

The employee wrote something in the register.

“Was the owner told?”

Phoolkali looked at Chandrika.
 He had been in Punjab at the time.
 Sunaina had been told.
 “The household was informed.”
 The employee administered the vaccine.
 Phoolkali stood stroking Lali’s neck.
 Chandrika moved a little aside.
 That evening Ramphal opened the herding register.
 “This register is incomplete.”
 Chandrika said, “The vaccination register is separate.”
 Ramphal replied, “That is not what I mean. Our herding register is incomplete.”
 He showed everyone the pages.
 The owner’s name was there.
 The animal’s identifying mark was there.
 The payment was there.
 But the person doing the work was not.
 There was no record of illness or injury.
 There was no rule for emergency expenses.
 There was no limit on whose permission counted, or up to what amount.
 Chandrika said, “If we write all this, herding will become an office.”
 Ramphal laughed.
 “Not an office. Five lines.”
 Phoolkali was not there.
 Ramphal said, “If we make the rule without her, it will again be incomplete.”
 The following Sunday people from all eight households sat beneath the peepal tree.
 Phoolkali came late.
 She had first taken the animals out to graze.
 Ramphal had brought a new notebook.
 Chandrika had brought the receipt too.
 Three hundred and twenty rupees.
 As soon as the meeting began, everyone started giving an opinion.
 One owner said, “Small cuts and scrapes are bound to happen in herding.”
 Another said, “If every medicine expense is separate, how high will the monthly cost go?”
 Phoolkali listened.
 Ramphal asked, “You tell us.”
 Phoolkali said, “I do not want any extra profit. I want a limit.”
 “What kind of limit?”
 “What is ordinary work, and what is an emergency.”
 Counting on her fingers, she said:
 “Untying and tying ropes, taking them out to graze, giving them water, clearing thorns, bringing them back in the evening—these are part of herding.”

"If a wound needs washing with household salt water or an old cloth, I will do that too."

"But money to buy medicine?"

She stopped.

"For that, set a limit beforehand."

"If the owner is available, I will ask."

"If the owner is not available, and delay may harm the animal, up to how much may I spend on my own decision?"

Someone said, "Fifty."

Someone else said, "A hundred."

Chandrika said, "What do you get for a hundred these days?"

Phoolkali looked at him.

It was the first thing he had said in her favour.

Ramphal wrote in the notebook: "Emergency limit: two hundred rupees."

Phoolkali asked, "And if it goes above two hundred?"

Sunaina said, "Permission from the owner or from the person in the household who makes decisions about the animal."

"And if the phone does not connect?"

Ramphal wrote: "One witness."

Chandrika asked, "Who can be a witness?"

"Another animal owner, Ramphal, or the livestock worker."

Phoolkali said, "And the receipt?"

"Where available, a receipt."

"And where none is available?"

Ramphal thought for a moment.

"Name of medicine, amount, date, and the person who brought it."

The lines in the notebook kept increasing.

Chandrika smiled.

"What happened to the five lines?"

Ramphal said, "Animals have more than five things to say."

The meeting laughed.

Phoolkali did not.

She said, "And one more line is needed—caregiver."

Everyone fell silent.

Ramphal asked, "Your name?"

"Today, mine. Tomorrow, if Munna goes, his. Sometimes if Sunaina keeps her heifer at home and watches her, then hers."

"The owner separate, the caregiver separate?"

"Yes."

Chandrika said, "Will the owner's name become less important?"

Phoolkali answered immediately, "Why would the owner's name become less important? The animal is yours. Whoever did the day's work has their name in the work line."

At the top of a new page Ramphal made six fields.

Animal number or identifying mark.

Owner.

Today's caregiver.
 What is included in ordinary work.
 Emergency expense/receipt.
 Handover.
 Someone said, "Vaccination?"
 Ramphal made a small mark beneath the emergency-expense line:
 "Health information."
 Phoolkali said, "Write the vaccination date too."
 Ramphal wrote it.
 The notebook now truly looked like an office register.
 But there would not be something to write every day.
 Only when something changed.
 The first entry was Lali's.
 "Old wound—right hind leg."
 "Medicine—three hundred and twenty."
 "Prior permission—Sunaina."
 "Receipt available."
 The amount exceeded the new two-hundred-rupee limit by one hundred
 and twenty.
 That raised another question.
 Ramphal said, "The rule was made today. Do not apply a new limit to an
 old event."
 Chandrika folded the receipt.
 "I will pay the three hundred and twenty."
 Phoolkali said nothing.
 Chandrika could not take out all three hundred and twenty from his
 pocket.
 He had two hundred and seventy.
 He said, "Fifty tomorrow."
 Phoolkali counted the money.
 "Fine."
 Ramphal asked, "Shall I write it in the register?"
 Phoolkali laughed.
 "That is my credit, not the heifer's."
 Everyone laughed again.
 The new register began operating the following week.
 For the first three days there was nothing to write.
 On the fourth day a black calf chewed through its rope while grazing.
 Phoolkali tied on an old cord from home.
 No money was spent.
 The register simply said: "Cord replaced, old household cord."
 On the sixth day another calf's eye began watering.
 Phoolkali informed the owner.
 The owner called the livestock worker.
 He himself bought the medicine.

In the register Phoolkali's name appeared only on the line: "Information given."

Phoolkali liked that.

Not every expense appeared under her name.

Not every task appeared under her name either.

Whoever did the work was written where the work belonged.

A month later Chandrika was preparing to leave for Punjab again.

Before going, he walked the herding route with Phoolkali to see Lali.

Lali was now running quickly.

Only a thin white line remained at the site of the wound.

Chandrika said, "Will this mark remain?"

Phoolkali said, "For a few days. Then the hair will cover it."

"Is the vaccination date in the notebook?"

"Yes."

"The fever?"

"Yes."

Chandrika remained quiet for a moment.

"I am the owner, but there were many things I did not know."

Phoolkali said, "Being the owner and being in front of the animal all day are not the same thing."

This time Chandrika did not argue.

He left for Punjab.

In Agahan it was decided that Lali would now remain at home.

She was growing bigger.

Her pace no longer matched the smaller calves in the shared herd.

On the day of handover Sunaina came beneath the peepal tree.

Ramphal opened the notebook.

There were three health notes on Lali's page.

The old wound.

The vaccination.

One occasion when herding had been stopped for half a day because her stomach had bloated.

Money for medicine had been spent only on the first wound.

The second time, household ajwain water had been given—"Cost zero" was written beside it.

Sunaina read the entries.

Phoolkali handed her Lali's rope.

Ramphal asked, "Handover all right?"

Sunaina looked at Lali's eyes, legs and neck.

"All right."

Phoolkali said, "There is a small itchy patch behind the left ear. Watch it for two days."

Ramphal wrote that down too.

Sunaina put her thumb impression.

Phoolkali slowly wrote her own name.

At the top of the page, the owner's name was that of Sunaina and Chandrika's household.

Below, in the caregiver line, Phoolkali's name appeared again and again across the months.

No one was asking for a share in the animal.

No one was dividing ownership.

It merely showed that the heifer had lived between two places of responsibility—the household and the daytime herd.

Lali pulled slightly on the rope and moved towards Sunaina.

Phoolkali kept her hand withdrawn.

The heifer turned once to look at her.

Phoolkali did not call out.

She looked at the notebook.

Earlier, the register had contained the animal, the owner and the money.

Now it also contained the name of the hands that did the work.

That was all that had changed.

STORY 112

THE OIL-PRESS CAKE

On the road from the eastern hamlet of Majhaul village to the market stood Jugal's oil-press house.

Seen from outside, it looked like a low, thatched room, but inside two smells always lived together—the sharp scent of mustard and the smell of hot iron.

Mustard sacks were stacked one after another to the left of the doorway.

On the right stood the iron pressing machine, whose belt made a steady ghar-ghar sound as it turned.

In front of the machine, a stream of oil dripped through a narrow brass-coloured channel; from the rear opening, warm cakes of pressed seed emerged and fell into a bamboo basket.

For oil, people in the village looked at the measure.

For oil-cake, most people relied on memory.

Someone remembered that the previous time they had received all the cake.

Someone remembered that the oilman had kept half.

Someone said, "I paid less cash, so I left the cake behind."

Someone else said, "I paid in full, so I took the cake home."

Rules that had been in use since Jugal's father's time survived differently in different people's mouths.

On paper, only three things were written—the name, the weight of the mustard seed, and the weight of the oil.

There was no line for oil-cake.

One clear morning after the Bhadon clouds had lifted, Malati Devi arrived with two sacks.

The larger sack had not come on her head; it had come on a bullock cart.

She dragged the smaller sack herself to the doorway.

There were two cows and a heifer in her household.

After the rains, green fodder had become scarce, and prepared feed in the market was growing expensive.

This time Malati had come thinking more about the oil-cake account than about mustard oil.

She needed oil for the house, but she needed the cake too.

She had tied a small knot of red thread to the large sack.

Jugal placed the sack on the scale.

"This one first?" he asked.

"Yes. This is mustard from our household," Malati said. "The small sack belongs to my sister. Press that afterward."

Jugal wrote the weight in the ledger.

Malati leaned over and looked at the page.

"Where is the line for the oil-cake?"

Jugal raised his head.

"The oil-cake?"

"Yes. Write down however much comes out."

Jugal smiled faintly.

"What is there to write? The oil-cake belongs to the press house."

Malati's hand stopped on the sack.

"Who said so?"

Jugal thought perhaps she had taken it as a joke.

"That is the custom here. We charge a lower pressing fee, so the oil-cake remains with us."

Malati's expression did not change, but her voice grew thinner.

"How am I to know that the pressing fee is lower?"

"Everyone knows."

"I do not."

Jugal did not close the ledger.

Malati looked at the rate-board hanging by the door.

In large letters it said: "Mustard pressing — per ten kilos ... rupees."

There was no mention of oil-cake.

Malati pointed to the board.

"Is oil-cake written here?"

Jugal too looked at the board.

"Not every old custom is written on the board."

"Then how does an old custom get placed on my head?"

At that moment three other customers were waiting inside the press house.

The first was Mahendra Yadav, sitting with two metal canisters.

The second was Radhika Devi, whose small sack lay by the scale waiting to be pressed.

The third was Budhan Sahu, who had come to watch a neighbour's sack being pressed before bringing his own mustard.

Mahendra intervened.

"I leave the oil-cake here. I have no cattle."

Radhika immediately said, "Last time I took half."

Jugal looked at her.

"You paid more."

Radhika scratched her head.

"How much more?"

Before answering, Jugal turned the pages of the ledger.

In the previous year's account only the total amount paid was written.

Why it was higher was not recorded.

Budhan laughed.

"My father used to say that in the old days the oilman took his own share from the cake."

Malati said, "How large a share?"

Budhan stopped laughing.

"That... varied from household to household."

"So is that a rule or a memory?" Malati asked.

The machine was still switched off.

Jugal's younger brother Mohan was oiling the belt.

He was listening to both sides but did not interrupt.

Malati continued, "I need both the oil and the cake. I saved this mustard thinking of fodder for the cows. If you were going to keep the cake, you should have told me beforehand. I would have worked out a different bargain."

Jugal said, "If I give everyone all the cake, the machine cannot run at this rate."

"Then change the rate."

"If I raise the rate, people will say Jugal has increased the charge."

"And if you keep the cake, what will people who do not know the custom say?"

For a few moments after that sentence, only the sound of crows outside could be heard in the oil-press house.

Jugal sat down on the threshold.

He was not angry.

He was uncomfortable.

He knew the cost of electricity, belt repairs, straining cloth and Mohan's wages.

The oil-cake could be sold, and that made it possible to keep the cash pressing fee low.

But the arrangement was so old to him that it had never seemed something that needed to be explained to customers.

For Malati, it was the first time she had heard it.

"Do one thing," Mohan said softly.

Jugal looked at him.

"What?"

"Do not press this sack yet. First look at the accounts of the last three or four customers."

Jugal frowned.

"Where is oil-cake written in the ledger?"

"That is exactly why we should look."

They opened the old ledger.

There were names.

Weights.

Oil weights.

Payments.

Beside some names, a small pencilled "kh" had been written.

In a few places, there was an "a."

Jugal said, "'Kh' means the cake was left here. 'A' means half."

Malati asked, "Where is the key to these signs written?"

Jugal kept turning the pages.

There was no key anywhere.

Mohan smiled.

"I thought 'A' meant 'arrived.'"

Mahendra burst out laughing.

Jugal laughed too, but immediately closed the ledger.

"Very well," he said. "It is unclear."

Malati said, "Lack of clarity cannot become my oil-cake."

Radhika looked at her own sack.

"Settle my pressing first. I do not want half; I want all the cake."

Mahendra said, "I do not need the cake. If that makes the cash fee lower, keep it."

Budhan said, "I have one calf at home. I want half."

Three customers, three needs.

For the first time, Jugal saw the custom of his press house not as one rule, but as a set of different bargains.

The problem was not simply who owned the oil-cake.

The problem was that before pressing began, no one clearly said whether the cash fee had been reduced in exchange for the cake.

Once the mustard seed went into the machine, it was easy for the terms to become blurred.

And once the cake came out and fell into a common heap, it became even harder to tell how much belonged to whom.

Mohan washed three bamboo baskets and brought them over.

"From today, keep each batch separate," he said.

Jugal asked, "Every day?"

"At least until the rule is written clearly."

Malati said, "Keep the batches separate even after the rule is written. Then people can see how much actually came out."

Jugal said nothing.

He sold oil-cake; weighing it was not unfamiliar work.

But weighing it separately for each customer's sack meant extra labour.

"That will increase the work," he said.

Malati replied, "The value of the cake is part of the work too."

The conversation might have stalled again.

Just then Mahendra placed his metal canisters on the floor and said, "Press Malati's sack first. Let the cake fall into a separate basket. Let us see how much comes out."

Jugal agreed.

Malati's sack with the red thread was brought in front of the machine.

Mohan opened it and poured the mustard seed into a shallow basket.

Jugal checked the scale again.

Beside the recorded weight, he drew a small line.

"What does that line mean?" Malati asked.

"It marks this batch."

"Write what the mark means too."

Jugal looked at her once, then wrote at the top of the page: "Oil-cake weighed separately."

The machine began to run.

Its ghar-ghar sound filled the press house.

The mustard seed slowly disappeared into the iron mouth.

The first stream of warm oil ran down the channel into a vessel.

At the back, Mohan broke the first cake as it emerged and placed it in the basket.

Malati watched the oil-cake more than the oil.

The cake was hot.

When she touched it, she immediately pulled her hand back.

"Not yet," Mohan said. "Let it cool."

Malati's entire sack was pressed.

The oil was measured.

After the oil-cake cooled, the basket and cake were weighed together.

Jugal subtracted the basket's weight and wrote the oil-cake weight separately.

For the first time, four figures stood beside Malati's name on the page—mustard, oil, oil-cake, and payment.

Malati looked at the numbers.

"Now tell me: what exactly is your fee?"

Jugal quoted the amount from the old rate-board.

"Is that the reduced rate?" Malati asked.

"Yes."

"What would the rate be if I paid in full?"

Jugal fell silent.

Because no full-cash rate had ever been written.

He began mentally adding the market value of the oil-cake.

Radhika said, "If you simply add the full market price of the cake now, that will not become a fair pressing rate for the day. You also have expenses in selling the cake."

Jugal looked at her.

So did Malati.

Radhika's point was not on the oilman's side. It was on the side of the account.

Mohan brought out the pages for oil-cake sales from the previous three months.

Jugal looked at the total quantity sold, the total cash received, and the number of days the machine had worked.

No one could sit there and immediately calculate the entire profit and loss.

Malati said, "I am not asking for the full accounts of your press house today. I am asking for the right to know the terms of my own batch."

Jugal nodded.

It was a small point.

And because of that small point, the entire quarrel became smaller.

Pressing did not stop for the rest of the morning.

Malati's oil-cake remained separate.

Before Radhika's pressing began, Jugal said clearly, "If you pay the old reduced cash fee now, the press house will keep a share of the oil-cake. If you

want all the cake, the fee will be higher. I will calculate and write the full rate by evening.”

Radhika said, “Do not press my sack until the rate is written.”

Jugal did not become irritated.

“Fine.”

For the first time, he held back three sacks at the doorway because the rule had only been half made.

That evening Jugal, Mohan, Malati, Radhika and Mahendra sat again inside the oil-press house.

Budhan came too, because without him no village meeting about accounts ever seemed complete.

Jugal had written two options on a thin sheet of paper.

First: “Full cash fee: all oil-cake produced belongs to the customer.”

Second: “Reduced cash fee: a pre-agreed share of the oil-cake produced belongs to the press house.”

Malati asked, “How much of a share?”

Jugal had thought of writing a percentage.

Mahendra said, “Not everyone understands percentages.”

Mohan said, “The amount of cake from ten kilos of mustard will not be exactly the same every time.”

Radhika said, “Then write ‘one-fourth of the oil-cake.’ One-fourth of whatever comes out.”

Jugal said, “Market prices keep changing.”

Malati replied, “Then the cash rate may change. But the choice must exist before the pressing begins.”

The conversation returned to the original point.

How much the rate should be was for the oilman to determine.

Which option to choose was for the customer to decide knowingly.

The difference between the two options had to be clear.

And the rule could not change after pressing had begun.

Jugal looked at his figures.

He set the full-cash fee a little above the reduced rate.

For the reduced rate he wrote a fixed share of the oil-cake.

Mohan suggested that the rate-board at the door should have two lines beneath the mustard pressing charge.

Malati said, “And the ledger should have a line for the option chosen.”

Jugal opened a fresh page of the ledger.

At the top he made five columns—name, mustard, option, oil, oil-cake.

A sixth column was made for payment.

Mahendra laughed.

“People will run away when they see so many columns.”

Malati smiled.

“People run farther from unclear accounts.”

There was still the matter of Malati’s batch from that day.

The old terms had not been stated clearly.

Jugal could not simply give away all the oil-cake while charging the old reduced fee, because that day's work had costs.

Malati could not accept a condition that had only been stated after the pressing was done.

Radhika said, "Today's mistake belongs to the rule. Do not put all of it on one person."

Jugal looked at Malati.

"You take all your oil-cake. Will you pay, at the next market, the difference between the full-cash rate and what you have already paid?"

Malati thought for a few moments.

"I will. But write in the ledger that this is the new full-cash rate, not a penalty."

Jugal wrote it.

Malati put her thumb impression.

She filled her oil-cake into a sack.

It was heavy.

Mahendra stood up and caught one side.

Malati said, "Leave it. I will have Mohan place it on the cart."

She took the oil-cake home.

Three days later a new rate-board hung at the entrance of the oil-press house.

The old board had not been removed.

Two new lines had been added beneath it.

"OPTION 1 — Full cash fee; all oil-cake belongs to the customer."

"OPTION 2 — Reduced cash fee; the written share of oil-cake belongs to the press house."

Below, in smaller letters, was written: "The option will be marked in the ledger before pressing begins."

On the first day, people read the board and asked more questions.

Jugal felt the work had slowed down.

On the second day, there were fewer questions.

On the third day, an elderly customer set his sack on the scale and said, "Do it the old way for me."

Jugal asked, "Which old way?"

The old man fell silent.

Mohan pushed the ledger towards him.

"Cash or oil-cake?"

The old man read the rate-board.

"I have no cattle. The reduced-cash option with the oil-cake."

Mohan wrote "oil-cake" in the option column.

Later Malati came carrying her younger sister's sack.

This time she had not tied a red thread to it.

Jugal placed the sack on the scale.

"Which option?"

Malati said, "Full cash. The oil-cake goes home."

Jugal wrote it down.

The machine started.
Warm cakes of pressed seed began falling into a separate basket.
No one asked any longer what the old custom had really been.
In place of an old custom, the chosen terms were now written down.
Oil had always been measured in the press house.
Now the oil-cake too was no longer merely a heap.
It had become part of the account.

STORY 113

THE HERDSMAN'S WHISTLE

In Majhaul village, the first communal sound of the morning was not the crowing of a cock.

On days when the shared herd went out to graze, a thin whistle sounded just before sunrise.

The sound rose from the eastern hamlet, travelled through the middle of the village, and moved towards the southern bund.

The moment it was heard, ropes began to be untied in the cowsheds.

Cows, heifers, bullocks, and even two or four goats were brought to the doorways.

The animals left behind the smell of their separate homes and became one large herd.

The whistle remained in the hand of the person whose turn it was to herd that day.

When the herd returned in the evening, the whistle was hung at the doorway of the next household.

The custom was so old that no one could say who had first bought the whistle.

The mouth of the little brass whistle was slightly flattened on one side.

Its sound was not sharp; it came out a little hoarse.

Even so, the animals recognised its signal.

A rule governing the village day rested upon one small whistle.

The rule was simple—turn by household.

As many households as there were on the list, that many days made up the cycle.

First Ramkripal's household, then Budhni's, then Devnarayan's, then Phoolmati's old household, and then onward.

The list did not change according to whether a household had one cow or five animals.

Nor did it immediately take notice when someone's cowshed became empty.

There was no formal sheet of paper; an old account book and people's memories together kept the turns moving.

Budhni Devi had one cow—Gauri.

Gauri was thin-bodied but quick-footed.

Budhni's husband worked away from the village at a brick kiln.

At home were Budhni, her daughter Chanda, and Gauri.

When Budhni's turn came, she herself took the herd out.

By noon Chanda would bring rice and a small container of salt and chilli to the edge of the field.

At the other end of the scale, Devnarayan's household had five animals.

Two milch cows, one heifer, one old bullock and one young bullock.

Devnarayan had three sons; there was no shortage of working hands in the household.

Even so, his herding turn came no more often than Budhni's.

Devnarayan used to say, "The herd grazes all at once. Whether there is one cow or five, the herder walks the same path."

Budhni would answer, "The path is the same, but the responsibility for five animals is not the same as for one cow."

The matter had never become a full quarrel in the village.

It would arise in conversation and then get buried beneath the next task.

The strangest name on the list was that of Phoolmati Devi.

Her husband Rameshwar had died three years earlier.

In Rameshwar's time there had been two cows in their household.

One cow was sold to pay for medical treatment.

A few months after Rameshwar's death, Phoolmati sent the other cow to her daughter.

Now Phoolmati's cowshed was empty.

Yet the old herding list still carried the name "Rameshwar Household."

In the first year Phoolmati sent her fifteen-year-old nephew on the day of her turn.

In the second year she gave Devnarayan's younger son half a seer of rice and had him take her turn.

By the third year she began to wonder—how long would this account continue?

One Bhadon morning the whistle was hanging at her doorway.

The previous household had left it there during the night.

When Phoolmati woke and opened the door, the whistle was swinging from a bamboo peg.

She took it down and placed it in her palm.

The brass was cold.

She smiled.

"There is no one in my cowshed, but the whistle has come looking for me."

Her neighbour Budhni was going to fetch water.

She heard the remark.

"It is your turn today, isn't it?"

Phoolmati said, "The list says so."

"Then who will go?"

"So far, only the whistle."

Both women laughed, but the laughter did not last long.

That day Phoolmati said to Devnarayan's middle son Chhotan, "You take the herd. In the evening I'll give you two kilos of rice."

Chhotan agreed.

He knew the animals, and he also knew how to blow the whistle.

At dawn the herd gathered at the village square.

Budhni placed Gauri's rope in Chhotan's hand.

Devnarayan brought out all five of his animals.

From the other households, twenty-seven animals gathered in all.

Chhotan blew the whistle.

The herd moved.

The day passed ordinarily.

At noon the old bullock once tried to enter the mud near the pond, and Chhotan stopped it with the sound of his stick.

In the evening a heifer ran towards home ahead of the others; Chhotan blew the whistle and brought it back into the herd.

No animal was lost.

No field was trampled.

Even so, the question arose after evening.

As Chhotan was returning home with the rice, Devnarayan asked, "Whose turn was it?"

"Phoolmati Kaki's."

"You went?"

"Yes."

"And you got rice?"

Chhotan nodded.

Devnarayan remained silent for a while.

Then he said, "I have five animals. Budhni has one. Phoolmati has none. Yet all three households get the same number of turns. Whose arithmetic is this?"

Chhotan did not answer.

The next evening four or five people began discussing the matter at the village square.

Budhni was there too.

Devnarayan said, "I send five animals and do one day's herding. Budhni sends one animal and also does one day. Phoolmati sends nothing, yet her household also has one day on the list. What kind of argument is this—that the rule is old, therefore it must be good?"

Budhni said, "You send five animals, but there are three young men in your household. I have one cow, and when my turn comes, I alone give up the whole day."

Devnarayan immediately replied, "Then should we count people or animals?"

Jagadish Kaka, sitting nearby, laughed.

"If we count everything, we will stop herding and start a census."

A few people laughed.

Phoolmati did not.

She said, "Remove my name."

Devnarayan looked at her.

"Removing your name will not settle the matter. What if you buy another cow tomorrow?"

"When I buy one, add my name again."

Jagadish Kaka said, "The old list is of households, not animals. As long as the household remains, the name remains."

Phoolmati asked, "If there is no animal in the household, whose herding am I supposed to do?"

Jagadish Kaka fell silent.

This time the matter could not be buried.

The following week a new cycle of the herding list was due to begin.

The old account book travelled with the whistle.

On its first page were the names of thirty households.

Some names were crossed out; some had been written again above the old ones.

Some households had split between two brothers but still remained one name on the list.

Some had moved to town and had empty cowsheds.

Some now had three to five animals.

The list remembered the village of twenty years ago, not the herd of today.

Budhni proposed, "First let us count."

Jagadish Kaka asked, "Count what?"

"The animals that actually go with the herd every day."

Devnarayan said, "Fine. If I have five animals, do I get five turns?"

"I did not say that."

"Then?"

Budhni thought for a moment and fell silent.

The truth was that counting turns only by number of animals was not simple either.

A herder took twenty-seven animals out in one day.

Adding five more animals did not make the path five times longer.

But a household with five animals certainly benefited more than a household with one.

The next evening ten people gathered on the veranda of the panchayat building.

No formal panchayat had been called.

The whistle, the account book and one blank sheet of paper lay on the table.

Phoolmati came too.

She placed a finger on the line bearing her household's old name.

"This says 'Rameshwar Household.' Rameshwar is no more. There are no animals. I am still here. Which of these three things is the herding register actually recording?"

No one answered at once.

Devnarayan said, "It should record the animals."

Budhni said, "It should record labour too."

"How?"

"Herding is not only walking behind the animals."

Budhni began to count.

"In Sawan the eastern footpath was blocked by grass—who cut it?"

"All of us."

“Near the pond the descent filled with mud—who planted the bamboo there?”

“All of us.”

“In the evening, when calves are counted, it may not be someone’s turn, but whoever is there helps.”

Devnarayan said, “Then count those tasks too.”

No decision was reached that night.

They agreed only that for three days they would observe the actual work.

On the first day it was Budhni’s turn.

At dawn Jagadish Kaka arrived with the account book in his hand.

“How many animals?”

They counted—twenty-eight.

“How many from each household?”

The numbers were written household by household.

One, two, five, three, one, four.

Phoolmati—zero.

Budhni blew the whistle and set off with the herd.

Jagadish Kaka walked some distance with her.

Within the first half-kos a heifer twice turned towards the green edge of a field.

Once, Devnarayan’s young bullock tried to lock horns with another bullock.

Budhni put her stick between them and separated them.

That evening Jagadish Kaka said at the square, “Five animals do not create five times the work, but they do increase the work.”

On the second day it was Devnarayan’s younger son Chhotan’s turn.

This time Jagadish did not go with him.

Budhni’s daughter Chanda took him lunch at noon, and when she returned she said, “Chhotan Bhaiya is managing alone perfectly well.”

At the evening count, one animal appeared to be missing.

There was alarm.

After a while they discovered that an old cow had turned towards its own home midway along the route.

It had been a counting mistake, not a lost animal.

Chhotan said, “When there are more animals in the herd, counting is also work.”

On the third day the turn belonged to a household that had two bullocks, but the elderly owner could not go himself.

His daughter-in-law Sarita went.

It was her first time taking the entire herd.

When she blew the whistle at dawn, the sound came out broken.

She blew it again.

This time the herd moved.

Everything went well until noon.

On the way back in the evening, thick bushes at one point on the footpath split the herd into two groups.

Sarita stopped the animals in front and went back to bring the rear group together.

When she returned she said, "If these bushes had been cut, half the work would have disappeared."

For the first time Phoolmati stepped forward on hearing that.

"I can cut the bushes."

Devnarayan was surprised.

"But you have no animals."

"That is why taking the herd out is not my work. But the path belongs to my village. I can cut the bushes during the day. Why should that mean I owe a herding turn?"

Budhni said, "Not a turn. An account of labour."

The paper was opened again at the square.

This time the village schoolmaster, Ramvilas, was called, because people wanted to keep the accounting from becoming too complicated.

Ramvilas listened to everyone first.

Then he said, "A rule that needs ten pages to count will not survive in a village."

On the blank sheet he drew three lines.

First—number of animals going with the herd.

Second—a full day of herding.

Third—labour spent improving the shared path and watering places used by the herd.

Devnarayan asked, "And money?"

Ramvilas said, "Do not add money yet. First understand the work."

The discussion went on for a long time.

In the end they made a short rule.

A household with one or two animals would count as one herding unit.

A household with three to five animals would count as two units.

Six or more animals would count as three units.

Taking the herd for a full day would count as two labour units.

A half-day substitute would count as one unit.

Cutting the footpath, repairing the pond descent, or fixing shared bamboo fencing would count as one or two units according to the amount of work.

A household with no animals would have no compulsory herding turn.

If such a household chose to do shared work, its labour would be entered in the register, but it would not be an obligation.

Budhni asked, "What if the number of animals rises or falls?"

Ramvilas said, "Count on the first evening of every month."

Devnarayan immediately asked, "If a calf is born, does it count from that very day?"

Chhotan burst out laughing.

"Does the turn get born the moment the calf is born?"

A few people laughed.

Ramvilas said, "An animal that begins going regularly with the herd will be included from the next monthly count."

The new rule seemed very strange to Jagadish Kaka.

"Before this, every household was equal. It was simple."

Phoolmati said softly, "It was simple, but even my empty cowshed used to go out grazing."

Jagadish Kaka looked at her.

He smiled.

"That is true."

The following month a new register was made.

The whistle's cord was replaced, but not the whistle.

The old brass whistle remained.

On the first page, instead of merely listing households, the number of animals was written.

On the second page were labour units.

Phoolmati's name was not on the animal list.

But one week later her name appeared in the labour register.

She cut back the kans grass that had overgrown the eastern footpath.

Chanda and Chhotan worked with her.

In three hours the path looked broad again.

Ramvilas asked, "How many units?"

Phoolmati said, "Whatever you think fair."

Budhni said, "One."

Devnarayan said, "Two. Three people worked for three hours."

Phoolmati laughed.

"Do not start another quarrel over me. Write one for me. Put the remaining two under the children's names."

Everyone agreed.

The new arrangement was not perfect in its first week.

Of Devnarayan's five animals, one cow became ill and stayed at home.

He said that since only four animals were going now, two units were still correct.

A bullock from another household went away for two weeks to plough fields elsewhere; the question arose whether it should still count.

They then decided that an animal absent from the herd for seven consecutive days would be temporarily left out of the following week's turn calculation.

Someone said the system was becoming too much like bookkeeping.

One day Jagadish Kaka, closing the ledger, said, "Blowing the whistle was easy. The accounting has become difficult."

Ramvilas replied, "The accounting was there before too. It simply was not written down."

After two months people became accustomed to the new method.

The whistle no longer moved household by household; it went to the next name in the turn register.

Sometimes the same household received another turn within fifteen days.

Sometimes a one-cow household's turn came much later.
 Sometimes someone did two half-days instead of one full day.
 One evening Budhni was tying Gauri in the cowshed when Chanda asked,
 "Ma, has our turn become less frequent now?"
 Budhni said, "A little."
 "Is that good?"
 Tightening the knot in the rope, Budhni said, "It is good when no one's
 share is quietly placed on someone else's head."
 At that moment Devnarayan's Chhotan passed their doorway carrying the
 whistle.
 His turn was the next day.
 He tested it with a blow.
 The hoarse sound came out.
 Chanda laughed.
 "Change that whistle."
 Chhotan said, "The whistle is fine. The list has changed."
 The next dawn, the same thin sound rose once more through the village.
 Ropes were untied in the cowsheds.
 The animals came out.
 Phoolmati was sweeping the doorway of her empty cowshed.
 When she heard the whistle, she stopped for a moment.
 Now the sound no longer reminded her of a herding turn she supposedly
 owed.
 It told her only that the herd had set out.
 That the footpath was clear.
 And that the register now recorded whose labour was moving with the
 herd that day—not by the old name of a household, but by the work actually
 being done.

STORY II 4

THE POTTER'S FIRE

On the southern side of Sonbarsa village, a little away from the old embankment of the pond, stood a round earthen kiln.

The kiln did not belong to any one household.

Four potter families each called it theirs, and then immediately added that the kiln belonged to all four households.

Jagesar's household made water-pots.

Phoolkali's household made small surahis and lamps.

Madan's household made little pots for setting curd and wide-mouthed cooking vessels.

Sitaram's household made thick-bottomed vessels meant to sit over the hearth.

Each family kneaded its own clay by its own hands and dried its ware in its own courtyard, but all of it met the same fire in the same kiln.

That was why people in the village used to say: the name of the vessel belongs to the household; its fate in firing belongs to the kiln.

The four families laughed at the saying.

When the vessels came out well, the laughter opened wider.

When some cracked or remained underfired, the meaning of the saying changed.

In the last week of Bhadon, a large batch was ready for the market.

Two days later would be the first market of Navaratri.

Jagesar had made forty-five water-pots.

More than a hundred lamps were drying beneath Phoolkali's thatch.

Madan had twenty-four curd-pots ready.

Sitaram had eighteen thick cooking vessels, some of which had already been sold on advance orders.

Everyone needed the money.

So there was no question of postponing the firing.

In the morning, the vessels were brought to the kiln.

According to old custom, each household had marked the bottom of its vessels with a small sign.

Jagesar's mark was a straight line.

Phoolkali's, two dots.

Madan's, a diagonal cross.

Sitaram's, a small crescent.

The marks were not for customers.

They were simply so each family could recognise its own vessels.

Everyone worked together to load the kiln.

The thick water-pots and cooking vessels went at the bottom.

The curd-pots in the middle.

The light surahis and lamps at the top.

The rule was written nowhere.
 Everyone said that this was how it had always been done.
 That day there was a little less room in the bottom row.
 Two of Sitaram's thick cooking pots had already been placed there.
 Jagesar pushed three water-pots close beside them.
 Madan said, "Leave a little gap."
 Jagesar replied, "If we leave gaps, half the vessels above will remain outside."
 Phoolkali was arranging baskets of lamps at the time.
 She said, "There will be room above. The little lamps can fit in between."
 In the end the water-pots stood somewhat close together.
 No one considered that unusual.
 It had happened before.
 By noon the kiln was full.
 Outside lay four separate piles of firewood.
 Jagesar had brought dry mango branches.
 Madan's pile contained more thin pieces of bamboo.
 Sitaram had brought babul wood left from the previous year.
 Some bundles from Phoolkali's household were slightly damp from the previous night's dew.
 Phoolkali opened one bundle with her own hands.
 "This is damp only on the outside. It is dry within."
 Jagesar smiled.
 "The fire will not ask whether the dampness is outside or within."
 He said it jokingly.
 Phoolkali laughed too.
 At dusk the kiln was lit.
 During the first watch Jagesar and Madan tended the fire.
 During the second, Phoolkali's son Ratan and Sitaram's brother Harinandan.
 The third watch had never been made clear.
 Jagesar understood that Harinandan would remain until dawn.
 Harinandan understood that Madan would return after two in the morning.
 Madan had said, "If there is need, call me."
 Who was to call whom had never been decided.
 The fire kept burning in the kiln.
 At about two in the night Phoolkali came carrying water.
 She saw Harinandan sitting with his back against the wall, nodding with sleep.
 "Is the fire all right?"
 Rubbing his eyes, Harinandan said, "It is still strong."
 Phoolkali watched the smoke.
 From the small smoke vent on the eastern side, less smoke was coming out.
 She said, "Why is this side so quiet?"

Harinandan stirred the ash with a wooden pole.

"The wind is against us."

Phoolkali said nothing.

She returned home.

By dawn the fire was allowed to die down.

The kiln remained closed for two days.

On the third day the mouth was opened.

The lamps from the top came out first.

Their colour was good.

Phoolkali tapped one lamp with her fingernail.

It gave a clear ring.

The curd-pots in the middle were also good.

Some had dark smoke stains, but the firing was sound.

When the bottom row was opened, Jagesar's face changed.

Three water-pots were pale in colour.

The bases of five of Sitaram's cooking vessels were still raw.

Two of Madan's heavier curd-pots were also underfired.

In the same row, vessels from three households had gone bad.

Phoolkali had no vessel in that row.

Jagesar's first words were, "Damp wood."

Phoolkali immediately looked at him.

"My wood was stacked on top. Were all the bundles used or not?"

Madan said, "Would wood alone cause the bottom row to come out like this?"

Sitaram was turning over one of his cooking vessels and inspecting the base.

He said, "The water-pots were packed so close that the fire could not move around."

Jagesar's voice sharpened.

"I did not place those pots alone."

"I told you to leave gaps," Madan said.

"Then should I have left your curd-pots outside?"

The conversation was beginning to move away from the vessels and towards the people.

Phoolkali raised her hand.

"Do not take everything out yet."

Jagesar said, "What is left to save now?"

Phoolkali bent down.

"First see where everything was."

She picked up an old broken tile and drew a circle on it with charcoal.

"This is the kiln."

Then she marked four sides.

"This is east. This is west."

Madan laughed.

"Are we making a map of the kiln?"

"The vessels have gone bad. Before deciding whom to blame, let us remember where they were."

Sitaram put his cooking vessel back down.

As the vessels were removed one by one, people began marking their positions on the broken tile.

Straight line—Jagesar.

Diagonal cross—Madan.

Crescent—Sitaram.

Two dots—Phoolkali.

It quickly became clear that the damaged vessels did not belong to one family alone.

The palest vessels had all been on the lower eastern side.

One of Jagesar's water-pots had been in the lower middle; it was somewhat better fired.

Two of Sitaram's pots had stood on the western side; they were fully fired.

Madan held the tile for a long time and looked at it.

"Then the wood?"

Phoolkali said, "Write that too."

No one could say exactly how much wood from which household had been used.

The four piles had been mixed.

No one had counted the bundles.

No one had kept damp and dry wood separate.

They then asked about the watches during the night.

Jagesar said, "I was there in the first watch."

Madan said, "I too, until ten."

Ratan said, "I stayed until midnight."

Harinandan said, "After two I sat down for a little while."

"And after that?"

Harinandan fell silent.

Madan looked at him.

"No one called me."

Harinandan said, "I thought you would come on your own."

Jagesar's face hardened again.

"So the fire was orphaned in the middle of the night?"

Harinandan wanted to answer, but Phoolkali spoke first.

"No one knew how long the next man was supposed to stay. Write that."

Jagesar said, "Will everything now run on paper?"

Rubbing charcoal on the eastern side of the tile, Phoolkali said, "The vessels will still run on fire. The paper will only keep our memory straight."

No decision about compensation for the damaged ware was reached that day.

Jagesar wanted Phoolkali to bear some share because of the damp wood.

Sitaram wanted those who had crowded the bottom row to take responsibility.

Madan said the largest failure was the empty watch over the fire.

All three possibilities were plausible.

None was proven.

In the end they decided that for this batch each family would bear the loss according to its own damaged vessels.

No one liked the decision.

But putting the whole blame on someone without an account felt worse.

The next batch was due a week later.

This time it was not for the market but for advance orders for two village weddings.

The four families gathered at the kiln again.

From the very first day Phoolkali brought an old ledger.

On its first page she wrote: "Kiln Rows."

Jagesar laughed.

"Will the fire read it?"

Phoolkali said, "No. We will."

Inside the kiln they recognised three levels—bottom, middle, top.

And four directions—east, west, north, south.

They marked whose vessels were placed where.

This time all the heavy vessels of any one family were not put in a single place.

Two of Jagesar's water-pots went in the lower east, two in the lower west.

Sitaram's cooking pots were divided between both sides as well.

Madan's heavier curd-pots went in the lower-middle.

Phoolkali placed two of her heavier surahis in the bottom row.

"Put mine down there too," she said.

Jagesar asked, "Why?"

"If something goes wrong again, no one can say only the clay of your pots was at fault."

Jagesar said nothing.

They agreed to leave a gap of two fingers between vessels.

Where there was not enough space, one vessel was left out.

Earlier people had regarded a vessel left outside as a loss.

This time Madan said, "One vessel in the next firing is better than a dozen half-baked."

After the kiln was loaded, the smoke vents were cleaned.

In the eastern vent they found a lump of old ash and clay blocking the passage.

Harinandan removed it with a stick.

Jagesar looked at Phoolkali.

"Was this here last time too?"

Phoolkali said, "No one knows."

The ledger recorded: "Eastern vent cleaned."

The firewood too was measured in separate piles.

There was no weighing scale.

So they made bundles of roughly equal thickness, twenty to a group.

Damp pieces were set aside.

Phoolkali spread her dew-wet wood in the sun.

Jagesar himself touched it.

"Now it is fine."

The watch over the fire was written down.

Six to nine in the evening—Jagesar.

Nine to midnight—Madan.

Midnight to three—Ratan and Harinandan.

Three to dawn—Sitaram.

At each change of watch, the previous person would not leave until the next person appeared in front of him.

Phoolkali drew two lines beneath that sentence.

Sitaram said, "What if I do not wake at three?"

Phoolkali replied, "Then Ratan will come to your house."

"And if I am not at home?"

"Then say so beforehand. The watch belongs not to a name, but to the person who is present."

At dusk the fire was lit.

The first watch passed easily.

Jagesar counted the bundles as he fed the fire.

At nine Madan arrived.

Jagesar wrote in the ledger: "Six bundles used."

Madan asked, "Six? How many last time?"

Everyone was silent.

No one had ever had an answer to that question before.

At eleven a strong west wind rose.

Madan went around to the eastern vent.

Once again there was less smoke there.

He did not push a stick inside immediately.

First he wrote in the ledger: "Less smoke on east."

Then he showed Ratan.

Ratan cleared away the ash.

The fire below rose slightly.

At midnight the watch changed.

Before going home, Madan walked Ratan and Harinandan once around all four sides of the kiln.

"Listen to this sound."

There was a low growl of fire inside the kiln.

"If one side becomes completely quiet, check it."

Ratan laughed.

"How do we write a sound in the ledger?"

Madan said, "Write 'quiet.'"

At half past one Phoolkali came again carrying water.

This time no one was dozing.

Harinandan was on the eastern side.

Ratan was arranging wood on the south.

Phoolkali asked, "Everything all right?"

Harinandan said, "The east side feels a little cooler now."

"How do you know?"

"I did not touch it. From the smoke and the sound."

Phoolkali smiled.

"Write it."

Ratan wrote in the ledger: "1:30 a.m.—east slow."

That night, for the first time, the kiln's fire began to be recorded against time instead of only in people's memory.

A little before three Sitaram arrived.

Ratan said, "You are early."

Sitaram replied, "I was afraid people would say again that I had not come."

Harinandan said quietly, "Last time no one said you had failed to come. No one knew whose watch it was."

Sitaram remained silent for a moment.

Then he said, "True."

At dawn the fire was allowed to die down.

The final line in the ledger read: "All watches present."

Two days later the kiln was opened.

Phoolkali said, "Not the top first. As far as possible, take things out while looking at the map."

They began removing the vessels slowly.

The lamps on top were good.

The curd-pots in the middle were good.

The first water-pot from the bottom came out ringing.

Jagesar tapped it near the ear.

A clear sound.

Sitaram's cooking vessel too was fully fired.

One of Phoolkali's surahis was slightly pale, but its base was not raw.

One of Madan's curd-pots, right in the lower-eastern corner, was underfired.

Everyone stood around that pot.

Jagesar opened his mouth to say something, then stopped.

Phoolkali opened the ledger.

In that same lower-eastern corner, the greatest number of damaged vessels had been found in the previous batch.

This time only one heavy curd-pot had been placed there.

The ledger also recorded at half past one in the night: "East slow."

Madan bent and looked inside the kiln.

On that side, near the base, a thin bank of ash had gathered.

The air-gap was narrower there than on the other side.

Sitaram said, "Then this is not a fault in Madan's clay?"

Madan laughed.

"Do not rescue the clay yet. First fix the place."

Jagesar laughed too.

"And Phoolkali's wood?"

Phoolkali replied, "Let that trial remain adjourned until the next batch."

All four laughed.
 The laughter was not as sharp as the previous time.
 After the kiln cooled, the ash in the lower eastern corner was cleared completely.
 One brick had shifted slightly inward.
 It was set back in place.
 A mark was made to keep one hand-span of space empty at that corner of the bottom row.
 A new rule was added to the ledger.
 Not the name of a vessel—the name of a place.
 “Lower east—leave an air-gap.”
 “Check that smoke vents are clear before sealing.”
 “At change of watch, the next person must appear in front of the previous one.”
 “Keep damp wood bundles separate.”
 “Do not place all the heavy vessels of one household in one spot.”
 Sitaram asked, “Will all these rules not slow the work down?”
 Phoolkali said, “Loading the kiln may take half an hour longer. Re-firing spoiled vessels costs two days.”
 Jagesar held the ledger in his hands.
 He looked at the page from the previous batch.
 There were more people’s names there—Phoolkali’s wood, Jagesar’s pots, Harinandan’s watch.
 On the new page there were more places and tasks—east, bottom, gap, vent, bundle, watch.
 He said, “Write one more thing.”
 Phoolkali raised the pen.
 “What?”
 Jagesar said, “If a defect is found, mark the place before lifting away the vessel.”
 Madan said, “And if someone’s clear mistake is found?”
 Jagesar replied, “Then write the name. But only after looking at the place.”
 Everyone accepted that.
 The following month the kiln was filled again.
 This time no one laughed on seeing the new ledger.
 While placing vessels, Ratan himself asked, “Which row should I write this under?”
 Harinandan counted the bundles of wood.
 Sitaram checked the time of his watch.
 Madan put his hand into the eastern gap to see whether ash had collected.
 Phoolkali placed the ledger on a brick outside the doorway.
 The fire was lit.
 The night deepened.
 Smoke came out on all four sides.
 Sometimes strong, sometimes weak.

When the east became quiet again, the person on watch checked the gap before adding more fire.

The ash was removed.

Air moved through.

Only three words were added to the ledger: "Eastern gap cleared."

At dawn Phoolkali closed the page.

The names of all four families were on that page, but there was no line for blame.

No separate box had been made for fault.

Instead it contained the kiln's three levels, its four sides, bundles of wood, and the watches of the night.

A few weeks later Jagesar's grandson was leafing through the ledger and asked, "Baba, why is 'lower east' written again and again on this page?"

Jagesar looked towards the kiln.

"Because earlier the fire did not reach there properly."

"Whose fault was it?"

Jagesar thought for a moment.

Then he said, "When we had not written anything down, everyone had an answer to that question. After we wrote it down, we understood—the answer lay in the place, not only in a name."

The grandson did not fully understand.

He closed the ledger and ran to the eastern side of the kiln.

There, on the earthen wall, a small charcoal mark had been made.

Beside it was written: "KEEP THE GAP CLEAR."

And beneath it there was no one's name.

STORY 115

THE RENTED PUMP

In the first week of Phagun, the soil looked dry on the surface, but a little moisture still remained around the roots of the wheat.

In the rear strip of Madhupur, the fields of Bisun Yadav and Nandlal Mandal lay side by side.

Their wheat had been planted at almost the same time, but the slope of the two fields was not the same.

Bisun's field lay slightly higher; Nandlal's slightly lower.

The village's old well had dried up in Magh that year.

So for irrigation everyone was looking towards rented diesel pumps.

There were three pumps in the village, but two of them were being used in distant fields that week.

Only Raghunath Sahu's pump was free.

It was an old five-horsepower pump that rarely started with a single pull of the rope.

Raghunath could tell its condition by its sound.

If the smoke thickened, he opened the air control; if the growl weakened, he checked the pipe joints.

Bisun reached his doorway early in the morning.

"Can you give us the pump until this afternoon?"

Raghunath asked, "How much land?"

"One kattha of mine on the higher side, and one and a half katthas of Nandlal's below."

Raghunath said, "The charge will be by the hour."

Bisun asked, "From what point does the clock start?"

Raghunath replied casually, "From when the engine starts."

Bisun did not answer immediately.

That was how pump hire worked in the village.

The engine ran; the clock ran.

Whether the water had reached the field, whether the pipe had been joined properly, whether a bund broke in between—those were considered the farmer's concerns.

But this time the route by which water had to reach Bisun's field was not short.

The pump would be installed at the boring near the dry bed of the pond.

From there the water would first run fifty hand-spans through an old earthen channel, then cross through a cut in the bund between the two fields before entering Bisun's land.

Bisun said, "What if the engine starts but the water gets held up in the line?"

Raghunath laughed.

"Will the engine then stop drinking diesel?"

Bisun smiled too.

"It will drink diesel. But the field will still receive no water."

The matter was left there.

Before noon the pump was loaded onto a bullock cart and taken towards the fields.

Raghunath's nephew Mohan went with him.

Bisun and Nandlal had agreed beforehand to clean the channel.

But Bisun had gone to the market early in the morning to bring fertiliser.

Guests had arrived at Nandlal's house.

Both had thought—the channel is old; a few strokes of the spade will make it run.

By the time the pump arrived, only the first twenty hand-spans of the channel had been cleared.

Raghunath looked at it and asked, "And farther ahead?"

Bisun said, "Once the water starts moving, it will make its own way."

Raghunath said nothing.

Mohan connected the suction pipe to the mouth of the boring.

They pulled the rope twice.

The engine coughed and died.

On the third pull a thick wave of smoke came out.

The growl settled into a steady rhythm.

Raghunath looked at the watch in his pocket.

"Twelve seven."

Bisun checked the time too.

Mohan placed a hand on the first pipe joint.

Before the water came, air escaped.

Then the pipe trembled.

A few moments later the first stream entered the earthen channel.

Nandlal went ahead with a spade.

The water reached the first bend properly.

At the second bend, the stream spread out.

There was a small hole in the soil.

Water left the channel and began flowing into an empty patch beside it.

"How did this gap get here?" Bisun shouted.

Nandlal struck the earth with his spade and pressed soil into it.

The stream rose slightly, then began leaking again underneath.

Raghunath stood by the pump at a distance, watching.

Mohan asked, "Shall we stop the engine?"

Raghunath said, "Then the water in the pipe will fall back. Filling it again will take time."

Bisun ran over.

"Stop it for a little while. Let us close the gap first."

Raghunath looked at his watch.

"Twelve fourteen."

The engine was stopped.

Suddenly the sound of the field changed.

Until then the engine's growl had drowned out every other sound.
 Now only the blows of the spade could be heard.
 Nandlal packed earth around the gap.
 Bisun pushed in two handfuls of straw.
 Mohan pressed smooth wet soil over the top.
 Eight minutes later Raghunath asked, "Start it again?"
 Nandlal said, "Let us look farther ahead once."
 They walked along the next stretch of channel.
 Thirty hand-spans farther on, the bund had sagged in another place.
 There was no hole there, but the channel was so shallow that the water could easily spill out.
 Bisun struck his forehead with his palm.
 "We were supposed to clean this channel yesterday."
 Nandlal answered at once, "Is this my channel alone?"
 Bisun said, "Did I ever say it was yours alone?"
 Raghunath stopped them both.
 "Fix the channel first. Quarrel afterward."
 It took another five minutes.
 At twelve twenty-seven the engine was started again.
 This time the stream crossed the first gap.
 At the second shallow stretch it spread a little, but did not cross the bund.
 At twelve thirty-five the water touched the first edge of Bisun's field.
 Bisun called out loudly, "Now the clock starts!"
 From beside the pump Raghunath replied, "My clock has been running since twelve seven."
 Nandlal stood between them.
 His field's turn had not yet come.
 Water began spreading through Bisun's field.
 The upper soil swallowed it quickly.
 It took time for the stream to reach the lower strip.
 Raghunath kept checking the fuel tank from time to time.
 At one five Bisun said, "Enough. Stop mine."
 Mohan opened a small cut in the bund and turned the stream towards Nandlal's field.
 Nandlal's field lay lower.
 The water ran into it quickly.
 At one ten his first bed filled.
 By one forty, water had reached all of his one and a half katthas.
 Raghunath stopped the engine.
 He checked the watch.
 "One hour and thirty-three minutes."
 Bisun said, "Water remained in my field for fifty minutes."
 Nandlal said, "Mine for thirty."
 Raghunath added, "The engine ran for one hour and thirty-three minutes."
 Mohan lifted the nearly empty diesel can.

“Almost everything we put in has gone.”

Bisun asked, “Who pays for the thirteen minutes when it was stopped?”

Raghunath said, “I will not count that. The engine was off.”

Nandlal said, “But during the first seven minutes, no water had reached the field.”

Raghunath replied, “The machine was running then.”

Bisun added, “And the channel swallowed another twenty minutes.”

Raghunath’s voice grew a little hard.

“Did I break the channel?”

No one answered.

Raghunath continued, “The diesel was mine. The machine was mine. Mohan’s time was mine. The water went into your channel. Am I supposed to carry it in my arms all the way to the field?”

Bisun did not stay silent either.

“Are we renting the machine or the water?”

“The machine.”

“Then even if no water reaches the field, the full rent is due?”

“If the engine runs, yes.”

Nandlal planted his spade in the ground.

“By that reckoning, the loss from the broken channel belongs to both of us, but the full rate still belongs to the machine owner?”

Raghunath looked at him.

“Where is my profit in that? The diesel burned.”

In the middle of the dispute, no one’s argument was completely false.

That was precisely why the dispute was difficult.

Two villagers heard the voices and came over.

One was Ramcharit Mahato, who irrigated his own field through a pipe.

The other was Shyama Devi, whose field lay farther along the same channel.

Shyama Devi first examined the channel.

“Did this gap appear today?”

Nandlal said, “Hard to say.”

She bent and touched the edge of the earth.

“The edge is dry. It is old.”

Bisun turned his face away.

Ramcharit asked, “Then why did you not inspect the channel beforehand?”

Bisun replied, “I thought running water would make its own path.”

Shyama Devi did not laugh.

“Running water makes its own path, yes. It also makes paths where you do not want them.”

Raghunath said, “My account is clear—from twelve seven to one forty. Deduct the thirteen minutes when the engine was stopped.”

Ramcharit asked, “When the engine starts, how long does it normally take to fill the empty pipe the first time?”

Mohan said, “Four or five minutes.”

"Does that happen every day?"

"Almost."

"Then is that pump preparation, or the farmer's field time?"

Raghunath thought for a moment.

"If the pipe is empty, it has to fill."

Shyama Devi asked, "And the gap in the channel?"

Bisun said immediately, "Our fault."

Nandlal looked at him.

Bisun added, "Both of ours. The channel was shared."

This was the first time in the dispute that anyone had placed part of the fault on himself.

Raghunath's voice softened.

"Then what about the diesel that burned?"

Bisun said, "We will pay for that. But not at the full hourly rate."

Raghunath frowned.

"Why?"

"Because during those twenty minutes the machine was not irrigating my field. Because of our mistake, it was merely throwing water away. Your diesel was spent, but the service was not complete."

A little distance away Ramcharit drew three lines on the soil.

Above the first he wrote: "MACHINE."

On the second: "CHANNEL."

On the third: "IRRIGATION."

"If all three things are always merged into one clock, this quarrel will happen again."

Raghunath asked, "Then should we keep three clocks?"

Shyama Devi said, "One clock. Three lines."

Everyone fell silent at that sentence.

Raghunath told Mohan, "Bring the old notebook."

There was a small notebook in the pump's tool box in which diesel, repairs and credit were recorded.

Mohan brought it.

At the bottom of the first page Ramcharit made four lines.

"ENGINE PREPARATION."

"CHANNEL/ROUTE FAULT."

"ACTUAL IRRIGATION."

"ENGINE OFF."

Raghunath said, "If the engine is off, there is no charge."

"Fine."

Bisun asked, "And preparation?"

Raghunath said, "It still uses diesel."

Shyama Devi asked, "How much preparation is normal?"

Mohan said, "Up to five minutes."

"Ten?"

"Then something is wrong."

Raghunath himself added, "If the engine is delayed because of my machine, that is not preparation—it is my breakdown."

That was a new point.

Ramcharit wrote: "Normal preparation up to five minutes—half rate."

Raghunath immediately said, "Why half?"

"Because diesel is being used, but service in the field has not yet begun."

Bisun said, "I agree."

Nandlal nodded too.

Raghunath thought for a while and said, "All right. But if more than five minutes are lost because the farmer still has not joined the pipe or prepared the channel, that goes under channel fault."

"And if the machine itself fails to start?" Shyama Devi asked.

"Mine."

A second rule was added to the notebook.

"Channel fault—diesel cost only, not full rent."

Raghunath stopped again at this line.

"How do we measure the diesel cost?"

Mohan explained the level marks on the tank.

Raghunath roughly knew how much fuel the pump consumed in an hour.

Ramcharit said, "Exact measurement is not necessary. Keep a small fixed rate—enough for diesel and the operator's blocked time."

Nandlal asked, "But what if the channel fault is shared by both of us?"

Bisun answered, "Then we split that small charge."

Shyama Devi asked, "And if only your bund breaks?"

"Then I pay."

Raghunath smiled for the first time.

"And if Shyama's goat breaks the channel?"

Shyama Devi smiled too.

"First prove it was my goat."

The tension eased a little.

They settled the remaining account that same day.

The engine had run for a total of ninety-three minutes.

The first five minutes were counted as preparation.

Eighteen minutes were assigned to the channel gap and the shallow stretch.

The remaining time was counted as actual irrigation.

Bisun and Nandlal paid the full rate according to the actual irrigation time for their respective fields.

For the eighteen minutes lost in the shared channel, the two of them split the smaller diesel-rate equally.

Raghunath charged half-rate for the five minutes of preparation.

No one was completely satisfied.

That was the best sign of all.

Raghunath still felt that the full rate for the first five minutes would have been fair.

Bisun still wondered why the farmer should pay anything for preparation.

Nandlal still felt that more of the channel-cleaning work had fallen to Bisun's side.

But all three agreed that the old single number had hidden three different things.

Two days later Shyama Devi called for the same pump to irrigate her field.

This time Mohan opened the notebook before starting the pump.

Raghunath said, "First inspect the channel."

Shyama Devi replied, "I checked it this morning."

"Check it again. It may save five minutes."

The three of them walked the channel.

In one place the earth at the side was loose.

Shyama Devi pressed it down with a spade.

They installed the pump.

Mohan wrote down the time.

The engine did not catch on the first pull.

Nor on the second.

Raghunath opened the fuel line and checked it.

Air had entered.

It took seven minutes.

Shyama Devi looked at the notebook.

"Five minutes preparation?"

Raghunath himself said, "No. Two minutes are my machine's delay."

Mohan wrote: "Preparation five, machine delay two."

No rent was added for those two minutes.

Raghunath's face tightened slightly, but he did not cross out the line.

The water entered the channel.

This time the stream reached the field without breaking anywhere.

Standing at the mouth of the channel, Shyama Devi called the time.

"Actual irrigation starts now."

Mohan wrote it down.

That day the final account was short.

The page in the notebook was clear too.

Within a few weeks Raghunath's pump went to five fields in the village.

The new lines did not apply in exactly the same way everywhere.

In some places the pipe ran directly to the field, so there was no question of a channel fault.

In some places, even after the pump arrived, the farmer was still cutting the bund; that time went into the channel/route line.

Once Mohan had left a pipe clamp at home.

A man went on a bicycle to fetch it and twelve minutes were lost.

Raghunath himself wrote: "Machine-side delay—no charge."

Bisun happened to be there that day.

He looked at the page and smiled.

"The notebook cuts you too now."

Raghunath said, "No. The notebook only changes the name of the time."

At the end of Chait Raghunath bought a new notebook.

On the first page Mohan drew four straight lines as neatly as though they had been printed.

Engine preparation.

Machine-side delay.

Channel/route fault.

Actual irrigation.

Below them a smaller line was added: "Engine off."

Bisun asked, "Does keeping all these accounts not take time?"

Mohan said, "One minute."

Raghunath added, "One minute of writing saves twenty minutes of quarrelling."

Nandlal said, "The quarrel lasted more than twenty minutes."

Everyone laughed.

On the next irrigation day the pump again reached the edge of Bisun's field.

This time Bisun and Nandlal had cleaned the channel from early morning.

Fresh earth had been packed over the first gap.

The shallow stretch had been deepened a little.

As Raghunath unloaded the pump, he asked, "Is the channel ready?"

Bisun said, "You inspect it first."

Raghunath walked the full length of the channel to the field.

When he returned, he said, "It is ready."

Mohan opened the notebook.

The engine started.

The clock started.

Five minutes later the water touched the edge of the field.

Mohan wrote the time in the first line, and then in the second.

Bisun watched from a distance.

That day there was only one clock.

But time was no longer only one thing.

STORY II6

TWO PASERIS OF MARUA

It was the last Tuesday of Katik.

The morning mist still lay low over the threshing ground, but the eastern sky had begun to brighten.

Near Dhaneshwar Jha's courtyard stood three heaps of marua—one for seed, one for household use, and one for sale.

Beside the heaps lay a brass paseri measure.

Its rim had been worn smooth with use.

The moment Phoolmati Devi saw it from a distance, she took the empty sack down from her shoulder.

Her husband Ramsevak was not with her.

He had been ill with fever for two days, so Phoolmati had come alone to collect the wages that day.

Four days earlier, Phoolmati, Ramsevak and their eldest daughter Chanda had cut Dhaneshwar's marua, tied it into bundles, and carried it to the threshing ground.

On the day the work was agreed, Dhaneshwar had said clearly, "Two paseris of marua for the complete job."

Phoolmati remembered exactly the same words.

Two paseris.

No less, no more.

In the threshing ground, Dhaneshwar's younger brother Naveen was beating the marua loose from the stalks.

Seeing Phoolmati, he said, "Sit down. Bhaiya is inside checking the accounts."

Phoolmati folded her sack and sat on it.

She was in no hurry, but the grain container at home was almost empty.

The previous night, wheat bran had been mixed into the remaining marua flour to make rotis.

Chanda had left half a roti so that her younger brother could eat it in the morning.

Phoolmati saw no need to tell anyone this.

A person who comes to collect wages does not bring an empty grain jar from home as evidence.

After a while Dhaneshwar came outside.

A thin ledger with a red cover was in his hand.

Behind him came Mohan Sahu.

Mohan Sahu ran the village grocery shop.

The moment Phoolmati saw him, she understood that the matter was not going to be merely about measuring out two paseris.

Dhaneshwar opened the ledger.

"Phoolmati, your two paseris are ready," he said.

“Yes.”

“But you also owe Mohan two hundred and forty rupees.”

Phoolmati looked at Mohan Sahu.

“I do owe it. Am I denying that?”

Mohan Sahu shook his head.

“No, you are not denying it.”

Dhaneshwar gestured towards the marua heap.

“Today the price is twenty-four rupees a seer. Two paseris make ten seers.

Exactly two hundred and forty. The account balances.”

Phoolmati was silent for a few moments.

Then she opened her sack again, but did not spread its mouth on the ground.

“The two paseris of marua are my wages, are they not?”

“Yes.”

“And the two hundred and forty rupees are what I owe Mohan Sahu?”

“Yes.”

“Then when did those two things become the same thing?”

Dhaneshwar frowned.

“On the day we fixed the work, you yourself said that the shop debt could be adjusted against the wages.”

Phoolmati shook her head.

“I said that when I received money, I would repay the debt. You said that if needed, the accounts could be adjusted. But no one said which day’s price would be used.”

Naveen stopped threshing and began to listen.

Mohan Sahu said quietly, “My ledger only says two hundred and forty rupees. It does not say ten seers of marua.”

Dhaneshwar looked at him.

“You will get the money by selling marua, won’t you?”

“I will,” Mohan Sahu said, “but my ledger does not say on which day it must be sold.”

Phoolmati placed her sack beside her feet.

“On the day the work was agreed, marua was thirty rupees a seer.”

Dhaneshwar answered at once, “That was the price of the old grain. Everyone knew the price would fall when the new marua reached the market.”

“If everyone knew, then when we agreed the work you should have said that the debt would be deducted at the price prevailing on the payment day.”

“Would you then have said you would not do the work?”

“Perhaps I would have. Perhaps I would have asked for half the wages in cash. But I would have decided knowingly.”

Dhaneshwar did not close the ledger, but rested a finger on the page.

“And if today the price were forty, would you accept the thirty-rupee rate from the day the work was agreed?”

Phoolmati answered without hesitation.

"If thirty had been written beforehand, then thirty. If 'price on the day of payment' had been written, then forty. If I choose whichever day benefits me, you would not find that fair either."

Mohan Sahu cleared his throat lightly.

"In this matter, the problem is less the price than the day."

Dhaneshwar looked at him.

"You are the shopkeeper. You want your money. It is easy for you to say that."

Mohan Sahu smiled faintly.

"I do want my money. That is why I too need to know by what calculation today's payment is being made."

Meanwhile Dhaneshwar's wife Sarojini came from the courtyard carrying two glasses of water.

Having heard the dispute, she held one glass out to Phoolmati.

"Drink some water first."

Phoolmati took the glass.

Sarojini asked Dhaneshwar, "What exactly was written in the ledger on the day the work was agreed?"

Dhaneshwar opened the page.

It said:

"Phoolmati family—marua cutting and carrying. Complete work—two paseris."

Below that, in pencil, was written:

"Mohan Sahu debt—to be adjusted."

Sarojini read the second line and asked, "What does 'to be adjusted' mean?"

Before answering, Dhaneshwar looked at the page again.

That was truly all it said.

No price.

No date.

No indication whether the entire debt would be deducted or only as much as Phoolmati chose.

No indication whether the marua was first to be treated as wages or the money first as debt repayment.

Phoolmati finished the water and put the glass down.

"Today those two words have become the price of my entire sack."

Sarojini did not stop Dhaneshwar, nor did she speak in support of Phoolmati.

She simply turned the ledger towards herself and looked at it.

"By this kind of account, tomorrow anyone in our household could choose whichever day suited them."

Dhaneshwar said, "Then what do we do now? Leave Mohan's money unpaid?"

Mohan Sahu said, "Leaving a debt unpaid and forgiving it are two different things. The debt will remain in my ledger."

Phoolmati said, "I will repay the debt. But first my wages must come into my hands."

Dhaneshwar did not laugh.

"You will take the marua, then sell it, then give Mohan the money. Why make three steps out of one?"

"Because the first thing is my wages."

"In the end the money will go there anyway."

"Whether all of it goes or half of it goes, I will decide. We need grain at home too."

For a few moments the threshing ground filled again only with the sound of falling grain.

Naveen resumed his work.

The marua seeds struck the bamboo winnowing tray with a dry khat-khat sound.

Dhaneshwar asked slowly, "When is the shop debt from?"

Mohan Sahu opened his ledger.

There were three entries.

Oil and salt in Sawan.

Medicine for Ramsevak's fever in Bhadon.

Two kilos of rice at the beginning of Asin.

Total: two hundred and forty rupees.

Mohan Sahu said, "I can receive this money gradually too. But last month Phoolmati herself said she would pay after the harvest."

Phoolmati said, "I said I would pay after the harvest. I did not say I would empty out my entire wages."

Sarojini asked, "How do we know what the price was on the day the work was agreed?"

Phoolmati replied immediately, "Thirty at the Tuesday market."

Dhaneshwar said, "It was twenty-eight too."

Mohan Sahu said, "At the shop that week I had bought at twenty-nine."

Three prices.

In the same week.

Phoolmati smiled slightly.

"See? Even if the day had been written, someone would still ask: whose price?"

For the first time, something other than irritation appeared on Dhaneshwar's face.

He looked at the two words in his ledger as though they themselves were annoying him.

"To be adjusted."

Sarojini said, "First measure out the two paseris."

Dhaneshwar looked at her.

"And after that?"

"After that, Phoolmati and Mohan can settle their account. Your wage account will be complete. Mohan's debt account will remain separate."

Dhaneshwar was about to say something, but Phoolmati spoke first.

"Today I will sell one paseri and give Mohan Sahu the money. I will take one paseri home."

Mohan Sahu asked, "Whatever money you receive from selling one paseri, I deduct that much?"

"Yes."

"A balance will remain."

"It will."

"Next week the price may fall further."

"It may rise too."

Mohan Sahu closed his ledger.

"Fine."

Dhaneshwar still did not look entirely satisfied.

"But by this reckoning, if the price falls, Phoolmati loses."

Phoolmati said, "Then the loss is mine. Because I chose the day of sale. If you had chosen it, there would have been a dispute."

That stopped Dhaneshwar.

He lifted the brass paseri.

He filled it with marua.

He swept his palm across the top and levelled it.

One paseri went into Phoolmati's sack.

The measure was filled again.

Two paseris were complete.

Phoolmati tied the mouth of the sack, then opened a second small bag.

"Separate one paseri here. I will sell it in the market."

Dhaneshwar asked, "Shall I buy it?"

Phoolmati thought for a moment.

"At what price?"

"Twenty-four."

"And if I get twenty-five at the Tuesday market?"

Dhaneshwar smiled.

"Then sell it there."

Phoolmati smiled too.

"This time I will choose the price."

Sarojini laughed.

The dispute was not completely over, but its edge had become blunter.

Phoolmati took one paseri home.

The other paseri sold that day in the market at twenty-five rupees a seer.

One paseri of five seers brought one hundred and twenty-five rupees.

On her way back from the market, Phoolmati stopped at Mohan Sahu's shop.

She gave him one hundred and twenty-five rupees.

In his ledger, beside the old two-hundred-and-forty-rupee balance, Mohan Sahu wrote:

"Received today—125."

Below it remained:

"115."

Phoolmati said, "Will you not write the marua price here?"

Mohan Sahu laughed.

"I received money. Where you sold the marua is not part of my account."

Phoolmati looked at the ledger.

"If it had been written like this from the beginning, there would have been no morning quarrel."

Mohan Sahu said, "The morning quarrel was not in your ledger. It was in Dhaneshwar's."

Two days later Dhaneshwar called Phoolmati again.

Not for work.

To show her the account.

On that same side of the threshing ground, the names of three labouring families were now being entered.

The next job was cleaning marua.

Dhaneshwar had made new lines in the ledger.

First—"In what form are the wages?"

Second—"How much quantity/cash?"

Third—"Is there an old debt separate from this?"

Fourth—"Is adjustment against wages authorised?"

Fifth—"If grain and money are to be converted, which day's price?"

Sixth—"Whose price record?"

Phoolmati read the lines one by one.

"The sixth line is the most important," she said.

Dhaneshwar asked, "Why?"

"There were three prices on the same day."

With a red pen Dhaneshwar added in smaller letters under the sixth line:

"Market/shop/mutual agreement—to be marked in advance."

Naveen was sitting beside them.

He asked, "Will every job need this much writing?"

Dhaneshwar said, "No. Where the payment is simply marua, writing 'two paseris' is enough. But when you turn marua into money, write the day too."

Phoolmati said, "And when you turn money into a debt, write whose debt it is."

Mohan Sahu had also come there.

Hearing this, he said, "And if the debt money is to be deducted from wages, ask first."

Sarojini came from the house with tea.

"And if the workday passes while you keep filling in all these lines?"

Phoolmati said, "Because two words were left short, half a day passed today."

Everyone laughed.

But the matter did not end there.

The following week the price of marua rose again to twenty-six rupees a seer.

Dhaneshwar's younger brother Naveen said, "See, Phoolmati Didi would have received another five rupees if she had waited a week."

At that moment Phoolmati was winnowing grain in Dhaneshwar's courtyard.

Without lifting her head, she said, "If I had waited, Mohan Sahu's debt would also have remained for another week. Whether the price rises or falls is something that comes after the work."

Naveen asked, "Then why did you ask for the price from the day the work was agreed?"

Phoolmati stopped the winnowing tray.

"Because that day I felt you were choosing today's date for your own convenience. I was choosing another day for mine. Both choices could have been wrong."

Dhaneshwar was listening.

He opened the ledger and placed a finger on the new line.

"That is why the day must be written beforehand."

Phoolmati said, "Otherwise grain remains wages and yet turns into a wager on the market."

That evening, when Phoolmati returned home, Ramsevak's fever had gone down.

Chanda was grinding marua beside the hearth.

Of the one paseri kept at home, half went into the grain jar and half was set aside for grinding.

Ramsevak asked, "Mohan's balance?"

"One hundred and fifteen."

"Dhaneshwar did not deduct it?"

"No."

"Was there a quarrel?"

Phoolmati thought for a moment before replying.

"It began over the price. Later we understood the quarrel was not really about the price."

"Then what was it about?"

"The day."

Ramsevak nodded as though he understood, though perhaps not completely.

Phoolmati closed the lid of the grain jar.

"The day wages are fixed, the day they are paid, and the day a debt is deducted—those are not necessarily the same day."

Chanda stopped the grinding stone and asked, "Then will all three be written in the ledger?"

Phoolmati said, "Where all three meet, all three should be written."

A few months later, around Holi, Dhaneshwar's marua was finished.

By then the market price had risen again.

In Mohan Sahu's shop ledger, below Phoolmati's old two-hundred-and-forty-rupee balance, the final line was written:

"Balance 115—paid in full in cash."

Phoolmati had paid that remaining amount from cash wages earned on another field job.

The price of marua on that day was not written in the ledger.

There was no need.

In the meantime many new names had been added to Dhaneshwar's ledger.

Some wages were paid in cash, some in paddy, some in marua.

Whenever the question arose of adjusting an old debt against wages, the new lines were filled in.

One day Naveen jokingly said to Phoolmati, "Your two paseris of marua made the ledger fat."

Phoolmati said, "The two paseris were already written."

"Then what was new?"

Phoolmati placed her finger on the line in the ledger that said: "Exchange day."

"This."

At that moment there was no fresh marua in the threshing ground.

Only the empty paseri lay overturned.

Sunlight fell across its brass rim.

The price would change again.

The paseri would remain the same.

STORY 117

GRASS ON THE EMBANKMENT

It was the last week of Bhadon.

The slope of the flood embankment east of Sonbarsa village was now covered with green grass.

The rains had not stopped completely, but the flow of water had diminished. People had begun walking again along the footpath over the embankment that led from the northern hamlet towards the market.

Jamuna Devi went there every morning with her two goats.

She had named the white-and-black goat Dhourri. The other was Kajri.

Dhourri had a habit of tugging at the rope the moment she saw tender leaves along the path. Kajri was a little calmer, though she could chew even a piece of discarded paper.

Jamuna kept the ropes short.

At that time the grass on the embankment was not yet to be cut.

There was an old village custom: once the water had receded and the grass had shed its seed, a day would be fixed for cutting the embankment grass.

There was another custom too—the grass would be divided among livestock-owning households that had land.

None of this was written anywhere.

But there was a register in people's mouths.

"Twelve households."

Every year the same twelve household names were recited. Some had fields below the embankment, some had fields beside it, and some said their ancestors had contributed earth when the embankment was built.

Jamuna was not among those twelve households.

She had no field of her own.

What she called home was a rented courtyard of five dhurs and two small rooms, half a kos behind the embankment.

The two goats were hers.

For fodder for those two goats, she walked along the embankment twice a day.

Except on the day appointed for cutting grass, she took nothing from the embankment but the path.

Yet she did not merely use the path.

At the end of Jeth, when thorny bushes bent over the footpath, Jamuna cut them back with her sickle and pushed them aside.

One night in Sawan, a stream of water had eaten a small hollow into the southern slope of the embankment.

When Jamuna went there with the goats in the morning, her foot sank into it.

At noon she brought earth in a broken basket from home, along with two handfuls of straw, and filled the hollow.

No one told her to.

No one stopped her.

Twice in Bhadon, dried water-hyacinth stalks and plastic became lodged on the footpath.

Jamuna cleared them away.

She did not call this work "service to the embankment."

She said, "If the path stays bad, the goats will fall and I will break my leg too."

That year the grass had grown thick.

An evening meeting was held on the veranda of the village school to fix the cutting day.

Jamuna did not go to the meeting.

She had not been invited.

The next morning she heard that the grass would be cut on Sunday.

Small bamboo stakes would be driven into the embankment slope to mark shares for the twelve households.

Jamuna remained silent for a while, stroking Dhouri's ribs.

There was only enough dry straw in her house for five more days.

Purchased fodder was expensive.

Kajri was close to giving birth, so she needed more green fodder.

On Sunday, shortly after sunrise, Jamuna reached the embankment carrying a sickle, two ropes and an old sack.

People were already there.

Gopinath was tying cord between two bamboo poles to show the divisions.

Ramlochan told his son, "From this stake to the shadow of that date-palm is ours."

Devaki Devi was testing the dampness of the grass with her hand.

Jamuna stood to one side.

Gopinath saw her.

"Have you come to graze the goats?"

Jamuna held up the sickle.

"Not to graze today. To cut."

Gopinath became slightly uncomfortable.

"All the shares have already been fixed."

"Where is my share?"

No one laughed.

Gopinath said, "Your name is not in the old division."

"My goats were not in the old division either."

Hearing this from a distance, Ramlochan said, "By custom, the grass is divided among households that own fields."

Jamuna asked, "Has the grass grown in the fields or on the embankment?"

Ramlochan paused before answering.

"The embankment belongs to the village, but landowners have looked after it for a long time."

Jamuna pointed towards the footpath on top of the embankment.

"Who clears this path?"

No one answered.

Jamuna continued, "Who filled the hollow on the southern slope?"

Gopinath said, "That was only a small hollow."

"It was small, so I filled it. Had it been large, I would not have filled it alone."

This time Devaki Devi spoke.

"The matter today is the grass. If we stop the cutting, the grass will dry."

Jamuna said, "I am not asking you to stop. I am asking for some share for my two goats."

Ramlochan said, "If we give you some today, tomorrow someone without any livestock will also come and say that they cleaned the path."

Jamuna replied, "Why would someone without livestock take grass?"

"They could sell it."

"Then make a rule—grass only if there are animals. But why should land be necessary?"

For a short while after that sentence, the sound of sickles on the embankment stopped.

Gopinath said, "Let us first complete today's cutting. We will discuss this again in the evening."

Jamuna did not put her sickle down.

"Will any grass be left by evening?"

Devaki Devi looked towards one side of her own share.

"I will give you one bundle from mine."

Jamuna shook her head immediately.

"I am not asking for charity."

Devaki Devi's face did not harden.

"Not charity. Manage with it this time."

"This time may be managed. What about the next?"

Gopinath gathered the cord in his hand.

"All right. Stop the cutting for half an hour."

Ramlochan said with displeasure, "The sun is rising."

"The grass will not run away in half an hour," Gopinath replied.

Everyone sat on the level top of the embankment.

Some sharpened their sickles. Some drank water.

Gopinath recited the old names.

One by one, twelve households.

Jamuna listened.

When the twelfth name was finished, she asked, "How many animals are there among these twelve?"

No one knew the exact number.

Devaki Devi said, "We have three cows and one heifer."

Ramlochan said, "We have two cows and two bullocks."

Gopinath's household had one buffalo.

One of the households named on the list had sold its cow the previous year.

Jamuna asked, "Then what happens to that household's grass?"

Ramlochan said, "Its share is old."

"No animal, but a share?"

"It is the custom."

Jamuna tightened Dhouri's rope a little.

"I have animals but no share. Is that also the custom?"

No one gave a harsh answer.

Gopinath said, "Perhaps every household had animals when the custom was made."

Jamuna smiled.

"Then the custom has grown old."

Ramlochan's son laughed. Ramlochan glared at him.

Gopinath drew two lines in the soil with the point of a sickle.

The first line—animals.

The second—work on the embankment.

"If we divide on these two things," he said, "how will we count?"

Jamuna said, "First see who actually has animals."

Devaki Devi added, "And how many."

Ramlochan said, "A cow or bullock cannot count the same as a goat."

Jamuna replied, "Not the same. But zero animals and two goats are not the same thing either."

Slowly the matter moved beyond that morning's cutting.

Gopinath proposed that the old division should not be cut completely that day. Only the upper half would be cut, leaving the lower slope. In the evening they would make a register.

Ramlochan objected.

"The lower grass will become old in two days."

Jamuna said, "It may grow old, but its roots will remain. If it rains tomorrow, the slope will remain protected too."

Ramlochan looked at her.

"Are you an embankment mason?"

"No. I walk here every day."

There was neither anger nor any attempt at humility in her answer.

In the end, they decided to cut only the upper part.

Jamuna did not cut any grass that day.

Devaki Devi again offered her one bundle.

Jamuna again refused.

"Dhouri and Kajri will eat leaves today. If I take a bundle without a rule, my argument will be weaker tomorrow."

The meeting was held again that evening on the school veranda.

This time Jamuna was invited.

For the first time the old register was put down on paper.

Twelve names.

Gopinath asked each household how many animals it had.

Everyone knew the exact number for three households. Four were estimates. People from two households did not attend the meeting. One household turned out to have no animals.

Beside her own name Jamuna had written: "Two goats."

Ramlochan said, "Animals alone will not settle this. The embankment protects the fields of landowners. If it breaks, our fields will flood first."

Jamuna said, "That is true. Which means landowners too have an interest in keeping the embankment safe."

Ramlochan frowned.

Jamuna finished the sentence.

"My interest is the path and the goats. Having an interest is not a bad thing. The question is who does the work."

Devaki Devi said, "In the last flood, Ramlochan brought two cartloads of earth."

Jamuna replied at once, "Write it."

Ramlochan was startled.

"What?"

"The two cartloads of earth. Whatever was given for embankment work, write it."

Gopinath made a third line in the register: "Maintenance/materials."

Then the question arose: how many past years of work should be counted?

Ramlochan said five years.

Devaki Devi said one.

Jamuna said, "The farther back we count memory, the longer the story will become. Start from this year."

Everyone found that reasonable.

But the next question was difficult.

What counted as work on the embankment?

Someone could cut two bushes and say, "I gave labour."

Someone might be cleaning the drain of their own field and throw earth up on the embankment.

Someone might do one large job in the rains, another small tasks every day.

Jamuna said, "The work should be identified beforehand."

Gopinath asked, "Who will identify it?"

"Everyone who takes grass should walk the embankment once and inspect it."

Devaki Devi said, "Not everyone will have time in the morning."

"Then two people at a time can inspect it by turns."

Ramlochan said, "This is becoming too much of a register."

Jamuna smiled.

"Remembering twelve grass shares was easy because my name was not among them."

A little laughter rose on the veranda.

Even Ramlochan could not suppress half a smile.

In the end they agreed on a seven-day trial.

The embankment would be inspected in four sections.

Where the footpath was blocked, bushes were thick, there was a small water-cut, or rubbish had gathered, the work would be written down.

The person doing the work would have their name recorded.
When the work was complete, someone else would inspect it.
The number of animals too would be counted afresh.
Seven days later the remaining grass on the lower slope would be cut.

On the second day Jamuna was assigned the footpath in the southern section.

The work there was not new.
She had already been cutting back those bushes.
But this time she did not go alone.
Devaki Devi went with her.

Together they cut two thorny bushes from near the ground, but did not pull out the roots.

Jamuna said, "If the roots remain, they will hold the earth."

Devaki Devi asked, "Who taught you that?"

"No one. Once I pulled out the roots. In the rains, the earth washed away from that spot."

Devaki Devi wrote in the register: "Southern footpath—two bushes cut, roots left."

Jamuna said, "Is there any need to write my name?"

Devaki Devi looked at her.

"That is what this whole quarrel is about."

On the third day Ramlochan and his son put earth on a broken footpath in the northern section.

He did not bring two baskets; he brought a full bullock cart of earth.

Jamuna saw it and said, "That is bigger work than my two bushes."

Ramlochan asked, "So will I get more grass too?"

"You also have more animals."

"Two benefits?"

"One for the animals, one for the work. But the account of work must not eat up all the grass."

That sentence raised another question.

If someone who contributed a great deal of maintenance labour took nearly all the grass, a household with few animals but much labour would benefit, while a household with many animals would lose fodder.

If they counted only animals, the people doing the work would become invisible again.

After looking at four days of entries, Gopinath said, "Keep the two things separate."

"How?" Devaki Devi asked.

"First—does the household have livestock or not? Without livestock, no grass. Second—how many animals? That sets the limit of the share. Third—maintenance work. That gives priority and the next turn."

Jamuna asked, "What does priority mean?"

"Where grass is scarce, the share of someone who has done the work is secured first."

Ramlochan said, "What about someone who was ill or away?"

Gopinath fell silent.

Jamuna said, "There should be another way to contribute—earth, bamboo, rope, or an adult from the household working in their place."

Devaki Devi added, "Money?"

Jamuna thought for a moment.

"Where materials have to be bought, money. But giving money alone will not clear the footpath."

By the evening of the seventh day, sixteen household names had appeared in the register.

Twelve old.

Four new.

Of the four new households, three—including Jamuna's—were landless livestock-owning households, and one had land but had never been among the old twelve.

One old household was removed—it had no animals.

Its elderly owner himself said, "I do not need grass. When I keep a cow again, add my name."

With that, one part of the dispute diminished on its own.

But another quarrel arose over the number of animals.

One household had five goats; another had one buffalo.

Someone said one buffalo equalled five goats.

Someone else said three.

Jamuna said, "I do not want weighing and arithmetic. Make three categories—one or two animals, three or four, five or more. Embankment grass is not the whole ration. It is support."

For the first time Ramlochan agreed immediately.

"Yes. Otherwise we will become trapped in the mathematics of animals' stomachs."

The following Sunday, when the grass on the lower slope was cut, the new division was used.

First, a minimum bundle was set aside for everyone.

Then additional shares were assigned according to livestock category.

The share of households that had completed maintenance work was marked first.

A household that had done no work was assigned a new maintenance turn within one week; its basic grass share was not withheld, but the additional share would come after the turn was completed.

Jamuna received three bundles.

She did not cut all of them at once.

For the first bundle she went to a strip on the southern slope where the grass was thick.

She moved the sickle a little above the soil.

Ramlochan called from a distance, "Cut lower down. The bundle will be bigger."

Jamuna replied, "If we bare the roots, next year the bundle will be smaller."

Ramlochan said nothing.

A little later he told his own son, "Above the soil."

By noon the colour of the embankment had changed.

It had not been stripped bare.

Between the cut strips, green roots and short grass had been left.

The footpath was clearly visible.

At the southern hollow, the old earth Jamuna had packed in had now hardened.

Gopinath planted a small bamboo stake there.

"We will look at this place again in the rains," he said.

Jamuna asked, "Will you write it in the register?"

"We will."

"Under whose name?"

Gopinath said, "This time we will write who did the work. The hollow belongs to no one."

Jamuna began tying her bundle.

Of her three bundles, the first two went home.

She did not cut the full third bundle.

Kajri's belly was heavy; too much green grass would not be good for her.

Jamuna left some grass standing in her marked share.

Devaki Devi asked, "Some of your share is still left."

"Let it remain."

"Someone will cut it."

"Write in the register—'not cut.'"

Devaki Devi laughed.

"Now you have begun to trust the register a great deal."

Jamuna said, "Earlier the register did not trust me."

The rule did not become permanent all at once after that day.

The following month one family complained that its young son lived in the city and the elderly father could not do the work.

The meeting decided that the household could provide materials or send an agreed labourer for one turn in its place; but the name and amount of the work had to be written beforehand.

Another household said it did not want grass but did use the embankment footpath.

Its name was not added to the grass register.

Gopinath said, "The grass register is not a register of every use of the embankment."

Jamuna agreed.

"Let each paper remain for the work it is meant to record."

The following year the rains were heavier.

One night in Sawan, a small cut appeared again in the southern section.

In the morning Jamuna did not begin filling it alone.

She informed the household whose maintenance turn was recorded in the register.

Ramlochan's son, Devaki Devi's nephew, and people from two households newly added to the register came.

Four people together filled the cut.

Jamuna pressed earth around the roots of the bushes.

At noon Gopinath wrote the date in the register.

Beside no one's name was the word "land."

There was one line: "Livestock."

Another: "Maintenance."

A third: "Grass share."

Beside Jamuna's name was written: "Two goats."

In the maintenance column were two dates.

The grass-share column was still blank.

The cutting day had not yet come.

Jamuna closed the register.

Dhouri tugged at the rope and moved towards the green slope of the embankment.

Jamuna stopped her.

"Not yet."

Kajri bleated from behind.

Holding both ropes in one hand, Jamuna took the footpath.

The path was clear.

The grass was still growing.

STORY 118

THE PARAPET OF THE DRY WELL

It was the third week of Jeth.

In the middle of the rear hamlet of Belwa village, the old well lay under the sun with its empty mouth open.

The bottom of the well was very deep, but from above the dark brown earth could be seen clearly.

For two or three months after the rains withdrew, water remained in this well.

By the end of winter the water would recede.

As summer advanced, people would say, "It has dried up again."

There were fourteen private hand pumps in the hamlet.

There were also two public hand pumps.

So the use of the old well had gradually declined.

Its parapet now bore more signs of people sitting on it than of water-pots being placed there.

In the evenings elderly people sat and talked.

Sometimes a goat's rope was tied to the parapet.

If children tried to peer inside while playing, someone from a household would scold them and pull them away.

The parapet was not safe.

Three bricks had fallen from the eastern side.

On the southern side the mortar had crumbled away, leaving a narrow groove.

In one place an upper brick moved when touched.

Rukmini Devi had already raised the matter of repairs twice at village gatherings.

Both times the answer had been almost the same.

"Why spend money where there is no water?"

Rukmini had no hand pump of her own.

She used the public hand pump.

For that reason people sometimes said of her concern, "It is useful to you, so of course you want it repaired."

Rukmini did not become angry at this.

She merely asked, "If the broken parapet falls on someone's head, whose useful thing will it be then?"

People would change the subject.

One morning the flow from Harinarayan's courtyard hand pump suddenly became thin.

The handle moved properly.

The sound too was as before.

But where five strokes of the handle had once given a full stream, now even ten or twelve strokes failed to fill half a bucket.

Harinarayan first tightened the pipe joint.
 There was no difference.
 At noon his son Suresh replaced the leather valve below.
 The flow remained thin.
 Suresh said, "The water may have gone lower."
 Harinarayan replied, "It was not like this even in last year's heat."
 That same evening Ramnaresh's hand pump also began drawing air.
 Ramnaresh's hand pump stood about two hundred feet north of
 Harinarayan's house.
 People from both households set out separately in search of a mechanic.
 The next day Bhola the mechanic came.
 He first opened Ramnaresh's hand pump.
 Before pulling out the pipe he worked the handle and listened to the
 sound.
 Then he went to Harinarayan's hand pump.
 The sound was different at the two places.
 Bhola said, "It would not be right to assume both have the same illness."
 Ramnaresh asked, "Has the water gone down or not?"
 Bhola shrugged.
 "You cannot describe the water under the whole earth by looking at one
 hand pump."
 Suresh asked, "Then how do we find out?"
 Bhola looked around.
 His eyes fell on the old well.
 "Is there anything in this well now?"
 Ramnaresh laughed.
 "Earth."
 Bhola went to the well.
 Seeing the broken parapet, he did not stand on the eastern side.
 He looked inside from the west.
 At one place on the bottom, dark wet earth was shining.
 Bhola said, "It is not completely dry."
 Rukmini was returning at that moment with a water-pot from the public
 hand pump.
 She heard him and stopped.
 "A little water shines there in the morning," she said.
 "By noon there is only wet earth again."
 Bhola asked, "Since when?"
 "I have not counted exactly. Since Jeth began, more or less."
 Bhola opened his tool bag.
 There was a thin rope inside.
 He tied a small iron screw to one end.
 Suresh asked, "What will you do with that?"
 "Measure."
 "The water?"
 "As far as the wetness reaches."

Ramnaresh asked, "Will that repair my hand pump?"

Bhola laughed.

"It will not repair the hand pump. It may give us one mark in place of a guess."

He lowered the rope.

The screw touched the bottom.

Bhola slowly drew the rope back up.

The lower few finger-widths were wet.

He laid the rope on the edge of the parapet and tied a knot.

"We will measure from this point," he said.

Rukmini pointed to the broken parapet.

"It is not safe to stand at this spot every day."

Bhola shook one of the parapet bricks by hand.

A brick actually shifted slightly.

"You are right."

Harinarayan said, "Take the measurements from the western side."

Bhola looked west.

"We can. But if we do not measure from the same exact point every day, the comparison will be weaker."

Suresh asked, "For how many days?"

"Seven days. Morning and evening."

Ramnaresh laughed.

"We will measure a dry well for seven days in order to repair a hand pump?"

Bhola said, "I will open the hand pump today too. The measuring is a separate matter."

He opened Ramnaresh's hand pump again.

At one of the lower joints he found a fault that was allowing air to enter.

Bhola replaced that joint.

By noon Ramnaresh's hand pump was again giving a full stream.

Ramnaresh was pleased.

"See? The water had not gone down."

Bhola answered at once, "That was the fault in your hand pump. Do not draw a conclusion about all the water underground from it."

No such fault was found in Harinarayan's pump.

Bhola measured the total length of the pipe.

"The water here may genuinely have gone lower, or the level may be dropping during the day because so much is being drawn."

Harinarayan asked, "Then add more pipe."

"I can. But I will not blindly add two or three hand-spans right now."

"Then?"

"Measure for seven days. The well in the morning, the well in the evening, and note the time when the flow from your hand pump becomes weak."

Ramnaresh laughed again.

"Now the dry well will read a register?"

Rukmini said, "I will write the register."

Bhola himself took the first morning measurement.
 At the southwest joint of the parapet he made a small charcoal mark.
 From that exact point the rope was lowered.
 Suresh measured the wet section of the rope and wrote down the figure.
 In the evening they measured again.
 There was a difference.
 In the morning the wet mark was higher.
 In the evening it was lower.
 Bhola said, "That is one day's measurement. It is not a conclusion."
 On the second day Bhola went to another village.
 Rukmini and Suresh took the measurements.
 Because of the broken parapet, Suresh had to keep his body slightly back while leaning over.
 Rukmini said, "Lower the rope, not your body."
 Suresh laughed, but moved his feet back.
 The difference between morning and evening on the second day was not the same as on the first.
 On the third day clouds gathered a little in the afternoon, but no rain fell.
 In the evening measurement, the wet section appeared slightly higher.
 Ramnaresh said, "Did the water rise after seeing the clouds?"
 Suresh said, "But it did not rain."
 Rukmini wrote in the register: "Clouds in afternoon; no rain."
 On the fourth day the flow from Harinarayan's hand pump was good in the morning.
 Weak at noon.
 A little better again in the evening.
 That same day the well measurements too showed a rise and fall between morning and evening.
 Bhola returned that evening.
 He read the register.
 "This well does not tell you the exact water level of your hand pump," he said plainly.
 "The locations are different. The depths are different."
 Harinarayan asked, "Then what use is this measurement?"
 Bhola lifted the rope.
 "If you measure the same place every day, you can see the pattern of rising and falling. It is not proof. It is an indication."
 Suresh said, "And what does the indication say?"
 "In the heat, the level is low. When water is drawn throughout the day, it falls farther. During the night it recovers somewhat."
 Ramnaresh looked towards his own hand pump.
 "My fault was separate."
 "Yes."
 Harinarayan asked, "Mine?"
 "It would be reasonable to lengthen your pipe a little. But not a great depth all at once."

The next day Bhola extended Harinarayan's pipe by two hand-spans.

The flow improved.

He said, "Watch it now. Next summer, measure again."

Ramnaresh slapped the well parapet with his hand.

"The hand pump is fixed. Do we stop measuring now?"

Suresh was closing the register.

Bhola said, "Stop if you want. But you have an old open place here that can tell you something about how the water level near this hamlet rises and falls."

Ramnaresh asked, "The dry well?"

"Yes. The dry well."

Rukmini smiled.

"With a broken parapet."

Bhola shook a parapet brick again.

"If you are going to keep measuring, repair the parapet. It would be foolish for someone to fall in while trying to take measurements."

This time when the question of repairs arose, the question itself had changed.

Earlier it had been: "Who uses the water in the well?"

Now it was: "Who will use the measurements?"

Ramnaresh said, "My hand pump is fixed. I do not need measurements every day."

Harinarayan said, "But the same situation may return next Jeth."

Mohan Sahu from the southern side said, "My hand pump is deep. Why should I care?"

Before Suresh could answer, Bhola spoke.

"These measurements will not tell you the depth at your house. They will only tell you the water level at one open point near the hamlet."

Mohan Sahu said, "Then it is only partly useful to me."

Rukmini said, "Then why should everyone's contribution be of exactly the same kind?"

A sheet of paper was opened at the meeting.

Bhola estimated what would be needed to repair the parapet.

Sixty-four bricks in all.

Some sand.

Cement.

One day of a mason's work.

Half a day's assisting labour from two people.

Ramnaresh said, "Not equal cash again."

Rukmini replied, "No one ever said equal cash."

She drew three lines on the paper.

Cash.

Bricks/materials.

Labour.

Harinarayan pledged twelve bricks.

Ramnaresh said, "I will clean the old bricks."

Mohan Sahu thought for a moment and said, "The sand can come on my cart."

Saroj said, "I will soak the bricks."

An elderly woman whose household had no hand pump wanted to contribute five rupees.

Rukmini asked, "Why should you give cash? Your son can work."

The old woman said, "He has gone away. I will give five rupees. What shame is there in that?"

Rukmini entered the money in the register.

Beside no one's contribution was written "less" or "more."

Bhola only added the totals.

They were still short of the sixty-four bricks.

Three days later, eighteen sound bricks were selected from the remains of Suresh's old cowshed.

The total was complete.

On the day of the work, half the mouth of the well was covered with bamboo planks.

Bhola opened the damaged eastern side.

The old mortar was hollow inside.

When two bricks were removed, three more loosened.

Ramnaresh said, "Sixty-four will be too few after all."

Bhola said, "We will open only what is damaged. We will not break good bricks just to make the colour even on top."

In the end seven additional bricks were required.

On his way back, Mohan Sahu stopped his cart by an old brick kiln.

He brought seven bricks.

By the time the parapet was rebuilt, evening had fallen.

At the southwest joint, from where the measurements were taken, Bhola set a small smooth flat stone into the parapet.

Suresh asked, "Decoration?"

"A measuring point."

Bhola cut a narrow groove into the centre of the stone.

"Lower the rope from this groove every time."

Ramnaresh said, "The well has acquired its own zero."

Bhola laughed.

"The zero is on the parapet. The water is below."

The new mortar was left untouched for three days.

On the fourth morning the old seven-day register was opened again.

Rukmini placed the rope in the groove.

The iron screw descended.

This time Suresh wrote the measurement.

Date.

Morning.

Distance to the wet mark.

Again in the evening.

Ramnaresh asked, "Every day?"

Suresh said, "Once a week for now. Twice a week when the heat grows."

Harinarayan asked, "Whose responsibility?"

Rukmini said, "Whoever has time."

Ramnaresh shook his head.

"That rule will end in three weeks."

Suresh agreed.

"So write a rota."

The names of four households were written in rotation.

Rukmini added her own name fifth.

No one wrote how deep anyone's hand pump was.

No one wrote that the well measurement gave permission to draw a certain amount of water.

Bhola had made it clear: the measurement was not an order. It was an indication.

The first rain of Asadh came.

Water became clearly visible at the bottom of the well.

The measured level rose sharply.

Ramnaresh said excitedly, "Look, two hand-spans higher!"

Rukmini wrote "rain" in the register.

"Write the cause too," she said.

In Sawan the well did not fill, but water remained at the bottom.

In Bhadon the level rose farther.

In Kartik it fell.

In Magh the bottom of the well could be seen again.

In Phagun the register remained almost closed.

No one felt a need to measure.

The following Jeth the flow from Harinarayan's hand pump again became somewhat thin.

This time he did not call Bhola first.

He took the register from the tin box in the shrine room.

He looked at the figures from the previous Jeth.

Suresh brought the rope.

The smooth groove on the parapet was still clear.

The rope went down.

The reading was slightly lower than in the same week of the previous year.

Harinarayan said, "Should we lengthen the pipe after seeing this?"

Suresh replied, "The mechanic will inspect it first. This is only an indication."

Harinarayan laughed.

"Bhola has left you his sentence."

Bhola came that evening.

This time he found a small fault in a joint of the hand pump.

The pipe was not lengthened.

The work was completed in half an hour.

Before leaving, Bhola stopped beside the well.

"Is the parapet holding up?"

Rukmini said, "So far."
Bhola looked through the measurement register.
Two or three weeks of lines were blank.
He said nothing.
He closed the register and handed it back.
After noon no one was by the well.
No water-pot.
No clothes.
No goat.
At dusk, returning from the field, Ramnaresh stopped there.
He saw the measuring rope lying on the parapet.
The iron screw at the end of the rope lay in the dust.
He picked up the screw.
Coiled the rope.
And hung it on the small peg made beside the groove in the parapet.
The bottom of the well was still almost dry.

STORY 119

THE LAST DAY OF HARVEST

It was an evening in Agahan.

In the eastern fields of Bakhri village, only the final strip of paddy remained.

The same team had been harvesting for eight days.

There were seven people in the group.

Phulo Devi, Jagarnath, Rukmini, Bhola, Sitaram, Chhotki, and Nandu.

The field belonged to Ramlochan Jha.

The wages had been settled clearly beforehand—cash by the day, a midday meal, and, when the harvesting was complete, one sack of paddy for the team.

That one sack had no name anywhere on paper.

Everyone called it “the last-day sack.”

No one remembered when the custom had begun.

Phulo Devi used to say, “I had heard of it even before I was married.”

Jagarnath said, “My father too used to harvest. It existed in his time as well.”

Ramlochan’s father used to say that after the last day’s work—sweeping the threshing floor, counting the tools, returning ropes and bamboo poles, stitching torn sacks, gathering the grain left behind—the sack was given.

But year after year the matter had shrunk into a shorter sentence.

“If you are there on the last day, you get a share.”

That was all.

On the evening of the ninth day of harvesting, Nandu untied the knot in his gamchha and took out a thin railway ticket.

“I have to catch the train tomorrow night.”

Phulo Devi, tying a bundle of paddy, asked, “But the harvest will finish the day after tomorrow.”

“That is the problem.”

“Then?”

Nandu folded the ticket again.

“I have to take Ma to the city. Her eye examination is scheduled for the morning after tomorrow. If I do not catch tomorrow night’s train, we will miss the appointment.”

Ramlochan was there.

He heard everything.

He remained silent for a while.

Then he said, “I will pay your full daily wages through tomorrow. But the last-day sack will be divided the day after tomorrow.”

Nandu raised his head.

“I will not get a share?”

Ramlochan said matter-of-factly, “That is the custom. Those who stay on the last day divide it.”

Nandu said nothing.

Rukmini put a bundle of paddy to one side.

"Is this sack for standing there on the last day, or for doing the last-day work?"

Ramlochan looked at her.

"Until now the two were the same thing."

"They are not the same now."

Phulo Devi laughed.

"Rukmini has caught the point."

Ramlochan smiled faintly but did not answer.

In the evening the team reached the threshing floor.

There lay eight sickles, three long ropes, two bamboo poles, one balance, eighteen empty sacks, and two needles with thread.

Some of the things belonged to Ramlochan.

Some had been borrowed from a neighbouring field.

Some had been brought by the labourers themselves.

Phulo Devi said, "Tomorrow, stop harvesting for five minutes in the middle of the day."

Bhola asked, "Why?"

"To look at the last-day sack."

Everyone laughed.

"The sack is still empty."

"That is why we will look at it."

The next day the sun was strong at noon.

They stopped harvesting and sat in the shade of the bund.

With the tip of a sickle Phulo Devi drew lines on the earth.

First line.

"Tools."

Second.

"Sacks."

Third.

"Ropes and bamboo."

Fourth.

"Threshing floor."

Fifth.

"Leftover grain."

Sixth.

"Final load."

Jagarnath said, "And the bullocks?"

Ramlochan said, "The bullocks are mine. I will take care of them."

Phulo Devi did not add a seventh line.

"Fine."

She looked at Nandu.

"Which of these jobs can you do today?"

Nandu answered at once, "I can count the tools."

Chhotki said, "Not just count them. The handles of two sickles are loose."

"I will bind them."

Bhola said, "Three sacks are already torn."

"I will stitch them."

Sitaram said, "Two ropes in the eastern field belong to the neighbour. They will be returned after the final load is lifted."

Nandu fell silent.

Rukmini said, "That cannot be done beforehand."

Phulo Devi made two marks in front of the lines drawn on the soil.

"Before."

"Last day."

Ramlochan watched carefully.

Jagarnath asked, "Sweeping the threshing floor?"

"Last day."

"Leftover grain?"

"Last day."

"Torn sacks?"

Phulo Devi said, "Those torn already—beforehand. Those torn on the final day—on the final day."

Everyone laughed again.

Ramlochan too.

But Nandu's face was still serious.

"This evening I will do the tools and the sacks that are torn now."

Sitaram said, "Then the day after tomorrow I will do your share of the threshing floor?"

Nandu asked, "In exchange?"

"You repair my sickle handle as well."

"Agreed."

Rukmini said, "Gathering leftover grain is not light work. Bending and bending breaks the back."

Nandu asked, "Will someone take that job?"

Chhotki raised her hand.

"I will. Today you stitch my two sacks."

Phulo Devi asked, "Is stitching sacks equal to gathering grain?"

Chhotki replied, "For me it is. His hand is quick with a needle; mine is quick with a broom."

Ramlochan's eyebrows lifted slightly.

"There has never been so much accounting before."

Phulo Devi said, "Perhaps no one had ever needed to catch a train one day early before."

Ramlochan said, "People must have gone early before."

"And their share?"

"Perhaps they did not get it."

"Then there was an accounting. It simply was not written."

Ramlochan fell silent.

The midday rest ended.

Harvesting began again.

That evening Nandu remained on the threshing floor until everyone else had nearly finished.

He examined all eight sickles one by one.

He tightened two handles with new strips of cloth.

The edge of one sickle was very blunt.

Jagarnath brought a stone.

Nandu kept sharpening it.

Chhotki separated the torn sacks.

There were four in all.

Nandu rubbed the thread with wax.

One by one, he stitched all four sacks.

Rukmini sat nearby winnowing paddy.

She asked, "Where are you catching the train from?"

"Laheria Sarai."

"What time will you leave from here?"

"As soon as the evening's work ends."

"In the dark?"

"Bhola will take me on his bicycle as far as the main road."

Bhola called from a distance, "I have already said I will."

Ramlochan brought an old notebook.

Half a page contained accounts for fertiliser.

There was empty space below.

Phulo Devi said, "Not there."

Ramlochan asked, "Why?"

"The closing work will disappear among the fertiliser accounts."

She gave him a separate thin sheet of paper.

At the top Phulo Devi wrote:

"CLOSING WORK."

Below it, six lines.

Tools.

Sacks.

Ropes and bamboo.

Threshing floor.

Leftover grain.

Final load.

Nandu marked the first two lines against his name.

Against Sitaram's name went the threshing floor.

Against Chhotki's name went the leftover grain.

Rukmini said, "Everyone will do the final load together."

Phulo Devi wrote: "All."

Jagarnath gave his name for the ropes and bamboo.

"I will return them."

Ramlochan asked, "Then does Nandu get a full share?"

Phulo Devi said, "How can we say yet? Let the work be completed."

Late in the evening the four stitched sacks were placed to one side.

Nandu counted the tools.

Eight sickles.
One sharpening stone.
Two needles.
One small bundle of thread.
Two weights for the balance.
He read the list aloud.
Ramlochan said, "Correct."
Nandu folded the paper and gave it to Phulo Devi.
"I will harvest until tomorrow evening."
"Yes."
"After that I will leave."
"Go."

The next day Nandu began work quickly from early morning.
No one asked him to harvest more than the others.
He cut his normal row.
By noon, half the remaining eastern strip was complete.
At dusk he shook off his sickle for the last time and put it down.
Ramlochan counted out his daily wages.
Nandu counted the money.
"It is complete."
Ramlochan said, "The last sack is tomorrow."
"Yes."

This time Nandu did not ask about his share.
Bhola brought the bicycle.
Nandu took his gamchha, small bag, and railway ticket and bowed to everyone.

Phulo Devi only said, "Get your mother's eyes examined."
Nandu left.

That night the wind blew.
One empty sack lying on the threshing floor flew into a thorny bush.
When it was taken out in the morning, there was a long tear through the middle.

Chhotki looked at the sack.
"Nandu did not stitch this one."
Rukmini laughed.
"Can the last day's work ever be completed beforehand?"
Chhotki picked up the needle.
"Some of it can. Some of it is born again."
She sat down to stitch the sack.
Phulo Devi took out the thin sheet.
Beside "Sacks—Nandu," she added Chhotki's name too.
Ramlochan asked, "Now?"
Phulo Devi replied, "Now let the work be completed."
The sun came out on the final day of harvesting.
By noon the remaining paddy in the eastern strip had been cut.
The last bundle was loaded onto the bullock cart.

This time no one announced that the work was finished.
 Everyone returned to the threshing floor.
 Jagarnath separated the two borrowed ropes and the bamboo poles.
 Sitaram picked up the broom.
 Chhotki joined him.
 Rukmini began gathering the small grains and panicles of paddy into a shallow basket.
 Bhola packed away the balance.
 Phulo Devi moved about with the list in her hand.
 Ramlochan had been sitting by the doorway.
 After a while he too got up and came over.
 "What should I do?"
 Jagarnath said, "Tie the mouths of the sacks from the final load."
 Ramlochan laughed.
 "The owner too in the closing work?"
 "The sacks are yours."
 Ramlochan took up the rope.
 Before evening the threshing floor was clean.
 The grains swept up from the floor made a small heap.
 Rukmini cleaned it by hand and removed the light rubbish.
 Chhotki had finished stitching the newly torn sack.
 Dust clung to Sitaram's palm.
 Jagarnath returned after taking back the ropes and bamboo poles.
 Phulo Devi spread the thin sheet on the ground.
 "Now the sack."
 Ramlochan brought a full sack from the house.
 "As per custom."
 Bhola asked, "Is the value of this sack for the work, or for the people?"
 Ramlochan said, "Until today I thought it was for the people."
 Phulo Devi asked, "And now?"
 Ramlochan looked at the list.
 "For the work."
 Chhotki said, "Then Nandu stitched sacks. But today I stitched one new sack."
 Jagarnath said, "Nandu did the tools before leaving."
 Sitaram said, "I took his share of the threshing-floor work, but he repaired my sickle."
 Rukmini said, "Chhotki took the leftover-grain work, but in exchange for Nandu stitching her sacks."
 Bhola laughed.
 "I rode the bicycle. Is that in the register?"
 Phulo Devi smiled.
 "No. That was a friend's work."
 Everyone laughed.
 Ramlochan said, "Then seven shares?"
 Phulo Devi shook her head.

“There are seven people in the team, but Nandu is not here today. Yet he is present in the work.”

“Then seven equal shares?”

Chhotki held up the needle.

“What about the newly torn sack?”

For a few moments there was silence.

If Nandu had been there, perhaps he would have said Chhotki should receive a little more.

But he was not there.

Reducing his share in his absence could once again return them to the old question.

Phulo Devi said, “Divide the sack into seven equal shares.”

Chhotki looked at her.

“And the new stitching?”

“We will let you and Nandu settle that when he comes back.”

Chhotki shook her head.

“No. That was the team’s work. The wind tore it, not Nandu.”

Rukmini said, “That is right.”

Ramlochan opened the sack.

The paddy was divided into seven small heaps.

At first none of the heaps was weighed.

They judged by eye.

Then Phulo Devi said, “Weigh them.”

Ramlochan laughed.

“So much accounting?”

“Today is the day for accounting.”

The balance was set up.

Two heaps turned out a little larger.

One was a little smaller.

They were made equal.

Nandu’s share was put into a clean sack.

As Chhotki stitched its mouth, she said, “This sack is not torn.”

Jagarnath asked, “When will Nandu return?”

Bhola said, “In two days.”

Ramlochan said, “It can stay with me.”

Phulo Devi replied immediately, “No.”

Ramlochan was surprised.

“Why?”

“His share is the team’s earning. Let it remain at one of the team’s houses.”

Chhotki said, “Leave it at my house.”

Nandu’s sack was lifted onto Chhotki’s head.

Evening was falling.

The threshing floor was so clean that the old cracks in the earth could be seen.

Before folding the thin sheet, Phulo Devi added a line at the bottom:

"Last day = closing work."

Ramlochan read it.

"That is not exactly equal. Some of the work can be done beforehand."

Phulo Devi opened the sheet again.

She struck out the line.

Then wrote:

"LAST-DAY SACK—AFTER CLOSING WORK IS COMPLETE."

Sitaram said, "And if someone leaves early?"

Phulo Devi wrote:

"If leaving early, arrange beforehand for one's share of the closing work."

Jagarnath added, "What about work that cannot be done in advance?"

Phulo Devi said, "Then someone must agree to take it in exchange."

Ramlochan asked, "And if no one agrees?"

"Then the share will be reduced. The reason will be the work left undone, not the face of the person."

Ramlochan took the paper in his hand.

"Next year I will read this out on the first day."

Rukmini said, "Read it on the first day, not the last."

Ramlochan smiled.

"Fine."

Two days later Nandu returned.

He did not go straight to Ramlochan's doorway.

First he went to Chhotki's house.

Chhotki was drying marua in the courtyard.

Nandu said, "Ma is all right."

Chhotki said, "Good."

"My sack?"

She brought it out from the room.

"Complete."

Nandu felt the sack with his hand.

"I was not there on the last day."

"Your work was."

"All of it?"

"Not all. The wind tore one new sack."

Nandu laughed.

"Who stitched it?"

"I did."

Nandu began opening his sack.

"Take a little paddy."

Chhotki stopped his hand.

"No."

"Why?"

"The wind tore it. It was not your job."

Nandu remained silent for a few moments.

Then he tied the sack again.

"Next year I will stay for the last day."

Chhotki said, "It will be good if you can."

She paused.

"If you cannot, say so on the first day."

Nandu lifted the sack onto his shoulder.

He walked home.

When harvesting began the following Agahan, Ramlochan brought out a new sheet on the very first day.

The wage rate.

Meal time.

Who owned which tools.

And at the end:

"LAST-DAY SACK—AFTER CLOSING WORK IS COMPLETE."

Below it were six lines.

Tools.

Sacks.

Ropes and bamboo.

Threshing floor.

Leftover grain.

Final load.

Phulo Devi read it and said, "One line is missing."

Ramlochan asked, "Which?"

"Substitution."

Ramlochan added a seventh line:

"Leaving early—substitute arranged."

The sheet was hung on a pillar of the threshing floor.

That day the first handful of paddy was cut.

The last day was still very far away.

STORY 120

THE NAME OF THE BUND

It was the first week of Margashirsha.

South of Baraha village, Jivachh Mahato's old three-bigha field had now been divided into three sections.

Two years before his death, Jivachh Mahato had divided the land among his three sons.

The eldest, Raghunath, received the upper strip.

The middle son, Devkant, received the middle strip.

The youngest, Naval, received the field lower down the slope.

On paper, the division was clear.

Separate plot numbers.

Separate measurements.

Separate boundary marks on all four sides.

But the slope of the land had not been divided.

And water did not read paper.

Across the old field, from east to west, ran a long bund.

Jivachh Mahato had called it "the middle bund."

After the division, that bund became chiefly the boundary between Raghunath and Devkant.

At one point in the bund there was an old irrigation opening.

When the upper field filled, water passed through that opening into Devkant's field.

From the rear corner of the middle field, the channel turned again and ran into Naval's field.

The three brothers had watched water travel by this route since childhood.

In their father's time, no one asked who owned the irrigation opening.

When one field had enough water, whoever was there lifted the wooden board a little.

The water flowed to the next field.

When the final field filled, the board was lowered again.

For the first two years after the division, the old arrangement continued.

In the third year, the boundary became more visible on the ground.

One day in Kartik, Raghunath had the amin's measurements checked again.

The red line on the cadastral map fell on the northern side of the bund.

Most of the soil of the bund counted within Raghunath's measurement.

Looking at the map, Devkant said, "The boundary still belongs to both of us."

Raghunath replied, "The boundary belongs to both, but most of the bund lies within my measurement."

Naval laughed.

"I did not get any bund at all. I only got the water."

That day the matter ended as a joke.

The following week Raghunath began strengthening the bund.

In the previous rains, the soil had collapsed in two places.

He cut earth from his side of the field and raised it onto the bund.

He pressed grass roots into the top.

In two days the bund stood a palm higher than before.

From a distance the boundary looked clear.

Seeing the bund, Devkant said, "Good. The soil will not wash away in the rains."

Raghunath was pleased.

But the old irrigation opening had risen with the bund.

As the earth was piled up, the lower sill of the opening had slowly filled.

The wooden board was still there, but its lower edge now almost touched the ground.

No one noticed at the time.

The first irrigation of the wheat was fixed for the third day of Margashirsha.

The three brothers had hired the same diesel pump.

The pump belonged to Ramsevak Yadav.

The rule was clear—the charge would be counted from the time the engine ran.

Raghunath had the pump started at eight in the morning.

Water spread well across the upper field.

At ten o'clock he lifted the old wooden board.

Where a thick stream used to descend, only a thin flow emerged.

Raghunath raised the board farther.

The stream increased a little, but not much.

Devkant stood below.

"The opening has filled up."

Raghunath brought a spade.

He scraped away some of the earth beneath the board.

The stream increased.

Devkant said, "Lower it farther."

Raghunath stopped.

"If I lower it that much, the water will not remain in my field."

"It used to be there before."

"The bund was weaker before."

From beside the engine Ramsevak shouted, "Decide quickly. The diesel is running."

By the time half of Devkant's field had filled, the clock had advanced far more than expected.

Naval waited at the lower channel.

It was afternoon before water reached his field.

That day all three paid more for the pump than expected.

Ramsevak said, "The pump ran at the same speed. The route became narrow."

Raghunath said, "The bund became stronger."

Naval replied, "The bund became stronger; the water became weaker."

He said it lightly, but Raghunath did not like it.

"If there is no bund, where is the boundary?"

Devkant said, "Keep the boundary. Keep the water-opening too."

"They are in the same earth."

"But they do different work."

At that sentence, all three fell silent.

The next day Devkant brought the cadastral map.

The three of them spread it on the grass beside the bund.

The red line was clear.

The irrigation opening was nowhere on the map.

Naval placed a finger on it.

"Where is the water written here?"

Raghunath said, "The map is of the land."

"Then on whose paper is the water?"

No one answered.

Ramsevak came at that moment to collect the money still owed to him.

Seeing the three brothers gathered around the map, he laughed.

"Looking for a way to reduce the pump bill?"

Devkant showed him the height of the opening.

Ramsevak bent down and touched the soil.

"When you raised the bund, the sill rose too."

Raghunath said, "If we lower the sill, the bund will become weak."

Ramsevak stood up.

"Why lower the whole bund? Make the opening separately at that spot."

Naval asked, "How low?"

Ramsevak laughed.

"I will not tell you that by looking. Run the water and see."

The three agreed that on the next irrigation day, before anything else, they would spend half an hour measuring the opening.

Devkant cut three thin bamboo stakes.

One was planted in the upper field.

One below the opening.

One at the start of the rear channel leading from the middle field towards Naval's land.

Charcoal lines were drawn on the stakes.

The first line marked the height at which Raghunath wanted water to remain in his field.

The second marked the point at which water crossed the opening.

The third marked the beginning of the channel leading from the middle field down towards Naval's field.

On the next irrigation day the pump was started.

Raghunath's field filled.

The board was raised.

The sill of the opening was still high.

Water moved slowly towards the second stake.

Ramsevak looked at the clock.

“Twenty-seven minutes.”

Devkant said, “Earlier it reached there in ten or fifteen minutes.”

Raghunath asked, “Do you remember that, or had you measured it?”

Devkant fell silent.

For the first time, all of them were looking at measurements instead of memory.

With the spade, Raghunath lowered the earth in the middle of the opening by two finger-widths.

The board was fitted again.

Water continued to stay in the upper field.

When the board was raised, the stream became thicker.

It reached the second stake in twelve minutes.

From below Naval called, “Now it is good.”

Raghunath pressed the earth on both sides of the opening with his hands.

“If this remains bare soil, it will wear away again.”

Devkant brought two old bricks.

The two bricks were placed inside the bund so that a sill of fixed width remained between them.

Earth was packed over the top, but the mouth between the bricks was left open.

The wooden board could slide in front of the bricks.

Naval brought an old iron ring from his house.

He tied it to the top of the board so it could be lifted without putting a hand into the water.

Raghunath looked at the ring and smiled.

“The bund is mostly within my measurement, the bricks are Devkant’s, and the ring is Naval’s.”

Naval said, “The water belongs to all three.”

This time no one laughed.

They drew new lines on the three stakes.

The fill-line for the upper field.

The sill-line of the water-opening.

The line at which the lower channel was to be opened from the middle field.

Ramsevak said, “Write the names of these lines down. Otherwise you will argue again two months from now.”

Devkant cut a strip from an old fertiliser sack.

On one he wrote: “Upper-field fill.”

On another: “Water-opening sill.”

On the third: “Lower channel.”

Naval asked, “And the name of the bund?”

Devkant did not answer.

The irrigation that day finished in less time than the previous one.

The pump charge too was lower.

Counting the money, Ramsevak said, "Diesel was saved today. The map did not change; only the height of the opening did."

Raghunath said, "The opening became lower, and the bund did not become weaker."

Pressing the earth down, Devkant said, "Because we understood the opening separately from the bund."

The work was settled, but the question of responsibility remained.

A week later Devkant was cutting grass on his side of the bund.

He saw that one brick of the water-opening had become slightly loose.

He called Raghunath.

Raghunath said, "The bund lies mostly within my measurement, but that brick came from your house."

Devkant replied, "The brick came from my house. The opening belongs to all three."

Naval arrived.

"Did you call me?"

Devkant said, "The iron ring is yours."

Naval laughed.

"Do not place the whole opening on my head because of the ring."

The three sat down again.

This time they did not open the map.

Raghunath said, "The ordinary part of the boundary bund will be looked after by the two of us—Devkant and me."

Devkant nodded.

"Because the boundary lies between our two fields."

Naval said, "The opening belongs to all three."

"Yes."

"And if someone damages the opening while doing his own work?"

Raghunath said, "He will repair it first."

Devkant added, "If the opening fills because of rain, all three of us will clear it."

Naval said, "And if an ordinary part of the bund collapses because of rain, you two."

Raghunath smiled.

"You did not receive a boundary."

Naval replied, "I received the water."

Devkant brought an old register from home.

On the first page they wrote the three plot numbers.

Below them were two separate headings.

"BOUNDARY BUND."

"IRRIGATION OPENING."

Beside the boundary-bund heading were the names of Raghunath and Devkant.

Beside the irrigation-opening heading were all three names.

A third line: "Soil/bricks deliberately altered—the person who changes them will restore them."

A fourth: "Opening filled by rain/silt—all three users will clear it."

A fifth: "Ordinary erosion of the boundary section—the two adjoining fields."

Naval read it and said, "This is becoming too much paperwork."

Devkant said, "It is five lines."

Raghunath said, "The quarrel used to last five days."

The register was closed.

In Magh came the second irrigation.

This time Raghunath wanted to raise earth again on the northern side of the bund.

Before beginning, he checked the sill-line of the water-opening.

The new soil was placed above that line, not inside the opening.

Devkant said nothing.

Neither did Naval.

At its turn, the water reached all three fields.

One evening in Phagun, a calf climbed onto the bund.

The stake in front of the opening became crooked.

Raghunath's grandson Chhotu reached out to straighten it.

Raghunath stopped him.

"Put it back after looking at the line."

Chhotu asked, "Which line is this?"

Raghunath showed him all three stakes.

Chhotu did not understand the cadastral plot numbers.

But he understood that the water would remain up to one line, and from another place it would go down.

In Chait the wheat ripened.

The colour of the three fields was not exactly the same.

In one corner of Raghunath's field the ears were thick.

Across a strip in Devkant's field they were somewhat thinner.

In Naval's lower field the soil was more clayey.

The water had followed one route, but the crop had not become one.

Devkant said, "A rule can give water. It cannot make the yield equal."

Naval replied, "If anyone makes a paper guaranteeing equal harvests, even God will refuse to sign it."

All three laughed.

After the harvest, the bund stood exposed.

One day the cadastral map came out again inside the house.

Raghunath needed a copy for a loan document.

He spread out the map and looked at it.

The red line was still in the same place.

Most of the bund still lay within his measured plot.

Devkant came in.

"Has the name of the bund changed?"

Raghunath said, "No."

Naval too came inside.

"And the name of the water-opening?"

Raghunath smiled.
“It is still not on the map.”
The three folded the map.
Before the first rains of Asadh, they fixed a day to clean the opening.
Raghunath checked the earth.
Devkant tapped the bricks.
Naval inspected the ring and the wooden board.
The work was finished in half an hour.
Naval cut a thin strip of bamboo.
With charcoal Devkant wrote on it:
“BOUNDARY—TWO FIELDS.”
Below it Raghunath added a second line:
“WATER—THREE FIELDS.”
The strip was planted in the earth of the bund.
No name in the cadastral register had changed.
The bund was still the same bund.
Only the opening in its middle now stated its own work separately from
the name of the land.

THE STYLUS OF THE DRY CANAL

That night, in the water-gauging house of a canal that had been recorded on paper as dry for six years, the stylus began to move.

The first time Harinath Jha heard the sound, he thought someone's fingernail was slowly scraping over paper. It was not loud. For twenty-five years he had heard old timber split, rats gnaw sacks, wind stir the edge of the tiled roof. But this sound was different.

Tick... srrr...

Tick... srrr...

He opened his eyes on the cot and stared at the ceiling for a few moments. Outside it was a Bhadon night, but there were no clouds. The day's heat had entered the body and remained there; even after nightfall, warmth seemed to rise from the earth like steam.

In the room ahead of the water-gauging house stood the old recording instrument—a brass-coloured cylinder, a clockwork frame, a fine stylus, and a drum around which paper was fixed. In earlier years Harinath had listened to it run so often that from a distance he could tell whether a tooth on the drum had caught or the stylus joint had gone dry.

But the machine was not supposed to be running now.

Six years earlier, this stretch of the Sonbarsa branch canal had been formally closed. Regular inflow from the main canal had stopped, the pipe to the gauging well had filled with silt, and the department had painted in red letters on the old building's door: "OUT OF USE."

That year the building was to be removed for widening of the new road. Assistant Engineer Aarti Mandal had told Harinath, "You know the old registers. If you can come for two days, the records may be saved. Otherwise, to the labourers, all of this is merely old paper."

Harinath had agreed.

All day he had sorted registers with Aarti—water levels, gate openings, rainfall, inspections, repairs, complaints. The years changed on the paper, handwriting changed, ink faded. On some pages he smiled on seeing his own younger hand. On others, the moment his eyes halted, he would quickly pick up another register.

The departmental guest room was far away, so that evening Aarti had said, "There is a cot in the back room here. I will stay at watchman Ramotar's house. I will come early in the morning."

Harinath was alone.

Tick... srrr...

He sat up.

The sound stopped.

He switched on the light of the mobile phone kept beside his pillow.

Nine twenty-seven.

Silence outside.
 Crickets sounded in the dry belly of the canal.
 Somewhere far away, a dog barked twice.
 Harinath lay down again.
 Five minutes later—
 Tick... srrr...
 Tick...
 This time he left the cot.
 The door to the front room had been fastened from inside.
 His palm was damp when he lifted the latch.
 He chose to blame the heat for the sweat.
 He did not wish to blame his mind.
 Inside the room, the smell of dust, old oil and paper mingled together.
 He turned the mobile-phone light straight ahead.
 Cupboards.
 A wooden table.
 A 2003 water-distribution map hanging crooked on the wall.
 And in the corner, the recording instrument.
 The stylus rested on the paper.
 Harinath stood still.
 The drum was turning very slowly.
 “This...”
 That was all that came from his mouth.
 He went closer.
 The clockwork section of the instrument had been dead for years.
 Without winding, the drum should not have moved.
 He touched its rim.
 The motion was so slight that it could scarcely be detected without touching it, but it was moving.
 The point of the stylus was drawing a fine black line.
 At first the line ran straight.
 Then suddenly it rose—
 one,
 two,
 three tiny divisions.
 That was how the line rose when the water level increased.
 Harinath’s hand froze on the machine.
 Outside, the canal was dry.
 He quickly picked up the lantern from the corner, lit the wick, and went around to the gauging well behind the building.
 The small iron cover had been jammed for years.
 During the day the labourers had partly loosened it.
 Harinath set an iron hook into it and lifted.
 Darkness below.
 He lowered the lantern.
 At first there was nothing.

Then the yellow light caught a gleam on the wall of the well.
Water.

Not very far down.

About a cubit and a half above the bottom.

Something tightened inside Harinath's chest.

"The canal is dry... then?"

He drew the lantern back.

At that instant an old night flashed before his eyes—a line drawn on paper, a red pencil, the hands of a clock, and a voice:

"Jha ji, write zero. What remains on paper will be accepted as the truth."

He dropped the cover shut.

When he returned to the recorder, the stylus was descending again.

Within five or seven minutes the rise had formed, and then the line became level.

Harinath did not tear the paper.

Nor did he try to stop the machine.

He simply stood in the middle of the room and watched the fresh line, as though the paper were watching him.

Aarti arrived at five fifty-five in the morning with two glasses of tea in her hands.

Ramotar followed carrying a bag.

"Did the night pass well?" Aarti asked.

Harinath did not take the tea.

"The machine ran."

Aarti did not understand.

"Which machine?"

"The recorder."

Ramotar laughed.

"That old thing? It used to rattle even when I was a child."

Harinath looked at him.

"There was water in the well last night."

Ramotar stopped laughing at once.

Aarti put the tea on the table and went to the machine.

She examined the line drawn during the night.

The time marks corresponded.

The rise ran from nine thirty-two to nine forty-nine.

"Did you change the paper?"

"No."

"Wind the clock?"

"No."

Aarti looked behind the drum.

"The main clock is still dead."

"Yet the paper moved."

She bent and touched a small auxiliary wheel.

"In this old model, if the grip is loose, movement of the float arm can shift the paper slightly. But where did the water come from?"

All three went to the gauging well.

In daylight very little water remained—only a damp circular mark on the wall.

Aarti tied a stone to a cord and measured the depth.

“The main pipe is supposed to be blocked with silt,” she said. “Yesterday the labourers dug into the canal bed. There was no flow.”

Harinath remained silent.

Aarti looked again at the wall.

“Water rose here at night. That means the well is still connected to something somewhere.”

Ramotar wiped his head with his gamchha.

“Madam, in the old days there were so many small pipes. Not all of them are on the maps.”

Harinath looked sharply at him.

“Which pipe are you talking about?”

Ramotar was startled.

“I was only saying.”

Aarti looked at both of them but said nothing.

Sorting the registers began again.

Harinath’s hands moved.

His mind did not.

1999.

2000.

2001.

2002.

2003.

He reached the bundle marked 2004 and stopped.

A red ribbon lay across the top.

There was less dust on the ribbon—perhaps Aarti had looked at it the day before.

He left that bundle and picked up 2005.

“Not 2004?” Aarti asked from the other end of the table.

Harinath’s hand stopped.

“Let us finish this first.”

“All right.”

Aarti bent again over her list.

Harinath watched the top of her head.

Her hair was tied tightly.

There was a fine line of sweat on her forehead.

A blue pen in her hand.

She asked questions constantly, but never as accusations.

That made Harinath more uneasy.

An accusation can be answered in advance.

A simple question enters inside.

At noon Ramotar brought rice and dal.

While eating, Aarti asked, "Which villages lay at the tail end of this branch?"

Harinath tried to answer naturally.

"Belouna, Majhigama, Chhotki Parsahi, and at the very end Haripur Tola."

"Were there more complaints from the last settlement about water distribution?"

Harinath's spoon struck the plate.

"In a canal, the last places always receive less water."

"There are many complaints in 2004."

"It was a drought year."

"Then why are the night-flow pages for this branch missing?"

Harinath did not look into Aarti's eyes.

"These are old records. Some things go missing."

Aarti merely said, "Yes," and continued eating.

That was all.

But inside Harinath, the old voice rose again:

"Write zero."

It had been Jeth of 2004.

Water had been scarce for three months.

There were quarrels at the main gate.

A little water reached Belouna, but the last villages were dry.

At that time Jagdish Singh, chairman of the branch committee, had two large fish ponds.

Water was released at night, but the register showed zero.

The order was never written.

Bansil Paswan, a daily-wage canal worker, opened the gate.

The order came from above.

One night Bansil refused.

He said, "Even the drinking pond in the last settlement is drying. Water must go there first."

The next day a complaint was made that Bansil opened the gate on his own authority and disturbed the water distribution.

An inquiry came.

Two records were placed in front of Harinath.

One was the original chart, showing that between one and two in the night the water had risen.

The other was a clean sheet.

"Write zero."

Harinath had written it.

Bansil's wages were stopped for three months.

Later he left the job.

For years Harinath had called the matter "a small mistake" inside his own mind.

Jagdish Singh had been powerful.

There had been a job to save.

There were two children at home.
 Bansilal had not died.
 He had not gone to prison.
 He had only left his work.
 People left jobs all the time.

But whenever the line on the night chart rose upward, the words “small mistake” became very small indeed.

After noon Aarti said they should inspect the dry bed of the main canal.
 The three of them went down.
 Grass reached their knees.

An old brick measuring mark was half broken.

If water had passed anywhere during the night, there should have been signs on the earth.

Harinath bent and looked.

Dry cracks ran across the canal bed.

“There was no water here,” Aarti said.

“Then in the well?” Ramotar asked.

Aarti looked towards old bushes on the left side of the canal.

“The well may no longer be connected to the main bed. There may be another connection.”

Harinath’s eyes went there too.

Behind the bushes was a low wall of old brick.

Beyond that wall had once been a “service outlet”—a small pipe built to release water during maintenance.

It had appeared on the first version of the government map and disappeared from later ones.

In 2001 the pipe had been shown as “permanently closed.”

Harinath did not move forward.

Aarti did.

She pushed aside the bushes.

Between the bricks, a round iron head protruded.

Rust covered its sides, but the middle edge shone with fresh abrasion.

“What is this?”

Ramotar said, “Looks like an old spindle.”

Harinath’s throat dried.

“It was the turning spindle for the service outlet.”

Aarti knelt and touched the metal head.

“This has been turned recently.”

Harinath said quickly, “Rust can fall away by itself.”

Aarti withdrew her hand.

“It can.”

The answer was so simple that Harinath heard the haste in his own voice.

Under the bushes the earth was dry, but a small white plastic fibre was caught there.

Ramotar picked it up.

“A strand from a rope.”

Aarti wrapped it in paper and put it into her pocket.

“We will watch tonight.”

“What?” Harinath asked.

“Whether the line rises again.”

Harinath wanted to say, I will not stay.

What came out was, “I will stay.”

In the evening Ramotar went home.

This time Aarti had a second cot placed in the back room.

“If the machine runs, we will see it immediately.”

Harinath asked, “Should we inform anyone?”

“Not yet. First let us understand.”

At eight o’clock the wind rose.

The grass in the dry canal bent in one direction and then straightened again.

Lightning flashed far away, but there was no thunder.

Aarti continued reading the registers.

Harinath sat outside on the veranda.

Smoke from the mosquito fire rose slowly.

His thoughts remained fixed on Bansilal.

Bansilal had a daughter—Hemlata.

At the time she must have been twelve or thirteen.

Once she had come to the water-gauging house with her father.

She had sat on a wooden board solving arithmetic problems.

Harinath had looked at her notebook and said, “You will turn out sharper than your father.”

Bansilal had laughed.

“My work is opening and closing gates. Her work will be reading paper.”

Harinath had not remembered that scene for many years.

At nine twenty Aarti came outside.

“Yesterday the line began around this time.”

They went silently into the front room.

They did not light the lantern.

They switched off the mobile-phone lights too.

Only enough grey night entered through the crack in the door to make out the shape of the instrument.

Nine thirty-one.

Nothing.

Nine thirty-seven.

Tick.

Harinath’s body tightened.

Srrr...

Aarti touched his arm and signalled for silence.

The recorder arm rose very slowly.

The drum jerked once.

Then slid.

Aarti whispered, “The well.”

They went outside.
 They lifted the cover of the gauging well.
 Water was rising below.
 Not still.

There was a slight tremor along the wall.

"The main canal is dry," Aarti said.

"The service outlet."

They went towards the bushes without a lantern.

There was no moon, but their eyes had adjusted to the dark.

No one was beside the old spindle.

Aarti knelt and placed her hand on it.

"This is vibrating."

From behind the brick wall to the left of the spindle came a faint growling sound.

Water.

Harinath's mouth went dry.

"The pipe is open."

"Opened by whom?"

They did not find the answer there.

The two followed the direction of the pipe, cutting through the bushes as they went.

The old service outlet ran parallel to the main canal for about fifty hand-spans before turning underground.

Harinath remembered the route, though he did not want to admit even to himself that he remembered it.

Ahead lay a narrow earthen path.

There was a fresh footprint on it.

Not a bare foot.

A slipper.

Beside it lay a small piece of plastic rope.

Aarti stopped.

"Like that fibre."

Harinath said, "Ramotar?"

"Why?"

"He knows all the old routes."

Aarti said nothing.

The path led towards Haripur Tola.

After half a kos they reached the edge of a low pond.

The pond was almost dry, but in one corner a thin stream of water was falling.

The sound was so slight that it could not be heard until they came close.

Three figures stood beside the stream.

Two women and a boy.

One woman held a thin iron rod.

The boy was using a bucket to clear soil from a small channel.

Aarti said softly, "Someone is there."

Harinath stopped.

The woman turned.

The light from an oil lamp in her hand fell across her face.

Around fifty.

Some hair at the forehead white.

Eyes direct.

Harinath recognised her.

“Hemlata?”

Her expression did not change.

“Harinath Babu?”

Two decades stood between them.

Aarti stepped forward.

“Where are you bringing this water from?”

Hemlata put the iron rod down.

“From the old outlet.”

“A key?”

“Not a key. A rod that fits into the spindle.”

“Who taught you?”

Hemlata looked once at Harinath, then at the pond.

“Babu.”

In Harinath’s ears the word Babu sounded like a very old voice.

Aarti’s voice was not harsh.

“You open it at night?”

“Forty minutes every third night. That is enough to keep this corner of the pond filled.”

“Permission?”

Hemlata gave a faint laugh, without joy.

“We applied twice for permission. The pump is broken. The tanker came for two weeks and then stopped. This pond is not for drinking—cows and calves, washermen, fire if one breaks out, household work when the tube wells fail. Drinking water we bring from far away. But if the pond dries completely, half the village’s work stops.”

Aarti looked at the boy.

“Who is he?”

“My nephew. The spindle is too heavy for me alone.”

Harinath suddenly asked, “Your father... did he tell you about this outlet?”

Hemlata looked at him.

“Yes.”

“When?”

“After he left the job.”

Something sank inside Harinath’s chest.

“What did he say?”

Hemlata did not hurry to answer.

She looked at the stream entering the pond.

“Many things. Must all of them be said here?”

Aarti remained silent.

The night air carried the smell of pond mud.
 Harinath understood.
 Hemlata knew.
 At least something.
 "That night..." Harinath tried to begin.
 Hemlata lifted a hand and stopped him.
 "It is time to shut the water now."
 The boy blocked the small channel with mud.
 Hemlata picked up the rod and moved ahead.
 "Madam, if you wish, you can watch how we close it."
 They all turned back towards the bushes.
 At the spindle of the service outlet Hemlata fitted the rod into place.
 The boy wound the rope around it.
 Together they turned it slowly.
 The metal groaned inside.
 The growl of the water diminished.
 At last it stopped.
 Aarti looked at the time.
 Ten seventeen.
 When they returned to the water-gauging house, the stylus of the recorder was descending.
 A small hill had formed on the night chart.
 Aarti lit a lamp.
 "This gauging well is connected to the service outlet, not to the main canal."
 Harinath stood holding the table.
 Hemlata remained at the doorway.
 "Shall I go?"
 Aarti said, "Come tomorrow morning. We need to make some written arrangement. Do not open it again for now."
 Hemlata nodded.
 She did not look at Harinath.
 She left.
 Harinath did not mention Ramotar's name again.
 Aarti opened the drum to remove the instrument paper.
 The catch was rusted.
 She applied a little pressure.
 With a "tak," the brass strip at the back of the drum came loose.
 From inside, along with dust, a narrow folded strip of paper fell onto the table.
 Harinath's breath stopped.
 Aarti bent and picked it up.
 The paper was old.
 Its edges yellow.
 Folded four times.
 In pencil on the outside was written:

“Night, 17.06.04.”

Harinath sat down in the chair.

Aarti slowly unfolded it.

It was the original chart from the recorder.

The time ran from midnight to four in the morning.

At one ten, the line rose.

At two five, it descended.

In one corner was Harinath’s own small signature:

“H. Jha.”

A long red-pencil mark ran through the middle of the paper, but the line itself had not been erased.

Aarti brought the official page for 17 June 2004 from another bundle.

It read:

“00:00-04:00: ZERO FLOW.”

Below it was Harinath’s full signature.

The two papers lay side by side on the table.

Aarti asked nothing.

Inside Harinath, every argument of twenty years rose one by one.

There had been an order.

There had been a job.

There had been a family.

What could I alone have done?

Bansilal remained alive.

The inquiry had already been decided.

Every argument rose and then fell again without sound.

“I hid this,” he said at last.

Aarti looked up.

“I could not tear it. I pushed it behind the strip. I thought perhaps someday... I do not know what I thought.”

Aarti’s voice remained level.

“Why was the official page changed?”

Harinath answered.

First in short sentences.

Then the whole story.

Jagdish Singh.

The fish ponds.

The night water.

Bansilal’s refusal.

The inquiry.

The stopped wages.

His own signature.

While speaking, he did not once say, “I was not at fault.”

Perhaps it was the first time.

Aarti listened.

She interrupted only to ask dates, names and times.

By the time the account was finished, the night outside had grown very deep.

“Does Hemlata know all this?” Aarti asked.

Harinath lowered his head.

“I do not know.”

“Shall we ask tomorrow?”

After a long silence Harinath said, “If she wishes to say.”

Aarti placed the original chart between clean sheets of paper and put it in a separate folder.

The official page too.

Then she kept the new night chart separately, not on top of either one.

“Three papers,” she said only.

“Three times.”

Harinath spent the rest of the night sitting on the cot.

Sleep did not come.

But the recorder did not run again.

Hemlata arrived in the morning.

This time she came alone.

She carried an old cloth bag.

Aarti had set up a table on the veranda.

Ramotar was making tea on the stove.

Aarti spoke directly.

“Releasing water at night without permission is against the rules. But this settlement needs a temporary water arrangement. I will send an inspection note today. Until then, I can request seven days of short controlled test-flow time. Until approval arrives, do not open it tonight.”

Hemlata nodded.

“All right.”

She looked at Harinath.

“Were you awake last night?”

Harinath said, “Yes.”

Hemlata took a thin notebook from the bag.

Its cover had swollen from dampness.

“This belonged to Babu. He wrote in it after leaving the job.”

Harinath’s hand moved forward, then stopped.

“May I see it?”

“Let Madam see it. It is departmental work.”

Aarti took the notebook.

Inside were dates, gate times, whose order, for how long—short notes.

Harinath’s name appeared on some pages too.

The colour drained from his face.

Looking at him, Hemlata said, “Babu did not write your name with abuse. He merely wrote what happened.”

To Harinath that sentence felt harsher than a scolding.

“He...”

His voice caught.

“What did he say about me?”

Hemlata looked past the veranda towards the dry canal.

“Sometimes he used to say, ‘The hands of the people who move the pen on paper may be tied, but the pen itself is not tied.’ I did not understand the meaning then.”

Aarti closed the notebook.

Harinath said nothing for a long time.

Then he took his spectacles from his bag, wiped them, and said, “I will write a statement.”

Ramotar stopped in the act of setting down the tea glasses.

Aarti simply pushed a sheet of paper towards Harinath.

Harinath began to write.

Slowly.

Date.

Post.

Incident.

He wrote that the order had been oral, but he did not hide behind that fact.

“My original chart showed flow, yet I recorded zero flow.”

His hand trembled as he wrote that sentence.

He stopped.

Then completed it.

Hemlata drank tea in the meantime.

She neither forgave Harinath nor insulted him.

When the statement was complete, Aarti read it.

“Will you sign this?”

Harinath did.

Outside, the sun was rising.

Light climbed over the cracked earth of the dry canal.

Until noon Aarti remained on the departmental telephone.

By evening permission arrived for a temporary test flow:

forty-five minutes each day for the next seven days,

in the presence of an employee,

with the water level recorded.

Permission was also given to clear the small channel to the pond.

When Hemlata heard the news, she asked only one thing.

“Will the water be released in daytime?”

“Yes. At four in the evening.”

“Then the children will not have to wake at night.”

She left.

At four that evening, the service outlet was opened officially for the first time.

Ramotar turned the spindle.

Aarti wrote down the time.

Harinath stood in the water-gauging house.

First a faint gleam appeared at the bottom of the well.

Then the water rose.

The recorder arm trembled.

The old stylus touched the paper.

Tick... srrr...

An old wave of fear from the night rose through Harinath's body.

But this time he did not move away.

The line climbed slowly.

Clean.

Thin.

Without cutting or alteration.

Aarti came into the room and asked, "Is the instrument working properly?"

Looking at the paper, Harinath said, "It is working now."

He clasped his hands behind his back.

He did not touch the stylus.

STORY 122

THREE SCRATCHES ON THE PADLOCK

The storeroom padlock bore three bright scratches, yet on the dust inside there was not a single new footprint.

Madhavi Mishra counted the scratches first.

Then she felt embarrassed at having counted them.

One.

Two.

Three.

The brass was old, but the scratches were new.

At three places, the yellow metal shone in pale lines.

The soft morning light passed through the iron grille of the veranda and fell on the lock, making those three marks stand apart from the remaining darkness.

“They were not there last night,” said the watchwoman, Phulo Devi.

Madhavi looked at her.

“Are you certain?”

“I made my round at nine last night. There was dust on the lock. I saw these three lines this morning.”

The old north wing of the Vidyapati Girls’ Hostel had been closed for two years.

The roof was damp.

Lime plaster had fallen from the walls.

The wooden window frames had swollen.

After the new building was completed, the students had moved to the southern side.

Only old cots, broken tables, annual registers, curtains, bedding, and boxes of belongings left behind by former students remained in this wing.

The first phase of building repairs was to begin in three days.

Before that, Madhavi herself had ordered the storeroom to be cleared.

And since the previous night, the final line of that order had been lodged in her mind:

“Unclaimed personal papers are to be destroyed securely.”

When she dictated that sentence, it had seemed proper.

Reading someone else’s private letters would be wrong.

Then what purpose was served by keeping anonymous letters eighteen or twenty years old?

No former student or family had made a verified claim.

The building was to be broken open.

Dampness was eating the paper.

Still, since the second letter from Vasudha Chaudhary—niece of the retired attendant Chandrakala Devi—had arrived the previous evening, Madhavi’s mind had not been settled.

Vasudha had written:

“Please do not destroy the bundle of old private letters kept in the north-wing storeroom. Do not open the envelopes. I can come within two days.”

Madhavi had replied:

“The building is unsafe. No verified bundle of that description appears in the inventory. The administration will not open private papers; they will be disposed of according to procedure.”

That reply was not outside the rules.

But Chandrakala Devi had died three weeks earlier, and people at the hostel spoke her name with respect.

Forty years of service.

Distributing letters.

Sitting through the night beside sick students.

Giving rice from her own store when money had not arrived from someone's home.

There were many such stories.

Madhavi did not wish to make a decision on the basis of sentimental stories.

Now there were three scratches on the padlock.

She took out the key.

The lock opened.

Phulo Devi stepped back one pace on the veranda.

“What if someone is inside?”

Madhavi said nothing.

She opened the door slowly.

The smell of dust came out.

The first light entered through the doorway in a slant.

A fine, even layer of dust covered the floor.

Directly in front of the entrance there was a strip about half a cubit wide where the dust had been disturbed.

Madhavi and two employees had walked there the day before, so old footprints remained on that strip.

Beyond it, the dust was untouched.

“Look,” Phulo whispered. “If anyone had gone inside, there would be marks.”

Madhavi first looked right, then left.

Iron racks.

Bundles of mattresses above them.

A brass water-pot in one corner.

Three old trunks in the middle.

On the rear wall, a high window with thick neem branches outside.

Nothing seemed to have moved.

Yet Madhavi felt as though the room had said something during the night and had now fallen silent.

“How far did we go yesterday?” she asked.

Standing on the threshold, Phulo pointed.

“Only along this clean strip. No one went farther in. You said we would check the inventory first.”

Madhavi looked at the window.

The inner latch was closed.

There were cobwebs on the grille.

She closed the door again and locked it.

The three scratches remained.

“Do not let anyone into this wing today,” she told Phulo.

“Police?”

“Not yet.”

Phulo studied her face.

“Someone has tampered with the lock.”

“They have tampered with it, not opened it.”

“Then inside?”

Madhavi did not answer.

The day advanced.

In the office of the new building, between student fees, meal registers, and telephone calls from guardians, Madhavi kept looking towards the north wing.

She grew irritated with herself.

Why give so much meaning to three scratches?

Perhaps an old key had been pushed into the lock.

Perhaps some labourer had played a joke.

Perhaps Phulo had not looked properly at the dust the night before.

But there was the dust inside.

And Vasudha’s letter.

At noon Ramdulari, an old hostel attendant, arrived.

She was over seventy.

Her back was bent, but her eyes were sharp.

Madhavi asked her about Chandrakala Devi.

“Didi valued letters above almost everything,” Ramdulari said.

“The girls would dance when letters came from home. If someone received none, Didi would make her write a postcard in her own hand.”

“Was there a bundle of letters in the storeroom?”

Ramdulari’s eyes narrowed.

“Who told you?”

“A former student has written.”

“Not just a former student. Vasudha? She is Chandrakala Didi’s sister’s daughter.”

Madhavi remained silent.

Ramdulari spoke slowly.

“Once there was a flood. The post office remained closed for two weeks. The hostel was evacuated. Some letters that arrived could not be distributed. Afterwards many girls changed homes, some left college, some were married. Didi never opened the envelopes. She wrote the names and kept them separately.”

"How many letters?"

"I do not know. Twenty or twenty-five. Perhaps more."

"Why were they not on the inventory?"

Ramdulari laughed, but there was no amusement in it.

"Would private letters be entered into an official inventory? Didi used to say—the thing belongs to the person whose name is on it, not to the administration."

"Then why did Chandrakala Devi not take them with her?"

"It would not have been right to take other people's letters home either. She left them in the care of the hostel."

Madhavi turned the pen lying on the table between her fingers.

"How does Vasudha know about the bundle?"

"In Didi's last month, she told her. I heard it. She said, 'If the building is broken, save the letters. Do not read them.'"

"What did she mean by 'save them'?"

Ramdulari looked directly at her.

"In the same sense in which you understand it."

Madhavi stopped turning the pen.

"Did you tell Vasudha to go inside?"

"Me? No. I am too old even to climb to a window."

"Window?"

Ramdulari immediately looked away.

Something shivered inside Madhavi.

"Why did you say window?"

"It is an old building. There are windows."

"The storeroom window?"

Ramdulari did not answer.

Madhavi stood up.

This time she went alone to the north wing.

The three scratches on the lock were unchanged.

She opened it and entered, but did not step off the clean strip onto the dust.

She carried a long bamboo pole.

With its far end she touched the window latch.

The latch was closed.

But the rust was not the same colour everywhere.

Along the left edge, a patch half a finger wide was smooth.

As if something had rubbed against it.

A dry neem leaf was caught on the window frame.

Neem leaves could enter—the grille had holes in two places.

By itself, that meant nothing.

Madhavi lowered the bamboo.

The leaf moved.

Under it, on the wooden sill, two or three thick fibres had caught.

Dull red.

Fibres from a floor mat.

There was no mat on the storeroom floor.
Madhavi sat on the threshold.
Her eyes remained on the window.
It was about seven feet above the ground.
Outside, a thick neem branch touched the wall at almost the same height.
Inside, directly beneath the window, an iron rack was fixed into the wall.
Bundles of mattresses lay on its upper level, and the trunks stood beyond.
If someone climbed the neem tree outside, opened the window and put one foot inside, the rack could provide the first foothold.

The upper part of the room could be reached without touching the floor at all.

But the window was latched from inside.
How could someone close it again from outside?
Madhavi studied the latch.
It was not a complete closed ring.
There was an opening in the loop.
A thin hook could be pushed through from outside to lift it.
On leaving, the same hook could pull it down again.
“Would anyone actually do that?” she asked herself.

The room gave no answer.

Among the mattresses on the top of the rack, the edge of one bundle seemed pressed in.

Beside it, the dust was broken—not on the floor, but on the iron of the rack.

Madhavi felt like moving the mattress aside with the bamboo.

Then she stopped.

If the letters truly were there, why should she herself search them out and open them?

Her order had been to destroy private papers, not to read them.

She went outside, locked the door, and told Phulo:

“Tonight you will not remain inside the north wing.”

Phulo was surprised.

“Why?”

“Sit at the south turn of the veranda. If you hear anything, tell me. Do not try to catch anyone yourself.”

“So someone is coming?”

“Perhaps.”

“A ghost?”

Madhavi laughed for the first time that day.

“What need would a ghost have to look for a key to an old lock?”

Phulo did not laugh.

At half past ten that night the hostel grew quiet.

Study lights still burned in some windows on the two floors of the southern building.

The north wing was dark.

Neem leaves rustled from time to time in the light wind.

Madhavi turned off the light in her office, silenced her mobile phone, and left the chair.

Phulo was at the southern turn.

“Anything?”

“Nothing yet.”

Madhavi did not go inside the veranda.

She went towards the flower garden outside the building.

The neem trunk stood in the darkness like a thick black pillar.

One branch rose close against the wall.

Dry leaves lay below.

She stood in the shadow of the distant water tank.

At eleven seven, a faint sound came—
metal against metal.

Once.

Then silence.

Madhavi’s body tightened.

Somewhere above, neem leaves moved.

The wind was not that strong.

A shadow separated itself from the trunk.

Slowly it climbed.

The person wore a dark shawl tied tightly over a salwar.

A thin cloth bag hung from one shoulder.

In one hand was a short rope or strap.

Madhavi did not move forward immediately.

The shadow reached the branch beside the window.

The person leaned towards the wall.

Something passed through the window grille.

From inside came a very faint click.

The latch must have lifted.

One shutter moved outward by half a finger.

The person pulled it slowly.

Then she took a folded strip of cloth from her bag and placed it on the sill.

A mat.

Madhavi now understood where the fibres had come from.

The person placed one foot on the window sill and the other on the neem branch.

Then she leaned her body inside.

She did not jump fully into the room.

With one hand she caught the rack and placed one foot on its upper iron bar.

Half her body remained inside, half outside.

There was no need to touch the floor.

Madhavi stood in the shadow and watched everything.

A few moments later came a faint rustling of paper from inside.

There was nothing frightening in the sound.

Even so, the pressure inside Madhavi did not lessen.

She remembered again the line from her own order:

“Destroyed securely.”

At the window, the person suddenly stopped.

Perhaps the bundle was heavy.

Perhaps it had caught.

Madhavi stepped forward.

“Vasudha ji.”

The shadow turned sharply and nearly slipped.

“Do not make a noise,” Madhavi said quietly.

“Come down. I am standing here.”

There was no answer for a few moments.

Then a woman’s voice came.

“You?”

“Yes.”

Vasudha came out through the window, picked up the strip of mat and put it into her bag, lowered the latch with the hook, and then climbed slowly down the neem tree.

When she reached the ground, her face was wet with sweat.

She was around forty, with both weariness and determination in her eyes.

Madhavi asked, “Did you try to open the padlock on the first night?”

Vasudha did not answer.

“Three scratches.”

She took an old key from her bag.

Its teeth were worn.

“Chandrakala Mausi’s key. I thought the old lock would still be there. I tried to insert it three times. It would not go in. Then I understood that the lock had been changed.”

“After that, the window.”

“I lived in this building when I was a student. The latch on this window could be opened from outside with a hook. During the rains, if water came inside, the attendants used to close it from outside with a bamboo pole. I remembered.”

“No footprints in the dust because of the rack.”

Vasudha nodded faintly.

“Have you come to steal the letters?”

“Would I write two letters under my own name if I meant to steal them?”

“Then why at night?”

For the first time Vasudha’s voice sharpened.

“Did you allow me to enter in daytime?”

Madhavi was silent.

“I wrote—do not open the envelopes, only save the bundle. You replied that it was not in the inventory and would therefore be disposed of. If I had come today in daylight, the watchman would not have let me inside. The labourers will break this wall the day after tomorrow. What was I supposed to do?”

“I could call the police.”

“Call them.”

The answer was so flat that half Madhavi’s anger disappeared.

“Entering the building at night is an offence.”

“Yes.”

“The window might have broken.”

“I did not break it.”

“You might have fallen.”

“That is true.”

Madhavi kept looking at her.

Vasudha held the key tightly in her fist.

“What is in the bundle?”

“Letters.”

“Whose?”

“Many people’s.”

“Yours?”

After a moment Vasudha said, “There may be one with my name on it too. I am not certain.”

“So the real purpose is your own letter?”

“If I wanted only my own letter, I would have searched Mausi’s list for my name and made a claim in daylight. What is in the bundle belongs to all of them. I do not want to read any of it.”

“Then what will you do?”

“Read the names on the envelopes. If living contacts can be found, tell them that a sealed letter exists. Those who cannot be found—their letters will be kept in a secure box. None will be opened.”

Madhavi’s voice remained hard.

“You cannot make that decision alone.”

“And you can make the decision to destroy them alone?”

The words stood between them like air.

Phulo was approaching from the distant turn, but Madhavi lifted a hand and stopped her.

Vasudha looked down.

“Mausi used to say—the contents of a letter belong to no one else, but the existence of the letter is the right of the person whose name is written on it. I do not know where that is written in any rule. Perhaps nowhere.”

Irritation rose in Madhavi again.

“A hostel cannot be run on emotion.”

“Nor should it be run merely for convenience.”

This time Vasudha’s voice was quiet.

Madhavi remembered her own reply from the previous day.

“The building is unsafe... disposal according to procedure...”

She had been in a great hurry while writing it.

Food-supply bills.

A quarrel between two students.

Notice of an inspection.

Vasudha’s letter had come in the middle of all that.

Madhavi had treated it as an obstruction and sent off a reply.

The rule was not wrong.

But perhaps the question remained outside the rule.

"You will leave now," Madhavi said.

Vasudha looked at her.

"You will not take the bundle."

"But the day after tomorrow—"

"Repairs will not begin with this room. I am changing the order."

"Will you trust me?"

"Not yet. But you will not climb the neem tree at night again."

For the first time some relief appeared on Vasudha's face.

"Very well."

"Give me the old key."

She handed it over without argument.

Madhavi called Phulo.

"Vasudha ji is leaving. Open the gate for her."

Phulo stood with many questions on her face, but asked none.

The next morning Madhavi sent a short notice to the hostel management committee:

Private sealed letters may be present in the north-wing storeroom.

The destruction order is suspended.

Only the names on the outside of envelopes will be recorded.

No letter will be opened.

The box will be removed in the presence of two former-student representatives, one woman teacher, and a hostel employee.

The committee secretary asked on the telephone, "Why so much trouble? They are old papers."

Madhavi replied, "Old, but not nameless."

"What if something objectionable comes out?"

"We will not open them."

"Then how will you know?"

"Only what is written on the envelope."

"Who will search for people after twenty years?"

"As far as possible, we will. We will decide separately about the rest."

The secretary let out a long breath.

"Do it on your own responsibility."

Madhavi said, "Yes."

After she put down the phone, the small word felt heavy, but not unbearable.

At noon the storeroom was opened.

This time four people were present.

Before stepping beyond the clean strip in the dust, they laid down thick sheets of paper so that new footprints would not merge with the old dust.

When they reached the iron rack, they lowered the mattress bundles.

Behind them stood a square tin box.

On its lid, in faded ink, were the words:

“PERSONAL MAIL—DO NOT OPEN.”

A shiver ran once through Madhavi’s body.

A small paper in Chandrakala Devi’s hand was pasted to the box.

“The names are on the envelopes. Do not read what is inside.”

That was all.

No final wish.

No dramatic sentence.

No special direction concerning anyone’s name.

Vasudha stood at a distance.

Madhavi did not call her closer.

First, a committee member recorded the external condition of the box.

Then the lid was opened.

Inside were twenty-seven envelopes.

Some yellow.

Some blue.

On some, the postage stamp had partly peeled away.

Two postcards were pressed between pieces of cloth.

Not one envelope had been opened.

They began reading out the names.

“Renu Kumari.”

“Nilima Thakur.”

“Sushma Jha.”

“Farida Khatoon.”

“Vasudha Chaudhary.”

For a moment the room fell silent.

Vasudha raised her eyes, then immediately lowered them.

Madhavi did not take the envelope in her own hand.

She told the teacher writing the list:

“Number five. Sealed. Recipient present, but it will be handed over only after formal identification.”

Vasudha said nothing.

The next name was read.

By evening a list of twenty-seven names had been made.

Addresses for eight were found through the old students’ association.

The families of five could be traced in the hostel records.

The remaining fourteen would have to be searched for.

Another question arose:

What if someone could not be found?

Madhavi did not decide immediately.

“They will remain in a sealed box for six months. During that time, efforts will be made to locate claimants. After that, the privacy committee will decide.”

Vasudha waited outside on the veranda.

After everyone else had left, Madhavi called her in.

“Identification?”

Vasudha provided it.

Her name matched the old hostel register.

Madhavi placed envelope number five on the table.

"The seal is intact. Sign for receipt."

Vasudha's hand trembled as she held the pen.

"Whose letter is it?" Madhavi asked without meaning to.

Vasudha turned the envelope over but did not break the seal.

The sender's name was on the back.

The moment she read it, her face changed, though she did not cry.

"My father's," she said.

"He was in hospital at the time. I had thought he no longer had the strength to write a letter."

The words escaped Madhavi's mouth on their own.

"Open it."

Vasudha put the envelope into her bag.

"At home."

There was so much privacy in that small answer that Madhavi understood immediately:

she had no entry into the world inside that letter.

Vasudha stood up.

At the doorway she stopped.

"About last night..."

Madhavi said, "The register says: 'attempted unauthorised entry.' No name."

"Why?"

"Because the incident happened. It must be recorded. But I do not think what you were trying to save needs to be turned into a public spectacle of punishment."

Vasudha was silent for a few moments.

"I chose the wrong method."

"Yes."

"You made your decision too quickly."

This time too Madhavi said, "Yes."

No apology passed between them.

Perhaps none was necessary.

Three days later repairs began in the north wing.

The old brass padlock on the storeroom was replaced with a new iron one.

Holding the old padlock in her hand, Phulo asked Madhavi, "Shall I throw this away?"

Madhavi took it.

She wiped off the dust.

The three scratches still shone on the brass, though not as brightly as before.

"No," she said.

"Put it in the office drawer."

Phulo laughed.

"A keepsake?"

Madhavi looked towards the window.
Neem leaves moved in the wind.
New labourers were dismantling the old rack.
Dust rose and floated in the light.
“The lock was secure,” Madhavi said quietly.
“It only took me too long to understand the question of the rights inside
it.”
Perhaps Phulo did not hear the whole sentence.
She walked away carrying the padlock.
Madhavi did not stop her.

STORY 123

THE THIRTEENTH MAILBAG

Even after twelve bags, the veranda of the Sarisab Sub-Post Office was not empty that night.

Shivnath Chaudhary saw the shadow first.

There was no lantern; a yellow electric bulb was burning.

Its light reached halfway across the veranda, after which the darkness thickened.

At the edge of that light lay a grimy cloth mailbag.

There had been nothing there during the day.

Shivnath trusted his count more than his eyes.

Twelve.

Twelve old government mailbags that were to be sent to the district store before the office closed.

Vibha Jha had entered the numbers of all of them in the register.

Out of old habit, Shivnath had counted them again and again—three blue, five khaki, four of heavy cloth.

Twelve.

Now there was a thirteenth bag on the veranda.

He did not go towards it.

First he stood holding the doorframe.

It had rained for half an hour in the evening, but now it had stopped.

Drops were still falling from the eaves.

A smell rose from the damp lime on the wall—a mixture of old paper, wet sacking, and iron rust.

Even from that distance Shivnath recognised the smell of the bag.

The smell of an old post office.

For someone who had served thirty years, certain smells were like dates.

Shivnath's right hand began trembling on its own.

He wiped it on the edge of his dhoti.

"Vibha!"

His voice came out louder than he expected.

The sound of papers shifting in the records room stopped.

"What happened?"

Vibha Jha came out.

She had a grey file in her hand and her spectacles had slipped low on her nose.

She was the final officer-in-charge of the Sarisab Sub-Post Office.

In two days the office would move into the new building, and this old building would be returned to the panchayat.

She looked towards the veranda.

"Where did this come from?"

Shivnath did not answer.

Vibha placed the file on the bench and went towards the bag.

"Don't touch it!"

Shivnath's voice was again unnaturally sharp.

Vibha turned and looked at him.

"Why?"

Shivnath's mouth had gone dry.

"First... first look."

"I am looking."

"Without touching it."

Vibha stepped back two paces.

She was the sort of person who followed rules, but not one who frightened easily.

The bag was made of old, heavy canvas.

Its colour was difficult to determine.

It might once have been khaki; now mud, dampness and time had turned it grey-brown.

A thick jute cord closed its mouth.

A small disc of darkened red sealing wax clung to the knot.

The name-tag had half decayed.

Even so, one letter could still be seen:

"S..."

Something sank inside Shivnath.

"Make the light brighter," he said.

"This is as bright as it gets."

"Use your mobile light."

Vibha took out her phone and switched on the torch.

As the light fell across the canvas, a faded blue number appeared in one corner.

13.

Shivnath stepped back.

Vibha now watched him.

"Do you recognise that number?"

"Bag number thirteen."

"That much is visible."

"No. This... this looks like that same bag."

Vibha was silent.

"Which one?"

Before answering, Shivnath looked outside the veranda.

Rainwater had collected in the low part of the courtyard.

The iron gate was closed.

There was no one on the road outside.

"The 1998 money-order case."

Vibha's eyebrows tightened.

"You said nothing about that during the day."

"There was no reason to."

"Is there one now?"

Shivnath looked at the bag.

"If this is the same one, there is."

Vibha asked quietly, "The bag disappeared?"

"Yes."

"For how many days?"

A bitter smile touched Shivnath's lips.

"Twenty-eight years."

Again the drops from the roof could be heard on the veranda.

Vibha went inside and rang the bell on the desk.

The office had closed for the day, but two labourers doing repair work were still putting away their tools in the rear courtyard.

Nasim Ansari came in with a wet gamchha over his head.

"What happened, Didi?"

Vibha showed him the bag.

Nasim fell silent for a moment.

"I did not put that there."

"Did you see it during the day?"

"No."

"Did anything fall onto the veranda?"

"I was opening the frame in the back wall from five o'clock onward. Nothing was here."

Shivnath immediately asked, "Which frame?"

"The old ventilator above. The one that was bricked shut. The wood had rotted. The panchayat told us to remove it."

Shivnath's eyes rose to the right-hand wall of the veranda.

High up, about a cubit and a half below the roof, there was a newly opened rectangular dark space.

He had not noticed it during the day.

The bricks had been removed from outside; on the inner side an old wooden strip was still jammed in place.

"Did anything come out of there?"

Nasim said, "Lime, brick dust, a rat's nest. That is all."

Vibha asked, "When did you stop work?"

"Half past five."

"And this bag was not here at seven," Shivnath said.

Vibha looked at him.

"You came through here at seven?"

"After counting the twelve bags."

"Then this arrived after that."

A faint fear appeared on Nasim's face.

"Could it have been inside the wall?"

Shivnath said at once, "Don't say that."

Nasim was startled.

Vibha said calmly, "No guessing yet. First we write what we can see."

She brought a blank sheet from the desk.

She wrote the time: 8:42 p.m.

Place: main veranda.

Object: old canvas postal bag, number 13, found sealed.

Persons present: Vibha Jha, Shivnath Chaudhary, Nasim Ansari.

“Can we touch it now?” Nasim asked.

“No,” Vibha said.

“First the external condition.”

Shivnath liked the way she was proceeding, and because he liked it, his fear grew.

Twenty-eight years earlier, they had not proceeded like this.

That night everyone had been in a hurry.

Floodwater was cutting across the road.

The district bus had left half an hour earlier.

The next mail vehicle would come in the morning.

It was the final day for sending up the money-order accounts.

Thirteen bags stood in a row on the veranda.

Narayan Mahato, the mail carrier at the time, had watched the rain and said, “Babu, let me sign the register first. When the vehicle comes, I will lift all of them. Otherwise there will be more delay.”

Shivnath had permitted it.

That was his first mistake.

The vehicle came late.

Darkness.

Rain.

Confusion.

No one counted again.

The next day the district office said twelve bags had arrived.

The thirteenth had not.

That thirteenth bag contained proof slips for money-order payments, the day's accounts, and a special list.

Because the list never arrived, the accounts for eighteen payments became stuck.

Five recipients said they had received their money.

There was no thumbprint proof for three.

Two households had become vacant.

The statements concerning the rest were confused.

Suspicion fell on Narayan.

His signature was in the register: received thirteen bags.

Shivnath's signature was there too: thirteen dispatched.

In truth, neither man had counted thirteen during the physical handover.

That was Shivnath's second mistake.

During the inquiry Shivnath wrote:

“All bags were handed over according to procedure.”

That sentence was not true.

At the time he had called it “protecting the reputation of the office.”

Now he understood that he had turned his fear into a sentence.

Narayan remained suspended for six months.

Later theft was not directly proved, but a remark remained in his service record.

His promotion was stopped.

Shivnath had never again looked properly into Narayan's eyes.

"The colour has gone from your face," Vibha said.

Shivnath returned to the present.

"It is nothing."

"It is something."

"Open the bag."

"We will inform the officer."

"By tomorrow?"

"Now."

Vibha began making a phone call.

Shivnath sat down, holding one of the veranda pillars.

She spoke to an assistant in the district superintendent's office.

Instructions came:

Do not open the bag.

Photograph its external condition.

Secure the object exactly where it was found.

An officer would come in the morning.

Vibha said, "I will lock the door. You should go home."

Shivnath did not smile.

"Not tonight."

"Why?"

"This bag has disappeared once already."

Vibha looked at him for a long moment.

"Do you think it will disappear again?"

"I no longer trust what I think."

Vibha said nothing.

Nasim brought two chairs from the rear room.

The veranda gate was locked from inside.

The bag remained where it was.

A square boundary was drawn around it with lime so that if anyone touched it, the marks would change.

The night deepened.

The electricity went out once.

It returned five minutes later.

During those five minutes, Shivnath's ears filled with the sound of an old monsoon.

"Did you know Narayan Mahato?" Vibha asked in the darkness.

"He worked with me."

"Where is he now?"

"He is alive."

"Where?"

"Near Biraul, with his son."

"Have you ever spoken to him since?"

Shivnath did not answer.

The electricity returned.

Vibha understood the answer.

A little after ten, a drop of water slid from beneath the bag.

Nasim said, "The veranda is dry. The bag is wet from inside."

Without crossing the boundary, Vibha bent to look.

There were three old dampness lines on the lower part of the bag, one above another.

The new water merely shone at the edge.

"That is not the mark of one night," Nasim said.

"Such stains form when something gets wet and dries again and again through many rains."

Shivnath looked up towards the ventilator.

Rains inside the wall.

Twenty-eight years of rains.

Vibha asked, "When was this ventilator closed?"

Shivnath's memory opened slowly.

"1998."

"Which month?"

"After Sawan. The roof leaked. Rain entered through the ventilator."

"Before or after the money-order case?"

Shivnath kept looking at the bag.

"That same week."

Nasim released a breath like a low whistle.

"Then it could be..."

Shivnath did not stop him.

Vibha said, "It could be. But that is not proof yet."

At half past ten Nasim went home.

Vibha and Shivnath remained in the office.

The bag was silent.

The thirteenth bag did nothing.

All the work of frightening Shivnath was being done by his memory.

At eleven Vibha brought out an old register.

"You will not stop me?"

"Why?"

"To read the old incident."

Shivnath said, "Read it."

Vibha opened the thick register marked 1998.

The paper was yellow, its edges brittle.

Across the pages were blue impressions from carbon copies.

She found the date in the dispatch register.

Thirteen bags.

Beside all thirteen, the same signature of Narayan Mahato.

Vibha stopped her finger there.

"One signature entered at the same time against all thirteen?"

"He signed beforehand."

Vibha looked up.

It was the first time Shivnath had said the sentence clearly.

“Why?”

“The rain. The vehicle was late. He said he would complete the paperwork first.”

“And you agreed?”

“Yes.”

“Did you say that in the inquiry?”

“No.”

Vibha’s finger remained still on the paper.

“Then his signature in the register was not proof that the bags had actually been handed over to him.”

“No.”

“And your dispatch certification?”

Shivnath’s throat went dry.

“I wrote that later.”

“After counting?”

“No.”

Vibha did not close the register.

“Will you say tomorrow, in front of the officer, what you are telling me now?”

The first answer inside Shivnath was no.

It did not come out.

After a few moments he said, “Yes.”

At midnight the rain began again.

Wind entered through the open ventilator above.

The remaining wooden strip rattled.

Vibha stood up and shone a light there.

“Look at the thickness of the wall.”

The old wall was about one and a half bricks thick.

When the ventilator had been closed, its outer part had been filled with brick, but the old wooden lattice had been left on the inside.

Between the two was a hollow space two palm-widths deep.

Nasim had removed the outer bricks that evening.

He had not removed the inner wood.

“Something could have remained trapped there,” Vibha said.

Shivnath replied, “The bag is this thick.”

“The space may have widened as the wood rotted.”

At that moment a small piece of lime fell from above.

Both of them started.

The bag did not move.

Vibha gave a faint laugh.

“The ghost has extraordinary patience.”

Shivnath could not laugh.

“Not a ghost,” he said.

“Some sentences remain inside a person.”

Vibha asked, "Which sentence?"

Shivnath looked at the register.

"All bags were handed over according to procedure."

Vibha said nothing.

At a quarter to six in the morning, two officers arrived from the district office—Assistant Superintendent Anil Kumar and Records Inspector Malati Mandal.

Nasim had also returned.

The lime boundary was undisturbed.

The first step was an external examination.

Malati put on gloves and examined the cord.

"The knot is of an old style."

Anil asked, "On what basis?"

"After two turns, the loop is folded inward. Such knots were common on service mailbags in that period. Today plastic security seals are used."

Shivnath stepped forward.

"Harishchandra Babu used to tie knots this way."

"Who?"

"The accounts assistant at that time."

"Are you certain?"

"He used to turn the final loop to the left. We teased him because his knots took so long to open."

Malati said, "Recognition of an individual's habit is useful, but not proof by itself."

Shivnath nodded.

This time the strictness of procedure did not feel excessive to him.

Half the red wax seal had broken away.

Malati examined it closely.

"There is something here."

On an inner fold of the cloth was a faint impression of circular lettering—reversed.

Anil asked, "What is that?"

Malati said, "A pressure transfer from the seal. When the wax was soft, the cloth must have folded against it, printing the letters in reverse."

Vibha said, "Meaning the seal has been pressed against this cloth for a long time?"

"At least it does not look like a recent imitation. A laboratory examination will be needed for certainty."

Shivnath's breathing opened a little, then tightened again.

If the bag was genuine, the past was genuine too.

Permission to open the bag was taken by telephone.

Every step was recorded.

The cord was cut just below the knot so the knot itself would remain preserved.

The moment the mouth opened, the smell grew stronger.

Malati stepped back.

“Old paper.”

For Shivnath, that smell opened the room from that monsoon in a single instant.

Inside were two thin bundles.

One wrapped in oiled paper.

The other in cotton cloth.

Between them lay decaying sheets.

On the first bundle was written:

“MONEY-ORDER PAYMENT PROOFS—SARISAB SUB-OFFICE.”

The date was the same.

Shivnath gripped a chair.

Anil looked at him but said nothing.

The papers were opened one by one.

Thumbprints.

Signatures.

Amounts.

Village names.

Some letters had bled.

Some remained clear.

Of the eighteen payment-proof slips, sixteen were found.

Two were missing.

Vibha asked, “Then the old dispute will not be completely resolved.”

Malati said, “Paper rarely gives the whole truth.”

The second bundle contained the day’s accounts, a cash-adjustment slip, and a short private note.

One corner of the paper was folded in red pencil.

Anil read:

“Two payments made in advance. Original order to arrive by next mail. Oral permission of Postmaster.”

Below was Harishchandra’s signature.

Everyone looked at Shivnath.

He did not blink.

“Did you give that permission?” Anil asked.

Shivnath said slowly, “Yes.”

“Why?”

“One household needed money for the treatment of a woman who had just given birth. There had been a death in another household. Notice of the order had come by telephone; the written order was to arrive in the next mail. I broke the rule and had the payments made.”

“Was this said during the inquiry?”

“No.”

“Why?”

Shivnath laughed.

This time the laugh was tired.

“Because if the bag was never found, my oral permission would remain without proof. I thought that if I concealed one irregularity, the office would be saved.”

Vibha asked quietly, “And Narayan?”

Shivnath’s gaze fell to the floor.

“I thought his signature was there, so the inquiry would go in that direction. Later the truth would come out.”

“Did it?”

“No.”

Morning light was spreading outside the veranda.

The rain had stopped.

Malati placed the papers separately into transparent sleeves.

Nasim kept looking up at the ventilator.

“May I look inside?”

Anil gave permission.

A ladder was brought.

Nasim climbed up and shone a light inside.

“There are cloth fibres here.”

Malati climbed up too.

On the floor of the hollow space were tiny jute fibres, flakes of red wax, and crumbling fragments of paper.

Three dark water lines marked the inner brick.

“Rain kept entering,” Nasim said.

“There was a gap in the outer brick joint.”

“How did the bag get from there onto the veranda?” Vibha asked.

Nasim climbed down and opened his tool bag.

He took out a long iron rod.

“Yesterday, while removing the outer frame, I pushed this rod in quite far. Something was jammed behind the wood. I thought it was a piece of brick. I pushed it. Something soft moved inward. Later I left it.”

“Then the dampness increased at night, the wood sagged, and the bag fell,” Vibha said.

Nasim nodded.

“It is possible. Look—the wooden strip slopes downward towards the veranda from inside.”

Malati said, “Write the sequence: repair rod, old support loosened, rain dampness, night-time fall. That is the mechanical explanation; we will examine it further.”

Shivnath kept looking upward.

The thirteenth bag had not returned as a ghost.

A labourer’s iron rod had pushed it out of twenty-eight years of darkness.

Such a small cause.

Such a large consequence.

Anil opened the register again.

“Shivnath Babu, your statement will be taken separately.”

“Take it.”

“The old disciplinary matter may be reopened.”

“Let it reopen.”

“You are retired, but the archival record will need correction.”

“Correct it.”

Vibha looked at him.

The fear inside Shivnath had not ended.

But its direction had changed.

Earlier he had feared the truth coming out.

Now he feared that someone might once again write only half of it for the convenience of the paperwork.

He said, “Write one thing fully.”

Anil stopped his pen.

“Narayan Mahato signed the register before lifting the bags. With my permission. There was no physical handover verified by counting thirteen.”

Anil wrote.

“And?”

“I concealed that fact during the inquiry.”

The pen moved.

“And?”

Shivnath was silent for a little while.

“The two money orders were paid in advance on my oral instruction.”

The pen moved again.

“And?”

Shivnath looked at the register.

“That is not all. One more thing.”

Everyone waited.

“The sentence I wrote increased the suspicion against Narayan. I wrote it without having personally counted the bags.”

Anil wrote.

For the first time Shivnath felt that the scratch of a pen on paper was not frightening.

By noon the old building had been sealed.

The bag and the papers were sent to the district office.

Repair work was stopped so the hollow wall could be examined.

Vibha said, “Go home. You have been awake all night.”

Shivnath said, “First I have to make one phone call.”

“To whom?”

“Narayan’s son.”

Vibha handed him the mobile phone.

Shivnath could not dial the number from memory.

He opened an old diary.

Three numbers had been crossed out; one new number had been written.

The final number rang.

A man answered.

“Hello?”

“I am Shivnath Chaudhary.”

There was silence for a while.

“Which Shivnath?”

Shivnath said, “The old postmaster from Sarisab Post Office.”

The silence lengthened.

“Babuji is here,” the voice finally said.

Shivnath’s palm began to sweat again.

“Please let me speak to him.”

There was some rustling.

A cough sounded from a distance.

“Hello?”

Narayan’s voice had grown old, but Shivnath recognised it.

“Narayan Babu...”

“Yes.”

“I am Shivnath.”

“I recognised you.”

After those two words, all the sentences Shivnath had been composing inside himself for years became useless.

He said directly, “The bag has been found.”

Silence at the other end.

“Which bag?”

“Number thirteen. The money-order bag.”

Silence again.

Shivnath could hear someone breathing.

Narayan asked, “Where?”

“It was trapped inside the post-office wall.”

After a long time Narayan’s voice came.

“Then I had not put it into the vehicle.”

Shivnath closed his eyes.

“No.”

“My signature was in the register.”

“You had signed beforehand. With my permission.”

“You did not say that in the inquiry.”

“No.”

There was another cough at the other end.

Shivnath said, “I have had it written down now.”

Narayan did not answer immediately.

“After so many years?”

“Yes.”

“Will my blocked promotion come back?”

Shivnath’s throat grew heavy.

“I do not know.”

“Will the six months of suspension come back?”

“I do not know.”

“Will the school year my son lost because he had to leave school and go to work come back?”

Shivnath was silent.

Narayan's voice was not harsh.

Perhaps that made it harder.

"Then it is good that the bag has been found. Correct the papers."

"I want to say to you—"

Shivnath stopped.

The word apology was easy.

Consequences were not.

Narayan said, "Write whatever must be written, fully. Save your words for me."

The call ended.

Shivnath placed the mobile phone on the table.

Vibha asked nothing.

Two days later the old sub-post office closed.

Work began on the first day in the new building.

The twelve current mailbags went to the district store.

The old thirteenth bag was kept separately as evidence.

The old veranda became empty.

Nasim removed the entire ventilator section.

The hollow space inside could now be seen.

No large secret chamber.

No mysterious tunnel.

Only a narrow space left between two incomplete stages of construction, where one bag had remained longer than it should have.

A small red stain of sealing wax remained on a brick inside the wall.

Shivnath came to see the building one last time.

Vibha had brought a copy from the new office—the preliminary note of archival correction.

She gave it to Shivnath to read.

The first page stated:

"The transfer of thirteen bags entered in the 1998 dispatch register was not verified by direct counting."

The second page:

"Bag number 13 was recovered after current repair work caused it to fall from the hollow portion of a sealed ventilator in the old building."

The third page:

"The suspicion focused on transport employee Narayan Mahato in the previous inquiry may have been based on an incomplete interpretation of the available records; review is required."

Shivnath read the sentence again.

"May have been" felt incomplete to him.

Vibha understood.

"The language of an inquiry can say only this much at present."

"Yes."

"Look at the next page."

Attached there was Shivnath's new statement.

Complete.

Advance signature.

Dispatch without counting.

Oral permission for payment.

Failure to state the facts in the old inquiry.

Shivnath did not fold the paper.

"Keep this copy," Vibha said.

"Me?"

"You asked for it."

Shivnath took the paper.

He went to the same corner of the veranda where the bag had been found.

The square lime boundary had been half erased by rainwater.

Above, the ventilator was now completely open.

Daylight entered through it and fell onto the veranda.

Shivnath looked at the three old water lines on the wall.

He thought:

The bag had remained in darkness for twenty-eight years, but the papers inside it had not been made to preserve the truth.

The papers had merely survived.

Whether the truth survived or not had depended on the next sentence a human being chose to write.

From outside Vibha asked, "Shall we go?"

Shivnath turned.

"Let us go."

Before closing the gate, he looked once more at the veranda.

There was no bag there now.

The place of the thirteenth bag was empty.

But this time, the empty place was not a mistake in the count.

STORY 124

THE WATERMILL'S REVERSED WHEEL

Bhadon was waning, but that year the Churia ridge wore only an incomplete green.

Along the Patharaha stream, the fields descended like steps when seen from a distance—maize above, rows of paddy in the middle, maize leaves below. But that monsoon pale cracks in the earth showed between the stretches of paddy.

Brijnandan Sahu was climbing that path after eighteen years.

He carried an old leather bag in one hand, a folded map under his arm, and the old pain still lived in his left knee.

The village water-use committee had called him.

The hill road was to be widened, so the boundary of the old watermill land had to be measured again.

The mill had stopped working long ago, but in the government register its name still stood as “Co-operative Grain Mill.”

Brijnandan had been the last accountant of that co-operative.

“Who will understand the old boundary without you?” committee president Devmani Yadav had said on the telephone. “On paper the channel lies one way; on the ground it lies another.”

Brijnandan had first thought of refusing.

Then he had said, “I will come.”

He himself did not know why he had said it.

The watermill stood about half a kos above the village.

When it still worked, water from the Patharaha stream was diverted through bamboo channels and wooden sluice-boards onto its wheel.

Inside, two millstones turned.

Wheat and maize were ground.

Outside, people stood in line with sacks.

Now half the channel was broken, the wood had blackened, and one corner of the roof had sagged.

The mill's great wooden wheel was still fixed outside the wall.

Brijnandan stopped and looked at it.

The wheel was still.

It was supposed to be still.

For eighteen years.

Devmani came up from below and said, “The measuring will not happen today. The amin will arrive tomorrow morning. I had the room cleaned for you to stay.”

“I could have stayed in the village.”

“If you remain up here, it will be easier to identify the old marks. And going up and down at night will be difficult.”

Brijnandan went inside the mill.

The smell of earth and dust.
 Bird droppings on the round millstone.
 Lime flaking from the wall.
 In one corner lay an iron balance with one pan missing.
 The desk was still there.
 He had written the accounts at that very desk.
 Brijnandan's feet slowed of their own accord.
 Dusting the table, Devmani said, "This desk too will go in the auction."
 "Yes."

"Some papers remain. See whether any are useful. If they are, the committee will keep them."

The desk drawer was stuck.

Devmani forced it open.

Inside were papers gnawed by mice, one broken red pencil, two rusted pins, and an old receipt book.

At the sight of the red pencil, Brijnandan drew his hand back.

Devmani did not notice.

"I am going down by evening. I will come back with the amin tomorrow."

Brijnandan nodded.

Devmani left.

As the sun went down, the hill air grew cold.

The Patharaha stream was very thin here.

Water appeared between stones in some places and vanished in others.

The old main channel was dry.

Brijnandan sat outside and opened the boundary map.

Along the northern edge ran a blue line: "MAIN WATERCOURSE."

To the south, a shorter line: "OUTLET."

In the middle, a square symbol: the mill.

His eyes remained fixed for a long time on that square.

Eighteen years earlier, on a Sawan night, an accident had taken place in this mill.

The report stated:

"After 8:00 p.m. the mill was closed. Temporary worker Lakhan Mandal entered the premises for personal reasons and slipped on the wet floor."

Brijnandan had not typed that report.

But its figures, time, and accounts had been certified by his signature.

The truth had been different.

That night the mill had not been closed.

The rain was heavy.

An order had come to grind the co-operative chairman's private wheat sacks during the night, ahead of the daytime queue.

The mill was run after dark.

The upper sluice-gate was sticking.

A new rope was tied to it and pulled with force.

Lakhan had said, "The teeth of the gate are broken. Not now."

No one listened.

The mill ran.

In the middle of the night the rope came loose.

The sluice suddenly opened fully.

The force of the water increased.

The wheel leapt into speed.

The wooden shaft inside kicked.

Lakhan, trying to run, fell from the stone ledge.

He survived.

But his right leg never again moved as before.

If the true cause of the accident had been written down, the co-operative would have had to pay compensation.

There would have been an inquiry against the chairman.

The record of private night grinding would have been opened.

At that time Brijnandan's house was newly under construction.

There was debt.

Two daughters were in school.

The chairman had told him, "Write the time only up to eight. The institution knows nothing after that."

Brijnandan had written it.

Lakhan was given two months' wages.

After that he left the village and went down to the Terai.

Brijnandan had placed the incident in one corner of his mind under the label "an old matter."

Today the desk, the red pencil, and the dry channel were opening that corner.

Night came quickly.

The committee had left a lantern, a lota of water, chura with curd, and a blanket.

Brijnandan bolted the door from inside.

In the hills, sounds travel far at night.

Crickets.

A dog somewhere.

Bamboo leaves.

The fine murmur of the stream.

Brijnandan lay on the cot but did not sleep.

After turning over many times, he heard another sound.

Gharr... gharr...

He opened his eyes.

The sound stopped.

Then—

Gharr... charr...

Like old wooden teeth.

Brijnandan sat up.

His first thought was the roof.

His second, some animal.

He did not want to accept the third thought.
 He lit the lantern.
 Opened the door.
 Went outside.
 The wind was very light.
 The sound came from the mill wheel.
 Brijnandan raised the lantern.
 The wheel was turning.
 Very slowly.
 Charr...
 One paddle descended.
 Gharr...
 Another rose.
 Brijnandan's hand shook.
 The water of the Patharaha stream was not flowing in that direction.
 The main channel was dry.
 Then why was the wheel turning?
 He took two steps forward.
 Then stopped.
 The wheel was turning the wrong way.
 When the mill had operated, the upper wood moved from left to right.
 Now it moved from right to left.
 Backward.
 In Brijnandan's ears, not an old scream but an old sentence returned:
 "The teeth of the gate are broken. Not now."
 The lantern flame trembled.
 "Lakhan?"
 The name came from his mouth on its own.
 No one answered.
 The wheel turned twice more.
 Then stopped.
 Brijnandan stood there for a long time.
 There was no water visible on the ground.
 He went back inside and shut the door, but did not sleep for the rest of the night.
 In the morning Devmani, amin Rajiv Thakur, and a local young man named Jitan Sahu came up.
 Brijnandan did not immediately tell them about the night.
 Rajiv opened his measuring instruments and began surveying the boundary.
 Jitan cut back bushes as they went.
 Devmani searched for old pegs.
 "Was the northern corner here?" Rajiv asked.
 Brijnandan looked at the map.
 "Three hand-spans west of where the old wooden water-channel turned."
 "This is the water-channel?"

“Yes.”

Rajiv stepped into the dry channel.

“It looks as though water has not passed here for a month.”

Brijnandan looked towards the wheel.

“It turned last night,” he said at last.

All three looked at him.

Jitan almost laughed, but stopped after seeing Brijnandan’s face.

Devmani asked, “Wind?”

“A wheel this large would not turn in that wind. And it turned backward.”

Rajiv went to the axle.

He tested it with his hand.

“The wood is old, but not completely jammed. It could move if pushed.”

“If someone pushed it.”

“Possible.”

Brijnandan did not like that word.

Rajiv bent beneath the wheel.

“It is wet here.”

Everyone came closer.

A narrow dark strip showed on the lowest wooden paddle.

Dust above.

Dampness below.

Devmani touched the soil.

“The ground is dry.”

Rajiv said, “Water fell on the wheel, but perhaps not enough reached the ground?”

“The upper channel is dry,” Jitan said.

Looking at the wheel teeth, Rajiv stopped at one place.

“Look here.”

A fine fibre of blue synthetic rope was caught between two wooden teeth.

New.

Such rope had not been used at the old mill.

In those days they used hemp, jute fibre, and thick twisted cord.

Brijnandan took the fibre into his hand.

Blue.

The rope tied to the sluice eighteen years ago had been reddish-brown hemp.

Even so, his palm began to sweat.

Devmani asked, “Does someone come at night to run the mill?”

Jitan laughed.

“To grind? Even the millstones inside are jammed.”

Rajiv turned the wheel by hand.

“Only the wheel can move. The inner shaft is broken. It cannot grind grain.”

“Then why?”

There was no answer.

The boundary survey continued until noon.

Brijnandan paid less attention to the paper than to the ground.

Again and again he saw the damp strip under the wheel, the rope fibre, and the backward turning of the night before.

After noon Rajiv went towards the old outlet.

The original mill channel had carried water over the wheel and then down into the Patharaha stream.

But years of landslides had half filled its route.

"Fresh earth has been cut here," Rajiv said.

Jitan bent down.

"It could be a goat path."

"Goats do not use spades."

There were two clear spade marks in the narrow trench.

Brijnandan's chest jolted.

"Shall we go upward?" Rajiv asked.

Devmani looked at his watch.

"Let us finish the measurement today. We will solve the mystery of the water tomorrow."

Rajiv agreed.

By evening everyone went down.

Brijnandan remained at the mill again.

This time he had himself chosen to stay alone.

During the day Devmani had said, "Come down with us."

Brijnandan had replied, "I need to sort the old registers."

In truth, he wanted to watch the wheel.

After sunset he placed the blue rope fibre on the desk.

Beside the red pencil.

Two different times.

Two different ropes.

But his mind tied both into the same knot.

He opened the old receipt book.

The middle pages were from the year 2062.

On one page, three entries for night grinding had been crossed out.

A straight red-pencil line ran over black ink.

Brijnandan's own hand.

He closed the page.

Nothing happened until nine at night.

At ten, the wind strengthened.

At ten thirty-five a faint metallic ring sounded from far above.

Brijnandan came outside.

The watermill was still.

He extinguished the lantern.

It took time for his eyes to adjust to the dark.

Ten forty-four.

A fine sound of water.

Not from the main stream.

From the rear slope behind the mill.

Brijnandan went behind the wheel.

First one drop.

Then another.

Then a thin line of water gleamed across the rear side of the wooden paddles.

The wheel moved.

Gharr...

Backward.

This time Brijnandan did not run.

He bent and looked below.

The water was not falling from the old upper channel.

A thin stream came diagonally through a narrow gap between the rear wall of the mill and the hillside earth and struck the wooden paddle.

The stream was not large.

But because the heavy wheel was balanced, it was enough to turn it.

Brijnandan reached out and touched the water.

Cold.

He followed it in the opposite direction.

The bushes were dense.

Thorns caught in his clothes.

A short distance away he saw blue rope stretched along the ground.

It was tied to a bamboo peg and then ran uphill.

Brijnandan followed it.

About fifty hand-spans above, three lengths of bamboo channel had been joined along a narrow path.

Their mouth received water from a black flexible pipe coming from the direction of the hill spring.

No one was there.

But the channel was new.

The cut bamboo was pale.

Wet mud covered the joints.

Water flowed down the bamboo towards the back of the mill.

Brijnandan understood.

Someone was diverting water.

But where?

He went down below the mill.

Instead of entering the old outlet, the water that passed the wheel was turning into a newly dug narrow trench beside it.

The trench ran east, parallel to the hill path.

Brijnandan did not light the lantern.

He followed the trench slowly through the darkness.

Farther ahead he heard whispers.

"Stop it here."

"Two more bunds."

"The rope is loosening."

Brijnandan stopped.

Human voices.

He went forward.

At a small level place there were three people—two women and a boy.

They were cutting an earthen bund and dividing the water into two streams.

One flowed down towards a row of paddy.

The other towards a marua field.

One woman started when she saw Brijnandan.

“Who?”

Brijnandan lit the lantern.

Her face appeared in the light.

Around forty.

Sharp eyes.

A cloth tied around her head.

“I am Brijnandan Sahu.”

The other woman said quietly, “The old accountant of the mill?”

Brijnandan looked at her.

“Are you the ones diverting this water?”

The first woman answered, “Yes.”

“With whose permission?”

The moment the question left his mouth, Brijnandan heard the hardness in his own voice.

The woman heard it too.

“Permission?”

The boy let go of the cord and looked from one side to the other.

The woman said, “My name is Revati Mandal. This is Sushila. This is my nephew Roshan.”

“Where does the water come from?”

“From the overflow of the community tank above. After the drinking-water tank fills, the water that otherwise falls onto the rocks—we bring that extra flow to the fields at night.”

“Why through pipes?”

“The old irrigation channel broke when the road was built. We submitted four applications for repair. The paddy is drying now.”

Brijnandan looked towards the wheel, which creaked slowly in the darkness.

“Is it necessary to turn the mill wheel?”

For the first time a faint, tired smile came to Revati’s face.

“No. The wheel is an obstruction.”

“Then?”

“If we took the bamboo channel straight through, the levels did not match on this side of the wall. It was easier to release the water through the gap behind the old wheel. We had tied the wheel with rope so it would not turn. Yesterday the knot must have come loose.”

“A rope fibre was caught in the teeth.”

“That would be ours.”

Roshan said, "We tied it again today, but the wheel is heavy."

Inside, Brijnandan felt hollow.

Not a ghost.

Not Lakhan.

Water.

Bamboo.

Slope.

A loose rope.

That was all.

But relief did not come.

Revati was looking at his face.

"Were you frightened?" she asked.

Brijnandan did not answer.

Patting the earthen bund into place, Sushila said, "People in the village say the mill turns backward at night. No one comes up here. It has been convenient for us."

Revati looked at her as if to stop her.

"Do not say such things."

"But it is true."

Brijnandan's ears caught on the word backward.

He repeated Revati's surname in his mind.

Mandal.

"Did you know Lakhan Mandal?"

Revati's hand stopped on the bund.

After a few moments she said, "He was my uncle."

Brijnandan's throat went dry.

Sushila and Roshan fell silent.

Revati looked straight at him.

"Do you know?" Brijnandan asked.

"Know what?"

"About that accident."

"As much as was told at home."

"What was told?"

Revati sat down on the bund.

"Uncle was in the mill at night. The gate opened violently. He fell. Later it was written on paper that the mill had been closed and that he had gone inside on his own."

Brijnandan's eyes went to the blurred outline of the wheel in the darkness.

"Who told you?"

"Uncle."

"He... is he still—?"

"He died two years ago."

Brijnandan lowered his head.

There was no sharp accusation in Revati's voice.

The absence of sharpness made it harder for him.

"Did he ever mention my name?"

“Yes.”

“What did he say?”

Revati broke a clod of earth in her hand.

“He used to say, ‘Brijnandan Babu was not a bad man, but he wrote bad paper.’”

Brijnandan found no answer.

Roshan began adjusting the cord again.

The creaking of the wheel grew a little louder.

Revati stood.

“First let us tie this. Water is being wasted.”

The three turned back towards the mill.

Brijnandan followed.

The blue rope had to be tied again near the wheel teeth.

Roshan began climbing when Brijnandan said without thinking, “Wait.”

Everyone looked at him.

He went to the right side of the wheel.

Below the old axle was an iron ring half buried in dust and moss.

“Do not tie the rope to the teeth,” he said.

“Take it through this ring and then to the rear peg. If you tie it on the teeth, the rope will cut.”

Revati asked, “You still remember?”

“Some things are not forgotten.”

The sentence came out.

Brijnandan himself fell silent.

The rope went through the ring.

Roshan tightened the peg.

The wheel slowly stopped.

Water slipped across the rear board and continued into the new trench.

The creaking ceased.

The night suddenly seemed very quiet.

Revati said, “The amin is coming tomorrow, isn’t he?”

“He came today. Tomorrow he will finalise the boundary.”

“Will this channel fall inside the land?”

“A part of it lies inside the old boundary of the government mill.”

“Then they will tell us to remove it.”

Brijnandan did not answer immediately.

In truth, he had no authority to promise anything.

He could have said, “Speak to the committee.”

He did not.

Committee papers, applications, repair requests—Revati had already done that many times.

He merely asked, “For how long does the excess water from the tank become available at night?”

“About two hours. After the village’s drinking-water needs are met.”

“Do all the fields below receive equal amounts?”

Revati paused before answering.

“No. Those closer to the channel receive more. That is why today we divided it into two. Farther ahead we still have to divide it again.”

“So there will be quarrels.”

“Possibly.”

For the first time Brijnandan smiled faintly.

“Wherever water reaches, accounts arrive with it.”

Revati too gave a thin smile.

Before dawn Brijnandan returned to the mill.

Revati and the others remained by the fields.

On the table Brijnandan placed the red pencil, the blue rope fibre, and the old receipt book in front of him.

He did not sleep for the rest of the night.

First he took out a blank sheet.

He wrote:

“NOTE CONCERNING VERIFICATION OF THE BOUNDARY OF THE OLD CO-OPERATIVE GRAIN MILL.”

Then he described the boundary.

Northern channel.

Southern outlet.

Iron ring.

Old wheel.

Half the page filled.

He stopped his pen.

He took out a second sheet.

For a long time he looked at the blank page.

Then he wrote:

“PERSONAL STATEMENT CONCERNING FORMER ACCIDENT REPORT NO. 17.”

The first line was difficult to write.

The second was less difficult.

He wrote that on the night of the accident the mill had continued operating after eight o'clock.

Private wheat was being ground.

The defect in the sluice-gate had already been known.

The account concerning the time and work status that he had certified was not true.

He wrote that he himself had signed the false entry.

He wrote the name of the person under whose pressure he had done so.

He added nothing.

He left nothing out.

At the end he wrote the date.

He signed.

He did not fold the paper.

He left it open on the table.

At dawn Devmani and Rajiv arrived.

Rajiv carried the measuring instrument.

Devmani carried tea.

"Did it turn again last night?" Devmani asked with a laugh.

Brijnandan took the tea.

"Yes."

"Did you find the ghost?"

"I found people."

Devmani stopped laughing.

Brijnandan showed them the bamboo channel above, the overflow from the tank, the field trench, and the route behind the wheel.

Rajiv carefully measured the slope.

"This is a temporary route. When the road is built, it will be cut."

Revati came up from the lower fields.

Roshan was with her.

Seeing them, Devmani frowned.

"You cut government land?"

Revati answered directly, "Two hand-spans. To save the field."

"After asking?"

"We kept asking until the paddy dried."

Devmani opened his mouth to answer, but Rajiv spoke first.

"First let us see where a permanent channel can go. If it is joined to the road drainage, this trench may not be needed."

Devmani looked at him.

"That is a separate scheme."

"In the boundary survey I will note that the old irrigation route is in use. Whoever makes the scheme will see it."

"In use?" Devmani looked towards the wheel.

Brijnandan said, "Water is moving. The old channel is broken, but the need for water has not ended."

Devmani remained silent for a while.

"Fine. But the committee will decide the night-time distribution. I do not want quarrels."

Revati said, "Decide it. Let the water reach first."

The boundary survey began again.

Brijnandan held the map.

Rajiv kept measuring.

An old peg turned out to be three hand-spans this way.

The outlet line two hand-spans that way.

The difference between paper and land slowly grew smaller.

At noon Devmani saw the second sheet lying on the mill desk.

"What is this?"

Brijnandan said, "A statement to correct the old report."

Devmani read.

The smile disappeared from his face.

"After so many years?"

"Even after years, what is wrong remains wrong."

Devmani put the sheet back on the desk.

“What will happen now because of this?”

Brijnandan did not answer quickly.

“I do not know. Perhaps nothing. But the old false paper will no longer be the only paper.”

Devmani looked towards the window.

Outside, Revati and Roshan were untying the blue rope.

No water would come during the day, so the wheel was being left free again.

“Will you give this to Lakhan’s family?” Devmani asked.

“One copy to Revati. One in the committee register. One to the district co-operative archive.”

“Will you send it yourself?”

“Yes.”

Devmani did not fold the sheet.

He merely placed a clean piece of paper over it so dust would not fall.

By evening the measurement was complete.

Rajiv drew a new line on the map.

Inside the old mill boundary he added a thin mark:

“CURRENT TEMPORARY WATERCOURSE.”

Devmani said, “This is not permanent approval.”

Rajiv did not laugh.

“The map shows what is true. Approval will come on another paper.”

Brijnandan listened.

As the sun went down, everyone prepared to descend.

Revati stood near the mill door.

Brijnandan gave her one copy of his statement.

She did not read it.

She folded it and placed it in her cloth bag.

“If your uncle had seen this?” Brijnandan asked.

Revati looked at him.

“I do not know,” she said.

“He understood the pain in his leg more than he understood paper.”

Brijnandan lowered his eyes.

Then Revati said, “But I will keep it.”

With that she left.

Brijnandan decided to spend one final night in the mill.

At dawn he would go down and return home.

The sky was clear.

The upper tank would be full by ten.

A little after ten, the fine sound of water came again.

Brijnandan went outside.

This time the blue rope was properly tied through the iron ring.

Water fell on the rear board, slipped over its edge, and ran into the new trench.

The wheel trembled slightly, but did not turn.

Brijnandan watched it for a long time.

The previous night, the backward-turning wheel had seemed to him a sign from his past.

Tonight it was only wood, bearing the pressure of water.

In the darkness of the fields below, someone opened a bund.

The direction of the water changed.

Brijnandan went back inside.

The red pencil still lay on the desk.

He did not put it into the drawer.

He picked up the broken pencil and placed it beside the crossed-out page in the receipt book.

Then he left the drawer open.

Outside, the water kept flowing.

This time the wheel remained still.

STORY 125

A BLACK DOT ON THE WHITE SCREEN

The old clock tower of the town was striking seven in the evening when Bhubaneswar Jha turned into the narrow lane off the square.

The rain had stopped, but water was still dripping from the eaves.

At the end of the lane stood his closed photography studio—"Prabha Photo Studio."

Half the blue lettering had flaked away. Of the word "Prabha," only "bha" remained clear.

The shop had been closed for twenty-seven months.

Bhubaneswar no longer took photographs.

His eyesight had dimmed, his hands trembled, and people now took wedding pictures on their mobile phones.

But the real reason was older than all of that.

The reason was inside the shop.

That night Bhubaneswar had come to examine the papers for selling the premises.

The new buyer wanted all the old material removed within three days.

As he opened the padlock, fine rust powder came away on his palm.

He pushed the door open.

The smell inside was the same as before—dust, wood, decaying paper, and somewhere deep within it the faint sourness of photographic chemicals.

He stopped.

Even after so long, that smell?

He himself had emptied every bottle from the darkroom.

The framed wedding sample photographs had been removed from the left wall.

Directly ahead, a long white backdrop hung from the ceiling, before which countless people had once assumed the most beautiful poses of their lives.

Bhubaneswar switched on a small electric lamp shaped like a lantern.

The white backdrop looked grey.

He looked once.

Then narrowed his eyes and looked again.

In the middle of the backdrop was a small black dot.

Like a mole.

"Rat droppings," he said to himself.

But the dot was not near the bottom of the cloth.

It was almost at eye level.

He reached out and touched the fabric.

Nothing.

The dot was not on the cloth.

When he moved to one side of the backdrop, it vanished.

When he returned to the centre, it appeared again.

Bhubaneswar turned around.

Above the darkroom door was a small light slit.

One pane of its glass was cracked.

Light from the electric bulb outside entered through that crack.

He looked at the backdrop again.

The black dot was still there.

Bhubaneswar tried to laugh.

“A trick of light.”

That night he kept sorting the studio’s old registers, tax papers, and the buyer’s agreement.

At nine, when he looked again towards the backdrop, there was not one dot but two.

The second was above the first.

This time he stood up at once and went to the light slit.

There was still only the same crack in the glass.

The electric light outside was steady.

Two black dots faced him on the white cloth.

A very old pounding awakened in Bhubaneswar’s chest.

Twenty-seven years earlier there had been a white screen like this too.

On it he used to show photographs—enlarging one frame after another, examining where a hand was, which way a face was turned, who stood where inside a crowd.

And one night he had destroyed them all.

“No,” he whispered.

The two dots gave no answer.

Bhubaneswar closed the shop early that night and went home.

When he awoke in the morning, his first thought was of the two dots on the screen.

His second thought:

Someone is entering the shop.

He came back at noon.

In daylight there was not a single black dot on the backdrop.

He inspected the entire room.

The padlock was intact.

The rear door was bolted from inside.

The dust on the window latch was undisturbed.

There were no footprints on the floor.

But at the lower right corner of the backdrop the fabric seemed slightly more folded than before.

Bhubaneswar straightened it.

A brown stain came away on his finger.

He smelled it.

Very faint, but unmistakable.

The smell of old fixer.

The smell of his darkroom.

Bhubaneswar's palm began to tremble.
He bent below the backdrop.
Something hard touched his fingers inside the fold.
He did not have the courage to open the cloth.
He stood up.
He opened the drawer of the wooden desk opposite.
Inside were empty envelopes, two broken pencils, an old light meter, and a small glass plate.
A white label was pasted onto the plate:
"Municipal Relief Distribution, Shravan."
Bhubaneswar shut the drawer at once.
He had not wanted to read the name.
But he had already read it.
Municipal Relief Distribution.
That day.
Twenty-seven years earlier, after the floodwaters had receded, relief was being distributed on the grounds of the old secondary school.
Sacks of rice.
Dry food.
Medicine.
Clothing.
Half the town had gathered there.
The committee had called Bhubaneswar to take photographs.
In the afternoon the bamboo barricade broke.
The crowd surged in one direction.
Some people fell.
Two children were injured.
An elderly woman died three days later.
The incident was not small.
But on paper its story was made very small.
"Disorder caused by a sudden increase in the crowd."
That was all.
Bhubaneswar's photographs contained more than that.
He had taken seven frames in sequence.
In the first, the bamboo barricade was intact.
In the second, a vehicle was reversing.
In the third, the rear iron corner of the vehicle touched the main knot of the bamboo structure.
In the fourth, the rope loosened.
In the fifth, a volunteer raised his hand to signal the vehicle to stop.
In the sixth, the bamboo fell.
In the seventh, people lifted one another from the ground.
One woman—Sharda Devi—who was later called "the woman who incited the crowd," was shielding a child with her own body in that seventh frame.
But that photograph was never made public.

Two days after the incident, three people came to Bhubaneswar's studio.

One was the secretary of the relief committee.

One was the school manager.

The third was Bhubaneswar's own elder brother, Kamalakant, who had been overseeing the vehicles that day.

The secretary said, "If those photographs go out, relief work will stop. Inquiry, court cases—everything will be held up."

The manager said, "No one will benefit."

Kamalakant said only one thing:

"Mother is ill now."

That sentence weighed more heavily than pressure.

Bhubaneswar tore up the photographic prints.

He cut the negative strip and spoiled it in chemical solution.

At least that was what he remembered.

That night his assistant Madhusudan cleaned the darkroom.

In the morning the floor was shining.

After that day, Bhubaneswar never again looked directly into Sharda Devi's eyes.

Sharda Devi lived for many years.

She never came to the studio.

Bhubaneswar never went to her either.

Standing in the shop that afternoon, Bhubaneswar again heard the old sentence in his ears:

"Mother is ill now."

His mother truly had been ill then.

But the truth had also been true.

Two truths do not cancel each other.

Bhubaneswar did not look at the backdrop.

He gathered the sale papers during the day and left early.

On the third day, deliberately, he returned at eight at night.

Outside the shop, the air was cool after the rain.

He opened the door and first looked at the backdrop.

One.

Two.

Three.

Four.

Four black dots.

They were not equally spaced.

Two stood above and below one another.

Two lay side by side.

This time Bhubaneswar covered the light slit with cardboard.

The black dots vanished.

He felt relieved.

He sat down in the chair.

Five minutes later there was a faint clatter from inside the darkroom.

Bhubaneswar sat upright.

Someone is there.

He took an old pair of scissors from the desk drawer.

"Who is it?"

No answer.

Another faint rustle.

The darkroom door was closed, but a thin line of light was coming from beneath it.

Bhubaneswar moved forward slowly.

He pushed the door open.

No one was inside.

But the small ventilation slit in the rear wall was open.

That slit had been jammed for years.

Today there were fresh scratches on its iron flap.

On the floor below lay a leaf.

A guava leaf.

There was no guava tree in the studio's rear courtyard.

But there was one next door.

Bhubaneswar understood.

Entry was not through the light slit.

It was through the back courtyard.

He closed the ventilation slit.

Then he went to the backdrop.

Because of the cardboard, there were no black dots.

He decided to open the fold of the cloth.

The stitching along the bottom was old, but in the middle there were two inches of new thread.

The thread was white.

The cloth had yellowed.

Bhubaneswar placed the scissors against it.

At that very moment he heard footsteps outside.

He turned.

The main studio door stood half open.

A young woman was standing inside.

A wet shawl.

A cloth bag under her arm.

A small key in her hand.

"Kaka," she said, "put the scissors down."

Bhubaneswar did not recognise her.

"Who are you?"

"Madhusudan's granddaughter."

Bhubaneswar's hand lowered.

"Madhusudan?"

"I am Anvita."

At the name an old image slowly formed.

At Madhusudan's daughter Urmila's wedding, there had been a mischievous little girl who always turned her face away whenever she saw a camera.

"How did you get inside?"

Anvita showed him the key.

"This is not for the rear ventilation slit. It is the old second key to the main door. Baba had it."

"Madhusudan had my key?"

"Yes."

Bhubaneswar's voice hardened.

"And what are you doing here night after night?"

Anvita looked towards the backdrop.

"Saving what you are about to cut open."

Bhubaneswar put the scissors on the table.

"The backdrop?"

"What is inside the backdrop?"

"What is inside?"

Anvita did not answer immediately.

She took cloth gloves from her bag and put them on.

Then she carefully opened the lower fold of the backdrop.

From inside she removed a thin paper tube.

Bhubaneswar's mouth went dry.

Anvita placed the tube on the table.

The paper was opened.

Inside were two small pieces of negative strip.

Bhubaneswar gripped the back of the chair.

The frames were tiny, but he recognised the sequence notation.

On the edge was a number in his own handwriting:

"S-17/6."

Relief Distribution.

Frame six.

"Where did you find this?"

Anvita pointed to the fold of the backdrop.

"There is not one compartment inside. There are many. Baba had them stitched."

Bhubaneswar remained silent for a long time.

"I destroyed all of them."

"You destroyed what you saw."

The sentence was direct.

It did not sound like an accusation.

Even so, Bhubaneswar felt it strike him.

Anvita took out a folded piece of paper.

"Baba wrote this."

Madhusudan's slanting handwriting was on it.

"I placed the second surviving copies of the frames inside the folds of the backdrop. I did not tell the owner. One day the times will change."

That was all.

No date.

No signature.

Bhubaneswar read it and then read it again.

"He deceived me."

Anvita remained calm.

"Perhaps."

Bhubaneswar looked at her.

Anvita added, "Or perhaps he made a decision separate from your fear."

A protest rose instantly inside Bhubaneswar.

Madhusudan had been his assistant.

He paid Madhusudan's wages.

His orders ran the studio.

But the protest did not reach his mouth.

"The black dots?" he asked.

For the first time a trace of embarrassment appeared on Anvita's face.

"They are because of me."

She went into the darkroom.

Near the ventilation slit stood a small hand lamp.

In front of it, five small clips were fixed to a thin strip of wood.

"I take the negatives out of the folds and hang them here. When I shine a direct light, their shadows fall on the backdrop. At first I did not realise they looked like dots from the front."

"Why not in daytime?"

"The shadows disappear in the outside light."

"And the light slit?"

"Without that angle, the image was not clear enough. At first I could not find where Baba had kept the old enlarger, so I used the small lamp."

Bhubaneswar went to stand in front of the backdrop.

Anvita removed the cardboard.

The outside electric light and the small lamp inside together made five black dots appear on the screen.

Five.

Yesterday there had been four.

Today there was one more frame.

"The chemical smell?"

"Some of the folded packets were damp when I opened them. I did not touch them with clean water. The university conservation room told me that if old chemical residue was present, I should isolate it. One packet released the smell. There are old stains on the backdrop too."

Anvita showed him the brown mark inside the cloth.

"It is not new."

Bhubaneswar touched it with a finger.

The stain on the inside really was old.

Dust on the outside had merely made it seem newly exposed.

"What do you study at the university?"

“Visual archives.”

“This is all for research?”

“Half of it.”

“And the other half?”

Anvita was silent for a while.

“Sharda Devi was my grandmother.”

Bhubaneswar’s eyes dropped automatically.

The name had returned again.

Sharda Devi.

The woman who incited the crowd.

The woman shielding a child in the seventh frame.

“Urmila—Madhusudan’s daughter—”

“My mother.”

“Then Sharda Devi...”

“My mother’s mother.”

Bhubaneswar understood the relationship.

Madhusudan had not merely been an assistant.

He had been preserving an image of his daughter’s mother-in-law.

“He never told me.”

“My grandmother never knew either that Baba had saved copies.”

“How did you find out?”

“Three months before he died, Baba gave me his papers. Among them was a measurement of the backdrop. Small numbers were written along the side. At first I did not understand. When I heard the studio was being sold, I remembered the measurements.”

Anvita opened a sheet of paper from her bag.

It showed the width and length of the backdrop, and twenty small marks inside its folds.

“Twenty?” Bhubaneswar asked.

“So far I have found five.”

“I took only seven frames.”

“They may not all be from that day.”

That possibility created a new fear in Bhubaneswar.

What else had Madhusudan preserved?

Whose images?

Whose truth?

How many times had he acted against Bhubaneswar’s orders?

“Have you removed everything?”

“No. The cloth is fragile. If I open more than two or three folds in one night, it will tear.”

“So the dots kept increasing.”

“Yes.”

For the first time Bhubaneswar could have laughed at the mystery.

But no laughter came.

The black dots were not ghosts.

They were the shadow of decisions preserved by living people.

“Why did you not tell me?”

Anvita met his eyes.

“The shop is yours. I should have told you.”

“Then why didn’t you?”

“I was afraid you would burn the backdrop.”

Bhubaneswar immediately wanted to say, “I am not that kind of man.”

But the scissors lay on the table.

He remembered the chemical solution of twenty-seven years earlier.

He remained silent.

Anvita held the piece of negative strip up to the light.

“Shall we look?”

Bhubaneswar’s first impulse was no.

His second was yes.

He pulled up a chair and sat.

Anvita placed the old enlarger on the table.

The instrument belonged to Bhubaneswar, but he did not remember how it had come to be there.

“It was in the rear cupboard,” Anvita said. “I replaced the bulb.”

She placed a sheet of white paper below and the negative strip above.

“No print yet. We will only enlarge it and look.”

The light came on.

An inverted image emerged on the paper.

Blurred at first.

Then Anvita turned the focusing wheel.

The lines sharpened.

The bamboo barricade.

The rear corner of the vehicle.

A hand in the air.

Bhubaneswar stopped breathing.

“Frame six,” he said.

“Yes.”

It was the moment just before the barricade fell.

At one side stood Kamalakant.

Bhubaneswar’s elder brother.

His hand was not at the rear of the vehicle.

It was reaching towards the bamboo rope.

Bhubaneswar leaned closer.

For twenty-seven years his memory had kept Kamalakant in charge of the vehicles.

In the photograph, he was gripping the rope and trying to stop the barricade from falling.

“The next frame?”

“Not found yet.”

Bhubaneswar kept his eyes on the paper.

That night Kamalakant had said, “Mother is ill now.”

For the first time Bhubaneswar wondered:

Had his brother come to protect himself, or to protect their mother?

Was he afraid that if the incident grew into a case, the only earning member of the household would become entangled in litigation?

Or had he himself not seen the full sequence of what happened?

Anvita switched off the enlarger.

The image vanished.

“Will you publish all of this?” Bhubaneswar asked.

“First I will preserve it.”

“And then?”

“When the surviving frames give a complete enough sequence, I will make a description. I will name people only to the extent supported by evidence.”

“My grandmother’s name?”

“If she is visible, I will write it.”

“People will reopen the old matter.”

“They may.”

“And accusations?”

“A photograph does not accuse. People do.”

Bhubaneswar gave a faint, bitter laugh.

“That sentence will look good in a book.”

Anvita did not answer.

After a while she said, “A photograph does not give the whole truth by itself either.”

Bhubaneswar looked at her.

“That is why the sequence matters.”

He had not expected that answer.

He had assumed a younger generation would find an image and immediately pronounce judgment.

Anvita was searching for sequence before judgment.

That night they opened only two more folds of the backdrop.

The sixth compartment was empty.

The seventh contained a small negative, but not from the relief distribution.

It was a wedding photograph—an unknown couple, the bride’s head covered by a long veil.

Anvita smiled.

“Baba thought everything was history.”

An unwilling smile came to Bhubaneswar’s face.

“Perhaps the customer never came back for this one.”

“Even so, it is history.”

At eleven Anvita left.

Bhubaneswar remained in the studio.

Seven black dots showed on the backdrop—five shadows from negatives, two from the clips.

He sat watching them.

When there had been two dots, he had thought dead photographs were returning.

Now he knew.

It was not a return.

It was the shadow of preservation.

Even so, fear had not vanished completely.

The return of truth can be no less frightening than a ghost.

The next day Bhubaneswar called the buyer.

"The material will not be removed in three days."

"The agreement—"

"Seven days."

"Why?"

Bhubaneswar thought for a few moments.

"An old cloth has to be opened."

The buyer probably did not understand, but agreed to seven days.

During those seven days Bhubaneswar came to the studio every evening.

Anvita came at eight.

Together they opened the folds of the backdrop.

They straightened the cloth.

Whenever they found a negative strip, they put on gloves and placed it in a separate envelope.

On each envelope they wrote only the sequence number, estimated year, and subject.

In the tenth compartment they found frame seven from the relief distribution.

Bhubaneswar did not at once have the courage to put it before the light.

Anvita waited.

At last he himself said, "Switch it on."

The light from the enlarger fell downward.

The frame became clear.

Sharda Devi was kneeling on the ground.

A child lay within the protection of her arms.

The bamboo had fallen behind her.

Two people were running at one side.

One man had turned back to lift her.

Bhubaneswar recognised him.

Madhusudan.

Anvita's grandfather.

For a long time Anvita said nothing.

"Did you make a print from this frame?" she asked.

"Yes."

"Did Grandmother see it?"

"No."

"Baba?"

"He was in the darkroom. It is possible."

Anvita switched off the light.

"Then Baba did not save only Grandmother's photograph."

"What?"

“He saved his own decision too.”

Bhubaneswar understood.

Madhusudan had been in the crowd that day.

In the photograph, he had turned back to lift Sharda.

Later he saved the negative.

A person may preserve evidence of his own good act out of pride.

A person may preserve evidence that removes a false stain from someone else out of a sense of justice.

Where the boundary lay between the two, Bhubaneswar could not say.

The twelfth compartment contained no negative.

In the thirteenth, they found frame five of the relief distribution.

The very frame in which the volunteer raised his hand to signal the vehicle to stop.

The volunteer’s face was half in shadow.

Anvita enlarged it.

“Who is this?”

Bhubaneswar recognised him.

“The school manager.”

The same man who had said two days later, “No one will benefit.”

In the frame, he was trying to prevent the accident.

Bhubaneswar’s mind grew tangled again.

For twenty-seven years he had thought of that man as one of those who suppressed the truth.

At the moment of the incident, however, he had been trying to save the barricade.

A human being does not become guilty or innocent within a single frame.

Anvita said quietly, “That is why the whole sequence matters.”

Bhubaneswar said nothing.

As they opened the fifteenth compartment, the fabric of the backdrop cracked.

Anvita stopped her hand immediately.

“Enough. Not today.”

“One remains.”

“It will tear.”

Earlier, at such a moment, Bhubaneswar would have said, “Nothing will happen. Open it.”

Today he himself let the backdrop go.

“Tomorrow.”

When they returned the next day, the electricity was out.

The studio was dark.

Anvita lit the hand lamp.

A black dot appeared again on the white screen.

This time Bhubaneswar did not count it.

He looked only at the angle.

“Lower the lamp by two finger-widths,” he said.

Anvita lowered it.

The dot grew smaller.

“Now the folds in the cloth are clearer.”

The two of them worked silently.

In the sixteenth compartment there was a thin piece of paper.

Madhusudan’s handwriting.

“The owner ordered all seven frames destroyed. I saved one set. If they ever come out, do not write the owner’s name as though he alone were guilty. Everyone was afraid.”

Bhubaneswar read it twice.

“He was trying to protect me,” he said.

Anvita replied, “Or trying to preserve the complete shape of what happened.”

Bhubaneswar put the paper back.

He might have felt anger towards Madhusudan.

Instead, there was emptiness.

For twenty-seven years he had carried his guilt alone.

Now he learned that the decision that night had not been his alone either.

The fear had been collective.

The failure had been collective.

The resistance too had quietly been collective.

When they opened the final compartment, there was no negative inside.

There was a small piece of white cloth.

On it were seven black dots from chemical stains.

Bhubaneswar laughed aloud.

Anvita was startled.

“What happened?”

“Nothing.”

He kept looking at the stains.

“On the first night I was frightened by dots like these.”

Anvita laughed too.

“The dots were not guilty.”

“No.”

Seven days were complete.

The buyer came.

The backdrop had been taken down but not thrown away.

Anvita wrapped it in acid-free paper and prepared it to be sent to the university conservation room.

The negative strips were placed in a separate box.

Bhubaneswar looked at the desk, the chair, the broken frames, the old enlarger.

“This instrument?” Anvita asked.

“Take it.”

“The university has a new one.”

“Then why?”

“Keep it yourself.”

Bhubaneswar ran a hand over the enlarger.

“My eyes are not as they used to be.”

Anvita said, “A print is not made by eyes alone.”

Bhubaneswar looked at her.

“Another sentence for a book?”

“No. Baba used to say it.”

The studio became empty.

After the backdrop was removed, a large white rectangle remained on the wall where less dust had settled.

Upon that white space, a small black dot from the cracked light slit outside was falling.

Only one.

The buyer asked, “Should I replace that glass?”

Bhubaneswar looked towards the light slit.

“Replace it.”

Then, after thinking, he added, “But not today.”

The buyer began getting the sale papers signed.

Bhubaneswar wrote his name.

His hand trembled slightly, but the letters were complete.

Outside, Anvita stood holding the box.

Before closing the door, Bhubaneswar looked inside once more.

The black dot remained steady on the white wall.

He no longer saw a face in it.

No curse.

No forgiveness.

Only a mark—one that appears when the direction of light changes, and disappears when the direction changes again.

Bhubaneswar pulled the door shut.

He locked it.

He did not give the key first to the buyer.

He handed it to Anvita.

“Put the box outside and check that rear cupboard once,” he said. “Madhusudan may have saved something else.”

Anvita took the key.

Bhubaneswar walked out of the lane.

The clock tower struck ten.

Behind him, after a little while, a light came on inside the closed photography studio.

On the white wall, one black dot became two.

STORY 126

THE MISSING SHOEPRINT AT THE COURTHOUSE

Dust had its own time in the old property room of the district courthouse.

Outside, the clock struck ten, then eleven; noon passed into afternoon. But inside, between the cupboards, time seemed to settle as a fine layer of ash.

Madhav Mishra had known the colours of this dust for twenty-eight years.

New dust was pale grey-brown.

Old dust took on a yellowish cast.

Dust that had absorbed monsoon dampness clumped the moment a finger touched it.

That Monday morning, the instant he opened the padlock of the property room, his eyes went to the floor.

In front of Rack Number Seventeen was a shoeprint.

Only one.

None before it.

None after it.

If someone had come from the door and walked that far, there should have been other prints in the dust between.

But the dust from the door to the rack was smooth.

The print was so clear that the square pattern of the sole, the diagonal scratch on the heel, and the clipped corner on the left could all be seen.

Madhav bent down.

He reached out a hand, then stopped.

The property room was not a playroom.

It contained seized objects, sealed envelopes, original papers from land disputes, old weapons, broken locks, counterfeit seals, and many objects kept under court orders.

A single mark could itself be evidence.

He called the watchman, Bhola Paswan.

The moment Bhola entered, he said, "The lock was closed in front of me last night, Babu."

Madhav asked, "Was it opened during the night?"

"No. There are two keys. One with you, one in the nazir sahib's sealed box."

Madhav looked at the print.

Bhola too fell silent.

"One shoe," he said softly. "But where is the man?"

Madhav did not answer.

At that moment he remembered a black cloth shoe from twenty-four years earlier.

Not the shoe itself.

Its label.

“Item No. 47—black cloth shoes, one pair.”

On paper it said one pair.

But when the box had eventually been opened, one shoe was missing.

Along with that case, the original land deed of a poor family had also been seized.

Madhav was a new records assistant then.

Senior clerk Raghuvir Babu had told him, “What is written in the list is what is written. We will count the contents of the box again only when there is an order.”

Madhav had not questioned him.

A few months later, the item number was altered.

The black shoes were replaced by a brass nameplate.

The nameplate was replaced by a copy of a land record.

And the original deed was entered as “attached to the file.”

Madhav’s signature stood beneath the register entry.

The original deed was never seen again.

The case ended.

The family lost the land.

Raghuvir Babu retired.

And Madhav slowly practised forgetting what his own signature meant.

Now there was a shoeprint in front of Rack Seventeen.

Bhola said, “Shall I have the floor swept?”

“No.”

Madhav immediately drew the position on paper, measured the distance with a tape, and called Nazir Arun Jha.

When Arun arrived, he laughed at first.

“So much fuss over one footprint?”

The laughter stopped when he saw Madhav’s face.

He had the print photographed.

He checked the seal on the door.

He counted the iron bars of the window.

Nothing was broken.

The ceiling was covered with old bamboo planks, with a tin roof above them.

In one corner, a new board had been fitted the previous year to stop rainwater.

Arun said, “There is nowhere for anyone to remain hidden inside.”

Madhav looked under the rack.

The edge of one floorboard stood slightly higher than the boards beside it.

He could not remember whether it had always been like that.

The property room was closed that day, but the print was not erased.

The next morning Madhav opened the lock.

A paper cover had been placed over the previous day’s print.

The cover was untouched.

Exactly two finger-widths to its south was another shoeprint.

The same square pattern on the sole.

The same diagonal scratch on the heel.

The same clipped left corner.

Bhola stepped back.

"It has come again."

Madhav's throat went dry.

He did not sleep that night.

Again and again Raghuvir Babu's voice returned to his ears:

"What is written in the list is what is written."

What had been written in the list was not the whole truth that day.

One part of the truth had been inside the box.

One part in the order sheet.

And one part in Madhav's silence.

On the third morning the print appeared again.

This time it was directly in front of the raised edge of the floorboard.

Nazir Arun became stern.

"Someone is playing a trick here. Tonight we double the guard."

A fresh seal was placed on the door.

Thin paper strips were pasted across the inside of the window so that if a bar moved, the strip would tear.

A fine line of ash was laid at one corner of the roof.

Madhav put his own key into a small cloth pouch, sealed it, and gave it to Arun.

That night Bhola and a second guard, Lalit, took turns staying awake on the veranda.

Until five in the morning there was no sound.

At five twenty, there was a faint scrape on the tin roof.

Lalit lifted his torch.

Thinking it was a cat, he sat down again.

At six the seal was broken.

The dust at the doorway was undisturbed.

The paper strips on the window were intact.

The line of ash at the roof corner was still visible.

But in front of Rack Seventeen there was a fourth shoeprint.

This time there was a faint sparkle at the heel.

Madhav knelt.

Two or three bright grains lay in the dust.

He did not pick one up with his fingernail.

He lifted it with the corner of a piece of paper.

Sand.

Not ordinary yellow sand.

There was a dark glitter in it, like fine fragments of mica.

Arun said, "There is no sand like this in the courthouse yard."

Bhola spoke at once.

"The sand brought for repairing the rear gate has that shine in it."

Everyone went outside.

For three days repairs had been under way in the narrow lane between the old civil building and the property room.

A bamboo scaffold had been erected.

Below it was a heap of glittering sand.

Madhav examined a handful.

The same dark glitter.

Arun looked up at the scaffold.

One bamboo pole reached the height of the property-room roof.

“From above the roof?”

Bhola shook his head.

“The tin is intact.”

Madhav said nothing.

He went back inside and stared at the ceiling for a long time.

The old bamboo planks crossed over one another.

Exactly above Rack Seventeen, one plank sat slightly lower than the others.

Along its edge ran a pale line of fresh abrasion.

“Bring a ladder,” Madhav said.

Arun stopped him.

“Call the engineer first. It is an old ceiling.”

Junior Engineer Nilima Karn from the municipal construction branch arrived in the afternoon.

She examined the bamboo and said, “This is not a load-bearing ceiling. But from the scaffold outside, a thin person could reach this plank with a hand.”

“Could someone climb down inside?”

“No. The gap is barely four inches.”

Madhav’s eyes fixed on the gap.

Four inches was too little for a man.

More than enough for a bamboo pole.

Nilima pushed a thin rod upward.

It entered through the gap.

The end of the rod could be bent towards exactly the part of the property room where the shoeprints were appearing.

Arun said softly, “The shoe was not on a person’s foot.”

A chill ran once through Madhav’s body, but the direction of his fear changed.

The question was no longer about a ghost.

The question was:

Why was someone tying a shoe to the end of a bamboo pole and pressing it into the dust inside?

The scaffold outside was examined.

At the third bamboo joint they found fibres from an old cotton cord.

Beside them was a small piece of black rubber.

The clipped edge matched the left corner of the shoeprint.

The shoe itself was not found.

Inside Madhav, the old Item Number Forty-Seven awoke again.

Black cloth shoes, one pair.

Could the shoe that disappeared twenty-four years ago still be somewhere?

There was less logic than guilt in that question.

Madhav did not tell Arun this.

That evening he asked for the old registers.

The property-room admission register from the year 2002.

The paper edges were crumbling.

Item Number Forty-Seven:

“Black cloth shoes—one pair.”

Below that entry, in red ink, was a later note:

“Description corrected.”

The correction was dated five months later.

Item:

“Brass nameplate.”

Signature:

Raghuvir Prasad.

Witness:

Madhav Mishra.

Madhav closed his eyes.

That day Raghuvir Babu had told him that the first seizure list was wrong and only the item description was being corrected.

Madhav had not opened the box to see.

He had simply signed.

The same file concerned one family:

Jagarnath Mandal, his wife Savitri Devi, and two sons.

The allegation was that the original sale deed to their land was forged.

Later, only a certified copy reached the court.

The original paper was entered as “missing.”

The family did not exactly lose the case, but it dragged on for so long that the land passed into other hands.

Jagarnath died before the judgment.

Madhav was about to close the file.

Then a loose paper fell from beneath it.

On the reverse of an old petition, in pencil, was written:

“Original paper—property room—Seventeen.”

The handwriting was not Raghuvir Babu’s.

Madhav recognised it.

Jagdish Das, the orderly at the time.

Jagdish had died five years earlier.

On the next morning a fifth shoeprint appeared.

This time, in the dust ahead of it, there was a very fine straight line—as though something had been dragged across the floor from the corner of the sole.

The line ended at the raised floorboard.

Arun asked, “Shall we open this board?”

Madhav did not answer at once.

The floor of the property room was itself part of an officially recorded structure.

It could not be opened arbitrarily.

Nilima tapped the board.

The other boards gave a solid sound.

This one sounded hollow.

"There is empty space underneath," she said.

Arun requested written permission.

The permission had not come by noon.

In the meantime Madhav asked the scaffold contractor for the names of the workers.

Eight people.

His finger stopped when he read one name.

Ragini Mandal.

She was not listed as a labourer, but as a "measurement assistant."

The contractor said, "She is on a temporary municipal engineering project. She records old measurements and drawings for the canopy."

"Where is she from?"

"Basantpur."

Jagarnath Mandal's village had also been Basantpur.

Something inside Madhav grew heavy.

For the first time that day, he looked carefully at Ragini.

A young woman of twenty-five or twenty-six.

Dust on her forehead.

A measuring tape in her hand.

A small pencil pouch at her waist.

When she climbed the scaffold, she removed her shoes and changed into light rubber slippers.

Madhav called from below.

"Ragini Mandal?"

She stopped.

"Yes."

"Did you know Jagarnath Mandal?"

Her face did not change immediately.

Only the caution in her eyes deepened.

"He was my father."

Madhav was silent for a few moments.

"Are you making the shoeprints in the property room?"

Ragini did not answer directly.

She climbed down.

"Do you have proof?"

Her voice was not challenging.

It carried tired caution.

Madhav said, "At present it is a question."

Ragini looked towards the heap of sand.

“Then ask the question in writing.”

She walked away.

Arun was displeased when he heard of this.

“If there is suspicion, post a guard. Question her properly.”

Madhav said, “First open the floorboard.”

Permission arrived in the afternoon.

In the presence of a judicial officer’s representative, the nazir, the engineer, two witnesses, and Madhav, the nails were slowly removed from the floorboard.

When the board came up, black darkness showed below.

The depth was not great.

About four inches.

First came the smell of dried paper.

Then the corner of a piece of cloth.

Using a gripping tool like forceps, Nilima pulled it out.

It was a flat bundle wrapped in old muslin.

Everyone stopped breathing.

The procedure for opening the bundle was recorded.

Photographs were taken.

The condition of the seal was noted.

Inside were three objects.

An original sale deed.

A carbon copy of the seizure list.

And a small piece of paper in Jagdish Das’s handwriting.

“On the day this paper was changed, I saved the original. If I put it back into the file, it will disappear again. Kept beneath Seventeen. I do not know whether justice will ever see the day.”

Madhav’s knees weakened.

He stood holding the wall.

Arun examined the seal on the original deed.

“This is the paper from that dispute.”

Madhav could say only, “Yes.”

There was no shoe beneath the floorboard.

That gave him both relief and shame.

Ragini was called immediately.

When she arrived the bundle lay in front of them, but she was not allowed to touch it.

She looked at the papers from a distance.

No triumph appeared on her face.

She gripped a chair and sat down.

“My father’s paper?”

Arun said, “At first sight, that is what it appears to be. There will be an examination.”

Madhav asked, “Why the shoeprints?”

Ragini remained silent for a long time.

Then she took a folded paper from her bag.

It was a copy of a letter written by Jagdish Das's grandson.

A few months before his death, Jagdish had told his family about the old matter.

"In front of Rack Seventeen, the third floorboard. But do not open the board without government officials present."

Ragini said, "I submitted a direct application."

"To whom?" Arun asked.

"Three times. The first time I was told, 'Old matter.' The second time, 'The file is being searched.' The third time, 'The property room will soon be demolished; anything necessary will be separated.'"

"So then you chose this method?"

"I was afraid that when the floor was lifted, the paper would leave with the rubble. I had no authority to open the board. If I stole the paper, it would become suspect again. I needed something that would force the officers to look at that exact place."

Madhav asked, "Where did the shoe come from?"

For the first time Ragini smiled faintly.

"A torn shoe belonging to the scaffold contractor. It was going to be thrown away."

She explained that she had cut away the front portion of the shoe and tied it to a thin bamboo pole.

After work ended at night, she climbed onto the scaffold on the pretext of checking measurements.

There was a four-inch gap between the property-room roof and the old bamboo planks.

She lowered the pole through that gap and pressed the shoe into the dust.

On the first day she merely drew attention to the place.

On the second she pressed the print a little farther south, because she saw the first print had been covered.

On the third she placed it directly in front of the board.

On the fourth, sand from the scaffold remained on the sole.

On the fifth, she dragged the clipped corner of the shoe through the dust to draw a line.

"Did you understand that this would create fear?" Madhav asked.

"Yes."

"Do you know that interference with a secured property room can be punishable?"

"Yes."

Ragini looked directly into his eyes.

"Was making the original paper disappear also punishable?"

Silence spread through the room.

Arun looked at Madhav.

Madhav could have said that he had been a new employee then.

That he had obeyed a superior.

That he had not personally switched the contents of the box.

All of those things were facts.

But all the facts together did not make the truth.

He said slowly, "My signature is on that correction register."

Ragini said nothing.

Madhav continued, "I signed without seeing the object."

Arun's face hardened.

"Why did you never say this before?"

"Because at the time I called it a mistake and kept making it smaller inside myself. Later I understood that it was not small. Then the more time passed, the harder it became to say."

Ragini kept looking at the bundle.

"I do not know whether my father died because of the land or because of the humiliation," she said. "But in our house it was always said that if the original paper had remained, things would have been different."

Madhav had no words of comfort.

He did not feel he had the right to offer comfort either.

The next steps were slow.

Examination of the original document.

Reconstruction of the old case file.

Comparison with the seizure register.

Verification of Jagdish's handwriting.

And a separate report on the security breach in the property room.

No immediate charge was filed against Ragini, but her statement was recorded.

She was not suspended from her work either.

Until the inquiry was complete, she was kept away from the scaffold over the property room.

Madhav prepared his own written statement.

In the first draft he wrote:

"I signed according to the senior officer's instruction."

He read the sentence and tore up the paper.

In the second draft he wrote:

"I signed without seeing the object, and even after I later understood there was a discrepancy, I did not submit a written objection."

After that sentence, his hand remained still for a long time.

That evening the property room was closed again.

The five old shoeprints still remained in front of Rack Seventeen.

The inquiry team had ordered that the dust not yet be removed.

On the sixth morning Madhav opened the lock.

He was not alone.

Arun, Bhola, and two employees were with him.

Everyone's eyes went involuntarily towards Rack Seventeen.

There was no new print.

Only the five old ones.

Madhav felt a strange emptiness.

The thing that had arrived for five days in the form of fear was absent now, and the room seemed even quieter.

Bhola tried to laugh.

“The shoe has gone to rest now.”

No one laughed.

A few weeks later repairs began in the property room.

The floorboards were lifted one by one.

The space beneath was cleaned.

A fresh inventory was made of every object.

Before Rack Seventeen was removed, Madhav ran a hand along its back.

There was a very faint pencil number on the wood:

“47.”

He was startled.

It might have been coincidence.

No one could say for certain how many times the old rack numbering had changed.

Madhav resisted the temptation to manufacture meaning from the number.

Not every mark is a message.

Some marks simply remain.

The final inquiry report came months later.

The original sale deed matched the genuine old paper; its legal effect would be decided separately by the court.

Evidence of an unauthorised alteration in the old seizure list was found, but some of the principal responsible persons had died and others were unavailable.

A departmental remark was entered against Madhav:

serious dereliction in the performance of duty, followed by silence.

His retirement was three months away.

No one called him a hero.

No one called him wholly guilty either.

Earlier he had found that middle ground unbearable.

Now he understood that many decisions in life are written precisely in that middle ground.

One day Ragini came to collect a certified copy.

The original paper was now in judicial custody.

She stopped in front of Madhav’s desk.

“Everyone at home keeps asking—now that the paper has been found, will the land come back?”

Madhav said, “I do not know.”

“I told them the same thing. Finding the paper and finding a judgment are two different things.”

Madhav nodded.

After a few moments Ragini asked, “You could have changed your statement against me?”

“I could have.”

“Why didn’t you?”

Madhav looked out the window.

The repair scaffold was being dismantled.

Half the heap of glittering sand remained.

"The price of what I failed to write once was paid by many people. I was not going to do the same thing a second time."

Ragini did not answer.

She put the certified copy into her cloth bag and left.

On the final day before his retirement, Madhav went once more to see the property room.

A new floor had been laid.

There was no dust.

In the place of Rack Number Seventeen stood a new metal cupboard with a clean label and a straight number.

There was no trace of the old shoeprints.

Bhola, who was still on guard duty, said, "Babu, the photographs of those prints are in the file. Where have they gone?"

Madhav did not laugh.

He stepped onto the new floor.

Without dust, his own shoe left no complete print.

He liked that.

As he went out, he looked back once from the doorway.

The room was ordinary.

No sound.

No mystery.

But it seemed to him that sometimes justice does not enter through the door on its own feet.

Sometimes it leaves only a single mark, exactly where someone needs to look.

STORY 127

THE CLOCK THAT STRUCK AT HALF PAST

The clock still hung on the eastern wall of the municipal library.

A round brass rim, a face gone grey, and two black hands behind the glass.

By day the clock merely told the time.

At night it became something else.

The brass bell cup had been removed twelve years earlier because its sound disturbed readers.

The clock's striking mechanism had also been disabled.

Yet for two weeks, every night after midnight, the reading room had heard two metallic notes at exactly half past twelve.

On the first night, Librarian Shivnarayan Mishra thought something had fallen.

On the second night, the sound came again.

Exactly twelve-thirty.

Two notes.

The first faint.

The second slightly deeper.

On the third night he stood beneath the clock.

The hands reached half past twelve, but nothing moved inside the clock.

At that very moment a metallic vibration came from the ceiling, travelled downward through the wall, and made something inside the clock frame ring.

A chill ran down Shivnarayan's back.

He was not a believer in ghosts.

But memory sometimes moves faster than reason.

At sixty, Shivnarayan had spent thirty-five years in this library.

He knew every corner, every cupboard, the smell of every old register.

But there were certain papers whose very names made him shut an inner door in his mind.

The chime at half past twelve sounded like a knock on that door.

The bell had been removed twelve years earlier.

But much earlier than that—twenty-seven years earlier—a student had filed a complaint.

His name was Naresh Paswan.

Naresh came to the library every evening.

His home was in an earthen lane behind the market.

His father was a tailor.

Naresh read books for competitive examinations, but his real love was for old bound volumes of history.

Books that other students never touched would find him bent over their pages.

One day he placed a four-page written complaint on Shivnarayan's desk.

“Give me a receipt for this,” he had said.

Shivnarayan had asked, “Let me read it first.”

Naresh’s eyes were tired, but his voice was steady.

“Read it. But please give me a receipt.”

The complaint stated that rare books from the library were being taken upstairs in the name of a “special exhibition,” after which pages were found missing from some volumes.

Naresh had twice seen Arun, nephew of the committee secretary, come out of the upstairs room carrying wrapped papers.

He had also written that some entries in the issue register were being filled in later.

Shivnarayan was an assistant librarian then.

The complaint frightened him.

That year Committee Secretary Awadhesh Babu had contributed half the money for roof repairs through his own business establishment.

The municipal grant was stalled.

The roof leaked.

Three months of staff salaries were unpaid.

Shivnarayan placed the complaint before the chief librarian.

The chief said quietly, “If this paper enters the register now, the library will be shut down. First let us investigate internally.”

The internal investigation was never completed.

Two weeks later a rare bound volume actually disappeared.

One page from the issue register was found torn out.

That day Naresh had been seen near the upstairs room.

No questions were raised about Arun.

Questions were raised about Naresh.

Shivnarayan knew that Naresh’s complaint had come first.

He also knew it was not clear whether Naresh’s name had been on the torn page.

But he remained silent.

“If the book is found, everything will become clear,” he told himself.

The book was not found.

Naresh’s entry to the library was barred.

The matter did not reach the police because the committee did not want scandal.

On paper it was written:

“Membership suspended on disciplinary grounds.”

Naresh never came to the library again.

Some months later, people heard that he had gone outside Darbhanga to look for work.

Shivnarayan pushed the matter into a mental cupboard labelled “old incident.”

Now the chime at half past twelve seemed to be coming from behind that cupboard.

On the fourth night, he kept watchman Raghu with him.

Raghu was a thin man in his forties.

After the library closed, he made rounds of the main door, courtyard, rear veranda, and upper roof.

"Where are you at twelve-thirty?" Shivnarayan asked.

"Near the back gate. I leave this room at twelve twenty-five and return by twelve thirty-five."

"Every day?"

"Almost."

Shivnarayan said nothing.

Raghu laughed.

"People say the old clock has started striking again."

"People have too little work."

"I heard the bell itself is gone."

"It is."

"Then what is striking?"

Shivnarayan did not answer.

At twelve twenty-five Raghu left for his round.

Shivnarayan switched off all the lights in the reading room except the small green-shaded lamp on the desk.

The clock hands moved slowly forward.

Twelve twenty-nine.

The room smelled of old paper and dampness.

Outside, neem leaves rustled.

Twelve-thirty.

Ton.

A moment.

Ton.

This time Shivnarayan was not looking at the clock.

He was looking towards the ceiling.

With the second note, a thin wire trembled.

It hung from near a wooden strip in the ceiling.

By day it looked like a line of dust.

In the slanting night light, it glinted.

Shivnarayan pulled over a chair and climbed up.

The lower end of the wire entered the wall behind the clock.

The upper end disappeared into the ceiling.

He touched it with a finger.

A faint metallic clink sounded inside the clock.

His breathing quickened.

The bell had been removed, but the old striker rod and pull-wire had never been completely taken out.

If the wire was pulled, the striker now hit the brass base plate where the bell had once been.

But who was pulling the wire?

When Raghu returned that night, Shivnarayan said nothing.

In the morning he searched for the old building plan.

The ceiling wire had once run to a hand bell in the upstairs reading room. After a fire alarm system was installed, that arrangement had been abandoned.

The wire had not been cut.

It had merely been bent and left inside the ceiling.

As Shivnarayan traced the wire's route on the plan, his eyes stopped on one notation:

"OLD RECORD CUPBOARD, ROOM 3."

Room 3 was no longer locked.

Half of it was now used for book repair.

Against one wall stood a huge wooden cupboard that was difficult to get behind.

At noon Shivnarayan went there.

There was less dust in front of the cupboard.

Something heavy had recently been dragged.

Fine wood powder lay on the floor at the right-hand corner.

He called Raghu.

"Who moved this cupboard?"

Raghu scratched his head.

"Not me. Perhaps the repair workers?"

"No repairs were done here."

It was difficult to reach the top of the cupboard.

Shivnarayan had a ladder brought.

In the dust above were two clear finger streaks.

Behind the cupboard was a narrow gap.

In the gap, the corner of a paper could be seen.

He tried to pull it out, but it was stuck inside.

Then the direction of the ceiling wire became clear to him.

The wire came down exactly behind the cupboard.

Whenever someone pressed or pulled the rear board of the cupboard, the board tugged the old wire.

The wire sent the vibration through the wall to the clock.

The clock was not striking at the half-hour.

Someone was searching for papers at the half-hour.

The question was no longer about the sound.

The question was:

Who?

That night Shivnarayan changed the timing of Raghu's round.

"Tonight do not go to the back at twelve-twenty," he said.

"Stay on the upstairs veranda. But make no sound."

"Is something wrong?"

"Yes."

"A thief?"

Shivnarayan thought for a moment.

"I do not know yet."

At twelve twenty-five the library looked normal from outside.

The main door was closed.
 The lights were out.
 Shivnarayan stood in the dark near Room 3.
 At twelve twenty-nine, the latch of the small rear window lifted very slowly.
 He had not noticed that latch during the day.
 A thin iron wire could be inserted from outside to lift its catch.
 The window opened.
 A shadow entered.
 The shadow went straight to the cupboard.
 Shivnarayan waited.
 The figure reached up and pressed the rear wooden board.
 Far away in the reading room came the metallic note.
 Ton.
 The board was pulled a second time.
 Ton.
 "Enough," Shivnarayan said.
 The shadow froze.
 Raghu lit a lamp from the veranda.
 It was a young woman.
 Twenty-five or twenty-six.
 A dark face.
 Sweat on her forehead.
 A cloth bundle in her hand.
 Shivnarayan had seen her somewhere.
 "Name?"
 At first the young woman was silent.
 Then she said, "Sudha."
 "Full name?"
 "Sudha Naresh Paswan."
 Something old inside Shivnarayan suddenly fell.
 Raghu looked at him.
 Sudha said, "Raghu Kaka knew nothing. I had noticed the old latch on the window during the day."
 "Why do you come here at night?"
 "For papers."
 "Which papers?"
 "The ones you people have not searched for in twenty-seven years."
 Shivnarayan's mouth went dry.
 Sudha pointed behind the cupboard.
 "Before my father died, he told me one thing. The original copy of his complaint had not been returned to him that day. Two weeks later, when he was accused, he saw an employee hiding some papers in this room. He suspected that the complaint and the original issue-register page were somewhere here."
 "Naresh... died?"

“Three months ago.”

Shivnarayan lowered his eyes.

Sudha said, “While sorting his belongings I found an old diary. It mentioned this library, you, Awadhesh Babu, Arun. I came during the day to ask.”

Shivnarayan remembered.

Two weeks earlier a young woman had requested permission to see the old membership register.

An employee had refused, saying it was a “personal record.”

Shivnarayan had signed the refusal and accepted it.

“Why did you not come directly to me?”

“I did. You were in a meeting. The next day I was told the old files were being sorted. On the third day I heard that papers considered ‘useless’ would be removed the following week.”

Raghu asked quietly, “So you came at night?”

“Yes.”

Shivnarayan tried to make his voice stern.

“This is an offence.”

Sudha looked directly at him.

“It may be.”

There was neither challenge nor apology in those two words.

Shivnarayan remembered his own sentence from twenty-seven years earlier:

“First let us investigate internally.”

After that sentence, so many inner doors had closed.

“Move the cupboard,” he told Raghu.

The three of them shifted the cupboard slightly forward.

The wooden panel at the back was split in the middle.

Inside the gap were old dust, cobwebs, and a thick layer of papers jammed together.

Sudha opened her cloth bundle.

Inside were thin tweezers, cotton cloth, and a small torch.

“The papers will tear,” she said. “Slowly.”

Shivnarayan did not stop her hand.

One paper came out after another.

The first: an old newspaper clipping.

The second: a repair expense sheet.

The third: a carbon copy of an issue-register page.

The fourth: a four-page handwritten complaint.

Naresh Paswan’s name was at the top.

Shivnarayan’s signature was at the bottom.

The date.

And a short note:

“Received; for preliminary inquiry.”

Shivnarayan searched for a chair and sat down.

The signature was his.

The ink had faded, but the letters were clear.
 Sudha said nothing.
 Raghu went outside.
 Perhaps he understood that what the room needed now was not a guard
 but privacy.
 Shivnarayan turned the pages of the complaint.
 On the back of the fourth page was a name:
 Harishankar Das, then the store assistant.
 Below it, in small handwriting, were the words:
 "Copy of issue page kept separately."
 The carbon copy lay beside it.
 On that copy was the entry for the missing bound volume.
 The book had not been issued in Naresh's name.
 It had been issued in the name of the committee office for the upstairs
 exhibition.
 The date was five days before the accusation against Naresh.
 The receiving signature was indistinct, but it was not Naresh's.
 First relief rose inside Shivnarayan.
 Naresh had been innocent.
 At once the relief turned into shame.
 The paper that could prove his innocence had been in this building.
 It had been there at the time as well.
 It simply had not been searched for.
 "Why would Harishankar Das hide these papers here?" Sudha asked.
 After a long time Shivnarayan said, "Perhaps to save them."
 "From whom?"
 "Perhaps from us."
 He remembered Harishankar.
 A thin man who spoke little and always kept his desk clean.
 Six months after the incident he left the job and returned to his village.
 At the time everyone said it was because of family problems.
 Perhaps the problem had been this building.
 Sudha reached for the complaint papers.
 Instinctively Shivnarayan stopped her.
 "This is a library record."
 Sudha's face hardened.
 Shivnarayan removed his hand.
 "I mean—a proper copy will be made. The original will remain protected
 in the file. You will receive a certified copy."
 "When?"
 "Today."
 "Things can change after daylight."
 Shivnarayan kept looking at her.
 The distrust could have hurt him.
 But the hurt felt deserved.
 "Then let us make the inventory now."

At one-ten in the night, the library receipt register was opened again.
Shivnarayan wrote down the names of the old files.
Sudha read aloud the condition of each document.
Raghu signed as witness.
Sudha asked permission to photograph them with her mobile phone.
Shivnarayan allowed it.

When the first page of the complaint came into the light, Shivnarayan's signature shone again.

For the first time he thought:
A signature is not merely receipt.
It is responsibility.

Until four in the morning, the three of them sorted papers.
Thirty-seven documents in all came out from behind the cupboard.
Most were useless—old bills, letters, lists.
But seven were connected to Naresh's case.
One paper was the most uncomfortable of all.

A short note written by the chief librarian:

"Keep the matter pending; discussion with the committee secretary remains."

Below it were Shivnarayan's initials.
Sudha stared at that page for a long time.

"Did you remember all of this?"

"No."

"What did you remember?"

Before answering, Shivnarayan looked towards the window.

The eastern sky was beginning to open.

"I remembered that the complaint had come. I remembered that I had given a receipt. I remembered that the inquiry was never completed. And I remembered that after Naresh was accused, I did not insist on finding my own signed copy."

Sudha did not fold the page.

She simply placed it on the table.

"My father used to say the accusation of theft was not what hurt him most."

Shivnarayan asked, "Then what?"

"He thought the library was his place. After the accusation, he understood that perhaps it had never been his place at all."

After that sentence, the room became very quiet.

From far away came the dawn azan from a mosque.

Somewhere in a lane a milk can clanged.

The old clock had stopped at one forty-five.

Its hands had not moved forward through the rest of the night.

Perhaps the mainspring had run down.

But no one was paying attention to it now.

At seven, the employees arrived.

Shivnarayan called everyone into the reading room.

He did not tell the whole story of the night.

Nor did he immediately mention that Sudha had entered through the window.

First he placed the seven papers on the table.

"From today these files go onto the preservation list," he said.

"And the membership-suspension entry from twenty-seven years ago will be reviewed."

One employee asked, "Why reopen something so old?"

Shivnarayan replied, "The paper is old. A mistake does not become correct merely by becoming old."

He called the committee chairman.

At first the chairman became uneasy.

The moment he heard the old names, he said, "What benefit is there in reopening such matters?"

Shivnarayan looked through the window.

Sudha was sitting on the veranda.

Eyes that had not slept all night.

A steady face.

"I calculated the benefit long ago," Shivnarayan said.

"Now I will calculate the record."

By noon a brief correction note had been prepared.

Its language made no accusation.

It recorded only what the evidence established:

At the time Naresh Paswan's membership was suspended, the original available issue-register copy had not been taken into consideration.

According to the newly recovered record, the missing bound volume had been issued in the name of the committee office.

The old decision had not been based on complete evidence.

No direct allegation was written against Arun.

There was not enough evidence against him.

Sudha noticed.

"You left his name out."

"Because I will not write more than the papers support."

Sudha was silent for a few moments.

Then she nodded.

It was not agreement.

But neither was it disagreement.

Shivnarayan felt that form was more proper.

In the afternoon Sudha left carrying the certified copies.

At the door she turned.

"Do what you need to do about my night entry."

Shivnarayan said, "The window latch will be changed today."

Sudha looked at his face.

Perhaps she understood that, for now, that was all that would be said on the subject.

"The clock sound?" she asked.

“That will stop too.”

Sudha left.

In the evening a repairman came.

Shivnarayan did not ask him to remove the clock.

He asked only for the old ceiling wire to be taken out.

The wire was much longer than expected.

It ran in several bends through the ceiling, rusted, snagged in wood.

One end was tied to the striker rod of the clock.

The other had become trapped behind the cupboard.

The repairman laughed.

“This thing has been useless for years. Who would have thought it could make so much noise?”

Shivnarayan said, “Useless things sometimes become useful again after a very long time.”

The repairman did not understand.

He coiled the wire and carried it away.

That night Shivnarayan stayed at the library again.

Raghu asked, “Tonight too?”

“One last time.”

At twelve twenty-five Raghu went on his round at the rear.

Shivnarayan sat alone in the reading room.

The old clock had now been repaired and was keeping proper time.

Twelve twenty-nine.

He opened a new register on the table.

One line had already been written:

“Review of old membership decision.”

The space for the name below was blank.

Twelve-thirty.

No metallic note sounded.

Shivnarayan watched the clock for a few moments.

Then he picked up his pen.

In the blank line he wrote:

“Naresh Paswan.”

He completed the letters and put the pen down.

The clock moved silently on.

STORY 128

THE TAUT ROPE AT THE DESERTED FERRY GHAT

At first light, when Harinarayan Jha reached the ghat, the river was grey.

The water had taken on the colour of the sky, but the old ghat had lost its own colour long ago.

Two wooden posts still stood on the two sides.

Once a thick rope had been tied between them, and the ferryboat used that rope to cut across the current.

Twelve years earlier, when the new bridge was built, the ghat had been closed.

A government board in red letters said: "FERRY CROSSING PROHIBITED."

Half the paint had flaked away, but the prohibition could still be read.

Harinarayan had no complaint about that prohibition.

His complaint was with the rope.

Until the previous evening the rope had been slack.

He had seen it himself.

Now, at dawn, it was stretched straight across the river.

As though someone had taken hold of both ends during the night and pulled them tight.

Harinarayan stopped at once.

His first glance went not to the rope but to the post on the right.

The wood at the bottom of the post was wet.

The upper part was dry.

It had not rained during the night.

He looked at the sky.

The clouds were far away.

"Again," he said without meaning to.

This was the third morning in a row.

On the first day he had thought some child had been playing there.

On the second, he had thought fishermen might have tightened the rope at night for support.

On the third day, excuses began to run out.

He reached out and touched the rope.

It was cold.

The lower fibres were still damp.

The upper fibres were almost dry.

Harinarayan drew his hand back immediately.

Fine river silt clung to his fingers.

The moment he saw its colour, an old scene opened inside him.

Nineteen years earlier the silt had been the same grey.

That night the river had been rising.

A red flag closing the ghat had been planted before evening.
But at half past nine the ferryboat Saraswati was opened for crossing.
There were fewer people aboard than sacks.
Twelve sacks of government rice.
Three sacks of salt.
Two boxes of medicine.
And seven men.

Boatman Mahesh Sahni had said, "I will not cross in this current."

A man from the block store officer's side had said, "The relief must reach by morning."

Mahesh had refused again.

Harinarayan, who was then the ghat clerk, had made a red entry in his register:

"CROSSING SUSPENDED."

But the boat left.

In midstream one sack slipped.

People rushed to steady it.

The boat tilted to one side.

The strong current pressed hard against the rope.

The old joint creaked.

The rope did not break.

But the boat swung beneath it.

Three men survived.

Four did not.

Mahesh did not survive either.

The next day officials came from the district.

Two sheets were placed before Harinarayan.

The first said that the boat had been sent out under pressure after the red flag was raised.

The second said that boatman Mahesh Sahni, tempted by private earnings, had violated the prohibition and opened the ferry on his own.

Harinarayan was told, "If the first page remains, the relief officer will be suspended, the entire store account will be opened, and a case may be made against you too."

At that time Harinarayan's son was in hospital.

The fear of losing his job closed around his neck like a hand.

He signed the second page.

After that, many things were buried.

Mahesh's family did not receive full compensation.

Two of the four bereaved families left the village.

Harinarayan remained in service.

And even nineteen years later, whenever he saw a wet rope, the ink of his own signature seemed wet to him.

"Babuji?"

The voice came from behind.

Harinarayan turned.

It was Bablu, son of the old ghat watchman.
 After his father's death, Bablu had taken up farming.
 "So early?"

Harinarayan said, "The committee says the old posts are to be removed. I came to look at the measurements."

Bablu looked at the rope.

"It was stretched again last night?"

Harinarayan's chest tightened slightly.

"Who told you?"

"Everyone sees it."

"Everyone?"

"Whoever comes towards the river in the morning."

Bablu added quietly, "No one comes here at night."

"So the rope tightens itself?"

Bablu did not laugh.

"People say Mahesh Kaka runs the ghat again at night."

Harinarayan's gaze hardened.

"A dead man does not pull rope."

Bablu kept turning his heel in the earth.

"Then a living man must be pulling it."

"Have you seen him?"

"No."

"Heard anything?"

"Sometimes a scraping sound."

"At what time?"

"Around two in the night."

Harinarayan fell silent.

Bablu left.

Harinarayan bent to inspect the knot.

He knew the old knot.

When the ferry operated, the rope went twice around the post and then formed a loop from above.

This knot was different.

Here the rope had been passed from below.

About two hand-spans above the ground there was fresh abrasion on the post.

The old ferry rope had been tied four hand-spans higher.

Whatever moved at night, therefore, used a lower rope.

Harinarayan walked to the riverbank.

There were no clear footprints in the sand.

But there were two long, thin lines.

As if some flat object had been dragged.

The lines ended in the river.

At that spot a small patch of oil shone like glass.

Harinarayan touched it with a finger and smelled it.

Mustard oil.

On old boats, mustard oil and ash were rubbed into the underside to preserve the wood.

Few people now knew that method.

He remembered Mahesh.

Mahesh used to say, "Oil saves the belly of the wood."

Harinarayan straightened.

Smoke rose from the sandy bank on the far side.

That was Dharkatta Tola.

In government records, the settlement had been marked "relocated" five years earlier.

The river had eroded the bank three times.

Twelve families had taken compensation and moved to higher land.

Nine families had not gone.

Some had not received full compensation.

Some had disputes over the new land.

For some, leaving their animals was impossible.

On the government map, the settlement was almost gone.

On the ground, cooking fires still burned.

The new bridge was not seventeen kos away, but it required a seventeen-kilometre road journey.

In the rains, the road grew longer still.

After the ghat closed, people on the far bank spent two hours going around to reach the market.

Harinarayan knew all of this.

But none of it, by itself, explained the rope at night.

He returned home.

All day he could not settle into his work.

At noon he opened an old trunk.

After retirement he had thought of burning many of the papers.

He had not been able to burn them.

At the bottom of the trunk, a copy connected with that accident still remained.

Not the official report.

A torn page from the ghat's daily register.

In red ink it said:

"CROSSING SUSPENDED."

Below it was Mahesh's thumbprint.

Then, in Harinarayan's handwriting:

"At the insistence of the store side."

Later, black ink had been worked over those words.

The letters could still be seen beneath it.

Harinarayan put the page back into the trunk.

After dinner his wife asked, "Are you going out again tonight?"

Harinarayan was startled.

"Who told you?"

"Your walking stick is ready by the door."

He did not answer.
 His wife said only, "The wind is strong at the old ghat at night."
 Harinarayan did not smile.
 "I am not afraid of the wind."
 His wife kept looking at him.
 "What you are afraid of is not the wind."
 Harinarayan picked up his stick.
 At half past twelve the ghat was deserted.
 The moon was behind clouds.
 The river sounded heavier than it did by day.
 Harinarayan sat behind the broken wall of the old ticket hut.
 The rope was slack.
 The posts were dry.
 He looked at his watch.
 One o'clock.
 Nothing.
 Quarter past one.
 A dog barked far away.
 Half past one.
 For an instant a light flashed on the far sandbank, then went out.
 Harinarayan held his breath.
 The rope trembled faintly.
 Once.
 Then twice.
 Then it slowly tightened.
 The post groaned.
 It was the same scraping sound Bablu had described.
 A shiver ran through Harinarayan's body.
 He told himself:
 A living person.
 The rope tightened again.
 In the darkness a low shadow moved across the middle of the river.
 Like a boat, but much smaller than a boat.
 There was no lantern at its bow.
 Someone on the far side was pulling the rope.
 On this side another shadow emerged.
 It came out from behind the ticket hut and reached the post.
 Harinarayan could not see the face.
 But he saw the movement of the hands.
 The rope was passed around the post from below.
 The same new knot.
 A small flat dinghy came to the bank.
 There was not a sack in it, but four bamboo baskets.
 Bottles clinked in one basket.
 Bundles of papers lay in another.
 The third held children's clothing.

The fourth contained not vegetables but small boxes.

Harinarayan stepped out of the darkness.

"Who is there?"

Both shadows stopped.

A woman's voice said, "Lower the stick, Harinarayan Babu."

He recognised the voice.

"Sudha?"

The woman came forward.

Sudha Kumari was an assistant at the health sub-centre.

She carried vaccines, antenatal check-ups, and medicines to Dharkatta Tola and the surrounding villages.

The other man removed the gamchha from his head.

Phekan Sahni.

Son of Mahesh Sahni's younger brother.

Harinarayan's mouth went dry.

Phekan said, "I thought one day you would see us."

Harinarayan looked at the rope.

"What is all this?"

Sudha removed the cloth from the baskets.

"Fever medicine. Iron tablets for two pregnant women. An asthma inhaler for a child. Some test slips."

"Government vehicle?"

"It does not go as far as Dharkatta."

"The bridge?"

"There is no transport at night."

Harinarayan's voice hardened.

"The ghat is closed."

"We know."

"This stretch of the river has been declared unsafe."

"We know that too."

"Then?"

Loosening the dinghy rope, Phekan said, "When someone cannot breathe, a prohibition board does not open the lungs."

Harinarayan stared at him.

"That is a very fine sentence. The river does not become calm by listening to fine sentences."

Phekan's face hardened slightly.

"I know this river no less than you do."

The sentence struck like a blow.

Mahesh's face flashed inside Harinarayan.

"Your uncle knew it too."

Phekan fell silent.

Sudha said between them, "This is no time to quarrel. Tonight's consignment has to reach."

"Consignment?" Harinarayan repeated.

"Do people cross too?"

Sudha did not answer directly.

Phekan said, "When necessary."

"How many?"

"No more than two."

"For how many nights?"

"Three months."

Harinarayan tightened his grip on the stick.

"Three months?"

Sudha said, "Since the rains began."

"And no accident?"

"No."

"Not yet."

Phekan turned his face towards the river.

Harinarayan asked, "Why only at night?"

Sudha said, "If we are seen by day, the administration will cut the rope."

"There is an order to cut it."

"And the alternative for the people of Dharkatta?"

Harinarayan was silent.

Sudha lifted a basket.

"On paper the settlement has been relocated. So no boat is sanctioned. The health vehicle does not go there. Schoolchildren must go around by the bridge. If labour begins at night, then God must help them."

"So you are making your own law?"

"No. Only filling its empty half twice a night."

Harinarayan felt anger.

Perhaps not at Sudha.

Perhaps at himself.

"Why does the rope stay wet?"

Phekan answered, "After reaching the far bank, we lift the dinghy. The lower part of the rope goes into the water."

"Why tie it low on the post?"

"The dinghy sits low. If we tie the rope high as with the old ferry, it will overturn."

"And the mustard oil?"

For the first time Phekan smiled faintly.

"Kaka taught me."

Harinarayan's eyes fixed on him.

Phekan's smile disappeared.

Suddenly the river curled in a small circle near the bank.

A floating leaf moved for a moment against the main current.

Harinarayan saw it.

"Reverse current."

Phekan nodded.

"At night, after the water is reduced at the upstream gate, a reverse eddy forms at this bend for about half an hour. We cross then."

"You time it?"

Phekan took a small notebook from the pouch at his waist.

It was not wet.

He opened it.

Date.

Water level.

Wind.

Load.

Number of people.

Departure time.

Arrival time.

Everything was written down.

In one place, in red letters, it said:

“CURRENT STRONG—CROSSING STOPPED.”

In another:

“TWO PERSONS—TOTAL LOAD WITHIN LIMIT.”

And in a third:

“ROPE FIBRE REPLACED.”

Harinarayan kept turning the pages.

He remembered his own old register.

Red ink.

“CROSSING SUSPENDED.”

And then the boat had left.

He returned the notebook to Phekan.

“Who taught you all this?”

Phekan said, “After the accident in which Kaka died, only one thing kept being said in our house: do not argue with the river.”

Harinarayan’s throat went dry.

Sudha asked, “Will you tell the administration?”

“I should.”

“Yes.”

Her easy answer startled Harinarayan.

“You will not try to stop me?”

“Why? A rule is being broken.”

“Then this night work?”

“The rule is being broken because the other half of the rule was never made.”

Harinarayan looked at her.

Sudha continued, “Tell them. But tell the whole thing.”

“The whole thing?”

“That the ghat is closed. That crossings happen at night. Why they happen. That Dharkatta has disappeared on paper, but people still live there.”

Phekan remained silent.

Harinarayan asked, “Are you not afraid?”

Phekan said, “I am.”

“Your boat can be seized.”

“It can.”

"You could go to jail."

"It can happen."

"Then why?"

Phekan looked into the darkness across the river.

"Last month little Rajni was bitten by a snake at night. If we had gone around by the bridge, it would have been morning before we reached the hospital. We brought her across in this dinghy."

Harinarayan said nothing.

"Did she survive?"

"She survived."

Somewhere in midstream a fish jumped.

The sound was small but travelled far through the darkness.

Harinarayan asked, "And the accident report?"

Phekan's face changed.

"Which report?"

"Your uncle's."

Phekan looked at Sudha.

Sudha slowly put the basket down on the ground.

Phekan said, "The copy we had at home was incomplete."

Harinarayan's heart began beating hard.

"What copy?"

"The carbon copy of the ghat register."

Harinarayan's hand slipped from the stick.

Phekan said, "It mentioned the red flag. It also mentioned the insistence from the store side."

Harinarayan felt as if the night wind over the river had suddenly grown cold.

"How long have you known?"

"For a long time."

"Then why did you never complain?"

Phekan took time to answer.

"Babuji wanted to complain. Grandmother stopped him."

"Why?"

"She said the proof was only half complete, and there was no one left to support the household. She used to say, 'Will clearing a dead man's name fill our stomachs?'"

Harinarayan lowered his eyes.

Phekan added, "I was angry before too. Less now."

"Why less?"

"Kaka will not come back."

He said it more softly than Harinarayan expected.

The softness cut deeper.

Sudha said, "Let us make tonight's crossing. Two households are waiting on the other side."

Harinarayan took hold of the rope.

It was taut.

He remembered the night nineteen years earlier when he had stood at this ghat and Mahesh had looked at him once before opening the ferry.

That look had not been a question.

It had merely asked for witness.

Harinarayan had not given witness that night.

Now he understood that penance for an old wrong could not consist of silently accepting a new wrong in the present.

He let go of the rope.

“Cross tonight.”

Phekan looked up.

“But not like this from tomorrow.”

Sudha asked, “Then?”

“Tomorrow I will write two papers.”

“Which?”

“One about the past.”

Harinarayan’s voice trembled.

“One about the present.”

No one answered.

Harinarayan sat on the broken bench of the ticket hut.

Phekan and Sudha placed the baskets into the dinghy.

Phekan tightened the knot.

“Load?”

Sudha said, “Forty-six.”

“Limit?”

“Sixty.”

“Wind?”

“Light south-westerly.”

“Current?”

Sudha dipped a bamboo pole into the water.

“The eddy has begun.”

Harinarayan listened to everything.

This was not carelessness.

But neither was it a safe, authorised arrangement.

Both things were true at once.

The dinghy slid slowly into the river.

Phekan kept pulling the rope.

Sudha held the baskets.

Near midstream the dinghy trembled slightly.

Harinarayan’s breath caught.

The boat from nineteen years earlier rose before his eyes.

But Phekan immediately eased the tension.

The dinghy slipped one hand-span downstream with the current.

Then straightened.

For the first time Harinarayan understood that Phekan knew how to read the river.

His fear did not end.

Its form changed.

When they reached the far bank, Sudha raised a hand once.

Phekan let the rope go slack.

Harinarayan stood by the post.

Night dampness settled again on the wood.

He did not go home before dawn.

Before sunrise Phekan returned.

The dinghy was empty.

"Sudha?"

"She will stay on that side. There are two antenatal check-ups in the morning."

Harinarayan asked, "Where is Rajni's house?"

"In the middle of Dharkatta."

"The girl who was bitten by the snake?"

"Yes."

Harinarayan nodded.

Phekan began turning the dinghy upside down in the bushes.

Harinarayan said, "Come to my house during the day tomorrow."

Phekan stopped.

"Why?"

"For your uncle's report."

Phekan looked at him for a long time.

"I do not want revenge."

"Nor do I want a way to escape by asking forgiveness."

Harinarayan said, "What was written was changed. What was changed will be written again."

Phekan said nothing.

The dawn light strengthened.

The rope became slack again.

At noon Phekan came to Harinarayan's house.

He brought an old tin box with him.

Inside were cloth, two old receipts, Mahesh's boat permit, and a carbon sheet.

Harinarayan took the original torn page from his own trunk.

The two copies were placed opposite each other.

On the carbon copy, the words "at the insistence of the store side" could be read clearly.

On Harinarayan's copy, black ink had been worked over the same words.

Phekan only watched.

Harinarayan said, "This black ink is in my hand."

Phekan did not look away.

"I knew."

"Who told you?"

"Your name was written on the black-ink bottle. Grandmother had kept it."

Harinarayan stopped.

Phekan said softly, "Villages are small, Babu."

There was no excuse left inside Harinarayan.

He pulled a sheet of paper towards him.

In the first paper he wrote that the written statement in the accident report prepared nineteen years earlier had been altered under pressure; that the actual daily register confirmed the red flag and the insistence from the store side; and that blaming Mahesh Sahni alone had been false.

He stopped after writing the word "pressure."

Phekan watched.

Harinarayan wrote again:

"Nevertheless, the signature on the final report was mine; I do not separate myself from that responsibility."

For the first time Phekan lowered his eyes.

The second paper concerned the present ghat.

Harinarayan wrote that keeping the ghat closed was justified from the standpoint of safety.

Then he wrote that a prohibition without alternative access was incomplete.

Dharkatta Tola remained inhabited on the ground even though it was shown as relocated in the records.

Unauthorised night crossings had been found to be taking place.

Private records were being kept of load limits, current timing, and weather, but these could not substitute for an approved safety system.

In the final line he wrote:

"Before enforcing the prohibition, a life-saving alternative crossing shall be made available immediately."

Phekan asked, "Will you write the names?"

Harinarayan stopped his pen.

"Yours?"

"Yes."

"If I simply write your name here, the first action may be your arrest."

"If you do not write it, then it is half the truth again."

Harinarayan looked at him.

It was a difficult question.

Nineteen years earlier he had chosen half the truth.

The half-truth had become a complete lie.

He wrote:

"Emergency crossings are being conducted by a local health assistant and a boatman; the names are provided in the attached confidential statement, on which action shall be taken in accordance with the safety review after alternative service has begun."

Phekan raised his eyebrows.

"Is that a middle path?"

"No."

Harinarayan said, "It is a way of writing both truths together."

"What if the officer reads only the first part?"

“Then I will make him read the second part again.”

The next morning Harinarayan went to the block office.

The new clerk was startled as soon as he saw the old accident papers.

“Such an old matter?”

“It is old. It is not finished.”

The officer first read the letter about the present ghat.

“Unauthorised crossing?”

“Yes.”

“The rope should be cut immediately.”

Harinarayan said, “Send a health boat first.”

“The rule—”

“I have read the rule.”

For the first time Harinarayan raised his voice slightly.

“Because of this rule, people cross the river secretly at night. Cutting the rope is easy. Shortening seventeen kilometres for a child who cannot breathe is difficult.”

The room fell silent.

The officer looked again at the old report.

“Why are you giving this now?”

Harinarayan replied, “Because even now a rope is being stretched at night.”

The officer did not understand the full meaning.

Harinarayan did not explain further.

For three days nothing happened.

On the fourth day the police came to the ghat.

A commotion rose in the village:

Phekan would be arrested.

But with the police came a small motorboat from the health department.

It was not a permanent solution.

It was an emergency service sanctioned for only thirty days.

The rules were set:

two crossings during the day,

and one emergency crossing at night upon a health message.

Whether Dharkatta Tola would be counted again as an inhabited settlement would be examined separately.

The old accident report was sent for re-examination.

Mahesh Sahni’s family did not receive justice immediately.

Paper moves more slowly than a river.

But this time the paper moved.

Phekan’s private dinghy was not confiscated.

He was warned.

Sudha was asked for a written explanation.

She wrote:

“There was no permission; there was necessity.”

Harinarayan remained silent for a long time when he heard that sentence.

A week later the committee came to remove the old posts.

The post on the right had half rotted away.

A labourer raised his axe.

Harinarayan said, "Wait."

Everyone looked at him.

He touched the fresh abrasion on the lower part of the post.

Three months of nights lived in that abrasion.

Someone's medicine.

Someone's examination papers.

A snake-bitten girl.

A broken rule.

Compassion.

He told the labourer, "Cut it."

The axe fell.

The first blow on the wood made a small echo over the river.

At the second blow the post shook.

At the third it leaned over.

The rope fell to the ground.

Harinarayan thought:

Nineteen years earlier, it had not been the rope that broke.

What broke was testimony.

This time the rope was being removed, but the testimony had already been written.

Phekan stood a little way off.

He came forward and picked up a small piece of the old rope.

Harinarayan asked, "What will you do with it?"

"Not use it for the dinghy."

Phekan said, "I will keep it at home."

"To remember?"

Phekan smiled.

"No. A rope is only a rope."

Then, tucking the piece under his arm, he added, "But one should remember how a knot is tied."

Harinarayan looked at the river.

The morning current flowed in its main direction.

Near the bank a small circular eddy was still moving backward.

A few moments later it too straightened.

That evening Harinarayan opened his old trunk.

He took out the torn page marked over in black ink.

Once he had hidden that page.

Now he placed it inside a transparent sleeve and wrote the date above it.

Before closing the trunk, he paused for a moment.

Then he did not close the lid.

He left the trunk open.

The next morning the rope was not stretched across the ghat.

The wooden posts too were gone.

But from across the river came the sound of the small health-department boat's engine.

Harinarayan stood in his doorway and listened.

The sound slowly receded.

His hand went involuntarily to his fingers.

There was no wet ink there.

THE BLUE GLASS BOTTLE

For seventeen years, the main door of the old dispensary at Belauncha had not opened for a patient.

Above the doorway, a brass plaque still bore faded letters:

“DISTRICT BOARD PUBLIC DISPENSARY, 1958.”

After the monsoon, lime had peeled from the walls in patches. Cobwebs were so tightly caught in the iron window grilles that even when the wind blew they hardly moved.

Before demolishing the building, the District Health Office wanted an inventory made of the old papers, instruments, and medicine containers inside.

Madhavi Jha was given temporary charge of the work for three weeks.

Madhavi was patient with records. Even when lifting the corner of a brittle paper, her hand did not hurry.

But on her first day inside the dispensary, the object that drew her most strongly was not a register.

It was an empty blue glass bottle.

The bottle stood on the second shelf of a locked cupboard.

Its neck was slender, its body rounded, and its base thick.

The label had fallen away long ago.

Only a grey trace of glue remained on the glass.

“Is this in the inventory?” Madhavi asked caretaker Harinandan Sahu.

Harinandan narrowed his eyes at it.

“There are many old bottles. What is special about this one?”

“Blue glass. Only one.”

“Then write it down. When the building is demolished, many such things will be thrown away.”

Madhavi entered a serial number for the bottle.

She locked the cupboard, pasted a thin paper seal bearing her own mark across the brass lock, and went home in the evening.

The next day the seal was exactly as she had left it.

The lock too was closed.

But the bottle was no longer on the second shelf.

It stood at the right-hand corner of the fourth shelf.

At first Madhavi doubted her own memory.

She opened the inventory.

It read:

“Empty blue glass bottle—Cupboard 2, Shelf 2, left side.”

She picked up the bottle.

A thin white crescent of dust clung to its base.

“Did you go inside?” she asked Harinandan.

“The seal is yours. How could I?”

“A second key?”

Harinandan did not laugh.

“One key is with me, one at the office. But the door cannot be opened without breaking your seal.”

There was about a hand-span of space between the back of the cupboard and the wall.

Dust lay so thick on the top that any hand touching it would have left a mark at once.

There was nothing.

Madhavi put the bottle back on the second shelf.

This time she drew a fine line in the dust directly in front of it.

On the third day the seal was again intact.

The line in the dust was intact.

The bottle was in the middle of the fifth shelf.

That was when Harinandan himself opened the old story of the dispensary.

“Have you heard the name Devkant Babu?”

Madhavi shook her head.

“He was the compounder here. Thirty-five or thirty-six years ago, fever medicine was distributed. After drinking it, many people developed stomach trouble, some got sores in the mouth, some began trembling. An inquiry was held. It was said that while preparing the mixture, the compounder had mixed in some cleaning liquid.”

Madhavi interrupted.

“A white cleaning liquid?”

“I do not know the chemical name. People then called it ‘strong water.’ Devkant Babu said the medicine had already been spoiled before it reached him. But there was no proof.”

“What happened after that?”

“He lost his job. Left the village. Five or seven years ago he came back and now lives here with his daughter. He cannot walk much.”

Harinandan looked towards the bottle.

“There were many blue bottles in those days.”

Madhavi tried to laugh the matter away.

But that night sleep came late.

She kept thinking:

If someone was entering the room, how was the seal remaining untouched?

If no one was entering, how was the bottle moving?

On the fourth day she examined the cupboard shelves carefully.

The wood was old, but the shelves were not equally level.

The third shelf sloped slightly to the left.

The fourth sloped towards the back wall.

She placed a small glass marble on the third shelf.

It rolled slowly and stopped in the left corner.

On the rear wood of that corner was a fine layer of lime.

Madhavi looked again at the base of the blue bottle.

The white crescent of dust resembled that lime.
But the bottle had been found yesterday on the fifth shelf.
Then she noticed something caught in the old glue-mark on its neck.
With tweezers she lifted it out.
Two extremely fine cotton fibres.
The fibres were new.
They had not darkened with dust.
At that moment Madhavi's fear changed.
She was no longer afraid of a ghost.
She was afraid of a person.
She requested the old office files.
Two days later a thick bundle arrived.

It contained dispensary expenditure registers, receipt registers, and copies of inquiry papers from 1989 to 1992.

The incident had taken place in Bhadon of 1990.

The inquiry note stated that "the possibility of an external liquid being mixed during local preparation" was strong.

Page three of Devkant Jha's four-page statement was missing.

A page from the receipt register for the same month had also been torn out.

Madhavi linked the two missing pages in her mind.

That was her first mistake.

She assumed Devkant himself had hidden the old papers and was now using someone to move the bottle in order to erase something.

That evening Madhavi went to Devkant's house.

The house stood half a kos from the dispensary.

There was a tulsi platform in the courtyard and an old neem tree beside it.

Devkant sat on a bamboo stool.

Age had taken flesh from his body, but his eyes were clear.

Madhavi introduced herself.

"I am making the inventory of the old dispensary."

Devkant's eyes rested once on her face.

"They are going to demolish it?"

"Probably the building."

"Breaking a building does not break what happened there."

Madhavi asked directly, "Do you recognise a blue glass bottle?"

Devkant's right hand became still on the bamboo of the stool.

"Many medicines came in blue glass."

"One empty bottle keeps changing places inside a locked cupboard."

Devkant did not answer.

A woman came from inside carrying water.

She was around fifty.

Harinandan had told Madhavi that Devkant lived with his daughter Mrinalini.

While setting down the glass, Mrinalini looked not at Madhavi but at her father's hand.

Madhavi noticed.

“Do you have any old dispensary papers in this house?”

Mrinalini answered immediately.

“No.”

Devkant said softly, “No papers. Only memory. Memory is worse than paper—you cannot tear it up.”

Madhavi returned, but her suspicion had settled on Mrinalini.

The next morning the seal was again intact.

This time the blue bottle lay on its side in the middle of the first shelf.

More cotton fibres had collected around its neck.

Madhavi did not disturb the cupboard.

Instead she began measuring the room.

To the right of the cupboard was the old medicine-dispensing window.

From outside it appeared to have been bricked up.

But inside there was a two-finger-wide gap between the wooden frame and the brickwork.

Fresh scratches showed in the gap.

At noon Madhavi went around outside.

Behind the bricks was a thicket.

Inside the bushes lay an old iron strip on the ground.

When she moved it, a thin wooden shutter lifted beneath it.

It was the old small delivery door through which medicines had once been handed out.

New plaster had hidden its existence.

The room could be entered without opening the main lock.

Madhavi told Harinandan nothing.

That night she sat not in front of the dispensary but in the bamboo grove behind it.

There was no moon.

Only when a vehicle passed on the distant road did light appear briefly.

Then the darkness thickened again.

Around ten, the bushes moved.

A figure bent and lifted the old shutter.

Madhavi waited a few moments, then followed inside.

A small oil lamp gave the room very faint light.

Mrinalini stood before the cupboard.

In her hand was the blue bottle.

A narrow strip of grey cotton cloth was tied around its neck.

Madhavi said, “So it was not a ghost moving the bottle.”

Mrinalini turned in alarm.

Her hand trembled, but the bottle did not fall.

“Call the police.”

“First explain.”

“What will explanation change?”

“For three weeks I have been trying to preserve the papers in this building. You are coming in at night through a hidden door. Explanation can change quite a lot.”

Mrinalini placed the oil lamp on top of the cupboard.

“I am not coming here to steal anything.”

“Then why have you moved the bottle across five shelves?”

Mrinalini remained silent for a while.

Then she untied the strip of cloth.

“Babu had kept this bottle at home. Three months ago he gave it to me. He said—if the dispensary is demolished, take this bottle and let it move across the shelves.”

Madhavi frowned.

“Why?”

“Because Babu had written that on that day the blue bottles were taken from their crate and placed on the third wooden shelf. That shelf sloped to the left. The bottles slid and rested against the lime-coated wood at the back. During the inquiry it was said there had been no such shelf—the medicine had been prepared at the mixing table.”

Madhavi looked towards the third shelf.

Mrinalini placed the bottle at its right edge.

She held the cloth strip in her hand so it would not fall.

The bottle rolled very slowly.

It moved left.

Tilted towards the back.

Then stopped in the lime-coated corner.

White dust marked only one side of its base.

A crescent formed.

“The first night I left it on the second shelf,” Mrinalini said.

“It did not move.

The second night on the fourth.

It moved backward, but no lime touched it.

On the third, it stopped exactly as Babu had written.”

“What does that prove?”

“By itself, nothing complete.”

Mrinalini’s answer came immediately.

“I have not come to have Babu declared innocent.”

That was not what Madhavi had expected.

Mrinalini ran her hand along the rear strip of the third shelf.

“Babu said that in the left corner of that shelf, one paper had been left behind. On the day of the inquiry, he did not have the courage to take it out. Later the cupboard was sealed.”

“What paper?”

“The counterfoil of a supply slip. It had the batch number.”

A chill passed through Madhavi.

“You have been moving the bottle for three nights to search for a paper?”

"First I wanted to make sure Babu's memory had identified the correct shelf. All five shelves look alike. If I tore up the wrong panel, the evidence of theft would be against me."

Madhavi lifted the oil lamp.

She examined the left corner of the third shelf closely.

Between the wood and the lime-coated rear strip was a gap as thin as a hair.

Mrinalini wrapped one end of the cloth strip around a thin piece of wood and tried to insert it into the gap.

"So that is how the new fibres got caught on the bottle," Madhavi said.

For the first time Mrinalini smiled faintly.

"I tie the cloth to the bottle. If Babu's bottle breaks, memory and evidence both break."

"Evidence?"

"Call it an indication."

Nothing came out of the gap.

Madhavi sat on the floor and looked beneath the shelf.

The wooden support on the left stood flush with the wall.

One patch of lime there was a different colour, as if a small section had been filled during an old repair.

She pressed it with a finger.

The lime flaked away.

A thin corner of paper appeared inside.

Mrinalini stopped breathing.

It would not be right to pull the paper out.

It had become brittle.

Madhavi decided to bring conservation tweezers and a flat support strip the next day.

"Come now," she said.

"We will take nothing out tonight."

Mrinalini asked, "You will not stop me?"

"From now on, do not come alone."

The next day Madhavi wrote a formal note to the office:

"Possible old paper located behind rear portion of cupboard; removal by conservation method required."

She did not write Mrinalini's name.

That evening Harinandan was present.

In front of all three, the loose lime was removed.

A folded paper came out.

Half of it had been eaten by dampness.

What remained legible was enough.

"SUPPLY—12 BOTTLES—FEVER MIXTURE—BLUE GLASS."

Below it, half the batch number could still be read:

"47-A."

The date was two days before the incident.

At one corner of the slip was Devkant's signature.

Below it, in red ink, a short note:

“Two caps loose; smell different—reported to officer-in-charge.”

Madhavi looked at that line for a long time.

“Why was this slip not in the inquiry?” Harinandan asked.

Mrinalini did not answer.

They needed to ask Devkant.

That evening Madhavi, Mrinalini, and Harinandan went together to Devkant’s courtyard.

The paper was inside a transparent protective sleeve.

For a long time Devkant said nothing.

At last he asked, “How many bottles does it say?”

“Twelve,” Madhavi replied.

Devkant closed his eyes.

“I opened seven.”

Mrinalini looked at him.

“You said the smell seemed different from the first day.”

“It did.”

“Then why seven?”

Devkant’s voice was very low.

“The doctor sahib said a new medicine might smell like that. Bhadon fever was spreading. People were standing in line. I could have stopped it.”

Mrinalini’s face hardened.

“Did you say this in the inquiry?”

“No.”

“Why?”

“After the first two patients became ill, I stopped distribution. But I changed the time in the register—made it appear that I had stopped before the first complaint. I wanted to save my job. The investigators found the discrepancy. After that they placed the whole blame on me. I did not have the courage to tell the full truth again.”

Mrinalini remained silent.

Madhavi understood that the newly found paper would not make Devkant innocent.

But it also became difficult now to leave the direction of blame resting on a single man.

The following week, the old files of the district store were searched.

The full page for Batch 47-A was not found.

But a circular from three days later had survived:

“Suspend distribution of the remaining fever mixture from the said batch; complaints received concerning smell and colour.”

The circular bore no receipt stamp from Belauncha dispensary.

Perhaps it never reached there.

Perhaps it arrived and was destroyed.

There was no answer.

In her final report Madhavi wrote that the 1990 inquiry conclusion could no longer be read as the only possible explanation.

The old supply slip and the district circular provided sufficient basis to consider that contamination of the batch might have originated outside the dispensary as well.

At the same time, the recorded time at which distribution was stopped had been altered.

Therefore local responsibility was not extinguished either.

Mrinalini read the report.

"You could have written that Babu was innocent."

"That would not be true."

"I know."

After a few moments she added, "That is why the report is right."

The decision to demolish the building was suspended for two months.

Three dispensary registers, the supply slip, the district circular, and the blue bottle were declared archival objects.

The bottle was now kept in a closed glass case.

Its label read:

"BLUE GLASS MEDICINE BOTTLE, CIRCA 1990; OBJECT ASSOCIATED WITH SOURCE EXAMINATION."

Madhavi did not write the word "evidence."

One day Devkant was brought to see the bottle.

He stood before the glass case for a long time.

Mrinalini asked, "Do you recognise it?"

Devkant said, "Yes."

"Is it the same one?"

Devkant looked at the crescent of lime on its base.

"It may be the same one," he said, "but I no longer have the right to say so with certainty."

That was his most difficult sentence.

Madhavi did not write it down.

She merely closed the lid of the glass case.

Evening was falling outside.

Light entering through the old window passed through the blue bottle and made a small blue patch on the lime-coated wall.

The patch remained still.

This time the bottle did not move anywhere.

THE KEY FOUND IN THE FAREWELL FOLD

It was the last day of Agahan.

East of Madhubani, beside an old pond, people had been gathering since morning in the courtyard of the Jha family home in the settlement known as Mehta Tola.

It was the day the house was to be divided.

The large front hall, the two southern rooms, the eastern kitchen, the mango grove at the back, the narrow path towards the pond, and the tulsi platform in the middle of the courtyard had all been measured and entered on paper.

Only the old inner room and its heavy teak cupboard remained unresolved.

Raghunath Jha sat on a wooden cot.

He was past sixty-five, but his voice still had the kind of authority that made people in the house fall silent without being asked.

His younger brother Nityanand had come from the city.

Their sister Kamala had arrived with her daughter Sangeeta.

On one side of the courtyard sat Raghunath's wife Malati, Nityanand's wife Aruna, and the younger generation of the family, quietly watching.

Their mother, Janaki Devi, had died two years earlier.

Since her death, division of the ancestral house had been postponed again and again.

"Let us finish it today," Raghunath said. "According to whatever has been written and measured. Afterwards no one should say the matter was left incomplete."

Kamala said nothing.

Malati glanced at her once.

The look seemed to contain the meaning of something very old, but Raghunath turned his eyes away.

Two elderly villagers were seated as witnesses.

Copies of the measurement register had also been kept ready.

Following the old departure custom, the women of the house were preparing Kamala's khoichha—the fold of her sari-pallu in which a married daughter was given rice, sacred grass, betel nut, turmeric, and a little grain before leaving her mother's home.

When Janaki Devi was alive, she always performed this ritual whenever her daughter returned home.

Malati lifted the fold of Kamala's pallu.

Aruna put in rice.

Sangeeta laughed.

"Mami, give two betel nuts this time. Nani always slipped in one extra."

For a moment that laughter loosened the hardness of a day devoted to division.

Malati released a handful of rice.

With it, an old brass key fell into the khoichha with a small metallic ring.

Everyone's eyes fixed on it.

Kamala picked up the key and held it in her palm.

"Where did this come from?"

Malati looked genuinely surprised.

"I did not put it there."

Aruna said, "It must have been in the rice bin."

Raghunath saw the key from a distance, and his back straightened slightly.

He knew that key.

"It is from the old storeroom," he said before he could stop himself.

Nityanand looked startled.

"The storeroom? That lock was changed thirty years ago."

Raghunath did not answer.

Janaki Devi's teak cupboard had once had a key of this very shape.

Its head was formed like a four-petalled lotus.

As a child, Raghunath had called it "Mother's flower."

After Janaki Devi died, the cupboard had remained locked.

Raghunath had said there were only clothes, old ritual vessels, and useless papers inside.

The key had not been found.

Kamala asked quietly, "Isn't this Mother's cupboard key?"

"No," Raghunath answered at once. "The teeth are different."

He said this without taking the key into his hand.

Kamala continued looking at him.

An old discomfort awakened inside Raghunath.

A few months before her death, his mother had told him, "Show the papers inside to Kamala."

Raghunath had cut her off.

"There are too many papers, Ma. I will see whose is whose."

Janaki Devi had said nothing more.

Now the last part of his own sentence rang again in his ears:

I will see.

Nityanand took the key and went to the cupboard.

The door of the old room was opened.

Inside was the smell of camphor, old cloth, and enclosed wood.

The cupboard lock had gone black.

The key would not enter.

One edge of its teeth was too thick.

"See?" Raghunath said, his voice harder than necessary. "It is not for this."

Kamala put the key back into her khoichha.

"Then let it remain. It must be some old thing of Mother's."

The partition resumed.

There was no dispute over the four mango trees.
It was written that the path towards the pond would remain shared.
The southern room went to Raghunath.
The eastern room went to Nityanand.
Kamala's name did not appear anywhere on the paper.
She did not ask for anything either.
After the midday meal the women went inside again.
Before leaving, Kamala said she wanted Janaki Devi's old tulsi rosary.
Malati did not open the cupboard.
She opened the small devotional chest beside it and took out the rosary.
When Kamala shook out the rice from her khoichha and separated the grains, the brass key was no longer there.
"Where did it go?" Sangeeta asked.
"It was right here."
Sangeeta sifted through the rice, paddy grains, and sacred grass.
Nothing.
This time Raghunath remained silent.
By evening the division could not be completed.
It was agreed that the final signatures on the last page would be done the next day.
Kamala stayed the night.
At dinnertime, something else happened.
Malati was changing her sari.
She lifted the pallu of the old red-bordered sari she had worn in the prayer room in order to fold it.
Inside the khoichha-fold was the same key.
This time a fine yellow powder clung to it.
Malati's hand trembled.
"Raghunath!"
Everyone came running.
At the sight of the key, Raghunath went pale like ash.
"Who keeps putting this here?" Nityanand's voice turned sharp.
Sangeeta said, "Someone in this house is playing a game."
Malati spoke softly.
"This is not turmeric."
She rubbed the powder between her fingers and smelled it.
"It smells of coriander and cumin."
Aruna looked towards the kitchen.
"The spice boxes are all closed."
Raghunath took the key.
The fine powder was indeed packed into the gaps between its teeth.
He tried to scrape it out with a fingernail, then suddenly stopped.
"Someone has taken out an old thing and is making a joke," he said.
"Who?" Kamala asked directly for the first time.
Raghunath did not answer.
No one in the house slept properly that night.

Leaves fell from the neem in the courtyard.

When a mongoose ran across the old tiled roof, its steps sounded from inside like footsteps.

Three times Raghunath got up and went to the cupboard.

The lock was untouched.

Even so, he kept feeling that someone inside was turning pages.

His mother's voice came back:

"Show the papers to Kamala."

At dawn he tried to persuade himself that with age, memory begins taking the shape of objects.

A key.

A smell.

An old sentence.

Together they can make the dead move through a house again.

But the moment he came down into the courtyard, the third incident occurred.

Aruna was arranging a sari for worship.

The same key was found in her khoichha.

This time the key was dry, but fine red chilli dust was caught in the petals at its head.

"Enough," Nityanand said. "This is no longer a joke."

All the children of the house were called into the courtyard.

Ten-year-old Anshu, Raghunath's grandson, stood silently beside the wall.

His eyes kept moving between the kitchen and the old room.

"Do you know anything?" Nityanand asked.

Anshu shook his head.

"Tell the truth."

"I did not put the key there."

"Who does?"

The boy was silent again.

Raghunath said sharply, "If you saw something, say it."

Anshu's eyes filled with tears.

"I did not see everything."

Malati called him closer.

"Say only what you saw."

Anshu spoke slowly.

"Yesterday afternoon I saw a hand."

"Whose?"

"I don't know. From behind the kitchen partition. There were red bangles."

Every eye in the courtyard turned at once towards Aruna and Sangeeta.

Both wore red bangles.

Malati's wrists carried white conch bangles.

Anshu continued.

"There was a small cloth in the hand too. Someone was rubbing the key."

“Where?”

“Near the spice shelf.”

Aruna rose angrily.

“You suspect me?”

Sangeeta stood too.

“I was with Ma yesterday.”

Kamala made them both sit.

“The child did not name anyone.”

Raghunath’s gaze remained fixed on Anshu.

“Anything else?”

Anshu thought.

“There was a black stain on one finger.”

This time everyone fell silent.

There was a third woman in the house who wore red bangles.

Nityanand’s widowed daughter Devika.

For the past three months she had been living in her maternal grandmother’s house.

There was usually a black stain of sewing-machine oil on one finger of her right hand.

Devika was not in the courtyard.

“Where is she?” Raghunath asked.

Aruna said, “She has gone to spread clothes on the roof.”

Raghunath stood.

Kamala caught his hand.

“First look at the key.”

“What is there to look at?”

“The teeth.”

The key was placed on the cot.

Kamala wiped away the powder with the edge of her pallu.

The right side of the teeth showed bright wear.

The left edge was almost untouched.

“If this is not for the cupboard, which lock keeps wearing this one tooth over and over?” Kamala asked.

Nityanand went into the old room and examined the outside lock again.

The key still would not enter.

Kamala went inside too.

On the inner left side of the cupboard door were three long scratches.

The outer lock was shut, but the scratches along the door edge looked fresh.

Pale yellow wood showed through the old surface.

“Were these here yesterday?” Kamala asked.

Raghunath could not say.

Nityanand touched the cupboard frame.

“Is someone trying to open an inner compartment?”

“There is no inner compartment,” Raghunath said at once.

Kamala turned and looked at him.

“How do you know?”

The question was very small.

Its effect was deep.

Raghunath’s throat went dry.

Thirty years earlier, while their father was still alive, a small secret compartment had been made inside the cupboard.

It opened with the key from an old wooden spice box.

The ordinary cupboard key was different.

Janaki Devi kept original land papers, jewellery, and some private letters inside that compartment.

Raghunath knew this.

He also remembered that one month before her death, his mother had asked him to open that compartment.

“The papers in Kamala’s name are on top,” she had said.

Raghunath had answered, “Whatever had to be given to a daughter was given at her wedding. Why create another quarrel between the brothers now?”

His mother had looked at him for a long time.

“A daughter does not stop belonging to the house because she is married.”

Raghunath had left the room.

He had never opened the compartment for her.

The memory came back complete.

Nityanand was speaking outside.

“Where did the key go after it disappeared from Kamala’s khoichha?”

Anshu said, “It went near the kitchen spice shelf. Then a small wooden box was brought onto the veranda.”

Aruna looked startled.

“What box?”

Anshu ran to the kitchen.

From behind the upper shelf he brought out a flat wooden box.

The box was empty.

Inside it were circular spice stains, and in one corner a polished shine where brass had rubbed against the wood.

Malati said, “This is Mother’s old spice box!”

Kamala inserted the key into the small lock-hole on the box.

The key turned easily.

The box opened.

There was nothing inside.

But on the inner face of the lid, in very old charcoal lettering, were the words:

“THE FLOWER OPENS THE INSIDE.”

Nityanand looked at the four lotus petals on the head of the key.

“The flower.”

Sweat appeared on Raghunath’s forehead.

Janaki Devi had kept the key to the secret compartment in this spice box.

The key had not been lost.

Someone had taken it out recently.

“Call Devika,” Raghunath said.

Devika came down from the roof.

She carried wet clothes in her hands.

Red bangles.

A black stain on the finger of her right hand.

Raghunath held up the key in front of her.

“Did you take this out?”

Devika first looked at the key.

Then at Anshu.

Anshu lowered his eyes.

“Yes,” Devika said.

Aruna stared at her.

“You?”

“Yes.”

“Why did you put it into the khoichha?”

Devika did not answer directly.

“If I had simply said there were papers inside, would anyone have believed me?”

Raghunath’s voice hardened.

“What right did you have to do this in the house—”

Kamala interrupted.

“Listen first.”

Devika sat at the edge of the cot.

“Two months before Nani died, she showed me the spice box. She said, ‘The flower key opens the wood inside.’ I did not understand what she meant then. Later, while we were sorting Nani’s papers, I found half a sheet. Kamala Mausi’s name was on it, along with the words ‘eastern room, one-third of the mango grove, pond path shared.’ The lower half of the page was torn.”

Kamala’s face changed.

Devika continued.

“I showed the page to Babuji.”

Nityanand was startled.

“To me?”

“Yes. You said, ‘It must be an old draft. Without the complete paper it means nothing.’”

Nityanand held his head.

“I remember... I did not take it seriously.”

“After that I thought of telling Mausi. But Nani became ill. Then she died. Later the atmosphere in the house became such that I remained silent.”

Raghunath asked, “Why suddenly now?”

“Because today the signatures would have been completed. After that no one would have thought it necessary to open the cupboard.”

“You could simply have given the key to Kamala.”

“If I had, you would have said it was some useless old key. Just as you said the first time.”

Raghunath fell silent.

“So the khoichha?” Kamala asked.

Devika’s eyes filled, but her voice remained steady.

“Nani used to say, ‘Never send a daughter away from the house empty-handed.’ I thought the key should first go into Mausi’s khoichha so everyone would see it. But all of you put the key aside. So I picked it up again. The second time I put it into Kaki’s sari. The third time into Ma’s khoichha. I wanted the matter not to be buried.”

“The spice powder?” Nityanand asked.

“The key was in the spice box. I did not clean it. The second time Anshu saw me rubbing the key with a cloth.”

Anshu said softly, “I did not see her face. Only the hand.”

Devika looked at him and smiled.

“You did well. It is not right to turn something half-seen into a whole story.”

Raghunath trembled at that sentence.

It seemed to him that the words were not meant for Anshu.

They were meant for him.

The cupboard was still locked.

“The main key?” Kamala asked.

Devika shook her head.

“I never found it.”

Nityanand said, “Then how do we know there are papers inside?”

“Because of Nani’s half-sheet.”

She took a folded paper from her cloth bag.

The paper had yellowed.

The handwriting was Janaki Devi’s.

Kamala recognised it at once.

Raghunath did not take the page.

“You read it,” Kamala said.

Raghunath reached out.

Kamala’s name was indeed written on it.

Below was half of their father Ramlochan Jha’s signature.

The rest had torn away.

A scene opened in Raghunath’s memory.

Three years before their father died, he had written a preliminary division of shares among all four children.

Whether a final registered document had later been executed in a different form, Raghunath could not say with certainty.

But Janaki Devi had apparently kept the preliminary agreement.

“This may be a draft,” Raghunath said quietly.

“It may be,” Kamala replied.

There was no triumph in her voice.

“I will not say anything either until the complete paper is seen.”

Her restraint made Raghunath feel smaller still.

By noon a carpenter had arrived.

Instead of cutting the cupboard lock, he worked a thin strip inside the old keyhole.

The lock was badly jammed, but after half an hour it opened.

The moment the door opened, the scratches inside became clear.

The main compartment contained clothes, ritual vessels, two brass plates, old letters, and a bundle of cotton.

On the inner panel to the right was a carving like a lotus flower.

At its centre was a small hole.

The brass key fitted perfectly.

Raghunath turned it himself.

A dry sound came from inside the wood.

The panel slid outward by half an inch.

The compartment opened.

Inside were three bundles of papers tied in red cloth.

On the upper bundle, in Janaki Devi's handwriting, were the words:

"ORIGINAL LAND PAPERS."

The second:

"KAMALA'S SHARE."

The third:

"COMMON THINGS."

Kamala did not reach for them.

"You open them," she told Raghunath.

Raghunath opened the first bundle.

Revenue receipts.

Maps.

Old sale deeds.

In the second bundle was a family agreement bearing their father Ramlochan Jha's signature.

It was not a formally registered will.

But it clearly stated that Kamala would have lifetime use-rights over the eastern room, one-third of the produce from the mango grove, and equal right of passage along the path to the pond.

Below were the signatures of four witnesses.

No one could immediately say what legal effect the document would have.

But its existence made one thing indisputable:

Janaki Devi's "papers in Kamala's name" had not been imaginary.

The third bundle contained written agreements concerning the shared well, the tulsi platform, the pond path, and use of the middle portion of the courtyard.

Nityanand took a long breath.

"Then today's partition register will have to be made again."

No words came from Raghunath.

Devika stood and began to leave.

Raghunath stopped her.

"You did not trust me."

Devika turned.

"I did."

"Then why did you not tell me directly?"

"Because you trusted your own old decision more than you trusted anyone else."

Raghunath looked wounded.

Devika continued.

"I am not saying my method was right. Taking the key without telling anyone, putting it into the khoichha—those were mistakes too. But I could see no other way to bring the papers out."

For the first time Kamala took Devika's hand.

"You did not merely save my share. You saved part of the house's memory."

Devika lowered her head.

Then Raghunath looked at Kamala.

"I was unfair to Mother."

Kamala remained silent.

"To you too."

"Yes," Kamala said.

One word.

No accusation.

No forgiveness.

Perhaps Raghunath had been expecting forgiveness.

Kamala did not give him that convenience.

"A lawyer will decide what legal meaning these papers have," she said. "But there will be no signatures today."

"No," Raghunath said. "Not today."

By evening the witnesses had gone home.

The pages of the measurement register were gathered and put away.

The courtyard slowly returned to the ordinary sounds of a household—utensils, hearth, water, children's laughter.

Devika picked up the spice box to wash it.

Raghunath said, "Let it remain as it is."

"Spices are stuck to it."

"Let them remain."

She began to put the key back into the box.

Kamala stopped her.

"Not yet."

Everyone looked at her.

Kamala spread the end of her sari.

Smiling, Malati placed a handful of rice in the fold.

Aruna added sacred grass.

Sangeeta put in a betel nut.

Kamala placed the brass key in her khoichha as well.

Raghunath's face tightened slightly, but he said nothing.

Kamala rested her hand over the key.

"After the papers are decided, this will return to the house."

Raghunath asked, "Whose house?"

Kamala looked around the courtyard—the southern room, the eastern kitchen, the tulsi platform, the shadow of the mango trees behind.

“That answer will not be given by the old papers alone,” she said. “We will give it too.”

A few days later, the family agreement was read again.

Legal advice was taken.

The old papers did not all carry equal legal weight, but Kamala’s use-rights and the shared path were clearly added to the new partition document.

A separate agreement was made for the produce of the mango grove.

No one called Devika a heroine.

Raghunath also scolded her for taking the key without permission.

Devika accepted that she should have made one more direct attempt to speak.

In the middle of the discussion Anshu said, “But I only saw a hand.”

Everyone laughed.

Malati stroked his head.

“Many times a half-seen thing opens an entire house, if we do not hurry to make it into a whole story.”

The partition was finally completed.

New boundary lines were drawn on the walls.

But the path to the pond remained open.

No single person’s name was written on the tulsi platform.

On the day Kamala left, her khoichha was filled once again.

This time the key was not in it.

It had returned to the compartment inside the cupboard.

A little fine yellow spice powder still clung to its teeth.

Raghunath did not clean it away.

As he closed the cupboard, he ran a finger once over the four petals on the key.

He heard no supernatural sign from his mother.

Only a small wooden sound from within—

the kind of sound a thing kept closed for a very long time makes when, after being opened, it closes again.

STORY 131

THE SMELL OF PARBOILED PADDY

The smell of parboiled paddy woke Nagendra Jha from sleep.

Midnight had passed.

The rear window of the house was open, and in the thin Agahan mist nothing could be seen clearly at any distance.

But the smell was unmistakable—

warm paddy,

wet husk,

and that particular mingling of steam which Nagendra had breathed for half his life at Sharda Rice Mill.

Still sitting on the bed, he first rubbed a hand over his nose.

An old body often manufactures the smells of old memories on its own.

He knew that.

The mill had been closed for five years.

The mouth of the great furnace had been bricked up.

A small peepal tree had sprouted on the chimney.

Rust had eaten the main gate so deeply that when the wind moved it, instead of ringing it made a dry rasping sound.

Even so, the smell came again.

This time warmer.

Nagendra got up.

His wife Sudha turned over and asked, "Where are you going?"

"There is a smell of paddy outside."

Without opening her eyes, Sudha said, "In a paddy-growing village, what else would you smell?"

"This is not from the fields."

After saying that, Nagendra fell silent.

The name that rose inside him after the sentence was one he did not want to speak aloud—

Bisesar Sadai.

Twenty-two years earlier, when the mill ran day and night, Bisesar worked at the boiler.

Thin-bodied, yet able to lift a hot iron strip with one hand.

On the day fifteen sacks of paddy were found short in the account, the owners had named him first.

Nagendra was the accountant then.

Weighing register.

Wage register.

Incoming and outgoing stock.

Everything passed through his hands.

What he wrote that night must still exist somewhere on paper:

“Shortage in night consignment; watch and boiler responsibility—Bisesar Sadai.”

Bisesar had said, “I did not take the paddy, Babu. If the steam ate it, how is that my fault?”

Everyone had laughed.

Nagendra had not laughed.

But he had not struck out the line in the register either.

He wrapped a shawl around himself and left the house.

The road to the mill was paved now.

Where bullock carts once turned beside the pond, there were now two grocery shops and a small pharmacy.

All were closed at night.

A dog barked once, then fell silent.

Mist made round halos around the yellow street lamps.

From a distance, the gate of Sharda Rice Mill looked like a black square.

Nagendra had seen the new signboard in daylight:

“MITHILA PADDY PRESERVATION CENTRE—MANAGER: REVATI CHAUDHARY.”

Revati, granddaughter of the former owner’s daughter, had returned from the city and bought the mill.

People said she did not intend to mill rice.

She planned only to dry paddy and operate storage sheds.

The gate was closed.

The smell was coming from inside.

Nagendra put an eye to the gap in the gate.

Darkness.

The old chimney stood still.

The bricked mouth of the main furnace was clearly visible.

No smoke.

Then he heard a faint “tap” on his right.

He pushed the small door beside the main gate.

To his surprise, it was not locked.

The first thing his eyes caught after he stepped inside was ash.

In front of the furnace lay the old heap of ash, grey by day but black in the night dampness.

Nagendra bent and touched it.

Cold on top.

Slightly warm underneath.

His chest tightened.

“The furnace is closed,” he said to himself.

A drop fell from the tin roof ahead.

Then another.

Small round marks formed on the floor.

There had been no rain for days.

Nagendra looked up.

Water gleamed at a pipe joint.

He recognised the pipe.
 It was the old steam line that had carried steam from the main furnace to the parboiling tank.
 It had not been used for five years.
 The smell thickened again.
 For a moment he seemed to hear Bisesar's voice:
 "If the steam ate it, how is that my fault?"
 Nagendra clenched his teeth.
 "Let thoughts remain thoughts."
 He moved forward.
 There was a fine trail of husk on the floor.
 The strange thing was that the night wind was blowing west to east, but the husk had moved east to west.
 Some particles had gathered near the feet of an old machine.
 Nagendra held his palm close to the floor.
 A very fine current of warm air was coming outward from deeper inside.
 A fan was running somewhere.
 The mill was not closed.
 Instead of relieving him, the thought made him more anxious.
 If Revati was secretly operating production at night, why?
 And if someone knew the old account, why conduct tests at midnight?
 A thump came from the storage room.
 Nagendra pressed himself into the shadow of the wall.
 A few moments later the beam of a torch moved across the floor.
 A woman's voice said, "Has the pressure dropped again?"
 Another voice answered, "Yes, Didi. Water is condensing at the old joint."
 Revati.
 Nagendra stepped out.
 "What is happening here at this hour?"
 The torch shone directly into his face, then immediately dropped.
 Revati started when she saw him.
 "Nagendra Kaka? How did you get inside?"
 "The small door was open."
 "Not open—it gets stuck. I have to have it repaired tomorrow."
 There was no irritation in Revati's voice.
 Only concern.
 "Do not remain here. The pipe is hot."
 "Hot?"
 Nagendra pointed towards the old furnace.
 "That is shut."
 Revati was silent for a moment.
 Then she said, "That is precisely why we are not running the old furnace."
 She took Nagendra to the tin shed at the back.
 Inside stood a small new steam unit on wheels.
 Beneath it was a narrow chamber for burning rice husk.
 A temporary iron pipe had been connected to the old main steam line.

“What is this?” Nagendra asked.

“A test.”

With Revati was a young man—Manoj, son of the mill’s old mechanic Ramphal.

He kept watching the pressure gauge.

Revati said, “Thirty-six sacks in the western godown picked up moisture. They look fine outside, but heating has begun inside. If we throw them away, the farmers will lose heavily. We are not fully parboiling them. We are testing a small batch with steam and drying it—how much can be saved, how much will break.”

“Why only at night?”

“In the daytime there are labourers, carts, dust. The pressure does not stay stable. At night the premises are empty for two hours. And if the test fails, why frighten the farmers with rumours before we know anything?”

Nagendra stared at her.

“Not secret production?”

Revati raised an eyebrow slightly.

“Did the smell bring you here?”

“Not the smell alone.”

Nagendra told her about the ash, the drops on the pipe, and the direction of the husk.

Manoj did not laugh.

He bent and stirred the ash.

“This ash is not old. The exhaust from our unit reaches this side and warms the old heap from underneath. We will have to remove it.”

Revati examined the pipe joint.

“And these drops are condensed steam. There is a leak in this joint.”

Nagendra had received answers to everything.

But the uneasiness did not leave.

Instead, every answer opened another door into the old night.

He asked quietly, “How much did the weight change?”

Revati looked at him.

“Why are you interested in that?”

“I am only asking.”

Manoj checked a sheet.

“In the first small batch, we started with one hundred kilos of damp paddy. After steaming, the weight rose. After drying, it ended a little above ninety-three kilos. But that is not a conclusion yet. We still have to measure the final moisture.”

Seven kilos.

Nagendra did not hear “fifteen sacks.”

He heard an old figure:

six maunds and seven seers.

A number from twenty-two years ago.

He sat down.

Behind the tin wall, the steam unit kept making its low sound.

Revati asked, "Are you all right?"
 Nagendra did not answer.
 He remembered clearly now.
 That old monsoon year, paddy in the western godown had become damp.
 Owner Harihar Chaudhary had said that before throwing the damaged paddy away, they would conduct a secret night test.
 If word reached the market, the price would fall.
 Bisesar and two labourers had loaded the paddy into the tank at night.
 The next day the dried paddy weighed less.
 The owner had said, "This test will not appear in the accounts. The shortage will be the workers' responsibility."
 Nagendra had objected.
 Very softly.
 "Malik, steaming and drying will change the weight."
 "Are you the accountant or are you teaching science?"
 After that one sentence, Nagendra had gone silent.
 "Where are the old account registers?" he asked.
 "Whatever survived is in the eastern room. Some rotted in dampness, some were eaten by rats. Why?"
 "I want to see them."
 Revati got up without questioning him.
 There were three wooden cupboards in the eastern room.
 New locks.
 The smell of old paper inside.
 Revati brought out the registers one by one.
 Nagendra's hands trembled.
 He remembered the year.
 2004.
 The last week of Sawan.
 The weighing register was not there.
 The incoming-stock register was.
 The wage register was.
 The furnace-fuel register was.
 On one page of that register was Nagendra's own handwriting:
 "Night use: zero."
 His throat went dry.
 Revati asked, "This page?"
 Nagendra remained silent.
 Manoj, who had followed them in, touched the edge of the page.
 "Kaka, if the furnace did not run that day, how did this soot mark get here?"
 At the lower corner of the page was half a black fingerprint.
 Nagendra closed his eyes.
 "The furnace ran," he said.
 Revati showed no reaction.
 "How much?"

“Two batches at night. A test to save damp paddy. The owner told me not to enter it in the register.”

“And the shortage?”

Nagendra’s eyes moved to the wage-register page where a red line stood against Bisesar’s name.

“The shortage was put against Bisesar.”

Manoj asked softly, “He had not stolen?”

“I did not see him steal anything. And the amount missing could have matched the loss from the test. I weighed it again. I understood the account did not add up cleanly.”

“Then?” Revati’s voice was low.

“Then I wrote that the furnace had not run at night.”

The smell of paper in the room suddenly seemed heavy.

Revati did not close the register.

“Where is Bisesar Kaka now?”

“He is gone.”

Nagendra’s voice dropped.

“He died eight years ago. His son is in Punjab. His daughter—Saraswati—is married in a nearby village.”

Manoj opened his mouth as if to say something, then stopped.

The whistle of the steam unit sounded from afar.

He ran out.

Nagendra and Revati remained in the room.

“You never had an opportunity to say this before?” Revati asked.

The question was not harsh.

Perhaps that was why it felt harsher.

Nagendra said, “I had many opportunities.”

Revati lowered her head.

“I was afraid the owner would dismiss me. The children were studying. I had debts. Then the owner died. I thought, what would saying it now change? Then Bisesar left the village. Then the years went by.”

“Does a line become lighter because years pass?”

Nagendra looked at his old handwriting in the register.

“No. Only the hand grows old.”

The test was not stopped that night.

Revati said, “If I panic and stop now, the farmers’ paddy may spoil tomorrow. Let us finish this batch first. The old matter can be decided in the morning.”

Nagendra had not expected that.

Some part of him wanted a large moral declaration.

An immediate punishment.

Instead, Revati checked the pressure gauge, recorded the moisture reading, and told Manoj to tighten the leaking pipe joint.

The damaged paddy of the present could not wait for the crime of the past.

Nagendra stayed.

Shortly before dawn, the second test batch was weighed.

From one hundred and twenty kilos of paddy, after drying, a little over one hundred and eleven kilos remained.

Revati wrote every figure separately:

initial moisture,

steam time,

drying time,

final moisture,

broken grain.

“Will you give me a copy of this calculation?” Nagendra asked.

“Why?”

“To keep with the old register.”

Revati looked at him.

“A new test will not prove the old wrongdoing.”

“No. But it shows that the old lie was possible. What I personally know, I will write separately.”

“Against yourself?”

“Against the lie I wrote.”

Dawn was opening behind the chimney.

The mist had thinned.

The smell of parboiled paddy still hung across the premises.

But now to Nagendra it no longer smelled of fear.

It was the smell of something which, once it enters a person, keeps opening the years in separate layers.

In the morning Nagendra did not go home.

He went with Revati to the block office to search the old revenue and inspection files.

There they found a copy of a mill inspection report from that same year.

It stated:

“No written admission from the worker is available regarding the alleged shortage. Matter settled internally at the owner’s request.”

“I had forgotten this line,” Nagendra said.

Revati replied, “Papers do not always prove guilt. Sometimes they show that guilt was never proved.”

Two days later Saraswati was called.

She was a woman past forty, carrying a bunch of keys from the school midday-meal centre where she worked.

The moment Nagendra saw her, he recognised Bisesar’s eyes.

Revati did not tell the entire matter in one breath.

First she showed the old register.

Then the figures from the present test.

Then Nagendra spoke:

that the furnace had run that night,

that the register had recorded zero,

that the shortage had been entered against Bisesar,

and that Nagendra had known the account was not clean.

Saraswati remained silent for a long time.

Nagendra had imagined she might cry.

Or curse him.

Or stand and leave.

She did none of these.

She only asked, "Will the money taken from Babuji for the theft be returned?"

Nagendra did not understand at first.

"What money?"

"The wages that were withheld."

Revati answered at once.

"Not at the old rate. We will calculate it at present value and pay it."

Saraswati stopped her.

"I will not take charity."

"It is not charity."

"Then first write that the theft was never proved."

Something collapsed inside Nagendra.

For years he had thought the truth meant his confession.

Saraswati's first demand was not about him.

She wanted the word placed before her father's name to be removed.

Revati said, "We will write it."

"Do not tear out the old register page."

"No."

"Let that line remain. Beside it, put a new note explaining why it was found wrong."

Nagendra looked at Saraswati.

"You want the page containing the lie to be preserved?"

"If you tear out the lie, people will later say nothing like that was ever written."

The room fell silent again.

Revati said quietly, "All right."

There was no ceremony on the day the mill reopened.

Only fresh paint on the main gate.

The old furnace section was left as an archive.

The new small unit was placed in a separate room.

A large part of the paddy from the western godown was saved.

Some had to be discarded.

Revati showed the farmers the complete account of the tests.

Nagendra did not take another job.

But once a week he came to help put the records in order.

From then on three pens lay before him:

red,

blue,

and black.

He was not permitted to strike out an old entry in red.

Blue was for corrective notes.

Black for current accounts.

One day Manoj asked with a laugh, “Kaka, why three colours?”

Nagendra said, “What was written, what was corrected, and what is being written now—if all three remain in one colour, confusion will return.”

Manoj said, “Write that rule in the register.”

Nagendra wrote it down.

In the last week of Agahan, the smell of parboiled paddy rose from the mill again at night.

This time the test had been announced.

Two farmers were present in person.

Revati was measuring moisture.

Manoj was watching the steam.

Standing by the window of his house, Nagendra smelled it.

From behind, Sudha asked, “Will you go to the mill again?”

He thought for a few moments.

“No,” he said. “What is happening there now is being written in the register.”

He did not close the window.

The smell kept entering—

warm paddy,

wet husk,

steam.

This time Bisesar’s voice did not come with it.

THREE KNOCKS ON THE ROOF

The first knock in the night was so faint that Shivnarayan Jha took it for the natural crack of dry bamboo and bent again over the register.

The second knock came exactly two moments after the first.

The third came two moments after the second.

Knock.

Knock.

Knock.

Then the school became as silent again as it had been since evening.

Three months earlier, this village primary school had been merged into the neighbouring middle school.

Lines of children.

Smoke from the midday meal.

The rush of the first bell.

Piles of slippers on the veranda.

All of it had suddenly become history.

The building was now under the panchayat.

In two days it was to become a temporary store for the health sub-centre.

Before that, responsibility for listing the old papers, broken desks and chairs, maps, and teaching materials had once again fallen upon retired headmaster Shivnarayan.

“Who knows these old registers better than you?” the letter from the block office had said.

Shivnarayan had not smiled when he read it.

He knew that recognising papers also meant recognising what lay inside them.

All day he had sat in the first room off the veranda sorting registers.

Admission register.

Attendance register.

Midday-meal accounts.

Building-repair papers.

Scholarship lists.

Sports-equipment receipts.

His hand had stopped on one old file:

“SPECIAL GRANT, YEAR 2008-09.”

There were three pages inside.

He clearly remembered that the file had once been thick.

He closed it at once.

Years earlier, the matter of that grant had spread through the school like fire.

Money had come for roof repair, two cupboards, books, and the veranda floor.

During the rains, the wall of one room cracked.

Shivnarayan had immediately allowed some of the grant money to be spent on that wall.

“We will correct the paperwork later,” the education committee chairman had said.

The paperwork was never corrected.

The original expenditure register could not later be found.

Questions arose during the audit.

Whispers gathered around the school’s clerk-assistant, Ramvriksh Sada.

The register had been under his charge.

Perhaps he had removed some papers.

Shivnarayan had not openly defended him at the time.

Because Shivnarayan knew that Ramvriksh had refused to sign false receipts.

He also knew that on the final rainy night he himself had sent the register towards the storeroom.

“Put it up on the loft. The water is rising.”

But later, when the register could not be found, he did not state that fact clearly before the auditors.

If he had, the unauthorised expenditure on the wall repair would have come to light.

He still remembered the day of the audit in every detail.

Two unfamiliar officers sat on the other side of the table.

The moment the register was mentioned, Ramvriksh rose and went towards the storeroom.

Ten minutes later he returned empty-handed.

“It should be on the loft,” he said.

Shivnarayan immediately replied, “That room has been closed for months.”

One officer asked, “The key?”

For half an hour they enacted the search for the key.

At last Shivnarayan himself said, “Perhaps the papers became mixed up during shifting.”

After that sentence, the direction of the questions changed.

Responsibility for the papers settled on Ramvriksh’s name.

Shivnarayan had told few direct lies.

But he had withheld the truth that was needed.

As the years passed, the difference between those two things seemed to him not smaller, but larger.

Ramvriksh died of fever two years later.

The accusation never reached a court.

But village speech often lives longer than a court judgment.

Again and again Shivnarayan’s eyes rose towards the locked storeroom door.

Its key had not been found since the school merger.

The new headmaster had said, "Tomorrow the carpenter will come and open the lock. Whatever papers are useless will be separated."

Shivnarayan had decided to stay that night because he wanted to complete the inventory.

At least that was what he told himself.

Three knocks came again from the roof.

Knock.

Knock.

Knock.

This time he counted the intervals.

The gap between the three sounds was almost equal.

Wind does not observe such discipline.

He lifted the lantern.

There had been no electricity since the day.

The moment he stepped onto the veranda, the wind moved the edge of his dhoti.

Thin clouds covered the sky.

The moon was somewhere behind them.

Peepal leaves stirred in the school courtyard, but not violently.

"Who is there?" he called.

No answer.

He walked around the building.

At the rear were bushes, an old hand pump, and an iron rainwater pipe.

There were no clear fresh footprints on the earth.

Workers had been coming and going during the day.

Shivnarayan raised the lantern.

The edge of the roof was swallowed by darkness.

For a moment he thought the gutter-cover had lifted slightly and settled back.

But when he held the light steady, nothing could be seen.

Beside the pipe, a thin black line marked the lime-washed wall.

He could not say whether it had not been there in the daytime or whether he had simply ignored it.

When he rubbed a finger over it, a fine green shaving of bamboo caught on his skin.

Why would a bamboo shaving be beside the pipe?

Two thick bamboo poles used by workers were certainly lying in the rear yard.

But this shaving was from something much thinner.

He set the lantern on the ground and tried to see upward.

Grey powder lay on one corner of the cover, as though brick had rubbed against it.

Even though there was little wind, the cover trembled once, extremely faintly.

Reason immediately offered him an explanation:

perhaps air was trapped inside the pipe.

But the teacher in him asked a second question:
 if it was air, why did it strike three times at equal intervals?
 He looked towards the place where the school bell had once hung.
 The bell had been stolen years ago.
 Only the iron ring remained.
 Once, the children's day had been divided by the discipline of sound:
 first bell,
 recess,
 dismissal.
 Now, in the silence of the abandoned building, even three knocks sounded
 like a rule.
 "A cat," he told himself.
 At once another voice inside replied:
 Why would a cat knock three times at equal intervals?
 He returned to the veranda.
 He touched the storeroom lock.
 Rusty, but strong.
 From beneath the door came the stale smell of paper, dampness, and mice.
 At half past ten, the three knocks sounded for a third time.
 This time, after the knocks, there was also a very faint dragging sound.
 Srrr...
 Shivnarayan ran outside.
 He reached the rear yard and raised the lantern.
 Nothing.
 But on the ground beneath the rain pipe, a small red thread gleamed.
 He picked it up.
 The thread was not new, but one end looked freshly frayed.
 He put his hand into the mouth of the pipe.
 Something soft touched his fingers.
 He pulled.
 The end of a thin rope emerged.
 The rope ran upward inside the pipe.
 A chill passed through Shivnarayan, but fear now carried curiosity with it.
 This was no ghost.
 Someone's hand was reaching the building.
 He left the rope where it was and returned to the veranda.
 He sat facing the storeroom.
 He remembered Ramvriksh's face.
 Thin.
 Dark.
 Eyes that always seemed to be measuring something.
 On the day of the audit, Ramvriksh had said, "Sir, I did not take the
 register. You know that."
 Shivnarayan had answered, "First find the register."
 The weight of those four words was still audible to him.
 Waiting for the next knocks, he remained awake until eleven.

Nothing happened.

Shivnarayan extinguished the lantern but did not sleep.

He watched the rear yard through a gap in the window.

Around eleven fifty, a shadow moved from behind the bushes.

Shivnarayan did not rush out.

Quietly he opened the door and stood in the darkness of the veranda.

The shadow reached the pipe.

Someone bent down.

The rope tightened.

On the roof—

knock.

The rope tightened again.

Knock.

A third pull—

knock.

“Enough,” Shivnarayan said.

The shadow froze.

“Whoever you are, come out.”

For several moments, only the peepal leaves made a sound.

Then a woman stepped from behind the bushes.

No shawl covered her head.

In her hand was a thin bamboo rod.

When Shivnarayan lit the lantern again, he recognised her face.

“Chanda?”

Ramvriksh Sada’s daughter.

Chanda now cooked meals at the neighbouring middle school.

She was around forty and usually spoke softly.

Looking not at Shivnarayan but towards the pipe, she said, “You were awake.”

“Are you doing all this?”

“Yes.”

“Why?”

Chanda did not answer.

“Climbing the roof at night? Tying ropes? This is a government building. What if you had fallen?”

For the first time Chanda looked at him.

“I did not climb the roof.”

“Then?”

She pulled the rope-end from the pipe and showed him.

“This pipe goes straight up to the gutter. The workers left bamboo lying there this evening. I pushed a thin bamboo up from inside. The cover above is loose.”

Shivnarayan still did not understand.

Chanda said, “Look.”

She pulled the rope slowly.

Something lifted above.

Then she released it.

One knock.

She pulled the rope a little—
the second.

Then the third.

“Why three different knocks?”

“There are three bricks.”

“Bricks?”

“The workers left three small bricks on the roof during the day. The bamboo bends beneath the gutter-cover. When I pull the rope, the edge of the first brick strikes the cover, then the second, then the third. The sound carries clearly inside.”

“You made all this?”

“It is not very difficult.”

Shivnarayan wanted his voice to become stern.

It did not.

“Who were you signalling?”

“You.”

“You could have spoken directly.”

Chanda did not smile.

“Babuji spoke directly years ago.”

Shivnarayan fell silent.

Chanda put the bamboo rod on the ground.

“I did not come to steal. I have not broken the lock. I want to save the register inside before it is thrown away with rubbish tomorrow.”

Shivnarayan’s throat dried.

“Who told you it is inside?”

“Babuji.”

“Ramvriksh?”

“A year before he died. He said the original grant register was on the loft in the storeroom. On the rainy night you told him to put the papers up high. He did. Later the room was closed for pest-control fumigation. Then the key was changed. When the audit came, Babuji kept saying so. No one wanted to open and search the whole room.”

“I...”

Shivnarayan’s words caught.

“I did not remember that it was on the loft...”

Chanda did not interrupt.

She merely watched him.

He did remember.

Not completely.

But enough to know that during the audit, the thought of that loft had crossed his mind one night.

If he had wished, he could have had the lock opened.

But the register recorded the unauthorised wall-repair expenditure.

The chairman’s order had been oral, not written.

Ramvriksh had refused to falsify the final expenditure head.

If the register had been found, the headmaster's administrative lapse would have come to light.

Shivnarayan had chosen silence.

"Why three knocks?" he asked softly.

Chanda looked towards the gutter-cover.

"When Babuji wanted someone's attention at school, he used to knock three times on the door. When I was a child, I understood—three knocks meant Babuji was standing outside."

The night suddenly became very old.

"Did you try to get inside?"

"No. If I broke the lock, then even if the register were found, people would say I planted it, removed it, altered it. I only wanted the papers to be opened by your own hands."

Shivnarayan wiped soot from the lantern glass with a finger.

"And if it is not there?"

"Then at least the story will end that we never even searched."

For a while neither spoke.

Shivnarayan did not sleep before dawn.

At five he telephoned the assistant at the block education office.

"The storeroom lock must be opened in the presence of an officer. No papers are to be taken out until all of you arrive."

"So early?" came a sleepy voice from the other end.

"Yes. Stop today's disposal list."

At half past eight, the assistant, the panchayat secretary, and the new middle-school headmistress arrived.

The carpenter cut the lock.

The moment the door opened, the smell of dampness drove everyone back.

Inside were a broken globe, an iron box, torn charts, two sacks of old books, and bundles of papers on the loft.

"Photograph everything first," Shivnarayan said.

"Touch nothing."

Chanda stood at the far end of the veranda.

She did not enter.

Five bundles were brought down from the loft.

Three contained examination papers.

One contained old admission forms.

When the cloth around the fifth bundle was opened, a thick register appeared inside.

Its edges were no longer new, but the letters were alive.

On the cover was written:

"SPECIAL GRANT EXPENDITURE REGISTER 2008-09."

Shivnarayan's hand trembled.

He did not open the register himself.

The assistant did.

Pages turned.

Roof repairs.

Timber.

Cupboards.

Books.

Then one entry:

“EMERGENCY REPAIR—EASTERN ROOM WALL.”

The amount had been taken from the head originally allotted for book cupboards.

Beside it was Ramvriksh’s handwriting:

“Oral order of Headmaster; revised approval awaited.”

Below was Ramvriksh Sada’s signature.

Then Shivnarayan’s.

After that came three original receipts.

Thumb impressions of two labourers.

One mason’s receipt.

The money had not disappeared.

The expenditure head had been changed.

A rule had been broken.

The report had been incomplete.

In one corner of a page, Ramvriksh had written in red pencil:

“Revised approval not received; place before next meeting.”

The matter never appeared in the meeting proceedings.

Shivnarayan remembered.

That week there had been news of an inspector’s visit.

Then a flood.

Then examinations.

What had been postponed to “the next meeting” remained postponed for years.

No single person owned the entire fault.

The chairman had given an oral order.

Shivnarayan had abandoned procedure and made an immediate decision.

Ramvriksh had refused to sign under a false expenditure head.

The office had never answered the request for revised approval.

But village stories prefer a simple answer.

The simple answer chose one name:

Ramvriksh.

Most important of all—

the register had not disappeared from Ramvriksh’s hands.

The block assistant looked at Shivnarayan.

“This will reopen the old audit objection.”

“Let it reopen,” Shivnarayan said.

“It is a very old matter. Adjustment papers—”

“Write what exists. Do not write what does not.”

He was startled by his own voice.

Why had he not been able to say such a simple sentence eighteen years earlier?

The assistant suggested writing a receipt note on the first blank page of the old register.

Shivnarayan stopped him.

"Do not write new matter in the old register. Attach a separate sheet.

Write the date.

The time.

Everyone present.

The room.

The loft.

And write that the register was found inside a locked room."

The panchayat secretary asked, "What about the matter of Ramvriksh Babu's name?"

Before answering, Shivnarayan looked towards Chanda.

She was still there, her eyes on the ground.

"The oral belief spread during the old audit that he was responsible no longer has a basis in this register," Shivnarayan said.

"Write that in a separate note.

And add my statement too—

I failed to have the room properly searched."

The assistant stopped his pen.

"You will give that in writing?"

"I will."

By noon, cloth lines had been stretched along the veranda so the papers could dry.

The sheets were placed one by one in the shade.

The vehicle bringing supplies for the health sub-centre turned back.

For one more day the building remained in the name of the school's papers.

Chanda quietly filled a bucket with water and brought it over.

Shivnarayan did not stop her.

After a long while he said, "Those three knocks last night... at first I was frightened."

Pressing a dry cloth against the damp corner of the register, Chanda said, "Sometimes fear opens the ears."

Shivnarayan had no answer.

Towards evening clouds gathered.

The first drop fell beyond the veranda.

Then another.

Then heavy rain began.

Water started dripping through one place in the old roof.

Chanda slid an empty bucket beneath it.

Drop.

Drop.

Drop.

Shivnarayan looked up involuntarily.
This time they were not knocks.
Only water.
He bent over the register again.

THE HEAT OF THE WOODEN CHEST

At one seventeen in the morning, Badrinarayan Chaudhary placed his palm on the chest again.

The wood was warm.

Not so hot that he had to withdraw his hand, but distinctly warmer than every other chest in the museum.

The sal-wood trunk beside it was cold.

The iron box against the wall was cold.

Even the door of the old manuscript room was cool with the dampness of the night.

But this square chest in the middle gallery gave off a warmth against his palm as though the day's sunlight were still trapped inside it.

Badrinarayan took his hand away.

The ceiling fan was off.

It was a Bhadon night, but after the rain the air outside had turned mildly cool.

The museum's thick walls did retain the day's heat for some time.

But why only one chest?

He brought a thermometer.

Without his spectacles, reading the numbers in the thin glass tube was difficult.

He placed it on the lid.

After a while the reading stopped near thirty-two.

The chest beside it was twenty-seven.

A difference of five degrees.

"Again," he said very softly.

This was the third night in succession.

For three weeks the district museum had been closed to visitors.

Roof repairs, termite inspection, and cleaning of the storage rooms were under way.

By day there were labourers, conservation assistants, clerks, officers—voices everywhere.

After eight at night there were only Badrinarayan, the outer gate, and the objects spread through the galleries.

He had been a guard here for seventeen years.

The first seven as a temporary worker.

After that, regular service.

Eight months remained before retirement.

He knew every corner of the museum—

which window seeped during the rains,

which cupboard door swelled,

beneath which statue dust gathered quickly,

which stopped clock still gave a faint metallic sound from within.
 But this wooden chest, familiar for years, had become unfamiliar.
 Its label read:

“Donation: Rajbanaili Family. Approx. nineteenth century. Mixed use.”

Inside were normally kept old garments, two broken wooden frames, and one brass lamp.

Nothing of great value.

Yet every time Badrinarayan stood beside this chest at night, he remembered an afternoon from nineteen years earlier.

At that time he was still a temporary guard.

The rear roof of the museum leaked.

The then curator, Ramanand Mishra, had wrapped a small bronze image in cloth and carried it out.

The object was called “Kamala-Kamalasana.”

About the height of a palm.

Recovered from a local excavation.

Date uncertain.

Ramanand Babu had said, “I will dry it at home for two days. If it stays in this dampness, it will develop green corrosion. I will make the outward-pass slip tomorrow.”

Badrinarayan had opened the gate.

Two days became four.

Four days became two weeks.

Then Ramanand Babu fell ill.

Three months later he died.

The bronze never appeared in the museum again.

An inventory inquiry followed.

Questions were asked.

Badrinarayan was asked:

“Did you see anyone carry an object out?”

He said:

“No.”

Only that.

The weight of that single “no” had not grown lighter with the years.

The more familiar the museum became, the heavier the word grew.

Sometimes he thought Ramanand Babu had truly taken the bronze away only to save it.

Sometimes he thought he had watched a theft happen before his own eyes.

His silence hung between those two possibilities.

Now, standing beside this warm chest, he kept remembering that cloth-wrapped bronze.

On the first night he blamed the heat of the day.

On the second, he found the courage to open the lid.

Inside were the old garments, the frames, the lamp.

Everything seemed ordinary.

He put a hand inside.

The bottom was warm from above.

He did not sleep that night.

On the third night he decided to find the cause.

With a small electric torch rather than a lantern, he knelt and examined the ground around the four feet of the chest.

There was little dust because the galleries had been cleaned during the day.

But beside the rear left foot lay a semicircle of fine grey-white powder.

He was about to touch it with his finger, then stopped.

During the day Conservation Assistant Tilottama Jha often said, "Never touch unidentified powder with your bare hand."

Badrinarayan lifted a little with a scrap of paper.

The smell was not sharp.

Slightly medicinal.

There was also a smell of neem.

"Pest-control powder?" he thought.

Something gleamed beneath the lower right corner of the chest.

He bent and brought the torch closer.

A very thin metal strip projected from between the wood and the floor—so thin that in daylight it would easily escape notice.

He did not try to pull it with his fingers.

The clock on the opposite wall showed one twenty-eight.

Rainwater kept dripping from the roof over the outer veranda.

Then he heard a very faint rustling from the direction of the storeroom.

He stood.

"Who is there?"

No answer.

Another sound.

Badrinarayan lifted his stick.

He was past sixty, but the old habits of night duty remained in his body.

He moved towards the storeroom.

The door was shut.

The padlock was in place.

Behind the window grille was darkness.

He turned back.

At the far end of the gallery something seemed to move like a shadow.

"Who is there?"

This time a woman's voice answered.

"It is me."

Tilottama stepped out from behind a pillar.

Badrinarayan lowered his stick slightly.

His suspicion did not lower with it.

"You? At this hour?"

"I left something behind."

"What?"

"My rain shawl."

"For your shawl you went to the storeroom?"

Tilottama was silent for a moment.
 "I had left it there."
 Her hands were empty.
 Badrinarayan said nothing.
 Tilottama read his look.
 "Were you looking for something?"
 "On guard duty one does not search," Badrinarayan said. "One observes."
 "Then observe."
 She turned and walked towards the wooden chest.
 Badrinarayan followed.
 Tilottama placed her palm on the lid.
 For one instant her expression changed.
 She immediately made it neutral again.
 "It is warm," Badrinarayan said.
 "Yes."
 "Why?"
 "Wood holds the day's heat."
 "The wood beside it does not."
 Tilottama gave no answer.
 "I have been watching for three nights," Badrinarayan said. "There is this powder beside the foot. There is a metal strip underneath. Do you know about them?"
 "We will look in the morning."
 "Why not now?"
 "Because it is not right to open it now."
 That sentence opened an old door inside Badrinarayan.
 Ramanand Babu's voice:
 "I will dry it at home for two days. I will make the slip tomorrow."
 He studied Tilottama's face.
 Recently appointed.
 Around thirty.
 Trained in museum studies, but working on a temporary honorarium.
 All day she dealt with mould, insects, torn paper, and old cloth.
 Officers listened to her advice less often than they used her labour.
 "If work cannot be spoken of in daylight," Badrinarayan said slowly, "does it become right at night?"
 Tilottama looked startled.
 "What are you trying to say?"
 "Open the chest."
 "I do not have the authority."
 "Neither do I. But the heat is not asking for authority."
 For a few moments both were silent.
 Then Tilottama asked, "Do you have the key?"
 "To the main lock."
 "Open the main lock."
 Badrinarayan's chest tightened slightly.

He took out the key.

The lock opened.

The lid rose.

Inside were the same old garments, the two frames, the brass lamp.

Tilottama removed the objects one by one.

The bottom lay empty.

“And now?” Badrinarayan asked.

Tilottama knelt.

She ran a fingernail along the inner left edge of the chest.

Nothing.

Then she removed a hairpin and inserted it into a tiny hole.

Click.

One panel of the bottom lifted.

Badrinarayan held his breath.

A false bottom.

Below lay a sheet of tin.

Over it was thick cotton cloth.

The moment the cloth was lifted, mildly warm air escaped.

At the very bottom were two bricks.

Red.

Warm, but not burning.

Wrapped in thick cloth.

Between them a metal strip spread the heat.

Above the insulating layer lay five bundles of old papers, two file covers, and a small wooden frame.

Pest-control powder had been placed at the corners.

Badrinarayan’s first feeling was not relief.

It was anger.

“What are you doing?”

“Reducing the dampness.”

“With hot bricks?”

“Not directly against the papers. Metal underneath, air space in between, cotton above. It is a temporary measure.”

“Authorised?”

Tilottama remained silent.

“So it is not.”

“When the roof leaked, the rear cupboard in the manuscript room became damp. Three days ago I submitted a written note saying the papers needed to be dried immediately. The curator said: first complete the full inventory, then relocate them. By the time the counting is finished, mould will be on the papers.”

“So you hid them?”

“I saved them.”

“Hiding and saving are not the same thing.”

For the first time Tilottama looked directly into his eyes.

“I know.”

The sentence was short.

But something in that short sentence stopped Badrinarayan's anger.

Tilottama lifted one document bundle.

"I needed this chest because air circulates inside it and insects are fewer. But I did not know about the false bottom at first. On the first night, while cleaning the base, this panel lifted."

"Then?"

"Then I found this."

From between the cloth layers she took out a very old brown sheet of paper.

The edges were brittle.

The ink had faded.

In the centre remained half the impression of a red seal.

Something emptied inside Badrinarayan.

At the top was written:

"TEMPORARY OUTWARD LIST."

Date:

nineteen years earlier.

Three objects were listed.

First:

two manuscript leaves.

Second:

bronze image "Kamala-Kamalasana."

Third:

small copperplate.

Reason:

"Excessive dampness; temporary conservation."

Destination:

"Residence of Curator."

Below was Ramanand Mishra's signature.

And beside it, in smaller letters:

"Exit through gate witnessed—Badrinarayan Chaudhary."

The signature was his.

He did not take the paper into his hand.

The darkness of the gallery suddenly seemed enormous.

"Where did you find this?"

"In this false bottom. It was trapped beneath the metal sheet. Perhaps it slipped there during some old repair to the chest."

"Did you show it to anyone?"

"No."

"Why?"

"First the paper had to be stabilised. It was not wet, but there were insect marks. Second—I did not know where the people whose names are on it were now."

Tilottama's eyes settled on his face.

"You know now," Badrinarayan said.

“Yes.”

“So that is why you came at night?”

“If I had brought this paper out in the daytime, half the office would have gathered around it. Someone would say it was proof of theft. Someone else that the curator was innocent. Someone would read your name. Someone would photograph it and send it outside. The original is brittle. I wanted first to make sure it did not break.”

“And you made that decision yourself.”

“Yes.”

Badrinarayan did not smile.

One corner of his mouth tightened bitterly.

“I too once suffered from the disease of making decisions by myself.”

Tilottama remained silent.

“That day Ramanand Babu carried the bronze out. I opened the gate. A slip existed—that is now proved. But later, when I was asked, I said I had seen nothing.”

“Why?”

“At first I thought it was only for two days. Then he became ill. Then he died. Then the inquiry. By then if I told the truth, the question would be: why did I not say it earlier? My job was temporary. I had two small children at home. I went silent.”

“Was the bronze found at his house?”

“No. At least it never returned to the museum.”

“Did you search?”

“No.”

There was more exhaustion in this “no” than in the first one.

Tilottama placed the sheet back on the cotton layer.

“This list shows that the bronze did not leave as an act of theft. But it does not say whether it came back.”

“And it also shows that I lied.”

“Yes.”

Badrinarayan looked at her.

He had not expected such simple agreement.

“You do not want to protect me?”

“I am protecting the paper,” Tilottama said. “Let the paper protect people by itself.”

Badrinarayan went towards the open gallery window.

Rainwater had collected in the courtyard.

Drops fell from one corner of the roof.

Far away, near the gate, the light of a bulb trembled in the water.

For how many years had he waited for some document to say that he was not a thief?

Now the document had appeared.

But at the same time it also said he had not been truthful.

Half relief.

Half punishment.

"Where do you get the warm bricks?" he asked.

Tilottama was slightly surprised at the change of subject.

"From the small stove in the rear courtyard. The labourers make tea there during the day. In the residual heat of the evening, I leave the bricks. When they are mildly warm at night, I wrap them and bring them."

"Every night?"

"Three nights."

"The key?"

"An old spare storeroom key was in the repair-material box."

"So you stole the key."

"Borrowed," Tilottama said, then did not smile herself. "All right—without permission."

"The pest-control powder?"

"Neem powder mixed with a very small amount of approved material. It does not touch the papers."

"The metal strip?"

"So the heat would not stay concentrated in one place."

Badrinarayan looked again at the false bottom.

Every clue had been in plain sight.

Warmth.

Powder.

Metal.

Night-time sounds.

The fear had been inside him, not inside the chest.

But understanding that did not end the problem.

"In the morning all of this will be put in writing," he said.

Tilottama's face tightened.

"If it is written down, I could lose my job."

"If it is not written, then it becomes the same mistake—"

Badrinarayan stopped.

"The same mistake again."

Tilottama was silent.

"I remained silent even though a slip existed. You are acting without a slip. Both our reasons may be good. But silence can corrupt the reason itself."

"The paper is still brittle. In the morning everyone will touch it."

"Then first prepare a conservation note. Write which sheets, their condition, the temperature, the measure taken. Write your decision too. I will write my statement separately."

"You will write about your old matter as well?"

Badrinarayan took time to answer.

"Yes."

Tilottama put a hand on the false bottom.

"Shall I remove the bricks now? Too much heat is not good."

"Remove them."

Together they took the bricks out.

When the cloth was opened, there was only the ordinary smell of earth.

No mystery.

Badrinarayan found it strange that the heat which had frightened him for three nights had come from only two red bricks.

Tilottama placed the papers separately on a flat board.

Before touching the old list, Badrinarayan put on cotton gloves.

He looked at his signature again.

The letters were young.

The hand had been steady.

"I made this signature," he said.

"That is good," Tilottama said.

"Why?"

"Because at least the exit was witnessed. What happened afterwards can still be searched for."

"And my lie?"

"That can be written too."

For the first time Badrinarayan smiled faintly.

"You are a person of papers."

"Are papers not of people?"

"Sometimes people become the property of papers."

Until four in the morning, they made an inventory of the damp-affected sheets.

Tilottama recorded temperatures with the thermometer.

Badrinarayan wrote down the measurements of the chest's false bottom.

The old list received separate cloth and separate backing.

At five ten, Badrinarayan began his statement.

The first line was difficult.

"Date..."

He stopped.

Then he wrote:

"Nineteen years ago, when the then Curator Ramanand Mishra removed three objects from the museum for temporary conservation, I was present at the gate."

Up to that point his hand remained steady.

On the next line, the pen trembled.

"In the subsequent inquiry, I denied this fact."

He stared at the paper for a long time.

Tilottama did not look at him.

She was sliding cloth beneath the broken corner of another sheet.

Badrinarayan wrote the next line:

"I bear responsibility for that silence."

That was all.

No explanation.

Children.

Temporary employment.

Fear.

All were true.

Their names could be written later if necessary.

The first sentence had to be about responsibility.

When Curator Prabhakar Thakur arrived in the morning, he saw the chest open in the gallery and immediately became angry.

“What is going on here?”

Tilottama stood.

“Emergency conservation was carried out at night. The written record is prepared.”

“Whose permission?”

“No one’s.”

“Do you understand this violates service rules?”

“Yes.”

Prabhakar turned towards Badrinarayan.

“And you?”

Badrinarayan extended his statement.

“I was on guard duty. I did not stop her. Then I inspected the matter. This is my statement. And this old outward list was found.”

The moment Prabhakar read it, he fell silent.

His finger stopped at the name Kamala-Kamalasana.

“Where was this?”

“In the false bottom of the chest,” Tilottama said.

“Who has seen it?”

“You are the third person.”

Prabhakar read Badrinarayan’s statement.

After a few moments he pulled over a chair and sat.

“This will have to go before the committee.”

“It will,” Badrinarayan said.

“You understand the old inquiry may reopen?”

“It may.”

“And your own statement will raise questions about you.”

“Let it.”

Prabhakar looked at Tilottama.

“Warm bricks?”

Tilottama explained the entire arrangement.

Prabhakar held his head.

“In the name of saving paper, will you set the museum on fire?”

“Not fire. The temperature was measured. But I accept that I acted without written permission.”

“From today this method stops.”

“All right.”

“And a separate room will be prepared for damp-affected papers.”

Tilottama said nothing.

But her face relaxed.

By noon, word had spread through the museum.

Some said a clue to the missing bronze had been found.

Some said the old guard himself had confessed.

Some called Tilottama courageous.

Others called her undisciplined.

Badrinarayan heard everything.

He offered no defence.

By evening the committee sealed the old list in a protective envelope.

They decided to search for the old address of Ramanand Mishra's family.

Assistance would be requested from the university conservation laboratory.

A written warning would be issued regarding Tilottama's night-time action, but her immediate effort to save damp-affected papers would also be recorded.

No decision was completely clean.

Kamala-Kamalasana was still missing.

Badrinarayan had not been proved innocent.

Tilottama's method had not been declared proper.

But three things were no longer hidden:

the object had left the museum,

Badrinarayan had seen it leave,

and in the warm chest at night there had been no theft—only an incomplete attempt at preservation.

That night, at one seventeen, Badrinarayan went to the gallery again.

The chest was closed.

A paper label had been tied to the main lock:

"TEMPORARILY NOT TO BE USED; FALSE BOTTOM RECORDED."

He placed his palm on the lid.

The wood was cold.

For a few moments he kept his hand there.

Whether he felt relief or regret, he could not tell.

The clock on the wall moved to one eighteen.

Badrinarayan took his hand away.

The heat of the chest was gone.

Whatever heat remained had been entered into the record.

STORY 134

THE KNOCKING INSIDE THE MUD WALL

The rain had stopped three days earlier, but the rear wall of the old house was still damp.

After dinner, Niranjan Mishra sat on a cot laid out in the courtyard.

The electricity had failed again.

The lantern flame had grown small, and drops of water kept falling from the leaves of the mango tree onto the same spot again and again.

Then two sounds came from inside the wall—

knock... knock.

He raised his head and listened.

Nothing more.

From inside, his wife Malati asked, "What happened?"

"Nothing. The bamboo must be drying."

He answered, but his own voice sounded unfamiliar to him.

This house dated from the time of Niranjan's great-grandfather.

Thick mud walls.

A lattice of bamboo within.

Lime and clay plaster outside.

One wall of the rear room was thicker than all the others.

When he was a child, he had been told that there had once been a recessed niche inside that wall where old decorative designs were made, and that the hollow had later been filled.

But Niranjan remembered something else as well.

Twenty-two years earlier, during the division of the family land, his father Gangadhar Mishra and his younger uncle Nageshwar had quarrelled in this very room.

The next day the amin came.

A rope was stretched.

Pegs were driven into the ground.

And two kathas of land on the western side were entered in Gangadhar's share.

For a long time afterwards Nageshwar kept saying that the measurement was wrong.

After that, the subject was closed inside the family.

Nageshwar died five years earlier.

His daughter Anima lived in the city.

The previous month she had suddenly come to the village, saying only that she had wanted to see the old house.

When Niranjan heard the knocking that night, his thoughts went straight there.

The next morning he examined the wall.

Nothing showed on the damp plaster.

Near the bottom were two small holes that looked like rat burrows.

At one place a little earth had crumbled away.

Malati said, "It is an old wall. Rats and cats will live in it. Leave the night's matter with the night."

Niranjan smiled faintly and went inside, but all day he could not keep his mind on the fields.

In the evening he had everything removed from the rear room.

An old low stool.

Two bamboo seats.

An empty grain bin.

And an iron lamp from his grandmother's time.

When the wall stood bare, a slight swelling could be seen in the middle.

He tapped it with his knuckle.

Most of the wall gave a solid sound.

At one place the sound was thinner—

tuk.

Beside that exact spot was a mark like a black line.

Niranjan brought the lamp closer.

The line was a scratch.

Not straight.

Slightly crooked, as though some thin tool had been inserted into the mud.

Malati's face became serious.

"A rat did not make this."

Niranjan gave no answer.

That night the electricity failed again.

This time he did not sit on the cot.

He remained inside the rear room.

Instead of a torch, he held a small oil lamp.

The clock showed eleven forty-five.

At first the house remained quiet.

At midnight wind moved over the roof.

The old bamboo creaked.

At twelve seven—

knock.

Niranjan went still.

A moment later—

knock.

The sounds came from the exact hollow section.

He put his ear to the wall.

Something seemed to scrape inside.

He immediately opened the door and went outside.

The rear courtyard was dark.

On the other side of the wall ran a narrow passage, beyond which lay his uncle's old portion of the house.

That section was now usually kept closed because Anima had returned to the city and the key was with her cousin Ratnesh.

There was no one in the narrow passage.

The earth was wet.

Niranjan looked for footprints.

Apart from one or two old sandal marks, there was nothing new.

In the morning he called Ratnesh.

Ratnesh laughed.

“Dada, if an old house does not knock, will it sing?”

“Open the room in your share.”

Ratnesh fell quiet for a moment, then brought the key.

The room on that side was smaller than Niranjan’s.

Against the rear of the wall were an old wooden chest, a broken cot, and a sack of cow-dung cakes.

Ratnesh kept moving the things away.

At the exact point where Niranjan had heard the hollow sound, a vertical piece of bamboo was half embedded in the wall.

The bamboo was very old.

Its upper part had dried and split.

Ratnesh said, “See? This bamboo must be moving. When the wind comes, it knocks.”

Niranjan shook the bamboo by hand.

A faint sound came, but not like the two distinct knocks of the night.

He bent lower.

Beside the bamboo, on the earth, lay fine white dust.

Dust from an old mud wall is yellow-brown.

This was white.

He took some on a fingertip and smelled it.

Lime.

“Someone has scraped here recently,” he said.

Ratnesh stopped smiling.

“Why would anyone scrape here?”

Niranjan looked at him.

“That is what I too want to know.”

That day Niranjan went to Budhan, an old mason in the village.

Budhan was past eighty, but his eyes were still sharp.

When he heard about the wall, he nodded slowly.

“I did not build that wall,” he said. “My father did. But once I came during a repair. In the middle there was a square raw-clay hollow, something like a recess. Old people made them to keep papers.”

“How large?”

“A hand or two. But later it was filled with earth.”

“Who filled it?”

Budhan closed his eyes, searching his memory.

“Your father Gangadhar said an empty cavity weakened the wall. Nageshwar was there too. The two brothers. I only remember that before it was filled, some papers were taken out.”

Niranjan’s chest grew heavy.

“What papers?”

“How would I know? I was hardly literate. They were wrapped in red cloth.”

All the way home Niranjan thought about that red cloth.

His father Gangadhar had died ten years earlier.

Near the end he spoke very little.

Once Niranjan had raised the matter of the land papers.

His father had said only this:

“Where the pegs were driven, that is the boundary. A house does not run by digging up old matters.”

At the time Niranjan had taken the sentence in an ordinary way.

Now he did not.

There was no knocking that night.

None on the third night either.

On the fourth night, Niranjan deliberately locked the rear room from outside but left one panel of the window open.

He stayed in the sleeping room with Malati.

After midnight Malati nudged him with her elbow.

“Listen.”

Knock.

A few moments.

Knock.

Niranjan got up.

This time he did not go directly to the narrow passage.

First he took the torch from the veranda, then left through the front door, walked around his uncle’s section, and came into the rear passage from the other side.

Someone was bent there in the dark.

The moment the torchlight fell, the figure stood up.

Anima.

For a moment Niranjan could not speak.

Anima held a thin iron rod in one hand.

Her other hand was smeared with earth.

“You?” Niranjan said at last.

Anima remained silent for a few moments.

“First lower the torch.”

“You are scraping my wall at night?”

“The wall was half on your side and half on my father’s side.”

“That is not an answer.”

“Then come inside. We will not talk in the passage.”

They went into Ratnesh’s room.

From her bag Anima took out a photocopy of an old paper.

The edges were worn.

At the top were the amin's name, a date, and copies of three witnesses' signatures.

"Where did you get this?" Niranjan asked.

"In Babu's old box. It is not complete. Only half a sheet."

The paper showed a land measurement line, but the western portion had been cut away.

At the bottom, in Nageshwar's handwriting, were two words:

"Original measurement—wall."

Niranjan stared at the paper for a long time.

Anima said, "The first day I came openly to look. You remember? I said I wanted to see the house."

"You said nothing."

"What would I have said? All his life Babu kept saying the measurement paper had been changed. Everyone in the village thought him greedy. If I came again with the same claim, I needed the paper first."

"And the knocking?"

"I was pushing the rod inside. There is an old bamboo lattice in the wall. When the rod strikes it, the bamboo knocks against the other side of the wall."

"Why at night?"

Anima lowered her eyes.

"If I did it by day, five people would gather. First I wanted to be certain there was something inside."

Niranjan was still angry.

"You planned to break the wall?"

"No. If I found a small opening, only that much."

"And if you found papers?"

Anima took a long time before answering.

"First I would read them. Then we would see what was true."

"Take back the land?"

Anima looked directly at him.

"Before the land, I want my father's name back."

The sentence struck Niranjan because his father Gangadhar's face rose before him.

The next morning the wall was not broken.

Budhan was called again.

He said it would be unsafe to open an old mud wall without support.

He placed two temporary bamboo props, then the plaster was slowly scraped away from the scratched place.

First layer:

mud.

Second layer:

lime.

Behind it:

an old flat clay tile.

The left corner of the tile sounded unusually hollow.

Budhan loosened the edge with a small hammer.

When the tile came out, the stale smell of enclosed earth emerged from within.

The cavity was very small.

Not a place for jewellery.

Inside were thin bamboo strips, and between them was a small bundle of red cloth whose colour had almost completely faded.

Niranjan's hands began to tremble.

Budhan took the bundle out and placed it on a low stool.

Before opening it, Anima wiped her hands on the end of her sari.

Inside the cloth were four folded sheets.

Two had been eaten by insects.

One contained a measurement diagram.

One bore the amin's writing.

Malati said softly, "Let them dry first. If we open damp paper, it will tear."

Everyone fell silent.

The papers were placed in the shade of the veranda to dry.

Niranjan did not want to move away from them all day.

Anima sat at a distance.

By evening the writing had become somewhat clearer.

On the measurement sheet, the western portion of the house land was divided in two.

But the line lay about five hands east of the present field boundary.

By that measurement, part of the land now within Gangadhar's share belonged in Nageshwar's share.

But the paper contained something else too.

At the bottom, the amin had written that by oral agreement the two brothers would leave the narrow western strip as a shared passage because it was the only route to the pond behind the house.

The present boundary had absorbed that common passage into Gangadhar's field.

Niranjan's first thought was:

How legally valid could this paper be?

Old.

Unregistered.

Half decayed.

Then came his second thought:

Why had his father left this paper inside the wall?

The answer was on another sheet.

Gangadhar's handwriting.

Very small.

Only four lines.

"In the new measurement, the western strip fell too far on my side. Nageshwar objected. In the crowd before the panchayat, the matter was

stopped. I am keeping the original measurement here. When there is peace in the house again, we will correct it.”

The date was two days after the division.

The correction never happened.

Niranjan could not lift his eyes from the page.

Anima too said nothing.

Ratnesh, who had been standing by a veranda pillar until then, slowly sat down.

Packing his tools, Budhan asked, “Shall I close the opening in the wall again or leave it?”

“Leave it for now,” Niranjan said. “Let air reach inside.”

No one discussed the land division during dinner.

Malati merely changed the dry cloth beneath the papers.

At midnight Niranjan woke again.

The house was quiet.

He went to the rear room.

The hollow remained open.

A strip of bamboo inside had dried slightly in the air and shifted.

Knock.

Niranjan stood still and listened.

A few moments later the bamboo touched the earth again.

Knock.

This time he was not afraid.

In the morning Anima was preparing to leave.

Niranjan gathered the papers spread on the veranda and placed them before her.

“The originals will remain here,” he said. “Copies will be made in the names of both households.”

Anima looked at him but said nothing.

After a moment Niranjan added, “We will call the amin as well. First we will see the measurement.”

Anima’s eyes filled, but she turned her face away and began straightening the corner of the paper.

By noon the opening in the wall was covered temporarily with wood.

Budhan said full repair should wait until after the new measurement.

Niranjan agreed.

Three days later the amin came.

The old papers, the current land record, and the actual boundary on the ground were all examined.

No immediate decision was made.

The question of five hands of land was not simple.

Registration.

Inheritance.

Shared passage.

Each required separate examination.

But from that day Niranjan did not plough the narrow strip leading towards the pond.

Ratnesh drove a small bamboo peg into the old boundary so that the line would remain visible until the measurement was completed.

Anima returned to the city.

The wall was repaired two weeks later.

Budhan did not completely fill the old cavity.

A small wooden box was fitted inside, and the original measurement papers were placed there between acid-free cloth.

Two keys were made for the box—

one for Niranjan,

one for Anima.

No one called the arrangement a reconciliation.

No one said the old dispute had ended either.

Only this much was now clear:

the papers had a known place inside the wall.

On the first night after the repair, Niranjan stayed awake for a long time.

There was no knocking.

None on the second night either.

On the third night the wind was strong.

The bamboo of the roof creaked.

Mango leaves rubbed against one another.

The old outer door slammed once.

Niranjan listened with his eyes closed.

The wall remained silent.

For the first time he understood that sometimes a sound does not come from inside the wall.

Sometimes it comes from both sides of it.

STORY 135

THE TURNING SEAL

By five in the evening, the veranda of the Bisnapur Panchayat Office was usually almost empty.

In the rainy season that emptiness felt even denser.

Water kept drumming on the tin roof, and inside, the smell of old papers mingled with damp walls to create a peculiar odour.

Harinath Jha had been a clerk in this office for twenty-seven years.

His daily routine was divided down to the corner of the desk, the bunch of keys, and the order of the files.

The object he touched least was the old round seal.

A thick wooden handle.

A circular rubber face below.

Around it the words:

“GRAM PANCHAYAT BISNAPUR.”

And in the centre, a small lotus.

After a new seal had been made, the old one was hardly used.

Even so, Harinath kept it on a sheet of white paper at the right-hand corner of his desk.

There was no rule behind that position.

Only habit.

One Monday evening, while closing the office, he lightly drew a pencil square around the seal.

He did it without thinking.

The next morning the square was empty.

The seal had moved three finger-widths to the left.

At first Harinath thought Phulo, who swept the office, must have touched it.

But Phulo had been cleaning the office for ten years, and before touching anything official on the desk she always called Harinath.

That day Phulo said, “I swept under the desk, not on top.”

Harinath laughed.

“The wood must have shifted.”

Phulo laughed too.

But nothing inside Harinath laughed.

On the white paper beneath the seal was half of a circular blue mark.

It was exactly the size of the outer ring of the seal.

Not a full impression.

As though the seal had not been pressed upright onto the paper, but had dragged along it on one edge.

Harinath folded the paper and put it into the drawer.

Until noon, his eyes kept returning to that drawer.

There had been blue ink like this thirteen years earlier too.

That monsoon had also been severe.

River water had reached two hamlets, and papers in dozens of houses had been soaked and destroyed.

The panchayat office had been crowded with requests for residence and family-verification certificates.

The then panchayat secretary, Devkinandan Babu, had said in haste, "If verification is complete, do not hold up the papers."

Harinath had written day and night.

One evening eighteen blank forms had been stamped in advance so that the verified names could be filled in the next morning and the certificates handed out quickly.

It was not the proper procedure.

Harinath knew that.

There was no electricity that night.

The veranda was crowded.

Wet clothes.

Mud.

Crying.

Desperation.

Everything together.

In the morning, seventeen forms were found.

One was missing.

Devkinandan Babu had said, "It must have been torn in the crowd. Do not make an issue of it."

Harinath entered seventeen instead of eighteen in the register.

He had not forgotten that single line in thirteen years.

A few months later whispers spread through the village that an outsider had shown a Bisnapur certificate to obtain flood relief.

Harinath never learned the name.

He never had the chance to see the paper.

But his mind had accepted one thing:

the missing form was still alive.

And one day it might return.

Now the seal was turning.

On Wednesday morning Harinath saw that the seal had moved two finger-widths forward from its place.

This time he had not drawn a pencil square.

Instead, he had left a small circle of dust beneath it on the wood of the desk.

The circle was broken.

On the paper there was again a half-round blue mark.

This one curved in the opposite direction from the first.

Harinath lifted the seal.

The wood was not cold.

It was slightly damp.

The round piece of wood holding the rubber beneath the handle seemed swollen on one side.

He brought it close to his nose.

The wood smelled of dampness.

Fine moisture from the wall above the desk crept downward in the rains, though no water dripped.

“This is the wood playing tricks,” Harinath told himself.

But the ink?

The seal was no longer used.

The ink pad stayed locked in the drawer.

He opened the drawer.

The lid of the pad was firmly closed.

Then he remembered the new employee, Rachna Kumari.

Rachna had joined the office two months earlier.

Around thirty.

Quiet-spoken.

Patient with papers.

Where others sneezed at the sight of old files and hurried away, Rachna dusted them and matched page numbers.

The district office had given her one assignment:

prepare a verification list of old certificate files.

Not make copies.

Only match serial number, date, signature, and seal.

Harinath had thought the work ordinary.

Now it did not seem ordinary.

That afternoon Rachna sat before the old cupboard.

Bent over a page, she was examining an impression of the seal with a magnifying glass.

Harinath watched from a distance.

“What are you looking for?”

Rachna raised her head.

“The impressions of the old round seal are not all alike.”

Harinath’s throat dried.

“Old rubber wears down.”

“That may be so.”

Rachna looked back at the paper.

“But in some impressions the outer ring is thick, in others thin. In some, the vowel mark in ‘Bi’ is broken, in others complete.”

Harinath sat down in his chair.

“So?”

“Nothing yet. First I will match the sequence.”

There was no accusation in her voice.

That made Harinath more uneasy.

If Rachna had accused him, he could have prepared an answer.

A silent investigation was harder to answer.

That evening, before closing the office, Harinath placed the old seal upright on a thick sheet of paper.

He drew lines around the sheet.

He pushed a folded paper beneath the left leg of the desk to try to level it.

He put the ink pad into the drawer and locked it.

The key went into his own shoulder bag.

In the morning the seal was still inside the outline.

Harinath's chest lightened.

But beside it was a new half-round stain.

The colour was a very pale blue.

He lifted the paper.

The ring was dark on the right and almost invisible on the left.

As though ink had touched it from one direction.

Harinath examined the rubber face of the seal.

There was blueness on the outer edge.

"The pad was locked," he thought.

"Then where did this blue come from?"

Watchman Batuknath appeared at the door.

He placed the night key register on Harinath's desk.

The panchayat office had two sets of the main keys.

One remained in Harinath's charge.

The other was locked at night in a box in the watchman's room.

If any employee entered the office after closing, the name and time had to be entered in the register.

Trying to appear casual, Harinath turned the pages.

Monday:

Rachna, 6:10 p.m. to 6:38 p.m.

Tuesday:

Rachna, 5:55 p.m. to 6:22 p.m.

Wednesday:

no name.

Harinath stopped his finger on Wednesday's line.

The seal had left a stain on Wednesday night too.

So Rachna alone was not moving it.

But why had Rachna come into the office on Monday and Tuesday evenings?

"She said she had files to examine," Batuknath explained. "There was written permission from the secretary."

"How many times?"

"Twice. Not yesterday."

Harinath closed the register.

That day he worked less and observed more.

In the afternoon the rain intensified.

Water collected on the floor beside the right leg of the desk.

Phulo dried it with a cloth.

Suddenly Harinath placed a drop of water on the surface of the desk.

The drop moved very slowly from left to right.
 The desk was not level.
 He removed the folded paper he had pushed beneath its leg.
 The drop moved faster.
 The old wooden top sagged slightly in the middle.
 He carefully tilted the seal onto one edge.
 Its round base and swollen wooden handle made it rest on two points.
 With a gentle push, it rolled half a turn.
 Harinath's palm grew cold.
 Not a ghost.
 Something else.
 But the question of the half-round blue stains remained.
 He called Rachna.
 "Did you use the old seal?"
 Rachna answered directly.
 "Yes."
 Harinath had not been prepared for such an easy admission.
 "On documents?"
 "On old waste paper. Not on certificates."
 "Why?"
 Rachna took three white sheets from her bag.
 Each bore an impression of the old seal.
 One complete.
 One faint.
 One half-pressed.
 "For comparison."
 "Permission?"
 "I am authorised to take seal samples for verification. But I did not take the old papers outside. I made the samples here."
 "At night?"
 "During the day there are too many people. When the old files are open, everyone asks questions. The secretary said I could work for half an hour after closing."
 "And why is the wooden handle damp?"
 For the first time Rachna looked surprised.
 "I did not wash it."
 She took the seal in her hand.
 She noticed the dampness beneath the handle.
 "This is from the wall. The paper it was lying on yesterday was damp too."
 Harinath looked at the three sample impressions.
 In all three, the blue ink was darker on the right side of the outer ring.
 "Why is the ink heavier on this side?"
 Rachna said, "One side of the rubber is recessed. The pressure is uneven."
 "And on the old certificates?"
 Rachna did not answer.
 She brought a file from the cupboard.

“This is why I am verifying them.”

The file was dated from the monsoon thirteen years earlier.

Harinath’s eyes stopped on the year.

Rachna placed five certificate copies before him.

On four, the vowel mark in ‘Bi’ was broken in the middle.

On the fifth, it was complete.

On four, the left petal of the lotus was thin.

On the fifth, thick.

On four, a small segment of the outer ring was missing.

On the fifth, the circle was perfectly clear.

“This fifth certificate is not in your register,” Rachna said.

The sound of rain suddenly seemed very far away to Harinath.

“The name?”

Rachna did not turn the paper towards him.

“First understand the seal.”

With the blunt end of a pencil, she pointed to one place on the old rubber face.

“Look here. Where the vowel mark in ‘Bi’ is broken, the rubber itself is split.”

“How long has it been split?”

“At least since the time of the first four certificates in this file, because all four carry the same break.”

“So the fifth?”

“This fifth certificate was not stamped with this seal.”

For a long time Harinath stared at the paper.

The shape of the suspicion that had lain like a stone inside him for thirteen years was changing.

The missing blank form had already been stamped with the old seal.

If that form had been used, its impression should have contained the broken vowel mark.

This certificate had been made with another seal.

“Then my missing paper?” Harinath asked softly.

Rachna looked at his face.

“What missing paper?”

The words had already escaped Harinath’s mouth.

He sat away from the back of his chair.

Outside, the rain was easing.

Phulo was tipping buckets of water off the veranda.

Harinath told Rachna about the eighteen pre-stamped blank forms from thirteen years earlier.

He also told her that he had written seventeen in the register.

He mentioned Devkinandan Babu’s instruction, but did not hide behind it.

“I could have written that one form was missing,” he said. “I did not.”

Rachna listened in silence.

"I was afraid the paper had gone outside. Then I heard the whispers. Since then I have kept thinking that one day this seal would catch me."

Rachna wiped the moisture from the wooden handle with a dry cloth.

"A seal catches no one," she said. "Papers do. Time does. Sometimes a mistake does."

Harinath said nothing.

Rachna showed him the name on the fifth certificate.

Harinath had never heard it.

The certificate was dated not thirteen years earlier, but ten years earlier.

Three years after the blank form had gone missing.

"This forged certificate is a separate matter," Rachna said. "It carries a copied seal. That is why I was taking samples from the original old seal."

"Why did you not tell me?"

"You are the old hand in this office. If I had told you first, your memory might have shaped the direction of my inquiry. I wanted to look at the papers first."

There was no accusation in the answer.

But there was distance.

Harinath felt that distance was justified.

He opened the key register again.

The times of Rachna's two evening visits were clear.

"You did not come on Wednesday night. Yet the seal moved."

Rachna examined the desk.

From one file she took a small round glass paperweight and placed it on the tabletop.

The ball slowly rolled to the right.

"The desk slopes."

Rachna laid the seal on one side.

"The wood has swollen with dampness. If it is left upright, nothing happens. If it rests on its side, it can roll."

"But I always leave it upright."

"Yesterday?"

Harinath tried to remember.

Yesterday he had lifted the seal, examined the rubber, and then put it down in a hurry.

Perhaps not fully upright.

Rachna looked at the sheet carrying the half-round stain.

"See this. It is not an impression. It is abrasion."

She turned the paper.

The darker portion lay in the direction of the desk's slope.

"Residual ink on the edge of the rubber touched the paper while it rolled."

"But the pad was locked."

"In this damp weather, ink does not dry completely in a single day."

Harinath counted the days on which Rachna had taken the sample impressions.

Monday and Tuesday.

By Wednesday the rubber edge could still have remained blue.

The connection was ordinary.

Fear had made it extraordinary.

In the afternoon the secretary came to the office.

Rachna showed him the fifth certificate, the sample impressions, and the verification list.

Harinath told his own story as well.

The secretary remained silent for a long time.

He was not from Devkinandan Babu's time.

For him the crowd of thirteen years earlier was history.

For Harinath it was smell and sound.

"Can we now mention that one of the eighteen forms was missing?" the secretary asked.

Rachna said, "Do not erase the original line. Add a delayed note beside it. Use today's date."

A knot tightened in Harinath's stomach.

"Then questions will arise."

"They will," the secretary said.

Harinath looked out the window.

The rain had stopped.

Water dripped from the mango leaves.

He asked for the register.

The page from thirteen years earlier had yellowed.

The line carried the number seventeen.

Harinath's own handwriting.

There was very little empty space beside it.

Rachna gave him a narrow strip of paper on which a note could be added and assigned a serial reference.

Harinath wrote:

"On the original working day, a total of eighteen pre-stamped forms were prepared; at the time of distribution, seventeen were available. One form remained unavailable. This fact could not be entered in the register at the time. The record is being completed through this delayed note."

He stopped after writing "could not be entered."

Then he did not strike it out.

Beside it he added in smaller words:

"was not entered."

The sentence changed.

The lapse was no longer the weather's.

It belonged to a person.

Harinath signed.

The secretary signed too.

Rachna entered the forged certificate separately in the verification list.

Its seal did not match the genuine old office seal.

That matter would be sent onward for investigation.

But Harinath's thirteen-year-old question about the missing form would remain separate.

Separate—

but not ended.

That evening, when closing the office, Harinath did not leave the old seal on the desk.

He asked for a small dry box.

Thick paper below.

Cotton cloth above.

The seal was cleaned and placed upright.

The ink pad was kept separately.

The date was written on the box.

Rachna said, "Now it will not turn."

Harinath smiled faintly.

"Have the desk levelled too."

The next day a carpenter came.

He nailed a thin wooden strip beneath the right leg of the desk.

The desk became level.

Harinath took the old paper with the half-round blue stain from the drawer.

He did not tear it.

Nor did he put it in the verification file.

He kept it among his private papers.

A few days later a letter arrived from the district.

The seal on the forged certificate had been found not to be the genuine office seal.

Further inquiry would proceed separately.

Harinath could have felt greatly relieved after reading the letter.

But he did not feel completely light.

There was still no answer about the missing form.

Perhaps it had never been used.

Perhaps it had.

Between those two possibilities there was now one difference:

it was written in the register.

Silence was no longer part of the official record.

A week later it rained again.

The office walls grew damp.

Water drummed on the tin roof.

Phulo swept the floor.

Batuknath placed the key register on the desk.

Rachna sat down and opened an old file.

Harinath opened the box and looked at the seal.

It was exactly where it had been placed.

He closed the box.

There was no new half-round blue mark on the desk.

Yet the shape of the old stain remained clear in Harinath's memory—

not a full circle.

Only half.

It seemed to him that some truths also arrive first as half a circle.

The remaining half has to be completed not by paper, but by a human being.

STORY 136

THE STRAIGHT STRIP THROUGH THE DEW

On Kartik mornings, Harinandan Yadav had always loved the shine of dew.

Pearl-like drops would rest on the tiny mustard leaves, and as eastern light rose, the field would suddenly turn bright green and white.

But that year, from the fifth morning onward, one thing stopped pleasing him.

Straight through the middle of the field ran a strip two finger-widths wide on which there was no dew.

On the first day Harinandan thought a mongoose or dog must have passed there during the night.

But the strip was too straight to be the path of a mongoose or dog.

On the second day, the same line.

On the third, a little to the right.

On the fourth, near the first position again.

On the fifth morning he sat on the field bund for half an hour watching the dew.

On both sides of the strip the mustard leaves were wet.

The leaves in the middle were almost dry.

There were no footprints on the soil.

People in the village still called that field “Jagesar’s Strip,” though Harinandan had bought it eight years earlier.

Jagesar Mahato had been drowning in debt.

His daughter’s marriage.

A new roof for the house.

Two bouts of illness.

Together they had caused his land to be sold piece by piece.

The final five kathas were this strip.

Harinandan paid the price.

The papers were proper.

The witnesses were proper.

Even so, somewhere inside him one thing had always troubled him:

on the day of the sale, Jagesar had said three times,

“If the price were just a little higher...”

Harinandan had replied then,

“The market is what it is.”

Now that sentence glinted again and again like Kartik dew.

Jagesar died two years later.

His wife had died before him.

His daughter Malti lived with her husband’s family, but Harinandan had heard that this month she had come back to clear the old parental house.

On the sixth morning Harinandan drove a small wooden peg into the beginning of the strip.

By evening the peg was still there.

That night he remained awake late on the veranda of his house.

A dog barked twice in the rear orchard, then fell silent.

After midnight, from somewhere in the distance, came a faint rasping sound like bamboo rubbing.

At dawn he went to the field.

The wooden peg was exactly as he had left it.

But the dewless strip ran to the left of the peg.

This time Harinandan bent down to inspect the leaves.

The tips of some leaves were pressed in the same direction.

The soil was dry.

No footprints.

Near the bund, a fine green fibre had caught on a stalk.

It resembled hemp or jute fibre.

He rubbed it between his fingers.

There was a faint smell of wax.

"This is not the work of an animal," he thought.

At midday he stopped Lalan Paswan as he passed the field.

Lalan had once worked on land-survey crews.

Harinandan showed him the fibre.

Lalan did not laugh.

"It could be from an old measuring tape," he said. "They used to be made of hemp. Wax was rubbed into them so they would not stretch too much in damp weather."

"Who would stretch a measuring tape across a field at night?"

Lalan looked at Harinandan's face.

"Someone who has something to measure."

Harinandan's first thought went to Malti.

To escape the thought, he walked to the market square in the afternoon.

At the tea stall he did not raise the matter himself.

But in a village, a thought in one man's mind often takes form on five tongues by the next day.

Someone said Jagesar's spirit was showing the old boundary.

Someone said perhaps nilgai walked in straight lines at night.

Old Kashi Sahu laughed.

"Who taught nilgai land surveying?"

Harinandan did not laugh.

He feared people's guesses more than ghosts.

If word spread that Jagesar's family was asking for land, the old sale price would climb back onto everyone's tongue.

The price had not been illegal.

But the fairness of a price and the justice of a person's desperation are not the same thing.

Harinandan understood that now, though he did not yet admit it.

Back home he searched the old account papers.

The amount from eight years earlier was written down.

On the same page were expenses for fertiliser, seed, and labour.

He told himself:

"I took the risk. I improved the land. I had the old irrigation channel cleared."

The argument was sound.

Beneath it, Jagesar's sentence could still be heard:

If the price were just a little higher...

That evening Harinandan conducted a small experiment.

On the outer bund of the field, where the crop was sparse, he left three things overnight:

a thin bamboo,

a handful of straw,

and an old jute measuring tape lying in Kamala's sewing box.

In the morning, the soil under the bamboo was damp.

Dew had gathered all around the straw.

But when he removed the tape, the leaves beneath it were almost dry in a strip two fingers wide.

Harinandan stood for a long time holding the tape.

One part of the mystery had broken open.

The fear did not lessen.

Now it was certain that a person was laying something straight across the field at night.

The question was no longer "what?"

It was "why?"

That evening he walked twice past Jagesar's old house.

The first time the courtyard was empty.

The second time Malti was sweeping beside the tulsi platform.

A white cloth was tied over her head.

She wore an old blue sari.

When she saw Harinandan, she stopped sweeping.

"I have come," Malti said simply.

"I heard."

"The house is falling apart. I have come to see what can still be saved."

Harinandan wanted to ask:

Do you go to the field at night?

But the question lodged in his throat.

He said only, "The cold is increasing."

Malti replied, "There is heavier dew in Kartik."

The ordinary sentence did not sound ordinary to Harinandan.

On the seventh morning he reached the field before daylight.

The dew had not yet fully settled.

At the eastern side of the bund he noticed two pieces of old brick he had never paid attention to before.

One was almost buried in the soil.

Black moss covered the other.

He could not judge the distance between them by eye.

Digging at the bund, he found a thin rusted iron peg.

Its head was not round but flat.

Old hammer marks scarred the edge.

Something trembled inside Harinandan's chest.

When the land had been purchased, a surveyor had measured it.

Harinandan had been present.

But now he remembered that the survey had started from a new bamboo peg to the south, not from this rusted iron peg.

He tried to reconstruct the day from eight years earlier.

The broker Ramdev walked ahead holding the papers.

Jagesar came behind.

Again and again the surveyor asked, "From here?"

Ramdev said, "Yes."

Whether Jagesar had opened his mouth once or not, Harinandan could no longer clearly remember.

Memory is a strange thing.

What one did not wish to hear at the time later becomes indistinct even in recollection.

When he scraped the earth beside the iron peg, he found a small piece of red clay with an old crust of lime on it.

Harinandan noticed that in a straight line north from that fragment, on the bund of Ramcharitra's field, there was a similar lime mark.

Two old marks.

His field between them.

This could not be a boundary.

A boundary runs around a field.

This was some other line.

He returned home and took out a copy of the sale deed from the chest.

The boundaries read:

North—Ramcharitra's field.

South—the village dirt road.

East—the old course of the irrigation channel.

West—the orchard.

There was no mention of any path through the middle.

But the old dirt road no longer lay directly to the south.

It had curved around one side of the field.

Harinandan could not say exactly when, in the eight years since the purchase, the road had shifted.

That night he hid near the field.

There was no way to hide among the short mustard plants, so he sat near bushes in the western orchard.

The cold deepened.

Half the night passed.

No one came from the village side.

Then there was a faint rustle near the northern bund.

Harinandan held his breath.

He heard no footsteps.
 Only a thin cord seemed to crawl through the darkness across the field.
 At first Harinandan thought it was an illusion.
 Then he saw:
 one hand on the northern bund,
 another on the southern bund.
 Neither person had stepped into the field.
 From both sides they stretched a long measuring tape across it.
 The tape lay flat over the mustard leaves.
 The figure on the southern side was Malti.
 On the northern side stood a teenage boy—
 her nephew Neeraj.
 Neither spoke.
 Malti tightened the tape.
 Neeraj tied it near the old iron peg.
 On her side, Malti aligned it with the edge of the half-buried brick.
 The tape became straight.
 Harinandan stepped out.
 “What is going on here?”
 Neeraj startled and dropped the tape.
 Malti did not startle.
 Only her hands relaxed.
 “A measurement,” she said.
 “By whose permission?”
 “Did I step into your field?”
 “No.”
 “Did I break the crop?”
 “No.”
 “Then ask about permission later. First look at this.”
 Malti did not wind up the tape.
 She untied a knot in the end of her sari and took out a paper.
 It was old, its edges yellowed.
 Red and black lines covered it.
 At the top was the village name in Devanagari.
 Below it, a year.
 Harinandan did not take the paper.
 Malti laid it on the ground beside the tape.
 “This is not my father’s copy. It is a photograph of an old block-office map. It took three months to obtain.”
 Harinandan remained silent.
 “From this point to this point there used to be a shared footpath two cubits wide,” Malti said. “From the rear hamlet to the main road. The old map shows it as a dotted line. It has disappeared from the new map.”
 “I bought the land. There is no path in the deed.”
 “You bought the land. But something my father had no right to sell also went into the paper.”

Heat rose through Harinandan's body.

"After so many years?"

Malti's voice was as cool as the dew.

"After so many years I understood why Father kept looking at this map at night."

Neeraj stood to one side, his eyes on the ground.

Harinandan said harshly, "Do you want the land back?"

"No."

The answer came so quickly that Harinandan was unprepared.

"Then why this drama?"

For the first time Malti lifted her eyes and looked directly at him.

"Children from the rear hamlet now walk two kos around by the main road to reach school. This month Ramsevak plans to put up a bamboo fence along the edge of his field. Then the old path will be completely closed. I only need proof of where the dotted line was."

Harinandan looked at the tape.

"You could have measured it during the day."

Malti was silent for a long time.

Then she said, "I sent you two letters."

Harinandan's throat dried.

The letters had come.

One three months earlier.

One fifteen days earlier.

He had read them.

The first mentioned the old path.

The second asked him to look at the map.

Harinandan had not replied.

He had pushed both letters into the lower compartment of his chest.

He wanted to say:

"I never received the letters."

But the words did not come out.

Malti said, "Father too remained silent once. On the day of the sale, the broker said that if the path remained written in the papers, the shape of the field would be spoiled and the price would fall. Father stayed silent. He told me later. His silence made your papers simpler. Your silence can now make the path disappear."

The sentence came not like an accusation, but like an account.

Harinandan picked up the map.

The red line showed the new boundary.

A black dotted line crossed the middle of the field.

Both ends of that line fell exactly at the old iron peg and the brick fragment.

"The dewless strip?" he asked.

Neeraj spoke for the first time.

"We leave the tape stretched overnight. We remove it before dawn. Dew does not settle on the leaves under it. We matched the distance for three nights."

"You never stepped into the field?"

"Not once."

Inside Harinandan, a strange relief and humiliation rose together.

Relief because no one had been wandering through the field at night.

Humiliation because his fear had needed no footprints at all.

A single straight dry line had been enough.

He took the map home.

He slept little that night.

His wife Kamala asked, "Are you unwell?"

He said, "There is a lot of dew."

Kamala did not laugh.

"Jagesar's daughter has come, hasn't she?"

Harinandan looked at his wife.

"Who told you?"

"What stays hidden in a village?"

After a while Kamala said, "You bought the land, not a person's silence."

Harinandan turned over.

The next day he called the old surveyor, Ramlochan.

Ramlochan's eyesight had weakened, but he remembered old survey work.

Running a finger over the map, he said, "Who removed this dotted line? I remember there was a shared path."

"During the sale survey, I was given a new paper. Not the old map."

"Who gave you the new paper?"

Ramlochan scratched his head.

"The broker. But Jagesar was there. He said nothing."

Harinandan asked, "And me?"

Ramlochan smiled faintly.

"You were watching the price and the measurement. Who was watching the path?"

There was no accusation in the answer.

Even so, Harinandan saw his own face clearly on that old day.

Three days later a small meeting was held in the panchayat house.

The mukhiya.

Ramlochan.

Malti.

Harinandan.

Two elderly men from the rear hamlet.

Two younger men.

The papers were opened.

The new map.

The old photographed map.

The sale deed.

The ground measurement.

Harinandan feared the meeting would turn into shouting.
It did not.

Questions were asked:

How wide was the path?

How much land would it occupy?

What would be the loss to cultivation?

Was there another route?

Who could testify to the old use?

Not once did Malti say "my land."

Again and again she said "the shared path."

No final decision was taken at the end of the meeting.

There would be another measurement.

The old records would be checked.

Until then, no bamboo fence would be erected.

Everyone rose.

Harinandan remained behind gathering the papers.

Malti was walking out.

"Malti," he called.

She turned.

"Do not stretch the tape at night anymore."

Malti's eyes hardened.

Harinandan added the next sentence:

"I will be there at dawn. We will measure in daylight."

Malti said nothing.

She merely nodded.

The next morning dew lay on the field as before.

There was no dry strip through the middle.

Drops shone evenly on the mustard leaves.

Harinandan stood near the old iron peg.

In his hand was a new bamboo peg.

Malti stood at the other side.

Ramlochan walked slowly between them, straightening the tape.

This time footprints appeared in the field.

Harinandan looked at those prints.

For the first time he understood:

some marks are not made to take land away.

They are made to show a path again.

The measurement was completed.

A line two cubits wide was marked.

No permanent stones were set immediately.

Only two small pegs were left on the bunds, to remain as indicators until the final record decision.

That evening Harinandan opened the chest.

He took out Malti's two old letters.

The fold of the first carried an old stain from his fingers.

The second was still clean.

He placed both letters not beneath the sale deed, but on top of it.
The next morning dew fell again.
This time there was no straight dry strip through the middle of the field.
But to Harinandan's eyes, the line between the two new pegs—from the southern bund to the northern—was perfectly clear.
The dew could not cover it.

THE BACK OF THE BROKEN MIRROR

Sharda Sewing House in Madhubani's old cloth market usually closed at five in the evening, but that day the light inside remained on until seven.

Sharda Devi was alone.

Outside, the cloth shops in the lane were lowering their shutters one by one.

Inside the sewing room, four machines stood covered with cloth, a half-cut blouse lay on the long wooden table, and on the rear wall hung the old mirror whose edges had broken and blackened.

A fine crack ran down the mirror's right corner.

By day one could look straight at it and fail to notice it.

Under the yellow night light, however, its line seemed to descend beside the reflected face.

Every day before closing the shop, Sharda swept beneath the mirror.

That evening, when she bent down, she found a tiny brown scrap of paper on the floor.

At first she thought it was dust from an old newspaper.

But the fragment was thick, almost like the brown backing paper pasted behind the mirror.

She looked up.

The paper at the back of the mirror could not be seen directly.

There was a two-finger gap between the wooden frame and the wall, through which only its edge was visible.

But today that edge was swollen.

Slowly it rose outward, then sank inward again.

As if the mirror were breathing.

Sharda straightened.

She reached out and touched the swollen paper.

At her touch it flattened inward.

Two moments later it lifted again.

At that instant, an evening from eighteen years earlier fell open inside her.

"I left the envelope with fifteen thousand here."

Janaki Chaudhary's voice.

She had been standing before this mirror while her wedding clothes were being fitted.

A red sari.

Sweat on her forehead.

A heavy bag in her hand.

Her daughter Vibha's wedding was approaching.

Sharda and her younger sister Kamala were sewing day and night.

Janaki had already paid five thousand.

That day she brought a second envelope containing fifteen thousand.

While the measurements were being altered, she placed the envelope on the small table beneath the mirror.

An hour later it was gone.

In the shop were Sharda, Kamala, Sharda's husband Nawal Kishore, and their twelve-year-old son Vikas.

Janaki's eyes went first to Kamala, because Kamala had gone alone into the fitting room once in the middle of the work.

Sharda could still remember Kamala's eyes.

No question.

No plea.

Only a wounded stillness.

"Didi, you too?"

That day Sharda had taken three breaths before answering.

Only three breaths.

But after those three breaths Kamala understood that even her elder sister did not believe her innocent.

The envelope was never found.

The wedding date was near.

Nawal Kishore paid Janaki half the amount from his own money.

The rest was entered as debt.

Janaki did not spread the matter outside.

But in a market, news travels by itself.

Within two months Kamala left the sewing house.

Six months later she moved to Saharsa.

Sharda never again spoke to her about the incident.

The paper behind the mirror swelled once more.

Sharda jerked her hand away.

"Air," she said to herself.

All the shop windows were closed.

She switched off the light, locked the door, and went into the inner part of the house.

The sewing room was the front room of the home.

On the other side of the rear wall was the kitchen.

Her daughter-in-law Rekha was putting away the stove.

Her granddaughter Nishtha sat at the table making something from scraps of cloth.

Nishtha had come home during her college holidays.

Her mother Rekha worked with Sharda in the shop during the day, but that evening she had gone to the market at four.

"Dadi, so late?" Nishtha asked.

"I was putting away some old things."

"Did you take down the mirror?"

Sharda stopped.

"Why?"

"The carpenter is coming tomorrow, isn't he? They said the mirror frame would be changed too."

“Who said that?”

“Babuji.”

Sharda did not answer.

The mirror was cracked, but she had told no one to remove it.

Her son Vikas had been talking for months about modernising the shop.

New lighting.

New tables.

A new mirror.

Sharda kept postponing everything.

That night sleep came late.

Around one in the morning she heard a faint rustling from the kitchen side.

She sat up.

The sound did not come again.

After drinking water, she looked out into the courtyard.

No one was there.

At dawn, when she opened the shop, two more brown paper fragments lay beneath the mirror.

This time the swollen section behind it was larger.

Sharda dragged a wooden chair over.

She tried to slip a hand behind the left side of the frame.

The gap was too narrow.

Her fingers could not enter.

But a fine white fibre caught on her fingernail.

A cloth fibre.

She felt along the back edge of the frame.

At three places were tiny holes.

Like needle-holes.

Not in cloth—

in the paper.

Opening time was approaching.

Sharda moved the chair away.

Rekha arrived at eight.

The first customer at half past eight.

At ten Nishtha brought tea and said she wanted to see the old cutting notebooks.

“You want to learn sewing?” Sharda asked.

“Not sewing. I want to look at old patterns for a college exhibition.”

“They are in the rear cupboard. Look at whatever you want.”

Nishtha went to the cupboard.

Five minutes later she stood before the mirror looking at her face.

The crack seemed to descend from the middle of her forehead.

“How old is this mirror?”

Sharda’s needle stopped in the air.

“Older than your father.”

“Was the backing paper replaced later?”

“No.”

“It looks thick, almost new.”

“Why are you so interested in the back of the mirror?”

Nishtha laughed.

“Because it is old.”

Sharda did not believe the laugh.

At noon Rekha went home for lunch.

There were no customers.

Nishtha continued looking through papers in the cupboard.

Sharda bent over her machine, but her ears remained turned towards the mirror.

After a while—

a very faint tick.

As if a needle had pierced paper.

Sharda raised her head at once.

Nishtha was not near the mirror.

She sat with her back to it, facing the cupboard.

“Nishtha.”

“Yes?”

“Show me your hands.”

Nishtha turned.

“My hands?”

“Show me.”

She held both hands out.

There was nothing on her fingers.

Sharda felt ashamed of her own tone.

“Nothing.”

Nishtha looked at her grandmother for a moment, then turned back towards the cupboard.

The carpenter did not come that evening.

Vikas telephoned.

“He will come tomorrow.”

Sharda breathed easier.

But she could not tell whether the relief came from the mirror being spared, or from fear that something behind it might be exposed.

Before closing the shop that night, she touched the wall.

The area behind the mirror was warm.

The kitchen stove was directly on the other side.

After the evening rotis were made, this section of wall must warm up.

She watched the backing paper swell again.

Perhaps air trapped between the warm wall and the mirror was expanding, she thought.

But the needle-holes?

The white fibre?

That night, after the stove had gone cold, she returned to the shop.

The backing paper now lay flat.

Holding a small lamp like a lantern, Sharda bent beneath the frame.
On the floor she found a thin thread.

Not white.

Faded blue.

There could be hundreds of such threads in a sewing shop.

But a brown paper fibre clung to one end.

She wrapped the thread in paper and kept it with her.

The next day Sharda asked Rekha, "Have you told Nishtha anything about Kamala Mausi?"

Rekha was startled.

"Why?"

"Just asking."

"She went to Saharsa last year. To Kamala Mausi's house. You know that."

"For how many days?"

"Three."

"Why did no one tell me?"

Rekha looked uncomfortable.

"I did tell you. Perhaps you did not hear."

Sharda understood that when the mind does not wish to hear something, the ears often cooperate.

There were few customers that day.

In the afternoon Sharda took out the old accounts register.

She found the page from eighteen years earlier.

Janaki Chaudhary—

first payment, five thousand.

On the second line, where fifteen thousand should have been entered, the space was blank.

Beside it was no signature from Nawal Kishore.

Only a small red-pencil mark.

Sharda had seen that red mark before.

Nawal Kishore used such a mark when money had been received but had not yet been entered into the main register.

On the night Janaki's envelope disappeared, Nawal Kishore had said,

"Stop talking about Kamala. There is no proof."

Sharda had snapped back,

"Then where did the envelope go?"

Nawal Kishore had not answered.

Three days later he developed a severe fever.

For a month he did not come to the shop.

He recovered, but the matter of Janaki's money was never raised again.

A year or two later Nawal Kishore died of a heart attack.

Sharda suddenly bent closer to the account page.

Beside the red mark were extremely faint characters:

"K-7."

K-7.

It was not an amount.

Nawal Kishore used the letter K and a number to file old cloth-slips separately.

K-7 must mean the seventh cloth-slip.

She closed the register.

That evening, when Nishtha came to the shop, Sharda asked without preamble,

“What did Kamala Mausi give you?”

Nishtha’s face changed.

Only slightly.

But Sharda caught it.

“Her blessings.”

“Papers?”

Nishtha was silent.

“How many days have you been trying to reach behind the mirror?”

Nishtha slowly sat down on a chair.

Sharda bolted the door from inside.

Rekha had already gone home.

The evening crowd in the lane was thinning.

“I am not stealing anything,” Nishtha said.

“Kamala said the same thing once.”

Nishtha looked into her grandmother’s eyes.

“Did you believe her then?”

Sharda’s throat dried.

“No.”

Nishtha took a small cloth bundle from her bag.

Inside were three things:

an old letter written by Kamala,

a credit receipt from a cloth merchant bearing Nawal Kishore’s signature, and a half-torn paper.

Sharda picked up the receipt.

The date was the same day Janaki’s envelope disappeared.

Amount:

fifteen thousand.

Below it was written:

“Old outstanding balance settled immediately; cash received.”

The shopkeeper’s seal appeared beneath.

Sharda’s fingers trembled.

“Where did this come from?”

“Kamala Mausi had it. Nana gave it to her two weeks later. He told her, ‘Keep this. If the matter ever comes up, show it.’ But Mausi said there was one more slip, on which Nana had written that he himself had taken Janaki’s envelope. That slip remained in the shop. Mausi knew where.”

“Behind the mirror?”

“Yes.”

“Did Kamala ever come here to look for it?”

“No. She did not want to return to this shop.”

“So she sent you?”

“No.”

Nishtha’s voice hardened.

“I came on my own. Mausī only told me the story. She has no need for that slip anymore. She said, ‘The age for showing proof to people who did not believe me has passed.’”

Sharda lowered her eyes.

“Then why are you searching for the proof?”

Nishtha remained silent for a while.

“Because Vikas Babu is renovating the shop. The mirror will be thrown away. Whatever papers are behind it will go with the rubbish. I thought I should take it out once. See whether it is truly there.”

“You could have told me during the day.”

“Would you have allowed the mirror to be taken down?”

Sharda gave no answer.

Nishtha stood and went to the mirror.

“If I tear the backing paper straight across, the slip itself may tear. So I made tiny holes with a needle. I was pushing a thin strip of lining cloth inside to move the slip downward. When the kitchen wall heats up, the air inside makes the paper swell. I thought it would be easier at night.”

“The white fibre?”

“From the lining cloth.”

“The blue thread?”

“Mine.”

The shape of Sharda’s fear suddenly became small.

What she had taken for breathing was warm air.

What she had imagined as some insistence from within was her granddaughter’s needle.

But the fear did not disappear.

Truth stood in its place.

“Nawal Kishore took the money,” Sharda said softly.

“It seems so.”

“Why did he not tell me?”

Nishtha remained silent.

Sharda answered herself.

“The cloth merchant had stopped extending credit. The wedding order was incomplete. He must have thought he would use the envelope to clear the outstanding amount and replace the money by evening. But Janaki asked too soon. He panicked. Then everyone’s eyes went to Kamala...”

The sentence remained unfinished.

Nishtha said, “Mausī says Nana told her that night, ‘I will clear the matter.’ But he never did.”

“And me?”

Nishtha looked at her grandmother.

“That question you must ask yourself.”

Sharda could have become angry.

She did not.
 Weariness came instead.
 "Take down the mirror," she said.
 Together they began loosening the screws of the frame.
 The screws were jammed.
 Nishtha applied oil.
 One by one all four screws came loose.
 The mirror was heavy.
 Together they placed it face down on the table.
 The brown backing paper was truly swollen in several places.
 Three tiny needle-holes showed.
 In one corner, a strip of faded blue lining cloth was caught inside.
 With a small knife Nishtha lifted only the edge of the paper.
 From within appeared dust, thread, and the corner of a folded slip.
 Sharda said, "Slowly."
 Nishtha pulled the cloth strip.
 The paper slid downward.
 She caught it with her fingers and drew it out.
 It was a small slip.
 Nawal Kishore's handwriting.
 "Janaki Devi's ₹15,000 cash today temporarily paid towards Harinarayan
 Cloth House's old outstanding balance. Amount to be restored by evening.
 Kamala unaware."
 Below was Nawal Kishore's signature.
 That was all.
 No apology.
 No explanation.
 No grand confession.
 Only a sentence like an account entry—
 outside which eighteen years of life had changed.
 Sharda sat down on the chair.
 "I had seen the red mark," she said.
 "I suspected something.
 That day too.
 Afterwards too.
 But I did not search Nawal Kishore's cupboard.
 I did not look at the register again.
 After paying Janaki half the amount, the shop was in debt.
 Vikas was small.
 I was afraid—
 if this came out, the shop, the house, his name... everything."
 Nishtha listened quietly.
 "Kamala's name was cheaper," Sharda said.
 This time Nishtha turned her eyes away.
 Outside, a handcart rattled past in the lane.
 Somewhere far away a metal shutter fell.

The sewing machines were silent.

The mirror lay face down on the table.

Now it showed no one's face.

After a while Sharda asked, "Would Kamala want to see this slip now?"

"I do not know."

"Call her."

"Now?"

"Not yet. First I will write."

Sharda took out the old account register.

She opened Janaki's page.

Beside the blank fifteen-thousand entry, in fresh ink, she wrote:

"Amount temporarily used by Nawal Kishore towards the cloth house's outstanding debt. Suspicion cast upon Kamala was unfounded. Slip attached."

Her hand trembled.

The letters did not stay straight.

She gave the slip to Nishtha to make a photocopy.

She did not paste the original into the register.

She placed it in a transparent sleeve between the pages.

She returned Kamala's old letter to Nishtha.

"Is Janaki Ji still alive?" Sharda asked.

"Mausi says she is in Darbhanga."

"I will write to her too."

"The money?"

Sharda closed the register.

"The money was settled through the accounts. But what is still owed to a name cannot be paid through accounts."

For the first time Nishtha softened a little.

"Mausi has not asked for money."

"I am not speaking of money."

The next morning the carpenter came.

He lifted the frame to take the broken mirror away.

Sharda stopped him.

"Throw away the glass. Keep the wood."

"Shall I fit a new mirror?"

Sharda looked at the empty wall.

Where the mirror had hung, a square patch was slightly lighter than the rest of the wall.

In the middle were a few black points like needle-holes.

"Not yet," she said.

At noon the shop opened again.

Customers came.

The machines ran.

Rekha took measurements.

Nishtha put away the cutting notebooks.

Sharda worked as before.

But again and again her eyes went to the empty square on the wall.

There was no face there now.
No paper breathing.
Only three tiny holes remained visible—
through which a thin strip of cloth had once gone inside.
When Sharda closed the shop that evening, she did not paste paper over
those holes.
She left them open.

THE RED THREAD ON THE VERANDA

Sharda Devi saw the first red thread while sweeping at dawn.

It lay in the middle of the veranda, between the old wooden pillar and the tulsi platform, about five finger-widths long.

A deep red.

A small knot at one end.

The other end frayed.

Sharda bent and picked it up.

The thread was wet with dew.

It left no red colour on her fingers.

For a moment she looked across the empty veranda.

There was no wedding being prepared in the house.

People in the village still called this house “the wedding house,” although the last wedding here had taken place twelve years ago.

A large courtyard built three generations earlier.

A long veranda.

Two rooms for guests.

A kitchen at the back.

Half the families in the village had seen a kanyadaan, an upanayan, a kirtan, or a mourning gathering on this veranda.

Sharda’s father-in-law had kept the house open to all four brothers.

Later walls went up, shares were divided, names changed.

But the name “wedding house” did not change.

The sight of the red thread awakened in Sharda’s mind not a wedding, but a broken wedding.

Thirty-two years earlier, this veranda had been decorated for the wedding of her husband’s sister Mrinal.

After half the night had passed, the groom’s party had suddenly risen to leave.

For years the family gave different explanations.

Some said dowry.

Some said the groom’s maternal uncle had insulted someone while drunk.

Some said Mrinal herself had withdrawn from the marriage.

Sharda knew one part of the truth.

And at the time, she had remained silent about it.

“Ma, what did you find?” Meera called from inside.

Sharda closed the thread in her fist.

“Nothing. It was caught in the broom.”

Meera was her younger daughter-in-law.

She had come from the city for two weeks—officially to sort old household papers, but really to settle unfinished questions of division after her father-in-law’s death.

At the far end of the courtyard lived Sharda's elder son Aniruddh.
 Her younger son Madhup was in Delhi.
 A few years after the broken wedding, Mrinal became a teacher and moved
 to Madhubani.
 She seldom came now.
 Sharda dropped the thread into a brass bowl near the kitchen hearth.
 The next morning another red thread appeared.
 This time beside a pillar.
 Seven finger-widths long.
 Two small knots in the middle.
 On the third morning there were three pieces on the veranda.
 One at the foot of a pillar.
 One in the corner of the steps.
 One against the wall.
 Sharda did not sweep them away.
 She called Meera.
 "Look at these."
 Meera spread all three pieces across her palm.
 "They look like sewing thread."
 "Who sews on the veranda at night?"
 "A cat may be playing with them."
 "Does a cat tie knots?"
 Meera did not laugh.
 She looked more closely.
 "The knot is strange. Turned twice, then tightened. The red ritual thread
 we have in the house is not tied like this."
 Sharda brought the first two pieces from the brass bowl.
 All five were laid in a row.
 They were not exactly the same thickness.
 Some were slightly thinner.
 But the colour was nearly identical.
 Meera said, "They may all have been cut from one market spool."
 Sharda said, "Yes."
 Her mind did not agree.
 That night she did not sleep early.
 She bolted the veranda door from inside and lay in her room.
 The rains had ended.
 The Kartik night was clear.
 Dogs barked here and there outside.
 Ten o'clock.
 Eleven.
 Around midnight came a faint tick against wood.
 Sharda sat up.
 Then—
 sirr.
 As though something thin had rubbed across a pillar.

She did not put on her slippers.
Slowly she went to the door.
She did not lift the inner bolt.
She tried to look through the crack, but the veranda was dark.
After a few moments—
another tick.
Then silence.

Sharda did not open the door.
At dawn another red thread lay in the middle of the veranda.
This time one end carried a fine white powder.
Meera smelled it.

“Not lime.”

Aniruddh was crossing the courtyard just then.

“What investigation is going on at dawn?”

Meera showed him the thread.

“This appears every day.”

Aniruddh glanced once.

“A bird must be bringing it for a nest.”

Sharda asked, “Do birds tie knots?”

“They get all sorts of things caught somewhere and carry them. You two have fixed your minds on nonsense.”

He was in a hurry.

In his hand was a blue file cover.

Outside, an unfamiliar man waited on a motorcycle.

Sharda’s eyes settled on the file.

“Where are you going?”

“To the market.”

“With whom?”

“It is some land work.”

Aniruddh paused for an instant, as though weighing his words.

Then he added, “Papers for the rear field.”

He left.

Sharda looked at Meera.

Meera looked back.

Neither said anything.

That afternoon Sharda examined the veranda pillars carefully.

There were six in all.

Old sal wood.

Round iron plates at their bases.

At about waist height on the fourth pillar were three fine scratches.

They were fresh.

Wood dust still clung to the edges.

A line marked the fifth pillar too.

Sharda ran a finger over it.

Perfectly straight.

As though a thread pulled taut had rubbed against the wood.

The old wedding night rose again inside her.
 There had been red thread everywhere on this veranda that night too.
 Around the bamboo poles of the mandap.
 Binding mango leaves.
 Around the ritual pots.
 Members of the groom's party had been speaking in the inner room.
 Sharda was a new bride in the family then.
 She had little place to speak.
 Pretending to fetch water, she had paused outside the room.
 Inside, the groom's maternal uncle had said,
 "If you transfer the two eastern rooms, the wedding rounds can take place now. Afterwards the matter will change."
 Sharda's father-in-law had spoken quietly.
 "This was never part of the marriage arrangement."
 "It is now."
 Mrinal had been standing on the other side of the doorway.
 She heard.
 She caught Sharda and asked one question:
 "Bhauji, has Babuji agreed?"
 Sharda knew the answer.
 She had said:
 "I don't know."
 After that one sentence, Mrinal did not sit in the mandap.
 For years the family said Mrinal was stubborn.
 That she had suddenly broken off the wedding.
 Sharda never said that Mrinal had done nothing suddenly.
 Now the red thread brought back the mandap, the eastern rooms, and that silence all at once.
 In the evening Meera went to the market and returned an hour later with a small spool of red thread.
 "Like this?"
 Sharda compared them.
 The market thread was bright.
 The threads from the veranda were duller.
 Meera said, "This is not sewing thread. It may be the marking thread used by builders or carpenters. Some workers stretch thread to hold a straight line."
 "Why red?"
 "So it can be seen."
 Sharda asked, "And the knots?"
 Meera tied two knots in the market thread.
 "The knots may mark distances."
 "Then who is measuring at night?"
 Both fell silent.
 That night Meera said, "Do not open the door. I will look through the window."
 At half past eleven a faint shadow moved across the veranda.

Meera opened the shutter by one finger-width.
Sharda stood behind her.
At first nothing was visible in the darkness.
Then the distant courtyard light cast a faint glow.
A man was bent near a pillar.
He pulled a thread taut.
It shone in a straight line from one pillar to another.
Sharda's breath stopped.
The man was thin.
A towel covered his head.
He wrapped one end around a pillar, measured something at the other end, then marked the wood with a small metal object.
Meera whispered, "Who is it?"
Sharda did not answer.
The man went to the doorway of the eastern room.
He stretched thread from the wall to the pillar.
Then wrote something in a notebook.
At that moment the door of Aniruddh's room moved from inside.
Sharda thought Aniruddh would come out.
But the door became still again.
The man in the darkness gathered the thread.
He cut a small piece.
As he cut it, the end fell beside the pillar.
He did not look for it.
He went out through the rear gate.
Meera said, "I could have caught him just now."
Sharda answered softly, "No."
"Why?"
"First understand."
At dawn they measured the veranda.
Meera brought the house's old iron tape.
She wrote down the distance from scratch to scratch.
Twelve cubits and four fingers.
Then to the outer wall of the eastern room.
Seven cubits and nine fingers.
Meera said, "This is not wedding decoration. This is plan measurement."
Sharda's eyes moved to the two eastern rooms.
The same rooms the groom's side had demanded thirty-two years earlier.
When Aniruddh went out that afternoon, Meera did not suggest entering his room.
She only said,
"The papers are not in front of us, but the measurements say a part of the house is being separated."
Sharda's voice hardened.
"By whose authority?"
Meera paused before answering.

"That is a question for Aniruddh Bhaiya."

"Now?"

"If we ask now, he may simply say a workman was measuring. I want to know which portion appears in the papers."

This time Sharda found Meera more patient than she had expected.

For three days no red thread appeared.

On the fourth day, the postman brought a thick envelope.

It was addressed to Aniruddh, but the address read:

"Sharda Devi's Old Wedding House."

Sharda did not open it.

In the evening, when Aniruddh returned, she handed him the envelope.

For a moment his face changed.

"What is it?" Sharda asked.

"Loan papers."

"For the rear field?"

"Yes."

He took the envelope inside.

That night Meera said, "Ma, the lie is small, but something is being hidden."

Sharda looked at the red threads collected in the brass bowl.

"Once before, I stayed silent in front of a small lie."

Meera asked no question.

The next day Mrinal telephoned.

In the middle of ordinary talk, she suddenly asked,

"Bhauji, are the eastern rooms of the house all right?"

Sharda's hand trembled.

"Why?"

"Nothing. Aniruddh called yesterday. He was saying the old house is badly decayed and perhaps it should be sold and a smaller one built."

"He told you?"

"Only generally. I told him—whatever share of mine remains, put it clearly in writing first."

Sharda was silent.

Mrinal spoke again.

"Bhauji?"

"Yes."

"My name is still on the papers of that house, isn't it?"

Sharda did not know the answer.

After the call ended, she summoned Meera.

"Where are the old partition papers?"

"In Babuji's iron trunk."

The trunk was opened.

The papers were yellow, their edges brittle.

The written partition described four shares.

One separate line referred to the two eastern rooms:

"To be given to daughter Mrinal after marriage; until marriage, joint use."

Sharda stared at the line for a long time.

"The marriage never happened," Meera said.

"Later Mrinal built a life on her own feet. But the paper was never changed."

Meera said softly, "Then this portion should not be sold without her written consent."

Sharda again heard her own old sentence:

"I don't know."

This time the sentence rose to her mouth.

It did not leave it.

That night the red thread returned.

This time Sharda opened the door.

The man bent on the veranda started and stood.

He was neither Aniruddh nor anyone in the family.

"Who are you?" Sharda's voice was hard.

The man folded his hands.

"I am Subodh. I do measuring work."

"At night?"

Subodh's eyes moved towards Aniruddh's room.

"I was told not to do it in the daytime."

"By whom?"

Before he could answer, Aniruddh's door opened.

Aniruddh came out.

His face looked tired.

More like a man caught than a man angry.

"I told you," he said to Subodh, "not today."

Sharda interrupted.

"Today is fine."

Meera too came outside.

For several moments Aniruddh was silent.

Then he said,

"There is a buyer for the eastern part of the house."

"Whose share?"

"The papers are complicated."

"Mrinal's name is there."

Aniruddh looked up.

"You opened the trunk?"

"Yes."

"Ma, understand the situation. The debt from the transport business is coming due. No one wants the rest of the house. The eastern part can open separately onto the road. I thought I would first get it measured, then speak to everyone—"

Meera did not interrupt.

Neither did Sharda.

Aniruddh stopped by himself.

"Why measure at night?" Sharda asked.

"If it were done during the day, word would reach Mrinal Fua's people. I wanted the buyer confirmed first."

"So first the deal, then permission."

"Not a deal—only discussion."

Subodh stood awkwardly.

In his hand were the red thread, a small tape, and a pencil.

Sharda looked at them.

"Why did these little pieces keep falling?"

Subodh said, "I tie knots to mark distances. I cannot drive iron hooks into these old pillars. I pull the thread tight around them. The cut ends keep dropping."

Meera asked, "The scratches on the pillars?"

"The brass end of the measuring tape."

"The white powder?"

"Marking powder. I put it on the thread so it can be seen in the dark."

All the ghosts vanished.

Only four people remained on the veranda—

a surveyor,

a son in debt,

a mother who had once remained silent,

and a daughter-in-law watching.

Aniruddh said softly, "I am not stealing."

Sharda looked at him.

"I did not say you were."

"I cannot see another way to pay the debt."

"Have you told Mrinal?"

Aniruddh was silent.

"Then you have not yet searched all the way."

No decision was made for a long time that night.

Subodh gathered his thread and left.

Aniruddh went inside, but did not slam the door.

Meera folded the papers from the trunk and put them away again.

Sharda remained on the veranda.

A faint red dust from the thread still marked one pillar.

The next morning she telephoned Mrinal.

For the first time in many years, Sharda told the whole story of the night of the broken wedding—

the groom's family demanding the rooms,

the pressure on her father-in-law,

Mrinal's question,

and Sharda's answer:

"I don't know."

There was silence for a long time at the other end.

At last Mrinal said,

"I knew you knew."

Sharda's throat dried.

“Then why did you never ask?”

“What would have been the use? I had already made my decision.”

Then Mrinal laughed very softly.

“So now the rooms are to be sold?”

“Aniruddh is in debt.”

“If my share is still there, send me the papers first. I will not oppose a sale merely on principle. I will see what is fair.”

Sharda had not imagined the answer would be so ordinary.

That afternoon, when Aniruddh came, Sharda placed the old partition deed before him.

She laid one piece of red thread straight across it—

under the line describing the eastern rooms.

“The measurement was not wrong,” she said.

“The order was wrong.”

Aniruddh kept looking at the paper.

“First Mrinal. Then the buyer.”

He said nothing.

He picked up the piece of thread.

Then put it back on the table.

Three days later Subodh came again.

This time in daylight.

Mrinal too was on the veranda.

She had returned to the house after many years.

Meera was making tea.

Aniruddh had the file open.

Subodh took out the red thread.

Mrinal laughed.

“So this was the ghost?”

Sharda said, “Not a ghost. A measurement.”

Mrinal ran a finger over an old scratch on the pillar.

“A house is not always divided by measurement,” she said. “But when it is sold, measurement is needed.”

For the first time Aniruddh smiled faintly.

Subodh stretched the red thread in daylight.

This time no piece fell on the veranda.

Whatever he cut, he put into his bag.

Sharda watched from a distance.

The red line stretched between two pillars—

straight,

ordinary,

made by a human hand.

On this side of that line lay the old silence.

On the other side, there was still room left for conversation.

STORY 139

FALLING LETTERS

In a narrow lane turning inward from Darbhanga's old Kachahari Road, the iron signboard of "Videha Printing Press" still hung in place.

The paint had peeled away, but the letters could still be read.

The press no longer worked regularly.

Wedding cards, invitations, memorial booklets, or some old-style printing still came occasionally, but the main room remained closed for most of the day.

Raghunath Jha was past seventy.

His grandfather had founded the press.

His father had expanded it.

Raghunath had spent his youth here, selecting metal type by hand.

To the new generation, those pieces of type were history.

To Raghunath, they were sounds.

If a wooden case slipped, he could tell by the sound which compartment had loosened.

When letters were set into a composing stick, the faint click of metal against metal sounded to him like the first drops of rain.

Eight old type cases were stacked one above another in the rear room of the press.

Each case contained many small compartments.

Some held Devanagari letters.

Some contained special vowel signs and sorts used for years in Maithili printing.

Others held punctuation.

Three months earlier Kaushal had come there to learn.

He was studying the history of printing at the university and said it was not enough to look at old printing in a museum.

One should also learn how to lift the letters by hand.

At first Raghunath had laughed.

"Learn to pick up a letter, and then learn to put it back," he said. "Putting it back is the harder art."

Kaushal understood that in the first week.

Place one 'ka' in the wrong compartment and half an hour later it could not be found.

And because of that one missing letter, an entire line would stop.

Gradually the responsibility for closing the press in the evening fell to Kaushal.

He switched off the main power to the machine.

Covered the paper.

Closed the ink tins.

And finally pulled shut the rear room door.

The first time he heard letters falling was one Agahan night.

He was locking the outer door when three metallic sounds came from inside.

Tin.

Tin.

Tin.

Kaushal turned.

The main room was empty.

He went to the rear room.

Four pieces of metal type lay on the floor in front of the uppermost case.

He bent and picked them up.

‘Na.’

The long-a vowel sign.

‘Ma.’

And a metal space.

Kaushal smiled.

“Name?”

He assumed the case was old, its bottom warped, and the sorts had fallen out.

He returned each piece to its compartment and left.

The next night the sound came again.

This time five pieces.

‘Cha.’

The long-a sign.

‘Ri.’

A punctuation mark.

Then ‘na.’

Kaushal examined them carefully.

Some letters lay upside down, some on their sides.

But when mentally turned upright, they could be read as:

“four na...”

That night he told Raghunath nothing.

On the third night he deliberately stayed late.

After eight the shops on the main road fell quiet.

Only the clatter of vessels from a tea stall remained in the lane.

At exactly eight forty-seven, the press table trembled very slightly.

At first Kaushal thought a truck had passed.

But there was no truck in the lane.

Then—

tin.

Tin-tin.

He ran to the rear room.

This time the letters were not scattered on the floor.

On the old galley tray beneath the case, seven pieces lay almost in a line.

Kaushal shone his torch over them.

“Name not...”

The next letter was reversed.
 A shiver passed through him.
 He became annoyed with himself.
 “They are metal,” he said softly. “Metal does not speak.”

When Raghunath arrived the next morning, Kaushal had left the galley untouched.

The moment Raghunath saw it, he stopped.
 He did not bend down.
 From a distance he asked, “Who arranged these?”
 “Not me.”
 “Then?”
 “They fell last night.”
 Raghunath’s face changed.
 “Fallen letters do not make lines.”
 “I know that much too.”

Raghunath strode over, gathered all the pieces, and threw them back into the case.

Kaushal asked, “Name not—what comes next?”
 Raghunath looked at him.
 “Nothing.”

That day Raghunath added a second lock to the rear room.
 Kaushal asked no question.

At the press, questions were often opened more effectively by observing things than by asking directly.

He examined the four legs of the table.
 Under the rear right leg a piece of old cardboard had been wedged.
 When he removed it, the table rocked.
 Beside the table stood an old belt-driven cutting machine.
 It was shut down.

But in the adjoining building, after eight at night, a small oil press operated.

The vibration of its heavy wheel travelled through the wall into the floor.
 Kaushal stood outside at night and listened.
 At eight forty-seven, the oil press’s heavy wheel started.

At exactly the same moment the table inside Videha Printing Press trembled.

One cause had been found.
 The line of letters remained unexplained.
 Four days later Raghunath went out of town for a relative’s shraddha.
 He gave Kaushal the key to the main room.
 Not the rear room.

That evening, while Kaushal was putting things away, he noticed something shining beneath the wooden table.

A thin black strip.
 He pulled it out.
 It was magnetic.

Two small steel strips clung to it.

Kaushal's first thought was that the metal letters were being pulled with it.

But he immediately picked up an old 'ma' and brought it close to the strip.

The type did not stick.

Raghunath had told him earlier that old printing type was cast from a lead-based alloy.

So the strip served some other purpose.

Kaushal ran a hand beneath the table.

Two fine nails protruded there.

Steel strips could be fixed against them.

The magnetic strip could hold those pieces securely.

It took him a while to understand.

If the strips were positioned beneath the bottom of the case at a certain angle, loose type could slide in one direction when vibration came.

But who was loosening particular letters?

Kaushal looked through the gap of the locked rear-room door.

One corner of the top case had been raised slightly.

Raghunath returned the next day.

Kaushal said nothing.

All day he selected type.

In the evening Raghunath left.

Kaushal did not.

He switched off the main light and sat behind a stack of paper.

At eight forty, a key turned in the outer lock.

Kaushal held his breath.

The door opened.

The footsteps did not creep like a thief's.

They came straight in like the steps of someone familiar with the place.

It was Neeraj.

Neeraj was not another trainee at the press.

By day he worked at a nearby bookshop.

Twice a week he had come on the pretext of looking at the old type with Kaushal.

In the darkness Kaushal watched him go to the cases.

Neeraj took a key from his pocket.

The rear room opened.

He pulled out the case.

Under its bottom he placed two steel strips and secured them with the magnetic strip.

Then he moved selected letters from specific compartments towards the edge.

Kaushal stepped out.

"So the oil press is about to start?"

Neeraj froze.

For a few moments neither spoke.

Then Neeraj took his hand away.

"Eight forty-seven," he said.

"Where did you get the key?"

"It was an old key."

"Whose?"

Neeraj did not answer.

Just then the wall trembled.

Inside the case the metal gave a fine rattle.

Three pieces slid down the incline, crossed the steel strip, and fell onto the galley tray.

Tin.

Tin.

Tin.

For the first time Kaushal watched the mystery being made.

"The letters were not falling by themselves," he said.

"No."

"You make them fall?"

"The vibration makes them fall. I only choose them."

"Why?"

Instead of answering, Neeraj opened the back of the case.

A piece of old paper was stuck beneath the uneven bottom.

Stained with ink and oil.

Its edge gnawed away.

"I found this here three weeks ago," Neeraj said.

Kaushal took the sheet.

It was not a complete page.

Perhaps it had once been part of a proof.

One line had partly faded.

At the top it read:

"Four names that remained outside the register."

Below were the names of four labourers.

Then an article began.

It described an incident in an old oil mill where a steam vessel had burst.

In the official account, two permanent workers were listed as injured.

But the article said four daily-wage labourers had also been inside that night.

Their names were not entered in the payment register.

Therefore they were also absent from the compensation list.

The writer's name had partly faded:

"Shashi..."

Kaushal asked, "Was this printed?"

Neeraj shook his head.

"No."

"How do you know?"

Neeraj took another paper from his bag.

It was an old letter.

“My grandfather was Shashibhushan Mishra,” he said. “He wrote this article.”

Kaushal stared at him.

“You are not Raghunath Babu’s grandson.”

“No. I am the grandson of the man who wrote the article.”

The story could suddenly have become simple.

One side guilty.

The other side wronged.

But Neeraj’s next sentence broke that simplicity.

“Later my grandfather regretted one thing in the article.”

“What?”

“He had directly named the mill owner as guilty. The evidence was incomplete. It was unclear who had decided to postpone repairs to the steam vessel.”

Kaushal looked again at the paper.

“Then it was right to stop the article?”

Neeraj’s eyes hardened.

“One sentence in the article was weak. The names of four labourers were not weak.”

That night no more letters fell.

The next day Kaushal told Raghunath everything.

Neeraj was present too.

For a long time Raghunath said nothing.

At last he sat down on an old chair.

“Was the key your grandfather’s?” he asked Neeraj.

“No. I found it among my uncle’s old papers. I did not know why he had a key to the rear room of this press.”

Raghunath closed his eyes.

“I gave it to him.”

For a while the only sound in the room came from the street.

Then Raghunath began to speak slowly.

At the time, he had been twenty-two.

Shashibhushan was his friend.

The article had been composed at night.

The first proof had also been printed.

Before dawn Raghunath’s father saw it.

“He became frightened,” Raghunath said.

“People from the mill owner had threatened to withdraw advertisements.

The press was already in debt.

But fear was not the only reason.”

He looked at Neeraj.

“Your grandfather had written more than the evidence supported about one man.

I told him—remove the name, keep the facts about the labourers.

He refused.”

“Then?”

"I stopped the proof."

Neeraj's jaw tightened.

"And the four labourers?"

Raghunath's voice dropped.

"Their names stopped too."

"Why?"

Raghunath took time to answer.

"Because once the press had stopped the article, printing another version required courage.

I did not have that courage."

Kaushal understood.

The central wrong in the story was not only one bad decision.

It was the long silence that followed the decision.

Shashibhushan had asked for the article back.

Raghunath did not return it.

He feared the article would be printed elsewhere with the same unsupported accusation.

He hid the proof in the bottom of the type case.

"For a few days," he said.

A few days became years.

Shashibhushan left the city.

Later people assumed he had taken his article back.

Some called him a coward.

Some said he had been paid to remain silent.

"I knew that was false," Raghunath said.

"But I never corrected it clearly."

Neeraj kept looking at the metal type on the table.

"That is why I made the letters fall," he said.

"I wanted you to read them."

Raghunath gave a bitter laugh.

"I kept reading them even without their falling."

No one spoke immediately after that.

The press remained closed for three days.

On the fourth day Raghunath called Kaushal and Neeraj.

On the table lay the old proof, Shashibhushan's letter, and a new sheet of paper.

The new page carried the heading:

"EDITORIAL NOTE WITH AN OLD UNPUBLISHED ARTICLE."

Neeraj read it.

Raghunath had written that the available papers strongly supported the fact that four labourers' names had been omitted.

But the direct accusation against the mill owner could not be established.

Therefore a facsimile of the original article would be printed with an editorial note clearly separating what was verified from what remained uncertain.

"You will print the original article again?" Neeraj asked.

“With a note wherever the evidence is weak.”

“And your own part?”

Raghunath pushed forward a second paper.

It contained only five lines.

“This press stopped the article.

Questions of evidence were part of the reason, but economic fear was also part of it.

My failure was that afterwards I did not return the article and did not correct the falsehoods that spread about the writer.”

Neeraj read for a long time.

“Is this enough?” Raghunath asked.

Neeraj did not immediately say yes.

“On what day is the word enough ever enough?” he asked softly.

Raghunath lowered his head.

Kaushal opened the old type case.

“If we print it, shall we use the old type?”

For the first time Raghunath looked at him.

“Yes.”

The three of them began selecting letters.

This time no letter fell by itself.

Kaushal searched for ‘cha’.

Neeraj found ‘ri’.

Raghunath selected the pieces for ‘name’.

One compartment was empty.

Raghunath turned the old case over.

The letter was caught in a crack at the bottom.

With a thin needle-like tool he drew it out, wiped it with cloth, and placed it in the composing stick.

At eight forty-seven that night, the oil press started again.

The table trembled faintly.

Some loose metal rattled.

The rear type case had now been levelled.

The steel strips had been removed.

Kaushal had placed the magnetic strip in a separate box.

No letter fell.

Raghunath stood beside the machine.

The first printed sheet came out.

The black letters were clear on the page.

Neeraj read the first line:

“Four names that remained outside the register.”

He did not pick the sheet up at once.

The ink was still wet.

The three stood a little distance away and waited for it to dry.

The table trembled faintly again.

This time the letters were locked inside the forme.

The metal rang, but did not move from its place.

Raghunath reached out and tested the pressure on the type frame.
“The lock-up is right,” he said.
Kaushal understood that the matter was not only about printing.
Some letters had fallen because the case was crooked.
Some lines had remained suppressed because human beings were afraid.
The two things could not be corrected with the same tool.

THE SOOT OF THE LAST LANTERN

It was the last week of Bhadon. The sky had remained grey all day, but no rain had fallen.

The air over the old eastern embankment of the Kamla River was heavy—so heavy that it seemed some distant cloud was sitting still under its own weight.

The first thing Navalkishore Mishra saw when he reached the veranda of the outpost was the lantern.

It hung from the same iron hook where, eighteen years earlier, he had spent the night watching the last flood of his service years.

The brass had gone dull. Small green rust spots marked the oil reservoir. The upper half of the glass was blackened with soot.

Navalkishore stopped.

“Who lit this?”

The present watchman, Manoj Paswan, came out from inside with a broom in his hand.

“What?”

Navalkishore indicated the lantern with his lips.

Manoj was silent for a moment.

“It is old.”

“The lantern is old. The soot is new.”

Manoj leaned the broom against the wall.

“You can tell the age of soot too?”

“I did this work for thirty-five years.”

No smile appeared on Manoj’s face. He stepped down from the veranda and looked along the top of the embankment. Far away, the plumes of kans grass trembled faintly even without wind.

Navalkishore had come to the outpost for three days.

The Water Resources Department was going to remove the old hut and build a new brick room. Old registers, tools, measuring rods, red flags, ropes, tin trunks—whatever was still useful had to be separated out.

Assistant Engineer Ishani Chaudhary had said, “You know the old equipment. Manoj will not recognise everything by himself.”

Navalkishore had agreed.

The moment he saw the outpost, an old smell rose around him—wet sacks, kerosene, rust, neem smoke, paper.

The smell was so familiar that for one instant he felt he had not retired at all; he had merely gone home after his last shift and had now returned for duty.

But the soot on the lantern drew a black line through that illusion.

The lantern should not have been lit for years.

Five years earlier the department had supplied rechargeable torches. A small solar panel had also been installed at the outpost.

Navalkishore took the lantern down.

He ran a finger across the lower part of the glass.

The soot was soft.

His finger turned black.

“Manoj.”

“Yes.”

“Who lit it?”

“I told you—I don’t know.”

“You are the only night watchman.”

“At night, yes. During the day there are labourers, herders, fishermen, engineers—who does not come here?”

The answer was correct.

The tone was not.

Navalkishore examined the glass again.

Inside, the wick stood half a finger high.

Its top was cut on a fresh slant.

An old dried wick would not look so even.

He opened the oil reservoir.

A quarter of it held kerosene.

Somewhere inside his body an old coldness awakened.

Eighteen years earlier, a lantern too had burned all night.

That night the water had risen to the shoulder of the embankment.

At 11:20 p.m. Navalkishore first saw a long wet fissure on the southern bend.

He ran back to the outpost, lifted the wired telephone, and informed the subdivision office.

Later, the report recorded the time as 12:05 a.m.

Forty-five minutes disappeared.

Those forty-five minutes appeared nowhere in his service register.

But they had remained inside him every day.

Until noon, Navalkishore sorted old equipment with Manoj.

Manoj worked normally—coiling rope, setting aside a rusted spade, blowing dust from the 2008 rain register.

The lantern was not mentioned again.

In the evening Ishani Chaudhary called and said she would come for inspection the next morning.

There had been continuous rain upstream. The water level could rise during the night.

“Have you checked the southern bend?” Navalkishore asked Manoj casually.

Manoj’s hand stopped for half a moment.

“I check it every day.”

“Anything?”

“Nothing yet that I would write in the register.”

Navalkishore studied his face.

“Nothing like that—meaning?”

Manoj lifted a sack and carried it inside.

“The water will rise tonight. Let us make tea first.”

The day faded without the sun ever appearing.

On the small stove behind the outpost, Manoj made tea.

Navalkishore sat on the veranda.

The river lay on the other side of the embankment. It could not be seen, only heard—dense, low, continuous.

By eight the wind had risen.

Navalkishore lay down on a cot, but sleep did not come.

Even with his eyes closed, he could see the soot on the lantern glass.

Around half past ten came a very faint scrape at the door.

Navalkishore opened his eyes.

Manoj’s cot was empty.

A yellow light moved across the veranda.

He got up.

At the doorway came the smell of oil.

Manoj was walking south along the crest of the embankment with the lantern in his hand.

A torch hung at his waist, but it was switched off.

Without making a sound, Navalkishore put on his shoes and followed at a distance.

The embankment earth had dried during the day, but night dew made its surface slightly slick.

Manoj did not walk quickly.

Every five or ten steps he stopped, lowered the lantern close to the earth, studied the ground, then moved on.

The southern bend lay about half a kos from the outpost.

There the embankment curved towards the river.

The old bamboo measuring stake had half-rotted away.

Manoj stopped beside it.

Navalkishore remained behind a clump of kans grass.

Manoj held the lantern only a hand-span above the soil.

In the slanting yellow light, a fine black shadow rose along the slope of the embankment.

Navalkishore’s breath caught.

A crack.

Very fine.

From above it looked like ordinary drying of the soil.

But in oblique light its edges were clear.

Nearly two cubits long.

Manoj took a thin oil-rubbed sheet of paper from his bag.

He laid it over the crack and rubbed something like charcoal across it.

Then he wrote the date.

Navalkishore stepped forward.

“What are you doing?”

Manoj startled so violently the lantern nearly fell from his hand.

“You?”

“Yes. Where did this crack come from?”

Manoj said nothing.

Navalkishore took the lantern and held it low over the soil.

At one end of the fissure lay fresh crumbly earth.

He touched it with a finger.

Slight dampness inside.

“Why is this not in the register?”

Manoj’s face hardened.

“I wrote it.”

“When?”

“Three times.”

“Where?”

“First on the seventeenth. Second on the nineteenth. Third yesterday.”

“It is not in the register.”

“Not anymore.”

A gust of wind came.

The lantern flame shivered inside the glass.

Navalkishore asked slowly, “What do you mean?”

Manoj opened his bag.

Inside were three thin sheets of paper—three tracings of the crack at different stages.

The first was short.

The second somewhat longer.

The third the longest.

“On the first day I wrote it in the register. The next morning a junior engineer came. He said, ‘It is a shrinkage crack in dry soil. Nothing to fear.’ In the evening I looked again. My line in the register had been crossed out. Beside it was written: ‘Surface contraction.’”

“Who crossed it out?”

“I don’t know.”

“And the second time?”

“I wrote separately and sent it to the office. They would not give me a receipt stamp. They said first there had to be a site inspection. The third time I sent a photograph by phone. The reply was: ‘Not clear.’”

Navalkishore looked at the crack.

“And these papers?”

“For comparison. In daylight this fissure looks flat. In slanting yellow light, the shadow of the edge becomes clear. Every day I trace it from the same angle.”

“Why not use the torch?”

“Its light falls straight. If I hold this lantern low, the shadow becomes longer.”

“And the soot?”

Manoj looked at the lantern.

"I trim the wick short, but the air vent is half closed. It smokes."

"Why keep the vent half closed?"

For the first time Manoj smiled faintly, though there was no humour in it.

"When the glass turns black, people ask why the lantern is being lit. If they ask, perhaps they will look at the crack too."

Navalkishore kept looking at him.

He had not expected that answer.

"This is how you preserve evidence?"

"There is another way."

Manoj twisted the bottom of the lantern.

A thin round brass plate slid off beneath the oil reservoir.

Inside was a hollow space.

Four folded paper strips were hidden there.

Navalkishore took one out.

Date.

Time.

Water level.

Length of crack.

Weather.

Everything written down.

At the bottom was Manoj's signature.

On two slips was also the thumb impression of Ramvilas, a labourer who cut kans grass.

"Why keep them here?"

"Papers in the outpost cupboard can change without anyone being told. No one opens the lantern."

Navalkishore's fingers froze against the brass.

Eighteen years earlier he too had seen a paper altered.

But he had not saved the paper.

He had signed beneath the altered time.

"The water level?" His own voice sounded heavy.

"Seven fingers higher since yesterday."

"Seepage?"

"Not outside yet. The soil near the inner toe is damp."

Navalkishore said at once, "Back to the outpost. We call Ishani now."

Manoj stopped him.

"She will come in the morning."

"Morning may be too late."

Manoj looked into his eyes.

"Have you said that sentence somewhere before?"

The question was not casual.

Navalkishore did not answer.

They returned to the outpost.

Navalkishore opened his mobile phone.

The network was weak.

He dialled Ishani's number.

Once.

Twice.

No connection.

The third time the call rang, but no one answered.

Manoj placed an old register on the table.

"The registers from your time are in this trunk."

Navalkishore stared at him.

"What are you trying to say?"

"Nothing. Only that while sorting the old papers yesterday I found one page."

He took the thick 2008 register from the tin trunk.

A red cloth ribbon marked a page in the middle.

He opened it.

Navalkishore recognised the line without reading it.

"23:20 — wet fissure at southern bend; immediate information sent."

The ink was faint, but the handwriting was his.

A blue line had been drawn through it.

Beside it was written:

"00:05 — first visual inspection; prior information unconfirmed."

Below were three signatures.

One belonged to Navalkishore.

Manoj asked, "Your signature?"

Navalkishore's mouth went dry.

"Yes."

"Was the time changed?"

Navalkishore turned towards the window.

Outside, the yellow lantern light trembled across the veranda.

"That night..." he began, then stopped.

Manoj waited.

"That night I informed them at eleven twenty. The subdivision office replied: 'It may be a local surface crack. Observe again.' At eleven forty the fissure had grown. I informed them again. Shortly before midnight, water appeared on the inner slope. At twelve five the assistant engineer arrived."

"Then?"

"By dawn the embankment had breached."

Manoj asked quietly, "Why was the time changed?"

Navalkishore sat down on the chair.

"When the report was prepared, they said that if the first warning remained recorded, questions would be asked about why nothing had been done for forty-five minutes. The officer said, 'You were not certain about the first fissure. Write that it was only a suspicion.' I refused."

"And then?"

"He had many ways of speaking. Service. Suspension. My daughter... her wedding was that month. He did not say all those things. I heard them myself. A frightened mind hears even unspoken things very clearly."

Manoj's face neither softened nor hardened.

Navalkishore continued.

"I signed it."

"And the report?"

"The report said the breach was sudden. Blame fell on Kailash, the temporary labourer at the rear outpost, for not patrolling properly that night. His service was terminated. I knew he was not at fault."

The wind on the veranda bent the lantern flame to one side.

A fresh line of soot formed across the glass.

Manoj did not close the register.

"Kailash was my maternal uncle," he said.

Navalkishore looked up sharply.

Manoj's voice remained flat.

"But I did not take this posting because of that."

Navalkishore could not speak.

"Later Mama went to Punjab. He used to say, 'The water did not blame me. The paper did.' I was small then and did not understand. Now I do."

Inside the outpost there was only the faint sound of the lantern flame.

Navalkishore placed a finger on the altered line in the register.

"You already knew who I was?"

"By name."

"So the soot... all this was meant for me to see?"

"No." Manoj answered immediately. "The crack existed before you came. The lantern was being lit before you came. You happened to see it. That is all."

A strange relief rose in Navalkishore—and then shame at the relief.

Some part of him had wanted all of this to have been arranged for him, so that the present danger would become smaller.

But the danger was not a play staged around his guilt.

There was a real crack in the earth.

Far away lightning flashed.

The sound arrived a little later.

Manoj said, "Try the network again."

Navalkishore lifted the phone.

This time Ishani answered on the first ring.

"Hello?"

"Ishani ji, there is a crack at the southern bend. It has been growing for three days. The soil inside is damp. Now."

"How long?"

"More than two cubits. There are comparison tracings. The water level is rising."

There was silence for a few moments at the other end.

Then Ishani's voice changed.

"Had Manoj reported it?"

Navalkishore looked at Manoj.

"Yes. Three times."

"I received one photograph, but it was unclear. No written paper reached me. Both of you remain there. I am leaving the subdivision office with a team. Do not go down on the river side of the crack."

The call ended.

Manoj asked, "Now?"

"Now we do not wait. Prepare sandbags. Do not load the crack itself. Check the dampness at the inner toe. Write the times."

Both went to work.

11:47 p.m.—water level one finger higher.

12:02 a.m.—damp strip at the inner toe wider.

12:09 a.m.—middle of the crack opened by about the width of a fingernail.

Manoj kept writing the times.

Navalkishore kept holding the lantern low.

At one o'clock the distant sound of a jeep arrived.

Ishani came with two engineers and four labourers.

After inspection, orders were given:

sandbags behind the dangerous section,

a small drainage channel at the inner toe,

and soil strengthening after dawn without heavy machinery.

A message was also sent upstream to reduce the rate of water release from the gate.

Ishani examined Manoj's slips.

"I need these papers."

Manoj removed all of them from the bottom of the lantern.

Ishani looked surprised.

"You kept them here?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

For a moment Manoj looked towards Navalkishore.

"I trusted the old cupboard less."

Ishani said nothing.

She photographed every slip with her phone and returned the originals to Manoj.

"In the morning, get them entered in the office receipt register. In front of me."

Navalkishore asked, "And the old register too?"

Ishani looked at him.

"Which one?"

Navalkishore lifted the 2008 register.

"This."

No rain began before dawn.

The sky merely hung low.

The danger had not passed, but the crack was no longer unseen.

Shortly before sunrise, Navalkishore sat at the table.

The old register lay open before him.

A narrow blank margin remained beside the altered time.

He picked up a pen.

Manoj stood at the doorway.

“Do not erase the old line,” he said.

Navalkishore looked at him.

“I won’t.”

In the empty margin he wrote:

“Today, eighteen years later, I, Navalkishore Mishra, acknowledge that the first information was given at 23:20. I accepted the revised time of 00:05 under pressure and fear. The original first entry was correct.”

Below it he wrote the date.

He signed.

Manoj stepped forward and read the page.

“This will not give Mama his service back,” he said.

“I know.”

“Nor will it return anything to the people who lost their homes in the flood.”

“I know.”

“Then?”

Navalkishore closed the pen.

“To leave a false line standing alone is also a decision.”

Manoj was silent for a few moments.

Then he did not close the register.

He left it open so the ink could dry.

On the veranda Ishani took down the lantern and examined it.

“Was this on the discard list?”

Navalkishore came outside.

Manoj said, “Not anymore.”

Ishani looked at the black soot on the glass.

“It smokes too much. Have the air vent cleaned.”

Manoj smiled.

“I will.”

Navalkishore took the lantern in his hands.

Compared with the previous night, the glass was even blacker.

He picked up a cloth to clean it, then stopped.

“Not yet,” he said.

Manoj asked, “Why?”

Navalkishore hung the lantern back on the hook.

“Let the inspection team see it.”

In the first light of dawn, the soot showed clearly.

It was no sign of a ghost.

It said only this:

someone had remained awake through the night.

And this time, the record had preserved the fact of that wakefulness too.

STORY 141

SEVEN MILLIMETRES ON THE NAMEPLATE

From early Monday morning, the veranda of the District Social Assistance Office smelled of fresh-cut wood.

Two days earlier all the old nameplates had been taken down, and now, after renovation, new ones were being fixed in place.

Black letters gleamed against the yellow wall:

“DISTRICT SOCIAL ASSISTANCE OFFICER”

“SECTION IN-CHARGE”

“ACCOUNTS OFFICER”

“ACCOUNTS ASSISTANT”

“RECORDS ASSISTANT”

For the people who worked in the office, these were not merely strips of wood.

One automatically noticed whose letters were thicker, whose plate stood higher, before whose title the word “In-Charge” appeared.

Gopal Jha was an Accounts Assistant.

He had worked in that building for fifteen years, but his desk had always stood in the third room opening towards the corridor.

People entered and first asked,

“Where does the officer sit?”

Gopal showed them the way.

Sometimes they placed a file on his desk, but the moment they realised he was only the Accounts Assistant, they picked it up again.

“This has to go upstairs.”

Gopal would smile as if the sentence were an old acquaintance.

Bauku, the carpenter who had come to fit the new nameplates, carried a measuring tape in his hand.

He held each plate against the wall, tightened two screws, then stepped back and squinted at it.

When Gopal’s plate went up, Mamta, an office assistant, was the first to notice.

“Why is your plate larger than the other Accounts Assistant plate?”

Gopal left his chair and went to the wall.

It truly was a little taller.

The lettering was the same size, but the wood was broader.

Bauku measured it.

“Seven millimetres.”

“Why seven millimetres?” Gopal asked.

“There was leftover wood,” Bauku said casually. “It had already been cut to the size of the plate above. I was supposed to trim seven millimetres off the bottom, but the edge would have gone crooked. I thought an Accounts Assistant’s work would not change because of seven millimetres.”

Mamta laughed.

"The work may not. The importance might."

Everyone laughed.

Gopal did too.

At that moment the remark carried no weight.

By noon the first effect appeared.

Vimla Devi, seventy years old, stood in the corridor holding an old cloth bag and a file.

Her widow assistance had been stalled for three months.

She had already come twice before.

This time, reading the new nameplates one by one, she stopped at Gopal's room.

She did not fully understand what "Accounts Assistant" meant, but the size of the plate was almost the same as the plate outside the next room marked Section In-Charge.

"Babu, do you look after my case?"

There was a kind of respect in her voice that Gopal rarely heard directed at him.

He could immediately have said,

"I am not the In-Charge."

Instead he looked at Vimla Devi's face.

Sweat on her forehead.

A strip of medicine visible at the edge of her bag.

The file papers softened at their corners.

"Sit," he said. "Let me see."

The moment he opened the file, he saw that the matter was not difficult.

A correction letter for the bank account number had arrived two months earlier, but verification of the old number being struck out and the new one entered had remained stuck on one desk.

Gopal carried the file to the room of Section In-Charge Shashibhushan Babu.

"This is Vimla Devi's file," Gopal said. "The verification is complete. Only the order line has to be written."

Shashibhushan Babu raised his spectacles and looked at Gopal.

"Why are you in such a hurry?"

"It has been three months."

"Three months is not very long in this office."

Gopal said nothing.

He placed the file on the desk.

Shashibhushan Babu looked towards the new plates on the wall.

For a few moments his gaze rested on Gopal's nameplate.

"Why is your plate so large?"

"Carpenter's mistake."

"Have it changed."

"I have told him."

Shashibhushan Babu opened the file, wrote two lines, and signed.

“Here. Now send it to Accounts.”

Gopal returned with the file.

A faint pleasure rose in him.

The work had moved.

Whether it moved because of the plate or because Vimla Devi had already waited three months did not, at that moment, seem important.

The next day a supplier came directly into Gopal’s room.

“Sir, please take a look at this payment.”

“I am not ‘sir,’” Gopal said. “I am the Accounts Assistant.”

The man smiled.

“I know, but everyone was saying decisions get made quickly in this room.”

Gopal did not like the sentence.

He turned the file around.

“Follow the proper channel.”

Even so, that afternoon two employees came to ask for his “remarks” on a paper.

Previously such a paper would have gone to Shashibhushan Babu’s desk.

Gopal wrote:

“Compliant from the accounts side.”

His hand paused for an instant as he wrote it.

In fifteen years he had formed such remarks in his mind thousands of times.

He had rarely had the opportunity to put them on paper.

On the third day Mamta asked again,

“Did you tell them to replace the plate?”

“Bauku has not come.”

“Did you call him?”

Looking down at a paper, Gopal said,

“I will call tomorrow.”

The truth was that he had not called Bauku at all.

Within a week, seven millimetres altered the invisible geography of the office.

Visitors looked first at the nameplate, then at the face.

Two or three times people left Shashibhushan Babu’s room and came to Gopal.

Someone had a mismatch in a pension number.

Someone’s death-certificate copy was blurred.

Someone’s bank branch had changed its name.

Gopal did not settle every file by his own decision, but he immediately understood where each one was stuck.

For the first time, his fifteen years of experience looked larger than the designation written on the wall.

On the seventh afternoon, a newly appointed clerk named Neeraj came with a request to correct his attendance entry.

Gopal said,

“This belongs to the Establishment Section.”

Neeraj remained standing.

“They told me there that you would see it.”

Gopal was surprised.

“Who told you?”

Neeraj shrugged.

“Everyone in the veranda.”

In an office, the person called “everyone” was the most influential of all.

He had no desk.

No signature.

But his words travelled faster than a file.

Gopal could have returned the request.

Instead he called the old clerk from Establishment.

Within two minutes the error was found.

Another employee’s number had been entered against Neeraj’s name.

The clerk corrected it then and there.

Delighted, Neeraj said,

“Sir, work really does move quickly when it comes to you.”

This time Gopal did not say,

“I am not sir.”

Not saying it was the first small wrong of that day for which no clause existed in the rulebook.

While leaving in the evening, Gopal turned once on the veranda and looked back at his nameplate.

The words were the same:

Gopal Jha, Accounts Assistant.

No lie was written anywhere.

The lie existed only in the height.

And height does not speak in words.

Perhaps that was why it was harder to oppose.

If the plate had said “Section In-Charge,” Gopal would have had it removed on the first day.

Against seven millimetres, what sentence could one write?

At home, his wife Rama asked,

“Why are you late these days?”

“More work,” Gopal said.

It was half true.

There really was more work.

But some of that work was not his.

After dinner he took out an old copy of his service record.

In fifteen years, promotion had come within reach twice.

The first time, the number of vacancies was reduced.

The second, a seniority dispute became stuck in court.

On paper he was still “Accounts Assistant.”

Only the wood on the wall had moved seven millimetres ahead.

The next day Shashibhushan Babu joked,

"Gopalji, your court is doing brisk business."

Two men in the room laughed.

Gopal smiled too, but there was a thorn inside the joke.

"People come on their own."

"People read the plate," Shashibhushan Babu said. "In an office, half the governing is done by words, half by size."

Then he bent over his papers again.

Gopal could not decide whether it had been sarcasm or a warning.

That afternoon an employee placed a cup of tea on Gopal's desk.

Earlier Gopal had gone outside to get his own tea.

"For me?" he asked.

"Yes, Babu. I left one for you along with the people upstairs."

At the word "upstairs," Gopal's hand stopped over the cup.

He drank the tea.

For a long time afterwards he could not tell what it tasted like.

That evening Mamta said plainly,

"If you want, the wood can still be cut. There is a saw in the storeroom."

Gopal tried to laugh.

"Cut a government nameplate myself? Then there will be another objection."

Mamta replied,

"Are you afraid of an objection, or of losing seven millimetres?"

Gopal said nothing.

Mamta picked up her papers and left.

That night at home, what returned again and again to Gopal was not a dream but a simple scene.

Why had Vimla Devi's file been stuck for three months?

Not because of a difficult rule.

Only because the right person had not looked at the right table at the right time.

If seven millimetres could change where people looked, was the fault in the wood or in the office?

The question offered him a convenient place to hide his own pleasure.

Gopal recognised the convenience.

He still could not let it go.

That week Vimla Devi received her first payment.

She came carrying a small packet of jaggery and makhana.

Gopal refused to take it.

Vimla Devi said,

"If you had not been here, I would have wandered for another two months."

Gopal wanted to answer:

"It was not because of me. Your papers were complete."

But the words did not come out.

Vimla Devi again looked towards the nameplate.

Gratitude stood in her eyes.

Gopal suddenly felt as though he were sitting inside those seven millimetres.

On the tenth day a notice arrived from the district announcing an inspection.

The subject read:

“Office Visual Standardisation and Record Consistency.”

Everyone assumed that registers, files, attendance, and furniture would be examined.

But in the first hour of the inspection, two officers began measuring the nameplates on the wall.

“Officer—seventy-five millimetres.

Section In-Charge—sixty-eight.

Accounts Assistant—sixty-one.”

One inspector stopped his tape at Gopal’s plate.

“Sixty-eight.”

The other inspector looked at Gopal.

“Your sanctioned post?”

“Accounts Assistant.”

“Why is your plate the size of the Section In-Charge plate?”

Gopal said,

“A carpenter’s mistake.”

“How long has it been like this?”

Gopal was silent.

At a distance Mamta was arranging papers.

Her hands stopped.

“About twelve days,” Gopal said.

“Why was it not corrected in twelve days?”

“The carpenter did not come.”

“Did you give written notice?”

“No.”

The inspector wrote:

“Visual designation indicator inconsistency.”

Then he asked,

“During this period, did you perform any work that arose from people assuming you held a higher post?”

Vimla Devi came into Gopal’s mind.

The supplier.

The two employees asking for remarks.

He could have said,

“No.”

No formal order had been issued under his signature.

But he knew the question was not only about signatures.

“People misunderstood sometimes,” he said.

“Did you correct them?”

Gopal remembered Mamta’s laugh on the first day:

“The importance might change.”

“At first I corrected them,” he said. “Later, not every time.”

For a few moments the room was silent.

The inspector had perhaps not expected such an answer.

He wrote:

“Employee did not dispel the misunderstanding on every occasion.”

A meeting was called in the afternoon.

The subject was the size of the nameplate.

Shashibhushan Babu said,

“It was an ordinary carpentry error. There is no need to turn it into such a major issue.”

The inspector replied,

“Visual signals are part of administration.”

Mamta whispered into Gopal’s ear,

“Were Vimla Devi’s three months not a visual signal?”

Gopal looked at her.

He did not smile.

The meeting decided:

the carpenter would be asked for an explanation;

Gopal would submit a written clarification;

all nameplates would be remeasured;

a size register would be created;

in future, before any plate was mounted, the Section In-Charge would verify it.

No one asked how many stalled files had moved during the previous twelve days, or why they had moved.

That evening Gopal sat down to write his explanation.

His first line was:

“The error in the nameplate size occurred through the carpenter.”

He stopped.

The second line:

“At the outset I orally requested that the error be corrected.”

That was true.

The third line was difficult.

After a long time he wrote:

“In the days that followed, it became clear that some visitors understood my post to be higher because of the size of the plate. I did not immediately correct this misunderstanding on every occasion.”

After that sentence he did not feel relief.

He felt a straight line of shame.

Seven millimetres wide.

The next day Bauku the carpenter came.

As he removed the old plate he said,

“Because of me, you had to write an explanation?”

“It began because of you,” Gopal said. “After that, it continued because of me.”

Bauku measured the new plate.

Sixty-one millimetres.

“Now it is correct.”

He was about to throw away the old sixty-eight-millimetre plate, but the storeroom assistant stopped him.

“Government property. It will be entered in the inventory.”

“It is not broken,” Bauku said.

“All the more reason. Keep it as an extra nameplate.”

In the stores register the item was entered as:

“One extra wooden nameplate, size sixty-eight millimetres, unusable.”

Gopal read the line and remained silent.

He felt like adding:

“Former effect: equivalent to Section In-Charge.”

He said nothing.

A few days later an elderly man entered the office leaning on a stick.

He read the plates on the wall.

His eyes passed over Gopal’s smaller plate, then he went straight towards Shashibhushan Babu’s room.

There was a crowd at the door.

The old man turned and stood in the veranda.

Gopal rose from his chair.

“What work do you have?”

“I need to meet the senior babu.”

“Show me the papers first. It may not be necessary to go to the senior babu.”

The old man opened the papers.

Gopal stood by the corridor window and began reading them.

This time the nameplate behind him was small.

There was no borrowed height in his voice.

Inside the storeroom, the old sixty-eight-millimetre plate was gathering dust.

Its status in the register read:

“Unusable.”

Perhaps for the first time in the office, the word meant exactly what it said.

STORY 142

THE EMPTY SPACE BETWEEN TWO SIGNATURES

In the payments room of the District Cooperative Office, paper had a peculiar geography.

The member number sat in the upper-left corner.

The date in the upper-right.

The amount in the middle.

Two signature spaces lay at the bottom.

But between those two signatures, a small square was also printed.

No name.

No designation.

No word saying “seal.”

No word saying “remarks.”

Only four thin lines.

The employees called it “the middle box.”

A new employee would ask during the first week:

“What goes here?”

An old employee would reply:

“Leave it for now. It will come from above.”

Where exactly “above” was, no file made clear.

Madhav Jha had joined the cooperative office five months earlier.

He was a junior clerk, and he had a habit of reading not only the order of papers but also the language of papers.

The first time he received a payment voucher, he opened the rules.

They stated plainly:

for withdrawal of funds, the signatures of the Accounts Assistant and the Secretary were required.

There was no mention anywhere of a third signature.

Madhav asked,

“What is this square in the middle?”

Umakant Babu, sitting at the next desk, pushed his spectacles up his nose.

“Intermediate approval.”

“Whose?”

“The middle officer’s.”

“What is the designation?”

Umakant Babu thought for a few moments.

“Earlier it used to be called ‘joint verification.’”

“And now?”

“Now too, probably the same. The designation may have changed.”

Madhav checked the staffing register.

The office had a Secretary, Assistant Secretary, Accounts Assistant, Store Clerk, Field Supervisor, two Junior Clerks, and one attendant.

There was no post called “joint verification.”

Umakant Babu smiled.

“The staffing register does not tell you everything. Watch the work.”

The work did indeed say many things.

A payment voucher would leave with the Secretary’s signature.

The Accounts Assistant would sign it.

Then the middle box would remain empty.

Because of that empty box, the file would go “up” for “intermediate approval.”

At the upper desk, the Assistant Secretary would write:

“Relevant branch to examine.”

The relevant branch would send the file back to Accounts.

Accounts would write:

“Intermediate approval required.”

Then the file would stand outside the Secretary’s room.

Madhav asked,

“If the post does not exist, who gives the approval?”

Umakant Babu answered,

“That is why the file is standing.”

The answer was so natural in the office that Madhav felt his question had been rude.

What surprised Madhav was not that no one knew what the square meant.

What surprised him was that everyone had a different meaning for it.

The Store Clerk said,

“This is for verification.”

The Field Supervisor said,

“Someone from the district used to come and sign there.”

Attendant Rambabu said,

“Earlier a red seal was stamped there.”

Accounts Assistant Devendra Babu believed it was perhaps a remnant of some old audit system.

One day Madhav wrote all these explanations on a small piece of paper.

Four people.

Four meanings.

All four meanings shared one feature:

in every one of them, the square was necessary.

No one considered that an empty space might simply be allowed to remain empty.

Devendra Babu did not like Madhav’s investigation, though he was not angry with him either.

His fear was practical.

Two years earlier, an inspection objection had been raised against a payment, and three employees had spent a month writing explanations.

“Inspectors ask about what they can see on paper,” he would say.

“If they see a blank space, they will ask why it is blank.”

Madhav replied,

"Then if they see it filled, will they not ask who filled it?"

Devendra Babu smiled.

"That is why government service requires age."

Sarojini Kumari, the newest employee in the office, matched names against the membership register.

Hearing the discussion, she said,

"We were never taught about a third signature in training."

Umakant Babu said,

"Training does not teach many things. In service, paper teaches by itself."

Sarojini looked at the square.

"This seems to be teaching even without anything written in it."

That week an elderly farmer named Harinarayan Mandal arrived.

He was owed thirteen thousand four hundred and eighty rupees for paddy procurement.

The paddy had reached the cooperative warehouse three months earlier.

The weighing slip was clear.

The moisture test was clear.

The member number was clear.

The two required signatures were also clear.

The middle box was empty.

Harinarayan seemed to handle his walking stick more carefully than his file.

He sat on the chair in front of Madhav's desk and asked,

"How many more days?"

Madhav looked at the file.

"There are two signatures."

"I too have two eyes," Harinarayan said.

"Does the money need a third eye?"

Madhav did not laugh.

There was less irritation than exhaustion in the old man's voice.

"The middle approval is still pending," Madhav said.

"Who gives it?"

No answer came immediately from Madhav.

"I am looking into that."

Harinarayan placed both hands on the handle of his stick.

"I have come five times.

The first time they said the Secretary's signature was pending.

The second time Accounts.

The third time they said the middle one.

The fourth time they said the middle babu was in a meeting.

Today is the fifth time.

I only want this much:

next time, tell me the name of the person I am supposed to find."

Madhav began reading the remarks written on the file.

"For intermediate approval."

"For consideration at middle level."

“Relevant middle officer.”

“After due intermediate approval.”

There were many words.

Not one person.

Harinarayan’s file was a solid object amid all these theories.

On it was written:

paddy weight—18 quintals 40 kilograms.

Below that:

deductions.

Transport.

Amount payable.

For the old farmer, these were not merely figures.

After kharif, he had taken seed on credit for the next sowing.

The shopkeeper had not yet pressured him.

But Harinarayan would say,

“The worst thing about debt is not the interest.

It is seeing your own name in someone else’s ledger.”

He did not ask for anyone’s mercy.

Once Madhav said he could take him directly to the Secretary if he wished.

Harinarayan refused.

“If my paper moves by rule, someone else’s will move too.

If it moves because they see my stick, what happens to the one who comes without a stick?”

Madhav liked the sentence.

But he did not turn Harinarayan into an example of moral perfection and feel reassured.

The next day the old man himself tried to give attendant Rambabu fifty rupees for tea.

“For letting me know about the paper.”

Rambabu returned it.

Harinarayan was embarrassed.

Madhav saw that waiting could make a person both principled and impatient at once.

That day another payment voucher arrived in the office.

It was for money owed to a widowed member for milk collection.

Its middle box was empty too.

Sarojini raised her pen to copy the old sentence onto the file:

“Intermediate approval required.”

Madhav stopped her.

“Required from whom?”

Sarojini held the pen in the air.

“This is what the old files say.”

“Then should we copy only what we ourselves understand?”

After a few moments Sarojini did not write the sentence.

She left the space blank.

For the first time in that office, leaving something blank became a decision.

That afternoon Madhav went to the old records room.

In a dusty wooden cupboard, ten years of payment vouchers were tied in bundles.

On some vouchers, the middle box contained a round seal.

On some, the word "Seen."

On some, only a diagonal line.

On a voucher from three years earlier, Umakant Babu's signature appeared in the middle box.

Madhav asked,

"Were you the middle officer?"

Umakant Babu was startled.

"When?"

Madhav showed him the voucher.

Umakant Babu removed his spectacles and held the paper away from his face.

"At that time the Secretary said it was not good to leave the box empty.

So I signed."

"What was your post then?"

"Accounts Clerk."

"If you signed now?"

Umakant Babu immediately shook his head.

"Not now. Inspections are much stricter now."

Madhav felt that the answer contained the whole philosophy of the office.

When the rule was unclear, a signature could be added.

When people began looking for the rule, no one dared sign.

Madhav found the old telephone number of the district cooperative office and spoke to a senior assistant.

The moment he heard the question, the man asked,

"What version of the form do you have?"

"Number 17-B."

"Form 17-B requires two signatures."

"And the square in the middle?"

There was silence on the telephone for a few moments.

"That must be part of your local printing.

It is not in our sample."

Madhav was startled.

The local voucher had the square.

The district's current sample did not.

He searched for the old printing bill.

Five years earlier, a press called Mithila Printing Works had printed the vouchers.

The bill said:

"As per old sample."

Mithila Printing Works was now a small shop in another market lane.

Madhav could not leave during office hours, so Rambabu asked there on his way home.

The next day he reported,

“The printer said he copied whatever sample was given to him.

The square was already there.

He remembers that once there was also a faint round mark inside it.”

This strengthened Madhav’s suspicion.

But it was not yet proof.

A printer’s memory of a faint mark was not a rule.

He needed the old sample.

The next day Harinarayan returned.

This time he was not chewing paan.

“Did you find the name?”

“Not yet.”

“Then did you find the post?”

“Not that either.”

Harinarayan studied Madhav’s face for a moment.

“If there is an empty place in the middle of a field, I fill it with soil.

You people are searching for a man to fill an empty place.”

This time Madhav laughed.

Harinarayan smiled faintly too.

That evening Madhav searched for an older edition of the rules.

In the records room he found a thin booklet from 2009.

It contained a sample payment voucher.

Between the two signatures was the same square.

But inside it, in tiny letters, were the words:

“Cooperative Emblem.”

Madhav carried the booklet to Umakant Babu.

“Look at this.”

Umakant Babu read it.

“Yes. Earlier the emblem used to be printed.”

“Then where did ‘intermediate approval’ come from?”

Picking at a corner of the paper, Umakant Babu said,

“Hard to say.

Once the emblem was omitted in printing.

The square remained.

Someone must have said—do not leave it empty.

Perhaps after that someone signed there.

Then people began to think the signature was necessary.”

“And the rule?”

“The rule says two signatures.”

“Then Harinarayan’s payment?”

Madhav made a copy of the old sample page and placed it beside the current voucher.

The lines matched.

The old emblem had disappeared.

The square remained.
 As though a house had collapsed and people had mistaken its doorway for the resident.
 That day Umakant Babu took an old round seal from his desk drawer.
 The rubber had dried.
 It bore the cooperative's old paddy-ear emblem.
 "Perhaps this used to be stamped there," he said.
 Madhav placed the seal over the square.
 It almost fit exactly.
 "So people created an officer in place of a seal?" Sarojini asked.
 Umakant Babu said,
 "Not people.
 We did.
 Slowly."
 No single person stood apart as guilty inside that "we."
 That made the matter more uncomfortable.
 Umakant Babu fell silent.
 His silence was not merely fear.
 Thirty years in service had taught him that a written rule was one thing and later responsibility another.
 He said quietly,
 "You are new.
 Paper sees rules.
 Inspectors see custom.
 Breaking custom is not easy."
 Madhav asked,
 "What if the custom was built on a misunderstanding?"
 "Then its age gives it strength."
 Meanwhile the pile of payment vouchers in Secretary Shashibhushan Prasad's room kept growing.
 Five files.
 Nine.
 Fourteen.
 All had the two required signatures.
 All had the middle box empty.
 One day, outside the Secretary's room, Umakant Babu joked,
 "The middle officer is very busy."
 No one laughed.
 The Secretary called everyone to a meeting.
 On the table lay the old rules, the new rules, three payment vouchers, and a measuring tape.
 The tape was not for nameplates.
 It was for measuring the empty square.
 The Secretary measured it.
 Thirty-two millimetres by thirty-two millimetres.

Before starting the meeting, he spent five minutes laying the vouchers one over another and aligning the squares.

Every square was the same size.

Perhaps it comforted him to know that at least the confusion had been standardised.

Devendra Babu presented his position.

"I am not in favour of an additional signature.

But if the old practice has been accepted in audit, removing it suddenly may raise questions."

Madhav said,

"There was no uniformity in the old practice either.

Sometimes a seal.

Sometimes a signature.

Sometimes a line.

That is not procedure.

It is fear signing itself in different forms."

Shashibhushan Prasad interrupted at once.

"No speeches.

Evidence."

Madhav placed the old rulebook, the district's current sample, the dried round seal, and the payment voucher on the table.

Each piece of evidence was small.

Placed side by side, they became a story.

"Why was this space made so large?" the Secretary asked.

Madhav answered,

"For the old cooperative emblem."

Umakant Babu nodded.

Accounts Assistant Devendra Babu said,

"But for many years files have been sent for intermediate approval."

The Secretary asked,

"Who gives it?"

Silence spread through the room.

Attendant Rambabu stood near the door.

Quietly he said,

"I carry the files upstairs."

The Secretary looked at him.

"Upstairs to whom?"

Rambabu thought.

"Wherever I am told."

"Who tells you?"

Rambabu thought again.

"Whichever desk the file comes from."

For a moment the meeting reached a place where every person was correct in his own position and the sequence of work was wrong.

Madhav opened Harinarayan's file.

"Under the rules, two signatures are sufficient.

This voucher is complete.”

Devendra Babu said,

“What if an inspection raises a question?”

“I will write the relevant rule clause on it.”

“You will write it?”

“Yes.”

The Secretary looked at Madhav.

“And if the payment is objected to?”

A slight fear rose inside Madhav.

Thirteen thousand four hundred and eighty rupees was not a small sum compared with his salary.

If the payment were later declared improper, recovery might be discussed.

Harinarayan sat outside on the veranda, but Madhav did not want to decide by looking at him.

He wanted to decide by looking at the rule.

He said,

“Then I will give a written reply that the two authorised signatures were present.

The empty box is not a post.”

For the first time Umakant Babu spoke clearly.

“I too will support that statement.

Because I saw how this custom began.”

The Secretary leaned back in his chair.

“Then write it on the file.”

Madhav wrote:

“Under Rule 8(a), the two required signatures are available.

The intervening square is an old printed space intended for the cooperative emblem.

No additional approval is required.”

The Secretary signed.

Devendra Babu signed too.

Another argument followed:

would the decision apply only to Harinarayan’s file, or to every stalled voucher?

Devendra Babu wanted one voucher sent as a test case first.

Sarojini said,

“If the rule is the same, which farmer will be made the test?”

Shashibhushan Prasad was not annoyed by the question.

He ordered all fourteen files brought in.

Every one had the two required signatures.

Two files contained calculation errors and were sent back to Accounts.

The remaining twelve were complete under the rules.

Madhav realised that once attention moved away from the empty square, the real errors became easier to see.

While everyone had been watching for an invisible officer, no one had noticed the small calculation mistakes.

The Secretary ordered all twelve payments to move forward and directed that the relevant rule clause be recorded on every file.

The decision was collective.

The signature was the Secretary's.

Even courage in an office ultimately required a signature of the proper size.

The obstruction could have ended there.

But an office often prefers naming an obstruction to ending it.

The next question arose:

how should the empty square now be left?

Someone said draw a line through it.

Someone said write "Not Applicable."

Someone said make a seal.

The Secretary finally ordered:

until new vouchers were printed, write in small letters inside the box:

"NO ADDITIONAL APPROVAL REQUIRED."

"Who will write it?" Devendra Babu asked.

The Secretary looked at Madhav.

"Whoever checks the voucher."

Umakant Babu lowered his face and smiled.

Harinarayan's payment was approved that same evening.

When he heard the amount had been released, he looked first at the paper and then at Madhav.

"Did you find the middle babu?"

"No," Madhav said.

"We discovered he never existed."

Harinarayan frowned.

"Then whom did I wait for five times?"

Madhav had an answer.

But the answer had no person's name.

"For an empty space."

Harinarayan lifted his stick.

"It is good that an empty space draws no salary."

He left.

Three weeks later the newly printed payment vouchers arrived.

The square between the two signature spaces had disappeared.

In its place was only a thin grey line, beneath which tiny letters read:

"For Office Use."

Madhav held the first voucher in his hand.

Devendra Babu ran a finger along the line.

"What are we supposed to write here?"

"Nothing," Madhav said.

Devendra Babu looked at the line again.

"Then why does it say 'For Office Use'?"

Before Madhav could answer, Umakant Babu lifted his old spectacles.

There was tired amusement in his eyes.

"Do not ask that question yet," he said.

“First let us see what people decide to fill in by themselves.”

STORY 143

CHAIR NUMBER ZERO IN THE WAITING ROOM

When the district hospital's new outpatient building opened, during the first week people talked less about doctors, medicines, or examination rooms than they did about the chairs.

In the old veranda people had sat with their backs against the wall, on steps, on window ledges, sometimes on the floor.

In the waiting hall of the new building, forty-eight identical grey chairs had been placed in two rows, and white numbers from 1 to 48 were painted on their backs.

The numbers were for the convenience of the staff.

So the cleaner could identify which chair in which row was loose.

So the repair worker could know which screw needed replacing.

So the inspector could know whether all forty-eight purchased items were present.

The numbers had nothing to do with the patients' order.

But in a hospital, a thing that is perfectly clear on paper often acquires a second meaning by the time it reaches the other side of the wall.

In the right-hand corner of the waiting hall, beside the drinking-water vessel, stood one old iron chair.

Its back was higher than the others.

It was painted blue.

And in the middle, in thick red paint, was the number "o."

One arm bore the mark of an old strip.

The lower right leg was slightly bent.

Why this chair was in the new building was a question for which different staff members had different answers.

Jagdish Babu, the store-room in-charge, said,
"It is an item removed from the old inventory."

Watchman Rambabu said,
"There is no order to throw it out."

Budhni, the cleaner, said,
"If it is kept outside, someone will carry it away."

And Neelam, who wrote the outpatient register, said,
"It was put wherever there was space."

The chair offered no explanation of its own.

Only the zero remained written on its back.

For the first two days no one sat on it.

People filled chairs 1 through 48, then stood against the wall.

They would notice Zero, pause for two moments, then move elsewhere.

In a hospital, a written number often looks like an instruction.

No one understood what instruction "o" was giving.

On the third afternoon, seventy-two-year-old Sheetal Paswan arrived with his grandson Manoj.

He was short of breath.

Manoj took a queue slip from the registration desk, but the crowd was so large that their turn to reach the doctor was still far away.

Sheetal Babu stood for five minutes.

Then his knees began to tremble.

"Sit somewhere," Manoj said.

Every chair was occupied.

Zero, beside the water vessel, was empty.

Without even looking at the number, Sheetal Babu sat down there.

Five minutes later Nurse Rama came to fetch water.

Her eyes fell on Sheetal Babu's lips.

They looked unusually blue.

Rama bent down, checked his pulse, listened to his chest, and said to Manoj,

"Show me the queue slip."

With trembling hands Manoj gave her the paper.

Rama wrote something on it and took Sheetal Babu inside immediately.

The entire incident lasted no more than three minutes.

But the thirty-seven people sitting in the waiting hall saw it in thirty-seven different ways.

One person saw the nurse come directly from a distance to Chair Zero.

Another thought Manoj had shown some special mark.

Someone thought they heard Rama say "first."

An hour later Sheetal Babu was in the observation room on oxygen.

By then Chair Number Zero had already been promoted in the waiting hall.

"It is for serious patients," one woman told another.

"For the elderly," the second replied.

"No, for getting an earlier number," a third person said.

Watchman Rambabu heard them.

"It is nothing special. It is an old chair."

All three looked at him with the kind of kindly expression people use for an employee who does not understand the rules.

The next morning before the hospital opened, a man had placed his towel on Chair Zero to reserve it.

He himself was standing in line at the registration desk.

Behind him stood an elderly woman.

Rambabu picked up the towel and handed it back.

"You cannot reserve a place here."

"My patient is coming."

"Then let the patient sit when they come."

"This is the special chair, isn't it?"

"Nothing special about it."

The man read the nameplate on Rambabu's chest, as though collecting evidence for a later complaint against this statement.

By half past nine, a small line had formed in front of Zero.

Five people stood in it.

Seven of the forty-eight ordinary chairs were empty.

Neelam came out from the registration desk.

"Please sit down."

One woman said,

"I need Zero."

"Why?"

"My husband is very dizzy."

"Then show him to the nurse."

"He will sit on Zero first, then the nurse will see him."

Neelam paused before answering.

Official hospital procedure said that critically ill patients were to receive primary screening at a small table to the left of the entrance.

But that day the table was short one nurse.

People often entered the waiting hall directly.

The rumour about Chair Zero was foolish.

But inside that foolishness, a real weakness in the hospital had found a place for itself.

Neelam said quietly to Rambabu,

"If someone genuinely looks very unwell, send them to Rama Didi."

Rambabu replied,

"People will say I am distributing Zero."

"Then do not distribute Zero. Look at the patient."

"That is not in my job."

Neelam did not smile.

"Then look after the chair. Is that in your job?"

For two moments Rambabu looked at the chair.

In government service, many things are neither within one's post nor entirely outside one's responsibility.

Within a week, Chair Number Zero had become a small hospital legend.

Some said sitting there made the doctor notice you sooner.

Some said it was the "emergency chair."

Some said the District Officer had sat there during an inspection and therefore it was prestigious.

The last story was entirely invented.

Because it sounded the most respectable, it spread the fastest.

Some people went over merely to look at the chair.

Some asked for "o" to be written on their queue slips.

One day Neelam saw the words "Chair-o" written in red ink beside a patient's name on a slip.

"Who wrote this?"

The patient's son said,

"The babu outside."

“Which babu?”

“The one who is telling everyone.”

There was no babu outside.

A young tea seller, answering so many people’s questions, had gradually appointed himself an information clerk.

He charged five rupees for tea.

The information was free.

Free information is often the most expensive.

Neelam struck out the red “Chair-o.”

Five minutes later the patient’s blood pressure was found to be dangerously low.

He was sent inside quickly.

His son came back out and told everyone,

“See? Zero was written there.”

Neelam’s cancellation line became proof of the rumour.

The matter reached the hospital administration when two contradictory letters appeared in the complaint box on the same day.

The first said:

“Influential people seize the special Zero chair and poor patients do not benefit.”

The second said:

“The Chair Number Zero arrangement is excellent. A similar chair should be provided in the women’s ward.”

Superintendent Dr. Pramod Mishra read both letters.

Then he called Store In-Charge Jagdish Babu.

“What is this Chair Zero?”

Jagdish Babu brought not a file but a register.

“Sir, officially, it is nothing.”

“Then why is it in the hospital?”

“Because officially it was never removed either.”

“Explain.”

Jagdish Babu opened the old furniture inventory.

Against Chair Number 73 it read:

“Paint peeled, arm damaged, declared unserviceable.”

On the next page a note in blue ink said:

“Proposed for inclusion in auction list.”

There was no order after that.

“Why is Zero painted on its back?”

“Perhaps someone marked it during the auction process.”

“Perhaps?”

“The old employee has retired.”

“Then remove it.”

Jagdish Babu fell silent.

“What is it?” the Superintendent asked.

“To remove it, we need an item number.”

“Seventy-three, isn’t it?”

“Seventy-three is not in the new building inventory.

It exists in the old auction proposal, but the auction order never came.

If I remove it as 73, there is no such item in the current inventory.

If I write 0, then Chair 0 does not exist in the government register.”

The Superintendent took off his spectacles and placed them on the desk.

“So the most famous chair in the hospital does not exist on paper?”

“Yes, sir.”

“And because it does not exist on paper, it cannot be removed?”

Jagdish Babu answered carefully,

“It can be removed, but later someone may ask which item was removed.”

A small meeting began right there over that question.

The Superintendent called Mahesh Babu from Accounts.

The moment he saw the register, Mahesh Babu said,

“Zero is a number, but not an asset number.

If we treat it as an asset number, it comes before one.

Then the purchase sequence is disturbed.”

Nurse Rama, who happened to enter on another matter, said,

“A patient can also arrive before one, if their breathing is stopping.”

Mahesh Babu looked at her.

“I am talking about the chair sequence, not the patient sequence.”

“That is exactly the problem,” Rama said.

“People are mistaking the chair sequence for the patient sequence.”

The Superintendent asked,

“Then write that the two are unrelated.”

Neelam, standing there with the complaint letters, said quietly,

“People read only half of what is written, sir.”

Mahesh Babu said,

“Then it is their responsibility to read the whole thing.”

Neelam replied,

“People do not come to a hospital after taking training in how to read rulebooks while ill.”

The meeting had been called for five minutes.

It lasted forty-five.

In the end everyone agreed that the chair was not “special.”

But they could not agree whether it was “extra,” “unserviceable,” “unlisted,” or “pending verification.”

Each of the four words belonged to a different branch.

The Superintendent put his spectacles back on.

“In this country an object is destroyed first, and its existence is proved later.”

Jagdish Babu did not laugh.

He understood that the remark could also be applied to his own department.

The next day an order was issued:

“Chair Number 0 shall be removed immediately from the waiting hall and kept safely in stores. Disposal procedure shall be undertaken after verification of item status.”

Rambabu read the order and tried to lift the chair.

Three patients objected at once.

“Why are you removing it?”

“Orders.”

“Where will the serious patients sit?”

“On any chair.”

“Then why was there a Zero?”

Rambabu stood there with the chair half lifted.

No one had given him a written answer to that question.

At that moment a thin woman entered holding the hand of her ten-year-old daughter.

The child’s forehead was hot.

Her eyes were half closed.

Seeing the crowd, the mother panicked.

Chair Zero was half in the air.

“Babu, may my child sit here?” the woman asked.

Rambabu looked at the order.

Then at the child.

Then he placed the chair back on the floor.

“Sit her down. I will call the nurse.”

The child was examined.

She had a high fever but was not in immediate danger.

She remained in the normal queue.

The mother breathed with relief.

Sitting on Zero did not move the child forward.

But no one clearly explained that outside that day.

People saw only that the child sat on Zero and the nurse came.

The order could not be implemented by evening.

The next day the administration tried a different solution.

A white notice was fixed to the wall above the chair:

“CHAIR 0 IS NOT A SPECIAL PRIORITY CHAIR. PATIENT PRIORITY IS DETERMINED BY MEDICAL SCREENING.”

Within fifteen minutes, a line again formed in front of Zero.

Rambabu held his head.

“Now what?”

The young tea seller explained with complete confidence,

“It is written on the notice itself—‘special priority chair.’ People are not reading the whole sentence.”

Neelam came outside.

Indeed, four people were standing there after seeing the large words “SPECIAL PRIORITY CHAIR.”

The word “NOT” in the middle looked small.

She had the notice taken down.

Meanwhile Nurse Rama wrote a short proposal.

A clearly marked primary-screening desk at the entrance.

Two designated chairs before it.

Training for the watchman.

The proposal was medical, but to implement it required approval from three branches:

Building.

Staffing.

Stores.

The file began circulating through all three.

Chair Zero remained in place.

Two weeks later a district inspection took place.

The inspector entered the waiting hall and counted the chairs.

Numbers 1 through 48 were all there.

Then his eyes fell on Zero.

"Is this on the inventory?"

Jagdish Babu replied,

"Pending verification."

"Use?"

Rambabu opened his mouth.

Neelam spoke first.

"For sitting."

The inspector placed a hand on the chair.

"Then why is the number zero on it?"

No one had a certain answer.

The inspector wrote in his notes:

"One additional chair available; include in inventory."

A week later the new stores register arrived.

After the forty-eight grey chairs, the final line read:

"Chair, iron, blue, old—1 unit."

It was assigned item number:

49.

Jagdish Babu breathed with relief.

"Now it can be removed."

But by then Nurse Rama's proposal had been approved.

Two chairs were needed at the entrance for primary screening.

To avoid a new purchase, the Stores Branch wrote:

"Use available extra old chair."

The following Monday, Chair Zero was lifted from the right-hand corner of the waiting hall and placed beside the primary-screening desk at the entrance.

The red "o" was still on its back.

In the register its number had become 49.

People now saw it and asked,

"Is the Zero chair for serious patients?"

Rama would say,

“No. Sit for screening.”
Most people heard “screening.”
The “no” was lost again.
A few months later the red zero had worn partly away.
Old iron began showing beneath the blue paint.
New patients kept arriving at the hospital.
New queue slips kept being issued.
New rules kept being hung on the walls.
In the stores register, Chair 49 became an ordinary regular item.
But in people’s speech it remained Chair Number Zero—
the chair that had never possessed any official authority, but because of
which the hospital had finally been forced to create a real system of primary
screening.

STORY 144

THE LEAVE APPLICATION'S LEAVE

There was no separate branch for leave-related work in the office of Mithila Jan College.

An old iron cupboard, two registers, one red seal, and Harimohan Jha's desk together formed the arrangement everyone called the "Leave Section."

Harimohan himself smiled at the name.

But there was pride in the smile too.

Teachers changed.

Principals changed.

The building was repainted three times.

But the route taken by a leave application changed very little.

First the application.

Then the Head of Department's remark.

Then Harimohan Jha's verification.

Then the Principal's signature.

And finally the entry in the leave register.

Someone might suddenly fall ill.

There might be a death at home.

A train might be missed.

A wedding date might change.

The paper travelled at its own pace.

Harimohan was the guardian of that pace.

He would say,

"A person may run. It is not right to make paper run. Running paper falls."

People laughed at him.

But papers did, in fact, fall less often on his desk.

He sorted applications by date.

Kept medical certificates separately.

Counted the leave days available.

And made a small mark in the corner of the register with a red pencil.

The problem began when Harimohan himself went on long leave.

One evening, while returning home, he twisted his knee on the stairs.

No bone was broken.

But the doctor told him to avoid unnecessary walking for six weeks.

The next day his son brought his leave application to the office.

The application was complete—

except for the Head of Department's remark.

Harimohan did not have a Head of Department.

Principal Raghuvansh Babu looked at the application.

Removed his spectacles.

Put them on again.

Then asked,
 “Who will handle the leave work?”
 Head Clerk Dinanath Babu said,
 “Give it temporarily to Suchitra.”
 Suchitra Kumari had joined six months earlier as a contractual typist.
 Her desk usually received scholarship letters, examination notices, and minutes of meetings.
 She typed quickly.
 Wrote remarks in a clear hand.
 And according to the people in the office, had so far “spoiled no tradition.”
 Dinanath Babu called her.
 “Look after the leave work for a few days.”
 Suchitra asked,
 “The registers and the cupboard key?”
 Dinanath Babu opened his desk drawer and took out a small envelope.
 In Harimohan’s handwriting it said:
 “Duplicate key—do not open except in necessary circumstances.”
 “Is this a necessary circumstance?” Suchitra asked.
 Dinanath Babu looked at the envelope for a while.
 “Hard to say. Harimohan Babu will explain over the telephone in two days.”
 Two days became five.
 Harimohan’s knee had swollen.
 His medicine was changed.
 And his son said the doctor had advised him to keep conversation to a minimum.
 Meanwhile leave applications began piling up outside the cupboard.
 There were nine in the first week.
 Suchitra tied them together by date and placed them on the left side of her desk.
 The tenth application belonged to Dr. Shailja Mishra of the Maithili Department.
 After severe abdominal pain, she had been admitted to the district hospital.
 A medical certificate and investigation slip accompanied the application.
 Shailja’s younger brother handed it over and said,
 “Didi said her salary must not stop. The tests may take several days.”
 Suchitra accepted the application.
 “I am receiving it. The Principal will sanction the leave.”
 “When?”
 She had no answer.
 Dinanath Babu said,
 “The old applications are inside the cupboard.”
 The register has to be opened before we can see how much leave remains available.

Without checking the register, we cannot send this to the Principal.”

Suchitra looked at the envelope.

“Then let us open it.”

Dinanath Babu immediately shook his head.

“Harimohan Babu has clearly written—do not open except in necessary circumstances.”

“Is an ill teacher not a necessary circumstance?”

“The phrase ‘necessary circumstance’ is not defined on paper.”

Everyone in the office found this answer reasonable.

When a matter was not defined, deciding it was considered risky.

For the first time, Suchitra made a small slip.

At the top she wrote:

“Leave application received; verification pending.”

But Dinanath Babu said that if “verification pending” was written, the application would count as pending.

And the pending total would increase in the monthly report.

The last inspection had already commented on the high number of pending files.

“Then what should I write?” Suchitra asked.

Dinanath Babu shrugged.

Jokingly, Suchitra said,

“Why don’t we give the application itself a few days’ leave?”

Ramprakash, who handled the fee register at the next desk, burst out laughing.

“Exactly! Leave for the leave application.”

Everyone laughed.

Suchitra did too.

Then she took a clean slip and wrote:

“Leave application temporarily on leave until return of the original verification officer.”

She clipped it to the top of Shailja’s application.

The sentence had begun as a joke.

But in an office, a written joke becomes less of a joke once it carries a date and a signature.

The next day Dinanath Babu saw the slip.

“Who told you to use this wording?”

“I wrote it.”

“With whose permission?”

“No one’s.”

Only so we can tell where the application stands.”

Dinanath Babu thought for a while.

“It does not say ‘sanctioned,’ does it?”

“No.”

“Then let it remain.”

By afternoon the same slip had been attached to the nine earlier applications too.

Three days later the Accounts Section asked about the status of Shailja's absence.

Suchitra replied:

"Leave application is temporarily on leave; medical records received."

Accounts wrote back:

"Is the employee's leave sanctioned or not?"

Suchitra wrote:

"Decision pending."

Accounts replied:

"If the decision is pending, under what category should the absence be recorded?"

Suchitra sat down to draft an answer.

After five minutes the paper was blank.

After ten minutes it was still blank.

Finally she wrote:

"During the temporary leave period of the leave application, the absence may provisionally be treated as under decision."

Dinanath Babu read it and frowned.

"This is too long."

Ramprakash suggested,

"Give it a short name—L.A.L."

"What?"

"Leave Application Leave."

This time no one laughed.

By the end of the week, "L.A.L." had already been written in three places in the office's small note book.

In the second week, the problem reversed itself.

Navalkishore Chaudhary, a lecturer in the History Department, wanted four days' leave.

There was a ceremony at his home, but the Head of Department was questioning the timing.

Navalkishore came to the office and asked,

"If I submit the application and it goes on temporary leave, will my absence remain under decision?"

Suchitra immediately understood that the joke was now climbing the second step towards becoming a rule.

"L.A.L. is not sanctioned leave," she said clearly.

Navalkishore replied,

"But it is not a decision either."

"Yes."

"So it is not rejected either."

"Yes."

"Then it is an intermediate state."

"For the paper, not for you."

Navalkishore smiled.

"How long can the two remain separate in an office?"

He submitted the application.

Within a week, talk of “leave for the leave application” had reached the staff room.

Some called it Suchitra’s clever device.

Some called it Dinanath Babu’s new rule.

Some called it the Principal’s silent order.

The Principal himself learned of the term only when a paper reached him headed:

“Status of seven cases under L.A.L.”

Raghuvansh Babu asked,

“What is this L.A.L.?”

Dinanath Babu explained in detail.

The Principal remained silent at first.

Then he asked,

“Has anyone’s salary stopped because of it?”

“Not yet.”

“Has anyone’s leave been treated as sanctioned?”

“No.”

“Rejected?”

“No.”

The Principal leaned back in his chair.

“Then let the arrangement continue as it is for now.

Harimohan will return and regularize it.”

Dinanath Babu immediately wrote a note:

“Current arrangement to continue as per the Hon’ble Principal’s oral instruction.”

That one line lengthened the life of L.A.L.

Originally it had existed only for applications that could not be verified because Harimohan was absent.

Now some Heads of Department began sending disputed applications directly marked L.A.L.

It suited them.

They bore neither the responsibility of sanctioning nor the unpleasantness of rejecting.

Suchitra objected.

“I did not create this.”

Dinanath Babu said,

“You did not create it. Circumstances did.”

“But the circumstances are on paper in my handwriting.”

“That is the ordinary nature of government work.”

In the third week the monthly report was prepared.

Suchitra was supposed to write 29 in the column for pending leave applications.

Dinanath Babu asked,

“Will L.A.L. be counted as pending?”

“No decision has been made, so yes.”

“But they are temporarily on leave.”
 Suchitra stared at him.
 Dinanath Babu continued,
 “If we write ‘pending’ in the report, inspection will ask why so many are pending.
 L.A.L. is a separate category.”
 Finally the report said:
 Pending: o.
 Applications temporarily on leave: 29.
 Two days later the Principal saw the report and looked pleased.
 “Pending zero? This is the first time.”
 Suchitra wanted to tell him that twenty-nine stood beside the zero.
 But by then the Principal had turned the page.
 Meanwhile Shailja’s illness became serious.
 She underwent surgery.
 A new certificate arrived from the hospital.
 Accounts again asked for her status because the mid-month salary preparation was about to begin.
 This time Suchitra did not write another slip.
 She went to Dinanath Babu’s desk.
 “We have to open the cupboard.”
 “Harimohan Babu may return in a week.”
 “Shailja Didi cannot wait a week.
 Her household runs on her salary.”
 Dinanath Babu picked up the envelope.
 Then put it down again.
 “What if something inside is disturbed?”
 “What if something is already being disturbed because we are not opening it?”
 This question too had no defined answer.
 Suchitra went directly to the Principal.
 Raghuvansh Babu first said,
 “Responsibility for papers on Harimohan’s desk is sensitive.”
 Suchitra placed Shailja’s medical certificate before him.
 “Human beings are sensitive too.”
 The Principal remained silent for a few moments.
 Then he called Dinanath Babu and gave written permission to open the envelope containing the duplicate key.
 When the cupboard opened, there was no mystery inside.
 Two registers.
 Bundles of old applications.
 An envelope of medical certificates.
 And a small notebook.
 On the first page of the notebook, in Harimohan’s handwriting, were the words:
 “Table for checking leave balance.”

Suchitra turned the pages.

Against each teacher's name were clearly written:

leave available at the beginning of the year;

leave taken;

leave remaining.

Shailja had sufficient medical leave remaining.

Dinanath Babu said softly,

"This could have been checked easily."

Suchitra looked at him.

"The key could also have been used easily."

On the inside of the cupboard, an old slip relating to the duplicate key was pasted:

"May be opened as required in the presence of the Head Clerk."

Dinanath Babu read it.

"Then where was the restriction?"

Suchitra held up the outside envelope.

"Do not open except in necessary circumstances."

The two sentences did not contradict each other.

The contradiction had been created by the office's fear.

Shailja's application reached the Principal that same day.

Her medical leave was sanctioned.

Accounts was informed.

Her salary was not stopped.

Suchitra thought L.A.L. would now disappear.

But by then the arrangement no longer depended only on Harimohan's cupboard.

Departments had already written L.A.L. on five new applications.

A new handwritten line titled "Applications Temporarily on Leave" had even been added to the monthly report format.

In the fourth week an inspector came from the district office.

He read the report.

"Pending zero. Good."

Then he read the next line.

"Applications Temporarily on Leave—thirty-four.

What is this?"

Dinanath Babu began explaining.

The inspector interrupted.

"Applications are on leave?"

For a few moments the room was silent.

Ramprakash's lips moved.

He did not laugh.

The inspector looked at three L.A.L. slips.

"What rule provides for this category?"

Dinanath Babu showed him the Principal's note:

"Current arrangement to continue."

The inspector asked,

“What was the original order?”

Suchitra showed her first white slip.

“This was not an order.

It was written only to indicate where the application stood.”

The inspector turned the slip over in his hand.

“Then whose decision created this arrangement?”

It was impossible to give a single name.

Suchitra’s joke.

Dinanath’s caution.

The Principal’s postponing remark.

The convenience of the Heads of Department.

The reporting column.

Together they had made a rule.

At last the inspector wrote:

“Unverified intermediate category shall be discontinued; time-bound decision on leave applications shall be ensured.”

Dinanath Babu breathed with relief.

“Now it is clear.”

But on the next line the inspector wrote:

“A separate list of existing cases shall be maintained for the transition period.”

Ramprakash whispered to Suchitra,

“L.A.L. has changed its name.”

Suchitra did not answer.

Six weeks later Harimohan Jha arrived at the office, walking with a stick.

Everyone asked about his health.

He sat at his desk and first looked at the cupboard.

Then the registers.

Then the separate list of thirty-four applications.

“What is this?”

Dinanath Babu told him the whole story.

Harimohan remained silent for a long time.

Then he looked at his own handwriting on the outside envelope:

“Do not open except in necessary circumstances.”

Slowly he said,

“I wrote that so people would not open the cupboard unnecessarily.

That was all.”

Suchitra said,

“We could not decide what ‘necessary’ meant.”

Harimohan rubbed his knee.

“My knee did not break.

But one word in the office certainly got twisted.”

He did not laugh.

Perhaps he could see his own share in the sentence.

Over the next two days Harimohan and Suchitra took out every application and checked them one by one.

Some were sanctioned.

Some teachers had withdrawn theirs.

Some had become meaningless because the leave period had already passed.

On Navalkishore Chaudhary's application, the Head of Department had written:

"Programme completed; is a decision still necessary?"

Beside it, Harimohan wrote in red pencil:

"Leave has already occurred; record decision required."

Suchitra read it and asked,

"This is not another new category, is it?"

For the first time Harimohan laughed.

"No.

This time we will write the whole sentence."

At the end of the month a new report was prepared.

Pending: 3.

Sanctioned: 26.

Rejected: 2.

Withdrawn: 3.

The line "Applications Temporarily on Leave" was struck out.

The Principal looked at the report.

"Pending is three again?"

Dinanath Babu said,

"Yes.

Because three really are pending."

Raghuvansh Babu looked slightly disappointed.

But he said nothing.

Suchitra's contract was due to end that week.

She had to go out for one day to attend an interview at another college.

She filled in her leave application and placed it on Harimohan's desk.

Harimohan read it.

Checked her remaining leave.

Entered it in the register.

And sent it to the Principal.

Two hours later the application came back sanctioned.

Suchitra looked at the paper carrying the official seal.

Ramprakash asked,

"Did the application get leave?"

Suchitra folded the paper and placed it in her bag.

"No.

This time I got the leave."

The following month the college office issued a short circular on leave procedure.

It stated that within three working days of receiving a leave application, either a decision must be recorded or the pending status must be entered with a clear reason.

The duplicate key could be used in the presence of the Head Clerk.

The final line of the circular said:

“Obsolete or unauthorized categories shall not be used.”

In parentheses it gave an example:

“For instance: Temporary Leave of a Leave Application.”

In other words, the category had been abolished.

But its name had now been permanently entered in the rules.

STORY 145

THE INVENTORY OF THE EMPTY DRAWER

That year a new kind of audit began in the municipal office.

Along with money, files, and buildings, the auditors were to count desks, chairs, cupboards, shelves, locks, keys, drawers, and even the objects inside drawers.

On the first day Auditor Shambhunath Jha told all the employees,

“Counting objects is easy.

The difficult part is proving that where there is nothing, there really is nothing.”

Nilambar, a junior assistant, smiled at the sentence.

He thought auditors were probably like that by nature—
they could see a question even in an empty space.

Three days later his smile had faded.

The municipal office’s old Map Room had now become an extra room of the Revenue Branch.

A faded nameplate nearly two decades old still hung on the wall:

“MAP SECTION.”

Inside stood four iron cupboards, one broad wooden desk, and two crooked chairs.

On the right side of the desk were three drawers.

The top drawer held broken seals, old thread, and a brass paperweight.

The middle drawer held copies of land records.

The bottom drawer was completely empty.

Shambhunath Babu wrote in the inventory:

“Drawer No. 3: item status?”

Nilambar said,

“Empty.”

“‘Empty’ is not an item status.”

“Then what is?”

“Since when has it been empty?”

Nilambar looked at the drawer.

The wood gave no answer.

Shambhunath Babu opened the old asset register.

He found the desk’s number:

Nagar/Ka/17.

Under it were three entries.

First drawer—

“Seals and auxiliary materials.”

Second—

“Land-record copies.”

Third—

“Map storage.”

Shambhunath Babu looked at Nilambar over his spectacles.

"The drawer is empty, but the register is full."

Nilambar said,

"The register is old."

"Then where did the maps go?"

"How would I know?"

"Before certifying the emptiness, show the disposal or transfer of the previous contents."

That single sentence created a new piece of work in the office.

The Stores Branch had an old form for "vacant item status."

It offered four options:

"Not in use."

"Transferred."

"Disposed."

"Reason unknown."

Nilambar thought of marking the first.

Dindayal stopped him.

"If you write 'not in use,' the drawer itself may be treated as unusable."

"Transferred?"

"Then write the current location of the material."

"Disposed?"

"Attach the disposal order."

"Reason unknown?"

Dindayal showed him the reverse side of the form.

"Under 'reason unknown,' a three-member inquiry committee will be formed."

Nilambar stopped his pen.

The office offered four choices.

Not one was easy.

In the end he left the form blank.

The first document meant to certify the drawer's emptiness remained empty itself.

Nilambar first went to Dindayal, the Stores Clerk.

Before opening any old papers, Dindayal asked,

"Which year?"

"The register says 'map storage' up to 1998."

Dindayal scratched his head.

"The 1998 transfer register is separate."

"Where?"

"The register recording that register's present location will tell us."

"Where is the current-location register?"

"In the old Records Room."

The key to the old Records Room was with Jagdish, the building attendant.

As he took out the key, Jagdish said,

"That room is not old anymore."

Last month the new tax slips were stored there.”

“Then where are the old records?”

“In the new store.”

“Where is the new store?”

Jagdish paused before answering.

“In the old meeting room.”

Rooms in the municipal office were known less by their names than by their former uses.

The new store was the old meeting room.

The old Records Room had become the new tax-slip room.

The Map Section had become an extra Revenue room.

Only the bottom drawer was empty—

though in the register it was still full of maps.

After two hours of searching, they found the transfer register for 1998.

Its cover had turned grey with dust.

On page 42, in red ink, it said:

“Maps temporarily removed due to roof repairs. See Temporary Materials List, K-7.”

With something like triumph, Nilambar placed the register before Shambhunath Babu.

Shambhunath Babu read it and said,

“Good. Now show me K-7.”

“Is this not sufficient proof?”

“This proves that the drawer was emptied.

It does not prove where the material went.”

Nilambar’s triumphant look began to fade.

The K-7 list was not found immediately.

One old index said that temporary materials in category “K” had been kept in Room No. 6.

But in the present building there was no Room No. 6.

After Room 5 came Room 7.

Harinarayan Babu, the oldest employee in the office, laughed when asked about it.

“There used to be a Room Six.

Behind the staircase.

Later its wall was broken and it was merged into Room Seven.”

“What is there now?”

“Pipes for the drinking-water tank and broken chairs.”

At the rear of Room 7, the old line of a half-demolished wall was indeed visible.

A shelf was moved.

Behind the pipes they found a rusted tin box.

But it contained no maps—

only old bills, labour slips from the roof repair, and one small scrap of paper.

On the scrap was written:

“The large sheets became wet.
 Spread them on the veranda to dry.
 Do not fold afterwards.
 They are mounted on cloth.”
 Nilambar read it.
 “The maps got wet.”
 Harinarayan Babu examined the handwriting.
 “This is Kailash Babu’s hand.
 He was in the Map Section then.”
 Kailash Babu had retired ten years earlier.
 He lived in another neighbourhood of the town.
 Shambhunath Babu said,
 “Personal memory is not audit evidence.
 But it can give us a direction.”
 That afternoon Nilambar and Jagdish went to Kailash Babu’s house.
 Kailash Babu was turning over sacks of makhana drying on the veranda.
 The moment he heard the name of the municipal office, the expression
 that often appears on a retired employee’s face came over him—
 half affection,
 half caution.
 “Maps?” he said slowly.
 “The year the roof leaked?”
 “Yes.”
 Kailash Babu remained silent for a while.
 “There were seventeen large sheets.
 Mounted on cloth.
 Two were badly soaked.
 We spread them on the veranda.
 After the roof was repaired, the maps were supposed to be returned to the
 Map Room.”
 “Were they returned?”
 “Not to the drawer.”
 “Then where?”
 Kailash Babu narrowed his eyes.
 “A new iron shelving unit had arrived around that time.
 A great deal of dust fell on its upper shelf.
 The maps could not be folded.
 So we rolled them with thick paper and placed them temporarily on top of
 the shelving.”
 “Which shelving?”
 Kailash Babu laughed, but there was embarrassment in it.
 “The one that was later turned into the old-paper store.”
 “Any identifying mark?”
 “There was brown wrapping outside.
 I meant to label it.
 That night my daughter fell ill.

The next day there was measurement work for the roof repair.

Then municipal election duty.

A week later other bundles had been piled on the shelf.

I kept thinking—

tomorrow I will write it down.”

“And tomorrow?”

Kailash Babu looked at the sacks of makhana.

“An office tomorrow can be very long, Babu.”

The next morning the old-paper store was opened.

It was a room in the rear part of the building where objects suspended between “fit for reuse” and “for disposal” had been waiting for one another’s decisions for years.

On the upper shelving lay old circulars, torn covers, empty bindings, and bundles of rolled papers.

Jagdish brought the bundles down one by one.

The first contained old printed tax forms.

The second, election notices.

The third, obsolete school charts.

The brown wrapper of the fourth bundle had almost become one with the dust.

On it, in faded pencil, only two syllables could be made out:

“Ma. Sha.”

Nilambar’s hand stopped.

The knot was opened.

Inside were land maps mounted on heavy cloth.

Some edges had browned, but the lines, plot numbers, old pond boundaries, public lanes, drains, and the town’s old land markers were still clear.

Sixteen of the seventeen maps were found.

In place of the seventeenth, the bundle contained a repair slip:

“Severely damaged; dried separately.”

Shambhunath Babu immediately raised the question of the seventeenth map.

In a tired voice Nilambar said,

“First let us certify that sixteen have survived.”

Shambhunath Babu did not reply.

He counted the maps.

Recorded their serial numbers.

Recorded their condition.

And added one line:

“Material previously presumed missing—recovered.”

News spread through the office that day.

Employees from the Revenue Branch came running.

The Municipal Engineer came.

Two lawyers heard about it.

By evening it had become clear that one of the recovered maps showed the old measurements of a public lane in Ward 9, whose boundary had been disputed for five years.

Another showed an old drainage outlet from a pond.

In the absence of that map, every meeting about monsoon drainage had been proceeding on estimates.

The next day an elderly woman, Janaki Devi, came with her son.

Three years earlier the municipal office had served her an encroachment notice over four cubits of land behind her house.

She had been told that the old map was unavailable, so the new measurement would be treated as final.

On the recovered map, the rear boundary lay elsewhere.

Nilambar did not try to explain the map to her.

He simply called a Revenue survey worker.

The survey worker compared the old markers with the present posts.

Janaki Devi sat silently on a chair.

Two hours later the survey worker said,

“The old measurement is correct.

The notice will go back for review.”

Janaki Devi stood.

She did not thank anyone.

She did not cry.

She made no speech.

As she left, she looked once towards the empty Map Room.

Nilambar thought—

inside the task of proving one drawer empty, a three-year-old notice was changing.

But the audit question was not yet over.

Shambhunath Babu returned to the original desk.

He pulled out the bottom drawer.

There was still nothing inside it.

“So what do we write as the item status now?” Nilambar asked.

“Empty.”

Nilambar laughed.

“Three days ago that answer was not acceptable.”

“Now there is proof.”

“What proof?”

Shambhunath Babu placed together the disposal slip, the transfer register, the reference to K-7, Kailash Babu’s written confirmation, the list of recovered maps, and the inspection notes.

“After this much paperwork, the drawer is officially empty.”

Nilambar looked at the drawer.

For the first time he understood that even being empty could be heavy work in an office.

But the difficulty did not end there.

After the maps were found, Stores Clerk Dindayal raised another question.

"If the maps were formerly the contents of this drawer, and they will now be kept in the Special Records Room, what will the classification of the drawer be?"

Do we remove 'Map Storage'?"

Shambhunath Babu said,

"Yes."

"What goes in its place?"

"Vacant."

"Permanently vacant or temporarily vacant?"

Nilambar held his head.

Dindayal was serious.

"If we write 'temporary,' something may be placed in it later.

If we write 'permanent,' the usefulness of the desk decreases.

That may affect asset valuation."

For the first time Shambhunath Babu remained silent for a while.

At last new wording was created:

"VACANT—FORMER CONTENTS RECOVERED AND SECURED SEPARATELY."

Nilambar asked,

"What does that classification mean?"

Shambhunath Babu said,

"It means there is nothing in it now, but its emptiness has a history."

A new inventory was printed.

Under desk Nagar/Ka/17, the third line had now grown long:

"Drawer No. 3: Vacant—former contents recovered and secured separately."

A small label was also pasted inside the drawer:

"CERTIFIED VACANT.

DO NOT PLACE MATERIAL WITHOUT STORES PERMISSION."

Two weeks later Nilambar noticed that the office was again running short of places to keep files.

He opened the empty drawer.

There was ample space inside.

He had five thick files in his hands.

Passing in front of him, Jagdish stopped.

"Will you keep them there?"

Nilambar read the label.

"Stores permission is required."

"Will you take permission?"

Nilambar closed the drawer.

"Not now."

A month passed.

Files accumulated on top of the desk.

Papers rose on top of another cupboard.

The empty drawer remained empty.

On the final day of the audit, Shambhunath Babu returned to the room.

He matched the inventory.
 Applied his seal.
 And opened the drawer to inspect it.
 There was nothing inside.
 Satisfaction appeared on his face.
 “Good,” he said.
 “Status unchanged.”

Nilambar looked into the empty interior of the drawer.
 Three weeks earlier, that very emptiness had been a question.
 Now it had become an achievement.

Across the room, the maps were secured in new covers for the Special Records Room.

Janaki Devi’s notice had gone for reconsideration.
 The Engineer had fixed a date to survey the pond’s old drainage outlet.
 And the desk’s third drawer—
 because of which all this had been found—
 was now so thoroughly certified as empty that no one in the office had the
 courage to use it.

STORY 146

THE FILE WITH THE YELLOW RIBBON

The District Treasury stood in the northern corner of the old court compound.

Its walls were thick, its windows high, and the air inside always carried the smell of paper, old cloth, and stamp ink.

The ribbons used to tie treasury files came in different colours.

Black.

Green.

Red.

Blue.

Yellow.

Ask what each colour meant and every employee would certainly answer.

But two employees rarely gave the same answer.

According to some, red ribbon was for returned files.

According to others, red was only for audit objections.

To some, green meant completed work.

To others, pensions.

No one could say with certainty when blue ribbon had entered the system.

But on the subject of yellow ribbon, everyone's voice became almost identical.

"A yellow-ribbon file is to be seen first."

"On whose order?" Madhav Jha, a newly appointed clerk, asked on his third day.

Raghuvir Babu, the senior clerk sitting beside him, pushed his spectacles onto his forehead.

"Order? It is an old practice."

"Where is it written?"

Without looking up from the file he was turning, Raghuvir Babu said,

"If every piece of work had to be written down, what would be the use of an attendant's experience?"

That experience belonged mainly to Bateshwar Mandal.

Bateshwar had served as an attendant in the treasury for more than three decades.

Officers changed.

Clerks changed.

Desks changed.

But Bateshwar's gait, his way of recognising the sound of the brass bell, and his memory for carrying a file to the proper desk had hardly changed.

He had no desk.

In one corner of the veranda stood a low wooden platform.

Beneath it were ribbons, string, old stamp pads, sealing wax, and two pairs of scissors.

A cloth bag containing yellow ribbon rested beside the platform's right leg.

During his first week, Madhav noticed that ordinary files moved in sequence.

But when a file tied with yellow ribbon travelled from desk to desk, people's eyes rose automatically.

No one said,

"Take this first."

Yet hands reached for it first.

One day two files arrived from the Pension Branch at exactly the same time.

One had black ribbon.

The other yellow.

Without reading either one, Raghuvir Babu opened the yellow-ribbon file first.

Madhav asked,

"Why this one first?"

Looking at the papers, Raghuvir Babu replied,

"Because it is yellow."

"But what is the subject?"

"We will read the subject afterwards."

The yellow file concerned assistance for the dependent family of a deceased teacher.

The papers were complete.

Approval had already been received.

Only treasury release remained.

Raghuvir Babu calculated it at once and sent it forward.

Madhav thought that seemed right.

Perhaps, he reflected, a practice could be unwritten and yet sometimes more humane than a written rule.

Two days later the first crack appeared in that belief.

A file from the Building Repairs Branch arrived tied with yellow ribbon.

The subject was payment for three broken curtain rods and two brass hooks in an old guest room.

The amount was not large.

The work itself was three months old.

The moment the clerk in the preparation room saw the file, he said,

"It is yellow. Send it first."

Madhav laughed.

"Are curtain rods an emergency too?"

"I do not look at the subject," the clerk said.

"I look at the colour."

That same day the file crossed three desks.

The money was released the next day.

Madhav became curious about how the curtain-rod file had acquired yellow ribbon.

He telephoned Chandramohan, a young employee in the Building Repairs Branch.

Chandramohan laughed first.

"How would I know?

There was no ribbon.

Yellow was lying in the drawer, so I tied it with that."

"You knew yellow meant special?"

"I learned that only after it reached your office."

"Then why did you not tell someone the colour was accidental?"

"Tell whom?

The moment the file left me, it started running."

The answer remained with Madhav.

The rule was moving so quickly that the cause of the rule's birth was being left behind.

That week an elderly woman came to the treasury for the fifth time.

Her name was Malti Devi.

Her husband had been a watchman in the Irrigation Department and had died in service a year earlier.

Dependent assistance had been sanctioned.

But because a copy of one certificate was unclear, the file kept circulating.

Malti Devi's file was tied with faded green ribbon.

She carried her papers in an old blue cloth bag.

The knot at the bag's mouth had been opened and tied so many times that the cloth had become smooth.

By now she remembered which corner of which certificate carried an officer's signature.

Which page had been called unclear.

And on which date the file had been on which desk.

The first time she came to the treasury, she believed approval meant the work was almost complete.

The second time she learned that there were many desks between approval and payment.

The third time she learned that an unclear copy had to be made again.

The fourth time she sat for two hours without asking anything.

On the fifth visit, there was less insistence in her voice than exhaustion.

Leaning towards the service window, she asked,

"Babu, is anything still missing today?"

Madhav examined the file.

Nothing was missing now.

The copy requested the previous week had been attached.

Even so, the file stood seventh in the queue.

He asked Raghuvir Babu,

"Why is this not yellow?"

Raghuvir Babu looked surprised.

"Do I tie the yellow ribbon?"

"Then who does?"

Both looked towards Bateshwar.

At that moment Bateshwar was returning from outside carrying a file.

He stopped when he heard the question.

"Yellow?" he said.

"It is tied on urgent work."

"Who decides what is urgent?" Madhav asked.

A faint smile came over Bateshwar's face.

"Whoever feels that delay should not happen."

"You mean you?"

"What authority do I have?" Bateshwar said at once.

Madhav asked again,

"Then who?"

Bateshwar took Malti Devi's file into his hand.

He turned the pages.

Said nothing.

He went towards his platform.

But he did not take out the yellow ribbon.

He returned the file to Madhav.

"The papers are complete," he said.

That day Madhav placed Malti Devi's file before his senior.

He wrote the reason:

"Dependent assistance; all papers complete; pending for a long period."

The senior officer added a written remark and sent the file forward.

The file moved.

But now Madhav's attention remained fixed on the ribbon.

He searched old office orders.

Nowhere did he find a clear list assigning meanings to file colours.

A materials register from 2007 recorded:

"Red ribbon—20 bundles; yellow—10; green—10."

It gave no use.

A purchase voucher from 2012 listed five colours of ribbon.

A 2018 stores list did not even name the colours.

It said only:

"Cloth ribbon, assorted."

Madhav said to Raghuvir Babu,

"Where did this special authority come from?"

Raghuvir Babu thought for a while.

"It existed when I joined."

"From whom did you learn it?"

"From Bateshwar."

"And whom did Bateshwar learn it from?"

Raghuvir Babu laughed.

"Ask Bateshwar that.

The history section is with him."

Meanwhile yellow ribbon had moved ahead with a life of its own.

The young men in the copying room began saying that acknowledgements for yellow files should be kept separately.

Cash Branch employees placed them on the right side of the desk.

One assistant at the service window began telling citizens,

“If it has yellow ribbon, it moves quickly.”

The idea reached outside the office.

One day a young man who wandered about like a broker came to Bateshwar and whispered,

“Kaka, where can I get yellow ribbon?”

Bateshwar glared at him.

“In a cloth shop.”

The young man smiled.

“The file kind.”

Bateshwar slapped his palm against the platform.

“A file moves by its papers, not by its colour.”

“Then why does everyone look for yellow?”

Bateshwar did not answer.

It was not the first such request.

Sometimes a contractor’s man invited him for tea.

Sometimes an applicant showed him a file and said,

“Kaka, give this that colour.”

Bateshwar generally scolded them.

But not every request was alike.

Once the wife of an employee seeking reimbursement for maternity treatment was crying.

Bateshwar himself tied yellow ribbon around the file.

Once a headmaster pleaded over a school-building payment file.

Bateshwar did not.

There was no register of these selections.

No appeal.

No reason slip.

Only Bateshwar’s memory, experience, and humanity.

That was exactly what made Madhav most uncomfortable.

Bateshwar was not a bad man.

For that very reason, the unwritten authority in his hands was a harder question.

The problem became serious on the day the Audit Branch noticed that an ordinary file had passed through at unusual speed.

The subject was payment for four new locks installed on the treasury’s rear veranda and for making three keys.

The file entered on Monday.

Calculation on Tuesday.

Approval on Wednesday.

Payment released on Thursday.

The auditor asked,

“Why so quickly?”

Raghuvir Babu looked at the file.
 "It had yellow ribbon."
 "What rule governs yellow ribbon?"
 Silence spread across the room.
 For the first time, colour needed written language.
 Assistant Treasury Officer Aniruddh Mishra called a meeting.
 Five colours of ribbon were placed on the table.
 Yellow lay in the middle.
 "Please tell me," Aniruddh Babu said,
 "what is the legal meaning of this colour?"
 Raghuvir Babu said,
 "Urgent."
 The assistant from the copying room said,
 "Special order."
 The Cash Branch employee said,
 "To be seen first."
 The Stores Clerk said,
 "As far as I know, nothing."
 When we purchase ribbon, we buy whichever colour is cheaper."
 Every eye turned to Bateshwar.
 He remained silent for a long time.
 Then he lifted the yellow ribbon in his hand.
 It was old.
 Its edges were frayed.
 "Many years ago," he said slowly,
 "Thakur Sahib was Treasury Officer.
 He used to forget many files.
 Once a widow's assistance file remained buried on his desk for three days.
 He told me,
 'Bateshwar, when I say something must be seen today, tie yellow ribbon on
 it so it catches my eye.'"
 Aniruddh Babu asked,
 "Written order?"
 "No."
 "How long did that continue?"
 "As long as Thakur Sahib was here."
 "After that?"
 Bateshwar placed the ribbon back on the table.
 "After that, people began moving yellow files forward as soon as they saw
 them.
 I did not stop it."
 "You kept tying them?"
 "Sometimes.
 When it seemed to me someone had already made too many rounds."
 Aniruddh Babu lifted the Building Repairs file.
 "Did you tie this one too?"

“No.”

“Then?”

Madhav repeated what Chandramohan had told him.

Yellow ribbon had been lying in a drawer, so he had used it.

For a while Aniruddh Babu kept looking at the file.

“So a colour that once signalled compassion was used here by accident.

But the office interpreted the accident as an order.”

Raghuvir Babu said quietly,

“The payment itself was not improper.”

“Perhaps not the payment,” Aniruddh Babu said.

“But the priority may have been.”

“You were deciding which work was special?” he asked Bateshwar.

Bateshwar immediately replied,

“Not deciding.

Only drawing attention.”

“Where is the difference?”

Bateshwar took time before answering.

“Earlier there was a difference.

Later perhaps there was not.”

The room fell silent again.

Madhav remembered Malti Devi.

He also remembered the curtain rods in the guest room.

The same colour had become compassion, accident, convenience, and authority.

Before the meeting ended, Aniruddh Babu asked everyone one question.

“If the yellow ribbon is removed, how will urgent work be identified?”

No one had an immediate answer.

Raghuvir Babu said,

“By experience.”

Madhav said,

“By writing the reason.”

Bateshwar remained silent.

Then he said softly,

“Writing the reason will take time.

But if someone asks later, there will be an answer.”

Aniruddh Babu looked at him.

Perhaps for the first time in the meeting, an attendant’s sentence was finding a place in the line of decision.

Aniruddh Babu ordered the use of yellow ribbon suspended for four days.

The order stated:

“Priority shall not be determined by colour alone.

An urgent file shall carry a written slip stating the reason.”

The moment the order was issued, a strange difficulty began.

What should be done with the old files already tied in yellow?

Should the ribbons be removed?

If removed, the original form of the record would be altered.

If not removed, employees would continue looking at them first.
 A meeting was held.
 It was decided that old yellow ribbon would not be removed.
 Instead a white slip would be pasted on top:
 "Colour carries no special meaning."
 Then came the next question.
 On which files should the slip be attached?
 Only yellow ones?
 Or every colour?
 A second meeting was held.
 Meanwhile Malti Devi's payment was released.
 This time she did not have to make a sixth visit.
 Madhav walked her outside.
 Malti Devi asked,
 "Babu, did my file finally get yellow ribbon or not?"
 Madhav said,
 "No."
 She looked surprised.
 "Then how did the work get done?"
 "The papers were complete.
 And the reason was written."
 Malti Devi nodded.
 "That is fine.
 I would not have understood the colour anyway."
 When Madhav returned inside, he saw Bateshwar pulling the cloth bag of
 yellow ribbon from beneath his platform.
 "What will you do with it now?" Madhav asked.
 "Deposit it in Stores."
 "Will you not miss it?"
 Bateshwar smiled.
 "I was not attached to the ribbon.
 Sometimes I felt that where written rules caused delay, one colour could
 make a person's work move.
 That was all.
 Slowly, the colour itself became a rule."
 Madhav said,
 "Your compassion became authority."
 Bateshwar lowered his head.
 "And the responsibility for that authority was never written anywhere in
 my name."
 The bag was deposited in Stores.
 A receipt was prepared.
 The Stores Clerk asked,
 "Under what category should I place yellow ribbon?"
 Madhav said,
 "Ordinary stationery."

The Stores Clerk looked dissatisfied.

“This used to be a special item.”

“Not anymore.”

He wrote in the register:

“Yellow cloth ribbon—formerly special use, presently ordinary.”

A week later a new written procedure came into force in the treasury.

Any urgent file would carry a small slip stating the reason, date, and signature of the responsible officer.

Colour would serve only as an aid to identification.

On the first day, a medical reimbursement file arrived.

The papers showed that the patient was due to undergo expensive treatment the next day.

Out of old habit, the clerk looked towards Bateshwar’s platform.

The platform was empty.

Bateshwar was outside delivering papers at the service window.

Instead of searching for yellow ribbon, the clerk filled in the urgent slip.

He wrote the reason.

Obtained the officer’s signature.

And sent the file forward.

By the time Bateshwar returned, the file was gone.

He said nothing.

He only looked once at the empty space beneath the platform.

At the end of the month, copies of a new order were distributed to all employees.

Its title read:

“Instructions Regarding Separation of File-Colour Use and Urgent Priority.”

The order ran to three pages.

The young man in the copying room asked,

“These copies have to be sent to every branch.

Which ribbon should I tie around them?”

Without looking up, Raghuvir Babu said,

“Whatever is available.”

The young man went to Stores.

The red ribbon was exhausted.

The green consignment had not yet arrived.

Black was reserved for audit work.

The Stores Clerk checked the register.

Then he took out an old cloth bag.

On it was written:

“Yellow cloth ribbon—formerly special use, presently ordinary.”

The next day, the order abolishing the special authority of file colours reached every branch of the treasury.

Every copy was tied with yellow ribbon.

STORY 147

HALF A LETTER IN THE DESIGNATION

The sub-office of the District Agricultural Marketing Office operated from the rear part of an old dharamshala in the market.

In front ran a narrow road.

To the left stood three seed shops.

To the right was Kailash's tea stall.

Between them was an iron gate whose new coat of paint could not quite hide two streaks of rust.

After the rains ended, the building was whitewashed again.

At the same time, new nameplates were installed outside every room.

The lettering on the old wooden boards had faded, so the district office had ordered tin plates of identical size and colour.

Outside Umakant Mishra's room, beneath his name, his designation was written:

"JUNIOR AGRICULTURAL OFFICER (MARKETING)."

But the first letter of the word meaning "junior" had not been painted fully.

The left half of the black letter "A" was clear.

The right half broke off midway.

From two yards away, the "A" almost disappeared.

The board then appeared to read:

"SENIOR AGRICULTURAL OFFICER (MARKETING)."

Murari, the workman fixing the plate, looked up at it twice.

Then he drove in the nail with his hammer.

He was in a hurry.

The "Accounts Assistant" board still had to be fitted outside the next room.

Tilakdhari Babu was the first to notice the mistake.

He entered Umakant's room carrying a stack of files under his arm and said with a laugh,

"Congratulations. You have been promoted."

Umakant removed his spectacles.

"What?"

"From junior to senior.

I have never seen such progress accomplished with half a letter."

Both went outside.

Umakant looked at the plate.

He laughed.

Then he immediately called Murari.

"The paint has dried, Babu," Murari said.

"If I paint over it now, it will not match the other letters.

The plate will have to be taken down and carried back to the workshop."

"Then take it."

"I need an order."

"An order?"

Murari said matter-of-factly,

"It is government property.

I cannot remove it on my own."

Tilakdhari Babu suppressed a laugh.

"You see?

The post has risen.

The authority is exactly the same."

Umakant wrote on a small sheet:

"Correction required in lettering on nameplate."

The paper went to the Stores Branch.

Stores asked whether the old plate was to be repaired or replaced.

If repaired, under which budget head would the paint be charged?

If replaced, how was the existing plate to be disposed of?

The questions began circulating.

For three days the nameplate remained unchanged.

On the fourth morning, an elderly farmer stopped at the gate.

He read the board, dusted off his dhoti, and entered the room with both hands joined.

"Pranam, Senior Sahib."

Umakant looked up.

"I am the junior officer.

There is an error on the plate."

The old farmer looked once outside and once at Umakant.

"I do not understand letters, Sahib.

I understand weighing scales."

He opened his file.

At the local procurement centre, a consignment of makhana seed had been weighed, but the weight written on the receipt did not match the amount paid.

The matter did not fall entirely within Umakant's authority.

The procurement centre was run by a cooperative society.

A district-level examination would be required.

Umakant studied the papers.

He circled two figures in red pencil and wrote down the name of the proper branch for the farmer.

As he rose, the old man said,

"I thought the Senior Sahib sat here and the work would be done from this office."

The sentence was ordinary.

But it stayed in Umakant's ears all day.

That evening Tilakdhari Babu searched again for the paper requesting correction of the nameplate.

It had moved from Stores to Accounts because the record of the old batch of paint could not be found.

“Three branches to repair half a letter,” Tilakdhari said.

Umakant did not answer.

The following week, word about the nameplate escaped the office.

Someone posted in a local farmers’ mobile-phone group:

“The Senior Marketing Officer now sits in the sub-office.”

Someone asked:

“Has a new post been created?”

Someone replied:

“Seems so.”

No new post had been created by the district office.

But rumours have no register.

They need no entry.

Earlier, people used to walk straight into Umakant’s room.

Now they paused at the door and asked,

“May I come in?”

Even Kailash the tea seller began washing Umakant’s glass separately.

In meetings, the chair that had once stood near the window gradually moved towards the head of the table.

Umakant kept correcting people.

“Not senior.

Junior.”

But people’s ears heard “senior” more readily than the missing “A.”

The word “junior” was not new to him.

For seventeen years it had travelled beside his name on appointment letters, salary slips, transfer orders, and identity cards.

Villagers sometimes asked,

“What does ‘junior’ mean?”

Umakant would laugh.

“Not the officer above.

The officer below.”

The person asking usually understood at once that any large approval would have to be sought elsewhere.

Sometimes that was convenient.

Having less authority meant some heavy decisions did not stop on his desk.

But sometimes the shadow of the word became larger than the work itself.

He inspected fields.

Someone above signed the conclusion.

His report was read in meetings.

The questions were directed to the district officer.

Farmers told him their full problem and then asked,

“So where do we find the real Sahib?”

Umakant was used to all this.

He did not take the limits of his post as an insult.

But after half the first letter disappeared from the nameplate, he saw for the first time how quickly people's behaviour could change not with the depth of the work, but with the height of a word.

Kailash had earlier placed the tea glass on the corner of the desk and gone.

Now he entered and asked,

"A little sugar or the usual?"

One block employee who used to toss files in through the doorway now opened the file and placed the correct page in front of him.

Meeting notices that once arrived at the last minute began coming a day early.

None of these small changes had been ordered officially.

Even so, Umakant had to admit that they were not entirely unpleasant.

One day Kaushalya Devi arrived.

She was around fifty-five.

A faded blue aanchal covered her head.

A cloth bag hung from her hand.

Inside were three receipts for sesame procurement.

A private procurement centre had withheld her payment for eighteen days.

The reason written on the receipts was:

"Excess moisture."

But nowhere was the moisture percentage recorded.

Kaushalya spoke directly.

"I have gone to the district office twice.

The first time the Babu was not there.

The second time the file was not there.

In the village they said the Senior Officer sits here."

Umakant was about to say:

"I am not the Senior Officer."

He did say it.

But this time he added,

"Show me the papers."

The moment he examined the three receipts, something troubled him.

The weighings were on different dates.

But the words giving "moisture" as the reason were written in the same shade of ink and with the same pen.

On the third receipt, even the date had been written after the day of purchase.

Umakant telephoned the manager of the local centre.

At first the manager's voice was casual.

When Umakant gave his name, there was a brief silence on the other end.

Then the voice changed.

"Yes, Senior Sahib?"

Umakant opened his mouth to correct him again.

But Kaushalya's receipts lay before him.

"Bring the original records for all three receipts tomorrow at ten," he said.

"Yes, Sahib."

The call ended.

For a moment Umakant's hand remained on the receiver.

The next day the manager arrived before time.

He brought the centre's weighing register, moisture-testing slips, and payment details.

The examination showed that the moisture in Kaushalya's sesame was within the prescribed standard.

The note "Excess moisture" had been entered for the convenience of the Accounts Room, so that some payments could be postponed until the following week.

Umakant wrote an inspection note within the powers of his actual office and sent it to the district office.

He told the centre manager that if there was any lawful reason for withholding payment, it must be stated in writing.

Three days later Kaushalya received her money.

She returned to thank him.

This time she looked at the nameplate, smiled, and said,

"Whatever the letters say, my work was done here."

Umakant liked hearing that.

More than he had expected.

From that day, the way he corrected people changed.

Earlier, if someone said "Senior Sahib," he stopped them at once.

Now, sometimes, he merely smiled.

If a matter lay outside his authority, he did say clearly,

"This belongs at district level."

But he no longer repeated his full designation every time.

Tilakdhari Babu noticed the change.

One day he said softly,

"The A is only half there.

The respect is complete."

Without raising his head from the file, Umakant said,

"People come for work."

"People also come after reading the designation."

"The two do not remain entirely separate."

Tilakdhari said nothing.

Two weeks later the Block Traders' Association requested a meeting.

Earlier, the association would have gone to district headquarters.

Now five men came to Umakant's room.

At their head was the association secretary, carrying a proposal for a new market shed.

The estimated cost was large.

It could not be sanctioned on Umakant's signature.

Umakant said clearly,

"I can send a recommendation.

I cannot grant approval."

The secretary replied casually,

“If the recommendation is yours, who above will stop it?”

The sentence did not feel as pleasant as Kaushalya’s:

“My work was done here.”

Umakant read the proposal.

The shed had been planned over the old open platform where small farmers sat with their sacks without paying any fee.

The Traders’ Association wanted an entry ticket introduced after the new shed was built.

“Remove this part,” Umakant said.

“Why?”

“The open platform will remain free of charge.”

The secretary fell silent for a moment.

His eyes went to the nameplate.

“If you wish, then—”

Umakant cut him off.

“What I wish will be written in the file.

Not on the nameplate.”

The meeting ended.

That evening Umakant himself stood outside and looked at the board.

In the fading light, the broken “A” was even less visible.

“SENIOR AGRICULTURAL OFFICER” read clearly.

For the first time the board did not seem funny.

It seemed slightly uncomfortable.

He went to the Stores Branch.

The correction paper was searched out.

The register carried the entry:

“Quotation proposed for repair.”

“Quotation from whom?” Umakant asked.

The Stores Clerk replied,

“Three suppliers are required.”

“For half a letter?”

“The rules do not measure the size of a letter.”

Umakant did not laugh.

He wrote:

“Urgent correction.

Members of the public are misunderstanding the nature of the post.”

The Stores Clerk read the remark and asked,

“This has become like a complaint.

Then we need proof that confusion actually occurred.”

“Proof?”

“Some application or letter addressed using the incorrect designation.”

Four such letters were lying on Umakant’s desk.

He hesitated.

If he submitted them as proof, it would also become clear how long the mistake had been known.

If he did not, the board would remain unchanged.

He had copies made of all four letters and attached them.

Meanwhile the rumour became firmer.

A meeting letter arrived from the Block Office inviting the “Senior Agricultural Officer (Marketing)” to an agricultural market coordination meeting.

Showing it to him, Tilakdhari Babu said,

“Now government paper believes it too.”

With a red pencil Umakant added an “A” before “Senior,” restoring “Junior,” and wrote beneath:

“Correct designation and record accordingly.”

At the meeting, he was given a chair in the front row.

His name card again said “Senior.”

The hall was full.

For a few moments Umakant stared at the card.

Then he turned it face down.

After the meeting, District Agricultural Marketing Officer Rashmi Sinha stopped him.

“When was your new post created?” she asked with a smile.

Umakant understood that the matter had reached upstairs.

“No new post.

Only a new nameplate.”

Rashmi laughed.

Then immediately asked,

“How long has it been like that?”

Umakant gave the date.

“Why was it not corrected?”

He told her about Stores, quotations, and proof.

He did not mention Kaushalya’s case.

Nor the Traders’ Association proposal.

But after a moment he added on his own,

“There was another reason.”

Rashmi waited.

“People had begun to listen.”

As he said it, Umakant’s own voice sounded unfamiliar to him.

Rashmi said nothing.

She turned the name card face up on the table.

Then she asked only,

“The work you did—

was it within your authority?”

“Everything I put in writing was.”

“And what did people think your post was?”

Umakant paused before answering.

“They thought I had more authority than I actually did.”

Rashmi wrote “JUNIOR” on the name card in red ink.

“Then there are two tasks.

Correct the board.

And create a clear process for the local complaints that can be handled from here.

Do not leave people dependent on half a letter.”

The meeting ended.

The following week a short order arrived from the district office.

Initial marketing-related complaints would be accepted at the sub-office.

Receipts would be issued.

If a matter required district-level action, the date of forwarding would be entered in a register.

Umakant’s name did not appear in the order.

At the same time, permission arrived to correct the nameplate.

Murari came again.

This time he carried a small tin of black paint and a thin brush.

He worked very carefully while completing the missing part of the old “A.”

After the fresh paint dried, the “A” looked slightly darker than the other letters.

Tilakdhari Babu stood outside.

“Now the A is so clear that even from five yards away it reads ‘Junior.’”

Umakant said,

“This time it is correct.”

Two days later Kaushalya came again.

This time a young man from her neighbourhood accompanied her.

There was an error on his maize-payment receipt.

Kaushalya read the nameplate in full.

“Junior Agricultural Officer,” she said slowly, as if learning a new expression.

Umakant gestured towards the chairs.

“Sit.”

Kaushalya sat.

The young man sat too.

After the greeting, no one discussed the designation.

Tilakdhari Babu brought in the new “Local Marketing Complaints Register.”

The first page carried a printed heading.

Below it, the responsible designation was written:

“JUNIOR AGRICULTURAL OFFICER (MARKETING).”

Umakant opened the register.

All the letters were of equal thickness.

No part was half missing.

Outside, Murari was putting away the old paint tin.

In the window glass the nameplate’s reflection appeared reversed.

There, “Junior” became some meaningless arrangement of letters again.

Umakant looked once at that reflection.

Then he began writing the first entry in the new complaints register.

STORY 148

THE CERTIFICATE'S BIRTHDAY

On the third floor of the District Records Building, old certificates were being entered into a digital archive.

The room contained four desks, three computers, two fans, and one iron cupboard.

Grey bundles of papers lay on top of the cupboard, each marked with a year:

1968.

1971.

1976.

1982.

Clerk Naresh Mishra's job was to read the old certificates and enter their details into the digital register.

There was a separate field for each item:

name,

village,

serial number,

issuing office,

subject.

The final field read:

"Date of issue: day-month-year."

The first week passed easily.

The newer certificates carried complete dates.

The trouble began after they opened the bundle from 1976.

On one certificate, in thick black ink, was written:

"Residence Rights Certificate, Serial No. 437, Year 1976."

Below it, the Circle Officer's signature and round seal were clear.

But nowhere was there a day or month.

Naresh left the day field blank and pressed Save.

The computer displayed in red:

"Date incomplete."

He left the month blank.

The same warning appeared.

Entering only 1976 would not save the record.

"Where am I supposed to get the date from?" Naresh asked Manorama Devi, who sat at the next desk.

Manorama turned the original paper over in her hands.

"How can we get it from somewhere if it is not written anywhere?"

Together they went to Assistant In-Charge Shyamkant Babu.

Shyamkant studied the certificate for a while.

"The system wants a complete date?"

"Yes."

“Then enter the middle day of the year.

First of July.

Neither early nor late.”

Naresh stopped.

“But what is the evidence that the certificate was issued on the first of July?”

Shyamkant smiled.

“The evidence is that the paper belongs to 1976.

The day is for the system, not for history.

Write in the remarks:

‘Day and month unavailable.’”

There was a small remarks field.

But that field did not appear on the citizen copy.

Naresh entered:

01-07-1976.

The record immediately displayed a green message:

“Saved.”

That day fourteen certificates were given birthdays in the same way.

The following week, thirteen certificates from 1971, twenty-one from 1968, and nine from 1982 all acquired the issue date 1 July.

A joke began in the room.

“Seven more birthdays today,” Manorama would say.

Naresh would reply,

“Where is the cake?”

Within a few months, the practice became a rule without ever becoming an order.

When a new employee joined, they were told:

“If the day and month are missing, use 1 July.”

No one asked who had first said it.

Shyamkant Babu had once said “the middle day.”

Later, in everyone’s memory, it became “the old instruction.”

Digitisation accelerated.

In the monthly report, the number of incomplete records began to appear as zero.

At a district-level meeting the room was praised for converting “old records with complete particulars.”

Naresh still felt a slight unease.

When a citizen copy was printed, the line:

“Issue date: 01-07-1976”

appeared clearly.

The remark did not.

But no citizen objected.

Most people took copies of certificates without having any reason to study the date.

Slowly, even Naresh began to see 1 July as fact.

Two years later, seventy-five-year-old Lakshman Mandal came to the room.

In his hand was an old plastic bag.

Inside it, wrapped in cloth, lay a yellowing sheet of paper.

His grandson Deepak was with him.

"This is the paper for my old house," Lakshman said.

"The canal is being widened and part of the land along the edge will be cut.

The compensation people told me to bring the digital copy."

Naresh examined the certificate.

Serial No. 437.

Year 1976.

The number seemed familiar.

But after so many thousands of papers, he did not trust his memory.

He searched the digital register.

The record opened:

Lakshman Mandal.

Residence Rights Certificate.

Issue date:

01-07-1976.

The copy was printed.

Lakshman folded the paper and placed it in his bag.

Within four days, the digital copy faced its first real test.

At the block's temporary compensation camp, Lakshman stood in line for three hours.

The assistant at the desk scanned the digital copy instead of examining the original certificate.

The moment 01-07-1976 appeared on the screen, he opened a printed list.

The cut-off date on it was:

30-06-1976.

"One day late," the assistant said.

Lakshman held out the original paper.

"Where is any day written on this?"

The assistant looked at the paper.

Then looked again at the date on the screen.

"The date exists in the district record.

I have to choose the category on the basis of that date."

Deepak said,

"The district record may contain the wrong date."

"Then have it corrected at the district office.

I cannot invent a date here."

Deepak remembered that sentence for a long time afterwards.

The assistant at the camp truly could not invent a date.

The district office already had.

That day Lakshman folded the corner of the original certificate a little more sharply than before.

At home Deepak opened the paper and flattened it.

Half the round seal now lay across the fold.

Only the words "Year 1976" were as clear as they had probably been forty years earlier.

Four days later they returned.

This time Lakshman walked faster.

His face looked tired.

"Where did this first of July come from?"

Naresh said,

"That is what the register shows."

Lakshman opened the original certificate.

"This has only 1976 on it."

Deepak interrupted.

"The canal-compensation rule says that residence certificates issued up to 30 June 1976 count as proof of earlier rights.

Because this has become 1 July, Dada falls one day outside the category."

The sound of the fan suddenly seemed louder in the room.

Naresh looked from the digital copy to the original paper and back again.

He remembered that first day.

Shyamkant Babu saying:

"Enter the middle day of the year."

He remembered the small remarks field too.

He opened the digital record and read the remark:

"Day and month unavailable."

"Why does this remark not appear on the citizen copy?" Deepak asked.

Naresh had no answer.

He went to Shyamkant Babu's room.

Shyamkant was now three months away from retirement.

Naresh told him everything.

Shyamkant removed his spectacles and placed them on the desk.

"I suggested first of July for convenience.

Not to take away someone's rights."

"But now the date is taking away a right."

"Then correct it."

"What date should I enter?"

Shyamkant fell silent.

To remove 1 July, another date was required.

The system would not accept an empty field.

The original document contained no day or month.

Inventing a second date would merely copy the first error.

Manorama suggested searching the old physical issue register.

The 1976 issue register was taken from the iron cupboard.

Its pages were crumbling at the edges.

Dates were legible up to Serial No. 432:

26 June.

The next two pages were blurred by water stains.

The name beside Serial No. 437 could still be read.
 But the date area had washed away.
 At Serial No. 441 the date became clear again:
 5 July.
 "So it could have been 4 July," Manorama said.
 "Or 28 June."
 Deepak said,
 "But it could also have been 1 July."
 Lakshman said nothing.
 He kept looking at the water stain on the page.
 Naresh's difficulty was that the truth was no longer merely unknown.
 The office had already filled the unknown space with a definite truth.
 The following day a letter arrived from the Canal Compensation Branch:
 "Since the issue date available in the digital record is 01-07-1976, the claim
 does not fall in the pre-cut-off category."
 The word "available" stung Naresh.
 The date had not been available.
 It had been manufactured.
 He searched out his old monthly conversion report.
 In the remarks for the first month, he found this line:
 "Where day and month were unavailable, 01-07 was entered as required by
 the system; original year unchanged."
 Below it were three signatures:
 Naresh.
 Manorama.
 Shyamkant.
 "So there is proof that the date was estimated," Manorama said.
 "There is proof," Naresh replied.
 "But the citizen copy carrying the wrong date has also become proof."
 A file was sent to the district office.
 It moved across three desks.
 The first remark said:
 "Authentic alternative date required for amendment of issue date in
 digital record."
 The second:
 "Alternative date unavailable."
 The third:
 "Existing date may be retained."
 Naresh stared at the file when it came back.
 The system was saying:
 to remove the false date, a true date was required.
 The true date was unavailable.
 Therefore the false date would remain permanently.
 That evening, after the room had closed, Naresh reopened the training
 manual for the digital register.
 Near the end was a page titled:

“SPECIAL RECORDS.”

No one used it.

It said:

“In historical documents with incomplete dates, source fidelity shall be preserved by recording the incompleteness through a separate remark/marker.”

But no such marker had ever been created in the present system.

At the district magistrate’s monthly review the following week, Naresh normally would not have spoken.

This time he carried with him Lakshman’s original certificate, the old issue register, and the first month’s conversion report.

“I do not need a corrected date,” he said.

“I need a place to write that the date is unknown.”

For a few moments the meeting was silent.

A technical assistant from the information unit said,

“If day and month are left blank, searching and calculation will be affected.”

Naresh replied,

“If we invent a day, a person is affected.”

At last a decision was made.

For old certificates containing only the year, a separate category would be created:

“Day-month unavailable.”

The exact same phrase would appear on the citizen copy.

Whenever a rule depended on a complete date, the decision would be made separately by examining the original document, serial-number register, and other evidence.

An invented date would not automatically become decisive.

The change did not happen in a day.

It took three weeks to modify the digital system.

Meanwhile Lakshman’s claim remained on hold.

The Canal Branch sent two reminders.

Deepak came to the room almost every third day.

Lakshman himself came only once.

He told Naresh,

“I want the decision about my land quickly.

But I cannot invent the birthday of a paper.”

Three weeks later the new copy was printed.

It said:

“Issue year: 1976.”

“Day-month: unavailable in original record.”

Below, in small type, appeared the source reference:

Serial No. 437 and the issue register.

The Canal Branch examined the old serial sequence, the entries between 26 June and 5 July, other residence-related tax receipts, and the field inspection.

Lakshman's claim was accepted in the prior-rights category.

No imaginary day appeared in the decision.

After this incident, the office began rechecking its old digital records.

It discovered that, across different years, a total of four hundred and twenty-three certificates were shown as having been "issued" on 1 July.

Looking at the list, Manorama said,

"So many people's papers were born on the same day."

This time no one laughed.

One by one, the citizen copies were corrected.

Where the actual date could be found, it was entered.

Where only month and year were available, only that much was retained.

Where only the year existed, only the year remained.

On the first day of the following July, Naresh opened the room in the morning.

Earlier, on that day, Manorama used to joke:

"Today is the certificates' birthday."

This time no such remark was made at the desks.

At noon, the envelope containing Lakshman Mandal's corrected copy was prepared for posting.

Naresh wrote the day's date on the envelope.

This date was real.

The envelope truly was being sent that day.

He paused.

Then, beneath the figures, he wrote in small letters:

"Date of dispatch."

The paper's own birthday was now left to the paper itself.

THE BELL'S AUTHORITY

In the old building of the Sub-Registry Office, there were two objects no one questioned.

One was the iron pillar leaning in the middle of the veranda.

The other was the brass bell on the desk of the Officer-in-Charge.

Whether the pillar was still bearing the building's weight or merely surviving through habit was a matter for engineers.

What rule governed the ringing of the bell was a matter for the people of the office.

Yet on this subject, the office staff were even more silent than engineers.

The bell was small.

On its round brass body, two or three patches of green had appeared amid the old polish.

A black knob stood on top.

Inside, a loosened spring plate.

Below, a thick brass base.

Whenever Officer-in-Charge Mahendranath Jha pressed the bell, everyone from the attendant in the veranda to the file examiner understood that an order had come from inside.

One ring, and one person rose.

Two rings, and usually two people.

Three rings, and everyone's pace quickened.

No one could say with certainty how many years the practice had existed.

The written rules mentioned the bell nowhere.

The office work-allocation register listed the duties of the attendant, clerks, copy clerks, writing assistants, and record keeper.

Nowhere did it say:

"Rise when the bell rings."

But the little brass sound was louder than anything written.

A junior clerk named Naveen Kumar worked in that office.

He was twenty-eight.

This was his fifth year in service.

He did not speak loudly.

He avoided arguments.

And he had the patience to read old remarks written on files.

People called him "Naveen Babu," but among the senior employees he was still "the new one."

On the upper floor of the building was the old records room.

Twice a day, bound registers and ledgers were moved from one room to another on a heavy iron trolley.

Some of the trolley's wheels were round.

Some had flattened with age.

As it rolled across the old upper floor, a faint vibration travelled down into the ceiling below.

The vibration spread through the pillar, walls, and wooden cupboards. Usually no one noticed it.

One day Mahendranath Jha had gone out for a district meeting. His desk was not in a locked chamber but in the ordinary office room. At about a quarter past twelve, the records trolley moved upstairs. The floor trembled.

The brass bell rang once.

Batuk, the attendant sitting in the veranda, sprang to his feet.

Two clerks stopped writing.

Mamta Kumari, seated at the copy window, half rose and then sat down again.

For five moments everyone looked at everyone else.

“Sahib is at the district office,” Mamta said.

Batuk slowly sat down.

“Then how did it ring?”

No one answered.

Naveen looked down towards the foot of the desk.

The bell’s top knob was still trembling slightly.

He said nothing.

The next day, around a quarter past twelve, the bell rang again.

This time Mahendranath was inside.

Batuk ran in.

“What is it?” Mahendranath asked over his spectacles.

“The bell rang, Sahib.”

“I did not ring it.”

Batuk’s face looked as though the very source of orders had deceived him.

On the third day Naveen watched the clock.

At 12:13, the trolley rattled upstairs.

Thirteen minutes later, the bell did not ring.

At 12:18, the trolley crossed the joint in the old floor.

The bell rang.

Naveen rose and placed a hand on its base.

The fine vibration was unmistakable.

He lifted the bell and examined it.

The green felt underneath had worn away.

On one side, the brass base touched the wood directly.

The top knob was so loose that a slight jolt made the small hammer inside strike the rim.

“Mystery solved,” he said to himself.

But in an office, the end of a mystery and the end of a habit are not the same thing.

During the following week the bell kept ringing by itself.

Sometimes because of the trolley above.

Sometimes because a heavy cupboard was moved.

Sometimes because the iron gate in the veranda slammed shut.
Gradually everyone understood the cause.
But old bodily habit remained.
At the sound of the ring, heads still rose.
“The bell lies,” Mamta said one day with a laugh.
Senior Clerk Ramchandra Mishra immediately corrected her.
“The bell does not lie.
The bell rings.
We add the meaning.”
The sentence stayed with Naveen.
On the last Tuesday of that month, the veranda was unusually crowded.
People had come from distant places.
Land partition.
Sale deeds.
Copies.
Corrections.
Certified records.
Every service window had a queue.
Clouds hung outside, and bus services were uncertain because of rain.
At noon an elderly woman arrived.
Her name was Sonwati Devi.
Her granddaughter Aarti was with her.
Sonwati carried an old cloth bag containing a bundle of papers.
Her husband had died.
Of her three sons, the youngest had remained at home to care for her.
By mistake, his name had been omitted from the new partition deed for the ancestral land.
The rest of the family agreed that he should be included.
The documents were ready.
But the file could not move without one necessary verification remark.
The employee authorised to make that remark had gone to another court building after lunch.
Aarti stood before Naveen’s desk.
“Babu, if it does not happen today, we may not be able to come again.
Dadi cannot walk properly.
Tomorrow we have to take her to Darbhanga for treatment of her eyes.”
Naveen examined the file.
There was no major dispute.
The concerned parties had given their consent.
The only obstacle was that an old reference paper had to be confirmed from the records room.
Senior Clerk Ramchandra Mishra had the authority to make that confirmation.
But because of the crowd he had already said:
“It will come in sequence.”
The sequence was long.

Sonwati sat with her back against the wall.
Her granddaughter kept fanning her with a sheet of paper.

12:57.

Naveen looked towards the staircase leading upstairs.

He knew that at one o'clock the records trolley would move old registers from the room on the right to the room on the left.

When it crossed the joint in the floor, the bell below often rang.

At 1:02, the rattling began upstairs.

Naveen picked up Sonwati's file.

At 1:03, the bell rang.

Heads rose across the veranda.

Batuk half ran.

Ramchandra Mishra too looked instinctively towards Mahendranath's room.

Mahendranath was speaking to someone on the telephone.

His hand was nowhere near the bell.

Naveen immediately went to Ramchandra Mishra's desk.

"Mishraji, this reference needs confirmation.

The records trolley is in that section just now.

The register can be brought down in two minutes."

Ramchandra looked at the bell.

Then at Naveen.

"Did Sahib ring?"

For one moment Naveen hesitated before answering.

He did not lie.

"The bell rang."

Mishraji took the file.

"All right. See to it."

Within ten minutes the old register arrived.

The reference matched.

The verification remark was written.

The file reached Mahendranath's desk.

He saw that the necessary checking had been done and signed it.

Before the afternoon ended, Sonwati's work was complete.

As they left, Aarti folded her hands to Naveen in thanks.

A small happiness rose inside him.

But beneath that happiness was something sharp.

He had not created an order.

He had only chosen the moment of the bell's false authority.

Yet if the bell had not rung, Sonwati's file might not have moved that day.

The following week he did it again.

This time the document concerned release of a labourer's land from mortgage.

The bell rang by itself.

Naveen carried the urgent file to the right desk.

The third time it was the case of a widowed school attendant.

Gradually Naveen learned the bell's timing.

He did not make it ring.

He merely used the moment of the ring.

His reasoning was simple.

If everyone in the office accepted the sound as an order without asking, how could it be wrong to draw a small benefit from that confusion for someone in genuine need?

But once confusion begins to produce benefits, its limits quickly become blurred.

One day a local deed writer named Harinarayan said to him in a low voice, "Naveen Babu, tomorrow I have a client's file.

You know the bell's time, don't you?"

A shiver ran through Naveen.

"The bell is not under my control."

Harinarayan smiled.

"I know.

But you know the timing."

That day, for the first time, Naveen saw his own actions through someone else's eyes.

What seemed to him like a small act of compassion had begun to look, from outside, like privileged access.

The bell was a symbol of the officer's authority.

Its shadow had now reached Naveen's desk.

The next day when the bell rang on its own, Naveen did not pick up any file.

There was no urgent case like Sonwati's.

Even so, he felt a strange restlessness—

as though an opportunity had been wasted.

A few days later Mahendranath noticed that the bell had been ringing too often without his hand.

He told Batuk,

"Have this bell repaired."

Batuk took it to a watch repairer in the market.

The watchmaker returned it that evening.

He tightened the spring plate.

He pasted a new strip of white woollen felt beneath the base.

The next day the bell remained silent.

The trolley moved upstairs.

The floor shook.

The pillar trembled faintly.

The bell did not ring.

The office day felt oddly quiet.

Twice, without any reason, Batuk walked as far as the Officer-in-Charge's door.

Mamta laughed.

"Now wait for a real order."

Three days later Mahendranath pressed the bell.

The ring was clearer than before.

Everyone's head rose.

Batuk ran.

"This is better," Mahendranath said.

But the problem did not end there.

An inspection team arrived from the district office.

One inspector was examining waiting times, file movement, and the list of pending cases.

He noticed that several files had moved with unusual speed during the same weeks in which the bell had been ringing on its own.

"Who ordered priority for these files?" the inspector asked.

The room fell silent.

Ramchandra Mishra looked at Sonwati's file.

"There was an urgent circumstance."

"Written priority order?"

"No."

"Oral?"

Ramchandra looked towards the bell.

Naveen felt his chest grow heavy.

At last he said,

"I moved some files to the appropriate desk at moments when the bell had rung."

The inspector asked,

"Who rang the bell?"

"No one.

It was ringing because of vibration in the building."

At first the inspector did not understand.

Then Batuk, Mamta, and Ramchandra described what had happened.

For a moment, both amusement and anger crossed the inspector's face.

"So here the building was issuing orders?"

No one laughed.

"And you," he said to Naveen,

"were interpreting the building's orders?"

Naveen lowered his head.

"I moved urgent work forward.

I took no money.

I did it for no one's private benefit."

"That is a separate question.

The fundamental question is:

what was the source of your authority?"

The meeting lasted three hours after that.

The bell remained silent on the desk.

Everyone looked at it from time to time, as though it were the witness.

The inspection findings were peculiar.

No allegation of bribery or personal gain against Naveen was established.

The files that had moved quickly were genuinely urgent in nature.
But the issue of an “unauthorised priority signal” was raised.
At the same time, another question was raised:
why did the office have no written procedure for identifying urgent humanitarian circumstances?

The district office issued an order.

The bell would be used only to summon the attendant.

For file priority, a separate short “reason slip” would be used.

The employee would write the urgency on it.

The Officer-in-Charge would sign.

And a new register was opened:

“Bell Use Register.”

Time.

Purpose.

Name of the person who rang it.

On the first day, Mamta looked at the register and said,

“Will the bell now write its name before it rings?”

Ramchandra smiled.

“No.

It will ring first.

Its history will be written afterwards.”

A formal warning arrived in Naveen’s name.

Two lines.

“Do not assign unauthorised administrative meaning to customary signals.”

He read the warning and put it into the file.

He felt hurt.

He also felt relieved.

A few weeks later the rains came.

Water began leaking in one part of the records room upstairs.

The heavy trolley had to be moved again across the old floor joint.

Below, Naveen was writing on a file.

Suddenly the building trembled.

The repaired bell did not ring this time.

But three employees sitting in the veranda raised their heads together.

So did Naveen.

A moment later everyone returned to work.

Mahendranath came out of his room.

“Did something happen?”

“No, Sahib,” Batuk said.

“Old habit.”

Mahendranath looked at the bell.

Then at the new stack of “Urgent Reason Slips.”

“All right.”

He went back inside.

At the far end of the veranda, an elderly farmer was unable to understand how to fill in a reason slip.

Naveen rose and went to him.

This time no bell had rung.

STORY 150

THE FIFTH SPACE FOR FOUR STAMPS

A new batch of government assistance forms arrived at the Block Assistance Office on Tuesday.

The paper was thick.

The printing was good.

The outline of the state emblem at the top was clear.

At the bottom were five square boxes spaced evenly apart.

Above four of them, in small print, were written respectively:

“Panchayat.”

“Revenue.”

“Engineering.”

“Accounts.”

Above the fifth box there was nothing.

Clerk Bholanath Mishra was the first to open the forms.

He pushed his spectacles up his nose and counted the five boxes.

Then he opened the rulebook.

The rules required four approvals.

He counted the paper again.

Five.

He counted the rules.

Four.

“It is a printing error,” Junior Assistant Niranjan said.

Bholanath did not answer immediately.

In the audit the previous year, an inspector had once written in red ink on one of his files:

“Blank box left unfilled.”

Because of that single line, Bholanath had had to submit explanations three times.

Since that day, an empty square on paper no longer looked empty to him.

Each one looked like a small mouth waiting to ask later:

“Why did you leave me blank?”

He read the rule again.

It said:

“Four approvals mandatory.”

It did not say:

“Leave the fifth box blank.”

“It is not proper to leave it empty,” Bholanath said.

“Then what do we put there?”

“First we must find out what it is for.”

In this way the fifth box officially came into existence inside the office, although it still had no name.

By noon, the first application arrived.

Half of Urmila Devi's house had sunk during the previous year's flood.

The Panchayat Secretary's stamp was there.

The Revenue employee's stamp was there.

The Junior Engineer's stamp was there.

The Accounts verification stamp was there.

The fifth box was white.

Bholanath turned the paper back and forth.

"One more stamp?"

Urmila Devi looked startled.

"Which one?"

Bholanath had no answer ready.

But when a visitor is standing in front of a desk, even silence in an office can feel like an order.

He placed a finger beneath the paper.

"This fifth place."

"Whose?"

Niranjan half rose from his chair and looked towards the rulebook.

Bholanath looked at him with an expression containing more question than help.

Niranjan said cautiously,

"Possibly final verification."

"Where?" Urmila Devi asked.

No one in the office knew.

But saying "We do not know" felt as unsafe as leaving the fifth box blank.

Bholanath said,

"Ask at the district office."

Urmila Devi did not fold the paper.

Carefully protecting all five boxes, she slipped it between the covers of an old file and left.

Three applications arrived the next day.

All had four stamps.

All had the fifth space blank.

Seven came on the third day.

By the end of the week ten files lay on the office desk in which the actual work was complete, but the fifth square had become the heaviest object in the file.

Employees began offering their own guesses.

The Panchayat Assistant thought the fifth stamp might be the bank's.

The Accounts Assistant said the bank would stamp after payment, not before.

Attendant Batuknath thought it might require the Block Development Officer's stamp.

The Officer said,

"If my stamp were required, my designation would be in the rules."

Everyone agreed.

But the fifth box remained empty that day too.

A week later Urmila Devi returned.

In the fifth space of her form was a "Received" stamp from the District Assistance Branch.

"This is not an approval," Bholanath said.

"They told me there is no branch for a fifth approval.

I told them this office would not accept the paper without a stamp.

So they put their receipt stamp on it."

Bholanath looked at the stamp.

Round.

Clear.

Blue.

The district office's name in the centre.

The paper now looked complete.

"Receipt and approval are different things," Niranjan said quietly.

Bholanath knew that.

But his eyes remained on the fifth box.

It was no longer blank.

"Keep the file," he said.

That day Urmila Devi's application moved forward.

Within two days, word spread that the fifth space required "the district stamp."

Crowds suddenly increased in the veranda of the District Assistance Branch.

At first the clerks there kept explaining that they had no authority to grant any fifth approval.

But when the crowd did not diminish, they began applying the receipt stamp merely in the hope that people would go away.

The receipt stamp gradually became an approval stamp.

Some applications carried the District Planning Branch stamp.

Some carried the Treasury stamp.

One even carried the stamp of the Public Information Room.

An elderly man obtained a stamp from a cooperative store near the bus stand because the word "District" was printed on it.

Outside the office, Munna, who ran a photocopy shop, hung a handwritten sheet from a bamboo pole:

"FIFTH STAMP—DISTRICT ASSISTANCE BRANCH."

No one had ordered him to write it.

Customers repeatedly asked for photocopies of that sheet as though it too were an official notice.

At first Munna explained that he had written it only for public convenience.

When the crowd grew, he added in smaller letters beneath:

"Ask at the Block Office first."

Twice, people travelled to the district, were told there was no fifth approval, returned, and then sat for hours in the Block Office veranda.

One young man said,

“If the branch does not exist, create it.
 At least people will save the bus fare.”
 Everyone laughed.
 The laughter was brief.
 Though it existed nowhere, the fifth office was consuming people’s time,
 money, and trust.
 Meanwhile a broker-like man began roaming the veranda.
 He would say,
 “I can get the fifth stamp put on in two days.”
 Bholanath drove him away.
 But that evening on the way home, he understood for the first time that
 the empty square no longer existed only on paper.
 Around it had grown trade, directions, bus journeys, and rumours.
 Bholanath rejected the stamp from the cooperative store.
 “Why?” the old man asked.
 “This is not a government approval.”
 “Whose is the fifth approval?”
 Bholanath fell silent.
 The old man asked again,
 “If no such office exists, on what basis is the wrong stamp wrong?”
 Bholanath did not like the question.
 It was a correct question.
 Correct questions in offices are often uncomfortable.
 Returning the file, he said,
 “Go to the District Assistance Branch.”
 “I went there yesterday.
 They said this stamp has no meaning.”
 “Then get that in writing.”
 The old man picked up his papers.
 The fifth box was still empty.
 The box stayed in Bholanath’s sight longer than the old man’s face did.
 Meanwhile Niranjana telephoned the printing office.
 The reply was:
 they did not have the original template.
 It had come from the District Stores Branch.
 The District Stores Branch said:
 the sample had been downloaded from the state portal.
 The copy on the portal had no fifth box.
 “Then where did this fifth box come from?” Niranjana asked.
 The Stores employee said,
 “Ask the printer.”
 The printing office said,
 “It was in the sample we received.”
 For the first time, the fifth box acquired a history of its own:
 everyone said it had come from somewhere else.
 One day the Block Development Officer called a meeting.

Five assistance forms were placed on the table.

One carried the District Assistance Branch stamp.

One the Treasury stamp.

One a bank stamp.

One the cooperative store stamp.

One was completely blank in the fifth box.

"The rules require four stamps," the Officer said.

"Once four stamps are present, treat the application as complete."

A slight fear rose in Bholanath's stomach.

"Sir, if inspection sees an empty box?"

"Write 'Not Applicable.'"

Everyone's face showed relief, as though the problem had been solved.

Niranjan took up a red pen and wrote in the fifth box:

"NOT APPLICABLE."

Bholanath stopped his hand.

"Who will write it?"

"I will."

"Under what authority?"

Silence spread through the room again.

The Officer frowned.

"Do we need authority to write 'Not Applicable'?"

Very politely, Bholanath said,

"If an inspector asks tomorrow who declared the fifth approval not applicable, we will need an answer."

The Officer leaned back in his chair.

He was not angry with Bholanath.

He knew Bholanath was driven less by love of rules than by the memory of punishment.

In an office, much rigidity is only an old layer of fear.

"All right," the Officer said.

"Prepare an order."

'Not Applicable' shall be written in the fifth box, and the office general stamp shall be affixed."

Niranjan drafted the order.

Bholanath read it.

Then asked,

"Who will affix the general stamp?"

"The attendant."

"The general stamp is in the Head Assistant's custody."

The Head Assistant said,

"I will not release it without a written presentation."

Thus, before writing "Not Applicable," a small presentation slip was created.

Niranjan signed the presentation slip.

The Head Assistant released the stamp.

The attendant supplied the ink.

Bholanath wrote "Not Applicable" in the fifth box.
 Then the general stamp was applied.
 Within three days, a new sentence began circulating inside the office:
 "Have you got the fifth stamp?"
 "This stamp is not an approval," Niranjan kept explaining.
 "Then what is it?" visitors asked.
 "This stamp says that the fifth stamp is not required."
 People nodded.
 On the paper five stamps could be seen.
 Four approvals.
 The fifth—
 a stamp rejecting the need for a fifth approval.
 Urmila Devi's payment had still not been released.
 Her first form carried the district "Received" stamp, not "Not Applicable."
 The Accounts Section returned the file:
 "Fifth box to be clarified as per new instructions."
 Urmila Devi came for the third time.
 "What do I need now?"
 Bholanath looked at the paper.
 He remembered that because of this fifth box the woman had already travelled to the district.
 Now because of the same box she was standing in the Block Office again.
 "The 'Not Applicable' stamp," the attendant said casually.
 Urmila Devi looked at him.
 "The thing that does not apply needs a stamp?"
 "Yes," the attendant said.
 "That is the rule now."
 Niranjan lowered his eyes.
 Bholanath took out a presentation slip.
 This time he filled it himself.
 He went to the Head Assistant's desk.
 Obtained the general stamp.
 Wrote "Not Applicable."
 Affixed the stamp.
 Then he placed Urmila Devi's file at the very top of the pile and carried it himself to Accounts.
 "Breaking the sequence?" the Accounts Assistant asked.
 "The sequence already broke because of the fifth box," Bholanath said.
 "Now look at the four real stamps."
 The Accounts Assistant examined the paper.
 The four real stamps had indeed been there from the first day.
 The fifth space was now filled by the office's own explanation.
 He accepted the file.
 A week later Urmila Devi's assistance was sanctioned.
 Meanwhile a circular arrived from the district.

An inquiry had found that an old form template had mistakenly been used for printing.

The fifth box was a remnant of a discontinued scheme in which approvals from five offices had been required.

It had no meaning in the present scheme.

The instruction said:

the next batch would be printed with four boxes.

On the existing forms, strike through the fifth box and write “Not Applicable.”

Bholanath read the circular and remained silent for a long time.

Niranjan smiled.

“You see?

The fifth office never existed.”

Bholanath folded the paper.

“The office did not exist.

But people were travelling there.”

Niranjan’s smile stopped.

The next batch arrived two weeks later.

At the bottom there were only four boxes.

The fifth space was simply clean paper—

no square,

no line.

The first application reached Bholanath’s desk.

He counted the four stamps.

All correct.

He sent the paper forward.

The second application came.

All four correct.

He sent that one forward too.

With the third application, an elderly farmer leaned over and asked,

“Babu, where will the ‘Not Applicable’ stamp go?”

Bholanath looked at the bottom of the paper.

There was no fifth box.

“It will not be needed now,” he said.

The old man did not look reassured.

“Certain?”

Bholanath paused.

Then he ran a finger over the four stamps.

“Certain.”

The old man left.

In the desk drawer, the small rubber stamp reading “Not Applicable” still remained.

The order authorising its use had ended.

But no order had arrived for destroying the stamp.

The Head Assistant had said an inventory would have to be prepared before disposal.

In the evening Niranjan came to place the office copy of the circular in the file.

Attached below it was the new four-box specimen.

Jokingly he asked,

“Shall I stamp ‘Not Applicable’ on this?”

At first Bholanath did not smile.

Then he smiled slowly.

“No,” he said.

“Not every empty space is meant to be filled.”

Niranjan closed the file.

Inside the drawer, the rubber stamp lay face down—
on the side from which its letters could not be read.

SERVICE WINDOW NUMBER NINE

After the eighth window in the Parcel Office, there was a wall.

After the wall, a drinking-water tap.

After the tap, an open veranda facing the railway tracks.

Dhanmanti looked at all three places.

Then she read the line printed at the bottom of her receipt:

“In case of difficulty, contact Service Window 9.”

She had ordered goods by rail for the first time.

A person visiting an office for the first time trusts the paper more than the wall.

Dhanmanti peered around the water tap.

There was a bucket.

No window.

“Where is Nine?”

The woman sweeping the floor stood her broom upright.

“After Eight?”

“That much I know too.”

Both women laughed.

Dhanmanti’s laughter ended quickly.

She had to catch another bus to return home.

In the village, the old warp had already been taken off the loom.

Somewhere inside this office lay the new parts she needed.

Window 3 handled weighing.

At Window 5, money was deposited.

At Window 7, papers for arriving goods were checked.

At Window 8, the release order for the goods was issued.

Dhanmanti had already gone twice between Seven and Eight.

At Seven she had been told:

“Two pieces have arrived.”

At Eight she had been told:

“The receipt says three.”

“The third one must have been left behind somewhere,” she said.

“Give me the two that are here.”

“How do we record partial receipt against a receipt for the full consignment?”

“Write ‘partial.’”

The employee behind the window looked at her as though she had used a very simple word for a very difficult act.

Then he placed a finger at the bottom of the receipt.

Following that finger, Dhanmanti had come as far as the water tap.

A small table stood in the veranda.

A piece of broken roof tile had been wedged beneath one of its legs.

Earlier it had held the weights for the scales.

After the new weighing machine arrived, the table had been moved outside.

Dhanmanti put her bag on it and flattened her receipt.

A young man came over.

He held a bicycle receipt.

"Is Nine here?"

"I am looking for it too."

He spread his paper beside hers.

Both carried the printed number Nine.

The young man's name was Rasik.

His bicycle had arrived.

But on the payment paper, the first two digits of the amount had been reversed.

The money had reached the office treasury.

It had not reached the bicycle.

After a while a trader carrying papers for four boxes of pickles came and stood there.

His goods were to be dispatched.

Dhanmanti made it clear that she was not an employee.

The trader said,

"I am not asking you to do my work.

Just let me put my papers down."

Three different difficulties lay open on the table.

Harinarayan, a clerk from inside, came out carrying his lunch box.

All three stopped him at once.

The moment he saw the receipts, he said,

"It is a printing error.

There is no Window Nine here."

"Then what is this line for?" Rasik asked.

"Leave it alone."

Rasik immediately folded one corner of his receipt over the printed Nine.

"Now?"

A smile appeared on Harinarayan's face.

He put his lunch box in the remaining space on the table and examined Rasik's paper.

On the payment slip from Window 5, 73 had been written instead of 37.

He went inside and called the employee from Window 5.

The man was counting money.

"Not now," he said.

Harinarayan came back and reached for his lunch box.

Dhanmanti did not catch his arm.

She merely placed a finger on the third item on her receipt.

"If I can get the two pieces that are here, our work at home can start."

"Whose work?"

"My husband's and mine.

We both work the loom.”

Harinarayan read the line on the receipt:

“Loom parts—three pieces.”

He did not remember the list of goods that had arrived.

He worked at Window 7.

But Window 7 did not give him enough time to remember everything.

“Call Bansal,” he said towards the doorway.

When Bansal came from the warehouse, his hands were dusty with wood.

He remembered shapes better than numbers.

Dhanmanti held out both hands to indicate the size.

“This long.

One had iron teeth.

The other was wooden.”

“Those are here,” Bansal said.

“There was also one thin bundle.

It did not say ‘loom’ on it.”

“What did it say?”

“Wood.”

“Does a loom contain no wood?”

Bansal looked not at Dhanmanti but at Harinarayan.

He might have laughed.

He did not.

It had rained on the night the goods were unloaded.

The outer label had become wet.

The surviving inner slip described the item as:

“Wooden frame.”

Bansal had had it placed in a separate pile.

Harinarayan said,

“We can settle it if the number matches.

Not by shape.”

He brought the unloading register from inside.

Bansal brought his small copy sheet.

The lunch box was pushed aside.

Dhanmanti placed her bag on the floor.

All three papers were opened together.

Dhanmanti’s receipt listed three pieces.

The unloading register showed two pieces under the same number.

On Bansal’s sheet, one line lower, it said:

“Wood—one.”

The ink had spread over the last two digits of its number.

“Just add that one,” Rasik said enthusiastically.

“Your own bicycle has two digits reversed,” Harinarayan said.

“So should we add somebody else’s wood to this?”

Rasik fell silent.

Dhanmanti too became quiet.

For the first time since entering the office, she realised that in her hurry to recover her goods, she too might claim something that belonged to someone else.

She asked to see the bundle.

Bansalal went inside alone.

It was not proper to take the crowd into the warehouse.

After a while he showed them, on his mobile phone, a photograph of the surviving part of the label.

The destination name and the clear part of the receipt number matched.

Harinarayan checked the sender's telephone number.

A copy of the original packing list came from the sender.

That list described all three parts separately.

The third bundle was Dhanmanti's.

But learning that fact did not place it immediately in her hands.

Harinarayan had to record the reason for correcting the register.

Bansalal had to reconcile the warehouse count.

Then the papers had to go again to Window 8.

This time Dhanmanti did not go to Window 8 alone.

Harinarayan went with her.

He completed his explanation from inside the window.

Dhanmanti listened from outside.

For the first time in that office, her consignment became three pieces in a single sentence.

By the time she returned, the employee from Window 5 had placed Rasik's paper on the table and was matching it against the payment register.

The trader was rewriting the address on his boxes.

He had received no special concession.

Rasik had merely pointed out that the recipient's village was missing from one box.

Dhanmanti left with the loom parts.

The loom did not run that day.

She missed the bus home.

By the time she reached the village on a cart, it was night.

At dawn the next morning, while fitting the iron-toothed part, she remembered the three papers spread open together on the veranda table.

The next day seven people were standing in the veranda.

Some had been sent to Nine.

Some had come after hearing about Nine.

Harinarayan was still seated at Window 7.

The table outside was empty.

But people stood around it.

A child wrote a 9 in chalk on the front of the table.

His father scolded him.

"Government property."

Then he looked at the Nine printed on his own receipt and fell silent.

At noon, Officer-in-Charge Nirmala Jha came outside.

She had received a complaint that a new service window had been opened in the veranda.

She walked around the table and looked at it.

“Who opened it?”

No one had an answer.

The table did not even have a drawer whose opening could be credited to someone.

Harinarayan said,

“People are matching their papers here.”

“Where does the employee sit?”

“Whoever is needed comes out.”

“So it has no window of its own?”

The question was difficult.

At Window 7, four people were waiting at that very moment.

One of them said loudly,

“My papers are correct, so I am standing there.

If there had been a mistake, I too would be sitting outside.”

Nirmala Jha heard him.

His complaint was reasonable.

She sent Harinarayan back inside.

Then she told the people in the veranda that no separate approval was given at this table.

No money was to be taken there.

Original documents were not to be kept there overnight.

Everyone must keep their own papers with them.

One man who had collected receipts from three people and was sitting there slowly returned all three.

He had not yet taken money from anyone.

But people had begun calling him:

“the Babu from Nine.”

He did not object to the title.

When Nirmala Jha went back inside, she called for the new batch of receipts.

The line mentioning Nine was indeed printed at the bottom.

The sample sent for printing had belonged to another, larger office.

The list of eight windows belonging to this office was correct at the top.

No one had read the help line at the bottom.

Her signature was on the approval.

She picked up a pen.

On the first receipt she struck out Nine.

Then on the second.

At the third, her hand stopped.

If Nine was crossed out, where were people supposed to go?

There was no place on the form to write the answer.

She closed the bundle.

For one week, half an hour after noon was set aside at the veranda table for document reconciliation.

Employees came out in rotation.

No new post was created.

Instead, half an hour was created between the old posts.

Three cases were resolved on the first day.

None on the second.

One man's trunk had been left at another station.

The veranda table could not pull it back.

Another man had lost his original receipt, and the available papers did not establish ownership clearly.

Angrily he said that Nine was just like the other windows.

Harinarayan could not contradict him.

On the third day Bansalal could not leave his work.

The people around the table waited.

One woman went home.

Her name did not appear in that day's queue because no one had even seen her papers.

At the end of the week Nirmala Jha asked for a report.

Harinarayan wrote:

Eight cases resolved.

Five remaining.

"And those who waited and went away without showing their papers?" Bansalal asked.

"They are not in the count."

Bansalal said nothing.

Harinarayan added a third line below eight and five:

"Count not maintained of persons who waited and returned."

There was no figure beside the line.

When Nirmala Jha read the report, she paused longest over that sentence.

Dhanmanti returned ten days later.

This time she had not come to collect goods.

The mechanic who had sent the new part needed the broken old piece returned so he could compare measurements.

Dhanmanti had written her name in three places on the bundle.

Beside the veranda table was a new nameplate:

"DOCUMENT RECONCILIATION ASSISTANCE."

There was no Nine on it.

An employee was trying to decide how to stand the board along the long edge of the table.

If placed there, papers could be handed forward easily.

But they would be difficult to open from both sides.

Dhanmanti put her bundle on the floor.

"Put it on this side," she said, indicating the short edge of the table.

"It will not be readable from a distance there," the employee said.

"People can come close and read it."

The employee placed the sign along the short edge.

Harinarayan came out carrying two registers.

He opened one towards himself.

He turned the other towards the visitor.

Dhanmanti asked where her bundle should be deposited.

He pointed her to Window 3.

This time her work was completed at Three.

On her way back, she did not stop at the table.

The chalk Nine was still on one of its legs.

Sweeping had erased its lower tail.

A young man was trying to move the broken roof-tile wedge beneath the leg because the table rocked when he wrote.

Dhanmanti bent down and pushed the piece farther in.

The young man began writing again.

STORY 152

THE TABLE BY THE GATE

On the first day of the camp, the table stood three cubits inside the gate.

On the second day, it was moved two cubits outward to escape the sun.

By the third day, no one had noticed that those two cubits—inside or outside—could change the status of a piece of paper.

The table belonged to the school.

In one corner, a student had once scratched his name with the point of a compass, and half the letters could still be read.

During the school holidays, a land-survey camp had been set up there.

Maps, measuring chains, files, and officers occupied the classrooms.

On the table by the gate lay stacks of white paper.

Jagesar was told to count them.

One hundred application forms.

Fifty receipt sheets.

Twenty thick envelopes.

He was the school watchman.

His real work was to lock the classrooms in the evening and open them in the morning.

While the camp lasted, he had also been told to remain there during the day.

The order did not say how much extra money he would receive.

He finished counting and placed the forms to one side.

He hung his lunch bag beneath the table.

Meanwhile a man placed a two-page application on the tabletop.

“Give it inside,” Jagesar said.

“I will. I’m just parking my bicycle.”

The man did not return.

He met a surveyor he knew and went with him towards the rear veranda.

Jagesar carried the application inside.

The clerk at the first desk said,

“There is an error in the name. Next desk.”

The employee at the next desk said,

“It is not a name error. It is matching an old name with a new one. Take it to the copying room.”

Jagesar reached that room.

The young man sitting there took the paper.

Jagesar had known him from the days when he was a student at the school.

Now he had a beard, and people called him a records assistant.

Jagesar called him by name.

“Sudhir, look at this.”

In the evening, the man came to thank him.

His work was not complete, but he had found the correct number of the old copy he needed.

Standing in front of the table, he told two other people,
“Give it here first. Jagesar Kakka understands.”

The next morning, five applications were lying on the table.

Jagesar was counting the stack of forms.

He put on his old reading glasses and read all five.

One concerned boundary measurement.

Two asked for copies.

One was for correction of a name.

And one began with the word “justice” in the first line, though below it the applicant merely asked for the date on which the survey team would come.

Jagesar understood at least this much:

merely writing “justice” did not mean the paper belonged at the desk that heard disputes.

Petition writers often made the first line of an application grand.

A person’s actual need was usually written below in smaller letters.

The third application belonged to Phulpatiya.

The northern ridge of her vegetable patch fell at the join between two map sheets.

On the copy hanging at the camp, one sheet was present.

The place where the second should have been was blank.

She had told the petition writer,

“Show me the boundary of my vegetable patch.”

He had written:

“For expeditious disposal of a boundary dispute.”

Jagesar read it and asked,

“Who is the dispute with?”

“No one yet.”

“Then why does it say dispute?”

“The writer said they would listen more quickly if it was written like that.”

Jagesar read the paper again.

He knew Phulpatiya’s vegetable patch.

When it rained, water from the school ground drained past that ridge.

But he did not know the ownership of the land or the exact boundary.

He told her only:

“First see the second sheet of the map.”

He carried the application to Sudhir.

Sudhir took out the map index.

The second sheet had never arrived from the district office.

A copy could be requested.

Phulpatiya was told to return after two days.

When she left, there was no stack of blank forms on the table anymore.

There were people’s papers.

She asked,

“Has mine been submitted?”

“It is with Sudhir,” Jagesar said.
 That was enough for her.
 She did not know where Sudhir sat.
 She could see where Jagesar sat.
 By the fourth day, a queue had formed in front of the table.
 The rooms inside were not empty, but the queue outside was more visible.
 Two employees joked that the camp headquarters had now moved to the gate.

Jagesar tried to hide the pride the joke gave him.
 Picking up an application, he said a little more loudly than necessary,
 “This one goes to Records.”
 He had begun to remember the names of the branches.
 He already knew the school’s rooms.
 The surveyor’s desk was the one with the chain in the bag.
 The copying desk was the one where the edges of the paper had yellowed.
 At the complaint desk, people stood for a long time.
 Jagesar routed papers by such signs.
 He did not alter anyone’s application.
 But he often added one sentence with his mouth.
 “This woman only wants to see the map.”
 “This man’s father’s and grandfather’s names have been reversed.”
 “The paper in this child’s hand was sent by his mother; the child is not the owner of the land.”

It saved time for the people inside.
 It also saved embarrassment for the people outside.
 Along with the work, a small authority of his own began to grow.
 When his neighbour Ramudit came, Jagesar placed his paper on top of the stack.

He saw Ramudit every day.
 Ramudit had to go for wage work that day.
 An unfamiliar woman standing behind him had also left her wage work to come.

She said nothing.
 Jagesar saw her.
 Then looked away.
 At noon, his lunch still hung untouched beneath the table.
 By the time he opened the bag, the rice had gone cold.
 In his mind he counted all the running about he had done that day.
 Placing Ramudit’s paper on top was not included in that count.
 On the sixth day, Phulpatiya returned.
 Sudhir was not there.
 He had been sent to the district office.
 The new employee sitting at his desk searched for the application and then asked,

“Receipt number?”
 “Jagesar Kakka took it.”

“Receipt?”

“He said it was with Sudhir.”

The new employee was not irritated.

He genuinely wanted to find the paper.

There were three piles on the desk:

incoming post,

requests for copies,

and papers given for comparison.

Phulpatiya’s name was not in the receipt register.

Her application was found in the comparison pile.

It had no submission number on it.

“This was kept only for examination,” the employee said.

Phulpatiya picked up the paper.

“I did not give it for me to look at.

I gave it for you to look at.”

She was not explaining the semantic difference.

She was explaining the loss of two days’ wages.

The new employee understood that.

But he did not dare enter an earlier date into the register.

He sent her to the Head Clerk.

Meanwhile the final date for applications for boundary measurement was announced.

For the first time Phulpatiya became frightened.

Until that day she had believed her work was already moving.

Now she realised that her paper had moved, but no one could say where her case had actually begun.

Head Clerk Shailendra Babu came to the gate.

“Are you receiving applications?”

Jagesar said,

“I carry them inside.”

“People say they submit them to you.”

“I never used the word ‘submit.’”

Phulpatiya interrupted.

“I asked him.”

Jagesar looked at her.

He remembered her question that day.

He remembered his answer too.

“It is with Sudhir.”

The empty space in that sentence had been filled by Phulpatiya with trust.

Shailendra Babu counted the papers lying on the table.

There were twenty-three sheets.

Jagesar said,

“They belong to eight people.”

“Twenty-three received is written here,” the clerk said, showing the paper in his hand.

That morning someone inside had asked Jagesar how many papers were outside.

He had counted the sheets and answered:
twenty-three.

Inside, the figure had been entered in the column for “applications received.”

“You sent eight of the twenty-three inside?”

“Twenty-three sheets belong to eight people.”

“Then where are the remaining fifteen?”

Jagesar opened one application with five attached copies.

Shailendra Babu fell silent.

Phulpatiya held her two sheets with both hands as though she too might now be counted as more than one person.

That evening a meeting was called.

The subject was:

“Determination of duties of the temporary table near the gate.”

Jagesar was called as well.

The chair they gave him to sit on was one he locked away every evening.

It was the first time he had sat in it.

Camp In-Charge Anamika Chaudhary first asked whether the table stood inside or outside the official premises.

The line of the school gate was shown on the map.

Shailendra Babu said the table now stood outside the line.

Jagesar said he had moved it to avoid the sun.

“Move it back inside tomorrow,” one employee suggested.

“Will that give it authority to issue receipts?” Anamika asked.

The employee said,

“No.”

“Then two cubits will not solve the question.”

For a while the meeting discussed the table’s responsibility and Jagesar’s appointment.

Could a school watchman be entrusted with Revenue papers?

Could he read applications?

On whose order had all this happened?

Answers began to be searched for in different documents.

Jagesar kept both hands on his knees.

He felt that if he rattled his bunch of keys just then, everyone would recognise him again.

Anamika called for the eight applications.

She examined them one by one.

Two were merely requests for forms.

Three needed formal registration.

One belonged to another camp.

Two were for looking up records.

The desks to which Jagesar had carried them were mostly correct.

But there was no mark anywhere showing that they had arrived.

“Do you also return papers?” she asked.

“To whoever I am told to give them.”

“Who received them?”

Jagesar gave no answer.

He remembered faces.

The office required numbers instead of faces.

Shailendra Babu said no application should be taken at the gate.

Everyone should come directly inside.

Anamika looked out through the window.

There were already queues in front of three rooms.

Some of the village women outside understood their work by the name of their village.

Not by the name of a room.

After much discussion, no new post was created.

Instead, it was decided that for the first two hours each morning, the desk of the clerk who maintained the receipt register would be placed near the gate.

Jagesar would count the blank forms and tell people where to go.

Written applications would be received by the clerk.

The number of attached pages would be recorded separately on the receipt.

Even when a paper was taken merely for examination, responsibility for returning it would be written down.

At the end of the decision, one line said:

“Receipt by watchman prohibited.”

Jagesar read it and remained silent.

Beside that line Anamika added:

“Assistance in giving directions to continue as before.”

Reading the two sentences together, Jagesar understood that half his work had been recognised.

The other half—

work he had not even realised he was doing—

had been forbidden.

Phulpatiya’s application was formally registered with that day’s date.

When Sudhir returned, he wrote that the paper had earlier been given to him only for checking the records.

The deadline had not yet passed, so Phulpatiya did not need to write a new application.

But no one asked about the wages she had lost.

Three days later the second map sheet arrived.

When the two sheets were joined, it became clear that measurement was needed.

Phulpatiya’s neighbour was also called.

Jagesar knew him.

But this time he did not say where he thought the boundary ridge lay.

The survey team fixed a date.

Phulpatiya did not receive a decision about the land.

She received written notice of the date.

She placed it deep inside her bag.

Ramudit came again.

He held out his paper towards Jagesar.

“Stand in this line,” Jagesar said.

“Don’t you recognise me?”

“I do.”

Ramudit stood for a while.

Then went to the back of the queue.

Jagesar felt his answer had sounded harsh.

He gestured to Ramudit to move into the shade.

On the final evening of the camp, the table was to go back into the school room.

The clerk was packing up the register.

Jagesar was counting the unused forms.

Phulpatiya arrived carrying her measurement notice.

One digit of the date was not clear to her.

The clerk read it aloud.

She began to leave.

Then turned back towards Jagesar.

“Now this will stay with me?”

“Yes.”

She did not fold the paper.

From her bag she took out the thick card of an old wedding invitation and placed the notice inside it.

Jagesar saw that before anything else she was making sure the receipt number would not be covered.

When it was time to lock the gate, Jagesar took his lunch bag down from beneath the table.

That day he had eaten on time.

THE RED PENCIL'S PROMOTION

A red pencil appeared in Dinesh's supply box on Monday.

Paper, pins, and pencils were being distributed from Stores.

Ramsevak placed all three items down, put a finger on one place in the register, and Dinesh signed there.

By the time he noticed the colour of the pencil, Ramsevak had already moved on to the next desk.

In the Audit Branch, red pencils were usually kept in the drawers of senior officers.

Dinesh had never seen a written rule saying so.

But in twelve years he had certainly seen this much:

people searched one another's desks for an ordinary pencil.

For a red pencil, they first looked towards the chair.

If the chair was empty, the work stopped.

Dinesh went to Stores.

Ramsevak said the boxes had been mixed up.

Ordinary pencils would arrive on Wednesday.

He had no objection to taking the red pencil back.

But that would require an alteration in the receipt register.

He had already closed the register and wrapped it in cloth.

"Keep it for two days.

The point sharpens the same way."

Dinesh brought the pencil back.

His old pencil had become so short that when he held it, his thumb and forefinger seemed to quarrel with each other.

The first circle he drew with the new pencil was on a monthly expenditure statement.

At the top it said "Bhadra," but the first date in the accounts was the fifth and the last was the twenty-ninth.

Dinesh wanted the actual accounting period to be written along with the name of the month.

He had said this before.

The file would circulate and return.

His request written in the margin would remain in the margin.

That day, by one o'clock, a revised statement arrived with the period clearly written.

Harikant Babu placed it on his desk and said,

"From now on it will come like this."

Dinesh looked at the red circle.

He wanted to say that he had marked it only for comparison.

But the new statement was better than the old one.

The dates were clear.

Work that had previously made him rise from his chair three times had been completed while he remained seated.

He thanked Harikant and kept the paper.

On Tuesday his red circle fell around a page number.

Two pages in the middle had been bound in reverse order.

Within half an hour the entire file came back resewn.

Urmila, who brought it, said that “the people above” were now paying attention to page order.

“Who above said so?”

“There was a red mark, wasn’t there?”

Urmila did not remain standing.

She had another batch to prepare.

Dinesh lifted the pencil.

Then put it down.

The page order was now correct.

There was no point in making it wrong again.

Ordinary pencils arrived on Wednesday.

Ramsevak placed one on his desk.

He had forgotten to ask for the red pencil back.

Dinesh kept both in the box.

He did some addition and subtraction with the ordinary pencil.

In the statement of departmental advances, the heading of one section was unclear.

When he reached it, his hand moved towards the red pencil.

This time he knew how the circle would be read.

By evening the heading had been corrected and returned.

Harikant Babu called him for tea.

He kept saying that if small things were noticed on time by the people above, useless objections would not accumulate below.

Dinesh held the cup.

In Harikant Babu’s “above,” Dinesh himself was nowhere.

Yet in the shadow of that word, his own point was being heard.

The following week the account for rebinding old registers arrived.

The thick cardboard covers of twenty-four registers had been replaced.

Their loose spines had been restitched.

Cloth had been pasted over the corners.

The total payment was sixteen hundred and eighty rupees.

Half had been paid in advance for purchasing materials.

Half was due after completion.

In the summary statement, two separate dates carried entries of eight hundred and forty rupees each.

The recipient’s name was the same in both places:

Saraswati Bookbinder.

Dinesh circled both amounts.

The original bill was not attached.

His intention was simply to compare the two entries once the bill arrived.

He had begun writing "bill" in the margin when his mobile phone rang from home.

His father's medicine had run out.

Dinesh had brought the prescription in his bag.

He read the medicine's name over the phone.

By then Urmila had picked up the summary statement along with another paper.

He remembered it only when the branch was closing.

He thought:

I will ask for it tomorrow.

The red circle is not going anywhere.

The next day Harikant Babu had the rebinding file with him.

He had already asked the clerk who prepared the account why payment for the same work had been made twice.

The clerk said he would answer after seeing the bill.

That did not reassure Harikant Babu.

He sent for Saraswati.

The next batch of registers was held back for the time being.

Saraswati arrived in the afternoon.

In her bag were a measuring tape, three pieces of cloth, and a box of thick needles.

She thought she had been called to measure the width of the spines in the next batch.

Harikant Babu raised the matter of returning eight hundred and forty rupees.

No formal letter had yet been issued.

He thought that if the matter could be understood between them, there would be no need to place an objection on the file.

"I received sixteen hundred and eighty," Saraswati said.

"There are two payments of eight hundred and forty here."

"Yes.

I received it in two instalments."

Hearing this, Harikant Babu turned the summary statement towards her.

Both red circles were clearly visible.

Saraswati looked once at the figures.

Then at him.

In her arithmetic, two payments of eight hundred and forty made sixteen hundred and eighty.

In the tone of the person showing her the paper, receiving the money in two instalments itself seemed to be some additional fact.

At that moment Dinesh was taking a register out of the nearby cupboard.

His hand remained on the register's spine.

"Has the bill arrived?" he asked.

Harikant Babu said,

"That is why I called her.

There is a mark from above.

It should be cleared first.”

Dinesh could have said that the circle was his.

It would have taken one sentence.

But behind that single sentence stood last week's tea, the corrected heading, the file resewn at once.

He closed the cupboard and said he would check the payment papers.

Saraswati did not take the next batch with her that day.

She had told the cardboard supplier that once she received more office work, she would pay part of the old amount she owed.

As she was leaving through the gate, she asked Dinesh whether she should bring the bill from home tomorrow or the same day.

“Bring it tomorrow,” Dinesh said.

His own voice sounded unnecessarily casual to him.

He kept the file open until evening.

The first payment order said:

“Advance for materials.”

The second said:

“Final payment.”

But the calculation sheet that should have accompanied it was missing.

There was only a receipt for eight hundred and forty rupees.

Harikant Babu's suspicion now had one basis.

That basis was different from Dinesh's red circle.

But the circle had carried him from question to conclusion.

Dinesh came early the next morning.

In the margin of the old payment register he found the bill number.

Using that number, the original paper was found in another file.

The calculation sheet had been folded behind the bill:

Total: 1,680.

Previous advance: 840.

Balance: 840.

There was also a signature acknowledging completion of the work.

Dinesh flattened the paper.

A fine line of dust ran along the fold.

Instead of blowing on it, he wiped it with a cloth.

He was afraid of rubbing the ink away.

When Harikant Babu arrived, Dinesh gave him all three papers.

Harikant said,

“It is all right.

Write that reconciliation has been completed.

We will send it upward.”

“The circle was mine.”

Harikant Babu removed his spectacles.

Dinesh explained that he had intended only to call for the bill.

He had not concluded that the payment was duplicated.

He had failed to write the words.

Harikant Babu asked why he had not said so in front of Saraswati the previous day.

Dinesh kept smoothing the fold in the paper.

For the first time the act seemed pointless.

The fold would remain where it was.

"I should have said it yesterday," he said.

At noon the Senior Accounts Officer arrived.

The matter of the red pencil was raised before him.

He asked where the order was reserving that colour for senior officers.

No one produced such an order.

Ramsevak was called.

He opened the distribution register.

It said only:

"Pencil—one."

There was no column for colour.

"Then how will anyone know who wrote something on the paper?"

Urmila asked.

The Senior Officer said remarks should carry a name.

Many of his own old comments consisted only of ticks.

Urmila pushed one file lying in front of her towards him.

Beside his tick, he put a small signature.

No lengthy instruction was issued after that.

Saraswati returned with her bill.

One corner of it was stained with bookbinding paste.

Dinesh gave her a chair and told her about his mistake.

He said she did not have to return any money.

Saraswati placed the bill back in her bag.

She ought to have been pleased by the information.

But she had never received any extra money in the first place.

"Will I get the next batch today?"

Harikant Babu said the list would be ready.

"I will not be able to take it today.

I accepted another job this morning.

I will come the day after tomorrow."

She did not say this as a complaint.

She merely stated the calculation of her own time.

Dinesh wrote in the file that comparison of the original bill with the adjustment of the advance showed the total payment to be correct.

Then he added one more sentence:

the unexplained circle had been made by him.

He wrote his name and date and sent the paper forward.

Harikant Babu read it.

He did not ask him to remove the last sentence.

He merely added the word "red" before "circle," using ordinary ink.

The next day two statements arrived on Dinesh's desk.

In the first, the accounting period had again been omitted.

He picked up the red pencil.
He drew a circle.
And beside it he wrote the full point:
state clearly the dates from which and to which the account runs.
Below that, he wrote his name.
The paper did not return immediately.
Noon passed.
Tea time passed.
In the evening the revised statement arrived with the period written in.
Along with it was a short note from the clerk saying that the next
month's form would include a space for the period.
Dinesh read the note and placed the paper in the file.
The pencil point had become blunt.
He took out a blade to sharpen it.
Red shavings fell into the box among the shavings of ordinary pencils.
He rose to empty the box.
Just then Urmila arrived carrying a file.
"I have come to ask what this circle means."
Dinesh opened the file.
This time Urmila sat down.

STORY 154

THE PINK MARGIN LOST IN THE PHOTOCOPY

In the Establishment Branch of the District Handicrafts Promotion Office, colours had meanings of their own.

Red ink was for objections.

Green for the outer cover of approval letters.

Blue stamps for incoming correspondence.

And a pale pink strip of paper was placed along the margin of charge notifications.

The papers were coloured.

Most office photocopies were black and white.

No one paid particular attention to the difference.

In the final week of Jeth, the District Handicrafts Officer was transferred.

The new officer would take some time to assume charge, so Senior Assistant Raghav Chaudhary was given temporary charge.

The order was one page long.

Its main text, in black letters, said that Raghav Chaudhary would handle daily administration, expenditure within the sanctioned limit, training files, and marketing-related files.

Along the right margin ran a pink strip two fingers wide.

In small letters on it was written:

“Charge valid until 30 June 2026 or until the new officer assumes office, whichever is earlier.”

Establishment Assistant Meera Jha had three copies made.

The machine was old.

It had a button marked “Text Clear.”

Pressing it made pale colours almost disappear, but the letters came out darker.

Meera almost always used that setting because even faint carbon copies became easier to read.

The first copy came out.

The main order was clear.

The signature was clear.

The seal was clear.

The right margin was completely white.

Meera looked at the pink strip on the original.

Then at the photocopy.

It seemed the writing in the margin had not reproduced.

She placed the original in the machine again and tried a normal copy.

This time the main text came out lighter.

The pink lettering was still incomplete.

“Make a colour copy,” said Ashok, the Stores Assistant sitting beside her.

Meera thought of searching her phone for the number of a photocopy shop in the market.

Then she looked at the clock.

The order had to reach Accounts, the Training Branch, and the notice board at the entrance immediately.

Pointing by hand to the pink margin on the original, she wrote in pencil on the black-and-white copy:

“Period indicated in original.”

Then she distributed the three copies.

On the Accounts copy, her pencilled line vanished by the second week after further photocopying.

On the notice-board copy, a pin went through the sentence.

On the Training Branch copy, someone trimming papers to uniform size cut off the right margin while binding a file.

First the period disappeared into colour.

Then into procedure.

When Raghav Babu sat in the charge officer’s chair on the first day, the chair itself was not changed.

His old desk was shifted into the officer’s room.

He brought his pen, a calculator, a copy of his service book, and his hard spectacles case.

Attendant Gajendra asked,

“Will the nameplate be changed?”

Raghav Babu said,

“Why cut wood for thirty days?

Put up a paper.”

A white sheet was pasted on the door:

“Raghav Chaudhary, Officer-in-Charge.”

The word “temporary” appeared nowhere because in the main text of the order the designation was simply “Officer-in-Charge.”

The time limit was in the pink margin.

And no photocopy of that pink margin had reached the door.

The first week passed smoothly.

Raghav Babu was an old employee.

He knew where whose files got stuck.

Which training centre’s rent was pending.

Which group had changed its bank account.

He also knew the limits of his order.

On large expenditure files he wrote:

“Approval of new officer awaited.”

Smaller payments he allowed to proceed under the rules.

On the last Monday of June, three women from Sakri’s Sonjharia Sikki Group came to the office.

The group had made one hundred and twenty sikki boxes and forty wall decorations for a school exhibition.

The goods had been submitted on time.

The inspection report was clean.

But payment of seventy-nine thousand six hundred rupees had been pending for three weeks.

Group secretary Sunita Devi opened the file.

“We bought the raw material on credit.

The shopkeeper’s payment date is passing.

The government has taken the goods.

The money is still sitting in the papers.”

Raghav Babu called Accounts Assistant Bibhuti.

The calculation was checked.

The quantity matched.

The receipt matched.

There was one issue.

The inspection team had written:

“Uniformity of colour satisfactory.”

But in the sample list, the colour names of two items had been recorded in different words.

Bibhuti Babu said,

“During audit they will ask how ‘kusum’ and ‘yellow’ became the same colour.”

Sunita Devi took two small pieces of sikki from her bag.

“Look.

In our village we call this kusum.

The market people write yellow.

The thing itself is the same.”

Raghav Babu turned the pieces in his hand.

“The colour has not changed.

Only the word has changed.”

He wrote on the file:

“Physical sample comparison available; difference only in local colour terminology. No ground to withhold payment.”

The file moved forward.

Sunita Devi bowed and left.

That day Raghav Babu said for the first time,

“Whatever can lawfully be completed by 30 June should not be stopped.”

Bibhuti Babu heard the date and asked,

“What happens after that?”

Raghav Babu said,

“After that we will see the new order.”

30 June arrived.

The new officer had not.

No extension letter had come from district headquarters either.

In the morning Raghav Babu went to the Establishment Branch.

Meera Jha opened the file containing the original order.

The pink margin was clear.

“Today is the last day,” Meera said.

"I know."

"Anything from headquarters?"

"There has been an oral conversation.

They said to let the work continue.

The order will come."

Meera ran a finger over the original.

"What colour is an oral instruction?"

Raghav Babu smiled.

"When it comes in writing, black."

By the time the office closed that evening, nothing had arrived in writing.

Raghav Babu looked at the files on his desk.

Most were routine matters.

Two training honoraria.

One vehicle repair.

Payments to three groups.

Travel allowance for one exhibition.

On some files he wrote:

"Order awaited."

On others he merely added a remark and returned them to the branch.

On the morning of 1 July, attendant Gajendra opened the officer's room as usual.

Raghav Babu wanted to go to his old desk.

But that desk was still inside the officer's room.

The paper on the outer door still said:

"Raghav Chaudhary, Officer-in-Charge."

"Shall I take it down?" Gajendra asked.

Raghav Babu looked at the paper.

"The new order will come.

Leave it for now."

That small sentence began an office day whose written basis had already expired.

Employees continued carrying files into the same room.

Visitors continued reading the same name.

Black-and-white photocopies remained scattered through the branches, none showing a final date.

Only in the Establishment file did the pink margin remain alive.

At noon on 2 July, the Sonjharla Group file returned to Raghav Babu's desk.

The audit check was complete.

The payment order now required the Officer-in-Charge's signature.

Bibhuti Babu placed the file before him.

"If this is stopped, the group's money will be delayed for another week."

Raghav Babu looked at the date.

2 July.

He picked up his pen.

Then put it down.

“Anything from headquarters?” Bibhuti asked.

“Still nothing.”

“I have a copy of the charge order.

There is no period written on it.”

Raghav Babu looked at him.

“It is written on the original.”

Bibhuti Babu fell silent.

Then he said,

“In that case, do not sign.”

At that moment Sunita Devi was sitting outside in the veranda.

Group treasurer Parmeshwari Devi was with her.

Both had come on the morning bus.

Before leaving home, Sunita had told the shopkeeper that if the order was passed that day, his money would reach within three days.

Now that promise sat in her bag as heavily as a file.

Raghav Babu closed the file.

“I will not sign the final payment without a written extension.”

Bibhuti Babu breathed with relief.

But as soon as he saw Sunita Devi’s face outside, his eyes dropped.

Meera Jha had also reached there.

She said,

“There is one way.

We can seek special approval from the new officer or from headquarters.”

“How many days?” Sunita Devi asked.

Meera did not answer.

In government time, counting days was easy.

Answering for them was difficult.

On 3 July, an email arrived from headquarters:

“Until the new officer assumes charge, the senior-most officer shall attend to daily work; financial powers as per the previous order.”

The moment the sentence was read, the dispute began.

Did “daily work” include payment?

Did “as per the previous order” mean the earlier financial limit continued?

Or did it mean the earlier expiry date continued too?

The paper had arrived.

Now the paper itself began asking for another paper.

Raghav Babu said,

“This is not a clear extension.”

Bibhuti Babu said,

“But it is not a clear prohibition either.”

Meera said,

“If the lack of clarity is equal in both directions, why should the file remain trapped in the middle?”

Raghav Babu himself was the senior-most person in the office.

So the phrase “senior-most officer” circled back to him.

He had photocopies of the email made.

This time Meera suggested sending out to the market for colour copies.
Ashok laughed.

"The email itself is black and white.

What will colour copying do?"

Meera said,

"At least what has no colour will look the same to everyone."

In the end, Raghav Babu did not issue a final order on the Sonjharia Group file.

He wrote instead:

"Work completed, receipt verified, payment admissible. Financial sanction by competent authority."

The file was sent to headquarters.

Sunita Devi was told it might take two or three days.

On 6 July, the Assistant Director at headquarters telephoned.

"Raghavji, your charge was only until 30 June, wasn't it?"

"Yes."

"The copy sent to us contains no date anywhere."

Raghav Babu was silent for a few moments.

"The pink margin did not appear in the photocopy."

From the other end came not laughter, but a long breath.

"Why is authority printed in colour?"

Raghav Babu said,

"Ask the person who drafted the order.

I am asking the same question now."

Headquarters asked for a colour copy of the original order.

Meera went to the market.

The shopkeeper scanned the original page and printed a colour copy.

The pink margin now shone clearly.

The date 30 June was so unmistakable that looking at her old black-and-white copy made Meera feel almost ashamed.

The main text of the two sheets was identical word for word.

But in one, the authority was alive.

In the other, the end of that authority had disappeared.

That evening the Assistant Director issued written instructions:

from 1 July onward, Raghav Babu would handle only daily correspondence and essential administrative work.

Financial approval would be given by an officer nominated by headquarters.

The Sonjharia Group payment file was to be sent immediately to that officer.

The payment was sanctioned on 8 July.

The money reached the group's account on 10 July.

Sunita Devi returned to the office.

This time she did not bring sweets.

She carried two small sikki boxes.

One for the office sample collection.

One to take back if it could not be accepted.

Raghav Babu said,

“I do not accept personal gifts.”

Sunita deposited the first box in the sample room.

She put the second back in her bag.

Then, in an ordinary tone, she asked,

“Was our payment held up because of a colour?”

Meera said,

“Not because of colour.

Because of the time limit.”

“The time limit was in colour?”

Meera did not laugh.

“That time, yes.”

Sunita looked at the copy with the pink strip on the right.

“Our group’s receipt has the amount written in black.

That is good.”

She left.

Meera could not decide whether the sentence had been a joke or experience.

The incident might have ended there.

But one question had taken hold of the Establishment Branch:

how many black-and-white photocopies had been distributed in the previous month in which coloured information had disappeared?

Meera began opening old files.

On the green edge of one training order was written:

“Women trainees only.”

On the black-and-white copy, it was faint.

On a blue strip of a vehicle pass:

“Night use prohibited.”

On an old copy, almost invisible.

On the yellow border of an invitation card was notice of a change of venue.

Ashok said,

“Then are we running an office of colours or an office of words?”

Meera replied,

“If we keep meaning inside colour, the photocopy will eat it.”

A new instruction arrived from headquarters:

“Where colour conveys statutory or administrative information, colour photocopying is mandatory.”

Below it, in black letters, was written:

“If colour reproduction is unavailable, the information shall be repeated in the main text.”

Meera liked the second line better than the first.

A separate register was opened for colour photocopies.

Anyone requiring a colour copy had to enter the page number, reason, and file number.

To save colour toner, the Stores Branch made a rule that only pages containing “important colour” would be copied in colour.

Then came the next question:

who would decide which colour was important?

For three days, employees kept offering different examples.

Raghav Babu returned to his old room.

The new officer assumed charge on 12 July.

On the first day, the new officer removed the paper reading “Raghav Chaudhary, Officer-in-Charge” from the door and handed it personally to Raghav Babu.

Instead of folding it and throwing it away, Raghav Babu placed it in his drawer.

“For memory?” Meera asked.

“No.

There is no period written on it.

I will keep looking at it.”

Both smiled faintly.

Joking was possible now because the Sonjharia Group had received its money and written authority was in new hands.

At the end of the month, the audit team arrived.

Meera did not hide the incident.

She placed together the original order, the black-and-white copy, the colour copy, the 3 July email, and the 8 July approval.

The auditor examined the papers.

“Did Raghavji issue any financial order on 2 July?”

“No.

He wrote an eligibility remark on one file.

He did not grant final approval.”

Raghav Babu himself said,

“I understood that the original period had expired.

I was orally told to keep the work moving.

But I did not sign the payment.”

The auditor lifted the black-and-white copy.

“Could anyone looking at this understand the time limit?”

Meera said,

“No.”

“Then the copy was incomplete.”

“Yes.”

The auditor lifted the colour copy.

“And the original order?”

“That too was drafted incompletely,” Meera said.

The auditor raised an eyebrow.

Meera added softly,

“The important condition should have been in the main text.

Not in the coloured margin.”

The auditor said nothing.

In the observation sheet he wrote:

“Duration condition obscured due to copying method; in future orders, important conditions shall be repeated in the main text.”

No separate objection was recorded against Raghav Babu’s conduct.

A few weeks later, a new charge order arrived.

The main text was black.

The duration was also black, in bold letters, at the end of the first paragraph.

A pink strip still ran along the right margin.

But it contained only one word:

“URGENT.”

Meera made a black-and-white photocopy.

“URGENT” disappeared.

The duration did not.

She showed the copy to Ashok.

Ashok said,

“Now it is right.

What disappeared can be allowed to disappear.”

Meera placed the copy in the file.

Immediately behind it lay the old black-and-white copy of Raghav Babu’s order.

Its right margin was perfectly clean and white.

There was no date anywhere.

The paper still said exactly what it had learned to say:

where colour does not reach, the end of authority cannot be seen either.

STORY 155

THE EMPTY DATE FIELD

That year, the old assembly hall of the Block Office had been turned into a flood-relief room.

A faded notice about marriage registration still hung on the wall.

Below it, a new sheet had been pasted:

“Application for Complete House Damage: Form 6-A.”

In the veranda, long bamboo platforms had replaced benches because the floor had remained under water until two weeks earlier.

People sat on the platforms drying their papers, waiting for their names to be called, and from time to time looking towards the river.

Junior Assistant Kumud Jha had been assigned the digital-entry work.

Before her stood an old computer larger than a mobile phone, a small printer, and two batches of papers.

The fields on the screen opened one after another:

Name.

Father or husband.

Village.

Family number.

Type of house.

Category of damage.

Bank account number.

And finally, a field enclosed by a red border:

“Exact Date of Damage.”

The word “exact” had troubled Kumud from the first day.

A name could be exact.

A bank account number could be exact.

But how could there be an exact date for a house taken by a river when the river first took the courtyard, then a wall, then the hearth, then the room?

The screen did not ask that question.

If she left the field blank, red text flashed:

“Date required.”

For the first two days, most people simply gave one date.

“Night of the fourteenth.”

“Morning of the fifteenth.”

“Afternoon of the sixteenth.”

Kumud kept entering them.

On the third day, Janaki Devi arrived.

She was close to seventy.

Her white hair clung to her head as if still wet.

In her hand was a blue cloth bag.

Her granddaughter Renu was with her, carrying all the documents in a transparent folder.

Kumud asked the name.

Renu opened the papers one by one and answered.

Village:

Kharihani Tola.

House:

mixed mud-and-brick.

Ownership:

Janaki Devi.

Family members:

three.

The site-inspection slip said:

“Complete damage.”

Kumud continued filling the screen.

Then came the final field.

“When did the damage occur?”

Janaki Devi looked at Kumud’s face.

“Which damage?”

“When did the house go?”

“When did the whole house go at once?”

Kumud stopped with her hands on the keyboard.

Janaki Devi said,

“The first night the vegetable plot behind the house was cut away.

The second night the wall of the kitchen fell.

The third night half the room where I slept went into the river.

By morning the roof had sagged down on its own.

You tell me—

when did the house go?”

Renu added softly,

“We had been sleeping on the neighbour’s veranda since the first night.”

Kumud looked again at the site-inspection slip.

The inspection date was 18 August.

The field for date of damage was blank.

“Which dates were those three nights?”

Renu said,

“10, 11, and 12 August.”

Below the form on Kumud’s screen, one line from the district notification glowed:

“Notified flood-damage period: 11 August 00:00 to 13 August 24:00.”

An event on 10 August was not eligible under Form 6-A.

Events on 11 and 12 August were.

Janaki Devi did not understand the significance of the line.

She only said,

“Write all three days.”

“It accepts only one.”

“Then leave it blank.”

“It will not accept a blank.”

Janaki Devi looked at the screen as though some stubborn employee were sitting inside it.

“Tell the machine the river took three nights.”

Kumud wanted to smile faintly.

She did not.

Twenty-five people were waiting on the bamboo platform behind her.

At the neighbouring table, Revenue employee Prabhakar Babu was examining papers.

Kumud called to him.

“In this case the damage occurred over three days.

Which date should I enter?”

Without raising his head, Prabhakar Babu said,

“The day the whole house went.”

Janaki Devi replied at once,

“It has not entirely gone even now.

One corner of brick is still standing.”

Prabhakar Babu looked up.

“The day it became unfit to live in.”

Renu said,

“We had been staying outside since the first night.”

“Then 10 August.”

Kumud said quietly,

“If I enter the tenth, the system shows it outside the notified period.”

Prabhakar Babu’s hand stopped.

He looked at the screen.

Then at Janaki Devi.

“When did the kitchen fall?”

“On the eleventh.”

“The main room?”

“On the twelfth.”

Prabhakar Babu thought for a few moments.

“Enter the twelfth.

Treat that as the day of complete damage.”

Janaki Devi asked,

“What does ‘treat’ mean?”

“For the paper.”

“And for the house?”

Prabhakar Babu picked up another file.

“The river knows about the house.”

Kumud entered:

12-08.

The red border turned green.

The screen moved on.

Janaki Devi’s application was accepted.

The printed receipt clearly said:

“Date of Damage: 12 August.”

Janaki Devi looked at the paper.

“The twelfth?”

Kumud said,

“Yes.

On the form.”

Janaki Devi put the paper in her bag.

Renu thanked her.

They left.

The next person sat down at Kumud’s desk.

Ramvriksh Yadav.

The rear part of his house had been cut away on the night of the thirteenth.

The main wall fell on the morning of the fourteenth.

He himself said,

“Write the thirteenth.”

Kumud asked,

“When did the complete damage occur?”

Ramvriksh replied,

“On the fourteenth.”

“Then the fourteenth?”

At once he said,

“No, no.

We had emptied the house from the night of the thirteenth.

Treat it as the thirteenth.”

Kumud looked at the district period.

The thirteenth was eligible.

The fourteenth was not.

“You just said the main wall fell on the fourteenth.”

Ramvriksh lowered his voice.

“Didi, did the river cut the house by looking at a clock?

Half before midnight, half after.

Which hour should I write?”

His question was no different from Janaki Devi’s.

But the stakes in the answer were different.

Kumud stopped the form.

“Show me the site-inspection slip.”

The Revenue employee had written:

“House unfit for habitation; family displaced from night of 13 August.”

Kumud entered 13 August.

The red border turned green.

Ramvriksh breathed in relief.

By noon that day, the “exact date” had become the hardest question in the room.

One person’s house had begun collapsing on the morning of 12 August, but he slept under a tree that night.

Another roof fell on the morning of the fourteenth, but the family had left the house on the evening of the thirteenth.

In another case, the first wall fell within the notified period and the second outside it.

Employees began creating informal definitions.

Some said:

“The day the roof went.”

Some:

“The day the hearth stopped.”

Some:

“The day the family slept elsewhere.”

The Stores Assistant joked,

“The day a man put the key to his own house in his pocket and slept on someone else’s veranda—that is the date of damage.”

Prabhakar Babu stopped him.

“Do not joke.

There will be an audit later.”

The joke stopped.

The definitions did not.

The next day Block Development Officer Archana Singh came to inspect the relief room.

She looked at the crowd, registers, bank numbers, and site-inspection papers.

Kumud raised the problem of the “exact date.”

Archana Singh first gave a simple answer.

“Enter the actual date.”

Kumud showed her Janaki Devi’s case.

“There is no single actual date.”

Archana Singh read the slip.

“Then the inspecting employee should write one.”

Prabhakar Babu said,

“Even during inspection we choose one day.

There is no rule telling us why that day should be chosen.”

Archana Singh sat down.

The screen with its red field was before her.

She clicked open the date field.

A calendar appeared:

choose one day.

There was no way to choose two days together.

No separate remarks field.

“Write to the district,” she said.

Kumud asked,

“Until then, should we stop the applications?”

The queue on the veranda had reached the wall.

Archana Singh looked outside.

“No.

Make an interim criterion.

In writing.”

A meeting was held that same evening.

The subject:

“Determination of Damage Date in Progressive River Erosion.”

The faded marriage-registration notice still hung on the assembly-hall wall.

Beneath it, employees were trying to decide the death date of a house.

Prabhakar Babu wrote three proposals:

First structural damage.

Displacement of the family.

Complete collapse.

The Accounts Assistant said,

“If we use first damage, many cases will fall outside the notified period.”

Archana Singh replied,

“We cannot define the rule by looking at eligibility.”

“If we use complete collapse, some houses are still incomplete even today,”

Kumud said.

“One piece of wall may remain standing, though no one can live there.”

Prabhakar Babu struck out the third line.

At last they wrote:

“In cases of progressive erosion, the date of damage shall be the date on which, according to site inspection, the dwelling first became unfit for habitation or the family left the house for safety, whichever occurred earlier.”

“Left permanently?” the Stores Assistant asked.

“If people return three days later to collect belongings?”

The wording was cut.

“Permanently” was removed.

It became:

“left for night residence.”

The Accounts Assistant asked,

“Why night?”

What if the house falls during the day?”

Again the wording was cut.

After five rounds of revision, the sentence became:

“The day on which the house became unsuitable for safe habitation and the family was compelled to stay elsewhere.”

Archana Singh signed it.

“If the district replies, we will change it.”

Kumud asked,

“What about the forms already entered?”

“If they match this criterion, leave them.

If not, correct them.”

Kumud reviewed sixty-four forms late into the evening.

In thirteen, the date appeared to require correction.

In five cases, changing the date would alter eligibility.

One of those five was Ramvriksh's.
 His site-inspection paper clearly said:
 "Family displaced from night of 13 August."
 The thirteenth remained unchanged.
 Another was Raghuni Sah's.
 His roof fell on the night of the thirteenth.
 But the family left the house on the morning of the fourteenth.
 The inspection remark said:
 "One room usable on night of 13 August."
 Under the new criterion:
 14 August.
 Outside the notified period.
 Kumud kept her hand on the file for a long time.
 Correcting the date would automatically mark Raghuni Sah's form
 "outside period."
 His relief would stop.
 Not correcting it would make Kumud herself the first person to violate the
 written criterion.
 Raghuni Sah was called the next morning.
 He was a thin man of about fifty-five.
 He did small tailoring work in a cloth shop.
 His sewing machine had also been damaged in the flood.
 Kumud asked,
 "Did you sleep in the house on the night of the thirteenth?"
 Raghuni Sah said,
 "I did not.
 I had sent my wife and children to my sister's house.
 I stayed behind to move the belongings."
 "Where did you sleep that night?"
 "On the dry part of the veranda.
 Until midnight.
 When the water rose, I went to the school."
 Prabhakar Babu asked,
 "Then was the house safe enough to live in?"
 Raghuni Sah remained silent for a moment.
 "Safe?"
 If it had been safe, why would I have sent the children away?"
 Kumud read the new criterion aloud:
 "The day on which the house became unsuitable for safe habitation and
 the family was compelled to stay elsewhere."
 Raghuni Sah said,
 "The family went elsewhere on the thirteenth.
 I was the fool who stayed to save things.
 Did my staying behind become proof that the house was safe?"
 No one in the room answered immediately.
 Prabhakar Babu said softly,

“The family did go elsewhere on the thirteenth.
On that basis the thirteenth can remain.”

Kumud asked,

“What if it had been a person living alone?”

Prabhakar Babu looked at the paper.

“Then the question would arise again.”

Raghuni Sah gathered his receipt.

“You people find the date.

I could not save the house.”

He stood up.

There was bitterness in the sentence.

His voice was tired.

The district’s reply came five days later.

The essential point in the two-page letter was one line:

“Entry of a single date on the digital platform is mandatory; on the basis of local inspection records, the competent authority shall determine an appropriate date.”

Kumud read the letter three times.

The word “appropriate” did not solve the problem.

It merely promoted it to a higher office.

Archana Singh read the letter.

“Our criterion will continue.”

Meanwhile, people in the relief room learned new ways of remembering dates.

Someone would say:

“It was a Monday.”

The staff checked a calendar.

Someone:

“The school closed that day.”

The school register was checked.

Someone:

“My eldest granddaughter had fever.”

A medicine slip was searched for.

Someone:

“The moon was half.”

At that, Prabhakar Babu said,

“Do not add the moon to the records.”

One elderly woman said,

“I do not remember the day, but that morning the mosque loudspeaker was silent.”

Another employee asked,

“Why?”

“Water had entered.”

To find the date, they telephoned the mosque caretaker.

He could not remember the date either.

He only said,

“The day the electricity transformer was shut down.”

The date was found from the electricity office register.

Gradually the relief room became less a place for examining house damage than a room for investigating dates.

On Kumud’s desk accumulated a small calendar, the school closure register, electricity-disconnection lists, boat-operation slips, and dates of medicine distribution from the health centre.

For an event in someone’s life to become a government date, it had to seek support from another document.

Kumud began to feel a certain satisfaction in this work.

Evidence was better than guesswork.

But she also understood that evidence was not equal for everyone.

A household with a mobile phone could produce the date from a photograph.

A family with a child in school could remember the day the school closed.

A person with no papers at all had only memory.

And memory could not be uploaded onto the digital platform.

Janaki Devi came again.

This time Renu was not with her.

She carried the same blue bag.

“My paper says the twelfth, doesn’t it?”

“Yes.”

“People in the village say that if the tenth had been written, I would not have received the money.”

Kumud did not conceal the truth.

“The tenth was outside the notified period.”

Janaki Devi sat down.

“I had left the house from the night of the tenth.

Then did I get a lie written?”

Kumud said,

“The main room went on the twelfth.

The site inspection says complete damage.

I entered it on that basis.”

“But you had asked:

when did the house go?”

“The question on the form is not right.”

Janaki Devi seemed a little calmer after hearing this.

“If the question is wrong, does the answer become a lie?”

Kumud had the rule sheet before her.

She had no answer to that question.

From the blue bag, Janaki Devi took out an old calendar, water-stained and damp.

The page was August.

The corners of the tenth, eleventh, and twelfth were grey with mud.

Later, Renu had written in red ink:

10 — “vegetable plot.”

11 — “hearth.”

12 — “room.”

“These are the three days of the house,” Janaki Devi said.

“Renu wrote them down.

Your paper has one day.

No harm.

If the money needs one day, let it have one day.

But my granddaughter will remember all three.”

Kumud kept looking at the calendar.

“Shall I place a photocopy of this in the file?”

Janaki Devi laughed.

“A paper with three days beside a field for one?”

“It will remain as a note in the file.”

“Keep it.”

Kumud had the calendar photocopied.

The three mud-grey dates did not reproduce clearly.

But Renu’s red writing appeared black.

She attached the copy to the file.

The digital platform still carried only one date:

12 August.

Two weeks later, the first batch of relief was approved.

Janaki Devi’s name was on the list.

So was Raghuni Sah’s.

Some families remained ineligible because their determined date fell outside the notified period.

They filed objections.

The first field on the objection form read:

“Disputed Date of Damage.”

Looking at the paper, Prabhakar Babu said,

“Now there is a separate form for the date problem.”

Kumud asked,

“Does this form have room to write a period?”

Prabhakar Babu turned the page.

“No.

One date here too.”

For a few moments both remained silent.

Outside, the river had receded far away.

A white strip of sand shone towards the villages as though no house had ever stood there.

At the end of the month, the relief room began to be dismantled.

The bamboo platforms were removed.

Registers were tied into bundles.

The computer was sent back to the regular office.

On the final day, Kumud was counting the pending files.

Janaki Devi’s file came into her hands.

On top:

“Date of Damage: 12 August.”

Inside:

the photocopy of Renu’s calendar—

10,

11,

12.

Kumud looked at the two papers together.

On one, the date was clear.

On the other, the event was clear.

She closed the file.

A few days later, Kumud met Janaki Devi in the market.

Janaki Devi was explaining to another woman how to fill the relief form.

The woman said,

“I do not remember exactly when the house went.”

Janaki Devi replied casually,

“Say the day the paper accepts.

My house went on 12 August.”

Kumud stood two steps away, listening.

She remembered the vegetable plot on the night of the tenth.

The hearth on the eleventh.

The room on the twelfth.

Janaki Devi adjusted her bag and moved into the market crowd.

Kumud felt an impulse to stop her and remind her of all three days from the calendar.

Then she stopped herself.

The government date had finished its official work.

Now it was being entered not only into the form—

but into memory as well.

STORY 156

PROOF OF A FIVE-MINUTE DELAY

The most securely guarded object in the District Archives was not an old land register, a map, or a seal.

At night, it was a small brass key.

The key belonged to the records room.

At five in the evening the room was locked.

The archivist placed the key in a cloth pouch, tied the mouth of the pouch with thread, sealed it in red wax, and handed it to the guard at the gate.

In the morning, the guard returned the same sealed pouch to the archivist.

Both times, the time and signatures were entered in a register.

The arrangement had continued for thirty years.

The pouch was small.

The rule was large.

Archivist Nandkishore Jha treated the ritual with great seriousness.

To him, examining the seal before opening the pouch, touching the thread, counting the knots, and writing the time in the register were no less important than unlocking the records room itself.

"If the key remains secure, the papers remain secure," he told new employees.

Night guard Harinarayan Paswan at the gate observed the rule too.

Four separate piles of registers lay on his desk:

the vehicle register,

the visitor register,

the night-patrol register,

and the key register.

When the wind blew, he placed a piece of brick over all their pages at once.

The problem turned out not to be the key.

It was time.

A financial audit team was examining the registers one Tuesday.

Auditor Kamlesh Singh moved line by line with a blue pencil.

Date.

Signature.

Seal.

Time.

On one page his pencil stopped.

"How is this possible?"

Nandkishore bent over the register.

Against the previous Thursday evening it said:

"Key pouch handed over by archivist: 17:03."

Immediately beside it, beneath Harinarayan's signature, it said:

"Received: 16:58."

The auditor placed a finger on the entries.

"The guard received the key five minutes earlier, and the archivist handed it over five minutes later?"

Nandkishore tried to laugh.

"The clocks must differ."

Kamlesh Singh did not laugh.

"The register records time, not clocks."

Harinarayan was called from the gate.

He looked at the page.

"I wrote the time shown by the gate clock."

Nandkishore said,

"I used the main clock inside."

"Were the two different?"

"They often are."

"By how much?"

No one knew exactly.

The auditor wrote:

"Five-minute inconsistency in key-custody chain; handover time recorded later than receipt time."

Nandkishore immediately said,

"But the pouch was never without someone's hand even for a moment.

I gave it.

Harinarayan took it."

Kamlesh Singh replied calmly,

"That is what you say.

The register says something else."

Five minutes that had never existed in reality had now been born on paper.

A file went to the Accounts Branch.

Its title read:

"Time Discrepancy in Custody of Records-Room Key."

An explanation was sought from Nandkishore.

And from Harinarayan.

Nandkishore wrote:

"The apparent difference arises because the main building clock runs approximately five minutes ahead of the gate clock; the key was directly handed from hand to hand."

Harinarayan wrote in his explanation:

"Pouch with seal intact received at 16:58 as per gate clock; archivist was present before me."

The Accounts Branch read both replies together.

The officer asked,

"Approximately five minutes?

Proof?"

Nandkishore said,

"The clocks are still there."

"How do the clocks now prove what the difference was last Thursday?"

It was a fair question.

The clocks were witnesses.

But the date had changed.

Madhusudan, the electrical assistant from the Establishment Branch, was called.

He checked the main clock.

10:14.

The gate clock:

10:09.

His own mobile phone:

10:11.

Kamlesh Singh said,

“Now we have three times.”

Madhusudan said matter-of-factly,

“The main clock runs a little fast.

The gate clock runs slow.”

“How much is ‘a little’?”

“It changes from day to day.”

The auditor put down his blue pencil.

“Time changes from day to day?”

Madhusudan understood the clocks.

Not the sentence.

“The batteries are old.”

The first solution seemed simple.

Synchronise the two clocks.

Madhusudan brought a ladder.

The main clock was moved three minutes back.

The gate clock two minutes forward.

The mobile phone time was treated as the middle.

The auditor asked,

“Is the mobile phone an authorised time source?”

Madhusudan stopped on the ladder.

“No.”

The clocks were not altered again.

But the basis of the decision had suddenly become unauthorised.

A letter was sent to the General Branch of the district office:

“Kindly clarify the authorised time source for the office.”

The answer came two days later:

“Indian Standard Time shall apply.”

Nandkishore read the letter.

“That much we know.

How do we hang Indian Standard Time on the wall?”

The employees laughed.

The audit objection remained open.

Meanwhile, every evening the key continued going to Harinarayan.

Every morning it returned to Nandkishore.

Now both looked at each other's clock before writing the time.

On the first day Nandkishore said,
 “You write first.”
 Harinarayan said,
 “No, you first.
 What if there is a difference again?”
 Both waited for five o’clock.
 The main clock showed 4:59.
 The gate clock 4:57.
 Nandkishore stood holding the pouch.
 “Shall I take it now?” Harinarayan asked.
 “By whose time?”
 The key was secure.
 But the handover stopped.
 At last Nandkishore looked at his wristwatch.
 “Five.”
 Harinarayan took the pouch.
 Both wrote 17:00 in the register.
 The next day the auditor asked,
 “The two clocks differed.
 How is the time identical?”
 Nandkishore’s face fell.
 “We agreed on one time and wrote it.”
 “So the register records agreement, not the time actually observed?”
 One objection became two.
 The General Branch then created an interim form:
 “Certificate of Time Discrepancy in Key Handover.”
 It had five fields:
 Main clock.
 Gate clock.
 Third time source.
 Actual handover.
 Certifying person.
 “Third time source?” Harinarayan asked.
 The General Branch clerk said,
 “Mobile phone, radio, attendance machine—whatever is available.”
 “And if the third one is different too?”
 The clerk looked at the form.
 “Then write it in the remarks.”
 Harinarayan shook his head.
 “There used to be one register for the key.
 Now there is another one for time.”
 Nandkishore said,
 “And remarks for the time of time.”
 In the midst of all this, an elderly woman had been making rounds of the records room for three days.
 Her name was Kanaklata Devi.

She needed a certified copy of a seventy-year-old irrigation map.
Part of her village field had fallen under a new canal-widening scheme.
Her compensation objection was to be heard on Friday afternoon.
Without the old map, her objection would remain incomplete.
The map was inside the third cupboard in the records room.
The application was complete.
The fee had been deposited.
The plot number was clear.
Only the room had to be opened.
On Wednesday morning, Nandkishore reached the gate at 9:55.
Harinarayan brought out the pouch.
The red seal was intact.

The knot was intact.
The main clock inside showed 9:59.
The gate clock 9:56.
The attendance machine 9:58.
Nandkishore took out the certificate form.

Main clock:

09:59.

Gate clock:

09:56.

Attendance machine:

09:58.

Actual handover:

blank.

“What do we write here?” Harinarayan asked.

Nandkishore said,

“The time when both of us sign?”

“Which clock?”

Again they stopped.

Kanaklata Devi was standing beside them.

“Babu, is the key inside that pouch?”

“Yes.”

“The seal is proper?”

“Proper.”

“Then open it.”

Nandkishore felt embarrassed.

“We have to write the time first.”

The elderly woman looked at the clocks.

“You can understand the key, but not the time?”

Harinarayan lowered his face.

At last the attendance-machine time, 09:58, was written under “third time source.”

Actual handover was also treated as 09:58.

Both signed.

The room opened.

By the time the map was taken out, it was half past ten.

Kanaklata Devi left with the copy.

That afternoon, the auditor examined the certificate.

"Is the attendance-machine time authorised?"

The General Branch clerk said,

"It is connected to the headquarters network."

"For handover of this office key, specifically authorised?"

"Not specifically."

Kamlesh Singh again made a note in blue pencil.

Now the proof of time discrepancy needed proof of its own.

A meeting was called.

Subject:

"Unified Time System for Handover of Records-Room Key."

The main clock in the meeting hall showed 10:04.

The notice said the meeting began at ten.

No one commented on that.

Baijnath Chaudhary, the Establishment Officer, proposed that one authorised digital clock be installed at the gate and only that time be entered in the key register.

Madhusudan asked,

"What if the power goes out?"

"Battery."

"And if the battery dies?"

"Reserve clock."

"How will the reserve clock be synchronised?"

The meeting was silent for five minutes.

At last the General Branch wrote:

"Network-synchronised digital clock installed at the gate shall be primary; if unavailable, the attendance machine; if both are unavailable, the Branch Officer's mobile phone."

Nandkishore asked,

"What if the Branch Officer is absent?"

Baijnath Babu said,

"Then remarks."

Harinarayan said softly,

"Remarks are always available."

The order was issued.

A new digital clock arrived.

Its red digits glowed from a distance.

On the first day, the main clock, the new gate clock, and the attendance machine all showed the same minute.

An unusual satisfaction spread through the office.

But to close the objection about the five minutes on the previous Thursday, written proof was still required that the old gate clock had been five minutes slow.

"Now the new clock is installed," Madhusudan said.

“The old one has been removed.

How can we prove the difference on that earlier day?”

The old rectangular clock lay in Stores.

Its hands were still moving.

But when the new clock was installed, someone had reset its time.

Harinarayan said,

“I will write that it was five minutes slow that day.”

The auditor asked,

“How are you certain?”

“Because I looked at it every day.”

“Written record?”

There was none.

Nandkishore’s first explanation had said “approximately five minutes.”

The auditor did not like “approximately.”

So the attendance-machine list from seven days earlier was brought out.

It was estimated that employees took an average of two minutes to walk from the gate to the machine.

Times in the vehicle register, visitor register, and meeting notes based on the main clock were compared.

A twenty-seven-page file was created to prove a five-minute difference.

Kanaklata Devi returned to the office.

Her hearing had taken place.

The certified map had arrived in time.

But the officer had said the line on the old map was unclear and asked for a copy of another register.

Seeing Nandkishore with the thick file, she asked,

“My map?”

“No.

The key’s time.”

“Was the key lost again?”

“Never.”

“Then?”

Nandkishore did not answer for a few moments.

“Five minutes are missing in the register.”

Whether Kanaklata Devi understood him or not, no one could tell.

She pushed her application forward.

“Do not lose my page.”

The sentence struck Nandkishore like a blow.

That evening, before placing the key in the pouch, he completed the map file first.

He took out the second copy Kanaklata Devi had requested and certified it.

Only then did he lock the room.

At the gate the new digital clock showed 17:01.

The attendance machine also showed 17:01.

Nandkishore handed the pouch to Harinarayan.

Both wrote 17:01 in the register.

"Now it is correct," Harinarayan said.
 Nandkishore looked at the sealed pouch.
 "The key was correct before too."

The file concerning the five-minute objection was finally closed a week later.

The conclusion read:

"Archival discrepancy arising from historical inequality of time sources; no evidence of actual breach of custody."

Along with it came instructions:
 monthly synchronisation of the new authorised clock,
 battery checks,
 and a time-certification register.

"Time-certification register?" Harinarayan asked.

The General Branch said,

"Once a month you will write that the clock is correct."

"Compared with what?"

"Indian Standard Time."

"Where on the wall will we find that?"

This time the clerk laughed.

"On a mobile phone."

The same mobile phone that had earlier been treated as unauthorised now became the basis for monthly synchronisation.

The order did not mention it by name.

It merely said:

"standard digital source."

After a few months the system became routine.

The pouch went out in the evening.

Returned in the morning.

The new clock generally kept proper time.

The register entries were clean.

On the first Monday of each month, signatures were placed in the time-certification register.

Much later, Nandkishore learned what had happened to Kanaklata Devi's canal-compensation objection.

It had been partly accepted.

One day she came carrying a small box of sweets.

Nandkishore refused to take it.

"Then shall I give it to the guard?" she asked.

From a distance Harinarayan folded his hands.

"Not to me either."

The elderly woman put the box back in her bag.

She looked at the new clock at the gate.

"Does it keep correct time now?"

Harinarayan said,

"According to the papers, yes."

Kanaklata Devi laughed.

“The clock has papers too?”

“It does.”

She left.

On the first Monday of the following month, the time check was due.

Madhusudan, Harinarayan, and Nandkishore gathered at the gate.

The new clock showed:

09:30:00.

The mobile phone:

09:30:04.

The attendance machine:

09:30:03.

Madhusudan said,

“Four seconds.”

Nandkishore opened the register.

The field read:

“Difference: in minutes.”

Harinarayan asked,

“How do we write four seconds?”

Nandkishore thought for a moment.

Then wrote:

“0 minutes.”

All three signed.

At that same moment, the records-room key pouch lay on Harinarayan’s desk.

Nandkishore picked it up.

The seal was intact.

The knot was intact.

The new clock showed 09:31.

Harinarayan pushed the register towards him.

“Time?”

Nandkishore had just closed the proof concerning four seconds.

He looked at the clock.

Then at the pouch.

“Nine thirty-one,” he said.

Both signed.

The records room opened.

No one was waiting at the gate.

This time the time in the register was correct.

And so was the key.

STORY 157

THE COLOUR OF THE FILE CLOTH

On the second floor of the District Social Assistance Building, the files looked colourful even from a distance.

Inside black cupboards, papers bound in blue, green, ochre, yellow, and grey cloth stood in rows.

The colours were not decorative.

Blue cloth was understood to belong to the Old-Age Assistance Branch.

Pale violet to Widow Assistance.

Green to Animal Husbandry.

Ochre to Student Assistance.

Grey to General Administration.

No one had a clear order showing when this system had begun.

But every employee understood the colours.

When lifting a file from a distance, the cloth was seen before the subject was read.

On her first day in the building, newly appointed Junior Assistant Maithili Chaudhary had been taught the rule in five minutes by Senior Clerk Bhola Babu.

“Look at the colour, understand the branch, enter it in the register, and send it on.

It saves time.”

Maithili had asked,

“What if the wrong cloth has been tied around the file?”

Bhola Babu had laughed.

“Cloth does not tie itself.”

After that answer, Maithili had asked no further question.

Three weeks later, on a Monday morning, fourteen files lay on the table in the Inward Room.

The postman had taken his receipt and gone.

Attendant Shivnath was dusting the files and making piles according to colour.

Five green.

Three blue.

Two ochre.

Four violet.

As Maithili lifted the fourth file in the violet pile, her hand stopped.

Its cloth was green.

But on an old paper slip pasted along the edge, faded letters read:

“Widow Assistance — Chandrakala Devi.”

Maithili read the slip.

Then looked at the green cloth.

Shivnath said,

“Send it to Animal Husbandry.”

“But it says Widow Assistance here.”

“Old slips often do not get changed.

The colour is new.”

Maithili opened the file.

The first page was an application:

Chandrakala Devi.

Village Bardaha.

Husband: Late Kamlesh Mandal.

Below were the bank account number, death certificate, Panchayat verification, and income-certificate list.

There was no mention of cattle, fodder, vaccination, or milk.

“This is a Widow Assistance file,” Maithili said.

Shivnath shrugged.

“Then why is it green?”

The question was small.

Its answer was not in the file.

Maithili entered the subject in the inward register as “Widow Assistance” and placed the file with the violet pile.

At ten o’clock Bhola Babu, checking the register, stopped at that file.

“Why is this green file in the violet pile?”

“The subject is Widow Assistance.”

Bhola Babu opened it.

Turned two pages.

His eyebrows tightened slightly.

“The subject is indeed that.

But the colour belongs to Animal Husbandry.”

“Then do we look at the subject or the colour?”

Bhola Babu did not answer immediately.

He closed the file.

“First check the movement register.”

The movement register was in the Records Room.

File No. 473/W-A/26 was searched.

The last entry was eight days old:

“For rebinding — Stationery Room.”

After that, nothing.

The Stationery Room was on the ground floor.

Old files were removed from torn cloth and rebound in new cloth there.

The binding work was done by Jagdish, an elderly craftsman hired on contract.

That day Jagdish was cutting thread in the veranda.

Bhola Babu showed him the file.

“Why was this Widow Assistance file bound in green?”

Jagdish pushed his spectacles onto his forehead.

“When it came, the violet cloth was finished.”

“Then why did you not stop the work?”

"If I had stopped it, you would have said the file was being held up.
The Stores man said there was plenty of green cloth.
Use that for now and put a slip on top."

"Written order?"

Jagdish bit through the thread with his teeth.

"I receive thread in writing.

Instructions come by mouth."

Stores Assistant Satyanarayan Babu was called.

He checked the register.

The violet cloth had indeed been shown as exhausted on the twenty-third of the previous month.

A request for fresh supply had been sent.

The consignment had not yet arrived.

"I told them to use green temporarily," he admitted.

Bhola Babu asked,

"How many files?"

Satyanarayan Babu turned pages.

"The count is not written.

Cloth is issued by the yard.

Files are counted by number."

For the first time, the office realised that the problem might not be confined to one file.

Maithili asked,

"Then do we have to inspect every file rebound after the violet cloth ran out?"

Bhola Babu said quietly,

"First send this one to the correct branch."

The file reached the Widow Assistance Branch.

The moment clerk Rameshwar Jha saw the green cover, he stopped the attendant.

"This belongs to Animal Husbandry."

Maithili had carried the file herself.

"Open it."

Rameshwar Babu opened it.

Read the application.

"This is ours."

"Then keep it."

He put it on the desk.

Then asked for the movement register.

"But where is the transfer from Animal Husbandry?"

Maithili was astonished.

"It never went to Animal Husbandry."

"The colour says it did."

"A colour is not a signature."

Rameshwar Babu leaned back in his chair.

His tone was not harsh.

It was cautious.

"In the last audit, three files were found outside the branch register.

I had to submit an explanation.

Now I do not retain any file without an entry number."

"Is the entry number given according to the subject or according to the cloth?"

"Normally both are the same thing."

"Not this time."

Rameshwar Babu looked at the file as though he himself had to judge between cloth and subject.

At last he wrote:

"Subject-wise: Widow Assistance. Cover: green. Source to be clarified."

The file was sent back to the Inward Room.

By afternoon Chandrakala Devi herself had reached the office.

In her hand was an old cloth bag containing receipts, a copy of her bank passbook, and medicine slips tied together.

She came to Maithili.

"Has my paper come back again?"

Maithili had never seen her before.

"Your name?"

"Chandrakala Devi. Bardaha."

The green file was on her desk.

The moment Chandrakala Devi saw the cloth, she said,

"This is not mine."

"Your papers are inside."

Surprised, she opened the file.

Seeing her own name on the first page, she remained silent for a few moments.

"When I submitted it, it was violet."

"You remember the colour?"

"I have come after this file four times.

Would I not remember the colour?"

There was more exhaustion than anger in her voice.

Her husband Kamlesh had died seven months earlier.

The assistance had already been sanctioned.

But after correction of one error in the bank account number, the file had begun circulating again for verification.

"When will the money come?"

That was her direct question.

Maithili wanted to answer.

But at that moment even the office had not decided which branch the file belonged to.

"We will get the file to the correct branch today," she said.

Chandrakala Devi did not smile.

"That was said last time too."

She went and sat in the veranda.

In the afternoon Assistant Officer Sudhanshu Mishra was informed.
 He was an old employee and considered the colour system useful.
 "Because of the colour, files can be sorted without reading them," he said.
 "If we open every paper and read it, half the day will go in classification."
 Maithili said,
 "But what if the colour is wrong?"
 "Correct the mistake."
 "What is the procedure for correcting it?"
 Sudhanshu Mishra stopped at the question.
 No one knew a clear procedure.
 Changing the cloth was treated as altering the physical form of the record.
 Changing a branch required a transfer note.
 But the file had never formally gone to the wrong branch.
 Bhola Babu suggested,
 "Sew a violet strip over the green."
 Satyanarayan Babu objected.
 "Then the register says green cloth, while outside it appears violet.
 Audit will ask."
 Rameshwar Babu said,
 "Attach a white strip with the subject written on it."
 Sudhanshu Mishra asked,
 "What if the strip falls off?"
 Shivnath stood listening near the door.
 He said softly,
 "The first page inside will not fall off."
 The room was silent for a few moments.
 Sudhanshu Mishra looked at him.
 "Who has time to open every file and read the subject?"
 Shivnath lowered his head.
 His job was to carry files.
 Not make policy.
 The meeting ended without a decision.
 Chandrakala Devi remained seated in the veranda until four in the
 afternoon.
 Maithili gave her water.
 "Is your home far?"
 "I have to change two buses."
 "Do not come again tomorrow.
 Give me a telephone number."
 Chandrakala Devi recited a number.
 "The mobile phone stays with my son.
 He goes to work as a mason during the day.
 You can speak to him in the evening."
 Maithili wrote the number not in the margin of the register, but in her
 own notebook.

The next day she began checking the binding register of the Stationery Room from the date on which the violet cloth had run out.

The register did not contain subjects.

Only file numbers and yards of cloth.

In the seven days after the twenty-third, thirty-two files had been rebound.

Eighteen of them had green cloth.

“Are all eighteen from Animal Husbandry?” Maithili asked.

Jagdish said,

“No.

Whenever the required cloth was unavailable, I used whatever was available at the time.”

“So for those seven days, the colour system was suspended?”

Jagdish laughed.

“I received no written notice saying whether the colour system was operating or suspended.”

Maithili wrote down the numbers of the eighteen files.

One by one, the movement registers were checked.

The first five genuinely belonged to Animal Husbandry.

The sixth turned out to be Student Assistance.

Three days earlier it had been returned from the Animal Husbandry Branch with the remark:

“Beneficiary’s livestock-ownership details not attached.”

The seventh was a General Administration building-repair file.

The Animal Husbandry Branch had written:

“Subject unrelated.”

The eighth was another Widow Assistance file.

It was currently lying in the Animal Insurance Section.

Maithili and Bhola Babu went there.

They found the file in a lower pile beneath the desk.

On top was written:

“Applicant has not stated livestock number; complete details to be obtained.”

Bhola Babu’s face fell.

“Who wrote this remark?”

Animal Insurance Clerk Shyamsundar Babu said,

“The form was incomplete.”

Maithili opened the file.

“This is a Widow Assistance application.”

Shyamsundar Babu put on his spectacles.

Read the first page.

Then looked at his own remark.

His ears turned red.

“I saw the outer list.

A green file had arrived.

There were eight enclosures.

Eight enclosures are common in Animal Insurance forms.”

“You did not read the name?”

“I did.

A widow can own livestock too.”

The answer might have sounded absurd.

Shyamsundar Babu was not joking.

Thirty-six files had reached his desk that day.

Two posts in the branch were vacant.

The colour had been created as a sign that saved him time.

Bhola Babu said slowly,

“We have turned the sign into the subject.”

Shyamsundar Babu said nothing.

Beside his old remark he wrote:

“Previous remark made in error on the basis of cover colour; actual subject is Widow Assistance.”

He signed it.

The eighth file was sent to the correct branch.

As the day advanced, five of the eighteen files were found to have circulated through the wrong branches.

On one scholarship application, “proof of animal vaccination” had been requested.

On a building-repair file, a remark asked for “clarification of beneficiary’s age.”

Two files, by luck, had not yet moved beyond the Inward Room.

Sudhanshu Mishra called an immediate meeting.

Five mismatched files were placed on the table.

All were wrapped in green cloth.

Their subjects were different.

“This makes it clear that we have become too dependent on colour,” Maithili said.

Rameshwar Babu replied,

“If we remove the colours, the work will slow down.”

Bhola Babu said,

“No one is talking about removing colours.

The problem is treating colour as proof.”

Satyanarayan Babu opened the Stores register.

“The violet cloth still has not arrived.”

“When will it come?”

“The supplier says the next consignment is due Friday.”

Sudhanshu Mishra ran a hand over his forehead.

“Then until Friday, what colour should Widow Assistance files be bound in?”

Again the room fell silent.

Maithili said,

“Write the branch name in bold letters on a white paper strip and tie it to the file.

Colour can remain an aid.

It must not become a substitute for the subject.”

Rameshwar Babu asked,

“Is that in the rules?”

“Where is the rule about the colours?”

It became the most uncomfortable question in the meeting.

Sudhanshu Mishra called for the old orders.

Office orders from 2011, 2014, 2019, and 2023 were examined.

Nowhere was there a complete colour list.

One order said only:

“Separate covers shall be maintained branch-wise.”

No colours were specified.

From his long service, Bhola Babu remembered,

“Earlier each branch bought its own cloth.

Old-Age Assistance used blue.

Animal Husbandry used green.

Gradually those colours became the identifiers.”

“So practice became rule,” Maithili said.

“Practice is also a system,” Rameshwar Babu replied.

“As long as the cloth is available,” Bhola Babu added.

By the end of the meeting, a temporary instruction was issued:

when receiving a file, the first-page subject must be checked against the colour.

If there is a mismatch, the actual branch must be written on a white strip.

In the rebinding register, the subject must now be entered along with the file number.

Sudhanshu Mishra signed the instruction.

“A permanent order will be prepared later.”

Maithili asked,

“And Chandrakala Devi’s file?”

Rameshwar Babu opened it.

The correction to the bank account had been verified.

The Panchayat certificate was valid.

The approval order was already attached.

In fact, nothing remained except release of payment.

“Why has this been circulating for three weeks?” Sudhanshu Mishra asked.

No one person answered.

Rameshwar Babu prepared the payment advice.

The Accounts Branch checked it.

By evening the payment order was issued.

At seven that evening, Maithili called the number Chandrakala Devi had given for her son.

There was noise from a construction site at the other end.

The young man asked “What?” three times.

Maithili spoke loudly.

“Tell your mother the assistance payment has been approved.”

There was silence for a few moments.

Then the young man asked,

“Does she have to come to the office again tomorrow?”

“No.

Check the bank.”

That “no” was perhaps the most useful word of the entire week.

Three days later Chandrakala Devi came.

This time she carried no bag.

She only wanted to show the receipt.

The money had reached her account.

Maithili said,

“Keep your papers now.

The work is complete.”

Chandrakala Devi looked at the green file, which lay closed on Rameshwar Babu’s desk.

A white strip had been sewn onto it:

“Widow Assistance.”

“Will it become violet again?” she asked.

Maithili smiled.

“Stores says the violet consignment arrives tomorrow.”

Chandrakala Devi said,

“Whatever the colour now, let the name inside remain correct.”

She left.

On Friday the violet cloth really arrived.

Three bundles were unloaded in Stores.

Satyanarayan Babu breathed with relief.

But the fear of audit remained.

The question was:

should the mistakenly attached green covers be replaced, or should the white strip be left on them?

If replaced, the old physical form of the record would disappear.

If not replaced, the colour system would remain incomplete.

A small committee was formed.

Five days later it recommended:

“Covers attached in error shall remain as they are; a clear branch strip shall be affixed and a correction note attached.”

That day in the Stationery Room, Jagdish was sewing white strips onto eighteen files.

Maithili went there.

“So the colours will not be changed now?”

“No.

The old mistake has also become part of the record.”

Threading a needle, he said,

“Paper lives longer than people.

Once a mistake is stitched in, it is difficult to open it again.”

Maithili read the branch names written along the edges of the files.

On green cloth:

Widow Assistance.

Student Assistance.

General Administration.

Colour and words disagreed with each other.

But this time the disagreement could be seen.

A few weeks later, the new arrangement became routine.

In the Inward Room, when Shivnath lifted a file, he looked first at the colour.

Then the white strip.

Then the first page.

At first the three checks took two extra minutes.

Later they became habit.

Bhola Babu sometimes said,

“Earlier I looked at the colour and knew the branch.

Now I look at the colour and know what question to ask.”

It took two months for the permanent order to be drafted.

The draft listed five colours, the branches, what to do when a colour was unavailable, the size of the white strip, and the entry to be made during rebinding.

At the final meeting, Sudhanshu Mishra read aloud:

“White strip: two inches wide.”

Satyanarayan Babu immediately asked,

“Do we have two-inch white cloth in Stores?”

“Paper strip.”

“What if the paper gets wet?”

Maithili suppressed a laugh.

Bhola Babu looked at her.

Then smiled himself.

At last the order said:

“Clear and durable branch strip.”

No material was specified.

On the Monday after the order was issued, a new batch arrived in the Inward Room.

Seven files were all bound in the same grey cloth.

Shivnath lifted the first one.

Out of old habit, he looked at the colour.

Then stopped.

On the white strip, in bold letters, it said:

“Animal Husbandry.”

He opened the first page.

Read the subject.

Maithili asked,

“What happened?”

Putting the file in the correct pile, Shivnath said,

“Nothing.

Colour is only colour now.”

ONE OFFICE, TWO NAMES

Three names were written at the main gate of the District Water Resources Building.

At the top, on a new blue board:

“District Rural Water Resources Coordination Office.”

Below it, two faded old boards partly covered each other:

“Minor Irrigation Assistance Branch”

and

“Rural Water Conservation Cell.”

The two branches had merged three months earlier.

On paper, the merger had taken one page.

No one knew how many months it would take for the building to complete it.

The employees of the old Minor Irrigation Branch sat in the rooms on the left.

Those from Water Conservation sat on the right.

The meeting hall in the middle carried a board with the new name.

But the old attendant still kept the keys in two separate bunches.

Junior Assistant Prabhakar Jha was deputed to the new office.

On his first day, he was given two seals.

One round seal read:

“Minor Irrigation Assistance Branch, Madhubani.”

The other, rectangular:

“Rural Water Conservation Cell.”

Prabhakar asked,

“Where is the seal of the new office?”

Accounts Assistant Suresh Babu said,

“The order to make it has already gone.”

“Then which seal do we use in the meantime?”

“Depends on the paper.”

That answer became Prabhakar’s first lesson in the office.

The very next day a letter came from the bank.

Its subject:

send a certified copy of the merger order for changing the name of an old savings account.

The letter was addressed to the “Minor Irrigation Assistance Branch.”

Prabhakar attached a copy of the merger order and prepared a reply.

At the top he wrote the new name:

“District Rural Water Resources Coordination Office.”

At the bottom, the old rectangular Water Conservation seal was affixed because the round one happened to be lying on another desk.

Four days later, the bank returned the letter.

Its remark was brief:

“Office name in letterhead and seal inconsistent.”

Suresh Babu read it.

“That is why I said it depends on the paper.”

Prabhakar asked,

“But the new office has no seal.”

“Then write the old name.”

“Which old one?”

Suresh Babu took off his spectacles and placed them on the desk.

“New employees ask this question too often.”

That week an application arrived from the Kunarapur Water Committee.

The village’s small irrigation channel had filled with sand after the rains.

The committee had cleared the channel through voluntary labour.

A sanctioned repair payment of eighteen thousand seven hundred rupees was still due.

Committee secretary Dayakant Paswan brought the papers himself.

He did not carry a file.

His five-page application was tied in red cloth.

“Just tell me when the money will come,” he said.

“The wheat seed is already down.

The channel is clean, but the money for replacing the gate plank is included in this payment.”

Prabhakar examined the papers.

Completion of the work was certified.

The Junior Engineer’s measurement book was there.

The committee meeting signatures.

Photographs.

Everything was in order.

The only obstacle lay in the heading of the payment order.

The sanction had been issued by the old “Rural Water Conservation Cell.”

The money was to be drawn from a bank account in the name of the “Minor Irrigation Assistance Branch.”

Now the payment order had to be issued by the new “District Rural Water Resources Coordination Office.”

One piece of work.

Three names.

Prabhakar told Dayakant,

“The papers are complete.

We are aligning the names.”

Dayakant laughed.

“My name is correct, isn’t it?”

“Not yours.

The office’s.”

For a few moments Dayakant looked at Prabhakar’s face.

“The office does not know its own name?”

Prabhakar did not answer.

He prepared the first draft of the payment order.

At the top he wrote:

“District Rural Water Resources Coordination Office
(after merger of the former Rural Water Conservation Cell and Minor
Irrigation Assistance Branch).”

Suresh Babu read it and shook his head.

“The name of the bank account is not clear.”

Prabhakar added in brackets:

“(Bank account operated in the former name of Minor Irrigation
Assistance Branch).”

Accounts Officer Manoranjan Babu read it.

“The sanction is from Water Conservation.

Write that too.”

Another bracket appeared:

“(Original sanction issued by Rural Water Conservation Cell).”

The heading grew from two lines to five.

Below it, Prabhakar wrote the subject:

“Payment of repair amount to Kunarapur Water Committee.”

Manoranjan Babu said,

“Put ‘related to’ before the subject.

There are three names.

The relationship should remain clear.”

Prabhakar added “related to.”

It seemed to him that words were not decreasing.

Only offices were multiplying inside them.

The payment order reached the Treasury.

The next day an objection came:

“Name of issuing office does not match name of bank-account holder.”

Prabhakar picked up the file and placed it before Suresh Babu.

“I have written all the names.”

Suresh Babu said calmly,

“Perhaps that is why they do not match.”

“If I write less, one name is omitted.

If I write more, all three look separate.”

“That is called administration.”

For the first time, Prabhakar did not laugh at Suresh Babu’s joke.

That afternoon Dayakant came again.

This time committee treasurer Rekha Devi was with him.

Wet mud from beside the canal had dried into pale streaks on her feet.

“Is there some mistake?” she asked.

Prabhakar said,

“Not in the papers.

In the name.”

Rekha Devi looked at her own sheet.

“Our committee has only one name:

Kunarapur Water Committee.”

"The mistake is on the office side."

Rekha Devi smiled.

"Then we have come to the right place.

People in the wrong place see their own mistakes quickly."

Suresh Babu heard her from a distance.

He smiled, but said nothing.

The next day Prabhakar went to the old records room.

He found the merger order.

It clearly stated that the property, liabilities, movable and immovable records, bank accounts, and ongoing schemes of both former units would be deemed to fall under the new office.

Prabhakar felt relieved.

He decided to send a certified copy of that paragraph to the bank.

But which seal should be put on the certified copy?

The elderly Records Assistant Ram Ekbal Babu laughed at the question.

"Son, this is why the merger has not finished in three months."

He took a thin file from the cupboard.

A draft letter for changing the bank-account name had been prepared but not issued.

The remark said:

"To be sent after official seal of the new office is received."

On the second page was the order to make the seal.

That too had not been issued.

The remark:

"Full name for seal to be finalised after title of new bank account is confirmed."

Prabhakar looked from one page to the other.

The bank name was waiting for the seal.

The seal was waiting for the bank name.

Ram Ekbal Babu said,

"Both are behaving like polite employees, each asking the other to go first."

"And payment in the meantime?"

"For old work, the old name was used.

For new work, the new name.

Work in between gets trapped."

"Kunarapur's work is in between."

"Then it is a true citizen of this office."

Prabhakar felt bad.

Ram Ekbal Babu's sentence was a joke.

But Dayakant's canal stayed in his mind like truth.

He prepared a new draft.

This time, instead of one name at the top, he made three sections.

First line:

the new office.

Second:

“Former unit: Minor Irrigation Assistance Branch.”

Third:

“Former unit: Rural Water Conservation Cell.”

By the time he reached the subject, nearly half the page had been used.

Dayakant’s payment details moved to page two.

Typist Suman Kumari printed the letter and handed it to Prabhakar.

“Looking at the first page, it seems the office is writing its own identity card.”

Prabhakar said,

“The citizen appears on the second page.”

Suman replied,

“Then the citizen has to cross the first page.”

The sentence stayed with Prabhakar.

The letter went to the bank.

This time the bank wrote:

“Legal identity of account holder unclear due to use of multiple office names.”

Manoranjan Babu was irritated.

“First they said the names did not match.

Now they say there are too many names.”

Suresh Babu said,

“The bank is protecting its papers too.”

“What are we doing?” Prabhakar asked.

No one answered.

At last Officer-in-Charge Shashikant Mishra called a meeting.

The first item on the agenda was:

“Uniformity of office name after merger.”

The second:

“Payment to Kunarapur Water Committee.”

Prabhakar was given the task of writing the proceedings.

He sat down to type the heading.

“District Rural Water Resources Coordination Office
(former Minor Irrigation Assistance Branch and Rural Water Conservation
Cell, consolidated unit)...”

Shashikant Mishra stopped him.

“Is this meeting for shortening the name or enlarging the heading?”

The room laughed.

For the first time, Prabhakar shortened the heading:

“District Rural Water Resources Coordination Office.”

At the meeting, the bank letter, Treasury objection, old seals, merger order, and Kunarapur payment papers were placed on the same table.

Ram Ekbal Babu said,

“The merger order clearly gives the new name.

In law, both old units are absorbed into it.”

Manoranjan Babu said,

“Then change the bank-account name immediately.”

Suresh Babu asked,
 “The bank will ask for the new seal.”
 Shashikant Mishra said,
 “Make the seal.”
 “The seal maker says the bank title must first be fixed.”
 For a few moments everyone was silent.
 Suman, seated in a corner typing the minutes, said softly,
 “The person who makes the seal is not a bank officer.”
 Everyone looked at her.
 She became slightly uncomfortable.
 “I only mean this:
 the merger order determines the office’s name.
 Not the bank.”
 Ram Ekbal Babu nodded.
 “She is right.”

Prabhakar was surprised that a knot of three months had loosened through one ordinary sentence from a typist.

The knot had not been difficult.

Everyone had assumed it had been tied in someone else’s hands.

Shashikant Mishra dictated an order:

“As per merger order dated ..., the official name of the new office shall be ‘District Rural Water Resources Coordination Office.’

The two former names may be mentioned in brackets or remarks where required solely for identification of earlier records, and shall not be used in the heading.”

Second line:

“A new official seal shall be prepared immediately.”

Third:

“Request for change of bank-account name shall be sent with certified copy of merger order and specimen signature of the officer.”

Manoranjana Babu asked,

“Which seal goes on the certified copy right now?”

Shashikant Mishra picked up the old round seal.

“Use this with the signature and add the remark:

‘Seal of former unit; under new office pursuant to merger order.’”

Suresh Babu said,

“The bank may object again.”

“If it does, it will give a written reply.”

Hearing the sentence, Prabhakar remembered not some other clerk from another story, but his own first week:

how often people in offices avoided doing something the rules allowed merely because they feared an objection might arise.

At the end of the meeting, the Kunarapur payment came up.

Shashikant Mishra asked,

“Papers complete?”

Prabhakar said,

“Complete.”

“Measurement?”

“Complete.”

“Committee’s authority?”

“Complete.”

“Then?”

Prabhakar showed the first page.

A five-line heading.

Shashikant Mishra lowered his head and read.

Then said,

“Cut half this paper.”

“Cut it?”

“Not the name.

Shorten the heading.”

Prabhakar prepared a new payment order.

At the top:

only the new office name.

Subject:

“Kunarapur Water Committee: Payment of Sanctioned Repair Amount.”

In the first line of the body:

one paragraph number from the merger order.

Then directly to the amount.

The whole letter fit on one page.

Suman printed it.

“Now the citizen has appeared on the first page.”

Prabhakar smiled.

The new seal took two days to make.

The new name was clear on the black rubber, but the letters were so small that to fit inside the circle the word “Coordination” was slightly compressed.

Looking at it, Suresh Babu said,

“After a meeting to shorten names, why is the seal so crowded?”

Ram Ekbal Babu replied,

“Administration does not understand the limits of a circle.”

The new seal was affixed to the Kunarapur payment order.

The bank was sent the merger order and a certificate of name continuity.

For three days there was no reply.

On the fourth day, Dayakant arrived.

This time he carried a broken wooden plank from the canal gate.

“What is that?” Prabhakar asked.

“The old gate plank.

It rotted in the rain.

We are making a new one, but the money still has not come.”

He placed the plank beneath the desk.

“The channel is clean.

If we release the water, the seed will survive.

Without the gate, someone may close it at night.”

Prabhakar telephoned the bank.
 After being transferred through five people, he reached an officer.
 The officer said,
 “The name-change process is underway.
 But there is no bar on valid payment from the old account if the
 authorised signature and merger proof are clear.”
 Prabhakar asked,
 “Will you give that in writing?”
 The officer paused.
 “I will send an email.”
 Half an hour later the email arrived.
 Suresh Babu read it three times.
 “So payment can be made,” Prabhakar said.
 “Not ‘can be,’” Suresh Babu corrected him.
 “It will be made.”
 Prabhakar laughed.
 “Today even the language is becoming uniform.”
 The order went back to the bank.
 That evening the amount was released.
 When informing Dayakant, Prabhakar asked,
 “The gate will be made now?”
 Dayakant said,
 “I will tell the carpenter today itself.
 Whatever the papers call the office, water has only one name.”
 From behind him, Rekha Devi said,
 “Even if you rename the water, the fields will not obey.”
 Everyone laughed.
 Five days later a photograph arrived from Kunarapur.
 A new wooden plank had been fitted to the small canal gate.
 No office name was written on it.
 Only, in white letters:
 “OPEN: 5 A.M.
 CLOSE: 6 P.M.”
 Prabhakar kept the photograph beside his desk.
 Meanwhile, the bank-account name change was completed.
 A new passbook came.
 New seal.
 New letterhead.
 An order was issued to deposit the two old seals in Stores.
 The Stores Assistant listed three items on a sheet:
 “Round seal — Minor Irrigation Assistance Branch.
 Rectangular seal — Rural Water Conservation Cell.
 One batch of old letterhead.”
 In the remarks he asked:
 “Reason for disposal?”
 Prabhakar wrote:

“Names obsolete after merger.”

The Stores Assistant read the words.

“The names are obsolete.

The history is not.”

“The history will remain in the file.”

“And the seals?”

“They will remain too.

In Stores.

Just not at the top of letters.”

A month later, the office letters began to look shorter.

One name at the top.

The address below.

Then the subject.

At first the employees found them oddly empty.

White space remained at the top of the page.

One day Suresh Babu said,

“So much blank space does not look good.”

Prabhakar asked,

“What shall we fill it with?”

Suresh Babu thought for a few moments.

“Nothing.

Leave it.”

That day a second letter came from Kunarapur.

The heading was clear:

“Irrigation Gate Repair Completed.”

The body contained only three lines.

At the end were the signatures of Dayakant and Rekha Devi.

Prabhakar entered the letter in the register.

At the top there was one office name.

Below it, the citizen’s work.

Between them, enough white space.

For the first time, the emptiness did not look incomplete to him.

It looked useful.

STORY 159

THE SECOND STEP OF THE STAIRCASE

The main staircase of the District Records Building had grown old even before the rains began.

The wooden railing had been polished smooth in many places by hands.

The stone steps had sunk slightly in the middle.

The lime on the wall had acquired layers like the edge of an old document.

Even so, people went up and down that staircase all day.

On the first floor were the Certified Copies Branch, the Record-of-Rights Branch, and the Old Registers Room.

One night in Bhadra, a drain on the roof became blocked.

Water kept seeping down through the wall beside the staircase.

The next morning the corner of the fourth step was found broken, and a fine crack showed beneath the fifth.

The Building In-Charge immediately had two bamboo poles tied across the staircase and a notice put up:

“MAIN STAIRCASE TEMPORARILY CLOSED.
USE THE REAR STAIRCASE FOR ACCESS TO UPPER FLOOR.”

The rear staircase went around the courtyard and climbed beside the storeroom.

It was made of iron.

It was narrow.

And when it rained, it became slippery.

Employees could climb it.

For visitors, even finding the route was difficult.

An arrow was painted at the main gate.

The first rain washed away half of it.

Shambhunath Jha, Senior Clerk in the Certified Copies Branch, had an old pain in his knees.

In thirty years of service he had never had a complaint against the staircase.

But the rear iron stairs were a different trial.

On the first day he climbed up holding tightly to the railing.

On the second, while coming down at noon, his right knee trembled.

On the third, he remembered an old doctor's advice:

“Avoid unnecessary climbing.”

Shambhunath went to Branch In-Charge Anant Babu.

“Until the main staircase is repaired—seven or ten days—allow me to sit downstairs.”

Anant Babu removed his spectacles.

“Where downstairs?”

“Beside the stairs.

The main registers can remain upstairs.

I can examine papers, make receipt entries, and point out deficiencies from below.”

At first Anant Babu laughed.

“A staircase is not an office.”

Shambhunath said,

“I am not asking for an office.

I am asking for one table.”

With the Building In-Charge’s permission, an old small table was placed against the wall to the left of the main staircase.

Its front leg stood two cubits from the first step.

The back of the chair was near the edge of the second.

The bamboo barrier began from the third step.

So any visitor who approached the main staircase saw Shambhunath first.

On the first day the table held only the receipt register, a black stamp pad, a blue pen, and a bottle of water.

Shambhunath also had his old nameplate brought down from his upstairs desk:

“SHAMBHUNATH

SENIOR

CERTIFIED COPIES BRANCH.”

At 9:20 the first visitor arrived.

He carried an application for a record of rights.

He saw the bamboo barrier.

Read the nameplate.

And asked,

“Is the upstairs branch here now?”

“The branch is upstairs,” Shambhunath said.

“I am sitting downstairs for the moment.

Show me your paper.”

The man handed it over.

The application gave the name of the mauza and the plot number.

But no year.

Shambhunath pointed out the omission.

The man went to the copying shop outside, added the year, and returned in five minutes.

Shambhunath entered the receipt and sent it upstairs in the hands of attendant Bhuvaneshwar.

By ten o’clock four applications had been received.

At eleven, Chandan, the junior clerk upstairs, came down carrying three files.

“These need the applicants’ signatures on the second page.

If we send them upstairs first, we will have to send them down again.

If the people come to you, get the signatures.”

Shambhunath placed all three files along the side of the table.

By noon the function of the table had become clear.

Anyone who could not climb upstairs,

JHA

CLERK

anyone who could not find the rear staircase,
 anyone who had brought an incomplete application,
 and anyone who merely wanted to know “whom should I go to?”
 stopped first beside the second step.

On the second day Bhuvaneshwar placed a low stool beside the table.

“Old people cannot remain standing.”

Shambhunath asked,

“Where did this stool come from?”

“From the old room upstairs.

The inventory marks it ‘surplus.’”

“Return it later.”

Bhuvaneshwar said,

“When the staircase is repaired.”

No one knew when the staircase would be repaired.

The Building Engineer’s letter said:

“Repair estimate shall be submitted after assessment of damage.”

Before the estimate came measurement.

For measurement, an engineer was needed.

The engineer was away on inspection outside the district.

The temporary table meant for seven days remained there on the eighth.

That day someone wrote in chalk on the wall:

“UPSTAIRS BRANCH ↓”

The arrow pointed directly at Shambhunath’s table.

Shambhunath wet a cloth and erased it.

The next morning the wall said again:

“COPY BRANCH.”

This time he did not erase it.

He merely wrote in smaller letters beneath the arrow:

“RECEIPT.”

Within two hours someone had added:

“AND CHECKING.”

Shambhunath looked at the words.

He did not strike anything out.

The real usefulness of the table was not only that it solved the problem of the route.

Upstairs, files moved between cupboards and registers.

Downstairs, at Shambhunath’s table, people’s faces remained attached to the papers.

After taking an application in hand, he asked:

“By what date do you need this?”

“Do you have an older copy?”

“How was the name spelled earlier?”

Such questions did not appear in the registers.

But they often saved time in finding the correct record.

One Monday, Kamla Devi arrived.

She was about seventy.

Her grandson Neeraj was with her.
Kamla Devi's husband had died thirty years earlier.
Half of the family house in her village had been taken in road widening.
Now, for demarcation of the remaining land, she needed a certified copy
of an old 1989 map.
The application had been submitted two weeks earlier.
The search result had come back:
"Record unclear."
Neeraj placed the paper before Shambhunath.
"We went upstairs."
They said ask in the Old Registers Room.
The Old Registers people said send it again through the branch."
Shambhunath read the paper.
The mauza name was written as "Bariyahi."
He asked Kamla Devi,
"Was the village called exactly this in the old papers?"
Kamla Devi said,
"When I was married, people called it 'Bariyahi Tola.'
Later, after the Panchayat was formed, 'Navbariyahi' began to be written."
Shambhunath's eyes sharpened.
"The year is 1989."
But the search was done under the new name."
He telephoned upstairs.
"Chandan, look in the 1989 index under Bariyahi Tola.
Not Navbariyahi."
Five minutes later came the answer:
"The number is there."
Map Book 42."
Kamla Devi's face changed.
"For the first time in two weeks someone has asked what the village used
to be called."
Shambhunath found it difficult to answer.
He only said,
"Old registers listen to old names."
The file went upstairs.
Two days later the map was found.
Its edges were worn, but the plot number was clear.
The process of making a certified copy began.
News of this small success spread through the office with a speed that rules
never achieved.
People began saying:
"Show it first at the staircase."
Bhuvaneshwar himself told visitors:
"Before going upstairs, have Babu check it."
Even the gate guard would say:
"If it is copy work, go to the second step."

Gradually, “the second step” became the name of a place.

No one asked that the step belonged to the staircase and the table stood beside it.

On the tenth day Chandan brought down a small printed white slip:

“CERTIFIED _____ COPIES _____ BRANCH _____

RECEIPT AND PRELIMINARY CHECKING.”

Shambhunath turned it over in his hand.

“Does Anant Babu permit this?”

“No.

People keep asking, so I thought we should hang it.”

“Do not hang it.

This table is temporary.”

Chandan smiled.

“The greatest quality of temporary things is that they have no expiry date.”

Shambhunath put the slip in the drawer.

Two weeks later, a problem arose.

A new batch of receipt registers arrived.

At the top of each page was a printed field:

“Room Number.”

The upstairs branch was Room 12.

Where was Shambhunath's table?

Bhuvaneshwar joked,

“Room: Step 2.”

Shambhunath glared at him.

Chandan said,

“I2-G?”

Anant Babu came downstairs.

For a while he looked at the table, the staircase, and the register.

“Write Room 12.

It is the same branch.”

Shambhunath said,

“But if a visitor looks for 12, he will go upstairs.”

“Then leave it blank.”

“The register accepts a blank field.

The computer does not.”

Anant Bābū remained silent for a few moments.

At last he said,

“Write 12-Temporary.”

Thus the building acquired its first room that had no walls but had a number.

Three days later the digital receipt began printing:

"ROOM 12-TEMPORARY."

Visitors read it and asked,

“Where is I2-Temporary?”

The guard replied,

“Second step.”

Shambhunath found the situation both amusing and troubling.

He knew that once a place entered the papers, removing it became difficult.

The table’s temporary existence now depended less on the bamboo barrier than on printed letters.

At the end of the month, a building-safety inspection arrived.

Two engineers.

One fire-safety assistant.

One accounts employee from the Building Branch.

They carried measuring tape, a building plan, and an inventory list.

The broken staircase was the first issue.

An engineer examined the crack.

Tapped the stone with a hammer.

Took photographs.

Then the fire-safety assistant noticed Shambhunath’s table.

“Why is this table in the staircase zone?”

The Building In-Charge said,

“Temporary arrangement.”

“The movement area must remain clear.”

Shambhunath stood up.

“The table is not on the steps.

It is against the left wall.”

The assistant measured with a tape.

“The width of the main exit has been reduced.”

At that moment five visitors were standing before the table.

One woman held a child.

An old man leaned on a walking stick.

Two young men held applications.

And Kamla Devi had returned to collect her certified map.

The fire-safety assistant asked,

“What is this queue for?”

The Building In-Charge said,

“Certified Copies Branch.”

“Where is the branch?”

Everyone looked upward.

The bamboo barrier was still there.

“First floor.”

The assistant looked again at Shambhunath’s table.

“Then what is this?”

Anant Babu, who had come downstairs after hearing of the inspection, said,

“Temporary receipt and preliminary checking.”

“Order?”

Anant Babu was silent.

“Location in the building inventory?”

The Building In-Charge's sheet listed on the ground floor:

Rooms 1 to 6.

Records Room.

Stores.

Toilet.

Veranda.

Staircase.

There was no "12-Temporary."

The accounts employee asked,

"Inventory number of the table?"

Bhuvaneshwar immediately bent down and read the faded paint underneath.

"Table 17."

"Location?"

Bhuvaneshwar said naturally,

"Second step."

The accounts employee stopped writing.

"'Second step' is not a location category in the inventory."

Bhuvaneshwar replied,

"The table was not informed of that."

Anant Babu signalled him to keep quiet.

Shambhunath turned his face away to hide a faint smile.

The written inspection remark arrived the next day:

"Unauthorised table, stool, and paper material to be removed immediately from main-staircase exit area.

For public convenience, consideration may be given to identifying a lawful location on the ground floor."

The first sentence was an order.

The second was a consideration.

In an office, orders travel faster than considerations.

That same evening Table 17 was lifted and placed outside Stores.

The stool was sent upstairs.

Shambhunath's nameplate returned to Room 12.

An attempt was made to find him a temporary chair on the ground floor.

There was no approved table.

The next morning Shambhunath climbed the rear iron staircase.

Halfway up he stopped to catch his breath.

When he reached the top, Chandan stood up from his chair.

"Babu, people are gathering downstairs."

"The guard will show them the way."

"Two elderly people cannot climb the rear staircase."

Shambhunath said nothing.

He rubbed his knee and opened the register.

At ten, Bhuvaneshwar came upstairs carrying five applications.

"People downstairs are giving these to me."

"You are not a receiving clerk."

“I know.

But they keep asking:
where did the second step go?”

Shambhunath did not take the applications.

“Bring whoever needs the service upstairs according to the rules.”

For the first time Bhuvaneshwar saw him looking slightly harsh.

He carried the papers back.

At noon Kamla Devi arrived.

Her certified map was ready.

But she had to sign for delivery in Room 12.

She climbed the first five steps of the rear staircase and stopped.

Neeraj held her arm.

The gate guard sent word upstairs.

Shambhunath slowly came down.

He carried the paper with him.

In the veranda, he placed the map on a window ledge and obtained Kamla Devi's signature.

Kamla Devi folded the map and put it in her bag.

“Babu, has your office been removed?”

“My office was upstairs.

It is upstairs.”

Kamla Devi looked towards the staircase.

“But I found it here.”

Shambhunath had no answer.

That evening Anant Babu called a meeting.

Subject:

“Ground-Floor Public Assistance Location.”

The options were listed:

half of Stores,

the guard room,

the western corner of the veranda,

the old ticket room.

Every option had some obstacle.

Stores contained government property.

The guard room was needed for security.

The veranda was an open passage.

On the building plan, the old ticket room was marked “Sealed Records Room,” although it contained only broken chairs.

Chandan asked,

“What about the empty triangle to the left of the staircase?”

The Building In-Charge said,

“The plan marks it as ‘open space.’”

“Can a table go there?”

“If a table is placed there, the open space will no longer be open.”

Bhuvaneshwar said softly,

“Then rename it ‘open space with table.’”

This time even Anant Babu laughed.

No decision was made.

At the end of the meeting, Shambhunath spoke plainly for the first time.

"Decide the name of the place later.

First decide where papers will be received from people who cannot climb the stairs."

The room fell silent.

The building plan had no field for that question.

The next day Anant Babu issued a one-page order:

"In the open ground-floor area to the left of the main staircase, while maintaining the required exit width, a movable table for public assistance shall be placed from 10 a.m. to 1 p.m.

The table shall be removed after working hours."

The fire-safety assistant asked for measurements over the telephone.

The Building In-Charge measured and reported that if the table was placed flush against the wall, the required exit width remained clear.

Permission came not orally, but by email.

Table 17 came out of Stores again.

This time it stood not immediately beside the second step, but eighteen inches farther to the left.

Chair towards the wall.

No stool.

No nameplate on the wall.

Only Shambhunath's old plate on the table.

Chandan took out the white slip he had printed earlier:

"CERTIFIED

COPIES

BRANCH

RECEIPT AND PRELIMINARY CHECKING."

Shambhunath looked at it.

"The order says 'Public Assistance.'"

Chandan had a new slip printed:

"PUBLIC ASSISTANCE DESK."

People still called it "the second step."

A week later repairs to the main staircase began.

The broken stone was replaced.

The railing was tightened.

Fresh lime was applied to the wall.

Two weeks later the bamboo barrier was removed.

The staircase reopened.

Shambhunath asked Anant Babu,

"Will the table go back upstairs now?"

Anant Babu looked at the order.

"The main staircase is open.

But there is no order removing the Public Assistance Desk."

"The first arrangement was temporary."

"This new order has no time limit."

Shambhunath smiled.

“So temporary is becoming permanent again.”

Anant Babu said,

“If we call it permanent, we will need a post, a room, a budget, everything.
For now call it the Public Assistance Desk.”

At the end of the month, the inventory was prepared again.

Against Table 17, the location was written:

“Ground-floor open area, left of main staircase.”

The words “second step” appeared nowhere.

No new room was added to the building list either.

Kamla Devi’s map matter was completed.

On the day of road demarcation, she sent a small packet of makhana through Neeraj.

Shambhunath returned it.

With it he sent a note:

“Keep the copy of the map safely.”

Bhuvaneshwar asked,

“Why did you return the packet?”

“The government pays me for the work.”

Bhuvaneshwar looked at the table.

“Who pays for the table?”

“The government.

Inventory No. 17.”

“And for the place?”

Shambhunath gave no answer.

The following Monday morning, a new visitor entered through the main gate.

He carried an old record of rights.

His eyes moved across the wall signs.

The newly repaired staircase shone.

He climbed two steps.

Then noticed Shambhunath’s table below.

He came back down and asked,

“The upstairs branch is here now, isn’t it?”

For a moment Shambhunath looked towards the staircase.

The second step was empty.

In the building inventory it was simply called a staircase.

Taking the visitor’s paper into his hand, he said,

“First show me what work you have.”

STORY 160

THE OFFICER OF THE LAST LINE

On the day the annual staffing register was prepared in the District Development Office, people looked first not for their names but for their lines.

Whose post was marked "Permanent."

Whose "Vacant."

Whose pay head had changed.

Whose branch had slipped onto the next page.

These matters ran hotter through the office corridors than tea.

That year, Pay Assistant Raghav Chaudhary was preparing the staffing register.

On his desk lay the thick register from the previous year, the current budget papers, and a digital statement received from the district.

Line after line matched smoothly until the final page.

Then his pen stopped.

The last line was blank.

No designation.

No sanctioned number.

No person.

But in the salary-budget column, an amount was written:

three hundred and twelve thousand rupees.

At first Raghav thought it might be a printing error.

Then he opened the previous year's register.

The final line there was blank too.

The budget figure was present.

He called for the copy from two years earlier.

There was a faint blue ink stain on the line, but no readable letters.

The budget figure was there even then.

"What is this?" Raghav asked Harinarayan Babu, the old Accounts Clerk at the next desk.

Harinarayan Babu removed his spectacles and leaned towards the page.

"The last line."

"I can see that.

What post is it?"

"All I know is that you should not delete it."

"Why?"

Harinarayan Babu looked at him as though Raghav were reading the letters in the staffing register but not its meaning.

"If you delete it, the number of sanctioned posts may go down."

"But no number is written."

"That is why you must be even more careful."

Raghav did not like the answer.

But bad answers in offices possess a special force:
they immediately produce the next question,
and finding the answer to the next question is harder than correcting the
first answer.

The next day, Establishment Branch In-Charge Bhuvan Jha examined the
register.

He too stopped at the final line.

“Was it there last year?”

“Yes.”

“Then keep it.”

“Designation?”

Bhuvan Babu turned through the budget papers.

“Write ‘Clarification Pending.’”

Raghav said,

“Has clarification been sought?”

Bhuvan Babu was silent for a moment.

“We will seek it.”

Thus, for the first time, words appeared opposite the blank line:

“Clarification Pending.”

Not in the designation column.

In the remarks column.

That same week, the six-month term of temporary employee Rukmini
Kumari was about to expire.

Rukmini had originally been engaged to digitise old assistance registers.

Three hundred and fifty-four registers had already been entered.

The project money was almost exhausted.

But in six months the office had taught her as many additional tasks as
were absent from her appointment letter.

In the morning she opened the post.

She matched addresses on returned letters.

She separated incomplete pages in assistance applications.

And at the end of the day, when no branch claimed a paper as its own, she
found the branch where it belonged.

The office had more such work than posts in the staffing register.

Three days before Rukmini’s term ended, Bhuvan Babu said,

“There is work.

But the project is over.”

Rukmini asked directly,

“Then I should not come from Monday?”

“It is difficult to say right now.”

“For me, how many days does ‘difficult’ mean?”

Bhuvan Babu did not answer.

He looked towards the register as though some extra field for time might
be found on the page.

His eyes fell on the final line.

A small meeting was held in the Accounts Room that afternoon.

The subject was not Rukmini.
 It was written as:
 “Use of Available Salary Budget.”
 Raghav, Harinarayan Babu, Bhuvan Jha, and Treasury Assistant Shyamsundar sat together.
 Shyamsundar asked,
 “This three hundred and twelve thousand belongs to which post?”
 No one answered.
 Harinarayan Babu said,
 “The post is old.”
 “Name?”
 “I do not remember.”
 “Order?”
 “It would be in the old register.”
 “The old register is blank.”
 Harinarayan Babu nodded.
 “Then someone must have erased the name.”
 Raghav said,
 “There is no sign of erasure.”
 Bhuvan Babu tried to gather the discussion.
 “The budget is sanctioned.
 There is work too.
 Rukmini can be kept temporarily.”
 Shyamsundar immediately asked,
 “Against which post?”
 The last line entered the room again.
 In the end, there was no decision.
 There was an arrangement.
 Rukmini’s term would be extended by one month on the ground of
 “urgent office requirement.”
 The designation field on the salary file could not be left blank.
 Raghav wrote:
 “Temporary Assistance — Last-Line Budget.”
 Rukmini read the file.
 “Is ‘Last Line’ a post?”
 Raghav smiled awkwardly.
 “Not a post.
 An identifier for the budget.”
 “In my appointment letter?”
 “That will still say ‘Temporary Records Assistant.’”
 “So in salary I am one thing, in work a third thing, and in the budget I am
 the last line?”
 Raghav said,
 “Your name will remain the same everywhere.”
 Rukmini read the paper again.
 “It is a good thing for a name to remain.”

Within a month, “last line” became office vocabulary.
Any small task with no clear owner:
“Put it on the last line.”
The list for correcting old telephone numbers:
last line.
Returned post:
last line.
Reconciling attendance at meetings:
last line.
A photocopy of a white ration card stuck between three branches:
last line.
Rukmini’s desk stood near the door of the Establishment Branch.
Earlier people called her by name.
Now many employees said,
“This is a last-line paper.”
The first time she heard it, she laughed.
The second time too.
The third time she said,
“Say the name of the paper.”
But language in an office behaves like a file.
Once it reaches the wrong desk, bringing it back is not easy.
A few days later, the Stores Branch sent a list for repair of five chairs.
Four chairs had room numbers beside them.
Opposite the fifth was nothing.
The Stores Clerk laughed.
“This one is last line too.”
Rukmini returned the list.
“First write where the chair is.”
“You find it.”
“If I find it, will the repair also be entered in my name?”
This time the Stores Clerk did not laugh.
He located the fifth chair and wrote:
“Old Meeting Hall.”
Slowly, Rukmini made a rule for herself:
nothing without a name would move forward until it was given one.
On returned post:
the correct branch.
On an incomplete application:
the missing certificate.
On a new list:
the date.
Because of this, her work sometimes looked slow.
But less of it came back.
One day Bhuvan Babu said,
“You ask too many questions.”
Rukmini replied,

"If I do not ask questions, everything will become the last line."

Bhuvan Babu said nothing.

He liked the sentence.

It also made him uncomfortable.

At the end of the month, the district audit team arrived.

Two officers began reconciling budget heads, vacant posts, temporary appointments, and payments.

The first day was normal.

On the evening of the second, one officer, Prabhakar Sinha, placed a finger on the last page of the staffing register.

"What post is this?"

Raghav answered,

"Clarification pending."

"Can a post itself be clarification pending?"

"The budget has been carried forward from an old line."

"Sanction order?"

Raghav placed the old files before him.

On some pages the total number of posts was twenty-seven.

On others, twenty-eight.

No document clearly gave the name of the final post.

In one ten-year-old statement, the edge of the final cell had torn away.

Directly opposite that torn edge, the salary-budget figure remained.

Prabhakar Sinha asked,

"You are paying salary from this?"

Shyamsundar said,

"For temporary assistance."

"Person?"

"Rukmini Kumari."

"Post?"

Everyone's eyes turned towards Rukmini's desk, although she was not in the room.

The answer to a question about paper had become a person.

Raghav said,

"Temporary Records Assistant."

"Sanction for that post?"

"Temporary requirement order."

"Then why use the budget of the blank line?"

For the previous month, the office had been answering that question through work.

Not through paper.

The audit team did not stop the payment.

But it raised an objection:

"Source of budget line without designation, sanctioned post strength, and lawful head for temporary expenditure to be clarified."

A reply was required within thirty days.

When a copy of the objection arrived, Harinarayan Babu was the first to say,

“See?

That is why a blank line should not be deleted.”

Raghav stared at him.

“The objection came because we kept it.”

“If we had deleted it, the budget would have gone.”

“Is it a budget?

Or only a figure?”

Harinarayan Babu fell silent.

In thirty years of service, those two words had often been treated as the same.

The Establishment Branch began searching old records.

A letter went to the district office.

A copy to the State Directorate.

Four days later, the district replied:

“According to available records, sanctioned post strength is 27.”

The current office register contained twenty-seven clearly identified posts.

The blank final line stood apart.

Bhuvan Babu said,

“Then this is not the twenty-eighth.”

Raghav asked,

“But the budget figure?”

The district Accounts Branch wrote in a second letter that in an old budget statement, a consolidated amount had shifted opposite the final empty cell during tabulation.

It was not a sanction for a separate post.

Through year after year of copying, the figure survived.

Its meaning fell away.

Harinarayan Babu read the letter twice.

“So all these years we have been protecting a shifted number?”

No one blamed him.

No one felt entirely blameless either.

Now Rukmini’s salary question stood clearly before them.

Once the wrong line disappeared, where would the next month’s money come from?

The project had ended.

There was no regular post.

The temporary requirement order would expire in five days.

Rukmini was called into the meeting.

Bhuvan Babu explained the situation.

The words were chosen carefully:

“accounts reconciliation,”

“sanctioned head,”

“reallocation,”

“extension presently uncertain.”

Rukmini listened to everything.

Then asked,

“Should I come next month?”

Bhuvan Babu said,

“It is not certain yet.”

“So again, how many days does ‘difficult’ mean?”

It was the same question she had asked a month earlier.

This time Bhuvan Babu did not look at the paper.

“We will give you a written answer within seven days.”

Rukmini nodded.

“All right.

Until then, I will finish whatever work is in my name.”

During those seven days, the office prepared a list of Rukmini’s work for the first time.

Making the list turned out to be difficult.

The Establishment Branch claimed mail classification.

The Social Assistance Branch claimed assistance applications.

The Receipt Branch claimed returned letters.

The Records Branch claimed digital reconciliation.

Every branch said the work was necessary.

None said the full-time post belonged to it.

Adding up the list, Raghav said,

“The last line was really the space between all the other lines.”

Shyamsundar said,

“A space does not pay salary.”

“But work kept coming out of it.”

A new proposal was sent to the district office:

a six-month “Temporary Records and Receipt Assistance” service, with a clear list of duties.

The money was requested not from the old blank line, but from the approved combined savings under ongoing records digitisation and receipt-improvement heads.

The amount was lower than before.

Rukmini was shown the proposal.

She asked,

“Why is the pay lower?”

Shyamsundar answered plainly,

“That is all that is available under the lawful head.”

Rukmini thought for a while.

“Is less work written too?”

Raghav looked at the list.

Two parts of her old work had indeed been removed:

reconciling attendance at meetings,

and incomplete Stores lists.

Rukmini said,

“Then it is fine.

As much pay as there is written work.

Do not add 'last line' again later."

Bhuvan Babu smiled.

"This time we will ask before adding anything."

Approval arrived on the evening of the fifth day.

Six months.

A clear designation.

Defined duties.

Lower pay.

Rukmini returned the following Monday.

Her desk remained where it had been.

But above it was a small nameplate:

"RUKMINI

KUMARI

TEMPORARY RECORDS AND RECEIPT ASSISTANCE."

That day the revised annual staffing register was printed too.

The final blank line had been removed.

Below it was a note:

"In previous copy, final blank line resulted from printing/table-shift error; not a separately sanctioned post."

Harinarayan Babu stared at the page for a long time.

"After so many years, deleting one line feels wrong."

Raghav said,

"The paper has become lighter."

"Post strength?"

"Twenty-seven.

What it always was."

Harinarayan Babu closed the page.

His face showed less relief than the grief of habit.

Sometimes a person becomes attached not to an error, but to having known it for a long time.

At noon a returned letter arrived.

The branch name on the envelope was incomplete.

The recipient's village was correct.

As before, attendant Ramsevak placed it on Rukmini's desk and said,

"This is last line."

Rukmini picked up the envelope.

In pencil she wrote the correct branch name on top.

Entered it in the receipt register.

And handed it back to Ramsevak.

"Not last line," she said.

"Receipt Branch."

Ramsevak read the name, nodded, and walked away.

Rukmini straightened the new nameplate on her desk.

The last page of the staffing register hanging on the wall was now one line shorter.

Her name was not on that page.

It was on the separate list for temporary employees, with the period clearly stated.

The list was thinner than the staffing register.

But not a single line in it was blank.

STORY 161

PRESENT IN THREE PLACES

The first time Jagdish Paswan was told that he was present in three places at the same time, he found it absurd.

The notice had arrived at the rented room in town.

Sushma had returned from college and opened the envelope.

At the top was the name of the District Integrated Eligibility-Matching Cell.

Below, in black letters, it said:

“Person bearing the same identity number identified with simultaneous permanent presence at three separate locations. Educational assistance withheld pending verification.”

Sushma did not fully understand the sentence.

But she understood “educational assistance withheld.”

She was in the second year of her undergraduate course.

The next instalment of the scholarship was supposed to cover the college fee and two months’ worth of books.

Jagdish began his night duty at the gate of the Agricultural Seed Depot at eight in the evening.

During the day he usually slept for three or four hours, then went sometimes to the village, sometimes to the rented room in town, sometimes to the market for errands.

His mother, Dulari Devi, lived in the ancestral village near Kamtaul.

His wife Devki and daughter Sushma rented a single room in town because the college was far from the village.

Twice a week Jagdish ate dinner at the town room and then went to the depot.

Three or four days a month he stayed in the village, though even on those days he still had to reach the depot on time for duty.

To him, the three places existed for three different reasons.

To the papers, perhaps all three had become the same thing.

The next morning, after finishing duty, Jagdish went straight to the District Integrated Eligibility-Matching Cell.

The office was new.

The building was old.

A blue board on the veranda wall read:

“Integration of Family, Residence and Eligibility Records.”

Inside were five desks, two computers, one printer, and three tall piles of paper in a corner.

An assistant named Premlata Jha examined his notice.

She was not reading the sheet.

She was searching the computer screen.

“Identity number?”

Jagdish gave it.
 Premlata entered the number.
 Three red marks appeared on the screen.
 “The problem is clear here,” she said.
 “It is not clear to me,” Jagdish replied.
 Premlata read the first line.
 “Village Family Register: Permanent Member, Ward Seven, Kamtaul.”
 The second:
 “Municipal Tenant Survey: Head of Family, Ward Eighteen.”
 The third:
 “Agricultural Seed Depot Night Attendance: Mandatory Night Presence on Premises.”
 Jagdish smiled.
 “All three are correct.”
 Premlata looked up.
 “How can all three permanent presences be correct at the same time?”
 “Not at the same time.
 My home is in the village.
 I rent a room in town because my daughter studies there.
 At night I guard the depot.”
 “Then which is the permanent place?”
 “The village.”
 “Current place?”
 Jagdish thought.
 “Are you asking about the day or the night?”
 Premlata did not laugh.
 Perhaps the system had no answer for that question either.
 She put a finger on the third line.
 “We will have to see why ‘mandatory night presence on premises’ has entered a residence source.
 But for now, the scholarship is blocked.
 Have one of these three records identified as wrong.”
 “Which one is wrong?”
 “You tell us.”
 Jagdish’s smile faded.
 “If I say the village is wrong, will my name be removed from my mother’s family register?”
 “It might.”
 “If I say the town is wrong, the tenant verification changes?”
 “That too.”
 “If I say the depot is wrong, what happens to my job attendance?”
 “That attendance is a separate matter.
 But the source is linked in the integrated register.”
 Jagdish folded the paper.
 “So, from among three true things, I must choose one lie?”
 “This is not asking you to choose a lie,” Premlata said after a pause.

“We need one primary residence.”

“My life does not run by first asking for a primary residence.”

Premlata looked at the piles of paper.

“Our system does.”

There was less rudeness than weariness in her answer.

Jagdish understood that someone on her side of the desk was trapped too.

Premlata wrote down a list of three proofs:

a certified copy of the village family register,

proof of the town tenancy,

and a certificate describing the nature of his depot duty.

“Bring all three.

Then we can propose that the meanings of the sources be separated.”

Jagdish kept the list.

As he walked out, the matter struck him as genuinely funny for a moment:

to prove the offence of being present in three places, he had to bring evidence from all three.

The village certificate seemed easiest.

Panchayat Assistant Ramvilas had known him since childhood.

Dulari Devi was drying makhana in the courtyard when Jagdish arrived.

“Papers again?” his mother asked.

“This time I have to prove where I live.”

“Ask me.

I will tell them.”

At the Panchayat office, Ramvilas opened the old family register.

Jagdish’s name, his wife, his daughter, his mother—

all under one family number.

“The certificate can be made,” Ramvilas said.

“I will write:

‘Shri Jagdish Paswan is a permanent resident of this village.’”

Jagdish paused.

“Permanent resident is correct.

But I do not sleep here at night.”

Ramvilas stopped his pen.

“Permanent resident does not mean where you sleep at night.”

“The district office may be understanding it that way.”

“Then they are understanding it wrongly.

I cannot change the language of the certificate.”

“Can you write ‘ancestral resident?’”

Ramvilas shook his head.

“The template has no such option.

Permanent or temporary.”

Jagdish chose permanent.

It was true.

But the sentence of truth was a little harder than what he actually needed.

The town tenancy certificate proved more difficult.

Landlord Shyamsundar Sahu brought out the tenant-verification copy. Jagdish was listed as “head of family.”

“It was made in your name,” Shyamsundar said.

“You were the one who signed the agreement when I rented you the room.”

“I stay here very few nights.”

“What does that matter to me?

The rent arrives on time.”

“Write in the certificate that my wife and daughter live here.”

Shyamsundar pushed his spectacles up his nose.

“The municipal form says:

‘So-and-so, together with family, resides at this address as tenant.’

That is the sentence I certify.

If I write something different, they will ask for another verification.”

Again Jagdish signed a sentence that was not false.

But it was not complete either.

The depot certificate turned out to be the strangest.

Depot In-Charge Narendra Babu read the notice and laughed heartily.

“Now the government is treating a guard’s attendance as his home?”

Jagdish said,

“Stop laughing.

Sushma’s scholarship is stuck.”

Narendra Babu became serious.

He brought out the duty order.

It said:

“Mandatory presence on premises from 8:00 p.m. to 5:00 a.m.; leaving the premises during duty hours shall constitute misconduct.”

“Shall I give this?”

Jagdish read the line.

“This is the very line that caused the problem.”

“But what lie should I write?

You are here at night.”

“I guard here.”

“You are here too.”

“I do not sleep.”

Narendra Babu smiled.

“Sometimes your eyes close on the chair.”

Jagdish looked at him.

“Shall we put that in the certificate too?”

Both laughed.

But Jagdish’s laughter shortened when he remembered Sushma’s fee.

In the end Narendra Babu wrote:

“Shri Jagdish Paswan is a contractual night guard. His night presence is purely work-related; the depot premises are not his residential address.”

He attached a copy of the duty order beneath it.

Jagdish returned to the district office with all three certificates.

Premlata read them one by one.

“Village — permanent resident.

Town — residence with family.

Depot — mandatory presence for nine hours at night.”

“And below it says the depot is not my residential address,” Jagdish said.

“Yes.

But the integrated system reads the principal line.

The remark has to be opened separately.”

“Then why is the remark there?”

Premlata said nothing.

She scanned all three papers.

The red marks on the screen did not turn green.

Instead a new message appeared:

“Physical verification required due to multi-location claim.”

Jagdish kept looking at the screen.

“I have given proof from all three places.

Now they will go to all three and look again?”

“More or less.”

“On the same day?”

“The teams may be different.”

“Do I have to be there too?”

“It is better if the person is found during verification.”

Jagdish laughed.

“Then you will have to cut me into three pieces.”

This time Premlata laughed.

Then immediately became serious again.

“You do not have to sit in all three places.

A family member or relevant person can confirm.”

“Does the system understand that too?”

Premlata did not answer.

The verification took place on Wednesday.

Jagdish had not been told the date in advance.

The rule was that surprise inspection was considered more reliable.

The team reached the village at half past ten.

Dulari Devi was in the courtyard.

“Where is Jagdish?” the verifier asked.

“He has gone to town.”

“Does he live here?”

“His home is here.”

“Where does he live now?”

Dulari Devi tried to understand the difference between the questions.

“His work is in town.

At night he stays at the depot.

When he is free, he comes here.”

The verifier wrote:

“Person absent at time of visit; family states work location in urban area.”

Dulari Devi said,
 "Write absent.
 But the house is his."
 The verifier smiled.
 "Mother, I am writing what I saw."
 The team reached the rented room in town at two.
 Devki was inside.
 Sushma was at college.
 "Jagdish Paswan?"
 "He has gone towards the depot."
 "So early?"
 His duty starts at eight, doesn't it?"
 "He had market work first, then some office papers to deal with."
 "Does he live here regularly?"
 Irritation came over Devki's face.
 "What does regularly mean?"
 He pays the rent.
 He brings some of the provisions.
 He eats here two or three times a week.
 He has night guard duty, so how can he stay here at night?"
 The verifier wrote:
 "Person absent at time of visit; wife states nighttime residence at workplace."
 By then Devki understood that the sentence could go in the wrong direction.
 "Not nighttime residence.
 Duty."
 The verifier struck a line through "residence" and wrote "presence."
 The crossed-out word remained legible.
 The third team reached the Agricultural Depot at four.
 Ramcharit, the day watchman, was at the gate.
 "Jagdish Paswan?"
 "He comes at eight at night."
 "Now?"
 "Not now."
 "Does he live here?"
 Ramcharit laughed.
 "Until five in the morning.
 Then he leaves."
 "Residence?"
 "What residence?"
 A gate, a chair, a lantern, a key."
 The verifier looked inside the small guard room.
 There was a cot.
 But sacks containing grain samples were stacked on it.
 "Does he sleep here?"

"If it rains very heavily, sometimes he leans back for a couple of hours. He also has to make rounds during duty."

The report recorded:

"Person absent at time of visit; no permanent evidence of premises being used residentially."

That Wednesday night Jagdish signed at the gate at eight, as usual.

He had already received news of all three inspections in separate phone calls.

His mother said,

"I told them the house is yours."

Devki said,

"They were writing night duty as residence."

Narendra Babu said,

"The team came during the day and asked where the night guard was."

Jagdish sat in the gate chair and laughed for a long time.

Ramcharit could not understand.

"What happened?"

"All day people looked for me in three places.

They did not find me in any of them."

"But you are here now."

"I am here now.

Tomorrow the report will understand."

Three days later Premlata Jha telephoned.

"Come to the office once."

"Has the scholarship opened?"

"Not yet."

When Jagdish arrived, the red marks on the screen had turned yellow.

At the top it said:

"Residential presence unverified."

Jagdish read slowly.

"First I was in three places.

Now I am nowhere?"

Premlata leaned back in her chair.

"The reports say you were absent at all three places at the time of visit."

"If the team had told me the time, they would have found me."

"The rule requires surprise verification."

"Does sudden life also run according to rules?"

Premlata was silent.

She opened all three reports.

Village — absent.

Town — absent.

Depot — absent.

Different employees had written the three reports.

Yet the sentences were almost identical.

"The strange thing," Premlata said, "is that earlier the system said you were in three places at the same time.

After verification it says you are nowhere.”

Jagdish said,

“Between those places I am often on the bus.

Perhaps the bus is my permanent home.”

Premlata smiled.

“Do not say that.

If the transport register gets linked, a fourth place will open.”

For the first time both laughed openly.

When the laughter ended, Sushma’s scholarship returned to the table.

“Deadline?” Premlata asked.

“Twelve days.”

Premlata looked again at the details of the three sources.

This time she read the names of the fields, not merely their values.

In the village family register, the column was:

“Permanent Family Affiliation.”

In the municipal survey:

“Current Family Address.”

In the depot register:

“Mandatory Presence During Duty Hours.”

The integrated system had extracted only the final concepts—

“presence,”

“address,”

“resident”—

and placed all three in one category.

She called Assistant Officer Ratanmohan Mishra.

Ratanmohan was fifty-five and read rules so habitually that people sometimes thought him timid.

In truth, he tried to see the possible consequences of a paper before they arrived.

Premlata showed him the three lines.

“The meanings of the sources are different.

The integration has made the categories one.”

Ratanmohan removed his spectacles and placed them on the desk.

“This scheme works on the principle of one person — one current address.”

“The current address can be the town.

The village is the permanent family address.

The depot is work-related presence.”

“There is no option called ‘work-related presence’ in the system.”

“Then why is the depot source being included in residence matching at all?”

Ratanmohan looked at the screen.

“The District Information Cell added all ‘person-presence sources.’

Perhaps because it saw the word presence.”

Jagdish spoke from between them.

“My job requires me to be present at night.

That means I am also required to be absent from home at night.”

Ratanmohan looked at him.

The sentence was perhaps clearer than the rulebook.

“Are you prepared to treat the town address as your current address?”

Jagdish said,

“Devki and Sushma live there.

I am there during the day sometimes, sometimes I go to the village, and at night I am on duty.

If you want to call it current, call it current.”

“And the village family register?”

“My mother is alone there.

The ancestral house, land, ration records—all are there.

It would not be right to remove my name.”

“No removal is necessary,” Premlata said.

“It can remain as permanent family affiliation.”

Ratanmohan frowned.

“Through a manual remark?”

“Yes.”

“The next integration will raise the red mark again.”

“Then send the Information Cell a request to change the source category.”

Ratanmohan exhaled lightly.

“For one scholarship, change an entire source category?”

Premalata answered directly.

“One scholarship made the error visible.

The error is not confined to one family.”

She opened the list behind the third red marker.

There were forty-two people in the district with the same problem:

night guards,

hospital attendants,

hostel staff,

pump operators,

railway night workers—

people whose work-related night presence had been linked as a residence source.

Ratanmohan’s face changed.

This was no longer merely Jagdish’s private difficulty.

“Why were the forty-two not checked earlier?”

Premalata said,

“The one whose benefit got blocked came here.

The others may be on their way.”

Ratanmohan sat upright.

“Write to the Information Cell.

For this case, make a manual decision now.

But the reason must be clear.”

Premalata opened a file.

She wrote the heading:

“Regarding Separation of Residential and Work-Related Presence Sources.”

Jagdish looked at the long heading.

“Will my daughter be able to study because of that line?”

“After that line, four signatures are required.”

Jagdish did not laugh.

By now he had learned the arithmetic of the office.

The first signature was Ratanmohan’s.

The second from the Scheme Branch.

The third from the Scholarship Branch.

The fourth, approval from the Information Cell.

The problem was that the Information Cell replied:

“Change of source category is a systemic matter; deferred until the next update.”

The scholarship deadline was nine days away.

Premlata looked for another route.

In the rules she found a line:

“In the event of a clear source discrepancy, the competent authority may accept a certified current family address and restore provisional eligibility.”

Ratanmohan said,

“The competent authority is the Deputy Director.”

The Deputy Director sat at district headquarters two days a week.

His next sitting was five days away.

Jagdish waited five days.

Meanwhile Sushma kept asking the college about the fee deadline.

Devki said,

“If necessary, borrow from the moneylender.”

Jagdish refused.

Last year’s debt was still not fully repaid.

From the village, Dulari Devi said,

“Sell the paddy I have left.”

Jagdish refused that too.

There was irritation inside him because the money was stuck.

But more humiliating than the money was the fact that although every paper was correct, he had to explain the geography of his own life.

The day the Deputy Director came, the office was crowded.

Jagdish arrived early in the morning.

Premlata had prepared the file:

three certificates,

three site-verification reports,

the source-category table,

the scholarship deadline,

and the list of forty-two similar cases.

Deputy Director Arunesh Jha stopped at one point as he read.

“The person was absent in all three verifications?”

“Yes,” Jagdish said.

“Then how is the current address established?”

Premlata answered,

“Through family, tenancy, and daily activity.

A site visit captures only the moment of the day.”

Arunesh Jha asked Jagdish,

“Where do you usually sleep at night?”

Jagdish remained silent for a moment.

The question was simple.

But the answer could again become paper.

“On nights when I am on duty, sleeping at the depot is not permitted.

I remain on the chair.

At dawn I go sometimes to town, sometimes to the village.

On my day off, I am at home.”

“Which home?”

Jagdish looked at the Deputy Director’s face.

“That is the very question everyone has been asking for six days.”

A faint silence settled over the room.

Arunesh Jha was not offended.

He read the file again.

He wrote:

“Permanent family location: village.

Current family location: town.

Work-related presence: depot.

These shall be treated as three distinct categories.

Scholarship eligibility restored immediately.

Information Cell to examine exclusion of work-related sources from residence matching.”

He signed it.

Jagdish was astonished that what he had said in one sentence on the first day had required nine days, three certificates, three inspections, five offices, and forty-two similar people before it could reach the paper.

When the order reached the Scholarship Branch, one more difficulty arose.

The system still showed a yellow marker.

The employee said,

“Payment cannot move until the digital hold is removed.”

Premlata went herself to the branch carrying a copy of the order.

“The rules allow manual restoration.”

The employee opened the book.

They found the line.

He said,

“All right.

But reason code?”

“Source discrepancy.”

“That code is not in the list.

There is ‘Address Incomplete,’ ‘Family Change,’ ‘Duplicate Record,’ and ‘Other.’”

Premlata selected:

“Other.”

Jagdish thought that his entire life had finally fitted into “Other.”

Two days later Sushma’s scholarship money reached the college account.

She telephoned and said only,

“Babu, it is done.”

There was relief in her voice.

Not victory.

Jagdish was at the depot gate.

“Concentrate on your studies,” he said.

Then put the phone back in his pocket.

The matter could have ended there.

But the flaw in the integrated system was not confined to Jagdish’s file.

Premlata kept working through the list of forty-two cases.

In some, the source was hospital night duty.

In others, hostel watch duty.

In others, night presence at an irrigation pump.

In all of them, the word “presence” had been pulled into the system as though it meant residence.

Three weeks later, the Information Cell released a correction.

“Presence” arriving from work-related registers would no longer be included in residence matching.

Old records would be matched again.

Premlata telephoned Jagdish.

“Your yellow marker has disappeared.”

“Where am I now?”

“Village: permanent family.

Town: current family.

Depot: work-related.”

“Three lines?”

“Three lines.

But one person.”

Jagdish was silent for a few moments.

“Could this not have been understood earlier?”

Premlata said,

“The system counted words.

Not meanings.”

That evening Jagdish went to the rented room in town.

Sushma was putting the scholarship receipt inside a book.

Devki had put lentils on the stove.

Jagdish ate.

At 7:20 he left.

He walked to the bus stand, then took a shared vehicle.

At 8:02 he reached the Agricultural Depot gate and signed the attendance register.

His name appeared only once against the time.

Far away in the village, Dulari Devi was putting out the hearth.

In the town room, Sushma sat down with her book open.

At the depot gate, Jagdish fastened the key at his waist and rose to make his first round.

The papers now had separate names for all three places.

Jagdish, at that moment, was in only one.

STORY 162

THE OPEN BRANCH IN A CLOSED ROOM

In the old building of the District Integrated Certificate Centre, Room Number Twenty-Seven stood at the end of the last corridor.

Above its door hung a tin board:

“Family-Dependent Certificate Branch.”

Below the board was a wooden doorframe, an iron cupboard on the left, and three desks on the right.

Three employees sat there every day:

Senior Assistant Naresh Jha,

Clerk Revati Kumari,

and Digital Assistant Chandan Paswan.

But on the building’s fire-safety plan, the space where Room Twenty-Seven should have been was marked by a black square.

Inside the square were the words:

“PERMANENTLY CLOSED.”

For a long time, no one noticed the contradiction.

The employees thought of the fire-safety plan merely as a coloured sheet hanging at the turn of the staircase.

Visitors looked at the branch sign.

The certificates did not carry a room number.

So the work continued.

One Monday morning a fire-safety inspection team arrived.

The team consisted of Deputy Fire Officer Nirmal Singh, Building Branch Engineer Ashutosh Mishra, and District Office Administrative Assistant Meena Jha.

They were to reconcile the rooms, exits, fire extinguishers, and electrical points with the building plan.

As they matched the first-floor plan, room by room, the team reached the final corridor.

Nirmal Singh placed a finger on the plan.

“There is no room ahead here.”

Meena Jha looked straight in front of her.

The door was open.

Inside, Revati was reading an elderly woman’s papers.

Chandan had an application open on his computer screen.

Naresh was closing the stamp box.

Ashutosh Mishra looked again at the plan.

“Room Twenty-Seven is permanently closed.”

Naresh smiled.

“The door is open.”

Nirmal Singh did not smile.

“It is closed on the plan.”

The elderly woman sitting before Revati, Chameli Devi, began looking from one person to another.

Her husband had been an attendant at a Panchayat school.

After his death, she needed a dependent-family certificate for settlement of the remaining service dues.

Revati gathered the papers and said,

“Please remain seated.

It is an inspection.”

Chameli Devi asked softly,

“Have I come to the wrong room?”

Before answering, Revati looked at the plan.

“Your work is in the correct room,” she said.

Nirmal Singh measured the width of the doorway.

Then he examined the windows inside.

One window was half blocked with bricks.

Outside the second was an old iron grille.

“Rear exit?”

Naresh said,

“There is none.”

“That may be why the room was marked closed.”

Ashutosh Mishra opened the old building register.

He found a repair note from five years earlier:

“Room 27 in western wing out of use until fire-exit improvement.”

“Was the improvement carried out?” Nirmal Singh asked.

Naresh looked towards the corner of the ceiling.

“I have been here three years.”

Revati said,

“I have been sitting here four years.”

Chandan said,

“Since my appointment.”

Ashutosh Mishra checked the date of the remark.

“So the branch continued operating here even after the room was marked out of use.”

Meena Jha asked,

“When did the branch move here?”

Naresh tried to remember.

The branch had originally been in Room Fourteen.

During the rains, the roof leaked.

After papers were soaked one year, the officer then in charge made an oral arrangement for the branch to sit in Room Twenty-Seven for seven days.

Seven days had become three years.

“Written relocation order?” Meena asked.

Naresh shook his head.

“None found.”

“Then how are all of you here?”

Naresh looked around.

Three desks.
 Five cupboards.
 Computers connected by wires.
 Stamps.
 Receipt registers.
 A holiday list on the wall.
 "By continuing to work."
 Nirmal Singh wrote on a small sheet:
 "Unauthorised occupancy."

The two words entered the room like a fourth employee who had suddenly come and taken a seat.

Chameli Devi placed a hand over her file.
 "Babu, will this affect my papers?"
 Naresh answered at once,
 "No."

Nirmal Singh looked at him.
 "Do not issue the certificate yet.
 The safety position must first be clarified."
 Chameli Devi's face fell.

Revati said,
 "Her application has been complete for three weeks.
 Today is only the final reconciliation."

"I am not ordering that a citizen's application be stopped," Nirmal Singh said.

"I am questioning the use of the room."
 Naresh said quietly,
 "Our work happens in the room."
 "Then shift the work temporarily elsewhere."
 "Where?"

No one on the inspection team had an answer.
 The team moved on.

Chameli Devi asked,
 "Should I come again tomorrow?"
 Revati opened her papers.

"No.
 Sit."

Naresh wanted to say something, but Revati placed the final page of the application in front of him.

"All the proofs are complete."
 Naresh read the file.
 The school's death notification.
 Family register.
 Bank details.
 Panchayat verification.
 Everything was correct.
 He signed.

Chandan generated the digital certificate.

The seal was affixed.

Chameli Devi took the paper in both hands.

At the top was the District Officer's emblem.

Below it, the branch's digital number.

"This is valid, isn't it?"

Naresh said,

"Yes."

Revati's eyes moved to the fire-safety plan hanging outside the doorway.

That afternoon an administrative meeting was held.

The problem was put in simple words:

"A branch is operating in a room marked closed on the safety plan."

The solution to the simple sentence was not simple.

The Building Branch said that changing the plan required improvement of the fire exit, electrical testing, wall measurements, and fresh approval.

The Accounts Branch said there was no money left that year for building improvement.

General Administration said there was no alternative room to move the branch into.

Ramanath Chaudhary, In-Charge of the Integrated Certificate Centre, said,

"Then the branch will continue here, but the status of the room will be treated as temporary."

Ashutosh Mishra asked,

"For how many days is temporary?"

Ramanath Chaudhary said,

"Until an alternative arrangement is made."

"There has been no alternative arrangement for three years."

"So the temporary period is long."

No one laughed.

At last an order was drafted:

"The Family-Dependent Certificate Branch shall continue to function as before as a temporary work point.

Room 27 shall not be treated as part of the building's permanent occupancy."

Naresh read the order.

"The work will remain.

The room will not."

Revati said,

"And us?"

"We will remain with the work."

Chandan laughed.

"And the chairs?"

Naresh read the second line:

"No increase in permanent furniture shall be made."

From that day, the life of Room Twenty-Seven changed.

The work did not.

The first problem was the fan.

The fan on the right began groaning as it turned.

Revati submitted a slip to the Building Maintenance Branch.

The next day it came back:

“Room 27 not included in permanent occupancy list; asset number unavailable.”

Revati placed the slip on Naresh’s desk.

“Will the fan give temporary air too?”

Naresh brought an old table fan from home.

The second problem was the fire extinguisher.

The inspection team had said an additional extinguisher was required near the room.

Stores wrote:

“Separate extinguisher cannot be issued for a closed room.”

Nirmal Singh’s objection remained.

A solution was found.

The extinguisher was issued in the name of the corridor and placed beside the door of Room Twenty-Seven.

Chandan read its label:

“Western Corridor — One.”

“Everything we have is in someone else’s name,” he said.

Revati replied,

“Only the certificates are in our own name.”

That was true.

On paper, the office code of the Family-Dependent Certificate Branch was valid.

The digital signature was valid.

The seal was valid.

Certificates issued by it were instantly verifiable on the state verification network.

Only the branch’s physical location was unclear.

Two weeks later, that uncertainty returned with Chameli Devi.

The Treasury had accepted her certificate.

But the school’s service-settlement branch demanded additional site verification because the “Office Contact” list printed on the back of the certificate had no room number for the Family-Dependent Certificate Branch.

Chameli Devi came again.

“You said the paper was correct.

Now they are asking where it came from.”

Revati checked the certificate’s digital number.

A green mark appeared on the screen:

“VALID.”

“The problem is not with the certificate.”

Chameli Devi said wearily,

“Then is the problem with me?”

“No.”

“Then whose?”

Revati looked at the plan outside the door.

“The place.”

Chameli Devi asked again,

“Is the place wrong or the paper?”

Revati did not answer.

Naresh wrote a verification letter:

“Certificate No. ... has been issued by the authorised Family-Dependent Certificate Branch of this Centre.”

Chameli Devi asked,

“Room number?”

Naresh’s pen stopped.

According to the order, Room Twenty-Seven was not to be treated as part of permanent occupancy.

If Naresh wrote the room number while sitting in that very room, he would contradict the order.

If he did not, the verification would remain incomplete.

He wrote:

“Western wing, temporary work point.”

Chameli Devi read the line.

“Where is that?”

Naresh pointed towards the doorway.

“Here.”

“Then why is there no number?”

Naresh tried to smile.

“A number is a very permanent thing.”

Chameli Devi did not laugh.

She had to catch the bus to the school.

A month later came the day of the fire-safety drill.

At 12:10 the alarm rang.

All employees were to reach the open ground by the nearest safe route.

Revati closed two visitors’ files like Chameli Devi’s and stood up.

Chandan tried to shut down the computer.

Naresh said,

“Leave it.

It is only a drill.”

All three went out through the corridor.

In the field, counting began branch by branch.

Room Fourteen — four.

Room Fifteen — five.

Accounts Branch — seven.

Receipt — three.

The Family-Dependent Certificate Branch did not appear on the list.

Revati went to Meena Jha.

"Where do the three of us get counted?"

Meena checked the list.

"Your posts are under the Integrated Certificate Centre."

"Then count us in the Centre."

The Centre's list contained all three names.

But against the location it said:

"Room Fourteen"—

the old branch location.

The In-Charge of Room Fourteen said,

"They do not sit there."

Nirmal Singh stood in the middle of the ground reconciling the total.

According to the employee register:

fifty-seven.

In the field:

sixty.

"Why are there three extra?"

Meena Jha looked at Naresh, Revati, and Chandan.

"These three are from the temporary work point."

"Which work point?"

"Western wing."

Nirmal Singh stopped his pencil on the drill sheet.

"On the plan, that room in the western wing is closed."

Naresh said,

"Then perhaps the three of us are extra."

Nirmal Singh looked at him.

This time his face carried something that might have been laughter or fatigue.

"In a fire, there are no extra people," he said.

For the first time in the entire matter, the sentence sounded to Naresh more like something about human beings than about rules.

The drill report stated:

"Three unlisted occupants found during evacuation count."

For two days the phrase "unlisted occupants" circulated through the office.

Chandan pasted a paper label on his tea cup:

"UNLISTED OCCUPANT 3."

Revati said,

"Joke less.

The report may get the branch closed again."

"It is already closed on the plan."

"The work may be closed."

The weight of that possibility fell on everyone at once.

An average of fifty-eight applications reached the branch each day.

Widow assistance.

Service settlement.

Scholarships.

Dependent appointments.

Family payments.

Many kinds of work depended on that certificate.

If the branch was closed, no one knew where people would go.

At the next meeting, three proposals were made.

First:

temporarily run the branch from the veranda.

Nirmal Singh said,

“The veranda is an evacuation route.

No desks there.”

Second:

divide the three employees among separate rooms.

Revati asked,

“Will a visitor go through three rooms for one application?”

Third:

correct the plan for Room Twenty-Seven.

The Building Branch raised the budget issue again.

Ramanath Chaudhary held his head.

“Such a large question for one small branch?”

Nirmal Singh said calmly,

“The question is not the size of the branch.

Fire does not come after reading a plan.”

The meeting was silent for a while.

At last a fourth possibility emerged.

Below the brick-blocked rear window of Room Twenty-Seven, the outline of an old service door was discovered.

On an older building plan, a small door opening outward had once existed there.

Later, when the area behind it was converted into storage, the door had been bricked up.

Ashutosh Mishra said,

“If we reopen this exit, carry out an electrical test, and correct the doorway width, the room can be brought back into the occupancy list.”

Ramanath Chaudhary asked,

“How much will it cost?”

The amount was not as much as everyone had imagined.

The problem was not the money.

It was the heading under which approval would be sought.

If money was requested for repair of a closed room, the question would arise:

why repair a closed room?

If repair of an operating branch was written, the question would arise:

where is the branch on the plan?

Three days were spent only on the heading of the proposal.

At last Revati suggested one line:

“Restoration of Evacuation Route and Workplace Safety Improvement in Western Wing.”

The heading mentioned neither Room Twenty-Seven nor the branch.
 The proposal was approved.
 For two weeks, work continued amid hammers, dust, and bricks.
 The employees sat in one half of Room Twenty-Seven during the day.
 Masons worked in the other.

Visitors asked,
 “Is the branch closed?”

Revati said,
 “No.

The wall is opening.”

Chandan said,

“In an office, the difference between those two things is difficult to understand.”

On the day the new exit door opened, direct air entered the room for the first time.

Sitting in his chair, Naresh could see the leaves of the neem tree outside.

For four years, sky had existed behind that wall.

On the branch’s papers, it had only been a closed portion.

Nirmal Singh returned for inspection.

He measured the doorway.

Checked the electrical-test report.

Read the date on the fire extinguisher.

“Now the plan will change,” he said.

Meena Jha brought the draft of the new plan.

The black square was gone.

Room Twenty-Seven appeared in clear lines.

Inside, in small letters:

“Family-Dependent Certificate Branch.”

Revati kept looking at the plan.

“Do we exist now?”

Nirmal Singh said,

“You do on the plan.”

Chandan asked,

“And before?”

Nirmal Singh thought for a few moments.

“Before, you did not exist in the fire-safety register.”

Naresh laughed.

“And all the certificates?”

“They were valid under their own rules.”

The answer was like the whole affair:

correct,

but not comforting.

That afternoon Chameli Devi came to the branch for the third time.

This time she carried no file.

Only a small paper bag.

The school dues had been released.

She had brought jaggery.
Revati refused to accept it.
Chameli Devi said,
“Then all of you share it.
My work is done.”

Outside the door she saw the new plan.
“Now the number is written here too.”
Naresh said,
“Yes.”

Chameli Devi laughed.
“Good.

Last time I went home and told my son:
the paper is correct, but the place it came from is temporary.
He said, ‘Mother, what kind of thing is that?’
What could I explain?”
She left.

In the evening Revati asked for a ladder to take down the old fire-safety plan.

The Building Branch employee said,
“Do not throw away the old plan.
It has to be deposited for the record.”
The sheet with the black square was carefully folded.
Across the top, in pencil, someone wrote:
“Previous position.”

Chandan kept looking at it.
“In the previous position the room was closed.”

Revati said,
“But we were working there.”
Naresh stood for a few moments holding the old plan.
“So was the paper wrong?” Chandan asked.
Naresh shook his head.
“No.

It was incomplete.”
“An incomplete paper ran the whole building for four years.”

Naresh placed the old plan inside the records envelope.

“In an office, sometimes the incomplete statement is treated as the most complete of all.”

The next morning Room Twenty-Seven opened on time.

One leaf of the doorway was old.

The other was the new exit.

Inside, all three employees sat at their own desks.

The first visitor was a young man.

He carried an application for a dependent certificate after his father’s death.

He looked at the new plan outside.

Then at the sign above the doorway.

“Is the Family-Dependent Branch here?”

Revati said,

“Yes.

Here.”

The young man entered and sat down.

He asked for no proof that the room really existed.

STORY 163

A SECOND NAME FOR PRONUNCIATION

When a new voice-based attendance machine was installed at the District Rural Water Quality Office, the first thing people gave it was not their faces, but their voices.

The device looked like a small black box on a table.

A green light sat on top.

Beside it was a tiny microphone opening.

Every morning, employees had to stand before it and say their name and employee number.

The trainer had instructed them:

“Say your name exactly as it appears in your service book.”

On the first day, the rule seemed simple to everyone.

“Madhukar Mishra, Employee Number One Hundred Forty-Nine.”

The green light came on.

“Usha Kumari, Employee Number Two Hundred Thirteen.”

The green light came on.

When his turn came, Kshemnarayan Jha stepped forward.

“Kshemnarayan Jha, Employee Number Four Hundred Seventy-Two.”

The black box remained silent for two seconds.

Then a small voice said:

“Name does not match. Please repeat.”

Kshemnarayan tried again.

“Kshemnarayan Jha. Employee Number Four Hundred Seventy-Two.”

This time the machine displayed:

“Sem Narayan Ja.”

A smile appeared on Madhukar’s face behind him.

Kshemnarayan turned.

Madhukar suppressed it.

On the third attempt the machine produced:

“Chhem Narayan Jha.”

On the fourth:

“Semnarayan Ja.”

On the fifth attempt the machine said:

“Attempt limit exceeded.”

That day a red mark appeared beside Kshemnarayan’s name in the attendance register:

“UNVERIFIED.”

Kshemnarayan was fifty-one years old.

His name had been the same in his service book since the day of his first appointment.

The same on his school certificate.

The same on his bank papers.

The same on his voter slip.
 He had never considered his name difficult.
 The problem belonged, for the first time, to a machine.
 But in an office, whoever owns the problem, the form is always filled by a human being.
 That afternoon Meena Jha of the Administration Branch said,
 "The trainer is still here for two days.
 Your name sample can be given again."
 Kshemnarayan went to the training room.
 There, Amarjeet, a machine-support assistant from Patna, sat with a computer open.
 "Say your name."
 Kshemnarayan said it.
 Amarjeet watched the screen.
 "It is getting stuck on 'Kshe.'"
 "I am not getting stuck."
 Amarjeet did not laugh.
 He was accustomed to such answers.
 "For machine training, we can keep an easier pronunciation.
 Your name will not change.
 It is only a voice cue."
 "What is easier?"
 "Whatever the machine captures clearly."
 Amarjeet made him say "Kshemnarayan" three times.
 Then:
 "Semnarayan."
 On the second form, the green line steadied.
 "This works."
 Kshemnarayan asked,
 "But that is not my name."
 "Not the name.
 A pronunciation aid.
 An internal technical marker.
 It will not appear anywhere outside."
 Amarjeet opened a field:
 "Simplified Pronunciation."
 He typed:
 "Sem Narayan Jha."
 "Now say it:
 Sem Narayan Jha."
 Kshemnarayan remained silent for a moment.
 Two employees were waiting behind him.
 He said softly,
 "Sem Narayan Jha."
 The green light came on.
 Amarjeet said,

“See?

Problem solved.”

The next morning Kshemnarayan stood before the machine.

“Sem Narayan Jha, Employee Number Four Hundred Seventy-Two.”

“Attendance recorded.”

It had never worked so quickly before.

He went to his desk and opened his papers.

By ten o'clock it occurred to him that, for the first time, he had entered the office without saying his own name.

For two weeks the system worked well.

Every morning the machine turned green when it heard “Sem Narayan Jha.”

In the evening too.

Kshemnarayan's colleagues did not begin calling him “Sem Babu” as a joke.

After the first two days, the teasing disappeared.

Once a machine accepts something, people seldom continue making fun of it for long.

At the end of the month, the payroll statement was prepared.

Accounts Assistant Chandramohan called Kshemnarayan over.

“You have twenty-nine days' attendance and one day of leave.”

“Correct.”

“But the name in the payroll does not match.”

“Which name?”

Chandramohan turned the screen towards him.

In the line imported from the attendance system it said:

“Sem Narayan Jha.”

In the salary register:

“Kshemnarayan Jha.”

The employee number in both was 472.

Chandramohan said,

“The number is the same.

Even so, the name match is red.”

“It was only the simplified pronunciation.”

“Easy or difficult, it has arrived here as a name.”

“The machine assistant said it would never appear outside.”

“He was looking at attendance.

I am looking at payroll.”

Meena Jha was called again.

She examined the technical details.

“It appears the pronunciation field is being pulled into the main-name position when the monthly attendance register is generated.”

Kshemnarayan asked,

“What does that sentence mean in Maithili?”

Meena thought for a moment.

“The name meant to stay inside has come outside.”

“And my real name?”

“That is inside too.”

“Both are inside?”

“Yes.

But in different places.”

The salary was not stopped.

Chandramohan manually reconciled the record.

But the problem did not end.

The following week a training certificate arrived:

“Sem Narayan Jha.”

Then came an order for a clean-water sample camp:

“Shri Sem Narayan Jha is nominated for Benipatti Block.”

Kshemnarayan signed beneath the order:

“Kshemnarayan Jha.”

The order came back.

The remark said:

“Name of signatory differs from name of nominated employee.”

He went to Meena.

“Now what?”

Meena looked at the order.

“We will have to certify once that both names refer to the same person.”

“Both names?”

“For the time being.”

“A permanent certificate for a temporary name?”

Meena remained silent.

Sometimes in an office, the question is correct.

There is simply no field for its answer.

A “Same Person Certificate” was prepared.

At the top it said:

“This is to certify that Shri Kshemnarayan Jha, Employee No. 472, and the person recorded in the voice-attendance system as ‘Sem Narayan Jha’ are one and the same person.”

Below it:

the signature of the Administrative Officer.

Seal.

Date.

Kshemnarayan stood for a long time looking at the paper in his hand.

He remembered his marriage certificate.

Appointment letter.

Caste certificate.

Bank papers.

For the first time, he possessed a document proving that he was not someone different from himself.

The camp order was issued again.

This time the name read:

“Kshemnarayan Jha (Voice Name: Sem Narayan Jha).”

The bracket was small.

But on the next order it grew slightly larger.

The office clerk thought that if the bracket were omitted, the attendance reconciliation might turn red again.

Three months later, the problem reached the bank.

The digital payroll list carried the employee number together with the name.

The bank system treated “Sem Narayan Jha” and the account-holder “Kshemnarayan Jha” as two different people.

That month his salary was not credited for five days.

Kshemnarayan went to the bank.

The young man at the counter said,

“Correct the name.”

“Where?”

“Wherever it is wrong.”

“Which one is wrong?”

The young man examined both papers.

“In the bank it is this:

Kshemnarayan.

From the office it has come as:

Sem Narayan.”

“The bank one is correct.”

“Then the office has to correct it.”

The office said:

“Bring a bank letter.”

The bank said:

“Bring an office letter.”

He had both.

Even so, each kept asking for the other’s proof.

On the sixth day Kshemnarayan pulled a chair into the Administration Branch and sat down.

Meena asked,

“Aren’t you going to the field today?”

“My salary has not come.

I am running short of bus fare.”

Hearing that, Meena immediately opened the system.

“I am making the original name primary again.”

“Then attendance?”

“Let us see.”

She emptied the “Simplified Pronunciation” field.

The next morning Kshemnarayan stood before the machine.

“Kshemnarayan Jha, Employee Number Four Hundred Seventy-Two.”

“Name does not match.”

Second attempt.

“Name does not match.”

Third.

“Attempt limit exceeded.”
 Meena said,
 “The name survived.
 Attendance disappeared.”
 Chandramohan said,
 “If attendance survives, the payroll name disappears.”
 Amarjeet was telephoned.
 He was now training staff in another district.
 “The simplified-pronunciation field is only supposed to be a supporting
 cue for voice recognition,” he said.
 Meena replied,
 “Here it is becoming the primary name and going outside.”
 Amarjeet was silent for a while.
 “It must be an older version.”
 Kshemnarayan was sitting beside Meena.
 He asked,
 “Who am I in the older version?”
 Meena gestured for him to remain quiet.
 Amarjeet continued:
 “Make a separate mapping table.
 Keep the employee number as the primary identity.
 The name-match block can be disabled.”
 After the call ended, Meena said,
 “There is a solution.”
 “What?”
 “Link everything through the number instead of the name.”
 Kshemnarayan laughed.
 “The number was there from the beginning.”
 “Yes.
 But the system was checking the name too.”
 “And now?”
 “Now it will see the name.
 But it will not believe it.”
 A new mapping table was built over two days.
 One row:
 Employee Number: 472.
 Service-Book Name: Kshemnarayan Jha.
 Voice Cue: Sem Narayan Jha.
 Payroll Name: Kshemnarayan Jha.
 Bank Name: Kshemnarayan Jha.
 Kshemnarayan looked at the row.
 “How many names do I have now?”
 Meena said,
 “One.
 The others are paths to identification.”
 “It is written four times on the paper.”

“So that it does not become one in the wrong way again.”

His salary was credited on the seventh day.

A message came from the bank.

Kshemnarayan read it while drinking tea.

Then put the phone down.

That day he had to collect two water samples in the field.

It was time to catch the bus.

The attendance machine at the gate had been connected to the new mapping table.

When he returned in the evening, he stood before it.

“Sem Narayan Jha, Employee Number Four Hundred Seventy-Two.”

The green light came on.

This time the screen displayed:

“Kshemnarayan Jha — Departure Recorded.”

For the first time he paused and looked at both names together.

One was for an ear.

The other for paper.

He said nothing.

The following month a new employee arrived:

Richa Karn.

On her first morning the machine wrote her name three different ways.

The Junior Assistant supervising training opened the “Simplified Pronunciation” field.

“Shall I write an easier form of your name?”

Richa Karn looked at him.

“An easier name?”

“For the machine.”

Kshemnarayan was standing behind her in the queue.

He pointed towards the new mapping table on the desk.

“Leave the name exactly as it is there.

Put the voice cue in the separate field.”

The assistant looked at the table.

Its headings had recently been changed.

First field:

“Authorised Name.”

Second:

“Voice Cue; Not a Name.”

Richa said her name again.

The machine misheard it again.

The assistant entered a short phonetic form in the voice-cue field.

He did not touch the authorised name.

When Kshemnarayan’s turn came, he stepped forward.

He said:

“Sem Narayan Jha.”

The machine turned green.

The screen flashed:

“Kshemnarayan Jha.”

Richa, standing behind him, asked,

“Why do you say your name like that?”

Kshemnarayan thought for a moment.

“That is not my name.

It is the machine’s ear.”

He went inside.

His service book lay on the desk.

The name at the top was the same as on the first day of his appointment.

Beside it had arrived the monthly attendance sheet.

The same name was there too.

Only the black box at the gate still turned green when it heard:

“Sem Narayan.”

STORY 164

THE FORM THAT DEMANDS ITS ANSWER IN ADVANCE

On the third day after the new digital form was introduced at the District Cottage Enterprise Assistance Centre, Prabha Devi arrived with the papers of her sewing group.

She carried five receipts, a bank letter, a copy of the group register, repair estimates for two machines, and the signatures of seven members.

She had tied the bundle of papers carefully inside a cloth bag.

There were four desks on the veranda of the assistance centre.

At the first, papers were counted.

At the second, the digital form was filled.

At the third, photocopies were checked.

At the fourth, a receipt was issued for the submitted application.

Prabha Devi passed the first desk and reached the second.

A young clerk named Navalkishore sat there.

The digital form was open on the screen before him.

"Name?"

"Prabha Devi."

"Group?"

"Sakhi Sewing Group."

"Village?"

"Belaura."

Navalkishore filled the fields one after another.

When almost all the details had been entered, a red line flashed on the screen:

"Final Application Number Mandatory."

Navalkishore stopped typing.

"Where is the final application number?" he asked.

Prabha Devi opened her bag.

"Look through these papers.

Whatever you need should be there."

Navalkishore turned over the receipts, examined the bank letter, and looked through the old group register.

"There is no number."

"Who gives the number?"

"The system, after submission."

Prabha Devi looked at him for a few moments.

"Then what do we write before that?"

Navalkishore looked at the screen.

The red line remained.

He tried typing:

"Blank."

The system rejected it.

He typed:

“Pending.”

“Numbers only.”

He entered:

“O.”

“Minimum six digits.”

He leaned back in his chair.

Ram Babu, the Senior Assistant at the first desk, had been watching from a distance.

“Stuck?” he asked.

Navalkishore said,

“It is asking for the final application number before submission.”

Ram Babu answered casually,

“Put in an old cancelled number.”

Navalkishore turned towards him.

“A cancelled number?”

“Yes.

Once the form is submitted, the new number will come.

We can change it later.”

“Whose cancelled number?”

Ram Babu opened a drawer.

Inside was a small notebook.

Numbers were written on its pages:

410231.

410244.

410257.

410271.

Some had black lines beside them.

“These are incomplete applications from last month,” Ram Babu said.

“They were never submitted.

The numbers are lying unused.”

“But the application numbers had already been generated?”

“In the old system, a number was generated as soon as the draft began.

In the new system, it is generated at the end.

The form itself was built from the old fields.”

Navalkishore looked at Prabha Devi’s papers.

“What if this number is still linked to someone’s old application?”

Ram Babu smiled.

“Then why is it marked cancelled?”

The answer sounded logical.

The question remained where it was.

Navalkishore entered:

410257.

The red line turned green.

Prabha Devi asked,

“Is that my number?”

“Not yet.”

“Then whose?”

“For now, no one’s.”

“Then why is it in my form?”

Navalkishore searched for an answer.

Ram Babu had already picked up the next set of papers.

“The system does not like empty spaces,” he said.

Prabha Devi’s application moved forward.

At the third desk, the photocopies were matched.

At the fourth, the Submit button was pressed.

A new number flashed on the screen:

520018.

The receipt printed.

Navalkishore breathed with relief.

“This is your real application number.”

Prabha Devi looked at both numbers.

“The first one?”

“Forget it.”

She folded the receipt and put it in her bag.

Two days later, a digital list arrived from the district office.

The application of Sakhi Sewing Group was described as:

“Revised version of previous application 410257.”

The moment Navalkishore saw the list, he went to Ram Babu.

“Why does it say revised version?”

“Which one?”

“Prabha Devi’s.

The final number is 520018.

But the system is treating it as a revision of 410257.”

Ram Babu opened the notebook.

There was a black line beside 410257.

He turned a page.

The old note read:

“Bamboo Craft Group; documents incomplete; no site inspection.”

Navalkishore’s expression changed.

“Then this number was not empty.”

“The application had been cancelled.”

“The number had not been cancelled.”

Ram Babu said nothing.

By afternoon, the matter had reached Section Officer Sudhanshu Babu.

He opened both digital entries.

The new application was in the name of Prabha Devi.

The old one was in the name of Bhuvaneshwar Mahato.

One was a sewing group.

One a bamboo craft group.

Different villages.

Different banks.
 But the initial number was the same.
 The system had treated both as two stages of one application.
 “Correct it,” Sudhanshu Babu said.
 Navalkishore asked,
 “How?”
 “Make the final number primary.”
 “That field is locked for revision.”
 “Then remove the initial number.”
 “It does not accept blank.”
 “oooooo?”
 Navalkishore tried it.
 The screen displayed:
 “This number is already in use.”
 Everyone looked at one another.
 Ram Babu said softly,
 “Someone found that solution before us.”
 They opened oooooo.
 Twenty-seven applications were linked beneath it.
 One was for a hostel renewal.
 One for beehive boxes.
 One for clay vessels.
 One for a loom.
 All had different final numbers.
 But inside the system, they had become papers of the same family.
 Sudhanshu Babu scratched his head.
 “Then not zero.”
 Ram Babu said,
 “Let us create new temporary numbers.”
 “How?”
 “From our own register.”
 A question rose in Navalkishore’s mind:
 the number the system was supposed to generate would now be assigned by
 employees themselves?
 There was little time for questions.
 The deadline for assistance applications was that week.
 The queue outside the door kept growing.
 Sudhanshu Babu called for a new notebook.
 At the top they wrote:
 “Temporary Entry Number Register.”
 The first number:
 990001.
 Second:
 990002.
 A rule was made:

before an application was submitted, one number would be assigned from this register.

After the final number was generated, the relationship between the two numbers would be recorded.

Navalkishore did not like the arrangement.

But at least the numbers would not repeat.

For the next three days the work moved quickly.

990001 went to a Madhubani painting group.

990002 to a bangle-making cooperative.

990003 to a bamboo basket group.

To free Prabha Devi's application from old number 410257, it too was given:

990004.

Now her papers carried three numbers:

410257,

which she had been told to forget.

520018,

which she had been told was the real one.

990004,

which had been created to correct the mistake.

Prabha Devi came back to the office.

"The bank says the assistance letter has application number 990004.

My receipt says 520018.

Which one should I write?"

Navalkishore said,

"520018 is the final number."

"Then why is the other one on the letter?"

"During the correction, the temporary number became the main number."

"Then which is final?"

No answer came immediately from Navalkishore's mouth.

From a distance Ram Babu said,

"Write both."

Prabha Devi replied,

"The bank has only one field."

For the first time, the problem seemed not to be with paper, but with the width of a box.

Sudhanshu Babu wrote to the bank branch:

"Application 520018, Temporary Entry No. 990004, former technical No. 410257; all three shall be treated as relating to the same current case."

The letter was signed.

Sealed.

Prabha Devi carried it away.

Two days later, the bank replied:

"Among the three numbers, the authorised number may please be identified."

Sudhanshu Babu picked up a red pen.

He underlined:

520018.

Then stopped.

Because in the district list, the application appeared under 990004.

He underlined 990004 as well.

Ram Babu said,

“If you mark two numbers authorised, the bank will ask again.”

Sudhanshu Babu put down the pen.

“Then you tell me.”

Ram Babu did not answer.

Meanwhile, an inspection team arrived.

The team wanted to examine the sequence of applications.

The inspector’s first question was:

“Why are temporary entry numbers being used?”

Sudhanshu Babu said,

“The final number is generated only after submission, but the form requires the final number before it can be submitted.”

The inspector was silent.

He opened the form himself.

The field was indeed there.

“This is a defect in the form.”

For a moment Navalkishore felt hopeful that the matter would now become simple.

The inspector’s next sentence was:

“Even if the form is defective, employees should not create numbers contrary to rules.”

“Then what should we have entered?” Navalkishore asked.

The inspector looked at him.

“The final application number.”

“But that is generated later.”

“Then fill it later.”

“Without filling it, the form cannot be submitted.”

The inspector looked at the screen again.

For a few moments, the only sound in the room was the fan.

At last he said,

“Seek written guidance on the matter.”

A letter seeking guidance was drafted.

In the digital correspondence system, the subject selected was:

“Application-Related Problem.”

Before the letter could be submitted, another field opened:

“Related Final Application Number.”

Navalkishore did not laugh.

Ram Babu did not either.

Sudhanshu Babu rose from his chair and went to the window.

“What number do we enter here?” Navalkishore asked.

No one had an answer.

At last Ram Babu opened the temporary register.

The guidance letter itself was assigned a number:

990028.

The letter was submitted.

Three days later, a reply came from the State Office:

"The current structure of the form shall continue to be used.

Where the final application number is not available, a unique pre-number may be assigned at departmental level.

Pre-numbers shall not be repeated.

After the final number is generated, the relationship between both numbers shall be preserved."

Ram Babu ran a hand over his notebook.

The method that had been called contrary to rules had now become a written rule.

Sudhanshu Babu said,

"Good.

Now it is clear."

Navalkishore asked,

"Will the final number remain primary, or the pre-number?"

They read the reply again.

It did not answer that question.

By then, Prabha Devi's assistance approval had reached the district office.

The letter carried application number 990004.

The bank payment order carried 520018.

The old revision history carried 410257.

Navalkishore placed all three papers in one file.

On top he pasted a white slip:

"ONE CASE — THREE NUMBERS."

When Prabha Devi came, she was told that the first instalment for machine repair had been approved.

She breathed with relief.

"Are the papers complete now?"

"Yes."

"For the next instalment, will I have to write an application number?"

Navalkishore looked for a few moments at the three papers.

Then he wrote all three numbers on a small piece of paper and handed it to her.

"Keep this."

"All three?"

"Yes."

"Which one is real?"

Navalkishore said,

"Whichever paper is in front of you, first write the number printed on that paper.

If another paper asks for another number, show them this slip."

Prabha Devi folded the slip and placed it in the small inner pocket of her bag.

She left.

At the end of the month, a revised version of the form arrived.

Navalkishore opened it eagerly.

Above the “Final Application Number” field, a new field had been added:

“Pre-Number.”

Below it was a help sentence:

“If pre-number is unavailable, obtain it from the office.”

For the first time, Navalkishore felt reassured.

He opened a new application to test the form.

First field:

Pre-Number.

He left it blank.

A red line flashed:

“Pre-Number Mandatory.”

Navalkishore looked at Ram Babu.

Without saying anything, Ram Babu took out the old notebook and placed it on the desk.

STORY 165

THE HALF-DAY EMPLOYEE

Every day Shanti Devi reached the gate of the District Public Service Building at five fifty-five in the morning.

The gate opened at six.

But guard Ramvilas recognised her from a distance and opened the small wicket five minutes early.

Before going inside, Shanti Devi took a pair of thin cloth gloves from her bag, signed her name in the gate register, and then collected the key to the room where the brooms, buckets, and mops were kept.

Her work was for four hours.

At least that was all the paper said.

The building had three floors.

In the morning, it was her responsibility to clean the public-service windows on the first floor, the staircase, both toilets, the officers' veranda, and the visitors' seating area.

By half past nine she would have finished everything and washed the cleaning materials.

At ten she returned the key to Ramvilas.

As soon as ten struck, the building began filling with people.

Mopping among that crowd was impossible.

Shanti Devi did not know who had fixed these hours.

On her first day, the supervisor from the contracting agency had told her:

"Six in the morning to ten.

Finish before people begin arriving."

She had had no reason to ask anything more.

For two years she had been coming at the same time.

At the end of each month, the contracting agency paid her for four hours' labour.

The wage slip said only:

"4 hours."

No clock time.

Once Shanti Devi had turned the slip over and asked the supervisor,

"Why is the time not written here?"

He had laughed.

"Four hours are four hours.

Will your pay change because the clock changes?"

Shanti Devi had laughed too.

On that Tuesday morning, the corridor on the second floor was unusually wet.

During the night, a joint in the pipe connected to the rooftop water tank had loosened.

Water had seeped along the wall and collected in front of the Records Room.

Shanti Devi first placed a bucket beneath the leak.

Then she called Ramvilas.

"We will have to close the main valve upstairs," he said.

"The key?"

"The maintenance babu keeps it."

The maintenance babu came at eight.

Within two minutes, the water had become a stream.

Shanti Devi tried to move three cardboard boxes stored there.

They contained old application forms.

The first box was light.

The second was heavy.

While she was pulling the third, the upper strip of a thin iron rack fixed against the wall came loose and fell.

The strip struck her near the left shoulder.

As she stepped back, she slipped on the wet floor and landed sitting down.

Ramvilas ran over.

"Are you hurt?"

Shanti Devi first moved her shoulder.

Then her palm.

"It moves."

But when she stood up, there was pain.

Ramvilas made her sit on the guard's chair downstairs.

It was 7:18.

Nishant Kumar, a Junior Clerk in the Maintenance Branch, arrived at 7:40.

Ramvilas had telephoned him.

He went upstairs, saw the water, had the main valve shut, moved the boxes, and then came down to Shanti Devi.

"Let us go to the dispensary."

Shanti Devi said,

"First stop that water.

It will reach downstairs."

"It has been stopped."

Nishant found that no official vehicle was available.

He sent Shanti Devi to the nearest primary treatment centre on his motorcycle, with Ramvilas accompanying her.

A few minutes after ten, Shanti Devi returned.

There was no bandage on her arm.

Only ointment.

The doctor had advised her not to do heavy work for two days.

"Go home," Nishant said.

Shanti Devi looked towards the cleaning-supplies room.

"The lower veranda is still left."

"Leave it today."

“Tomorrow?”

“Rest tomorrow too.”

She fell silent.

The question of whether two days’ wages would be deducted was visible on her face.

She did not ask it.

When the officer arrived in the afternoon, the question of an accident report arose.

There was a standard form for any person injured while working in a government building.

Nishant opened the form on the computer.

The first page was simple:

date,

time,

place,

incident.

On the second page was a question:

“Status of Person at Time of Incident.”

Below it were four options:

Employee.

Contract Worker — Approved Shift.

Visitor.

Unauthorised Presence.

Nishant selected:

“Contract Worker — Approved Shift.”

Red letters appeared:

“Registered shift: 13:00–17:00. Incident time outside shift.”

Nishant thought he must have entered the time incorrectly.

He opened the contracting agency details.

Shanti Devi.

Cleaning Assistant.

Four hours.

Approved time:

13:00 to 17:00.

He looked back at the form.

Incident:

07:18.

“How can that be?” he said to himself.

Ravindra Babu from Accounts heard him.

“What?”

Nishant turned the screen around.

Ravindra Babu pushed his spectacles up onto his forehead.

“In the system, it is afternoon.”

“But she works in the morning.”

“I know that too.”

“Then this?”

Ravindra Babu thought for a moment.

"When the contract was first made, perhaps the afternoon shift was proposed.

Later, because of the crowd, the time was changed.

The paper was not."

"For two years?"

"The four hours are completed, aren't they?"

In that answer Nishant heard something like the supervisor's sentence: four hours are four hours.

The form remained red.

"Contract Worker — Approved Shift" was not accepted.

Nishant selected "Visitor."

This time the system asked for a visitor-pass number.

Shanti Devi had no visitor pass.

Her name appeared every day in the gate register under:

"Contract Cleaning."

When he selected "Unauthorised Presence," a field opened asking for the reason.

Ravindra Babu immediately said,

"Do not fill that."

"Then what?"

"Ask upstairs."

Upstairs meant the Administration Branch.

The Assistant Officer there looked at the form.

"At the time of the incident, she does not appear to be an employee."

Nishant said,

"But she was working."

"I understand that.

The system is another matter."

"The system is wrong."

The officer's face showed not disagreement, but fatigue.

"Do not write 'wrong.'

Say there is a time discrepancy."

"What do I put for status?"

"Get a certificate from the contracting agency explaining why she was there in the morning."

Nishant telephoned the agency supervisor.

At first the supervisor said,

"She goes every morning."

"Put that in writing."

"On paper the time is one to five."

"Then why does she work in the morning?"

There was silence at the other end for a few moments.

"The building requires it."

"Write that too."

"If I write that, they will ask for a contract amendment."

"Then what will you write?"

"I can write that she was voluntarily present earlier."

Nishant's voice changed.

"Voluntarily sweeping and mopping?"

The supervisor said softly,

"You understand.

The four hours are completed."

The call ended.

By evening the accident report remained incomplete.

The next day Shanti Devi did not come.

The contracting agency sent a young man in her place.

He arrived at one in the afternoon.

By one o'clock, dust covered the veranda.

Dry leaves had gathered near the gate.

Water stood outside the toilets.

People in the queue at the public-service windows stepped carefully to avoid dirty patches.

The officer asked,

"Was there no cleaning today?"

Nishant said,

"The cleaner arrived at one."

"Now?"

"The approved shift begins now."

The officer looked at Nishant for a moment.

"Do not joke."

"I am telling you the system time."

The young man cleaned the first floor by two.

But because of the crowd, he had to keep stopping the mop.

At three, the officer ordered that the remaining cleaning be done in the evening after the office closed.

At five, the contracting-agency supervisor telephoned.

"Four hours are complete.

We cannot keep the worker longer."

"Then the second and third floors?"

"Shanti Didi will come tomorrow morning."

Nishant remained silent, holding the phone.

"Tomorrow morning?"

"Yes."

"Approved shift?"

This time the supervisor did not answer.

On the third day, Shanti Devi again reached the gate at 5:55.

There was still mild pain in her shoulder.

But the doctor had told her not to lift heavy boxes.

He had not told her to stop sweeping and mopping.

Ramvilas pushed the register towards her.

As Shanti Devi signed, she asked,

"Why was I not called yesterday?"

"You were ordered to rest."

"Will my pay be cut?"

"I do not know," Ramvilas said.

Upstairs, Nishant was waiting.

He explained the problem with the accident report.

Shanti Devi listened carefully.

Then asked,

"So what was I at seven eighteen?"

Nishant searched for an answer.

"That is exactly what we have to write."

"I was cleaning."

"Yes."

"Then write that I was cleaning."

"There is a separate field for status."

"Cleaning was not my status?"

Nishant could not laugh.

Shanti Devi picked up her broom.

"Write what I understand.

In the morning I am an employee.

On paper, I become an employee in the afternoon."

She went towards the staircase.

Nishant watched her go.

That day he left the accident report aside and began looking for old attendance records.

The gate register was the first piece of evidence.

For the previous three months, Shanti Devi's entry time was almost always between 5:55 and 6:05.

Departure:

between 9:50 and 10:10.

Then came the cleaning inspection slips.

Every day they said cleaning was complete before the public-service windows opened.

Different employees of the Maintenance Branch had signed them.

Then the key register.

The cleaning-room key was issued in the morning and returned at ten.

Then the monthly contract bills.

They carried no time.

Only:

"Daily four hours."

Nishant placed all four kinds of paper together.

Ravindra Babu said,

"This proves she works in the morning."

"Then the system?"

"In the system, she works in the afternoon."

"The same day, both?"

“The system records approval, not time.”

Nishant said,

“But the accident asks for time.”

Ravindra Babu fell silent.

The Administration Branch called a meeting after seeing the four sets of documents.

The contracting agency attended too.

The supervisor brought the original work order.

It clearly said:

“Cleaning service: four hours daily.”

The time field was blank.

Nishant asked,

“Then where did 13:00–17:00 come from?”

An old Accounts Assistant said,

“The digital register would not accept an empty time field.

When the contract was entered, someone may have put one to five for convenience.”

“For whose convenience?”

No one answered.

They opened the old entry history.

On the day the contract was first entered two years earlier, 13:00–17:00 had been filled in.

After that, the same time copied itself every month.

The officer said,

“Then correct it.”

The Accounts Assistant replied,

“If we change the earlier period, the bill timings will change too.”

“The bills contain no time.”

“The system will say the approved shift was amended.”

“Then change it from now.”

“The accident happened on an earlier date.

A current correction will not change her status on that day.”

The meeting fell silent again.

At that very moment Shanti Devi was outside, mopping the veranda.

Inside, they were discussing whether she had existed at 7:18 in the morning.

At last the officer said,

“Add a remark to the accident report:

‘Work order does not prescribe clock time; actual working hours established from gate register, key register, and cleaning inspection slips.’”

Nishant asked,

“Status?”

“Contract Worker.”

“The system will show red.”

“Let it remain red.

Add the remark.”

With that decision, the form still could not be submitted.
 The system saved forms containing red errors.
 It did not submit them.

The Digital Assistance Cell then suggested temporarily changing the “approved shift” to include the incident time.

After the accident form was submitted, the shift could be restored to the original time.

Ravindra Babu said,

“That means changing time for the sake of the paper.”

The Help Cell replied,

“But the work really happened in the morning.

We would be aligning it with the truth.”

Nishant asked,

“Then why change it back to one to five afterwards?”

Silence at the other end.

“Because that is the original approval,” came the answer.

The proposal that Shanti Devi’s time should change to fit 7:18 for a moment and then return to the afternoon seemed so strange that no one accepted it immediately.

Nishant said,

“Instead of bending the time around the accident, correct the wrong shift.”

For the first time, the contracting-agency representative objected clearly.

“Then the timings of the other cleaning workers will have to be checked too.”

“Why?”

“The four hours differ from building to building.

In the system, most have the same time.”

Shanti Devi was no longer alone in the meeting.

There were ten cleaning workers.

Three buildings.

Four different real schedules.

And one identical afternoon in the system.

Ravindra Babu said quietly,

“In other words, half a day has been created on paper.”

Nishant replied,

“And people do the actual work in the other half.”

The officer looked out of the window.

Shanti Devi was washing the bucket.

The clock showed 9:40.

He dictated an order:

the actual working hours of all contract workers were to be separately verified and entered into the current register;

where a work order specified only duration, duration and clock time were to be treated as separate fields;

old bills would not be altered;

but the accident report would be accepted on the basis of evidence of actual presence.

The Digital Assistance Cell had to grant special permission.

Three days later, the accident report was submitted.

Status:

Contract Worker.

Incident Time:

07:18.

Approved Duration:

Four Hours.

Actual Shift:

06:00–10:00.

No red error appeared.

Shanti Devi's two days of wages were also recorded not as absence but as medical rest.

Ravindra Babu told her about the decision.

Shanti Devi asked only,

“Will the time be written on the slip now?”

“Yes.”

The following month, for the first time, her wage slip said:

“06:00–10:00.”

She read the slip and put it in her bag.

Three days later, new identity cards were distributed.

The card carried her photograph, her name, the contracting agency's name, and the entry time.

Shanti Devi turned the card over in her hands.

At the bottom it said:

“ENTRY VALID: 13:00–17:00.”

She held the card out to Ramvilas.

Ramvilas adjusted his spectacles and read it.

Then he took out a pencil.

Beside the printed time he wrote in small letters:

“Morning.”

Shanti Devi hung the card around her neck.

It was six o'clock.

The gate opened.

STORY 166

THE WORK OF THE SEALED ROOM

In the old building of the District Primary Education Service Records Branch, the door of the Records Room had once been secured by nothing more than an ordinary brass padlock.

On Monday morning, two round impressions of red wax had appeared above that lock.

Between the two seals a white sheet was pasted:

“ENTRY PROHIBITED UNTIL COMPLETION OF AUDIT.”

Clerk Abhay Jha read the paper and felt for the key in his pocket.

The key was still there.

The door was now locked not by his key, but by the paper.

“For how many days?” Nirmala Devi, standing behind him, asked.

Abhay Babu said,

“The order gives no number of days.”

Nirmala Devi was the Senior Assistant in the Service Records Branch.

For thirty years she had known the cupboards, bundles, and habits of dust in that room.

“If there is no number of days, how will the work continue?”

Abhay Babu had no answer.

At half past ten, the first application arrived.

Chandrakala Devi was a retired teacher.

Two years had been omitted from the calculation of her pension.

She had her old appointment letter from the school.

But the original service register was inside the Records Room.

“All I need is confirmation that my service has been continuous since 1998,” she said.

Abhay Babu looked towards the door.

“The original file is inside.”

“Then?”

“The audit is in progress.”

“My service too?”

Abhay Babu tried to smile faintly.

The smile did not last.

Chandrakala Devi took four papers from her bag:

an old salary slip,

a school certificate,

the bank pension statement,

and a photocopy.

Her name appeared faintly at the top of the photocopy.

Nirmala Devi took it in her hand.

“This looks like a page from the service register.”

“I got it from the school twenty years ago,” Chandrakala Devi said.

“Certified by whom?”

“The headmaster at that time.”

Half the headmaster’s seal was legible.

Abhay Babu said,

“No decision can be made without the original.”

Nirmala Devi looked at him.

“How many days will the original remain unavailable?”

“The auditors will say.”

“And the pension?”

Abhay Babu fell silent.

That afternoon, the Branch Officer called a meeting.

Seven employees sat in the room.

In the middle of the table lay a photograph of the red-sealed door, as though someone might forget that the papers inside were, for the moment, no longer papers but prohibited objects.

The officer said,

“Routine work must not stop.”

Abhay Babu asked,

“Without the original files?”

“Wherever possible, use the available records.”

“What are the available records?”

The officer looked at the papers for a few moments.

“Whatever can be used.”

That answer was not written down.

The next day, Abhay Babu wrote at the top of a clean sheet:

“TEMPORARY WORKING PAPER.”

Below it:

Chandrakala Devi’s name.

Then he attached:

the appointment letter,

three salary slips,

the school certificate,

the bank statement,

and the old photocopy of the service register.

At the very top, in red pencil, he wrote:

“ORIGINAL FILE IN SEALED RECORDS ROOM.”

Nirmala Devi read it.

“This is not a file.”

“I know.”

“Then a decision will be made on this?”

“The officer said the work must not stop.”

Nirmala Devi moved her chair closer.

“Add one more thing:

‘Reconciliation required when original is opened.’”

Abhay Babu added it.

Chandrakala Devi’s application moved forward.

Three days later, another case arrived.
 For a teacher's promotion, a training period from 2007 had to be verified.
 A photocopy of the original certificate was available at the school.
 Five days later came a third case:
 service period for settlement of dues to the family of a deceased teacher.
 Within a week there were seven "Temporary Working Papers."
 By the second week there were seventeen.
 Then a new problem emerged.
 Different employees were creating them in different forms.
 Some wrote "Temporary" at the top.
 Some "Reconstructed."
 Some "Based on Available Papers."
 Some wrote only the name.
 Nirmala Devi said,
 "Temporary things become uniform before anything else."
 She designed a format.
 Name at the top.
 Below it:
 the original file number, if it could be found in any outside
 correspondence.
 Then:
 a list of available copies.
 Then a separate field:
 "INFORMATION BASED ON MEMORY."
 Abhay Babu stared at her.
 "We will write memory too?"
 "Some things I remember.
 Some you remember.
 If we write them down, at least it will remain clear that they are not
 documents."
 The first memory entry concerned the service location of an elderly
 attendant.
 Nirmala Devi wrote:
 "As remembered, file was tied in green cloth; 2003 transfer order was in
 the final section."
 Abhay Babu laughed.
 "Has green cloth become evidence?"
 "No.
 That is why I wrote 'as remembered.'"
 Three days later, the same fact about the green cloth became useful in
 another letter.
 The school's reply said:
 "The old green service bundle was sent to the District Office."
 Abhay Babu looked at Nirmala Devi.
 "The memory was correct."
 Nirmala Devi said,

“A correct memory does not become paper.”

But the work continued.

Every day, the audit team entered the sealed room according to its own schedule.

They came with their own key, their own register, and their own signatures.

The branch employees remained outside.

Sometimes the door opened for five minutes.

Inside one could see dust, bundles, and rows of iron cupboards.

But no one from the branch was permitted to enter.

One day, seeing the door open, Abhay Babu called out Chandrakala Devi's file number.

The Audit Officer immediately raised a hand.

“No specific file will be taken out.”

“We only need to look at one page.”

“It will disturb the audit sequence.”

“Her pension is held up.”

“That is an administrative matter.

We are checking the integrity of the records.”

The door closed again.

Abhay Babu returned to the outside desk.

For the first time he understood that the integrity of a record and the use of a record could become two different kinds of work.

After that, the branch began collecting outside papers more seriously.

Photocopies were requested from schools.

Salary lists from the Treasury.

Personal copies from old employees.

Whatever had survived anywhere began returning to the office.

Sometimes the edge of a paper had been cut off.

Sometimes only half the seal remained.

Sometimes the date was clear but the name blurred.

Sometimes the name was clear but the decision missing.

Abhay Babu wrote the source separately on every page:

“School copy.”

“Employee copy.”

“Treasury copy.”

“Attachment to earlier letter.”

“Memory.”

Two weeks later, the audit team asked the branch:

“Produce the basis for decisions made during the sealed period.”

Abhay Babu placed seventeen Temporary Working Papers before them.

The Audit Officer turned the first page.

“This is not the original file.”

“The original is sealed with you.”

“Then how was the decision made?”

Before answering, Abhay Babu looked towards the officer.

The Branch Officer said,

“On the basis of available evidence.”

The Audit Officer examined Chandrakala Devi’s working paper.

Photocopy.

Salary slips.

School letter.

Bank statement.

“Its serial number?”

“It is temporary.”

“Without a serial number?”

Abhay Babu said,

“The original file number is written.”

“What record is this paper itself?”

The room fell silent.

Nirmala Devi said,

“For now, a working paper.”

The Audit Officer picked up his pencil.

At the top he wrote:

“RECONSTRUCTED RECORD — R-17.”

Then on the next one:

“R-18.”

From that day, the Temporary Working Papers acquired serial numbers of their own.

The following week, the Accounts Branch returned a letter.

The reason:

the attached basis referred to a “Temporary Working Paper.”

Abhay Babu showed them the copy on which the audit team had described the same paper as:

“Reconstructed Record R-17.”

The Accounts Branch accepted the letter again.

One word had changed.

The paper was the same.

Chandrakala Devi’s pension-correction order was issued.

When she came to the office, Abhay Babu gave her the news.

“The two years have been added?”

“Yes.”

“Was the original file found?”

“Not yet.”

Chandrakala Devi looked at him for a few moments.

“So my service was found, but the file was not?”

From behind, Nirmala Devi said,

“For now, accept that much.”

Chandrakala Devi laughed.

“I had already performed the service.

It was the file that needed finding.”

She put a copy of the order in her bag.

The sealed room did not open in the third week either.

By the fourth week, the Reconstructed Records had crossed fifty.

Now another problem arose.

Some new letters began citing the Reconstructed Record numbers:

“On the basis of R-31.”

“As per R-44.”

“Facts available in R-19.”

The papers created only to be checked against the originals once the room reopened were now beginning to become originals for other papers.

One day Abhay Babu said,

“What if the original opens and says something different?”

Nirmala Devi closed the register.

“Then we will look at both.”

“Which one will be treated as true?”

“The decision made without seeing the original has already been made.”

“So?”

Nirmala Devi did not answer.

On Tuesday of the fifth week, the red wax seals were cut.

The audit was not complete.

But an order had arrived reopening the Records Room for branch use.

In the morning, all the employees gathered at the door.

Abhay Babu turned the key.

When he pushed the door inward, the smell of old paper, cloth, and dust came out together.

The room was the same.

The cupboards the same.

The green, red, and blue bundles the same.

In five weeks, an entire second world of records had been created outside.

The first reconciliation began with Chandrakala Devi's file.

The original bundle really was green.

Nirmala Devi smiled slightly.

Abhay Babu brought the file out and placed it on the desk.

The service register was opened.

The page from 1998 was found.

The original date of appointment was the same.

But there was one difference.

The original register recorded a break in service of two months.

The Reconstructed Record did not.

Abhay Babu felt heat rise to his head.

“Will the pension have to change again?”

Nirmala Devi examined the page carefully.

Beside the line recording the break was a small pencil mark.

She turned the following page.

There was a later-order reference:

“Earlier break in service cancelled; salary continuity recognised.”

No one had a photocopy of that page.

Abhay Babu breathed deeply.

"Then the result in the Reconstructed Record was correct."

Nirmala Devi said,

"Because it had incomplete papers, but this time the incompleteness happened to point in the right direction."

"And if it had not?"

That question found its answer in the next file.

In R-22, a teacher's training date was recorded as 14 June.

The original file said 17 June.

In R-36, the father's name was spelled one way.

The original spelled it another.

In R-41, the transfer-order number was incomplete.

In the original, complete.

Some differences were minor.

Some could alter a decision.

The Branch Officer called another meeting.

On one side of the table:

the original files.

On the other:

the Reconstructed Records.

Between them:

the orders issued over five weeks.

"Do we reopen every decision?" Abhay Babu asked.

The Audit Officer was present too.

"The original is the supreme record," he said.

Nirmala Devi asked,

"When the original was sealed, were you the one who gave the R-numbers?"

The Audit Officer remained silent for a few moments.

"For audit purposes."

"And the Accounts Branch accepted those numbers."

"So that the work would not stop."

"And now the work has been done."

No answer came immediately.

At last an order was drafted:

"Decisions already made on the basis of Reconstructed Records shall be subject to review only where a material difference is found.

All Reconstructed Records shall be reconciled with the original files."

Abhay Babu asked,

"Where will the proof of reconciliation be recorded?"

Nirmala Devi opened a blank register.

At the top she wrote:

"ORIGINAL-RECONSTRUCTED RECONCILIATION REGISTER."

Abhay Babu laughed.

"One more register."

"Yes."

“Temporary?”

Nirmala Devi stopped her pen.

“Do not write that word yet.”

The reconciliation began.

An original file was brought out.

The record carrying the R-number was placed beside it.

Dates, names, orders, and periods of service were matched.

Where there was no difference:

a green mark.

Where the difference was minor:

a remark.

Where it affected a decision:

a red slip.

Three days later, an odd situation emerged.

Some original files were missing pages.

But the Reconstructed Records contained certified copies obtained from outside.

Abhay Babu asked,

“Here the original itself is incomplete.”

The Audit Officer said,

“Verify the outside copy.”

“Against what?”

He looked towards the original file.

Then towards the Reconstructed Record.

“Against the available sources.”

Abhay Babu understood that now even the original was no longer sufficient by itself.

Within a week, although the room was open, a new queue of original files formed on the outside desk.

Each carried a small slip:

“RECONCILIATION PENDING.”

There was no red wax on the door.

Anyone could enter.

But a paper brought out from inside was no longer considered immediately fit for decision until it had been matched with the records created outside.

One day Chandrakala Devi came again.

She had already received the first corrected pension payment from the bank.

She had not come only to say thank you.

She had brought an old paper.

“I found this at home,” she said.

It was a copy of a school attendance statement from 1998.

Abhay Babu looked at the paper.

“The original room is open now.”

“So this is useless?”

Before answering, Abhay Babu looked at Nirmala Devi.

Nirmala Devi took the paper.

“Not useless.

Record the source and keep it.”

Abhay Babu made a slip:

“Employee’s Personal Copy — To Be Reconciled with Original.”

Chandrakala Devi read it and laughed.

“Now the original also has to be reconciled?”

Nirmala Devi laughed too.

“In this office, every paper now recognises every other paper.”

In the evening, Abhay Babu went to lock the Records Room.

The brass padlock went back on.

No red wax.

Outside the door, on a wooden table, lay five original files.

On every one was the same white slip:

“ORIGINAL RECORD — RECONCILIATION PENDING.”

Abhay Babu switched off the light.

The room was open.

The original papers waited outside.

STORY 167

THE TRANSLATED VILLAGE

When the new digital address register was introduced in the District Public Service Office, no one celebrated.

Work began on entering the old addresses of every branch into a single system.

Whatever name appeared in Devanagari was automatically given a Roman form, and on that basis letters, verification teams, assistance slips, and mobile-phone messages were routed towards different services.

The officers called the change convenience.

The clerks called it extra work.

The people in the villages called it nothing at all, because nothing had yet happened to them.

The first problem reached Piprahi.

Piprahi was an old village on the eastern side of the river.

On the wall of the Panchayat building, its name was written in large Devanagari letters:

“पिपराही.”

Thirty-two kos to the west stood another village:

Piparhi.

The two belonged to different blocks.

Their postal routes were different.

Their police stations were different.

Their school clusters were different.

But in the new digital address register, both received the same Roman search-name:

PIPRAHI.

The machine did not preserve the long “aa” of Piprahi.

It also dropped the lighter middle vowel of Piparhi.

Two villages disappeared into the same letters.

The first mistake involved a scholarship letter.

A scholarship-verification letter for Sunita, daughter of Madhukar Jha of Piprahi, reached the school in Piparhi.

The headmaster did not open the envelope.

The student’s name was written in Devanagari on top.

The Roman address said:

PIPRAHI.

“There is no such family in our village,” he said.

The postman replied,

“The screen shows this place.”

“Does the screen know the village?”

“I know the road.

But now the screen makes the road.”

The letter remained at the Piparhi school for three days.

On the fourth day it was sent to Piprahi in the hands of local teacher Sudhir Paswan.

Sudhir's sister was married there, so once a week he travelled that way.

When Sunita's father received the letter, he said,

"Three days late."

Sudhir said,

"Not three days.

Thirty-two kos."

Both laughed.

At the time, neither understood that a new arrangement was being born inside the joke.

A week later, ten agricultural-assistance slips arrived in Piprahi.

None of the names was familiar there.

Malti Devi, the Panchayat Assistant, read the slips one by one:

Ramcharit Yadav.

Mahendra Paswan.

Lalita Devi.

Jeevachh Sah.

Any of those names could also have existed in Piprahi.

But the fathers' or husbands' names, hamlets, and land numbers did not match.

At the bottom, the Roman address was again the same:

PIPRAHI.

Malti Devi telephoned Sudhir Paswan.

"Is there a Ramcharit Yadav in your village?"

"There are two.

Whose son?"

She read the slip.

"Yes, that one is from here."

"Then ten of your slips are with me."

Sudhir was silent for a moment.

"Sunita's scholarship letter came here earlier.

Are the accounts even now?"

"The accounting has only begun."

That Tuesday they met at the weekly market.

Malti Devi handed over the bundle of agricultural slips.

Sudhir handed her an envelope containing a life-verification notice for Jamuna Devi, an elderly woman of Piprahi.

The same Roman name was printed on both bundles.

For the first time, Malti Devi looked at it carefully.

"What is your village called in Roman letters?"

"What is written there."

"Mine too."

Sudhir turned the slip over, as though another answer might be printed on the back.

There was nothing.

From that day, a small exchange began at the Tuesday market.

Malti Devi kept aside letters arriving in her village that belonged to Piparhi.

Sudhir separated papers reaching Piparhi that belonged to Piprahi.

Once a week they met and exchanged the bundles.

At first it was a matter of five or ten envelopes.

Within a month, the number had reached thirty-seven.

School notices.

Maternity assistance.

Old-age payments.

Irrigation inspections.

Copies from birth registers.

Housing inspections.

Animal vaccination.

Bank verification.

Papers changed villages.

People did not.

Jamuna Devi's problem became serious when her old-age payment stopped.

The notice said:

"Beneficiary not present at designated location for verification."

Jamuna Devi had sat at the Panchayat building in Piprahi from early morning on the appointed day.

No verification team came.

Later they learned that the team had gone to Piparhi.

There, the officials spent three hours searching for Jamuna Devi.

People in Piparhi told them:

"There is no elderly woman by that name here."

A remark was entered in the verification register:

"Beneficiary unavailable at location."

Malti Devi went to the District Office.

Room Number Six contained the address-correction desk.

Clerk Arun Babu first entered Jamuna Devi's beneficiary number.

The screen showed the address:

PIPRAHI.

"What needs correction here?"

Malti Devi placed a paper before him with the village name written in Devanagari.

"This is Piprahi.

The verification team went to Piparhi."

Arun Babu searched the second village.

The screen again showed:

PIPRAHI.

He frowned.

"Both have the same name?"

"Not in Devanagari."

"Different blocks?"

"Different."

"Different location codes?"

"Different."

"Then why has the system combined them?"

Malti Devi smiled faintly.

"I came to you for the answer to that question."

Arun Babu opened the correction form.

The first field was:

"Current Roman Village Name."

He entered:

PIPRAHI.

The second field:

"Corrected Roman Village Name."

He entered:

PIPRAHI.

The screen turned red.

"Old and new values are identical. No correction required."

Arun Babu tried again.

This time he entered:

PIPRAAHI.

The system automatically shortened it back to:

PIPRAHI.

On the third attempt he inserted a dot.

The dot disappeared.

On the fourth he added the location code.

The field accepted letters only.

After a while he leaned back in his chair.

"To correct an error, the system must first be able to see the error," he said.

Malti Devi did not understand.

"The error is right in front of us."

"I can see it.

The system cannot."

"Then?"

"A report will have to go to the higher office."

The report was prepared.

This time the problem was that the subject line showed the two village names identically.

Arun Babu wrote:

"Regarding name conflict between PIPRAHI and PIPRAHI."

The superior officer added a remark:

"Attach proof that these are two separate villages."

Malti Devi submitted certificates from both Panchayats, separate location codes, separate block registers, and maps.

Fifteen days later came the reply:

“Roman names identical in both records. Ensure uniformity at local level.”

Arun Babu read the reply and scratched his head.

“The uniformity is already there.”

Malti Devi said,

“That is the problem.”

Meanwhile, another difficulty arose in Piparhi.

Ramcharit Yadav’s crop-loss assistance had been routed towards the bank branch serving Piprahi.

The preliminary list had been generated not from the bank-account number, but from the branch service area.

Ramcharit went to the bank three times.

The bank said,

“You do not belong to this service area.”

The Agriculture Office said,

“In the system, you belong to that village.”

Ramcharit asked Sudhir Paswan,

“Where do I belong?”

Sudhir said,

“Where your house is.”

“Where does the money belong?”

He had no answer.

After two months, both villages learned to recognise one another’s papers.

In Piprahi, a wooden box was placed with the label:

“WESTERN PIPARHI.”

In Piparhi, a basket was marked:

“EASTERN PIPRAHI.”

There was no government order.

There was need.

At the Tuesday market, the contents of the two containers were exchanged.

Sometimes Sudhir could not come, so a bus driver carried the bundle.

Sometimes Malti Devi fell ill, so a school student delivered it.

The digital route kept making mistakes.

The human route kept correcting them.

At last the District Office formed an inspection team.

The order said:

“Site verification of both villages named PIPRAHI.”

The team set out in a vehicle.

The driver asked,

“Which PIPRAHI first?”

The team leader looked at the order.

It said only:

PIPRAHI.

“Whichever is nearer by road,” he said.

The vehicle reached Piprahi.

The people there were ready because Sudhir had informed them in advance.

The team saw both villages' Devanagari signboards.

Recorded the location code.

Asked about Panchayat boundaries.

They were supposed to go to Piprahi in the afternoon.

But the driver's daily distance limit had been completed.

The team returned.

The report said:

"One site verified; verification of the second pending."

Which site had been verified?

Again the report contained only:

PIPRAHI.

Arun Babu read the report and remained silent for a long time.

Then, in pencil, in the right-hand corner, he wrote:

"Piparhi."

No one stopped him.

A week later, a temporary solution arrived from the higher office.

The instruction was to add the first letter of the block after each Roman village name.

For Piprahi:

PIPRAHI-K.

For Piparhi:

PIPRAHI-M.

Arun Babu was pleased.

He sat down to correct Jamuna Devi's record.

But the beneficiary register accepted no village name longer than seven letters.

The suffixes were cut off.

The screen again showed:

PIPRAHI.

This time Arun Babu did not laugh.

He wrote again to the higher office.

The reply said:

"Before changing legacy service registers, ensure compatibility of all connected systems."

In other words:

first correct everywhere,

then the first place may be corrected.

Malti Devi read the reply.

"How many days will that take?"

Arun Babu said,

"If it began from one place, I could answer.

Here, the end is required before the beginning."

Jamuna Devi's payment was still stopped.

For a while Arun Babu looked at her papers.

Then he found a separate procedure for requesting re-verification on the basis of the location code rather than the village name in the beneficiary register.

That procedure required three additional proofs.

But the Roman village name was not decisive.

Malti Devi collected the proofs within two days.

Jamuna Devi was verified again.

This time the inspection team wrote the village name by hand in Devanagari on the letter.

The payment resumed.

The original problem remained.

Ramcharit's assistance was later corrected through the location code too.

Case after case escaped by separate routes while the single error in the register remained firmly in place.

Three months later, the District Office issued a new circular.

It said:

"In applications for correction of Roman village name, the current name in the source register shall be entered exactly as recorded."

Malti Devi read the circular and showed it to Sudhir.

"So, to ask for a correction, first write the erroneous name exactly."

Sudhir said,

"No.

The system says it is not an error.

It is the current name."

Both laughed again.

By then, the Tuesday market had become an informal postal station between the two villages.

Beside the tea stall, two white boxes stood on an old wooden table.

On one, in Devanagari:

"पिपराही."

On the other:

"पिपरही."

Below, in smaller Roman letters, both carried the same word:

PIPRAHI.

One day a schoolboy named Neeraj looked at the boxes and asked,

"Why do both have the same English name?"

Sudhir opened his mouth to answer.

Then stopped.

Malti Devi said,

"The paper takes a shorter road."

Whether Neeraj understood it, no one knew.

He took out his pencil.

Beneath the Roman name on the first box, he wrote in small letters:

"EAST."

Beneath the second:

“WEST.”

Sudhir did not stop his hand.

The market bus arrived.

The bundle from Piprahi travelled west.

The bundle from Piparhi travelled east.

In the District Register, both villages still had the same name.

On the market table, their two roads were perfectly clear.

THE ATTENDANCE ORDER ON A HOLIDAY

Before nine in the morning, the telephone had already begun ringing in the District Establishment Branch.

Sitting at her desk, Archana Jha gave the same answer to the first three calls:

“Yes, the notice has not been cancelled so far.”

Before answering the fourth, she looked again at the paper.

Across the top, in bold letters, it said:

“MANDATORY IDENTITY-VERIFICATION CAMP.”

Date:

the coming Friday.

Time:

10 a.m. to 4 p.m.

Venue:

District Integrated Hall.

Below it was written:

“Employees who fail to undergo verification on the scheduled day shall have their attendance identity treated as inactive from the next salary cycle.”

The notice had been issued five days earlier.

But the previous evening the District Administration had issued another order:

that same Friday would be a public holiday on account of a local festival.

The two papers now lay one over the other on Archana's desk.

One said:

if you do not come, there will be consequences as though you were absent.

The other said:

do not come, the office is closed.

She lifted the first notice.

Beneath it, in pencil, the Branch Officer had written:

“Camp unchanged?”

The question mark had been circled twice.

The previous evening Archana had telephoned Vibhor Singh, representative of the agency supplying the identity-verification equipment.

Vibhor had answered clearly:

“The machine, engineer, and central key have all been fixed for that day.

If the date changes, the next opportunity will be three weeks later.”

Archana had asked,

“But a holiday has now been declared.”

He had replied,

“Our contract is based on the fixed date, not on holidays.”

For the Establishment Branch, it was a holiday.

For the agency, it was a fixed date.

For the employees, it was a question.
 At half past nine, Branch Officer Pramod Mishra arrived.
 Archana pushed both orders towards him.
 Pramod Babu put on his spectacles and read the first paper, though he already knew it.
 Then he read the second.
 "Anything from above?"
 "No."
 "The camp people?"
 "They say the date cannot be changed."
 "District Administration?"
 "The holiday order says 'all government offices closed.'"
 Pramod Babu remained silent for a while.
 Then he said,
 "Put out a short clarification."
 Archana opened the computer.
 "What shall I write?"
 Pramod Babu leaned back in his chair.
 "Write:
 'With regard to the previously scheduled identity-verification camp, employees shall remain present as per the earlier instructions.'"
 Archana stopped typing.
 "'Remain present?'"
 "Yes."
 "On a holiday?"
 "For the camp."
 "And the office?"
 "The office will be closed."
 Archana stopped again.
 Pramod Babu looked at her.
 "What happened?"
 "Who will open the gate?"
 Pramod Babu had no immediate answer.
 The hall was inside the District Office compound.
 On holidays the main gate remained closed, and the security register allowed entry only to pre-authorized essential-service staff.
 Employees coming for identity verification were not on the "essential services" list.
 Pramod Babu said,
 "We will tell the Security Branch."
 Archana typed the clarification.
 By afternoon it had gone out on the office internal group.
 Five minutes later the telephone rang again.
 "This is Neelam from Araria Block.
 Is it a holiday or is there verification?"
 Archana said,

"The verification camp will go ahead."

"Then it is not a holiday?"

"It is a holiday."

There was silence at the other end.

"Both?"

"You will have to come for the camp."

"Will attendance be marked?"

The clarification did not answer that question.

Archana said,

"No separate instruction has yet been issued on that."

Neelam asked again,

"If I do not come, will I be absent?"

Before answering, Archana looked towards Pramod Babu.

He was busy with his papers.

"Your verification will be missed," Archana said.

"And if I come?"

"Your verification will be completed."

"Attendance?"

Archana gave the same answer again:

"There is no separate instruction yet."

On Friday morning, when Archana left home, her daughter Nidhi was standing at the door.

"Today was supposed to be a holiday."

"It is."

"Then where are you going?"

Archana put the bag on her shoulder.

"To do holiday work."

Nidhi did not laugh.

She only asked,

"Will you be back by evening?"

"I will try."

When Archana reached the District Office, the main gate was indeed closed.

Seven employees were already standing outside.

One carried a photocopy of an appointment letter.

One had an identity card.

One had a copy of Aadhaar.

One merely held up the notice on a mobile phone.

Inside the gate stood guard Devkant Mandal.

Through the grille he said,

"Today is a holiday."

Archana showed her identity card.

"There is a camp."

"I have not received a list."

"The Security Branch was informed yesterday."

Devkant turned through the register.

Under essential services, there were five names:
 an electrician,
 a water-supply employee,
 two Control Room employees,
 and Devkant himself.

Archana's name was not there.

There was no mention of the camp.

"How do we go inside?" one employee asked from outside.

Devkant said,

"Let the order arrive."

At 10:05 the verification agency's vehicle arrived.

The vehicle wanted to enter.

Devkant looked at the list again.

Vibhor Singh got out.

"We have a permission letter."

He showed the paper.

The letter authorised use of the District Hall.

It said nothing about entry on a holiday.

Devkant said,

"You have permission for the hall.

Not permission to open a closed office."

Vibhor did not laugh.

"The equipment is in the vehicle."

"Let it remain there."

The number of employees outside kept growing.

Some had travelled eight kos.

Some thirty.

One woman employee had brought her small child because the childcare centre was also closed for the holiday.

By eleven, nearly fifty people were gathered outside.

Pramod Babu's mobile phone was switched off.

The Security Officer did not answer.

At last Archana spoke to the Sub-Divisional Officer's Control Room.

They said,

"If this is previously scheduled government work, the Branch Officer should send written permission."

"The Branch Officer is on holiday."

"Then?"

Archana said nothing.

At half past eleven, a message arrived from Pramod Babu:

"Open the gate and conduct verification.

Attendance matter will be looked into later."

The message was on a mobile phone.

Devkant read it.

"This is not a security order."

"Then what do you need?"

“Paper.”

“The office is closed.”

“Then where will the paper come from?”

They looked at one another.

At last a one-page permission arrived from the Control Room.

The gate opened.

People went inside.

The lights in the hall came on.

Vibhor’s team connected the equipment.

The first employee’s thumbprint was read.

Then the iris image.

Then the identity card.

The machine said:

“Verification complete.”

Second employee.

Third.

At one side, Archana opened a handwritten register and began writing names.

Employee number.

Time.

Signature.

Someone asked,

“Is this attendance?”

Archana said,

“This is the camp register.”

“Where is attendance?”

“The attendance machine is shut down.”

“Why?”

“It is a holiday.”

For a moment laughter rose in the queue.

It quickly faded.

At one o’clock Neelam arrived too.

She had changed two buses.

“What happened about attendance?”

“Nothing yet.”

“I have been on the road since morning.”

“I am writing it down.”

“Will this be accepted?”

Archana said,

“That is now my question too.”

By four o’clock, eighty-three employees had been verified.

Twenty-seven did not come.

As Vibhor shut down the machine, he printed a list.

At the top it said:

“Verified: 83.

Did Not Reach: 27.”

Archana's handwritten register contained eighty-three signatures.
In the District Attendance System, every employee carried the same mark for that day:

"HOL."

Holiday.

The first problem arrived as soon as the office reopened on Monday.

A list was generated to deactivate the identity numbers of the twenty-seven employees marked "Did Not Reach."

Of those twenty-seven, sixteen submitted written representations:

"As the day was a public holiday, the question of attending the designated office did not arise."

Four had submitted medical information.

Seven submitted nothing.

The Establishment Branch opened the digital form to record the reasons for all twenty-seven.

The options were:

"Absent."

"Leave."

"Tour."

"Other."

There was no "Holiday."

Archana selected:

"Other."

A red message appeared:

"Select reason."

She had already selected "Other."

But a second reason list opened below it:

"Disciplinary."

"Personal."

"Technical."

Archana selected:

"Technical."

Pramod Babu said,

"This is not technical.

The people did not come."

"But it was a holiday."

"The camp remained scheduled."

"Then attendance should have been marked."

"The attendance system had the day as a holiday."

"Then how is 'Did Not Reach' equivalent to absence?"

Pramod Babu removed his spectacles and placed them on the desk.

"Archana ji, we have to run an administration, not study philosophy."

Archana said nothing.

That day a second problem arose.

Some of the eighty-three employees who had come submitted applications for compensatory leave.

The form asked:

“Date of Additional Work.”

They entered Friday’s date.

The system replied:

“Employee not present on this date.”

Because the attendance register showed:

“HOL.”

Neelam placed her application before Archana.

“I left home at five in the morning and returned at seven in the evening.

Now this says I was not present?”

Archana looked at the paper.

“Your signature is in the camp register.”

“Then tell this paper.”

In pencil Archana wrote on the application:

“Verification Register Serial No. 56.”

The Accounts Branch returned the application.

The remark said:

“Additional work not admissible on an absence day.”

Archana read the remark and went to Pramod Babu.

“It says ‘absence day’ here.”

“Yes?”

“The Attendance System says holiday.

The Accounts Branch says absence.

The Verification System says present.”

Pramod Babu placed the three papers separately.

One said:

“HOL.”

One:

“Verified.”

One:

“Absence Day.”

For a few moments he looked at them.

“We will have a meeting.”

The meeting was held on Tuesday.

Representatives from Establishment, Accounts, Security, Information Technology, and the verification agency were present.

Vibhor Singh said,

“Our work is complete.

Eighty-three verifications succeeded.”

The Accounts representative said,

“Additional service has not been certified.”

The Security representative said,

“The gate was opened under special permission, so entry was valid.”

The IT Officer said,

“The holiday master register marked the day as a holiday, so the attendance machine did not accept attendance marks.”

Pramod Babu asked,
 “Then were those eighty-three people there or not?”
 Instead of answering together, representatives of all four branches began looking at their own papers.
 Archana opened her handwritten register.
 “These are all their signatures.”
 The Accounts representative said,
 “This is not an approved attendance-register format.”
 “But their verification was completed.”
 “Verification is not attendance.”
 “Then why are those who did not come classified as ‘Did Not Reach?’”
 The room fell silent again.
 Vibhor Singh said softly,
 “‘Did Not Reach’ is only a term used by the camp.”
 “But identity numbers are being deactivated on that basis,” Archana said.
 The IT Officer displayed the rule on the screen.
 “The system module has no separate category for a holiday conflict.”
 “Then the category is wrong.”
 He said,
 “I can only show what the system contains.”
 At the end of the meeting, it was decided:
 the twenty-seven employees would be given a second opportunity for verification;
 there would be no penalty.
 Compensatory rest for the eighty-three employees would be sanctioned through a separate order on the basis of the verification register.
 And in future, no mandatory camp would be scheduled on a declared holiday.
 While Archana was typing the decision, Pramod Babu said,
 “Add one more line.”
 “What?”
 “If a holiday is declared after a camp has already been scheduled, the date shall be deemed automatically rescheduled.”
 Archana typed it.
 Then asked,
 “Automatically by whom?”
 Pramod Babu laughed.
 “Leave that question this time.”
 The order was issued.
 Three days later, a new option was added to the identity system:
 “Holiday Conflict.”
 The identity numbers of all twenty-seven employees were reactivated.
 The compensatory rest of the eighty-three employees was also approved.
 Neelam took her leave the following Monday.
 She came to Archana’s desk and said,
 “This time it really is leave, isn’t it?”

Archana smiled.

“It is in the attendance register.”

“And verification?”

“No camp.”

“The gate?”

“It will remain closed.”

Neelam folded the paper and put it in her bag.

“Then shall I believe it?”

Before answering, Archana looked at the calendar for the coming month hanging on the wall.

The holidays were marked with red circles.

She picked up her pencil.

Beneath one red circle she wrote in small letters:

“NO MANDATORY PROGRAMME ON THIS DAY.”

A few moments later she stopped.

Then underlined the word:

“MANDATORY.”

The holiday was now clear on paper.

That day, no one was present there.

STORY 169

THE COMPLAINT BORN OF A QUESTION

The assistance window at the District Public Service Centre opened at nine in the morning, but Chandrakala Devi had arrived at eight forty.

In her hand was a bundle of papers wrapped in green cloth.

On top lay the receipt for her flood-rehabilitation assistance application.

Beneath it were a copy of the house-damage inspection, her bank passbook, identity card, and tickets from three journeys.

The southern wall of her house had collapsed in the last flood.

The rains had ended, but the wall had still not been rebuilt.

The family passed the nights behind a bamboo screen and two sheets of tin.

Chandrakala Devi had submitted her application four months earlier.

The receipt said:

“Decision expected: thirty working days.”

In four months, the ink of that sentence had faded.

The decision had not arrived.

Vidyapati Mishra, sitting at the assistance window, took her papers.

“Application number?”

Chandrakala Devi placed a finger on the receipt.

Vidyapati entered the number.

A green circle spun first on the digital screen.

Then a line appeared:

“Case under process.”

“That is all?” Chandrakala Devi asked.

“That is all it shows.”

“Where is it under process?”

Vidyapati opened another field.

It said:

“Related Branch.”

“Which branch?”

Vidyapati smiled.

“That does not show.”

Chandrakala Devi did not begin tying up her papers again.

She remained seated.

“All I want to know is where my papers are stuck.”

Vidyapati said,

“I will register a status query.”

A field titled “Assistance” opened on the screen.

Below it were two choices:

“General Information”

and

“Formal Complaint.”

Vidyapati selected "General Information."

A new screen opened:

"General Information available only for published scheme details."

Below it, for:

"Question regarding individual application"

there was a button:

"Register Complaint."

Vidyapati paused.

"This is only a question," Chandrakala Devi said.

"Yes."

"Then why a complaint?"

"There is no separate route in the system."

Vidyapati himself looked uncomfortable.

He glanced at Renuka Devi, the clerk sitting beside him.

"Is there another way to ask about an individual case?"

Without lifting her head, Renuka said,

"No.

Open a complaint and write in the remark:

'Status enquiry only.'"

Vidyapati did exactly that.

In the subject field he entered:

"Request to know current status of application."

Below, in remarks:

"Citizen has not challenged the decision; she is only asking for the location/status of the pending application."

When he pressed "Submit," a new number appeared in large letters on the screen:

GR-7318.

Chandrakala Devi started.

"What is that?"

"The number for your question."

"For the complaint?"

Vidyapati was silent for a moment.

"The system calls it a complaint number."

A small machine printed a slip.

Across the top it said:

"FORMAL COMPLAINT RECEIVED."

Chandrakala Devi read it.

"I did not make a complaint."

Vidyapati wrote beneath it in pen:

"Status Query."

"Keep this.

You should get an answer in two or three days."

Chandrakala Devi put the slip into the paper bundle.

As she was leaving, she turned back.

"Whose complaint is it?"

Vidyapati searched for an answer.

"The application's."

"And against whom am I complaining?"

"Against no one."

"Then fine."

She left.

Five minutes later, a red band flashed on Vidyapati's screen:

"Original Case Under Dispute."

At first he paid no attention.

The matter became clear in the afternoon when Manoj from the Flood Rehabilitation Branch telephoned.

"Did you open GR-7318?"

"Yes."

A status enquiry."

"Not a status enquiry."

A formal complaint."

"Read the remarks."

"I have read them."

But the case is blocked now."

Vidyapati straightened in his chair.

"Why?"

"The rule says no final decision shall be taken on the original case while a related complaint is pending."

"But the complaint is not against the decision."

"The system does not read that distinction."

Vidyapati opened the original application again.

The case that had said "under process" for four months now carried another line:

"Under Dispute: Decision Deferred."

He showed Renuka Devi.

Renuka pushed up her spectacles.

"This has gone backwards."

"I only asked for the status."

"The question became a complaint."

The complaint became a dispute."

The dispute stopped the decision."

For a while they both stared at the screen.

Vidyapati searched for an option to close the complaint.

The "Complaint Disposal" screen opened.

It contained three questions:

"What final action was taken on the original application?"

"What solution was given to the complainant?"

"Is the complainant satisfied?"

Until the first question was answered, the "Submit" button remained grey.

Vidyapati telephoned Manoj again.

"Enter the final action on the original application."

Manoj laughed.

"I can write the final action only after taking it."

"Take it."

"The complaint is pending."

"Close the complaint."

"To close the complaint, I need the final action."

They were silent for a few moments.

Manoj said,

"Did you design this system?"

"No."

"Neither did I."

"Then?"

"Ask the Complaint Branch."

The Complaint Branch was on the third floor.

Vidyapati went there himself after lunch.

There were five desks.

Four employees.

On the fifth desk stood a basket full of papers labelled:

"Additional Cases."

Pramila Jha, In-Charge of the Complaint Branch, opened GR-7318.

"The citizen's question is clear."

"Then cancel the complaint."

"It cannot be cancelled."

"Why?"

"A received complaint cannot be erased.

The sequence would break in audit."

"Then close it."

Pramila showed him the disposal screen.

"It requires final action."

"The same circle."

"Yes."

Vidyapati said,

"Write in the remarks that this is not a complaint."

Pramila smiled.

"On a complaint screen, I can write that the complaint is not a complaint.

But the complaint will still remain open."

"And the original application?"

"Under dispute."

Vidyapati read again the line he himself had written:

"Citizen has not challenged the decision."

The sentence was correct.

The system behaved exactly the opposite way.

Pramila said,

"There is one possible way.

The department can give an 'interim status.'"

"Then?"

“That can be treated as the solution and the complaint can be closed.”

“What is the interim status?”

“Case under process.”

Vidyapati did not laugh.

For four months Chandrakala Devi’s receipt had been saying exactly that.

“She came here for that answer?”

Pramila shrugged.

“I am telling you the workaround.”

The next day Manoj entered an interim status:

“Case under process.”

The complaint screen rejected it.

Red letters appeared:

“Resolution unclear. Select result of action.”

The choices were:

“Approved”

“Rejected”

“Partial Relief”

“Other.”

When Manoj selected “Other,” a reason field opened.

He wrote:

“Original application deferred due to complaint.”

The screen replied:

“Do not mention the complaint in the resolution.”

Manoj rose from his chair and went to the window.

Outside, a line of people stood along the veranda.

Some had come for caste certificates.

Some for old-age payments.

Some for damage assistance.

To them, the papers belonged to different lives.

On the screen, everything became boxes of the same colour.

Three days later, Chandrakala Devi came again.

She carried the same green bundle.

“Has the answer come?”

Vidyapati asked her to sit.

“There has been a complication.”

“In the papers?”

“In the question.”

“Was my question wrong?”

“No.”

“Then?”

Vidyapati turned the screen towards her.

“Your question became a complaint.”

“I told you that the same day.”

“And as soon as the complaint opened, the original application was stopped.”

For a few moments Chandrakala Devi looked at the screen.

"I asked why the application was stuck.
By asking, I have now made the application truly stuck?"

Vidyapati did not answer.

From beside him, Renuka Devi said softly,

"This time, yes."

Chandrakala Devi opened the bundle.

She took out the GR-7318 slip.

"Shall I tear this up?"

"No.

Tearing it will not erase the screen."

"Then I withdraw the complaint."

Vidyapati searched for a "Withdraw Complaint" option.

He found one.

When he opened it, the system asked for the reason:

"Resolution completed."

"Complaint registered by mistake."

"Other."

Vidyapati selected the second.

A new warning appeared:

"Complainant shall confirm that no further action is required on complaint."

Chandrakala Devi said,

"That is correct."

Vidyapati continued.

The next question was:

"Current status of original application?"

There were four choices:

"Approved"

"Rejected"

"Disposed"

"Closed."

There was no:

"Under Process."

Vidyapati stopped again.

Chandrakala Devi understood that something else had jammed.

"Now what?"

"To withdraw it, the system also wants the status of the original application."

"The very status I asked about and became a complainant for asking?"

"Yes."

Chandrakala Devi placed the slip on the desk.

"Then you keep this."

She stood up.

Vidyapati said,

"Where are you going?"

"Home."

"I will find some solution."

"Will the tin on the house wait for the solution?"

The question was asked very quietly.

Vidyapati did not answer.

That evening a strong wind rose.

The upper sheet of tin over the southern bamboo screen of Chandrakala Devi's house tore loose again.

Her younger son Rohit stood holding the bamboo until neighbour Ramsevak arrived with rope.

That night Chandrakala Devi did not look at the application receipt.

She looked at the wall of her house.

The next morning Vidyapati went to the Flood Rehabilitation Branch.

Seeing him, Manoj asked,

"Have you come from the Complaint Branch?"

"No.

The tin on the citizen's house came loose."

Manoj fell silent.

He took out the original file.

The papers were complete.

Damage inspection complete.

Bank verification complete.

There was even an officer's note:

"Eligible."

"Then why four months?" Vidyapati asked.

Manoj turned through the pages.

"First we were waiting for the budget instalment.

Then list reconciliation.

Now the complaint."

"No decision until the complaint is removed?"

"Not on the digital screen."

"On paper?"

Manoj looked at him.

"On paper the officer can write the decision.

But generation of the digital order is blocked."

"Write the decision."

"And the complaint?"

"Write the reason for the complaint:

'Citizen's status query.'"

Manoj smiled.

"Are you making rules now?"

"No.

I am writing the question."

They went together to the Branch Officer's room.

Branch Officer Naresh Thakur heard the whole matter.

At first he became angry.

"Why was a complaint opened on an individual application?"

Vidyapati said,

“There is no other field for asking the status of an individual application.”

“Then the citizen should have been told to wait.”

“She had already been hearing that for four months.”

Naresh Babu looked at Manoj.

“File complete?”

“Yes.”

“Eligible?”

“Yes.”

“Budget?”

“Available in this instalment.”

“Then write approval on paper.”

Manoj wrote it.

Naresh Babu signed.

The decision on the original file was now clear.

The digital screen still said:

“Under Dispute.”

Vidyapati hurried to the Complaint Branch.

Pramila looked at the file.

“Now we have final action.”

She opened the complaint screen.

“Original Application — Approved.”

“Resolution — Status clarified and decision taken on application.”

“Complainant satisfied?”

Everyone stopped.

Vidyapati said,

“I will not fill that.”

“Why?”

“She never made a complaint.

How can I presume satisfaction?”

Pramila said,

“The field is mandatory.”

“Is there a ‘Not Applicable’ option?”

“No.”

Manoj, who had come with him, said,

“Press ‘Yes.’

The application is approved.”

Vidyapati remembered Chandrakala Devi’s question:

“Whose complaint is it?”

He did not press “Yes.”

He pressed “No.”

The screen immediately opened a new field:

“Dissatisfied complaint shall be escalated to higher level.”

Pramila held her head.

“See?”

Vidyapati went back to the previous page.

He did not press “Yes.”

He did not press “No.”

He left the screen open.

That day GR-7318 was not disposed of.

On paper, the original file was approved.

The digital order still had not been generated.

There was a District Coordination Meeting that afternoon.

Pramila presented GR-7318 as an example.

Representatives from the Digital Branch, Flood Rehabilitation Branch, Complaint Branch, and Public Service Centre were present.

Rakesh, the Digital Branch engineer, said,

“The system assumes that a question raised about an individual case is a complaint.”

Vidyapati asked,

“Why does it assume that?”

“Because the status of an individual case is not public information.”

“Then where is the right to ask for status?”

Rakesh was silent for a few moments.

“The user can see status on their dashboard.”

“It shows only ‘under process.’”

“For security reasons, internal branch stages are not displayed.”

“Then the citizen will ask.”

“That is what the assistance window is for.”

“The assistance window opens a complaint.”

There was a faint laugh in the room.

Rakesh smiled too.

Then he said,

“Then we need a new category.”

Pramila wrote it down:

“Status Enquiry.”

Naresh Babu said,

“It should not be a complaint.”

“And it should not block the original application.”

“And for answering it, the branch should give a one-line stage:

inspection pending,

budget pending,

decision pending,

papers pending—

whatever can be disclosed.”

Vidyapati added,

“The citizen should not be treated as having lodged an objection.”

Rakesh said,

“A new field can be made.

But what about old GR-7318?”

Everyone fell silent again.

Pramila said,

“The old register cannot be erased.”

“Then?”

“Close it through a special remark.”

“Satisfaction?”

Rakesh looked at the screen.

“I do not have authority to remove that field.”

Naresh Babu said,

“Call Chandrakala Devi.

Enter her answer.”

The next day Chandrakala Devi came again.

This time she was taken to the third floor.

Seeing people from four branches seated before her, she looked startled.

“Have I done something wrong?”

Pramila immediately said,

“No.”

Vidyapati said,

“Your application has been approved on paper.”

Chandrakala Devi’s face opened slightly.

“When will the money come?”

Manoj said,

“As soon as the digital order is generated.”

“It has not been generated yet?”

“The complaint has to be closed.”

Chandrakala Devi took out the GR-7318 slip.

By now, from repeated folding, the paper had become soft.

Pramila asked,

“We need the answer to one question.

Are you satisfied with the resolution of the complaint?”

Chandrakala Devi remained silent for a long time.

“What complaint?”

No one answered.

She asked again,

“The thing I asked—

where my papers were stuck—

did I get the answer to that?”

Vidyapati said,

“You have it now.

First the case was held up by budget and list reconciliation.

Then by the complaint.”

“So now I know the answer for the first four months?”

“Yes.”

“And the complaint?”

Pramila said softly,

“That was the question.”

Chandrakala Devi smiled.

“Then write:

the question has been answered.”

Rakesh said,

“The screen asks for ‘Yes’ or ‘No.’”

“Then the screen is not asking me what I said.”

The room fell silent again.

Naresh Babu picked up his pen.

On paper he wrote:

“Citizen had submitted no complaint; status enquiry was mistakenly registered under complaint category. Citizen has been informed of status. Satisfaction field not applicable.”

Rakesh opened the special technical-comment permission instead of entering “Yes.”

The same remark was entered.

GR-7318 was closed.

The red “Under Dispute” band disappeared from the original application.

Manoj generated the digital order.

Two days later, the first instalment reached Chandrakala Devi’s bank account.

She did not come back to the Public Service Centre.

A week later Vidyapati saw her in the market.

She was asking prices at a bamboo shop.

He raised a hand from a distance.

Chandrakala Devi recognised him.

“The wall?”

“Half of it is up.”

“The rest?”

“After the second instalment.”

Vidyapati smiled.

“If you need to ask the status again?”

Chandrakala Devi smiled too.

“This time, before asking, I will ask:
what will open if I ask the question?”

Vidyapati was about to reply, but just then the shopkeeper called out the measurement of the bamboo.

They left the conversation there.

A month later, the digital screen at the Public Service Centre changed.

Between:

“General Information”

and

“Formal Complaint”

a new option appeared:

“Status Enquiry.”

Five people pressed that button on the first day.

None of their original applications was stopped.

In the evening, while closing the screen, Vidyapati searched for GR-7318.

The case was closed.

The remark still remained below:

“Citizen has not challenged the decision; she is only asking for the location/status of the pending application.”

Beside that line, the system had added a new word on its own:

“Disposed.”

Vidyapati closed the screen.

The system now had an answer to Chandrakala Devi’s first question too.

But the question itself remained preserved in the history of a complaint.

STORY 170

THE SCANNER'S BLACK SHADOW

In the digital room of the District Pension Branch, the work of scanning old papers was usually done after noon.

In the mornings there was a crowd of people: receipts were issued for applications, service books were matched, bank details were checked. After two in the afternoon the window was closed, and inside, the process of turning old files into images began.

Madhav Jha was a junior records assistant in this room. On his desk stood a dual-screen computer, a flatbed scanner, a thin wooden strip for straightening papers, and a small box filled with metal clips.

That Tuesday an application came to him—the payment of arrears on Sumitra Devi's family pension.

The application had been stuck for three months.

On the line for the reason were only four words: "Service certificate appears cancelled."

At first Madhav assumed that the certificate itself must indeed bear a cancellation stamp. He opened the digital file.

On the screen appeared the image of a thirty-year-old document. The paper looked yellowed, with the school inspector's blue seal in the middle, two signatures below, and a black diagonal mark in the upper right-hand corner.

The mark was small, but it almost touched the outer ring of the seal.

Madhav enlarged the image.

The black line was thick in one place, thin in another. In the middle lay a semicircular shadow. Seen from a distance, it looked as though someone had struck a black line through the seal.

The previous note in the file read: "Cancellation mark suspected; verification against original required."

After that came a second note: "Original record in secure repository; not immediately available."

A third note followed: "Verification pending."

That was the whole history of three months.

Sumitra Devi came to the window again that same day.

She was around seventy. She wore a white cotton sari, carried an old bamboo walking stick, and kept her receipts in a cloth bag.

She asked, "Babu, is it still cancelled?"

Madhav looked straight at her.

"It has not yet been decided whether the document is cancelled or whether there is merely a mark in the image."

"My husband taught in that school for thirty years. How did that become cancelled?"

Madhav said, "Not the service. There is a mark on the image of the document."

Sumitra Devi remained silent for a few moments.

"If the image gets cancelled, the service stops too, doesn't it?"

Madhav had no direct answer to that question.

He wrote a new date on the receipt and said, "I will examine the source of the old scan."

Sumitra Devi put the receipt back into her bag.

"Where is the original document?"

"In the district secure repository."

"Then look at it."

"Entry there is through a list."

"Put the name on the list."

Madhav gave a faint smile.

"The list is prepared at the end of the month."

Sumitra Devi smiled too, but there was weariness in her smile.

"Will the month of my pension end first, or the month in which the list is prepared?"

Madhav did not answer.

That evening he searched the old register of the scanning room.

Bundles of papers had been scanned year by year. Sumitra Devi's certificate had been digitised five years earlier in "Batch 47."

The register gave the name of the person who had scanned it—Shashikant.

Shashikant was now retired.

Madhav opened an old cupboard in the repository. A box of materials used during scanning was still there—erasers, dusting brushes, old cloths, glass-cleaning fluid, and several metal clips.

Some of the clips were straight; some had been pressed and bent out of shape.

One clip had a raised semicircular top.

Madhav turned it over in his hand.

Then he looked again at the black shadow on the certificate on the screen.

The shapes were almost alike.

But "almost" is not official proof.

The next day he opened other images from Batch 47.

First page—no shadow.

Second—a small black semicircle in the upper right-hand corner.

Third—none.

Fourth—the same semicircle again.

Madhav examined twenty images. Five had a black mark in almost the same place.

The documents were from different departments, different years, and bore different signatures.

One was an order correcting a date of birth, one a transfer letter for a school building, one an old pay fixation, one a library grant, and one Sumitra Devi's service certificate.

All five documents had been scanned on the same day.

The first clear suspicion formed in Madhav's mind—the mark was not on the paper; it lay in the manner of scanning.

He called Ravindrakant from the Image Quality Section.

Ravindrakant looked at the screen.

"The position of these marks is almost the same."

"A clip?" Madhav asked.

"Possible. If the paper was lifting, someone may have fastened it with a clip."

"Would the shadow be this black?"

"In the old scanner, the light fell strongly from one side. A raised piece of metal would cast a black shadow."

Madhav placed the old bent clip on the desk.

"This?"

Ravindrakant looked at it.

"The shape matches, but that does not prove that this was the very clip used five years ago."

"Then what would prove it?"

"The same-shaped mark in the same place on several unrelated documents from the same batch—that is strong evidence."

Madhav said, "Will strong evidence release the pension?"

Ravindrakant did not laugh.

"Read the rules."

The rules had no separate category called "scanner-generated shadow."

There were three categories—clear, illegible, doubtful.

Sumitra Devi's document was "doubtful."

For a doubtful image, the original was required.

The original was in the secure repository.

After the previous flood, the secure repository had been shifted to the new building of the District Archives. The old files there had been kept in a closed section for mould control and cataloguing.

Entry required the branch head's permission, the record number, and the monthly withdrawal list.

Madhav prepared a permission note.

The branch head, Nilima Chaudhary, read it.

"Open the closed repository for one pension case?"

"Not only for one pension case. Five images from Batch 47 carry the same mark."

Nilima Devi examined all five images.

"Did the other four cases face any difficulty?"

Madhav checked.

Two of the documents had already been used. No one had raised any question about the mark. A school-building transfer had been accepted on the basis of the same image. The library-grant file had also been closed.

Madhav told her this.

Nilima Devi leaned back in her chair.

"So the same mark means cancellation on one document and nothing at all on another?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

"In Sumitra Devi's image, the shadow cuts across the ring of the seal. On the other papers it lies only near the edge."

Nilima Devi enlarged the image again.

"So the meaning of the mark is being decided by where it falls, not by where it came from."

Madhav said, "Exactly."

Nilima Devi signed the permission.

"Call for the original from the repository. Also arrange a sample check of Batch 47."

The permission was sent.

Three days later the reply came: "Record section closed to withdrawals for the next fifteen days owing to ongoing conservation work."

Sumitra Devi came for the fourth time.

Madhav read the reply out to her.

She listened in silence.

"After fifteen days?"

"Then the list will be prepared again."

"And the pension?"

"Pending."

Sumitra Devi took an old photocopy out of her bag.

"I found this at home."

Madhav took it.

The school inspector's seal was clear on it. The upper right-hand corner was clean. There was no black shadow.

For a moment Madhav's heart beat faster.

"Is this a photocopy of the original?"

"My husband had it made sometime. I do not know when."

Madhav compared the two. The handwriting, seal, date, and folds in the paper all matched.

But the photocopy from home was not officially certified.

He knew the rule.

"This is very useful."

"Then can the work be done?"

Madhav paused.

"It shows that the black mark may not be part of the original document. But the Payment Branch will ask for a certified source."

Sumitra Devi closed her bag.

"I have the paper, you have the image, and the repository has the original. All three places say the same thing, yet the work cannot be done."

Madhav said quietly, "The black shadow is standing between all three."

That afternoon Madhav conducted a small test.

He placed a sheet of white paper on the scanner and fixed the bent clip at the upper right-hand corner.

The first image was faint.

Ravindrakant said, "Raise the clip a little."

Madhav slipped a thin piece of cardboard beneath the paper. The clip rose halfway.

In the second scan, a black semicircular shadow appeared.

He opened Sumitra Devi's image beside it.

The shapes were not exactly identical, but the physical character of the shadow was clear—a thick black edge, a pale semicircle within it, and a thin grey spread in the direction opposite the light.

Ravindrakant retrieved sample images from the records of the scanner used five years earlier.

In that machine the light had fallen from right to left. The spread of the shadow on Sumitra Devi's image followed the same direction.

Madhav prepared a report titled "Test of Mechanically Generated Image Shadow."

The report listed five grounds: a mark in the same position on unrelated documents from the same batch; absence of the mark from the old photocopy kept at home; reproduction of a black semicircle with a metal clip; correspondence between the shadow and the old scanner's direction of light; and the temporary inaccessibility of the original because of conservation work.

Nilima Devi read the report.

"In your conclusion you have written, 'The document is not cancelled.'"

Madhav said, "Shouldn't I?"

"We do not have the original. What we can say is that the mark in the image is not proof of cancellation."

Madhav changed the sentence.

"There is insufficient basis to treat the black mark visible in the available digital image as a cancellation mark; there are strong technical indications that the mark is a scanner-generated shadow."

Nilima Devi said, "Now it is correct."

The report went to the Payment Branch.

A question came back from there: "If it is not cancelled, what is the proof that it is valid?"

Madhav read it and remained silent for a while.

Nilima Devi said, "They are asking the question backwards. What we have to establish is that there is no basis for cancellation; the other elements of validity are already in the file."

Ashok Babu, the officer in charge of the Payment Branch, came for a meeting.

He said, "I will not take the risk. What if the original is opened tomorrow and an actual cancellation mark is found?"

Madhav placed all five images before him.

"Then what about these four documents?"

Ashok Babu looked at the image of the school-building transfer.

It carried the same black mark, but near the corner.

"This one was accepted earlier."

"Yes."

"No one objected?"

"No."

"Then the same mark has produced different decisions."

Nilima Devi said, "Not the rule. The eye has."

The room was quiet for a few moments.

Ashok Babu looked at the photocopy from Sumitra Devi's home.

"This is not certified."

"Not certified, but it is comparative evidence," Madhav said.

In the end, an interim order was issued: until the original record could be opened, the undisputed portion of the family pension would continue on the basis of the available valid service details, pay register, appointment order, and school certification; only the disputed old arrears would remain withheld until verification of the original.

Sumitra Devi had to make a fifth journey this time.

Madhav read the order out to her.

She was not very pleased, but for the first time her eyes held something besides waiting.

"The monthly pension will continue?"

"Yes."

"The arrears?"

"After the original is seen."

"And the black shadow?"

Madhav said, "It is no longer being treated as a cancellation mark."

Sumitra Devi looked at the paper.

"So the shadow has been given a name of its own?"

Madhav smiled.

"Imaging error."

She laughed.

"Once it has a name, half the trouble is gone."

Fifteen days later, withdrawals from the secure repository opened again.

Madhav, Ravindrakant, and the records officer examined the original certificate together.

At the upper right-hand corner of the paper were two small pressure marks from a metal clip, but no black stroke. The inspector's blue seal was intact.

Madhav kept looking at that corner for a long time.

The black shadow existed only in the digital image.

The records officer said, "There is nothing here."

Madhav replied, "There was a great deal in the image."

A new image was made from the original. This time the paper was held flat with a transparent strip, without a clip.

The new image was clean.

The old image was not deleted.

It was retained under the name “Previous image—with scanner shadow,” because three months of decision-making history had been built upon it.

The order releasing Sumitra Devi’s arrears was issued the following week.

Madhav thought the matter was over.

But the other four images from Batch 47 still remained.

He opened them all.

On one document the shadow lay at the edge.

On another it was far from the signature.

On the third it lay in a blank space.

On the fourth it was not directly over a seal, but close to a number.

Madhav added a technical note to all four files: “A black mark must not be treated as a basis for a documentary decision without independent examination of its source.”

On this basis Ravindrakant prepared a short guideline.

The new rule was not very long.

Only three lines: if a black line or shadow in an image changes the meaning of a document, examine other images from the same batch, any available copy of the original, and the imaging device’s pattern of error; if the original is unavailable, do not automatically treat the shadow as a cancellation mark; record the basis of the decision in a separate note.

A month later, a new subcategory was added beneath “Doubtful” on the digital screen—“Possible Imaging Error.”

For a test, Madhav opened Sumitra Devi’s old image.

The black semicircle was still there.

The new screen had not removed it.

But beside it, in green letters, now appeared: “Original verified; shadow scanner-generated.”

Madhav looked at it for a long time.

For three months, the shadow of a five-year-old clip had stood between a dead teacher’s service and a living woman’s pension.

The shadow had not been erased.

Only its authority had ended.

THE INSIDE LETTER SENT OUTSIDE

In the northern row of rooms at the District Archives, a thin line of damp would begin to descend the wall as soon as the rains began.

The room held old land-record files, map tubes, settlement registers, and bundles of orders twenty or twenty-five years old.

This year the roof repairs had remained unfinished. After the first heavy rain, Record Keeper Naresh Jha had two bundles lying beneath the northern wall lifted away.

That afternoon Assistant Director Suchitra Devi had a short internal order drawn up—the records from the five cupboards in the northern room were to be shifted temporarily to the southern hall, and returned only after the roof inspection was complete.

The order was routine.

At the top of the paper was written: “For Internal Circulation Only.”

The recipients were three branches—Records, Building Maintenance, and Indexing.

Naresh Babu thought the work would begin by evening.

But the order had not reached his desk by evening.

The next morning he telephoned the Indexing Branch.

The reply came from there: “We have not received it either.”

The Building Maintenance Branch said, “On the digital portal the order is showing as ‘Dispatched.’”

Naresh Babu was startled.

“Dispatched where?”

The answer came: “External mail.”

He went straight to the mail room.

In the mail room, Ramakant Babu was cleaning a rubber stamp. Before him lay a stack of outgoing letters, registered envelopes, and the open dispatch register.

Naresh Babu gave him the order number.

Ramakant checked the register.

“Yes. Yesterday at four twenty-seven, an external dispatch number was assigned to it.”

“But this was an internal order.”

Ramakant pushed his glasses up.

“It was. But one line slipped in the list.”

He opened the digital portal. Two orders had been created at the same time. The first was an external letter to the District Construction Division for a roof inspection. The second was the internal order for shifting the records within the building.

While the dispatch list was being prepared, the recipient of the first letter had remained against the second line, and the number of the second order had been entered in the external dispatch register.

Naresh Babu said, "Correct it."

Ramakant Babu moved the cursor beside 'Dispatched.'

The correction box was greyed out.

"It cannot be changed now."

"Why?"

"Once an external dispatch number has been generated, the status can change only to 'Received.'"

"Received by whom?"

"By the person to whom the letter was sent."

Naresh Babu looked at him for a few moments.

"Where did the letter go?"

Ramakant Babu looked towards the stack.

The order was still there.

In the upper right corner was a blue stamp—'External Dispatch 4873.'

The paper had not left the building.

Naresh Babu picked it up.

"Then I am the recipient myself."

Ramakant Babu shook his head.

"The digital portal will not accept that. Receipt of an external dispatch requires an external inward number."

"Shall I take this paper to the Records Branch?"

"The paper can go. But on the portal the order is still 'outside.' If the branch starts the work, an inspection may ask how an internal transfer was carried out on the basis of an external letter."

Naresh Babu put the paper back on the table.

Outside, the rain had begun again.

In the afternoon, the first drop fell from the ceiling of the northern room.

It landed on top of Cupboard Number Six.

Naresh Babu sent for a tarpaulin sheet. The cupboard was covered.

Mamta Jha from the Indexing staff asked, "Shall we shift the files?"

"The order is stuck."

"But the order has been issued."

"It has been issued, but according to the office it has gone outside."

Instead of replying, Mamta looked up at the ceiling.

A second drop fell.

In the evening Suchitra Devi herself came to inspect the northern room.

Naresh Babu explained the situation.

She looked at the order.

"I have signed it."

"Yes."

"The paper is here."

"Yes."

"Then how is the order outside?"

Ramakant Babu was called.

He came carrying the dispatch register.

"The status is tied to the external dispatch number."

Suchitra Devi asked, "Strike out the number."

"Striking anything out in the register is prohibited. For correction, the status 'Undelivered/Returned' is required, and that status will not open without a postal receipt report."

"The paper never went to the post office."

"Then how can it be returned?"

For a few moments there was only the sound of rain in the room.

Suchitra Devi looked at the portal.

Against Order 4873 it read: 'Dispatched; receipt awaited.'

She said, "Enter today's date and add a note—dispatch error."

Ramakant Babu tried.

The note box opened, but the status did not change.

'Dispatch error—the letter did not leave the office premises' was entered and saved.

Naresh Babu asked, "Can we act on the basis of this note?"

On the digital portal the 'Implementing Branch' field was blank.

That field opened only when the status was 'Received.'

Suchitra Devi said quietly, "The paper will have to go around and come back."

Ramakant Babu understood.

"The post office?"

"Yes."

An ordinary envelope was made for the order.

In the recipient field the office's own name was written—"District Archives, Main Building."

Naresh Babu said, "We have to send our own letter to our own address?"

Suchitra Devi said, "The letter does not need the route. The portal does."

Before five that evening, Ramakant Babu took the envelope to the nearby post office along with the external mail.

The postal employee laughed when he saw the address.

"This is your own building."

"Yes."

"You could have delivered it by hand."

Ramakant Babu replied, "It was delivered by hand. Now it has to come back by post."

The employee laughed again, but stamped it.

That night the rain intensified.

In the northern room, Naresh Babu, Mamta, and two peons stayed late.

Under the order, they were not authorized to move the cupboards.

So they did not move the cupboards.

They lifted the lower bundles inside the cupboards onto the upper shelves, laid wooden strips on the floor, stretched tarpaulin three cubits away from the damp wall, and placed buckets beneath the dripping places.

Mamta said, "Is this not shifting?"
 Naresh Babu said, "No. This is preservation."
 They looked at each other and smiled.
 By ten at night, five buckets had been replaced in turn.
 The rain stopped towards dawn.
 At half past ten in the morning, the postman arrived at the main gate.
 In his bag was the office's own envelope.
 Its arrival was entered in the gate register.
 The envelope was opened in the mail room.
 Ramakant Babu assigned it an external inward number—"Receipt 2161."
 On the digital portal, the status of Order 4873 changed from 'Dispatched' to 'Received.'
 Immediately the 'Implementing Branch' field opened.
 The names of the three branches were selected.
 At eleven o'clock the same order appeared again on Naresh Babu's portal.
 At the top it read: 'Internal implementation after receipt of external letter.'
 Naresh Babu looked at the sentence for a long time.
 What he had wandered from his desk to the mail room searching for yesterday had today gone around through the post office and returned to his desk, now valid.
 The work of shifting the cupboards began.
 Each file was ticked off in the list and placed in the southern hall.
 By afternoon, Cupboard Number Six was empty.
 The wall behind it was wet.
 Mamta showed him a thin file whose outer cover had caught a little damp at one corner.
 The papers inside were safe.
 Naresh Babu breathed a sigh of relief.
 In the afternoon Suchitra Devi came for an inspection.
 On the portal she saw the entire journey—internal order; External Dispatch 4873; dispatch-error note; dispatch through the post office; External Receipt 2161; internal implementation.
 She said, "A paper left the building and returned to the building, and only then did we accept what it was saying."
 Ramakant Babu remained silent.
 Mamta said, "The paper was saying the same thing yesterday too."
 Suchitra Devi looked at her.
 "Yes. But yesterday the system was not listening to it."
 That week the mail-room list and the internal-circulation list began to be printed on sheets of different colours.
 A new safeguard was also added to the digital portal—if an order marked 'For Internal Circulation Only' was entered in the external dispatch list, it would ask for confirmation a second time.
 While testing this new safeguard, Ramakant Babu searched for Order 4873 again.

Its entire journey was still preserved on the portal.

In that sequence, one small detail caught his eye.

The inward time of the envelope that had returned from the post office was half past ten.

But the first entry in the preservation register of the northern room was from seven-oh-five the previous evening—‘Lower bundles lifted upward; wooden strips laid on floor.’

In other words, people had begun the work long before the paper’s valid journey was complete.

Ramakant Babu told Naresh Babu about it.

Naresh Babu said, “I did not implement the order.”

“Then what was this?”

“What, if left undone, would have let the papers get wet.”

Ramakant Babu looked at the portal again.

The first status of the order there was ‘Dispatched.’

The second—‘Received.’

The third—‘Implemented.’

There was no status for the preservation carried out at night.

He thought of adding a short note, then stopped.

If he added a note, another question would arise—how had the work been done before the order was received?

He closed the portal.

In the afternoon Naresh Babu stood looking at the empty cupboard in the northern room.

Outside, the sun had come out.

A thin line of water was still visible on the damp wall.

The old files were safe in the southern hall.

And in the dispatch register, the journey of Order 4873 was complete.

The paper had truly gone outside.

But the people who had saved what the order was made to save had remained inside all the while.

STORY 172

THE FIRST DAY OF APPOINTMENT

At twenty past nine on Monday morning, Vinayakant Jha reached the gate of the District Land Records Office. In his hand was a brown envelope containing his appointment letter, copies of his educational certificates, his character certificate, and three photographs. The final line of the appointment letter read: "Service shall be deemed to commence from the day of assumption of charge."

Vinayakant had read this sentence two or three times along the way. To him, the matter seemed perfectly clear. Reach the office, assume charge, and service begins from that day.

At the gate, the guard examined the appointment letter, entered his name in the register, and handed him a visitor slip. The time on the slip was 9:22.

"Establishment Branch, second floor," the guard said.

Outside the Establishment Branch on the second floor, seven blue files lay on a table. Inside, Pramod Babu was searching for something on his computer screen. Vinayakant held out his appointment letter.

Pramod Babu read the letter and smiled. "All right—" he began, then stopped and changed the sentence. "All right, you are here from today."

He opened a thick charge register. The first box on the new page was for the employee's name. The second—for the payroll number. The third—for the date of assuming charge.

After writing the name, Pramod Babu stopped at the second box.

"Your payroll number?"

Vinayakant said, "I have not been given one."

"Not in the appointment letter?"

They both looked at the letter again. There was no number.

Pramod Babu picked up the telephone. "Rekha ji, there is a new appointment. Where will the payroll number come from?"

The answer came from the Accounts Branch downstairs: "Once the service-start date is entered."

Pramod Babu put down the telephone and looked at Vinayakant.

"But the service-start date is what we are supposed to enter in this register," Vinayakant said.

"Yes. But the register cannot be entered without a payroll number."

For a few moments, both remained silent.

With a pencil, Pramod Babu put a small dot in the empty box of the register. "Sit down. I will ask the Establishment Officer."

Establishment Officer Sujata Chaudhary arrived at ten. She read the letter, opened the digital portal, and began entering Vinayakant's details. Name, father's name, date of birth, address, post—everything went in. The final box turned red: "Employee number mandatory."

"The Payroll Branch will issue the employee number," she said.

Rekha Devi was called upstairs. She came carrying her small notebook. She looked at the portal and said, "To create the payroll number, we need the appointment date, date of assumption of charge, and office code."

"The date of assumption of charge is today," Sujata Chaudhary said.

Rekha Devi shook her head. "In the digital system, the date of assumption of charge can be entered only after the employee number is created."

"Then create the number first."

"The screen for creating the number will not move forward without the date of assumption of charge."

A faint ripple of laughter passed through the room, but no one quite laughed.

Sujata Chaudhary said, "All right. Put it in writing that the employee reported today. We will enter it once the system opens."

On the copy of the appointment letter, Pramod Babu wrote: "Reported on 22 September 2026 at 9:22 a.m." He signed below. Sujata Chaudhary signed as well.

Vinayakant was given a desk in the third room. One leg of the chair was slightly shorter than the others; in the desk drawer lay old carbon paper and two broken clips.

His work was to check the digital lists of old land records. The computer could not be opened without login credentials, and login credentials could not be created without an employee number. So on the first day Pramod Babu gave him twenty pages of printed lists.

Vinayakant began marking errors on paper. By evening he had identified differences in names, khasra numbers, or village spellings in thirty-seven entries.

At five o'clock he went to the charge register. The second box was still empty.

"Where do I sign?" he asked.

Pramod Babu said, "For now, in this visitor register. The number should come by tomorrow."

The number did not come the next day. Nor on the third day.

Every day Vinayakant took a visitor slip at the gate, went upstairs, sat at his desk, and checked papers. By the seventh day, the guard had begun filling out the slip in advance when he saw him. Only the time was left blank.

On the tenth day, Sujata Chaudhary gave him a file—the digital index of a seventy-year-old map. "You have a good eye for this. Prepare a discrepancy list within three days."

Vinayakant prepared the list. In the space for his designation beside his name on the file, Pramod Babu wrote in pencil: "New appointee."

On the fifteenth day, an inspection team arrived. One member of the team asked, "Which branch does this gentleman belong to?"

Pramod Babu replied naturally, "Record Assistant under Establishment."

The inspector looked at the list. "Employee number?"

No one answered immediately.

Vinayakant took out his appointment letter. The inspector examined it and then said, “Proof of assumption of charge?”

Pramod Babu showed him the handwritten note dated 22 September.

The inspector said, “This is proof of attendance. Where is the entry in the charge register?”

“The payroll number has not been created.”

The inspector removed his glasses and placed them on the table. “Then, in the system, this employee has not begun service.”

At that moment, every eye in the room turned towards Vinayakant. He had been sitting at that same desk for three weeks.

After the inspection, a short observation arrived: “The legal status of work performed by the employee during the pre-assumption-of-charge period shall be clarified.”

Vinayakant read the observation three times. “Pre-assumption-of-charge period” had been written for the days on which he had spent eight hours a day in the office.

At the end of the month, the salary list was prepared. Vinayakant’s name was not on it.

Rekha Devi said, “We can add the name, but first we need the start date.”

“Twenty-second September,” Vinayakant said.

“The portal will not accept that date, because your employee number did not exist on that day.”

“Then on what day will the number be created?”

“When the start date is entered.”

Vinayakant did not laugh. By now the sentence had become familiar to him.

The following week, an instruction came from the district office that in such cases a “temporary employee number” could be issued. Everyone felt relieved.

Pramod Babu opened the screen for creating a temporary number. First box—name. Second—post. Third—“Date of commencement of service.”

Pramod Babu leaned back in his chair.

“The same thing again?” Sujata Chaudhary asked.

“Yes.”

After much thought, Rekha Devi suggested, “Enter today’s date provisionally. Once the number is created, we can correct it to the earlier date.”

Vinayakant asked, “Then what happens to my first month?”

Rekha Devi said, “It can be paid as arrears once the correction is made.”

“And for the correction?”

“Proof of the original date of assumption of charge will be required.”

Pramod Babu picked up the handwritten note of 22 September. The inspection team had called that paper only proof of attendance.

Sujata Chaudhary remained silent for a long time. At last she said, “Without a temporary number, nothing else will move. Enter today’s date. Also attach a note that the actual date is under determination.”

That day Vinayakant received a temporary employee number—T-741. His computer login was created. For the first time, the attendance machine accepted his thumb. Green letters appeared on the screen: “Welcome. First day of service.”

Vinayakant kept looking at the screen. The date that day was 21 October.

The previous twenty-nine days existed in the visitor register, in files, in the inspection observation, in the error lists, and in the memories of his colleagues; for the digital system, all of them belonged to a time before service.

His salary came at the end of the month, but only from 21 October. He was told to submit a separate application for the arrears of the earlier days.

The first question on the application form was: “Employee’s service-start date.”

Vinayakant entered 22 September. The portal turned red: “Does not match the recorded service-start date.”

He entered 21 October. The next box opened: “The arrears period cannot precede the service-start date.”

Vinayakant leaned back in his chair.

Pramod Babu said, “Submit it on paper. I will send it separately.”

A paper application was prepared. Attached to it were the note on the appointment letter dated 22 September, twenty-nine visitor slips, his pencil remarks on three files, the inspection query, and the temporary-number letter dated 21 October.

The district office replied: “There is no dispute over the fact that the employee did in fact work. However, for determination of the formal service-start date, the office shall clarify on the basis of which record the employee’s first working day is to be accepted.”

Sujata Chaudhary read the letter and called Vinayakant.

“In your view, which day was the first day?”

For the first time, Vinayakant was slightly startled by the question.

“The day I came here.”

“Proof?”

Vinayakant took out his first visitor slip from the gate. 9:22.

Sujata Chaudhary said, “This is proof that you entered the building.”

“Then Pramod Babu’s note on the appointment letter.”

“That is proof of attendance.”

“My work on the files?”

“That is proof of work.”

“Then what separate thing is proof of the first day?”

No answer came immediately.

That evening Sujata Chaudhary created a new document. She titled it: “Register for Determination of Date of Assumption of Charge.” In the first row, separate boxes were made for Vinayakant’s name, date of appointment letter, time of first entry, file of first work, temporary employee number, and remarks.

The final box was: “Determined date of assumption of charge.”

That box remained empty.

Two weeks later, another new employee arrived at the office. Taking a visitor slip at the gate, he came to Pramod Babu's desk.

Pramod Babu read the appointment letter and opened the charge register.

"Payroll number?" he was about to ask, but stopped the sentence midway.

Vinayakant rose from his desk and came over.

"First write the time on this paper," he said. "Write when you entered the building, before whom you presented your appointment letter, and what first work you were given—write everything."

The new employee asked, "Is this assumption of charge?"

Vinayakant looked at him for a few moments.

"For now, this is only proof that you were here today," he said. "The rest will be decided later."

The new employee signed.

Vinayakant looked at the clock and wrote down the time.

His own first day was still under determination. But that day no longer existed only in someone's memory.

TWO SALARIES UNDER THE SAME NAME

The salary slips at the District Agriculture Office were prepared two days late that month. Since morning, employees had been coming into the accounts room with their slips in hand. Someone's dearness allowance looked too low; someone else's provident-fund deduction too high. As soon as Ramnaresh Sah looked at his slip, he first checked the date, then the name, then the gross salary. Everything seemed in order. Then his eyes stopped at one line near the bottom—"Unpaid leave: 1 day."

Ramnaresh Babu had been in the office for twenty-five years. The previous month he had not taken even a single day's leave. On the contrary, on the last Sunday of the month he had stayed two extra hours for an emergency count at the seed store. He placed the slip before Neelima Jha, the accounts assistant.

"Where has this one day come from?"

Neelima looked at the computer screen. "The fourteenth."

"On the fourteenth I was right here. My signature is in the seed-distribution register."

Neelima opened another window. "Medical leave is approved here."

Ramnaresh Babu laughed. "Then was the body mine, or the leave?"

Neelima too tried to smile, but when she saw the name on the screen, her face grew serious. "Ramnaresh Sah... employee number 2714."

Ramnaresh Babu said, "Yes."

Neelima opened another line. "But the employee number on the leave application is 7214."

Only the positions of the digits had changed. The name was the same.

Neelima said, "The employee with this number is at the Soil Testing Sub-Centre."

"He is Ramnaresh Sah too?"

"Yes."

Ramnaresh Babu remained silent for a few moments. For the first time, his own name seemed to him not a private possession but a shared article.

At noon a telephone call was made to the Soil Testing Sub-Centre. The reply from there was that the other Ramnaresh Sah had indeed been on medical leave on the fourteenth. His fever certificate had also been uploaded.

The accounts room concluded that the salary deduction had mistakenly gone to the other employee. The error seemed simple. Neelima looked for the correction option, but a new problem opened on the screen—the two employee numbers had been linked beneath a single "person record."

While records were being transferred from the old payroll system to the new digital system, the machine had seen the same name, the same father's name, and the same date of birth, and had treated the two men as one person.

Ramnaresh Babu was startled. "Even the father's name is the same?"

Neelima read it out—"Jagdish Sah."

Ramnaresh Babu said softly, "My father's name was Jagdish Sah."

The Ramnaresh Sah at the sub-centre also turned out to have a father named Jagdish Sah.

"Date of birth?"

"First of January, nineteen seventy."

Ramnaresh Babu sat upright in his chair. "That is what is written in my service book. But it is not my actual date. When my name was entered at school, only the year was known, so the first of January was written."

Neelima asked the sub-centre again. The Ramnaresh Sah there replied that his school certificate too showed the first of January, because no one in his family remembered the exact day of his birth. The year should have been different, but the digit in the digital copy of the old file was blurred; the new system had read both years as 1970.

"So this machine has made the two of us one human being?" Ramnaresh Babu asked.

Neelima said, "For the moment, that is what it believes."

For corrections there was a "Different Persons" option. As soon as it was opened, five proofs were demanded—full name, father's name, date of birth, district, and service category.

The first three were the same. The district for both was Madhubani. Both belonged to Class III service.

Neelima stared at the screen for a while. "The system asks for difference on the basis of five things, and in all five you are the same."

Ramnaresh Babu said, "We are not the same. I am sitting here, and he is sitting there."

"There is no box in which to write that."

The next day the Ramnaresh Sah from the sub-centre came to the district office himself. He looked about fifteen years younger than Ramnaresh Babu. He was shorter too. He wore a beard, whereas Ramnaresh Babu was always clean-shaven. The two looked at each other and burst out laughing.

"At least the mirror will not call us one," the younger Ramnaresh said.

Seeing the two seated together in the accounts room, employees kept peeping in from time to time. Someone joked, "Share one salary between you."

The younger Ramnaresh took out a slip. His problem was not salary. He had received a promotion notice stating that his length of service was twenty-six years. He had been appointed only seven years earlier.

"My service has grown longer," he said, "and his salary has grown smaller."

Ramnaresh Babu said, "You took my leave; I took your age."

Laughter rose again, but Neelima did not laugh. The promotion file had now become a serious matter. The system was adding the service years of the two men and treating them as one continuous service. The younger Ramnaresh's eligibility for promotion had been counted from the older Ramnaresh's year of appointment. Then, in the same merged record, the leave on the fourteenth had been deducted from the older Ramnaresh's salary.

To prove that they were different, both men brought their respective service books. On the first page of each was the name—Ramnaresh Sah. Father's name—Jagdish Sah. Date of birth—1 January. District—Madhubani. Even the category on their caste certificates was the same.

The differences lay in the year of appointment, village, employee number, and photograph. But in the "Different Persons" form, the box for the full village name allowed only twelve characters. The older Ramnaresh's village was "Pipra West," and the younger Ramnaresh's was "Pipra East." The screen displayed both only as "Pipra."

Neelima said, "The more proof I add, the denser the sameness becomes."

Both men brought their bank passbooks. The account numbers were different. But the bank branch was the same. Their signatures were different, yet both wrote "Ramnaresh Sah" in Devanagari.

Fingerprint comparison was suggested. The personnel assistant said that biometric-identification data existed in the new attendance system, but the old payroll person record did not permit access to match it.

"Then use your eyes," the older Ramnaresh said. "Both of us are standing here."

A little embarrassed, the personnel assistant said, "I believe you. But I have to make the correction from evidence, not from my eyes."

The matter was sent for approval to the District Officer. The note that came back said—"Attach departmental proof of the separate existence of the two employees."

The superintendent was ready to issue a departmental certificate. But the digital format for the certificate had an option marked "Select employee." As soon as "Ramnaresh Sah" was entered, the same person record opened, with both employee numbers linked beneath it. There was no facility for selecting two separate employees.

The superintendent wrote the certificate on paper—"Mr Ramnaresh Sah, employee number 2714, and Mr Ramnaresh Sah, employee number 7214, are two separate persons."

A digital copy of the certificate was made and placed in the file. The system rejected it as a "self-declaration," because the office issuing the certificate was the employer attached to that same merged person record.

Meanwhile, the date for preparing the month's payroll drew near. Neelima tried to stop the deduction temporarily. The machine asked—"Whose leave is to be cancelled?" In the options there was again only one Ramnaresh Sah.

The younger Ramnaresh did not want his genuine medical leave cancelled. The older Ramnaresh did not want to accept a deduction from his salary. Inside one person, the two claims became contradictory to one another.

At last the Accounts Officer issued a paper order—the older Ramnaresh's one day of salary was to be corrected manually; the younger Ramnaresh's promotion case was to be held back; and no automatic change was to be applied to either man until the merged record had been resolved.

The order saved the salary, but the problem in the system remained.

A week later an inspection team arrived. The team leader said that direct verification should be carried out. The two Ramnareshes would be observed present at two different workplaces at the same time.

At eleven in the morning, the older Ramnaresh was counting sacks of seed in the district store. At exactly eleven, the younger Ramnaresh was fifteen kos away at the Soil Testing Sub-Centre, entering sample numbers. Two members of the inspection team took photographs and signatures at the separate locations.

In the evening, when the report was being uploaded to the digital file, a new obstacle appeared. The system would not accept attendance at two locations at the same time for a single person record. In red letters the screen displayed—"Possible duplicate attendance."

The leader of the inspection team remained silent for a long time. Then he wrote on paper—"In this case, presence at two places at the same time is not evidence of an error; it is evidence of two persons."

The system had no ready-made box for that sentence. The report was attached to the file.

At the end of the month, instructions came from headquarters that the two records should not be split immediately; first the old entries for service years, leave, salary, promotion, and provident fund were to be separated one by one. For this work, two new temporary registers were created—"Ramnaresh-1" and "Ramnaresh-2."

The older Ramnaresh looked at the registers and said, "So now the names have become different?"

Neelima said, "Not the names. Numbers have been added for convenience."

The younger Ramnaresh asked, "For how long?"

"Until the system understands that there are two of you."

Two months later, the older Ramnaresh's salary was running correctly. The younger Ramnaresh's promotion was under fresh examination according to his actual years of service. In the paper files the two men were clearly separate. But the moment the digital screen was opened, the same name still shone at the top—Ramnaresh Sah. A short note had been added beneath it—"Two employees with the same name; do not auto-match."

One day the younger Ramnaresh asked with a laugh, "So are we separate now?"

Neelima looked at the screen. "On paper, yes. As for the machine, it has been instructed to keep the two of you separate."

The older Ramnaresh Babu folded his salary slip and put it in his pocket. "All right," he said. "We were separate human beings to begin with. Now we will keep reminding the system from time to time as well."

STORY 174

ABSENT FOR PROOF OF ATTENDANCE

At the Block Agriculture Office, the last Wednesday of the month meant something different from all the other days. On that day, every field employee was required to reach the district headquarters and certify his or her field attendance for the previous month. The rule was new, but in three months everyone had learned its rhythm—finish the village work by seven in the morning, reach the district by nine, give a fingerprint, show the field register, obtain the officer's signature, and return to one's work area by evening.

Poonam Kumari's work area extended across five villages. She was an Agriculture Field Assistant. Her job was to carry information to the fields about seed, disease, irrigation, and government assistance. On paper, her office was a small room in the block building, but her actual work was usually done on the bund of a field, on a panchayat veranda, at a seed shop, or in someone's courtyard.

That Wednesday she was supposed to go to Sonbarsa village early in the morning. For three days, two farmers had been asking her to look at yellow spots that had appeared on maize leaves. But on headquarters-verification day, going to the village was not possible. On Tuesday evening Poonam had told the farmer Ramlochan, "Tomorrow I have to go to headquarters. I will come and look on Thursday morning."

Ramlochan had asked, "Are you on leave?"

"Not leave. It is the day for certifying attendance."

Ramlochan had laughed. "Absent from the field in order to prove you are present?"

Poonam had laughed too. At the time, it had sounded like a joke.

At half past six on Wednesday morning, Poonam left home. In her bag were the field register, visit slips for five villages, the seed-distribution list, and, in a small box, two diseased maize leaves. Ramlochan had sent the leaves to her house the previous evening so that, at the very least, she could show them to the Plant Protection Officer at headquarters.

By the time she reached the district headquarters it was ten minutes past nine. At the gate there was a long queue of field employees—some from the Animal Husbandry Department, some from the Land Measurement Branch, some from Water Resources. Everyone carried registers, verification slips, and bags.

The fingerprint machine installed at the gate kept stalling that day. The first time, it failed to capture Poonam's fingerprint. The second time, the screen displayed—"Try again." The third time, a green mark flashed. The time was recorded—9:27.

A small line appeared beneath it—"Headquarters Verification Attendance."

Poonam breathed a sigh of relief. At least the first stage of the day's principal task was complete.

By ten o'clock all the employees were seated in the hall. Names were called one by one, field registers were checked, and the previous month's visit dates were matched against the digital record. Poonam's turn came at eleven fifteen.

Checking Officer Arun Jha turned the pages of her register and asked, "Ramapur on the seventeenth, Sonbarsa on the eighteenth, Pipra on the nineteenth?"

"Yes."

"There is no fingerprint at the block office for three consecutive days."

Poonam said, "I was on field visits. The field slips are here."

Arun Jha examined the slips. The panchayat secretary's signature, the farmer group's mark, and the times of the visits were all recorded. He affixed the approval stamp.

"Today's verification is complete," he said. "Again on the last Wednesday next month."

Poonam gathered her register. She was heading towards the Plant Protection Room to show the maize leaves when her mobile phone rang. It was Ramlochan.

"Didi, the officers have come to the field."

Poonam stopped. "Which officers?"

"An inspection team from the district. They are asking where the Field Assistant is. I told them you have gone to headquarters. They are asking why the field has been left unattended on a working day."

Poonam turned back towards the hall. Arun Jha was still checking registers at the table. After hearing her, he said, "The inspection team belongs to a different branch. Tell them that headquarters verification was compulsory."

"I can tell them, but they are at the field."

"Your proof of attendance for today is here."

Poonam asked softly, "Then is my absence there also being proved?"

Arun Jha was silent for a few moments before answering. "Under the rule, you are supposed to be here."

The mobile phone rang again. This time it was Manoj Babu, the Block Agriculture Officer. His voice was a little sharp. "Poonamji, the inspection team has reached Sonbarsa. Where are you?"

"At the district headquarters. Monthly verification."

"I know. But the inspection team says that a field employee's absence without prior notice is a service lapse."

"The prior notice was the headquarters order that came to your own office."

Manoj Babu sighed. "I told them. They are writing that the employee was not found present in the work area at the time of inspection. Take proof from wherever you are."

Poonam still had the verification slip with the green stamp in her hand. She looked at it. Suddenly the paper seemed more strange than useful.

At one in the afternoon Poonam left headquarters. By the time she caught a bus and reached Sonbarsa it was half past three. The inspection team had gone. Ramlochan, Kishori Mahato, and two other farmers were standing on the field bund.

Ramlochan said, "They looked at the leaves. They said the employee was not here, so they would not take the sample."

Poonam took from her bag the same diseased leaves she had been carrying since morning. "I had thought of showing these leaves at headquarters too."

Kishori Mahato asked, "So what now?"

"Tomorrow I will take the sample again."

That evening the inspection note reached the block office. One line was in red letters—"At the time of field inspection, the concerned Field Assistant was found absent; the farmers were deprived of necessary advice."

Manoj Babu read the note and looked at Poonam. "I will have to reply to this."

Poonam placed the verification slip on the table. "This proves that I was not absent. I was present at headquarters."

Manoj Babu said, "Correct. But the note does not say you were absent from service. It says you were absent from your work area."

Ramlochan's sentence from the previous evening rose again in Poonam's mind—absent from the field in order to prove you are present.

The next day a reply was drafted—"The concerned employee was present at the district headquarters for compulsory monthly attendance verification; therefore, her absence from the work area at the time of inspection was due to an approved administrative reason."

The reply reached the District Inspection Branch. Three days later a question came back from there—"If the purpose of verifying an employee's field attendance is to ensure the employee's actual presence in the field, then leaving the field unattended on verification day runs contrary to the purpose of the arrangement. Suggest an alternative."

A meeting was held at the block office. Manoj Babu said, "What alternative are we supposed to suggest? The order comes from the district."

The accounts assistant suggested, "Send employees by turns. Not everyone on the same day."

Poonam said, "The slip clearly says—the last Wednesday of the month, all field employees."

Someone said, "Next time send half the people in the morning and half in the afternoon."

Manoj Babu shook his head. "Fingerprint verification is between ten and two. After two, the officer is not there."

The meeting ended without a conclusion. The reply stated—"Guidance from the higher level is awaited."

The last Wednesday came again the following month. This time, because of the inspection note, all the employees were alert. Some left assistants in

their work areas; others informed farmer groups in advance. Poonam told Ramlochan of Sonbarsa, “I have to go to headquarters again today. If any officer comes, show them this slip.”

She gave him a copy of the monthly verification order.

Ramlochan asked, “Will there be another inspection this time?”

“Hard to say.”

At headquarters the queue was even longer this time. After the previous month’s incidents, the district had asked every block for a list of “absent field employees.” The verification officers were matching the inspection notes against everyone’s registers as well.

Poonam’s name was called. Arun Jha looked at the file. “You are recorded as absent from your work area on the previous verification day.”

Poonam showed the green slip. “That day I was here for verification.”

Without smiling, Arun Jha said, “That is recorded here too. The problem is that both are correct.”

“Then today’s verification?”

“Today’s verification will be done here. What arrangement have you made in your field area?”

“I have given the farmer group a copy of the order.”

Arun Jha affixed the stamp. Then, after a brief pause, he said, “We are here on this day too. If an inspection team comes to headquarters, it could just as well say that we are not in our regular rooms.”

Poonam wanted to laugh, but the laughter did not come.

At half past twelve in the afternoon, a message arrived from Sonbarsa. The inspection team had indeed come again. This time Ramlochan had shown them the copy of the order. The team read the slip and wrote—“Employee at headquarters verification; field service under alternative arrangement.”

For the first time, this sentence was softer than the previous note. But by evening a new question arose. Who was the alternative arrangement? Ramlochan was not a government employee. He was a member of the farmer group. The inspection team wrote—“Clarify the legality of government field service being performed by a person who is not an employee.”

Poonam put a hand to her forehead. “I left the slip only to give information, not to do the work.”

Manoj Babu said, “The paperwork seems to be generating work all by itself.”

In the third month the district headquarters devised a new arrangement. On verification day, every field employee had to send proof of attendance from a location within the work area along with a digital location marker, and then come to headquarters to give a fingerprint.

At eight in the morning Poonam sent a location marker from in front of Sonbarsa School. Then she took a bus to the district. On reaching headquarters, the officer asked, “The location marker is from eight o’clock. Verification begins at ten. Where were you during the two hours in between?”

“On the bus.”

“Proof of the bus journey?”

Poonam took out the bus ticket.

There was no time printed on the bus ticket.

The officer said, "All right, we will accept it for today. Next time keep travel proof that carries the time."

For a moment Poonam wondered whether an employee was expected to prove the work, or every step taken in order to reach the work.

That month the inspection team reached Pipra in the afternoon. Poonam was at headquarters. The team saw the location marker—Sonbarsa, eight in the morning. The inspection note stated—"Employee absent from the field at the time of afternoon inspection; available digital location marker relates to a time different from the inspection time."

This time Poonam did not contest it. She simply attached all three papers together in the file—the morning location marker from the field, the afternoon fingerprint attendance at headquarters, and the field absence recorded at the time of inspection.

A special meeting was called at district level. Thirty-three such cases had accumulated from five blocks. Water-measurement assistants, animal-health workers, Agriculture Field Assistants, land-measurement employees—the same kind of contradiction appeared in all their files.

At the meeting one officer said, "There are two kinds of attendance—administrative and field."

Another said, "Then keep them in two separate registers."

A third asked, "If the two are not possible at the same time, which one has priority?"

Silence spread through the room.

Poonam was permitted to speak. She said, "For me, attendance is not a paper; it is the place where the work is. But if I leave the place of work in order to prove attendance on paper, then the two registers make each other guilty."

The officer wrote down the remark.

A week later a revised order arrived. Monthly verification for field employees would no longer take place on the same day for everyone. There would be separate dates block by block, and verification could be completed within a half-day window. The Inspection Branch would also be supplied with the verification dates, so that absence during that period would be treated as pre-approved.

A sense of relief spread through all the offices.

But the last line of the order caught Poonam's eye—"On verification day, before proceeding to headquarters, the field employee shall certify attendance in the work area and then commence the journey."

Poonam read the line twice.

The following month her verification day was Tuesday. In the morning she went to Sonbarsa, entered 8:05 in the farmer group's register, sent the location marker, and then caught a bus. By the time she reached the district headquarters it was noon. The fingerprint machine turned green.

On her way back in the evening, she met Ramlochan on the field bund. "Was your attendance proved today?"

Poonam set down her bag and examined a fresh maize leaf. “Yes. Here in the morning, there in the afternoon.”

Ramlochan asked, “Then when will the work happen?”

Poonam turned the leaf over and looked at the spots. “Now.”

She sat down on the bund. The farmers gathered around her. In the distance the dust raised by the bus was still visible on the road. Poonam opened the field register. Beneath today’s date, the first line had already been filled in—“Attendance certified.” Below it she added a second line—“Work begun: 4:40 p.m.”

THE ORIGINAL PAGE OF THE CORRECTION REGISTER

The rule for opening the old master registers of the District Land Records Branch was simple—nothing written in the original register was to be struck out. If an error was found, a small red dot was placed beside it, and the full correction was entered in a separate “Correction Register.” The original page remained exactly as it was.

Suresh Mishra had been a clerk in the branch for the past eighteen years. He was proud of this rule. He would often say, “What was written is history; what was corrected is the next line of history.”

There were three thick master registers in the office. One was for land accounts, one for boundary demarcation, and one for changes of ownership. The Correction Register had once been a thin volume. By now it had grown into five volumes.

With time, the master registers were opened less and less. People came with applications, employees consulted the Correction Register, and the final position could usually be found there. The master registers were heavy, their bindings weak. The corner of one page had broken away; on another, old ink had spread.

On her first day, the new employee Neha Jha had asked, “If the final position is in the Correction Register, why open the master register at all?”

Suresh Babu had smiled. “Because to understand what a correction corrected, you have to see the original.”

A few months later Neha herself understood that, in practice, people looked first at the Correction Register. The master register was opened only in a dispute, an inquiry, or when an old date had to be established.

Meanwhile, a case arrived—Account 482, Mauza Kataiya. The applicant was Ramvriksh Yadav. His request seemed simple: a certificate of landholding for farmers’ assistance.

Against Account 482, the Correction Register stated—“Owner: Ramvriksh Yadav. Correction Order No. 37/2018.”

Neha began preparing the certificate. Then the digital system displayed a warning drawn from the copy of the old master register—“Original entry: Sita Devi.”

Neha called Suresh Babu.

“This is normal,” Suresh Babu said. “Sita Devi would have been his mother. After her death, the mutation must have been made.”

“Then shall we look at the correction order?”

The file was brought out according to the reference in the Correction Register. The order was clear—after Sita Devi’s death certificate, family consent, and heir verification in 2018, Ramvriksh’s name was to be entered.

“Then the certificate can be issued,” Neha said.

Suresh Babu agreed.

Just then an elderly woman called from outside, “Is Ramvriksh’s paper here?”

Everyone looked towards the doorway. A woman of about seventy stood there in a white sari, an old cloth bag in her hand.

She said, “I am Sita Devi.”

The room fell silent for a few moments.

Ramvriksh, who had been sitting on the veranda, came inside. His face fell.

“Ma, why have you come here?”

Sita Devi put the bag on the table. “I heard your certificate was being prepared. I have only now learned that the land has been removed from my name.”

Neha looked at Ramvriksh. Suresh Babu opened the file again. The death certificate carried the name—Sita Devi. Father/Husband—Late Bhuvaneshwar Yadav. Village—Kataiya. Age—sixty-eight years.

The woman seated before them handed over her voter slip. Name, husband, village—everything matched.

“Whose death certificate is this?” Suresh Babu asked.

Ramvriksh said softly, “My aunt was also named Sita Devi. She was my father’s younger brother’s wife. Her husband too was named Bhuvaneshwar—Bhuvaneshwar Prasad Yadav. While the paper was being made, ‘Prasad’ may have been left out...”

Suresh Babu stopped him at once. “No assumptions. We will see the file.”

The old file contained a copy of the family tree. There, two Sita Devis were recorded in separate branches. One was Ramvriksh’s mother, the other his aunt. The death certificate belonged to the aunt.

In the 2018 inquiry paper, someone had omitted “Prasad” from “Bhuvaneshwar Prasad.” The village, caste, and age were nearly the same. The mutation order had been applied to the land of Ramvriksh’s mother.

Neha said softly, “Then the Correction Register is wrong.”

Suresh Babu said, “What we see now is an error. But the Correction Register is an accurate record of the order the office issued in 2018.”

Sita Devi was dissatisfied. “I am alive. What more than that do you need?”

“Being alive is the greatest fact,” Suresh Babu said, “but to correct the register we need the proper sequence.”

A new proceeding was opened. The correction in the Correction Register had itself to be corrected. The rule said—the old correction was not to be struck out; the new correction was to be added under the next serial number.

Neha asked, “Then where will the final truth remain?”

“In the next line,” Suresh Babu said.

The inquiry began. Sita Devi’s proof of being alive, family register, tax receipts, land revenue records, and neighbours’ statements were all collected. Ramvriksh too stated that the land actually belonged to his mother; he had needed the certificate for farmers’ assistance and had no intention of taking away her ownership.

Three weeks later an order was passed—the 2018 correction order was not validly applicable to Account 482; the name of the original owner, Sita Devi, was to become effective again.

Neha opened the Correction Register. The old line could not be erased. Beneath it she wrote—“Order 12/2026: Previous correction applied to wrong person; owner Sita Devi restored as effective.”

Suresh Babu wrote the new serial number beside the red dot.

The matter seemed finished. But the next day a letter arrived from the bank.

In 2021, Ramvriksh had taken an agricultural loan on the basis of this land. The bank asked—“According to the valid record on the date the loan was sanctioned, who was the owner?”

Neha said immediately, “Sita Devi. Because the 2018 correction was an error.”

Suresh Babu remained silent.

The bank’s question was read again—“According to the valid record on the date the loan was sanctioned.”

In 2021, the Correction Register showed Ramvriksh’s name. The office certificate had also been issued on that basis. At that time, the 2018 order had not yet been cancelled.

Neha said, “But now we know that it was wrong.”

Suresh Babu said, “We know it now. The office in 2021 did not know it.”

“Then was Ramvriksh the owner in 2021?”

“The question of the actual right in the land is one thing. The state of the official record is another.”

Neha found the answer uncomfortable. “Two truths for the same land?”

Suresh Babu spread the master register, the old Correction Register, and the new order before her.

“No. Three times of the same fact.”

A reply was prepared for the bank—“On the date of sanction of the loan, Ramvriksh Yadav was shown in the department’s then-effective record; a later inquiry found that the said entry resulted from an order concerning the wrong person; the currently effective owner is Sita Devi.”

Neha read the letter and said, “In this answer no one is completely right, and no one completely wrong.”

Suresh Babu said, “Records are not always so clean.”

A few days later, a district inspection took place. The inspector looked at the Correction Register and immediately asked, “Why are there three positions against the same account?”

Neha explained the entire matter. The inspector said, “If the old correction is cancelled, strike it through with a red line.”

Suresh Babu opened the rule book. “Neither the original nor a corrected entry is to be erased or made illegible. The reason for cancellation and the subsequent order are to be added.”

The inspector grew a little irritated. “Then how is an employee supposed to identify the final position?”

Neha said at once, “That is the problem here.”

She showed him the five volumes of Correction Registers. In some places one correction was followed by another, elsewhere by a third. Many employees looked only at the last line, but sometimes the effective date of an older order was what mattered.

The inspection team suggested creating a new “Status Summary Page,” on which the currently effective entry would be shown separately and clearly, with the serial numbers and periods of effect of all previous corrections listed below.

Work began. Account 482 became the first sample.

Three lines were entered on the Status Summary Page—

“Original entry: Sita Devi — from the beginning until 2018.”

“Correction Order 37/2018: Ramvriksh Yadav — departmentally effective record from 2018 until Order 12/2026.”

“Order 12/2026: Sita Devi — currently effective position.”

Neha looked at the page. “Now it is clear.”

Suresh Babu said, “It is clear because time has been added.”

The following week another case arrived. In the old master register, pond land stood in the name of the panchayat; in the 1998 Correction Register it stood in the school’s name; in a 2012 correction it returned to the panchayat. The question was—under whose authority had permission for construction of the school building been granted in 2005?

Earlier, employees would have looked at the “current position” and answered. This time Neha checked the period of effect. In 2005, the school’s name was effective in the departmental record.

She understood that Account 482 had exposed more than a single mistake; the very structure of the registers had been concealing time.

It was impossible to create Status Summary Pages for all active accounts within three months. So a rule was made—wherever there was more than one correction, checking the “effective date” would be compulsory before preparing a certificate.

The employees’ work increased. Some complained that earlier one register was enough to finish the task; now three pages had to be checked.

Neha would say, “Earlier we got an answer quickly; now we will get the answer for the correct time.”

One evening, before the office closed, Sita Devi came again. This time there was no dispute. She had come to collect the new certificate.

Neha handed her the certificate. Name—Sita Devi. Current owner.

Sita Devi read the paper and put it into her bag. “So am I alive again now?”

Neha smiled. “You were never dead. The register understood it late.”

Sita Devi left.

Suresh Babu was closing the master register. Neha looked towards the five volumes of the Correction Register.

“You used to say—the original is history, and the correction is the next line of history.”

“Yes.”

“Now it seems the next line sometimes begins doing more work than the original.”

Suresh Babu ran his hand over the binding. “Then that too has to be read as history, not as an order.”

Neha opened the Status Summary Page for Account 482 once more. Beside the same name were three times. For the first time, the register seemed to her not like static paper but like moving time—to understand what is true today, yesterday’s truth and the day-before-yesterday’s error both have to remain preserved.

STORY 176

THE ENVELOPE WITHOUT A SENDER

On Monday morning, a sealed envelope was found on the receipt desk of the District Social Assistance Office. It was not in the mailbag, nor had anyone handed it over. It lay squarely on top of the document box kept against the wall just inside the gate.

On the front of the envelope, in clear letters, was written—"District Social Assistance Officer, Sahayata Bhavan." Beneath that there was nothing. No name, no village, no department, no mobile number. There was no sender on the back either.

Receipt Assistant Rama Jha picked up the envelope. The paper was thick. It did not seem to contain more than two or three pages. There was not even the impression of anyone's seal on a corner.

Rama first opened the mail register. In the digital receipt system, the first box for adding a new letter was—"Sender." An asterisk showed that the field was mandatory.

She typed "Unknown." The screen turned red—"Select a valid sender."

She typed "Anonymous." The reply came—"Not available in list."

She entered her own name, merely to see whether the next field would open. At once the next options appeared—subject of letter, date received, department, number of enclosures. She deleted her own name.

Senior Assistant Devkinandan Thakur, seated beside her, asked, "What has got stuck?"

Rama showed him the envelope. "There is no sender."

Devkinandan Babu said casually, "Then open it and look. The name will be inside the letter."

Rama stopped her hand. "We are not allowed to open it without a receipt number."

"Why?"

"The rule came after the last inspection. Sealed mail must first be entered in the register and only then opened. Otherwise there may be a dispute that pages inside were added or removed."

Devkinandan Babu remembered the rule. "All right. Then enter it in the register."

"The register will not accept it without a sender."

For a few moments both of them looked at the envelope. The problem was small, but two solid walls of rules had risen around it—receipt was required before opening; a sender was required for receipt; and the sender might be written inside.

Devkinandan Babu asked, "Post-office stamp?"

"No."

"Gate register?"

"The guard said this morning that it was already lying on top of the box."

“Camera?”

Rama telephoned the security room at the gate. The night footage was checked. From half past nine at night until five in the morning, the camera had been off; when the power failed, the backup had not worked. The picture resumed at 5:22, and by then the envelope was already on top of the box.

Devkinandan Babu smiled. “So we do not even know whether the envelope came before the power failure or after it.”

Rama said, “In whose name will the receipt be made?”

At that question, Devkinandan Babu did not laugh. A receipt was not merely a ritual. The reply, file number, and time limit for every letter in the office began from its receipt number.

They took the envelope to the room of Branch Officer Meena Karn. Meena looked at it, turned it over, and held it up to the light to make out the shape of what was inside.

“It has not been opened?”

Rama explained the rule.

Meena said, “Without a sender, we cannot return it either.”

Devkinandan Babu said, “That is exactly why it is here.”

Meena had the rule book brought. The clause on sealed letters was clear — “After the receipt number has been entered, the authorized employee shall open the envelope.” There was nothing about a letter without a sender.

“What about the rule for anonymous complaints?” Rama asked.

Meena turned the pages. “An anonymous complaint is a different matter. To know that it is a complaint, the letter must already have been opened.”

The envelope remained lying on the table.

By noon, talk about it had spread through the office. Someone said, “It is certainly a complaint.” Someone else said, “It may be some court paper; the name must have been left off in printing.” Another whispered, “It may be evidence for an audit.”

Rama listened to all the guesses. It seemed strange to her that the less information the envelope gave, the more people filled into it.

After noon, Social Assistance Officer Vinay Mohan came to the office. Meena showed him the matter.

Vinay Mohan’s first question was, “Has a security check been done?”

The security guard at the gate was called. The envelope was examined from the outside. It appeared to contain only paper; there was no unusual object inside.

“Then open it,” Vinay Mohan said.

Rama placed the rule book before him.

The officer read the page. “The purpose of this rule is to protect documents, not to stop them.”

Meena said, “True, but if we break the rule and open it, tomorrow an inspection may raise a question.”

Vinay Mohan asked, “Can it be opened by special order?”

Devkinandan Babu said, “Even a special order will require the reference of a received letter. This letter has no receipt number.”

Silence fell in the room.

At last Vinay Mohan directed that the envelope be kept in a locked cupboard as “unentered mail,” and that headquarters be asked how the digital system should receive a letter without a sender.

On an ordinary sheet of paper Rama wrote by hand—“One sealed envelope; recipient clear; sender absent; no receipt number issued.” Three employees signed it.

The envelope was placed in the iron cupboard. It had not been officially received, but the paper recording that it had been stored became official.

No reply came from headquarters the next day. Nor on the third day.

Meanwhile, guesses about the importance of the envelope kept changing. Employees in the pension branch said it might be an original life certificate. People in the student assistance room said it might be a scholarship appeal. At the women’s assistance desk, someone said it might be an urgent protection application.

Meena stopped everyone. “We do not know what is inside. Do not create a file on the basis of guesses.”

On the fourth day it rained. Water dripped lightly from the old roof of Sahayata Bhavan near the cupboard. The envelope did not get directly wet, but the air became damp. Rama wanted to put it into a plastic sleeve, then stopped.

“Will putting a new cover over a sealed item also have to be recorded?” she asked Devkinandan Babu.

Devkinandan Babu said, “If it is to protect the paper inside, put it on. But let three people be witnesses.”

Three employees signed again—“Envelope secured in an outer transparent sleeve without being opened.”

Rama laughed. “More paper is being produced outside this envelope than there is paper inside it.”

Devkinandan Babu replied, “An office does not trust paper alone; it trusts the journey of paper.”

On the fifth day a reply came from headquarters—“Send a copy of the local rule regarding receipt of physical letters without a sender.”

Meena read the letter and held her head. “I asked for a solution, and they are asking me for the rule.”

The very copy of the local rule that said nothing about such a situation was sent.

On the seventh day an elderly man came to the office. His name was Dayashankar Mandal.

He asked, “Was any sealed envelope found last week?”

Rama became alert. “Did you send it?”

Dayashankar immediately said, “No. I am only asking.”

“Why?”

He hesitated. “A woman from my village had said that an important paper had been sent to the district. She did not want to disclose her name.”

“What was the paper about?”

Dayashankar avoided saying. “She said that if it reached the right place, people would understand.”

Rama said, “It may have reached the right place, but the rules do not understand it.”

Dayashankar remained silent. The envelope was not shown to him; officially, the office had still not received it.

He left.

After that meeting, instead of becoming more mysterious, the envelope became more ordinary to Rama. Someone genuinely wanted a paper to reach the office, but did not want a name to remain on the outside.

On the eighth day a second reply came from headquarters—“If a letter from an unknown source is a complaint, apply the complaint rules; if it is ordinary correspondence, sender details are required.”

Meena said, “To decide whether it is a complaint or ordinary correspondence, we have to open it.”

Rama said softly, “And to open it, we need a receipt.”

Everyone laughed, but there was fatigue in the laughter.

Vinay Mohan decided to seek the opinion of the Legal Branch on how the rule should be interpreted.

Two days later the Legal Branch wrote—“Whether a document that has physically come under the control of the office is to be treated as received is a question of fact; a digital entry may be evidence of receipt, but is not a condition of the document’s existence.”

That one sentence stopped everyone.

Meena read it again—“A digital entry is not a condition of existence.”

Devkinandan Babu said, “Meaning the envelope is here, therefore it has been received; whether the machine accepts it is a later matter.”

Vinay Mohan directed that a temporary paper receipt number be issued, that “Sender—unknown/verification pending” be written, that the envelope be opened in the presence of three employees, and that further action be taken according to the nature of the letter inside.

Rama wrote the number by hand—“Temporary Receipt 7/Ka.” It was not a number from the digital system; it was the first entry in a new, small office register.

When the envelope was opened, Meena, Rama, Devkinandan Babu, and Vinay Mohan were present. Rama cut the seal. There were three pages inside.

There was no name on the first page. At the top was written—“Correction of Facts Concerning Assistance List Serial Numbers 41-47.”

On the second page were the names of seven beneficiaries. Beside three names, in red ink, was written—“Reported dead, but alive.” Beside two names—“Village changed, not person.” Beside one name—“Entered twice.” Beside the last name—“Death correct, but family assistance application pending.”

On the third page there was only this much—“Verify by comparing the local register, ration list, and panchayat death register. Do not publish the name of the informant; otherwise no one will send a paper next time.”

The room fell silent again.

Meena read the first name. “This was on last month’s list of cases in which assistance was stopped.”

Devkinandan Babu placed his finger on the second name. “An application concerning this person’s proof of life came yesterday.”

The information in the letter was not immediately accepted as true. All seven cases were sent separately for verification.

The first results came within two days. Two of the three people were indeed alive; in one case, the death register had been matched with another person of the same name. In the two cases where the village had changed, one family had settled in a neighbouring panchayat after the flood, but the old list was treating them as different people.

Within four days, the seventh case too proved correct—the family assistance application had mistakenly remained stuck in another branch.

Now the question arose—who had given this information?

Vinay Mohan said, “Is that necessary for the work?”

The Accounts Officer said, “What about the reliability of the source?”

Meena replied, “Reliability has been established not by the name, but by checking all seven facts.”

Rama looked at the outside of the envelope. It was torn now, but the blank place for the sender remained exactly as it had been.

The entire incident was reported to headquarters. This time the reply came quickly. The instruction was that all offices should keep an option called “Sender unknown/verification pending” in a local temporary register, and a proposal should be sent to the Technical Branch to add such an option to the digital system.

A few weeks later the system was updated. A new option appeared at the receipt desk—“Sender unavailable.” As soon as it was selected, a receipt could be generated, but the receipt clearly printed—“Sender verification pending; truth of contents subject to independent verification.”

On the first day Rama saw the new option, she called Devkinandan Babu.

“Look, now the machine accepts the unknown too.”

Devkinandan Babu said, “It does not accept the unknown; it has given the unknown a place to remain unknown.”

A few months later another envelope without a sender arrived. This time Rama did not become anxious when she picked it up.

The recipient was clear. The sender space was blank.

She selected “Sender unavailable” in the digital register. A receipt number was generated at once.

The envelope was opened in the presence of three employees.

Inside there was only one page—no complaint, no secret evidence. The family of an elderly beneficiary had written that he had died and that his old-age assistance should be stopped from the following month. No one in the family had written a name; perhaps they believed the name of the deceased person was sufficient.

Rama read the letter and remained still for a few moments. Then she began the death-verification process.

In the evening, while closing the mail register, she looked again at the temporary register for the first envelope without a sender. Against its first entry there was now a note—"Contents verified; seven cases disposed of; sender unknown."

Rama thought—the office had long believed that what had no name could not enter. But sometimes the absence of a name did not make information false; it only changed the way it had to be verified.

STORY 177

THE SHADOW SIGNATURE

A new template for approval letters had been created in the District Social Assistance Office. At the top was the department's name, in the middle the applicant's details, and at the bottom three boxes—Inquiry Officer, Accounts Branch, and Final Approval. To make the template easier to understand during training, the clerk who created it had inserted, as a sample in the final box, an image of the signature from an old approved case.

Above the image, in small letters, was written—'Sample.' On the computer screen this was clearly visible. But no one had noticed that the image itself had become a permanent part of the template.

Two weeks later, new applications began to be prepared on that same template. Employees changed the name, date, amount, and remarks, then printed a copy. The paper was supposed to go to the Deputy Director's desk for final approval and, after the actual signature had been made, be sent to the block office below.

Kamla Devi's application was among the first twenty prepared on the new template. Her husband had died three years earlier. An arrear instalment under the Family Assistance Scheme had been stuck for a year. The inquiry was complete, the bank account had been verified, and the village-register certificate was also in order.

Looking at the case, clerk Sunil Jha said, "This time there is no reason for the work to stop."

Kamla Devi smiled. "I have heard that sentence three times already."

A little embarrassed, Sunil Babu said, "This time everything really is complete."

He opened the template and filled in the details. The old signature in the final box was already there in grey. Since the word 'Sample' was visible on the screen, he paid no attention to it. The actual approval looked blank because the signature image had been kept in a pale shade.

The paper was printed. The office's old black-and-white printer darkened the grey. The word 'Sample' remained very faint, but the signature emerged in dark black lines.

Sunil Babu set the file aside to be sent to the Deputy Director's desk. That afternoon the power failed twice. Before the office closed, an assistant was sorting all prepared papers into piles for different branches. Kamla Devi's page was mistakenly placed in the pile marked 'Approved copy—send to block.'

The next day the copy reached the block office. There, accountant Mukund Yadav looked at the final page. At the bottom was a clear mark resembling the Deputy Director's signature. There was no seal, but under the new order, a seal was no longer compulsory on papers generated from the digital template.

Mukund Babu asked, "Is there a dispatch number?"

There was a number in the mail register.

“Then it is all right.”

The process of releasing Kamla Devi’s arrears began. Her name was entered in the bank list. Three days later the amount reached her account.

After returning from the bank, Kamla Devi telephoned Sunil Babu. “The money has come.”

Sunil Babu was surprised. He remembered that the file was still supposed to go for the Deputy Director’s signature. He immediately searched for it. The original file was still lying in the cupboard beside his desk. The final approval page was missing.

He opened the digital copy. The signature was visible on the page.

Sunil Babu went to the room of Deputy Director Meera Karn. “Madam, has Kamla Devi’s case been approved?”

Meera Karn looked up over her spectacles. “Kamla Devi? I have not seen the file.”

“The amount has been released.”

“On what basis?”

Sunil Babu placed the printed copy before her.

As soon as Meera Karn saw the signature, she sat upright. “This looks like my signature.”

“Looks like?”

“I did not sign this page.”

Silence fell in the room.

The old approval letter was called for. The training sample file was found. It carried Meera Karn’s actual signature. The image of that very signature had been cut out and placed as a sample in the new template.

Meera Karn said, “This signature is mine, but this decision is not.”

For the first time, Sunil Babu understood that a signature could be genuine and misleading at the same time.

An immediate order was issued stopping use of the new template. Every copy prepared during the previous two weeks was to be checked.

Eighteen cases were found in which the old signature image had been printed. Thirteen files were still in the office awaiting an actual signature. Copies in five cases had already reached subordinate offices. Of those, Kamla Devi’s amount had been released; payment orders had been prepared in two cases; and two were still pending.

Inquiry Officer Rajiv Thakur asked, “Who created the template?”

The record was checked. Sunil Babu himself had created it for training.

Sunil Babu said at once, “I had put the signature there as a sample. It was clearly written above it.”

Rajiv Thakur showed him the printed copy. “Here, ‘Sample’ is almost invisible.”

“It is clear on the screen.”

“The action was taken not on the screen, but on this printed paper.”

Meera Karn intervened. “We can decide whose fault it was later. First determine the status of the citizens’ cases.”

Kamla Devi's file was opened again. There was no dispute over eligibility. The inquiry was correct, the amount was correct, and the bank details were correct. Only the final approval was not genuine.

The Accounts Officer said, "The amount has gone to the correct person."

Rajiv Thakur said, "But without approval."

Meera Karn asked, "If I grant actual approval today, will the amount released three days ago become valid?"

There was no ready answer.

A written opinion was sought from the Finance Branch. The reply came—"Granting approval with retrospective effect is not in accordance with the rules. Approval may be granted from the present date; responsibility for the earlier payment shall be determined separately."

With that one sentence, Kamla Devi's correctly done work became disputed again.

Instructions went to the block office to stop further action in all five cases. Mukund Babu sent back a reply—"On the paper received by us, the signature of the competent authority was visibly present; the dispatch number was also valid. There was no external indication that the paper was a sample."

The district office's mail branch said that the dispatch number was genuine, because the page had in fact gone out from the district office.

The Records Branch said that the original approval page was not in the file.

The digital system said that the page had been saved under the name 'Final Template.'

The creator of the template said that the signature was a 'sample.'

The officer said that the signature was certainly an image of hers, but not her decision.

Kamla Devi said, "The money is in my account. Then what is the decision as far as I am concerned?"

No branch gave her a direct answer.

Seven days later she was called to the office. Kamla Devi came carrying her bank passbook and a copy of her original application.

Meera Karn met her herself. "Your eligibility is valid. The department will not ask you to return the money."

Kamla Devi asked, "Then why have you called me again?"

"I have to grant the actual approval."

Kamla Devi asked in surprise, "After the money has already been received?"

"Yes."

"Then what was the signature that was there before?"

Meera Karn placed her finger on the paper. "It was an image of my signature, not my decision on that day."

Kamla Devi looked at it for a while. "If the signature was yours, whose decision was it?"

Meera Karn replied, "That question is exactly why this inquiry is going on."

She read the entire file. Finding the eligibility in order, she granted approval from the current date. This time she signed in blue ink, wrote the date, and beside it wrote her full name in letters.

Kamla Devi looked at the two signatures together. Their shapes were almost the same. One black, one blue.

“How am I to know which one to accept?”

Meera Karn said, “The blue one.”

Kamla Devi immediately asked, “But the black one too was once made by your own hand, wasn’t it?”

Without smiling, Meera Karn said, “At some earlier time. On another paper.”

The inquiry committee separated all eighteen cases. Where actual approval was subsequently obtained, payment continued. Where eligibility was incomplete, the process was stopped. No recovery was made merely because of the image-signature if the other basis of the payment was valid.

But fixing administrative responsibility remained difficult. The creator of the template had made an error; ‘Sample’ had faded in printing; the assistant had placed the page in the wrong pile; the block office had trusted a genuine dispatch number. Not one mistake, but four small acts of trust had combined to create a complete approval.

Rajiv Thakur wrote in the report—“A visible signature alone shall not be treated as sufficient proof of a decision; it must be matched with the decision register, date, and dispatch status.”

A new arrangement was made. Keeping the image of any real signature in a template was completely prohibited. In training samples, only the words ‘SIGNATURE HERE’ would be written in bold where a signature belonged. A digital decision number would also be generated for every actual approval.

Sunil Babu opened the old template and deleted the signature image. After it was removed, a white empty box remained beneath it. It seemed strange to him—the mark that had travelled for two weeks as an order had in fact been only an image.

When he saved the template, he gave it a new name—‘Approval-Template-Revised.’

The system asked—‘Delete old template?’

Sunil Babu stopped his hand.

The inquiry report said that the old template was evidence. It must not be erased.

He selected ‘No.’

A few months later, the incident began to be told as an example in training for new employees. The old template was displayed on the screen, but a large red rectangle was drawn over the signature image. The trainer would say, “This looks like approval. It is not approval.”

A new employee asked, “If the officer later accepts the same decision, what should the first image be regarded as?”

The trainer paused for a few moments. “A shadow. The shadow of a decision.”

That same week Kamla Devi came to the block office to show a new page in her passbook. Mukund Babu recognized her. “Everything all right now?”

Kamla Devi said, “The money was all right from the beginning. Are the papers all right now?”

Mukund Babu laughed. “Now there is an actual approval too.”

Kamla Devi took two copies out of her bag. On the first was the black shadow-signature. On the second, the blue actual signature.

“My name, my amount, and my work are the same on both,” she said. “The only difference is that once the decision arrived first and the officer came later.”

Mukund Babu did not reply.

Kamla Devi put both papers back into her bag. As she stepped outside, she saw a new notice on the wall—“Do not treat an image of a signature as approval; always verify the decision number.”

She read the notice and smiled faintly. It occurred to her that the shadow on the paper had been misleading, but the work behind that shadow had turned out to be correct. To reach one correct piece of work, the office had first had to find the officer’s decision separately from the officer’s own signature.

SERIAL NUMBER 000

On the first working day of the new year, the District Citizen Assistance Centre opened at nine o'clock. Outside there was fog; inside, the smell of new registers. At their desks, the employees had cleared away the previous year's files and arranged papers for the new sequence.

In the receipt room, as soon as Archana Jha switched on the computer, she saw that the system was restarting itself. A New Year welcome message appeared on the screen, and beneath it, in small letters—"Annual serial numbering restarted."

That was routine. The last application of the previous year had been 847. Today, the first application should begin with 001.

At five past nine, the first citizen arrived—Malti Devi, about fifty-five years old. Her husband had died three years earlier. She had come to resubmit a pending claim under the Family Assistance Scheme. The papers previously submitted at the block office had been declared incomplete; this time she had brought all the original proofs.

Archana checked each paper one by one—the death certificate, family register, bank details, Aadhaar document, income certificate, two photographs, and the block office's earlier rejection letter. Everything was in order.

"Digital copies of all the original papers will be made, and then I will return them to you," Archana said.

Malti Devi placed her bag on the desk.

Archana opened a new application, filled in the details, made digital copies of the documents, and finally pressed 'Submit.'

The screen went white for a moment. Then a green line appeared—"Application saved."

Beneath it was the serial number—000.

Archana started slightly. "What is this?"

Naveen Babu, seated at the adjoining desk, leaned over to look. "It must be a test serial number. The system has been opened for the first time in the new year."

"But it says the application has been saved."

Naveen Babu laughed. "Can 000 ever be a real serial number? The first real one will be 001."

Archana pressed 'Submit' again. The system replied—"This application has already been saved."

"Then what now?"

Naveen Babu said, "Close it and open it again."

Archana closed the application. In the search box she typed Malti Devi's name. No result. She searched by Aadhaar number. No result. She entered

serial number 000. A message appeared on the screen—“Test records are not displayed in search results.”

Malti Devi sat silently in her chair. “Have my papers been submitted or not?”

Archana did not answer immediately. The original papers were still lying before her in the scanning machine.

“One minute,” she said.

The technical assistant was called. He opened the lower-level details of the system. There the date, time, seven digital copies, and an internal identifier were all clearly visible.

“A record has been created,” the technical assistant said, “but the serial number is 000.”

“Then is it real?”

“It exists in the data.”

“In the work queue?”

“No.”

“Why?”

The technical assistant worked at the keyboard for a while. “The work queue displays only serial numbers greater than zero.”

Naveen Babu said, “See? 000 is only for testing.”

The technical assistant shook his head. “If it is only a test, why are there a name and documents attached to it?”

Malti Devi asked from between them, “Am I a test?”

No one in the room laughed.

Archana tried to print a paper receipt. A slip came out of the printer, but across the top in bold letters it read—“Serial No. 000 — Test Copy.”

Archana did not think it proper to give that slip to Malti Devi.

The technical assistant said, “At the beginning of the new year the system first creates 000, then starts counting from 001. Normally only an empty test is made under 000. Today, as soon as the office opened, a real application was submitted first.”

“Then change it to 001,” Naveen Babu said simply.

The technical assistant replied, “The serial number cannot be changed. The digital copies, time stamp, and receipt history are all linked to 000.”

“Cancel it and make a new application?”

“To cancel it, the application has to appear in the work queue. 000 does not appear there.”

Archana gathered Malti Devi’s original papers. “Take all these back. We will get the problem corrected.”

The technical assistant stopped her. “Wait. The digital copies of the original papers are complete, but there is a rule—until the digital copies attached to an application are verified, its originals cannot be treated as released from ‘received’ status. If the papers are returned and the record later becomes active, the audit will show that the originals were returned without verification.”

Malti Devi placed her hand on the stack of documents. "These are my papers."

Archana grew uncomfortable. "Yes, but the system..."

Malti Devi asked, "The system says this is not an application. Then how did it come to possess my papers?"

No one had an immediate answer.

The matter went before Branch Officer Sudhir Jha. He examined the receipt, the screen, and the list of digital copies.

"Serial number 000 is not valid," he said.

Archana asked, "But the record exists."

"A record existing and a valid application existing are two different things."

"Then should we return the original papers?"

"Why were original papers retained in the office without receipt of a valid application?"

Archana fell silent.

Sudhir Jha said, "First decide what 000 is."

That day Malti Devi was given a handwritten slip—"Original documents are being kept in a secure office cover; error concerning the digital serial number is under examination." The serial-number field on the slip was left blank.

Malti Devi returned home. Her application did not.

The next day the system was normal. The first new application was 001, the second 002, the third 003. 000 was nowhere to be seen.

Archana searched again by name. No Malti Devi. But on the technical assistant's special screen, 000 was still there—seven digital copies, submission time 09:12, user Archana Jha.

"It is like a ghost," Naveen Babu said. "It cannot be seen, but it is there in the data."

Archana said, "Not a ghost. Malti Devi was sitting here yesterday."

The problem was sent to the District Information Cell. The reply came—"Serial number 000 is reserved for system start-up testing; it is not acceptable as a real application."

Sudhir Jha added a note—"Nevertheless, the application data and original documents of an actual citizen are linked to the said serial number. Resolution required."

A second reply came from the Information Cell—"Register the application again."

Archana tried. As soon as she entered Malti Devi's Aadhaar number, the system displayed—"Active record available for same applicant."

"Active?" Naveen Babu almost shouted. "Until now it was saying it was not valid!"

The technical assistant explained, "The duplicate-prevention rule treats 000 as a record. The work-queue rule does not."

Sudhir Jha said, "Two rules in the same system are giving different decisions about whether the same paper exists."

Malti Devi came again on the third day. She carried the handwritten slip in her hand.

“Has the work been done?”

Archana said, “The record exists, but the question of validating the serial number is stuck.”

“There is a serial number, isn’t there?”

“ooo.”

“Then why is it not valid?”

Without thinking, Naveen Babu said, “Because zero is nothing.”

Malti Devi looked at him. “Three zeros are written there. If it is nothing, what has been written?”

Naveen Babu fell silent.

By afternoon, that sentence had spread through the entire room. Someone said ooo was merely a code, not a number. Someone said zero was a number, but application serials did not begin with zero. Someone else said three zeros had the same value as one zero.

At last Sudhir Jha said, “I am not going to debate mathematics. I need an administrative answer.”

He drafted a note—“If the system has generated ooo as a unique record identifier, and genuine documents are linked to that identifier, the existence of the record cannot be denied merely because its numerical value is zero.”

The note went to the Information Cell. A telephone call came from the technical head.

“I can see the row in the database,” he said. “The problem is in the workflow filtering rule. The condition says—the serial number must be greater than zero.”

Sudhir Jha asked, “Do you regard ooo as a number or not?”

The technical head laughed. “It is a number. But in the system, zero has been treated as ‘blank.’”

“If it were blank, where did Malti Devi’s seven documents get linked?”

There was silence for a few moments at the other end of the telephone.

The technical head said, “All right. This is an edge case.”

Sudhir Jha said, “I do not need an edge case. I need an application.”

A new rule was proposed as a solution—instead of treating ooo as test-only, if verified citizen details and documents were linked to it, it would be treated as a “special initial serial number.”

Until the rule was approved, Malti Devi’s work remained stuck again.

On the seventh day another problem arose. The time limit under the Family Assistance Scheme was counted from the date of application. If Malti Devi’s new application were treated as having been filed on some later day after 001, her eligibility date would change.

Archana said, “She submitted the application at 9:12 on the first day. The time stamp is clear.”

The Accounts Room asked, “Is that the time stamp of a valid application, or of an invalid serial number?”

Sudhir Jha wrote in reply—“The event was real; an error in numbering does not make the event invalid.”

That sentence was added to the file.

On the tenth day, permission arrived from headquarters—“Treat serial number 000 as a valid application number in this single case and complete the process; in future, the annual start-up test shall be completed before actual citizen services begin.”

For the first time, Archana saw 000 in the normal work queue. It stood at the very top, before 001.

Malti Devi was called.

When she came, Archana printed her receipt. This time ‘Test Copy’ was not written across the top. It clearly read—“Application Serial No. 000.”

Malti Devi held the slip and looked at it for a while.

“Has it become a number now?” she asked.

Archana smiled. “It was a number from the beginning. The office has accepted it now.”

The original documents were verified and returned to her. The application moved onto the officer’s work queue. Two weeks later the assistance was approved.

In the second month of the year, the Information Cell added a new safeguard to the system. Whenever the annual sequence restarted, 000 would remain only for internal testing; testing had to be completed before citizen services were activated.

Archana read the order. At the bottom an example was given—“Valid real serial numbers: 001, 002, 003...”

She asked the technical assistant, “Why is there no example of 000?”

“It will not happen again,” he said.

Archana opened her drawer. She had kept a copy of Malti Devi’s first handwritten slip. On it, the serial-number field was blank.

On the computer she opened Malti Devi’s file. At the top shone—“Serial No. 000 — Disposed.”

For a few moments Archana looked at both—the paper with no serial number, and the record whose serial number had not been accepted as a number for ten days.

She closed the file. The next application was 047.

The counting on the screen was moving smoothly. But Archana now knew—the first step in counting sometimes falls exactly where the system says that nothing has begun at all.

STORY 179

A WITNESS TO LIFE

Devnarayan Mandal was seventy-eight years old. Once a year he had to go to the Block Public Service Centre and submit proof that he was alive, so that his old-age allowance would continue for another year. For the past two years, the fingerprint machine had not been capturing his print clearly. This time, therefore, the employee told him of another route—two witnesses who knew him.

Under the rule, both witnesses had to have known him for at least five years, could not belong to the same family, and had to verify their own identities and certify that Devnarayan Mandal was present alive before them.

Devnarayan laughed. “I am sitting right here. Do I need two more men to prove that?”

Public Service Assistant Rupa Kumari smiled. “I can see you, but the system does not accept my seeing you as proof.”

“Then what does the system accept?”

“Verification by two witnesses.”

Devnarayan gave the names of two acquaintances from his village, Laukahi—Harihar Mahato and Jagdish Paswan. Harihar had been going with him to the same market for forty years. Jagdish looked after the panchayat library, and his house stood on the boundary of Devnarayan’s field.

By noon Harihar Mahato had reached the Centre. Sitting opposite Devnarayan, he said, “I have had to come before the government to declare that you are alive?”

Devnarayan replied, “My life now depends on your testimony.”

Harihar laughed. “Then stay properly alive; you have given me a responsibility.”

Rupa checked both their identities. Harihar gave his fingerprint. A green mark flashed on the screen—“Witness 1 verified.” The time recorded was 11:43.

Jagdish was outside the village that day. Over the telephone he said he would reach the Centre at nine the next morning. The system allowed forty-eight hours for verification by both witnesses.

Devnarayan returned home. His slip said—“Proof of life: one witness remaining.”

That night sudden news spread through the village. Harihar Mahato had developed severe pain in his chest. His family took him to hospital, but at around four in the morning he died.

Devnarayan reached his house at daybreak. As morning advanced, preparations for the cremation began. Jagdish was there too. No one remembered the visit to the Public Service Centre.

At ten o’clock a red notification flashed on Rupa’s computer—“Witness 1: declared deceased. Certification invalid.”

Rupa was startled. She checked the previous day's time—11:43. The time linked from the death register—today, 04:10.

Harihar had been alive when he completed the verification. But the system, looking at his current status, had cancelled yesterday's certification.

A second line appeared beneath it—"Applicant's life status: pending."

Rupa stared at the screen for a long time. Yesterday Devnarayan had been sitting in front of her. Today, because one witness was dead, his status read "life status pending."

At noon Devnarayan himself came to the Centre. His face was tired. "Harihar is gone," he said softly. "I have not brought Jagdish today. People are gathered at the house."

Rupa said, "I have received the notification."

"Then change the witness. I will bring another man in two days."

Rupa opened the 'Change Witness' option. Three reasons appeared—'Witness absent', 'Identity failed', 'Witness did not consent'. There was no option for 'Witness deceased'.

She tried selecting 'Witness absent'. The system stopped her—"Witness verification already complete; reason not applicable."

She selected 'Identity failed.' The reply—"Identity successful."

She selected 'Did not consent.' The reply—"Consent recorded."

Rupa looked at Devnarayan. "Harihar Babu completed everything. So the system will not let me replace him as a failed witness. But now, because he is dead, it will not accept his successful testimony either."

Devnarayan remained silent for a while. "So while he was alive he was successful, and the moment he died he became unsuccessful?"

"That is what the system is saying at present."

"And along with him, I too have become pending?"

Rupa did not answer.

Jagdish came to the Centre on the third day. He looked as though he had come straight from Harihar's cremation rites. There was a faint smell of smoke on his clothes.

"I am the second witness," he said. "Do the verification."

Rupa searched for the name. Jagdish's field opened, but at the top was a red warning—"Case under deceased-witness review; second verification suspended."

Jagdish asked in astonishment, "I am alive. Devnarayan Kaka is alive. One witness is no more. Then why are the two of us stopped?"

Rupa said, "Because the review has not been completed."

"A review of whose life?"

The form had no answer to that question.

The matter went to the Block Allowance Branch. Officer Shyamsundar Jha opened the file and said, "The witness has died, so take a new witness."

Rupa said, "The replacement option is blocked."

"Attach the death certificate."

Harihar's family had already applied for the death certificate, but it was still under process. The final certificate was issued two days later. Devnarayan himself brought a copy.

Placing it on the table, he said, "To prove that I am alive, do I now need Harihar's death certificate?"

Shyamsundar Jha remained serious. "The system requires it."

The death certificate was uploaded. The system displayed a new status—"Death-linked certification; higher review required."

Rupa put a hand to her forehead. "First I could not change the witness. Now that his death has been proved, the whole case has gone upward for review."

Devnarayan asked, "Where do I go?"

"You stay here. The file will go to the district."

"And my allowance?"

"If the proof of life is not completed, payment may stop next month."

Devnarayan gripped the handle of his walking stick. "I will try to remain alive until the payment is stopped."

Rupa looked at his face. It was not a joke.

The first reply from the District Allowance Office came—"Verification by a deceased witness is not acceptable; obtain verification from a new witness."

The block wrote back—"Field for adding a new witness is blocked."

The district replied—"Remove the previous witness."

The block wrote—"A verified witness cannot be removed."

The district asked—"Then how was the witness's verification cancelled?"

Rupa read the question and smiled faintly. "That is what I have been asking from the first day."

The matter was sent to the Technical Cell. Digital details were requested there—the time of Harihar's verification, the time the death register was updated, and the time the application status changed.

The record was clear. Harihar Mahato had verified at 11:43 on 6 January. He died at 04:10 on 7 January. The death-register entry was linked to the system at 09:58 on 7 January. At 10:02 his earlier testimony was automatically invalidated.

The technical assistant said, "The system checks the witness's current life status, not the status at the moment of verification."

Shyamsundar Jha asked, "But the act of witnessing took place when he was alive."

"Yes."

"Then why did an event that happened later—his death—erase testimony given earlier?"

The technical assistant shrugged. "The rule says—the witness must be active."

Rupa asked, "Active until when? Until the application is submitted? Until payment is made? Until the old person comes again next year to prove he is alive?"

No one had a written answer.

The matter went before the district review meeting. Devnarayan was called as well. He made the long journey to the district office. In the meeting room sat seven officers, two technical employees, and an Allowance Inspector.

The chairperson asked, "For how many years had you known Harihar Mahato?"

Devnarayan said, "More than forty years."

"Was he in front of you on the day of verification?"

"Both of us were sitting in front of Rupa bitiya."

"And now he is no more?"

Devnarayan answered in a slightly hard voice, "To prove that fact I have even submitted his death certificate. In the file meant to prove that I am alive, his death has now become a more certain document than I am."

The meeting room fell silent.

The technical officer said, "There are two possible solutions. Cancel the old verification and take a new witness, or accept its validity at the moment of verification and retain the first testimony."

The Allowance Inspector asked, "Under the second option, a dead person will appear as the current witness."

Rupa, who had brought the file from the block, said, "He is not the current witness. He was the witness at the moment of verification."

The chairperson looked at her. "What is the difference?"

"Only this: the proof is based on an event, not on eternal life. Harihar Babu was alive at 11:43 on 6 January and saw Devnarayan Babu alive. His death on 7 January does not make what he saw on 6 January untrue."

Jagdish's verification was still pending. The chairperson ordered that the first testimony be retained as 'valid at the moment of verification' and that the field for the second witness be reopened.

The Technical Cell made a temporary correction. Beneath the red warning a new line appeared—"Witness currently deceased; verification event completed before death."

Jagdish was called the next day. He gave his fingerprint. The screen turned green—"Witness 2 verified."

Devnarayan was sitting in the same room. At last the status changed—"Proof of life approved."

Rupa printed the receipt and handed it to him. Devnarayan read the paper for a long time.

"Is Harihar's name on it?"

"Yes. Witness 1."

"Does it say he is dead?"

"No. It gives only the verification date."

Devnarayan folded the receipt. "That is right. On that day he was alive."

After the case was closed, the district office issued a new instruction. The validity of a witness's verification would be determined by the witness's eligibility at the moment of verification; a later death would not automatically cancel an earlier verification. Current death status would remain in a separate record.

The system too was given two new fields—“Status at time of verification” and “Current status.”

A few weeks later Rupa looked at the new screen. Beside Harihar Mahato’s name, the first field was green—“Alive/verification complete.” The second was grey—“Deceased.”

Both were true in the same line.

The following year Devnarayan came to the Centre again for his proof of life. This time his fingerprint was captured on the first attempt. The screen turned green. No witness was required.

Rupa laughed. “This time your life has been proved by your own finger.”

Devnarayan looked at his hand. “Good. The responsibility for my being alive no longer rests on someone else’s life.”

He took the receipt and walked out. At the doorway he stopped for a few moments, then said, “But do not erase Harihar’s testimony.”

Rupa said, “It will not be erased. On that date, it was true.”

Devnarayan slowly nodded and walked away. His new proof glowed on the screen. Harihar’s name too remained in the old file—the testimony of a dead man that could remain true only because the office finally accepted this: proof of life does not require eternal life; it requires a truthful moment.

THE LAST TASK OF A CLOSED DEPARTMENT

The nameplate of the District Rehabilitation Assistance Cell had once gleamed in blue letters. On the third day after the reorganization order arrived, a carpenter came and took the board down. Two screw marks remained on the wall.

The room was still there. Inside were three cupboards, two desks, a fan, an old seal, and Shashikant Jha, a contractual clerk.

Under the order, the Cell ceased to exist from the evening of 30 June. From 1 July, all its routine work was transferred to the newly created "District Citizen Compensation Branch." The employees too were reassigned. One officer went to Land Acquisition, another to Social Security, another to the Accounts Branch.

Shashikant's name was not on the reassignment list. The final line of his contract said—"Until disposal of the Cell's pending cases or for a maximum of six months, whichever is earlier."

By five in the evening on 30 June, only one case remained.

Case No. 14/R—Kamla Devi versus District Rehabilitation Assistance Cell.

Twelve years earlier, three kathas of Kamla Devi's courtyard land had been taken for widening a road. Compensation had been assessed; half had been paid; the other half had become stuck in a boundary-demarkation dispute. The dispute was now over. The accounts audit too was complete. Only the final order remained.

The rule said—"The final compensation order shall be issued under the signature of the Head of the Cell."

On the evening of 30 June, Cell Head Vibhuti Narayan Singh left for headquarters to assume charge of his new post. His old post was deemed to have ended at that very moment.

On the morning of 1 July, Shashikant opened the room. There was no nameplate outside. Inside, Kamla Devi's file lay on the desk.

He went to the new branch. Branch Officer Pallavi Karn looked at the file.

"Why was this case not transferred to me?"

Shashikant showed her the annexure to the order. "Against this one case it says—'Final order under the existing rules of the Cell.'"

"Then was it transferred or not?"

"The file was left with me."

"Which branch are you an employee of?"

Shashikant smiled faintly. "I have come to find out exactly that."

Pallavi Karn returned the file and said, "I cannot sign it. The rule says Head of the Cell."

"The post of Head of the Cell has ceased to exist."

"Then obtain an order from the competent authority."

The search for a competent authority began. The Establishment Branch said—the powers of an abolished post did not automatically pass to a successor officer. The Legal Branch said—if the reorganization order did not expressly identify a successor, a special authorization order was required. The Accounts Branch said—payment could be made only when the order bore the signature of a legally competent officer.

Kamla Devi came on 2 July. Seeing no nameplate outside, she first began to turn back. Shashikant called from inside, “Maaji, here.”

She came in. “Has the office closed?”

“The Cell has ended.”

“And my work?”

“That has not ended yet.”

For a while Kamla Devi looked at Shashikant’s face. “The office is over, but the work is still left?”

Shashikant placed his hand on the file. “Only this one now.”

Kamla Devi opened her old cloth bag. Inside were the receipt for the first payment, the land map, papers in the name of her late husband Harinarayan Jha, and twelve acknowledgements.

“These papers have been going round for twelve years. Now the office itself has gone round?”

Shashikant had no answer.

He drafted a letter seeking a special authorization order. Half a day passed over whether the heading should carry the name of the old Cell or the new Branch. If he used the old name, the sender would be an institution that no longer existed. If he used the new name, the question would arise as to when the new Branch had become a party to this case.

At last he wrote the heading—“Regarding a pending case of the former District Rehabilitation Assistance Cell.”

In the sender’s place he wrote his own name—“Shashikant Jha, Contractual Clerk (Pending Case).”

The letter reached the District Magistrate’s office. The receipt desk asked, “Employee code?”

Shashikant gave his old code. The system displayed—“Unit inactive.”

“New unit?”

“I do not have one.”

“Then the letter will be entered as a private application.”

“This is not private. It is a government file.”

The receipt clerk kept looking at the paper. Finally, the letter was given a handwritten serial number under the category “Special Residual Work.”

Five days later, a note came from the Legal Branch—“For disposal of the abolished Cell’s final case, a proposal may be made to grant limited authority to the former Head of the Cell or to an officer of equivalent rank.”

Shashikant breathed a sigh of relief. But the Establishment Branch wrote—“The former Head of the Cell is now posted in another district; delegation of authority in the name of an abolished post is technically not possible.”

The Legal Branch wrote again—"Authority should be granted not to the person, but for the specific case."

A draft order was prepared—"For Case No. 14/R, Mr Vibhuti Narayan Singh is hereby authorized solely to pass the final order."

The Finance Branch objected—"It is not clear by what authority an officer whose present posting is in another district may issue an order against the treasury of this district."

The proposal changed again. Now the question arose of granting the authority to Pallavi Karn.

Pallavi said, "I will sign, but the order must clearly state that this is a case of the former Cell. Otherwise, tomorrow the audit will say the new Branch made a payment beyond its jurisdiction."

Meanwhile, Shashikant's honorarium for July was stopped.

The Accounts Branch said, "Your unit code is closed."

Shashikant showed them his contract. "My service continues until the pending case is disposed of."

The accounts clerk said, "Your service continues, but from which unit is your pay to come?"

"From the Cell that has ceased to exist?"

"Payment cannot be made from that code."

"The new Branch?"

"Your post is not sanctioned there."

For the first time, Shashikant understood that his job was alive on paper, but there was no place from which its pay could come.

He drafted a letter on that question too. The Establishment Branch wrote—"Contractual obligation continues until disposal of the residual case; expenditure may be adjusted from the former Cell's remaining administrative head."

The Accounts Branch replied—"The old head was closed on 30 June."

The Finance Branch suggested—"Special contingency head."

The officer in charge of the contingency head asked, "How can the regular honorarium of an abolished department be treated as a contingency?"

Shashikant laughed. When Kamla Devi came that day, she asked, "Has your work been done?"

Shashikant said, "I am doing your work."

Kamla Devi asked again, "And your own?"

For the first time, Shashikant fell silent.

Two weeks later, the District Magistrate issued a special order. Pallavi Karn was declared "Residual Competent Authority" solely for Case 14/R. The order clearly stated—the authority would exist only until the moment of signature and would end as soon as the order was issued.

The file reached Pallavi's desk. She examined every page again—the demarcation report, accounts audit, heir verification, payment calculation.

"Everything is in order," she said.

Shashikant smiled.

As Pallavi was about to sign the final order, she stopped. "The seal?"

Should the seal of the new Branch be used, or that of the old Cell?

The special order said—“Under the rules of the former Cell.”

Shashikant took the Cell’s round seal out of the old cupboard. Its use had been stopped after 30 June, but the certificate recording its destruction had not yet been prepared.

Pallavi looked at the seal. “The seal of an office that has ended?”

Shashikant said, “For this final order—”

He stopped. Then he said, “For this final order, the rule refers to this very seal.”

An opinion was taken from the Legal Branch over the telephone. The answer came—the old seal should not be used; the seal of the new Branch should be affixed, but the number of the special authorization order must be written below it.

At last the order was signed.

Kamla Devi was informed. The payment order reached the Treasury.

The Treasury sent back one question—“The authority of the officer issuing the order ends at the moment of signature; if clarification concerning payment is required later, who will provide it?”

Shashikant read the paper and held his head.

The Legal Branch replied—“The signed order is complete; any subsequent clarification shall be provided by the new Citizen Compensation Branch.”

The Treasury accepted the payment.

On the day the remaining compensation reached Kamla Devi’s account, she came to the office. There was still no nameplate outside, but the door was open.

“The money has come,” she said.

Shashikant’s face brightened. “Then the case is over.”

Kamla Devi said, “Mine is.”

She left.

In red ink, Shashikant wrote on the file—“Fully disposed of.”

At that very moment, the condition in his contract too was fulfilled.

He went to the Establishment Branch. “Now please issue my service-termination letter.”

The employee list was checked. The old Cell’s name was not there. Shashikant’s employee number was linked to an inactive unit.

The Establishment Assistant asked, “Which office are you currently posted in?”

“None. That is precisely why I need the service-termination letter.”

“The employee’s current office will issue the termination order.”

“My current office has ceased to exist.”

“The new Branch?”

“I was never posted there.”

“Then the old one?”

Shashikant remembered the two screw marks on the wall. “Its nameplate has been removed.”

The Establishment Assistant kept turning the pages of the file. "Then first we will have to determine your current unit. After that, your service can be terminated."

Shashikant laughed. "An officer's post was created to close the case. Now will an office be created to close the job?"

No one answered.

At last an interim note was prepared—"Mr Shashikant Jha, contractual clerk of the former District Rehabilitation Assistance Cell, shall be deemed relieved of responsibility following disposal of the residual case; the formal service-ending order shall be issued once the competent administrative unit is determined."

Shashikant read the note. "Shall be deemed relieved of responsibility."

"Yes," the Establishment Assistant said. "You need not come from tomorrow."

"My honorarium?"

"That is proceeding in a separate file."

Shashikant returned to his old room. He cleared the desk. He tied up Kamla Devi's file to be sent to the records room of the new Branch. He sealed the old official stamp in an envelope. He took the cupboard key in his hand.

The key-deposit list showed Room No. 12, but in the building register Room 12 was now marked "Vacant."

The Store Clerk said, "How can I take the key of a vacant room from you?"

Shashikant said, "The room has become vacant now. Until this moment, the key was with me."

"Vacant means it is in no one's charge."

"Then whose key is this?"

The Store Clerk thought for a while. At last he wrote a receipt by hand—"One old key, relating to former Cell, received."

In the evening, Shashikant closed the door for the last time. Where the nameplate had been, a pale rectangle remained on the wall.

He put the receipt, the relief-from-responsibility note, and the number of the pending honorarium file into his bag.

As he walked down the stairs, the guard asked, "You will not come tomorrow?"

Shashikant said, "The work is finished."

"The job?"

Shashikant paused for a moment.

"They are still deciding which office it belongs to."

STORY 181

TWO TICKETS

In the small village house, two envelopes lay on top of an old iron trunk. On one, Lalita had written in her own hand—"Delhi." On the other, Ganesh had written—"Patna."

Inside the two envelopes were railway tickets. One was Ganesh's, the other Lalita's.

Ganesh Mahato worked with a mason. He built houses from village to village, cast roofs, tore down old walls. As soon as the rains came, work declined. This time a construction crew in Delhi had called five men from the village for three months' work. The wages were twice what they earned here, but on arrival they would need separate money for worker registration, safety insurance, and a tool deposit.

Lalita worked as an assistant in the panchayat nutrition room. The honorarium was small, but for two years she had been taking the examination for health-assistant training. This time her name had been selected for three days of verification and training at the Patna centre. If her certificates passed scrutiny, there could be an opportunity for regular work at the village health centre the following year.

The two journeys fell in the same week.

The household savings were not enough to cover the tickets, travel expenses, Ganesh's registration, and Lalita's verification fee all at once. The tickets had been booked long before at a low fare. At that time, neither of them had known the full amount of the other expenses.

After dinner that night, the two sat beside the hearth and added up the figures.

Ganesh wrote on a sheet of paper—"Eight hundred and fifty on reaching Delhi."

Lalita wrote on her slip—"Seven hundred and eighty at the Patna centre."

There were five hundred and thirty rupees in cash in the house.

For a while, both remained silent.

Ganesh said, "Your training is important. I may get another chance to go to Delhi."

Lalita replied at once, "When will this crew call again? Three months' wages will do a great deal for the house. There will be another batch of my training too."

"Your name has come this time."

"Your name has come this time too."

The sheet of calculations lay between them.

At last Ganesh laughed and said, "We will both go. We will see what happens on the way."

Lalita knew that "we will see what happens on the way" was often the name given to a problem for which no solution had yet been found.

The next morning Ganesh went to work. At noon the work stopped after half a day because the sand had not arrived. He went straight to the railway reservation window in the market.

He took out the Delhi ticket and placed it at the window.

"You want to return it?" the clerk asked.

Ganesh looked at the ticket for a moment. The date was five days away. The name was clearly printed—Ganesh Mahato.

"Yes."

After deduction, nine hundred and twenty rupees were refunded to him.

He put the money in his pocket and went to the service centre in the market. A photograph of Lalita's training letter was stored on his mobile phone. He paid the certificate-verification fee of seven hundred and eighty rupees. With the remaining one hundred and forty, he bought a small slip bearing the address of the Patna centre and two transparent document sleeves.

When he returned home, he said only, "Keep all your papers together. Do not get nervous when you reach Patna."

Lalita asked, "Did you arrange the money for Delhi?"

Ganesh turned his eyes away. "It will be arranged."

Lalita did not ask again.

That same evening, while returning from the nutrition room, Lalita stopped in the market. Ganesh's Delhi envelope was at home, but he kept the ticket in the inner pocket of his shirt. Lalita had already written down the ticket number because, while preparing a list for the journey day, she had copied all the details into a notebook.

At the reservation office, she showed the number to the clerk. Once the identity matched, a digital copy of the ticket was brought up. Lalita said, "I want to return it."

The clerk asked, "You are not the passenger."

"I am his wife. The original ticket is at home."

Under the rules, the ticket could not be returned without the original. Lalita went back home.

That night Ganesh was bathing. His shirt hung on a peg. Lalita took out the ticket, put it in her bag, and in its place folded the Delhi call letter and slipped it into the pocket.

The next morning she went to the market again. This time the ticket was returned. After deduction, she received one thousand and ten rupees.

Lalita went to the Labour Assistance Centre. In Ganesh's name, she paid a total of eight hundred and fifty rupees for temporary worker registration, accident insurance, and the tool deposit. The receipt bore Ganesh's name, the code of the Delhi construction crew, and the validity date.

She kept the remaining one hundred and sixty rupees separately in her bag. When she returned home, she placed the receipt in the pocket of Ganesh's shirt.

In the evening, as Ganesh put on the shirt, he felt the thickness of the paper. He took it out and saw—worker registration complete.

He looked towards Lalita, who was sitting on the veranda.

"Who paid this?"

Serving rice, Lalita said, "The person who had to."

"The money?"

"It was arranged."

Ganesh understood some of it, not all. He thought to himself that Lalita must have borrowed from someone.

That night both remained awake for a long time. Each had one secret, and each believed that the secret would make the other's road easier.

The day of travel was the same for both. Ganesh's train from Darbhanga to Delhi was due at 2:20 in the afternoon. Lalita's train to Patna was at 3:10.

They locked the house in the morning and left together. They told the neighbour that Ganesh was going away for three months and Lalita would return after three days.

When they reached the station, Ganesh lifted Lalita's bag onto his own shoulder. Lalita took Ganesh's small tool bag.

The platform was crowded. The voices of tea sellers, water sellers, porters, and ticket inspectors mingled with one another.

Ganesh's train was due first.

Lalita said, "You board first. My train is an hour later."

Ganesh said, "No, I will show you your platform first. Then I will catch my train."

"Your train is first."

"There is time."

Each kept trying to send the other ahead.

At last Lalita laughed. "All right, take out the ticket. Let us see the coach."

Ganesh's face changed slightly.

"The ticket?"

"Yes, the Delhi one."

Ganesh put the bag down. "I thought you were going to take out your ticket."

Lalita tried to read his face.

Ganesh said softly, "I returned the Delhi ticket."

Lalita went still.

"Why?"

Ganesh took a receipt from his pocket—the receipt for Lalita's certificate-verification fee.

"You go to Patna. The fee has been paid."

Lalita's hand moved of its own accord towards her bag. She took out the receipt for the worker registration.

"I returned the ticket too."

Ganesh took the paper. He read the name. Insurance, registration, tool deposit—all paid.

"Your Patna ticket?"

"I do not have it."

For a while, both stood silent amid the crowd.

Just then the clerk at the reservation window recognized them from a distance. He could not leave the window and come outside, but called from within, "Oh! These are the two people with yesterday's tickets!"

Ganesh and Lalita looked towards him at the same time.

The clerk laughed and said, "One ticket was returned yesterday afternoon, the other this morning. I thought someone's journey at home had been cancelled. But both passengers are standing here!"

For the first time, Lalita smiled.

Ganesh laughed too, though there was weariness inside the laughter.

"What now?" Lalita asked.

Ganesh looked at the platform clock. "A general ticket can still be bought. How much money do we have?"

They searched their pockets and bags. Together they had three hundred and sixty-five rupees.

It was not enough for a general ticket to Delhi. It could buy one person's ticket to Patna, but almost nothing would remain for the journey expenses.

Ganesh said, "You go. The fee has been paid."

Lalita shook her head. "If I go, you will miss the Delhi crew."

"My ticket is already gone."

"Mine too."

An announcement came—the train towards Delhi would arrive on Platform Three in a few minutes.

Ganesh looked in that direction. Then at Lalita.

"I thought your three days of training were worth more than my three months of wages."

Lalita said, "I thought your three months of wages were worth more than my three days of training."

Ganesh laughed. "The account is balanced again."

This time Lalita laughed openly. "This was a harder calculation than the five hundred and thirty we wrote on the paper at home."

The Delhi train arrived. People boarded, bags went inside, hands waved from the windows. Ganesh and Lalita remained standing on the platform.

The train pulled away.

An hour later, the Patna train arrived too. This time both remained seated on the bench.

Lalita said, "I will ask whether the verification fee will remain valid for the next batch."

Ganesh said, "The registration is valid for three months. If the Delhi crew calls another batch, we will see."

"So both tickets are gone, but neither road is completely closed."

Ganesh folded the two receipts together. "Tickets can be bought again. Paying these fees again would have been difficult."

Lalita took the papers from his hand. "From now on, we will not sell anything without telling each other."

"You too?"

"Me too."

On the way back from the station, they did not take a bus. To save money, they travelled half the way in a shared vehicle and walked the other half.

When they reached home, the two envelopes on top of the trunk were opened. One held the Delhi call letter; the other, the Patna training list. Neither held a ticket.

Lalita placed the two receipts between the envelopes—one for Ganesh's registration, one for her own verification fee.

Ganesh asked, "What shall we write on the envelopes?"

Lalita looked at the words already written—"Delhi" and "Patna."

She erased nothing. In the empty space between the two envelopes, she wrote in small letters—"First, each other's road."

That night they added up the figures again. This time, instead of travel dates, they wrote down how much they would have to save before the next earnings came.

There were no tickets on top of the trunk. But two journeys were still waiting to begin from that house.

THE BANGLE BOX

For years, a small red box had been kept apart inside Sarita Jha's iron trunk. Clothes, papers, old photographs, the wedding veil—everything in the house changed places from time to time, but the red box never did.

Inside the box were two bangles. They were neither broad nor very heavy. Fine patterns of flowers and leaves ran over them, with patches of worn golden gleam here and there.

Two months before she died, Sarita's mother, Devaki Devi, had placed the box in her hands.

"Give these to Manjari at her wedding," she had said.

Sarita had asked, "Your own bangles?"

Devaki Devi had only nodded. "What belongs to the house should remain in the house."

At the time, Manjari was in college. There was no talk of marriage. Sarita put the box away in the trunk.

Six years passed.

Sarita could not have counted how many times she opened the box during those six years. But never to wear the bangles. Only to make sure they were safe.

The first time, half the roof of the house had collapsed in the rains. The mason asked for eight thousand rupees. There was not even four thousand in the house. Sarita's husband, Naval, had said, "Pawn the bangles. The work will get done. We can redeem them later."

Sarita took out the box and held it for a long time. Then she closed it and put it back in the trunk.

"These are Manjari's," she said.

From that night, Sarita began taking on extra sewing work. For three months she stitched tunics, children's clothes, and pillow covers until midnight. The roof was repaired. The bangles did not go.

The second time, her son Abhinav's school fees fell into arrears. The headmaster had said that the dues had to be cleared before he could sit the examination. Naval again said softly, "The box is still there."

This time Sarita did not even open it. She stitched curtains for two households, worked day and night through the wedding season, and paid the fees.

The third time, the motor of her sewing machine burned out. When she heard the price of a new one, she sat before the box for a long time one evening.

Her mother had said—"Give them to Manjari at her wedding."

Sarita drew back her hand. For two months she worked the machine with the foot treadle.

Manjari did not know all these things in full. She completed her studies at the district training college and began teaching at a private school. Later she obtained a post as a contractual teacher with the panchayat. She managed her own expenses.

When the marriage was fixed, Sarita opened the box in front of Manjari for the first time.

“Mother kept these for you.”

Manjari fell silent as she took the bangles in her hands. “I remember them. Mother used to wear them during worship and festivals.”

“She said they were to be given to you at your wedding.”

Manjari ran a finger along the worn edge of a bangle. “You have kept them safe all these years?”

“What did I do? They were yours.”

Manjari closed the box. “We will open it on the wedding day.”

Five days before the wedding, Sarita thought she should have the bangles cleaned. The joint of one bangle also seemed a little loose. Jagdish Sah, an old goldsmith in the market, had known the family since her mother’s time.

Sarita wrapped the red box in cloth and went to his shop.

Jagdish Sah put on his spectacles and examined the bangles. First the engraving, then the joint, then the inner rim. He became quiet for a moment.

“How old are they?”

“My mother’s. More than thirty years, as far as I know.”

Jagdish Sah rubbed the edge of a bangle on a small testing stone. A fine line appeared. Then he let a drop fall from a bottle.

Sarita waited.

Jagdish Sah tested the second bangle too.

“Sister,” he said softly, “these are not gold.”

Sarita did not understand. “What?”

“They are brass. A golden coating was put over them. It is very old work.”

Sarita almost snatched the bangles from his hand. “These are my mother’s bangles.”

“They may well be. I am not saying they are not yours. I am only saying the metal is not gold.”

All the sounds in the shop suddenly seemed far away in Sarita’s ears—the ring of the hammer, the whirl of the fan, the bell of a bicycle outside.

“Test them again.”

Jagdish Sah tested them again. This time he scraped a tiny blackened spot on the inside of one bangle. What gleamed beneath was not yellow, but a reddish metal.

“Brass.”

Sarita sat down on the chair.

The first thing that came to her mind was the day the roof had collapsed and she had refused to sell the bangles. Then Abhinav’s fees. Then the burned-out motor of the sewing machine.

She thought—so the thing for which she had chosen the harder road so many times had never possessed the value she had believed it did.

Then another thought came—who had changed the bangles?

The box had come straight to her from her mother's hands. After her mother's death, it had never left the house even for a day. The key to the trunk remained with Sarita.

"Were these ever real gold?" Sarita asked.

Jagdish Sah said, "Not this pair. The coating is old. How many years ago it was applied would be difficult to say."

Sarita was about to lift the box when Jagdish Sah said, "Why is the cloth inside raised here?"

There was a layer of velvet at the bottom of the red box. One corner seemed slightly lifted. Sarita had not noticed it in all these years.

Jagdish Sah raised the corner with a pointed pair of tweezers. Beneath the velvet lay two folded papers.

The first was an old goldsmith's receipt. It was dated eight years earlier. The description read—"Two old gold bangles, total weight..." The sale amount was written below.

Sarita's hands began to tremble.

The second paper was in Devaki Devi's handwriting. The ink had faded, but the letters were still recognizable.

"Sarita," the first line said, "if this paper ever reaches you, understand that the gold of the bangles did not leave the house; it changed its form."

Sarita kept reading.

Devaki Devi had written that during Sarita's father's final illness, the southern courtyard of the house and two rooms had been mortgaged to a moneylender. After his death, the moneylender had given them three months—if the money was not repaid, the land papers would be transferred into his name. There was nothing else in the house that could be sold. Devaki Devi sold the real bangles and repaid both the principal and the interest on the mortgage.

On the back of the same paper, her mother had written—"My heart would not let me leave the box empty, so I had these two imitation bangles made in the market. I say they are to be given to Manjari at her wedding, because if the real bangles had not been sold, the courtyard where her wedding pavilion will stand would no longer have remained in our hands."

Sarita read the paper again.

The southern courtyard of the house rose before her eyes—the place where the two sisters had played seven-stones as children, where their mother had dried paddy, and where the bamboo poles for Manjari's wedding now stood. For all these years Sarita had thought of that land simply as "our home"; for the first time she understood that one piece of it had been brought back by the gold from her mother's bangles.

The real bangles Sarita had spent six years protecting had not been inside the box at all. Their gold had long ago redeemed a mortgage on paper and become earth, wall, and courtyard.

Jagdish Sah silently returned the papers.

"Shall I clean them?" he asked.

Sarita looked at the bangles. "Yes. But do not make them shine like gold. Let them remain as they are."

Jagdish Sah only cleaned away the dirt and tightened the loose joint. Whatever golden coating remained was left as it was.

On the way home, one heavy question stayed in Sarita's mind—what would she tell Manjari?

The wedding house had already filled with people. Clothes were being folded in one room, spices ground in another, songs rising somewhere else. Henna was being applied to Manjari's hands.

Sarita put the red box in her own room. After everyone had gone to sleep that night, she called Manjari.

"There is something I have to tell you."

The moment Manjari saw her face, she asked, "What happened?"

Sarita opened the box. First the bangles, then the two papers beneath them.

"These are not gold."

For a moment Manjari said nothing.

Sarita told her everything—the goldsmith, the test, the old receipt, her mother's note.

Manjari sat for a long time holding her grandmother's handwriting in her hands. Then suddenly she laughed. There were tears in her eyes, but the laughter was clear.

Manjari lifted her eyes from the note. "So the land where my wedding pavilion is standing was saved by these bangles?"

"Yes. Mother sold the real bangles and redeemed the mortgage."

Manjari looked out through the window. In the courtyard, bamboo poles, mango leaves, and clay stoves had all been arranged. "Then Mother was telling the truth when she said, 'Give them at her wedding.'"

Sarita remained silent for a few moments. "I thought she meant they were to be placed in your hands."

Manjari took Sarita's hand. "She did place something in our hands—the box. But the real thing had already been beneath our feet."

Sarita kept looking at her.

Manjari lifted the bangles. "The metal is imitation, but the courtyard they saved is not."

Sarita said softly, "Mother left this for me to understand later."

Manjari replied at once, "Yes—her note says it clearly."

The two sisters laughed.

On the wedding day, Sarita had thought of giving something else in place of the bangles. Naval too had said, "Let us buy some small silver piece. What will people say?"

Sarita asked Manjari.

Manjari answered plainly, "Buy nothing. Certainly not by taking a loan."

"Then shall your hands be empty at the wedding?"

Manjari laughed. "Grandmother's box is there, isn't it?"

Before the farewell, during a small ceremony inside the house attended only by close women relatives, Sarita opened the red box. She slipped the bangles onto Manjari's wrists. No one asked what metal they were made of. Their old gleam looked gentle in the light of the oil lamps.

Two minutes later Manjari took the bangles off and placed them back in the box.

"Why did you take them off?" Sarita asked.

"They are less something to wear than a story to keep."

She put her grandmother's note inside as well. This time not beneath the velvet, but on top, beside the bangles.

At the time of farewell, Sarita put the box into Manjari's bag. Manjari took it out again and returned it to Sarita's hands.

"You keep this."

"Mother gave it for you."

"Mother kept it for you. The real bangles she gave to this house."

In the end they decided that the box would remain with Sarita, while Manjari would keep a digital image of her grandmother's note on her phone.

After the wedding crowd had gone, Sarita opened the trunk that night. She placed the red box once more in its old place.

This time, looking at it, she did not remember only the hardship of the roof, the school fees, and the burned-out motor. She understood that the sacrifices she had made had not been wasted. She had not endured hardship merely to preserve the price of imitation bangles; she had endured it to preserve one of her mother's promises—a promise whose true form was not inside the box, but in the courtyard of the house.

Inside the box was brass under a golden coating. Beneath it, an old receipt. Beside it, her mother's handwriting.

Sarita closed the lid.

Now she knew—the true gold of the bangles had never been in the box. Long ago it had redeemed the mortgage papers and mingled with the soil of this house; on that very soil Manjari's wedding pavilion had stood.

STORY 183

THE RED SWEATER

At Saraswati Devi's house, preparations for winter began before Diwali. Old quilts were spread in the sun, woollen clothes came out of the iron trunk, and blankets hung all day from the bamboo pole on the veranda.

This time an old brown blanket was found at the bottom of the trunk. Its edges were torn, the wool had thinned in places, and there was a black stain on one corner. Saraswati Devi lifted it and said, "This is no use to anyone now."

Her daughter Mira immediately said, "Do not throw it away."

"Will you use it?"

"No. But there is still wool in it."

Saraswati Devi laughed. "There is dust in the cobwebs on the wall too."

Mira took the blanket into her hands. "This blanket used to smell of Babuji when I was little."

Saraswati Devi's laughter faded a little.

Her late husband, Jagdish Thakur, had brought the blanket from Nepal in the first year of their marriage. The wool was thick and the colour brown. For many years it was the warmest thing in the house. A child fell ill, a guest stayed the night, someone had to guard the paddy on a Paus night—the turn always came to that blanket.

When Mira was five, the Kosi once rose as far as the edge of the village. While evacuating the house at night, Saraswati Devi had wrapped Mira in that same blanket and carried her to a neighbour's pucca house.

Mira did not remember the whole incident, but she remembered the brown colour of the blanket.

"Something can still be made from this wool," she said.

At the village market, a women's group unravelled old woollen clothes, washed the wool, spun it again, and made new yarn. The group was called the "Sakhi Reweaving Centre." People brought old sweaters, blankets, and mufflers; usable wool was weighed, dyed, and then made into new things for a labour charge.

Mira took the blanket there. Rekha Devi, the head of the group, examined the wool and said, "It is very old, but the fibres inside are good. We will cut away the edges, unravel the yarn, wash it, and spin it again."

"How much will be saved?"

"A little under three kilos. It will not make a whole blanket again, but two or three smaller things can be made."

Mira deposited the blanket. The receipt read—"Household account: Saraswati Devi. Estimated wool: 2 kilograms 870 grams."

Mira said, "Why Mother's name?"

Rekha Devi laughed. "Didn't you say the blanket was hers?"

Mira folded the receipt and put it in her bag.

A month later, Mira found work as a library assistant at a private school in Madhubani city. The salary was not very large, but it was regular. She had to catch the bus at seven in the morning and return in the evening. The school building stood beside an open field; in winter the wind struck hard.

During the first week Mira went wearing an old shawl. In the second week, one end of the shawl almost caught in the bus seat.

When she returned home, Saraswati Devi said, "You need a sweater."

Mira said, "I will buy one with the next salary."

"From the first salary, household rations, your monthly bus pass, and your examination books come first."

"Then the shawl will do for now."

Saraswati Devi said nothing.

The very next day she went to the market. At the Sakhi Reweaving Centre, Rekha Devi was going over the accounts of the old wool.

"Saraswati Didi, the wool from your blanket is ready. Very good fibre came out of it."

Saraswati Devi started. "My blanket?"

Rekha Devi understood that Mira had not told her at home.

She said gently, "Mira deposited it. It was old, so we spun it again."

For a few moments Saraswati Devi looked at the skeins of yarn. The brown wool, once washed, had become a pale muddy shade.

"Can a sweater be made from this?"

"Yes. If we dye it, it can even become a fine red."

Saraswati Devi said at once, "Red."

Rekha Devi asked, "For whom?"

"Mira."

"Measurements?"

Saraswati Devi estimated the size from one of Mira's old kurtas. Buttons down the front, the neck a little high, full sleeves. She wanted the sweater neat enough for Mira to wear to school.

Rekha Devi opened the wool account. "The sweater will take about one kilo two hundred grams. The rest of the wool will remain in the account."

"Let it remain. Do not tell Mira."

"All right."

Saraswati Devi paid half the labour charge. The rest was to be paid when she collected the sweater.

Meanwhile, something was troubling Mira. As the cold increased, her mother's knees hurt at night. Saraswati Devi would sit on the cot with the corner of an old quilt over her knees, but because she had to keep getting up to see to the hearth, the water, and the door, carrying the whole quilt around was difficult.

Mira said, "You need a light blanket."

"There are two blankets in the house."

"Both are heavy."

"Heavy blankets are warm."

"A person should not have to wrap herself in a sack just to keep warm."

Saraswati Devi smiled. "Buy your own sweater first."

Mira fell silent at that, but the following Saturday she went to the market. At the Sakhi Reweaving Centre, Rekha Devi suppressed a smile when she saw her.

"Tell me?"

Mira said softly, "I want a light blanket made for Mother. Not very large. Enough to cover her from knees to shoulders when she sits on the cot."

Rekha Devi opened the account.

Under Saraswati Devi's name, the remaining wool was now recorded as—1 kilogram 670 grams.

Rekha Devi asked, "Will you buy new wool, or use the old wool remaining in this household account?"

Mira was surprised. "There is still that much left?"

"Yes."

"Then make the blanket from this."

"Colour?"

Mira thought. "Keep it brownish, like Mother's old blanket. Give it a red border."

For a moment Rekha Devi looked at Mira's face. "A red border?"

"Yes. Why?"

"Nothing."

Mira paid the labour charge. "Do not tell Mother."

Holding back her laughter, Rekha Devi said, "The wool from this household is doing a great deal of secret work."

Mira did not understand what she meant.

In the first week of December, the red sweater was ready. Rekha Devi called Saraswati Devi separately.

The sweater was deep red. The yarn was not perfectly uniform—darker red in some places, lighter in others. Because it was old wool, there were tiny variations across the surface.

Saraswati Devi took it in her hands and stroked it for a long time.

"It does not look like the old blanket," she said.

Rekha Devi replied, "The wool is old; the form is new."

Inside one sleeve, there was a very thin black fibre that had not taken the red dye completely.

Rekha Devi said, "There was some black wool mixed into the yarn of the old blanket. I can remove this."

Saraswati Devi stopped her. "Let it remain. It has its own mark."

She wrapped the sweater in paper, took it home, and hid it in the upper compartment of the trunk.

Three days later the blanket was ready. Mira stopped at the market while returning from school.

The blanket was light, brownish-grey, with a red border all around. There was a small square weave in the middle to hold the wool firmly in place.

Mira put it over her shoulders to test it. "Right for Mother."

Rekha Devi said, "The history of this wool is in your house."

Mira replied, "That is why."

At one corner of the blanket ran a thin line of black fibre.

Mira ran her finger over it. "Why this black thread?"

"A remnant from the old wool. I can cut it out if you like."

Mira shook her head. "No. Let it stay."

Rekha Devi smiled again.

At home, mother and daughter kept hiding their gifts from each other. Saraswati Devi kept the upper compartment of the trunk closed. Mira kept the blanket beneath the bag in which she carried her school clothes.

There was no particular festival fixed for giving the gifts. But on one very cold evening in Paush, the electricity went out. Wind came through the gap in the door. When Mira returned from the library, her mother's hands were stiff with cold.

Saraswati Devi said, "Today I have something to give you."

Mira said too, "I have something as well."

"You first."

"No, you first."

Both laughed.

Saraswati Devi opened the trunk and took out the red sweater.

Mira truly fell silent.

"Ma, this—?"

"Try it on."

Mira put on the sweater. The fit was almost right. The sleeves were a little long, but it was warm. The deep red shone against her dusky face.

"Why did you spend so much money?"

Saraswati Devi answered at once, "Very little money. The wool was ours."

Mira was startled.

"Which wool?"

Saraswati Devi showed her the black fibre inside the sleeve. "From that old blanket."

For a few moments Mira stared at the sleeve of the sweater. Then, without saying anything, she went inside.

Saraswati Devi thought Mira had become emotional.

Mira came back carrying the brown blanket from her bag.

"Then look at this too."

She spread the blanket over her mother's shoulders.

The red border gleamed in the lamplight.

Saraswati Devi caught one corner of the blanket. Her finger stopped on the black fibre.

Both their eyes went to the same black thread at once.

"This—?" Saraswati Devi began.

Mira burst out laughing. "From that same old blanket."

For a moment the two looked at each other.

Saraswati Devi lifted the sweater sleeve; Mira lifted the corner of the blanket. Both carried the black fibre—a thin line that even the red dye had not erased.

Mira said, "I thought I would have a blanket made from that same wool for Mother. You had already taken half of it."

Saraswati Devi replied, "I thought a sweater would be made for my daughter and the remaining wool would stay for later. You took the rest as well."

"So the old blanket of the house has become two pieces?"

"No," Saraswati Devi said softly, "it has taken two forms."

That night the two spent a long time recalling the story of the old blanket. Jagdish Thakur had brought it in the first winter of their marriage; Mira had been wrapped in it on the night of the flood; it had covered Saraswati Devi for three nights during a fever; once it had even been lent for a newborn child in the neighbourhood.

Mira said, "I was afraid that if it were thrown away, all those stories would go with it."

Saraswati Devi adjusted the blanket over her knees. "Stories do not live in wool."

Mira stroked the sleeve of the sweater.

Saraswati Devi completed the sentence. "But sometimes wool lets us touch the story."

The next day Mira wore the red sweater to school. The children in the library asked, "A new sweater?"

She only said, "Made from old wool."

The children did not understand.

At home, Saraswati Devi cut vegetables with the light blanket over her shoulders. She no longer had to lift the heavy quilt.

A few days later, both went together to the Sakhi Reweaving Centre. Rekha Devi laughed when she saw them together.

"So the secrecy is over now?"

Saraswati Devi said, "You understood beforehand?"

"There was one account in the same name. The wool came from one batch. The orders were two separate ones."

Mira asked, "Why did you not tell us?"

"My work in a gift ended with the weaving. Revealing the secret was not my work."

Rekha Devi showed them the account. Under Saraswati Devi's name were two lines—"Red sweater: 1.200 kilograms." "Light blanket: 1.670 kilograms." Balance—zero.

Saraswati Devi laughed. "The whole blanket is gone."

Rekha Devi said, "Not the whole blanket. Only the yarn."

Mira closed the account book.

On the way home, Saraswati Devi ran a hand over the sleeve of the red sweater. "She had offered to remove the black fibre."

Mira looked at the corner of her blanket. "From mine too."

"We did right not to have it removed."

"Yes."

The Paush nights were still cold. But nowhere in the house was the old brown blanket to be found. In its place, a red sweater travelled to the city, and a light blanket rested on Mother's shoulders at home.

They were two different things. Their uses were different.

But whenever the sleeve of the red sweater and the corner of the brown blanket lay together on the cot, that thin black fibre silently joined them—as though the old wool had changed its dwelling, not its home.

STORY 184

ON THE OTHER SIDE OF THE POND

The water in the pond had receded. After the Bhadon rains stopped, the green water in the middle looked still, but the earth around the edges was still soft. On the western bank, three new bamboo stakes had been driven into the ground. Red thread was tied across their tops.

Harimohan Jha was sitting on the third step of the old stone stairway. A cane walking stick was in his right hand, but he had laid it on the ground. Madhav sat beside him, one step lower. He had arrived from the city only the previous evening.

The two had sat together beside this pond many times. When Madhav was a child, he would go down as far as the water, and Harimohan Jha would call from above not to step on the moss. Today Madhav wore city shoes. He looked at the moss on the steps but made no attempt to go down.

"The water is low," Madhav said.

"It filled very little this time," Harimohan Jha said.

"Was the upper drain not cleared?"

"Only halfway. The day the men came, it rained."

Madhav looked to the other side of the pond. The red thread appeared taut even though there was no wind.

"Who drove in these stakes?"

Harimohan Jha looked that way too. "The survey men."

"When did they come?"

"On Tuesday."

"You did not tell me."

Harimohan Jha turned a finger around the handle of the stick. "You were coming on Wednesday."

Madhav said nothing. The corner of a folded paper showed from the upper pocket of his shirt. After dinner the previous night, he had taken the paper out, placed it on the table, then folded it and put it back in his pocket. Harimohan Jha had seen it but had asked no question.

Two children with schoolbags on their backs were coming from the other side of the pond. A narrow path ran between the bamboo stakes. There had once been more grass there. Now, under repeated footsteps, the soil had turned dark and hard.

One child bent under the red thread between the stakes and passed through. The other stepped over the thread from the side.

Madhav said, "Why has a path formed here?"

"It is shorter."

"The public path is to the south."

"It is."

"Then?"

Harimohan Jha kept watching a dried lotus leaf floating on the pond.
“Children take the shorter path.”

With the toe of his shoe, Madhav scraped at dried mud stuck to the stone.

“Are the stakes in the right place?”

“The survey men said they are.”

“On the paper?”

“They should be right on the paper too.”

Madhav put a hand over his pocket. The folded paper made a crisp sound.

A dry leaf fell from the peepal tree beside the pond and landed on the steps.
With the tip of his stick, Harimohan Jha pushed it towards the water. The leaf got stuck halfway.

“Would it be more than two dhurs on that side?” Madhav asked.

“I do not remember the measurement.”

“Babuji, you do remember.”

Harimohan Jha smiled faintly. “Remembering and saying are two different things.”

For the first time Madhav looked at him. Harimohan Jha was looking across the pond.

From a distance, a woman came along the narrow path carrying a bundle of grass on her head. At the red thread she stopped, lowered the bundle, lifted the thread to pass beneath it, then put the bundle back on her head.

“Does everyone use this path?” Madhav asked.

“Those who are in a hurry.”

“There are fields ahead.”

“Beyond the fields is the road.”

“The price of land near the road has gone up.”

“Has the road grown, or the price?”

Madhav did not laugh. “Both.”

Harimohan Jha lifted the stick and straightened a small stone lying at the edge of the step. “Everyone in the village knows that prices have gone up.”

“In the city, people pay a great deal for this much land.”

“Who pays for a pond in the city?”

“Not for the pond. For the strip beside the road.”

Harimohan Jha fell silent again.

Madhav took the paper from his pocket. He did not open it. To shield his eyes from the sun, he held it upright near his forehead for a moment, then placed it on his knee. The name of the circle was printed in bold letters at the top. Beneath it was the plot number.

Madhav could not tell whether Harimohan Jha had read it.

“The western-side measurement is clear on this paper,” Madhav said.

“Good.”

“The three stakes fall on that measurement.”

“Then the survey men did their work well.”

Madhav folded the paper again. “If the thread stays here, the path will run through the middle of it.”

Harimohan Jha said, "Whether the thread stays or not is for the thread to know."

Madhav turned towards him. "For the thread to know?"

"People tie it. People untie it."

Just then a girl came running from the other side of the pond. She had a notebook in her hand. Her foot caught at the red thread, but she did not fall. She stopped, looked at the thread, then went around the outside of the stake. The earth was soft. Half her slipper sank into it. She pulled the slipper free, took it in her hand, and continued along the path barefoot.

Harimohan Jha watched her for a long time.

Madhav tapped the paper against his knee.

"If she had taken the southern path, her slipper would not have sunk," he said.

"The southern path is half a kos longer."

"How much is half a kos?"

"Ask someone who walks it every day."

Madhav did not reply.

A breeze rose over the pond. The red thread trembled once. Small circles formed on the water in the middle.

Harimohan Jha said, "Your mother used to take that very path to the market."

Madhav's fingers stopped on the fold of the paper.

"There was no road then," he said.

"There was no road. There was a path."

"Did Mother find it difficult to go the long way round?"

"She was always in a hurry."

Something came to Madhav's lips, then he did not say it.

After a while he asked, "Will the survey men come again?"

"They said they would."

"When?"

"When they are called."

"Who will call them?"

Harimohan Jha lifted the stick and rested it beside his knee. "Whoever has need of them."

Madhav put the paper back in his pocket.

Kishun Mahato was approaching from the fields in the distance with a hoe on his shoulder. When he reached the pond, he stopped.

"Babu, shall I replace the bamboo on the other side tomorrow?"

Harimohan Jha said, "Has the old bamboo rotted?"

"One of them is hollow at the bottom. If the thread remains taut, it will bend."

Madhav looked at Kishun. "How long will the thread remain?"

Kishun looked a little uncertain. "How would I know, Babu? The survey men tied it."

Harimohan Jha said, "Look at it tomorrow morning. If the bamboo is bad, replace it."

“Where should I drive the new bamboo?” Kishun asked.

Before answering, Harimohan Jha looked at Madhav.

Madhav looked across the pond. Even from here, the mark where the girl’s slipper had sunk looked dark.

“Where the old one is,” Harimohan Jha said.

Kishun nodded and went on.

Madhav said softly, “But this is not the old stake.”

“No.”

“Where was the old boundary?”

Harimohan Jha ran the tip of the stick through the doob grass growing beside the steps. “A boundary lives on paper. On the soil, there are marks.”

“Marks disappear.”

“Yes.”

“Then there is another survey.”

“Yes.”

Both fell silent.

Two or three times Madhav opened his mouth to speak of the city. The loan from his office, the instalment on the house, his daughter Sanvi’s fee for the next school term—all of it was on his mind. Among all those things, the price of this narrow strip appeared like a clear figure. Yet on the other side of the pond, children kept passing again and again beneath the red thread.

Madhav could not tell what was in Harimohan Jha’s mind. His face was still. Only his fingers kept turning again and again over the handle of the stick.

“Did you change the lock at the back of the house?” Harimohan Jha asked.

Madhav was startled. “Yes. The old lock had jammed.”

“Where is the new key?”

“With me.”

“Leave one here before you go.”

Madhav looked at his father for a few moments. “I will leave one.”

Harimohan Jha nodded.

The sun had begun to slope down. The colour of the pond was turning from green to grey. The red thread on the other side now looked more distinct.

Madhav rose to his feet. As he straightened his knees, he gave a slight groan. Harimohan Jha got up holding the stick.

“Shall we go?” Madhav asked.

Harimohan Jha said, “Let us walk around that side for a while.”

The two walked slowly along the rim of the pond. When they reached the western side, the earth was soft. The first stake stood straight, the second leaned a little, and all around the third were the footprints of children.

Harimohan Jha tapped the second stake with his stick. The bamboo gave a hollow sound from within.

“Kishun was right,” he said.

Madhav bent down and gripped the stake. The bamboo was indeed loose. The red thread pulled towards him and came within reach of his hand.

At that moment three children arrived there again. Seeing the two men standing by the stakes, the children stopped.

Madhav held the thread in his hand. The children looked towards the long turn to the south, then at Madhav.

Without saying anything, Madhav lifted the thread. One by one the children passed beneath it. After the last child had crossed, he called “Pranam” and ran on.

Madhav did not let go of the thread.

Harimohan Jha stood beside the third stake.

“This bamboo will be replaced tomorrow,” Madhav said.

“Yes.”

“If it is set a little farther inward, the ground will be firmer.”

Harimohan Jha looked at him.

With his foot Madhav scraped at the soft earth. About two cubits inward from the stake, the ground was hard.

“Here,” he said.

Harimohan Jha only nodded.

Madhav loosened the red thread and untied it from the old stake. One end of the thread remained in his palm. With his stick, Harimohan Jha made a small mark on the hard ground farther inside.

The two began walking back towards the house.

Behind them the pond was still. The narrow path on the other side remained where it had been. The red thread no longer stretched taut from stake to stake; one end hung from a bamboo, while Madhav had folded the other and put it into his pocket.

In that pocket, beside the thread, was the folded survey paper.

Neither of them spoke of it.

THREE EMPTY CHAIRS

Janardan Mishra moved the three chairs away from the wall and placed them at the far end of the dining row.

The chairs were not new. White paint had been scraped from the back of one; the right arm of another was slightly loose; the four legs of the third were uneven. Janardan Mishra slipped a folded piece of paper beneath the third chair.

“Why here?” Abhay asked.

Janardan Mishra measured the space between the chairs with his eyes. “This is fine.”

“The row is over there.”

“This too is part of the row.”

Abhay said nothing. He held the guest register in his hand. At the top, written in red ink, was the number—four hundred and forty-two.

On the northern side of the courtyard, the cooking was under way. Steam rose from a large cauldron of pulao. The smell of ghee, cumin, and smoke drifted with the air towards the dining area.

It was Archana’s wedding. The wedding procession had arrived. The ceremonies at the mandap were in progress. There was still a little time before the feast began.

Abhay had come from the city three days earlier. Numbers, leaf plates, glasses, sweets, water—every calculation was in his notebook. Janardan Mishra never looked at the notebook.

“These three extra chairs are not written down,” Abhay said.

“Are chairs written down?”

“Everything hired is counted.”

Janardan Mishra did not laugh. “Then count them.”

Abhay added nothing to the register.

As the afternoon declined, the first row sat down to eat. Children first. Then guests from far away. Dal in brass-coloured buckets, vegetables in tin buckets, and puris in baskets began moving along the row.

The three chairs remained empty.

An elderly guest moved towards the last chair. Janardan Mishra folded his hands and said, “Kaka, please sit here.” He seated him on an empty chair farther forward.

Abhay watched from a distance.

“Are these being kept for someone?” he asked when he came near.

“Yes.”

“For whom?”

“For those who are still working.”

Abhay looked towards the cooking area. Ten or fifteen people were running about there. “A lot of people are working.”

Janardan Mishra only said, "Yes."

The second row filled up.

Ramcharit, the cook, lifted the lid from a hot cauldron and let out the steam. The corner of his dhoti was tucked up to his knees. From time to time he washed his hands, then opened a box of spices.

Phulo Kaki was counting leaf plates. Whenever she saw a torn plate, she replaced it with another. If a child reached for sweets, she would say, "Eat your rice first."

Nandu was filling water. Between two large drums and four jugs, his feet never stopped.

The three chairs remained empty.

In Abhay's register were estimates for the first row, the second row, the third row. Again and again he crossed out numbers and wrote them afresh.

"Has Ramcharit Kaka eaten?" Janardan Mishra asked.

"Not yet," Abhay said. "He is in the cooking area."

"Phulo?"

"Looking after the leaf plates."

"Nandu?"

"Water."

Janardan Mishra nodded.

Abhay looked at his face. "Are these three for them?"

Before answering, Janardan Mishra saw a boy climbing onto the arm of one chair. "Baua, not there."

The boy climbed down.

"Yes," Janardan Mishra said.

Abhay folded the register. "They eat at the end."

"Why?"

Abhay paused a little. "Because they are working."

"After the work is over?"

"Then they eat."

Janardan Mishra looked at the three chairs. "They will sit here."

Abhay said nothing.

The third row rose. Water, curd, and grains of rice lay scattered on the ground. Two boys tried to sweep, but the next row arrived.

Nandu came running with two jugs in one hand. Janardan Mishra stopped him.

"Sit down for a while."

Nandu laughed. "Now?"

"Yes. Five minutes."

"Who will serve the water?"

"Someone else."

Nandu looked towards the rear drum. "That drum is only half full. Let me fill it, then I will sit."

He went away.

Abhay said, "See?"

Janardan Mishra did not answer.

A little later Phulo Kaki passed carrying a stack of leaf plates. Janardan Mishra pointed towards the chairs.

“Kaki, your place.”

The moment Phulo Kaki saw the chair, she laughed. “Mine?”

“Yes.”

“If I sit here, who will count the leaf plates?”

“Someone will.”

“If someone else counts, they will hand out two plates at a time.”

She walked on again.

Janardan Mishra watched her go.

Abhay said softly, “Babu, you want to stop the work so that people can eat.”

“Not eat. Sit.”

“What is the difference?”

Janardan Mishra looked at him. “You do not understand?”

Abhay did not answer.

A conch sounded from the mandap. Some women left the feast and rose to go that way. The empty places filled again.

Archana appeared once at the edge of the courtyard. A veil covered her head and flowers hung at her neck. Two cousins were with her. She quickly went inside.

Janardan Mishra looked that way for a moment, then towards the three chairs.

“If Ma were here, all of this would have been on her head,” Abhay said.

Janardan Mishra’s fingers stopped on the back of a chair. “Yes.”

“She would have had so much work at Archana’s wedding.”

“Yes.”

Abhay wanted to say something more, but did not.

Ramcharit, the cook, came out wiping his face, wet with steam. Janardan Mishra called to him.

“Ramcharit!”

“What happened?”

“Sit down.”

Ramcharit looked at the three chairs. “The fish still has to come off the fire.”

“The fish will not run away in ten minutes.”

Ramcharit smiled. “The fish will not run away, but the people will eat it.”

“Let them eat.”

Ramcharit wiped the sweat from his face with his gamchha. “I will eat later, in peace.”

“Here.”

Ramcharit looked at Janardan Mishra for a moment. “Here?”

“Yes.”

Ramcharit’s smile faded slightly. “Guests sit here.”

“What are you?”

Ramcharit placed the gamchha over his shoulder. “I am the cook.”

"That is your work."

"Today, I am the work."

He turned and walked back towards the cooking area.

Abhay no longer held the register. He had placed the notebook on the sill by the window.

"Babu," he said, "will putting out chairs change anything?"

Janardan Mishra pushed the paper farther beneath the third chair. "I do not know."

"Then?"

"I will not remove them while they are empty."

Abhay fell silent.

Night deepened. The strings of electric lights flickered off and came on again. The crowd at the feast thinned. Guests from far away began taking leave.

The dining rows became smaller now. Four people, six people, then ten.

The three chairs remained empty.

Phulo Kaki gathered the last leaf plates and went towards the cooking area. Nandu poured the remaining water from the drum towards the drain. Ramcharit scraped the rice left at the bottom of the cauldron into a small vessel.

Janardan Mishra asked for three plates.

Abhay set the plates down.

"Shall I call them now?"

"Yes."

Abhay called Nandu first. Nandu washed his hands and came over. He stopped in front of the chairs.

"Sit," Abhay said.

Nandu looked towards Phulo Kaki.

Phulo Kaki arrived. Her hands had been washed with soap, but turmeric still clung around her fingernails.

Ramcharit came too.

All three stood in front of the three chairs.

For a few moments no one spoke.

Janardan Mishra lifted the covers from the plates. "Sit."

Phulo Kaki said softly, "I will eat in the cooking shed."

"What is wrong with here?"

"What could be wrong?"

"Then?"

Phulo Kaki gave no answer.

Nandu wiped his wet palms on his dhoti. "I too will feel better over there."

Ramcharit touched the arm of a chair, then withdrew his hand. "Babu, I understand that you want us to sit."

Janardan Mishra looked at him.

Ramcharit continued, "But if I sit here today, people will say—the cook left the kitchen and sat down at the feast."

"The people have gone now."

Ramcharit looked around. Truly, most people had left.

"My own mind is still in the kitchen," he said.

Phulo Kaki laughed. "And my plate is already there."

"Since when?" Abhay asked.

"Since the first row began. I have been saving a little at a time."

Abhay kept looking at Phulo Kaki.

Nandu said, "They have kept the fish head for me."

Ramcharit said, "This boy will never leave a fish head."

All three laughed.

Janardan Mishra did not.

Phulo Kaki ran her hand along the back of one chair. "Keep these. We will sit next time."

"Next time?" Janardan Mishra asked.

"Will there not be another wedding in the house?"

Abhay laughed for the first time. "Mine?"

Phulo Kaki said, "Is it written in your register or not?"

Abhay shook his head.

The three picked up their own plates and walked towards the cooking shed.

Janardan Mishra did not stop them.

The courtyard was almost empty. In the distance, the ceremony at the mandap was still under way. Fragments of the mantras came on the wind.

Abhay stood in front of the three chairs.

"Shall I remove them?" he asked.

Janardan Mishra said, "Not yet."

"Why?"

"Let them stay."

Abhay placed a hand on one chair, but did not move it.

A little later laughter came from the cooking shed. Nandu had said something. Phulo Kaki's loud laughter rang out, followed by Ramcharit's quieter voice.

Janardan Mishra looked that way.

Abhay did too.

The plates still rested on the three chairs. No steam rose from the rice. Beside one plate, a small drop of curd had fallen and was beginning to dry.

"Shall I pick up the plates?" Abhay asked.

This time Janardan Mishra nodded.

Abhay picked up the plates and carried them towards the cooking shed.

The chairs remained where they were.

The last guest of the night also left. The courtyard was swept. Water was sprinkled. Grains of rice, scraps of leaf plates, and flower petals were washed to one side.

The seats of the three chairs were clean.

The folded paper beneath the third chair had become wet. The chair now stood level.

Abhay bent down and pulled out the paper. He opened it and looked. It was an old torn page from the guest register. No one's name was written at the top.

He folded the page and placed it beneath the chair leg again.

Janardan Mishra said nothing.

The three chairs remained empty to the end.

EVENING ON THE EMBANKMENT

Evening came quickly upon the embankment.

The western sunlight lay long across the grey water. The river's current was a little distance from the embankment, but the sound of erosion seemed close—first the faint rustle of earth, then a heavy mass breaking away and falling into the water.

Jagdish sat on the slope of the embankment. In his hand was an old measuring cord. A small brass-coloured ring was fixed to one end.

Ramakant stood a little distance away. He was looking towards the river.

The two brothers had come to look at the field before the day faded.

The land between them lay at the very place where the river was now cutting into the bank.

"It had not come this far yesterday," Ramakant said.

Jagdish looked at the newly cracked line in the earth. "No."

For a while neither spoke.

Below, two boys were driving cattle home. One cow pulled towards the green grass near the eroded edge. The boy turned it back with the sound of his stick.

Jagdish uncoiled the measuring cord.

Ramakant looked at him but said nothing.

The cord was old. Soil clung to its knots. Since their father's time, it had been kept in the wooden trunk at home. It was not an official survey cord, but the family's own cord.

Their father used it to measure field ridges, the garden plot, distances between bamboo clumps, the width of a shed—everything.

Jagdish stood up.

The two came down from the embankment and went towards the eroded edge.

The earth was not wet. It was dry on top, loose and crumbly within. Fine soil slid away under each step.

"Do not go farther," Ramakant said.

Jagdish stopped.

The first stake stood ahead.

Half the stake had emerged from the ground. The river had eaten away the earth beneath it.

Ramakant bent down to look. "Will it last through the night?"

"Hard to say."

This stake had been driven in five years earlier.

That day the surveyor had come. The two brothers, their two wives, three neighbours, the mukhiya, and two boys had stood watching. The surveyor had opened a red file and taken the measurements. This stake had then been accepted as the boundary in the middle.

After that, the land was not divided.

The papers were prepared, a day was fixed for signatures, and then Mother fell ill.

Mother passed away.

The signatures were never made.

Meanwhile, Jagdish's son found work outside. Ramakant's daughter began going to college. One year turned into another.

The land remained where it was.

A little more than three kathas.

Half was to be Jagdish's. Half Ramakant's. On a narrow strip in the middle stood the root of an old mango tree, because of which the surveyor had not been able to draw a straight line.

Now the mango tree was gone.

It had fallen in the last storm. Only the stump remained.

Jagdish hooked the ring of the cord around the stake.

"Shall we measure?" Ramakant asked.

"Let us see."

Ramakant took hold of the other end of the cord.

The two slowly stepped backwards.

The cord grew taut.

Where the second stake should have stood, there was no level patch of earth. There was only the fresh line of erosion.

Ramakant stood holding the cord in his hand.

"The second stake is gone," he said.

Jagdish said nothing.

The cord slackened.

In the distance, evening smoke rose from the village. Someone had set fire to straw at a house. The smell drifted as far as the embankment.

Ramakant began winding up the cord.

Jagdish said, "Leave it."

Ramakant stopped his hand.

The two climbed back onto the embankment.

The wind was stronger above.

On the other side of the embankment were paddy fields. Some had already been harvested; in others the ears still stood.

Jagdish's bicycle lay on the grass. Ramakant's old motorcycle stood a little distance away.

There was an empty space between the two.

Ramakant sat down.

Jagdish sat too.

The measuring cord lay between them.

After a while Ramakant said, "I called the surveyor yesterday."

Jagdish kept looking towards the river.

"He can come on Wednesday."

"Yes."

"I took out the papers too."

Jagdish nodded.

"Your signature is still pending."

"I know."

Silence again.

An egret landed in a shallow part of the river, then flew away.

Ramakant said, "What would Babu have done if he were here?"

Jagdish did not answer at once.

"Babu would have quarrelled with the river," he said after a while.

A faint smile came to Ramakant's face. "He would have driven in bamboo poles."

"Twenty of them."

"Forty."

The two laughed a little.

The laughter died quickly.

The sound came again from the eroded edge.

Both looked down at the same moment.

The first stake was still there. But the earth beside it had fallen away. The stake had tilted.

Ramakant stood up.

Jagdish caught his hand. "No."

Ramakant stopped.

"I will pull it out," he said.

"The earth will collapse."

"The stake will be carried away."

Jagdish let go of his hand.

Ramakant did not climb down.

The red part of the sun was now sinking below the tops of the trees.

Jagdish lifted the cord.

One end was still hooked around the stake.

He pulled the cord slowly.

The stake moved.

The earth did not break.

Jagdish pulled again.

The stake came free.

Ramakant watched him.

The stake was a piece of bamboo about two cubits long. Its lower part had turned black. The red survey mark was still visible at the top.

Jagdish laid the stake on the embankment.

Ramakant unfastened the end of the cord.

Neither of them said anything.

Below, the place where the boundary had been was now empty.

"Wednesday?" Ramakant asked.

Jagdish kept winding the cord.

"The surveyor?"

Jagdish said, "Call him."

"What shall I say?"

Jagdish straightened the last knot in the cord with his fingers.

"Tell him not to come yet."

Ramakant was silent for a while. "For how long?"

Jagdish looked towards the river.

"Let this water go down first."

Ramakant nodded.

The two sat down again.

Darkness was growing now.

Two women carrying bundles of grass passed along the top of the embankment. Seeing the two brothers, they greeted them. The brothers returned the greeting.

From the direction of the distant mosque came the call to prayer. After it, the bell of a temple.

The village was returning into evening.

Ramakant's mobile phone rang.

He looked at the screen. "From home."

He did not answer the phone.

"Answer it," Jagdish said.

"Two minutes."

The ringing stopped.

Ramakant said, "Bhauji will ask how many kathas are left."

Jagdish did not smile. "They will ask in your house too."

"Yes."

Again came the sound of erosion.

This time, after the fall, the water foamed for a few moments. Then the current became even again.

Jagdish picked up the stake lying on the embankment.

Ramakant thought he would take it home.

But Jagdish held the stake out towards Ramakant.

Ramakant did not take it.

For a few moments the piece of bamboo remained between their two hands.

Then Ramakant took hold of the other end.

Together, they did not break the stake.

They carried it to the inner side of the embankment.

There was an old rainwater drain there. The earth beside the drain was cracked.

Jagdish inserted the lower end of the stake into the crack.

Ramakant pressed the earth down around it with his foot.

The stake was no longer a boundary.

It was only a piece of bamboo holding up the sunken earth beside the drain.

Jagdish folded the cord to put it back in the trunk.

Ramakant took out his mobile phone.

"Shall I tell the surveyor now?"

Jagdish lifted his bicycle.

“Yes.”

Ramakant dialled the number.

Jagdish did not wait. He turned the bicycle around.

Ramakant put the phone to his ear.

“Hello? Aminji?”

Jagdish had already gone a little distance.

“Do not come on Wednesday,” Ramakant said. “There will be no measurement now.”

He listened.

“No, there has been no quarrel.”

Ramakant looked towards the river.

In the darkness, the line of erosion could no longer be seen clearly.

“We will tell you when the water goes down.”

He ended the call.

Jagdish had stopped at the bend of the embankment.

Ramakant walked towards his motorcycle.

He turned once to look back.

The old stake driven beside the drain was barely visible in the darkness.

The red mark was still on it.

But it no longer marked the boundary of any field.

Below, the river kept flowing.

STORY 187

THE LAST LOCAL

It was already half past ten at night.

The crowd at the station had thinned. The ticket window was half shuttered, and the tea seller was separating the fire from beneath his brass kettle.

Across the tracks, the yellow lights stood one by one, steady in the dark.

Upendra Jha stood beside the second pillar. An old black bag was tucked under his arm. Inside it lay his old office identity card and a flower garland wrapped in paper.

The garland had been given to him at the office. He had decided not to wear it all the way home.

When the wind blew, a corner of the paper fluttered out of the mouth of the bag.

Upendra pushed it back inside.

After a burst of static on the loudspeaker, a woman's voice announced that the last local train would arrive ten minutes late.

Upendra looked at his watch.

At that moment, his gaze went to the top of the stairs.

A man was coming down with a large blue cloth bag in one hand and a folded blanket in the other.

Upendra recognized the bag first, then the walk.

"Madhav?"

The man stopped.

"Upendra Babu?"

Madhav Mishra came down the stairs. For a few moments the two simply looked at each other's faces.

In the village they saw each other from time to time, usually at the market, the medicine shop, or someone's doorway. Meeting at the station this late at night was unusual.

"So late?" Upendra asked.

Madhav set the bag down. "I am catching the local."

"To town?"

"Yes."

Upendra looked at his watch again, as though searching for something more in the answer.

"Tonight?"

Madhav laughed. "The local runs tonight, doesn't it?"

Upendra laughed too, but only briefly.

The two went towards a bench with an iron back.

The bench was cold. Madhav sat with the strap of the bag between his feet.

Upendra sat at the other end.

For a while they both looked at the tracks ahead.

The tea seller called out, "Last tea!"
Madhav asked, "Will you have some?"
"Not today."
"Why?"

"There was too much at the office."

Madhav opened the mouth of his bag a little, then closed it again. "A feast?"

"A farewell."

Madhav looked at him.

"Today was my last day," Upendra said.

"Retirement?"

"Yes."

Madhav nodded slowly. "Then this is your last local."

For the first time, Upendra laughed openly. "You have understood correctly."

Madhav placed a hand on the strap of his blue bag.

"Mine is the first."

Upendra's laughter stopped.

"First what?"

"Going to night work."

"Where?"

"At a warehouse outside town. My nephew introduced me. Night watch."

Upendra said nothing.

Madhav kept looking ahead. The second hand of the station clock moved across its white face.

"The shop?" Upendra finally asked.

"Closed."

"Completely?"

"Not completely. My younger son will open it during the day if a customer comes."

"And your own work with your hands?"

Madhav turned over his right palm. Black grime clung to the tips of his fingers like an old stubbornness.

"There are fewer bicycles now. Battery vehicles have increased. My tools are not made for that kind of work."

"You could have learned."

"I might have learned. But while I was learning, who would have run the household?"

Upendra remained silent.

At the distant bend of the tracks, the signal turned green.

Madhav asked, "Everyone at home must be happy?"

"About what?"

"That you will be home every day now."

Upendra shifted the bag between his knees.

"We shall see."

"We shall see?"

"For thirty-one years I have returned at night on this local. By the time I reached home, everything was over. Dinner covered and kept aside. At first the children would already be asleep; later they would be studying; then they began going to their own rooms."

Madhav listened.

"Now I will be home at seven," Upendra said. "Then I will learn what happens at home at seven."

A small smile returned to Madhav's face.

"I used to think people with city jobs came home in the evening."

"Some do."

"You did not?"

"I did. Just late."

The two fell silent again.

On the track across from them, a freight train moved slowly. For a long time the metallic clank-clank of the couplings between the wagons could be heard.

Madhav opened his blue bag. Inside were a change of clothes, a gamchha, a strip of medicine, and a small brass-coloured torch.

"Midnight to eight," he said.

"First night?"

"Yes."

"Sleep?"

"We shall see."

"The first few days will be difficult."

Madhav closed the bag. "You have experience."

Upendra did not reply.

After a few moments he said, "I did not work at night. It was only that the work ended late."

"Is there a difference?"

Upendra thought. "There must have been."

Madhav rested his head against the back of the bench.

"Do you remember our school days?" he asked.

"Which part?"

"When both of us used to say we would go away."

"Everyone said that."

"You went."

"Only as far as this town."

"I did not."

"Your shop was doing well."

"Yes."

"At the time, I thought you had chosen well. Your own work, your own time."

Madhav looked at him. "I thought you had chosen well. A fixed amount every month."

Both laughed once.

The laughter did not last long.

The tea seller threw the water used to wash the kettle beside the tracks. A little steam rose and vanished at once.

Madhav asked, "Where is your elder son now?"

"In Pune."

"The younger one?"

"In Bengaluru."

"At home?"

"My wife and I."

"Then now you will have time together."

Upendra nodded.

"And yours?"

"The elder daughter is married. The younger son will look after the shop. Mother is at home."

"Will you come home every week?"

Madhav looked towards the tracks.

"For now they have said there will be leave after fifteen days."

Upendra's fingers grew still on the strap of his bag.

"Fifteen?"

"At first they are short of men."

"Where will you stay?"

"There are four cots behind the warehouse."

Upendra said nothing again.

The loudspeaker crackled. The arrival of the local was announced.

A whistle could be heard in the distance.

Madhav picked up his bag.

Upendra stood too.

"Dinner tonight?" Upendra asked.

"It has been packed from home."

"What time will you eat?"

"Whenever I get the chance."

Upendra looked at his own bag.

"I used to eat at eleven," he said.

"So late?"

"Not on the local. After reaching home."

Madhav's eyes rested on the mouth of Upendra's bag, where one flower petal from the garland wrapped in paper could be seen outside.

"Is that a garland?"

"Yes."

"Go home wearing it."

Upendra answered at once, "No."

Madhav smiled. "Why?"

"There has been enough of that today."

Madhav wanted to say something, but did not.

The headlight of the local appeared around the bend.

The wind arrived first. Then the vibration of iron travelled through the bench and into their feet.

Both stood behind the yellow line.

"Where will you get down?" Madhav asked.

Upendra named his station.

"I go beyond that."

"Yes. Go as far as Nagar East. Get down from the door on the right. At night the stairs to the footbridge are closed, so take the lower path."

Madhav listened carefully.

"And after that?"

"Turn left outside the station. You may get a shared vehicle at night. If not, it is half a kos on foot."

"You remember everything."

"Thirty-one years."

The local entered the platform. Tired faces and empty seats appeared and disappeared in the windows.

The train stopped.

Both boarded the same coach.

There were only six or seven people inside.

Upendra sat by the window. Madhav sat opposite.

The train moved.

The station lights slid backwards.

After a while Madhav said, "Do you feel sleepy on the local on the first night?"

Upendra kept looking into the darkness outside.

"Not for the first month."

"And after that?"

"After that, even in dreams you are afraid you will miss your station."

Madhav laughed.

Upendra did too.

The train crossed a small bridge. The water below could not be seen; only its sound could be heard.

"Now that fear of yours is over," Madhav said.

Upendra paused before replying.

"One fear."

"The other?"

"Waking in the morning and knowing there is nowhere I must go."

Madhav asked no question.

The local stopped at the next station. Two people got off. A young man boarded, put earphones in his ears, and stood near the door.

Madhav shifted his blue bag closer to his knees.

"My mother used to tell me not to take night work," he said.

Upendra only said, "Hmm."

"At that time the shop was doing well."

"Hmm."

"Today I did not tell her it was my first night. I told her I was going to deliver some goods."

Upendra looked at Madhav.

“Why?”

“So that she can sleep.”

Upendra looked outside again.

After a while he said, “My father came to the station to see me off on the first day of my job too.”

Madhav waited.

Upendra said nothing more.

The train kept moving.

The next three stations passed without conversation.

The first light of Upendra’s station appeared ahead.

He tucked the bag under his arm.

Madhav stood up too.

“You sit,” Upendra said. “Your station is still far.”

Madhav sat down again.

The train slowed.

Upendra went to the door.

From behind him Madhav said, “At this time tomorrow, where will you be?”

Upendra turned around.

He did not answer immediately after hearing the question.

“At home,” he said at last.

Madhav nodded.

The door opened.

Upendra got down.

The platform was almost empty.

He walked two steps, then turned back.

Beyond the window, Madhav sat with the blue bag between his feet.

Madhav did not wave. Upendra did not either.

The whistle blew.

The local slowly moved forward.

For a few moments their eyes remained fixed on each other.

Then the window slid away.

Upendra stood alone on the platform.

In his bag lay the folded farewell garland.

In Madhav’s bag, on the train, lay the brass-coloured torch for his first night.

The last local moved on into the darkness.

STORY 188

HALF A GLASS OF WATER

It was half past nine in the morning.

Rows of grey chairs filled the hospital waiting room. Outside the window, drops from the night's rain still clung to the neem leaves.

Jaynarayan Mishra sat holding two chairs at the corner of the third row.

His wife Kamla sat to his left.

In the empty space between them were a small cloth bag, a file of test reports, and a half-filled glass of water.

The glass belonged to the hospital drinking-water room.

Kamla had taken two sips. Then she had moved the glass a little away from the file so that if the water spilled, it would not wet the papers.

Jaynarayan shifted the glass slightly back towards the file.

The edge of the chair was level there.

Kamla moved it two fingers farther away again.

Neither of them said anything.

The red number 47 glowed on the wall.

Their slip had 52 written on it.

Jaynarayan looked at the number for the fourth time.

Kamla straightened the sari over her knees.

"Only five people now," Jaynarayan said.

"Hmm."

"It will be soon."

Kamla nodded.

Jaynarayan took his mobile phone from his pocket. He looked at the time on the screen, then put it back without calling anyone.

A few moments later, he took it out again.

"Did you tell them at home?" Kamla asked.

"Whom?"

"Manoj."

"I told him there is another test."

"And?"

"And what?"

Kamla tightened the sari a little around her ribs.

"Nothing."

Jaynarayan switched off the phone and put it back in his pocket.

The number on the wall changed to 48.

An elderly man came out from inside. Two young men were with him. All three walked quickly towards the door.

Kamla did not look at their faces.

She picked up the glass.

Jaynarayan stretched out his hand, as though he would hold it for her.

Kamla took only one sip and put the glass back.

The water was now a little less than half.

"Drink some more," Jaynarayan said.

"I am not thirsty."

"You have had nothing since morning."

"I had tea."

"Half a cup."

Kamla looked at him.

"Do you keep count?"

Jaynarayan did not answer.

The number 49 lit up on the wall.

The fan in the waiting room turned slowly. One blade had a black line of dust on it that rose and fell again and again as the fan revolved.

Kamla watched it for two turns.

Then she opened the mouth of the bag.

Inside were a gamchha, a small towel, a spectacle case, two bananas, and a pair of slippers.

Jaynarayan looked at the bag.

"Why the slippers?"

"They said sometimes it can take a long time."

"A long time does not mean overnight."

"Did I say overnight?"

Jaynarayan fell silent.

Kamla closed the bag.

After a while Jaynarayan asked, "Will you eat a banana?"

"No."

"Shall I eat one?"

"Eat it."

Jaynarayan opened the bag. He took out one banana.

He turned it in his hand, then put it back inside.

Kamla said nothing.

In a distant row, a child began to cry. His mother got up, took him in her arms, and went towards the veranda.

The child's crying could still be heard for a while even after they had gone outside.

Jaynarayan placed his palm on his knee.

There was a slight tremor between his fingers.

Kamla looked at that hand.

"Are you feeling cold?"

"No."

"Why is your hand trembling?"

Jaynarayan immediately covered that hand with the other.

"It happens like this."

Kamla went back to watching the fan.

The number on the wall changed to 50.

"What time is the bus?" Kamla asked.

"One twenty."

"After that?"

"Two fifty."

"There is also one at three fifteen."

"That one goes the long way round."

"It takes time."

"Yes."

For a while they kept talking about bus times.

Which bus went all the way inside the station, which dropped passengers at the square, and which was usually more crowded.

Neither said which bus they would take today.

A nurse came to the door and called, "Fifty-one."

A middle-aged woman stood up. The man sitting with her immediately picked up her file.

Kamla put a hand on her own file.

Jaynarayan's hand moved towards it too.

Their fingers reached the file at the same moment.

Jaynarayan drew his hand back.

"Leave it," Kamla said.

"It is not heavy."

"I know."

Kamla placed the file in her lap.

Jaynarayan looked at the glass.

"Water?"

"Let it be."

"What if it takes time inside?"

"There will be water there."

"They had said on an empty stomach—"

Kamla looked at him at once.

Jaynarayan stopped the sentence.

"What had they said?" Kamla asked.

"Nothing. I remembered wrongly."

Kamla opened the file.

The top sheet bore the date from the previous week. Beneath it were two lines written in black ink, which both of them had already read many times.

Kamla closed the page immediately.

"Do not read it," she said.

"I was not reading."

"You were looking."

"At the paper."

"The paper says the same thing."

Jaynarayan looked away from the file.

The number on the wall did not change.

The room suddenly seemed quieter.

Jaynarayan slipped off one slipper, then put it on again.

Kamla pushed the bangle on her left wrist upward.

Then downward.

Then upward again.

Jaynarayan looked at that hand.

"Does it hurt?"

"No."

"Then?"

"It has become loose."

"We will tie a thread around it at home."

"Hmm."

For a few moments she remained on the words "at home."

Jaynarayan said at once, "On the way back, we can get thread at Harsingar Chowk."

Kamla smiled faintly.

"Go to the market for such a small thing?"

"We are passing that way."

The smile ended quickly.

The number on the wall was still 51.

Jaynarayan stood up.

"Where?"

"Nowhere."

"Sit."

He sat down again.

The metal chair made a faint sound.

"Do not call Manoj again," Kamla said.

"I was not going to."

"He will be at work."

"Hmm."

"And do not call Rashmi either."

Jaynarayan did not answer.

Kamla looked at his face.

"Did you hear me?"

"Yes."

"Let us hear first."

Jaynarayan's eyes went to the file for a moment.

"Hear what?"

Kamla did not answer the question.

She picked up the glass.

This time she did not drink. She only ran a finger over the outside of the glass, where the chill of the water had now disappeared.

She put the glass back in the middle.

The water remained still.

The nurse came out.

A small slip was in her hand.

She looked at the number on the wall.

51 went dark.

52 lit up.

Jaynarayan and Kamla both sat straight at the same moment.

The nurse looked at the slip.
 “Kamla Mishra?”
 Kamla stood up.
 Jaynarayan did too.
 “Only one person inside,” the nurse said.
 Jaynarayan sat down again.
 Kamla tucked the file under her arm.
 She walked two steps.
 Then she turned back.
 “My spectacles?”
 Jaynarayan immediately opened the bag. He took out the spectacle case and gave it to her.
 Kamla stood holding it for a few moments.
 “You will stay here?”
 “Where else would I go?”
 Kamla nodded.
 Then she went inside.
 The door closed.
 The chair to Jaynarayan’s left was now empty.
 The bag was still under that chair.
 He lifted it and placed it between his feet.
 The glass remained on the middle chair.
 Jaynarayan looked at it.
 The water was a little less than half.
 He reached out and picked up the glass.
 He brought it to his lips.
 Then stopped.
 He put the glass back.
 Near the drinking-water room, someone opened a tap. The sound of running water could be heard for a few moments.
 Jaynarayan did not look at his watch.
 The mobile phone remained in his pocket.
 He only kept looking at the door.
 He could not tell how much time passed.
 Once, the sound of a metal tray falling came from inside.
 He stood up at once.
 No one came out.
 He sat down again.
 After a while, a cleaner entered the room carrying a broom.
 He moved along, picking small scraps of paper from beneath the empty chairs.
 Jaynarayan drew his feet in.
 The cleaner reached towards the glass.
 “Leave it,” Jaynarayan said.
 The cleaner stopped his hand.
 “Is it yours?”

“Yes.”

For the first time Jaynarayan moved the glass towards himself.

The cleaner went on.

The room became quiet again.

The door opened.

Kamla came out.

The file was not in her hand.

Jaynarayan stood up.

“The papers?”

Kamla gestured towards the door.

“They are in there.”

“What did they say?”

Kamla sat down.

“Now the doctor will see me.”

“Now?”

“Yes.”

Jaynarayan sat too.

He looked at her face.

Kamla straightened the sari over her knees again.

“Pain?”

“No.”

“Inside—”

“Nothing.”

Jaynarayan fell silent.

Kamla picked up the glass.

She brought it to her lips.

This time too she did not drink.

She held the glass out towards Jaynarayan.

Jaynarayan took it.

He took one sip and stopped.

Very little water remained in the glass.

Kamla said, “Drink it all.”

Jaynarayan looked at the glass.

“And you?”

“I do not want any.”

“You first.”

Kamla said nothing.

Jaynarayan put the glass back on the middle chair.

They began waiting again.

The number on the wall was now 54.

Their number had already disappeared from there.

Even so, both of them kept looking again and again at those red digits.

After a while Kamla asked, “Shall we buy salt on the way back?”

Jaynarayan looked at her.

“Is there none at home?”

“A little.”

"We will buy it."

"And oil?"

"Oil too."

"Manoj had said it is cheaper near the petrol pump."

"That does not fall on our way."

"Then leave it."

"We can go around."

Kamla smiled faintly.

"We will miss the bus."

Jaynarayan smiled too.

"We will take the two-fifty one."

For a few moments both were silent.

Then Kamla said softly, "If it does not get late."

Jaynarayan's smile became still.

He picked up the glass.

He looked at the water remaining in it.

Then he put the glass back again.

The door to the doctor's room opened.

An assistant came out and asked the name.

Kamla stood up.

Jaynarayan did too.

This time the assistant called both of them inside.

Jaynarayan picked up the bag.

Kamla took one step forward, then looked towards the middle chair.

"The water?"

Jaynarayan bent to pick up the glass.

Then straightened again.

"We will drink it when we come back."

Kamla said nothing.

Both walked towards the door.

The glass remained on the chair.

A little water was left at the bottom.

The surface of the water trembled faintly in the breeze from the fan.

THE VERANDAH BULB

The evening sunlight had already slipped down from the veranda wall.

A little water had collected near the tulsi altar in the courtyard. The afternoon rain had not lasted long, but even now, from time to time, a single drop fell from the edge of the roof.

Ramprasad Jha sat in his old bamboo chair.

In front of him, a bulb hung in the middle of the veranda.

The light was on.

It flickered once.

Then steadied.

Ramprasad looked up.

Two minutes later the bulb flickered again.

This time three times.

Then it went out.

The veranda did not become dark all at once. Light was coming from the window of the house on the west. From the kitchen doorway on the east as well.

Only the bulb in the middle had gone out.

Ramprasad kept looking at it for a few moments.

Then he said, "Change the bulb."

Whom he was speaking to was not clear.

Surendra appeared at the western doorway.

Naresh too appeared at the eastern doorway.

Both looked at their father.

Not at each other.

Ramprasad looked up again.

"It has gone out."

Surendra turned back inside.

So did Naresh.

Ramprasad kept running his palm along the arm of the chair.

The two doorways opened again at almost the same moment.

Surendra held a small cardboard box.

Naresh too had a bulb in his hand, without a box.

Surendra placed his bulb on the wooden stool.

Naresh kept his bulb in his hand.

Ramprasad looked at both bulbs.

"Only one is needed," he said.

Neither replied.

There was a wooden stool in the left corner of the veranda.

The stool used to stand in the middle.

After the house was divided, Surendra had moved it towards his own wall.

Ramprasad pointed towards the stool.

"Climb on this."
 Surendra bent to lift it.
 Naresh too stepped forward.
 Their hands fell on two different ends of the stool.
 Both immediately withdrew their hands.
 Ramprasad sat in his chair and watched.
 Surendra brought the stool to the middle by himself.
 Naresh moved a little away.
 "Is the switch off?" Surendra asked.
 The question was directed at their father.
 Ramprasad looked towards the eastern wall.
 The switch for the veranda bulb was beside Naresh's doorway.
 That switch had been there long before the house was divided.
 Without saying anything, Naresh switched it off.
 "Off," he said.
 Surendra climbed onto the stool.
 As he touched the old bulb, he pulled his hand back.
 "It is hot."
 Ramprasad said, "Let it cool a little."
 All three remained silent.
 A drop fell into the water in the courtyard.
 A circle formed.
 Then vanished.
 From the western house came the sound of a plate being set down.
 In the eastern house a child was reciting a lesson—the sound of counting
 reached as far as the veranda.
 Ramprasad looked towards the box in Surendra's hand.
 "How many watts?"
 "Nine."
 Then towards the bulb in Naresh's hand.
 "Yours?"
 "Twelve."
 Ramprasad nodded.
 "Nine is more than enough."
 Naresh slowly placed his bulb on the threshold of his doorway.
 Surendra opened the box.
 He took the bulb out.
 There were now two bulbs in the veranda.
 One on the stool.
 One on the threshold.
 The old bulb hung above.
 Ramprasad narrowed his eyes.
 "It must have cooled now."
 Surendra climbed onto the stool again.
 This time he grasped the bulb.
 He turned it slowly.

The bulb came out.

He looked inside the empty holder.

"It has blackened."

Naresh looked up.

"The holder?"

Surendra did not reply.

Ramprasad said, "He is asking whether the holder has blackened."

"A little."

Naresh left the threshold and came a little forward.

"What if the wire is loose?"

Surendra was fitting the new bulb into the holder.

"Let us see this first."

Ramprasad looked towards Naresh.

Naresh stopped where he was again.

The bulb was tightened into place.

Surendra climbed down from the stool.

"Switch it on."

Ramprasad did not feel it necessary to tell Naresh that.

Naresh pushed the switch up.

Nothing happened.

The veranda was still half dark.

Surendra looked up.

Naresh pushed the switch down and up again.

The bulb did not light.

Ramprasad sat a little straighter in his chair.

"There is electricity, isn't there?"

Surendra looked towards his own house. The light in the western window was on.

Naresh looked towards the eastern doorway. There was light there too.

"There is," both said almost at the same time.

Both fell silent for a moment.

Surendra climbed onto the stool again.

He placed a finger beneath the holder, but did not put his hand inside.

"Switch it off."

Naresh switched it off.

Surendra unscrewed the bulb and tightened it again.

"Now."

Naresh switched it on.

Nothing.

Surendra removed the bulb and held it in his hand.

He examined the glass and the metal at the base.

Then he put it back in its box.

Naresh picked up the twelve-watt bulb from the threshold.

He extended it slightly forward.

Surendra looked at him.

Naresh stopped his hand midway.

Ramprasad said, "Try the other one."
 Surendra did not take the bulb from Naresh's hand.
 He held out his palm.
 Naresh placed the bulb on that palm.
 Their fingers did not touch.
 Surendra climbed up again.
 He tightened the twelve-watt bulb into place.
 Naresh switched it on.
 Nothing happened.
 "The fault is not in the bulb," Naresh said.
 Still standing on the stool, Surendra said, "So it seems."
 After four days, this was the first sentence either of them had spoken directly to the other.
 Ramprasad lowered his head and ran a finger along the arm of the chair.
 Surendra climbed down.
 "We will have to check the wire."
 Naresh went inside and brought a screwdriver to open the switch plate.
 Surendra shifted slightly the slippers he had left beneath the stool.
 Naresh bent his knees and sat near the switch.
 "Is it off?" Surendra asked.
 "I will cut the main switch."
 Naresh went inside.
 The light in the eastern kitchen went out.
 A few moments later he returned.
 He opened the switch plate with the screwdriver.
 There were two old wires inside.
 One was wrapped with cloth tape.
 "One of these is loose," Naresh said.
 Surendra bent to look.
 "Not here. It must be above."
 "How?"
 "This wire has tension."
 Naresh pulled the wire gently.
 It did not move.
 Surendra looked towards the ceiling of the veranda.
 The wire ran westward along an old bamboo strip.
 In the middle was a patch of newer plaster.
 The wire disappeared beneath that plaster.
 Ramprasad looked up too.
 "When was this plaster done?"
 No one answered.
 Surendra moved the stool towards that spot.
 This time, without being asked, Naresh caught the other end.
 Together they shifted the stool.
 The wood made a small scraping sound on the floor.
 Surendra climbed up.

He tapped the edge of the plaster with a finger.

At one spot it sounded hollow.

"There used to be a joint here."

Naresh said from below, "Earlier?"

"Yes."

"Whose wire?"

Surendra climbed down.

Ramprasad answered, "The house's."

Naresh looked at his father.

Ramprasad said again, "At that time there was only one house."

For a while, the only sound in the veranda was the dripping from the roof.

Surendra asked for the screwdriver.

Naresh handed it to him.

Surendra scraped a little at the edge of the plaster.

White powder fell onto the stool.

Inside, the old wire joint became visible.

One end of the joint had blackened.

Beside it was the edge of a newer brick.

Four years earlier, when the middle room was divided, a half wall had been raised here.

The wall was below.

The wire above.

The wire had not been divided.

Only its joint had been covered with plaster.

Surendra climbed down.

"It needs a new joint."

Naresh said, "The wire will fall short."

"We will add a small piece."

"Who has some?"

Both fell silent.

Ramprasad pointed towards the small cupboard at the back.

"Look in the upper compartment."

Surendra opened the cupboard.

In the compartment were old nails, a lock, two candles, some jute string, and a small coil of wire.

He took the wire out.

Naresh looked at its end.

"This is very thin."

Surendra said, "It will do for a bulb."

"The joint will have to be covered."

"Do you have tape?"

Naresh looked towards the old cloth tape wrapped inside his switch.

"Not this."

He went inside the house.

A few moments later he returned with black electrical tape.

Surendra cleaned the end of the wire.

Naresh held the bulb wire.
 Their heads were bent at almost the same height.
 Ramprasad moved his chair slightly back so that he could see better.
 "Tighten it," Naresh said.
 Surendra twisted the wire.
 "This much?"
 "A little more."
 Surendra twisted it again.
 Naresh handed him the tape.
 Surendra covered the joint.
 No one spoke of the old wall.
 No one spoke of the land papers.
 No one said that four years earlier, when the half wall was being raised,
 both of them had stood right there.
 Ramprasad did not either.
 The joint was ready.
 Surendra climbed onto the stool and pushed the wire back up.
 The broken edge of the plaster remained open for now.
 "Do not close it yet," Naresh said.
 "Let us test it first."
 Surendra climbed down.
 Naresh went inside to turn the main switch back on.
 The light in the eastern kitchen came on again.
 He returned to the veranda switch.
 He placed his hand on it.
 Surendra looked at the bulb.
 So did Ramprasad.
 Naresh pressed the switch.
 The twelve-watt bulb lit up.
 The veranda turned bright.
 In the light, the old chalk line across the middle of the floor became
 visible.
 The line was now very faint.
 In some places footsteps had rubbed it away.
 In some places it was still white.
 Ramprasad did not look at it.
 He looked at the bulb.
 "It is too bright."
 Naresh said, "It is twelve watts."
 Surendra picked up his box.
 "The nine-watt one is fine. The fault was in the wire."
 Naresh looked at the bulb.
 "Shall we change it?"
 Surendra paused for a moment.
 "Let it stay."
 Ramprasad said, "Wasn't nine more than enough?"

Suppressing a faint smile, Naresh said, "Let twelve stay now."

A faint line appeared on Surendra's face too, then vanished at once.

He lifted the stool.

Naresh again moved to take the other end.

This time Surendra did not withdraw his hand.

Together they carried the stool towards the middle.

When they reached there, they stopped.

On whose side should the stool be placed?

Ramprasad said, "Leave it here."

The two left the stool in the middle of the veranda.

Surendra took his box and walked towards the western doorway.

Naresh picked up the screwdriver and tape and turned east.

At the doorway, Naresh looked back.

The open patch of plaster was still visible.

"I will put mortar on it tomorrow," he said.

Surendra stopped at his own doorway.

"I have some cement."

Naresh nodded.

That was all.

Both went into their own houses.

Ramprasad remained sitting alone in the veranda.

The twelve-watt light fell on his chair, the stool in the middle, the faded chalk line, and the new joint above.

After a while the western doorway closed from inside.

Then the eastern one.

The bulb remained lit.

Ramprasad stood up.

He moved the chair against the wall.

The switch was on the eastern wall.

He walked over to it.

He placed his hand on the switch.

He paused for a moment.

Then he turned off the light.

The veranda went dark.

A little light came from the western window.

And from beneath the eastern doorway as well.

The stool in the middle still remained in the middle, in the darkness.

STORY 190

TWO KATHAS OF SAND

At dawn, the water of the Kamla had receded a little.

Where the current had run until night, sticky mud and fresh sand now glistened.

Shivnath Mandal came down from the embankment and walked towards the field.

His younger son Bipin followed behind him.

Neither said anything.

The northern edge of the field had once extended as far as the mango tree.

Now the mango tree stood directly before the current.

Half its roots were exposed.

Bipin looked towards the tree.

"It cut away more in the night."

Shivnath bent towards the ground.

He took some sand in his hand.

He pressed it and tested it.

The sand was dry on top.

There was a little moisture underneath.

"Did you bring the spade?"

"Yes."

"Put it over there."

Bipin put down the spade.

Paddy was to be transplanted in that field this season.

The seedbed was on the higher ground to the east.

The seedlings were green.

Transplanting had been fixed for three days later.

Bipin looked again towards the mango tree.

"How much do you think is gone?"

Shivnath did not answer.

He walked two steps east.

Then he looked for the old bamboo stake.

The stake was half buried in the sand.

He pulled it out.

The soil beneath the stake was black.

"The drain will run from here," he said.

Bipin remained silent for a while.

"A drain?"

"The water is going down. We will hold it in the eastern part."

"Will we transplant?"

Shivnath tucked the stake under his arm.

"Why did we raise the seedbed?"

Bipin said nothing.

Two people were approaching from a distance.
One was Ramsevak Kaka.
The other was his son-in-law.
From far away Ramsevak asked, "Shivnath, did it cut away much?"
Shivnath raised his head.
"The water is going down."
Ramsevak came near and stood there.
"Three kathas on my western side are gone. Yours?"
Shivnath picked up the spade and handed it to Bipin.
"Cut one hand deep from this spot."
Ramsevak moved his foot over the sand.
"Looks like two kathas right here."
Bipin began to work the spade.
As soon as the top sand was removed, wet soil showed beneath it.
Ramsevak said, "You will have to give the measurement in the register."
Shivnath said, "First the water has to be held back."
Ramsevak looked at him.
Then towards the current.
"All right. I am going."
He walked on.
Bipin said softly, "Kaka is right. We will have to give the measurement."
"We will."
"Today?"
"The drain today. Measurement tomorrow."
Bipin began to work the spade again.
Ten hands farther on, there was less sand.
The old paddy stubble was still visible there.
Shivnath sat down beside that stubble.
He rubbed some soil in his palm.
The soil was smooth and clayey.
"Transplant this part first," he said.
"How much?"
"As much as there is soil."
"Three kathas?"
"We will measure it."
Bipin turned his face towards the river.
The current was not far away now.
The water was muddy.
Small clods of earth were falling from the edge.
One clod fell.
The water carried it away.
Neither of them said anything.
Shivnath stood up.
"Is the rope at home?"
"The old measuring rope?"
"Yes."

"It is."

"Bring it after the meal."

Both returned home.

In the courtyard, Saraswati Devi was sitting near the hearth.

The moment she saw them, she asked, "Is the soil left?"

Shivnath took water in a lota.

He washed his hands.

"Is the seedbed all right?"

Saraswati Devi paused a little.

"It is all right."

"See that the heifer does not go there."

"It will not."

Bipin sat down on the veranda.

Saraswati Devi placed flattened rice and curd before him.

"The field?"

Bipin opened his mouth.

Shivnath spoke first. "We will hold water in the eastern part."

Saraswati Devi looked towards Shivnath.

"Have the transplanting workers been called?"

"For the day after tomorrow."

"Will the day change?"

"Not yet."

Saraswati Devi asked nothing more.

She turned towards the kitchen.

Bipin kept mixing the flattened rice.

After a while he said, "Ma was asking how much is gone."

Shivnath emptied his bowl of curd.

"She will hear."

"From whom?"

"Does news stop in a village?"

Bipin did not laugh.

After the meal he took the old measuring rope out of the room.

There were knots along the rope at measured intervals.

Some of the knots had turned black.

The rope was from Grandfather's time.

Bipin held one end.

Shivnath the other.

The two went back to the field.

The afternoon sun had risen high.

The sand was beginning to grow hot.

Shivnath stretched the measuring rope from the old eastern marker.

First knot.

Second.

Third.

Bipin kept counting.

"The old field came up to here."

The rest of the rope hung out in the air.
There was no earth in that direction now.
The current ran below.
Bipin pulled the rope taut and stopped.
“Farther?”

Shivnath said, “Let go.”
The end of the rope fell onto the sand.
Bipin counted again.
“Two kathas less.”
Shivnath walked east.
“We can transplant these three kathas.”
“Not three. About two kathas and ten dhurs.”
“Measure it.”

They measured again.
Bipin’s measurement was right.
Shivnath said, “There are too many seedlings.”
“Shall we sell them?”
“No.”
“Then?”

“Ramsevak’s lower field is empty. He will be short of seedlings.”
“Shall we give them to him?”
“If he lends a hand tomorrow in holding back the water.”
For the first time Bipin smiled a little.
“Kaka will go to enter his measurement in the register.”
“He will be back by evening.”

That afternoon the two cut the drain.
The drain was not large.

Only enough for the receding water to remain for a while in the lower eastern part.

As they removed the sand, the spade touched black soil again and again.
Wherever black soil appeared, Shivnath would say, “Leave it here.”
Where there was only sand, he would say, “Farther.”

Bipin stopped the spade for a while and looked at the line forming behind his father’s feet.

Then he worked the spade again.
Before evening Ramsevak returned.
He had a folded sheet of paper in his hand.
“I entered the measurement,” he said.
Shivnath stopped the spade.

“How much?”
“Three kathas two dhurs.”
“Hmm.”

Ramsevak looked at the drain Bipin had cut.
“Will this water stay?”
“If the river does not cut away more tonight.”
Ramsevak looked at the field for a while.

"My men are free tomorrow. Shall I send two?"

Shivnath said, "Do you need seedlings?"

"I am a little short."

"Take whatever is left over."

Ramsevak nodded.

"Then I will send two men tomorrow."

He went away.

Bipin said, "Had you thought of it beforehand?"

"Of what?"

"Giving him seedlings."

"I understood as soon as I saw the seedbed."

"Before the field was cut away?"

Shivnath levelled the sand with the spade.

"The seedbed does not ask the field. The seedlings become ready."

Clouds gathered again at night.

It did not rain much.

Bipin got up twice to look outside.

Shivnath did not get up.

At dawn, when they went to the field, there was a little water in the drain.

The eastern part was wet.

The current had cut away a little more during the night, but the mango tree was still standing.

One more root had been laid bare.

Bipin looked at it.

Shivnath did not stop.

He banked up earth at the mouth of the drain.

"Today we will pull up the seedlings," he said.

"Transplant the day after tomorrow?"

"If the water remains."

"And if it does not?"

"One day later."

"And if the current comes again?"

Shivnath looked at Bipin.

For a few moments.

Then he said, "Then we will see again."

The two returned home and went towards the seedbed.

Saraswati Devi was examining the water among the seedlings.

She said, "There are too many seedlings."

Bipin said, "Ramsevak Kaka will take some."

Saraswati Devi looked towards Shivnath.

"All right."

She touched one corner of the seedlings with her hand.

"These are small. Leave them."

Shivnath said, "Yes."

All day people kept coming to see the erosion at the field.

Someone asked, "How much is gone?"

Someone said, "The river is fierce this time."

Someone spoke of the previous year.

Shivnath kept giving short answers.

"Two kathas of sand."

"The eastern part remains."

"Transplanting the day after tomorrow."

The same three sentences again and again.

In the evening Bipin washed the measuring rope.

Sand had worked into the knots.

He swirled the rope in the pond water and washed it out.

Then he spread the rope over the bamboo of the veranda to dry.

The last two knots hung into empty air.

Bipin picked up a sickle to cut them off.

Shivnath was sitting on the veranda.

He saw him.

"Shall I cut them?"

Shivnath looked at the rope.

"Why?"

"There is not that much field now."

Shivnath remained silent for a while.

"Shortening the rope will not make the field larger."

Bipin put the sickle down.

The two knots remained hanging in the air.

The next day people from both families pulled up seedlings from the seedbed.

Ramsevak's men came too.

The seedlings were tied into bundles.

One heap for Ramsevak's field.

One heap for Shivnath's eastern part.

The two kathas covered in sand remained empty.

Only one end of the drain held some moisture there.

On the morning of transplanting, men and women stepped into the field.

There was not enough water to reach their ankles.

At times their feet sank into the mud.

At times, near the sand, the soil became hard.

Shivnath stood on the field ridge opening the seedling bundles.

Bipin kept the rows straight.

Once he looked towards the west.

Where the two kathas had been, sunlight glinted on the sand.

He looked towards his father.

Shivnath looked there too.

He said nothing.

He opened the next bundle.

"Shift this row a little east," he said.

Bipin shifted the row.

By afternoon half the transplanting was done.

By evening the remaining field was filled with green rows.
While returning home, Bipin turned to look back.
The green part was small.
The sand looked white.
Beyond it, the current.
Shivnath walked ahead.
Bipin asked, "What tomorrow?"
"We will look at the drain."
"And the day after?"
"The field ridge."
"The sand?"
Shivnath paused a little.
"For now, sand."
The two began walking again.
On reaching home, Shivnath saw the measuring rope on the veranda.
The rope had dried.
He wound it up.
He kept the last two knots inside as well.

STORY 191

THE SILENT RADIO

It was the last week of Jeth.

The wind had settled in the afternoon.

Heat had settled even beneath the shade of the veranda roof.

Raghunath Babu sat on a bamboo stool.

An old screwdriver was in his hand.

The radio lay on the wooden platform in front of him.

The colour of its wooden casing had faded years ago.

There were scratches along the corners of the black cover.

Dust filled the grille at the front.

The round knob on the right was half worn smooth.

A thin cloth lay over it.

Malti had removed the cloth.

The radio had been lying on the loft for three years.

That day Sonu had climbed onto the loft looking for an old kite.

His hand fell upon the radio.

He called down, "Baba, does this work?"

Raghunath Babu did not look up.

"We shall see."

Sonu brought the radio down.

Malti came out of the kitchen.

For a few moments she kept looking at the radio.

Then she said, "There is a lot of dust."

Raghunath Babu asked for a cloth.

Malti gave him a piece of an old gamchha.

He began wiping the grille.

Lines of dust kept falling onto the platform.

Sonu sat down beside him.

"Will it run on batteries?"

"First let us see what is inside."

"Shall we open it?"

"I will open it."

Sonu drew his hand back.

Raghunath Babu turned the radio around.

There were four screws.

Three were of the same colour.

One was slightly bent.

He placed the screwdriver on the bent screw.

The screwdriver slipped.

He placed it again.

The screw slowly loosened.

Sonu asked, "This one is not like the others?"

"It is old."

"Shall we replace it?"

Raghunath Babu did not answer.

He began loosening the second screw.

Malti stood beside a pillar of the veranda.

The end of her sari was damp in her hand.

Raghunath Babu lifted the back cover.

Inside was a thin layer of dust.

A dry spiderweb in one corner.

Green corrosion on the battery metal.

Red and black wires.

A small board in the middle.

Sonu leaned a little closer.

"Where does the sound live in this?"

Raghunath Babu placed a finger on the round speaker cone.

"It comes out from here."

"Where is it made inside?"

"It passes through many places before it reaches here."

Whether Sonu understood or not, he did not say.

Raghunath Babu took the old batteries out of the battery compartment.

Two of the batteries had swollen.

One was rusted.

Malti said, "Throw them away."

Raghunath Babu set the batteries aside.

"First I will clean them."

"Why keep all these?"

"It shows how much dirt came from where."

Malti fell silent.

Raghunath Babu put two drops of kerosene from a small bowl onto the cloth.

He rubbed the metal terminals.

The green corrosion began to come off.

Sonu wrinkled his nose.

"Smell."

"Sit a little farther away."

He did not go far.

He merely shifted to the other end of the platform.

Raghunath Babu turned the knob.

A thin cord moved inside.

It stopped after half a turn.

He turned it again.

The cord had gone slack.

"Is this broken?" Sonu asked.

"Not completely."

"Then?"

"It slips."

Malti said, "Nasim Kaka in the market can look at it."
Raghunath Babu let go of the knob.
"We shall see."
He did not put the back cover on again.
The radio remained open.
It lay there until evening.
Clouds were rising from the west.
Thunder could be heard in the distance.
The electricity went out twice during the night.
The mobile network too was there at times and gone at others.
From the courtyard Malti said, "Did you find any news about the clouds?"
Raghunath Babu looked at his mobile phone.
There was one old message.
Nothing new.
"We will look at the radio tomorrow," he said.
Malti did not reply.
At dawn Raghunath Babu wrapped the radio in a cloth.
Sonu was getting ready for school.
"Where are you taking it?"
"To the market."
"Shall I come?"
"Go to school."
"Will we open it when I come back?"
"If it is still open."
Sonu laughed as he put on his shoes.
Raghunath Babu placed the radio in a bag.
The bag was old.
There was a patch at the bottom.
Malti came to the doorway.
"Will Nasim Kaka have opened his shop?"
"By eight."
"It is not even seven yet."
"It will take time on the way."
He set out.
The market was a kos and a half away.
Dust rose along the side of the paved road.
The clouds still stood overhead.
Half the shutter of Nasim's shop was raised.
Inside, fans, wires, bulbs, and small devices lay on the table.
Nasim Miyan was cleaning his spectacles.
Raghunath Babu placed the bag on the bench.
"Look at this."
Nasim Miyan removed the cloth.
For a moment he stared steadily at the radio.
His hand stopped halfway.
"This is..."

Raghunath Babu looked towards the bent screw.
 "Do you have a screw of this size?"
 Nasim Miyan left the sentence unfinished.
 He opened a drawer in the table.
 He took out two or three screws.
 "Yes."
 Raghunath Babu picked up a straight screw.
 He compared it with the old bent one.
 The new screw shone.
 The head of the old one was worn.
 "Look at the cord too," he said.
 Nasim Miyan opened the radio.
 He turned the knob.
 "The cord has stretched."
 "Can it be changed?"
 "I can change it."
 "And the speaker cone?"
 Nasim Miyan pressed it lightly.
 "It is not torn."
 He examined the wire joints.
 At one place the copper wire was slightly thicker.
 An old soldered knot.
 Nasim Miyan again looked as though he was about to say something.
 Raghunath Babu asked, "How much time?"
 "Half an hour."
 "I will sit here."
 There was a long wooden bench outside the shop.
 Raghunath Babu sat on it.
 A milk van passed along the road.
 A bus stopped.
 Four people got off.
 Two got on.
 Inside, Nasim Miyan kept removing the old cord.
 Now and then came a small metallic sound.
 Now and then the sound of the screwdriver being placed on the table.
 Raghunath Babu kept looking towards the road.
 The tea seller opposite the shop asked, "Tea?"
 "No."
 After a while he asked again.
 "Half a cup?"
 "No."
 The shadow of the clouds moved across the road.
 Nasim Miyan brought the radio forward.
 "I have changed the cord."
 He put in batteries.
 He turned the switch.

First, static.
Then a faint indistinct voice.
He turned the knob.
The sound became clear.
Some advertisement was playing.
Nasim Miyan smiled.
“The speaker cone is still good.”
Raghunath Babu looked towards the radio.
The sound filled the shop.
Nasim Miyan changed the station.
An old song began.
Raghunath Babu reached out and turned the knob.
The song disappeared halfway through.
Static.
Then the news.
“Leave it here,” he said.
Nasim Miyan looked at him.
“All right.”
He picked up the new screw.
The old bent screw lay to one side.
“Shall I replace this too?”
Raghunath Babu looked at both screws.
“No.”
“The head is worn.”
“It works.”
Nasim Miyan fitted the old screw back in.
Raghunath Babu paid him.
Nasim Miyan tried to reduce the amount.
Raghunath Babu paid the full amount.
The radio went back into the bag.
When he reached home, Sonu had not yet returned from school.
Malti was spreading clothes in the courtyard.
Raghunath Babu placed the bag on the platform.
Malti asked, “Fixed?”
“It works.”
“How much did it cost?”
He told her the amount.
Malti nodded.
That was all.
Raghunath Babu had brought new batteries.
He put them in.
He placed the radio at one corner of the platform.
He turned the switch.
The sound did not come immediately.
After two moments, static.
Then the announcer’s voice.

It was a report on river levels.

Kamla.

Bagmati.

Kosi.

The names of the rivers came one after another.

Malti stopped spreading the clothes and began to listen.

Raghunath Babu lowered the volume a little.

"What did they say?" Malti asked.

"Normal for now."

"Clouds?"

"More towards the north."

Malti began spreading the clothes again.

The radio kept playing.

At noon Sonu came running in.

He dropped his schoolbag in the veranda and went straight to the radio.

"It works!"

"Do not touch it. Change your clothes first."

Sonu ran inside.

After a little while he came back.

A farming programme was on the radio.

They were talking about paddy seed.

Sonu wrinkled his nose.

"Put on a song."

Raghunath Babu said, "Listen to this for now."

"I do not have to plant paddy."

"You have to eat it."

Sonu laughed.

He reached towards the knob.

Raghunath Babu stopped his hand.

Not forcefully.

Only with two fingers.

"Turn the knob gently."

"Why?"

"The cord is new."

"New things are stronger."

"Not everything new becomes strong at once."

Sonu drew his hand back.

The farming programme ended.

Then a song was announced.

Raghunath Babu did not switch off the radio.

The song began.

Sonu sat on the platform with his legs folded.

Malti went into the kitchen.

Halfway through the song she came out again.

There was flour on her hands.

She looked not at the radio but at Raghunath Babu.

Raghunath Babu was writing down the size of the old batteries on a piece of paper.

Malti went inside again.

The song ended.

Sonu asked, "Baba, who bought this radio?"

Raghunath Babu's pencil stopped.

"It has been in the house from before."

"You?"

"It is many years old."

"Did my father listen to it?"

There was no sound of a fan in the veranda.

The electricity had gone out again.

A crow called in the distance.

Raghunath Babu placed the tip of the pencil on the paper.

"Everyone in the house listened to it."

Sonu remained silent for a while.

"Did he repair the knob?"

Raghunath Babu looked towards the back of the radio.

"Sometimes."

"Nasim Kaka?"

"Everyone fixes one thing or another in their own turn."

Whether Sonu was satisfied with that answer was not clear.

He got up and went to drink water.

Raghunath Babu finished writing the battery measurements on the paper.

Then the static on the radio increased.

He straightened the antenna.

The sound became clear.

The first raindrop fell in the evening.

Three or four drops on the tin roof.

Then it stopped.

Malti gathered the clothes from the courtyard.

The radio was not taken inside.

It remained in the veranda.

Dinner was eaten in the veranda that night.

Sonu in the middle.

Malti on one side.

Raghunath Babu on the other.

The radio on the platform.

The volume a little low.

The news had ended.

Now there was a folk-song programme.

Sonu was mixing curd into his rice.

Suddenly he asked, "Baba, why did you not change the bent screw?"

Malti's hand stopped.

Raghunath Babu kept breaking off a morsel of rice.

"It works."

“The new screw was better.”
 “It shone.”
 “Then why not that one?”
 Raghunath Babu put the morsel into his mouth.
 He drank water.
 On the radio, a madal sounded in the middle of the song.
 He said, “You do not replace something that works merely because something else shines.”
 Sonu nodded.
 He began eating again.
 Malti said nothing.
 The night deepened.
 Sonu went to sleep.
 Malti washed the utensils.
 Raghunath Babu rose to switch off the radio.
 His hand went to the switch.
 At that very moment, the next weather bulletin began.
 He stopped his hand.
 The Kamla’s water level was announced again.
 At one place the Bagmati had risen.
 The Kosi was steady.
 Raghunath Babu listened to the entire bulletin.
 Then he switched it off.
 The veranda suddenly became quiet.
 Crickets were sounding outside.
 He picked up the radio.
 He did not climb up to put it back on the loft.
 There was a wooden shelf beneath the platform.
 He placed it there.
 Malti watched from inside.
 “You will not put it back up?”
 “Let it stay here.”
 “It will gather dust.”
 “Give me a cloth.”
 Malti brought the same old cloth.
 She spread it over the radio.
 The cloth covered the black casing.
 One corner at the back remained uncovered.
 The head of the bent screw remained visible.
 Raghunath Babu could have reached out and pulled the cloth over it completely.
 He did not.
 There were clouds again at dawn.
 Before going to school, Sonu uncovered the radio.
 Raghunath Babu was sweeping the courtyard.
 “Baba, shall I put on the news?”

“Put it on.”

“Turn the knob gently?”

“Gently.”

Sonu turned the switch.

After the static, the sound became clear.

He began searching for a station.

When he found a song at one place, he stopped and looked towards Raghunath Babu.

“Not this?”

Raghunath Babu listened for a few moments and said, “Let it play.”

Sonu let go of the knob.

The song spread through the veranda.

Raghunath Babu went on sweeping.

He did not say the name.

The radio kept playing.

STORY 192

THE SHOES LEFT ON THE ROOF

It was an evening in Bhadon.

Rain had been falling since the afternoon.

As the sun went down, the clouds thinned.

Small pools of water still stood on the roof.

Abhay climbed the stairs and came up.

He held a pair of shoes in his hand.

The shoes were wet.

Mud from below clung to the soles.

He placed two bricks near the southern wall.

He set both shoes upside down on the bricks.

A little water dripped out from inside.

Abhay kept watching.

Saraswati Devi's voice came from below.

"Have you checked the bag?"

Abhay said, "I have."

"The papers?"

"They are in the bag."

"The ticket?"

"Yes."

Saraswati Devi said nothing more.

Abhay picked up one shoe and pressed the sole with his thumb.

The front was beginning to come apart a little.

He put the shoe back on the brick.

He had to catch the bus at five in the morning.

The bus would go as far as Darbhanga.

From there, the train.

Three days later he had to report for work at a textile factory in Surat.

Everyone in the house knew this.

All day, no one had said it in a complete sentence.

A breeze began to move across the roof.

Abhay removed the shoelaces and spread them separately.

He stuffed pieces of old paper inside the shoes.

The paper became wet at once.

He took it out.

Neha appeared at the top of the stairs.

A small cotton gamchha was in her hand.

"Ma gave this."

Abhay took the gamchha.

"What will you do?" Neha asked.

"Wipe them."

"Will they dry by morning?"

Pressing the gamchha inside the shoe, Abhay said, "They will dry."

Neha stood there for a while.

"Does it rain there?"

"It must."

"This much?"

Abhay looked at the sky.

"Rain falls everywhere."

Neha did not laugh.

She went down the stairs.

Abhay pulled the gamchha out.

He placed the shoes upside down again.

Down on the veranda, Jagdish Babu was examining the strap of the old bag.

The strap had already been stitched three times.

At one place the thread had come loose again.

Jagdish Babu threaded a needle with thick thread.

Saraswati Devi was filling a small tin with sattu.

"Why so much?" Jagdish Babu asked.

"He can eat it on the way."

"There will be food on the train."

"There will."

Saraswati Devi closed the tin.

Then she tied some salt into a small piece of paper.

Jagdish Babu kept pulling the needle through the strap.

"There will be sattu there too," he said.

"There will."

Both fell silent.

On the roof, Abhay turned the toes of the shoes towards the breeze.

The western part of the sky was growing brighter.

The evening light lay like a thin line across the wet roof.

Abhay rested a hand on the railing.

The courtyard could be seen below.

Ma was putting the tin into the bag.

Babu was cutting the thread and tightening the knot with his teeth.

Neha had quietly opened her notebook and sat down.

Abhay looked at the shoes again.

This was the only pair of shoes he had to wear.

They had been bought at the market two years earlier.

At first he had worn them to college.

Later he had gone towards the fields in them as well.

That was why the sole was coming apart at the front.

He pressed the opened part with a finger.

The joint lifted again.

Abhay left the shoes and went downstairs.

Jagdish Babu had finished stitching the bag strap.

Abhay said, "Where is the screwdriver?"

“Why?”

“Nothing.”

“In the box on the veranda.”

Abhay opened the box.

He found the screwdriver.

There was also a small hammer.

He picked up the hammer.

Jagdish Babu looked at him.

“What is broken?”

“The shoe.”

“Show me.”

Abhay stood still for a few moments.

Then he put the hammer back there.

“It has opened a little. I will glue it.”

Jagdish Babu stood up.

“Where is it?”

“Upstairs.”

The two climbed the stairs.

On reaching the roof, Jagdish Babu took the shoe in his hand.

He pressed the sole.

Then looked towards the toe.

“Glue alone will not hold this.”

Abhay said, “I will get it repaired after reaching Surat.”

“On the very first day?”

Abhay did not answer.

Jagdish Babu turned the shoe over and examined it.

“It needs a small nail.”

“Leave it.”

“A small nail.”

He went downstairs.

Abhay remained on the roof.

After a little while Jagdish Babu returned carrying a small box.

Inside the box were nails, screws, pieces of wire, and two old tacks.

He selected three fine nails.

“Do not strike hard with the hammer here,” he said.

Abhay held the shoe.

Jagdish Babu slowly tapped in the first nail.

Then the second.

He stopped with the third nail in his hand.

“Not here.”

He put the nail back into the box.

Abhay pressed the sole.

The front no longer lifted.

“Shall we leave it like this?” Jagdish Babu asked.

“Yes.”

“It is still wet inside.”

“Let it get some air.”

Jagdish Babu moved the two bricks a little farther apart.

He placed the shoes at an angle.

“Like this.”

Abhay said, “Yes.”

The two stood on the roof for a while.

Down in the lane, two children were floating paper boats in the water.

One boat got stuck at the bend of the drain.

The other moved ahead.

Looking towards the drain, Jagdish Babu said, “It may rain again by morning.”

“I will take the shoes down.”

“There will be dew at night too.”

“Let them get a little more air.”

Jagdish Babu nodded.

The two went downstairs.

Dinner was early that night.

Less rice had been cooked.

Saraswati Devi said, “Get up and eat something in the morning.”

Abhay said, “I cannot eat that early.”

“Two mouthfuls.”

“We shall see.”

Jagdish Babu kept mixing salt into his dal.

Neha asked, “Will you get a seat by the window on the train?”

Abhay said, “Whatever is on the ticket.”

“And if you do not get a window?”

“I will sit wherever there is a seat.”

“For three days?”

“Not three days. I will change trains in between.”

Neha asked nothing more.

After dinner, Saraswati Devi opened the bag again.

Sattu.

Salt.

Two pairs of clothes.

One gamchha.

A small towel.

The packet of papers.

She touched each thing with her hand, one after another.

Abhay said, “Everything is there.”

“Medicine?”

“What medicine do I need?”

“For fever.”

“Will there be no shop there?”

Saraswati Devi put a strip of medicine into the bag.

Abhay did not stop her.

On the veranda, Jagdish Babu was winding the old clock.

"I will wake you at four," he said.

"Half past three."

"The bus is at five."

"I have to walk to the bus stand."

"You will find a rickshaw."

"So early?"

Jagdish Babu held the clock to his ear.

"Half past three."

Abhay went into his room.

His clothes were lying on the bed.

He folded them one by one.

The roof could not be seen through the window.

But the sound of the wind could be heard.

After a while he got up again.

He climbed the stairs and went to the roof.

Night had fully descended.

Lights were burning in only two or three houses in the village.

The shoes were on the bricks.

Abhay touched them to check.

The outer cloth was almost dry.

Inside, they were still damp.

He picked up the laces and checked them.

The laces had dried.

He began threading them into the shoes.

First eyelet.

Second.

Third.

In the dark he missed one eyelet.

He pulled the lace out and started again.

Footsteps sounded behind him.

It was Jagdish Babu.

"Cannot sleep?"

"Not yet."

"The shoes?"

"They are drying."

Jagdish Babu did not touch the shoes.

He stood at the edge of the roof and looked towards the lane.

The sound of some vehicle came from far away.

Then silence again.

Abhay kept tying the laces.

Jagdish Babu said, "On your first day at the factory, do not borrow money from anyone."

Abhay stopped threading the lace.

"All right."

"Spend as little as you can."

"All right."

“Understand the work before you do it.”

“All right.”

Jagdish Babu remained silent for a while.

“Do not put your hand into a machine because someone tells you to, unless it is switched off.”

Abhay raised his head.

“Have you seen that machine?”

“No.”

“Then?”

Jagdish Babu said, “A running machine is the same everywhere.”

Abhay smiled faintly.

Jagdish Babu did not smile.

Then he said, “Take the shoes inside. There will be dew.”

Abhay picked up one shoe.

Then put it back.

“A little longer.”

Jagdish Babu went downstairs.

Abhay remained alone.

He did not sit down on the roof.

He stood by the railing.

In the darkness far away, no lights of the station could be seen.

Surat was nowhere to be seen either.

Only the roofs of the village.

Some tin.

Some tile.

Some concrete roofs.

The same night over all of them.

Abhay picked up the shoes.

He came down the stairs.

Jagdish Babu was not on the veranda.

The ticking of the clock could be heard.

Abhay placed the shoes near the door.

He left the laces loose.

He went to his room and lay down.

Sleep did not come at once.

He kept listening to the wind moving over the roof.

Sometimes it seemed the shoes must be getting wet again.

Then he remembered that he had brought them inside.

At half past three, Jagdish Babu knocked on the door.

Abhay sat up.

It was still night outside.

Saraswati Devi had already lit the hearth.

Neha was awake too.

“Why did they wake you?” Abhay asked.

Neha said, “I woke up by myself.”

Abhay washed his face.

He went to the shoes.
 He put his hand inside.
 They were still a little damp.
 He put on his socks.
 He slipped his feet into the shoes.
 They felt cold.
 Saraswati Devi looked at him.
 "Dry?"
 "Yes."
 Jagdish Babu picked up the bag.
 "It is not heavy."
 Abhay said, "I will carry it."
 "Up to the door."
 He carried the bag and walked ahead.
 The night's water was still shining in the lane.
 The sole of Abhay's shoe made a faint sound on the first step.
 Not on the second.
 Neha stood at the doorway.
 Saraswati Devi behind her.
 No one said any farewell words.
 Jagdish Babu kept walking down the lane.
 Abhay followed behind him.
 At the bend, Jagdish Babu handed him the bag.
 "Straight from here."
 Abhay said, "I know."
 "Do not miss the bus."
 "I will not."
 Jagdish Babu looked towards the toe of his shoe.
 "If the nail comes out, get it repaired at once."
 "Yes."
 "Send word when you arrive."
 "I will."
 The two stood there.
 From the direction of the distant mosque came the first sound of dawn.
 Abhay put the bag over his shoulder.
 "I am going."
 Jagdish Babu said, "Go."
 Abhay turned and walked away.
 Jagdish Babu remained standing there until he reached the end of the lane.
 Abhay did not look back even once.
 He passed the bend.
 Jagdish Babu slowly returned home.
 Saraswati Devi was still standing at the doorway.
 "Will he get the bus?" she asked.
 "He will."

“The shoes?”

“They were dry.”

Jagdish Babu went inside.

After a while he climbed to the roof.

The two bricks lay where they had been.

Between them were two faint dry marks left by the shoes.

All around, the roof was still damp.

Jagdish Babu picked up the first brick.

Then the second.

He moved both back against the wall.

The roof became empty.

For a few moments he kept looking at that place.

Then he went down the stairs.

STORY 193

ONE CUP OF TEA LESS

Every morning, before opening the shop, Harinath Sah made tea.

For years, he had made three cups.

Since this month, there were only two.

One for him.

One for Pawan.

The third cup lay upside down on the shelf.

The cup was not broken.

Its rim was intact.

Only its use had changed.

Earlier, Sumitra Devi used to drink tea from that cup.

The shop shutter would remain half raised.

She would sit on the bench inside and open the ledger.

Harinath Sah would shift the sacks.

Pawan would sweep.

Sumitra Devi would reconcile the previous day's credit.

The tea of all three would grow cold at the same time.

Now Sumitra Devi left home at dawn.

She had found work keeping the register at the village milk collection centre.

The centre opened before five forty-five.

The milk suppliers began arriving while it was still dark.

Measurements, fat content, quantity, names, and payments had to be entered.

Sumitra Devi's handwriting was clear.

For twenty years, the shop ledger had run in that hand.

Harinath Sah would say, "I can write it."

And he did write.

But among the accounts, Sumitra Devi noticed many small things.

Whose credit belonged to the household.

Whose to the field.

Whose payment would come by next Monday.

Which name belonged to one of two men in the village with the same name.

These things were written not in the margins of the ledger, but in her mind.

One day the cooperative president came to the shop to collect milk.

He saw the ledger.

He asked, "Whose handwriting is this?"

Harinath Sah said, "Sumitra's."

Two weeks later, Sumitra Devi began sitting at the milk collection centre.

On the first day, Harinath Sah had made three cups of tea.

Pawan had asked, "Kaki?"
Harinath Sah had looked at the cup.
Then he poured a little extra tea into his own cup.
The second cup went to Pawan.
The tea meant for the third cup remained in the kettle.
From that day, the measure changed.
Now, water for two cups.
Milk for two cups.
Two pinches of tea leaves.
Two small spoonfuls of sugar.
Harinath Sah did not get the quantities wrong.
By seven, customers began to arrive.
The first customer was Ramsevak.
He bought half a kilo of oil and two bars of soap.
While paying, he said, "Write the rest in the ledger."
Harinath Sah opened the ledger.
There were three entries under the name Ramsevak.
One Ramsevak Yadav.
One Ramsevak Mahato.
One simply Ramsevak.
Harinath Sah asked, "How much of your previous balance remains?"
Ramsevak said, "Kaki knew."
Harinath Sah looked at him.
Ramsevak immediately said, "I do not remember."
Harinath Sah turned back through the old pages.
There was a small mark beside one entry.
Half a circle in red pencil.
Sumitra Devi used to make that mark.
Harinath Sah understood.
He wrote down the new credit.
Ramsevak left.
Pawan said, "You understood the mark?"
Harinath Sah said, "This was Ramsevak from the fields."
"How?"
"There was a circle."
Pawan nodded.
"All circles look the same to me."
Harinath Sah did not reply.
By noon, the ledger had been opened five times.
Twice, Harinath Sah found the correct page immediately.
Three times, he had to search.
A woman buying salt said, "I will pay next month when my daughter comes."
Harinath Sah wrote down her name.
Then he stopped.
He asked, "On what date?"

The woman laughed.

“Kaki never asked the date.”

“She knew.”

“Yes.”

Harinath Sah wrote ‘next month’ on the page.

Not the exact date.

At ten, Sumitra Devi returned.

She carried a blue cloth bag.

The centre’s new ledger was not inside it.

That ledger remained there.

In the bag were a small steel box and a bottle of water.

Sumitra Devi stopped in front of the shop.

Harinath Sah was weighing rice.

He said, “Late today?”

“Two milk vehicles arrived at the same time.”

“How much?”

“Two hundred and thirty-seven litres.”

Harinath Sah nodded.

Pawan asked, “Kaki, do they give you tea there?”

Sumitra Devi looked at him.

“They give me work.”

Pawan laughed.

Harinath Sah smiled a little too.

Sumitra Devi looked at the cup lying upside down on the shelf.

She said nothing.

She pulled the ledger towards herself.

“Did Ramsevak come?”

Harinath Sah said, “He came.”

“Oil?”

“And soap.”

“Written down?”

“Written.”

Sumitra Devi looked at the page.

She put a small dot slightly above the entry.

Harinath Sah asked, “What is that?”

“He will receive money from the field this week.”

“Did he say so?”

“His daughter-in-law said it yesterday.”

Harinath Sah pulled the ledger back towards himself.

He looked at the dot.

Then closed the page.

Sumitra Devi went home.

At noon, Pawan brought the lunch box from the house.

Earlier, Sumitra Devi used to bring it herself.

Pawan opened the box.

Three rotis for Harinath Sah.

Four for Pawan.

The vegetable was in one shared container.

Pawan asked, "Now that Kaki is not at home, who cooks the meal?"

Harinath Sah said, "She makes it at dawn."

"So early?"

"She has always been used to waking early."

Pawan broke a piece of roti.

After a while he said, "Does the centre pay well?"

Harinath Sah took some vegetable.

"It is pay for work."

"Monthly?"

"Yes."

"Good."

Harinath Sah said nothing.

In the afternoon, the wholesale trader came.

He unloaded five sacks of sugar.

Harinath Sah wrote down the account.

The trader asked about the previous balance.

Harinath Sah looked at the ledger.

The figures were clear.

So was the date.

But at one place Sumitra Devi had written—"Two crates to be returned."

Harinath Sah counted the crates.

There was only one.

Pawan said, "The other must be in the back room."

They searched.

It was not found.

The trader waited.

Harinath Sah took out his mobile phone.

He called Sumitra Devi.

"Where is one of those two crates?"

Her voice came from the other end, "On the upper shelf to the right. Behind the sacks."

Pawan ran.

The crate was found.

Harinath Sah said, "Found it."

Sumitra Devi asked, "Is it not written in the ledger?"

Harinath Sah said, "It is."

There was silence for a few moments.

Then he said, "It does not say which shelf."

From the other end Sumitra Devi said, "Write it now."

Harinath Sah ended the call.

In the margin of the ledger he wrote—"Upper shelf on the right."

Pawan watched.

"Does this have to be written too?"

Harinath Sah said, "It does now."

In the evening, two schoolchildren came to buy notebooks.
 One child was five rupees short.
 Harinath Sah said, "Give it tomorrow."
 The child said, "Ma said not to put anything on credit."
 Harinath Sah kept the ledger closed.
 "Then bring the money tomorrow."
 The child put the notebook down.
 Then went as far as the doorway.
 He turned back.
 Harinath Sah held out the notebook towards him.
 "Take it."
 "Five rupees?"
 "Tomorrow."
 The child took the notebook and left.
 Pawan asked, "You will not write it in the ledger?"
 Harinath Sah thought for a moment.
 Then he wrote the child's name on a small piece of paper.
 He placed the paper inside the ledger.
 "Did Kaki do it this way?"
 "No."
 "Then?"
 "I will do it this way."
 Pawan said nothing.
 At seven, Sumitra Devi came to the shop again.
 This time her hands were empty.
 She sat on the bench by the doorway.
 The same bench where she had once drunk her morning tea.
 Harinath Sah had lowered one half of the shutter.
 Pawan had already gone home.
 Sumitra Devi asked, "Did the sugar arrive?"
 "It did."
 "Five sacks?"
 "Yes."
 "Did you find both crates?"
 "Found them."
 "There is an inspection at the milk centre tomorrow."
 Harinath Sah said, "So you will leave even earlier?"
 "At five."
 "Sleep?"
 "It will happen."
 Harinath Sah wiped the shelf.
 The upside-down cup came into his hand.
 He went outside to wash it.
 Sumitra Devi opened the ledger.
 She looked at Ramsevak's page.
 Harinath Sah returned.

He placed the cup upside down on the shelf again.

Sumitra Devi saw the small paper with the child's name.

"What is this?"

Harinath Sah said, "Five rupees."

"Whose?"

"The boy's."

"Why not in the ledger?"

Harinath Sah said, "He will give it tomorrow. If he does not, then I will write it."

Sumitra Devi put the paper back where it had been.

"All right."

Harinath Sah closed the shutter.

He put on the lock.

The two walked towards home.

On the road, Sumitra Devi walked ahead.

Harinath Sah behind her.

After some distance, Harinath Sah asked, "How is the ledger at the centre?"

"Clean."

"Many names?"

"Twenty-seven."

"Have you memorized them all?"

Sumitra Devi laughed.

"Not yet."

Harinath Sah said, "You will."

The next dawn, Sumitra Devi left at five.

Harinath Sah came to the shop a little later.

Pawan had not yet arrived.

He raised the shutter halfway.

He lit the stove.

Into the kettle he measured water for two cups.

Milk for two cups.

Two pinches of tea leaves.

Two small spoonfuls of sugar.

The tea kept boiling.

Harinath Sah opened the ledger.

He looked at the previous day's margin.

"Upper shelf on the right."

He turned the page.

At the top of a fresh page, he wrote the date.

Below it, he made three small columns.

Name.

Balance.

When payment will come.

Pawan bent beneath the half-open shutter and came inside.

"Tea?"

Harinath Sah took the kettle off the stove.
He filled two cups.
He gave one to Pawan.
He kept one for himself.
Pawan looked at the ledger.
“These new columns?”
Harinath Sah said, “From now on, we will write it this way.”
Pawan raised the cup to his lips.
The third cup lay upside down on the shelf.
The morning light fell across it.
Harinath Sah did not turn it upright.
He pulled the ledger towards himself.
He began waiting for the first customer.

STORY 194

THE BAMBOO BRIDGE

It had rained all night.

By dawn, the water of the large pond had begun flowing towards the drain.

By afternoon, the drain looked like a river.

The unpaved road leading to the western hamlet of the village had been cut through in the middle.

Across that breach stood a bamboo bridge.

Six thick bamboo poles lay lengthwise.

Thin slats were tied across them at intervals.

Earth supports stood on both sides.

There was no railing.

When the rain eased a little, Hariprasad came towards the bridge.

He carried a long bamboo pole in his hand.

An old gamchha was tucked under his arm.

He stood on this side of the bridge and looked at the water.

The water was rushing swiftly beneath the bamboo.

Water hyacinth, straw, and tree branches had become lodged under the belly of the bridge.

The current struck against that blockage.

The bridge trembled lightly.

Hariprasad lowered the tip of the pole.

At that very moment, a man appeared on the other side.

It was Ramjatan.

Ramjatan too had a bamboo pole in his hand.

A little shorter.

The two looked at each other.

There was no greeting.

For twelve years, they had not spoken to each other.

The reason had not been a large one.

There was a footpath three hands wide.

The footpath ran between their two fields.

On the day of the survey, a stake had been driven a hand and a half to this side.

Hariprasad had said—the stake has shifted.

Ramjatan had said—the stake is in the right place.

The matter had begun with the footpath.

Then it went to the field ridge.

Then to the two families.

Then as far as the police station and the court.

The papers grew tired later.

The two men did not.

When passing in front of each other's houses, they would turn their eyes away.

If a bullock entered the other man's field, they would send a child.

If they had to sit in the same row at a wedding or a funeral feast, one of them would get up.

Today the two stood on opposite sides of the bridge.

Between them was the surging water.

Ramjatan pointed his bamboo towards the straw trapped below.

Hariprasad raised his long pole a little.

That was all.

Hariprasad stood near the mouth of the bridge.

Ramjatan examined the earth on his side.

The support on Ramjatan's side had sunk halfway.

He wedged his shorter bamboo beneath the support.

He took the other end of the bamboo onto his shoulder.

The bridge lifted a little.

Hariprasad pushed his long pole beneath the bridge.

The first thrust struck the straw.

The second struck the water hyacinth.

A thick branch was jammed in the middle.

Hariprasad worked the pole beneath it.

Ramjatan kept the support raised on his shoulder.

"More."

After twelve years, the first word from Ramjatan's mouth to Hariprasad came out.

Hariprasad did not reply.

He pushed the pole farther in.

The branch shifted a little.

Water rushed in at once.

One part of the straw broke free.

The current carried it away.

The bridge shook hard.

The support pressed down on Ramjatan's shoulder.

He clenched his teeth.

Hariprasad pulled out the pole and laid it across the bridge.

He stepped two paces forward.

One thin slat was loose.

The moment his foot came down on it, it lifted.

Hariprasad's heel became trapped between the slats.

The bridge tilted.

Hariprasad's body leaned to one side.

Ramjatan could not release the support from his shoulder.

He slid his shorter bamboo forward.

The end of the bamboo reached Hariprasad's chest.

Hariprasad caught it with both hands.

Ramjatan pulled the bamboo towards himself.

Hariprasad managed to free his heel from between the slats.
He remained lying on his stomach on the bridge.
The water roared below.
Ramjatan did not let go of the bamboo.
Hariprasad sat up.
The skin on his heel had been scraped.
He wiped it with the gamchha.
Ramjatan took the support onto his shoulder again.
Hariprasad turned back.
This time he did not climb onto the bridge.
He worked the long pole from the bank.
With his shorter bamboo, Ramjatan pressed against the other side of the branch.

Their two bamboo poles bore against opposite sides of the branch.

Hariprasad pushed.

Ramjatan lifted upward.

The branch turned.

The thick clump of water hyacinth split apart.

Half the debris flowed away with the current.

Space opened beneath the bridge.

The water rushed out swiftly.

The bridge still trembled, but less than before.

Ramjatan pulled out the shorter bamboo.

The support began sinking again.

He looked at the earth.

Something was needed to hold the earth in place.

Hariprasad saw two thin bamboo poles lying on his side.

He pushed one into the water.

The current carried the bamboo towards Ramjatan.

Ramjatan caught it.

He broke it into two pieces.

He wedged one beneath the support.

He braced the other crosswise against it.

The support became steady.

Hariprasad looked at the water again.

The thick branch was still trapped.

One end of it was on Ramjatan's side.

Ramjatan understood.

He set a foot on the bridge.

Hariprasad watched the way he walked.

Because of an old injury, Ramjatan's left leg did not bend fully.

On dry days, it was not noticeable.

On wet bamboo, it was.

He advanced one step at a time.

On reaching the loose slat in the middle, he stopped.

Hariprasad laid his long pole crosswise over the bridge.

One end was in his hand.
 The other reached Ramjatan.
 Ramjatan took hold of it.
 The pole was now like a temporary railing.
 Keeping one hand on the pole, Ramjatan moved forward.
 From his side, Hariprasad held the pole firmly.
 Ramjatan reached the branch.
 He drew a small sickle from his waist.
 He began cutting the thin twigs trapped around the branch.
 One.
 Two.
 Three.
 The twig came free.
 The thick branch bent a little lower.
 The current climbed over it.
 Ramjatan tried to step back.
 At that moment, the loose slat turned.
 His left foot slipped.
 Ramjatan's body leaned towards the side of the bridge.
 His right hand was on the long pole.
 Hariprasad pulled the pole tight against his chest.
 He planted his feet in the earth.
 Ramjatan did not hang from the pole.
 Using it as a support, he brought his foot back onto the bamboo.
 Hariprasad slowly pulled the pole back.
 Ramjatan took one step backward.
 Then another.
 He returned as far as the middle.
 Neither said anything.
 The thick branch suddenly turned.
 The water pulled it out from beneath the bridge and carried it away.
 Along with it went the straw, the water hyacinth, and two smaller branches.
 The current opened.
 The bridge sprang upward once.
 Then settled down.
 Ramjatan returned to his side.
 Hariprasad lifted the long pole.
 The two stood on their respective banks.
 The bridge between them.
 Clear-flowing water below.
 The rain began again.
 First in large drops.
 Then heavily.
 Hariprasad tied the gamchha around his heel.
 Ramjatan straightened his left leg.

Both were about to turn towards home.

At that moment, three children appeared from the direction of the western hamlet.

They had spent the night in the high school building.

An elderly woman was with them.

She carried a small bundle in her hand.

The children stopped the moment they saw the bridge.

Ramjatan stood at that end of the bridge.

Hariprasad at this end.

The first child set a foot on the bridge.

The bridge moved.

Hariprasad extended the long pole crosswise above the bridge.

Ramjatan caught the other end.

Between the two of them, a taut bamboo support formed.

“Keep your hand on this.”

Holding the pole, the child crossed.

The second one too.

The third one too.

Before stepping onto the bridge, the elderly woman handed her bundle to Ramjatan.

She came slowly.

In the middle, her feet trembled.

Hariprasad raised the pole.

Ramjatan gripped it firmly from his side.

Holding the pole, the elderly woman crossed.

She looked at both of them.

“May God bless you.”

Neither said anything.

The elderly woman walked towards the village with the children.

The rain had thinned now.

Ramjatan looked at the bridge support.

Hariprasad looked at the loose slat.

Ramjatan said—

“This slat will have to be replaced tomorrow.”

Hariprasad said—

“The support too.”

Both fell silent again.

The account of twelve years had not ended there.

The stake was still where it had been.

The footpath was still where it had been.

The old court papers were still at home.

But that evening, the bridge had survived.

The two went home by separate paths.

It rained again at night.

At dawn, people from the village came to look at the bridge.

The bridge was still standing.

One slat was still loose.
One support was still temporary.
Hariprasad arrived first.
He carried a new sickle and one thick bamboo pole.
A little later, Ramjatan appeared on the other side.
He too had a bamboo pole on his shoulder.
The two stopped at the mouths of the bridge.
Hariprasad put his bamboo down.
Ramjatan put his bamboo down.
One bamboo was right for the support.
The other for a railing.
No one decided which bamboo should go where.
Ramjatan pointed towards the support.
Hariprasad picked up his bamboo.
Hariprasad pointed towards the loose slat.
Ramjatan picked up his bamboo.
The two climbed onto the bridge.
One from this side.
One from the other.
They reached the middle.
The loose slat was there.
Hariprasad straightened it with his foot.
Ramjatan untied a length of hemp cord.
Both bent down.
Over the same slat.

STORY 195

THE HALF-CUT MANGO

The house had been divided ten months earlier.

The two rooms to the north belonged to Janardan.

The three rooms to the south belonged to Madhav.

Separate kitchens.

Separate grain stores.

The well water in turns.

A wall had been raised through the middle of the courtyard.

But the wall had stopped when it reached the mango tree.

The trunk there was so thick that a straight line of bricks could not pass without touching it.

The mason had stretched the line three times.

All three times, the line had caught against the trunk.

In the end, a space of a cubit and a half was left beside the trunk, and the wall continued beyond it.

A small bamboo lattice had been fitted into that space.

The lattice opened from this side too.

And from the other side too.

In the partition papers, one line had been written separately—

“The mango tree in the courtyard shall remain shared.”

No one had disputed that line.

That day the quarrel had been over the rooms, the veranda, the cattle shed, and the rear passage.

Not over the mango tree.

The tree was old.

Babuji used to say it had been planted in the second year after his marriage.

Now Babuji was no more.

The tree remained.

There were marks of an old rope on its trunk.

One branch leaned over the northern roof.

Another towards the southern courtyard.

The blossoms came at the same time.

The leaves fell on both sides.

When summer began, tiny green mangoes appeared.

While sweeping in the morning, Janardan would pick up the fallen mangoes on his side.

Madhav would pick up those that fell on his side.

No counting.

No accounting.

The lattice remained closed.

But it was never locked.

In the last week of Jeth, the first storm came.

The sky had been clear until afternoon.
 At five in the evening, black clouds rose in the west.
 The leaves turned over.
 The upper branches of the tree began to sway.
 A thick branch was rubbing against Madhav's tin roof.
 A grinding sound came from it.
 Madhav came outside.
 He looked up.
 The bark of the branch had been scraped in one place.
 Two long scratches had appeared on the tin.
 Janardan too came out from his veranda.
 Both looked towards the tree.
 Madhav said—
 "The storm is strong this time."
 Janardan said—
 "Yes."
 That was all.
 The storm lasted half an hour.
 The branch survived.
 It rained at night.
 At dawn, green leaves and two raw mangoes lay on the tin roof.
 Madhav removed the leaves.
 He picked up the mangoes.
 He placed one mango near the lattice.
 He carried the other towards the kitchen.
 At that time Janardan was touching the trunk and looking upward.
 A thin crack could be seen at the joint of the thick branch.
 The crack was new.
 The bark inside was pale.
 He did not touch it with his finger.
 He only looked.
 In the afternoon Janardan went to the market.
 When he returned, there was a new saw in his hand.
 He put the saw on the veranda.
 Madhav saw it.
 He said nothing.
 The next day before sunset, Janardan set up a ladder and climbed the tree.
 The saw was tucked into his waist.
 Madhav was connecting a hose for watering in his courtyard.
 The first sound of the saw came.
 Kharr.
 Then kharr again.
 Madhav looked up.
 Janardan was cutting the branch that had been rubbing against the tin.
 The branch leaned towards Madhav's roof.
 But its joint was on Janardan's side.

Madhav went on connecting the hose.
The saw kept moving.
Beneath the branch was a small cluster of raw mangoes.
One mango was right beside the saw.
Janardan stopped sawing.
He tried to move the mango aside with his hand.
Its stem was short.
The mango would not move away.
Janardan began sawing again.
Once.
Twice.
The saw touched the body of the mango.
A pale cut appeared in the green skin.
The mango was cut halfway through.
But it remained hanging from the stem.
Janardan looked at it.
Then began cutting the branch again.
The sky was clouding over once more.
The wind strengthened.
The ladder trembled slightly.
Madhav left the hose and stood up.
He came to the foot of the ladder.
He held the ladder with both hands.
Janardan did not look down.
He kept sawing.
More than half the branch had been cut.
At that moment, large drops began to fall.
Sparse at first.
Then hard.
Janardan withdrew the saw.
The branch was still only half cut.
Thin fibres inside were holding it together.
Madhav said—
“Come down now.”
Janardan climbed down the ladder.
Madhav let go of it.
The two stood beneath the veranda and looked at the tree.
The wind was moving the branch.
The half-cut section opened and closed.
The pale wood appeared between the movements.
The mango scored by the saw was still hanging from that branch.
The rain intensified.
Janardan wiped the saw and put it inside the house.
Madhav placed two bricks on his tin roof.
At eight that night the wind strengthened again.
The branch began knocking against the tin.

Janardan left his meal and came outside.
Madhav was already in the courtyard.
He held a thick bamboo pole from an old cot.
One end of the bamboo rested on the ground.
The other end was under the branch.
The bamboo lifted some of the branch's weight.
Because of that, the branch did not fall fully on the tin.
Janardan watched for a moment.
Then he went towards the trunk.
He opened the lattice.
It was the first time the lattice had been opened at night.
Janardan entered Madhav's courtyard.
He looked at the lower end of the bamboo.
The earth was wet.
The end was sinking.
Janardan brought a flat brick from near the cattle shed.
He placed the brick beneath the bamboo.
Madhav lifted the bamboo a little.
Janardan adjusted the brick.
The bamboo no longer sank.
"Will it hold through the night?" Janardan asked.
Madhav looked up.
"If the wind stays only this strong."
Both fell silent again.
The rain was reaching as far as the edge of the veranda.
Janardan turned towards his house.
He closed the lattice.
He did not lock it.
Once in the middle of the night, a loud sound came.
Janardan sat up.
Madhav too had switched on the light on his side.
Both looked at the tree through their windows.
The branch was still resting on the bamboo.
The cut had opened a little more.
The mango could no longer be seen.
At dawn the rain stopped.
Madhav came outside first.
The half-cut mango lay on the ground.
One side had opened along the cut made by the saw.
The flesh inside had turned from pale white to yellow.
Madhav picked up the mango.
He washed off the soil.
He placed it on the thin slat of the lattice.
A little later Janardan came with the saw.
He saw the mango.
He did not touch it.

He opened the lattice.
 Madhav held the bamboo.
 Janardan climbed the ladder.
 This time the saw worked from the upper side of the cut.
 Madhav slowly lowered the bamboo.
 The branch did not fall suddenly.
 It bent downward.
 Then settled onto two old sacks laid in Madhav's courtyard.
 The tin was spared.
 The trunk was spared.
 The cut was clean.
 Janardan climbed down.
 Madhav began plucking the raw mangoes from the branch.
 Janardan plucked them from the other side.
 Both kept placing the mangoes into the same basket.
 No one counted.
 The basket did not fill.
 There were twelve or thirteen raw mangoes at the bottom.
 Madhav placed the basket in the middle by the lattice.
 Janardan went towards the well to wash the saw.
 When he returned, he looked.
 The half-cut mango was still on the slat.
 The cut surface had begun to darken.
 Janardan picked up the mango.
 With a knife he sliced away the thin blackened part.
 He cut the remaining mango into two pieces.
 He put one piece into the basket.
 The other he placed in a small plate on Madhav's veranda.
 He said nothing.
 By afternoon the sun came out.
 A little sap was seeping from the place where the branch had been cut.
 Madhav brought a thin paste of earth and cow dung.
 He opened the lattice.
 Janardan was standing near the tree.
 Madhav held out the paste.
 Janardan took it in his hand and applied it to the cut.
 Madhav watched from below.
 The work was finished.
 Madhav returned towards his courtyard.
 Janardan towards his veranda.
 The lattice was closed again.
 There was still no lock.
 In the evening, a child from Janardan's house came to the lattice.
 A child from Madhav's house came from the other side.
 Both reached into the basket.
 Each picked up one raw mango.

Then each ran back to their own side.
The basket remained in the middle.
The tree had one branch less.
The scratches on the roof were still there.
The wall was still in the middle.
But beside the trunk of the tree, that space of a cubit and a half was still open.
The lattice was there.
The lattice opened from both sides.

STORY 196

THE FISHING NET

Before evening fell, Dharanidhar left the house with the fishing net tucked under his arm.

His son Mohan followed behind him.

The afternoon rain had now stopped.

A grey light remained in the sky.

The water of the Kamla was muddy.

The current was cutting away more of the bank than before.

The two reached the river and stood there for a while.

Dharanidhar placed the net on the ground.

Mohan looked towards the bank.

Where there had been two hands of earth the previous week, there was water now.

Dharanidhar did not look there.

He began checking the knots of the net.

One mesh was loose.

He tightened the thread with his teeth.

Mohan said—

“Do not spread it on this side.”

Dharanidhar stopped his hand.

“Why?”

“The earth below has become hollow.”

Dharanidhar struck the bank with a bamboo pole.

From above, the earth seemed firm.

The pole sank half a hand into it.

He pulled the pole out.

He said nothing.

The two walked fifty paces upstream.

There the current was a little straighter.

Mohan took hold of one end of the net.

Dharanidhar the other.

Together they lowered the net into the water.

Small patches of foam settled along the upper cord of the net.

Dharanidhar said—

“Slowly.”

Mohan shortened his steps.

Both went into the water up to their knees.

The net spread like a half-moon.

For a while there was only the sound of water.

A dog barked in the distant village.

Mohan looked back.

From the river side, one corner of the roof of their house could be seen.

Only one corner.
 The rest was behind the bamboo grove.
 Dharanidhar kept his eyes on the net cord.
 Mohan looked ahead again.
 "More earth fell last night."
 Dharanidhar said—
 "I heard."
 "The crack has reached the front post of the veranda."
 Dharanidhar raised the net a little.
 A small fish leapt and became caught in the mesh.
 He removed the fish and placed it in the basket.
 "Cracks appear in the rains."
 Mohan said nothing.
 The two moved ahead.
 Two leaves became caught in the net.
 A handful of water hyacinth too.
 Dharanidhar removed the leaves.
 Mohan threw away the water hyacinth.
 "The water does not rise to the upper garden."
 Dharanidhar did not answer.
 Mohan's hand remained on the cord.
 "It did not rise there even in the last great flood."
 This time Dharanidhar looked at him.
 "The garden is for the fields."
 "Half of it is empty."
 "Some empty space is necessary too."
 Mohan did not smile.
 "A house is necessary too."
 Dharanidhar looked back at the net.
 A round ripple formed in the water a little distance away.
 He signalled.
 Together they turned the net towards it.
 Three small fish were caught at once.
 One slipped out through a mesh.
 Dharanidhar did not look after it.
 The other two went into the basket.
 "This mesh will have to be mended tomorrow."
 Mohan said—
 "The thread for mending the net is at home."
 Dharanidhar remained silent.
 After a few moments he asked—
 "Where?"
 "On top of the chest."
 Dharanidhar said—
 "You people have emptied the chest."
 Mohan's hand paused for a moment.

"We took out the paddy seed."

"Where did you put it?"

"In the shed in the upper garden."

No expression changed on Dharanidhar's face.

He went on handling the net.

"The sacks of wheat?"

"Those too."

"The plough?"

"The plough is still on the veranda."

Dharanidhar said, "Hmm."

The two moved farther into the water.

The current was stronger here.

Mohan's foot slipped once.

Without letting go of the net, Dharanidhar caught his arm.

Mohan regained his balance.

Both took hold of their respective ends again.

Neither said anything about it.

The sun could not be seen, but the light was fading.

Dharanidhar said—

"Enough for today."

The two began gathering the net.

Wet, the net was heavy.

Its lower part was filled with mud.

Mohan bent towards the river and shook the mud out.

A broken strip of bamboo was caught in the middle of the net.

Dharanidhar pulled it free.

The strip was old.

There was a small blue mark at one end.

Mohan looked at it.

"This looks like the colour of the fence at our house."

Dharanidhar turned the strip over twice.

"Ours is not the only house in the village with blue paint."

He dropped the strip into the water.

The strip floated away with the current.

Mohan kept watching it.

Dharanidhar lifted the basket.

"We caught fewer fish."

"The current has changed."

"Fish move with the current."

Mohan said—

"People?"

Dharanidhar did not answer.

The two climbed onto the bank.

They washed the mud from their feet and tucked the net under an arm.

The footpath leading home split into two.

To the left was the old house.

To the right, the upper garden.
 Dharanidhar turned left.
 Mohan followed him.
 After ten paces, a dull collapsing sound came from the river.
 Both stopped.
 They looked back.
 A broad piece of the bank had fallen into the water.
 Muddy foam rose for a few moments.
 Then the current flowed as before.
 Dharanidhar began walking again.
 Mohan did too.
 On reaching home, he placed the net beside a post of the veranda.
 Mother was inside near the hearth.
 She came out.
 She looked at the fish in the basket.
 "Only this much?"
 Dharanidhar said—
 "The current was strong today."
 Mother looked towards the net.
 "Do not dry it here."
 Dharanidhar looked at her.
 Mother pointed to the crack beside the front post of the veranda.
 The crack was wider than yesterday.
 Mohan quietly picked up the net.
 Dharanidhar said nothing.
 Mohan asked—
 "Where shall I spread it?"
 Dharanidhar looked out from the veranda.
 Evening had nearly fallen.
 The footpath towards the upper garden was still visible.
 He said—
 "Fold it and keep it today."
 Mohan began folding the net.
 Mother carried the fish inside.
 Dharanidhar sat beside the crack.
 He touched the earth with a finger.
 The soil was wet.
 A small piece fell away on its own.
 At dinner that night, there was no discussion of leaving the house.
 They discussed the price of paddy.
 They discussed that fodder for the cattle would fall short.
 They discussed that Mohan's daughter had moved into a new class at school.
 They discussed whether it would rain again.
 They did not discuss the house.
 After dinner Mohan came outside.

Dharanidhar was on the veranda.

The net lay folded.

Dharanidhar asked—

“Are there four bamboo poles in the upper garden?”

Mohan said—

“There are six.”

“Straight?”

“Four straight, two bent.”

Dharanidhar thought for a while.

“Keep two for posts to dry the net.”

Mohan looked at him.

Dharanidhar’s gaze was towards the darkness.

“The other four?”

“They will be used to enlarge the shed.”

Mohan said softly—

“The shed is small.”

“The roof will be extended first.”

“And the house?”

Dharanidhar did not step on the crack in the veranda.

He moved around it and stood up.

“At dawn, move whatever from the house can be moved first.”

Mohan remained silent for a few moments.

“The door?”

“The door last.”

“Mother’s hearth?”

Dharanidhar said—

“A hearth can be made again.”

After that, neither of them said anything.

It did not rain that night.

But the sound of the river kept reaching the house.

At dawn, the first thing Dharanidhar picked up was the net.

Mohan was putting tools into the empty part of the chest where the paddy seed had been kept.

Mother was sweeping the earth of the veranda.

Dharanidhar tucked the net under his arm.

He did not turn towards the river.

He walked towards the upper garden.

Mohan put down the tools and followed him.

The six bamboo poles lay in the garden.

Dharanidhar separated four of them.

He left two straight poles on the ground.

Mohan asked—

“These two?”

Dharanidhar said—

“For the net.”

Together they dug two holes.

The bamboo poles were set into the ground.
The wet net was spread between them.
The morning air passed through every mesh of the net.
Dharanidhar looked at one knot.
“This mesh will have to be mended.”
Mohan said—
“The thread for mending the net is on the chest.”
Dharanidhar did not ask—which chest.
He looked towards the old house in the distance.
One corner of its roof could be seen above the bamboo grove.
The river could not be seen from there.
Only its sound could be heard.
Mohan placed a brick beneath the net so that the cord would not touch the earth.
Dharanidhar pulled the other end taut.
The net was now spread between two new posts.
The fish were still in the river.
The house was still in its old place.
But the net had arrived first.

STORY 197

SMOKE AT DAWN

Dawn had not fully broken yet.

The bricks in the courtyard were damp with the night's dew.

Inside the kitchen, Malti sat on her haunches before the hearth.

She blew twice through the blowpipe.

A red point glowed inside the wood.

The smoke first rose towards her face.

She drew the end of her sari a little farther over her head.

Then she blew again.

This time the fire caught.

Two iron trunks stood on the veranda.

A small bag lay on top of one of them.

The trunks had been packed the previous night.

No one in the house looked directly at them.

Yet since dawn everyone's eyes kept going towards them.

Malti put water on to boil.

The wok had been washed.

A brass bowl lay upside down.

One by one, she was lifting each thing from the same place from which she had lifted it for years.

In the inner room, her mother-in-law coughed.

Malti listened.

Then she began measuring rice.

The previous day her mother-in-law had said—

“You need not cook anything at dawn. We will get something from outside.”

Malti had not replied.

She had washed the rice the night before and left it ready.

Now, while draining its water, her hand stopped once.

She looked behind her.

The kitchen doorway was empty.

She put the pot on the hearth.

Her mother-in-law came out slowly.

An old woollen shawl was in her hand.

She sat down on the veranda.

“So early?”

Malti said—

“It is almost time for the bus.”

Her mother-in-law looked towards the trunks.

“Isn't it the nine o'clock one?”

“Nine ten.”

“There is still plenty of time.”

Malti opened the lentil tin.
 "Babuji's tablet is at eight."
 Her mother-in-law said nothing.
 Sanjeet came out from another room across the courtyard.
 He had a small trunk key in his hand.
 He went straight to the trunks.
 Bending down, he tugged at the lock.
 The lock was properly fastened.
 Even so, he pressed it again.
 Malti watched from beside the hearth.
 Sanjeet did not look towards her.
 "Are the papers in the upper trunk?"
 Malti said—
 "Below, between the clothes."
 "The sewing centre register?"
 "In the bag."
 Sanjeet nodded.
 He put the key on a peg in the veranda.
 Malti said at once—
 "Not on that peg."
 Sanjeet stopped his hand.
 "This is the grain-room key."
 He picked the key up again.
 For two moments he turned it in his hand.
 Then he placed it in front of his mother.
 His mother did not pick it up.
 The water on the hearth began to boil.
 Malti tilted the lid of the pot slightly.
 The smoke was now rising straight upward.
 A thin film of it had settled on the black bamboo of the roof.
 Malti looked at it.
 Five years earlier, Sanjeet had laid new roof tiles over that bamboo.
 The two of them had spent the whole day on the roof then.
 Malti lowered her eyes.
 She added turmeric to the lentils.
 Her mother-in-law said—
 "No ginger."
 "I won't add any."
 "His stomach will burn again."
 "I know."
 Babuji called from inside—
 "Whose stomach?"
 Her mother-in-law answered—
 "Not yours."
 Babuji came as far as the doorway.
 The fold of his dhoti was not yet properly tied.

He looked at the trunks.
Then at Malti.
“Is the tea ready?”
Malti said—
“Drink water first.”
She filled a glass for him.
Babuji took it.
“Orders even today?”
A faint smile came to Malti’s face.
“Only until your tablet.”
Babuji smiled too.
Taking the glass, he went and sat on the veranda.
Sanjeet began sweeping the courtyard.
He hardly ever did that work.
Malti looked towards him twice.
She said nothing.
The broom rasped over the bricks.
The younger niece came out from inside, rubbing sleep from her eyes.
“Kaki, you still haven’t gone?”
Her grandmother said at once—
“The day has not even risen yet.”
The girl placed a hand on one of the trunks.
“Are both of these going?”
Malti said—
“Both.”
“And this yellow glass?”
“No.”
“Why?”
Malti kept stirring the lentils.
“It belongs to the house.”
The girl picked up the glass and looked at it.
There was a small crack along its rim.
Malti gently took the glass from her hand.
“Put it down. It will break.”
The girl asked—
“When will you come again?”
The sound of the broom in the courtyard stopped.
Her mother-in-law’s hand grew still on the shawl.
Babuji began drinking the water in his glass.
Malti pushed a piece of wood farther into the hearth.
“Let your school examinations finish first.”
The girl said—
“My examinations are two months away.”
“Then study.”
“Will you come then?”
Malti looked at her.

"We shall see."

The girl went inside.

Sanjeet began sweeping again.

Malti took the lentils off the fire.

She opened the basket where the potatoes were kept.

She took out four small potatoes.

Her mother-in-law said—

"Leave the mashed potatoes."

Malti said—

"Babuji will not eat only rice and lentils."

From a distance Babuji said—

"I will."

Malti answered—

"You did not yesterday."

Babuji fell silent.

The potatoes were put on to cook.

Sanjeet leaned the broom against the wall.

He came and stood at the kitchen doorway.

"The driver will come at eight forty-five."

"As far as the bus stand?"

"Yes."

"The fare?"

"I have paid it."

Malti nodded.

Sanjeet said—

"The key to the room there?"

"My sister has it."

"As soon as you reach, phone—"

He stopped the sentence.

Malti gathered the ash in the hearth a little.

"I will send word."

Sanjeet placed a hand on the kitchen doorframe.

"The centre starts Monday?"

"Yes."

"It was difficult to go every day from here."

Malti said—

"It was."

Sanjeet said—

"I will come there on Sunday."

Malti said—

"First get Babuji's medicine."

Sanjeet nodded.

After that, both were silent.

The potatoes had boiled.

Malti began peeling them.

Sanjeet picked up one potato.

It was hot.
He shifted it immediately from one hand to the other.
Malti pushed a small bowl towards him.
“Put it here.”
Sanjeet put the potato in the bowl.
Then he picked up another.
The two began peeling potatoes together.
His mother watched from the veranda.
Babuji began looking for his box of tablets.
Without looking, Malti said—
“To the left of the window.”
Babuji reached there.
He found the box.
For a few moments he kept it in his hand.
Then he said—
“When you get there, keep your own things in their own places.”
Malti kept mashing the potatoes.
“Yes.”
“You have a habit of putting other people’s things in order too.”
Her mother-in-law said—
“Enough now.”
Babuji fell silent.
Malti added salt to the mashed potatoes.
Sanjeet asked—
“That much?”
“A little less for you.”
Sanjeet said—
“Will you still remember my salt?”
Malti’s hand stopped.
She closed the salt tin.
“Everyone in this house has a different measure of salt.”
Sanjeet laughed softly.
The laugh lasted a moment and ended.
The first light of the sun fell on the courtyard wall.
The smoke was no longer visible.
Only its smell remained.
Malti began setting out plates.
Babuji’s first.
Then her mother-in-law’s.
Then the girl and her mother woke up as well.
Food was served to everyone.
Malti did not set a plate for herself.
Her mother-in-law asked—
“And you?”
“I will eat something at the bus stand.”
Her mother-in-law pushed her plate forward.

“Sit.”

Malti said—

“I will clean the kitchen.”

“From tomorrow, we will do it.”

For the first time, Malti looked properly at her mother-in-law’s face.

Her mother-in-law said again—

“Sit today.”

Malti pulled a low wooden stool towards herself.

She sat at the kitchen doorway.

Her mother-in-law put a little rice from her own plate onto Malti’s plate.

Malti did not protest.

Babuji said—

“The lentils are good.”

Malti said—

“There is no ginger.”

“That is why.”

The younger niece burst out laughing.

This time the others in the house laughed too.

Sanjeet did not laugh.

He kept looking towards Malti’s plate.

Malti ate two mouthfuls.

Before the third, the sound of a vehicle came from outside.

The courtyard fell completely silent.

Malti put her plate down.

“It is time.”

Sanjeet stood up.

He lifted the first trunk.

Babuji tried to lift the second.

Malti stopped him—

“Not you.”

Sanjeet said—

“I will make two trips.”

The trunk was taken outside.

Malti returned to the kitchen.

The fire in the hearth was low now.

She separated two half-burnt pieces of wood.

She covered the fire with ash.

She hung the blowpipe on its old nail in the wall.

She washed the yellow glass and turned it upside down.

Her mother-in-law stood at the doorway.

“Leave it. I will do it.”

Malti said—

“Just this much.”

She closed the tin of flour.

She moved the salt tin to the right.

She moved the water-filled lota away from the hearth.

Then she washed her hands.
Her mother-in-law held out the key.
The grain-room key.
Malti did not put out her hand.
“It will stay here.”
“It was in your hands.”
“It belongs to the house.”
Her mother-in-law closed her fist around the key.
Malti came out onto the veranda.
The younger niece was holding her bag.
“I will carry this to the vehicle.”

Malti said—
“It is heavy.”
“I can carry it.”
Malti let the bag remain in her hand.
Babuji stood near the doorway.
He said nothing.
Malti touched his feet.
Babuji placed his hand on her head.
For only a very brief moment.

As Malti touched her mother-in-law’s feet, the end of her sari brushed the ground.

Her mother-in-law raised her up.
“Send word on the way.”
“Yes.”
Sanjeet came in from outside and said—
“The second trunk.”
Malti looked at him.
“It is heavy.”
“I know.”

The two took hold of opposite ends of the trunk.
As they stepped down from the veranda, the trunk caught once against the threshold.

Sanjeet raised his side.
Malti lowered hers.
The trunk came free.
The vehicle stood outside.
The dawn dust had not yet risen on the village road.
The trunk was placed in the vehicle.
The younger niece handed over the bag.
Malti took it.
She looked towards the house once.
A thin trail of smoke was rising again above the kitchen roof.
Her mother-in-law had probably stirred the embers from inside.
Sanjeet said—
“Was the fire still alive?”

Malti said—

“Under the ash.”

Sanjeet looked towards the house.

“Until evening?”

“No.”

“Then?”

Malti placed the bag in her lap.

“It will have to be blown alive again.”

The vehicle moved.

Sanjeet remained standing by the roadside.

Malti did not turn back.

The roof of the house remained where it was.

The smoke rose a little higher.

Then dissolved into the light of dawn.

THE BICYCLE WITHOUT A BELL

The afternoon was drawing to a close.

There was little dust in front of the bicycle shop in the market.

Kesho Mistri was filling air into a new tyre.

At that moment Madhav Jha arrived, pushing an old bicycle.

The front wheel turned slightly crooked.

The rear wheel would turn and then stop at one point.

There was no bell on the right side of the handlebar.

Only the round mark where a bell had once been remained.

Kesho detached the air hose.

“What needs to be done?”

Madhav stood the bicycle upright.

“Make it fit to ride.”

“That all?”

“That all.”

Kesho spun the front wheel.

The rim swayed once to the left, once to the right.

“The spokes will need changing.”

Madhav said—

“Whatever is necessary.”

Kesho pressed the brake.

The brake pad had worn down to half its thickness.

“This too.”

“Yes.”

Kesho looked towards the handlebar.

“The bell?”

Madhav said at once—

“No.”

Kesho looked at his face.

Madhav kept running his hand over the bicycle seat.

The black leather at the rear corner of the seat was torn.

The torn part had been stitched in five places with red thread.

Kesho said—

“Shall I change the seat?”

“This will do.”

“It is torn.”

“It is stitched.”

Kesho said nothing.

He turned the bicycle upside down and set it on the repair stand.

A black layer of old oil coated the chain.

Madhav sat on the wooden bench in the shop.

Three old bells lay beneath the bench.

One brass, two iron.
 Madhav looked down once.
 Then turned his eyes away.
 While removing the chain, Kesho asked—
 “Whose bicycle is it?”
 Madhav did not answer.
 Kesho asked again—
 “Yours?”
 “The house’s.”
 “Who rides it at home?”
 Madhav pressed a loose nail in the bench with his finger.
 “The one who used to ride it before.”
 Kesho smiled.
 “The repair will not become more expensive if you say the name.”
 Madhav too smiled a little.
 “Repair it.”
 Kesho put the chain into kerosene.
 The rod of the rear carrier was bent downward in the middle.
 He picked up a hammer.
 Madhav said at once—
 “Do not straighten it.”
 Kesho’s hand stopped.
 “Things will fall off like this.”
 “They did not fall off.”
 “And now?”
 “They will not fall off now either.”
 Kesho left the rod alone.
 Two small iron rings were fixed to the left side of the carrier.
 On the right side, an old cotton strip was knotted.
 Its colour had faded.
 Kesho tried to untie the strip.
 Madhav said—
 “Leave that.”
 “It has rotted.”
 “Even so.”
 Kesho drew his hand back again.
 He began checking the spokes of the front wheel one by one.
 A milkman passed in front of the shop.
 The moment he saw the bicycle, he stopped.
 “Will this come back onto the road again?”
 Madhav looked at him.
 “Why not?”
 The milkman laughed.
 “Then in the morning we will have to clear the road again.”
 Madhav said nothing.
 The milkman went on.

While loosening a spoke, Kesho asked—
“Why did people have to clear the road?”
Madhav pressed the nail in the bench again.
“She was always in a hurry.”
“Without a bell?”
“She had a voice.”
Kesho laughed.
Madhav did not.
A child came from behind the shop.
He took away the air pump.
A small strip of blue cloth was tied to the handlebar of the bicycle.
The child looked at it.
“This looks like school uniform cloth.”
Touching the strip, Kesho said—
“It is old.”
Madhav said—
“Leave it.”
The child went away with the pump.
Kesho straightened the handlebar.
The grip on the right side was much more worn by a palm.
The left grip looked almost new.
“Did she ride with one hand?”
Madhav said—
“When was the other hand ever empty?”
Kesho looked at the broken prong of the front basket.
The basket itself had been removed long ago.
Only the prong remained on the frame.
“Shall I fit a basket?”
“No.”
“Then shall I cut this prong off?”
“No.”
Kesho shook his head.
“You are stopping more repairs than you are allowing.”
For the first time Madhav laughed properly.
“I want it fit to ride. Not new.”
Kesho did not question that sentence again.
He kept working.
The chain was cleaned.
The black grime caked on the teeth came off.
The axle of the rear wheel was opened.
The ball bearings inside were dry.
Kesho filled in grease.
At that moment the tea seller from the market came over.
He carried two cups of tea.
He gave one to Kesho.
He held the other out to Madhav.

Madhav took it.
 The tea seller looked at the bicycle.
 "After so many days?"
 Madhav said—
 "Yes."
 "Her knee?"
 Madhav raised the cup to his lips.
 "Better now."
 The tea seller stood there for a few moments.
 "Did the doctor allow her to ride?"
 "Slowly."
 The tea seller looked towards the bicycle's carrier.
 "Will this stay bent?"
 Madhav said—
 "It is better that way."
 The tea seller went away laughing.
 Kesho asked no more questions.
 He removed the rear tyre.
 There were three patches on the inner tube.
 There was room for a fourth patch too.
 "The inner tube will have to be changed."
 Madhav said—
 "Change it."
 Kesho looked a little surprised.
 "This can be changed?"
 Madhav emptied his cup.
 "Change what is inside and cannot be seen."
 Kesho looked at him.
 Madhav put the empty cup on the bench.
 The afternoon was now leaning towards evening.
 The shadow in front of the shop grew long.
 Kesho fitted a new inner tube.
 He changed the brake pad.
 Four new spokes went into the front wheel.
 The rear wheel was straightened.
 The chain was oiled.
 The seat remained the same.
 The carrier remained bent.
 The blue strip remained.
 The round mark where the bell had been remained too.
 Kesho lowered the bicycle to the ground.
 "Ride it once and see."
 Madhav took hold of the handlebar.
 "Not me."
 "Then who?"
 Before answering, Madhav looked towards the market.

Around the bend in the road, a woman was approaching slowly.
A bamboo walking stick was in her right hand.
Her left hand was empty.
She came and stopped in front of the shop.
Kesho stood up.
Madhav rose from the bench.
The woman looked at the front wheel of the bicycle.
Then the rear.
Then the seat.
Her eyes went to the right side of the handlebar.
There was no bell there.
She looked at Madhav.
“You did not put one on?”
Madhav said—
“No.”
A small smile appeared on the woman’s face.
“Did you change the seat?”
“No.”
“The carrier?”
“Not that either.”
The woman handed her walking stick to Madhav.
She took hold of the handlebar.
Kesho said—
“Slowly at first. The brake is new.”
The woman placed one foot on the pedal.
With the other she pushed off from the ground.
The bicycle moved two hands forward.
She got down.
Madhav stepped forward.
The woman raised a hand to stop him.
She placed her foot on the pedal again.
This time the bicycle went five hands.
The handlebar trembled a little.
The bent rear carrier shook lightly.
She got down again.
Kesho said—
“It would be better with a bell.”
The woman placed her palm on the right side of the handlebar.
“When did it ever have one?”
Kesho fell silent.
Madhav turned the walking stick in his hand.
The woman looked towards the road.
At that moment, the crowd leaving school was approaching from a distance.
Two children were walking in the middle of the road.
The woman mounted the bicycle again.

She began pedalling slowly.
On reaching the road she called out loudly—
“Move aside.”
Both children turned around.
One moved aside at once.
The other burst out laughing.
“Hey, Bicycle Kaki is riding again!”
The woman did not stop.
She went a little farther.
Then as far as the bend.
Madhav remained standing in front of the shop.
Kesho looked at him.
“Whose bicycle is it?”
Madhav rested the walking stick on the ground.
Beyond the bend, the bicycle disappeared from sight.
Madhav said—
“The house’s.”
Kesho asked nothing more.
He picked up the brass bell lying beneath the bench.
He brushed off the dust.
Then put it back underneath.

STORY 199

FIVE MINUTES LATE

It was an evening in Jeth.

The sun had gone down, but the soil in the fields was still warm.

The tube well was running to the east of the village.

Its grinding hum could be heard from far away.

The irrigation channel was full of water.

Small earthen ridges on both sides of the channel gleamed.

Mahendra Jha placed his spade on the ridge of his field and looked at his watch.

There were seven minutes to half past four.

Dayakant's turn for water was from four to half past four.

After that came Mahendra's field.

From five o'clock, Sonma Devi's seedbed.

The schedule had been made this time.

The rains were late in coming.

The pond had half dried up.

Five households depended on the tube-well water.

So everyone's time had been written down.

There was another line too—water would not be held back for anyone who was not present at their allotted time.

Dayakant was already there.

He sat at the mouth of the channel, pulling out grass.

Mahendra said—

"I'll go home, untangle the calf's rope, and come back."

Dayakant nodded.

"You'll be here by half past four?"

"By half past four."

The two had been friends since childhood.

They had gone to school together.

They had gone to the market together for the first time.

Together they had learned to swim in the river.

Each had worked a spade in the other's field without asking.

Keeping account of time had never been a large matter in their friendship.

Mahendra walked towards home.

On reaching the courtyard, he saw that the calf had wound the rope around itself and become caught at the stake.

Its hind leg was inside the rope.

He bent down and began loosening the knot.

The knot was wet.

It had tightened.

From inside the house, his wife asked—

"Weren't you supposed to release the water?"

“There is still time.”

Mahendra pulled the end of the rope with his teeth.

The knot did not open.

He went inside to fetch a knife.

The knife was not in its usual place.

He came outside again.

The calf turned and looked at him.

Mahendra borrowed a knife from the neighbour’s boy.

He did not cut the rope.

He slowly loosened it.

He freed the calf’s leg.

Then he tied the rope again with a new knot.

He looked at his watch.

It was half past four.

“It’ll be all right,” he said to himself.

Dayakant was there.

He would have released the water.

This had happened before too.

Many times Mahendra had watched Dayakant’s turn.

Many times Dayakant had watched his.

Mahendra remembered the spade.

The spade was at the field.

He set off empty-handed.

He met Ramsevak on the way.

“Where are you going?”

“For the water.”

“Then run.”

Mahendra laughed.

“He is one of our own.”

He walked quickly, but he did not run.

The sound of the tube well grew nearer.

The mouth of the irrigation channel came into view.

Dayakant stood on the ridge.

Mahendra’s spade was in his hand.

On reaching the edge of the field, Mahendra looked at his watch.

It was five minutes past half past four.

His field was dry.

The water was flowing towards Dayakant’s field.

Mahendra looked first at the water.

Then at Dayakant.

“It was my turn.”

Dayakant said—

“It was.”

“It’s only been five minutes.”

“Yes.”

Mahendra held out his hand for the spade.

Dayakant gave it to him.
“You could have released it.”
Dayakant looked towards the channel.
“It was half past four.”
Mahendra did not laugh.
“And when it was four?”
Dayakant said nothing.
Water was filling the first bed of Dayakant’s field.
The soil was turning dark.
The dry cracks were slowly disappearing.
Mahendra moved towards the mouth of the channel.
Dayakant did not step forward.
“You cut five minutes from my turn.”
Dayakant said—
“At five, it is Sonma’s turn.”
“But my half hour?”
“From half past four to five.”
Mahendra tightened his grip on the spade handle.
At that moment a voice came from farther down the channel—
“Hold the earth there a little.”
It was Sonma Devi.
She had a small spade in her hand.
She was building up the earth at the mouth of her seedbed.
Her twelve- or thirteen-year-old daughter was with her.
The girl had placed two empty buckets to one side.
Sonma did not come upward.
She went on repairing her ridge.
Mahendra said in a low voice—
“Her time is at five.”
Dayakant said—
“Yes.”
“Then five minutes could have been taken from her.”
This time Dayakant looked at him.
After a while he said—
“Have you asked her?”
Mahendra did not answer.
The tube well kept grinding.
A kite circled in the sky.
Water from the channel was seeping through a small hole in the ridge.
Dayakant pressed the earth down with his foot and closed the hole.
Mahendra went into the dry bed of his field.
He lifted some soil in his hand.
It crumbled at once.
“What difference do five minutes make?” he said.
Dayakant replied—
“That is why the schedule gives the time in minutes.”

Mahendra walked some distance away.
 He sat down on the ridge.
 He placed the spade in front of him.
 Dayakant kept watching the water.
 He did not come towards Mahendra.
 There were twenty hands of distance between them.
 There had rarely been that much distance between them before.
 Old things rose in Mahendra's mind.
 At Dayakant's wedding, he had not gone home for three days.
 During Mahendra's father's illness, Dayakant had accompanied him all the way to the hospital.
 Once, when Mahendra's bullock fell ill at night, Dayakant had remained there until dawn.
 When Dayakant's thatch roof blew away, Mahendra had given him his bamboo.
 So many years of friendship.
 Five minutes.
 Mahendra looked at the water flowing through the channel.
 Nothing was written in that water.
 Dayakant looked at his watch.
 Five minutes past half past four had gone by.
 He picked up the spade.
 He closed the mouth of his own field.
 Then he opened the channel towards Mahendra's field.
 The water suddenly entered Mahendra's dry bed.
 At first the soil drank it in.
 Then the water moved ahead.
 Dayakant said—
 "Twenty-five minutes."
 Mahendra looked at him at once.
 "What?"
 "At five, Sonma's turn."
 Mahendra lifted the spade.
 "I need half an hour."
 Dayakant sat down on the ridge of his own field.
 "You may need whatever you need; there isn't that much water."
 Mahendra began moving along with the water.
 As the stream passed from one bed to the next, he cut through the soil to open its way.
 He was working quickly.
 He had never worked that fast before.
 Dayakant remained silent.
 Four forty.
 Mahendra's first two beds were wet.
 Four forty-five.
 The water reached the third bed.

Mahendra looked at his watch.
After that he did not look at it again.
Sonma Devi sat on her ridge.
Her daughter had turned an empty bucket upside down and was sitting on
it.

The two were saying something softly to each other.
The water had not yet reached the last bed of Mahendra's field.
Dayakant stood up.
He did not go into Mahendra's field.
He stood at the main mouth of the channel.
Mahendra saw him from a distance.

"Not yet."

Dayakant looked at his watch.

"One minute."

Mahendra opened the mouth of the last bed.

The water turned towards it.

"Now?"

Dayakant said—

"Now."

It was five o'clock.

Dayakant closed the channel leading towards Mahendra's field.

He opened the mouth towards Sonma's seedbed.

Mahendra's last bed was only half wet.

The water stopped there.

The soil drank it in.

Mahendra stood holding the spade.

Sonma's daughter got up.

She moved the empty bucket aside.

With her small spade, Sonma cut the first ridge.

The water ran towards the seedbed.

She looked upward.

"Thank you."

Dayakant only nodded.

Mahendra heard her.

He said nothing.

The sun was now behind the trees.

The smoke from the tube well had grown thin.

Water gleamed in Sonma's seedbed.

Mahendra looked at his half-wet last bed.

With the spade he levelled the soil a little.

Where the water had not reached, the cracks remained.

Dayakant started for home.

Mahendra did not stop him.

The two took the same road.

Dayakant first.

Mahendra behind.

At the bend in the village, Dayakant stopped.

Mahendra came up to him.

Dayakant said—

“Tomorrow morning I’ll put two buckets of water on your dry patch.”

Mahendra said—

“No.”

Dayakant said nothing.

Mahendra spoke again—

“Tomorrow is not your turn.”

Dayakant looked at him.

Mahendra walked ahead.

That night there was no sound on the narrow path between their two houses.

The next day Mahendra went to the field.

The soil of the last bed was still a little damp.

He pulled two handfuls of seedlings from the seedbed and planted them there.

Some of the seedlings remained bent.

He straightened them.

Dayakant was approaching from a distance.

He had a spade in his hand.

He stopped beside Mahendra.

“Will they survive?”

“We’ll see.”

Dayakant bent down and pressed the soil around one seedling.

Then he stood up.

Neither spoke of the old matter.

Not of the five minutes either.

Three days later the tube well ran again.

This time Dayakant’s name came first in the schedule.

Then Mahendra’s.

Then Sonma’s.

Dayakant arrived ten minutes before his time.

Mahendra was already sitting there.

Dayakant looked at his watch.

“Early today?”

Mahendra said—

“No.”

He showed him his watch.

“There are still five minutes left.”

Dayakant sat down beside him.

The spade lay between them.

The channel was still dry.

The tube well’s grinding had not yet begun.

Down below, Sonma Devi was repairing her ridge.

Mahendra did not look at his watch again.

Neither did Dayakant.
The tube well started.
The first water entered the channel.
Both men stood up.

STORY 200

THE WASHED-AWAY RIDGE

On the third night of Ashadh, the rain fell hard.

By dawn, the eastern fields of the village were gleaming with water.

When Devanath Jha reached his field, he did not look first at the paddy.

He looked at the ridge.

The ridge between his field and Raghunath Yadav's had been washed away in three places.

The earth had been carried down by the water and deposited below.

At one place the gap was so wide that the water in the two fields seemed to be of one colour.

Devanath stood there for a while.

Raghunath was already on the other side.

He had a spade in his hand.

The two looked at each other.

Neither said Ram-Ram.

Devanath climbed onto the ridge.

Raghunath began scraping up the earth that had washed down below.

Three years earlier, this ridge had not been so high.

In those days, people from both families would cross it freely into each other's fields.

A child from Devanath's house would bring milk from Raghunath's cattle yard.

If a guest came to Raghunath's house, a cot would be carried over from Devanath's veranda.

If labourers fell short during paddy transplanting, no one counted whose field was whose.

Whoever was free would step into the other's field.

In those days the ridge stopped only water.

Not people.

Three years earlier, one night in Sawan, something had happened over a turn of water.

Too much water had entered Devanath's seedbed.

By morning, half the seedbed lay flattened like paste.

Raghunath had said that he had not opened the mouth of the channel before his own turn.

Devanath had said—

“Then did the water come on its own?”

Raghunath had replied—

“Ask the water.”

That was all.

A few days later, fresh earth was piled onto the ridge.

After that, two bamboo stakes were driven into it.

After that, people too began walking only on their own sides.
Milk stopped coming from Raghunath's house.
Devanath's cot remained on his own veranda.
Invitations still reached for weddings and family ceremonies, but people arrived late.

They sat separately.

They returned separately.

For the first few days, the children tried to understand.

Then they too learned the rule, like the ridge itself.

Today that same ridge had been washed away in three places.

Devanath drove his spade into the earth.

The first gap was small.

He began cutting earth from his side of the field and filling it.

Raghunath began adding earth from the other side.

The earth from both sides met in the middle.

Their hands did not.

After a while Devanath's son Naval arrived.

He carried two baskets on a shoulder pole.

Raghunath's daughter Chanda came behind him carrying a pan of earth.

Naval stopped on the ridge.

Chanda stopped too.

The two could not pass through the gap at the same time.

Naval stepped down.

"Go."

Chanda said nothing.

She passed with the basket.

Raghunath looked up once.

So did Devanath.

Then both began cutting earth again.

The second gap was deep.

There the spade struck something hard inside the earth.

There was a knock.

Raghunath cleared the earth away with his hand.

An old earthen pipe emerged.

Half broken.

The mouth of the pipe opened towards both fields.

Naval asked—

"What is this?"

Raghunath lifted the pipe.

He brushed the earth from it with his hand.

Devanath said—

"The old outlet for releasing water."

Naval asked again—

"Here?"

This time no one answered at once.

Chanda put down the basket and began looking at the pipe.

Raghunath said—

“My father made it.”

Devanath added—

“With my father.”

Naval took the broken piece of pipe in his hand.

“Shall we put it back?”

Devanath remained silent.

So did Raghunath.

Rain clouds were gathering again in the east.

Thunder sounded in the distance.

Raghunath took the pipe from Naval’s hand.

One side of it was cracked.

“This will not hold now.”

Devanath climbed down from the ridge and went towards his side of the field.

Some pieces of dry bamboo lay there.

He picked up a hollow piece and brought it back.

He placed it beside the pipe.

“This will hold.”

Raghunath looked through the bamboo.

“The opening is too wide.”

“We will bury half of it in earth.”

“What if the water runs hard?”

Devanath tapped the bamboo with the handle of his spade.

“We will put a stone on top.”

For the first time in three years, the two men were speaking more than five sentences about the same piece of work.

Naval did not count them.

Neither did Chanda.

They simply kept bringing earth.

The piece of bamboo was laid beneath the ridge.

One mouth towards Devanath’s field.

The other towards Raghunath’s.

Earth from both sides was piled over it.

Raghunath pressed the earth down with his foot.

Devanath tamped it with the back of the spade.

The opening remained clear.

Chanda asked—

“Won’t you close it?”

Raghunath said—

“Not now.”

Devanath said nothing.

The third gap was the largest of all.

There the ridge had almost disappeared.

The two families’ fields seemed to have run into each other.

There had once been a small footpath at that spot.

People from the village used to walk along this ridge towards the pond.
After the quarrel, both households had piled earth there and erased the
footpath.

People began taking the longer way around.
Today the rain had lowered that place again.

Devanath said—

“We need more earth here.”

Raghunath said—

“There is sand below.”

“Cut some heavy clay from the side.”

Raghunath went towards a corner of his field.

The soil there was heavy.

Devanath followed him.

For the first time in three years, he set foot in Raghunath’s field.

Nothing happened.

The soil was still there.

The transplanted paddy was still there.

Raghunath’s spade was still there.

Devanath cut two spadefuls of earth.

Raghunath filled the basket.

The two returned towards the ridge.

Sarju Kaka was passing along the village path.

He stopped.

He looked from a distance.

“The ridge washed away?”

Devanath said—

“Yes.”

Sarju Kaka looked towards Raghunath.

“How much?”

Raghunath said—

“A little more than what you can see.”

Sarju Kaka did not laugh.

He went on.

By afternoon, all three gaps had been filled.

The ridge stood again.

But the bamboo opening in the middle remained clear.

Naval placed a leaf over it.

The leaf fell through.

Chanda pulled it out from the other side.

“It works.”

Naval said.

Raghunath said—

“We will know when the water comes.”

The sky had grown darker still.

Devanath’s wife, Sharda Devi, came from a distance carrying two lotas of
water.

She stopped a little away from the ridge.
 She gave one lota to Devanath.
 She held the other out towards Naval.
 Naval said—
 “Babu, you drink first.”
 Devanath drank half the water and put the lota down.
 At that moment Raghunath’s wife, Kamla Devi, also reached the field.
 She had a small container of sattu in her hand.
 The two women looked at each other.
 Sharda Devi’s lota stood on the ridge.
 Kamla Devi put the container of sattu down on her side.
 After a while, the first large drop of rain fell.
 Sharda Devi picked up one lota.
 She left the other where it was.
 Kamla Devi picked up the container.
 She placed that lota in the middle of the ridge.
 No one said anything.
 Everyone started towards home.
 It rained hard again at night.
 Devanath did not sleep for a long time.
 From the veranda, nothing could be seen towards the fields.
 There was only the sound of water.
 Once he got up and went as far as the doorway.
 Sharda Devi asked—
 “Will you go to the field?”
 “Not now.”
 “The ridge?”
 After a while Devanath said—
 “We will see in the morning.”
 At dawn the rain stopped.
 Devanath went towards the field.
 Raghunath was already there.
 The ridge stood.
 Both fields were full of water.
 Devanath’s field was a little higher.
 Raghunath’s a little lower.
 Leaves and grass were caught in the mouth of the bamboo.
 The water had stopped.
 Raghunath held out the spade.
 Devanath stopped him with his hand.
 He knelt down.
 He removed the leaves by hand.
 First a thin stream came through.
 Then water began flowing towards Raghunath’s field.
 The two watched the stream for a while.
 Raghunath said—

“If it becomes too much, we will pack in some earth.”

Devanath said—

“If it becomes too little, we will take some out.”

Raghunath nodded.

The two walked farther along the ridge.

At the place of the third gap, the earth had sunk a little.

Devanath drove his spade into the ground there.

Raghunath turned to bring earth from his own field.

Devanath said—

“There is some heavy clay left on my side.”

Raghunath stopped.

“Then cut it from there.”

Both climbed down into Devanath’s field.

In the distance, Naval and Chanda could be seen going to school.

They reached the place where the old footpath had been.

Naval stopped.

Chanda stopped too.

This time Naval did not climb down.

He moved to one side on the ridge.

Chanda passed beside him.

Then both went ahead along the same path.

Devanath looked that way.

So did Raghunath.

Neither told them to take the longer way around.

After a while, both men were back on the ridge.

Earth was filled in.

It was tamped down with the spades.

The old footpath was not fully restored.

But the ridge was left a little wider there.

By afternoon, the water had gone down.

The stream through the bamboo opening had grown thin.

Raghunath placed his spade on his shoulder.

So did Devanath.

The two turned towards their separate homes.

After ten paces, Raghunath stopped.

“We will look at the outlet again this evening.”

Devanath stopped too.

“Yes.”

The two went on towards their respective homes.

The ridge stood.

There was also a place in the middle for the water to pass.

Stories remain alive for as long as people and language remain alive.

— GAJENDRA THAKUR

Gajendra Thakur's three hundred selected stories are a living mirror of the many forms of life in Mithila, Vajji, and Anga: human relationships, changing times, village and town, sorrow and joy, tradition and modernity, nature and society, women and men, the minds of children, old age, migration, memory, struggle, and hope.

Volume II gathers Stories 101–200. Across these three volumes, the simplicity of the people's language, the depth of lived experience, and the cultural pulse of Mithila, Vajji, and Anga abide together.



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Three Streams of Stories

STORIES 201–300

VOLUME

III

GAJENDRA THAKUR

Translated from the Original Maithili into English by the Author Himself

VIDEHA

Three Hundred Selected Stories

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Stories 201-300

Gajendra Thakur

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Gajendra Thakur's three hundred selected stories form a vivid mirror of the many shapes of life in Mithila, Vajji and Anga: folk life and human relationships, changing times, village and city, sorrow and joy, tradition and modernity, nature and society, women and men, childhood and old age, migration, memory, struggle and hope.

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STORY 201

School Shoes

...

The first rain of Ashadh had fallen through the night. By morning, mud had gathered on the unpaved village road, and water dripping from the thatch had made little pools beside the veranda. Moti Paswan rose before dawn and ran a hand over the spade lying at the edge of the courtyard. The soil in the fields was soft today; on a day like this, seed settled readily into the earth.

At the other end of the veranda, his daughter Sarita was drying her school shoes. The black cloth shoes were now less black than the colour of mud. The sole of the left shoe had come loose at the toe, so Sarita had tied it twice around with twine. Inside the right shoe she had placed a piece of cardboard; without it, her heel would have touched the ground.

Moti looked at the shoes but said nothing.

Sarita asked, “Babu, will you get your wages today?”

“The munshi said yesterday that I would.”

“Then will you go to the market?”

Moti picked up the spade. “Let the money come into my hands first.”

Sarita said nothing more. She tightened the twine around the shoe, put her books into a cloth bag, and set off for school, picking her way around the mud.

Moti’s last three months had passed in ordinary day labour: unloading sacks of paddy one day, carrying bricks another, cutting field ridges on a third. He had no land of his own. Behind the house there were four dhurs of kitchen ground, where Kamli grew greens and vegetables. That year Nihal Yadav had offered him six kathas of fallow land on a half-share. The terms were simple: plough and oxen Nihal’s, labour Moti’s, seed Moti’s; the crop to be divided equally.

To Moti those six kathas were not merely a field. In a life measured out in days of hired labour, it was the first place where something sown by his own hands might bring a certain share of grain into his own house.

Seed would cost seven hundred and eighty rupees. Moti was owed one thousand three hundred and twenty rupees in wages. Sarita’s shoes would cost at least six hundred and fifty in the market—he had learned that the previous week.

The two things could not be done together.

By noon Moti and the other labourers were fixing sheets of tin onto the roof of a warehouse. The air was heavy after the rain. The sharp edge of the tin could slice a hand, and everyone worked with care.

At the meal break, the munshi took notes out of an old bag and began calling names.

“Moti Paswan.”

Moti stepped forward. The munshi counted out one thousand three hundred and twenty rupees into his palm.

“That settles the account.”

Moti folded the notes and knotted them into the corner of his gamchha. The word settled pleased him for a moment, but at once the image of Sarita’s loosened sole rose before his eyes.

When work ended, he went straight to the market. He stopped first at the seed shop. Tulsi Sah opened a sack of maize seed and showed him the kernels.

“Take eight kilos of this. Enough for six kathas.”

“How much for eight kilos?”

“Seven hundred and eighty.”

Moti took a few kernels into his palm. They were yellow and smooth, almost identical in size. He thought of Nihal’s field—the rain-darkened soil, ready to take the plough before evening.

“What if I take six kilos?”

Tulsi Sah shook his head. “I can give you six. But will you leave patches of the field empty? If you sow thin and the yield is poor later, don’t blame me.”

Moti let the kernels fall back into the sack.

Tulsi Sah asked, “Short of money?”

“There is another expense.”

“If you want it on credit, I’ll put your name in the book.”

Moti’s hand stopped over the sack. “Against the harvest?”

“Against the harvest. Like everyone else.”

Moti knew what that ‘like everyone else’ meant. As soon as the crop was cut, the price of the seed would be recovered first, then the higher charge laid on top of it, then the merchant’s share. Even his half of a sharecrop would carry the teeth of debt. Before his first cultivation had properly begun, he would already be caught in someone else’s ledger.

“Not now,” Moti said.

He crossed the market and reached the shoe shop. Shoes of many kinds hung from bamboo posts. The shopkeeper, seated inside, turned Sarita's old shoe over in his hand. Moti had brought it with him.

"Put the sole back on," Moti said.

The shopkeeper pressed the cloth near the toe with his thumb. It tore at once.

"If I fit a new sole to this, it won't last even two weeks. The upper has rotted through."

"Can you stitch it?"

"The stitches won't hold."

Moti was silent.

The shopkeeper drew out a pair of black shoes from below. "Take these. Seven hundred and twenty."

"The ones for six hundred and fifty?"

"That size is too small. How old is your daughter?"

"Thirteen."

The shopkeeper brought out another pair. "These are six hundred and seventy. I won't promise they'll last a very long time, but they'll see her through the rains."

Moti held the shoes in his hands and bent the soles. They were only this much weight, yet they would swallow more than half the notes knotted into his gamchha.

He walked out without buying them.

In the middle of the market, beside Teli Pond, stood a peepal tree. Moti sat beneath it. In front of him people bought vegetables, salt, oil, rope, sickles. No one else's expense seemed to be the enemy of another expense; only his rupees seemed to be pulled in two directions at once.

If the seed was not bought by evening, Nihal would give the field to someone else. If the shoes were not bought, Sarita would walk four kos again tomorrow in the same shoes bound with twine.

Moti looked down at his own feet. One strap of his rubber sandal was fastened with wire. It was good enough for going to work. For a moment he wondered—were shoes truly so necessary? One studied with the head, not with the feet.

Then he remembered the morning: Sarita adjusting the cardboard inside her shoe. She had never once said, 'I won't go.' The torn shoe had not become her excuse; it had become one more task she performed every day.

Moti rose and started home. The school lay on the way. Classes had ended. Near the gate, two children came out wheeling bicycles. Then Sarita appeared from behind them. Her pace was slower than usual.

“What happened?” Moti asked.

Sarita tried to smile. “Nothing.”

“Show me your foot.”

“Babu—”

“Show me.”

Sarita sat at the roadside and took off the shoe. The skin on her right heel had been rubbed raw and red. The cardboard had soaked up water and gone soft, and mud had worked its way inside the sole.

Moti asked, “Will you go in these tomorrow?”

Putting the shoe back on, Sarita said, “I can manage two more days. You buy the seed. Nihal Kaka will give the field to someone else.”

Moti looked at her. “Who told you that?”

“Ma told me.”

“Your ma says too many things.”

“I understand it too. If we get six kathas, maize will come into the house.”

For some distance Moti walked beside his daughter without speaking. Whenever Sarita stepped into the mud, she lifted her right foot a little, so that less pressure fell on the heel.

At home Kamli was blowing on the hearth. Moti untied the corner of his gamchha and laid the notes on the cot.

Kamli asked, “Did you bring the seed?”

“I didn’t bring the seed.”

“Then the shoes?”

“Not yet.”

She watched his face for a few moments. “Then?”

Moti said, “I’m going back to the market now.”

Kamli looked at Sarita’s foot. Without a word she rubbed turmeric and oil onto the chafed heel.

By the time Moti reached the market again, darkness was coming down. The seed shop was half packed away. From a distance Tulsi Sah called, “Taking it?”

Moti shook his head and walked on.

The shoe seller was untying the bamboo post. Moti asked for the pair that cost six hundred and seventy rupees. The shopkeeper wrapped it in paper. As he paid, Moti counted out a five-hundred-rupee note, hundred-rupee notes and smaller notes separately. Six hundred and fifty rupees remained in his hand.

On his way home he stopped at Nihal Yadav's courtyard.

"I couldn't arrange the seed," Moti said.

Nihal watched him for a few moments. "Then the field?"

"Give it to whoever you need to."

"I can hold it until tomorrow."

Moti touched the knot in his gamchha. "The seed will not appear by tomorrow."

Nihal said, "All right. I'll speak to Ram Bali in the morning."

Moti bowed and left. Saying the decision aloud did not make the burden lighter; it only gave the burden a clear shape.

That night Sarita tried on the new shoes. She rose from the cot, walked as far as the veranda, and came back.

"Not loose?"

"They fit properly."

"Not cutting your heel?"

"Not now."

Kamli said, "Before you wear them tomorrow, I'll tuck some dry cloth inside. They'll get wet in the rain."

Sarita took the shoes off and set them side by side beneath the cot. Moti kept looking at them. He thought of Nihal's six kathas, where seed should have gone into the earth that day.

The next morning Ram Bali ploughed that field. Moti went to work in another field. Nihal's land lay along the way. Furrows were being drawn across the freshly turned soil for maize. Moti stopped for two moments, then walked on.

Sarita wore her new shoes to school. The monsoon mud swallowed their shine on the very first day.

By the end of Sawan, Ram Bali's maize had grown above the knee. From time to time Moti passed the field. He looked at the spacing of the rows, at the colour of the plants, but said nothing to anyone.

In Bhadon there was less work. The household tightened again around its expenses. Kamli planted pigeon pea and kodo in one corner of the kitchen plot.

Whenever Moti was paid a few seers of grain instead of wages, it all went into the household store.

In Kartik, on the day Nihal's maize was harvested, Moti too went there as a hired labourer. Ram Bali was the sharecropper; Moti was a labourer. From morning onward they broke off cobs and piled them in heaps.

At noon Ram Bali said, "The yield is good this year. I caught the first rain, that's why."

Moti said, "Yes."

In the evening the labourers were paid. Nihal gave Moti some money and two paseris of maize as well, because some workers had chosen part of their wages in grain. Moti carried his sack home.

Kamli spread a bamboo mat to dry the maize. While emptying the sack, Moti set aside a few well-filled, healthy cobs.

Kamli asked, "Why are those separate?"

"For seed."

"There isn't much maize in the house."

"Let these five cobs remain."

Kamli said nothing. She picked up all five and tied them to a rafter above the veranda, where the smoke would reach them and insects would be less likely to spoil them.

By then Sarita's new shoes were no longer new. The toes were scuffed and the laces had been replaced once, but the soles were sound. She continued going to school every day.

One evening in Agahan, Sarita sat studying on the veranda. Above her, the five cobs tied to the rafter swayed lightly in the moving air. She asked her father, "Aren't we going to eat those?"

Moti said, "No. Next rains, we'll put them into the earth."

Sarita looked up, then down at her shoes. A faint line of dried mud marked the black cloth.

She opened her book again.

Leaning against a post of the veranda, Moti counted the cobs tied to the rafter—one, two, three, four, five.

This time the count was small, but the seed belonged to the house.

STORY 202

The Sack of Paddy

...

In the fog of Agahan, Rambriksh Yadav's bullock cart left the village just as the eastern sky was turning pale, though there was still no sign of the sun. Thirteen sacks of paddy lay on the cart. All were tied with the same old-looking rope; only the sack at the front bore a small knot of red thread. Dulari had tied that knot the previous night so that Rambriksh would remember—before the money from this sack was spent on anything else, he was to bring home her medicine.

For three days Dulari had spent most of her time on the cot. The doctor at the village health centre had prescribed medicine for seven days. Tablets for the first three days had been available at the centre; the rest had to be bought outside. Rambriksh had thought that once the paddy was weighed at the government procurement centre, he would buy the medicine from the market on his way home. There was not enough cash in the house to buy the full course beforehand.

His seventeen-year-old son Manoj rode with him. Sitting atop the sacks, he kept watching the road appear and disappear through the mist.

“Babu, will it be weighed today?” Manoj asked.

“When our turn comes, it will.”

“Last time Ramdev Kaka had to make the trip for three days.”

Rambriksh gave the bullocks a light tap on the back. “Our paddy is dry. There is no question of making the trip for three days.”

That sentence was meant to reassure Manoj more than Rambriksh himself. Two days after the harvest there had been a light rain. Rambriksh and Dulari had together dragged the paddy beneath the veranda, then spread it in the courtyard through two days of sunshine. Every night the grain had been brought back inside in sacks. He was certain it was dry now.

The procurement centre had been set up in an open field behind the old cooperative storehouse. By the time they arrived, eight bullock carts were already lined up. One man's paddy was on the scale, another's sample was being tested, someone else's sack had split. Every now and then, husk and chaff lifted in the air and settled in people's hair and on their clothes.

Rambriksh collected the slip bearing his serial number and drew the cart into the queue. Manoj unyoked the bullocks and tied them to a post at the side.

Two hours later their turn came. An employee at the centre opened a sack, scooped a handful of grain from the top, rubbed it in his palm, then put some kernels into a small measuring device.

A number flashed on the instrument.

"It's wet," the employee said.

Rambriksh asked at once, "How much?"

The employee showed him the device, but Rambriksh did not understand what the number meant.

"We cannot take it in this condition. Dry it and bring it back."

"I have dried it in two full days of sun."

"Dry it more."

Rambriksh opened another sack. "Look at this one. The top sack may be a little damp. This is from inside the load."

The employee tested the second sample as well, then shook his head. "Take the whole consignment back."

"At least weigh the two or four sacks that are dry. I need money at home for medicine."

The employee looked first toward the queue and then at Rambriksh. "We do not take half a consignment. Those are the rules. The next cart is waiting."

Manoj was standing there. His eyes went to the sack marked with the red thread.

Rambriksh remained silent for a few moments. Then the sacks were tied shut again. As he turned the cart around, it seemed to him that all thirteen sacks were as heavy as before, and yet the cart had somehow become empty.

Two grain traders stood by the roadside outside the centre. Whenever a consignment was turned away, they stopped it. One of them came up to Rambriksh's cart and asked, "How many sacks?"

"Thirteen."

"I'll take them all. Cash, right here."

The rate he named was far below the government price. Rambriksh moved the cart on without answering.

The trader walked beside them for some distance. "The paddy is damp. I bear the cost of drying it. Then there is the weight loss on top of that."

Rambriksh said, "Will you take one sack?"

"Will I set up my scale for one sack?"

“Then leave it.”

He drove on. Manoj turned and looked back at the trader.

About half a kos farther on, a second trader came up on a bicycle and stopped the cart. “If you want to sell one sack, I’ll take one. But the rate will be no higher than his.”

Rambriksh stopped the cart. At that moment he saw in his mind the half-filled water pot beside Dulari’s cot, the bowl of thin rice gruel, and the medicine strip going empty. He looked at Manoj.

“Take down the one with the red thread.”

Manoj asked nothing. Together they lowered the sack. The scale was set up and the sack was weighed. The trader counted out the money into Rambriksh’s hand.

Rambriksh counted it twice. The amount was plainly less than what the same sack would have fetched at the government rate. He could feel the difference immediately: it was enough to contain two days’ wages.

Manoj said softly, “If we sold the rest too, the house would get all the money at once.”

Rambriksh knotted the cash into one corner of his gamchha. “One sack went because illness could not wait. The rest will not go like this.”

At the market, he bought the medicine first. Then he returned home not with an empty cart, but with twelve sacks still on it.

Dulari was sitting on the veranda. Hearing the creak of the bullock cart, she came outside. At the sight of the sacks, her eyes counted them first; only then did she notice the small paper packet in Rambriksh’s hand.

“They did not weigh it?”

“They said there was too much moisture.”

“There were thirteen sacks.”

“I sold one and brought the medicine.”

Dulari said nothing. She took the packet, looked inside, then looked at Manoj. “Did he cut the price badly?”

Rambriksh did not answer. Manoj began unyoking the bullocks.

From that afternoon onward, every task in the house changed. The courtyard was swept. Old bamboo mats, two pieces of sacking, and a torn tarpaulin were spread out. The twelve sacks were emptied one by one. A golden layer of paddy spread across the courtyard.

The sun did not appear, but there was wind. Rambriksh kept turning the paddy with a wooden plank. Barefoot, Manoj walked up and down the rows,

stirring the grain. Dulari rose from the cot and sat at the edge of the veranda, calling out from time to time, "The layer is too thick in that corner. Spread it thinner."

Rambriksh said, "You stay inside."

"Will the paddy dry if I stay inside?"

As evening came, the fog began to gather again. It was impossible to fill all the grain back into sacks.

At Manoj's suggestion, bamboo poles were planted at the four corners and the tarpaulin was stretched over them. Whatever paddy could not be brought under it was covered with the pieces of sacking.

Rambriksh rose three times during the night. The first time, the wind had lifted one corner of the tarpaulin. The second, the cow had pulled at its rope and wandered near the paddy. The third time, he merely ran a hand over the sacking to see whether dew had settled on it.

The next day the sun came out. The paddy was spread again. Dulari had taken her medicine and sat on the veranda. The exhaustion of the previous day was still on her face, but her voice was a little clearer.

At noon, their neighbour Sitaram came over. He too had brought his paddy back from the procurement centre.

"I sold two sacks to a trader," he said. "I'm drying the rest."

Rambriksh asked, "At what rate?"

The figure Sitaram named was a little lower than the rate Rambriksh had received.

"Now I understand," Sitaram said with a laugh. "Outside there is one price for moisture, and inside another price for dry paddy."

Rambriksh did not laugh. He kept turning the grain.

On the third morning he bit a kernel between his teeth. It was hard. Manoj said, "Shall we go again today?"

Rambriksh looked at the sky. The sunlight was clear. "Let's go."

This time there were twelve sacks on the cart. Rambriksh could not tell by sight whether they weighed less, but while lifting them Manoj said, "They feel lighter than yesterday."

Rambriksh replied, "The water is gone."

"Was the water being weighed too?"

Rambriksh smiled. "On the government scale, water too gets weighed as if it were paddy. But when they buy, they do not want that water."

The queue at the centre was shorter this time. The same employee took a sample again. Grain went into the measuring device. After looking at the number, he said nothing. He tested a second sack, then a third.

“It’s fine now. Put it on the scale.”

Rambriksh looked at the man’s face for a moment. He felt like bringing up what had happened the first day, but two carts were waiting behind him. He signalled to Manoj. The sacks were taken to the scale.

The twelve sacks were unloaded one by one. The figures on the scale were written down. The total weight was lower than Rambriksh’s estimate from the first day. He added it up in his head: one sack had already been sold cheaply; the remaining paddy had lost weight as it dried. The procurement-centre rate was higher, but the cart had travelled from home to the centre twice, two days of labour had been spent, and one sack had gone at an emergency price.

Manoj asked, “How much will we get this time?”

Rambriksh showed him the weight written on the paper. “Whatever is written here will come into the account. Let’s go home first.”

“But we have the medicine now.”

“Yes. That is why we can wait now.”

When they reached home, Dulari did not count the sacks first. She asked, “Was it done?”

Rambriksh said, “It was done.”

Manoj took out the weighing slip and hung it from a peg on the veranda. Dulari could not read it, but she asked the total weight. Rambriksh told her the figure.

After a moment’s thought Dulari said, “There were thirteen sacks the first day.”

“One went to the market. The rest lost water.”

“How much did we lose?”

With a finger, Rambriksh wrote two figures on the earth—on one side the estimated amount that the single sack would have fetched at the government price, on the other the cash actually received for it. Then he added the cost of making the journey twice.

Manoj sat down beside him. “That much?”

“Yes. That much.”

Dulari looked toward the packet of medicine. “And if you had not brought the medicine that day?”

Rambriksh wiped the figures from the earth with his hand. "Then it would have been a different calculation."

No one said anything more.

Four days later, the money came into the account. Rambriksh first cleared the old debt at the fertiliser seller's shop, then set aside money for salt and oil for the house. Manoj said, "Next time, after the harvest, we'll dry it for two full days before taking it."

Rambriksh said, "Who can say the weather next time will be the same?"

Dulari was folding the empty paddy sacks and stacking them on the veranda. Twelve sacks lay in one pile. The thirteenth, the one with the knot of red thread, was not there. Manoj had cut off that red thread while opening the sack on the first day and tied it to the front bamboo rail of the bullock cart.

The cart now stood outside the veranda. In the moving air, the little piece of red thread fluttered.

Rambriksh looked at it once, then went inside and took out the old register in which he kept the accounts for the next paddy season.

STORY 203

The Panchayat Hand Pump

...

It was an evening in Jeth. Four women were returning from the western hamlet with water pots balanced on their heads. The sun had gone down, but the dust was still warm. Malati's little daughter Gudiya followed behind carrying an empty lota. It was empty because, in the crowd at the distant well, she had not found a chance to fill it.

When they reached the hamlet, Malati lowered her pot onto the veranda. The ring of cloth on her head was soaked with sweat. Her mother-in-law asked, "Why so late this time?"

"The water in the well has gone down. We had to lower the rope twice over."

That same evening word came that the panchayat had sanctioned a new hand pump for the western hamlet. The boring would be done the following week. As soon as the news spread, the women first began talking about where the pump would be installed. In the middle of the hamlet, behind the pipal tree, there was an empty strip of public land where four paths met. Everyone assumed the pump would be placed there.

But on the day the boring vehicle arrived, it did not stop by the pipal tree. It drove through the gate of Navalkishore Singh's house.

Navalkishore's house stood at the edge of the hamlet: a plastered boundary wall, an iron gate, two cows, a bullock cart, and a large courtyard within. In the village, whether the matter was fertiliser bought on credit, fields given on share, or panchayat elections, people listened to his opinion on many things.

Malati and Shanti went as far as the gate. Inside, in the right-hand corner of the courtyard, the boring equipment had been set up.

Malati asked, "The hand pump will be here?"

Navalkishore said, "The soil near the pipal is loose. We'll get better water here. The gate will remain open. A panchayat hand pump will remain the panchayat's."

Shanti looked at the boundary wall. "The gate will remain yours."

Navalkishore laughed. "A gate cannot stop water."

For the first week, it truly did not. From morning till evening, the women went in, worked the pump, filled their pots, and came out. The pump yielded a

strong flow. What had taken two hours at the distant well could now be done in half an hour.

In the second week, rules began.

First it was said that the gate would not open before five in the morning. Then it was said that from one to three in the afternoon the women of the household rested, so there should be no crowd at that hour. Then, after evening, the gate began to be chained.

If someone needed one extra pot of water, the servant would ask, "What will you do with so much water?"

The first time Malati heard this, she replied, "What one does with water."

The servant laughed. Malati did not.

A few days later, Shanti's daughter-in-law returned late from the fields. There was no water left in the house. At eight that night she went to the gate. A voice from inside called, "Come tomorrow now."

She walked to the distant well. In the dark, while lowering the rope, she scraped the skin from her palm.

The next morning, showing the wound, she said, "By day the panchayat hand pump belongs to the panchayat; by night it belongs to the house."

At that sentence, everyone fell silent.

That evening nine women sat on Malati's veranda. No one made a speech. No one took out a sheet of paper. One by one they simply told what had happened to them—who had found the gate closed and when, who had been made to wait and for how long, whom the servant had questioned.

Shanti said, "We go separately, so we are given separate answers."

Malati asked, "Then?"

Renu said, "If one household is stopped, all of us must understand that all of us have been stopped."

Everyone liked that. From that day they made a rule of their own: if anyone was stopped at the gate, she would not quietly turn back. She would send word through the hamlet. Then four or five women would go back with her. No one would use kinship, wage work, or personal acquaintance to obtain a separate privilege.

The first test came two days later.

Kamli went to fetch water at half past four in the morning. She was told to wait until five. Kamli turned back and went to Malati's house. Within ten minutes, five women were standing at the gate.

Navalkishore himself came out. "Why are all of you here so early?"

Malati said, "If the water of one household is stopped, our water is stopped."
 "Fill your pots from five."

Shanti asked, "What about those who leave for wage work at four?"

Navalkishore said, "Then fill your water at night and keep it ready."

Kamli showed him her scraped palm. "The gate is closed at night."

Irritation came over Navalkishore's face. "This is a house, not an inn."

Malati answered quietly, "We too have houses. The hand pump belongs to the panchayat."

The matter stopped there. At five the gate opened. Everyone filled her water and went home.

Over the next few days there was no open clash, but the rules did not change. The women did not abandon their rule either. Whenever one of them was stopped, a group formed. Those inside the gate understood that telling one woman, "Come tomorrow," could now turn into questions from five women.

On the day the first clouds of Ashadh gathered, it was time to pull up the mung crop in Navalkishore's field. The crop was ready. As he watched the clouds, his worry grew. If rain came, the dry pods in the field could get wet and turn black.

He needed many hands the next morning. The women of the western hamlet knew well how to pull up mung and bind it into bundles. That evening Navalkishore's servant came with a message: "Reach the field at four in the morning. You will receive the full wage."

Malati asked, "At four?"

"Yes. There are clouds."

Shanti, who was sitting there too, said, "And water for the house before four?"

The servant said nothing.

Malati said, "Tell Naval Babu—first water, then the field."

A little later Navalkishore came himself. "Tomorrow, for one day, the gate will open at half past three. All of you fill your water and come to the field at four."

Renu asked, "And the day after tomorrow?"

Navalkishore understood where the question was leading. "The day after tomorrow, the usual hours again."

Malati said, "Then opening it tomorrow is not our right. It is a convenience for your crop."

Navalkishore's voice hardened. "Do you want the wages or not?"

Shanti replied, "We do. Do you want labourers or not?"

For two moments no one spoke.

Thunder sounded in the distance.

Navalkishore asked, "What is it that all of you want?"

Malati gave the answer she had already thought through. "Once the hand pump is here, there should be no restriction on the time when the gate may be used. Anyone who comes as far as the pump should not have to ask anyone's permission. Your house is farther inside; we will not go into it. We ourselves will keep the place around the pump clean."

"Open at night too?"

"At night too. Thirst does not look at the hour before it comes."

Navalkishore looked toward the boundary wall. The hand pump was not very far inside the gate. To the right was the cowshed, to the left the veranda. The women of his household objected mainly because strangers moved through the courtyard all day.

His wife Vimla had been listening from the veranda. She did not come outside, but called from within, "If a bamboo screen is put up between the pump and the veranda, the inner part of the house will be hidden."

Navalkishore turned and looked inside. "A screen?"

"The old bamboo from the cowshed is lying there."

Malati said nothing. This was a solution the household itself had offered.

Navalkishore looked at the women again. "The ground around a hand pump turns muddy. Who will keep it clean?"

Renu said, "We will. One of the seven households each day. But the chain will not be put on."

"If the gate remains open, the cows will get out."

Shanti said, "Tie the cows separately in the cowshed. A panchayat hand pump is not there to guard cows."

Vimla's laughter came from inside. Navalkishore looked toward her, then toward the clouds.

"All right," he said at last. "From tomorrow the corner with the hand pump will remain open. The inner veranda will be screened off with bamboo. No one is to go beyond the screen."

Malati replied, "We will go as far as the hand pump for water. What business would we have beyond the screen?"

The next morning the gate opened at half past three. This time, however, it was not merely for one day. A new bamboo screen stood beside the cowshed.

From the hand pump, the inner veranda could no longer be seen. The chain of the gate had been hung on a nail above it.

The women filled their water quickly. By four o'clock, twelve women were walking toward Navalkishore's field.

The rain came after noon. By then much of the mung had already been pulled up and tied into bundles. Some of it got wet, but not the whole crop.

That day, when the wages were paid, Navalkishore paid the ordinary rate. No one raised the matter of the hand pump. The women too counted their wages and went home. In the first week, the new arrangement was tested twice. One night a guest arrived late at Kamli's house; at nine she went to fetch water. The gate was open. The next afternoon Rekha's daughter filled two extra pots to wash clothes. No one asked, "Why so much water?" The women kept their turns for cleaning. Mud around the pump was removed, broken bricks were laid down, and whenever the handle grew loose it was tightened in time. Sometimes Vimla too would leave the sweepings from inside outside to be taken away; around the hand pump now, the rhythms of the household and the hamlet had begun to fit together.

A month later Malati came at dawn to fetch water. The old iron chain of the gate still hung from the same nail above. A light film of rust had begun to form on it. As Gudiya worked the handle, she asked, "Ma, why don't they use this chain anymore?" Malati steadied the pot and said, "If they use it, it will have to be opened again." Gudiya did not fully understand what the answer meant. She pressed the handle once more. Water came from the pump. On the other side of the bamboo screen, the household's morning was beginning; on this side, the hamlet was filling its pots. The chain hung silently on the nail.

STORY 204

The Price of the Ox

...

On an Ashwin morning, beside the tethering post in the cattle shed, Basant kept lifting his left foreleg and setting it down again. The night dew had left the earth damp, yet the round mark around his hoof showed up sharply, like a crack in dry soil. Dukhna Yadav watched from a distance. He held a sickle for cutting paddy leaves, but his eyes remained fixed on the ox's leg.

Basant had been in the household for twelve years. Once his hide had shone, his neck had been thick, and the tips of his horns had risen proudly upward. Now the bones of his back stood out clearly. Near the base of his right horn, an old scrape had turned white. The previous winter his leg had swollen while pulling the plough, and since then heavy work had stopped.

Dukhna's son Kishun called from the courtyard, "Babu, Ramsevak will come again today. Yesterday he said that if the price is not settled this time, he'll look for another ox."

Dukhna gave no reply. He scattered two handfuls of bran over the dry straw in Basant's manger. Basant slowly stretched his muzzle toward it.

The household accounts were not simple. The kharif paddy had been good, but half the crop had gone in sharecropping. The cow at home gave milk and needed her own supply of straw. The tractor owner wanted an advance for the rabi ploughing. The old plough and yoke were now useful only for small patches because Basant's partner had died two years earlier. By the time a neighbour's ox could be borrowed to make a pair, ploughing was often delayed.

Three days earlier Kishun had worked out the figures on paper. Adding three months of Basant's straw, fodder, bran and oilcake, he had said, "With this much, we can buy wheat seed for half a bigha and pay for the first irrigation as well. The ox no longer ploughs the field. If we sell him, the rabi crop will be saved."

Dukhna had not looked at the paper. He had asked only, "Who will take him?"

"Ramsevak. He drives a small cart. He says he'll keep the loads light."

"Saying it and doing it are not the same thing."

Kishun had fallen silent. He understood his father's heart, but he understood the household expenses too.

Ramsevak arrived later in the morning with his seventeen-year-old son, Bhola. First Ramsevak examined Basant's teeth, then pressed his leg. Basant jerked the leg away.

"He is old," Ramsevak said, "but he can still pull a light cart. I take vegetables to the market. There'll be no heavy loads."

Kishun asked, "The price?"

Ramsevak offered six thousand. Kishun asked for eight. Between them, the bargaining stalled at seven.

Dukhna had not spoken a single word. He went out to look at Ramsevak's cart. The wheels were old, but fresh oil gleamed on the axle. The wood inside the yoke had been smoothed down. Behind the cart he saw the light bamboo baskets used for carrying cauliflower, aubergines and greens.

"How many trips in a day?" Dukhna asked.

"Once to the market, once back. Rest in between."

"Don't beat him."

Ramsevak was about to laugh, but stopped when he saw Dukhna's face. "What work will I get out of an old ox by beating him? If his leg gives way, the loss will be mine."

For the first time Dukhna looked straight into Ramsevak's eyes. There was less tenderness than calculation in the man's words; yet for Dukhna, that very calculation offered a small foothold for trust. A man who regarded injury to the animal's leg as his own loss would, at the very least, try to preserve that leg.

The price was finally settled at seven thousand five hundred rupees. Ramsevak paid two thousand in advance and said he would bring the balance in the evening, then left with the cart.

The money was not handed to Dukhna; Kishun took it. From the two thousand he sent five hundred to the tractor owner. The remaining fifteen hundred went into the iron chest at home.

Dukhna returned to the cattle shed and took down Basant's old yoke to examine it. On the inside, its right half was far more worn. In a pair, Basant had always walked on the right. The pressure of his neck had hollowed a smooth groove into the wood. Dukhna ran his thumb through it.

He could not count how many fields had been ploughed under that yoke. Yet certain scenes rose by themselves: the cart loaded with river sand when the new house was being built; the journey back from the market on the day they bought their first cow; a winter morning when sacks of paddy had lain too long in the threshing ground and clouds had risen at night—Basant and his partner had made three trips and brought the sacks home.

Dukhna did not call such memories 'favours'. The ox was an animal of the household; work had been his share of household life. But now that a price had been fixed, it seemed that against twelve years of work, seven thousand five hundred was only a number from the marketplace.

At midday, while serving rice on a leaf plate, Dukhna's wife Phulo asked, "So the sale is settled?"

"The price is settled."

"Are the two the same thing?"

Dukhna remained silent.

Washing her hands, Phulo said, "My heart feels heavy too. But the cow needs straw, and the rabi field needs ploughing. If we keep Basant now, we'll keep him only for the sake of the heart. The heart does not grow straw."

Dukhna looked at his wife. The words were hard, but her voice was not.

"Have you seen Ramsevak's cattle shed?" Phulo asked.

"No."

"Then the price is settled. The sale is not."

For the first time Dukhna smiled faintly.

Before evening he took Kishun with him to Ramsevak's house. Ramsevak was surprised. "I was just about to bring the money to you."

Dukhna said, "First I'll see the cattle shed."

Ramsevak's house stood at the western edge of the village. The small cattle shed was enclosed with reed matting and half covered by a tiled roof. A young ox was already there. The manger was clean and the water vessel full. Beside it, a thick tether lay in place of an old rope.

Dukhna squatted on the ground and checked the height of the manger. Basant's neck now bent lower; a very high manger would trouble him. This one was low.

"Will you yoke both of them to the same cart?"

Ramsevak said, "For the first two or three days I'll make them walk together. If the old one gets tired, he'll do only one trip. My son will push from behind."

Bhola immediately added, "I keep a bucket of water in the cart."

Kishun looked at Bhola. The two were nearly the same age.

Dukhna stood up. "All right. One more thing. For the first seven days Kishun will come in the evening and look in—whether Basant is eating, whether his leg is swelling."

Ramsevak nodded. "Who would stop him from coming to see?"

Kishun broke in, "That condition wasn't part of the price."

Dukhna turned toward his son. "The price is for the ox. The condition is for my debt."

Kishun said nothing.

In the evening Ramsevak came with the full amount. Dukhna counted the notes. Seven thousand five hundred, complete. He separated five hundred rupees and held them out to Ramsevak.

"Keep this."

Ramsevak started. "Why?"

"For bran and oilcake in the first month."

"I can buy that myself."

"I know. This is not a reduction in the price. Just don't change Basant's old feed all at once."

Ramsevak did not want to take the notes, but Dukhna placed them in his palm. The sale had, in effect, come down to seven thousand. For a moment displeasure showed on Kishun's face. Five hundred rupees was no small sum in the household accounts.

Basant's tether was untied. Dukhna did not fasten the old bell around his neck with his own hands; instead, he removed it and hung it from the post. "This belongs to the house," he said. "Let the new place have a new sound."

Ramsevak led Basant away. Basant took two steps and paused once because his hoof caught on a small rise in the earth outside the courtyard. Bhola immediately slackened the rope. Basant moved on again. He did not look back. Dukhna did not call to him either.

Kishun sat on the veranda counting the money. Of the seven thousand rupees left, three thousand went toward the tractor advance and arrears, two thousand was set aside for wheat seed and fertiliser, and the remaining two thousand for household expenses.

Dukhna listened to the account. "The rabi field will be ploughed on time?"

"Yes."

"Then it is all right."

The next morning the tractor came to the field. Its growl carried a long way. Dukhna stood on the embankment and watched the soil turn over. The field Basant had ploughed again and again over twelve years was turned in two hours. The work was done quickly; Dukhna's heart did not grow light, but the reason for the decision stood clearly before him.

For seven days Kishun went to Ramsevak's house every evening. On the first day Basant was slow to eat. On the third there was no swelling in his leg. On the

fifth he went to the market in a lightly loaded cart and was walked unyoked for half the return journey. On the seventh day Kishun came back and said, "He's all right. Bhola really does keep water with him."

Dukhna said only, "Hmm." After that Kishun did not go every day.

A month later, at the Agahan market, Dukhna saw Ramsevak's cart. It carried five baskets of cauliflower and two baskets of greens. Basant was yoked on the right, beside the young ox. His gait was slow but even. Near the market Ramsevak unyoked them both, and Bhola gave them water from a bucket.

Dukhna watched from a distance. Basant did not see him—or, if he did, gave no sign. This time Dukhna was glad of it. The animal had found a new routine; he did not have to carry the debt of the old household with him.

On his way home, Dukhna took down the old bell hanging by the cattle-shed post. He wiped away the dust and set the bell on top of the yoke. Outside, a sack of wheat seed had been opened for sowing. Kishun called to him to come to the field.

Dukhna picked up the sickle and went out. The cattle shed was empty, but now the manger held only as much straw as the cow could eat by evening.

STORY 205

Wages

...

At dawn in Phagun, the earth at the brick kiln was still damp with the night's dew. To the east, a long plume of smoke rose and dissolved into the pale sky. In the grey light, the rows of unbaked bricks looked as though enormous rectangular grids had been drawn upon the ground.

Ramphal Sada pressed the wooden mould into the clay and lifted it away. His wife, Jasoda, packed in the wet earth. Their fourteen-year-old son, Bhola, picked up the bricks released from the mould and laid them in rows. Twelve-year-old Chanda had once helped with the same work, but for the past three weeks she had begun attending a temporary school that ran for two hours every evening beside the kiln.

That morning Chanda was not carrying bricks. In her hand were half a broken pencil and an old slate. She sat at the head of the rows, counting the bricks twenty at a time.

"Five rows done?" Ramphal asked.

"Five rows make one hundred," Chanda said. "It is four hundred and eighty now."

Bhola burst out laughing. "Are we here to make bricks, or to sit your examination?"

Chanda wrote 480 on the slate. "Both."

Ramphal laughed too, but Jasoda did not. She was pleased that Chanda went to the evening school. During their first month at the kiln, Chanda had carried clay all day. Then, one day, a teacher from the nearby primary school had come to the kiln. She had said that for children unable to attend school during the day, there would be evening classes in letters and numbers. Ramphal had initially brushed the idea aside. Jasoda had said, "She will carry less clay for two hours, but she will learn something."

In three weeks Chanda had moved beyond addition and subtraction and was learning multiplication. Numbers felt like a game to her—especially zero. The teacher had explained that when the place value changed, one added a zero: zero was nothing in itself, yet by changing its place it could change the value. Chanda had liked that thought very much.

At the kiln, wages were paid by the thousand bricks. At the beginning of the work period, the contractor had told Ramphal: lay one thousand unbaked bricks and the payment would be six hundred rupees. The work of the whole family would be counted together. Advances, grain and oil taken on credit would be deducted in the final settlement.

Ramphal understood "six hundred." He understood "one thousand" as well. But when the bricks made through the day, the broken bricks, advances, ration credit and weekly payments were all entered together in the ledger, his eyes grew tired. Every evening Harinarayan, who kept the accounts, took small wooden tokens from a red cloth pouch. One token stood for one thousand bricks.

That evening Harinarayan came to Ramphal's section. He looked over the rows of unbaked bricks, measured the spacing at two or three places with his foot, and said, "One thousand complete. The rest tomorrow."

He gave Ramphal one token.

Chanda looked at her slate. It said 1,360.

"Three hundred and sixty?" she asked.

Harinarayan looked at her. "The rest will be added tomorrow."

Below 1,360, Chanda wrote in small letters: "Token 1, remainder 360."

The next day they made 1,420 bricks. In the evening, again, there was one token.

Chanda asked, "Yesterday's three hundred and sixty plus today's four hundred and twenty makes seven hundred and eighty. Where is that written?"

Harinarayan laughed. "Girl, mind your lessons. This is the kiln's accounting."

Ramphal said at once, "Be quiet, Chanda. The people who run the work know the accounts."

Chanda fell silent. On the slate she wrote: "Remainder 780?"

She had only recently learned the question mark.

On the third day there was a light shower. The family hurried to cover the rows with straw so the unbaked bricks would be saved. They made 1,380 bricks that day. Harinarayan again gave one token.

Chanda asked nothing. She only added: 780 and 380—1,160.

By her reckoning, another full thousand had now been completed, with one hundred and sixty left over.

But there were only three wooden tokens.

That night Jasoda sat by the hearth baking rotis. Chanda placed the slate before her.

“Ma, look at this.”

Jasoda could recognise the numerals, but she could not add them. “What am I supposed to see?”

Chanda showed her the entries for the three days. “We have made four thousand one hundred and sixty bricks. The tokens account for three thousand.”

Ramphal heard from outside and came in. “Broken bricks are deducted.”

Chanda said, “The broken ones are in a separate heap. I have not counted them.”

“Then they must know.”

“Shouldn’t we know too?”

Ramphal picked up the slate and looked at it. To him the numerals were signs whose meaning he did not fully command. It was easier to trust Harinarayan’s ledger than Chanda’s small slate. The ledger was thick, bound in covers, and Harinarayan walked about with a pen tucked behind his ear. One corner of Chanda’s slate was broken.

Ramphal handed the slate back. “Count again tomorrow. But do not quarrel with anyone.”

For the next four days Chanda did not quarrel. She only counted.

1,540. 1,290. 1,480. 1,000.

The seven-day total came to 9,470.

Tokens—7.

This time Chanda took her slate to her teacher, Neelam. Neelam checked the addition once more.

“Your addition is correct.”

“Then where did two thousand four hundred and seventy bricks go?”

Neelam did not answer at once. She asked, “How did you count these numbers?”

Chanda explained the arrangement of the rows—twenty in one row, five rows to one hundred; broken bricks separated after they were made. Neelam said, “Look only at your own family’s account. Do not draw conclusions about anyone else. And do not call anyone a thief without proof.”

Chanda had not used the word “thief,” but her face grew hot.

The next day she said to Ramphal, “Will you agree to one thing today?”

“Say it. What is it?”

“After one thousand is complete, let us keep the leftover bricks in a separate row.”

Ramphal scratched his head. “That will take space.”

“For one day.”

Jasoda said, “Let her do it.”

That day the family made 1,260 bricks. The first thousand were laid in the usual rows. Chanda placed the remaining 260 in two short rows apart from the rest. On the corner of the first brick she made a small circular mark with her finger.

In the evening Harinarayan gave them one token.

“These two hundred and sixty tomorrow?” Chanda asked.

“Yes, tomorrow.”

The next day the family made 1,480 bricks. Chanda combined the previous day’s 260 with the first 740 of the new day and said to Ramphal, “This is one thousand complete.”

This time Ramphal counted them himself. Twenty to a row. Five rows to one hundred. One hundred ten times. Exactly one thousand.

The remaining 740 from the new day stayed separate.

In the evening Harinarayan came. He counted the new day’s rows and gave one token.

Ramphal asked, “And the token for this separate thousand?”

Harinarayan’s eyes went to the brick with the circular mark. “That was yesterday’s remainder.”

“Yesterday you said it would be added today.”

“It must have been added.”

“Where is it written?”

Harinarayan opened the ledger. Beside Ramphal’s name were seven short strokes. He had just drawn the eighth.

“See? Everything is written.”

Chanda did not bend over the ledger. She pointed instead to the separate thousand bricks on the ground. “Which stroke is for this thousand?”

Harinarayan’s voice hardened. “Will a child teach me accounts?”

Ramphal would normally have silenced her, but this time he had counted that separate thousand himself. He said, “Not the child. I counted these bricks.”

Two families working nearby stopped and began listening. Jasoda said quietly, “Ask about our account first, not theirs.”

Ramphal did just that. “Today we need two tokens. One for the new thousand, and one for the thousand completed by combining yesterday’s and today’s remainder. Seven hundred and four ten—” He stopped.

Chanda corrected him softly, “Seven hundred and forty.”

Ramphal repeated, “Seven hundred and forty will remain for tomorrow.”

Harinarayan shut the ledger. “Speak to the owner.”

The kiln owner arrived after dusk. His name was Shivkant Chaudhary. He first heard Harinarayan, then Ramphal. At last he looked at Chanda’s slate—the numbers for seven days, the number of tokens, and the total written below.

“Are the bricks for all those days still separately identifiable?” he asked.

Chanda said, “Not for the first seven days. Today’s and yesterday’s are.”

Shivkant had the separate thousand counted again. This time Harinarayan did not count them; two labourers did. The full thousand was there.

Harinarayan said, “If we keep every day’s remainder separate, the whole yard will fill up.”

For the first time Chanda spoke in front of the owner. “There is no need to keep them separate. Write the remainder on paper. Add it the next day.”

Harinarayan looked at her.

Shivkant asked, “Where did you learn this?”

“At the evening school.”

“Multiplication too?”

“I am learning it now.”

Shivkant did not smile. He turned to Ramphal. “The heaps from the previous seven days have been mixed. A complete verification is difficult now.”

Ramphal’s face tightened.

“But the thousand from yesterday and today is clear,” Shivkant continued. “Give them its token. From now on, the remainder will be entered in the ledger.”

“And the old amount?” Jasoda asked.

Shivkant was silent for a moment. “Whatever can be proved with certainty will be added. I will not reopen the previous month merely on someone’s word.”

It was not complete justice. Ramphal understood that. Jasoda did too. Chanda understood it most clearly of all—9,470 still stood on her slate, but the bricks from those first seven days had already been mixed among the rows of other families, and the proof was gone.

That night eight families from the kiln gathered outside Ramphal's hut, bringing their wooden tokens and whatever estimates they had of the day's work. Chanda did not make anyone's account for them. She only kept asking, "How many full thousands today? What was the remainder?" Where someone did not know, she left a blank beside the name.

The next morning, before beginning work, all eight families said that the remainder must first be written down.

For half an hour the moulds lay empty.

The clay was ready. The carts had already unloaded earth. The sun was climbing. If the prepared clay lay too long, its moisture would change. Shivkant came again.

This time the new arrangement was simple. Beside Ramphal's name in the ledger, two columns were made: "Full thousands" and "Remainder." The wooden tokens remained as before, but at the end of each day the remainder was spoken aloud and entered in front of the labourer. The next day's first count began from that same remainder.

On the first day under the new system, Ramphal's ledger read: full thousands 1, remainder 740.

On the second new day they made 1,310 bricks. Add 740 and the total was 2,050. They received two tokens. Remainder 50.

Ramphal stood for a long while looking at the tokens in his hand. Then he gave them to Chanda.

"Count."

Chanda counted the two tokens. "Two."

"What is the remainder?"

"Fifty."

Ramphal looked at Harinarayan. "Is fifty written?"

Harinarayan turned the ledger around and showed him. 50 was written there.

At the end of that week, the wages for the clearly verified thousand from the two disputed days were added separately. The full discrepancy from the old seven days was never recovered. Shivkant added the money corresponding to the two days for which there was clear proof; about the rest he said, "There is no count."

Ramphal argued, but after half an hour he fell silent. He knew that some of the money had again been buried in the clay. But this time he knew where the clay was.

At the evening school, Neelam looked at Chanda's slate. The old line, 9,470, was still there. Beneath it Chanda had written the new calculation:

$$\begin{array}{rcccccc} 740 & & + & & 1,310 & = & 2,050 \\ 2 & & & & & & \text{thousand} \\ \text{Remainder } 50 & & & & & & \end{array}$$

Neelam asked, "Now do you understand how zero changes place?"

Chanda smiled. "Not zero. The remainder changes."

On the way home she put the slate into her cloth bag. At the kiln, Ramphal and Jasoda were covering the clay for the next day. Bhola was washing the empty moulds.

In the distance Harinarayan sat at his table closing the ledger. Beside Ramphal's name, the words "Remainder 50" remained written.

Chanda read the number once. Fifty was not a very large number. But for the first time, it had not disappeared anywhere.

STORY 206

The Aadhaar Thumbprint

...

The morning sun had not yet reached the tin awning of the ration shop, but a queue had already formed in front of it. Some people carried cloth bags, some old sacks, some brass measures. Phulmanti Devi stood quietly with a small cloth pouch pressed under her arm. Inside it were a thin Aadhaar card, the ration slip, and two one-rupee coins.

When her turn came, the shopkeeper, Ghanshyam, looked at the register.

“Phulmanti Devi?”

“Yes.”

“Place your thumb here.”

Phulmanti placed her right thumb on the glass of the fingerprint device lying on the table. A small light came on and went out. Ghanshyam said again, “A little straighter.”

Phulmanti tried again.

The device rejected it again.

“Left thumb.”

That failed too.

Then, one by one, the other fingers were tried. The pads of Phulmanti’s fingers had grown smooth. Sixty-five years had passed transplanting paddy, cutting hemp, patting cow-dung cakes into shape, kneading wet earth. The ridges were now so faint that though her hand rested on the glass, the machine seemed to read an empty space.

The queue behind her was growing.

Ghanshyam wiped the glass of the device with a cloth. “One more time.”

Phulmanti placed her thumb on it.

Failure again.

Ramcharit Paswan, standing behind her, had been watching everything. His bag was torn halfway through, an old gamchha wrapped around his head. There were four people in his household. The previous week his younger son had only just recovered from fever; at home, even the rice was being measured out carefully from meal to meal.

Ghanshyam said quietly, "It isn't working today. The day after tomorrow is the exception-verification day. We'll try another method then."

Phulmanti understood, but did not move the pouch from under her arm.

"I won't get the grain today?"

"Unless your name opens on this machine, I cannot record the distribution."

The shop assistant, Lalan, looked toward the queue. The crowd was increasing. He knew Ramcharit. Coming close, he said softly, "Your thumb reads well. Let me issue your grain first; then we'll think of something."

When Ramcharit's turn came, he placed his thumb on the device. The light turned green on the first attempt. His rice and wheat were weighed out. As he tied his bag, Lalan leaned near his ear and said,

"There is one way. We can give the old mother her grain now. You put your thumb again. I'll balance the account later."

Ramcharit's hand stopped on the knot of his bag.

"Her grain against my thumb?"

"Would you send her home hungry? We'll set the accounts right later."

Phulmanti stood holding her pouch in both hands. She had not heard the whole conversation, but she kept looking at Ramcharit's face.

Ramcharit's first thought was not pity. His first thought was that it would be easy. He would place his thumb, the old mother would take the grain, and the crowd would move on.

The second thought came at once: against whose grain would his thumb now be recorded? And what if, next time, the quantity allotted to his own family appeared reduced? Lalan was saying that the account would be adjusted, but once a line had been entered on paper, who would ever understand whose line it was?

Ramcharit lifted his bag.

"No," he said.

Lalan was startled. "The old mother will get her grain."

"But the thumb will be mine."

"Then?"

Ramcharit did not answer. He went over to Phulmanti.

"Mother, can you come again the day after tomorrow?"

Phulmanti did not smile. "If my legs carry me, I'll come. But there is only enough rice at home for tonight."

The bag under Ramcharit's arm suddenly felt heavy.

The road home was half a kos. Phulmanti walked slowly. Ramcharit would go a little ahead, then stop. Twice he offered to carry her bag; Phulmanti refused.

Ramcharit's house came first, near the pipal tree in the middle of the village. He asked Phulmanti to sit on the veranda.

Ramcharit's wife, Basanti, came out from the kitchen. "Back so soon?"

Ramcharit opened his bag. He did not at once divide the newly issued rice in half. First he checked what remained in the earthen storage bin at home. There were about two seers of rice at the bottom. With the new rice added, the household could manage for two weeks—if no one fell ill, if no guest arrived, if wage work did not stop in between.

He took out the brass measure.

Basanti understood. "How much will you give?"

"Two seers."

"And our house?"

"Until the day after tomorrow."

Basanti looked at Phulmanti. The old woman sat at the edge of the veranda as though the conversation were not about her.

Basanti was silent for a few moments. "Write it down as a loan."

Ramcharit looked at her.

"If you call it charity, Mother won't take it," Basanti said.

Phulmanti spoke at once. "I won't take charity."

Ramcharit laughed. "A loan. Two seers. When you get your grain the day after tomorrow, return it."

Phulmanti opened her pouch and tried to take out the two coins.

Basanti closed her hand around them. "This rice is not for sale."

Two seers of rice went into Phulmanti's bag. On an old wooden board, Ramcharit wrote in chalk: "Phulmanti—2 seers." He hung the board from a beam in the kitchen.

"Why is there any need to write so much?" Phulmanti asked.

"So that it does not turn into charity."

For the first time Phulmanti gave a faint smile.

That night Ramcharit lay awake for a long time. His younger son turned in his sleep and asked for water. Basanti opened the grain bin and looked at the measure of rice inside.

"What if the machine still does not read her the day after tomorrow?"

Ramcharit said, "Then the account of two seers will run longer."

“If you had simply put your thumb on it, she would have received her grain today.”

After a while Ramcharit said, “She would have received it today, but tomorrow the paper would say that my thumb was her stomach. I did not like that.”

Basanti kept gathering the ash from the hearth. She neither agreed nor objected.

The day after tomorrow, Ramcharit reached Phulmanti’s house at dawn. That day he was supposed to get work cutting earth beside the river. If he missed half the day, half a day’s wages would be lost. Before he left home, Basanti had counted it out plainly: if he earned a full day’s wage, they could buy oil, salt, and medicine for the younger boy that evening; if half the wage was lost, the oil would have to wait until the following week.

Ramcharit stood at the doorway for a few moments. To him this was not a matter that could be settled simply by saying, “She is a neighbour.” The needs of his own household were real too. Phulmanti came out leaning on her stick and said, “Why should you come? I can get there. Yesterday you gave me two seers; today will you lose half a day’s work as well?”

Ramcharit took his spade down from the beam, then hung it back again. “The earth will still be there to cut half a day later. If your finger fails again, there should be someone with you to hear what is said.”

There were fewer people at the shop that day. A block-office employee sat with Ghanshyam. The names of those whose fingerprints repeatedly failed were being entered on a separate sheet. The employee matched Phulmanti’s Aadhaar number, checked her previous distribution record, and then another method of verification was tried.

Phulmanti’s thumb failed again.

Her aged fingers too were placed on the glass, one after another, but the light turned red each time.

The employee said, “The ridges on the fingers have worn down. In this situation we will use alternative verification.”

Ramcharit listened carefully. He did not fully understand how many rules the process contained. But this time no one asked for his thumb.

After a while, distribution was approved against Phulmanti’s name. Ghanshyam opened the sack. Rice was weighed out, then wheat. When Phulmanti tried to lift the bag, Ramcharit picked it up and carried it outside.

Lalan stood by a post of the shop. Smiling, he said, “See? It only took two days longer.”

Ramcharit replied, "It took longer, but each thumb remained its own."

Lalan's smile faded. There was no argument.

On the road Phulmanti stopped Ramcharit. "Your house first."

"Let us get your grain home first."

"I owe two seers."

"Give it in the evening."

"A loan does not have an evening."

They reached Ramcharit's house. Basanti brought out the brass measure. From her newly received rice Phulmanti measured two seers and placed it before the storage bin. She tried to add one extra handful on top.

Basanti stopped her hand. "Two seers are written."

Phulmanti let the handful fall back into her own bag.

Ramcharit took down the wooden board. Across the line "Phulmanti—2 seers," he drew one straight stroke of chalk.

Phulmanti asked, "Why don't you erase it?"

Ramcharit hung the board back from the beam. "There are other accounts written on it. I'll erase it this evening."

Phulmanti lifted her bag. Ramcharit walked with her as far as the doorway.

That evening he returned home with half a day's wages from cutting earth. The money was less. Basanti counted it and put it in the kitchen tin. No one came to praise the decision. Phulmanti did not come to offer thanks either.

On the next month's distribution day, Ramcharit stood in the queue when his turn came. Phulmanti was ahead of him. Her thumb again failed on the first attempt. Without fuss, Ghanshyam took out the sheet for alternative verification.

Ramcharit set his bag on the ground.

Phulmanti turned back and said, "Keep an eye on your own bag. I'll look after my turn now."

Ramcharit laughed and remained standing in the queue.

The glass of the device on the table shone. The ridges of Phulmanti's thumb were still faint. Ramcharit stood in the queue with his hand resting on the knot of his own bag; his thumb remained far from the machine.

STORY 207

The Maize Field

...

The Bhadon night was cloudless, but the air was heavy. Whenever the maize leaves rubbed against one another, a rustling ran far across the field. At the far edge of Barail village lay fourteen kathas of land belonging to Maheshwar Mahato. South of the field was a belt of scrub, and beyond it an old drainage channel. For three nights, wild boars had been coming in from that side.

Maheshwar sat on a bamboo watch-platform in the middle of the field. Beside him lay a stout bamboo staff, an old iron plate, and two handfuls of dry clods of earth. In the other corner of the platform his sixteen-year-old son Ratan sat with his knees drawn up. In the light of a small lantern, his practice notebook lay open.

Maheshwar said quietly, “The rustle of pages muffles what the ears need to hear.”

Ratan held the page still. “My mathematics test is tomorrow, Babu.”

“The test will be in the daytime. The field is here at night.”

“School by day, work at home in the evening, the field at night—when am I supposed to study?”

Maheshwar did not answer. He kept looking towards the darkness in the south.

The first boars had entered the previous Monday. Seven plants had been uprooted. On the second night five cobs were found half-eaten. On the third night Maheshwar had heard them and reached the field in time, but one row had still been trampled. The maize was not yet fully ripe. The kernels were between the milky stage and hardness; it was precisely then that wild boars came most eagerly for the grain.

That year Maheshwar had sold the paddy left in the house to buy fertiliser for this field. Twice he had hired labourers for weeding. Because he no longer owned a pair of bullocks, the first ploughing had been done by tractor. These fourteen kathas of maize were not merely cobs to him; they were the household’s assurance of expenses until Agahan.

Ratan’s Class Ten examinations were also close. For two weeks the teachers at school had been giving practice tests. Ratan had not spoken at first of bringing his books to the watch-platform at night. The first night he had only

kept watch. On the second, when his eyes kept closing again and again, he brought a book so that reading might help him stay awake.

Maheshwar did not like the arrangement.

“You cannot study while keeping watch,” he said.

Ratan answered softly, “And my studies cannot continue if I leave the books and spend the nights keeping watch.”

Maheshwar’s hand tightened around the staff. “If the field is not saved, where will I get the money for your studies?”

Ratan closed the notebook. His voice was clear in the darkness. “To save my studies I watch the field, and to save the field I give up my studies—this arithmetic makes no sense to me.”

Maheshwar turned sharply towards him. “You have begun to understand a great deal of arithmetic.”

At that very moment the leaves to the south moved all at once.

Maheshwar sprang up. He struck the iron plate with his staff—clang, clang, clang. Ratan lowered the lantern wick and slipped his notebook into the cloth bag. A heavy rustling came from the side of the channel. Maheshwar climbed down from the platform and ran south.

“Stay where you are!” he called to Ratan.

But Ratan climbed down on the other side. Running along the field ridge, he reached the eastern edge and began beating the leaves with a bamboo pole. In the darkness three dense shadows broke through the rows and fled towards the channel. One smaller boar turned back in the middle; Maheshwar hurled a clod of earth. It missed, but the animal too veered towards the scrub.

Ten minutes later the field was quiet again.

Maheshwar lifted the lantern and examined the southern rows. Eleven plants were bent over. Three cobs had broken off and lay on the ground. He picked one up and pressed a kernel. Instead of milk, thick sap came out.

“See?” he said. “You kept your eyes buried in that book for so long.”

Ratan was still breathing hard. “The book was already closed when the boars came.”

“I heard the leaves first.”

“Then why did you not stop them?”

Maheshwar fell silent.

Ratan sat down beside a broken plant. “Babu, I am not running away from the work of the field. I will work in the daytime. I will be here for the harvest. I

was here for the weeding. But if I sit here every night, my examinations will suffer.”

Maheshwar said, “Farming watches day and night. It does not look at the clock.”

Ratan replied, “The school will hold its examination on its own day too. It will not change the date because of the field.”

They climbed back onto the platform. This time Ratan did not open the notebook. The lantern remained between them. No boar came again during the rest of the night, but neither of them slept properly.

In the first light of dawn Maheshwar walked around the field. The two rows along the southern edge bore the most marks. The scrub stood so close to the field that the boars could slip in under cover of the leaves and become visible from the platform only when they were already inside.

Ratan went home. Before leaving for school he still had to bathe, eat rice, and go over two chapters of mathematics once more.

Maheshwar remained in the field.

When the sun rose higher, he began examining the cobs on the first southern row one by one. Some had already filled out completely; others were still soft. They needed another eight or ten days to ripen fully. He sat for a long time on the ridge, looking at the distance between the drainage channel, the scrub, and the watch-platform.

When he reached home at midday, Pano Devi asked, “How much went again today?”

“Eleven plants.”

“Will Ratan go again tomorrow?”

Maheshwar drank water from the earthen pitcher and said, “No.”

Pano Devi understood that he was speaking out of anger. She said nothing.

That afternoon Maheshwar returned to the field with a sickle. He began cutting the cobs from the first two southern rows that were mature enough to be sold as green maize in the market. He left the very soft ones. Those whose kernels had filled out he piled together.

When Ratan came back from school, he found his father cutting cobs.

“Already?” he asked in surprise.

Maheshwar cut through a leaf with the sickle. “If they ripen fully they will fetch a better price. But if the southern strip is opened up, I will be able to see the scrub clearly from the platform.”

Ratan looked at the pile. “How much will we lose?”

“There will be a loss.”

“Then—”

“You will stay at home tonight.”

Ratan wanted to say something, but Maheshwar bent and took hold of the next plant. Ratan picked up the basket and walked towards the first pile.

By evening the two thin southern rows had been opened up in patches. Pano Devi and Ratan carried the cobs home in baskets. The next day Lalan, who sold roasted maize at the crossroads, took the pile at a lower price. Maheshwar did not bargain for long. He knew the cobs would have fetched more if allowed to ripen fully, but time was no longer something he had.

That night Maheshwar went alone to the watch-platform.

He did not light the lantern on the southern side. Even in the pale moonlight the cleared strip was visible. After midnight the scrub stirred. Maheshwar saw the boars before they could enter under cover of the leaves. He beat the iron plate, climbed down to the ridge, and threw two clods. The rustling inside the scrub retreated.

At home Ratan continued his mathematics practice. Now and then the sound of the iron plate came from far away and his hand paused. Then he bent over the page again.

The same pattern continued for the next three nights. One night the wild boars came in from the east and trampled four plants. Maheshwar slept less; his body grew tired. But he did not call Ratan back to the platform.

On the fourth morning Ratan came to the field carrying milk. Maheshwar was sitting on the ladder of the platform. His eyes were red.

Ratan said, “Tonight I can stay until midnight.”

Maheshwar took the lota of milk. “Your examination is tomorrow.”

“The examination is in the afternoon.”

“Even so.”

Ratan ran a hand over the bamboo of the platform. “The field is not yours alone.”

Maheshwar drank the milk and said, “Nor are your studies yours alone. The household’s money goes into them.”

He set the lota down on the ridge. After a while he said, “Let the examination finish. After that, there will be no leave during the harvest.”

Ratan smiled. “Harvesting happens in the daytime.”

Maheshwar could not suppress a smile either. “You understand a great deal of arithmetic.”

Ten days later the maize was harvested. The two southern rows had already been thinned by the early picking, four plants on the eastern side had been trampled by the boars, and the crop in the middle had done well. The grain came to roughly one sack less than Maheshwar had first estimated.

On the day the cobs were shelled in the courtyard, Ratan was at home, his examination finished. He kept beating the dried cobs with a wooden mallet. Pano Devi gathered the kernels. Maheshwar filled the sacks.

The fifth sack remained half full.

Ratan said, "If the southern rows had remained, this one would have filled too."

Maheshwar straightened the sack. "Those rows were sold earlier."

He twisted a jute cord and tied the mouth of the sack tight.

After a while he asked, "When is your next examination?"

"The day after tomorrow."

"Shell the rest of the cobs tomorrow morning. From the afternoon, look at your books."

Ratan raised the mallet again. "All right."

The watch-platform still stood in the field. Taking it down was on the list of tasks for after the harvest. The old iron plate remained hanging from the bamboo; when the wind touched it, it gave a very faint sound, but now there was no maize left in the field for the boars to come and eat.

STORY 208

The Flood Loan

...

By the first week of Ashwin, the water of the Kamala River had receded, but the fields of Belahi village were still full of the marks left by the flood. On the northern wall of Lakshman Mahato's house, muddy water had left a line a handspan high. Two old sacks of paddy kept in a corner of the courtyard had rotted, and only the seed grain raised onto a bamboo platform had survived.

When Lakshman returned from inspecting the fields that morning, drying silt clung to his feet. His wife, Sarju Devi, was sitting beside the hearth. She asked, "How much of the land is fit for sowing?"

Lakshman wiped his feet with his gamchha. "The upper five kathas. Once the soil in the middle dries, another seven. Water is still trapped in the southern part."

On the night of the flood they had climbed onto the roof. When the water fell in the morning, Lakshman had first opened the cowshed, then checked the grain store. The sacks of paddy kept lower down had swollen; the moment he touched them, a sour smell rose. Sarju Devi had spread the wet grain across the courtyard in an attempt to save it, but two days later more than half had to be thrown away. That day Lakshman had said for the first time, "The crop is drowned, let it be drowned. We must not let the seed for the next sowing drown." Sarju Devi had replied, "First there must be a next sowing."

"The seed?"

"What remains in the house is enough for five kathas."

Sarju Devi understood that this was not the whole matter. There was little wheat seed in the small storeroom, fodder for the oxen was running short, and the field embankment had broken in three places. The flood had not merely taken away a crop; it had also cut away the means of beginning the next one.

That afternoon, people from the agricultural cooperative society were seated on the veranda of the panchayat building. For two days the village had been talking about an emergency post-flood loan. Lakshman went as well. The veranda smelled of wet footwear, mud, and old sacks. Behind a table, the society secretary, Shambhunath Jha, was writing down names.

When Lakshman's turn came, Shambhunath said, "You can get up to thirty thousand rupees. The first installment of principal will be due after six months."

Lakshman immediately asked, “Nothing has to be paid for six months?”

Shambhunath pushed his spectacles up and looked at him. “No principal. Interest starts from the day you draw the loan.”

Lakshman was silent for a moment.

“The rate is written here,” Shambhunath said. “Understand it before you sign.”

Lakshman could read. He went slowly through the page. He understood the figures, understood the dates, and understood this as well: the installment of principal was postponed for six months, the interest was not. Even so, he signed. Without money, the next crop could not even begin.

Before taking the loan, Lakshman had once counted the cash kept in an old brass box at home. There were four thousand three hundred rupees. That would barely cover two months of food, oil, salt, and animal fodder. It could not pay for embankment repairs, seed, and the plough all at once. That was why, even after understanding the interest, he could not step back from the loan. He did not mistake the money for something free; the difficulty was simply that the cost of beginning the next harvest had to be paid before the hunger of the present could be met.

Three days later thirty thousand rupees came into his account. In the very first week, more than half of it went toward wages for rebuilding the embankment, fodder for the oxen, wheat seed, lentil seed, and repairs to the plough. Counting the remaining money, Sarju Devi said, “The moment one heard the word relief, one imagined some of the weight would be lifted.”

Lakshman said, “The weight has been lifted. Without this, the fields would have remained empty.”

“But this weight will return.”

Lakshman gave no answer.

By the end of Kartik, the soil was ready for sowing. Lakshman had planned to put wheat in twelve kathas and lentils in four. But one evening, sitting on the field ridge, he changed the calculation. When he returned home, he told Sarju Devi, “We will put green peas in three kathas.”

Sarju Devi asked, “Less wheat?”

“Yes, three kathas less.”

“Why peas?”

“The peas will sell earlier.”

Sarju Devi understood at once. “The interest?”

Lakshman kept looking toward the ridge. “The wheat will come in Chaitra. The society says the interest is due in Phagun.”

“The money from the peas will not stay in the house?”

“Some of it will. But that comes first.”

Sarju Devi said nothing that night. The next day she herself sat down to sort the pea seed. The grains were divided into two heaps: the full, shining ones for sowing; the small and cracked ones for the animals.

On the day of sowing, Lakshman marked off the three-katha pea plot separately. As he turned the oxen, his younger brother Nandu asked, “Why no wheat here?”

Lakshman said, “This patch will produce the money for Phagun.”

Nandu laughed. “Does the field understand dates too?”

Lakshman replied, “If I fail to understand them, the interest will.”

Nandu said nothing more. He knocked the soil from the ploughshare and opened the next furrow.

In Agahan the fields turned green: thin rows of wheat, the low growth of lentils, and the three kathas of peas growing quickly. For the first time since the flood, Lakshman saw such greenness in the fields that it held the eye. Yet when he looked at the pea plot, he was not counting flowers; he was counting the date in Phagun.

Others in the village had taken loans as well. One repaired a roof, another fixed an irrigation machine, another bought seed. The loan came up again and again in conversation at the crossroads. To some it was the means of beginning life again; to others, the next burden. Lakshman did not argue. To him it was both.

At the end of Paush, the first picking of peas began. Sarju Devi, Lakshman, and his sister-in-law reached the field while it was still dark. The leaves were wet with dew. As the baskets filled, Sarju Devi said once, “This year we will hardly get to eat the peas ourselves.”

Lakshman tried to smile. “Keep two baskets.”

“Will two baskets reduce the interest?”

“No. The account will follow its own road.”

“Then we will keep only one.”

Lakshman said nothing.

The peas went to the market at the crossroads. The first lot fetched a good price, but the quantity was small. In the second week the price fell. In the third, the trader said that peas from all the surrounding villages had arrived at once. Lakshman could not take the baskets back home; if green peas were held back, their value would fall further.

Over the days of selling peas, Lakshman gradually understood one thing: profit was not measured only by how much a field produced; when the produce was sold mattered as well. At the first market, five baskets had brought as much as seven baskets did at the third. Hearing the account, Sarju Devi said, “So grow early, pick early, and still depend on the market’s mood?”

Lakshman said, “Farming already depended on the sky’s mood. Now add the market’s mood too.”

On the first Monday of Phagun, he went to the society. Shambhunath opened the ledger and told him the amount due. Lakshman opened his cloth bag and placed the notes on the table. Most of the money from three pickings of peas and two smaller market days went across that table.

After counting it, Shambhunath said, “The interest is paid in full.”

Lakshman asked, “And the principal?”

“Still thirty thousand.”

Lakshman asked again, as though he had not heard properly the first time. “Even after paying this much?”

Shambhunath looked at him. “That was interest. Installments on the principal begin next month.”

Lakshman’s hand remained inside the cloth bag. Seven hundred rupees had been kept there for the household. Outside on the veranda, two farmers waited for their turns. Lakshman tied the bag shut.

On the way home, he stopped beside the pea field. The plants in the three-katha plot had thinned now. A few flowers still remained, but the first fierce greenness was gone. Beside it the wheat stood dense. Lakshman remained on the ridge, looking at the difference between the two plots.

In the evening Sarju Devi asked, “How much is left?”

“Seven hundred.”

“And the interest?”

“Paid.”

“The principal?”

“Just as it was.”

Sarju Devi pushed a piece of wood farther into the hearth. After a few moments she said, “Then the peas went into the interest.”

Lakshman said, “If there had been no peas, the interest would have been added to the principal.”

Sarju Devi said, “Yes. Added to the principal.”

This time only the sound of the wood in the hearth remained between them.

In Chaitra the wheat was harvested. The loss of three kathas of wheat became clear as the sacks were filled. Lakshman filled eleven sacks completely; the twelfth was a little more than half full. He estimated that if wheat had stood where the peas had been, the household grain store would have held two more sacks. But without the money from the peas, he could not have paid the interest in Phagun.

After the harvest, the date for the first installment of principal arrived. Lakshman sold three sacks of wheat and paid the installment. This time, after leaving the society, he did not go straight home. He stopped at the bamboo shop at the crossroads and bought four thick bamboo poles.

Seeing the bamboo, Sarju Devi asked, "Why this expense now?"

Lakshman said, "We will build a new platform above the courtyard storeroom."

"For what?"

"For seed. Paddy, wheat, lentils—whatever is meant for the next year."

Sarju Devi understood. The old platform had been low; during this flood, the water had risen almost to its underside. Together they fastened the new platform high against the wall. Old planks were cut and laid across it. The earthen jars of seed were lifted up.

One evening in Jeth, Lakshman went to the fields. The three-katha pea plot lay empty; nothing more would be planted there until the next season. Wheat stubble rustled across the rest of the land. He sat on the ridge and looked back toward the village. From that distance, the muddy flood-line on the wall of his house could not be seen, but he remembered its height.

The rains would come again. The loan installment would come again as well. Lakshman rose and walked home.

When he reached the courtyard, Sarju Devi was arranging the seed jars on the upper platform. The old storeroom below was half empty. Above, the jars stood in a row. Without saying anything, Lakshman checked one of the bamboo joints with his hand, then looked from the old flood-line on the wall up to the planks of the new platform.

STORY 209

The Little Teacher

...

In the western hamlet of Sirsiya village stood an old oil press. The circular track where the bullock once walked had long ago been filled with earth, but the veranda remained—three bamboo posts, a tiled roof, and one thin wall. Every evening at five, eleven children spread mats on that veranda and sat down. Upendra sat before them.

Upendra was a graduate. He had earned his degree three years earlier, and since then, wherever an application had opened—in the district offices, the block, the railways, the postal department, a cooperative institution—he had kept applying. In some written examinations his name reached the first list; in others, it did not. Once he made it as far as an interview, but no job came of it.

The village respected his education, but noticed his unemployment even more.

“The big masters are at the school,” someone would say at the crossroads. “This little master looks after children in the evenings.”

The name had begun as a joke. Slowly, it stuck.

Upendra did not object. The agreed monthly fee was thirty rupees per child, but the full amount rarely came in. One child’s father worked for daily wages, another’s mother laboured in the fields; in some homes there was money one month and none the next. Upendra kept no ledger. On the first day he had written down only the children’s names and classes; after that, the matter of fees remained a spoken understanding.

Of the eleven children, Gauri was the quietest.

She was in Class Seven. She could read a lesson, and if an answer could be found in the book, she could write it down too. But if someone said, “Explain it in your own words,” her eyes would come to rest on the page.

During the first week, Upendra one day had her close the book.

“Now tell me in one sentence what you have just read.”

Gauri was silent.

“Do not open the book.”

Her fingers rested on the cover.

“Say the first word that comes to mind.”

After a long while she said, “Seed.”

“Good. What happened to the seed?”

“A sprout came out.”

“Why?”

Gauri fell silent again.

Chhotan, sitting behind her, began to laugh. Upendra did not rebuke him. He merely asked, “Do you know the answer?”

Chhotan went quiet at once.

Upendra had brought a small earthen bowl of chickpeas that he had soaked two days earlier. He placed it before Gauri.

“Look at this. Not the sentence in the book. Tell me what you can see.”

Gauri picked up one chickpea. A tiny white root had emerged from it.

“It has burst open from inside.”

“That is enough. Now a second sentence.”

That was how Upendra’s evening lessons went. He had made one rule: before the lesson ended, for ten minutes one child would explain to another one thing learned that day. Whoever could not explain it would ask again. There was no punishment and no applause.

At first, the children waited for those ten minutes chiefly because they expected a chance to laugh. After a few weeks, the laughter lessened. The child who laughed at someone today knew that tomorrow his own turn would come.

Gauri’s father, Sahdev Mandal, was not greatly impressed by these lessons.

He worked as an agricultural labourer and grew vegetables in the half-katha patch beside his courtyard. He had two younger sons. When Gauri returned home, she helped her mother with the evening meal and then looked through her little brothers’ books.

Two months later, Sahdev came to Upendra’s veranda.

“Master, Gauri’s marks have not gone up.”

Upendra asked, “How many did she get?”

“Forty-one last time. Forty-three this time.”

“They went up by two.”

“Thirty rupees a month for two marks?”

Upendra remained silent.

Sahdev said, “I am not saying that she should stop studying. She will keep going to school. But there is work at home in the evenings too.”

Gauri was sitting on the mat. Her eyes were lowered.

Upendra said quietly, "Give it one more month. I cannot promise you marks."

"Then what can you promise?"

"Nothing. After one month, you can see for yourself."

A faint displeasure crossed Sahdev's face. "You sit for job examinations too, don't you?"

"I do."

"Have you passed one?"

The question was direct. Upendra answered just as directly. "Not yet."

Sahdev said, "Hm," and left.

That night Upendra sat for a long time with a copy of an application form before him. The following week there was a district-level clerical examination. On the lesson veranda he told the children, "Say it in your own words." Yet in what words he himself would explain his own life was not clear to him.

There was no evening lesson on the day of the examination.

The next day the children asked, "How did it go?"

Upendra said, "I answered the questions I understood. The ones I did not understand, I left."

Chhotan asked, "You leave questions too?"

"Yes."

For the first time, Gauri smiled faintly.

Two weeks later the result came. Upendra's name was not on the list.

The news reached the crossroads before it reached his home. Four young men had applied; one was selected, three were not. But Upendra taught children, so his failure was more visible to people.

That evening, someone at the tea stall joked, "Now the Little Master can at least make the little children pass their examinations."

Upendra heard him. He did not stop.

That day Gauri was already seated on the veranda. Beside her was her younger brother Manoj, who usually stayed at home.

"Why is he here?" Upendra asked.

Gauri said, "Mother has gone to the fields. He could not be left alone at home."

"Then let him sit."

That day's lesson was fractions: one-half, one-fourth, three-fourths.

Upendra drew a circle on the ground like a round roti. Then he divided it into four parts.

“If three parts are coloured, how much is that?”

Chhotan answered at once, “Three-fourths.”

“Why?”

Chhotan stopped.

Gauri said slowly, “The whole thing has been divided into four equal parts. Three of those parts have been taken.”

Upendra did not interrupt her.

“And two parts?”

“One-half. Because two out of four are equal to half.”

Upendra said only, “Yes.”

Manoj, who was younger than the children in that class, began drawing four sections in the earth with his finger.

In the final ten minutes that day, it was Gauri’s turn. She had to explain fractions to Chhotan. At first she tried to open the book, then closed it herself.

“Four rotis were made in your house,” she said. “You ate two. What part did you eat?”

Chhotan said, “Half.”

“Why?”

Chhotan laughed. “Now I understand.”

Three days before the month was complete, Sahdev, returning from the fields, stopped near the veranda. He did not come inside. He stood behind a bamboo post and listened.

At that moment Gauri was explaining the difference between a river and a pond to Sita, who was in Class Five. Her sentences were not from the book. Now and then she stopped, searched for another word, and continued. Sita asked a question. Gauri explained again.

Sahdev said nothing. He quietly went home.

The next morning, Gauri’s mother Sarita came to Upendra’s house. In her hands were a bottle gourd and a small bag of peas.

“We could not collect the full money this month,” she said. “Keep these.”

Upendra did not take the bag. “Pay whenever it comes together.”

Sarita set the bag down on the veranda. “This is not the fee. It is from the field. We have more at home.”

She turned to leave, then stopped.

“Sahdev says Gauri will not stop the evening lessons.”

Upendra only nodded.

“Did her marks go up?”

Sarita laughed. “He did not say anything about that.”

She left.

The following week, Ramapati Babu, the language teacher at the school, met Upendra at the market. The two already knew each other.

Ramapati Babu said, “Gauri studies with you, doesn’t she?”

“Yes.”

“Earlier she memorised answers, but if you questioned her she fell silent. Now, even when her answer is wrong, she explains her reason. That is a good change.”

Without thinking, Upendra asked, “Her marks?”

Ramapati Babu laughed. “You worry about marks too?”

They went their separate ways.

In Phagun there was a wedding in the village. Two appointed teachers from the school were seated on chairs near the raised platform. Upendra was with the young men of his own age, helping lay out leaf plates for the meal.

Someone called to him from a distance, “Little Master, put these four wooden stools over there.”

He carried the stools over and arranged them.

As evening fell, he found Gauri, Chhotan, and Sita in an empty veranda behind the wedding house. All three had books in their hands.

Upendra was surprised. “There is no lesson today.”

Chhotan said, “We know.”

“Then why the books?”

Gauri said, “We gave three different answers to yesterday’s question. We thought we would ask you.”

Upendra sat down on the corner of a wooden stool. In the distance, the elders were talking near the platform, the rows for the meal were forming, and at any moment someone might call him again to bring a bundle of leaf plates.

He listened to the children’s question.

He did not answer at once.

First he asked, “What did each of you think?”

One by one, all three began to explain their ideas.

Amid the noise of the wedding, four people bent together in that small veranda, listening to three answers to the same question.

STORY 210

Smoke from the Hearth

...

When the red cylinder supplied under the scheme arrived at Harinandan Paswan's house, Jamuna first placed it in the eastern corner of the kitchen. The old earthen hearth stood there too, and the wall above it had been blackened by years of smoke. A low stool was moved aside to make room for the new stove, one row of utensils was shifted higher, and the red cylinder stood two arm's lengths from the mud wall.

That first evening, rice was set to cook on the gas stove. Mahesari, Harinandan's mother, sat by the doorway watching the blue flame.

"Fire without smoke?" she said.

Jamuna laughed. "There is fire. There is no smoke."

The rice cooked quickly. So did the lentils. Jamuna did not have to keep blowing into the fire and wiping her eyes. Mahesari could sit inside the kitchen and cut vegetables. She had an old cough; whenever woodsmoke rose, she generally had to go out to the veranda.

Within two weeks, the household routine had changed. Breakfast was ready early, Harinandan left on time for field labour, and Birju reached school before the first bell. Jamuna no longer had to go as often to the edge of the stream to gather firewood. The old hearth remained cold, and ash slowly settled in its mouth.

That year the roof was repaired as well. High on the western wall of the kitchen was a small smoke vent. When wood burned, some of the smoke escaped through it; but in heavy rain, water also dripped in through the same opening. The mason who had come to repair the roof asked, "Should I leave this vent open?"

Harinandan looked at the red cylinder and said, "What smoke is there now? Seal it."

The mason fixed a piece of broken tin over the opening and plastered mud over it from outside. Jamuna swept the kitchen and gave the wall a thin wash of lime. Amid the blackened wall, a white strip appeared. Mahesari ran her hand over it and said, "The house feels new."

The first cylinder lasted a month and a half. A second was refilled. The third time the delivery vehicle came to the village crossroads, Harinandan

heard the price and fell silent. That week he had found work for only three days. If the refill money was set aside, what remained for oil, salt, and the seed kept in mind for the winter crop would shrink.

“Wait two days,” he told Jamuna.

Two days became five. Five became ten. The blue flame first grew thin, then one evening went out. Jamuna closed the valve and placed the empty cylinder back in the eastern corner.

The next morning, the old hearth was cleaned again. The ash was scraped out, fresh mud was patted around its mouth, and dried pigeon-pea stalks were fed into it.

As soon as the first smoke rose, Jamuna understood that the household had returned to the old hearth—but not to the old kitchen.

The smoke climbed upward toward the western wall, struck the sealed tin, and rolled back down. Within moments, the room was full of it. Jamuna blinked hard and opened the door. Mahesari came out coughing. Birju carried his bowl to the veranda and sat there.

“Why did we close the vent?” Jamuna asked.

Harinandan did not answer. The decision had been his, but it had been made for the house as it was then—a house in which there was gas.

That afternoon he went outside to pry off the piece of tin. The mud had dried hard. Half an hour later, the small opening was open again. That evening the smoke did escape through it, but a black streak began to run down the wall below the vent.

Three days later it rained. Driven by the west wind, water blew in through the opening. The dry wood stacked beside the hearth became wet. Jamuna propped the tin back over part of the hole, narrowing the vent.

After two days of sunshine, Jamuna moved the hearth into the courtyard. Three bricks were set down and an old iron grate laid across them. In the open air the smoke troubled them less, but a new set of difficulties began. When the wind rose, the flame leaned to one side and ash blew onto the utensils. At dusk, when the cattle came back toward the shed, the hearth had to be cleared away. Once, the lentils were only half cooked when clouds gathered; pot, wood, ash—everything had to be shifted back inside. Mahesari laughed and said, “Are we cooking the meal now, or moving the hearth?”

Jamuna laughed too, but the next day she put the hearth back in its old place in the kitchen. Cooking outside was a solution for sunny days, not a rule a household could live by.

From then on, the vent was opened and closed according to the weather. Open on dry days, half closed on rainy ones. The smoke never went out completely. Mahesari generally stayed on the veranda while food was being cooked.

“Refill the cylinder,” she told Harinandan one day.

“As soon as I can put the money together.”

“I am not telling you where to bring the money from. I am only saying that this smoke is settling into the body again.”

Harinandan looked at his mother. There was no accusation in her words. That made them harder to answer.

Returning from the fields, Harinandan began gathering dry stalks and bringing them home. He wanted Jamuna to have to go less often to the streamside for wood. But that solved only the question of fuel; it did not give the smoke a way out.

One evening a strong wind rose while the hearth was burning. Because the door was open, the flame bent sharply to one side and ash flew onto the lid of the rice pot. Jamuna half closed the door, and the smoke began circling inside. From the veranda Mahesari said, “Close one mouth of the house, open the other and rain comes in. How are both to be managed together?”

That night Harinandan sat for a long time looking at the western wall. The vent was just below the roof. Because the tin had been fixed flat against the wall, the rain was being driven straight inside. At dawn, without calling the mason, he split two thin pieces of old bamboo. He fixed them outside the vent as small supports and tied the tin not flush against the wall but tilted slightly outward. Rain falling from above would strike the tin and run down, while a gap between tin and wall would remain for the smoke.

Jamuna watched from a distance. “Will it hold?”

“We will know when it rains.”

The first heavy rain came two days later. The wall around the vent became slightly damp, but water no longer blew inside as before. When the hearth was lit, a ribbon of smoke could be seen escaping beneath the tin. The kitchen did not become clean; their eyes still stung. But the smoke no longer gathered beneath the roof and rolled back into the room as heavily as before.

Mahesari came in from the veranda and sat inside for a while. She coughed once, then the cough subsided.

Meanwhile, the cylinder remained empty. The price did not fall, and the household’s earnings never arrived all at once. For three weeks Harinandan

kept aside a little from each day's wages. Jamuna added the small amounts she earned from selling milk. No one gave these savings a name.

In the fourth week, the delivery vehicle came again to the crossroads. This time Harinandan tied the empty cylinder to his bicycle and took it there. When the filled cylinder returned home that evening, Birju did not run to watch the blue flame as he had the first time. For him, it was no longer a new thing.

Jamuna put tea on the gas stove. Mahesari sat inside.

"Shall we break up the old hearth?" Harinandan asked.

Jamuna poured the hot tea into bowls. "Why?"

"The cylinder is full now."

"It is full now."

Harinandan fell silent. He understood.

From then on, the house lived with two fires. On rainy mornings, for a hurried meal, or to warm milk for Mahesari—the gas stove. When lentils needed to simmer for a long time, when cattle feed had to be cooked, or when there was plenty of dry stalk at home—the old hearth. The cylinder lasted longer that way, but wood did not disappear entirely from their lives.

The only real difference was that now the smoke once again had a way out. Harinandan did not remove the tilted piece of tin over the vent. Even when there was gas in the house, the opening remained.

A few months later, the white strip of limewash began to turn grey again. But this time the soot did not gather in a single thick layer; it rose in a thinner trail toward the vent. Jamuna wiped the wall from time to time. When the smoke grew heavy, Mahesari went out to the veranda; when it was lighter, she remained seated inside.

One evening, rice was cooking on the gas stove and lentils on the old hearth. A light rain was falling outside. Water dripped from the sloping tin—tip, tip—and beneath it a thin line of smoke slipped out.

Jamuna lifted the lid and checked the rice. Harinandan pushed a slender stalk farther into the hearth. Mahesari looked at the black-grey strip on the wall, then quietly went on cutting vegetables.

In the eastern corner stood the red cylinder. In the western corner lay a small pile of firewood. In the wall between them, the vent remained open.

STORY 211

A One-Kattha Pond

...

When Jhalo Sahni reached the pond at first light, a fishing net tucked beneath his arm, the first thing he saw was not the water but a new bamboo enclosure.

The barrier ran around three sides of the pond. At the narrow eastern ghat, where for years Jhalo had washed his nets and Phulo Sahni had sorted fish, two thick bamboo poles had been driven into the ground and a rope tied between them. Inside the rope, the water gleamed; outside it, Jhalo stood.

He looked around once. The pond was scarcely a kattha in area. To the north lay the shade of a peepal tree, to the south an old earthen slope, and to the west Domon Chaudhary's kitchen garden. This little pond did not provide the rice for Jhalo's household, but it paid for what went with the rice. If two or three seers of mixed fish—pothi, garai, singhi, little prawns—went to the market at dawn, there would be money for salt, oil, soap, and sometimes a child's books and paper.

Domon Chaudhary was standing inside the enclosure with a sack of mustard-seed cake in his hand.

"From now on, no net is to be cast here," he said.

Jhalo understood, yet he asked, "Why?"

"I have stocked fingerlings. The oilcake, bran, all the expense is mine. Whoever earns from the water must also look after the water."

Jhalo looked toward the western bank. The previous winter Domon had dug the foundation for a new cattle shed. Half the excavated earth had lain on the pond's edge and gradually slipped into it. Where water had once stood, a narrow strip of land now carried creeping sponge-gourd vines.

"The pond belonged to the village," Jhalo said quietly.

Domon opened the sack. "When did the village ever look after it? It filled with silt and weeds. I had it cleaned and stocked fish. A pond does not raise fish merely because its name belongs to the village."

Jhalo said nothing. He folded the net under his arm and went home.

When he arrived, Phulo was taking the starchy water off the cooking rice. Seeing the empty net, she asked, "Has the pond dried up?"

"Not the water. The way to it has dried up."

She listened to everything. Then she looked at the empty fish basket by the hearth. The two pothi left from the previous day had been eaten the night before.

“Go to the river,” Phulo said.

The river lay three and a half kos from the village. Jhalo went that day. He left at four in the morning and returned after the sun was high. Some fish had come into the net, but after half the journey on foot their shine had already dulled. They fetched a lower price in the market. After three days, Jhalo did the reckoning: whatever extra fish he brought back was being offset by the time lost on the road.

Phulo no longer went to the dawn market every day. She went twice a week. On the other days she began cutting makhana leaves and selling them as cattle fodder. Their son Sonu, who had earlier helped gather the small nets by the pond, now faced the same question again and again each morning: should he go with his father to the river, or to school?

“Go to school,” Jhalo would say.

“Then who will gather the nets?”

Jhalo would not answer.

Earlier, Phulo had sat in her regular place at the market through the first hour of the morning. Even when she had little fish, the old customers knew she would be there again the next day. Once the river trips began, the days became uncertain: sometimes there was plenty of fish, sometimes an empty net. Within two weeks, they had to count in advance how many days remained before the tins of salt and oil ran empty. Once, Sonu’s small monthly contribution at school was paid three days late. That day Phulo had suggested selling her brass bowl, but Jhalo refused.

What angered Jhalo most was not only the money. The pond was so close to the house that he could fit fishing around the time for giving medicine to his old mother, Sonu’s school hours, and day labour in the fields. The river swallowed half a day. Even when the net earned something, another day’s work slipped from his hands.

Meanwhile, Domon’s pond was changing. The rohu and catla fingerlings were growing. Inside the enclosure he scattered oilcake and sometimes poured in a slurry of cow dung. The water near the edge turned green. Children stood outside the barrier watching the backs of fish flash in the water. Domon was pleased.

In the last week of Jeth, the heat hardened. At night the wind stopped. By day the pond water grew hot; by dawn it looked exhausted. One morning Domon’s grandson came running to Jhalo’s house.

“Uncle, the fish are coming to the surface with their mouths open.”

Jhalo was tying up his net to leave for the river. He did not get up at once.

“Grandfather has called you.”

Phulo looked at him. “Go.”

“They are his fish.”

“If the water dies, it won’t be only his fish that die.”

Jhalo left the net where it was and went to the pond.

Inside the enclosure, many fish were at the surface, their mouths opening and closing again and again. Some were wavering near the mud at the edge. The water smelled sour with oilcake.

Domon’s face had fallen. “They were fine until last night.”

Jhalo waded in up to his knees. He lifted water in his hand and smelled it. He examined the mud at the bank and the green film.

“Do not give them oilcake today.”

“Then what will they eat?”

“This is not the time for eating. It is the time for breathing.”

Domon opened his mouth to reply, then remained silent.

Jhalo went to the north-western corner of the pond. Beneath the old slope there had once been a narrow water outlet. When the rains were heavy, pond water drained through it toward the lower edge of the fields. Earth from Domon’s cattle-shed foundation had half blocked the passage.

“Bring a spade,” Jhalo said.

“Drain the water? The fish will escape.”

“Not all of it. Let a little of the foul bottom water out. Bring fresh water in from the other side.”

Domon had a water-lifting machine in his garden. Jhalo said the tube-well water should not be released straight into the pond, but allowed to fall first over a bamboo screen so that it would break into splashes before entering. Sonu and Domon’s grandson brought an old screen. Phulo came too. She untied the rope and loosened the enclosure on one side so that people could move in and out.

They worked for two hours. Water from the machine struck the bamboo screen and burst into white spray. Jhalo slowly cut away the earth from the old outlet. Black water from the bottom of the pond ran out in a thin stream. Phulo used a bamboo basket to lift two fish that had rolled over at the surface and placed them in a tub of separate water.

By the time the sun climbed higher, fewer fish were opening their mouths at the surface. Some had gone back into deeper water.

Drinking from a brass lota on the veranda, Domon said, "Tell me your wage."

Jhalo kept washing the spade.

"I will pay you for today."

Jhalo raised his head. "If you pay for today, I'll take it. But this is not only about today."

Domon's eyes narrowed slightly.

Phulo spoke first. "Do not give the pond back to us. Just leave us the way to the place where we used to work."

"I have stocked fingerlings," Domon said. "If nets are cast, my fish will come up too."

Jhalo said, "No big net. Only the small basket-net at the bank—snails, prawns, pothi. We will not touch the rohu and catla. When harvest time comes, if you ask us, we will cast the net for you."

Domon did not agree then.

For two days the matter remained there. On the third morning, as Jhalo was leaving for the river, Domon himself met him on the path.

"I'll move the enclosure two bamboo lengths back from the eastern ghat," he said. "Small nets only at dawn. Not after the sun is up."

Jhalo asked, "Snails?"

"Take them."

"When the water rises?"

"I will not block the outlet."

Jhalo nodded. He neither said anything more nor showed any sense of victory.

That evening, the two eastern bamboo poles were pulled out and the rope tied in a new place. The pond did not become completely open again, but half the mouth of the old ghat was visible.

The following week Phulo returned to the dawn market. There were no large fish in her basket—only pothi, little prawns, two singhi, and a few snails. The earnings were not what they had once been, but half a day's journey to the river had been saved. Sonu began going to school regularly again.

Domon's rohu and catla continued to grow. Twice a week Jhalo smelled the water, watched whether the green film was becoming too thick, and told Domon when to reduce the oilcake. He asked no separate payment for this; in

return, he kept his dawn share of small fish. The relationship was not equal, but it was no longer one-sided.

In Sawan, heavy rain came. The pond filled until the water touched the banks. A thin stream ran from the old north-western outlet toward the fields. Domon came there once carrying a sack of earth. It was clear that the thought of blocking the flow had crossed his mind. Jhalo watched from a distance and said nothing. Domon set the sack down, looked at the stream, then carried it back unopened.

At the end of Bhadon came the first day for the large net. Domon could have called two fishermen from outside, but he asked Jhalo, "Is your net strong enough?"

Jhalo laughed. "The pond is one kattha. The net is bigger than the pond."

At dawn, four men waded into the water. Phulo arranged baskets on the bank. The big rohu went into one basket, the catla into another. The small fish caught along the bottom of the net fell into Phulo's basket. Domon looked once and said nothing.

When the harvest was over, the water was muddy. The enclosure still stood. Domon still had his sacks of oilcake. The earth filling the western edge still carried sponge-gourd vines. Phulo placed the basket on her head. Sonu wrung out the rope of the net. Jhalo looked toward the small north-western channel, where rainwater was slowly flowing out.

On the way home, he passed between the two bamboo poles on the eastern side. Where the rope had once been stretched chest-high, it now lay shifted toward the bank. The pond was still only one kattha. But the morning path once again ran through it.

STORY 212

The Bag of Seed

...

On the last evening of Jeth, clouds were gathering over the southern tract of Sonbarsa village. Shyamanandan Mahato sat at his doorway with two bags before him. One was a bright printed packet of hybrid okra seed bought from the seed shop in the market. The other was an old cotton bag, its mouth tied with red thread, containing seed from local okra chosen and saved from the family field the previous year.

Dulari Devi was turning over dried okra pods on the veranda. She set aside five or six long, brown pods.

“Will you save these again this year?” Shyamanandan asked.

“Why should I not?”

Shyamanandan lifted the bright packet. “Raghuvansh Sah says this seed will give uniform fruit. The first picking will come early. Prices are good in the first week at the market.”

Dulari looked toward the old bag. “And this?”

“The plants from this are not uniform. Some fruits are thick, some thin. The market men sort them and pay accordingly.”

They had six katthas of land. For the past three years, after the paddy crop, Shyamanandan had been growing vegetables to meet the household’s cash expenses. Paddy kept food in the house; vegetables paid for oil, salt, clothes, small repairs to the plough and bullocks, and the expenses of festivals and ceremonies. That year he had little spare cash. Even so, he bought two printed packets of hybrid seed. Each cost nine hundred and twenty rupees. Raghuvansh Sah had said that if the sowing was done on time, the first picking would come early.

Shyamanandan’s calculation was simple. If okra prices remained good in the first week, the extra cost of seed would come back in two or three pickings. The local seed cost nothing to buy, but it took a few more days to reach the first market. How many days depended on that year’s sun and rain.

“Hybrid on all six katthas?” Dulari asked.

“Yes. This time, all of it.”

“And the local-seed bag?”

“Keep it. It is not something to eat.”

Dulari did not laugh. She lifted the bag and put it on the upper bamboo shelf in the kitchen, where less smoke reached it.

The first rain came that night. It was not enough to flood the field, but it softened the soil. In the morning Shyamanandan went to the field with his son Bablu. Rows were opened with a small hoe, seed was placed at intervals of two hand-spans, and a thin layer of earth covered it. The hybrid seed was small, clean, and almost uniform in size. Bablu counted the seeds out of the printed packet.

“Babu, why two in one place?”

“If one does not sprout, the other will remain.”

“And if both sprout?”

“Then we will thin one later.”

By evening all six katthas had been sown. Shyamanandan did not throw away the empty printed packets. He folded their mouths and tucked them into the knot of his dhoti. At home he gave them to Dulari.

“Keep them. The name is printed on them.”

Dulari hung them from a peg on the wall. The old cotton seed bag remained on the upper shelf.

Three days later the second rain came. This time the clouds did not clear from one evening until the following afternoon. The old bund on the western side of the field was low. Water from the neighbouring field also entered from that direction. Twice during the night Shyamanandan went out with a lantern to open a drain, but the flow was strong.

By morning, nearly two of the six katthas lay under water. Even in the central rows, the soil had become sticky. Shyamanandan waded in up to his knees and cut a narrow outlet through the bund. It took the whole day for the water to fall.

On the fifth day, the seedlings that should have appeared were not everywhere. On the higher eastern side, two green leaves had emerged. In the western two katthas there were stretches of ten hand-spans with nothing, then five hand-spans bare again. In some places, seeds had swollen and turned black.

Bablu asked, “Shall we sow again?”

Shyamanandan did not answer. He kept counting the empty stretches. Back home, he took the empty printed packet down from the peg, read the number on it, and then counted the money left in his pocket.

He could buy another printed packet, but then the money for labour at weeding time would run short. And if new seed was sown now, half the

advantage of an early first picking would already be gone. A week's delay could make a large difference in the market price.

At midday he went to Raghuvansh Sah's shop.

"I need one packet of the same seed," Shyamanandan said.

Raghuvansh looked at the box on the upper shelf. "I have it. But it is fifty rupees more now. Stock is short."

Shyamanandan took the packet in his hand, then put it back.

"I can write it on credit," Raghuvansh said.

"No credit."

"Then will you leave the field empty?"

Shyamanandan said nothing. When he returned home, Dulari pointed toward the upper shelf.

"The bag tied with red thread is still there."

"Who knows how much of it will germinate?"

Dulari brought the bag down. "We can find out."

She took a handful of seed and spread it over half of an old gamchha. The cloth was moistened. Forty seeds were counted out, the cloth folded around them, and the bundle placed in an earthen plate. Dulari kept it damp for two days. On the third morning, when the cloth was opened, many of the seeds had sent out tiny white roots.

Bablu counted them.

"Thirty-two."

Shyamanandan counted again. Thirty-two.

"Not all of them," he said.

Dulari replied, "No one expected all of them."

That afternoon, the local seed was sown in the empty rows. In some places they put in three seeds, elsewhere two. Shyamanandan marked the spots among the hybrid plants: wherever local seed had been sown, he pushed a thin bamboo sliver into the ground. The marks were not for selling the crop; they were for choosing seed later.

After that, the rain stopped completely. For eight days clouds gathered but no water fell. The topsoil began to crack. In the mornings Shyamanandan drew water from the channel with a bamboo bucket and poured it along the newly sown stretches. The hybrid plants had already taken root; the local seed was only just emerging, so it needed more care.

One day Bablu said, "If you had bought the second packet, you would still have had to water it."

Shyamanandan smiled. "The price of seed is one thing. The price of water is another."

Ten days later a light rain came. The bare parts of the field began to turn green. But the two kinds of rows were easy to distinguish. The hybrid plants were taller and growing at almost the same pace. Among the local plants, some were ahead and some behind. Shyamanandan had once regarded this unevenness as a loss. Now he could see in it different days of picking.

Budhan Mahato, the neighbour, stood on the bund looking over the field. "You mixed two varieties?"

Shyamanandan said, "I did not mix them. The water did."

Budhan laughed. "How will you tell them apart at harvest?"

"Okra is not harvested in one day. Whatever fruit comes, we will pick it."

Budhan looked at the bamboo slivers. "What are those for?"

"I have marked the plants for seed."

"You will not save seed from the hybrid?"

Shyamanandan shook his head. "There is no certainty that the next generation will give the same qualities. From the local plants that survived, I will choose the best ones."

Budhan walked on. Shyamanandan remained standing in the field for a while. In Jeth his calculation had gone only as far as the price of seed and the price at the first market. Now the calculation also included a day of standing water, half a day cutting the drain, two days of re-sowing, and eight days of dry sky. None of these had a line printed on the packet.

At the end of Sawan, the first hybrid okra was picked. The quantity was small because many rows in the western part had been re-sown. Even so, it fetched a good price at the first market. Raghuvansh Sah was there too.

"See? The hybrid gave early," he said.

Shyamanandan said yes. That was true.

After three pickings, more okra began arriving in the market and prices started to fall. By then the local plants were coming into harvest. Some fruits were thick, some thin, some slightly crooked. The trader would not pay one rate for all of them. Before leaving home, Dulari sorted them into three baskets by size. The best went in front; the small and thick ones were for another buyer; fruits allowed to grow very large were left on the plants for household seed.

The total earnings were not as much as Shyamanandan had calculated in Jeth. The first spell of rain had almost wiped out two katthas of hybrid seed. Re-sowing had cost two extra days of labour. The market price too had fallen

quickly. But the field had not remained empty. The rows filled from the local-seed bag kept giving pickings, though later.

One evening in Bhadon, Shyamanandan and Dulari sat on the veranda counting the day's earnings. Bablu came from the field carrying five dried okra pods.

"These are from the plants beside the bamboo slivers," he said.

Dulari turned a pod in her hand. "Keep them. Let them dry completely."

Shyamanandan asked, "How much seed shall we save this time?"

"Enough for all six katthas?"

Shyamanandan did not answer at once. He looked at the empty hybrid packet hanging from the peg. Its paper had curled slightly in the dampness of the rains.

The following week he went to Raghuvansh Sah's shop. Sah asked, "Shall I put down your name for two packets next season?"

Shyamanandan said, "One."

"One packet will be short for six katthas."

"I know. Still, one."

"And the remaining three katthas?"

Shyamanandan looked outside the shop at the sky. There were clouds, but whether they would bring rain was hard to say.

"The rest is at home."

That evening Dulari split the dried pods and took out the seed. Bablu blew away the light chaff. Shyamanandan stitched the torn corner of the old cotton bag with needle and thread. The old red tie had worn out, so Dulari fastened a new red thread around its mouth.

The empty bright printed packet remained hanging from the peg. On the bamboo shelf, the bag of local seed was put back in its place. The next season was still a long way off.

STORY 213

Two Goats

...

In the first week of Bhadon, evening descended early over Belahi Tola. After the humidity of the day, a breeze would rise from the bamboo grove, and Kamala Devi would once again check the ropes of the two goats tied to the posts of her veranda. Dhauri's body was white, except for two black patches near the front of her ears. Kajri was entirely black, her belly full and her gait slow.

For two years these two goats had been Kamala's household savings on four legs. After her husband's death, the only land left that could be called theirs was four dhurs of garden behind the house. Daily labour paid for rice and lentils, but expenses such as her daughter Sunita's college admission, books, examination forms, and shared transport were difficult to match with day wages. When such expenses arose, Kamala sold a kid.

She did not announce this arrangement to anyone. People in the tola merely knew that Kamala owned two goats. But in her own mind she kept a separate account for each one. The male kid Dhauri had borne the previous year had paid Sunita's first-year admission fee. Of Kajri's two kids, one had been sold for books and three months of travel expenses; the other, a female, had died of illness.

This time Kajri was pregnant again. Kamala had calculated that she would kid by Agahan, and that if a male kid grew well, it could be sold after Magh to cover Sunita's annual examination form and the opening expenses of the next academic session. There was little paper in this calculation and much of the seasons.

When Sunita returned from her studies in the evening and sat on the veranda, Kajri would try to chew the edge of her shawl. Laughing, Sunita would push her head away.

"Don't you understand that you are worth the price of my books?" she would say.

From inside, Kamala would answer, "She does not want your books. She wants your shawl."

That evening both goats ate normally. Kamala gave them jackfruit leaves and a little straw. After supper, Sunita opened her books. Outside, a light rain began.

Around midnight Kamala woke to a strange rustling sound. Kajri was pulling hard at her rope. Dhauri sat with her head drooping. Kamala came out with a lamp. Foam-like saliva clung around Kajri's mouth and her body was hot. Dhauri's ears were cold, yet she would not get up.

"Sunita."

Her daughter came at once. Together they loosened Kajri's rope. Water was set in front of her, but she would not touch it.

The livestock worker lived two kos away. In that rain, at that hour, there was no way to send for anyone. Their neighbour Ramparikshan heard the commotion and came over. He looked at the goats' mouths and felt their bellies, but instead of guessing at a diagnosis he said, "Send someone as soon as morning comes. For now, tie them separately."

Kamala stood an old bamboo screen in the middle of the veranda and separated the two animals. Sunita sat beside Dhauri. Kamala remained with Kajri.

The night was very long. At times Kajri tried to rise, then folded at the knees and fell again. Rain kept beating the roof in the same rhythm.

In the first light of dawn, Kajri's body shuddered once and became still.

Kamala said nothing. She merely untied the knot of the rope, which was no longer needed.

Sunita looked toward Dhauri. "Will she live?"

"The veterinary doctor will see her first."

The veterinarian arrived by about nine in the morning. Dhauri had a fever. There were sores inside her mouth. He gave medicines, advised them to keep her separate for two days, give her clean water, and keep her away from other animals. He said it was difficult to state the certain cause of Kajri's death; because an infectious disease was suspected, they were told to bury the body quickly.

Kajri had been pregnant. That was the heaviest fact of all when they buried her.

The medicines, injections, the livestock worker's travel, and a few necessary supplies almost emptied the savings Kamala had kept in a bamboo box. That money had been meant for Sunita's examination form.

The last date was six days away.

That evening Sunita took out the form and laid it on the veranda.

"What if I don't submit it this time?"

Kamala was changing the water in front of Dhauri. "Why would you not?"

"The money must go to her first. Dhauri has to live."

Kamala straightened the bowl of water. "Dhauri's treatment will continue. Your form will be submitted too."

"Where will that much money come from?"

"There are six days left. We will find a way."

Sunita did not ask again.

The next day Dhauri stood up, but after two steps she sat down again. Kamala thought of selling her. If she had been healthy, she would have fetched a good price. Now any buyer, on hearing of the illness, would halve the offer, and some would refuse to touch her for fear of disease. Besides, if Dhauri were sold, the household's entire livestock would vanish in a single night.

Kamala abandoned that option.

To the east of the tola, Bhubaneswar Jha still had weeding left in three bighas of paddy. Kamala normally worked for daily wages; she did not like taking advance payment. That day she went to Bhubaneswar's courtyard herself.

"I need four days' wages in advance," Kamala said.

Bhubaneswar was surprised. "The work is next week."

"I know. Write down four days. I will take no wages for the first four days."

"Has something happened?"

Kamala did not explain at length. "A goat died. My daughter has an examination form to submit."

Bhubaneswar remained silent for a moment, then went inside and brought the money. "Four days. Not five."

"Four only."

Kamala counted the notes. This was not help; it was future labour sold in advance. She liked the clarity of that.

On the third day, Sunita's examination form was submitted. She returned with the receipt while Kamala was giving medicine to Dhauri.

"It is done," Sunita said.

Kamala nodded. "Keep it safely."

"Amma, those four days of wages—"

"I will work four days."

"I could also do something—"

"Your work now is to study."

Her voice was not harsh, but the matter ended there.

Dhuri slowly began to rise again. On the fifth day she ate two handfuls of leaves. On the seventh, she stood in the sunshine outside the veranda. Kamala did not immediately let her out to graze. The illness had thinned her body.

The following week Kamala went to weed Bhubaneswar's field. By the evening of the first day, her fingers had swollen. On the second, pain caught her when she straightened her back. She completed all four days. During those four days not a single rupee in cash entered the house, because the money had already become Sunita's examination form.

At the end of the fourth day, Bhubaneswar said, "The advance is fully worked off. From tomorrow, whatever work you do, you will be paid in the evening."

Kamala went to the field on the fifth day as well. When the first cash wage reached her hand that evening, she did not go straight home. From a small shop near the market she bought half a seer of bran, a little salt, and mustard oil. Seeing the packet of bran, Sunita asked, "The first money goes to Dhuri?"

Kamala said, "After an illness the body does not fill out quickly on leaves alone."

That night there was little rice, so the lentils were cooked thin. Sunita said nothing about it.

She understood now that the lump of cash which once came into the house when a kid was sold would have to be rebuilt, little by little, from daily wages.

Meanwhile, Sunita began bringing grass for Dhuri when she returned from college. Her own studying shifted later into the night.

Twice Kamala told her, "I will bring the grass."

Sunita replied, "You are working off those four days you took in advance. I can cut grass for half an hour."

Kamala did not argue. She merely said, "Come back before dark."

By Asin, Dhuri's body had begun to fill out again, but Kajri's empty post remained on the veranda. Kamala had once expected Kajri to bear a kid in Agahan. Now there would be no kid in Agahan, and nothing certain to sell in Magh.

The household arithmetic changed. Instead of taking the shared vehicle every day, Sunita walked to the main road three days a week, where cheaper transport was available. Instead of buying all her books new, she bought two from the second-hand market. Kamala took a few extra days of work parboiling paddy. Dhuri's fodder was not reduced.

In Kartik, the livestock worker came to the tola again. Kamala had Dhuri vaccinated. The fee was small, yet she hesitated for a moment before handing

over the money. Earlier, the goat had seemed to her simply a source of income; now she understood that a source of income had its own expenses, its own illnesses, and its own uncertainties.

Sunita asked, "Will you have her bred again?"

Kamala ran a hand along Dhauri's back. "Let her recover completely first. What is gained by rushing?"

"And next year's expenses?"

"Next year has not come yet."

The examinations were held in Paus. As Sunita left in the morning, she touched Dhauri's head. She did not look at the empty post.

The day after the examinations, Kamala and Sunita were cleaning the veranda. Kajri's old rope had been hanging from a bamboo beam for many days. Sunita took it down and asked, "Shall I throw this away?"

Kamala took the rope in her hand. One end still bore old tooth marks where Kajri had once gnawed it.

"No," she said. "Wash it and keep it. The rope is still good."

Sunita carried it away to the water.

There was now only one goat on the veranda. Dhauri stood by the post chewing leaves. The second post was empty, but its rope had not been thrown away.

STORY 214

The Labour Card

...

Behind a warehouse under construction on the outskirts of Surat stood a tin-roofed shed. At night twelve labourers spread their bedding there. Nandlal Paswan's bedding was at the very edge, because every morning he was the first to rise and go to fetch water. He had left Belahi village in Madhubani three months earlier. At home were his wife, his elderly mother, and two children.

On the first day, the labour contractor, Jagesar, had asked everyone for a photocopy of their Aadhaar document, a photocopy of the relevant page of their savings-bank passbook, and two photographs. Later he said he would have all their names entered in a government labour register. A few weeks afterward, everyone's labour cards arrived together in a blue plastic envelope. Jagesar put all the cards in his iron box.

"They will be safe here," he had said. "If you keep them with your bedding, half of you will tear or lose them."

At first no one objected. The labourers' days passed among bricks, reinforcing rods, sand, and mortar. At night their bodies were so tired that who would worry about papers?

One Sunday, while food was being cooked, two young men came to the nearby tea stall distributing leaflets. They said that the following Sunday a labour-assistance camp would be held. Migrant workers could check their registration, verify their details, and obtain information about government labour schemes. Nandlal turned the leaflet over in his hands. He could read the letters, but the small printed lines were difficult to understand. Salim, another worker, read it aloud to him.

Nandlal remembered what a panchayat worker had told him before he left home: "When you go outside, keep your labour identity with you."

That evening Nandlal went to Jagesar.

"Give me my labour card. I want to take it to the camp next Sunday."

Jagesar was chewing paan and adding up accounts. Without looking up from the paper, he said, "The card will stay here. What will you do at the camp? Your name is registered, isn't it?"

"I want to look at my own document once."

“What is there to look at? We got all of them made. If I hand the cards out, half the men will lose them.”

Nandlal remained silent. Then he asked, “Give me a copy.”

This time Jagesar looked up. “Are you looking for work somewhere else?”

Nandlal understood the meaning inside the question. The card was no longer merely a document; inside that iron box, his freedom to come and go was being shut away with it.

A week earlier Sukhdev, who also slept under the shed, had asked for his card because he was going back to his village. His younger brother was ill, and Sukhdev had said that on the way home he wanted to show the document at the labour office in his village. Jagesar had put him off for three days. In the end, instead of the card, he gave Sukhdev only a photocopy of its front side, on which the number on the reverse was incomplete. Sukhdev left for home, but the fact remained among the men in the shed that even to ask for a document bearing one’s own name, permission was required.

Nandlal remembered that incident. He now understood that “keeping it safe” and “keeping it with oneself” were two different things.

“I work here,” Nandlal said, “but the name on the card is mine.”

Jagesar laughed. “The name is yours; the document is my responsibility. Go now. There is concrete pouring first thing tomorrow morning.”

That night Nandlal stayed awake for a long time. He had an old photocopy of his Aadhaar document that his wife had tucked between his clothes when he left home. Its edges were worn, but the number was clear. He also found his savings-account number written at the back of his small notebook. He did not have the number of the labour card.

The following Sunday he went to the camp. Salim went with him. The camp was in a community hall across the road. The official sitting inside heard Nandlal’s account and asked, “Why do you not have the card?”

“It is with the man who gives us work.”

The official asked again, “Why did you give him the original card?”

“He got the cards made for all of us. When they came, he kept them with him.”

The official checked Nandlal’s Aadhaar number against the details recorded in the register. Nandlal had to state the name of his village, his father’s name, his year of birth, and the kind of work he did. Some of the details matched.

The official read out the card details one by one. The name was correct. His father’s name was correct. His occupation was entered as construction labour. Nandlal checked the last four digits of the savings account against the small

slip he carried. For the first time he realised that Jagesar's name appeared nowhere on the card.

"If I leave this warehouse job and go to another construction site?" he asked.

The official said, "Your registration identity number stays with you. The work details may change, but the number does not belong to any employer."

Nandlal asked again, "Is it necessary for him to keep the original card?"

"No. A copy can be given at the worksite. It is better to keep the original with yourself."

The official also made it clear that it was not necessary to deposit the original document there in order to inspect one's registration. The first-day image came back to Nandlal: twelve cards in one blue envelope, the envelope inside Jagesar's iron box. The meaning of that envelope had now changed.

Salim looked at Nandlal. Nothing needed to be said between them.

"Can this address be changed?" Nandlal asked.

"Wherever you are staying, those details are yours. Changing work does not change your identity," the official said.

Nandlal repeated the sentence as if to make sure he had heard it properly. "Changing work does not change the identity?"

"No. Even when the work changes, the identity remains yours."

The official wrote down his registration identity number and printed a fresh copy for him. No fee was charged. Nandlal held the paper and looked at it for a long time. It bore his name, the name of his village, and the number that ought to have been inside Jagesar's box.

Outside the community hall, Salim said, "Shall we show this to Jagesar now?"

"Not yet," Nandlal said.

He did not fold the card. There was a photocopy shop outside the community hall. He had three copies made. He put the original paper in a small cloth wallet, one copy in a pouch inside his bedding, gave one to Salim to keep, and kept one with himself.

On Monday Jagesar asked nothing. Nandlal said nothing either.

Two days later, five workers were needed for three days on another section of the new warehouse. That section was being run by a different labour contractor. At lunchtime he came near the shed and said, "Anyone who wants three days of extra work can give me his name this evening. I will need a photocopy of the labour card."

Jagesar immediately said, "These are my men. They work here."

Nandlal said nothing. In the evening, after finishing his regular work, he went to the contractor of the other section and gave him a copy. The man looked at the name and number and gave him two extra hours of work each morning for the next three days. He did not ask for the original card.

When Nandlal received the first day's extra wages in his hand, he understood that this was not merely about three days' money. The card locked inside Jagesar's box was not the doorway to work. The doorway was his own name and number, of which he now possessed a copy.

Jagesar heard about it. That night he called Nandlal over.

"You gave your card to the other section?"

"Not the original. I gave a copy."

"Where did you get the card?"

"From my own registration."

Jagesar's face hardened. "You got it without me?"

"The name was mine. I had another copy issued."

For a few moments both were silent. Jagesar opened the box. Inside was the blue envelope. He took out Nandlal's card and placed it on the table.

"Take it. If you lose it, do not come blaming me."

Nandlal picked up the card. It was the old original. On one corner Jagesar had written a 7 in red ink—perhaps Nandlal's number in his labour list. Nandlal looked at the number and said nothing.

"And the Aadhaar copy?" he asked.

Jagesar looked inside the box. "You want that too?"

"The original was never with you. Keep the copy. But whatever document belongs to me, I will keep a copy of it with me as well."

Jagesar looked at him sideways but said nothing.

The next evening Salim asked for his own card. Jagesar did not give it immediately. Salim said, "I will go to the camp. Nandlal went."

On the third day two more workers asked. By the end of the week, not all the cards remained in the blue envelope. Jagesar kept photocopies; the original cards began staying with the workers.

This change did not suddenly make Jagesar generous. He still kept the wage accounts, still assigned the work hours, and still disliked the men taking work elsewhere. But the additional hold he had possessed merely because their identity papers remained inside his box had loosened.

At the end of the month Nandlal asked for two days' leave to go home. As before, Jagesar asked, "You will come back, won't you?"

“If there is work, I will come,” Nandlal said.

“You are taking the card with you?”

“Yes. I will take the original card with me.”

“Leave it here.”

This time Nandlal did not laugh. He simply said, “You have the copy.”

On the night he was to catch the train, he checked his cloth wallet. Inside were the old, worn photocopy of his Aadhaar document, the original labour card, and the small slip bearing his savings-account number. All three pieces of paper were very light.

In the corner of the shed, Jagesar’s iron box lay where it always had. Its lid was closed.

Nandlal put his wallet in the inside pocket of his shirt and began to roll up his bedding.

STORY 215

The Earthen House

...

On the last evening of Jeth, in the rear hamlet of Sirhuli village, Jitan Paswan was plastering fresh mud onto the eastern wall of his old earthen house. Rain over the past year or two had eaten a narrow hollow into the base of the wall. Bringing water in a brass lota, Phulkumari said, "Why repair it again this much? The roof of the new house should be up by next month, shouldn't it?"

Jitan pressed the mud into place with his palm and smiled. "If the installment comes."

On the other side of the courtyard, the walls of two new brick rooms had already risen to waist height. One side had reached roof level, but there was no roof. A bundle of reinforcing rods rested on two bamboo supports under a sheet of sacking. The new house was being raised where the eastern room of the old earthen house had stood. After the first installment arrived, the family had demolished that room with their own hands. The old bamboo, tiles, and wooden planks had been sorted and kept aside; whatever mud could still be used, Phulkumari had shaped into lumps and applied to repair the rear wall.

On the day the housing assistance was approved, Jitan had folded and unfolded the paper for a long time. He had believed that before the rains at least one room would have a roof. The first installment went into the foundation, bricks, sand, cement, and the mason's wages. On the day the old eastern room was dismantled, thirteen-year-old Lalita had picked up the roofing tiles one by one and stacked them. She had asked, "Why are we breaking the old house before the new one is built?"

Jitan had said, "There is only this much space."

Lalita had asked again, "What if the rains come first?"

Jitan had given no answer. At the time he had been sure the second installment would arrive on schedule.

From the demolished room they saved a wooden doorframe, two thick bamboos, three slender poles, and many pieces of roofing tile. Phulkumari had said, "Just because the new is being built does not mean everything old becomes something to throw away." Some of the bamboo she reused in the rear portion of the thatched roof. The wooden frame was leaned against the courtyard wall.

The mason raised the walls to roof height and presented his account. He said the roof slab could not be poured in stops and starts; the money for

reinforcing rods, concrete mix, and labour would have to be available all at once. Jitan counted the remaining money three times that day. It was not enough to begin the roof. By the time the walls reached roof level, the second installment had stalled.

Ramsevak, who moved around among panchayat work, came one evening. He was not a government employee, but he always seemed to know before others whose measurement would happen when and whose papers would move forward.

"Keep two thousand ready," he said quietly. "It will go in tea and water for the people who write up the measurement. Otherwise the rains will begin."

Jitan asked, "Will I get a receipt for that money?"

Ramsevak smiled as he rose. "If you go looking for a receipt, you should go looking for time as well."

That night Phulkumari kept looking at the bundle of reinforcing rods. There was enough cash left in the house to begin the first stage of roofing work, but if two thousand were taken out, the mason's wages would be held up. "Shall we sell the rods and pay the offering?" she asked.

"No," Jitan said.

After that came five visits to the panchayat office. Twice the person who did the measurements was not there; once the register was not opened; once they were told that the next list was being prepared. The fifth time Jitan returned empty-handed. The walls of the new house still stood without a roof.

The first rain of Asadh came at night. At first the drops were thin, then the sound on the roof grew dense. In the two surviving rooms of the old house, Jitan, Phulkumari, his mother Saraswati, and the two children sat pressed together. Inside the new house, rain fell directly from the sky. Water ran in thin streaks down from the mortar on top of the brick walls.

When the sun came out in the morning, Jitan went inside the new house. The pile of sand in one corner was soaked. The bundle of reinforcing rods had been covered, but the sack over it had drunk in water and become heavy. Phulkumari looked at the pile of tiles saved from the old eastern room. Half were broken pieces, half still whole. The two thick bamboos and three slender poles were there as well.

"Can we cover one room?" she asked.

Jitan looked up at the new brick walls. "Not like a roof. It would not be good to put weight on the walls."

From the veranda Saraswati said, "Then do not put it on the walls. Give it supports inside."

The old wooden doorframe rescued from the demolished room was still standing against the courtyard wall. Jitan brought it inside. Turned upright in another direction, the frame became a central support. The two thick bamboos were laid with one end on a wooden ledge tied along the inner face of the brick wall and the other end resting on top of the frame. The slender poles went across them. Phulkumari selected the old roofing tiles and laid them one by one. Where a piece was too small, she used two layers. It did not cover the whole room, but from one corner to the other a sloping shelter took shape.

By noon, inside the new brick house, a section of the old earthen house's roof was standing again.

Lalita went inside and looked overhead. "Is this the new house or the old one?"

Dusting tile grit from her hands, Phulkumari said, "Ask the rain."

That night there was drizzle again. During the first hour, water dripped through in two places. Jitan set earthen pots beneath them. In the heavier rain one row of tiles shifted, but the bamboo frame remained standing. Half the new room stayed dry. Two sacks of paddy, Lalita's books, a bundle of clothes, and Saraswati's bedding were moved beneath it. The family still slept in the old house, but for the first time the unfinished new house had begun to protect something.

Two days later Ramsevak came again. Seeing the slope of old tiles inside the brick walls, he laughed a little.

"An earthen-house roof again inside a pucca house?"

Jitan said, "Until the rains pass."

"If you had paid the two thousand, you would not have had to make all this arrangement."

Phulkumari was moving a sack of paddy at the time. She did not look at Ramsevak. Jitan too remained silent. The bundle of reinforcing rods was still covered on its bamboo supports.

The rains intensified. The temporary slope of tiles did not remain the same every day. When a strong westerly wind came, three tiles along the edge had to be reset. One night one leg of the doorframe sank slightly into the wet earth. Jitan placed a flat piece of old stone beneath it. Phulkumari tightened the knots on two poles again. Saraswati said, "We broke the old house, and its timber is still holding up the new house."

Jitan did not answer. He kept looking at the bend in the bamboo above.

For a week the clouds remained without a break. The family's daily life was now divided between two houses. When the sun appeared, the children spread a

mat in the new room and studied. When the rain became hard, the things under the tiled shelter were shifted farther into the dry portion. Food was cooked on the old hearth. At night the old mother slept beside the earthen wall of the surviving house, but during the day her bedding remained in the new brick room.

One day Lalita asked, "When the roof is finished, where will these tiles go?"

Phulkumari said, "Whatever survives will go over the cattle shed."

"And this doorframe?"

"We will think then."

There was no plan in that answer—only the old habit of putting whatever survived to work again.

In the first week of Sawan, rain fell for three nights without pause. On the second night the wind was so strong that an old sack tied over the tiles began to flap wildly. Jitan went outside. Phulkumari followed. Soaked by the rain, the two of them tightened the knots on the poles. Lalita stood inside holding a lamp. From the doorway Saraswati called, "If something starts falling from above, do not run inward."

After a while the wind weakened. One tile broke and fell inside, but it struck no one. Jitan picked up the broken piece and placed it in a corner. That night the top of the new house's walls became wet, but the sacks of paddy inside remained dry.

In the morning Phulkumari saw that only the last two sacks of cement meant for the mason remained. She said, "Do not raise the walls any higher with this. Have the top mortar leveled, otherwise the rain will keep washing it away."

Jitan agreed. The mason came for half a day. He added no new bricks; he simply spread a thin layer of cement mortar over the exposed tops of the walls, sloping it so water could run off. After paying his wages, the cash in the house fell further, but the tops of the walls no longer drank in rainwater directly.

The second installment still had not arrived.

One day a notice was pasted at the panchayat office saying that measurements of unfinished houses would be carried out in sequence. Jitan went, had his name entered, and returned. Ramsevak was there, but no words passed between them. It was still unclear when Jitan's measurement would take place.

That evening when Jitan reached home, Lalita was studying in the new room. A thin shaft of light entered through a gap between the tiles. A sack of

paddy stood beside her. In the middle, the old doorframe stood upright as a support.

From outside, Jitan looked at the scene. The new brick walls had risen to roof level and stopped. Inside them, bamboo, poles, a doorframe, and roofing tiles from the old earthen house had joined together to hold back the rain. On the remaining rear wall of the old house, the mud he had applied that evening still showed in a different colour.

It rained again that night. Water dripped in two places through the tiles. Phulkumari placed an earthen pot beneath one and a brass plate beneath the other. Then she went into the old room and lay down to sleep.

By morning there were two finger-widths of water in the plate. The paddy sacks were dry. The reinforcing rods were covered.

The second installment had still not arrived.

Across the courtyard the new brick walls stood. Inside them, the old house's doorframe was still holding up the roof.

STORY 216

The Loan Papers

...

It was an afternoon in Jeth. In the small room of the Parasauni Cooperative Credit Society, the violet ink pad kept by the window had half dried in the heat. Sugna Mahato pressed his right thumb onto it, then placed his thumbprint in the square the clerk pointed out.

Turning the paper around, the clerk said, "Principal: eighteen thousand. Interest: one and a half percent per month. First installment: six thousand, due by the fifteenth of Asin. The remaining two installments later."

Sugna nodded. The irrigation motor's winding had burnt out, and he also needed maize seed and fertiliser. Without the loan, the field would remain empty. He listened as the clerk read the terms aloud; but the thin lines of print before him looked like markings of one colour.

When he returned home, he put the paper in an old tin trunk. The night before taking the loan, the household expenses had been calculated orally. The motor winding and the mechanic's labour would cost six thousand eight hundred; the maize seed a little over two thousand; sacks of fertiliser close to four thousand; the rest would go on diesel, the ploughman, and unforeseen expenses. Sugna's wife Parbati had asked, "Will eighteen thousand be enough?" Sugna had given only an estimate. Once the paper was in his hand, he understood for the first time that estimates too had dates. If the date written on the paper passed, the season of the field would continue in its own place, while the loan account would continue in another.

That evening, when his daughter Revati returned from school, she saw him opening the trunk.

"What is it?"

"The loan paper. The motor will run again."

Before taking the paper from him, Revati looked at her father. "Shall I read it?"

"The clerk read it aloud. Eighteen thousand."

Revati went through the lines slowly. "It is eighteen thousand. The first installment is six thousand. Fifteenth of Asin. Interest is one and a half percent per month."

Sugna smiled. "So the clerk did not lie."

“Where does the question of lying arise? I am only reading the paper.”

After supper that night, Revati took out an old cracked slate. On one side she wrote the ten digits, from 0 to 9. On the other she wrote five words: principal, interest, installment, deposit, balance.

Sugna laughed. “Are you sending me to school now?”

“Learn five words needed to read this paper. Not a whole book.”

For the first three nights Sugna confused 6 and 9. He learnt 2 and 3 quickly. The word “interest” made him hesitate at the beginning, but “balance” came more easily. Revati never marked the loan paper itself; she rewrote the same figures on the slate.

Ten days later Sugna opened the document and recognised 18000.

“This is the principal.”

“Yes, the principal.”

“This 15... is the date?”

“Yes, the fifteenth of Asin.”

“And what is written before the six thousand?”

“First installment.”

He could not read a complete sentence. But the document was no longer a thicket of one colour; some leaves had begun to separate from the others. Revati kept changing the exercises. One day she wrote 12000 with a stick on the dry courtyard earth and asked, “How much is this?” Sugna first said, “One thousand two hundred.” Then he counted the zeros and stopped. The next day she wrote 7080. On the third day she wrote only the word “balance.” Sugna was not learning the full form of each letter; he was beginning to recognise its bends and turns.

One evening Parbati laughed and said, “The daughter studies and studies, and now she examines her father.”

Holding the slate, Sugna said, “This is not an examination. If my thumbprint is on a paper, why should I hear only from someone else how much debt is written on it?”

Revati immediately said, “But if something is not clear, never stop asking.”

Sugna paid particular attention to that one sentence. He was ashamed of not knowing letters, but even more ashamed of what people might think if he asked questions. Slowly he began to understand that the two kinds of shame were different.

With the loan money the motor was repaired. Maize was sown in three katthas of low-lying land and arhar in two katthas. The rain in Asadh was

adequate. By the end of Sawan, the maize ears had filled. By day Sugna inspected the field; at night he returned home and repeated the five words on the slate.

As Bhadon waned, the maize reached the stage for drying. That week a village trader was paying eighteen hundred rupees per quintal. People said, "Hold it until Kartik; the price will rise by two hundred." Sugna's household had a little more than seven quintals of maize.

His younger brother Bhola said, "Selling now would be a mistake. Keep it for a month."

Sugna remained silent. That night he took the loan paper out of the tin trunk. Revati was sitting beside an oil lamp.

"If I do not pay this month, the interest keeps running?"

"Yes. The paper says one and a half percent per month on the outstanding principal."

"What is one and a half percent of eighteen thousand?"

Revati did not answer at once. "Ten percent is eighteen hundred. One percent is one hundred eighty. Half a percent is ninety."

Sugna added 180 and 90 on the slate. "Two hundred seventy."

"Yes, two hundred seventy."

He fell silent again. If the market price rose by two hundred rupees per quintal after a month, seven quintals might bring fourteen hundred rupees more. But that was an estimate. The two hundred seventy rupees of interest were certain, and in the first week of Asin the household's paddy would still not be ready.

The next day Sugna did not sell all the maize. He sold four quintals and brought home seven thousand two hundred rupees. The remaining maize was stacked on a bamboo platform. As they separated out the four quintals, Parbati asked, "If you sold all of it, we could replace the bamboo on the roof over the water side of the house."

Lifting a sack, Sugna said, "If I sell everything, there will be no chance of gaining from a higher price. If I keep everything, the interest will keep eating. Half the grain from the field, half the decision."

That night the sacks of remaining maize were lifted onto the platform. Bricks were placed underneath so the sacks stayed above the ground, because in the dampness of Bhadon the grain could heat up. Sugna now regarded both loan interest and moisture in grain as separate kinds of loss; time had a price in both.

Bhola said again, "The price will rise. You will see."

Sugna said only, "If I hold everything, the loan will not stand still."

At the society office, the clerk calculated the first installment and four months' interest. The amount came to seven thousand eighty. Sugna counted out the notes. The clerk handed him a receipt.

"Thumbprint here."

Sugna pulled the paper toward himself. He did not try to read every line; he searched only for the words he knew. Beside "deposit" was 7080. Beside "balance principal" was 12000.

"Twelve thousand remaining?"

The clerk nodded. "Yes."

Only then did Sugna put down his thumbprint. Outside, he folded the receipt and placed it inside his kurta. Earlier he would have looked for someone to read such a paper to him; today he kept repeating only two numbers to himself. When he reached home, Revati looked at the receipt. She looked at her father's face and asked, "How much remains?"

"Twelve thousand."

"Did you say that after reading the receipt, or because the clerk told you?"

Sugna was silent for a moment. "Both. First I looked, then I heard it from his mouth."

Revati put the receipt in the trunk. "This time the order was right."

Sugna laughed. "Is the order written on the paper too?"

"No. That is learnt at home."

In Kartik the price of maize did rise, but not by two hundred—by one hundred twenty. Sugna sold the remaining grain and arranged money for the household's oil and salt, the weeding of the arhar, and seed for the winter crop. Bhola laughed and said, "Your calculation half won and half lost."

Sugna laughed too. "Accounts are not about winning and losing, Bhola. They are about understanding how much money is tied up where."

Revati heard him from a distance but said nothing.

In Paus, an employee of the society went around the village preparing a list of new loans. Arriving at Sugna's courtyard, he said, "Let us merge the old twelve thousand into a new loan. You will have cash in hand again for the farming season."

He opened a fresh document. Sugna did not immediately extend his thumb as he once would have.

"What principal will be written on the new paper?"

The employee said, "Twelve old, ten new—twenty-two thousand."

Sugna searched the new document for 22000. He found it. Beneath it was a line about interest, but he could not understand the whole sentence.

“Read this line aloud.”

The employee read it. If a new loan was created, the next installment on the old loan would no longer remain separate; interest would run from the new date on the entire twenty-two thousand.

Sugna handed the paper back. “Not now. Let the old twelve thousand remain separate. We have seed at home for the winter crop.”

The employee said nothing. He gathered the paper and moved on.

When Revati heard about it that evening, she asked, “Did you read everything?”

“No. What I did not understand, I had read aloud to me.”

Revati smiled. “That too is part of reading.”

In Phagun, the second installment was paid after the arhar was sold. The wheat in Chait paid the final principal and the remaining interest. On the last day, the same violet ink pad lay in the society’s room; by then its edge had torn. The clerk wrote out the receipt and placed it before Sugna. Sugna first looked for “deposit.” Then “balance.” Beside it was a round digit—0. He put down his thumbprint.

When he reached home, Revati was changing the cow’s water beside the feeding trough. Sugna held out the receipt to her.

“Read it,” Revati said.

“First I will say it.” Sugna placed the tip of his thumb on the line. “Balance—zero.”

Revati opened the receipt and read the entire line. Sugna still could not read a long sentence. But when he placed the papers in the tin trunk this time, he put the loan document underneath and the receipt on top.

The cracked slate did not go into the trunk. It remained in the corner by the window, where in the evening the five words could still be seen like faint lines of lime.

STORY 217

Community Paddy

...

In the middle of Sawan, even at noon the cooking fires in Sonbarsa Tola were being lit late. Transplanting was over, green rows of paddy stood in the fields, but the next round of earnings was still far away. In the homes of the village's agricultural-labour families, the old paddy bins were going empty one by one.

The village community granary stood at the rear of the panchayat building. Two years earlier, after harvest, twenty-two families in the village had deposited paddy according to their means. Some had given five seers, some a paseri, some an entire sack. That year fifteen sacks of paddy remained in the granary. The rule was simple: in a time of distress, paddy would be lent out, and after the new harvest the same quantity would be returned along with one extra seer, so that losses from rats, drying, and transport could be covered.

Two people kept the keys to the granary—the mukhiya, Vimla Devi, and panchayat member Shambhunath Mahato. Alongside farming, Shambhunath also traded in paddy on a small scale. At harvest time he bought at low prices and stored it, then sold in Sawan and Bhadon when prices rose. This year eleven sacks lay in his own storehouse.

The first request came from Budhni Paswan's household. Her husband worked outside the village as a bricklayer, but work had been stopped for a month and a half. There were five people at home. Budhni came to Vimla Devi and said, "There is rice for three days. I do not know when the next wages will come."

The next day two more households added their names. By the third day there were seven families.

Scarcity did not enter every house in the same form. A family with a cow could sell milk and buy some rice. A family with a kitchen garden could stretch its rice by eating pumpkin, squash, or greens. But for a landless household like Budhni's, after reducing the rice there was only the stomach left to reduce. Within three days the midday meal stopped in her house; the children were given rice-water in the morning and rice in the evening. That was why the demand at the panchayat door was not for "charity," but for timely access to their own share of the granary.

Vimla Devi said to Shambhunath, "It is time to open the granary."

Shambhunath had the key tied into the cloth at his waist. He did not refuse at once. He said, "Only half of Sawan has passed. If we open it now, what will remain in Bhadon? The distress may grow worse yet."

The argument sounded reasonable. Vimla Devi too fell silent.

That same evening word came from the market that the price of paddy had risen by another two rupees per seer.

The value of the paddy in Shambhunath's own storehouse rose as well. The next morning he called five members of the panchayat.

"I have a proposal," he said. "The granary's paddy is fetching a good price now. A trader will lift all fifteen sacks at once. Let us sell them. With the extra money, the granary roof can be replaced and a bamboo platform built. Later, at harvest, we can buy paddy again."

Ramdev Yadav immediately said, "The price will rise further. Hold it for another week."

Vimla Devi asked, "And the seven households?"

Ramdev shrugged. "They can buy on credit from the market for a few days."

Shambhunath's argument was not solely about his own profit. He said that if all fifteen sacks were opened and distributed, rats, damp, and uncertainty about repayment could leave the granary empty the following year. The previous year two families had not returned their full paddy on time. Vimla Devi did not deny this. Her concern was that, in the name of "saving for the future," leaving present hunger to the market would also turn the granary's purpose upside down. So the argument did not settle into one person against another; it remained focused on how much to save and when to use it.

The meeting split evenly. Three members said the paddy should be sold; cash would remain in hand and the granary could be improved. Three said the paddy had been stored for times of distress, not for sale. The seventh member, old Phekan Sah, remained silent.

Shambhunath stated his position plainly. "I have held back my own paddy too. If the price rises, I will sell. Holding paddy is no crime. Selling the granary's paddy will increase the village's assets."

Vimla Devi said, "Your paddy is yours. The granary's paddy belongs to everyone. But I too will not decide without doing the arithmetic."

The granary did not open that day.

The next morning Vimla Devi, Phekan Sah, and Budhni had one paseri of paddy weighed on Shambhunath's scale and took it to the village husking mill. They watched with their own eyes how much rice came out after milling, how

much broken grain, and how much husk. After deducting the milling charge, the market value of the rice yielded by one paseri of paddy was calculated at that day's price.

Phekan Sah drew three lines on the earth with his finger.

The first line—the extra gain that would come from selling the granary's paddy to a trader.

The second line—the extra amount the seven families would have to pay if they bought the same quantity of rice in the market.

The third line—the cost of milling and transport.

Vimla Devi counted the figures again and again. Budhni sat silently. Shambhunath too was called.

When the calculation was complete, Phekan Sah said, "Selling the granary's paddy will bring about four thousand four hundred rupees extra. But if the seven families buy the same amount of rice in the market, together they will pay nearly seven thousand rupees extra. Four thousand is coming into one hand of the village, while seven thousand is going out through the other."

Shambhunath kept looking at the lines in the earth.

Ramdev said, "But what about the granary roof?"

Vimla Devi replied, "The roof is not leaking. It can last another year. A stomach cannot be postponed for a week."

This time Shambhunath took out the key and placed it on the table, but said, "Not all fifteen sacks."

The argument began again. In the end they decided that five sacks would be opened in the first round. The seven families would receive paddy according to household size; after ten days the situation would be reviewed. Three sacks would remain untouched in one corner of the granary as a "last reserve." The remaining seven sacks would be decided upon at the next meeting.

When the granary door opened, the smell of paddy came out. The sacks stood on bamboo slats two fingers away from the wall. Vimla Devi opened the first sack. Budhni's share was measured out.

No one called it charity. No one called it a favour. The paddy was a loan; it would return after harvest.

Budhni could not lift the sack onto her head. Her elder daughter and a neighbour held it from either side and carried it home. That evening her cooking fire was lit on time.

Within ten days the paddy in two more households ran out. At the second meeting, another two sacks were opened. By then the market price had risen by another rupee.

Shambhunath sold six of the eleven sacks in his private storehouse to a trader. He made a good profit. No one in the panchayat objected.

But that week something curious happened. Poor families in the village bought less paddy from the market because they had received grain on loan from the granary. Two small shopkeepers in the market tried to raise the price further, but sales remained slow. The price rose, but not as much as the traders had expected.

Shambhunath himself mentioned this at the meeting. "Opening the granary reduced market demand."

Phekan Sah smiled. "Then your six sacks got out at the right time."

Shambhunath laughed too. "Five are still left."

There was no speech about reconciliation. The disagreement in the panchayat did not disappear either. Ramdev still believed there should be a cash reserve. Vimla Devi believed a paddy granary was more useful when it remained in paddy. The decision had been only for that particular Sawan.

By the last week of Bhadon, a total of nine sacks of paddy had gone out on loan. Three sacks remained untouched. Of the other three, one sack showed signs of rat damage, so it was opened, dried in the sun, and filled into a new sack. The granary roof was not replaced, but two weak bamboo slats were replaced by the villagers through their own labour.

In Asin the first early paddy harvest was still far away, but wage work was slowly beginning again. In Budhni's house, as before, the cooking fire began to burn twice a day. Passing the granary, she said, "At harvest, the first paddy will return here."

Vimla Devi said only, "As much as you took, and one seer more."

On the last day of Kartik, Budhni was the first to return. She unloaded a small sack of new paddy and had it measured. The borrowed quantity was returned, with one seer added. The new sack was placed on an empty bamboo slat in the granary.

That day Shambhunath was preparing to sell the remaining five sacks in his own storehouse. The price was good, though not as high as he had imagined in Sawan. As he passed the panchayat building, he saw the new sack. He did not stop. He only glanced at it once and walked on.

Inside the granary there were not fifteen sacks now. The empty spaces were plainly visible. Yet those empty spaces seemed to hold, all at once, the smoke from the cooking fires of seven households in Sawan, ten days of borrowed grain, and the first returned sack of Kartik.

Vimla Devi closed the door. The two keys once again went away separately, tied into two different cloth knots at two different waists.

STORY 218

The First Harvest

...

Four months after returning from Surat, Nayan Mandal stood for so long on the ridge of his field that his father called to him twice from the house. Nayan had spent eight years in a cloth warehouse in the city, counting bundles, and had come home believing that a man who understood numbers ought also to understand the profit and loss of farming. The family owned one bigha and six katthas of ancestral land. His father Ramlochan's knees no longer worked as they once had, so the main responsibility for cultivation was about to pass into Nayan's hands.

Before Asadh, he took a blank page in an old register and wrote down the expected expenses: paddy seed, the seedbed, ploughing, water, fertiliser, harvesting, transport. Against transplanting he wrote: "Twelve labourers, one day." He added the wage rate as well. That single line made the whole account seem clear to him.

Ramlochan looked at the page. "Will you find twelve labourers on the same day?"

Nayan said, "If I pay, why would I not?"

Ramlochan did not answer. Looking toward the seedbed, he said, "Paddy transplanting runs more by the day of the water than by the day of the wage."

Nayan laughed. In the city, work had fixed timings; labourers came, lifted loads, filled trucks. To him a field was work too—only between soil and water.

By the end of Jeth the seedbed had turned green. Nayan had levelled the soil before broadcasting the seed, so the seedlings stood clean and dense. The field was ploughed after the first rain. The second rain filled the ridges. Ramlochan pressed the wet earth between his fingers and said, "The next two or three days will be good for transplanting."

That evening Nayan went out to find twelve labourers.

In the first hamlet, four women told him they had already committed themselves to Budhan Paswan's field. Nayan offered a higher wage. Lalita Devi said, "This is not about the rate. Last week people from Budhan's household came to uproot seedlings in our seedbed. If we leave his transplanting now, who will come to our field next time?"

In the second hamlet he found three people, but they were free only the day after next. At a third place, two people said they could come for half a day, not the whole day.

Nayan returned home and said, “People are leaving money aside and holding on to turns.”

Ramlochan said calmly, “They are not leaving money aside. They are saving time. When transplanting comes, every field asks for hands at once.”

Nayan still did not accept it. What harm, he thought, could two days’ delay do?

On the second day water still stood in the field. On the third the sun turned fierce. By the fourth, the water within the ridges had fallen until only a thin sheen remained over slick mud. Nayan called six labourers from a distant village. Their wages were higher, and he also had to pay for their morning meal and travel. Half the field was transplanted that day. The other half, the next.

By the time the transplanting was finished, the seedlings in the seedbed had grown longer and somewhat hardened. Ramlochan took one plant in his hand and looked at its roots, but said nothing.

Seven days later the rain stopped. Some of the transplanted plants took hold and turned green, but in the half planted later many rows drooped. The surface soil began to crack. Nayan brought water by pump. The pump operator had already committed that day to three other fields, so Nayan’s turn came at night. Until midnight he stood on the ridge with a lantern, guiding water from one section to another.

Two weeks later the field was no longer one colour. The first half was densely green; in the second, empty gaps showed row after row. Nayan tried to fill them with seedlings left in the seedbed. This time Ramlochan too bound his knees and entered the field. Phulo, Nayan’s wife, carried bundles of seedlings from the ridge into the field. It took three mornings.

In his register Nayan crossed out the amount he had first written against “transplanting” and entered a new one: labour from the distant village, meals, travel, extra pump water. The page was filling up.

By Bhadon the paddy had grown, but unevenly. The plants used to fill the gaps were behind the rest. Weeds also rose more thickly in the open soil. Labour was needed again for one round of weeding. This time Nayan tried to arrange people in advance. But some were repaying labour owed from transplanting, others were cutting weeds in their own fields. Those he could find asked more than the rate in Nayan’s original estimate.

That evening Budhan Paswan came to Nayan’s ridge. Looking at the green field, he said, “The crop has survived.”

Nayan showed him the two colours of the field. "It has survived, but why does one field look like two?"

Budhan did not laugh. Sitting on the ridge, he said, "You did not get hands on your transplanting day. It happened to me one year too. After that I tied myself into reciprocal turns with four households. Today I work in his field, tomorrow he works in mine. Labour is not always settled in cash; sometimes money returns, sometimes labour returns."

Nayan asked, "Who counts the hours?"

"Not the hours. The turn is counted. When the field is ready, what matters is whether the hands arrive."

Nayan listened, nothing more. That night he wrote nothing in the register.

At the beginning of Kartik the panicles emerged. In the portion transplanted first, they were full. In the later portion, some plants were still short. Even the harvest could not be done on a single day. After cutting the first part, they had to wait five days. In the meantime a strong wind came one night and bent some of the paddy in the later section.

At harvest, Ramlochan counted sacks in the courtyard. The previous year the field had filled twelve sacks. This time there were eight full sacks, and a ninth a little more than half full. Nayan held some grain in his palm and remained silent for a long time.

Ramlochan said, "The rain was less this year too."

Nayan nodded. "The rain was less in everyone's fields. Half of ours was late."

When the paddy was sold, the costs of seed, fertiliser, water, distant labour, meals, travel, weeding, and harvesting were deducted. The money left was not enough to restore what had been drawn down from Nayan's savings brought from the city.

Phulo asked, "Did you write down our three mornings of gap-filling, and Baba's work?"

Nayan looked at the register. He had not.

Phulo said nothing more.

The following week it was time to harvest the early paddy at Budhan's house. In the morning Budhan's son came to Nayan's courtyard. "Uncle, we need two days of hands."

Nayan first opened the register. At the end of the old account was an empty line. He wrote: "Budhan's harvest—give two days." Beside it he wrote no amount of money.

He and Phulo spent two days in Budhan's field, cutting and threshing. By noon their backs ached; by evening their palms burned. On the third day Budhan himself came to Nayan's house.

"When you need four hands to cut your ridges for the rabi crop, tell me."

For the first time Nayan understood that this promise was not an alternative to wages but another form of wages. A household that gave labour today created the possibility of receiving hands at the needed time tomorrow.

During those two days in Budhan's field, Nayan noticed something else. People from four households were working together, yet no one kept watching a clock. On the first day an elderly woman from one house went home before noon, while a young man from another stayed until evening. The next day the pattern reversed. The midday meal came from Budhan's house, but a woman from a third household had brought pickle from her own home. Nayan tried for a while to add up the hours in his head, then gave up. The account of this group did not balance at the end of each day; balance was sought across the whole season. If water was escaping from someone's field, that household got more hands that day; another time, another household did. For that reason it was difficult to compare the arrangement with a cash wage rate, but within the narrow transplanting window it made labour available when it was needed.

In Paus, Nayan opened a new page for the next kharif season. This time, beside "transplanting," he did not write only a wage rate. First he wrote: "Within three days of the field becoming ready." Under that: "Reciprocal labour: two days given to Budhan's household; four hands to be fixed in advance for my transplanting." Then: "Outside labourers: only to fill any shortage." Finally: "Household labour: count separately."

Ramlochan looked at the page. "Will writing all this make the paddy yield more?"

Nayan smiled. "No. But if hands fail to come at the right time, that will no longer sit outside the account as if it costs nothing."

One morning in Magh, Nayan went out with Budhan to repair field ridges. There was no new crop yet in his own field—only the empty space after harvest, the stubble of the last paddy, and dew.

When he had returned from the city, Nayan had begun the mathematics of farming with money. Now, on the transplanting page of his register, there was a line on which no rupees were written—only four hands and three days of time.

His first harvest had given him less grain, but it had filled the blank space on the page where earlier there had been only: "Twelve labourers, one day."

STORY 219

The Locked Room in Madhubani

...

For the past three nights, as soon as evening fell, Kaushal Paswan had been shutting the western room from the inside. The other rooms of the house remained open; bowls for mixing pigments, bamboo pens, thread, and paper lay on the veranda. But the key to that western room stayed knotted into his dhoti. On the fourth night, when Chandrakala followed him, Kaushal gripped the door latch and whispered, "I will look again tonight. Yesterday the fish's right eye was turned toward the kadamba branch. Earlier it looked straight ahead."

For fifteen years Chandrakala had watched him paint. She was one of the two or three younger painters in the village who had learnt at Kaushal's house how to mix colours, copy the lines of old wall paintings, and make new compositions on paper. But she had never been allowed inside the western room. Kaushal always said the mural there was old, that damp was eating into it, and that even too many people breathing inside could damage it.

That night Kaushal went in carrying a small oil lamp. Chandrakala remained by the door. Paintings filled almost the entire room: a kadamba tree in the centre, two fish below it, vines and leaves all around, birds with spread wings, scarcely any empty space. The colours were old. In some places the earthen plaster had swollen; in others the white rice-paste lines had faded.

Kaushal raised the lamp in his right hand and said, "Look. This wing was not this low yesterday."

Chandrakala watched in silence for a while. "Where was the lamp yesterday?"

Kaushal turned toward her. "I know where my own painting is."

"I asked where the lamp was, not where the painting was."

Kaushal did not answer. He went closer to the wall and held the lamp a thumb's breadth in front of the fish's eye. On the rough surface, the lamp-shadow thickened and thinned the painted lines. A dark trace of old dampness descended from the roof above. Kaushal did not look at it. His eyes had fixed on three tiny white dots near the fish's tail.

"These three dots..." he said, and no more. Then he lowered the lamp.

Chandrakala asked, "They were not there before?"

“No,” Kaushal answered at once. “This painting changes at night.”

Eleven years earlier, the room had not been locked. Renuka Devi had mixed colours there beside Kaushal. She was younger than he was, but her lines were sharper. Fine double outlines along a fish’s body, tiny veins inside leaves, and three white dots at the corner of a tail were characteristic touches of hers. Kaushal used to say they were merely decoration; but when villagers saw those three dots in a painting Renuka had made, they immediately recognised her hand.

At that time a trader from Madhubani had commissioned a large painting for an exhibition outside the region. Kaushal and Renuka had first worked out the composition on the western wall—a kadamba tree, two fish, and a surrounding field of vines. Seeing the wall design, the trader asked for the same subject on paper. Renuka painted the fish in the centre and half the vine-work; Kaushal completed the rest. When the paper painting was finished, only Kaushal’s name was written beneath it.

Renuka had neither laughed nor become angry at first. She had only asked, “Why did you erase my three dots?”

Kaushal had said, “The trader asked for one name.”

“Then the lines should have been from one hand too.”

After that day the matter did not remain small. Praise came from the exhibition, and then two new commissions. In front of others, Kaushal began saying that Renuka painted by looking at his older designs. Renuka objected, but Kaushal was already known, the commissions came through his house, and most of the pigments and materials were kept there. Gradually people accepted his account. A few months later Renuka stopped painting. Then she went back to her mother’s home.

Kaushal covered Renuka’s three dots on the western mural with black paint. After that, the room was locked. He told everyone it was necessary to preserve the old painting. The reason inside him he never fully spoke even to himself.

This year Sawan had been long. The western wall had stayed damp. Parts of the earthen surface and old plaster had swollen and then dried. On the first night Kaushal said the fish’s eye had turned. On the second, he thought one branch of the kadamba had bent lower. On the third, the white empty patch between the vines seemed to have widened by a thumb’s breadth. On the fourth, the three dots had appeared again.

Chandrakala said, “Let us open the room in daylight and look.”

Kaushal’s hand tightened on the latch. “Daylight eats old colours.”

“From opening the door once?”

“You would not understand.”

Chandrakala said nothing more. But the next morning, while sweeping the veranda, she noticed black-red pigment under the nails of Kaushal’s right hand.

She asked, “Were you painting again last night?”

Kaushal wiped his hand on his dhoti. “I touched an old colour bowl.”

That night he entered the room again. This time Chandrakala did not remain outside. She reached the latch and said, “Let me stay inside too.” Before Kaushal could refuse, she had stepped in.

The lamp flame was small. The three dots near the fish’s tail were no longer clear; they looked rubbed and abraded. Fine powder from the earthen wall lay on the floor around them.

Chandrakala bent and touched the powder. “Did this fall because of the damp?”

Kaushal said, “The painting is saving its own form.”

“Or is someone erasing it again?”

Kaushal held the lamp up. The flame trembled. The shadow over the fish’s eye again made it appear to turn. His breathing quickened. “You saw that? It changed again.”

Chandrakala was not looking at the wall. She was looking at his hand. White earthen dust clung between his thumb and forefinger.

That night Kaushal woke again and again. The first time, he thought he could hear a bamboo pen scratching across the wall inside the room. The second time, he thought someone was drawing lines inside the leaves. The third time, he rose to look for the key, but it was not beneath his pillow.

At dawn, the key was already in the western door. The door stood half open.

Kaushal went inside. The three dots near the fish’s tail were gone. In their place were three small deep scratches. The black surface of the wall had been scraped away, and old white plaster showed underneath. One of his old bamboo pens lay on the floor, fresh earth clinging to its tip.

“Someone came in here,” Kaushal said loudly.

Chandrakala came up behind him. “Where was the key?”

“I cannot say.”

“Last night it was in your hand.”

Kaushal turned on her. “Do you think I am lying?”

Chandrakala said quietly, “I am looking at the painting. You are looking at fear.”

Kaushal's eyes remained fixed on the wall. After a long time he said, "Renuka did more work than I did on this painting."

Chandrakala said nothing.

"My name was the one that travelled," Kaushal continued. "Those three dots were hers. I erased them. I told people she made her lines by looking at mine. That was a lie too."

No lamp was burning in the room now. Morning light entered through the open doorway and fell across the wall. In daylight the fish's eye looked straight ahead, the kadamba branch was in its place, and so were the leaves of the vine. Only parts of the damp wall had swollen, and beneath the three scratches near the tail the old white plaster showed through.

Chandrakala asked, "Where is Renuka now?"

Kaushal said, "Somewhere toward the city. I have not met her in years."

"Will you paint again?"

Kaushal did not answer immediately. He picked up the bamboo pen, then carried it out and placed it on the veranda.

That day he did not lock the western door.

For the next three nights Kaushal did not enter the room. On the first, he remained seated on the veranda. On the second, he slept without a lamp. On the third, it rained again; the dark line of dampness on the western wall crept farther downward.

In the morning Chandrakala went inside. The painting was the same. The three scratches were the same. But just below them, in the old plaster, two extremely fine white dots were visible again. Whether they had appeared through damp, through old pigment, or through someone's hand was impossible to say.

Kaushal stood in the doorway. Chandrakala looked toward him. He did not enter. He only said, "Leave it."

From that day onward, the latch of the western room remained open day and night. Kaushal never again discussed whether the painting had changed. But whenever a new student began counting the white dots near the fish's tail, Kaushal would put his hands behind his back and silently keep looking at that place.

STORY 220

The Sound of the Bell

...

Half the night had passed in Sawan. The rain had stopped, but drops were still falling one by one from the tiled roof of the old haveli. Beyond the veranda, mango leaves glistened in the wet darkness. Shailkant Jha lay on his wooden cot with his eyes closed when, as if from inside the wall, a faint metallic note rose.

Ting.

A few moments of silence.

Then twice more—ting, ting.

Shailkant sat up. The head of his cot was pressed against the thick western wall. He strained his ears. Frogs sounded outside, a dog barked somewhere far away, then everything fell silent again.

Long ago the haveli had possessed a network of bells. Fine iron wires ran from the inner rooms to the hall, where small brass bells hung overhead. By the tone of a bell, a servant could tell which room was calling. Now the wires had rusted, most of the bells had been removed, and the one remaining in the western hall had its clapper tied with a cloth cord.

Shailkant lit a lamp and went to the hall. The bell was still. Dust lay on the cord.

In the morning his niece Mrinalini arrived. The haveli was to be divided among three siblings, and before repairs began she was making an inventory of the old objects.

In an offhand voice Shailkant asked, “Did you hear the bell last night?”

Mrinalini shook her head. “I sat on the veranda until late. I heard nothing.”

“It rang three times.”

“Perhaps it was a cowbell outside?”

Shailkant did not answer. He knew the tone. It was not the bell of an animal outside. The old western bell used to sound first with one thin note, then, when the wire tightened, with two short strikes. Three decades earlier he had heard that pattern ten times a day.

On the second night Mrinalini deliberately slept on the veranda. Shailkant lay on his cot. After midnight the sound came again—one note, then two.

“Mrinalini,” he called softly.

From the veranda came her answer. “What happened?”

“Did you hear it just now?”

“No. Nothing.”

Shailkant kept looking at the wall. His palms had begun to sweat.

The next day the carpenter Jitnarayan was examining an old frame near the western wall. Mrinalini mentioned the bell jokingly. Jitnarayan looked up at the old wire. It entered the wall from the hall and was broken somewhere near the outer eaves.

“The wire may still run inside the wall,” he said. “It can vibrate when the wind blows.”

Mrinalini asked, “Then why do I not hear it?”

Jitnarayan tapped the wall. “This wall is thick. It is hard to know where the wire touches timber inside.”

Shailkant remained silent. The head of his cot was pressed against that very wall.

That evening he pulled the cot two arm-lengths away from the wall. He stayed awake late into the night. No metallic note came. Near dawn he fell asleep.

The bell did not sound the second night either.

On the third night a strong easterly wind blew. The cot was still away from the wall, yet sometime after midnight Shailkant thought he heard a very faint ting. This time the sound was so slight that he could not be sure whether it came from a utensil outside, from the old wire, or from memory.

But memory had now opened.

Thirty-one years earlier, Shailkant had kept the accounts and registers of this haveli. The master’s eldest daughter was to be married. The house was full day and night with relatives, cooks, musicians, craftsmen, and servants. The master had given a clear order: during the three days of the wedding, no servant was to leave without permission.

That afternoon Bhola Paswan had come to Shailkant. Bhola used to attend to the western hall when its bell sounded. His seven-year-old daughter Paro had fallen dangerously ill with fever. A child had run from home with word that unless she reached the vaidya before evening, the night might become difficult.

With folded hands Bhola had said, “Let me go for two ghari. I will take the child to the vaidya and return.”

Shailkant knew the master's order. At that moment the master was sitting with guests.

Shailkant had said, "Go quietly. I will watch the western hall. Return before the first watch is over."

Bhola ran home.

As evening grew crowded, Shailkant became caught up in the register, market expenses, and counting utensils. Going to the western hall slipped from his mind.

During the first watch of the night, a bell sounded from the southern room—once, then twice. The master's elderly aunt was asking for hot water. No one went at the first call. No one went at the second. On the third, the aunt herself came to the doorway and called someone.

The master became angry. "Where is Bhola?"

Shailkant's mouth went dry. He could have said: I sent him. But with that one sentence, the blame for breaking the master's order would fall on him. He had charge of the wedding accounts; his employment was new; he had two small children at home.

He said, "He did not tell me. Perhaps he went on his own."

Bhola returned late that night. The vaidya had given medicine to his daughter, and the fever had eased a little. But at the haveli gate the master called him inside and asked, "Why did you leave without telling anyone?"

Bhola immediately looked at Shailkant.

That one look stayed with Shailkant for years.

Bhola said, "I had told Munshiji."

The master turned toward Shailkant.

Shailkant had said, "He told me his daughter was ill, but there was no question of his leaving."

Bhola remained silent for a few moments. Then he said only, "All right."

The next morning the master dismissed him from work. His wages for the previous fifteen days were withheld. After the wedding Shailkant wrote in the attendance register: "Left work at night without informing anyone."

Paro survived. Bhola found work in another village. Gradually the matter was buried beneath other household events.

Only the tone of the western bell was not buried.

On the fourth night Shailkant pushed the cot back against the wall. Mrinalini asked nothing. After midnight the sound rose clearly—one note, then two.

This time Shailkant did not go to the hall. He placed his palm on the wooden head of the cot. There was a very fine vibration in the wood. Somewhere inside the wall, a rusted wire was moving in the wind. Perhaps that vibration was travelling through the wood of the cot to his ear. The clapper of the main bell was tied, after all.

But wood could not answer why he recognised the old pattern so clearly.

In the morning Shailkant said to Mrinalini, “Where is the old attendance register?”

They found the register from the year of the wedding beneath a trunk. Beside Bhola Paswan’s name was Shailkant’s own handwriting: “Left work at night without informing anyone.” Under it was a red line, and fifteen days’ wages had been deducted.

Mrinalini read it and looked at him. Shailkant told her the whole story.

She did not interrupt. At the end she asked, “Is Bhola Kaka still alive?”

“Yes. In the eastern village.”

Shailkant took a separate sheet of paper. He wrote down the year and page of the old register and Bhola Paswan’s name. Then, in his own hand, he wrote: Bhola had informed him that he was taking his daughter to the vaidya; Shailkant had given him permission to go; before the master, Shailkant had denied this out of fear; the old entry in the attendance register was incorrect.

Beneath it he wrote the date and his name.

Mrinalini made two copies. One was kept with the old register. Shailkant put the other inside his kurta.

That afternoon he went to the eastern village. Bhola was sitting in his courtyard splitting strips of bamboo. A middle-aged woman sat near his feet sorting paddy. Shailkant did not recognise her.

Bhola said, “This is Paro.”

She was the same seven-year-old child who had had the fever.

Paro read the paper aloud. Her voice neither sharpened nor softened as she read. After the last line she handed the paper to her father.

Bhola remained silent for a long time.

Shailkant said, “The wages that were withheld—if I calculate them now—”

Bhola raised his hand. “The master withheld the money. What you withheld was the truth. Today you have said it. Leave this paper here first.”

Shailkant placed the paper in his hand.

“The rest another time,” Bhola said.

There was neither forgiveness nor quarrel. Shailkant rose from the veranda and left.

Repairs at the haveli began the following week. When Jitnarayan opened the upper part of the western wall, he found the old rusted bell wire. It had been rubbing again and again against a loose wooden piece near the outer eaves. When the wind was strong, the wire touched an inner piece of wood. The main bell remained still, but the vibration could travel through the wall.

Jitnarayan removed the wire and brought it down. "Now you will not hear that sound at night."

Shailkant looked for a few moments at the coil of wire. "Keep it," he said. "Do not throw it away."

That night the cot stood two arm-lengths from the wall. An easterly wind was blowing too. Shailkant remained awake for a long time. No bell sounded.

After midnight he opened his eyes once. Out of habit he listened. Outside there was only the dripping of water from the roof.

On the trunk beside the head of his cot, a copy of the new correction note lay on top of the old attendance register. Shailkant did not rise to look at it. He closed his eyes again.

Much later, somewhere toward the courtyard, there came a very faint metallic ting of brass—perhaps a bucket tied to a rope, perhaps a cowbell.

Shailkant did not open his eyes.

STORY 221

The Eye of the Pond

...

I had not chosen, of my own accord, to spend the night by that pond. Two fishing nets had been stolen from the western hamlet of the village, and my maternal uncle's son Naresh, who had recently taken the fishing lease, had come down with fever. He said, "Just one night. There is a cot on the watch-platform. I will come in the morning."

The pond was called Kajrahi. No one could say clearly why it had acquired that name. The water was not black, but when one looked toward the deeper part, the green suddenly darkened. It was the last week of Asadh. Half the surface was covered with fine waterweed, and here and there round patches of open water shone through.

At dusk I climbed onto the platform. There was a bamboo staff, two old tin cans, and a lantern. The arrangement against theft was simple: if I heard any rustling, I was to beat the cans, and the noise would wake people in the hamlet.

I first saw the "eye" as the sun was going down.

Among the waterweed was a round dark patch. A pale green ring encircled it, and in the middle lay still water. From a distance it truly looked like a pupil. I laughed. Weed drifts on water, a round opening forms—what more could there be to it?

But as the night deepened, that round patch seemed closer than before.

I lifted the lantern and set it beside the bamboo post. The platform stood roughly twenty handspans from the pond. At dusk the dark circle had been toward the middle; now it was near the western bank, directly opposite me.

Not a single leaf was moving.

I explained it to myself: waterweed floats, and air can move over water even when the eye cannot see the wind. But then I noticed that the weed around it was still. Only the round opening of water was slowly widening.

Then a sound like *bhuk* rose from inside the water. A bubble broke in the centre of the dark patch. Then another. Then three together.

Sweat ran down my back.

"Gas," I said aloud, as though someone else were listening. "Rotting leaves at the bottom. That is all."

Hearing my own voice steadied me a little. I sat on the cot. Half an hour later, when I looked again, the round patch had grown smaller. The waterweed was closing over it again.

No one stole anything that night. But I did not sleep.

Naresh did not come in the morning. His fever had worsened. His wife sent word through a child: "Please watch tonight as well."

By day the pond was ordinary. Fish cut through the water, egrets walked along the edge, two children ran on the embankment. I told no one about the night. I only asked an old fisherman, Bauku Sahni, "Why do round patches of open water appear in the middle?"

Without even looking toward the pond, he said, "Water must be rising from below. It is an old pond. Here and there the earth breathes."

"The earth breathes?"

Bauku laughed. "It is only a way of speaking. You are the educated one."

The word "breathes" stayed caught in my mind all day.

On the second night I drove three slender bamboo stakes into the ground near the platform—one at the northern edge, one at the western edge, and one directly in line with the place where the round patch had been at dusk. I wanted only to find out whether it was truly shifting or whether my eyes were deceiving me.

The moon was behind clouds. The lantern gave little light. Nothing happened through the first watch of the night. Then a long rustling moved across the pond, as though some heavy thing had passed beneath the waterweed.

A round patch opened—this time two of them.

Two eyes.

I regretted the word at once. They were merely two round openings of water. One to the left of the bamboo marker, the other to the right, with a narrow strip of weed between them.

I climbed down from the cot and went to the edge. The soil was damp. Stretching out the staff, I touched the water. Nothing. Inside one of the round openings, a small fish flashed. Then the weed shifted, and the opening on the right closed.

"Alive," someone inside my mind said.

I stepped back.

In the middle of the night I felt as though there was water beneath the platform. The cot was moving. I rose and lit the lantern. There was no water,

but the two front bamboo posts of the platform had sunk slightly into the wet earth.

The pond's edge seemed a handspan closer than before.

I pulled the cot farther back.

At dawn I examined the three bamboo markers. The round patch from dusk was not where it had been. But one of the two openings from the night really had appeared beside the western stake—I remembered that clearly.

I looked at my footprints in the mud. Some led toward the pond, some back. That was natural; I had walked to the edge myself during the night.

Only one print disturbed me.

It ran from behind the platform toward the pond, from a place I could not remember walking.

The mark looked like my sandal.

During the day I pressed my sandal into the earth and compared them. The size matched. But dozens of people in the village wore sandals like mine.

Naresh's fever was coming down that day. He said, "From tomorrow I will watch. You stay only one last night."

I could have gone home that evening if I had wished. I did not. Even now I cannot clearly say why. Was fear drawing me in, or was I searching for proof of my fear? The difference between the two had become very small.

On the third night I did not light the lantern. Once my eyes adjusted to the darkness, the pond seemed clearer. The waterweed lay like a grey sheet; the exposed water looked black.

For a long time that night the eye did not open.

I began to feel relieved. Then something beneath the platform went thak. After that came bhuk.

Far out on the water a round patch opened. Not one—three. Then two closed. One remained.

It slowly widened.

I did not rise. I only watched.

A star trembled in the middle of the black circle. A cloud moved across it and the star disappeared. Then fine ripples rose on the surface. It seemed to me that the ripples were moving not outward but inward—as though the pond were drawing its own water into itself.

My breath grew short.

"The earth breathes."

Bauku's words sounded again.

Then someone coughed behind me on the embankment. I turned—there was no one.

When I looked back, the round opening had vanished. The whole surface was covered with waterweed.

At that moment I became convinced that the pond had been waiting for me to turn away.

I climbed down from the platform and started toward home. I had gone perhaps ten steps when a loud splash came from the water behind me. I did not turn. Twenty steps farther, another came.

Then the earth gave way beneath my right foot.

A small section of the bank collapsed into the pond. I sank into mud up to my knee. Had I still been sitting on the platform, the collapse would have reached exactly to its front post.

I do not clearly remember how I got free. When I reached home, my dhoti was covered in mud and waterweed clung to my right palm.

In the morning Bauku Sahni and Naresh came with me to the pond. The earth on the western bank had indeed collapsed. Bauku pushed a staff into the water and said, "It has become hollow underneath. An old spring must have shifted this way."

"Round openings kept appearing in the water at night," I said.

"When a spring rises, the weed moves aside."

"In three places at once?"

He shrugged. "Who knows where water travels under the bottom?"

I remained silent.

Two days later labourers filled earth along the western bank. Some of the waterweed was cleared. The platform was moved farther back. Naresh began keeping watch at night.

He never saw the "eye"—at least, he never told me he did.

A week later I went to Kajrahi again at dusk. The pond looked much more open. There was less weed, so there was no question of a round dark patch forming where the weeds parted.

I tried to feel ashamed of the fear I had felt on that first night.

Then Bauku called from a distance, "Do not stand there. There is a spring underneath."

I stepped back two paces.

At that exact moment, in the clear water, a round ring formed. There was no waterweed to move aside. The surface simply rose from below, darkened for a single instant, then flattened again.

I saw it.

Whether it saw me, I cannot answer.

I know only this: after that day I stopped calling the pond alive. But sometimes at night, when the smell of water comes without any wind, my right foot steps backward of its own accord.

STORY 222

Inside the Wall

...

For three days the rain had been falling on and off. A broad damp stain had spread down the eastern wall of Shashibhushan Chaudhary's old house, and the inner plaster crumbled at the touch of a finger. There was no question of selling the house; once this year was over, he intended to come and live here with his wife. So he had called Kanak, the mason, to open the damaged portion and rebuild it.

Kanak tapped the wall lightly with his hammer, listening to the sound. At one place the note changed.

"It is hollow inside here," he said.

Shashibhushan stood by the doorframe. "Open it. Remove as much as has gone bad."

When the old earthen plaster came away, two courses of brick appeared. Black soil had been packed between them. Kanak pushed in his chisel. Earth spilled out, and with it a small object dropped to the floor.

It was a clay bird, no longer than a finger, with a rounded belly, a thin tail, and a whistle-hole in its beak. A faded streak of blue still remained along one wing. There was a small chip beside the beak.

Shashibhushan bent down at once.

"This is mine."

Kanak did not laugh. He only asked, "You recognise it?"

"I was seven. It had been brought from the fair. Manjari kept asking for it. I would not give it to her. The beak had chipped—look, here. I hid it in a gap in this wall."

The moment he said the words, the scene rose before him with complete clarity. There had been sunlight. Paddy was drying in the courtyard. His mother wore a yellow sari. Manjari was running behind her, crying and crying. He had come to this eastern wall with the bird clenched in his fist, lifted a loose brick near the bottom, and slipped the bird inside. Then his mother had called from a distance, "Shashi, have you snatched her toy again?"

The memory was so clear that Shashibhushan saw no reason to doubt it.

Kanak wiped the bird with a cloth and placed it in his hand. “The bricks look as though they were laid a very long time ago. The earth between them may have been packed in later.”

“Yes, the wall was opened once,” Shashibhushan said. “After the great flood.”

That evening Manjari arrived. She now lived in Benipatti, but hearing that the old house was being repaired, she had come for two days. Shashibhushan placed the clay bird before her.

Manjari smiled at first, then drew her brows together.

“Where did you find this?”

“Inside the eastern wall. My bird.”

“This was yours?”

“Don’t you remember? You used to ask for it. I hid it.”

Manjari picked up the bird and turned it over in her hands. “I had a clay bird. But mine had a red stripe. It broke at Nani’s house.”

“No. This was yours. You were crying for it.”

“Why would I have been crying? Had you taken my bird?”

Shashibhushan stopped. The scene rose again, but this time the bird was in Manjari’s hand, and he himself was snatching it and running away. His mother was calling after him. Even the direction of the sunlight seemed to have shifted.

“The wall was opened after the flood,” he said, trying to steady the subject.

Manjari said softly, “Which flood?”

“The year Baba replaced the rear roof.”

“That year I was at Nani’s house. The eastern wall was not opened. The rear wall was.”

Shashibhushan grew irritated. “How would you remember everything?”

“How do you?”

It was a simple question, but Shashibhushan spent the whole night looking for its answer.

The next day Kanak opened more of the wall. The old masonry looked uniform all the way through. Here and there were earth and brick dust, but there was no gap into which a child could have pushed a hand from outside.

Kanak said, “This object must have been trapped inside while the wall was being built, or it may have fallen in from above sometime later.”

Shashibhushan immediately said, “There used to be a small window here.”

Kanak stopped his hammer. “A window?”

“Yes. Low down. I used to sit on it.”

He placed his hand against the middle of the wall. He could see it distinctly now—two wooden shutters, a neem tree outside, his knees on the sill, the same clay bird in his hand. He used to blow into the bird’s beak and the whistle came out very thin.

Kanak went outside and examined the brickwork. “There is no sign that this section was ever opened.”

Shashibhushan himself went out. From the eastern side the wall was straight. The old courses of bricks near the bottom were unbroken. There was no trace of a window.

“The plaster must have been changed many times,” he said.

Kanak said nothing.

That afternoon Manjari found him sitting in the courtyard with the bird in his hand.

“You are remembering the low window at Nani’s house,” she said suddenly.

“Which window?”

“There was a low window at Nani’s. A neem tree stood outside. You used to sit there and blow whistles.”

Shashibhushan’s hand stiffened.

“The bird at Nani’s was red,” he said.

“Perhaps. I do not remember the colour. But the window was not on the east. It faced north.”

“No. East.”

“See? You are mixing this house with that one again.”

Shashibhushan wanted to become angry, but the courtyard of his grandmother’s house suddenly appeared so clearly that the anger would not hold. There really had been a neem tree there. One thick root rose almost to the window. He remembered placing a foot on that root and jumping outside.

But why, inside that memory, was his mother standing there? It would have been natural for her to be at Nani’s house. But why could he hear his father’s voice? Had his father gone there that day or not? And had Manjari been crying for a red bird, or a blue one?

That afternoon Shashibhushan went toward Sakri to the old potters’ quarter. Nunu Kumhar had grown old; his son now worked the wheel. Shashibhushan showed him the bird.

Nunu brought it close to his eyes. “Birds like this used to be made in great numbers. Not all from the same mould, but nearly the same in form. See this

blue stripe? That kind of colour was put on with cheap market blue. You might have found twenty such birds in twenty houses.”

“And this chip on the beak?”

“What kind of identifying mark is a chip on a clay toy?”

Shashibhushan did not laugh. He wrapped the bird again in his gamchha.

When he returned home, Kanak had finished opening the damaged section of the eastern wall. Shashibhushan did not mention the old window again. He only asked, “Did you find anything else inside?”

“Nothing else.”

“Any gap?”

“There was an empty space between two bricks higher up. The bird could have fallen through there and lodged below. But who can say when it fell?”

That answer ought to have reassured Shashibhushan. Instead, it deepened his unease. If the bird had fallen from above, how could he remember so clearly hiding it there as a child? And if the memory had been made afterward, where had the chipped beak, his mother’s yellow sari, and Manjari’s crying come from?

After supper that night he placed the bird on the table. His wife Vimla asked, “Why are you thinking so much about this broken toy?”

Shashibhushan said, “I thought this was my memory.”

“Does memory have a name written on it?”

He was not pleased by Vimla’s answer. Yet afterward the sentence kept returning to him.

Sleep did not come for a long time. He closed his eyes and tried to summon the first scene again—the courtyard with paddy drying in it, his mother, the yellow sari, Manjari crying. This time, instead of paddy, the courtyard floor was freshly plastered with cow dung and earth. Then the neem tree appeared. Then the neem vanished. His mother’s yellow sari became red.

Shashibhushan opened his eyes.

Until then he had believed memory was like an object stored inside—wherever it had been placed, there it would be found. Now it seemed to him that perhaps memory was like that wall whose plaster was renewed again and again; the bricks underneath might be old, but the shape on the surface could be new.

At dawn he felt embarrassed by his own comparison. A metaphor was not truth.

On the third day of repairs Kanak began laying new bricks. Shashibhushan stood holding the bird.

Kanak joked, "Shall we put it back inside?"

"Not inside again."

The mere idea of putting the bird back into the wall made him uneasy, as though if the object went inside again, one version of his memory would become permanent.

When Manjari was leaving, she looked at the bird.

"Keep it. It must have belonged to someone."

"You do not want it?"

"Even if it had been mine, you should keep it. You remember more of a story around it than I do."

"A story, or a memory?"

Manjari did not answer.

The new plaster began to dry. The eastern wall became smooth again. For two days Shashibhushan stood before that section searching for something—the height of the old window, a gap between bricks, some trace of childhood. He found nothing.

He placed the bird on the wooden shelf where books were kept. Sometimes he took it in his hand, then set it back. Once he raised the hole in its beak to his lips, but did not blow.

It was not the sound he feared. He feared that the moment he heard it, some other scene might return to him—one whose truth he would have no way to test.

One evening after the rains had stopped, sunlight fell on the new plaster for the first time. Shashibhushan took the bird down from the shelf and looked at the faded blue streak on its wing.

For a long time he wondered: before the wall had been opened, had he remembered that blue streak at all? Or had the memory turned blue only after the bird came into his hand?

He found no answer.

And now he was no longer certain whether he had remembered the chip in the beak from before, or only from the instant the bird fell into Kanak's palm.

STORY 223

Soot

...

As the first smoke of dawn rose, Malati's eyes went to the wall above the hearth. Only the previous evening she had scrubbed that wall well with ash and a wet cloth. The white limewash had shown again. But now, amid the black smudges, a crooked shape had emerged—half a circle above, a long vertical line below it, and two short cuts to the left.

"It has come back again," twelve-year-old Neelu said.

Malati stopped the ladle in her hand. "It has not come back. Soot has settled there."

When Neelu moved closer to the wall, Malati snapped, "Do not touch it."

Her voice came out sharper than she had intended. In the courtyard, her elder sister-in-law Sudha, who was sorting paddy, turned and looked.

"Was it there yesterday too?"

"It is soot," Malati said. "If a hearth burns, there will be soot."

The old kitchen of the house had been reopened four days earlier. During the previous rains, the tin roof of the new kitchen had started leaking, and a carpenter had come to replace the bamboo supports. Until then the cooking was being done in this mud-plastered room. The hearth was old. Its smoke rose toward a small vent high above, but because the room had remained closed for years, soot had accumulated inside. On the first day everyone's eyes had burned. On the second the smoke was somewhat less. On the third Neelu had seen a "sitting person" on the wall.

Everyone had laughed.

Malati had not.

Sudha came near the wall and examined the stain. "To me this does not look like a person. It looks like a heron bending forward."

Neelu protested, "No, Kaki. Look at the head. It has one hand raised."

Malati kept pushing dry pigeon-pea stalks into the hearth. The flame rose, smoke swirled upward, and for an instant the edges of the black figure deepened.

Her palm grew damp.

It was not a person.

Nor a heron.

It was a sign.

Half a circle, one long line, and two short cuts on the left.

Malati had drawn that sign when she was sixteen.

By evening the story of the wall had spread through the house. When Malati's husband Raghunath returned from the fields, Neelu ran first and pulled him into the kitchen.

"Babu, look."

Raghunath narrowed his eyes at the wall. "This is simply the path of the smoke. Where the plaster is smooth, less soot settles; where it is rough, more settles."

"Then why does the same shape appear every day?" Neelu asked.

"Because the same hearth burns every day and the wind moves in the same direction."

The answer was straightforward. It ought to have reassured Malati. Yet after supper, when everyone else had gone to sleep, she carried a lamp into the kitchen again.

The figure on the wall was fainter now, but the long line and the two short cuts remained distinct.

She raised her finger in the air and traced the movement of the lines. The central vertical stroke was straight. Two short cuts stood to its left. A half-circle was above.

The meaning of that sign had been: "The back way is open."

Years earlier, when Malati had come into this house as a young bride, her sister-in-law Gauri had been seventeen. Gauri had a fierce hunger for reading. Maithili books, old magazines—whatever she found, she read. The older people in the family believed that education up to Class Eight was more than enough for a girl. Marriage arrangements for Gauri had begun. She was made to leave school and learn household work.

At that time the kitchen was the safest secret place in the house. At night, after everyone slept, Gauri and Malati sat there and read. The mud hearth would have gone cold, embers still glowing beneath the ash, and in the thin light of an oil lamp Gauri opened her books.

"Bhauji, if they let me sit the examination, I will pass," she used to say.

Malati would laugh and answer, "Read first. Worry about passing afterward."

In those days there was a small bamboo gate behind the house. Gauri's school friend Kamala often came with old question papers and books. When

Kamala was forbidden to come during the day, Malati and Gauri devised signals. If the back gate was open, Malati would draw in the hearth soot one long line, two short cuts, and a half-circle—"The way is open." If someone was near the gate, she would complete the circle—"Not today."

Only Malati added a small turn on the right.

Gauri used to say, "That has become your signature."

The memory was so clear that Malati's throat went dry.

But one thing was not clear.

When had she last made the sign?

The next morning Malati scrubbed the wall with reetha foam and the blunt back of a scraper. The thin coat of lime emerged again. When Raghunath saw it, he said irritably, "Why are you ruining the wall?"

"The old soot has gone deep inside."

"Kanak the mason will come and replaster it. Why put so much mind into this?"

Malati did not answer.

That day Sudha lit the hearth. Malati deliberately stayed away from the kitchen. At noon Neelu came running.

"Ma! It is forming again."

Malati did not go.

In the evening, when she entered on the excuse of fetching water, the figure was there again. But this time the half-circle above seemed wider. The central long line was broken.

Malati remembered their old signal. A broken vertical line had meant nothing.

"This is not the sign I used to make," she said softly.

From behind came Sudha's voice. "Then what sign is it?"

Malati turned. Sudha was standing at the doorway.

"Nothing. I used to draw lines like this in childhood."

"Your childhood in this house?"

Malati understood at once that she had made a mistake.

"It was only a way of speaking."

Sudha watched her for a while, then began gathering the ash from the hearth.

"Gauri Didi used to draw lines on the wall too. I remember faintly."

The lota almost slipped from Malati's hand.

“You remember?”

“Not much. I was small then. Didi used to hide books in the kitchen and read. Once Babuji caught her.”

An old night opened inside Malati.

Two days before Gauri’s examination, Babuji had found a book. There had been no beating in the house, but his voice had been so cold that Malati had never forgotten it. Gauri was told, “From now on, not one step outside.”

That same night Gauri had come into Malati’s room and whispered, “Bhauji, Kamala will bring the question paper tomorrow. Open the back gate just once.”

Malati had become frightened. Everyone in the house was alert. She said, “Not today. Put it off for now.”

“By then the examination will be over.”

“What if I am caught?”

Gauri had said nothing.

In the morning Malati had gone to the kitchen. She raised her finger to make the signal in soot, but at the last moment she drew a complete circle — “Not today.”

Kamala did not come.

Gauri did not sit the examination.

A few months later she was married.

It had not been a disaster that tore the family apart. Gauri was alive, living with the joys and sorrows of her own family. She visited her mother’s home two or three times a year. Later she resumed her studies through adult education, but she had not taken the examination that year. No one had blamed Malati. Gauri had not blamed her either.

Yet for years Malati had carried a different version of the memory: that on the final morning she had drawn the sign meaning “The way is open,” and she simply did not know why Kamala had failed to come.

Now the wall was disagreeing with her memory.

On the third day Gauri herself came to her mother’s home. Neelu immediately told her the story of the soot. Gauri went into the kitchen, looked at the wall, and burst out laughing.

“All this commotion over this?”

Malati kept trying to read her face. “Does it look like any sign to you?”

Gauri went closer. “There is one long line, two short cuts to the left, and a circle above. Why?”

“Do you remember nothing?”

Gauri thought. “We used to make lines here as a game. You used to write letters with ash.”

“The back gate?”

Gauri’s laughter stopped. “I remember that too.”

Malati’s heart gave a sudden thud.

“What sign did I make the last time?”

Gauri looked at her. “Who keeps such an old thing in mind?”

“I think I made the sign that the way was open.”

“Perhaps.”

“But Kamala did not come.”

Gauri bent toward the mouth of the hearth and stirred the ash. “Kamala did come.”

Malati went still.

“When?”

“In the morning. You had gone to fetch water. She handed me the book from the back. I took it.”

“Then the examination?”

“I did not go.”

“Why did you stay back?”

Drawing a circle in the ash with the handle of the ladle, Gauri said, “I chose not to go.”

Malati could not believe it. “You had been forbidden.”

“Yes. But Kamala said her uncle would take me on his bicycle. The back way was open. I could have gone.”

“And you did not?”

Gauri shook her head. “No.”

“Then why did you not go?”

Gauri remained silent for a long time. “Fear. That was all. Later it felt easier to let the blame remain with the house. Naming one’s own fear was harder.”

Malati looked at the wall. The figure no longer seemed quite so frightening. But one question remained.

“Do you see these two little cuts on the left? I used to make those.”

Gauri moved close and looked. “You? To me they look like streaks in the smoke.”

That evening Kanak the mason came. While scraping the upper plaster, he found at one place a thin, smooth, oily layer.

He said, "Old ghee or oil must have splashed here. Soot settles differently on such a surface. However much you wipe it, if the grease has gone deep, a shape can reappear."

Raghunath told Neelu triumphantly, "Heard that? Not a ghost—oil."

Neelu looked disappointed. "But how did the shape form?"

Kanak shrugged. "Someone with oil on a hand may once have touched the wall. It could be an old hand-mark."

Malati looked at her right hand. Years ago, when she used to make those signals, she also filled the mustard-oil lamp. There might well have been oil on her fingers.

The explanation was possible.

Very possible.

Fresh plaster was applied. Nothing remained on the white wall.

Before leaving that night, Gauri said to Malati, "Bhauji, whether or not you opened the way that day does not make the entire account of my life."

Malati said, "But in my mind it had become the entire account."

"The mind keeps accounts, not a ledger."

Gauri left.

The kitchen remained closed for two days so the new plaster could dry. On the third morning the hearth was lit again. Malati deliberately did not look at the wall. She washed rice, ground spices, and answered Neelu's questions.

At noon, when the smoke had thinned, Neelu quietly caught her arm.

"Ma."

Malati looked.

On the new white plaster, roughly one handspan to the left of the earlier place, a thin soot-mark had formed. It did not yet have a definite shape. Only a narrow upright line, two small smudges to the left, and something like a blurred circle above.

"The same again?" Neelu whispered.

Malati looked at it for a long time. Then she pushed the wood a little farther into the mouth of the hearth.

The direction of the smoke changed. For a moment the black line on the wall broke apart.

"No," she said. "Nothing is certain yet."

But when she lay down to sleep that night, she felt the old smell of mustard oil on her right forefinger.

She brought the hand to her nose. There was no smell.

Even so, for a long time her finger lay straight outside the edge of the blanket, as though it had paused in the darkness before completing a sign.

STORY 224

The Lantern

...

South of Jhanjharpur, half a kos from the Kamla embankment, stood an old cooperative seed store. New zinc sheets had been fitted to the roof, but the western gate, the heavy wooden beam, and the iron spikes inside still belonged to another time. Before the rains, paddy seed, sacks of lentils, and bags of fertiliser accumulated there. By day the place rang with farmers, weighing, receipts, and bullock carts; as soon as evening fell, the whole compound emptied into silence.

Ramautar Sahni had been the watchman there for thirty-two years. He was nearing seventy, yet whenever anyone spoke of giving up night duty, he would say, "Everyone sees the work of the day. There are fewer witnesses to the work of the night."

The store now had electricity. Two bulbs hung in the veranda, and a brighter light had been fixed over the gate. Even so, before dusk Ramautar always brought out his old lantern.

It had a brass fuel chamber, glass bound with wire, and three small holes in the upper cap. He filled it with kerosene, trimmed the wick, lit it with the first match, and hung it from a hook just inside the western gate.

Birendra, the new assistant watchman, found this strange from the very first day.

"There is electricity," he said.

Running a palm over the glass, Ramautar replied, "You do not pass a night by trusting electricity."

"There is a hand torch too."

"A hand torch needs a hand to find it. A lantern stays where it is."

Birendra laughed. He thought it was simply an old man's habit.

But soon he understood that it was more than habit. Ramautar watched the lantern flame with the attention a farmer gives newly transplanted paddy. If the wind rose, he checked the glass frame. If the oil dropped to half, he refilled it even in the middle of the night. If the flame sank even slightly, he raised the wick.

The strangest thing was that he did not put it out immediately when the first morning light appeared. The eastern sky would whiten, birds would begin

calling, and only then would he open the gate, look once all around outside, and finally pinch down the flame.

During the first week Birendra asked no questions. In the second week, one night a westerly wind rose. The zinc sheets began to creak. The electricity flickered twice. The third time the bulbs went out.

The lantern kept burning.

Ramautar rose from his cot and went straight to it. The flame was steady, yet he opened the glass and inspected the top of the wick.

"There is plenty of oil," Birendra said.

Ramautar did not answer.

About half a watch later, a ghass—ghass sound came from the direction of the western gate, as though some heavy sack were being dragged across the ground.

Birendra picked up his staff. "Who is there?"

Ramautar's hand suddenly closed around his arm. The grip was so hard that Birendra started.

"Do not open the gate."

"It could be a thief."

"No. I will not open the gate."

"Then why?"

Ramautar looked at him for a few moments. Then he loosened his grip and said, "There is bamboo lying near the roof. The wind must be dragging it."

Birendra peered through a gap in the gate. It was dark. The sound did not come again.

In the morning he went to the western wall. Two thin bamboo poles really did lie there, but there were no fresh drag marks on the earth. Beneath the gate he saw only old water tracks and the prints of rats.

By day, among the farmers who came for seed, the incident was forgotten. At dusk Ramautar lit the lantern again.

Two hundred handspans east of the store stood a small tea stall. Its owner, Kisun Yadav, had known Ramautar for years.

One afternoon Birendra casually asked, "Why does Ramautar Kaka never let the lantern go out at night?"

Kisun stopped while straining tea. "What did he tell you?"

"That electricity cannot be trusted."

A half-smile appeared on Kisun's lips, then disappeared. "That part about trust is true."

“Is there something else?”

“It is an old store. There are many old stories too.”

“What old story?”

Kisun looked at the two farmers sitting at his stall and changed the subject. “Keep the gate shut at night. Snakes move about more during the rains.”

Instead of satisfying Birendra, the answer increased his curiosity.

A few days later the elderly accountant Harinarayan came to inspect the seed accounts. Asking Ramautar’s age, he said, “Still on night duty? You were here even at the time of the relief-rice theft, weren’t you?”

The bunch of keys in Ramautar’s hand jingled once, then became still.

Whether Harinarayan noticed the effect of his remark was unclear. He walked on toward the weighing room.

Birendra asked from behind, “What theft?”

Checking the gate latch, Ramautar said, “A very old matter.”

“Here?”

“If a store holds seed, paddy, and fertiliser, there will also be stories of theft.”

“Were you on guard then?”

This time Ramautar looked at him. The rims of his eyes were red. “Watch your own night.”

That evening the lantern was lit earlier than usual.

In the last week of Bhadon, clouds hung for three days. On the third night it rained so hard that spray reached well inside the veranda. The electricity had gone at dusk. One hundred twenty-seven sacks of new seed were stored inside, so both watchmen stayed awake.

Ramautar had taken the lantern down from its hook and placed it beside his cot.

Around two in the morning, the zinc sheet on the western side rattled violently. A gust entered the veranda. The lantern flame lengthened, leaned downward, then steadied itself.

Ramautar immediately shielded it with both hands.

“The glass is closed,” Birendra said.

Ramautar seemed not to hear him.

A second gust came. This time a heavy drop of water fell from some joint in the roof directly onto the lantern. The glass rang. The flame turned blue for an instant and went out.

Darkness filled the veranda all at once.

A sound came from Ramautar's mouth unlike anything Birendra had heard from him before—not a cry, not a groan, but as if someone sinking into sleep had suddenly held his breath.

“Kaka?”

Ramautar remained silent.

Birendra searched his pocket for the matchbox. Just then there came a thak from the western gate.

Then twice more.

Ramautar whispered, “Three times.”

“What did you say? Say it again.”

“That night too, it struck three times.”

Birendra's hand stopped on the matchbox.

“Who struck it?”

In the darkness Ramautar said, “I had lowered the wick myself.”

Outside, the rain kept beating against the gate. Inside, the smell of the seed sacks was heavy.

“Kaka, shall I light a match?”

“Wait.”

“Why wait?”

“Do not open the western gate.”

“I am not opening it.”

Ramautar's breathing quickened. “There were nine sacks. First they said six. Then they said nine. I had counted them.”

Birendra said nothing. He felt that if he interrupted with a question, the old man would fall silent again.

Ramautar's voice came in fragments through the dark.

“The Kamla had risen. People on the embankment were asking for rice. The store was full of relief rice. The secretary came at night. He said—leave the western gate open for one watch. A vehicle will come. Orders from above.”

“Did you open it?”

A long silence.

“I gave him the key.”

The gate rattled again. This time Birendra understood that the wind was shaking a loose ring in the latch.

Ramautar said, “He told me to put out the lantern so the vehicle would not be seen from a distance. I lowered the wick.”

Birendra felt the matchbox growing damp in his palm.

“And in the morning?”

Ramautar’s voice dropped lower. “In the morning they blamed Lakshman. He was a night labourer. He had been asking for his back wages. His gamchha was found near the western wall. Everyone said he must have brought the men.”

“What did you say?”

By then the rain outside had begun to lessen. The darkness inside felt even thicker.

“I said I had seen him near the gate that night.”

Birendra’s body became still.

“Had you seen him?”

After a long time Ramautar said, “The lantern was out.”

After those five words, only the sound of dripping water remained in the store.

Birendra struck a match. The first stick was damp. The second lit. In the yellow light Ramautar stood a few paces from the gate, both hands stretched forward as if stopping someone. His eyes were not on Birendra. They were fixed on the empty gate.

The lantern wick was lit again. One side of the glass was fogged with water.

Ramautar slowly sat down on the cot.

Birendra asked, “What happened to Lakshman?”

“He was taken to the police station. Beaten. Released after two days. Then he took his family and left for another place.”

“Did he ever come back?”

Ramautar did not shake his head. He only said, “No. I will not open the gate.”

“Did you look for him?”

“How many places could I go asking only a name? I was young then. First I was afraid the truth would come out. Later I felt ashamed. Much later, when I wanted to look for him, his house had already been sold.”

Birendra thought Ramautar would stop there. But staring at the lantern flame, he said, “If he came back, something might become right.”

The moment the words came out, he seemed startled by them. He corrected himself at once. “It might.”

Birendra offered no consolation. At that moment consolation seemed out of place.

The lantern burned until dawn.

The next day the loose ring above the western gate was tightened. Tar was spread over the leak in the roof. The night-time thak stopped. The ghass—ghass sound was not heard again either.

But Ramautar's rule did not change.

Before dusk, the lantern was lit. Before the oil fell to half, it was refilled. If the flame sank, the wick was raised.

Birendra no longer asked questions.

By Kartik, his temporary watch duty was due to end. On his final night the sky was clear. The paddy harvest had begun, and the smell of burning straw came from distant fields. The electricity remained steady. The new lamp above the gate was so bright that the lantern flame looked pale beside it.

Around midnight Ramautar said, "I am going behind to wash my hands and face. You stay here."

He hung the lantern on the hook and went away.

After a while the flame began to shrink. Birendra rose and went to it. There was enough oil. The wick had merely slipped down.

He reached out, then stopped.

For a moment he thought he heard something heavy dragging near the western gate.

He listened.

There was nothing.

Beyond the veranda lay the fields after harvest. A dog barked far away. The electric light remained steady.

Birendra raised the wick a little. The flame became round and steady again.

Ramautar returned. He looked at the lantern, then at Birendra. He asked nothing.

At dawn the eastern sky brightened. The gate was opened. The first farmer was approaching in a bullock cart with empty sacks to collect paddy seed. Birendra tied up his bag.

Ramautar still had not put out the lantern.

The first ray of sunlight fell on the wood of the western gate. The electric lamp was still burning. Day was fully clear.

Then Ramautar reached out and pinched down the lantern flame.

A thin thread of smoke curled inside the glass, rose, and disappeared.

As Birendra crossed the gate, he looked back once. Ramautar was hanging the empty lantern on the hook. From that distance it was hard to tell whether his hand was trembling or whether the iron hook itself was loose.

STORY 225

Seven Steps

...

My printing press usually closes at about half past ten at night. All day it is filled with the rumble of machines, the rustle of paper, the clink of type, and the voices of people; but the moment the last worker crosses the gate, the building suddenly begins to show its age. Wooden beams creak, old iron sounds in a tired voice, and the smell of damp from the basement at the back rises all the way upstairs.

There are seven steps down to the basement.

I knew that number very well. Before locking up at night, I had to go down and check the valve on the main water line. During the rains, if it was left loose, water could rise through the wall and ruin the paper. For twenty years this had been part of my routine.

But from that week in Sawan onward, another sound began to come after the seventh step.

The first night I paid no attention to it.

I shut down the machine, put the files into the cabinet, checked the rear door, and went downstairs carrying a lantern. The electricity had been out since evening. As I descended, the sound of my sandals on the steps was distinct.

One.

Two.

Three.

Four.

Five.

Six.

Seven.

My foot came down on the level brick floor.

Immediately afterward, behind me, there was a thak.

I turned. I raised the lantern. All seven steps were empty. In the doorway above there was only darkness.

I thought a wooden plank must have shifted. I tightened the water-line valve and went back upstairs.

The same thing happened the second night.

This time I had not been counting. My mind was elsewhere: the next day five thousand copies of a wedding invitation had to be delivered, and the red ink was running low. I reached the bottom and bent beside the pipe. Then, from above, came one clear thak.

As though someone behind me had just stepped down from the final stair.

I straightened. I listened. Nothing.

On the third night I took Sudhir with me. He had been running the press machine for ten years and laughed immediately at things like this.

I said, "You go down first."

He descended the seven steps and stood below. There was no extra sound.

"Did you hear anything?"

"No. Nothing."

I followed him down.

From one to seven, my footsteps sounded. I reached the floor.

Thak.

Sudhir lifted the lantern and looked upward. "What was that?"

I felt some relief that the sound was not something invented by my ears alone.

"You heard it?"

"Yes. But why did it sound like a footstep?"

For half an hour the two of us searched around the basement. To the left of the stairway was a thick brick wall; on the right, an old wooden brace. When we struck the brace, it gave a hollow sound, but not the same thak. We shook the beam above. We opened and closed the water line. We dragged the iron chest aside. The sound did not come again.

The next day I wrote the numbers one through seven in chalk along the edges of the steps.

Sudhir joked, "If we find an eighth, shall we give that one a number too?"

I did not scold him. I only said, "We will see tonight."

The matter stayed in my mind throughout the day. The machine kept running, paper kept being cut, the red borders of the wedding invitations kept printing, but every now and then I saw those seven chalk numbers before me.

That evening an old compositor named Hiralal came by. His eyesight had weakened now, but once he had set type in this very press. He belonged to my father's time. He lived on his small plot of land and his son's earnings, and from old attachment he sometimes came to look in on the press.

I showed him the staircase.

“Hira Kaka, were there always only seven?”

At first he did not understand the question. Then he looked down.

“Seven.”

“Are you certain?”

“I have walked these steps for forty years. Seven.”

I said, “I seem to remember eight when I was a boy.”

Hiralal laughed. “You boys used to make up stories about the eighth one.”

Something inside me shivered.

“What story?”

He looked at me. “Have you forgotten? You used to tell the younger boys that after the seventh, an eighth step appears in the dark.”

I kept staring at the chalked number seven.

With that sentence, a night from very long ago opened in my mind.

I had been sixteen then. My father ran the press. My maternal cousin Gopal had come to stay with us for two months. He was an average student, but quick with his hands. He had learnt to lift the cases of lead type, count paper, and spread out printed sheets.

Gopal was not afraid of the dark. If anything, he was braver than I was.

That irritated something small inside me.

Only later does one understand how trivial the causes of childhood jealousy can be. My father praised Gopal’s work: “The boy learns as soon as he sees a hand do it.” It seemed to me that someone was proving himself better than I was inside my own house.

One night there was a large wedding job. The size-twelve lead type was stored downstairs. My father told Gopal to bring up two cases. I went with him carrying the lantern.

At the bottom, Gopal lifted one case in each hand. I took the lantern and started climbing ahead of him. On the fourth step, some foolish impulse seized me. I turned the wick down. The light became very dim.

Gopal said, “Raise it. The type will spill.”

I said, “Are you frightened?”

He laughed. “You are.”

The answer stung.

I put the lantern out completely.

The basement sank into absolute darkness.

Gopal stopped. He had heavy cases in both hands. He said, "Naval, give me light."

I stood on the upper steps laughing.

Then I said, "There is an eighth after the seventh. Mind your foot there."

It was a lie I had told younger boys before—the eighth step that appeared only in darkness.

Gopal became serious. He kept climbing slowly.

Five.

Six.

Seven.

The moment he passed the seventh, he had already reached the level floor above. But my words were in his mind. Carrying the heavy cases, he lifted one more high step—a step under which a stair was supposed to be, but was not.

His body tipped backward.

Both cases fell clattering down the steps. Gopal's left wrist struck the corner of the doorway.

He did not scream loudly. He simply sat down.

I lit the lantern.

Lead letters were scattered all over the stairs. Gopal was holding his wrist. There were tears in his eyes, but he did not cry.

My father came running. The wrist had swollen. Gopal was taken to the vaidya. The bone was not broken, but the sprain was severe. For nearly twenty days he could not work in the press.

No one ever learnt that I had deliberately put out the lantern or that I had invented the eighth step.

Gopal did not tell anyone either.

Once I asked him, "Why did you not tell them?"

Eating with his right hand, he said, "What would I have said? That you did something stupid?"

He even laughed.

Perhaps that laugh saved me. Slowly the incident turned into an ordinary accident. Years passed. Gopal finished his studies and went away to other work. In my memory the swelling of his wrist faded.

But the words "eighth step" never went anywhere.

That night, while we were closing the press, Sudhir said, "Tonight I will check the water line."

I answered at once, "No. I will go."

He shrugged and went home.

I locked the rear door alone. The electricity was on. There was no need for the lantern this time. A bulb burned above the staircase, and another small light below. All seven steps were clearly visible.

I placed my foot on the first.

The chalked numbers had half rubbed away.

One.

Two.

Three.

Four.

Five.

Six.

Seven.

I reached the bottom.

No sound came.

I checked the water-line valve. Then I looked up. Empty steps. White light. No shadow.

A faint laugh rose in my mind. Darkness, rain, an old memory—human beings add their own fear to such things.

I turned and was picking up the cloth kept beside the pipe when, behind me, there came a thak.

Perfectly clear.

My hand stopped.

This time the sound seemed to come from the old wooden brace beside the right edge of the seventh step.

The next morning I called Shyamkant, the son of Ramlakhan the carpenter. He climbed and descended the staircase again and again. Nothing happened under his weight. Then I went down.

As soon as I passed the seventh step—thak.

Shyamkant crouched below and felt the wooden brace. In the right corner of the seventh step, an old iron spike had worked half loose. When my weight came down, the wood compressed slightly; a moment after my foot left it, the brace returned to its position and the spike struck the brick.

He smiled. “We found the eighth step.”

I did not laugh.

Shyamkant removed the spike, fitted a new one, and tightened the wooden brace. I went down five times to test it. After the seventh step there was no thak.

The extra sound was never heard again.

The cause was known now—wood, an iron spike, weight, and a moment's delay.

But knowing the cause did not erase the memory.

Sometimes, after the machine has stopped, a piece of wood gives a sound and my ears pause for an instant. Sometimes the upper door moves in the wind and I remember the eighth step. But now I do not run to investigate.

One thing has changed.

At night, when I descend to the basement, I have stopped counting the steps.

Even after my foot lands on the seventh, my body sometimes pauses for a moment, as though some old counting inside me has not yet finished.

Then I place my foot firmly on the level floor, look toward the light, and go on with my work without counting.

STORY 226

The Locked Clock Tower

...

My watch-repair shop stands in the old market of Benipatti. Directly opposite, across the road, rises the clock tower whose four faces have been stuck for years at the same time—four twelve. The glass has turned grey, pigeons sit on the hands, and rust has spread so thickly over the iron gate below that its original colour can no longer be guessed.

All day I open and close people's wristwatches. Tiny screws, fine wheels, springs, hands—such small parts of time pass through my fingers. Yet for twenty-eight years I had not set foot inside the clock tower standing before me.

Everyone in the market knew, in his own version, why the tower had stopped. Some said the cord of the main weight had snapped. Some said the toothed wheel above had cracked. Some said the town could not raise the money for repairs.

I knew the actual reason. The mechanism had grown worn, the repair was expensive, and in the end they simply stopped it. The iron hammer that struck the hour bell had been tied back separately.

I knew this well because, at that time, I had been an apprentice to Raghunandan the watchmaker. Raghunandan Kaka looked after the tower, and twice a week I climbed up with him.

In those days the clock tower did more than tell the time. Its eight o'clock bell in the evening marked the close of the old market's grain auction. The moment the eighth stroke fell, traders stopped bidding, clerks closed their ledgers, and labourers covered the sacks.

I was seventeen then, and I understood enough to know when the hands of a clock could be stopped.

I had never told anyone this.

It was a night in the last week of Kartik. The market was full of heaps of paddy, smoky oil lamps, and the smell of raw mustard oil. Banshi Sah was an old acquaintance of my father. Two of his bullock carts loaded with paddy had been held up on the road. If they did not arrive by eight, that day's auction would close.

He stopped me behind the clock tower and gave me five rupees.

“Hold it for fifteen minutes,” he said. “No one will be harmed. Let the goods arrive, then start it again.”

Five rupees was a great deal to me then.

I climbed the tower. Raghunandan Kaka had gone below for tea. I removed the small pin that governed the minute movement. The clock stopped at seven fifty-nine.

Below, people in the market kept glancing up at the clock.

Banshi Sah’s carts arrived.

The paddy was unloaded.

The bidding began.

I put the pin back.

But the mechanism did not start immediately. A spring had caught. I panicked.

Then from below the hour bell began to sound—once, twice, three times...

Eight times.

The hands were still fixed at seven fifty-nine.

Raghunandan Kaka came running up. He understood that the striking train and the hands had gone out of step. He asked me, “Did you touch anything?”

I said, “No.”

The next day the blame fell on Majid Mian, who attended to the hour bell. People believed he had caused it to strike at the wrong time. Majid Mian kept saying that his hand had never touched the rope, but no one believed him. A week later he was removed from the job.

Later, when Raghunandan Kaka opened the mechanism, he must have understood that the movement had been stopped. Whether he suspected me, he never said.

Only once he told me, “If a clock is wrong, it can be repaired. It is harder to keep a lie sitting on time.”

I spent the five rupees long ago.

The sentence remained.

Some years later Majid Mian moved to Darbhanga. Raghunandan Kaka died. The clock tower itself was closed. The striking hammer was tied back. The clock stopped at four twelve, and gradually the people of the market ceased to look at it as something that told the time. It became merely an old building.

I opened my shop opposite it.

Twenty-eight years passed.

That night was at the beginning of Aghan. A westerly wind had blown all day, and by evening clouds had gathered. By nine the market was nearly empty. I was repairing the spring of an old man's wristwatch. The electricity failed twice, then the light steadied.

After the old man left, I bolted the shop from inside. My eyes went, without intention, to the clock tower.

Four twelve.

As always.

Then the bell rang.

The first stroke was so deep that the glass of my shop trembled slightly.

I stood up.

The second.

The fine tweezers slipped from my hand onto the table.

The third stroke.

The fourth.

I did not want to count, but the counting continued by itself.

The fifth.

The sixth.

The seventh.

My throat went dry.

The eighth.

After the eighth stroke the market was silent again.

For a few moments I stood gripping the table. Across the road all four hands of the clock tower remained fixed. The gate was closed. There was no movement in the dark window above.

I went outside.

At the road bend, Kishun, the tea seller, was closing his stall.

"Did you hear it?" I asked.

"Hear what?"

"The bell."

He rubbed behind his ear. "There was one loud metallic sound. I thought a sheet of tin had fallen."

"One?"

"Yes. How many did you hear?"

I did not answer.

Just then Ramvilas, a home guard returning from the police station side, came past. I asked him too.

He said, "I was far away. It sounded as though something struck once."

Only one stroke.

I had heard eight.

I went home that night but could not sleep. Majid Mian's voice kept returning to me—"I did not touch the rope."

What was strange was that I did not remember his voice that clearly from the actual night. Now, in memory, I heard the words distinctly, even though it was possible he had never said exactly that sentence.

In the morning I asked the municipal store for the old key to the clock tower. I gave as my reason that a loose sheet of metal above might fall into the market.

By midday an employee named Sitaram arrived with the key.

The moment the gate opened, the smell of dust came out. Pigeon feathers, dried droppings, and cobwebs covered the stairs. After twenty-eight years I climbed up again.

In the first chamber stood the main clock mechanism. Rust covered the iron wheels. The thick cord of the weight had been cut. I immediately recognised the small place in the minute movement from which, as a boy, I had removed the pin.

I did not touch it.

Sitaram climbed higher toward the bell.

"The hammer is tied back," he said.

I went up. The heavy iron hammer really had been pulled back with an old wire. But the wire was not fully taut. When the wind moved the wooden lattice above, the whole frame trembled faintly.

Sitaram pushed the hammer with his hand. It did not reach the bell.

"That cannot make the sound," he said.

I ought to have felt relieved.

I did not.

Then a gust of westerly wind came. The lattice creaked. A loose iron strip near the roof vibrated and struck the outer rim of the bell.

Tann.

A single stroke.

My body shivered.

Sitaram laughed. "That is all. That must be what happened last night."

I kept looking at the bell. “Once?”

“Once. If the wind comes again, it will strike again.”

Inside myself I counted to eight.

The wind did not send another gust.

As I came down the stairs, that old scene of seven fifty-nine formed again in my mind. But now some details were wrong.

I remembered removing the pin with my right hand. As I descended, it occurred to me that perhaps I had used my left.

I remembered that the five-rupee note was green. What colour a five-rupee note had been then, I could no longer say with certainty.

I remembered Majid Mian looking me in the eyes and saying something. It was possible he had not looked at me at all.

Only the eight strokes were clear.

When we reached the bottom I told Sitaram, “Have the iron strip tightened.”

The next day he brought a mechanic, and the strip was secured. After that no unfamiliar metallic sound was heard from the clock tower.

But the matter inside me did not end there.

I tried to find Majid Mian’s address in Darbhanga. Through very old acquaintances I learnt that he had died many years earlier. His son Samad was still living there.

I went to meet him.

Samad did not recognise me. I introduced myself. At the mention of the clock tower, he smiled.

“Abba used to tell many stories about that clock.”

I asked, “The story of that night?”

“Which night?”

I understood then that the incident which had echoed inside me for twenty-eight years had perhaps never been the central story of their household.

I had gone there intending to tell him everything—the five rupees, the pin, the eight bells, the lie.

But in Samad’s courtyard, his grandson was playing with a small brass clock, opening it apart.

Samad said casually, “Abba used to say that the fault of the clock tower was put on him. Later he found another job. That is why he came to Darbhanga. He used to say—even a wrong thing can sometimes change the road.”

This was not forgiveness.

Nor was it absolution.

I told him the truth.

Samad remained silent for a long time. Then he asked only, "Why did you tell me after so many years?"

I found no answer.

By the time I returned to Benipatti, evening had fallen. There was no need to open the shop, yet I stood for a while near the gate.

Across the road the clock tower rose in darkness.

All four hands at four twelve.

I looked at my wristwatch.

Five minutes to eight.

I stayed there.

Eight o'clock came.

No bell rang.

I resisted the urge to count to eight.

A bicycle bell sounded on the road. A dog barked in the distance. Somewhere a metal plate clattered inside a house.

The clock tower remained silent.

For the first time it occurred to me that perhaps I would never know whether the tower had truly struck eight times that night, or whether the eighth bell that had remained trapped inside me for twenty-eight years had added the other seven sounds behind one actual metallic blow.

I closed the gate of my shop.

The clock tower did not tell the time.

But that night I did not try to stop time by fifteen minutes again.

STORY 227

White Feather

...

By late afternoon in Magh, the westerly wind in Jhanjharpur grows so strong that reed screens, roofs, and old rafters all begin to sound in their own voices. My seed shop stands at the eastern edge of the market. All day I weigh sacks of paddy, wheat, lentils, and mustard seed. In the evening I bring the account ledger home, because I do not leave the reckoning of cash and credit in anyone else's hands.

The room where I sleep and write the accounts has one window. In Magh it usually remains shut. I latch the wooden shutters from inside and also stuff a thin cloth along the top so that the westerly wind does not send the papers flying.

I found the first white feather in that room on the morning of the ninth of Magh.

It lay on my ledger. It was so light that it slid aside when I breathed out. About two fingers long, milk-white, with a slender shaft. At first I thought it had come out of the pillow. But my pillow was filled with cotton, not feathers. The quilt on the bed was stuffed with pieces of old cloth.

I picked up the feather and threw it into the courtyard.

I did not think about it again that day.

The next morning a feather lay on the ledger again.

Exactly beside the page where, the previous night, I had entered a credit sale of mustard seed.

I checked the door latch. It was fastened from inside. Both window shutters were tightly shut. There was no rat hole in the room; the floor was lime and brick, not earth. The roof was made of wooden rafters and tiles, but from inside it was almost entirely covered with bamboo strips and earthen plaster.

I asked my wife Saroj, "Did you put a feather in the room?"

She was sorting paddy in the courtyard. The question struck her as strange.

"Why would I put one there?"

"There was one yesterday too."

"There are pigeons flying all over the house. It must have stuck to some cloth."

It was an easy answer. I should have accepted it. But the second feather was just as completely white as the first.

I did not throw it away. I pressed it between two blank pages of the ledger.

On the third day, when I returned from the shop, I shook out my dhoti, shawl, and bag thoroughly outside the gate. Before entering the room I washed my feet. I shut the window. I placed the ledger in the middle of the table. The first feather I folded into a small piece of paper and put inside the box.

In the morning another white feather lay on the table.

This time I did not touch it with my fingers. I called Saroj.

“Look at this.”

She looked at the feather, then at me.

“Where did it come from?”

“How did it come in?”

“With the wind.”

“The window was shut.”

“Is the roof of this room a roof, or the lid of a trunk?”

She laughed. I did not.

I put a tiny dot of kohl on the shaft of the feather. Then I folded it into a second piece of paper and placed it in the box beside the first one. I shut the lid and tied the key into the knot at my waist.

On the fourth morning there was no feather on the table.

I felt an unfamiliar relief. I told myself that was all: something must have come from a cloth or through a crack in the roof.

But in the evening, when I opened the ledger to write the accounts, a white feather fell out from between the pages.

There was no kohl dot on its shaft.

I opened the box at once. Both folded papers were inside. The first contained a feather. The second contained—nothing.

The folds of the paper did not seem to have been opened. I turned it over again and again. The feather with the kohl dot had vanished.

“Saroj!”

She came in. I showed her both papers.

“You must have taken it out yourself.”

“The key was with me.”

“Then how is the paper empty?”

She had no answer. Neither did I.

I picked up the new feather that had fallen onto the table. I examined the shaft carefully. Completely clean. No kohl.

So this was a third feather, and the second feather from the box had gone somewhere else.

That night I could not write the accounts.

I took pride in my business because of numbers. If a one-maund sack of paddy was short by two seers, I could often estimate it simply by lifting the sack. If a digit was reversed in the credit ledger, I would remember it at night. Yet within two days the number of feathers was slipping out of my hands.

On the fifth night I decided not to sleep.

Saroj said nothing about my stubbornness. She left water in a brass lota and filled the mustard-oil lamp. "Stay awake if you want, but you still have to open the shop in the morning," was all she said.

I bolted the door. I checked the window shutters. I cleared the table. The ledger was shut. The box was shut. The lamp flame was steady.

The first watch passed.

Outside, dogs barked two or three times. Somewhere far away came the bell of a bullock cart. The westerly wind kept moving over the roof. Nothing happened inside the room.

Around midnight there came a faint srrr near one of the wooden rafters.

I looked up.

The sound did not come again.

I took the lamp and went beneath the rafter. In the earthen plaster I noticed an old hole about the width of a finger, something I had never paid attention to in daylight. Perhaps a cord for a hanging fan had once passed through there; I had a dim memory that in my father's time a cloth punkah had been used in summer.

I stuffed a piece of cloth into the hole.

Then I returned to the table and sat down.

How many times my eyes closed, I do not know. I believed that I had stayed awake the whole night. But in the morning Saroj said she had heard me snoring in the third watch. I objected at once. She did not argue.

There was a white feather on the table.

The piece of cloth had come halfway out of the hole.

This feather had a grey mark at one end. I looked for the kohl dot. It was not there.

I began to feel angry with my own eyes.

I decided to put every feather into a separate piece of paper and write Devanagari numerals on them—I, 2, 3. But when I opened the box, there were actually only two feathers inside. One white, one with the grey mark. The kohl-dotted feather was nowhere.

“Where is the third?” Saroj asked.

“The third was the one I found on the table just now.”

“Then these two and that one make three.”

“No. One had already vanished.”

“Vanished, or did you throw it away?”

I opened my mouth to answer, but the scene from the first day was no longer entirely clear. I was certain that I had thrown the first feather into the courtyard. I had pressed the second into the ledger. I had marked the third with kohl. Then there had been a new feather on the table... or had the order been different?

I checked the dates in the ledger. There were accounts for the ninth, the tenth, the eleventh. But I had not written a single line about the feathers.

I had been trusting only memory.

For the first time, I became more afraid of my counting than of the feathers.

At midday I closed the shop and brought Mahendra the carpenter home. He understood the old joins of the roof and rafters well. I showed him the small hole.

He did not laugh. He set up a ladder and climbed. He pulled out the cloth and pushed a thin bamboo rod into the hole. It went almost one and a half handspans inside.

“There is a hollow passage here,” he said. “The old punkah cord must have run through this route up to the roof.”

“Does it open outside?”

“We will have to see.”

The two of us climbed onto the roof. Under the tiles, near a rafter on the eastern side, the earthen plaster had broken. Mahendra lifted two tiles. Inside lay dry straw, dust, and a small heap of white feathers.

In the middle was the dried body of a dead pigeon.

It was not completely white. The body feathers were grey, but the fine down beneath them was white. It had probably entered through a gap in the tiles and been unable to get out. How many days the body had been there was impossible to say.

Mahendra traced the passage with the bamboo rod. "The westerly wind comes through this gap. Feathers can slip down through the old cord channel. What difference does a shut window make? The wind has found a road from above."

The simplicity of the answer made me laugh.

I had placed the fear of several nights upon a dried pigeon and an old cord-channel.

Mahendra removed the dead bird and the loose feathers and brought them into the courtyard. I dug a pit and covered the bird with earth. The outer gap of the channel was sealed with mud and brick dust. The small opening inside was plastered over as well.

That evening the room seemed quieter than before.

I opened the box and counted the feathers that remained. Two. I had taken none from the pile Mahendra had removed. I folded the two feathers back into paper and put them in the box.

This time I gave the key to Saroj.

"Keep it," I said. "For one night I no longer trust my own counting."

She took the key. "Trust your sleep, not the feathers."

That night we slept as usual.

In the morning the table was clear. The second morning too. For an entire week not a single feather appeared.

The fear faded, but one question remained: where had the feather with the kohl dot gone?

I stopped looking for it.

On the last day of Magh, while gathering up old ledgers in the shop, I felt something caught between two pages. I opened them.

There was a white feather.

A black dot on the shaft.

For a long time I looked at it. Whether it was the same feather, or another feather that had somehow acquired a kohl mark, was difficult to say. The ledger had travelled between the house and the shop in the meantime. Perhaps the feather had already been trapped between the pages. Perhaps I myself had put it there and forgotten.

I did not put it back in the box.

A small fire was burning behind the shop. I laid the feather on it. It shrank first, then, together with the black dot, turned to ash in an instant.

That night I shut the room's window. I bolted the door. I put out the lamp.

As sleep came, once, from the direction of the roof, I heard a very faint srrr.

I did not open my eyes.

Not because I believed another feather would come.

But because I was no longer certain that, if I found something in the morning, I would remember its number correctly.

STORY 228

The Last Picture

...

In the old quarter of Laheriasarai, at the bend where the road turns toward the Kali temple, stood a small shop called Prabha Studio. Vinod's father had given it that name. After his father died, Vinod Jha took over the shop. Wedding photographs, small portraits for identity cards, family group pictures—these kept the household going. But there was one kind of work he rarely spoke about himself.

When an old person died in someone's house, or when sons and daughters working far away wanted to see the face one last time, someone from the family would call Vinod. He would make a photograph of the dead. Sometimes amid flowers and garlands, sometimes on a cot in the courtyard, sometimes just before the bamboo bier was lifted.

For this work Vinod used his father's old wooden camera. The new camera was lighter, but the old one had a large ground glass, and fine lines appeared more clearly in the pictures made with it. Draping the black cloth over his head, he would correct the inverted image on the dim glass, then insert the photographic plate.

That day it was an afternoon in Bhadon. Someone came from a house in Bahadurpur. The eldest woman of the family had died that morning. Her two sons were in Delhi and Surat; the cremation could not be delayed until evening. The family wanted a final picture.

Vinod tied up the old camera, the tripod, and two glass plates and went.

There were not many people in the courtyard. The rain had stopped, but water still dripped from the veranda. The body was wrapped in white cloth, the face left uncovered. Tulsi leaves and Ganga water had been placed near the forehead. A granddaughter sat in silence.

Vinod set up the camera. He pulled the black cloth over his head and looked at the scene on the ground glass.

First the flower garland appeared upside down, then the dead woman's face. He was turning the focusing screw when, in the right-hand corner, another face emerged.

A young man's face.

Narrow cheeks. Eyes looking straight toward him.

Vinod immediately threw off the black cloth.

There was no one to the right of the camera. Three women sat on the veranda, but there was no young man.

He put the cloth over his head again.

The face was gone. There was only the white cloth, the flowers, and the dead woman's still face.

"Is something wrong?" the woman's son-in-law asked.

"No," Vinod said, tightening the screw. "I am adjusting the light."

He made the photograph.

That night in the shop, as he developed the plate, his hands trembled slightly. The picture came out clear. The dead woman's face, the garland, the veranda pillar—everything was there. The unknown young man was nowhere.

Vinod told himself there must have been a water stain on the glass. The damp was heavy in Bhadon.

Three days later a call came from the town hospital. The body of an elderly man found near the railway line had not been identified. The police wanted a clear photograph of the face before the cremation.

This time Vinod could have taken the new camera. Without thinking, he picked up the old one.

The body lay in the rear veranda of the hospital. The cloth was pulled away. Vinod planted the tripod, adjusted the glass, and put the black cloth over his head.

The old man's face appeared upside down on the dim glass.

And behind it, the young man again.

This time more clearly.

A narrow nose. A broad forehead. The hair on the left side of the head seemed wet.

Vinod stepped backward and became entangled in the cloth.

The hospital attendant started. "What happened?"

"My eyes played a trick on me."

"Did the body move?"

"The body did not move."

He was lying, but he himself could not tell exactly what the lie concerned.

The photograph again came out clear.

No young man.

That evening Vinod set the camera on the shop table and tried to open the glass. The rear frame had not been opened since his father's time. The thin brass screws at the four corners had seized. He oiled them but did not force them.

His father used to say, "If this glass takes a blow, the eye of the camera will go dark."

The next day, after his assistant Harimohan arrived, Vinod said, "Bring the black cloth. I want to test something."

He seated Harimohan on a chair and adjusted the camera. Harimohan's face was clear on the glass.

There was no unknown young man.

"Now wrap this white sheet around yourself."

Harimohan laughed. "Are you making me into a corpse?"

"Sit quietly. It will take only a moment."

Harimohan wrapped the white sheet up to his neck. Vinod went beneath the black cloth.

Something grey appeared in the right corner of the glass. At first only what looked like a forehead. Then hollows for eyes. Then a nose.

Vinod's mouth went dry.

"Do not move."

"I am not moving at all."

Vinod pulled off the cloth. Harimohan sat wrapped in the sheet.

"Do you see the photograph of any person here?" Vinod asked, pointing toward the ground glass at the back.

Harimohan brought his eye close. "There are stains. This old glass has plenty of marks."

"Not a face?"

"Whose face?"

Vinod did not answer.

All that day he tested the camera with different things placed before it. A black cloth, a red gamchha, a green sack—nothing. The moment a white sheet was spread, the grey face emerged in the right corner of the glass. The more he searched for it, the clearer it seemed. The moment he looked away, it became only a stain again.

When they were closing the shop that night, Harimohan said, "Replace the glass. It is old."

The simple solution seemed somehow wrong to Vinod. He felt the problem lay in the glass, yet he could not decide whether, if the face vanished after replacing it, he would feel relief or disappointment.

For two days he refused work involving the dead. When a family came to call him, he said the camera was broken.

On the third day an elderly man from Majhaulia came himself. His wife had died during the night. Their son was in Nepal. With folded hands the old man said, "Not one good picture of her was made while she was alive. At least do this much now."

Vinod could not refuse.

He picked up the new camera.

Then put it down.

He took the old wooden camera instead.

All the way to Majhaulia he remained irritated with his own decision.

The house was small. Near the dead woman's head lay her old red vermilion box. Her husband kept saying, "Turn the face a little to the right. She looked better from that side when she was alive."

Vinod set up the camera and went beneath the black cloth.

The white cloth gleamed. The dead woman's face was still.

The young man appeared again in the right corner.

But this time Vinod did not become afraid.

He looked carefully.

The young man's face was not behind the body. It seemed to lie upon the glass itself.

When Vinod shifted his own head to the right, the scene changed, but the young man's face did not.

He turned the focusing screw. The dead woman's face blurred. The young man remained unchanged.

Something suddenly opened inside Vinod's understanding.

"One moment," he said from behind the camera.

He held his palm in front of the white cloth. On the glass his palm appeared inverted. But it did not cover the young man's face.

So the face was not part of the outside scene.

It was in the glass.

Vinod made the photograph, but as soon as he returned home he decided to open the camera.

The brass screws loosened slowly. Harimohan stood beside him holding a lantern. When the frame lifted, they saw a thin transparent layer clinging behind the ground glass. Not another piece of glass—more like an old chemical coating that had dried into a fine skin.

Harimohan moved a fingernail to lift it. Vinod stopped him.

“Hold it against the light first.”

They placed the glass before a white wall.

For the first time Harimohan fell silent.

“There is something here,” he said softly.

“A face?”

Harimohan tilted the glass. “Not exactly a face. But there are two deep marks like eyes.”

Vinod saw the young man clearly.

So clearly that he felt that, if he knew the name, he could recognise him in the market.

Two days later he took the glass to Shivji Sah, an old camera repairman in Darbhanga. Shivji Babu examined it in sunlight, then in shade, then beside a lantern.

“In very old times,” he said, “glass photographic plates carried a chemical layer. Even after washing, an image was sometimes not completely erased. Someone may have fitted a piece of old plate glass into this frame as support. In damp weather the layer can become visible again.”

“So this is an old photograph of someone?”

“Possibly. Old glass can play such tricks.”

“A dead person?”

Shivji Babu laughed. “Is that written on the glass?”

Vinod did not laugh.

“And you can see a face?” Shivji asked.

“Yes. I see it clearly.”

Shivji Babu turned the glass again. “I see only stains. The human eye makes many things out of stains.”

Vinod had a new ground glass fitted. He brought the old one home wrapped in paper.

The following week he made two final pictures. No unknown face appeared in the new glass.

The work became simple again, as before. Vinod went back to photographing weddings, children’s birthdays, and families.

Yet he did not throw the old glass away. He placed it on the upper shelf of the shop.

A month later, one night the electricity went out. Harimohan had already left. Vinod lit a lantern and took the old glass down from the shelf. He felt that now he would look not out of fear, but out of curiosity.

He placed white paper behind it.

The grey young man's face emerged again.

Vinod kept looking carefully.

This time he became certain that the eyes were closed. Earlier they had seemed open.

He tilted the glass. The stains changed. The eyes seemed open again.

He understood that Shivji Babu had been right: when the light and angle changed, the meaning of the marks changed.

Then his attention dropped below the face. There was a thin white line, as though white cloth had been drawn up to someone's neck.

Vinod immediately turned the glass face down on the table.

A few moments later he picked it up again.

This time he did not search for the young man. He tried to see only stains—two dark patches, one long mark, one white line.

But once a human being has seen a face, it is difficult for stains ever to become only stains again.

Vinod wrapped the glass in black paper. He did not return it to the shelf; he put it in a locked trunk.

From the next day onward, whenever he went to make a final picture, he always carried the new camera. The old wooden camera remained above the shop gathering dust.

Even years later, whenever an elderly family called Vinod to make a last photograph of a dead loved one, he first looked at the white cloth.

Then, for a moment, his eyes involuntarily searched the right-hand corner.

There was no one there.

But Vinod had learnt at least this much: a camera does not always capture only the faces outside it. Sometimes the shape a person keeps searching for with his own eyes is the shape the glass gives back to him.

STORY 229

Water in the Cellar

...

On the fourth day after the floodwater had receded from the house, Amresh Sah descended all the way into the cellar for the first time. In the old market of Darbhanga he had a shop that repaired brass and bell-metal utensils. In the front part above were the hammer, grinding stone, and furnace; behind was the house; and beneath the ground was a small brick cellar where customers' old utensils, coal, and pieces of metal kept for repair were stored.

The flood had filled the cellar for three days. A pump had been used to drain it, and then the windows and doors were left open for two days to let air circulate. Even so, as soon as Amresh went down, the same smell filled his nose—wet brick, black mud, and green corrosion on brass.

Holding a lantern, he moved forward examining things one by one. Two wooden boxes had swollen. A sack of coal had dissolved into something like mud. On the wall, the old flood line rose as high as his chest.

Then he heard it—tap.

Amresh stopped.

A few moments later—tap.

He raised the lantern. The ceiling was dry. No fresh streak ran down any wall. The moisture on the floor was only the remnant of the flood. He turned and looked all around.

Tap.

This time the sound seemed to come from below the stairs.

“Jugal!” he called upward.

Jugal Paswan, the shop's old craftsman, came down the steps. “What happened?”

“Do you hear this?”

They both remained silent. Half a minute passed.

Tap.

Jugal nodded. “Water must be trapped inside the bricks. Give it two or four days; it will dry.”

Amresh wanted that answer too.

But five days later the sound had still not stopped.

The shop reopened. All day above there was the clang of hammers, the hiss of the furnace, and the scrape of metal being ground. During the day the cellar's dripping sound disappeared beneath the noise. In the evening, after the shop closed and the market thinned into quiet, it became clear again.

Tap.

Sometimes after ten breaths. Sometimes after twenty. Sometimes after so long that Amresh thought it had finally stopped.

Then again.

One night he placed four brass plates in different places—the foot of the stairs, beside the northern wall, where the old box had stood, and in the middle.

In the morning all four plates were dry.

“Then where is the sound coming from?” his wife Kaushalya asked.

Amresh said, “That is what I intend to find out.”

Kaushalya kept looking at him. “The flood has gone. The house survived. The shop survived. Let the cellar remain only a cellar now.”

Amresh did not answer.

On the night of the flood, he had been trapped in the cellar for nearly an hour. The water rose so quickly that while he was still choosing which utensils could be carried upstairs, the first two steps had gone under. Jugal had thrown a rope down from above. Amresh had pushed through chest-high water to get out.

From that hour, what he remembered most was not an image but a sound—water dripping steadily somewhere in the darkness.

It had been strange to hear dripping in the middle of a flood: water everywhere, yet separately, one drop at a time.

Now the floodwater had receded, but that single drop seemed to have remained behind.

Amresh decided he would find its source.

The following Sunday he kept the shop closed and removed the old plaster low on the northern wall. Jugal worked with the chisel. Between the bricks they found black earth, but very little damp. In one place a round passage appeared, like a thin earthen pipe.

Jugal said, “An old drain, perhaps.”

Amresh remembered something his father had told him. When the house was first built, roof water had once been channelled down toward some soak pit below; later, after a new drain was made, the old route had been sealed.

They cleaned the mouth of the passage.

First came a faint hiss of escaping air. Then about two spoonfuls of black water ran out.

“See?” Jugal laughed. “It was trapped here.”

Amresh felt lighter.

That night the cellar was silent.

The second night too.

On the third night, after half a watch—tap.

Amresh opened his eyes on the cot. Kaushalya was asleep. There was no rain above. Pale moonlight lay in the courtyard.

Tap.

Whether the sound had truly come from the cellar, or whether his mind had simply placed it there, he could not be certain.

He rose and lit the lantern.

Everything below was dry. He had tied a thread across the mouth of the opened passage. The thread was dry. All four plates were dry. He ran a hand over the ceiling—dust came away on his fingers, no moisture.

Tap.

This time the sound came from behind him.

He turned. Nothing.

Amresh set the lantern on the floor and sat down in one place.

“Do it again,” he said very softly.

The cellar remained silent.

“Do it again.”

Nothing.

He felt ashamed of himself. Could water be commanded?

Then the lantern flame trembled once. The small metal cap above its glass had heated and shifted slightly—tick.

Amresh’s body shivered.

The sound resembled the drip, but it was not exactly the same.

He touched the cap with a finger, then let it go.

A few moments later—tick.

“This could be one of them,” he said to himself.

But during the first five days after the flood he had heard the sound even without the lantern.

The following week he had an electric light wired down into the cellar instead of using the lantern. The mouth of the old passage was sealed again with lime and earth.

Four nights passed in silence.

Slowly Amresh began arranging the old utensils below again.

One evening Jugal went down to place a large bell-metal platter in storage. Five minutes later he came upstairs and said casually, "Is there still water somewhere below?"

Amresh's hand stopped. "Why?"

"I heard a dripping sound. Once."

"Where?"

"Could not tell. I was putting down the platter when it happened."

Without saying anything, Amresh went down.

Along with fear, an odd relief rose inside him this time—Jugal had heard it. So the sound was not only inside Amresh's mind.

That evening the two of them sat quietly for two hours.

The sound did not come again.

As he got up, Jugal said, "Perhaps the platter rang by itself. Metal sounds when the temperature changes."

He flicked a finger against it. A thin tang sounded.

"Not like a tap," Amresh said.

"But from a distance?"

Amresh remained silent.

After that they performed a small test.

Jugal placed four kinds of vessels in the four corners of the cellar—a bell-metal bowl, a brass lota, an earthen pot, and an empty zinc tin. He himself stood at the top near the stairs. Amresh sat below with his eyes closed.

At long intervals Jugal gave each vessel a very light tap, one at a time. Amresh kept saying where he thought the sound had come from.

The first three times he was right.

The fourth time he said the northern wall, though Jugal had struck the zinc tin in the southern corner.

The fifth time Amresh said beneath the stairs.

Jugal had touched nothing at all.

"Then?" Jugal asked.

Amresh opened his eyes. "I heard it."

“I did nothing.”

The answer should have frightened Amresh. Instead it irritated him.

He wanted the sound to have one place, one cause, one object he could seize and say—here it is.

But sound travelled around the curve of the cellar. Brick, metal, and hollow vessels all shifted its direction.

That night he placed a thin dot of kohl on the wall beside the old flood mark. A second dot below the stairs, a third near the old passage. Whenever he heard the tapping, he drew a short line toward the direction from which he thought it had come.

Five days later, no one place had more lines than the others. They were almost evenly distributed.

When Kaushalya came down and saw the kohl marks, she asked, “What calculation is this?”

“The direction of the sound.”

“And did you find the direction?”

“No.”

“Then what use are the marks?”

Amresh thought about the answer.

At last he said, “At least I know I am not relying only on memory.”

Kaushalya let out a long breath. “Sometimes the thing being measured begins to measure the mind.”

Amresh did not like the sentence.

He wiped all the kohl marks away with a cloth.

From that day he began a new practice.

Whenever the sound came, instead of immediately searching for its source, he first took five breaths. Then he looked around—the ceiling, the walls, the electric bulb, the metal vessels, the place where the old drain had been.

Sometimes he found a cause: a platter contracting as it cooled; a light knock travelling through a metal pipe from the tap above; a wooden step speaking slightly in the damp air.

Sometimes he found nothing.

A month passed.

The smell of the cellar changed. The odour of wet brick faded, and the dry dust of coal became dominant again. The flood line remained on the wall, but new goods were stacked beneath it.

One day Kaushalya asked, “Does it still drip?”

Amresh thought for a moment. "Sometimes."

"Water?"

"That I do not know."

By the time the rains ended, Amresh placed an empty bell-metal bowl at the spot where, on the first night, he had heard the sound most often.

He did not put the bowl there with any real confidence that it would catch water. Perhaps he only wanted proof for his own eyes: if there was a drop, one day it would have to appear in the bowl.

For a week the bowl remained dry.

On the eighth morning Amresh went down. In the middle of the bowl was a round pale mark.

He bent over it.

He touched it with a finger.

Not wet.

Only a clean gleam had appeared amid the old tarnish on the bell metal, as though a drop had dried there and left a mark.

He did not call Jugal.

He picked up the bowl, polished it clean with a cloth, and placed it upside down in the same spot.

That night there was no sound in the cellar.

Nor on the second night.

On the third night, while Amresh was adding up the shop accounts upstairs, a very faint tap came from below.

He stopped his pen.

He took five breaths.

Then he went on adding the figures.

Later he could not remember with certainty whether the sound had come a second time.

STORY 230

The Night Line

...

Beside an old channel of the Kamla River, the municipal cremation ground looks by day like an ordinary patch of open sky. At night the shape of everything changes. The shed where bamboo for funeral pyres is stored seems to lengthen; the smell of half-burnt wood mixes with the smell of water into a heavy layer; and the register kept in the small office room, under the light of a lantern, looks like some ancient volume because of its thick pages.

My name is Nilkanth Jha. By day my work in the municipal record room was to sort files, issue certified copies, and put old papers back into proper order. When Shivji Sah, who kept the regular records at the cremation ground, broke his leg, I was given the duty of filling the night register for fifteen days.

The work was not difficult. Name of the deceased, village, age, time, name of the person arranging the cremation—that was all. But at two in the morning, after everyone has gone, even writing a single name can sometimes feel heavy.

Nothing unusual happened during the first five nights.

On the sixth night it was raining. The river had swollen, so people were coming here even from distant ghats. Wet wood would not catch quickly; one pyre took a long time, while another family waited under the shed.

I kept advancing the serial numbers in the register—one thousand seven hundred eighty-three, eighty-four, eighty-five.

By half past twelve, three cremations remained.

Badri Mallah, one of the cremation-ground workers, had gone to bring tea. I was alone in the room. Smoke had settled on the lantern glass, so the light was thin and yellow.

I completed the line for serial number 1785. The deceased was Ramcharittar Paswan, aged sixty-two, village Belahi. His son had placed a trembling fingerprint beside the entry. I laid blotting paper over the page and capped the pen.

Then my eyes went to the next line.

A name had already been written there:

Nilkanth Jha.

At first I thought the lantern shadow was forming letters. I lifted the page and brought it close to the light.

The name was clear.

My name.

The vowel mark in 'Ni' leaned forward exactly the way I wrote it. The belly of the 'ṭh' was small. The upper loop of the 'jha' was unusually open.

The boxes after the name were empty. No age. No village. No time.

Only the name.

My first feeling was not fear but irritation. I assumed it was Badri's joke. All day he teased me by calling me 'Babu.' Perhaps he had written it before going out for tea.

I rubbed a finger over the name. I could not tell whether the ink was dry or whether it was ink at all. The colour was not blue but black-grey. I scraped it lightly with my nail. Nothing came away.

When Badri returned, I pushed the register toward him.

"Who wrote this?"

He narrowed his eyes at the page. "What?"

"This name."

"That is your name, isn't it?"

"I can see that. Can't you?"

He brought the page closer to the lantern. "I can see it. But I did not write it."

"You could not even make a 'ṭh' like this."

This time Badri laughed. "Then you must have written it yourself."

"Why would I write my own name in the cremation register?"

"Why are you asking me?"

He took the tea and went outside.

His answer was ordinary, but something remained caught inside me.

The third family arrived. The dead woman's name was Sugni Devi. I opened the same page.

My pen stopped at the line bearing my name.

The rule was that no serial line should be skipped. Yet I wrote Sugni Devi on the next line. I placed serial number 1786 beside her name.

The line with my own name I left without a serial number.

Badri noticed. He said nothing.

When I reached home at dawn, my wife Mrinalini asked, “Why are you so quiet today?”

I said, “I did not sleep enough.”

I did not tell her about the register. The moment one said it aloud, the whole thing sounded foolish.

The next afternoon, while I sat in the record room, the previous night’s page kept circling in my mind.

I had spent years looking at handwriting. When people came for certified copies and a name was wrong in an application, I could catch it at a glance. I had written ‘Nilkanth’ thousands of times.

Why did the letters in the register look so much like mine?

When I reached the cremation ground that evening, the first thing I did was examine the page.

In daylight the name did not look as dark as before. It was grey, as though no pen had written it at all, but pressure had been left in the paper and dust had settled into the grooves.

I tilted the page toward the window light.

There really was a faint indentation around the letters.

That cut my fear in half.

I turned the previous page. Nothing. The next page also had nothing.

I opened the desk drawer. Inside were old blotting papers, two receipts, a piece of string, and a torn duty slip. On the slip my name had been written: ‘Night Duty: Nilkanth Jha.’

The handwriting was not mine. It belonged to Harinarayan Babu, the head clerk.

I placed the slip against the register page and compared them. The letters differed in size. It seemed unlikely that this was the source of the impression.

Badri arrived. I showed him the indentation in the page.

“Perhaps someone put another sheet over the register and wrote the name,” he said.

“Who?”

“You. Me. Some office clerk. Many people come here in the day.”

“But the register was shut inside.”

“Was it shut, or do you remember it as shut?”

I looked at him.

He immediately added, “I am not saying you forgot. But on night duty every day begins to look like the same day.”

I did not like that sentence.

That night three more names were entered. The empty line with my own name remained in the middle.

I drew two thin strokes across it and wrote in the margin: 'Cancelled.'

Writing 'Cancelled' gave me an odd sense of relief, as though authority over the register had returned to me.

On the third night, a municipal inspector came.

The moment he saw the page, he asked, "Why was this line cancelled?"

I said, "A wrong name had been entered."

"Whose name?"

I hesitated for a moment. "Mine."

The inspector lowered his glasses and looked at me. "Why did you write your own name in the line for the deceased?"

"I did not write it."

He examined the page. "This is not ink."

He rubbed it with a finger. The 'Ni' became slightly lighter.

"It is a pressure impression," he said. "Someone must have written on a sheet placed above it. Dust filled the grooves."

Badri did not look at me.

The inspector ordered me to put the date and my signature beside the cancelled line. I did so.

For the second time, my name now appeared on that same line of the cremation register—this time as a signature.

The two Nilkanths lay near one another.

One clear.

One grey.

The grey one looked older.

After the inspector left, I closed the register.

At a quarter past one that night, the body of an unidentified man was brought in. It had been found downstream in the river. Two constables and two cremation-ground workers accompanied it. Since he had not been identified, the name column had to say 'Unknown.'

I opened the register.

The lantern light was thin again. I could see the two cancellation lines across the grey Nilkanth. Beneath that, my signature. Then Sugni Devi, then the other names.

My hand did not tremble as I opened a new line for the unidentified man. I wrote the serial number, wrote the time, and wrote 'Unknown male.'

A constable asked, "Age?"

"About fifty?"

He looked at the body. "Write fifty-five."

I wrote fifty-five.

I was fifty-two.

The fact had no meaning.

But give the mind a night, smoke, and a register, and it will manufacture meaning.

The cremation began.

I went outside and stood for a while facing the river. The rain had stopped. Smoke from the pyre bent low. A dog barked somewhere along the distant road.

Badri came and stood beside me.

"Babu," he said softly, "may I say something?"

"Say it."

"Three days ago, when it was very crowded, didn't you place a sheet on top of this register and fill out your travel-allowance form?"

I answered at once, "No."

Then a scene came back to me.

Not the whole scene—only a fragment.

An office messenger had brought a form at night. I had written something quickly. Whether the register had been open or shut, I could not remember. I could not remember where I had placed the form either.

"How do you remember?"

"You asked me for my pen."

"Then I wrote my name?"

"That is possible."

"At that exact place in the register?"

Badri shrugged. "That I did not see."

I ought to have felt relieved.

But when memory arrives as evidence and then stops halfway, it can become more frightening than evidence itself.

The next day I searched for the travel-allowance form in the record room. I found it among the files.

My name was at the top, the date below. The handwriting was mine.

On the back of the form were two faint blue marks like the ruled lines of the register.

I compared the width of the form with the register. It was almost a match.

This time the knot inside me loosened.

That night at the cremation ground I showed the form to Badri.

He said, "Then the matter is finished."

I too could have said, "Yes."

But I opened the register.

The grey name had now become very faint. The cancellation strokes were clear.

I placed the form over the page and aligned the name.

It did not match completely.

Where my name stood on the form, it fell almost two fingers above the line in the register.

I shifted the form downward. Then the width matched, but the writing lower on the form should also have left impressions on the other boxes in the register. There were no such impressions.

Badri said, "The paper must have slipped."

"That seems possible."

"The table slopes."

"That too is possible."

The two of us looked at the page for a while.

"Finished?" he asked again.

I closed the register. "Begin the work."

The fifteen days ended. Shivji Sah returned, leaning on a stick.

I handed the register back to him. He asked why the line had been cancelled.

I said, "A pressure impression."

He took little interest. Misspellings, incomplete names, repeated serial numbers—small errors of that kind were nothing new to him in a cremation-ground register.

I returned to my daytime work in the record room.

Two weeks later the cremation register was called for to prepare a certified copy.

The register came to my desk. I turned the pages looking for the required name.

The page from that night appeared before me again.

The grey Nilkanth had almost disappeared. Only one curved stroke of the 'ṭh' and a faint mark above the 'jha' remained. My 'Cancelled' and my signature were clear.

I did not turn the page immediately.

On the next line, the unidentified man's name had later been added. He must have been identified.

The name was Harinandan Yadav, village Khajauli.

I did not know his living face. I remembered only the wet shroud from that night.

I closed the register and prepared the certified copy.

I no longer have to work nights at the cremation ground.

Even so, whenever I open a thick register in the record room and see an empty line after a written one, my hand pauses for a moment.

First I look to see whether it is truly empty.

Then I write.

STORY 231

The Latch

...

In the narrow lane that runs from Sakri market toward the station stood Deepnarayan Sah's house. On the front veranda he kept a small table for silverwork. All day he joined the tiny bells of anklets, repaired breaks in bangles, straightened the thin circles of toe rings, and at evening tied each customer's jewellery into a separate cloth bundle and placed it in an iron chest.

The house was old, but Deepnarayan trusted its main door. It was made of thick sal wood, with a long iron latch on the inside; the end of the latch entered the iron socket in the frame by three fingers' depth. Before sleeping, Deepnarayan would pull the door shut, slide the latch into place, and shake it twice with his hand to make sure. Silver jewellery remained in the house, and he had followed this habit for years.

The first time he found the door open was on a late night in Aghan.

At dawn his wife Kaushalya rose to offer water to the tulsi plant. She came from the inner courtyard toward the front and immediately called out, "Who opened this door?"

Deepnarayan jumped from his bedding and ran.

The door was not fully open, but stood about a handspan ajar. The lane outside showed in the grey light.

Yet the latch was still inside its iron socket.

For a few moments Deepnarayan could not understand how the sight before him was possible. The right edge of the door, where the latch was fixed, still touched the frame. The left edge, where the hinges were, had swung inward.

It was as though the door had abandoned its natural direction and opened from the other side.

He checked the iron chest. The lock was untouched. He counted the bundles. Not a single thing was missing.

"You must have opened it in the night," Kaushalya said. "The latch is still fastened."

"Then did the door move by itself?"

Deepnarayan did not answer.

He caught hold of the door and straightened it. Lifting the left side and pushing, he set it back into place. The door looked normal again. He saw no fresh break in the hinge straps.

The day's work grew busy. Seven bells on a young bride's anklet had to be replaced; two elderly women came to have old chains thinned. Now and then Deepnarayan looked toward the door. In daylight the incident seemed foolish.

That night he took greater precautions than before.

He slid the latch shut. Across the iron socket and the joint of the latch he drew a thin soot line. Then he tied a red thread from the latch bar to a nail in the frame. If the latch lifted, the thread would snap or slacken.

"Now even a ghost will have to give an account," Kaushalya laughed.

Deepnarayan laughed too, but not naturally.

At dawn Kaushalya's call came again.

This time the door stood open by nearly two handspans. The left side leaned inward. The latch on the right remained inserted in the iron socket. The red thread was intact. The soot line was almost exactly where it had been.

Deepnarayan's hands went cold.

He sat down on the floor beside the door and examined the left hinge. Old rust covered the upper iron strap. The lower hinge seemed sunk into the wood. But he saw nothing that could explain how the panel had opened in the night.

"Could someone be doing this from inside?" Kaushalya asked softly.

"There are only the two of us inside."

"The rear door?"

"There is a bamboo fence there. If anyone came through, we would hear it."

That day Deepnarayan did not open the silver chest near the shop table. He worked only from the small bundles already taken out earlier. His mind kept returning to one question: if the latch had not moved, how had the door opened?

He did not let word of the second incident spread through the lane. A silversmith's reputation rests not only on the quality of his hands but also on the security of his house. If people learnt that his main door opened by itself at night, who would leave anklets or bangles with him?

He told Kaushalya too, "Do not speak of this outside."

After daylight strengthened, he examined the ground outside the door carefully. Dew had left the dust in the lane slightly damp. There were no unfamiliar footprints—only two marks from the milkman's wooden sandals and Deepnarayan's own older prints.

Inside the threshold he scattered a fine layer of ash. If anyone worked at the door during the night, there would be marks.

He measured the latch socket. Three fingers deep. He pushed a thin wire inside; nothing was broken. Then he went outside and tried to pull the door open. With the latch engaged, the right side would not move even a fraction.

Instead of reducing his fear, this increased it. If the latch was so difficult to tamper with from outside, how was the door opening at night?

That evening an old acquaintance came to leave his daughter-in-law's anklet for repair. Deepnarayan hesitated for an instant as he took it in his hand. It seemed improper to keep jewellery in the house that night.

But what reason could he give?

In the end he said in his usual voice, "Come for it tomorrow afternoon."

As he placed the bundle in the chest, for the first time he looked more at the hinges of the door than at the lock of the chest.

On the third night he spread his bedding on the veranda. Kaushalya slept inside. The iron chest stood near his pillow. He turned the lantern wick low enough that the whole outline of the door remained visible.

Nothing happened during the first watch. Footsteps, bicycle bells, and distant station announcements continued in the lane for a long time. Then everything fell quiet.

Sometime after midnight, a long freight-train whistle came from the Sakri side. A few moments later the ground trembled very faintly.

Deepnarayan was accustomed to that vibration; the house was not very far from the railway line.

Then came a kirr.

He sat up.

The left edge of the door had separated from the frame by the width of a hair. The right edge, where the latch was fixed, remained still.

Deepnarayan held his breath and watched.

A second kirr.

The left edge moved inward by a finger's breadth. The upper hinge strained, as though its iron strap were being pulled out of the wood. The lower corner of the door scraped along the floor.

Slowly the door was turning around its right edge as though that were the pivot—the latch side fixed, the side where the hinges should have held it swinging open.

A chill ran through Deepnarayan's body.

What was happening before his eyes could have a cause, yet the sight was stranger than the cause.

He got up at once and caught the door. Lifting the left side, he pressed it back into the frame.

From below came a tak, and the panel settled into place.

He brought the lantern close and examined the lower hinge. Inside the old wood was an iron pin serving as the pivot. The pin had worked halfway out of its socket. Of the two nails in the upper hinge strap, one was loose.

He did not wait for dawn.

He brought a hammer, a small chisel, and a bottle of oil. He drove the lower pivot back into place and hammered the upper nail tight. He opened and shut the door three times. Everything worked normally.

Kaushalya had woken.

“Did you find it?”

“The hinge was loose.”

“And the latch?”

“The latch kept doing its work. The door was coming loose from the other side.”

Kaushalya kept looking at the door. “Can that happen?”

“Now I have seen it.”

In the morning Deepnarayan called the neighbouring carpenter Ramudgar, but did not tell him why. He only said, “Check the hinges once more.”

Ramudgar crouched and scraped the wood around the lower hinge.

“This part has gone hollow inside. The wood looks sound from outside, but woodworm has eaten it within.”

He pushed in a thin iron probe. It travelled half a finger farther than it should have.

“With vibration at night, the pivot can work its way out,” Ramudgar said. “The panel is heavy. The upper strap cannot carry it alone. The latch keeps the right side held, so the left side swings inward.”

Deepnarayan ought to have felt relief.

He did.

But not completely.

“Two nights in a row?”

“Freight trains run every day.”

“Why not before?”

Ramudgar shrugged. "Woodworm does not hollow out a beam in one day either."

He cut away the rotten section below and joined in new wood, fitted a thicker pivot, and drove two new nails into the upper strap. When the work was finished, the door had become so tight that Deepnarayan had to use force to shut it.

For four nights nothing happened.

Deepnarayan returned to his normal way of working. He untied the red thread and threw it away. He wiped off the soot mark. The iron chest again spent the night in its old place.

On the fifth night, the station's last passenger train went through late. Deepnarayan was awake. When the train passed, a light tremor ran through the house, but the door did not move.

A faint smile came to his lips.

Then, without any other sound, the iron latch gave a very soft tick.

Deepnarayan did not sit up at once. He listened first.

Then he lit the lantern.

The door was shut. The hinges were in place. The latch was fully engaged.

He went close and put a finger on the latch.

Nothing.

At dawn he checked Ramudgar's new joint again. The wood was hard, the nails steady, the pivot seated.

The cause of the tick was simple enough: in the cold of night the iron latch may have contracted slightly and touched the edge of its socket. Working with silver, Deepnarayan knew such minute movements of metal.

He explained it to himself that way.

Even so, from that day onward, after fastening the latch at night, he no longer checks only the right side. Once, with his hand, he presses the left hinge side too.

And sometimes, when a freight-train whistle comes from far away, his eyes go first not to the latch but to the left edge of the door.

STORY 232

The Heartbeat

...

On the southern side of Madhubani town, the rear room of Prabhakar Mishra's small clinic had not been opened to patients for a long time. In the two rooms at the front, people with fever, cough, stomach pain, cuts, and bruises came and went all day. But in the rear room there remained only an old cot, empty medicine bottles, a bamboo table, and the dead pipe of an old water-lifting system beside the wall. Before the room was repainted, all the old things were being cleared out.

After the evening patients had left, Prabhakar sat there alone. He was past fifty-nine now. Thin spectacles had come to rest on his eyes, but his hands were still steady.

He was sorting old papers—medicine-order lists, tax slips, the case of a broken thermometer. He had already separated the old patient files and sent them home.

At about half past nine that night, the sound came for the first time.

Dhuk... dhuk... dhuk-dhuk...

Prabhakar's hand stopped.

The sound was so faint that at first he thought a handcart must have passed on the road outside. But the road was quiet. Then came a pause about three breaths long.

Dhuk... dhuk...

He stood up.

He opened the window and looked outside. There was not even a dog in the rear lane. Far away, toward the railway line, a freight train was moving slowly, but its rumble was different.

Prabhakar closed the window and sat down again.

The sound returned.

This time he recognised its pattern—three short knocks, a pause, then two.

His left hand closed involuntarily around the edge of the table.

During Sarayu Sahni's last half-hour, his heart had been beating in that same pattern.

A night from seventeen years earlier entered the room without invitation.

Sarayu made bamboo baskets. One evening in Sawan, his family had brought him here with a high fever and severe difficulty breathing. The clinic was new then, the number of patients small, and Prabhakar's confidence greater.

Sarayu's pulse had first been rapid, then irregular. Prabhakar ordered one medicine. A short while later, growing impatient, he had a second dose given even though there had not yet been enough time to see the full effect of the first.

Prabhakar had never forgotten the sequence of that night.

Sarayu's pulse suddenly took on a broken rhythm. Three beats, a pause, two beats. Then a longer pause.

Prabhakar began arranging to take him to another clinic, but Sarayu became still before the vehicle arrived.

The next morning Prabhakar looked again at the treatment slip. His eyes stopped on the line recording the second dose.

He crossed the line out.

On a fresh slip only the first dose was written.

The family was told that Sarayu had been brought in when the illness was already very severe. That statement was not false, but neither was it the whole truth.

In seventeen years Prabhakar had discussed this with no one.

The dhuk-dhuk rose again in the room.

He put his ear to the wall.

The sound became clearer.

Dhuk... dhuk... dhuk-dhuk...

"The pipe," he said softly.

An old iron pipe ran inside the wall. Once, water had been lifted through it to a tank in the rear courtyard. Five years earlier, after a new water system was installed, this pipe had been shut off.

He thought air might be trapped somewhere inside, and changes in pressure might be making the metal sound.

He turned off the main pump switch.

The sound stopped.

His chest loosened.

Ten minutes later, as he gathered the papers to leave the room, the same rhythm returned.

Dhuk... dhuk... dhuk-dhuk...

This time the pump was off.

Prabhakar opened the door and walked into the front room. The sound was not there.

He returned to the rear room—dhuk... dhuk...

He went to the old cot and bent down to listen.

The sound seemed to be coming from inside the wood.

A thin iron strip was fixed to one of the cot legs. He placed his hand on it. No vibration.

He dragged the cot two handspans away.

The sound stopped.

“That is all,” he told himself. “The wood is touching the wall.”

He left the cot in the middle of the room and went out.

The next day Harinarayan, the carpenter, came. Prabhakar showed him the cot. Harinarayan tightened the loose strip on the leg and drove a new nail into a wooden joint.

Then he struck the old wall pipe with his hand and said, “It is hollow inside. It can sound when heat and cold change.”

Prabhakar asked casually, “In a rhythm?”

Harinarayan laughed. “We make rhythms. Wood only makes sounds.”

That answer stayed in Prabhakar’s mind all day.

In daylight he tried to reproduce the sound. He tapped the wall with his thumb, knocked a finger against the cot leg, wedged a thin piece of bamboo near the mouth of the pipe.

Sometimes one of the sounds resembled it, but never the five-beat pattern.

Seeing how absorbed he was, the young man who dispensed medicines in the front room asked, “Is something broken?”

Prabhakar said only, “An old pipe is making noises.”

After giving that answer, he remembered the face of Sarayu’s wife, Chandrakala.

For several minutes after the death, she had kept asking the same thing: “Listen to his chest once more.”

Prabhakar could no longer be certain how long he had listened through the stethoscope then. He remembered only the trembling of his own hand, a wet gamchha, and the stillness of Sarayu’s chest.

Was the distinctive dhuk-dhuk rhythm from the first phase of treatment, from the last phase, or a pattern formed later by memory?

He was no longer certain.

That evening he considered looking for the old treatment slip, then abandoned the idea at once.

Finding the slip would not identify the source of the sound.

And even if the crossed-out line had survived somewhere, it would prove only that the paper had been altered—not what rhythm Sarayu's heart had actually been beating.

For the first time, Prabhakar understood that two different parts of the truth were troubling him: what he had done, and what he had heard.

He knew the first.

His trust in the second was weakening.

That night he deliberately sat in the rear room again.

This time there were no papers on the table. Only a clock and a notebook.

The first sound came at 9:42 p.m. Prabhakar wrote down the time.

The second came at 10:03.

The third at 10:27.

There was no regular interval.

But the pattern was almost the same—three, pause, two.

He counted the pulse at his wrist. It was regular.

Then he put the stethoscope in his ears and listened to his own heart. The beats were strong, but not like Sarayu's final rhythm.

He removed the stethoscope.

The room was quiet.

Then one knock came from the wall.

Then two.

Then nothing for a long time.

Prabhakar wrote in the notebook: "Three-two not certain."

The moment he wrote it, he felt uneasy.

For seventeen years the rhythm had seemed so clear in his memory. Had it truly been exactly that?

On the night of treatment he had been watching the clock, counting Sarayu's pulse, answering the family's questions. In the fear and haste of that night, how had memory preserved such a clean pattern of five beats?

The next day he thought of going to see Mahesh, his former assistant, who now ran a medicine shop in Jaynagar.

Then Prabhakar did not go.

He realised he was not seeking Mahesh's memory; he was seeking confirmation of his own.

If Mahesh remembered another rhythm, would the truth change?

If he remembered the same rhythm, would the guilt become smaller?

On the third night it rained. The outer face of the wall became wet.

At about eleven the sound rose so clearly that Prabhakar stood at once.

Dhuk... dhuk... dhuk-dhuk.

This time he did not put his ear to the wall.

He went out into the rear courtyard.

The old pipe emerged close to the ground where the earth had been dug away. Rainwater had collected in a small hollow. The mouth of the pipe was closed, but fine bubbles were rising as though air were escaping from inside.

Prabhakar put his hand over the mouth of the pipe.

From inside came a tak.

Then another tak.

Then two knocks close together.

He took his hand away.

The next morning a plumber was called.

When the pipe was opened, they found inside a piece of old leather and a thin rusted ring. As water and air pressure changed, the ring struck against the pipe within the wall.

The plumber said, "This must be what was making the sound at night."

Prabhakar asked, "Three times, then twice?"

The plumber turned the ring in his hand. "As much pressure, so many knocks. How could the count be fixed?"

The pipe was cut out and removed.

The gap in the wall was filled.

The rear room was replastered.

The cot too was taken outside.

For three nights no sound came.

On the fourth night Prabhakar was at home. His wife was asleep. The rain outside had stopped.

He lay on his back looking at the ceiling.

Inside his ears a very faint dhuk-dhuk began.

He caught his wrist.

His pulse seemed to be moving in the same pattern.

One, two, three.

A pause.

Then two.

Prabhakar immediately counted again.

This time the beats were even—one, two, three, four, five.

No pause.

He let go of his wrist.

At dawn, when he reached the clinic, he stood for a while before the newly plastered wall of the rear room.

He heard nothing.

On the table lay the treatment slip of a new patient.

After writing the name of the medicine, Prabhakar wrote the time, then the dose, and read it once through.

Before folding the paper, his pen paused for a moment.

The room was quiet.

But Prabhakar no longer trusted that quiet and soundlessness were the same thing.

STORY 233

The Black Mirror

...

In a narrow lane leading inward from Shankar Chowk in Madhubani stood Malati Devi's shop for lac bangles and vermilion. In the front, glass cases held rows of red, green, yellow, and violet bangles; on the rear wall hung an old mirror, taller than the waist. Its wooden frame was dark brown, the corners worn, and the backing had peeled away in so many places that black, cloud-like stains appeared here and there across the glass.

Malati had not bought the mirror new. Two weeks before the wedding season began, an old cosmetics shop at her maternal uncle's house had closed. From there she had obtained a cupboard, two low stools, and this mirror cheaply. She thought there was no need to spend money on a new one. It was still bright enough for a woman trying on bangles to look once at her hands, sari, and hair parting.

Malati first noticed something wrong in the hand of a newly married young woman.

The woman was arranging two red bangles among green ones when she turned toward the mirror and raised her right wrist.

Malati felt that the wrist in the mirror rose one breath later.

She dismissed it as a trick of her eyes and began opening another bangle case.

But when the young woman lowered her wrist, Malati had the same impression again—the real hand came down first, the reflected hand after it.

"Is something wrong?" the young woman asked.

"No," Malati said. "The light is a little dim."

After noon, the projecting balcony above the lane cast shadow into the shop. Malati drew back the curtain by the door. The light increased.

Everything in the mirror looked normal.

Before closing the shop that night, she tested it once while alone.

She raised her right hand.

The reflection rose with it.

She touched her head.

So did the reflection.

Malati laughed at herself.

Nothing happened the next day.

On the evening of the third day, when the number of customers had thinned, she was locking a case and again saw her hand in the mirror seem to move late.

This time the delay was so small that it was difficult even to call it a delay. It was as though her eyes caught the real hand first and reached the mirror a blink afterward.

She went close to the mirror.

Among the black stains she saw her own face: the fine lines of age, the vermilion in her parting, two thin strands of hair near the ear—all familiar.

She blinked.

The reflection blinked too.

Then she raised her hand very slowly.

This time she became certain that the mirror was behind.

Malati's daughter Chanda was writing the shop accounts. That evening, seeing her mother repeatedly raising a hand before the mirror, she asked, "What are you measuring?"

"Stand here."

Chanda came near the mirror.

"I will raise my hand. Do not look at my hand—look in the mirror. Tell me whether both move together."

Malati raised her hand three times.

"Together," Chanda said.

"Look carefully."

A fourth time.

A fifth.

"Together."

Malati said nothing.

That night, even while cooking at home, her mind remained caught in the shop's black mirror.

She was not afraid of mirrors. For thirty years, in the work of bridal adornment, she had spent her days in front of mirrors. Whose forehead mark was crooked, whose bangles did not match the sari, whose vermilion line leaned a little left—her eyes caught such fine differences at once.

So Chanda's answer unsettled her more than it reassured her.

The next morning she devised a simple test.

She tied a small piece of red lac bangle to a thread and suspended it before the mirror. She gave the thread a push. The fragment began swinging left and right.

The real fragment and its reflection moved together.

Ten times.

Twenty times.

No delay.

Then Malati began matching the tip of her index finger to the swing of the bangle fragment.

One... two... three.

Her finger was on time.

Yet the reflected finger seemed slightly behind.

She stopped her hand.

The bangle fragment was still swinging, and its reflection remained exactly with it.

That troubled her most.

If the mirror was wrong, the bangle should also move late. If the mirror was right, why did only her own body seem delayed?

It was time to open the shop. She cut the thread and put the bangle fragment back in the case.

For the next four days Malati tried to look at the mirror less.

While helping customers try on bangles, she kept her gaze limited to their wrists. If someone looked at herself in the mirror, Malati began opening another case.

Work went on normally.

On the fifth day it rained. The light in the lane diminished. A yellow bulb burned inside the shop.

A teenage girl was choosing bangles for her wedding. She raised her hand to show her mother.

Malati's eyes went to the mirror against her will.

The girl's hand rose with her.

Her mother's hand rose with her.

Chanda's hand, arranging a case, moved with her.

Only Malati's own reflection remained still.

She held her breath.

One moment.

Then the reflection's left hand rose from above the case and adjusted the sari.

Malati had not moved her left hand until then—at least that was how she remembered it.

“Ma?” Chanda called.

Malati immediately looked away from the mirror. “Nothing. Take out the broad red bangles.”

After the customer left, she asked Chanda, “Did I just adjust my sari?”

Chanda looked surprised. “Yes. Your anchal was caught in the case. You pulled it free.”

“When?”

“When that girl was showing her hand.”

Malati had no memory of her left hand going to the sari.

But the anchal was indeed free from the case now.

That day, for the first time, she covered the mirror with a cloth.

Chanda asked, “Have the black stains spread?”

“Yes,” Malati said. “I will have the backing redone.”

Covering the mirror immediately affected the work. In wedding season, women trying on bangles repeatedly wanted to lift the cloth to compare colours. Malati made excuses, saying that the backing had come away.

One elderly woman laughed and said, “Broken mirror or not, the price of the bangles will not come down.”

Everyone laughed.

Malati smiled too, but her attention remained on the glass beneath the cloth.

When she added up the accounts that evening, Malati realised that closing the shop for three days to have the mirror repaired would reduce her earnings during the wedding rush.

Even so, she did not change her decision.

She now wanted to trust the mirror's movement more than its shine.

Chanda said they could manage with a small hand mirror.

Malati agreed, though in her heart she did not accept that convenience alone was why she wanted the large mirror removed.

Two days later Jagdish, a glassworker from Rajnagar, arrived.

He took the mirror down and laid it on the floor. When he opened the wooden backing, the old silvering was found flaking away in patches. Near the edge lay a fine grey layer.

Examining the thickness of the glass, Jagdish said, "This is very old. One faint image forms from the front surface, another from the backing. On a moving hand you may see two edges."

Malati immediately asked, "Will one edge move later?"

Jagdish did not laugh. "Not later. Both move together. But the eye may catch one first and the other afterward, especially in dim light."

He leaned the mirror to one side. "With new backing it will become clear."

Malati's chest loosened a little.

She told herself—this was the cause. Old glass. Double image. Dim light.

But one question remained inside her: why had the swinging red bangle fragment never seemed delayed?

The mirror stayed with Jagdish for three days to be resilvered.

During those three days, Chanda hung a small hand mirror in the shop.

Malati left it for customers alone.

She did not look at herself.

On the fourth day Jagdish brought the mirror back.

The black stains were gone. The glass was bright and clear. The frame was the same old one.

Malati shut the door and tested it alone.

She raised a hand.

Together.

She blinked.

Together.

She tilted her head to the right.

Together.

She let out a long breath.

Everything remained normal through the third day.

On the evening of the fourth, Malati was turning the key in one of the cases.

She saw her hand in the mirror.

It seemed to her that the real key had already turned inside the lock, while the reflected wrist was still halfway through the motion.

She stopped at once.

The reflected hand stopped too.

Malati did not call Chanda.

She made no test.

She simply stood before the mirror for a few moments.

Outside in the lane, women carrying baskets of vegetables were returning home.

The yellow bulb was steady.

There were no black stains in the new backing.

She looked into her own eyes at the centre of the mirror.

This time it seemed to her that the delay was not in the hand, but in the seeing.

The harder she tried to catch her own movement, the longer the delay became.

Malati switched off the light.

She locked the shop door.

The mirror remained inside in the dark.

The next morning she opened the shop again.

Work began.

Red bangles, green bangles, vermilion, bargaining, laughter—everything as before.

The mirror remained on the wall, but Malati stopped testing it.

When a woman raised her hand and asked, “Does this colour look good?” Malati looked not at the mirror but directly at the wrist and answered.

And sometimes, when in the corner of her eye her own reflection seemed to slip a little behind, she did not turn at once and wait for it.

STORY 234

Footsteps on the Roof

...

A little inside the old cloth market of Jhanjharpur, in a narrow lane, Ram Ballabh Das had a small workshop where he fitted skins to mridangs. In the front room he soaked hides, stretched them over circular wooden shells, and ground the black paste; in the rear room stood his cot, two trunks, and several old mridang shells beside the wall. The house had only one storey, but there was no staircase to the roof. Long ago an outside staircase had stood on the southern side, but it had been removed after the wall collapsed. Now, whenever anyone had to climb to the roof, a long bamboo ladder had to be brought from the lane.

Ram Ballabh knew the sounds of the night particularly well. After listening all day to the right and left strokes of mridangs, his ears could catch the smallest difference. Which strap was a little loose, which skin had been stretched too tight, which stroke sounded hollow within—he could tell with his eyes closed.

So on the first night, when he heard the sound of feet on the roof, he did not take it for a rat or a cat.

It must have been around eleven. Rain had already fallen during the day, and the lane was damp, but the night air was still. Ram Ballabh sat on his cot untangling the cord of a half-finished mridang.

Then from above came a thump.

A few moments later, another thump.

Then two more, a little quicker.

He stopped his hands and listened.

The sound was moving from the northern side toward the south.

One... two... three... four... five.

Then the roof became silent again.

Ram Ballabh got up and opened the door.

The lane was deserted. The light in the veranda of the house opposite had gone out. He craned his neck toward the outer edge of the roof. In the darkness he could see only the line of the wet parapet.

“Is anyone there?” he called upward.

No answer came.

There was no staircase to the roof. The bamboo ladder used in the lane was kept during the day in a storehouse beside the pond. If someone had brought another ladder from outside, some mark should have remained in the mud of the lane.

Ram Ballabh went outside twice with the lantern and looked carefully.

There were no fresh footprints beside the wall.

The sound did not return that night.

In the morning his nephew Naval came to collect a mridang. When Ram Ballabh told him what had happened, he laughed.

“It must have been a cat.”

“A cat’s feet are that heavy?”

“If the roof is empty, even a small sound seems loud.”

Ram Ballabh did not answer. He put a finger on the left head of the mridang and said, “The difference between this stroke and that one—you do not hear it. I do.”

Naval looked at his face and stopped laughing.

At noon the two of them brought the bamboo ladder from the lane. Naval climbed first. Ram Ballabh followed.

The lime-and-brick-dust surface of the roof was old. There were fine cracks in several places, dried moss along the western edge, and on the northern side an old bamboo water channel tied against the wall. During the rains it carried roof water toward the southern drain.

There was no human footprint on the roof.

No mud.

Only pigeon droppings in two or three places and the faint print of a cat near one edge.

Naval said, “See?”

Ram Ballabh walked five steps across the roof. Naval went down and listened. Then Naval walked above while Ram Ballabh stood inside.

It was true that footsteps on the roof sounded heavy in the room.

But the sound from the night had been slightly different—as though the feet were not falling on the roof but inside it.

The second night Ram Ballabh did not go to sleep early. He put away his mridang work and sat quietly on the cot.

Eleven o’clock.

Half past eleven.

Nothing.

He told himself Naval had been right.

Then, a little before midnight, there came a thump from the north.

Ram Ballabh's back straightened.

Two... three... four... five.

Then it stopped.

This time the fifth thump had come directly above his cot.

He went outside at once.

No one in the lane.

The sky was clear. Stars were visible.

On the third night Naval stayed with him.

He put out the kerosene lamp so that outside sounds could be heard more clearly. Until midnight the two of them talked quietly about work.

Suddenly the first thump came from above.

Naval stopped in the middle of a sentence.

The second thump.

"Did you hear it?" Ram Ballabh whispered.

Naval did not answer.

Third.

Fourth.

Fifth.

Naval jumped from the cot and ran to the door. Both went outside and looked toward the roof.

Nothing in the darkness.

"That is not a cat," Naval said softly.

Ram Ballabh should have felt satisfaction at hearing this.

Instead his uneasiness increased. The sound was no longer something heard only by his own ears.

The next day Naval brought a handful of fine ash. Across the roof, from north to south, he spread it in a thin strip.

"If anyone walks here, there will be prints."

The idea seemed childish to Ram Ballabh, but he did not stop him.

That night the sound came again.

Five thumps.

As before.

In the morning they went up.

The strip of ash was almost untouched. In the middle the wind had made one line through it, and near the edge there were two small cat prints.

Naval fell silent.

As they were coming down from the roof, Ram Ballabh's eyes went to the old bamboo water channel beside the northern wall.

The bamboo was held in two places by iron rings and in three places by wire loops tightened around spikes driven into the wall. Rainwater ran through it toward the south. The bamboo had grown old and black.

He shook it with his hand.

The bamboo rubbed against the wall.

Thak.

From below Naval called, "That is not a footstep."

"No," Ram Ballabh said. "But it sends sound into the wall."

Ram Ballabh had little work that day. Two mridangs had to be made ready by evening for a wedding troupe, but his attention kept going upward.

The sun came out at noon. The old roof warmed. The bamboo water channel began to dry.

Toward evening, while Ram Ballabh was tightening a skin in the rear room, two sudden thaks sounded above.

Not like footsteps, but travelling in the same direction from north to south.

He left his work and went outside.

There was no wind.

After the evening customer had gone, he called Naval.

The two considered taking the bamboo channel down, but the rainy season was not yet over. So they loosened the loops and wedged folded pieces of an old sack between the bamboo and the wall, preventing the bamboo from rubbing directly against it.

That night no footsteps were heard.

The second night too the roof remained completely quiet.

Nothing on the third night.

Naval laughed. "The ghost saw the sack and ran away."

Ram Ballabh smiled.

He felt relief.

He could trust his ears again. There had been a sound. There had been a cause. Fear lasted only until the cause was known.

A week passed in that silence.

Work increased. With Durga Puja approaching, the demand for mridangs grew. From morning until night Ram Ballabh cut hide, tightened cords, and ground black paste.

The roof slipped out of his mind.

One night the work ended late.

The sky was completely clear. It had not rained all day. The bamboo water channel was dry.

Ram Ballabh washed his hands and face and lay down on the cot.

He was beginning to fall asleep when a thump came from above.

He opened his eyes.

A few moments later came a second thump.

Ram Ballabh immediately sat up on the cot.

Third.

Fourth.

The fifth thump did not come.

Ram Ballabh waited for a long time.

Nothing.

In the morning he examined the bamboo channel.

The sack was still in place. The loops were loose. The bamboo was not touching the wall.

This time he said nothing to Naval.

Two weeks later the rains ended. Ram Ballabh had the bamboo water channel removed altogether. The spikes in the wall were taken out as well.

There was now no long object on the roof running north to south that could carry sound.

After that, nearly a month passed in silence.

Ram Ballabh became certain that the bamboo had been the cause. Perhaps those four thumps in between had happened because the sack had not been wedged properly. There was no need to give them another meaning.

One night in Kartik, the cold had begun to deepen slightly.

Ram Ballabh was removing the torn skin from an old mridang. The room light was steady. Not even a dog barked in the lane outside.

Then from above came a thump.

Ram Ballabh's hand stopped on the hide.

No second thump came.

He did not rise from the cot.

He only listened.

For a long time there was nothing.

Then from the northern side of the roof came a faint scraping sound—as though someone were rubbing a heel before lifting a foot.

Ram Ballabh slowly placed the mridang across his thigh.

With the fingers of his right hand he gave it one stroke.

The sound came out round, deep, and clear.

He gave a second stroke.

No answer came from above.

Ram Ballabh did not strike a third time.

He took up the cord of the half-open mridang again.

There was much of the night left, work remained, and there was still no staircase to the roof.

STORY 235

The Smell of a Letter

...

After retiring from the old post office at Benipatti, Shashinath Jha now ran a small shop on the front veranda of his house, selling stamps, envelopes, and pens. Twelve years had passed since he left service, but his old habit of sorting paper had never left him. Whenever a letter came into his hand, he first noticed the thickness of the paper, then the fold, then the colour of the ink. He read the name only afterward.

One afternoon in Bhadon, while a fine rain was falling outside, his younger brother brought an old iron trunk and set it down on the veranda. It had been taken down from the loft of their ancestral house. The rear part of the house was to be repaired, so the old clothes and papers inside had to be sorted.

Shashinath opened the trunk.

On top lay two torn gamchhas, his father's old dhoti, a small clay container, and several bundles of letters. A thin layer of dust covered them. Many were addressed to his father, some to an uncle, some to people whose names Shashinath no longer even remembered.

He began separating them one by one.

Then a yellowed envelope came into his hand.

One corner was slightly torn, the ink on the front very faint, the stamp half peeled away.

The moment he opened it, a smell rose.

Shashinath's hand stopped.

Wet jute sack.

Kerosene smoke.

And old blue ink.

All three together.

He did not bring the envelope to his nose. On the contrary, he moved his hand slightly away.

Even then the smell was clear.

In twelve years of postal service he must have encountered such smells a thousand times, but in this combination they belonged to only one night in his memory.

Sawan, 1992.

Shashinath immediately wanted to fold the letter shut again, but his fingers remained on the paper.

“What happened?” his wife Kamala called from inside.

“Nothing. Old papers.”

He placed the envelope on the lid of the trunk.

Five minutes later he picked it up again.

He had never spoken at home about that night.

There was no line about it in his service record either.

Even among former colleagues, the story had later been reduced to this much: one monsoon year, many letters in the old Benipatti post office had been damaged by rainwater.

The truth had not been that simple.

Shashinath had been twenty-three then, a temporary mail-sorting worker. The old post office stood in a low part of the market. Rain had been falling for three days. The roof leaked in two places, and half a finger of water stood on the floor of the rear storeroom. The jute mail sacks were kept on wooden planks.

On the night shift were Shashinath, the elderly watchman Ramphal Das, and the clerk Jagarnath.

After nine that night, water began dripping more heavily from the eastern part of the roof. One registered-mail sack was directly beneath it.

Jagarnath said, “This sack is entered in the register. Do not let it get wet.”

Shashinath dragged it to another place.

That place was dry, but an old lantern hung beside the wall there. A little kerosene leaked from its base.

Ramphal said, “Babu, do not keep it here. The smell will settle into the paper.”

Shashinath laughed. “Save it from the water first. The smell will go later.”

Half an hour later Jagarnath went to inspect the outer gate. Ramphal went to the rear veranda to make tea on a small stove. Shashinath was alone at the sorting table.

Then one bamboo joint in the roof suddenly loosened and water poured in like a stream.

In alarm, Shashinath shifted two sacks at once.

The first was saved.

The second became wedged beneath the lantern.

Shashinath could not move it immediately. It was heavy. He called Ramphal.

Ramphal came running.

Together they pulled the sack away.

By then kerosene from the lantern base had soaked into the jute fibres. Nothing caught fire, but the smell of oil and hot metal spread through the whole room.

“I told you,” Ramphal said quietly.

Shashinath was irritated. “There was no fire. Check the letters.”

They opened the sack.

The letters on top were slightly damp. Those in the middle were mostly dry. Blue ink had spread on some envelopes.

The two of them spent the night separating the papers and spreading them across planks. Ramphal laid down old newspapers. Shashinath moved the lantern farther away.

Before dawn most of the letters had dried.

The trouble could have ended there.

But in the morning the inspector arrived.

He became angry when he saw that a registered-mail sack had been opened. There was no entry in the register recording the opening of the sack.

Before Jagarnath could explain the events of the night, the inspector asked, “Who opened the sack?”

No answer came from Shashinath’s mouth.

Ramphal said, “I opened it, Babu. The letters were getting wet.”

That was half the truth.

Ramphal had opened the sack, but at Shashinath’s instruction. Shashinath had placed it in the wrong place. The oil beneath the lantern had soaked it because of him.

The inspector descended on Ramphal.

Ramphal was a temporary watchman. His service was already being extended three months at a time. After that incident, it was not renewed at the next extension.

On paper the reason read: “Unauthorised opening of postal articles.”

Shashinath remained silent that day too.

He explained it to himself in many ways: Ramphal himself had said that he opened it; the inspector had not asked me; no fire had started; the letters were saved; if I had spoken, I might not have got a permanent job.

Each of those facts had a separate meaning.

Put together, they became only one thing—he had remained silent.

Later Ramphal began working as a night watchman at a grain shop in the market. Two years afterward Shashinath was transferred. They met less often.

Whenever someone happened to mention Ramphal's name, Shashinath changed the direction of the conversation.

Sitting on the veranda now, Shashinath opened the envelope again.

Inside was a one-page letter.

The date was blurred, but the year could still be read—1992. The month of Sawan. The Benipatti postal mark.

His throat went dry.

The letter said nothing remarkable.

A young man had written to his mother that he would send his wages the following week; that she should not stop his younger brother's studies; that the repair of the roof could be postponed for now.

At the end he had written: "There is a great deal of rain, but we are well."

Shashinath finished reading.

The smell was still there.

He called Kamala.

"Smell this."

Surprised, Kamala took the envelope.

"It smells of old paper."

"Kerosene?"

She smelled it again. "I do not notice any."

"Wet jute?"

"There were old clothes in the trunk. Everything will smell like that."

Shashinath took the letter back.

To him it was unmistakable.

This was not the ordinary smell of old paper.

It was that night itself.

The hot base of the lantern.

The wet sack.

The blue ink.

Ramphal's soaked kurta.

He examined one corner of the envelope. There was a black-brown stain.

It could have been oil.

It could have been dirt.

When he rubbed it with a finger, there was no greasiness.

Thirty-four years had passed. Even if oil had once been there, could the smell have survived like this?

He sat in the shop all afternoon.

Customers came and went. Someone bought stamps, someone an envelope, a student a pen.

Again and again Shashinath's attention returned to the trunk.

In the evening he placed the letter in a separate paper bag and left it on a low stool in the courtyard.

When he closed the shop at night, he smelled the veranda.

No odour.

He felt relieved.

At midnight the rain grew heavy. The sound of water on the tin roof woke him.

Kamala remained asleep.

Suddenly Shashinath felt there was a faint smell of kerosene in the room.

He sat up.

No lantern had burned in the house for years. They used electric light now. There was no kerosene in the kitchen either.

He opened the door and went to the veranda.

The letter lay on the courtyard stool inside its closed paper bag.

When he reached it, the smell seemed weaker.

When he returned inside, stronger again.

Shashinath stood in the darkness for a long time.

Then, for the first time, a doubt came to him:

Perhaps the smell was not rising from the letter.

Perhaps the sound of rain opened the road back to that night, and the smell came by that road.

In the morning he thought of searching for the son of his old colleague Jagarnath.

Then he did not go.

He was not even certain whether Ramphal was still alive.

What would change if he found someone and told an old story? He had no answer.

He did not throw the letter away.

Nor did he return it to the trunk.

He placed it on the upper shelf of the shop in an open earthen plate, where air could reach it.

After three days the smell had almost vanished.

Kamala said, "See? It was only old dampness."

Shashinath nodded.

On the evening of the fourth day, rain began again.

Shashinath was closing the shop. The letter on the shelf was dry. Without touching it, he looked upward.

No smell.

Then a customer came running in from outside with a wet jute sack over his head.

The moment he put the sack on the floor, the same three smells rose together—wet jute, kerosene, and something sharp like blue ink.

Shashinath's hand lifted by itself toward the shelf, then stopped halfway.

The customer asked for a stamp.

Shashinath opened the drawer, took out the stamp, handed it over, and counted the change.

His fingers did not tremble.

After the customer left, the veranda filled again with its ordinary smell.

Shashinath did not look toward the letter on the shelf.

He kept his eyes fixed instead on an empty place on the wall where an old iron hook had been removed when the shop was built.

The rain continued outside.

It seemed to him that a night could become very old, yet the age of its smell was different from the age of paper.

STORY 236

Nilkanth

...

Phulo Devi was the first to see the bird on the electric wire leading from the eastern hamlet of Manigachhi toward the fields. The morning sunlight was still caught in drops of dew. On one side of the courtyard, black makhana seeds were spread over a bamboo mat; on the other, sand was heating in an iron kadai.

The bird sat on the wire—its body dull-coloured, but when it opened its wings the blue flashed so brightly that Phulo Devi's hand stopped of its own accord. It gave three harsh calls.

“Nilkanth,” Phulo Devi said softly.

At once her daughter-in-law Saroja, who was stirring the kadai, stopped her hand. Manoj, the younger son, sitting with a wooden mallet, also looked up.

No one in the household was surprised. In place of surprise, an old caution spread through the courtyard.

“Lower the fire,” Phulo Devi said. “No one will go out during the first watch today.”

Without arguing, Saroja pulled the firewood back from the hearth. The hot sand began to cool slowly. The seeds remained only half-heated. Manoj put down the mallet.

In this house, the call of the Nilkanth was not merely a birdcall.

It was a signal to stop work.

Fifteen years earlier, Phulo Devi's husband Jagdish Mallah had fallen from a bamboo platform while unloading sacks of makhana. That morning a Nilkanth had sat on a dry mango branch and called repeatedly.

Three years later, on the day their elder son Kamlesh burned his hand on the rim of a hot kadai, the bird had called from the wire.

And once, when their granddaughter's bicycle slipped from a ridge, the same harsh cry had been heard from the roof half an hour before.

Three incidents were enough for the family.

At first the rule had been simple: when the bird called, be careful for a while.

Gradually the rules multiplied.

If it called from the east, postpone a journey.

If it called from above the house, do not light a fire.

If it called three times in succession, stop cracking makhana.

If it called five times, do not let children go outside.

Phulo Devi had never written these rules down; nevertheless every member of the household knew them by heart.

Some rules had attached themselves over time. No one could say exactly who had first spoken which one.

The problem that day was that seventy kilos of makhana had to be prepared by evening for a trader from Darbhanga.

The first roasting had been completed the previous day. The seeds had rested for two days; if the second roasting and cracking were delayed too long, the puffing would suffer.

Saroja knew this.

Phulo Devi knew it too.

“We will begin after noon,” Phulo Devi said.

Saroja looked at the kadai. “Heating the sand again will take time.”

“Then let it take time.”

“The trader will send his vehicle at five.”

Phulo Devi did not answer.

Her eyes remained on the electric wire.

The Nilkanth was still sitting there, moving its tail lightly. Then it spread its wings and flew toward the fields. For one instant, the blue of its wings flashed in the sunlight, then vanished.

Manoj wanted to laugh, but after seeing his grandmother’s face, he remained silent.

Work remained stopped until noon.

The house was so quiet that when the iron kadai beside the hearth cooled and made a small tick, everyone’s eyes turned toward it.

Saroja kept taking the seeds into her hand and examining them. Some had already received heat on their outer shells; others had received less. The evenness of the heating had been broken.

At two o’clock Phulo Devi herself said, “Now begin.”

Work started again.

The sand heated.

Saroja stirred the seeds.

Manoj took the hot seeds out in small batches and struck them with the wooden mallet. The white makhana burst through the shell and opened like flowers.

But the first batch was uneven. Some puffed fully; some remained hard in the centre.

“At this rate there will be a loss,” Saroja said.

Phulo Devi heard her but remained silent.

At three o’clock, from the fields behind the house, the harsh call came again.

This time the bird could not be seen.

Only the sound.

Manoj’s mallet stopped in mid-air.

“Dadi?”

Phulo Devi’s face tightened. “That was once.”

A few moments later came the second call.

Saroja continued stirring the kadai.

The third call sounded closer than the first two.

Phulo Devi stood up. “Enough. Smother the fire.”

Saroja’s hand did not stop. “Ma, the first time we stopped, half the batch was spoiled. If we stop again, all of it will spoil.”

“There will be makhana again.”

“How will the money come again?”

Never before had the question been put so directly in that house.

Phulo Devi looked at Saroja. “Will you invite an accident for money?”

“Does the bird invite the accident, or do we lose our work because we are afraid?”

Manoj put down the mallet. He knew there was no place for him in this argument.

Just then a bamboo basket kept to the left of the hearth suddenly overturned. Some hot seeds scattered across the ground.

Stepping backward, Manoj caught his foot on a low stool and fell sitting down. His elbow scraped against the earth.

Phulo Devi’s face went pale. “See?”

Saroja immediately went to Manoj.

The skin on his elbow had been scraped and two small drops of blood had appeared. It was not a serious injury.

Manoj looked toward the basket. "My foot hit it."

"The call came first," Phulo Devi said.

Saroja said nothing.

She washed Manoj's elbow and wiped it with cloth. Then she began gathering the seeds scattered on the ground.

That day the batch was completed late.

The trader's vehicle came after dark.

The seventy kilos came out five kilos short. Because of the uneven puffing, some of the makhana had to be kept aside.

The trader cut the price.

After supper that night, the subject of the Nilkanth returned.

Phulo Devi pointed to Manoj's scraped elbow.

Saroja pointed to the sack holding the five kilos of under-puffed makhana.

Each had her own evidence.

Over the next few weeks the rules became stricter.

The moment Phulo Devi heard the call, she had the hearth put out.

Kamlesh stopped himself from going to the market.

Manoj would take his bicycle outside and then bring it back in.

At first Saroja continued to object. Later, even she began slowing her hands involuntarily whenever the call came.

Gradually she understood one peculiar quality of fear: even when the mind does not accept something, the body can learn its rules.

One morning in Kartik a new batch of makhana arrived.

This time the trader had paid half the money in advance. He had made it clear that if the goods were not delivered on time, the next batch would be given to another household.

The first day's work passed without interruption.

So did the second.

On the evening of the third day, while the final roasting was underway, a Nilkanth came and sat on the electric wire.

Saroja saw it first.

The bird was silent.

A strange hope rose in her—fly away, do not call.

She kept stirring the kadai.

Phulo Devi was inside sorting paddy.

Manoj was stitching a sack.

The Nilkanth moved its tail.

It turned its neck.

Then it gave the harsh call.

Saroja's hand stopped by itself.

The second call.

Footsteps sounded from inside: Phulo Devi was coming.

Saroja looked at the kadai.

The sand was very hot. At this temperature the seeds had to be turned within moments. If she smothered the fire and abandoned the kadai now, the loss would be like the first batch.

The third call.

Phulo Devi reached the doorway.

"The fire—"

"No," Saroja said.

After that single word, the courtyard became so still that the dry rustle of the seeds in the hot sand could be heard.

Saroja kept stirring the kadai.

Phulo Devi remained standing where she was.

The needle and thread stopped in Manoj's hand.

The Nilkanth called again.

A fourth time.

Saroja's palm grew damp.

Against her will, Manoj's old scraped elbow, Kamlesh's burned hand, and Jagdish's bamboo platform all rose together in her mind.

The handle of the kadai was growing hot.

"Ma, stay two handspans away from the fire," was all she said.

Then the seeds were taken out.

Manoj lifted the mallet.

The first seed burst.

The second.

The third.

One by one, the white flowers opened.

Nothing happened.

Ten minutes.

Twenty minutes.

Half an hour.

Phulo Devi slowly sat down on the veranda.

Her eyes remained on the wire.

The bird had flown away long before.

By evening the batch was complete.

No hand was burned.

No one fell.

No sack overturned.

Saroja ought to have felt relief.

Instead, an empty place opened inside her—as though something had been due to happen and had merely not happened yet.

That night the trader took the goods away.

The money was counted.

Everyone in the house ate supper.

Phulo Devi spoke very little.

Around midnight, Saroja woke at a sound.

Harsh.

Brief.

Far away.

She sat up on the cot.

Nilkanth?

The bird normally did not call at night—Manoj had said that one day. Saroja was not sure where his knowledge had come from.

Outside, it was dark.

The sound came again.

This time from the eastern side of the house.

Saroja slowly opened the door.

The courtyard was empty.

The electric wire could not be seen in the darkness.

There was little wind.

Then she realised the sound was not coming from above.

It was coming from near the hearth.

The old iron kadai, heated throughout the day, was cooling. Along its outer rim ran a fine crack. As the metal contracted, it gave an occasional harsh

kirr—a small piece of exactly the kind of sound the household had come to recognise as the Nilkanth's cry.

Saroja sat beside the kadai and waited for the next sound.

After a while, kirr.

She did not smile.

She only listened.

From the cot behind her came Phulo Devi's cough.

"Did the bird call?"

Saroja paused before answering.

"It is the kadai, Ma."

Phulo Devi said nothing.

Until dawn, no accident occurred.

In the morning, while cleaning the hearth, Saroja showed Phulo Devi the fine crack in the kadai.

Phulo Devi touched it with a finger, then withdrew her hand.

"That was the night sound," Saroja said.

"At night, perhaps," Phulo Devi replied. "And in the day?"

Saroja fell silent.

At that very moment a Nilkanth came and sat on the eastern electric wire.

The sunlight was still soft.

The bird sat with its wings folded, looking around.

No one stopped working.

It called once.

Manoj continued stitching the sack.

Kamlesh continued untying the bullock cart.

Saroja poured sand into a new kadai.

Only Phulo Devi became still for a moment.

Then she pushed the wood farther into the hearth.

The bird called a second time.

Work in the courtyard continued.

Before it could call a third time, it flew from the wire.

Its blue wings flashed in the sunlight.

Phulo Devi looked up without meaning to.

Her hand was still on the firewood.

She did not take it away.

STORY 237

The Second Room

...

Inside the old market south of Jaynagar station stood a hotel called Mithila Vishram. The name was grand; the building was ordinary—a two-storeyed brick house with a narrow courtyard in the middle and, above, a veranda with a wooden railing.

I was staying there for three nights. A publisher from Darbhanga had sent me to a printing press in Jaynagar to supervise corrections for a new edition of a school textbook. All day my eyes remained fixed among ink, paper, and type; by the time I returned to the hotel at night, my body was tired.

My room was number seventeen on the second floor.

As soon as one climbed the stairs, a plan of the building hung in a glass frame on the wall to the right. Escape routes for fire or other emergencies were marked in red, the rooms in blue squares.

The sequence ran from eleven to eighteen.

After eighteen came a thick wall; then the corridor turned and ended near a latticed window.

On the first night, a little after the rain had stopped, I went outside to drink water.

The main corridor light was out. The yellow glow of the bulb in the courtyard rose faintly to the upper floor.

Beyond room eighteen, on the wall that I had seen bare during the day, there now appeared a narrow door.

I stopped.

The door looked black. Both upright lines of the frame were clear; the upper horizontal line was slightly crooked. On the right was a round dark spot, like a handle. Along the bottom ran a thin pale strip.

There was no number above it.

I went five steps closer.

The door did not move.

That part of the wall was darker than the rest, but the shape was so distinct that it was difficult to blame my fatigue.

I reached out to touch it.

My fingers met cold, damp plaster.

Not wood—a wall.

I stepped back at once.

When I looked again, the shape was still there.

A door to the eye; a wall to the hand.

Back in my room, I remembered the plan.

There was no room after eighteen.

In the morning I went to the same place.

The wall was a dull white and flat. There was no trace of the black frame from the night.

Where I had seen the round handle on the right, there was only a grey spot about the size of a fingertip. Where the pale strip had been below, a fine crust of lime had formed.

I laughed at myself.

Wet wall, yellow light, tired eyes—between them, a door could easily be made.

But the curiosity remained.

After tea I went down into the courtyard and tried to reckon the outer side of that wall.

Below the veranda ran an old earthen drainpipe for rainwater. At one joint, drops of water were still sliding down the wall.

From outside there was no extra window and no projection.

I tried counting steps to see whether there was room for a separate chamber inside, but the thick courtyard pillar and the thickness of the walls spoiled the calculation.

At the printing press that day, even while matching page numbers, my mind kept running back to the hotel.

When I returned in the evening, the rain had started again.

The hotel owner, Ramlochan Sah, was writing accounts at the reception desk.

I asked casually, “Has the wall after room eighteen ever been opened?”

He looked up. “During the rains it has to be opened up for repairs. It catches damp. Why?”

“Nothing. The plaster looked swollen.”

“The mason is coming tomorrow.”

That was all he said.

No old story. No mystery.

His indifference should have reassured me. Instead I began to feel that there really was something in that wall which the hotel people simply dismissed as dampness.

The rain was heavy on the second night.

At about midnight I went out deliberately.

The courtyard bulb was still burning.

The door on the wall was clearer than on the first night.

The space within the outline was a shade darker than the surrounding wall. The round spot too had deepened. The pale strip below now shone almost across the full width.

I brought a piece of red chalk from my room. I kept it for marking corrections on proofs.

Where I saw the left upright line of the door, I made a small red dot on the wall. Then a second dot on the right line.

To measure the distance between the two, I laid my palm along the wall five times.

The shape was a little more than six palm-widths across.

At dawn I went back.

The door had vanished.

The two red dots remained on the wall.

The distance between them really was a little more than six palm-widths.

I resisted the urge to draw a straight line joining them. If, in daylight, I made the door myself, what would be left of the night's mystery?

At noon a mason came. His name was Sakur.

He tapped the swollen plaster low on the wall with the back of his hammer. I sat on the veranda pretending to read proofs while watching him work.

First he scraped away the crumbling crust below.

Then he put his chisel to the round grey mark.

As soon as the first layer fell away, the brick behind it showed a different colour.

The old wall was built of dark red brick; in the middle, a rectangular section was made of paler yellow brick. The bonding too was newer.

Sakur scraped the plaster upward.

Slowly an entire rectangular boundary emerged—exactly where I had seen the door at night.

A shiver passed through me again, but this time the cause stood in front of me.

There had once been a doorway here.

Later it had been filled in with brick.

“Was this a passage before?” I asked.

Sakur brushed dust from the wall. “Could be. These bricks are later. But it is not hollow behind them. It has been fully built up.”

He struck two bricks.

A solid sound.

“Then why does the frame show at night?”

He looked at me, then touched the wall. “These newer bricks draw more water. The older ones draw less. When it rains, the joints take on different colours. Once dry, they look almost the same again.”

Pointing to the pale strip along the bottom, he said, “That is salt coming out. As the water in the wall dries, lime and salts rise to the surface.”

And the round grey spot?

Sakur pushed his chisel into it and drew out a small rusted piece of iron—perhaps the remnant of an old latch fitting or wire. Rust around it had made the circular stain in the plaster.

I remembered my night-time ‘handle.’

The mystery was, for the most part, finished.

But one question remained: what had been behind this closed passage?

On the plan there was no room after eighteen.

Sakur measured from the inside. “This section must fall behind room eighteen. In the old arrangement perhaps there was a door here, and later an inner partition was removed. Now there is no separate room.”

I stood outside room eighteen and worked through the measurements.

He was right.

Once the wall thickness and the length of room eighteen were added together, there was no space left for a separate chamber.

What I had begun to call ‘the second room’ may once have been a separate room—or may never have been one—but in the present building there was no place for it.

By evening Sakur had removed the damaged plaster and applied fresh lime.

The old rectangular section became white again.

Both red dots disappeared beneath the new coating.

That night there was no rain.

I went outside at ten, at midnight, and again at one.

No door.

Only the white wall and the smell of fresh plaster.

I felt faintly embarrassed by my own fear.

I was to return to Darbhanga the next morning.

I thought I would sleep early.

But in the last watch of the night I woke to the sound of water falling on the roof.

It had begun raining again.

I opened my door and stepped into the corridor.

The main light was out. Only the yellow courtyard bulb was burning.

The new plaster was getting wet.

Beyond room eighteen, the rectangular section of wall had begun to darken again.

This time I knew the reason.

New brick, old brick, different behaviour under dampness.

There was no pale salt line below now because Sakur had scraped it away.

The round rust stain was gone too.

Even so, it looked like a door to me.

I went close and laid my palm against the wall.

Cold, wet lime.

Solid.

Just then, from inside, came the sound of a page being turned.

One page.

Then another.

I took my hand away.

The sound could have come from room eighteen. The wall adjoined it. Someone might be awake reading at night. That was entirely ordinary.

Yet the direction of the sound seemed to me to come from the middle of that rectangular section.

I did not put my ear to the wall.

I had no wish to begin searching for a second illusion behind the first.

In the morning I packed my belongings and went downstairs.

I stopped once beside the building plan.

Eleven through eighteen.

After that, a thick wall.

No second room.

Taking the key, Ramlochan said, "The damp upstairs should be all right now."

"Yes," I said. "There is nothing inside the wall."

He looked at me questioningly, but I said nothing more.

As I walked toward the station, I remembered that when I had heard the pages turning in the night, there had been no light under the door of room eighteen.

Perhaps the person inside had been asleep in darkness, and the sound had only been water drops or a loose sheet of paper.

I did not turn back to look at the hotel.

But after I sat down in the train, the coldness of wet lime remained in my palm for a long time.

STORY 238

Beneath the Earth

...

For three years the courtyard of our ancestral house in Khajauli had been slowly sinking. During the rains, water crept toward the eastern veranda; in winter, fine cracks appeared in the middle of the courtyard. This time I decided that the old bricks should be removed, the soil beneath repaired, and stone laid again. Gudari Paswan and his son Chhotan arrived early in the morning with spades.

I had been born in that house, but for thirty-five years I had worked in bookbinding in Darbhanga. Now I came home only two or three times a year. I remembered which tree had once stood in which corner of the courtyard, which wall had formerly been mud-built—but how could I know what lay beneath the earth?

By noon two rows of old bricks had been lifted.

At the third row Chhotan's spade struck something hard.

The sound was metallic, not the sound of brick.

He bent his knees and cleared away the soil.

A rusted metal box appeared—slightly longer than a palm, half as wide, with a small clasp on top.

I was sitting on the veranda writing accounts when I heard the metallic note and looked up.

The moment I saw the box, my left hand closed into a fist by itself.

Then I said a sentence whose meaning I did not understand even as I spoke it:

“Do not lift the upper right corner. Press the clasp first. The blue marble will be stuck there.”

Chhotan's spade stopped in his hand.

Gudari looked at me.

“What marble, Malik?”

My mouth went dry.

“I... only meant that it is rusted. Do not force it.”

“The blue marble?” Chhotan asked again.

I did not answer.

They brought the box out of the earth and placed it on the veranda.

The clasp really did loosen when pressed from the right.

Chhotan lifted the lid halfway, then stopped.

Inside the upper right corner, caught between soil and rust, was a blue glass marble.

Gudari's eyes were no longer on the box.

They were on me.

"Had you seen this before?"

"No."

"Then how?"

"There may have been a box like this in childhood. I do not remember."

I gave that answer less to him than to myself.

The lid was opened fully.

There was nothing frightening inside.

A blue glass marble, two brass buttons, a smooth black pebble, half a clay whistle, and a decayed knot of red thread.

All the objects were embedded in rust-dust and dry soil.

They were the sort of things that could have been found in any child's pocket.

But what happened inside me did not match the ordinariness of the objects.

Without thinking, I picked up the blue marble.

I placed it in my right palm and tapped it twice with a finger.

Then I set the two brass buttons some distance apart, placed the black pebble between them, and the clay whistle below.

When I lifted the knot of red thread, my hand began to tremble.

"Where is the fifth one?" I heard myself say.

Chhotan did not laugh.

Neither did Gudari.

"The fifth what?"

I counted the things.

One blue marble. Two buttons. One black pebble. One clay fragment. Red thread.

The count itself had become confused.

What exactly had I been counting?

"Nothing," I said. "Put everything back inside."

Gudari asked slowly, "Shall we stop digging here?"

"Yes," I said at once.

Then, just as quickly, I corrected myself.

"No. Why stop the work? The soil is weak. We need to see all of it."

The digging continued that day, but my attention no longer remained on the work.

I left the box on a shelf in the veranda.

Again and again my eyes went toward it.

Whenever I thought of the blue marble lying inside, the centre of my right palm seemed to remember its coldness.

In the evening my wife Malati returned from the market.

At first the box interested her. She took out the objects one by one and looked at them.

"These are children's playthings," she said. "Could they have been yours?"

"I do not know."

"Then how did you know about the blue marble before the box was opened?"

Gudari had already told her everything.

I became irritated.

"Something must have flashed in my mind. A childhood thing. Must everything have an explanation?"

Malati fell silent.

I disliked the sound of my own voice.

There was nothing in the box that gave me any reason to be angry with her.

After supper I decided to make a test.

I asked Malati to rearrange the objects inside the box however she wished while I stayed outside.

Five minutes later she called me.

With my eyes closed, I put my hand into the box and tried to find the blue marble.

First I touched the black pebble.

Then the clay whistle.

The blue marble was in the left corner, and I found it only at the end.

"See?" Malati said. "You do not have any special knowledge."

I breathed more easily.

But not completely.

The first time, before I had seen the blue marble, I had known not only where it was but how the clasp would open.

Under the lantern light I examined the outside of the box again.

Beneath the handle, a fine dry root had become trapped in the rust. It was so old that it powdered at a touch.

Across the lid were three parallel scratches.

At once my mind said: I made these scratches.

Then I startled at my own certainty.

Such scratches could exist on any ordinary box.

Malati asked, "Are you looking for your name or some mark?"

"No."

But my finger kept moving between the scratches.

For a moment I felt that at the end of the third scratch there ought to be a small circle.

There was nothing there.

Yet the empty place disappointed me—as though something expected had gone missing.

That disappointment made me still more uneasy, because I did not know where the expectation had come from.

I could not sleep until late.

I tried to remember the courtyard of my childhood.

There had once been a jujube tree here.

In the northern corner we made a mud hearth.

After rain, my younger brother Pawan and I sailed little boats in the mud.

There was also a hazy memory of playing with glass marbles.

But a metal box?

Red thread?

A black pebble?

Nothing became clear.

One scene returned again and again.

I was kneeling beside a small square hole in the soil.

Someone was holding my left hand.

That was all.

Whose hand? Why? What year?

Everything beyond that was smoke.

Whenever I tried to make the scene clearer, it changed.

Sometimes it was day.

Sometimes evening.

Sometimes I seemed to be alone.

I got up and drank water.

Then I went toward the veranda.

The box was on the shelf.

I did not want to touch it.

Even so, my hand reached out.

This time my right finger did not go to the clasp. My left thumb did.

The clasp opened.

Then I noticed that the left end of the thin metal strip had lifted slightly. The thumb rested there naturally.

Perhaps the first time too I had unconsciously read the construction of the clasp and understood how it opened.

The blue marble was not so easily explained.

I closed the box again.

Instead of returning it to the shelf, I carried it into the middle of the courtyard.

The trench opened during the day was still unfilled. Pale moonlight lay along the edge of the soil.

I stood beside the trench.

Then something strange happened.

I took a step as though measuring—not after deciding to do so.

One.

Two.

Three.

At the third step I turned left.

Then two more steps.

My body moved as though it knew an old path.

At the fifth step I stopped.

The soil there was untouched. No one had dug it during the day.

My right hand rose by itself and pointed downward.

I clasped both hands behind my back.

The next day, when Gudari arrived, he asked, "Shall we open the eastern side today?"

"Yes."

He raised his spade and moved toward the untouched spot where my feet had stopped during the night.

My throat tightened.

I wanted to say, Not there.

The words reached my mouth.

But I held them back.

The spade entered the earth.

Once.

Twice.

Three times.

Only ordinary black soil came out.

No metallic sound.

Whether I laughed inwardly or trembled, I could not tell.

Gudari dug down about one and a half handspans.

Nothing was found.

"The soil is sound here," he said. "This part has not sunk."

"Then leave it," I said.

He moved on.

For a while I remained standing beside the empty hole.

It should have reassured me.

Instead another question arose:

If the path I had walked in the night was not memory, why had my body counted five steps and brought me to that spot?

And if it was memory, why was there nothing beneath the earth?

By noon the courtyard had begun to level out again.

I did not clean the first box.

I left the rust as it was.

Malati said, "Shall we throw it away?"

"No."

"Then where will you keep it?"

I took too long to answer.

My mind said first: beneath the earth.

So clearly, so naturally, that it seemed not to be my own answer.

I placed the box on the shelf.

“Here.”

After the new stone was laid, the courtyard became level.

There was no trench, no line of old bricks.

Yet whenever I cross the courtyard from the veranda, my body still slows slightly at the fifth step.

I do not look down at that place.

What frightens me is not what may have been inside the box.

It is the thought that my body may know a place beneath the earth better than my mind does.

STORY 239

The Stamp

...

In the Jhanjharpur circle office, the smallest object was a round brass stamp. It was so small that it could fit entirely in a palm, yet without its impression half the papers of the office could not leave the building. Certified copies of land records, notices of mutation, copies of old khatiyans—at the end of all of them came the round red impression, and only then did people regard the paper as official.

The wooden handle of the stamp had grown old. The round brass face underneath was held in place by a small screw. Harinandan Jha, the copy clerk, would often turn it with his fingers to make sure it had not come loose.

But on that Monday morning, when he opened the ink pad and lifted the handle, there was only wood underneath.

The round brass face was gone.

At first he thought it must have fallen into the ink box. He lifted the red pad.

Nothing beneath it.

The desk drawer, the stacks of paper, the pen holder, under the chair—everything was searched.

“Lallan!” His voice rose without intention.

Lallan Paswan, the peon, came running from the veranda. “What happened?”

Harinandan showed him the empty wooden handle.

Lallan’s mouth remained open. “Where did the face go?”

“That is what I am trying to find.”

Within five minutes the matter had reached Head Clerk Shyamanand Babu.

Within ten minutes the door of the Circle Officer’s room was closed.

Within fifteen minutes Lallan had been stationed at the main gate with instructions not to let anyone leave without permission.

The people already standing in line for certified copies first assumed that some inspection had arrived.

But when voices began to rise from inside—"Open every drawer," "Turn over the papers," "Stop the sweeping"—the news spread outside as well.

Sukhiya Devi of Phulparas had changed buses for three hours to get there. She needed a copy of an old jamabandi in her husband's name.

Holding her paper at the window, she asked, "Will I get my copy today?"

Harinandan did not even look at her. "The stamp is missing."

"Has someone gone to bring new ink?"

"The ink is here. The stamp is missing."

Sukhiya Devi remained silent for a few moments. "But the paper has been written?"

"It has."

"Signed?"

"That too."

"Then why is my paper stopped?"

For the first time Harinandan looked at her. "Without the round impression, how can it be certified?"

Meanwhile the Circle Officer ordered every employee to remain beside his own desk.

The Head Clerk called for a new register.

At the top was written: "Stamp Search Record."

The time was entered: 10:17 a.m.

Who had last seen it, who had touched it, what time the office had closed the previous evening—everyone's statement began to be recorded separately.

Harinandan said that after five the previous evening, a specimen impression of the stamp had been made for the annual inspection.

A specimen of every government stamp was kept on thick paper, with its serial number and dimensions, and preserved in a secured file. Shyamanand Babu himself supervised it.

"After the specimen was made?" the Circle Officer asked.

"I wiped the stamp and put it back in the ink box."

"Did you actually see that you had put it back?"

Harinandan stopped.

"I remember putting down the handle."

"Did you see the brass face?"

For a moment silence filled the room.

With that one question, the crisis grew larger.

It was no longer merely a matter of a missing object. It was now described as a possible misuse of an official stamp.

If someone had taken it, any number of false documents might have been stamped during the night.

There was discussion of informing the police station.

Two clerks disagreed over whether the departmental letter should be prepared first or the search completed first.

One clerk said, "A letter can be prepared, but the letter itself will need a stamp."

Everyone looked at him.

He added quickly, "I mean the ordinary outward stamp."

The Head Clerk frowned. "This is not the time for jokes."

No one laughed, though Lallan went out to the veranda and began clearing his throat.

By noon the whole rhythm of the office had changed.

Files that had been gathering dust on upper shelves for years were brought down.

Old newspapers were unfolded.

The bamboo basket of Sona Devi, the sweeper, was overturned.

Lallan's bag was searched.

Harinandan himself turned his pockets inside out.

Sukhiya Devi remained seated beside the window.

Her bus left at four.

Again and again she looked at her certified copy, where the final empty circular space waited for the red impression.

At two o'clock a constable arrived from the police station.

His first question was the size of the stamp.

"One and a half inches round," Harinandan said.

"Brass?"

"Yes, brass."

"Weight?"

No one had the answer.

Someone immediately proposed sending Lallan to the market for a scale, but the Circle Officer stopped them.

"When the object itself is missing, how will you weigh it now?"

The constable wrote in his register: "Weight unknown."

Those two words made everyone more serious.

Meanwhile the Head Clerk called for the old stores register.

Five years earlier, the wooden handle purchased for the stamp had been entered at a price of thirteen rupees and fifty paise; the brass face had no separate price.

This raised another question: what financial value should be assigned to the missing object?

The accounts clerk said, "If we do not know the value of the object, the loss report will remain incomplete."

In a tired voice Harinandan said, "Write the value of all the people's work that has stopped in one day because there is no impression."

The accounts clerk looked at him as though he had damaged the language of the register.

It was decided that the value would be fixed later.

First, the dimensions of the round brass face had to be established.

They measured the diameter of the empty wooden handle, but the constable said the handle and the face did not necessarily have to be equal.

Someone suggested deriving the diameter from the specimen impression made the previous day.

Shyamanand Babu immediately objected. "It would not be proper to open the secured specimen file unnecessarily."

At that sentence, Satish looked up once, then lowered his head again.

Outside, the people in line had begun offering their own estimates.

Some said the brass piece would fetch no more than five rupees if sold.

Others said an entire village's land could be altered with it.

Sukhiya Devi silently kept straightening the corner of her paper.

The empty round space for the red stamp now looked like a hole in the document.

Then Satish, a new employee in the copy section who had joined only three months earlier, asked quietly, "Has yesterday's specimen file been checked?"

Shyamanand Babu said, "It is secured."

"Checked?"

"Why open a secured file? It contains the specimen impression, not the stamp."

Satish fell silent.

Half an hour later the Circle Officer himself said, "Bring it anyway."

The file was in the upper compartment of an iron cupboard.

The key was with the Circle Officer.

The cupboard was opened.

A thick file tied in red cloth was taken out.

On it were the previous day's date, the stamp number, and Shyamanand Babu's signature.

When the file was opened, the round red specimen impression was clearly visible on the first page.

Everyone gathered around it.

"See," Shyamanand Babu said, "the stamp was in its proper place until yesterday."

Satish lifted the page.

The paper felt heavier than expected.

Behind the specimen impression, the thin layer of wax that had been placed there had dried hard.

As the page was separated from the sheet beneath it, there came a small scraping sound.

Below, a round brass edge gleamed.

No one spoke at first.

Satish carefully turned the page over.

The brass face of the stamp was half embedded in the red wax.

While the specimen impression was being made the previous day, the screw must have loosened. The wooden handle had lifted away, while the brass face remained caught in the warm wax.

The specimen sheet had immediately been pressed beneath another page to dry and placed inside the file.

Then the file, considered "secure," had been locked in the cupboard.

A smile first appeared on Lallan's face, but seeing the Circle Officer, he suppressed it.

The constable closed his register.

Shyamanand Babu lifted the round brass piece as though someone had found a sick child.

Harinandan brought forward the wooden handle.

The brass face was screwed back onto it.

After two turns Satish said, "The screw is worn."

"That is why it fell off," Harinandan said.

The Circle Officer did not answer.

He first looked at the "Stamp Search Record," then at the constable from the police station.

"What should be written in the report?" Shyamanand Babu asked.

After much consideration, the sentence was framed:

"The stamp had not left the office premises; during the annual specimen-security procedure, it had temporarily become secured within the original specimen file."

Satish kept his head lowered, looking at the paper.

At the words "temporarily become secured," his lips moved, but he said nothing.

At 3:40 p.m. the main gate was opened.

People carrying their papers again moved toward the window.

Sukhiya Devi stood first in line.

Harinandan took her copy, pressed the stamp onto the red pad, and placed the round impression on the paper.

The impression came out half unclear.

The screw was loose again.

Harinandan tightened it and moved to stamp the paper a second time, but Shyamanand Babu stopped him.

"Two impressions on one paper will look against the rules. The first is sufficient."

Sukhiya Devi folded the paper and put it in her bag.

She said nothing.

It was time for her to catch her bus.

The next morning a new arrangement appeared on the desk.

A thin brass chain had been attached to the wooden handle of the stamp, and the other end tied to a leg of the desk.

Now the stamp could not disappear.

But the chain was so short that the stamp could not reach the papers held by people standing at the window.

For every document Harinandan first had to pull the paper inside, bring it to the corner of the desk, stamp it, then slide it back out.

By noon, the line outside the window had grown longer than the day before.

Inside, the brass stamp lay secure within the limits of its chain.

STORY 240

Autobiography of the File

...

I was not born on a writer's desk. I was born in the Copy Section of the Biraal Block Office, between two sheets of red cardboard, when twenty-seven people of Piprahi Tola put their thumb impressions and signatures on a petition.

The petition was brief. The old wooden footbridge over the irrigation channel had broken. In the rains, children going to school, people carrying milk to the market, and labourers heading for the fields had to wade through knee-deep water. All they asked for was two strong bamboo poles and four planks.

In the beginning I had seven pages.

The first was the petition. The second carried twenty-seven names. The third held the mukhiya's recommendation. On the fourth were two photographs of the broken bridge. The fifth contained a mason's estimate. The sixth gave the width of the channel. And the seventh was a red slip marked: "Urgent."

At that time I found the word "Urgent" very impressive.

Later I learnt that in a government file the word is often like the name printed at the top of a wedding invitation: conspicuous above everyone else, but with no separate place reserved for it when the meal is served.

At the first desk sat Junior Clerk Bhola Jha.

One leg of his desk was shorter than the others; beneath it lay the torn cover of an old register as a prop.

He read me, nodded, and wrote: "The matter appears to pertain to the Rural Works Section."

I liked the word "appears."

It was the kind of word by which a person could accept a thing without quite admitting it, and reject it without quite denying it.

I reached the second desk.

That desk was two fingers higher than the first.

Assistant Clerk Shivkant Babu sat there.

He seemed to like Bhola Jha's blue ink more than my seven pages.

He wrote: "The irrigation channel may fall under the Irrigation Department. Verification of ownership required."

I was sent to the third desk.

The third desk had a sheet of glass over it.

The babu there did not place tea on top of me; a separate circular stain had already been reserved for his glass.

He called for a map of the channel.

When the map arrived, the channel was not on it at all.

The reason was simple: when the map had been made, the place where the channel now ran had still been a field.

Then arose the question: if the channel did not exist on the map, which department should repair the bridge built over it?

In the search for an answer, my pages grew from seven to thirteen.

For the first time my thread was replaced with a thicker one.

I was pleased.

I thought becoming larger meant making progress.

A week later I reached the desk of the Block Engineer.

He opened me and looked at the first photograph.

Two children stood beside the channel. One held his slippers in his hand; the other was scraping mud with his foot.

The engineer said, "This is not a bridge. It is a temporary crossing."

The land surveyor sitting beside him said, "How can a temporary structure receive permanent repairs?"

Both laughed.

It was then that I first understood the hierarchy of human beings.

A question travelling from below to above is called serious.

An answer travelling from above to below is called an order.

And a matter moving round and round on the same desk is called deliberation.

The engineer wrote: "Site inspection required."

I returned to Bhola Jha's desk, because the letter for the site inspection had to issue from there.

Seeing me, Bhola said, "You again?"

Had I been allowed to speak, I would have said: "Not I. It is everything you people have written that has come back."

But a file has no right to speak.

Its only right is to grow more pages.
 A date was fixed for inspection.
 It rained that day.
 A second date was fixed.
 The jeep had gone elsewhere on official work.
 On the third date the engineer fell ill.
 By the fourth date the water in the channel had gone down.
 When the inspection team finally arrived, the children were crossing easily,
 hitching their clothes above the shallow water.
 The report stated: "Passage currently possible; difficulty likely during the
 rains."
 That sentence made me want to laugh.
 When the difficulty existed, inspection had not been possible.
 When inspection became possible, the difficulty could no longer be seen.
 Human intelligence on paper is highly disciplined by the weather.
 Meanwhile, Subhadra Devi of Piprahi came to the office three times.
 The first time she asked Bhola Jha, "What happened to our bridge?"
 Bhola said, "The file has gone up."
 The second time Shivkant Babu said, "The file is with the engineer."
 The third time the engineer's clerk said, "The file has gone down again."
 Subhadra Devi looked up at the sky and said, "The bridge is in the same
 place. Why does the file keep going up and down?"
 No one answered.
 I knew the answer.
 Human beings measure the height of their posts by the journey of paper.
 Two months later I went to the Subdivisional Office.
 The peon carrying me held me tight against his chest on the bus.
 For the first time I saw beyond the walls of the block office.
 At the subdivision I was welcomed by a new page: "The financial limit
 applicable to the matter is unclear."
 My estimated cost was only three thousand eight hundred rupees, yet
 clarification of the financial limit required opinions from two branches.
 The Accounts Section circled passages in me with red pencil.
 The Planning Section added a green slip.
 The Rural Works Section added a yellow one.

My red cover began to look too small for what I had become.

I now had thirty-four pages.

To find the original petition, half my body had to be turned over.

One day an Assistant Officer read only the slip on top without opening me and wrote: "Guidance of the higher authority required."

I reached the District Office.

There the desks were much wider, the chairs much more heavily cushioned, and the hands that touched me much fewer.

One employee opened me, another marked me, a third tied me shut again.

The officer's pen gave me only thirteen words: "The matter shall be disposed of at the local level in accordance with rules."

I returned to the subdivision, then the block office, then the engineer, then Bhola Jha.

My journey was circular, but every note said "forwarded."

I came to understand that word in my own way: return to the very place from which you started, but because you touched several desks on the way, let each of them believe you have moved forward.

By the next rainy season, the people of Piprahi had stopped waiting.

They cut two thick palm trunks and laid them across the channel, tied bamboo over them, and packed earth at both ends.

The children began going to school again without removing their slippers.

Subhadra Devi contributed old bamboo from her house.

Parsu Yadav, who sold milk, gave rope.

Vinod the mason worked for two days without taking wages.

News of this reached me in the form of a new photograph.

The land surveyor who went for site verification attached it and wrote: "Temporary crossing presently available."

I thought perhaps the matter would now be considered finished.

But in a human office, whatever becomes complete on the ground often becomes a new question on paper.

The Accounts Section asked: "Under which budget head was the said temporary structure constructed?"

The Panchayat replied: "Community contribution."

Then came the second question: "If passage is available through community contribution, what is the immediate necessity for government expenditure?"

Inside me, the first page of the original petition seemed to tremble faintly.

That page said that in heavy rain the bamboo was washed away, and that the children needed a permanent bridge.

But by then, before anyone could reach the first page, they had to pass through thirty-seven notes, nine opinions, five inspection slips, and two reports.

Subhadra Devi came again.

This time she brought with her the boy who had stood in the first photograph holding his slippers.

He had grown tall now and was studying in Class Eight.

Seeing his old photograph on my open page, he laughed.

“Is that me?”

Bhola Jha said, “Yes. This file is still moving because of you.”

The boy asked, “But now I cross without taking off my slippers.”

Bhola smiled. “Files take time.”

Again I wanted to laugh.

Time did not happen to me.

Wherever I was placed, I simply lay there.

Time happened to human beings—waiting for one another’s signatures, sliding their own responsibility into the shadow of the next desk.

Eventually I had fifty-nine pages. A new decision arrived: instead of building a permanent bridge, there would be a safety inspection of the temporary structure. The engineer visited the site. The palm trunks were solid, and the bamboo had recently been replaced. He wrote: “No immediate danger; reinspection advisable before the next rainy season.”

After that sentence, no desk sent me upward again. I was placed in an iron cupboard in the record room. A number was painted on my spine in white ink. Around me lay files concerning land disputes, old-age assistance, a broken hand pump, and warehouse rent. Each had its own journey. At night, when the office fell silent, dust slowly settled over us.

A few months later Bhola Jha opened the cupboard while looking for another file. He saw me and pulled me out. My thread had loosened, so he opened me to retie it. The first page appeared before him—the twenty-seven names, the broken bridge, the photograph of the two children. For some time Bhola looked at the picture. Then he read the last page: “Reinspection advisable before the next rainy season.” Whether he laughed or sighed, I could not tell.

Just then a new peon appeared at the doorway. In his hand was a thin new file. On its cover was written: “Piprahi Tola—petition regarding repair of the temporary crossing constructed through community contribution.”

Bhola Jha placed the new file on top of me. It was very light—only five pages. I remembered my own childhood of seven pages. I could tell it nothing. I only thought this much: human beings create hierarchies so that paper may climb upward; paper travels so that responsibility may descend downward. In between, the channel keeps flowing with its own water.

STORY 241

Chair Number Seventeen

...

The chairs in the Madhubani Irrigation Subdivision Office were numbered in the year an order came from the district to inventory all movable property. Before that, a chair was simply a chair—one had a broken arm, another a crooked back, another stood with the torn cover of an old file wedged beneath one leg. After the order, small red numbers were painted on them, from one to twenty-three.

Bankeshwar Jha had been a clerk in that office for sixteen years. His chair was number nine. The left leg of number nine was short, so a thin piece of wood always remained under it. In front was the wall, to the right an almirah, to the left the back of Shivanandan Babu.

Shivanandan Babu sat on chair number seventeen.

Seventeen stood beside the window.

The window opened to the east. In winter, sunlight fell on the arm of the chair until nine in the morning. In summer, the leaves of the mango tree filtered it. Across the road outside was Phekan's tea stall. A person sitting inside could signal with a hand, and Phekan would count the cups without a word. During the rains, one could hear water falling on the window shade. On the other chairs in the office a person watched the time; on seventeen, a person watched the day.

In his early years, Bankeshwar had paid no special attention to these advantages.

But in his fifth year, the electricity failed for three hours one day. Every room inside grew hot. Shivanandan Babu continued reading files comfortably by the window. Wiping sweat again and again with his gamchha, Bankeshwar understood for the first time that in a government office there were ranks beyond official rank.

From then on, number seventeen lodged itself in his mind.

At that time Shivanandan Babu had four years of service left. Bankeshwar thought four years was not very long. He decided to wait.

While waiting, he began to understand the small comforts of Shivanandan Babu's place.

When the window latch stuck, he oiled it.

When rain blew inside, he did not block it with an old office file; he brought a torn sack from home.

When a mango branch drooped too low and darkened the room, he asked the gardener to cut two branches.

If someone asked, "Why do you take such care?" he would laugh and say, "The office belongs to everyone."

Three years later the first promotion list came.

Bankeshwar's name was not on it.

He was disappointed, but not very much.

That day Shivanandan Babu said, "So your name did not come. What of it? Next time."

Bankeshwar looked toward the window.

"Next time," he said.

In the fourth year, three months before Shivanandan Babu's retirement, there was discussion in the office about rearranging the chairs.

The Head Assistant said that seating would be reassigned according to seniority.

Bankeshwar immediately opened a small file titled: "Suggestions Regarding Seating Arrangement."

On the first page he wrote that proper use of natural light would reduce electricity expenditure.

On the second, he wrote that employees who had to read the greatest number of files during the day should sit near the window.

On the third he supplied section-wise figures for file volume.

His own section appeared to have the highest number.

His colleague Lalan Babu asked, "Where did these figures come from?"

"From the registers," Bankeshwar said.

"Two months of our section's register have not been added."

"When they are added, revised figures will be prepared."

The revised figures were never prepared.

Shivanandan Babu retired.

On the day of his farewell he was garlanded, sweets were distributed, speeches were made.

At the end he rose from the chair and said, "Seventeen and I have kept each other company for a long time."

Bankeshwar's hand touched the back of the chair without his intending it.

The next day he reached the office early.

But Janardan Babu was already sitting on chair seventeen.

Janardan Babu was the younger brother of the Head Assistant's brother-in-law and had been transferred in only two weeks earlier.

"Has a seating order been issued?" Bankeshwar asked.

Opening the window, Janardan Babu said, "Oral."

It is difficult to ask for a copy of an oral order.

Bankeshwar moved his file forward.

The Head Assistant did not read it for three days.

On the fourth he wrote at the top: "To be considered if required."

After that single sentence, chair seventeen remained Janardan Babu's for two years.

Bankeshwar did not consider himself defeated.

He did not openly practise the politics of the chair.

He practised the politics of its advantages.

In winter he said sunlight from the window reduced dampness in papers.

In summer he said fresh air increased the speed of work.

During the rains he said an experienced employee was needed there to protect files from spray.

Once, when a rat entered beneath the window, he wrote a complete note: "Responsible seating arrangement for prevention of entry by external creatures."

Some people thought Bankeshwar wanted to improve the office.

Gradually Bankeshwar himself began to believe the same thing.

The second promotion list came.

This time his name was on it.

The Head Assistant was pleased. "Congratulations. You will become Senior Assistant. A desk is vacant in the front room."

The front room was in the middle of the building. It had two almirahs, a clock, and a ventilator.

No window.

Bankeshwar read the order three times.

"When will you move?" Lalan Babu asked.

"First a few matters must be clarified," Bankeshwar said.

That evening he went home and told his wife he had been promoted.

She was delighted.

His son asked, "Will the salary increase?"

"A little."

"Then what is the problem?"

Bankeshwar did not answer.

The next day he submitted an application requesting that, because he had to care for his aged mother, he be allowed to remain at his present place for a few months.

His mother lived with him and was healthy, but there was no false sentence in the application—he did care for her.

A few months became a year.

The promotion lapsed; another name moved up.

People in the office called Bankeshwar a fool.

He laughed.

Janardan Babu remained beside the window.

Time passed.

Janardan Babu's arthritis worsened.

In winter the air from the window no longer suited him.

One day he himself said, "Move me inside. This window has become my enemy."

Bankeshwar's heart beat faster, but his face remained still.

The seating had to be decided again.

This time there were four claimants.

A new clerk said natural light was good for his eyes.

A woman employee said that from there she could see the outer gate and understand the movement of visitors.

Lalan Babu joked, "Bankeshwar Babu is the priest of seventeen."

Bankeshwar did not laugh.

The Head Assistant postponed the decision.

"Form a committee."

A three-member committee was formed.

Before it met, Bankeshwar submitted a five-page statement covering seniority, section workload, number of files, window light, and the direction of the fan.

The committee met once and reached no conclusion.

At the second meeting one member was on leave.

On the day of the third, an inspection team arrived.

By the time of the fourth meeting, Janardan Babu had already moved to an inside chair and seventeen stood empty.

Fearing that someone might sit there temporarily, Bankeshwar began placing one of his old files on chair seventeen every morning.

He removed it each evening.

One day the Superintending Engineer arrived unexpectedly for an inspection.

Seeing the file on the empty chair, he asked, "Whose seat is this?"

The Head Assistant hesitated. "Under decision."

"For how many days?"

At that question everyone fell silent.

The engineer said, "Give it to whoever is senior. A committee for such a thing?"

Bankeshwar was the senior-most.

That afternoon an office order was issued: "Seat beside the east window, together with chair number 17, allotted to Shri Bankeshwar Jha."

Bankeshwar read the copy of the order twice.

Then, with great care, he emptied the drawer at chair nine.

Pens, ink, date stamp, two registers, an old handkerchief—he gathered everything and carried it to seventeen.

He opened the window.

Outside was a brick wall.

For a few moments Bankeshwar could not understand.

Where the mango tree, the road, and Phekan's tea stall had once been visible, a freshly built brick wall now rose at a distance of one handspan. The cement at the top had not yet fully dried.

From behind him Lalan Babu said, "No one told you? The new records room is being built. There was not enough space, so they extended it on the eastern side. The wall went up only yesterday."

"The window?"

"It will remain. The plan requires a separate order to close the old window. So the window will stay here, with a wall outside it."

Someone laughed.

Someone did not.

Bankeshwar opened the window leaves fully.

One leaf struck the wall and stopped halfway.

Sitting on seventeen, no sunlight fell on him.

No air came in.

Phekan's stall could not be seen.

Instead, the damp smell of the new wall entered the room.

The Head Assistant came to console him.

"If you want, we can change your seat again. Janardan Babu's old place inside is vacant."

Bankeshwar answered at once, "No. The order has been issued."

"But the benefit of the window is now—"

"Government orders are not changed according to benefit."

The Head Assistant kept looking at his face.

Bankeshwar opened a file.

Two weeks later the movable-property inventory was conducted again.

Because the new records room had been built, the desks and chairs were measured and counted once more.

The young man doing the inventory saw the red number painted on the back of the chair and asked, "Is seventeen permanently here?"

Without looking up, Bankeshwar said, "Yes."

The young man wrote in the register: "Chair 17—beside east window—in use."

Bankeshwar signed.

In the evening everyone left.

He remained seated a little longer.

Out of old habit he reached over and opened the window.

The leaf struck the new wall again.

He did not close it.

The darkness deepened.

In the narrow half-handspan gap between the outside wall and the room, there was no air at all.

Bankeshwar ran a finger over the arm of the chair.

The red number "17" had faded slightly.

He took a small brush from the drawer, dipped it in red ink, and painted the number dark again.

STORY 242

The Spelling of a Name

...

The first crisis over the spelling of a name in the Darbhanga District Horticulture Office arose one morning when five bundles of the newly printed annual report were unloaded from a handcart. On the first page was the name of the department, beneath it the year, and at the very bottom, in bold letters, the officer's name: "Shri Naagendra Jha, District Horticulture Officer."

The problem was that the officer's name was not Naagendra, but Nagendra. The printed form carried one extra vowel mark.

The moment Head Clerk Baleshwar Babu saw the printing, he first removed his glasses and wiped them. Then he put them back on and looked at a second copy. He opened a third. All the way through the fifth bundle, the name was printed the same way.

"How did this happen?" he said.

The responsibility for checking the proof had belonged to office clerk Navalkishore. He immediately brought the file. "The copy I sent had the correct spelling."

Baleshwar Babu held the paper up toward the light as though the shadow of the guilty person might be visible inside the letters. "Did the printer add the vowel mark on his own?"

"The printer will say the handwritten copy was unclear."

"Why was a handwritten copy sent?"

"The typist was on leave."

"Then the question is no longer only one of spelling."

With that sentence, the crisis became larger.

Nagendra Jha himself arrived at half past ten. The page of the report was shown to him. At first he smiled. "It is only one vowel mark. Have it corrected."

Baleshwar Babu said softly, "Sir, five hundred copies have already been printed. The distribution list is ready. Three copies have already gone to the district office."

Nagendra Jha's smile stopped. "My name is not spelled that way."

"We all know that."

"What will people outside know?"

That afternoon the first committee was formed: the Spelling Verification Committee. It had three members—a Senior Assistant, an Accounts Clerk, and a Horticulture Supervisor. Its task was to determine which form of the officer's name was valid according to official records.

At its first meeting, seven pieces of evidence were gathered: the service book, salary register, appointment letter, identity card, salary-account statement, training certificate, and the old office nameplate.

Six of them carried "Nagendra." One old salary-account paper carried "Naagendra."

The Accounts Clerk said, "That means the variation already existed."

The Senior Assistant immediately wrote a note: "The matter cannot be treated merely as a printing error."

Nagendra Jha read the note and stared in surprise. "You people are thinking more about my name than I am."

"It is procedure, sir."

The first committee was supposed to reach a conclusion in two days. It took four. Its conclusion was that the official name was "Nagendra", but because a different form existed in the salary-account paper, the "origin of the error" should be investigated separately.

For this, a second committee was formed: the Error-Responsibility Determination Committee.

While that committee was being constituted, the crowd of farmers on the office veranda was growing. Fifteen days earlier a hailstorm had knocked down the new blossoms on mango and litchi trees. The final date for compensation applications was approaching. People came with papers, received serial numbers, and then waited for their files to move forward. But two clerks were members of the first committee, one employee belonged to the second, and Navalkishore was busy searching for the original proof copy.

Ramcharittar Mandal, a farmer from Bahera, asked, "When will my application be signed?"

Without raising his head, Baleshwar Babu said, "Verification is going on."

"Of my trees?"

"No. Of a name."

Ramcharittar stood there for a moment. "A name's tree?"

The people seated on the veranda burst out laughing. Baleshwar Babu looked up. "The officer's name. Keep your receipt safe."

Ramcharittar folded the receipt and tied it into the knot of his gamchha. His application was file number 37.

The second committee summoned the printer. Mukesh Paswan came with two samples. He said that on the page sent by the office, the ink had spread above the relevant syllable, so the compositor had read “Naagendra.” Navalkishore objected: “I wrote it clearly.”

The printer placed the paper on the table. The ink had indeed spread. But whether it had spread before printing or later while pressed inside the file became a new subject of debate.

The second committee held four meetings. The first examined the history of the proof copy. The second asked why a handwritten copy had been sent. The third recorded the compositor’s statement. At the fourth they discussed whether responsibility should be assigned to one person or treated as a “collective procedural error.”

Meanwhile the application files had grown from number 37 to number 84. The veranda benches were no longer enough.

Ramcharittar came a second time. This time his young son was with him, having come straight from school. Reading the number on the receipt, the boy said, “Babu, it was thirty-seven before. Is it still thirty-seven?”

Ramcharittar did not laugh. “Government numbers do not increase quickly.”

That day Nagendra Jha himself crossed the veranda and saw the crowd of farmers. He asked Baleshwar Babu, “Why are the applications being held up?”

Baleshwar Babu showed him three files. “Two clerks are on committees. One employee is counting every copy of the report. And a decision on how to make the correction is still pending.”

“Cross out the extra vowel mark in red ink.”

Baleshwar Babu remained silent.

“What is it?”

“If five hundred copies are corrected by hand, the appearance of the government publication will be spoiled. And then we still have to decide who will make the correction, who will certify it, and which stamp will be used.”

Nagendra Jha leaned back in his chair. “Then form a third committee.”

For one moment Baleshwar Babu looked at the officer’s face. He could not tell whether it was sarcasm or an instruction. In a government office, misunderstanding that distinction can be risky. He prepared the note.

On the third day the Correction-Method Committee was formed.

An effort was made to keep its members different from those of the first two committees, but the office did not have enough employees. As a result, the Accounts Clerk became a member again because he had served on the first

committee but not the second. The Horticulture Supervisor was supposed to go out for field inspection, but the trip was postponed because of the meeting.

The third committee listed three options: reprinting, correction by hand, or pasting an erratum slip. Reprinting was expensive. Hand correction would be "uneven." An erratum slip required fresh printing. So a cost comparison was requested.

Three quotations were sought from the printer. Mukesh laughed and said, "Correcting the name will cost more than printing it wrong did."

"Do not write that remark in the quotation," Navalkishore said.

Ramcharittar came to the veranda a third time. By now the corner of his receipt had worn away. He said, "The blossoms are gone. Now even the little fruit that survived is falling in the wind. When will the inspection happen?"

Navalkishore searched for his application. File 37 lay beneath the third stack. Across the top, in red pencil, was written: "Field inspection required."

"Why has the supervisor not gone to the field?" Ramcharittar asked.

Navalkishore did not answer. The supervisor was sitting in the adjoining room at a meeting of the third committee, writing his opinion on whether a copy corrected by hand could be considered "certified."

A week later the papers of all three committees reached Nagendra Jha's desk together. The first committee: the official name was "Nagendra". The second: the error was collective and procedural. The third: an erratum slip would be cheapest, but every copy would require an authorised signature.

Nagendra Jha kept turning the pages. "This much paper for one vowel mark?"

Baleshwar Babu said, "Eighteen pages."

"And the applications?"

"Eighty-four."

Nagendra Jha immediately wrote an order: "Pending applications from the public shall be disposed of first. Correction of the report may be taken up afterward."

Baleshwar Babu read the order and was pleased. Then his eyes went to the typed name beneath the signature line. In the prepared draft, Navalkishore had already typed the officer's name as "Naagendra Jha."

Silence spread through the room.

Nagendra Jha looked at the paper and rubbed his forehead. "How again?"

Navalkishore's face went pale. "The form must have been taken from an old sample."

Baleshwar Babu said softly, "Would it be proper to issue this order without correcting it?"

No one answered.

On the veranda, Ramcharittar's son was reading the number on the receipt again. This time he had himself reached the pile containing file 37 and was showing it to his father. The peon moved him away. "Do not touch the files."

Inside, Nagendra Jha picked up a red pen. He drew one straight line through the extra vowel mark in his own name. Above it he wrote the correct form clearly. Beneath it he signed and handed the order to Baleshwar Babu.

"Issue it now."

Baleshwar Babu took the paper. "Sir, certification of the handwritten correction?"

Nagendra Jha looked at him for a long time. Then he took the red pen again and wrote in small letters beside the correction: "Correction certified." He signed again.

By evening that day, seven applications had moved forward. Ramcharittar's file also went into the supervisor's bag. The supervisor fixed the next morning for a visit to Bahera.

The papers of all three committees were tied together into a separate file and placed in the almirah. Its title read: "Case Regarding the Spelling of the District Horticulture Officer's Name."

A month later the erratum slips for the annual report arrived from the printer. The slips were very small. Two temporary labourers were hired to paste them into all five hundred copies.

While pasting the first slip, one labourer read aloud "Shri Nagendra Jha." He asked Baleshwar Babu, "Is this officer still here?"

Baleshwar Babu said, "No. He was transferred yesterday."

"Then should we paste all these?"

For a moment Baleshwar Babu looked at the stack of slips, the bundles of reports, and the committee file that had grown thick inside the almirah. Then he said, "The order was issued during Nagendra Babu's tenure. Complete the work."

The labourer straightened the first slip and pasted it down.

Outside, the veranda was empty. The hailstorm applications had by then gone out for field inspection. On the desk lay only one new paper—the charge-taking notice of the new officer.

Baleshwar Babu picked it up and read the name once. Then a second time.

The new officer's name was "Shri Shashibhushan Chaudhary."

The typed copy below also read "Shri Shashibhushan Chaudhary."

Baleshwar Babu breathed with relief.

Then his eyes went to the signature. Beneath it, in his own hand, the officer had written: "Shashibhusan Chaudhary."

Baleshwar Babu slowly placed the paper back on the desk.

The red pen lay near his hand.

He picked it up, then stopped.

From far down the veranda came the voice of Ramcharittar's son, reading someone's application number aloud.

Baleshwar Babu put the red pen back.

This time, he first pulled the pile of pending applications toward himself.

STORY 243

The Great Inspection

...

News of the inspection reached the Jhanjharpur Weights and Measures Sub-Office at nine on Monday morning. The letter said that on Wednesday an Assistant Controller from the district would come to examine the office's working methods, public service, verification of measuring instruments, and records.

The moment Head Assistant Mahendranath Mishra read the letter, he first looked at the wall clock and then at the rooms around him. It seemed to him that he had been given two days in which to separate the entire office from its own history.

The office stood in an old government building on the eastern side of the road. There was a small veranda in front, three rooms inside, and an iron testing platform at the rear.

Immediately to the right stood the cooperative paddy procurement depot—a tin roof, a large scale, sacks, bullock carts, and the voices of farmers. Faded government signboards of almost the same colour hung before both buildings. From a distance it was difficult to tell them apart.

"First remove the dust," Mahendranath said. "Then separate the pending files."

Clerk Nareshkant asked, "Separate in what sense?"

Mahendranath looked at him. "On inspection day, only as much will remain on the desks as ought to be there. The rest goes into the cupboards."

The cupboards were already full.

So the remaining files went into the rear room.

The rear room already contained broken weights, old scales, ten-kilo iron weights, cancelled registers, and tin boxes from years before.

Where were those things to go?

Peon Bholanath said, "There is an empty shed behind the paddy depot. Shall we keep them there for two days?"

"Government property in another department?" Mahendranath frowned.

Bholanath asked, "Then where do we keep all this?"

In the end, white sheets were spread over the broken objects. A paper notice was pinned on top: "Material Under Verification."

By Tuesday, the appearance of the office had begun to change.

Of the three old benches on the veranda, two were covered with fresh sackcloth.

Oil was applied to the rusted bars of the windows.

The crookedly hung summary of the Weights and Measures Act was straightened.

A thin wash of lime was applied to the part of the wall where the plaster had flaked away.

The greatest task was to create the appearance of public service.

On ordinary days, people wandered in as they pleased and asked questions; applications moved from table to table; no clear queue formed anywhere.

For inspection day, two queues were created with red string — “Applications” and “Receipt.” Nareshkant wrote the words in large letters on paper.

Mahendranath read them. “Receipt of what?”

“Whoever gets a paper.”

“Will people understand?”

“They can ask.”

Mahendranath was not satisfied with the answer, but there was little time.

On the testing platform, field inspector Shambhunath Paswan was opening and cleaning three weighing scales.

One scale had not been correct for an entire year. Its needle rested two divisions beyond zero.

Shambhunath said, “If we keep this here during inspection, questions will be asked.”

Mahendranath said, “Remove it.”

“But this is the very scale through which complaints from the market are understood. It is a sample of a defect.”

“During an inspection, one does not display a sample of a defect. One displays a sample of improvement.”

Shambhunath said nothing.

He carried the scale into the rear room, under the white sheet.

By Tuesday evening, every employee had been assigned a separate role.

One would show the registers, another the seals, another samples of verified weights.

Bholanath was told to inform everyone inside the moment the inspector’s vehicle appeared.

New glasses were bought for tea.

Sugar was measured and placed in a tin, as though in the Weights and Measures Department even the proportion of sugar might be part of the inspection.

A small direction sign was also made for the road: “Weights and Measures Sub-Office →”.

The district officer had never visited before.

The sign was fastened to a bamboo pole with one nail and a piece of wire.

During the night, a strong westerly wind blew.

The board rotated almost halfway round.

Instead of pointing east, the arrow now pointed right—toward the gate of the cooperative paddy depot.

On Wednesday everyone was present from seven in the morning.

Mahendranath wore a fresh dhoti and kurta.

Nareshkant had kept only three files on his desk.

Shambhunath placed the best scale on the testing platform.

Two farmers on the veranda were stopped and told, “When Sahib arrives, give your applications then. Stand in the queue.”

The farmers looked at each other, but remained standing.

Ten o'clock.

Ten fifteen.

Ten thirty-seven.

“Why has the vehicle not come?” Mahendranath asked.

No one had an answer.

Meanwhile, the district office vehicle had already arrived from the other end of the road.

It stopped beside the direction sign.

The driver saw the turned arrow and steered right.

The vehicle went straight through the gate of the cooperative paddy depot.

At that time paddy was being weighed there.

Farmers were unloading sacks.

One pan of the large scale rose and fell, the clerk wrote down weights, and the weighing worker, Ramvilas Yadav, changed the iron weights.

Seeing the vehicle, Ramvilas assumed that an inspection team from the district procurement branch had arrived.

He brushed dust from his hands and stepped forward.

Assistant Controller Arvind Kumar got out of the vehicle.

Seeing the large scale in front of him, he was pleased.

“Is the weights-and-measures office here?”

Ramvilas heard “weights and measures” but paid little attention to the word “office.”

He said, “Yes, weighing happens here. Paddy is being weighed today.”

Arvind Kumar took this as an example of field service.

“Good. The arrangement is directly at the place of work.”

The depot clerk too assumed the officer was from the procurement department.

He opened the register.

Arvind Kumar asked his first question: “When was the scale last verified?”

Ramvilas immediately showed him the metal plate fixed to the arm of the scale. “In Phagun this year. But the right pan tends to become heavy, so every morning we balance the empty scale again.”

Arvind Kumar bent and examined the pointer. “Have you submitted a written complaint?”

“Twice. The babu from Weights and Measures came once and tightened a screw. The second time he said to send a proposal for a new scale.”

Arvind Kumar wrote a note.

He liked the fact that the worker was not concealing the defect.

He asked the farmers, “Is the weighing done in front of you?”

An elderly farmer said, “In front of us. Sometimes there is a quarrel over a difference of two kilos, and then it is weighed again.”

“Receipt?”

The depot clerk immediately showed him the slip.

Arvind Kumar’s inspection continued.

There was dust in the depot, sacks, the smell of sweat, but the work was going on.

In one corner lay a broken five-kilo weight.

Ramvilas himself said, “This is not in use. I have cut a mark into it.”

Arvind Kumar turned it over.

There really was a transverse groove cut across the middle.

“This is a proper way to keep defective material clearly marked and out of use,” he said.

Ramvilas smiled with pride.

For the first time he realised that even a broken weight could earn praise.

At that same moment, in the actual Weights and Measures office, Mahendranath was looking at the clock.

It was eleven.

The farmers standing in the red-string queue had already sat down twice.

The tea had gone cold.

The shine of the new glasses was fading.

Bholanath went out to the road and returned saying, "There are tyre marks going toward the paddy depot."

"Marks?"

"Tyre marks in the mud."

Mahendranath ran outside.

The moment he saw the direction sign, his body stopped.

The arrow was pointing right.

"Who turned this?"

Straightening the bamboo, Bholanath said, "The wind."

"The wind can turn a government arrow?"

Shambhunath said softly, "It was tied with one nail."

Mahendranath immediately started toward the paddy depot.

He had gone halfway when the district vehicle appeared from the opposite direction.

Without stopping, it climbed onto the road.

In the rear seat Arvind Kumar was writing something in a file.

Mahendranath raised his hand, but the vehicle had already gathered speed.

He reached the paddy depot.

With a pleased expression, Ramvilas said, "Your Sahib is very good. He saw the scale, spoke to the farmers, even looked at the broken weight."

"Our Sahib?"

"The weights-and-measures officer."

For a few moments Mahendranath kept looking at Ramvilas's face.

Then his eyes moved over the depot's dust, the open sacks, the working scale, and the crowd of farmers.

He remembered the red string in his own office, the white sheets, and the cold tea.

At noon a message arrived from the district office: "Inspection completed. Officer departed."

No one laughed.

First they all looked at one another.

Then Nareshkant asked quietly, "Shall we remove the queue now?"

Mahendranath said, "First take the farmers' applications."

The red string was removed.

The two farmers immediately came to the desk.

The white sheet remained over the objects in the rear room until evening.

Four days later the inspection remarks arrived.

The first line read: "Public service is being provided by the office at the actual work site; the arrangement for allowing consumers to observe the weighing process is commendable."

The second line said: "The practice of clearly marking defective weights and keeping them out of use is exemplary."

The third line said: "Unnecessary paper display minimal."

Nareshkant stopped while reading.

Mahendranath silently took the remarks.

He read them three times.

He remembered Shambhunath's defective scale hidden beneath the white sheet.

"Do we have to send a reply?" Nareshkant asked.

"An action-taken report has to be sent on the inspection remarks," Mahendranath said.

"What shall we write in the reply?"

Mahendranath looked toward the veranda.

The red string had been removed.

Farmers were coming inside in their usual way.

The sheet in the rear room had been lifted.

Shambhunath had brought the defective scale back onto the testing platform, because it was needed to understand complaints.

Mahendranath said, "First let us learn to do what has been written."

From the following week, on two days each week, one office table began to be set up beside the paddy depot.

Shambhunath tested small weights there, checked farmers' scales, and wrote down complaints.

Ramvilas's broken five-kilo weight was replaced.

There had been no special order for this work; the praise written in the inspection remarks had to be made real.

Two months later another letter came from the district: "Submit a proposal for implementing the field public-service method mentioned in the previous inspection in other offices."

Mahendranath read the letter and remained silent for a long time.

Nareshkant asked, "Shall we prepare the proposal?"

Mahendranath looked out the window.

At the bend in the road, the old direction sign was now fastened securely with two nails.

The arrow pointed correctly toward the office.

He said, "Prepare it. But this time first ask Ramvilas at the paddy depot how his work actually runs."

Nareshkant opened a file.

At the top he wrote the title: "Field Public-Service Method."

Then he paused, thinking.

"Shall I write the details of inspection day?"

Mahendranath looked again toward the arrow.

"Do not write what we were doing on inspection day. Write what we were farthest from doing that day, and what we do now."

Outside, the pan of the cooperative depot's scale clanged.

Shambhunath lifted his bag and started toward it.

Mahendranath folded the inspection remarks and placed them in the file.

There was no white sheet anywhere in the office now.

STORY 244

The Fan Proposal

...

On the first Monday of Jeth, the first thing one heard on entering the Benipatti Circle Office from the eastern veranda was the gharr-gharr of fan number four. It rotated less than it shuddered. A thin coat of dust lay over its three blades, and on the central cap, in faded white paint, was written: 4/87.

Ramparikshan Jha sat directly beneath that fan. On his desk lay applications for mutation, files concerning land-measurement disputes, and two bundles tied with red string. Once the heat of Jeth rose, he moved the gamchha over his head more often than he moved the papers.

By ten o'clock that Monday, the fan first slowed, then trembled once to the right, once to the left, and stopped.

Ramparikshan looked up. "Punit, turn the regulator."

Punit Paswan turned the round wall regulator three times. Nothing happened. Then he shifted a chair and pressed the switch. The fan moved by the width of one blade and stood still.

"Gone," Punit said.

"Not gone," Ramparikshan replied. "How can a government thing leave so easily?"

By noon the room had become like a furnace. People who had come with work stood in the shade of the veranda. The four employees sitting inside fanned themselves with the thick covers of files. An elderly woman who had been coming for fifteen days to obtain a copy of a land record placed her small palm-leaf fan on Ramparikshan's desk.

"Babu, use this for air. Write my work down; I will sit outside."

Ramparikshan took the fan, waved it twice, and then wrote the date on her application. The woman's name was Jagrani Devi.

That very evening, a proposal was written to replace the ceiling fan.

In the first line Ramparikshan wrote: "Office fan number 4/87 is no longer fit to operate; because of the heat, the work of both employees and visitors is being obstructed."

Head Clerk Harinarayan Babu read it and said, "How have you established that it is unfit to operate?"

"It does not operate."

“What is visible to the eye and what is technically certified are different things.”

For the first approval, a maintenance-section electrician was required.

The electrician came on Wednesday. He asked for a ladder. The office's bamboo ladder had gone to the tehsil store. The tehsil store's ladder had gone for school-enumeration work. Punit brought a wooden ladder from the neighbouring tea stall.

The electrician climbed up, opened the fan cap, touched the wires, and turned the blades by hand. After coming down he said, “The winding is burnt.”

Ramparikshan asked, “Can it be repaired?”

“It can, but the cost will be more than half the price of a new fan. Look at its age—eighty-seven.”

He gave the certificate in writing.

The first stage was complete.

The second stage was the stores section. The storekeeper had to certify that no spare fan was available.

The file remained on his desk for three days because the stores register showed two fans in reserve.

Ramparikshan went there himself. “If you have two spare fans, give me one.”

The storekeeper lowered his spectacles. “They are in the register.”

“In the store?”

“One has been out for repair since 1998. The other is temporarily installed in the assembly hall. In the register, both are spare.”

“Then write that none is available.”

The storekeeper said, “How can the register write a lie?”

“Then give me a fan.”

“The store is empty.”

After much thought, the sentence was framed: “Spare fans as per register: two; immediately transferable: zero.”

The second stage was complete.

The third stage was the cost estimate.

Three quotations were required.

Punit went to the market.

The first shopkeeper wrote a price on paper.

The second asked, "Government quotation for one fan?"

"Without three quotations the file will not move."

The third shopkeeper wrote a price fifty rupees lower than the cost of the fan, but added separate charges for wire, hanging hook, and installation labour.

A comparison of the three quotations was prepared.

The lowest rate was selected, but the Head Clerk noted: "Energy-saving capacity not mentioned."

The file went back to the market.

Meanwhile Jagrani Devi came for the third time.

The same palm-leaf fan lay in the corner of the desk.

Ramparikshan found her copy and gave it to her.

Jagrani reached to take back the fan, then saw the sweat on Ramparikshan's forehead and stopped her hand.

"Keep it. I have received the copy. I can make another fan."

From that day onward, the palm-leaf fan belonged to the office without ever being entered in the register.

The fourth stage was the Accounts Section.

There the question arose whether the fan should be purchased under "Office Expenditure" or "Minor Equipment."

There was money under both heads, but two notes were written on which head was proper.

A third note cited an old rule.

The file remained held up for a week while a copy of that rule was searched for.

Meanwhile the heat increased.

After noon Ramparikshan's desk began to be shifted onto the veranda.

Following his example, two other desks came outside as well.

Only Head Clerk Harinarayan Babu remained inside because there was a small ventilator beside his wall. By evening, even he came out.

The visitors liked the arrangement.

Everyone could see where each file was.

Punit called out names, and people came forward when their turn arrived.

The suffocation inside decreased, while the file containing the fan proposal kept growing thicker.

The fifth stage was an "essentiality certificate" from the Assistant Officer.

He read the file and asked, "The employees are working on the veranda?"

"Because of the heat."

"Then the work is continuing."

Ramparikshan remained silent.

The officer asked again, "Without the fan, has work stopped completely?"

Harinarayan Babu said, "If we write 'completely stopped,' a question will arise about attendance."

"Then write 'work obstructed.'"

"That is already written in the original proposal."

The officer looked at the original proposal and nodded. "Fine. Obstruction certified."

The fifth stage was complete.

The sixth stage was the Purchase Committee.

The committee met on the last Saturday of the month.

That Saturday a block-level meeting on pre-flood preparations was scheduled, so the committee was postponed until the next month.

Ashadh arrived.

After the first rains, the tin awning behind the room cooled. The air was damp, but no longer burned like Jeth.

Sitting on the veranda had become a habit.

Jagrani's palm-leaf fan now lay on top of the application stack; whoever felt hotter picked it up.

When the Purchase Committee finally met, the question was not the price of the new fan but the future of the old one.

"Is the old fan fit for auction?"

"The winding is burnt."

"It still contains metal."

"Then after replacement it will be deposited in stores."

"How can proof of deposit be obtained beforehand?"

"First the new fan must be installed; then the old one will be taken down and deposited."

The committee member read the sentence three times.

At last it was written: "The old fan must be deposited in stores within seven days of installation of the new fan."

The sixth stage was complete.

The seventh and final approval had to come from the Subdivisional Office.

The file went.

One week passed.

Two weeks.

Half of Sawan.

Ramparikshan now looked less often at the fan.

He had begun to like his desk on the veranda.

When he raised his eyes toward the road, he could see visitors arriving; people had less need to wander in and out of rooms.

One day Harinarayan Babu said, "If this fan starts working, we will all go back inside."

Ramparikshan laughed. "First let it start."

In the first week of Bhadon, the file returned.

In blue ink at the top was written: "Approved."

All seven stages had been crossed.

Punit ran onto the veranda holding the paper. "Babu! We will get a fan!"

Everyone looked up.

The old fan stood still, coated in dust.

Clouds were outside.

A westerly breeze crossed the veranda and entered the room.

Harinarayan Babu read the approval letter. "Now the purchase order will be issued."

Ramparikshan asked, "Today?"

"The quotation was valid for ninety days."

"Have ninety days passed?"

Harinarayan Babu counted from the date on the first quotation. "Tomorrow."

A laugh escaped Punit, but he immediately pressed his lips together.

Ramparikshan said, "Then prepare the purchase order today itself."

By four o'clock the order was ready.

It was signed.

Punit carried it to the market.

The shopkeeper looked at the paper. "This model of fan is no longer available at this price. Prices rose after the rains."

Punit returned empty-handed.

Harinarayan Babu scratched his head. "New quotations?"

Ramparikshan said nothing for a long time.

Then he picked up Jagrani Devi's palm-leaf fan.

Its thin palm strips were broken in several places, but it still moved air.

The next day fresh quotations were invited.

This time, however, Ramparikshan added one line at the top of the proposal: "Previous approval may be treated as continuing; permission is sought only for the revised rate."

The file began moving again, but now it did not need all seven stages.

Three stages were enough.

At the beginning of Asin, the new fan arrived.

The electrician took down the old fan.

Holding the cap marked 4/87 in his hand, he said, "Thirty-seven years."

Punit asked, "Where does this go now?"

"Stores."

"Will the register show it as spare?"

The electrician laughed. "No. Unserviceable."

The new fan was installed.

The moment the switch was pressed, a strong wind rose.

Two thin sheets of paper flew from the desk.

Punit ran and caught them.

Ramparikshan looked toward the window.

The sunlight outside was mild.

The air was already cooler than before.

Harinarayan Babu asked, "Shall we move the desks back inside now?"

At the question, everyone's eyes turned once toward the desks on the veranda.

Three visitors were sitting there.

Their files lay open in front of them.

Ramparikshan sat for a moment feeling the air from the new fan, then put Jagrani's old palm-leaf fan into the desk drawer.

"Let the desks remain here," he said. "The fan's air will reach outside too."

The new fan continued turning.

The old fan stood against the wall, waiting to be taken to stores.

Its three dust-covered blades were still, but 4/87 could still be read clearly on its cap.

By the time the seven-stage approval was complete, the heat had almost ended. For the first time in the office, no one argued over whether the proposal had been approved late or on time. Everyone's attention was on the fact that the fan now worked—and the desks were still on the veranda.

STORY 245

The God of the Office

...

In the old records room of the Benipatti Circle Office stood a dark brown-black cupboard. Of its two doors, the right one had swollen at the bottom, and the left latch would close only after someone pressed the door with a knee and pushed. Dust gathered on the wooden top, except for one round patch in the middle that was always clean. Someone idly ran a palm over it, someone left keys there, someone a cup of tea.

The people in the office called it “the god.”

No one knew who had first given it that name. Old Assistant Dinbandhu Jha said he had been hearing it since his first year of service. New employees would laugh and ask, “Why a god?”

The answer was always the same: “If a file has been stuck too long, leave it with the god. A few days later, the burden becomes lighter.”

“Does the work get completed?”

“Not that much of a miracle. The file itself can no longer be found.”

Everyone would laugh.

Sudip Mishra was a newly appointed clerk. At first he saw nothing special in the joke. In a government office, a file might move from one desk to another, from one room to another, and vanish somewhere along the way; that did not seem impossible.

But within a week he understood that “the god” was not merely a joke. It was a small office tradition.

When a file had already received three comments, had twice been found short of papers, the applicant had made five rounds of the office, and in the end no one could say who was supposed to look at it next, Dinbandhu Jha would quietly say, “Leave it with the god for one night.”

There was no written rule.

Yet everyone understood.

The first such file on Sudip’s desk belonged to Chandreshwar Mahato.

The matter concerned measurement of a field boundary: a dispute between two brothers over five dhurs of land, an old map, a measurement receipt, an incomplete note from the amin, and three years of movement through the office.

Chandreshwar was a thin man who brought copies of his papers tied into the end of his dhoti.

Every time he came, he asked the same question: "Where is my file now?"

The first time Sudip answered, "It is being examined."

The second time: "The amin's comment is still pending."

The third time Sudip himself did not know what to say.

The file lay on his own desk, but the two most recent comments contradicted one another.

One said: "Old map unclear."

The other said: "Decision possible according to old map."

That evening Dinbandhu Jha looked at the file.

"Leave it with the god."

Sudip laughed. "How is this file going to disappear?"

"Did I say anything about making it disappear?" Dinbandhu pushed his spectacles higher. "Just leave it there. We will see in the morning."

Sudip placed the file on the middle shelf of the cupboard.

Deliberately, he tied a thin knot of red thread to one corner so that he could identify it again.

The cupboard doors were shut, and the key was placed in Dinbandhu Jha's drawer.

In the morning the cupboard was opened.

On the middle shelf lay two old thick files, a bundle tied with string, and an empty cardboard cover.

Chandreshwar's file was not there.

At first Sudip thought Dinbandhu had played a joke.

He searched every desk, drawer, the top of the cupboard, and underneath it.

There was no red thread anywhere.

Dinbandhu Jha continued chewing paan with a grave face.

"The god is pleased," was all he said.

At noon Chandreshwar arrived.

Sudip did not ask him to sit.

He said, "Your papers have gone to another section. Come again in two days."

The moment the sentence left his mouth, he felt uneasy.

He had no idea where the file had actually gone.

From that day Sudip began watching the cupboard carefully.

It had three shelves.

Thick registers were kept on the upper shelf.

The middle shelf was considered the god's place.

The lower shelf held broken cardboard covers, old string, and useless papers.

The strange thing was that thick files never disappeared.

Thin files, especially those pushed toward the back, were the ones most likely to take part in the trick.

Sudip mentioned this to no one.

One evening he put three blank sheets inside an old discarded cover, wrote "TEST" on top, and pushed it toward the back of the middle shelf.

He shut the cupboard.

That day he kept the key himself.

In the morning the cover was gone.

Now he stopped laughing.

He reached inside the cupboard and felt along the back panel.

Above, it was solid.

At the middle, on the right, his fingers felt something like cool air.

He probed again.

The wooden rear panel had bent inward at one place just above the middle shelf.

The gap was so thin that it could not be seen easily, but the corner of a sheet of paper could slip into it.

He took an old sheet from the shelf and pushed it backward.

The leading edge entered the gap.

When he pushed farther, the entire sheet vanished.

"Come and see this," Sudip called to Dinbandhu Jha.

Dinbandhu put his hand inside, felt the gap, and then said calmly, "It is an old cupboard."

"What is behind it?"

"The wall."

"How did the paper go into the wall?"

This time Dinbandhu remained silent for a while.

"It is an old building."

That answer made Sudip more uneasy.

The following week the rains began.

Dampness descended along the wall behind the records room.

Lime started flaking from one corner.

A repair worker was called.

The moment he saw the wall, he said, "The cupboard has to be moved. Otherwise the damp behind it cannot be seen."

The office reacted as though the worker had proposed moving not a cupboard but the bones of an ancestor.

"This cupboard will not move," Dinbandhu Jha said at once.

"Then the wall will not dry," the worker replied.

At last the Circle Officer said, "Move it two handspans. Then put it back."

Four men took hold of it.

The cupboard was heavier than expected.

Fine dust from soil and paper had collected beneath it.

When it was pulled away from the wall, everyone fell silent at what appeared behind it.

At waist height in the wall was an old rectangular recess.

Perhaps there had once been a small opening there for passing papers in and out.

The outside had been bricked shut long ago, but the hollow space on the inside had remained.

The broken rear panel of the cupboard had bent directly over the mouth of that recess.

Inside the recess were files.

Not one or two.

Layer upon layer.

Dust, crusted salt, dried lizard droppings, bundles of paper.

Some strings had rotted away; on some covers the colour had peeled off.

Sudip reached in and pulled out the top file.

At one corner was a thin knot of red thread.

Chandreshwar Mahato's file.

Below it lay Sudip's cover marked "TEST."

Beneath that were a five-year-old mutation file, a seven-year-old measurement dispute, applications for grants, certificate files, and papers bearing applicants' names that none of the newer employees had ever heard.

Dinbandhu Jha sat down on the floor.

"So many?" escaped from his mouth.

The repair worker did not laugh.

He only said, "The back panel was loose. Any paper pushed backward kept falling into the recess."

Sudip looked at Dinbandhu Jha.

"The god."

For the first time Dinbandhu did not smile at the name.

By noon all the files had been taken out.

When counted, there were one hundred and twenty-seven.

The oldest was thirteen years old.

The problem now was no longer missing files.

It was found files.

On whose desk should each one be placed?

Should its old date of receipt be used, or today's?

If the applicant had already filed again, how should the first file be joined to the second?

If the applicant had died, how should the file be closed?

There was no separate column in the office register for such a condition.

The Circle Officer spread all the files across a long table and said, "First see the status of the applicant. If the work is still pending, revive the file. If a decision has already been made on a second file, join the two."

Dinbandhu Jha said softly, "Then the number of pending cases will suddenly rise a great deal."

The officer looked at him.

"Was the number truly lower before, or were the papers merely out of sight?"

No one in the room answered.

The next day Chandreshwar Mahato came again.

Sudip placed his file in front of him.

The red thread was still tied to it.

Chandreshwar looked first at the file, then at Sudip's face.

"It was found?"

"Yes. It was found."

"Where was it?"

Sudip looked toward the open recess in the wall.

"Inside the office itself."

For a while Chandreshwar kept his hand resting on the file.

He neither abused anyone nor laughed.

He only asked, "Will the measurement happen now?"

"It will," Sudip said. "This time the file will remain where we can see it."

After the repairs were completed, the recess was filled with bricks.

A new wooden panel was fixed to the back of the cupboard, but the cupboard was not pushed flush against the wall again.

A gap of one handspan was left so that the space behind it would remain visible.

For several days no one called it "the god."

The name seemed to die by itself.

At the end of the month a new complicated file reached Dinbandhu Jha's desk. Comments from three sections contradicted one another. Holding the file, he started toward the old cupboard. Halfway there he stopped. The new wooden back was clearly visible. Between the wall and the cupboard lay an open gap. He tapped the wood once with a finger. The wood remained silent. Dinbandhu turned back to his desk, placed the file in front of him, and for a long time kept reading its first page.

STORY 246

The Signature

...

For three months Ramlochan Pandit's potter's wheel in Babhaniyatol of Bisfi had been creaking on its old wooden axle. Diwali was approaching, and three shopkeepers in the village had already spoken for a thousand lamps each. Ramlochan's name had been approved under the District Crafts Office assistance scheme for an electric wheel; the money had also reached the bank, but before the payment could be released, one signature from the District Crafts Officer was required.

"One signature," the bank clerk had said. "On this paper. That's all."

Ramlochan had liked the words "that's all." For a single signature he took the first bus to Madhubani in the morning. In his shoulder bag was the file tied with red string, a dry roti and roasted gram wrapped in cloth, and in his mind the calculation that if the work was done by noon, he could return by the evening bus and begin dismantling the axle of the wheel.

The District Crafts Office occupied the second floor of an old building. At the head of the stairs, the wall was stained red with paan spit; two crooked benches stood in the veranda; above the rooms were small signboards. Ramlochan read the first one: "Receipt and Dispatch."

The clerk in Room One opened the file and looked at the first page.

"Where is the receipt number?"

"The bank said only Sahib's signature is needed."

"Does the bank know the office's internal rules?" The clerk pushed his spectacles up his nose. "First the receipt number."

He stamped the paper in red, entered the name in a register, and wrote a small number on the file.

"Now Room Two—Schemes."

Ramlochan went to Room Two. A young woman was reading three files at once. The moment she saw his papers she said, "The beneficiary list must be matched."

"But the name is already on this page."

"Having the name there and matching it with the list are two different things."

She opened a thick register, found Ramlochan's name, wrote "matched" in the corner of the page, and returned the file.

"Room Three—Accounts."

The man in Room Three looked at the bank paper. "The account is correct. But the pre-payment note from the Schemes Section has not come."

Ramlochan pointed to "matched" on the file.

"That is list matching. I am talking about the pre-payment note."

"Where will I get that?"

"Ask in Room Four."

The sign on Room Four read "Assistance Material." Two employees were tying bundles of papers beneath a fan. One of them looked at the file and asked, "Where is the proof that the wheel has been received?"

At first Ramlochan did not understand. "The wheel will be bought after the money is released."

"Then there is no proof of receipt."

"I have not received the wheel yet."

"How can a payment note be made without proof?"

Ramlochan took the bank-stamped paper from his bag. "The shopkeeper says that if the money is not released by next Wednesday, he will sell the wheel to another buyer. It is already time to make Diwali lamps. The axle of my old wheel needs oil three times a day."

The employee took the paper, checked the date, and carefully placed it inside the file. "I understand your urgency. But the space for proof is blank."

"What should be written in the blank space?"

"I cannot say. The Technical Section has the authority to write there."

For the first time Ramlochan understood that a blank space on paper was also a kind of object in an office. To fill it, one needed a person; for that person, another paper; and for that paper, another room.

Ramlochan stared. "How can I get the wheel without payment?"

The two employees looked at each other. One of them said, "That is a technical matter. Room Five."

In Room Five, an elderly assistant sat by the window cutting betel nut. Ramlochan told him the whole story.

The assistant examined the papers calmly, then wrote in pencil: "Purchase of material possible after payment."

"Show them this line," he said. "Now go back to Room Three."

Ramlochan turned toward Room Three, but the smell of tea reached him in the veranda. In the courtyard below, the tea seller had arranged earthen cups in a row. Five or seven employees, two citizens, and a middle-aged man in a plain white kurta were standing there. Ramlochan joined the line.

He recognised the clay cups as coming from his own village. Along the rim was the thin pressure mark of a finger, and on the base the small round mark left by his kiln. The tea seller had perhaps bought them from a trader in Bisfi.

The man in the white kurta took a cup and examined its rim. "This cup is well made. The thickness is even."

Ramlochan said without thinking, "It must be from Babhaniyatol. That kind of rim is made there."

The man turned toward him. "Are you from there?"

"Yes. I make cups like these myself."

"Then you do good work."

Ramlochan smiled and took his tea. His mind lightened. At once he thought: if government work too were like a clay cup—earth, wheel, fire—three stages, and the thing was ready.

After tea he returned to Room Three. When the accounts clerk saw the elderly assistant's pencilled line, he said, "Good. Now the pre-payment note can be made. But before Sahib signs, the file must be submitted through Establishment."

"Where is Establishment?"

"Room Six."

There were two empty chairs in Room Six. The clerk on the third chair said, "Sahib is in a meeting."

The clerk kept the file on his desk and rang an old bell. No one came.

Then he said, "Actually the file for Sahib's signature goes through me. But since Sahib is not in his room, you can leave the file here."

"How long before I get it?"

"When it is received."

"What should I do?"

"You may wait if you like."

Ramlochan looked at the wall clock and calculated the bus time in his head.

"I will find him myself."

The clerk's face tightened slightly, as though Ramlochan had proposed breaking an ancient rule of the office.

“Sahib is not searched for. Sahib is met when he is available.”

“What is the difference?”

The clerk did not answer. He handed the file back to Ramlochan.

“Where is the meeting?”

“Near Room Seven, in the conference room.”

Ramlochan reached Room Seven.

The conference-room door was open. Inside were only ten empty chairs and a long table in the middle. A woman cleaner was sweeping.

“Sahib’s meeting?” Ramlochan asked.

“There has been no meeting here today,” she said. “Two people sat here for five minutes in the morning and then left.”

In the adjoining room, a young man was tying files beneath a trembling fan.

Ramlochan asked, “Where is Sahib?”

Without looking up, the young man said, “He may be on a field visit.”

“Establishment said he is in a meeting.”

“Then Establishment must know.”

“There is no one in the meeting.”

This time the young man looked up. “If you want to check attendance, Room Eight.”

Ramlochan reached Room Eight. The board read “Confidential/Attendance.” Inside, a thin employee was matching dates in the attendance register.

Ramlochan repeated his question.

The employee opened the register and placed a finger on an entry.

“Sahib is not on leave. He signed at 10:07.”

“He is here?”

“The register says so.”

“Then where can I meet him?”

The employee shrugged. “Sahib’s movements are not entered in the register.”

After going through eight rooms, Ramlochan untied and retied the red string around the file. It had been tight before; now it was loose. The corners of the pages had bent. He thought: the file had been neat and clean at the bank. Had the office moved his work forward, or only changed the file’s appearance?

At the other end of the veranda, two women sat with papers related to a sewing scheme. One asked, "Are you here for a signature too?"

Ramlochan tried to laugh. "Yes."

"How many rooms?"

"Eight."

The second woman said matter-of-factly, "Then you must have covered half the distance."

Ramlochan could not tell whether it was a joke or experience speaking.

The afternoon was slipping away.

Ramlochan sat down on a bench in the veranda. There was a roti in his bag, but he had no appetite. The file now looked thick; eight kinds of ink and pencil marks had accumulated on its first page, though the bank had asked for only one signature.

From the courtyard below came the call again: "Hot tea!"

Ramlochan decided he would drink tea once more before missing the evening bus, and then whatever happened, happened.

There were fewer people in the line this time.

Ahead of him stood the same middle-aged man in the white kurta, holding a half-finished clay cup.

An employee came running from behind. "Sahib, your signature is needed on this file."

The man in the white kurta casually shifted the clay cup to his left hand, took out a pen with his right, and signed the employee's file.

For a moment Ramlochan's body went still.

The same man.

The man who had praised the clay cup in the morning.

The man for whom Ramlochan had already walked through eight rooms.

As the employee turned away, Sahib's eyes fell on Ramlochan.

"You make the cups from Babhaniyatol, don't you?"

Ramlochan held out the file with both hands. "Yes. And I need one signature from you on this."

Sahib opened the file.

He read the first page, then looked over the comments filling the upper and lower margins.

His eyebrows rose slightly. "Why are there so many notes?"

Ramlochan thought before answering.

Then he said, "Perhaps this is the road one has to travel to reach you."

Sahib gave a faint laugh, but Ramlochan did not.

He examined the paper, read the pencilled line from Room Five, checked the accounts note, and signed.

It took perhaps six or seven seconds.

"Now give it to the bank," Sahib said. "Your work will be done."

Ramlochan kept looking at the signature.

So small.

So little ink.

He could hardly believe that the weight of an entire day had been lifted by those two curved lines.

He picked up his bag.

As he started toward the stairs, the tea seller came up to Sahib. In his hand was the paper for a month's tea bill.

"Sahib, please sign this. The payment is stuck."

Sahib looked at the paper. "How did this come directly to me? First have Accounts verify it."

For a moment the tea seller looked at Sahib's face, then folded the paper and put it into his bag.

Ramlochan stopped on the first stair.

In his hand was the signed paper; behind him, the tea bill was about to begin its journey through the rooms.

He said nothing.

He only tucked the bag firmly under his arm and hurried down to catch the evening bus.

STORY 247

The Special Hat

...

On his first day at the District Seed Certification Office in Madhubani, the new officer, Shambhunath Karn, arrived wearing a hat that attracted more discussion than the office work itself.

The hat was made of ordinary khadi, but along its front edge were two small stitches of blue thread. It was pressed down slightly on the right and raised a little on the left. Shambhunath Babu came inside, removed the hat, hung it on a peg, greeted all the employees, and asked his first question: “How many seed tests are incomplete?”

Later, Accounts Clerk Baijnath Jha said, “Did you notice? On his very first day the man did not ask about files; he asked about unfinished work. Even the hat is disciplined like an officer.”

The sentence had been spoken as a joke, but by noon half the office had passed near the peg on one pretext or another to look at the two blue stitches.

Shambhunath Babu spent a good deal of time in the fields. Paddy seed plots, low ground near makhana fields, wheat samples—wherever inspection was required, he went himself. He wore the hat in the sun and took it off the moment he entered a room.

Naresh Yadav, a junior assistant who accompanied him twice on field inspections, arrived in the second week wearing a khadi hat made in exactly the same style. There were two blue stitches along its front edge as well.

“Where did you get it?” Baijnath asked.

“Fakira the tailor, on Station Road.”

“Exactly like his?”

Naresh smiled. “The sun falls the same way on everyone’s head.”

Three days later the Stores Assistant came in one, then the Records Clerk, then the Cash Assistant. By the end of the week, seven hats with blue stitches could be seen in the office.

Fakira’s shop had earlier been known for pyjamas, kurtas, and school uniforms. Now, on its wooden board, someone had written in charcoal: “Khadi hats with two stitches available.” He did not dare write “officer hat,” but customers asked for it by that name among themselves.

Inside the office, the meaning of the hat slowly changed. At first it was something to protect the head from the sun, then a neat article of clothing, and finally a sign.

No one openly said that a hat would bring promotion, but when news came that the annual promotion list was about to be prepared, the number of hats rose from seven to fourteen.

The most enthusiastic was Copying Assistant Raghuvir Chaudhary. The blue stitches on his hat were half an inch longer than those on the original. Each morning, when he reached the office, he first straightened the edge of his hat and only then signed the attendance register.

“How far to the right does the officer tilt his hat?” he asked Naresh one day.

“I have not measured it.”

“You travel with him. You should pay attention.”

Everyone laughed at that, but the next day Raghuvir came with his hat tilted slightly to the right.

On the third day, three hats were sitting at the same angle.

Only one person stayed outside the fashion: Devkant Paswan, Seed Sample Assistant.

His work was to weigh samples from sacks brought in from the fields, check moisture, and enter figures in the register. His head became very hot in the sun, so for years he had kept a gamchha with him.

When the discussion of hats arose, he only said, “My head suffocates in a hat.”

Raghuvir joked, “Your promotion will suffocate too.”

Devkant laughed. “If air to the head and promotion travel through the same pipe, let the promotion go.”

The farmers waiting outside the office noticed the change too.

Earlier they read employees’ nameplates. Now they looked at hats.

An elderly farmer mistook Naresh for Shambhunath Babu and began handing him an application.

Startled, Naresh said, “I am not the officer.”

The old man looked at the hat and asked, “Then this?”

By noon, that sentence had travelled through the entire office.

No one was sure whether Shambhunath Babu noticed any of this.

He never made a single comment about the hats.

He asked for files on time, checked field-inspection records, and had every employee’s old service record called for separately.

There was no column for hats in those records.

Even so, people looked more at his head than at the service records.

One day it was decided that a group photograph should be taken for the department's annual booklet.

The photographer arranged everyone in two rows on the veranda.

Fourteen hats with blue stitches gleamed together.

Devkant stood in the back row with his gamchha over his shoulder.

Shambhunath Babu was holding his hat in his hand.

The photographer said, "Sir, please put on the hat. The group will look uniform."

He put it on.

The employees interpreted that small incident in their own ways.

According to Raghuvir, it proved that the officer himself wanted uniformity.

According to Baijnath, once the hats appeared in the annual booklet, the message would reach all the way upward.

Naresh said nothing, but the next day the blue stitches on his hat were sewn afresh.

Then the rains came.

Field inspections decreased.

Shambhunath Babu began wearing the hat less often, but the employees now kept theirs on even inside the office.

Sweat ran down their foreheads in the heat, yet the hats stayed in place.

One day the Cash Assistant's ink blurred with sweat. He wiped the paper first, then straightened his hat.

One afternoon the electricity failed.

Because there was no air inside, everyone removed their hats and placed them on the window ledge.

When the electricity returned and people began picking them up again, a problem arose: they were all nearly identical.

Raghuvir put one on and said, "This is not mine. My stitches are a little longer."

Baijnath placed another on his head and said, "This must be Naresh's. The circumference is smaller."

For five minutes the work of the office stopped while people identified their hats from head size, sweat stains, inner stitching, and the curve of the brim.

The next day Raghuvir proposed that everyone have his name sewn inside the hat.

The proposal never became a formal file, but Fakira the tailor's income increased.

He now added the first letter of the wearer's name in white thread inside, along with the blue stitches outside.

From the outside all the hats looked alike; inside, each was different.

Meanwhile another rule formed without ever being written.

Whenever Shambhunath Babu came out onto the veranda, employees wearing hats would involuntarily touch their own—one straightening the brim, another pressing the blue stitches.

Earlier greetings had been made by joining the hands; now half the greeting happened on the head.

One day the officer stopped and asked, "Have all of you developed an itch on the same day?"

Laughter rose along the veranda.

Raghuvir laughed the loudest, though his hand did not immediately leave his hat.

Fakira's shop now had two samples: "ordinary" and "two-stitch."

The two-stitch version cost three rupees more.

By the end of Sawan he had received so many orders that he had to deliver two school uniforms a day late.

His wife asked, "Has some new uniform been introduced in the office?"

Fakira said, "There has been no order. If there had been an order, who would have bought them so quickly?"

On the morning the promotion list was due, the entire rhythm of the office changed.

Everyone knew that a sealed envelope was coming from the district office.

As soon as the postman stopped his bicycle, Raghuvir adjusted his hat with both hands.

Unable to find a mirror, Baijnath examined the brim of his hat in the window glass.

Devkant continued weighing mustard seed in the sample room.

The envelope went to Shambhunath Babu's desk.

Half an hour later two names were pinned to the notice board.

The first was Devkant Paswan—promoted to Senior Sample Assistant.

The second was an employee from another block.

The veranda suddenly fell silent.

Raghuvir read the notice three times.

Then he looked toward Devkant, who was washing his hands.

“But you never wore the hat.”

Shaking the water from his hands, Devkant said, “Whoever made the list must have looked at my service record, not at my head.”

The sentence was simple, but people interpreted it too as a sign.

By noon a new explanation had formed: anyone whose work was secure had no need of a hat; the hat was useful only for those whose case was somewhere in between.

As a result, not a single hat came off.

On the contrary, two employees went to Fakira to be measured for new ones.

In the evening Shambhunath Babu called Devkant in and congratulated him.

As he came out, Devkant did not see the officer’s hat on the peg.

He turned back and asked, “No hat today?”

Shambhunath Babu ran a hand over his head.

“The doctor had told me not to let strong sunlight fall directly on an old wound. The wound has healed now, so I have stopped wearing it.”

For a moment Devkant looked at his scalp.

There was only a small pale scar among the hair.

“And the blue stitches?”

“My daughter sewed them. The brim had torn.”

Devkant went outside thinking of telling someone.

Then he saw Raghuvir and Baijnath returning from Fakira’s shop with two new hats in their hands.

He said nothing.

The following week Shambhunath Babu went out on field inspection without a hat. All fourteen hats remained in place in the office. Fakira wiped the old charcoal writing from his board and added a new line: “Two-stitch pattern prepared immediately.” Below it, in smaller letters and on his own initiative, he added: “For office people.” That day the blue stitches on Raghuvir’s hat were lengthened by another half inch.

STORY 248

The Tea Committee

...

At the Jhanjharpur Drainage Subdivision, tea arrived at exactly 10:40 in the morning.

The time was written in no office order, but the moment the hands of the clock reached that point, a clinking of glasses could be heard from the veranda, like a small brass bell.

The tea was brought by Chandrakala Devi.

Her little stall stood just outside the gate—two bamboo posts, a tin awning, one clay hearth, two brass kettles, and a narrow wooden plank in front.

In the morning she served labourers, rickshaw pullers, and visitors to the office; at ten, the employees; after noon, people from the road again.

Her household ran on that rhythm.

On that Monday, the new Executive Officer, Sureshwar Mishra, drank the office tea for the first time.

One sip went into his mouth.

There was no second.

He placed the glass on the desk and asked, “Who makes this tea?”

Attendant Bhola Jha answered in a slightly nervous voice, “Chandrakala Devi, outside the gate. It has been coming from there for years.”

“Where is the taste of the tea leaves?”

Bhola looked at the glass as though the taste might be sitting at the bottom.

“Sahib, if the milk is a little less—”

“I am not talking about milk. Tea should taste like tea.”

That was all he had said.

But by noon the whole office knew that the new officer was dissatisfied with the tea.

Nandkishore from Accounts said, “At least the work has begun at a good place.”

Dayanand from the Maps Section replied, “First the drain, then the tea.”

The next day the tea came again.

Chandrakala added a little more tea leaf.

This time the Assistant Engineer said, “Too bitter.”

On the third day she increased the milk, and the Cash Assistant said, “More milk than tea.”

On the fourth day she reduced the sugar, and two employees asked separately for extra sugar in their glasses.

On the fifth day Sureshwar Mishra drank only half a glass and said, “This is not about individual preference. The quality must be uniform.”

The word “uniform” remained in the office.

On Friday an order was issued: a five-member committee would be formed to examine the quality, quantity, and expenditure of the tea supplied to the office.

Assistant Engineer Raghunath Chaudhary was made chairman.

The members were Nandkishore, Dayanand, Bhola Jha, and Junior Engineer Meena Kumari.

They were to submit recommendations within seven days.

Bhola read the order and asked, “Why am I on the committee?”

Nandkishore said, “You distribute the tea. You have practical experience.”

Bhola scratched his head.

He had been handing out glasses for years, but this was the first time his experience had received government recognition.

The committee’s first difficulty was whether it would be proper to sit and drink the very tea that was under examination.

Raghunath Chaudhary said, “Depending upon the item under scrutiny may raise questions about impartiality.”

Therefore the first meeting was held half a kos away from the office, at Kamla Bhojanalaya.

Tea there came in white porcelain cups, with two thin savoury biscuits on the side.

One cup cost eighteen rupees.

Office tea cost eight.

Meena Kumari took the first sip and said, “This is a little thin.”

Raghunath Chaudhary said, “We need a basis of comparison. We cannot reach a conclusion from one sample.”

A second sample was ordered—more milk.

A third—with ginger.

A fourth—with cardamom.

The bill came to one hundred and forty-four rupees.

Lifting the bill, Nandkishore said, "This will go under committee expenditure."

For the second meeting, Dayanand proposed that they first identify where the best tea in the market was available.

There was discussion.

In the end they chose Mithila Rest House on Station Road, where one cup of tea cost thirty-two rupees and sugar was served separately in a small bowl.

Holding the cup, Bhola asked softly, "Will it be necessary to serve cups like this in our office?"

Raghunath Chaudhary laughed. "Not the cup. Look at the quality."

Bhola smelled the tea. "There is more leaf here."

Meena said, "And the milk is thicker."

Looking at the sugar bowl, Nandkishore said, "Serving sugar separately might reduce wastage."

Dayanand immediately added, "But then spoons will be needed."

"Who will wash the spoons?"

That question continued for five minutes.

Then a second round of tea was ordered.

This time savouries came with it too, because it was already noon and it seemed difficult to discuss quality on tea alone.

The bill came to three hundred and sixty-six rupees.

Meanwhile Chandrakala had merely been told to "improve" the tea.

She asked for the measure of improvement.

Bhola could not answer.

He was a member of the committee, but the committee had not yet decided the measure.

Chandrakala made her own calculations.

The price of a seer of milk, tea leaves, sugar, coal, the labour of washing glasses, carrying the tea up to the gate, and then, at the end of the month, usually twenty to twenty-five days of credit.

At eight rupees a glass, her margin was no more than one and a half to two rupees.

If she increased the tea leaves, she would have to reduce the milk; if she increased the milk, the margin would disappear.

The next day she showed Bhola three kinds of tea leaf in three small bowls.

“This is what I use. This is one grade higher. This is the most expensive. Which one does the committee want?”

Bhola smelled all three and said, “I cannot decide. It will be a collective decision.”

Gathering up the bowls, Chandrakala said, “Then let the collective nose smell them.”

Bhola burst out laughing, but later he did not repeat the remark before the committee.

The third meeting was held in the dining room of the District Guest House because—in Raghunath Chaudhary’s view—“standard service” was available there.

One cup of tea cost thirty-eight rupees.

On a white tablecloth came a separate kettle, separate milk, and separate sugar.

Two kettles were ordered for the five members.

The meeting agenda was divided into four points: colour, aroma, temperature, and sweetness.

Dayanand wanted to describe the colour of the tea as “coppery.”

Nandkishore said, “Who will understand that word in the register?”

Meena suggested, “Neither too pale nor too dark.”

Raghunath Chaudhary said, “Government recommendations are not written like that.”

Twenty minutes went on colour.

Fifteen on aroma.

On temperature, Bhola said that Chandrakala poured the tea from the kettle and brought it immediately, so the temperature was normally right.

Raghunath Chaudhary asked, “What is the measure of ‘right?’”

Bhola fell silent.

“We need a number.”

No one had an instrument for measuring temperature.

The guest-house cook was asked.

He said, “After it boils, let it settle a little.”

The committee did not consider that answer useful.

By the end of the meeting, the five members had drunk seven cups of tea.

Two plates of savoury makhana had also arrived.

The total bill was five hundred and seventy-eight rupees.

Nandkishore looked at the bill and remained silent for a moment.

Then he asked, "Shall this expenditure be entered under 'sample testing'?"

Raghunath Chaudhary said, "Write meeting expenditure. There should be transparency."

At that time Chandrakala's bill for the previous month—two thousand four hundred and thirty-two rupees—was still pending in the office.

The previous officer had been transferred without signing it.

The new officer had said the old dues would be paid after verification.

Chandrakala did not ask Bhola about it every day.

Only once a week she said, "Please look at the file."

Bhola looked.

The file kept moving between Accounts and the officer's desk.

By the fourth committee meeting a draft had been prepared: fixed quantity per glass, a minimum proportion of milk and tea leaves, the option of serving sugar separately, supply in a covered vessel, and clean glasses.

The only problem was price.

Nandkishore calculated that according to the proposed quantities, the actual cost of one glass would be at least fourteen rupees.

With labour added, sixteen.

"But the approved rate is eight," he said.

"Increase the rate," Dayanand said.

"This office has no authority to increase the rate. Fresh approval will be required."

"Then what recommendation do we give?"

Nandkishore placed a finger on the paper.

"Improvement in quality without additional expenditure."

Meena Kumari looked at him. "How is that possible?"

Nandkishore did not laugh. "That is the question the committee has to answer."

That day the meeting was not held in the office.

The five members went to a new restaurant on Station Road, where tea cost forty-five rupees.

Raghunath Chaudhary had said that before reaching a final conclusion they should also examine the "highest available sample."

The tea came with jaggery in a small brass bowl.

Everyone was pleased.

Dayanand proposed that replacing sugar with jaggery would also give the tea a local character.

Nandkishore immediately asked, “What is the rate for jaggery?”

The proposal stopped there.

On the fifth day, the committee called Chandrakala into the office.

She arrived with three small tins in her old cloth bag—tea leaves, sugar, and fennel.

Raghunath Chaudhary read out the draft.

“This much milk, this much leaf, sugar separate, glasses covered—can you do it?”

Chandrakala remained silent for a while.

“I can.”

“For eight rupees?”

“That is not possible.”

The room fell silent.

“Then for how much?”

“At least fifteen. Leave me one rupee as profit.”

Nandkishore said, “The approved rate is eight.”

Chandrakala put her hand into the bag and gathered up the tins again.

“Then eight-rupee tea will be eight-rupee tea.”

Dayanand said in a softer voice, “Is there some way to improve the quality a little?”

“There is. Make the glass a little smaller. Quantity will decrease and taste will improve.”

The committee members looked at one another.

The draft already contained the words “fixed quantity.”

Raghunath Chaudhary said, “If quantity is reduced, there will be complaints.”

Chandrakala replied matter-of-factly, “If the price will not rise, the quantity will not fall, the milk must increase, and the tea leaves must increase—all four at once—then I will have to keep both a cow and a tea plantation at the gate.”

Bhola lowered his head and smiled.

Meena too could not hold back her laughter.

Raghunath Chaudhary’s face first hardened, then he too laughed.

It was the first moment in the entire meeting process when every member agreed on the same thing.

The final recommendation was changed.

The sentence became: "Clean vessel, fresh tea, balanced quantity of sugar, and limited variation according to employee preference."

No fixed quantity of milk, tea leaves, or price remained in it.

The rate stayed at eight rupees.

The committee completed its work in twelve days instead of seven.

Across its five meetings, expenditure on tea came to two thousand eight hundred and sixty rupees.

Nandkishore attached all the bills together to the accounts file.

That same afternoon Chandrakala came with her previous month's bill—two thousand four hundred and thirty-two rupees.

Bhola saw both files on the same desk.

On top were the committee-meeting bills.

Below was Chandrakala's old unpaid claim.

Nandkishore said, "The committee expenditure will be paid first. It belongs to the current period. Verification of the old bill is still pending."

Chandrakala heard him.

She said nothing.

She merely straightened the corner of her bill.

The next morning at exactly 10:40, tea came again.

The same brass kettle.

The same thick glasses.

The same eight rupees.

Sureshwar Mishra took one sip.

"A little better today," he said.

Bhola looked at Chandrakala.

He knew that neither the milk nor the tea leaves had changed.

Only half a spoon less sugar had been added, because the price of a sack of sugar had risen the previous week.

Chandrakala continued distributing the glasses.

After placing the last glass on Nandkishore's desk, she opened her small account register and wrote on a new line: "Tea—eight rupees."

The old unpaid amount remained above it exactly as before.

On the other side of the desk, the five bills from the committee meetings lay fastened with a paper clip.

On the top bill one line could be read clearly: “Special tea—five cups.”

Amount: two hundred and twenty-five rupees.

Nandkishore was signing it.

Chandrakala closed her register, lifted the empty kettle, and walked back outside the gate toward her hearth.

STORY 249

The Vanished Bell

...

At Pathrahi Middle School in Benipatti, an old brass bell hung from a thick wooden beam at the eastern corner of the veranda. Only two digits were engraved on its body—1956. No name. No donor, no craftsman, no headmaster of the time. For seven decades, the ringing of that nameless bell had marked the times for prayer, lessons, the midday meal, and dismissal.

On Tuesday morning, when attendant Mahavir Paswan reached up to pull the rope, his hand moved through empty air. The iron hook on the beam was bare. The rope lay coiled below, but the bell was gone.

Mahavir first looked up, then down, as though the bell might occasionally climb down of its own accord and move to another corner of the veranda. He ran to Headmaster Manbodh Jha.

“The bell is not there.”

Manbodh Babu was opening the attendance register. “Did the rope break?”

“The rope is here. The bell is not.”

Both came outside. The hook was not broken; its screw had been carefully removed. The old circular rub marks of the brass body were clear on the wood, and the emptiness between them was new.

Morning prayer was due at 8:15. Without the bell, the children began forming lines in the field according to their own guesses. Some classes arrived early, some late. Mathematics teacher Kameshwar Yadav looked at his wristwatch and shouted, “It is eight fifteen!” but his voice did not reach all five hundred children.

In the end, a brass plate was brought from the midday-meal kitchen. Mahavir struck it with a wooden ladle. The sound did not travel like the bell; it clanged in the veranda and died there.

By ten o’clock, news of the missing bell had spread farther through the village than through the school.

The first to arrive was Panchayat Mukhiya Raghunandan Singh. Two young men were with him, one of whom kept writing something on paper.

“This was no ordinary bell,” the Mukhiya said. “My grandfather, Shivnarayan Singh, donated it after the school opened.”

Manbodh Babu asked, “Is there any old evidence of that?”

“The memory of the village is evidence.”

Exactly five minutes later, retired teacher Shyamlal Mishra arrived. He heard the Mukhiya’s statement in the veranda.

“Shivnarayan Babu donated the bell?” he said, pushing his spectacles upward. “Where has this new history come from?”

Raghunandan Singh’s eyebrows rose slightly. “Were you a teacher then?”

“I was a student. Grain was collected house to house in the village for that bell. My mother gave two paseris too.”

“A brass bell is cast from grain?”

“Grain is sold and becomes money.”

A bell that had disappeared from the beam ten minutes earlier now hung between the prestige of two families.

Manbodh Babu said in the middle of it, “First let us find the bell.”

But the Mukhiya said, “Certainly. At the same time it should be clear who donated the object. The history must not become wrong in the theft report.”

Shyamlal Mishra laughed. “Whether the bell is found or not, the name must be found first!”

By noon a third party had arrived: Dinesh Chaudhary, coordinator of the Former Students’ Association.

His proposal was simple. If the old bell was not found, the association would donate a new one.

“Twice as large as the old one,” he said, “and below it there will be a small plaque—Courtesy of the Former Students’ Association.”

Manbodh Babu said, “The old bell is still being searched for.”

“Search for it. If it is found, keep it as a memorial. A new bell would be better for daily use.”

The Mukhiya immediately asked, “Why only the association’s name on the plaque?”

Dinesh said, “Because the association will give the bell.”

“The school is in the Panchayat.”

“The school belongs to the Education Department,” Shyamlal Mishra cut in.

Meanwhile, because there was no second bell, the Class Five Hindi lesson ran ten minutes too long, the Class Six science teacher arrived ten minutes late, and Class Seven left half a lesson unfinished to line up for the midday meal. No one debated this disorder. On the veranda everyone continued discussing whose name should appear in letters of what size on the new bell.

Manbodh Babu took Mahavir with him and searched around the school.

Near the mango tree at the back were two deep drag marks in the soil.

The bell was heavy; one person could not easily carry it.

The drag marks ran from the veranda to the rear gate of the school and then disappeared on the unpaved road.

“Who was here last evening?” Manbodh Babu asked.

Mahavir thought. “I closed the gate at five. The bell was here then. Dinesh Babu was standing in the field with two men, looking at the preparations for Foundation Day.”

“Anyone else?”

“The Mukhiya’s nephew was playing football until around six. Shyamlal Master also comes here in the evening for a walk.”

One bell, three respected parties, and all three near the school the previous evening.

Manbodh Babu said nothing about the coincidence.

He sent information to the police outpost.

Hearing the news, more villagers gathered.

Someone said the price of brass had risen.

Someone said it must be an outsider.

Someone said it had to be the work of a villager, because whoever removed it had known how the hook was fitted.

In the afternoon, Manbodh Babu, Mahavir, and Kameshwar Yadav went to the old metal buyers in Benipatti market.

At two places they learnt nothing.

At the third, elderly craftsman Sakaldev Sah listened to them and asked, “Does the bell have 1956 engraved on it?”

All three looked at one another.

“Yes. Those very digits.”

Sakaldev Sah put down his hammer. “I have not seen the bell. But three days ago two young men came asking for the measurements of a bell like that. They asked how much brass would be needed to make a new one in the same size.”

“Who were they?”

“I know one of them. Bablu. He works at Dinesh Chaudhary’s shop.”

Manbodh Babu returned to the school at once.

Dinesh Chaudhary was still in the veranda. In front of him lay a paper containing an estimated cost for a new bell.

“Why did Bablu go to ask for measurements?” Manbodh Babu asked directly.

For a moment Dinesh’s eyes rested on the paper. “I was thinking of donating a new bell.”

“Three days ago?”

“Foundation Day is near.”

“Before the old bell disappeared?”

Silence fell in the veranda.

An expression came over Raghunandan Singh’s face as though he already knew the answer.

Shyamlal Mishra removed his spectacles and began wiping them with a cloth.

Dinesh said slowly, “I did not steal the bell.”

“I am not accusing you of theft. I am only asking why its measurements were being taken.”

Dinesh rose from the chair. “I had thought of presenting a new bell for Foundation Day. We needed the measurements of the old one. That is all.”

“Was the bell taken down for measuring?”

“No. There was no question of removing it.”

At that moment the creak of a bullock cart came from the rear gate.

Everyone looked that way.

A heavy round object covered with a sack lay on the cart.

Bablu and another young man were with it.

Mahavir ran over.

The sack was removed.

Inside was the school bell—1956 on its body, the old crack along the rim, and fresh oil on the upper hook.

Manbodh Babu said nothing.

Dinesh Chaudhary’s face hardened.

Bablu spoke first. “We were told to take its measurements and hang it back again. We removed it last night. The cart driver was not available, so we could not take it to Sakaldev’s place. We kept it in my godown. When the news spread this morning, we got frightened.”

“Who told you?” Manbodh Babu asked.

Bablu looked toward Dinesh.

Dinesh raised a hand to stop him. "I told them only to find a way to take the measurements. I never told them to remove the bell and carry it away."

Bablu remained silent.

Raghunandan Singh immediately said, "This is clearly theft."

Dinesh turned toward him. "Why was your nephew measuring the beam yesterday evening?"

Raghunandan's tone changed. "He was seeing where the Foundation Day plaque should be placed."

Shyamlal Mishra burst out laughing. "More than the bell, everyone wanted the measurement of a name."

The discussion began moving in a different direction again.

The Mukhiya wanted a written apology.

Dinesh said the intention had been to increase the school's prestige.

Shyamlal Mishra insisted that no new name should be added to the old bell.

Meanwhile Mahavir lifted the bell and began hanging it back on the beam.

Kameshwar Yadav helped him tighten the screw.

Manbodh Babu looked toward the classrooms.

The Class Eight teacher was watching the clock and waiting to end the lesson.

The Class Five children were looking toward the window.

The temporary routine created by the clanging brass plate had already broken down five times during the day.

"First tighten the bell," Manbodh Babu said. "The decision about names can come later."

Mahavir tightened the screw, tied the rope, and pulled once.

Tannnn.

The sound passed beyond the school veranda, across the field, past the mango tree, through the gate, and out to the road.

In three classrooms teachers stopped in the middle of sentences.

The children closed their exercise books and took out the books for the next lesson.

On the veranda Raghunandan Singh was saying, "The Foundation Day programme must certainly include the history of the donor."

Dinesh Chaudhary replied, "Then the contribution of the Former Students' Association must also be included."

Shyamlal Mishra said, “First decide how the history is to be made.”

Mahavir pulled the rope a second time.

The bell rang again.

Inside the classrooms, time moved forward.

On the veranda, the argument over names remained exactly where it was.

STORY 250

Certified Copy

...

On the veranda of the District Handicrafts Assistance Centre in Darbhanga, Bhubaneswar Mandal sat with a small bamboo supati resting in his lap. It was not for sale. It was his sample. This year a notice had come that each artisan would be given one stall free of charge at the district fair, and the application had to be accompanied by a certified copy of the old artisan identity certificate. Bhubaneswar's certificate was eighteen years old: yellow paper, a green border, his younger photograph in the middle, and the signature of the officer of that time below. He had brought the original certificate wrapped between two folds of red cloth.

When his turn came, clerk Raghunath Jha looked at the application and then at the certificate.

"Where is the copy?"

Bhubaneswar opened the red cloth and placed the original paper in front of him. "Here it is."

"This is the original."

"Yes. That is why I brought it."

"I need a certified copy."

For a few moments Bhubaneswar looked between the original paper and Raghunath's eyes. "The original is in front of you. Look at it, compare it, write whatever has to be written."

Raghunath smiled. "Looking at the original is not a substitute for a certified copy. The rule says copy."

Outside the veranda, beneath a peepal tree, stood Suresh's photocopy shop: a tin awning, a wooden table, and a small picture of a deity covered with red cloth on top of the machine.

Bhubaneswar hesitated before giving the original paper into Suresh's hand. "Do not bend the edge."

Suresh said, "You have preserved it for eighteen years. Trust me for five minutes too."

He made two copies. In one, the old photograph came out so dark that Bhubaneswar's eyes looked like two black dots. In the other, the signature was too faint. Suresh ran the machine a third time.

“This one is in between. Everything is visible.”

Bhubaneswar carried all three copies inside. Raghunath selected the third.

“Now get this certified.”

“Who will certify it?”

“The Section In-charge.”

“Where does he sit?”

Raghunath indicated with his chin the glass-fronted room opposite.

Section In-charge Vidyapati Mishra sat there. Two files lay open on his desk, a cup of tea rested beside them, and to his left was a round stamp pad.

Bhubaneswar went in and placed both the original and the copy before him.

Vidyapati Mishra looked first at the copy, then at the original.

“This is your certificate?”

“Yes, it is mine.”

“You are Bhubaneswar Mandal?”

“Yes, I am Bhubaneswar Mandal.”

“Identity card?”

Bhubaneswar opened the small pouch tied near the knot of his dhoti and took out his voter identity card.

Vidyapati Mishra looked at it. The photograph there was also old, though seven years newer than the photograph on the certificate.

“You do not have a beard in this.”

Bhubaneswar ran a hand over his white beard. “I did not have one then.”

“I know. But I need a basis for writing that the identity has been matched.”

“I am standing in front of you.”

Vidyapati Mishra smiled. “You are standing here, but the paper too must understand that you are standing here.”

He asked for a photocopy of the voter identity card.

Bhubaneswar went back beneath the peepal tree. This time Suresh asked nothing. He copied the identity card and handed it over. Bhubaneswar returned.

Vidyapati Mishra compared the copy with the original, but before signing he stopped.

“Self-attest the copy of the identity card.”

“What does that mean?”

“Sign it yourself to state that this is your copy.”

A pen was placed in Bhubaneswar's hand. He wrote his name slowly: Bhuba-nesh-war. He was then told to write the date below the signature.

Bhubaneswar asked Raghunath for the date.

From a distance Raghunath called out, "Twenty-seventh September."

Vidyapati Mishra looked at the identity-card copy once more. Then, on the copy of the artisan certificate, he wrote: "Compared with the original." He signed and applied the stamp.

At the sight of the round blue ink mark, a slight sense of relief appeared on Bhubaneswar's face.

He wrapped the original certificate again in the red cloth and handed the certified copy to Raghunath at his desk.

Raghunath turned it over and examined it.

"Two copies are required."

Bhubaneswar's hand stopped in mid-air. "The notice said one copy."

"One with the application. The second for the selection register."

"Why did you not say so earlier?"

Straightening the corner of the application, Raghunath said, "You had brought only one copy, so first one was certified. Get another made now. There is still time."

Bhubaneswar went outside again.

This time Suresh asked, "Another copy of the original?"

Bhubaneswar held out the certified copy. "Make one from this."

Suresh shook his head. "That will become a copy of a copy. The In-charge will say to make it from the original."

Bhubaneswar opened the red cloth again. The original paper came out for the fourth time.

Suresh lowered the machine lid carefully. "Your certificate is doing a lot of service today."

"Have I come for service, or has it?" Bhubaneswar asked.

Suresh laughed, but Bhubaneswar did not.

Carrying the second copy, he returned to Vidyapati Mishra.

This time Mishra recognised the original the moment he saw it.

"Again?"

"Two copies are required."

"All right."

He lifted his pen, then stopped his hand.

“Copy of the identity card?”

“I gave it earlier.”

“That one has been attached to the first certification file.”

“But I am still here.”

“You are here. But this is a second certification.”

Bhubaneswar said nothing.

He made a third trip beneath the peepal tree.

Seeing him from a distance, Suresh stretched out his hand for the voter identity card.

“This time I will make two. You may need another later.”

“No,” Bhubaneswar said. “Make only one. The more paper one keeps, the more work grows.”

For the first time, Suresh became serious at that sentence. He made one copy and handed it over.

Vidyapati Mishra again wrote the comparison note on the second copy of the certificate and signed it.

This time the stamp did not come out fully on the first impression; the right side of the round border remained faint. He pressed the stamp into the ink again and placed a second impression beside it.

Bhubaneswar looked at the papers. One certified copy had one stamp; the other had two.

Raghunath accepted the second copy with satisfaction.

By then two other artisans waiting in the line had also been watching the movement of Bhubaneswar’s papers.

One was a woman who made sikki baskets; in her hand was a transparent bag full of certificates.

She asked softly, “How many copies are needed?”

Bhubaneswar said, “Make only as many as you are told. If you try to guess what will be needed next, the papers only increase.”

The woman counted the contents of her bag again.

Beside her, a young man who made clay horses took out his original certificate and then put it back inside.

For a while the rustle of paper on the veranda sounded as though all the artisans were not examining their crafts, but opening and checking their proofs of themselves.

Raghunath gathered all the pages of the application together.

“Now show the original.”

Bhubaneswar slowly opened the red cloth.

“You have already seen this original twice.”

“Not I. The In-charge saw it. At the time of accepting the application, I have to record that the original was seen.”

Raghunath took the certificate in his hand, holding it carefully by the edges so that his fingers would not touch the photograph.

Then, in a small square box on the application, he marked: “Original seen.”

Bhubaneswar asked, “Is it done now?”

“One minute.”

Raghunath opened a register.

“Your village?”

“Makrampur.”

“Father?”

“Late Jagdish Mandal.”

“Age?”

“Sixty-two.”

“Craft?”

Bhubaneswar placed the supati from his lap on the table. “This.”

Raghunath smiled. “I need the name to write in the register.”

“Bamboo and cane work.”

“Contact number?” Raghunath asked.

“I do not have my own. My son does.”

The number was written down.

Then Raghunath attached the two certified copies, the application, and the self-attested identity-card copy together in the file.

He returned the original certificate to Bhubaneswar.

Bhubaneswar opened the red cloth, but before putting the paper inside, he looked at it carefully once more.

Repeated flashes from the copying machine had made the old folds in the paper appear more distinct. Fibres had risen at one corner. A minute piece of the green border fell onto the desk.

He picked it up with a fingertip and placed it inside the cloth too, as though it were also part of the original.

“Take your receipt,” Raghunath said.

He wrote the application number on a small slip and handed it to him.

Bhubaneswar read the slip.

“Do I need a copy of this receipt?”

Raghunath opened his mouth to laugh, but Bhubaneswar’s voice was completely ordinary.

He did not laugh.

“No. Keep this with you.”

“Whose original?”

“The receipt’s original.”

“Yes. Keep the receipt itself with you.”

Bhubaneswar thought of placing the receipt inside the red cloth with the certificate, then stopped.

The certificate had been safe in that cloth for eighteen years. The receipt had been created today.

He put the receipt in the upper pocket of his kurta instead.

As he came out of the veranda, Suresh asked, “Finished?”

Bhubaneswar held up the supati. “No one asked whether I made this or not.”

Suresh took the supati in his hand and examined the weaving along the edge.

“The hands themselves are saying it.”

Bhubaneswar took the supati back into his lap. “What the hands say cannot be heard on paper.”

He crossed the shade of the peepal tree and started toward the road.

Inside the red cloth was the original certificate; in the office file were two certified copies of it; on separate sheets were the marks of two copies of his identity card; and in the register were written his village, his father’s name, his age, and his craft.

Over the course of the day, the office had written down a great deal about him.

Whether he would receive a stall at the fair would be known only after selection.

But as he went to catch the bus home, Bhubaneswar looked at both his hands—the fine lines cut by thin bamboo strips, an old scar beside the thumb, green splinters caught beneath the nails.

No copy had been made of those marks.

STORY 251

The Height of the Table

...

On his first day at the District Agricultural Implements Assistance Office in Madhubani, the new officer, Vibhakar Chaudhary, had been sitting for barely five minutes when his knees struck the drawer beneath the desk twice. The desk was old teak, so heavy that four men could not shift it without lifting it. Vibhakar was tall. If he pushed the chair back, the door was half blocked; if he pulled it forward, his knees hit the drawer.

After the third knock he did not ring the bell. He simply called Budhan Thakur, the carpenter who was repairing a doorframe in the veranda.

“Can you raise this desk by two inches?”

Budhan examined its legs. “I can put four sal-wood blocks beneath them. Half an hour.”

“Do it. It will save my knees.”

That was all.

Budhan cut four equal blocks from an old sal plank, placed one beneath each leg, and fixed them with two thin nails. The desk rose by two inches.

Vibhakar sat down again. His knees now fit comfortably. He opened a file and went back to work.

But in that office a desk was not merely an object made of wood.

At noon Head Assistant Ramnarayan Jha went into the officer's room carrying a file.

As he placed it on the desk, he noticed that he had to lift his hand slightly higher than before.

He looked at the blocks beneath the desk legs.

After coming out he asked Accounts Assistant Vinod Mandal, “Has a new desk arrived?”

“It is the old one.”

“Then how did it become taller?”

From a distance Budhan called out, “I raised it by two inches.”

Vinod smiled. “New post, new height.”

Ramnarayan did not laugh.

His own desk had always been smaller than the officer's, though almost the same height.

Now the difference was visible to the eye.

He returned to his desk and, for the first time, looked at its legs.

Under the rear right leg was a piece of old register-board because the floor had sunk slightly there.

The next day, discussion of those two inches occupied the office more than the files did.

Someone said the new officer liked proper arrangement.

Someone said a large desk was a symbol of authority.

Someone else said that at the district headquarters the Section Officer's desk was always taller than the assistants' desks.

No one had proof of this, but everyone had an example he claimed to have seen.

Deepak Paswan, a junior clerk in Accounts, wrote bent over his desk. His back hurt.

Hearing the discussion, he said to Budhan, "Raise my desk by one inch too. It will make writing easier."

Budhan asked, "Permission?"

"The desk is assigned to me."

"The desk belongs to the government."

Deepak laughed. "Then let the government's back hurt?"

Budhan handed him two thin blocks but did not install them.

"Keep these. When written permission comes, I will nail them in."

Deepak put the blocks in his drawer.

The matter could have ended there.

But that evening Head Assistant Ramnarayan Jha removed the piece of board from beneath the rear leg of his desk, folded it double, and put it back.

The desk rose by half an inch.

Vinod Mandal noticed it the next morning.

"The floor here had not sunk that much until yesterday," Vinod said.

Ramnarayan replied, "It is an old building. Who can say when the floor changes?"

From the third day onward, the measurements of desks lodged themselves in everyone's eyes.

How tall was each desk?

Whose chair arms stood above the edge of his desk?

Whose hand rose higher when passing a file?

No one had noticed such things before.

Now everyone did.

Records Assistant Shambhu Sah's desk was naturally an inch and a half taller, because years earlier iron caps had been fitted over all four legs.

Shambhu was junior in service.

The moment this fact was discovered, Ramnarayan's brows tightened.

"Why is this desk so tall?"

Shambhu said, "The termite-damaged legs were cut and iron caps fitted over them."

"When was this repair done?"

"Before I came here."

"So the original form of a fixed asset was altered?"

Shambhu laughed at first, then stopped when he saw Ramnarayan's face.

"It was repaired."

"Can a repair change the height of a desk?"

"The legs were shortened, so caps were added. The height was preserved."

That answer did not make the problem smaller.

It enlarged it.

If the height of Shambhu's desk had been 'preserved,' what had its original height been?

And how could that be proved?

At noon Ramnarayan called for the old fixed-assets register.

It contained serial number, name of item, year of purchase, and condition — "Desk 12, teak, in use"; "Desk 13, mixed wood, repairable."

Nowhere was height recorded.

Turning the pages, Vinod said, "In government records, the height of a desk does not exist at all."

Ramnarayan replied gravely, "That is precisely why arbitrary changes are possible."

By evening a measuring tape was found.

An old tape lay in the office iron almirah, though its first two markings had worn away.

Budhan brought his bamboo measuring rod.

Both were used.

The officer's desk was thirty-four inches high, Ramnarayan's thirty-two and a half, Shambhu's thirty-three, Vinod's thirty-two, and Deepak's thirty-one and three-quarters.

Once those five lines were written on paper, a new form of hierarchy appeared.

The difficulty was that height and official rank did not run in the same order.

Shambhu's desk stood half an inch above the Head Assistant's.

Mahendra the office attendant had a small desk on which visitors' names were entered. It stood thirty-three and a half inches high—a full inch higher than Ramnarayan's.

"Mahendra's desk is higher than mine?" Ramnarayan said.

Mahendra laughed. "I have to write standing up, so perhaps it was made higher."

Everyone fell silent at that.

On the fourth day the matter took shape.

The two blocks from Deepak's drawer disappeared.

Instead, one iron cap on Shambhu's desk was found slightly loose.

Shambhu accused no one, but sat at his desk looking at everyone's shoes.

Vinod drew a thin ink line on the right leg of his desk so that if anyone placed anything underneath it, he would notice immediately.

Mahendra pasted a paper on the visitors' desk: "DO NOT MOVE THIS DESK."

The actual work of the office continued amid all this, though with a slightly distorted rhythm.

Farmers came with applications for machinery subsidies.

People asked, "Where should I submit my application?"

An employee would first take the file, then involuntarily glance at the other desks.

What had once been only a matter of bodily comfort had become arithmetic for the eye.

On the fifth day Vibhakar Chaudhary noticed that the way files were being placed on his desk had changed.

Ramnarayan set a file down and stepped back slightly.

Vinod straightened his arm and raised it upward.

Whenever Shambhu entered the room he first pulled his shirt sleeve straight, as though a taller desk demanded a different etiquette.

Vibhakar asked, "Has something happened in the office?"

"No," Ramnarayan said.

"Then why has Budhan been measuring desks for three days?"

Silence.

At last Vinod said, "Some questions have arisen concerning equality of seating arrangements."

"Whose seating?"

"The desks."

At first Vibhakar did not understand.

Ramnarayan explained in order: the fixed-assets register, the five measured heights, and the matter of Shambhu's iron caps.

Vibhakar listened.

His knees rested comfortably beneath the desk.

"Did anyone ask why I had this desk raised by two inches?"

Ramnarayan said, "For convenience, I understand."

"Whose convenience?"

"Yours."

"Yes. My knees were striking the drawer."

After that sentence there was a silence in which the ringing of a bicycle bell on the road outside could be heard clearly.

Deepak opened his drawer and looked inside, as though the missing blocks might suddenly reappear there.

Vibhakar called Budhan.

"Can these blocks be removed?"

Budhan said, "They can. But then your knees will hit again."

"Then do not remove them."

Vibhakar pushed his chair back.

"If someone else's desk is wrong for his body, correct it according to his body. Not according to rank."

Confusion showed in Ramnarayan's eyes; so simple a reason seemed incomplete to him.

"Then there is no prescribed height?"

"If the purchase specifications mention one, look there. If they do not, let any desk that is safe and fit for work remain in use."

Vinod said quietly, "Then Shambhu Babu's desk—"

"If it was saved from termites, that is a good thing."

The meeting ended.

No written order was issued.

For that reason everyone felt lighter and dissatisfied at the same time.

A written order would have created a basis for the future; an oral statement depended on memory.

That afternoon Budhan went to Deepak's desk.

He sat in Deepak's chair, tried the position, then said, "Before raising the desk, let me raise the chair by half an inch. Your back will stay straighter."

He loosened the old screw and raised the seat slightly.

Deepak wrote two pages to test it.

"This really is better."

The missing blocks in his drawer were no longer needed.

The iron cap on Shambhu's desk was tightened again.

Mahendra's high desk, which he used standing up, remained where it was.

Vinod wiped away the ink line he had drawn on his desk leg.

Gradually the office returned to files, applications, and accounts.

Ramnarayan did not remove the double-folded board beneath the rear leg of his own desk.

Budhan asked once, "Shall I leave this board there?"

Ramnarayan looked at the floor.

"It is a little low here."

Budhan said nothing.

He folded up his bamboo measuring rod and went away.

At the end of the month the annual verification of fixed assets was carried out.

The old entries remained exactly as before—Desk 12, in use; Desk 13, in use; Desk 14, in use.

Height was once again recorded nowhere.

Only one line was added to Budhan's small work slip: "Officer's desk: four sal-wood blocks, two inches each."

The box for the reason was left blank.

That evening Ramnarayan was the last to rise.

The rooms were being locked.

He placed a hand on the corner of his desk and pressed once.

The desk rocked slightly.

The board beneath the rear leg had softened with old dampness.

He opened the drawer, took out two thick old reports, folded the cover of one, and put it where the board had been.

The desk became steady.

As Vinod was leaving, he noticed.

“Has the floor become level now?”

Turning the key, Ramnarayan said, “The floor is exactly the same. Only the method of keeping the desk steady has changed.”

The two crossed the veranda and went outside.

In the darkness within, the desks stood silently at their respective heights.

Everyone’s rank was recorded in the register.

How high each desk stood was no longer anyone’s business.

STORY 252

Red Tape

...

On Monday morning, with the first post at the Madhubani District Rural Works Cell, a yellow envelope arrived. Across its face, in large letters, was written: “Red-Tape Elimination Fortnight—URGENT.” Suman Jha, the clerk opening the post, first read the heading, then looked at the bundle of old files lying to the right of his desk. The bundle was, in fact, tied with red cloth tape.

“Has this come for you or for all of these?” Ramudit, seated beside him, asked with a laugh.

Suman held the envelope out to him. “Read it first. If we decide from the heading alone, the files will become anxious.”

By noon the circular had passed across the desks of the Head Assistant, the Accounts Section, and the officer. It directed that every case pending for more than fifteen days be identified, the reason for delay recorded, unnecessary stages removed, and the maximum possible number of pending matters disposed of before the fortnight ended. One line also stated: “A red strip shall be attached to every pending file identified for review, so that it may be recognised immediately.”

Officer Dinesh Chaudhary underlined that line with a red pencil.

“How much red tape will we need?” he asked.

Storekeeper Jitendra Mishra pushed up his spectacles. “Red tape?”

“For marking the files.”

“There is none in stores.”

“Files used to be tied with red tape.”

“Those old tapes are worn out. Some have turned almost brown.”

Dinesh Babu read the circular again. “We need new tape. Every pending file should be clearly marked.”

Jitendra opened his small register. “How many files?”

No one had an immediate answer. Figures were called for from all sections. By evening the first count came in: Land Section, 312; Irrigation, 486; Housing, 271; Wage Payments, 198; Bridges and Roads, 349; Miscellaneous, 157. Some sections sent back only: “Counting in progress.”

Ramudit added the figures. “One thousand seven hundred and seventy-three so far.”

Jitendra began calculating the tape. "Suppose one and a half cubits per file?"

Suman said, "Are we tying a knot or merely marking it?"

"Without a knot it will slip off."

"Then two cubits."

An old strip was spread across the desk. One person said one and a half cubits would be enough; another insisted on two. In the end they decided to calculate in metres, because if "cubits" were entered in the purchase register, the next inspection might raise questions. An old wooden measuring rule was brought out. The average came to one metre and twenty centimetres per file.

Jitendra multiplied on paper. "At the present count: two thousand one hundred and twenty-eight metres. Add the remaining sections, add breakage, keep ten percent extra—let us requisition three thousand metres."

Dinesh Babu remained silent for a moment. "Three thousand metres of red tape for a Red-Tape Elimination Fortnight?"

Laughter rose in the room.

Jitendra remained serious. "For compliance with the circular."

Even Dinesh Babu could not suppress a smile. "Very well. But purchase it according to the rules."

With that one sentence, a second file was born: "Purchase of Red Cotton Tape for Red-Tape Elimination Fortnight."

The first page stated the requirement. The second contained the calculation. The third gave the estimated cost. The fourth sought approval to obtain quotations from three sellers. The fifth specified the width of the sample tape. Jitendra wrote: "One inch." Accounts returned it with the note: "Specify in millimetres." The tape was measured again. Twenty-five millimetres was entered.

By Tuesday three shops had been selected: Jhunki Cloth Store, Mithila Sewing Materials, and Janak Tape House on Station Road. A messenger carried letters to all three.

That evening Phoolkumari Devi, proprietor of Jhunki Cloth Store, came herself with samples. She held three kinds of red tape: thin cotton, thick cotton, and shiny synthetic.

"It is for tying files," Jitendra said.

Phoolkumari lifted the thin cotton tape. "This one is cheaper, but if the knot is opened repeatedly the edge will fray."

"It needs to last."

"Then this thicker one."

The accounts clerk took the sample in his hand. “Will the colour run?”

Phoolkumari looked at him. “Are you planning to wash the files?”

The room filled with laughter again.

By Wednesday all three quotations had arrived. Phoolkumari’s rate was the lowest, but the shop stamp on her letter was slightly blurred. Jitendra considered sending it back. Suman said, “The stamp is readable. This fortnight is meant to reduce red tape; why spend another day making the stamp darker?”

Jitendra thought for a moment and forwarded the file.

Meanwhile the sections continued counting their pending files. As they counted, several odd facts emerged. Of the 198 Wage Payment files, twenty-seven needed only a date on the payment order. Of the 312 Land files, forty-one already contained the papers that had supposedly been called for. In Irrigation, 103 files had completed site inspections, but the reports had never moved to the next desk.

Suman looked at the bundle in his own section. The red tape had not yet arrived. He opened the first file. It was a community application from Mahendra Paswan of Piprahi for cleaning a small drain beside his field, pending for three weeks. On the reason sheet was written: “Map to be seen.” The map was already attached at the back of the same file.

Suman took out the map, matched it with the next page, wrote his note, and sent the file to the engineer.

Ramudit asked, “Won’t you put red tape on it?”

“By the time the tape arrives, this will no longer be pending.”

The second file was much the same. The third needed one signature. In the fourth, the spelling of the applicant’s name was clear; only a pencilled question mark had caused it to stop. Suman moved nineteen files forward that day.

Word spread to the other sections. Someone joked, “There is one way to escape the red tape—dispose of the file before the tape arrives.” But the joke became a working rule. In three days the number of pending files fell from 1,773 to 1,234.

On Friday Phoolkumari delivered three thousand metres of red tape in thirty large rolls. The red circles were stacked one above another in the veranda. From a distance it looked as though wedding decorations had been unloaded in the office.

Jitendra opened the register and counted the goods. “Thirty rolls. One hundred metres each.”

The accounts clerk asked, “Length verification?”

Phoolkumari raised her eyebrows. “Will you open and measure every roll?”

The rules required sample verification. Three rolls were selected. A distance of twenty-five metres was measured from the veranda into the courtyard and marked at both ends with lime. Four employees stretched out the tape, folded it, stretched it again, and kept measuring. Children gathered near the gate to watch the spectacle.

The first roll measured a full hundred metres. So did the second. The third measured ninety-nine metres and seventy centimetres.

Jitendra's face became grave. "Thirty centimetres short."

Phoolkumari immediately opened the folded inner end of the roll. A little tape had been pressed inside. It was measured again—four centimetres more than a full hundred metres.

"Now?" she asked.

Jitendra wrote: "Sample verification satisfactory."

The goods were accepted.

On Monday the fortnight formally began. But now another problem arose: how much tape should actually be cut? The original calculation of three thousand metres had been based on the old pending-file count. After a week of counting and clearing, only 951 files remained pending. Nearly two thousand metres of tape had become surplus.

Dinesh Babu asked, "Why is so much left over?"

Jitendra showed him the original calculation. "The number was higher when the purchase was made."

"The files have come down. That is good."

"The tape has gone up. That is a stores problem."

On the main day of the fortnight, the pending files from every section were brought into the veranda. Employees cut tape, tied knots, wrote the number of pending days on small slips, and attached them. The sight was peculiar: before a file could be marked for speedy disposal, the tape first had to be cut, measured, knotted, tagged, and entered in the register.

Suman picked up one file and said, "This only needs approval. Shall I send it now?"

Ramudit was holding the tape. "Mark it first, otherwise it will not appear in the fortnight's count."

Suman looked at him. "Why should a disposed file not appear in the count?"

Ramudit folded the tape and put it on the corner of the desk. "Ask that question upstairs."

Dinesh Babu was passing by and stopped when he heard them. “If it can be disposed of now, there is no need to tie tape around it. Do the work first.”

After that small sentence, the pace in the veranda changed. Employees tied red tape around some files and sent others straight onward. By evening the bundle carrying red tape was smaller, but the pile of orders issued was larger. Mahendra Paswan’s approval for cleaning the drain was in that pile.

At the end of the fortnight a report was prepared. It listed the initial number of pending files, the number disposed of, classification by reason, the balance remaining, and the target for the following month. At the end was a box marked “Special Achievement.”

Suman joked, “Write: less red tape used.”

Jitendra did not laugh. Nineteen rolls of red tape remained in his store.

“What do we do with all these?” he asked Dinesh Babu.

“Keep them in stores. They are government material.”

“How long will they remain here?”

“Until they are used.”

“Used where?”

Dinesh Babu paused before answering. “For tying old files?”

The two looked at each other. Then Dinesh Babu burst out laughing. “No. Not for that.”

In the end, the nineteen rolls were placed on the upper shelf of the store. Jitendra wrote a paper label and tied it on: “Red-Tape Elimination Fortnight—Surplus Material.” To fasten the label, he naturally cut off a piece of the same red tape.

Two weeks later Mahendra Paswan came to the office to collect his approval letter. Work on cleaning his drain had already begun. Suman handed him the letter. Mahendra folded it into his angoccha, thanked him, and started out.

As he crossed the veranda, his eyes fell on the open store-room door. Inside, on the upper shelf, the red rolls were arranged in a row. The end of one roll hung down. Jitendra stood on a small stool, pushing it back up.

Mahendra asked, “Babu, what is all that tape for?”

Climbing down from the stool, Jitendra said, “For eliminating red tape.”

Mahendra stood still for a few moments. He thought the clerk was joking. But Jitendra’s face was entirely ordinary.

Mahendra walked out. A gust of wind rose near the gate. Inside, the label tied to the shelf fluttered slightly: “Surplus Material.” Its knot was red.

STORY 253

The Forgotten Order

...

The front gate of the Jaynagar Minor Irrigation Materials Store was wide enough for two bullock carts to pass through side by side. In front of it was a paved ramp, and beyond that the main road. Yet on Tuesday morning a handcart loaded with a thick iron pipe came up to the open gate, stopped, and was then turned around by six labourers and taken toward the rear of the store.

Raghav Mishra, the new storekeeper, watched the scene from the window. "Is the front gate closed?" he asked his assistant, Naresh Kamati. "No. The gate is open." "Then why is the pipe going round to the back?" Naresh raised his head from the register. "There is an order." "What order?" "An old one. Materials are not to enter from the front." Raghav looked again toward the gate. Both leaves stood open. The inner ramp shone with new cement. A bicycle came in easily; the young man delivering the post dismounted and placed a bundle of letters on Naresh's desk. "A person may enter from the front, but a pipe may not?" Raghav asked. Naresh laughed. "A person is not material." The answer was so orderly that Raghav did not immediately ask another question.

It was only his third day after joining the store. During the first two days he had been occupied with old registers, the stock count, and the accounting of keys. Now he began to understand that the logic of the building depended not only on what objects were kept inside it, but also on the route by which those objects entered. At noon he called for the file titled "Entry Arrangement." It was a thin file. The first page contained an order four years old. During Sawan that year, part of the front ramp had subsided. The order stated that during the period of repair all heavy material would enter through the rear gate so that the damaged portion would not bear any load. The last line read: "This arrangement shall remain in force until further orders."

"When was the repair completed?" Raghav asked. Naresh pointed through the window at the shining ramp. "That same year. In three weeks." "And the further order?" Naresh shrugged. "An order cancelling this one had come. But that file has disappeared." Raghav turned the pages again. After the first order there were two inspection notes, a measurement sheet for the ramp repair, and three pages of annual stock verification. There was no copy of the cancellation order. "So all of you know that the order was cancelled?" "Everyone knows." "Yet the old order is still in force?" "There is no paper for the cancellation

order.” For the first time Raghav encountered a situation in which memory was not proof, yet forgetfulness had become the rule.

The next day four brass pump components arrived. The bullock cart reached the front gate. Gatekeeper Ramji Yadav raised a hand and stopped it. “To the back.” The cart driver said, “The road there is muddy.” “There is an order.” “But this ramp is new.” “I know nothing about the ramp. I know the gate.” The bullock cart turned around. The rear route passed along the store wall, beside a pond, and between two houses. After the rains the earth was still soft. One wheel sank. The labourers got down and pushed. Half an hour later the components reached the store.

Raghav called Ramji. “Do you remember the cancellation order?” “Yes, Babu. I was posted here that day too.” “Then why do you stop things at the front gate?” Ramji answered plainly, “The first order is with me in writing. The second is in my memory. Government service does not run on memory.” Raghav did not write that sentence in the file, but it stayed in his mind all day. He called for the dispatch register. On a page from four years earlier he found an entry—No. 47/Bh, subject: “Regarding restoration of normal arrangement for entry of materials.” The date of dispatch, three recipients, and the outgoing letter number were all clearly recorded. “This is proof,” Raghav said.

Accounts Clerk Shashikant Jha lowered his spectacles. “It proves that some letter was sent. The entry does not fully tell us what was written in the letter.” “The subject is written here.” “A subject is not an order.” “So for four years everyone understood the subject, but not the order?” Shashikant smiled. “We understand many things. A file accepts only as much as is written.” Raghav wrote to the district office asking for a copy of letter No. 47/Bh. The reply came five days later: “A search is being made in old correspondence records.” During those five days the mud on the rear road dried. Materials continued to arrive by the same route. For the employees this was normal. Only Raghav paused every time he saw the open front gate. Above it, in blue paint, were the words “MAIN ENTRANCE,” but for heavy objects they had become merely writing.

One evening Bishun Sah, who had brought pipe joints from Darbhanga, came to Raghav with a transport bill. Below the original carriage amount an additional sixty rupees had been written. “What is this?” Raghav asked. “Labour for taking it round the back. The handcart unloaded at the front, then had to be taken round by the pond. Six men were needed.” Shashikant examined the bill. “There is no provision for additional entry labour in the rate schedule.” Bishun Sah said, “There is no provision in the rate schedule for going round the back either.” “Then under what head can this be paid?” “I do not know. The labourers had to be paid.” Raghav looked through the window. From the front gate to the store veranda the distance was no more than fifty

paces. To reach the same place by the rear route, one had to go halfway around the pond, pass through the narrow lane between two houses, and climb an earthen slope. That day the six labourers sat near the veranda catching their breath. Basant Paswan, the oldest among them, wiped beneath his arm with his gamchha and said, "Babu, they said the front route should not bear the load. Now the load falls on us."

Raghav could not immediately arrange payment of the extra sixty rupees. The rate schedule was indeed silent. On the back of the bill he wrote: "Additional carriage due to previous entry arrangement." Shashikant kept it aside because no such expenditure head had existed before. Thus the old order did not merely lengthen the route of carts; it also created a new kind of account for which there was no column. On the sixth day a records assistant arrived from the district. His name was Chandramohan Das. He carried a thin register and a cloth bag. He examined the store's old records list, then said, "The original copy of letter No. 47/Bh will not be found here." "Why?" Raghav asked. "That letter was entered under 'temporary correspondence.' Under the rules, it was weeded out after three years." "You mean destroyed?" "That is what the register says."

He opened the register. Against a group of twelve letters, including No. 47/Bh, one line read: "Retention period completed; weeding approved." Raghav showed him the file containing the original order. "Why has this four-year-old order survived?" Chandramohan looked at the green slip on top of the file. "It was retained as a 'permanent instruction.'" "But it was only for the repair period." "The classification says permanent." "The letter cancelling it was temporary, and the thing it cancelled was permanent?" Chandramohan remained silent for a moment. Then he closed the register. "The life of a record is determined by its classification, not by human intention." No one laughed. Outside, a new supplier had arrived with a small truck. Ramji was gesturing with his hand and explaining the rear route.

That day Raghav wrote out the entire situation and sent it to the current officer, Vibhuti Narayan. His comment returned in the evening: "If a copy of the earlier cancellation is unavailable, submit a draft of a fresh order clarifying the present position." Naresh was pleased. "Now the matter will be resolved." Raghav drafted: "The repair of the front ramp has been completed; therefore heavy materials may also enter through the front main gate. The temporary restriction imposed four years ago shall be treated as ended." Shashikant read it and asked, "Will you mention the number of the previous order?" "Yes." "The number of the cancellation letter?" Raghav looked at him. A smile appeared on Shashikant's lips. "Leave that reference out."

The draft went to the officer. He added one word—"immediately"—and signed it. Three copies of the new order were made: one for the gatekeeper, one for the store, and one for the district office. Ramji read his copy and very carefully placed it over the photocopy of the old order. The next morning the first heavy material entered through the front gate: a thick bundle of twelve bamboo poles. Suraj Paswan, pulling the handcart, came straight up the ramp without stopping. For the first time Ramji did not signal him to go around the back. Suraj laughed. "Has the road become shorter today?" Ramji said, "The road is the same length. The order has become shorter." Raghav heard this from the veranda. He felt like laughing, but did not.

At noon Naresh went to the rear gate. A wooden sign had hung there for four years: "ENTRY OF HEAVY MATERIALS THIS WAY." After the new order it was no longer needed. Naresh took it down and brought it inside. "What shall I do with this?" he asked Raghav. "Put it in stores." "Under what category?" Before Raghav could answer, Shashikant said, "Permanent material." Naresh carried the sign inside. A little later he returned and placed a small paper on Raghav's desk. It was a new entry in the stores register: "One wooden direction board, relating to previous entry arrangement, use ended, retained in custody." Raghav read the line. A long strip of sunlight was entering through the front gate. There was no cart at the rear gate now. He picked up his pen and signed against the entry.

STORY 254

The Government Umbrella

...

There was only one umbrella in the store of the Jhanjharpur Road Maintenance Subdivision, but it had a register of its own. On the first page, in blue ink, was written: "Departmental Umbrella No. 38." Against it were the year of purchase, price—four hundred and eighty rupees—black cloth, metal shaft, wooden handle. The last column was headed "Condition." Year after year the same word had been entered there: "Serviceable."

On the third day after taking charge, the new storekeeper, Gopal Thakur, examined the umbrella. It lay on the top shelf of the iron cupboard inside a white cloth cover. From the handle hung a small brass plate marked "38." As he opened the cover, Sahdev Paswan, the office attendant, said, "Carefully, Babu. Two of its ribs are new." Gopal opened the umbrella. Two of the twelve ribs shone more brightly than the other ten. There were three round patches on the cloth. The handle had fresh polish. Two small red marks showed on the central shaft.

"Is this umbrella in use or under repair?" Gopal asked. Sahdev laughed. "Both."

Gopal's curiosity increased when he examined the old store accounts. In the first year: stitching of cloth—one hundred and twenty. In the second: two ribs—two hundred and ten. Then repair of handle—one hundred and seventy. Later, removal of rust after it was soaked in the rains—three hundred and twenty. Once, when the brass number plate went missing, a new one was made—two hundred and sixty-five. The previous year, when the ring used to open the umbrella jammed, an inspection came from the district store; travel and repair together cost seven hundred and twenty.

Gopal began adding. All the small and large items over four years came to four thousand nine hundred and sixty rupees. He looked again at the first page—original price, four hundred and eighty. "Is this account wrong?" Sahdev turned the register toward himself and looked. "No. The previous storekeeper added it three times." "Ten times the price of the umbrella spent on it?" "The umbrella is old. The accounts keep becoming new."

That afternoon Junior Engineer Shashibhushan Rai was about to leave for a field inspection. The sky outside was grey. Sahdev took out the departmental umbrella and placed it in the veranda. Shashibhushan stopped when he saw it.

“You expect me to take this in today’s rain?” “Yes.” “Last time it turned inside out in the wind, didn’t it?” “Two ribs were replaced after that.” Shashibhushan looked outside. Drops had begun to fall. He took a small folding umbrella from his own bag. “Leave the government umbrella here. Mine will do.”

Gopal asked, “Then who is the departmental umbrella for?” Shashibhushan replied casually, “For field inspections. But today the wind is too strong.” Sahdev put the umbrella back in its cover.

During the first week of the rains, an old carpenter who did work for the store, Nathuni Sah, came in. Gopal showed him the umbrella. Nathuni first pressed the ribs, then held the cloth up to the light and counted the three patches. “What would a new umbrella like this cost today?” Gopal asked. “Five hundred and fifty to six hundred.” “And this old one?” “It is old now. But the ribs are strong.”

Gopal did not show him the total in the register. He only asked, “What value would you put on an umbrella repaired for four thousand rupees?” Nathuni Sah burst out laughing. “The price of a repair does not live inside the umbrella, Babu. What was broken has been joined again, that is all.” Sahdev, standing nearby, said, “Everything lives in the register.” Whether Nathuni understood the remark or not was unclear. He picked up his bag of tools and moved on to another job.

Gopal ran a hand over the umbrella’s handle. The polish was smooth, but the old grain of the wood could still be seen beneath it.

Two days later Lakshminarayan Mahato, an assistant from the district store, arrived for physical verification. His rule was simple: whatever existed in the register had to be seen with the eye, its number read, and its usability recorded. Umbrella No. 38 was placed before him. Lakshminarayan opened and closed it three times. Then he held it over his head and walked as far as the veranda. Rain was falling outside, but he did not cross the threshold.

“Serviceable,” he said. Gopal asked, “Its value?” “Whatever is in the register.” “Current value?” Lakshminarayan shook his head. “I inspect condition, not the market.” “Repairs have cost ten times the original price.” “Then write that in the repair column.” “Does that change the condition?” “Does the umbrella open?” “Yes.” “Then serviceable.”

He made a small verification mark in red pencil. The umbrella went back into its white cover. For the first time, it became clear to Gopal that the body of an object and its accounts could live two separate lives.

A week later a letter came from the district office for the annual physical verification. The number, condition, and maintenance expenditure of every movable asset had to be reported. Against No. 38, Gopal wrote original value:

four hundred and eighty rupees; cumulative repairs: four thousand nine hundred and sixty. The paper went upward. Three days later it came back with a red-pencil circle: "Maintenance expenditure excessive. Clarify reasons."

Gopal opened the register again to search for reasons. Items that had looked small when scattered across separate years became absurd when added into a single line. He called Sahdev. "When was the first repair?" "In the second month after purchase." "Two months after purchase?" "The first time it went toward Madhepur for an inspection, a rib bent in the wind." "Why wasn't a new umbrella bought then?" "Why a new one? This one was new." "The second rib?" "The next year." "The polish?" "The wood in the handle had begun to crack. An inspection note said departmental material should receive proper maintenance."

Gopal wrote as the reason: "Necessary repairs from time to time." Then he read it and crossed it out. It seemed merely to repeat the question.

He examined the older files. Along with the original purchase bill he found a short note: "For the convenience of field staff during monsoon inspections." After that, every paper concerned the health of the umbrella, not the field staff.

The next morning Accounts Assistant Prabhakar Jha came in. Gopal showed him the figures. Prabhakar lowered his spectacles on his nose. "The problem is not that the expenditure became ten times the price," he said. "The problem is that it was all on the same item." "If it had been spent on different umbrellas?" "Then there would have been different serial numbers." "And the total expenditure?" "If the total were the same, the question would have taken a different form."

Gopal looked at Prabhakar's face for a few moments. Then he asked, "The solution?" Prabhakar closed the register. "Prevent further damage."

That short sentence had an immediate effect. New rules were made for the umbrella: it was not to be used in strong wind; after prolonged rain it must be fully dried before storage; if splashed with mud, it must be wiped with a damp cloth; it must not be leaned against a wall with the handle downward; it could not leave the store without an entry. Sahdev read the rules and said, "The umbrella will be saved." Gopal asked, "And the people?" Sahdev smiled. "People will carry their own umbrellas."

On the second day after the rules came into force, something happened. The Subdivisional Officer himself was going out to the field. It had rained throughout the night; the roadside near the Kamla Balan had subsided. The officer's vehicle stood at the gate. Sahdev brought the departmental umbrella to the veranda. At that exact moment a strong gust of wind came and the cloth fluttered.

From inside the store Gopal called, "Use is prohibited in strong wind." Sahdev's hand stopped. The officer looked at Gopal. "By whose order is this restriction?" "Maintenance instructions issued after the district remarks." The officer looked at the half-open umbrella for a moment. Then he said, "All right. Close it." Sahdev closed the umbrella. The officer ran to the vehicle. Within five paces his kurta was wet.

When he returned at noon, his first question was, "Is the umbrella safe?" Sahdev said, "Yes. Completely dry." Gopal could not tell whether the officer laughed. He had had to go home to change his clothes.

At the end of the month the district replied: "Excessive maintenance expenditure shall be controlled in future. Measures shall be adopted to extend the useful life of the material." This time Gopal did not open a separate file. He called Suresh Mandal, the store carpenter. Two wooden pegs were fitted to the wall beside the cupboard so that the umbrella could hang without putting weight on the ribs. An extra layer of old cotton cloth was added inside the white cover so that the metal would not rub against the wall. Total expenditure: one hundred and sixty rupees.

Prabhakar saw the bill and asked, "Under what head is this?" Gopal said, "Measures to extend useful life." Prabhakar said nothing. The bill was passed.

The rains intensified. The unpaved ground in front of the office remained full of splashing water all day. Employees came and went with their own umbrellas, plastic sheets, or gamchhas. No. 38 hung straight on the wall. Because its black cloth now became wet only rarely, some of its shine returned.

One day Sahdev's own umbrella tore midway on the road. At noon he had to carry an official letter to the post office. Outside, rain was pouring. He stood on the store threshold and looked at the departmental umbrella. Gopal was there too. Their eyes met once.

"Take it," Gopal said. Sahdev reached out, then stopped. "The wind is strong." "Today it is a little less." "Its outside use will have to be entered in the register." "We will enter it." Sahdev looked at the umbrella again. Beneath the black cloth the brass 38 was shining. In the end he picked up his own torn umbrella. "The post office is not very far."

He went out into the rain. One side of his umbrella drooped low. Gopal walked over to the wall. The cover of the government umbrella had slipped slightly. He pulled it up and straightened it. Then he opened the register and wrote in the "Condition" column for No. 38: "Serviceable, safe." Outside, Sahdev's figure slowly disappeared behind the curtain of rain. Inside the store, the umbrella remained dry.

STORY 255

Attendance

...

The iron gate of the Benipatti Cooperative Extension Office opened every day at 9:45 in the morning. Opening it was the duty of attendant Naresh Paswan. He first swept the veranda and then placed a thick blue-bound register on the Head Clerk's desk. On its cover, in white letters, was written: "Employee Attendance."

There were seventeen employees in the office. Work was officially considered to begin at ten, but by old custom people continued arriving until 10:20, 10:25, sometimes even 10:40. One blamed the bus, another a bullock that had held him up on a field embankment, another a delay in the children's breakfast. Head Clerk Ramsharan Jha, after years of hearing everyone's reasons, had acquired a special skill—the skill of hearing nothing.

On the third day after the new Block Cooperative Officer, Amarnath Thakur, arrived, he called for the register at 10:05. Thirteen signatures were there; four lines were blank. He drew a straight line in red pencil before the empty lines.

At 10:30 Shambhunath Mishra arrived. When he did not find the register, he asked Naresh, "Where has it gone?" "To Sahib." "And now the signature?" "After the red line." Shambhunath's expression changed. "How does one sign after a red line?" Naresh shrugged. "I open the gate, not the rules."

The four late employees were not docked half a day that time, but all were asked for written explanations. The next day, by 9:55, sixteen employees had signed. The office had never looked so alert before.

At 10:10 Amarnath Thakur came out to inspect the sections. In Accounts, two of four chairs were empty. In the Loans Section, only one of three people was present. In Records, bags sat on two chairs, but the people were missing. "Everyone signed?" he asked Ramsharan. "Yes, almost everyone." "Then where are they?" Ramsharan thought for a moment. "Someone may have gone for tea, someone to fetch papers, someone outside with a visitor." Amarnath said, "Attendance is required in the office, not merely in the register." By afternoon that sentence had reached every section.

The following week a new arrangement appeared. After signing, people left something or other on their chairs. Shambhunath hung his gamchha over the chair-back. Accounts Assistant Vimla Devi left her cloth bag under the desk.

Store Clerk Suresh Mandal left a half-filled lota on his table. With such objects present, an empty chair did not look quite empty.

One day at 10:30 Amarnath inspected again. In one room five chairs held five different objects—a gamchha, an umbrella, a bag, a lunchbox, and an old pair of slippers. Only two people were there. He asked, “Are these employees or materials?” No one answered.

The next day a notice appeared: “Personal articles left on chairs shall not be treated as proof of attendance.” Ramsharan said quietly, “Now the question of proof has arisen.” Shambhunath laughed. “The register is the proof.” “Sahib says the register is not enough.” “Then why have a register?” No one in the office had a direct answer.

The employees’ difficulty was not entirely invented. Three of them often had to inspect PACS godowns, two brought loan statements from banks, and one clerk made rounds of the post office and treasury. If someone went straight to the field, he could not sign the register. If he came to the office first to sign, the field might lie in the opposite direction.

One day Vimla Devi said, “Rahika PACS is closer to my house, but for attendance I must first come to Benipatti and then turn back toward Rahika—two hours merely on the road.” Ramsharan prepared a note on this practical difficulty and sent it to Amarnath. Amarnath wrote: “Employees proceeding on field duty shall inform the Head Clerk before departure.”

Instead of decreasing, the problem grew. How was the information to be given? The Head Clerk himself arrived by bus in the morning. Shambhunath proposed, “If the register meets us on the road, both purposes will be served together.” Ramsharan laughed, but the idea did not die there.

Half a kos east of the office was an old pipal-tree crossing. Three employees coming from the Madhubani side got off the bus there. Two came by bicycle along the same route. The road from Rahika also met there. Naresh’s house was on that side too.

One Monday Naresh reached the office at 9:20 and Ramsharan said, “The register remained with me from yesterday. I took it home to total the month. You pass by the tea shop, don’t you?” “Yes.” “Tomorrow morning collect the register from my house. Shambhunath will meet you at the pipal crossing. He is going to the field; let him sign, then bring it straight here.”

It was meant to be an arrangement for one day. But the next morning Vimla too met Shambhunath at the pipal crossing because she was going to Rahika PACS. She signed as well. When a third employee, Suresh, got off the bus, Naresh opened the register for him. Three signatures in ten minutes.

The register reached the office at 9:55. All three employees had gone on to their field assignments. Amarnath looked at the register—three punctual signatures, and field work also underway. The arrangement seemed successful.

Two days later Accounts Assistant Harikishore told Naresh, “My bus stops at the same crossing. Hold the register there for five minutes.” “I have to reach the office.” “One minute.” One minute gradually became five. The old pipal crossing became the attendance register’s first halt.

Then a second halt developed at the Dak Bungalow crossing. Ramvilas Yadav came that way by bicycle. Naresh left the pipal crossing at 9:35 and reached the Dak Bungalow crossing at 9:40. Ramvilas bent over the register and signed, then turned his bicycle toward the market to buy vegetables and send them home with someone.

A third halt formed near the old pond. Sumitra Devi’s rickshaw reached there. She would sign and say, “I’ll be in the office in five minutes.” Five minutes sometimes became fifteen because she bought milk on the way.

Naresh’s route became as fixed as the hands of a clock: 9:20—Ramsharan’s house; 9:25—the old pipal crossing; 9:40—the Dak Bungalow crossing; 9:45—the old pond; 9:55—the office.

There was one difficulty in this arrangement. The register was thick, and its corners bent when carried on the rear carrier of the bicycle. Naresh cut an old fertiliser sack and made a cover for it. When the rains came, he added waxed cloth on top. The register’s journey became safer than the employees’ journeys.

At first Ramsharan regarded the arrangement as temporary. But at the end of the month he examined the register and found only two late signatures. Earlier there used to be twenty or twenty-two. He was surprised. Amarnath too was pleased. “There has been improvement.” Ramsharan merely said, “Yes.”

That afternoon Naresh asked, “Should Sahib be told the route the register takes?” Ramsharan pushed his spectacles upward. “Sahib has seen the result. He has not asked for a description of the route.”

The system now began to grow under its own power. Employees whose homes lay away from the register’s route began adjusting their time to meet it. Someone got off the morning bus at the pipal crossing and waited for Naresh; another stopped his bicycle at the Dak Bungalow crossing. Everyone’s clock began matching the register’s clock, not the office clock.

After a few days something strange happened. A person who had earlier reached the office at 10:15 could now sign the register at 9:25, leisurely finish a small errand in the market, talk to someone for a while, and still reach the office at 10:15. The time in the register improved. The time of the chairs remained the same.

One day Amarnath again went out to inspect the sections. It was 10:05. The register contained sixteen signatures. Including Naresh, only seven people were in the office. “The rest?” Ramsharan replied, “Some in the field, some on the way.” “All have signed?” “Yes.” Amarnath looked at the register. Every time was between 9:25 and 9:55. He studied the page for a few moments. “Attendance has become very good.” Ramsharan tried to discover the meaning of the sentence, but Amarnath closed the register.

Then fear of inspection arose. News came from the district that attendance might be checked on any day. The employees held a meeting. Shambhunath said, “The register is fine, but what about the chairs?” Vimla Devi said, “On inspection day everyone should arrive on time.” Someone asked, “Which day will be inspection day?” That was the main problem.

Ramvilas suggested that when Naresh set out with the register, he should inform everyone if he saw a district vehicle. Naresh became annoyed. “Should I deliver the register or guard the road?” The matter stopped there.

One morning in Magh there was dense fog. Naresh’s bicycle bell could be heard ten handspans ahead, though the rider himself could not be seen. He collected the blue register from Ramsharan’s house, tied it in the cloth cover, and set off. At the pipal crossing five employees were already waiting. All signed quickly. Ramvilas was not at the Dak Bungalow crossing; his son said, “Father will be here in five minutes.” Naresh did not wait. Bringing the register on time had now become a matter of his own prestige.

Near the old pond Sumitra Devi appeared late through the fog. She ran up, placed the register on the bicycle seat, and signed. Naresh looked at the time—9:49. He pedalled fast. The office gate opened at 9:55. Naresh did not even sweep the veranda; first he placed the register on Ramsharan’s desk.

At that exact moment a white vehicle stopped at the gate. An Inspection Assistant from the District Cooperative Office got out with two employees. “Attendance register,” he said the moment he entered.

Naresh placed the blue register before him. The Inspection Assistant turned the page. Sixteen signatures were there. Ramvilas’s line was blank. The clock showed 10:02. He said approvingly, “Discipline is good.” Then he looked up. The veranda was empty. Of the four chairs in Accounts, one held Vimla Devi’s bag, but Vimla herself had not yet reached the gate. In the Loans Section only Ramsharan sat wiping his spectacles. The store key was tied at Naresh’s waist.

The Inspection Assistant asked, “Where are the people?” Ramsharan said, “They must be coming.” “But the signatures?” Ramsharan looked at Naresh. The lower part of Naresh’s trousers was wet with the moisture of the fog. An empty cover made from a fertiliser sack was tied to the bicycle carrier.

For a few moments no one spoke. Outside, three employees could be seen approaching slowly from the direction of the pipal crossing. The Inspection Assistant closed the register. "This will be discussed separately." He walked toward Amarnath's room.

For two weeks the morning journey of the register stopped. Employees again came directly to the office. During the first three days there were five, then four, then six signatures after the red line. Complaints resumed—bus, field, godown, bank, distance from home.

At the end of the month Amarnath issued no new order. He simply placed the register in Naresh's charge and said, "This will not leave the office." Naresh said, "Yes."

The next day he opened the gate at 9:45, swept the veranda, and placed the register on the desk. By 9:55 three employees had arrived. At ten there were seven signatures. A week later people again began adjusting their schedules. Some ran in at 9:55, others exactly at ten. The register continued to reach the desk regularly at 9:45.

One morning in Phagun Ramsharan arrived a little early. All the office rooms were still closed. Naresh was opening the gate. The blue register was already on the desk.

Ramsharan asked, "When did this arrive?" Naresh said, "With me. At 9:45." Ramsharan looked out through the window. There was no sign of any employee on the road. He ran a hand over the blue cover of the register.

There had been a time when the attendance of the people in the office depended on the register. Now the only thing one could rely on to reach the office on time was the register itself.

Naresh picked up the broom and went toward the veranda. The clock showed 9:56. On the desk, the attendance register was regularly present in its proper place.

STORY 256

Photo Identification

...

When new identity cards were introduced at the Jhanjharpur Minor Irrigation Division office, Ramkishun, who sat at the gate, had the greatest difficulty. He had been guarding the place for twenty years. How fast a person walked, whose cough could be recognised from a distance, how many times whose bicycle bell rang—such signs were enough for Ramkishun to identify everyone in the office. But an order came from the district that entry would be allowed only after a photo identity card had been shown.

In red letters the order said: “Look at the proof, not the person.” Ramkishun read the sentence twice. The third time Head Clerk Shashibhushan Babu read it aloud to him.

“So now you will stop even me if I come without an identity card?” Accounts Assistant Bhola Jha asked with a laugh.

Ramkishun said, “That is what the order says.”

“You have been seeing my face for twenty years.”

“The face is not mentioned in the order.”

During the first week, all the employees came enthusiastically with their identity cards hanging from their necks. A blue strip bore the department's name, a photograph occupied the middle, and below it were the name and designation. Some photographs were so old that hair now half white was black in the picture; someone's spectacles had changed; someone had had a moustache then and no longer did. Ramkishun looked at both the identity card and the person. If the person was familiar but the photograph seemed wrong, he trusted the person. Yet the sentence in the order remained stuck in his head—look at the proof, not the person.

One Monday Bhola Jha forgot his identity card at home. There were two files in the front basket of his bicycle and a bag of vegetables on the rear carrier. Ramkishun recognised him from far away, yet lowered the bamboo barrier in front of him.

“What happened?” Bhola Jha asked.

“Identity card?”

Bhola Jha touched his neck. Empty. “It is at home. Don't you recognise me?”

“I do.”

“Then how do I go inside?”

Ramkishun showed him the copy of the order.

Bhola Jha looked toward the veranda inside, laughing at first, but Ramkishun did not lift the barrier. “My desk is inside, my files are inside, my salary comes from this office.”

“All correct. But the identity card is outside.”

Bhola Jha stood near the gate for half an hour. In the end his son brought the card by bicycle from home. Ramkishun looked at the card, read the name, examined the photograph, and only then lifted the barrier. As he went inside Bhola Jha said, “Today you introduced me to myself all over again.”

After that incident the status of the identity card rose in the office. Employees bought transparent covers. Someone changed the neck strap, someone had a new photograph taken. Shashibhushan Babu wanted the letters of his name printed larger because on the old card he needed spectacles to read them. But the printing agency said the layout had been fixed by the district.

A small new economy grew around the identity card. In the morning, queues of employees could be seen at photographers’ shops in the market. Some wanted to replace old photographs, some wanted stronger straps for hanging the card around the neck. A transparent cover cost five rupees, a blue strap twelve, a strong clasp twenty. Vimla Devi from Accounts said that protecting the identity card was costing more than the identity card itself. Bhola Jha replied, “Identity is hardly protected cheaply.”

One day Junior Assistant Raghunath’s identity card became wet in the rain. One corner of the photograph blurred. When he reached the gate, Ramkishun first looked at Raghunath and then at the identity card. Raghunath himself said, “You recognise me, but recognise the identity card too.” They both laughed. Until then the rule was still a joke, not a difficulty.

As a precaution, the Head Clerk also had an entry register placed at the gate. The names of outsiders, their time of arrival, and whom they were going to meet were all to be written down. For employees, however, the identity card was considered sufficient. No one objected to this distinction because everyone assumed that Ramkishun already knew the people who belonged to the office. Paper was supposed to be for outsiders. The sentence “Look at the proof, not the person” was slowly becoming the gate’s new habit.

Two weeks later, on a Wednesday morning, an unfamiliar young man came to the gate. He carried a cloth bag in one hand, a thin bamboo rod under his arm, and a shining identity card around his neck. The card showed his photograph; above it, in bold letters, was written “Technical Service,” and

below, “Divisional Maintenance Assistant.” In one corner there was also a round blue mark.

Ramkishun took the card in his hand and examined it. The transparent cover was new, the photograph clear, the letters glossy. The young man gave his name as Mahendra.

“Whom are you going to see?”

“I have orders to inspect the fans and lights.”

Ramkishun looked at the card again. It said “Technical Service.” Fans and lights were technical things. He lifted the barrier.

Mahendra went inside. First he inspected the veranda fan, then the bulb in Accounts, then stood by the window of the engineer’s room and measured something. No one stopped him. The shining identity card around his neck was enough for everyone to assume that he belonged there for work.

Even Gopal the tea seller handed him a cup without asking. After two sips Mahendra said, “The wiring overhead is very old.”

Gopal became serious. “I have been saying that all along.”

By noon Mahendra reached the door of the store room. Storekeeper Navalkishore asked, “Whose orders?”

Mahendra showed the identity card.

As soon as he saw it, Navalkishore opened the register. “Write your name.”

Mahendra wrote his name. He went inside, measured two old fans, looked at a bundle of wire, and came out again.

At that moment Assistant Engineer Devkinandan Mishra arrived. Bhola Jha was sitting at the gate because Ramkishun had gone to eat. Devkinandan saw Mahendra coming out.

“Who is this?”

Bhola Jha said, “Technical Service. He has an identity card.”

Devkinandan stopped. “I have not called any technical service.”

Mahendra stopped walking. He turned and said, “I was sent from an electrical-goods shop in the market.”

“Which shop?”

“Shiv Shakti Electrical Goods.”

Devkinandan raised his eyebrows. “The owner of that shop was supposed to give me a quotation tomorrow. Are you a departmental employee?”

Mahendra took the identity card hanging from his neck into his hand. “Not an employee. I do service work.”

“Then how was the identity card made?”

Mahendra hesitated slightly. "A printer in the market made it. It took too long to get inside government offices. Everywhere they ask for papers. So I had an identity card made."

Bhola Jha took the card in his hand. Seen closely, the blue round mark was not a departmental seal at all but a small picture of a fan. Above "Technical Service" there was no department name. The card was merely glossy.

When Ramkishun returned from his meal, a small assembly had formed in the veranda: the Head Clerk, the engineer, the storekeeper, Bhola Jha, and Mahendra. The moment Ramkishun arrived, Shashibhushan Babu asked, "How did you let this young man inside?"

Ramkishun answered simply, "He showed a photo identity card."

"But this is not the department's identity card."

"The order given to me said to look at the identity card. No sample of the department's card was given to me."

Shashibhushan Babu fell silent. It was true: there was no specimen identity card at the gate. There was only a copy of the order.

Mahendra did not seem frightened. He said, "I have taken nothing. I measured two fans. I will submit a quotation. If you do not want it, do not take it."

Navalkishore immediately checked the store register. Not a single item was missing. Devkinandan examined Mahendra's bag—measuring tape, screwdriver, two pliers, papers, and a cotton gamchha.

Nothing had been removed, but the irony was clear: the fake identity card had proved more effective than real familiarity.

That evening the Head Clerk drafted four new instructions. First—only identity cards issued by the department would be valid. Second—specimens of all valid identity cards would be kept at the gate. Third—outside service personnel would receive a separate entry slip. Fourth—Ramkishun would compare the person's face with the identity card as well.

Ramkishun read the fourth point and asked, "What if the face and the photograph do not match?"

"Then no entry."

The next morning Bhola Jha was the first to arrive. This time the identity card was hanging from his neck. Ramkishun stopped him at the barrier, took the card, looked at the photograph, and then at Bhola Jha's face. The card was five years old. In the photograph Bhola Jha had a thick moustache; now he was clean-shaven. In the photograph he wore no spectacles; now he had thick-framed glasses. The hair on his head had also thinned by half.

Ramkishun kept comparing the two for a long time.

Bhola Jha became impatient. “Now what?”

“The photograph does not match.”

“The identity card is mine, the name is mine, I am the employee.”

“But the new instruction says I must match the face.”

Bhola Jha did not laugh. He looked at his own old photograph on the card and then at Ramkishun.

“Then what should I do?”

Ramkishun looked toward the new instructions pasted on the wall inside the office the previous day. “You will have to submit a new photograph.”

Bhola Jha stood outside the gate beside his bicycle. Inside were his desk, his files, the salary register, and twenty years of service. Around his neck hung the department’s genuine identity card. But the photograph inside it belonged to a man five years younger.

At that very moment, across the road, Mahendra removed his shiny fake identity card from his neck, put it into his bag, and walked toward Shiv Shakti Electrical Goods. Ramkishun looked at him, then looked at Bhola Jha’s identity card. The new instruction was clear. He did not lift the barrier.

STORY 257

The Welcome Gate

...

In the Phulparas Block compound, the Citizen Service Centre had once been difficult to find. It occupied a small service window between four rooms at the back of the old building. Above it, a board painted blue with the words "Citizen Service Centre" had half peeled away. Visitors entering from outside usually reached Accounts first, were sent from there to Nazarat, then wandered past the Treasury veranda before finally reaching the Centre.

Ramudgar Paswan, the Centre's sole assistant, had grown accustomed to this wandering. Someone would arrive panting and ask, "Is this the Citizen Service Centre?" He would open the window and say, "Yes. You have reached it now."

One Monday a letter arrived from the district under the "Citizen-Friendly Campus Improvement Scheme." It directed that entry access, directional signs, shaded seating, and reception arrangements be strengthened. A special grant of two lakh eighty-four thousand rupees had been sanctioned. The money could be spent only on improving external access; it could not be used to increase staff or for service materials inside.

Block Development Officer Shashikant Jha called a meeting. The Head Clerk, engineer, accountant, Ramudgar, and a representative of the construction workers sat together. The engineer opened a drawing: beside the main gate, a twenty-two-hand-wide arch; brick pillars on both sides; an iron frame above; in bold letters across the middle, "YOU ARE WELCOME," and below it, "Citizen Service Centre—Straight Ahead." Simple designs of makhana leaves and fish would be made on both pillars. Two lamps would be fitted for the night.

Ramudgar looked at the drawing and asked, "Will the board above the service window inside be replaced too?"

The engineer turned the paper over. "This head is for external access improvement."

"The latch on the window jams."

"That will come under repairs."

"Is there money under that head?"

The accountant laughed. "Not at present."

For two weeks the main gate was crowded with bricks, sand, bamboo, and tins of paint. Citizens entered from the side. Ramudgar's service window remained open. Sixty to seventy applications came each day—housing assistance, old-age pension, income certificates, caste certificates, family benefits, corrections in birth registration. He issued receipts, counted papers, separated incomplete documents, and arranged the files in order until evening.

As the welcome gate took shape, discussion of it grew throughout the office. The pillars were first to be painted light yellow, but then a telephone call came from the district office saying that the standard colour for Citizen-Friendly buildings would be a mixed ochre-yellow. The second colour was painted over the first. The letters of "YOU ARE WELCOME" were first white, then given black edging. One day the curve of one letter looked crooked, so the entire word was painted again.

Inside, Ramudgar kept the service-window latch moving with oil. Outside, the arch grew brighter day by day.

The inauguration was fixed for the first Thursday of the month. An order was issued that the campus should be clean, the main approach kept clear, a welcome register maintained, and a representative of the Citizen Service Centre posted at the gate to guide visitors. The Head Clerk told Ramudgar, "You know the Centre and understand all the schemes, so you stay at the gate."

Ramudgar asked, "Then at the service window?"

"The inauguration is only for one day."

He agreed.

On Thursday morning the welcome gate was decorated with marigold garlands. Two brass plates held rice grains and flowers. Block employees arrived early in clean clothes. The chief guest cut the ribbon, stood beneath the arch for photographs, said, "Respect for the citizen begins at the first door of the office," and moved forward. Inside, the service window remained closed because Ramudgar was at the gate directing guests.

By noon the programme ended. As Ramudgar was about to return inside, the Head Clerk handed him a new paper. The district had ordered a month-long "welcome monitoring" exercise. One person would remain at the gate, recording the visitor's name, village, purpose of visit, and the directional assistance provided. The number would be sent at the end of each day.

"Who will sit there?" Ramudgar asked.

The Head Clerk said, "There is no additional person at present. You manage it for one month. We will see later."

Ramudgar looked toward the service window. A half-day's queue of applicants had formed there.

From the next day the welcome arrangement became regular. Ramudgar sat beneath the gate at a small table with the register open. People no longer had to search for the Citizen Service Centre. The arch could be seen from far away. A visitor arrived, Ramudgar asked the name, wrote the village, filled in the purpose column, and pointed toward the inner veranda. "Go straight, then turn right."

Five minutes later the same person would return.

"The service window is closed."

Ramudgar would say, "I am on reception duty here."

"Then who will take the application?"

"Sit for a while. If the crowd decreases, I will go inside."

The crowd did not decrease. The more people went in, found the service window closed, and returned, the more questions accumulated at Ramudgar's table. The number in the welcome register rose rapidly.

On the third day, Ramkali Devi of Mahindwar arrived at eleven. She needed the name of a bank branch corrected in her widow-pension application. The sun was strong; a red gamchha covered her head. She read the arch and was pleased: "YOU ARE WELCOME." Ramudgar wrote her name, examined her papers, and sent her inside.

A little later she returned. "The window is closed."

"Sit down, Mother. I will go in after a while."

"I left home at seven in the morning."

Ramudgar half rose from his chair. At that moment the Head Clerk called from the veranda, "Ramudgar! Do not leave the gate unattended. Someone from the district may come to inspect."

He sat down again. Ramkali Devi remained seated on the new bench placed in the shade.

At noon Ramudgar ran inside for five minutes. He opened the service window and took three applications. Then a whistle sounded from the gate. The Block Development Officer's vehicle was entering. Ramudgar shut the window and ran back. The vehicle passed beneath the arch. The officer lowered the window and asked, "Is the welcome register being maintained?"

"Yes, Sir."

"How many?"

"One hundred and thirty-seven so far."

The officer nodded with satisfaction. "Good. People should feel that the facility is useful." The vehicle moved on.

Ramudgar looked at the register. Ramkali Devi's name had been entered twice—once on arrival, and again when she returned with the question about the closed service window and the assisting employee had asked her name again. He wanted to strike out the second entry, then remembered the instruction: "Visitors reaching the gate shall be recorded." Ramkali Devi had in fact reached the gate a second time. He left the entry as it was.

At the end of the first week the first review of the welcome gate was held. The figures were encouraging. Earlier the Citizen Service Centre had been estimated to receive an average of sixty citizens a day; now the welcome register contained between one hundred and seventy and two hundred names daily. The Head Clerk said, "Access has increased since the gate was built."

Ramudgar said quietly, "Many names are being entered again and again."

The accountant asked, "Do the instructions say that one person's name may be written only once?"

"They do not."

"Then the figures have been prepared according to the rules."

The application register inside the service window was then examined. Where fifty to sixty receipts had earlier been entered each day, there were now five, seven, sometimes ten. The Head Clerk scratched his head. "This figure has not been asked for in the review report."

So only the visitor count went into the welcome report.

On the tenth day a two-member team came from the district. The team first measured the width of the arch, checked the paint, read the directional lettering, checked whether the lamps were switched off during the day, and measured the distance of the benches. Looking at Ramudgar's register, one member said, "Footfall is good."

Ramkali Devi had come again that day. Her application had still not been submitted. She went up to one of the team members. "Babu, the window inside stays closed."

The member looked at Ramudgar. "Why?"

Ramudgar answered, "I remain on welcome duty."

"Another employee?"

The Head Clerk said, "Only one post is sanctioned."

The team remained silent for a while. Then one member wrote a comment: "Reception arrangement active; reconsideration of internal human-resource deployment required."

Ramkali Devi asked, "My application?"

The member smiled. "Submit it at the Centre."

She went inside. The service window was closed.

On the last day of the month, the total in the welcome register reached four thousand two hundred and thirteen. The district sent praise saying that citizen footfall at the Centre had increased significantly. The Block Development Officer ordered that the welcome arrangement continue for a second month. The proposal for an additional employee was kept for consideration “at an appropriate opportunity.”

That evening Ramudgar was closing the register. Ramkali Devi had come for the fourth time that week. This time she asked nothing. She crossed the gate and sat directly on the new bench. Her folded application was in her hand.

Ramudgar looked toward the service window inside, then at the welcome register spread before him. The evening light was fading. At the appointed time, both lamps on the arch came on. Above him, the words “YOU ARE WELCOME” shone in white letters.

Ramudgar placed his pen on the next blank line in the register. Ramkali Devi’s name was about to be written for the fifth time that month.

STORY 258

Annual Report

...

In the last week of Chait, the rear veranda of the Madhubani District Rural Construction Division was at its busiest. The bustle was not of bricks, sand, or stone chips, but of paper. Three tables had been joined in the middle. On one side lay bound copies of the previous year's annual report, on another the files of the current year's schemes, and on the third envelopes of photographs. On the wall above, the final line of the calendar had a red circle drawn around 31 March.

Head Clerk Harimohan Mishra would say as early as half past nine in the morning, "This time the report will not cross the deadline. Whatever state the work may be in, the report will go on time."

Accounts Assistant Bindeshwar Mandal had laughed at that sentence on the first day. By the third day he understood that it was not a joke but the office's principal objective. The district had ordered every division to send its annual statement of achievements in printed form by five in the evening on 31 March. Any delay would bring a separate call for explanation.

That year the division was responsible for twenty-seven schemes: five rural roads, six small culverts, eight community buildings, four drains, and four market sheds. Twenty-seven on paper. On the ground, the situation was different. Three roads were complete, two unfinished. Two culverts were ready, one lacked railings, and three had reached only the foundation stage. Of the community buildings, one was ready for inauguration, three had reached the roof, two the wall stage, and two were stuck in land disputes. Of the drains, one was complete and three half done. All four market sheds had pillars standing, but none had a roof.

Assistant Engineer Raghunath Kamati wrote in the first draft: "Completed schemes: 7."

Harimohan Mishra read the line and pushed his spectacles higher on his nose. "Such a small number will not enhance the dignity of the cover page."

"I have written as many as were completed," Raghunath said.

"Completed work is one thing; achievement is another," Harimohan explained. "One completed scheme gives one achievement. But even in an incomplete scheme, much work may have been done."

He began turning through the files. In the first unfinished road there were administrative approval, technical approval, site inspection, soil testing, arrival of materials, first layer, second layer—seven stages. Harimohan picked up his pen. “Road construction—seven major progress points.”

Raghunath kept looking at his face. “But the road is only one.”

“The progress is seven.”

By that formula the form of the report changed. A culvert without railings became “main structure completed.” A culvert that had reached the foundations became “foundation work completed.” A community building at wall level was described as “vertical structure progressing.” The two buildings held up by land disputes became an achievement titled “site problem identified and resolution process initiated.” The pillars of the market sheds became “structural presence established.”

Bindeshwar, adding the figures, asked, “If we total all this, the number will cross a hundred even though there are only twenty-seven schemes.”

Harimohan was pleased. “Then whoever reads the report will understand that the office did not sit idle all year.”

“The office hardly sat anywhere,” Raghunath said softly. “Half the time we are at the sites.”

Harimohan either did not hear him or chose not to answer.

The next day the selection of photographs began. The rule required at least twelve colour photographs in the report. There was no official photographer, so field staff had brought printed photographs taken on their own devices. One showed half a culvert, with bamboo scaffolding behind it. Harimohan said, “Crop it from this side. The scaffolding will disappear.”

Bindeshwar asked, “Then the incompleteness will not show.”

“An annual report is not an inspection file. It shows the year’s achievements.”

In another photograph four labourers were levelling earth in front of a community building whose walls were only waist-high. Its caption became: “Construction work linked to the community complex proceeding at a rapid pace with local participation.”

A third photograph showed a fully completed road, but it had been built the previous year. Raghunath recognised it at once. “This is not from this year.”

Harimohan put the envelope aside. “Then do not use it. It must already have appeared in the old report.”

Bindeshwar felt some relief at that. The office was bending the language of the paper, not the year itself.

Meanwhile Lakhan Paswan, a mason working on the Piprahi market shed, came to the office three times. Four weeks of his wages were pending. The first time Accounts said the measurement book was incomplete. The second time the measurement book arrived, but the engineer's signature was missing. The third time Raghunath was in the office, but he was choosing photographs for the report.

Lakhan stood in the veranda and said, "Babu, for two days we have been buying rice on credit at home. Please sign the measurement."

Raghunath reached for the file. From across the table Harimohan said, "First finish the sequence of these twelve photographs. The printer is waiting."

Lakhan did not understand. "What does the photograph have to do with my wages?"

"Nothing," Raghunath said. "That is why both tasks are not moving at the same time."

Harimohan looked up. Bindeshwar lowered his head and began counting papers.

By noon the photographs had been arranged. By evening the number of achievements had risen from 7 to 143. Those 143 included 21 site inspections, 17 technical measurements, 13 material tests, 26 progress reviews, 19 community meetings, 7 completed schemes, and the remaining individual stages.

Bindeshwar checked the total again. "Nineteen community meetings?"

Raghunath said, "There were twelve meetings."

Harimohan opened the file. "Seven meetings were held at the sites."

"Those are included within the twelve."

There was silence for a moment. Harimohan struck out 19 and wrote 12. The total became 136.

"The number has gone down," Bindeshwar said.

"The benefit of verification," Harimohan replied, "is that a smaller number becomes more durable."

On the third day the printer's man brought the draft. The cover showed, against a green background, three small photographs: a finished road, a culvert, and a community building. The title read: "Annual Report: A Year of Progress." Below, in smaller letters, was "Rural Construction Division, Madhubani."

Divisional Engineer Devkinandan Jha examined the draft. He had spent most of the year in the field and was seeing the report preparation only during its final three days. Reading the first page, he asked, "What is the total financial expenditure?"

Bindeshwar gave the figure.

“Total physical progress?”

Raghunath gave the details of the seven completed schemes.

Devkinandan frowned. “Then how are there 136 achievements?”

Harimohan explained the stage-wise formula in detail. The engineer remained silent for a while. Then he said, “Phrase it so that no number can be read as the number of completed schemes.”

“I will write ‘major work-achievement points,’” Harimohan said.

“All right. Keep it that way.”

Devkinandan turned the page. “Have you written the reasons for incomplete work as well?”

Raghunath listed five reasons: rain, land disputes, sand supply, labour migration, and delayed payments.

Harimohan said, “The section on reasons will become too long. It will increase the negative weight in an achievement report.”

The engineer said, “Write it in smaller type, but write it.”

Then three hours were spent solely on deciding how many times the word “delay” should appear. Five seemed too many. It was reduced to two. Elsewhere they wrote “time extension,” “under process,” “in the next phase,” and “according to local circumstances.”

On the evening of 29 March, almost no file connected with actual construction was opened in the office. Everyone was occupied with the report. One checked figures, another the contents, another photograph captions, another the printing estimate.

Lakhan Paswan came again. This time he carried the measurement book in his hand. Raghunath signed it, but the payment order became stuck at the next desk because Bindeshwar was preparing the advance adjustment for printing expenses.

“Tomorrow,” Bindeshwar said.

Lakhan asked, “Will the work open tomorrow?”

“It will.”

“And the report?”

“That too will be open.”

On 30 March the printer delivered five proof copies. On one page the lines were in reverse order. The captions of two photographs had been exchanged. In one place “7 completed schemes” had been printed as “70 completed schemes.” Harimohan’s face went pale.

“This one zero will change the entire year,” he said.

For the first time Bindeshwar laughed loudly. “It is difficult to add one zero to the work; easy to add it in the report.”

Proof correction continued until eight that night. Lakhan’s payment order remained pressed beneath a corner of the desk.

On the morning of 31 March, one thousand copies arrived. The smell of new paper spread through the entire room. The binding was glossy. The green on the cover had come out darker than expected, but everyone was pleased. Harimohan handed the first copy to Devkinandan Jha. The engineer looked at the clock—10:27.

“On time,” Harimohan said.

At noon a vehicle from the district office arrived. Two boxes of reports were loaded into it. The dispatch register recorded the time as 2:40. A separate employee went along to obtain the receipt. At 3:45 word came back—the report had been received.

Harimohan leaned back in his chair. “This time there will be no call for explanation.”

Bindeshwar said, “That in itself is an achievement.”

Bindeshwar had said it laughing, but Harimohan suddenly sat upright. He opened the last page, where under the heading “Administrative Efficiency” there were three points: monthly review regularised, record weeding completed, field coordination strengthened. The fourth line was blank.

“One thing has been left out,” he said.

“Which achievement?”

“Annual report compiled and published within the prescribed time.”

Raghunath looked at Devkinandan. The engineer did not smile. He only said, “It is already printed. Add it next year.”

Harimohan wrote the point in his small notebook so that he would not forget.

At four in the evening the office returned to normal work. Lakhan Paswan was still in the veranda. Bindeshwar opened his payment order. One signature remained—the Divisional Engineer’s. Devkinandan had gone out to inspect the receipt brought back by the vehicle that had deposited the report at the district office.

“It will be done tomorrow,” Bindeshwar said.

This time Lakhan did not argue. He sat down on the veranda bench. In front of him the store door stood open. Inside, eight boxes of the new report

were stacked one upon another. Behind them, five boxes of last year's report lay dulled with dust.

Harimohan was making the final entry of the evening. At the top was the date, 31 March. Below he wrote: "Annual report dispatched on time. Major administrative work of the year completed."

He capped his pen. In the veranda, Lakhan's measurement book was still lying beside his feet. Outside the office, two construction vehicles unloaded sand from the road works and drove away. The Chait evening was falling over the pillars of the unfinished market shed.

In the store, the boxes of the new annual report stood straight, even, and complete.

STORY 259

Permission

...

East of Jhanjharpur's old market, at the end of a narrow lane leading toward an old channel of the Kamla River, stood Raghunandan Chaudhary's house. In front was a pipal tree; inside, a square courtyard; three rooms to the north, the kitchen to the south, and a small garden at the back. The bricks at the base of the walls had turned black after seeing the rains of three generations. Raghunandan's grandfather had been born there, his father had died there, and in all sixty-seven years of his own life Raghunandan had never made another permanent place to spend the night.

On Monday morning he found a yellow paper pasted to the gate. Across the top, in bold letters, were the words: 'RESIDENCE-PERMISSION VERIFICATION.' Below were his name, the khesra number of the house, and an instruction to appear before the Block Citizen Administration Section within seven days. The final line read: 'If permission is not verified, the present residential status shall be treated as unverified.' Raghunandan read the paper twice. From inside, his wife Kusum asked, 'What happened?' 'I have been asked to show the paper that gives me the right to live in this house.' Kusum laughed at first. Raghunandan did not.

He opened the old wooden chest in the house. He took out the land khatian, a land-revenue receipt in his father's name, a newer receipt in his own name, an electricity bill, a clipping from the electoral roll, a photocopy of the ration book, and a yellowed paper from his grandfather's time. The smell of the papers held damp, dust, and old ink together.

The next day he put all the papers in a cloth bag and went to the Block Office. The Citizen Administration Section was on the second floor of the new building. The gatekeeper, Shambhu Paswan, knew him. For years he had bought mustard oil from Raghunandan's shop. 'Uncle, where are you going?' 'To get permission to live in my own house.' Shambhu laughed. 'Your house has been there since before I was born.' 'Then go inside and tell them that.' Shambhu immediately became serious. 'I cannot say anything inside. My job is to watch the entrance.'

There were three desks in the section. Applications were taken at the first, documents checked at the second, and the decision file prepared at the third. The clerk at the first desk read the notice and said, 'Give proof of residence

permission.’ Raghunandan placed the khatiyā before him. ‘This proves ownership.’ ‘The house is mine. That is why I live there.’ ‘Ownership and residence are two different matters.’ Raghunandan handed over the electricity bill. ‘This proves consumption.’ The electoral roll. ‘This proves the electoral address.’ The ration book. ‘This establishes the distribution address.’

Raghunandan’s bag gradually emptied. The clerk had seen every paper, but proof of residence permission had still not been found. ‘Then how is residence permission proved?’ Raghunandan asked. The clerk took a green application form from the drawer. ‘Write the permission number here.’ ‘I do not know the number.’ ‘Look at the old permission.’ ‘No old permission was ever taken.’ ‘Then where will the number come from?’ Raghunandan looked at the clerk’s face. ‘That is what I am asking you.’ The clerk thought for a few moments, then wrote at the top of the application: ‘Previous permission unavailable.’ ‘Go to the second desk.’

At the second desk, Assistant Sudhanshu Jha looked at the year in the khatiyā. The original entry for the house was seventy-two years old. Turning through the register, he said, ‘The rule came only five years ago. There ought to be a separate provision for old houses.’ ‘Is there one?’ ‘There ought to be.’

He took a thick rule book from the almirah. Section 14 covered new construction, 15 tenants, 16 institutional buildings, 17 vacant buildings. There was no mention of old ancestral houses. At the end was one line: ‘In unspecified situations, directions shall be obtained from the competent authority.’ Sudhanshu wrote on the application: ‘Situation unspecified.’ ‘And now?’ ‘Third desk.’

At the third desk sat the Section In-charge, Vimlesh Thakur. Raghunandan knew him too. Twenty-five kilos of oil from Raghunandan’s shop had gone to Vimlesh’s wedding. But from that side of the desk Vimlesh spoke not of acquaintance, but of the file. ‘How long have you lived in this house?’ ‘Since birth.’ ‘Birth certificate?’ Raghunandan fell silent. He had been born at home with a midwife. There was an old school certificate, but the date of birth in it was approximate. Vimlesh said, ‘Do not worry. I do not doubt what you are saying. The question is only of procedure.’ ‘If you do not doubt it, give me permission.’ ‘Permission is made on proof, not on trust.’

Raghunandan returned home. That night, for the first time, he looked at his courtyard as though someone might ask why he was there. On the wall was a wooden peg his father had fixed. The tulsi platform had been built after Kusum came there as a bride. On the door of the north room, the marks of his son’s childhood height were still scratched into the wood. None of these were papers.

The next day he went to the school. His name was found in the old admission register—father: Ramlochan Chaudhary; address: the same house. The headmaster gave him a certified copy. From the Panchayat Office he obtained a copy of the 1986 family register. An elderly postal employee said that letters had been delivered to that house for years, but there was no form for a certificate saying, ‘This person truly lives here.’ Three days later Raghunandan returned to the section. Sudhanshu examined the new papers. ‘These are all very useful.’ ‘Then the permission?’ ‘They prove that different departments have continued to accept this house as your address.’ ‘That is what I am saying too.’

‘But residence permission is separate.’ For the first time Raghunandan raised his voice. ‘If every department accepts me at this house, where does this section accept me?’ Instead of answering, Sudhanshu wrote something in pencil in the blank margin of the rule book. Then he said, ‘Your case will have to be sent upward.’ ‘Upward where?’ ‘To the competent authority.’ ‘Where does he sit?’ ‘The file will decide that.’

The file first went to the Circle Office, then to the Subdivisional Office, then came back to the Block with a comment. Along the way one question was added: ‘The applicant’s present residential status shall be verified.’ Field employee Rambabu Sah was sent for verification.

Rambabu reached Raghunandan’s house in the evening. He saw the gate, courtyard, rooms, and kitchen. He asked two neighbours, ‘Does he live here?’ Both laughed. One said, ‘He was living here even when I was born.’ Rambabu wrote in the register: ‘Applicant found present at site; residing with family.’ Raghunandan breathed with relief. As Rambabu closed the papers, he said, ‘There is one problem.’ ‘What now?’

‘The purpose of the verification was to see whether the person seeking permission actually lives at that place. It is clear that you live here. But if permission has not yet been granted, I cannot describe your present residence as “permitted.”’ ‘Then what did you write?’ ‘Residing.’ ‘Is that not enough?’ ‘The section will decide.’

A week passed. The yellow paper was still pasted to the gate. Rain came and curled one corner. Kusum twice told him to take it down. Raghunandan said, ‘No. Until the decision comes, this too is proof that the government found me at this place.’

On the tenth day he was summoned to the section. The file before Vimlesh Thakur had now become thick. On top were the khatian, the school copy, the family register, the field verification, and comments from three offices. Vimlesh said, ‘Special directions have come in your case.’ Raghunandan sat upright.

‘For an old ancestral house, asking for previous permission has been considered impractical. Therefore, before the first residence permission is granted, site verification will be carried out on two separate dates. On both occasions the applicant himself must be found at home.’ ‘One verification has already been done.’ ‘That was of present residence. Now there will be eligibility verification for first permission.’ ‘What is the difference?’ Vimlesh looked at the page. ‘The first established that you live there. Now it will be established that, even while applying for permission, you continue to live there.’ Raghunandan was silent for a few moments. ‘Suppose on the day of verification I have gone to the market?’

‘Then it will be written that you were not found at the site.’ ‘So I should not leave the house?’ ‘The rule says nothing of that kind.’ ‘But if I am outside, the verification fails?’ ‘That too is not stated so explicitly in the rule.’ Raghunandan looked at the file. The weight of what was not written on the paper seemed greater than what was written.

The first eligibility verification took place five days later. A field employee arrived at eleven in the morning. Raghunandan was sitting in the veranda. Name, father’s name, khesra number, number of rooms, direction of the courtyard—everything was entered again. The neighbours again bore witness.

No one announced the date of the second verification. Raghunandan did not open his shop for the first two days. On the third day the wholesaler’s oil truck was due, so he went to the market for one hour. The employee arrived during that very hour. Kusum said, ‘He lives here. He has gone to the market.’ The register recorded: ‘Applicant not found present at site.’ When Raghunandan heard in the evening, he ran to the office. Sudhanshu said, ‘Absence is not proof that you do not reside there, but your presence was not verified either.’ ‘Then?’ ‘The second verification will be done again.’ ‘When?’ ‘Without notice. Only then will it be considered neutral.’

This time Raghunandan did not stop leaving the house. He had understood that freezing one’s life while waiting for an uncertain date would be a harsher rule than the permission itself. He went to his shop, sat with friends on the temple platform, and one day even went to Darbhanga to visit his daughter. Whenever he returned, he looked at the gate to see whether a new slip had appeared. On the thirteenth day, at half past seven in the morning, the verification employee arrived. Raghunandan was sweeping the courtyard. Seeing him, the employee was pleased. ‘Found you today.’ ‘I live here,’ Raghunandan said. ‘For my register, I found you today.’

The second verification was treated as successful. The file again travelled between the section, Circle Office, and Subdivision. At one place the comment came: ‘Ownership undisputed.’ At another: ‘Permanent residence established.’

At a third: 'Previous permission unavailable because residence predates enforcement of the rule.' The final comment was: 'First permission may be issued.'

Three weeks later the postman brought an envelope containing the permanent residence permission. The envelope was addressed to that same house. Seeing Raghunandan sitting in the veranda, he said, 'Uncle, now the paper has found you here too.'

Raghunandan opened the envelope. Inside was a single sheet. At the top was his name, below it the khesra number of the house. In the middle it said: 'Shri Raghunandan Chaudhary is hereby granted permanent permission to reside in the said building.' He read the final line: 'The permission shall take effect from the date of approval.'

Raghunandan folded the paper. The pipal tree's shadow was lengthening across the courtyard. The peg his father had fixed was still there on the north wall. The first yellow notice on the gate had been half washed away by rainwater. The postman asked, 'Everything all right now?' Raghunandan opened the chest and placed the new permission on top of the khatiyān. The old khatiyān was seventy-two years old; the permission was valid from today. 'According to the paper,' he said, 'I have been living here since today.'

STORY 260

The Waiting Room

...

In the main veranda of the old building of Benipatti Subdivisional Hospital, three colours of arrows had been painted that morning. Green arrows pointed toward registration, yellow toward preliminary examination, and blue toward medical consultation. Above them, in bold letters, was written: "MAKE PATIENT FLOW SIMPLE."

Ramsevak Mahato followed the blue arrow inside. His right shoulder had been hurting for three weeks. The health worker at his village sub-centre had written on a slip that he should get it examined once at the subdivisional hospital. Ramsevak was a farmer; the time for transplanting paddy was near, so he had thought that if he arrived at eight in the morning he would be home again by ten.

The young man at the main desk looked at his slip. "Registration first."

"But this slip was made at the sub-centre."

"That is a referral slip. An arrival slip will be made here."

Ramsevak followed the green arrow. Five minutes later he received a small sheet of paper with 47 written on it. Beneath that, in red letters, was written: "Waiting Room 1."

Waiting Room 1 had twelve blue chairs, two long benches, one fan, and a diabetes poster on the wall. Ramsevak sat for fifteen minutes. Then the door opened. An attendant called, "Numbers forty to fifty, all of you inside."

Hearing number 47, Ramsevak rose. Beyond the door there was no doctor, but another waiting room. This time the chairs were green and a blood-pressure poster hung on the wall.

Ramsevak looked back. The attendant had already shut the first door from inside.

"What happens here?" he asked.

A woman health worker said, "Preliminary examination."

"I was going to the doctor."

"Preliminary examination is necessary first."

His blood pressure was taken, his name asked, his age written down. A round stamp was placed on the paper. The health worker pointed toward the next door. "Sit there."

Beyond the next door was yet another waiting room. There were fewer chairs here, but more patients. An old woman sat where two benches met. A young man had already read his slip three times. In one corner a father held his five-year-old son asleep in his lap.

Ramsevak asked the old woman, "Where does the doctor sit?"

She pointed toward the closed door in front. "They told me the same place."

"How long have you been sitting?"

"Since half past seven this morning."

It was eleven o'clock.

After a while the door in front opened. An employee collected fifteen slips, put a blue tick on each, and said, "Those whose slips have been ticked, go to the next waiting room."

Ramsevak laughed. The employee looked at him. "What is it?"

"Nothing. I thought the doctor would be on the other side of this door."

"The arrangement for reaching the doctor is phased."

"How many phases are there?"

The employee glanced at the slip. "There is no provision here for counting phases."

The fourth waiting room was at the back of the building. Through its window half the pond could be seen. Numbers had been painted in white on the chairs. Ramsevak's slip now carried, along with 47, three stamps, two ticks, and one diagonal line. He looked for Chair 47. The chairs went only up to 39.

"Where is 47?" he asked the guard.

"Chair numbers and slip numbers are unrelated."

"Then why are the chairs numbered?"

"For physical verification."

Ramsevak sat on an empty chair in the corner. After a while the old woman from the earlier room arrived there too. Seeing him, she smiled.

"I think you are ahead of me."

Ramsevak said, "I think all of us are going round in circles."

The old woman took chura from her bag and ate two handfuls. Ramsevak had drunk only tea before leaving home in the morning. The water pitcher had been left behind near the first waiting room; in this room there were empty glasses, but no pitcher. A young man asked the attendant for water. He replied, "Water is a facility of the first waiting room." The young man tried to go back.

The door was locked from inside. "Under one-way flow, going backward is prohibited," the attendant explained.

An elderly man sitting nearby said he had come from Madhepur. He had a slip for a chest examination, but in the third room someone had written "consultation first," while in the fourth he had been told it ought to say "after consultation." He spread the slip on his palm. An arrow had been drawn between the two phrases, but the ink had spread so much that it was impossible to tell which way the arrow pointed.

"Then what will you do?" Ramsevak asked.

"I will go through whichever door opens first," the old man said.

The people in the room gradually learnt to recognise doors by their sounds. When the heavy wooden panel opened, it meant the next stage. When the thin iron panel opened, it meant an employee. When the small rear door opened, it meant the cleaner. The patients became less alert to names and illnesses than to the sounds of doors.

Once the wooden panel opened and everyone stood up. An employee called from inside, "Not yet. This has been opened only for air." Everyone sat again. Five minutes later the door opened for air was shut. The room became hot once more.

For the first time Ramsevak felt that waiting was not merely the passage of time; it was itself a task. People guarded their slips, listened for numbers, watched doors, estimated their turn, and sat half-alert so that no instruction would escape them. In farming one waits for clouds, but whether clouds will come can at least be guessed by looking at the sky. Here, what lay beyond a door remained uncertain even after the door opened.

At noon an announcement came that medical consultation had begun. All the patients became alert. The door of the fourth waiting room opened. Every slip was checked again. This time "Eligible for consultation" was written on Ramsevak's slip. He was sent forward.

Beyond the door was a fifth waiting room.

This time Ramsevak remained standing near the door.

"Sit down," the attendant said.

"Where is the doctor?"

"He is coming."

"Through which door?"

The attendant looked at two doors, thought for a moment, and said, "That changes according to procedure."

A newly painted board hung on the wall of the fifth room: “ONE-WAY PATIENT FLOW PLAN.” Beneath it were four points: reduce crowding, make patient order clear, prevent unnecessary movement, provide easy access to the doctor.

Ramsevak read the fourth point twice.

A middle-aged man in neat clothes was sitting beside him. He said, “First time here?”

“Yes.”

“This is my third.”

“Third time for this illness?”

“No. Third time for this system. The first time my slip was missing one stamp. The second time, by the time I reached the fifth room, consultation hours had ended. Today I have been here since seven.”

Ramsevak asked, “Have you seen the doctor?”

“Once, in the veranda.”

“Why doesn’t he come here?”

The man said softly, “I heard that the doctor’s route to the patients has also been changed.”

Ramsevak took this as a joke. But at half past one a doctor looked in through the rear door of the fifth room. He had a register in his hand. He asked the attendant, “Where are patients numbered forty to fifty?”

The attendant was startled. “Sir, they have been sent to the fifth waiting room.”

The doctor looked around. “Which room is this?”

“The fifth.”

The doctor ran a hand over his head. “I was told the fourth.”

“Numbers fifty-one to sixty are there now.”

“Then forty to fifty are here?”

“Yes.”

The doctor stepped forward to enter, but the attendant stopped him with folded hands. “Sir, this door is not listed for doctors’ entry. Your entrance is from that side.”

He pointed to the other door in front. The doctor walked that way.

Two minutes later came the announcement: “Patients numbered forty to fifty, go to the next waiting room.”

Ramsevak did not get up.

The old woman kept looking at him. “You are not going?”

“This time I will sit here.”

“Your number will be missed.”

“Let it be missed.”

The remaining patients slowly filed out through the next door. The old woman too finally rose and left. The fifth room became empty. Ramsevak sat alone. The fan turned overhead. On the board, the words “prevent unnecessary movement” gleamed.

Ten minutes later the doctor came through the door assigned for his entry. He stopped when he saw the empty room.

“Where are the patients?”

Ramsevak said, “In the next waiting room.”

The doctor looked at him. “Why didn’t you go?”

“I was waiting for you.”

A tired smile came to the doctor’s face. “I too was waiting for all of you.”

He pulled a chair forward and sat beside Ramsevak. He took the slip, examined the shoulder, asked a few questions, made him raise his arm, and located the point of pain. He wrote the name of a medicine and a few precautions on the paper. The entire consultation lasted five minutes.

Ramsevak stood up with the slip in his hand. “Now how do I get outside?”

The doctor pointed to the door in front. “Through that one.”

Ramsevak opened it.

Beyond it was a sixth waiting room. On the wall was written: “WAITING FOR MEDICINE DISPENSING.”

For a few moments he stood there. Behind him, the doctor walked toward another door to search for the next patient. Ramsevak sat down in the sixth room. His consultation was over now; only the waiting remained.

STORY 261

Number

...

At the gate of Darbhanga's Integrated Public Grievance Building, the first thing Ramlochan Yadav saw was not his name but a small yellow slip. In bold letters it said: "Serial No. 47." Beneath that, in very fine print: "For impartial disposal, the applicant's name and identity shall be kept separate from the internal process." Ramlochan read the slip twice. Then he said to the security guard seated inside the gate, "I am Ramlochan Yadav. I have come from Bahadurpur." Without raising his head, the guard said, "Names have no work inside. Keep the slip safely. You are 47."

Ramlochan's complaint was very simple. After repairs to a government drain beside his field, soil had been kept on two katthas of his land for a month. The soil had been removed, but the compensation of three thousand two hundred rupees had not arrived. The block office had told him that payment was held up at the district. After the old district-office building was demolished and the Integrated Public Grievance Building was opened, it was announced that a "name-free process" would reduce bias. With that hope, Ramlochan had come on the first bus of the morning.

In the first room, a woman clerk took his application. Over the words "Ramlochan Yadav" at the top, she pasted a thin strip of paper. On it she wrote "47" in red ink.

Ramlochan asked, "Why have you covered the name?"

"Whoever sees the application will not know you. That will preserve impartiality."

"But the payment will be made in a name."

The clerk smiled. "Payment is the final stage. For now, you are a number."

She stamped the application with a round seal and sent him toward the second room. On the door was written: "Serial Matching." Inside, a young man looked at Ramlochan's yellow slip and read the 47 written on the application. Then he turned through a register.

"This 47 is an old serial," he said.

Ramlochan was startled. "Old? I received it five minutes ago."

"That is the gate serial. In this branch the complaint serial is different."

The young man issued a new blue slip: "47/3."

“What is the three?”

“Third subject category. Temporary use relating to land.”

Ramlochan folded the yellow and blue slips together and tied them into the knot of his gamchha.

The young man said, “The yellow slip is no longer needed.”

Ramlochan asked, “If I go out through the gate and come in again?”

The young man thought for a few moments. “Then you will need the yellow one. Do not throw it away.”

Four people were sitting in the third room. There was no electronic display on the wall; numbers were being written in chalk on a wooden board. “46/3” was crossed out. “47/3” was written. Ramlochan stood up.

The assistant sitting inside looked at the application. “This needs a branch-register serial.”

“Then what is 47/3?”

“Subject serial. The branch-register serial is different.”

The assistant wrote “127” on the application. “Now you are 127.”

Ramlochan did not laugh. “I have changed three times already.”

The assistant said gravely, “You have not changed. The serial number has changed. Those are not the same thing.”

Ramlochan’s application was kept for scrutiny. He was told to ask after noon. He went and sat on the veranda. Beside him an old woman kept looking at a slip marked “61.” She asked him, “Son, what number are you?”

“Now 127. Earlier I was 47.”

The old woman said in surprise, “Mine was 58 this morning. Inside it became 61.”

They compared their slips. After a while an employee in the veranda called loudly, “One hundred twenty-seven!” Ramlochan rose. The old woman also half stood up. She too had a slip marked 127, but in small letters beneath it was written “distribution.” The employee looked at both of them.

“Whose 127?”

Ramlochan said, “Mine.”

The old woman said, “Mine too.”

The employee held his head. “State the subject.”

Ramlochan said, “Land use.”

The old woman said, “Old-age assistance.”

“Then land 127 to the right, assistance 127 to the left.”

Ramlochan went right. There he was told that the day's applications would be entered under a fresh daily serial after noon. The serials used during the first half of the day were only for "temporary movement." By three o'clock, 127 had been crossed out on his application and "18" written in its place.

"Now eighteen?" Ramlochan asked.

The clerk said, "Afternoon daily serial."

"If I come tomorrow?"

"Tomorrow is a new day. New serial."

"Then how will you identify my application?"

"The file will identify it."

"But the name on the file is covered."

Turning the page, the clerk said, "A file does not need a name. It has its own serial."

"Which one?"

The clerk showed him the back page of the application. In one corner, written in pencil, was "B-37/12."

Ramlochan said slowly, "Then among 47, 47/3, 127, 18, and B-37/12—which one am I?"

For the first time the clerk looked at him. "You are the applicant."

"Do you know my name?"

"The name will be opened at the final stage."

The afternoon wore on. Ramlochan was told that the file would go for accounts scrutiny and the answer would be available the next day. Before going home he showed the yellow slip at the gate. The guard looked at it and said, "This 47 is from the morning. For exit you need the later serial."

Ramlochan showed 18.

"That is an internal serial."

"Then how do I get out?"

The guard discussed the matter with the employee seated behind him. In the end Ramlochan's name was asked for in the exit register. Clenching the end of his gamchha in his fist, he said, "Ramlochan Yadav."

The employee wrote down the name. As he crossed the gate, Ramlochan felt like laughing. His name had been forbidden inside all day; to get out, the name was necessary.

The next day he returned. At the gate he showed the previous day's yellow slip. The guard said, "Yesterday's serial has expired. Today there is a new serial." A new slip was issued: "23."

“Yesterday I was 47.”

“Yesterday was yesterday.”

“Inside I was 18.”

“That was the afternoon serial.”

“The file is B-37/12.”

The guard said, “Then give the file serial, not your own.”

Ramlochan went inside. In the Serial Matching room, an employee told him that when B-37/12 reached the Accounts Branch it became “L-91,” because the letter changed when the branch changed. In Accounts, L-91 was searched for, but there were two L-91s—one for land use, the other for lantern purchase. Since the year was not written, both sets of papers had to be examined separately.

“Open the name and you will know immediately,” Ramlochan said.

The clerk shook his head. “Opening the name in the middle of the process would compromise impartiality.”

“Then will I receive my three thousand two hundred rupees, or a lantern?”

The clerk did not laugh. “Payment only after the serial is clarified.”

By noon three branches together worked out a solution. All Ramlochan’s previous serials would be tied together under one “integrated serial number.” A new white slip was prepared: “612.” Beneath it were listed, in order: 47, 47/3, 127, 18, B-37/12, 23, L-91.

Ramlochan looked at the slip. “Now is this the final one?”

The Head Assistant said, “It is integrated. The word final is not written.”

“Meaning?”

“If the branch changes in future, a sub-serial may be added.”

The accounts scrutiny was completed. Verification that soil from the drain repair had been kept on his field was already in the file. Payment was approved. Ramlochan felt lighter. He was given the payment order. He looked at the paper. The recipient field was blank.

“There is no name here,” he said.

The Accounts Clerk replied, “Under the name-free process, the name has not yet been opened.”

“Will the bank pay money to serial number 612?”

The clerk fell silent. Another clerk was called. The Head Assistant came. All three examined the paper. The rulebook was opened. The name-free process applied only up to the impartial scrutiny of the complaint; actual payment required the real name. But authority to reopen the real identity belonged to

the “Identity Recombination Branch,” and no such separate branch had been created in the building.

After some time the Head Assistant proposed a solution. The thin strip pasted over the top of the application was slowly lifted. Beneath it, “Ramlochan Yadav” was clearly visible. For a few moments everyone looked at the name as though meeting an old acquaintance after many days.

The Accounts Clerk said, “The name was here from the beginning.”

Ramlochan said, “So was I.”

His name was entered in the payment order. He was told to sign. He wrote “Ramlochan Yadav.” Beside it the clerk also wrote in red ink: “Integrated Serial No. 612.”

Ramlochan walked toward the gate to go home. The guard looked at the white slip.

“This 612 is not in today’s entry list.”

Ramlochan was tired. He did not open the bundle of papers. He only said, “Ramlochan Yadav.”

The guard opened the exit register. The name was there on the line from the first day. He wrote today’s date beside that line and said, “Go.”

Outside the gate Ramlochan opened the white slip on his palm. Beneath the seven earlier serials, 612 stood in bold letters. He did not throw the slip away. At home he put it, along with the payment order, into the old tin box where paddy seed was kept.

Three days later a bank employee looked at the payment order and asked, “What is this 612?”

Ramlochan said, “It was my number.”

“And what does the number mean now?”

Signing beneath his name, Ramlochan said, “Now it belongs to the paper.”

STORY 262

The Open Case

...

East of Sakri, at Jagatpur Middle School, Udaykant Paswan was teaching mathematics to Class Eight. It was a day after the rains. Outside the window, water had collected in two places on the school's small field, and inside, on the blackboard, Udaykant was adding three fractions. Just then the attendant Harilal appeared at the door. He had a brown envelope in his hand.

"The Headmaster is calling you," Harilal said softly.

Udaykant wrote five questions for the children and went to the Headmaster's room. Headmaster Shashibhushan Jha had his spectacles lowered on his nose and was looking at the envelope. On the desk lay an open letter bearing the round seal of the Block Education Office.

"Sit down," he said, then held the letter out to Udaykant.

The first line read: "An inquiry is in progress against Shri Udaykant Paswan, Assistant Teacher, Middle School Jagatpur." The second: "Submit your explanation within seven days of receipt of this letter." Beneath it was written: "Details of the allegation as per Annexure-A."

Udaykant turned the letter over. The back page was blank. He checked the envelope. There was no other paper inside.

"Where is the annexure?" he asked.

The Headmaster searched the envelope again. "It is not here."

"Then what am I supposed to explain?"

Shashibhushan Jha remained silent for a few moments. "First go to the office and ask. The letter says seven days."

The next day Udaykant went to the Benipatti Block Education Office. Outside the Inquiry Section were two wooden benches. Inside, behind a thin green curtain, stood three desks. Navalkishore Mandal sat at the first. He read the letter, checked the file number, then turned through a register.

"Yes, the inquiry is open," he said.

"The annexure containing the allegation was not supplied."

Navalkishore placed a finger on one line in the register. "The annexure is confidential."

"The allegation is against me. It will not be given to me?"

“It will. First acknowledge receipt.”

“I have already acknowledged this letter.”

“Receipt of the letter is one thing. Receipt of the allegation details is another.”

Udaykant looked at him for a few moments. “How can I acknowledge receipt of something I have not received?”

Navalkishore did not find the question strange. He took a printed slip from the drawer. At the top it said: “Acknowledgement of Receipt of Allegation Details.” Below were spaces for name, designation, date, and signature.

“Sign this. Then the confidential envelope will be called for.”

Udaykant took the slip in his hand. “Give me the envelope first. Then I will sign.”

Navalkishore shook his head. “The sequence cannot be reversed.”

Udaykant put the slip back. “Then I will write that the allegation details have not been received and therefore a reply is not possible.”

“You may write that. But it will be treated as a representation, not an explanation.”

On a white sheet Udaykant wrote two lines: “The allegation details are not enclosed. I shall submit my explanation within the prescribed time after receiving them.” Navalkishore stamped it as received.

When he returned to school, Udaykant thought the matter would become clear in two or four days. But on the third day the Headmaster showed him another letter. Because the inquiry was pending, Udaykant was not to place the final signature on the scholarship verification register.

“Then who will do this work?” Udaykant asked.

“You prepare all the details. I will put the final signature.”

Udaykant matched the names, dates of birth, bank details, and attendance of eighty-five students. At the end Shashibhushan Jha signed in five minutes. The next week the monthly account for the midday meal came. Udaykant had prepared that account for years, but this time the Headmaster’s signature appeared on the page he had prepared.

The children did not understand the meaning of the change. To them, Udaykant was the same teacher who taught fractions, percentages, and area. But in office papers a new word appeared in small letters beside his name: “Under Inquiry.”

On the seventh day Udaykant went again to the Block Office. Navalkishore was absent. In his place sat a new clerk, Kiran Kumar. Udaykant showed him the first letter and his representation. Kiran Kumar found the file. It contained

four pages: the order initiating the inquiry, the copy of the letter sent to the school, Udaykant's representation, and one line: "Accused teacher has not acknowledged receipt of allegation details."

"Where is the allegation paper?" Udaykant asked.

Kiran Kumar turned through the file again. "It is not here."

"Then on what basis is the inquiry proceeding?"

"The basis must be in the Confidential Section."

The Confidential Section was a small room at the back of the same building, with a latch on the door. The key was with the Head Clerk. The Head Clerk had gone to Madhubani for training. Kiran Kumar said, "Come on Monday."

On Monday the Head Clerk returned, but had forgotten the key to the confidential cupboard at home. On Tuesday the cupboard was opened. Inside were five envelopes tied in red cloth. The envelope bearing Udaykant's file number was also found. The Head Clerk placed it on the desk but did not open it.

"Where is the acknowledgement slip?" he asked.

Udaykant said, "Open the envelope. I will read the allegation and sign immediately."

The Head Clerk opened the rulebook. "Acknowledgement first, opening afterward."

"But the wording says 'receipt of allegation details.' Where have I received them yet?"

The Head Clerk placed his finger on the page. "This wording has been printed by the district. I cannot alter it."

This time Udaykant decided to sign. He wrote his name and the date, but above the signature added in small letters: "Before opening of envelope."

The Head Clerk looked at the slip. "With this remark, the acknowledgement will not be treated as clean."

"What is a clean acknowledgement?"

"One without any remark."

Udaykant did not take the slip back. He left it on the table and returned to school.

Meanwhile his name was removed from the training list. The reason column said: "Inquiry pending." A list was prepared for examination-centre superintendents; Udaykant's seniority was sufficient, but his name was not sent. The Headmaster told him, "There is no restriction on your work, only on special responsibilities for the time being."

“What is the allegation?” Udaykant asked.

Shashibhushan Jha said quietly, “I do not know either.”

On the last Friday of the month, an attendant from the Block Office came to the school. He carried a blue-bound register titled “Pending Inquiry Awareness Register.” Udaykant was asked to sign against one line. It read: “The concerned employee has been informed that an inquiry is in progress.”

Udaykant signed. “Why does this not mention the allegation?”

The attendant shrugged. “I was told to circulate the register and take signatures.”

The same register came the second month. And the third. Each time Udaykant signed to confirm that he knew an inquiry was in progress. He still did not know why it was in progress.

Three months later the district office reviewed pending inquiries. Four members sat at the Block Office. Udaykant was not called; the file was called. The first question in the review note was: “Allegation communicated?” Answer: “No.” Second: “Reason?” Answer: “Acknowledgement of receipt incomplete.” Third: “Next action?” Answer: “Obtain complete acknowledgement of receipt.”

A copy of this decision reached the school. Udaykant read it and went to the office himself the next day. He signed the slip without any remark. The Head Clerk smiled.

“Now it is done. The allegation details will be given within two days.”

The red-cloth envelope was taken out of the cupboard. It bore the Block file number, but in one corner was another stamp: “Issued from District Confidential Section.” Before opening it, the Head Clerk checked the contents list. It said: “Annexure-A: Original allegation letter—one page.” The envelope was opened. Inside was only a small slip: “Original allegation letter retained securely at District Office. Certified copy may be requisitioned.”

Udaykant did not laugh. Neither did the Head Clerk.

A requisition was sent to the district office. A week later the reply came: “Attach proof that the inquiry has been duly registered at Block level.” The Block file contained the order initiating the inquiry, but the district register had no corresponding entry. The reason was that at district level the case was entered only when the preliminary report returned together with the accused employee’s acknowledgement of receipt. The acknowledgement had now been obtained, but the allegation letter still had not arrived.

Kiran Kumar explained this quietly to Udaykant. “Now it must first be registered. After that the copy can be requisitioned.”

“What is needed for registration?”

“The preliminary report.”

“And for that?”

Kiran Kumar looked at the file. “A reference to the allegation.”

This time Udaykant sat down on the chair. People kept coming and going through the veranda outside. On the desk inside, the red-cloth envelope lay open. It contained not the allegation, but information about where the allegation was.

A few weeks later the half-yearly examination began at the school. Udaykant distributed question papers, counted answer books, and wrote down the names of absent students. One Class Eight student, Amresh, had misspelled his own name. Udaykant corrected it in red ink on the paper.

Amresh asked, “Sir, if the name is wrong, will the answer book be cancelled?”

“No,” Udaykant said. “The name is simply corrected.”

At that moment Harilal appeared again at the door. In his hand was a new brown envelope from the Block Office. Udaykant opened it. Inside was one page: “A new registration number has been assigned to the inquiry file. Until the allegation details are received, the matter shall be treated as open.”

Below was the new number. The allegation was still absent.

Udaykant folded the letter and placed it in his register. Then he picked up Amresh’s answer book. The corrected name at the top was clearly visible. He moved on to the next child’s paper.

STORY 263

Boundary

...

In Sirkharia village of Rahika Block, a boundary had once meant only the ridge between fields. Where Ramlochan Yadav's paddy ended, Nandlal Mahato's arhar began. The bamboo screen around a courtyard, the edge of a pond, the platform of a well—each had its own visible marker. But the boundary that descended into the middle of the village one Monday morning had no ridge, stake, colour, or rope.

A table was placed beneath the neem tree at the crossroads. On it were two registers, slips in three colours, and a board that read: "Administrative Boundary Assistance Point." Beneath that, in smaller letters: "Area A / Area B."

Devnarayan Mahato was cycling toward the market with a milk can tied to his bicycle. Madan Mishra, the clerk at the table, raised a hand and stopped him.

"Where are you going?"

"To the milk cooperative."

"That is in Area B."

"What difference does that make?"

"You are coming from Area A. You need a transit slip."

Devnarayan looked at both sides of the road. There was no line anywhere.

"Where is the boundary?"

Madan Mishra placed a thumb on the map spread over the table. "From this point to this point."

"On the ground?"

"It has not yet been marked on the ground."

"Then when did I cross it?"

Madan Mishra studied the map again. "From behind the neem tree."

Devnarayan looked back. His house stood on one side of that very neem tree, the milk cooperative on the other. Between them ran the road he had crossed several times a day since childhood.

The rules on the first day were described as simple. An adult travelling from Area A to Area B would have his name, father's or husband's name, house number, and purpose of journey entered, and would receive a yellow slip. On

returning, the slip would be surrendered. By evening a queue had formed beneath the neem tree. Someone was going to buy fertiliser, someone medicine, someone to the flour mill, someone to his maternal uncle's house.

Devnarayan's difficulty was that his own house lay in both colours on the map. The main door was in Area A, the kitchen in Area A, but the rear courtyard, cowshed, and handpump were in Area B. To milk the cow in the morning he had to carry a slip inside his own house.

His wife Malti laughed the first time. "Permission from outside even to live in one's own house?"

"Not to live. To cross."

"Show me the boundary."

Devnarayan said nothing.

On Tuesday a new clarification arrived. Local ration-card holders were exempted from slips for essential work. The villagers were pleased. But in the afternoon another notice came: the exemption applied only when the essential work was within one's own area. The first rule still applied when the boundary was crossed.

On Wednesday schoolchildren were exempted. Devnarayan's daughter Sarita attended the higher secondary school in Area B and left without a slip. But her younger brother Manoj's school was in Area A while his bookshop was in Area B. Madan Mishra gave him a slip for buying books, but wrote on it: "School purpose, one time."

"If I need another book tomorrow?" Manoj asked.

"Tomorrow's rule will be seen tomorrow," Madan Mishra said.

On Thursday a separate arrangement was introduced for goods. Milk, paddy, straw, bamboo, bricks, and vegetables were classified as "goods transit." Devnarayan filled a green slip for the milk can. His own slip was yellow; the milk's was green.

"The bicycle?" he asked.

Madan Mishra scratched his head. "The bicycle travels with the person."

"The can?"

"Goods."

"And the milk?"

"Inside the can."

"The cow?"

Before answering, Madan Mishra turned a page of the register. "Separate instructions for livestock have not yet arrived."

That evening a calf broke loose from the cowshed and ran across the road. Malti ran after it. The assistant seated beneath the neem tree rose to stop her, but by then the calf had already crossed from Area B back into Area A.

Panting, Malti said, "Make a slip for it."

The assistant did not laugh. "We will ask about livestock tomorrow."

On Friday the livestock rule actually arrived. Between six and eight in the morning and five and seven in the evening, movement would be allowed without a slip. At other times the owner's name would be entered.

Hearing the order, Malti said, "Will the cow look at the clock?"

This time Devnarayan laughed, but the laughter stopped when he reached the neem tree.

Three new employees had arrived there—an inspection team from the district. The map was opened. The inspector expressed a desire to see the boundary.

Madan Mishra stood at one point on the road and said, "Approximately here."

"Why approximately?"

"The map uses the 'old western channel' as its reference."

The inspector looked around. "Where is the channel?"

Durganand Jha, an elderly villager, was called. He said that years ago rainwater had flowed along the left side of the road. Ramlochan Yadav said, "No, it was on the right." Nandlal Mahato said that before the road was widened, the channel had run down the middle.

The inspector wrote down all three statements and continued staring at the line on the map.

Meanwhile Sarita returned from school and reached the neem tree. Her mathematics exercise book was in her hand. She saw her father and stopped.

"Babuji, which slip today?"

"None for you."

"Yesterday Teacher said that after Saturday's holiday a new identity slip will be made."

The inspector heard her. "Has anyone stopped the children?"

"No," Madan Mishra said. "The rules keep changing."

The inspector frowned. "Rules do not change; they become clearer."

Madan Mishra immediately wrote the substance of that sentence into the register.

On Saturday a special provision arrived for “joint households.” Any house lying on the boundary could apply for a one-month joint-movement pass. Devnarayan was the first to apply.

The form asked: “In which area is the applicant’s principal residence?” He wrote: Area A. The second question: “Livestock/storage in which area?” He wrote: Area B. Third: “Usual family entrance?” Area A. Fourth: “Water source?” Area B.

The fifth asked: “Latrine?” Devnarayan stopped his pen. It had been built near the boundary, but the map showed no mark for it.

“What should I write in this box?” he asked Madan Mishra.

“It will be decided after site verification.”

“Then the pass?”

“After verification.”

“When the officer goes to the house for verification, will he cross the boundary?”

Madan Mishra looked at Devnarayan for a few moments, then said quietly, “The inspection team will be on official duty.”

“Their slip?”

Madan Mishra did not answer.

On Monday the site-verification team arrived: an amin, a Panchayat worker, and an assistant. The amin carried a measuring tape, but before measuring could begin another problem arose—the exact position of the old western channel could not be established.

Devnarayan showed them the rear courtyard. The ground was slightly lower in one corner. Durganand Jha said, “The channel must have been here.” Ramlochan called from outside, “No. That is a rainwater hollow.”

The amin measured twice, then rolled up the tape. “Classification of the joint household is difficult without permanent boundary demarcation.”

The Panchayat worker asked, “Then what for now?”

The amin said, “Temporarily, recognise the existing practice.”

“What is the existing practice?”

Everyone looked at Devnarayan.

Devnarayan said, “In the morning I go to the cowshed, then carry the milk across the neem tree to the cooperative. At noon I go to the field. In the evening I return to the cowshed. Malti moves between both sides of the courtyard all day. The children cross according to the school and the shops.”

The amin wrote in the register: “Movement customary according to local practice.”

The assistant asked, “Is this to be treated as permission?”

The amin said, “This is a fact.”

“The rule?”

“Seek clarification from above.”

This time Madan Mishra did not smile either.

Three days later a new order came from the Block Office. The boundary remained where it was, but “ordinary activities of daily life” were exempted from slips. Which activity counted as ordinary would be decided by the Assistance Point.

The queue beneath the neem tree became shorter. Milk, school, water, livestock, and fields were all treated as ordinary. But whether attending a wedding was ordinary or special was debated for two hours. One man wanted to go to a feast at his sister’s house; Madan Mishra finally issued a yellow slip.

Devnarayan now filled fewer slips. But the old yellow, green, and blue slips remained tied together with thread on a nail in his house. Malti wanted to throw them away. He said, “Keep them for now. The rules may become clearer again.”

The rains came. Water dripped from the neem leaves. The table at the Assistance Point was moved under the veranda. Water flowed along the road. No one could say where the old western channel had been; the new water found the low ground and flowed where it would.

One evening Devnarayan was returning home with the empty milk can. Madan Mishra sat alone beneath the neem tree, drying the pages of the register. Out of habit, Devnarayan slowed down.

“Slip?”

Madan Mishra raised his head. He thought for a moment, then said, “Ordinary today.”

Devnarayan crossed the road and walked toward his house. Beneath his feet, the water kept flowing between the two areas without stopping.

STORY 264

Verification

...

Tilak Paswan reached the Social Security Branch of Khajauli Block before nine on Monday morning. He was the first person on the long bench in the veranda. Beside him lay an old green cloth bag containing his old-age pension passbook, voter identity card, ration card, two old land-revenue receipts, and the previous year's life-verification slip.

Tilak's age was recorded as eighty-two. The older men of the hamlet estimated that he was two years older than that. Tilak had no particular concern about those two years. His concern was simply that his monthly pension had stopped for three months, and the bank clerk had told him: "Life verification is pending."

"I have come myself," Tilak told the branch clerk, Ramkrit Yadav. "What greater verification can there be than this?"

Ramkrit looked at the register. "A person being present is one thing; the process being complete is another."

"Where is the process?"

"First, residence must be verified at the site."

Tilak opened the bag. "This is my ration card. This is my voter card. These are the land receipts."

"The papers show the address. Site verification will show that you are still living there now."

Tilak nodded. "Let the verification man come to my house tomorrow. I will remain at home."

Ramkrit said, "I do not give the date. The employee will go according to the field sequence."

Tilak returned home that afternoon. In Pipra hamlet he had a small mud-and-brick house. His wife had died five years earlier. His son worked as a labourer in Punjab. Tilak himself looked after five katthas of land, cut grass for his cow twice a day, and in the evening blew life into the hearth and cooked rice and dal.

For the next three days he did not go far from home. On the fourth day his medicine ran out, so he had to go to the market. That very afternoon Panchayat Assistant Subodh Mandal arrived for verification. The door was

locked. Neighbour Janki Devi said, “He has gone to the market. He will return by evening.”

Subodh wrote in the register: “Not found at home.”

Tilak heard about it that evening. The next morning he went to the Panchayat building.

“What happens now?”

Subodh said, “There will be a second visit.”

“After how many days?”

“According to sequence.”

“Should I remain at home again?”

“If you do, it will be convenient.”

“For pension verification I should sit at home? What about the field?”

Subodh did not smile. “I do not make the rules.”

In the second week a notice came from the Block Office that in Tilak’s old pension register his father’s name was entered as “Ramphal,” while in the voter record it was “Ramphal Paswan.” The two had to be reconciled. Tilak went to the Block Office again. Signatures of two witnesses were required. He returned to the village and the next day brought Janki Devi and Ramvilas Sahni with him.

That same day the second site verification took place. Tilak’s door was again locked.

This time Subodh asked Janki Devi’s daughter-in-law, “How long has he been away?”

She replied, “He was here until yesterday evening. Today he has gone to the Block Office for verification.”

Subodh paused for a few moments. “Not found at home for verification.” Then he wrote in the register: “Absent during second visit as well.”

At the Block Office Tilak reconciled his father’s name in front of the two witnesses. Ramkrit said, “The name issue is clear now. We still need the site-verification report.”

“The employee has gone twice.”

“Did he find you?”

“I was here.”

Ramkrit looked at the register. “Then the report will say absent.”

Tilak placed the green bag in his lap and sat silently on the bench. After a while he asked, “I am present here, but absent at home. Which presence counts?”

Ramkrit answered, "The one belonging to the box that is being verified."

Before the third visit Tilak tried a solution. In thick charcoal letters on the door he wrote: "I AM ALIVE. I HAVE GONE TO THE BLOCK OFFICE FOR VERIFICATION. I WILL RETURN IN THE EVENING." Beneath it he wrote the date.

Unfortunately, the third visit did not take place that day. It took place five days later. Tilak was then in the field cutting the ridge of his paddy plot. Subodh read the old date written on the door and asked a neighbourhood child. The child said, "Grandfather has gone to the field."

Subodh wrote in the register: "Not found at residence during third visit either; prolonged absence suspected."

The effect of three months without pension was plainly visible in Tilak's house. The fertiliser dealer had stopped giving him urea on credit. He had to halve the oilcake for the cow. Janki Devi lent him rice twice, but Tilak did not want to stretch out his hand a third time. He would say, "The money will come later. First let the paper say that I exist." Janki Devi laughed at the sentence, but Tilak did not. It seemed to him that his field, house, neighbours, cow, and body were all witnesses to his presence; only the office column had not yet decided.

That one line began a journey of its own. In the Panchayat's monthly list Tilak's name moved from the column "Eligible for Re-verification" to "Status Unclear." The list reached the Block Office. The Block summary offered only three options: "Alive," "Dead," "Shifted." There was no separate box for "Status Unclear." There was a space for remarks below, but thirty pages of the monthly list had to be sent that same day.

Assistant Navalkishore read "Not found at home" three times. On the next page was the name of an elderly person who had actually died, with "Dead" marked against it. Tilak's line was left blank. The list reached the Branch Officer. Seeing the empty line, the Branch Officer wrote in red ink: "Indicate status." The list came back to Navalkishore. He turned through the register, read "prolonged absence," and put a mark in the "Dead" column. In the remarks below he wrote: "Repeatedly absent at site."

The Pension Branch placed a permanent stop order on payment on the basis of that list. The monthly status list also went to the Birth and Death Branch, because when an old-age pensioner was identified as dead, other family benefits were updated. There the clerk asked, "Date of death?"

It was not on the list.

Navalkishore was asked. He looked at the date of the first site-verification visit—the day Tilak had not been found at home. “Status doubtful from this date,” he said.

The clerk in the Birth and Death Branch replied, “A doubtful date is not a date of death.”

“Then leave it blank?”

“A certificate cannot be made with the date blank.”

The matter remained pending for two days. On the third day the new monthly list had to be prepared. There was pressure to clear old pending entries. Finally, the date of the first visit was entered, the remark “As per administrative verification” was added, and the death certificate was printed.

Meanwhile Tilak had made four more journeys to the Block Office for his life verification. On the fifth journey Ramkrit said, “Now the problem has become serious.”

“The pension?”

“Your status in the record is dead.”

At first Tilak did not understand. “Whose?”

“In your name.”

“Me, myself?”

Ramkrit lowered his eyes. “A certificate has been made in the Birth and Death Branch.”

Tilak gripped the green bag tightly. “I have been coming here to get myself verified as alive.”

“I know.”

“Where was I on the day they say I died?”

Ramkrit turned the pages of the register. The date was the same as Tilak’s first application. On that day Tilak had signed at the Block Office at 9:12 in the morning.

For a moment no sound passed between them.

Ramkrit said, “The death certificate will have to be cancelled. After that the life verification can be reopened.”

“What papers are needed to cancel my death?”

“Proof of the applicant’s presence, two witnesses, a Panchayat report, and the original death certificate.”

Tilak did not laugh. “Where will I get the original death certificate?”

“From the Birth and Death Branch.”

He went to the adjoining building. The clerk checked the register. "The certificate is ready but has not been collected."

"Who can collect it?"

"A member of the family."

"Can I take it?"

The clerk first looked at Tilak, then at the register. "The certificate is in the name of the deceased person."

"The name is mine."

"That is what it appears to be."

"Then give it to me."

The clerk called the Senior Assistant. They discussed the matter for five minutes. In the end the certificate was handed over on the ground that Tilak was a member of the same family and the address was the same. In the receipt register Tilak wrote his own name.

On the certificate his name, father's name, village, and age were all correct. The date of death was the very day he had first come to the Block Office for life verification. Under place of death it said: "Own residence."

Tilak did not fold the paper. He placed it flat inside the bag so that the seal would not be damaged. Then he returned to the Social Security Branch.

Ramkrit wrote out the application for cancellation. Instead of using a thumb impression, Tilak signed with his trembling hand. The names of two witnesses were needed again. It was decided that Janki Devi and Ramvilas would be brought the next day.

"Will there be site verification again?" Tilak asked.

Ramkrit said softly, "For cancellation, yes."

"This time should I remain at home or come here?"

Ramkrit's hand stopped over the pen. "Remain at home."

"And if you call me here?"

Ramkrit did not answer. At the top of the application he wrote: "Applicant personally present."

Tilak rose. In the green bag, beside last year's life-verification slip, there was now this year's death certificate. Crossing the veranda, he opened the bag once and looked at both papers. The old slip said: "Verified Alive." The new paper said: "Death Certified." Between them lay today's application, bearing Ramkrit's words: "Applicant personally present."

He closed the bag and set off for home. For the next site verification, this time he had to be found there.

STORY 265

The Closed Lift

...

The Regional Cooperative Building in Darbhanga had six storeys. The building was not new, but its lift was. In the old building people had once climbed the stairs; three years earlier a lift had been installed under an “Office Accessibility” scheme. At first there were six round buttons inside—I, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6. No one had any objection to that arrangement.

The trouble began when an order came from headquarters stating that floor numbers were “meaningless indicators” for ordinary visitors. The numbers were to be removed and the names of the branches written on the buttons instead, so that people could directly choose the branch where they had work.

During the first week the buttons were labelled Accounts, Stores, Grants, Legal, Records, Officer. At first the arrangement pleased Dinbandhu Mandal, the records carrier. For eighteen years he had carried files up and down the building. Earlier someone had to tell him, “Third floor.” Now he could simply be told, “Grants.” The lift itself would take him there.

But in the second week there was a departmental reorganisation. Accounts was to move to the fifth floor, Stores to the second, Grants to the fourth. Moving employees and cupboards took time, but the paper labels on the buttons were changed in a single evening.

On Monday Dinbandhu carried a payment file and pressed “Accounts.” The lift stopped on the fifth floor. When the door opened, he saw two empty desks, three sacks of bundled papers, and a board reading: “Accounts Branch—Under Transfer.” Only Ramvinod Babu was sitting there.

Dinbandhu asked, “Is Accounts here?”

Ramvinod said, “According to the order, it is here.”

“The staff?”

“Still on the second floor.”

“Then where should I go?”

“For work, the second floor. According to the records, the fifth.”

Dinbandhu returned to the lift. There was no longer any button called “second floor.” He pressed “Stores,” because under the old arrangement Stores

had been on the second floor. The lift stopped on the fourth. A new board there read: “Stores—To Be Shifted Shortly.”

Dinbandhu came down again. Beside the gate, security guard Muneshwar Paswan had a sheet hanging near him: “Today’s Branch Position.” It had been crossed out and rewritten in pencil several times.

“Where is Accounts?” Dinbandhu asked.

Muneshwar looked at the sheet. “According to this list, second.”

“There is no second-floor button in the lift.”

“Using numbers is prohibited.”

“Then how do I get to the second floor?”

Muneshwar thought for a moment. “Press Records. Records is on the second floor at present.”

Dinbandhu pressed “Records.” The lift stopped on the second floor. He reached the Accounts Branch with the file.

By noon the trick had spread through the whole building. Employees began remembering not the branch name, but the old branch that occupied the present location of the branch they wanted. Someone would say, “If you want Legal, press Stores.” Someone else would say, “For Stores, press Officer.” Inside the building, one branch began to be reached through the name of another.

On Tuesday another order came from headquarters. Branch names too were to become “function-based.” Accounts would now be called “Payment Scrutiny,” Stores “Material Verification,” Grants “Scheme Approval,” and Records “Record Preservation.” New paper labels were pasted on the lift buttons.

At ten in the morning Dinbandhu pressed “Payment Scrutiny.” The lift went to the fifth floor. By then two Accounts cupboards had reached the fifth, but half the staff were still on the second floor and half on the fifth. The Head Clerk said, “If the file concerns payment, leave it here. If it requires verification before payment, take it downstairs.”

“Which button for downstairs?”

The Head Clerk raised a hand. “I no longer know the names of the lift buttons.”

On Wednesday a new notice was put up in the building: “Floors shall be identified only by approved branch names. Use of old numbers creates confusion.” The 2, 3, 4, 5, and 6 painted on the stairwell walls were whitewashed over.

That day Dinbandhu kept a small piece of paper in his pocket. On it he wrote: “Payment Scrutiny = fifth. Material Verification = fourth. Scheme Approval = third. Record Preservation = second.”

At a quarter to two, an employee from Building Management came and announced that “Scheme Approval” would now occupy half of the fifth floor because water was leaking from the ceiling on the third. Dinbandhu crossed out five and wrote three, then crossed out three and wrote five. The paper soon contained more crossings-out than branch names.

On Thursday two buttons inside the lift bore the same name: “Scheme Approval.” One button had earlier been Grants, the other Officer. The employee who pasted the labels had left one old sheet in place.

Dinbandhu pressed the first “Scheme Approval.” The lift stopped on the third floor. Water was dripping from the ceiling there and four buckets stood beneath it. The branch had already moved away.

Dinbandhu pressed the second “Scheme Approval.” The lift went to the sixth floor. The Joint Registrar’s room was there. The attendant said, “Scheme Approval is on the fifth floor.”

“Then this button?”

“I am not sure either. It looks as though a new label has been pasted over an old button.”

At the words “not sure,” Dinbandhu fell silent. There was no button in the lift for guesswork.

On Friday morning there was a crowd at the building gate. The lift door was closed. A white sheet pasted over it said: “Use Suspended Due to Annual Safety Inspection.”

Employees turned toward the stairs. At the first landing half of the old “2” could be seen beneath the whitewash. At the second, the “3” was almost completely covered. People began climbing according to their own estimates.

An elderly farmer asked, “Where is Payment Scrutiny?”

Dinbandhu paused before answering. “It should be on the fifth today.”

“Where is the fifth?”

Dinbandhu looked toward the stairs. The numbers had been painted over. He said, “Count five turns upward.”

The old man went on, counting.

At half past ten the technical team arrived to inspect the lift. The team leader asked how to reach the machine room. “Where is the sixth floor?”

Muneshwar said, “Use of numbers has been discontinued.”

The technician did not laugh. "Our machine measurements are based on numbers. First stop, second stop, third stop. Changing the names does not change the length of the cable."

Muneshwar showed him the office order. The technician showed his own sheet. It clearly said: "Inspection of stops 1 through 6."

The two papers did not understand each other.

In the end Dinbandhu led the team upstairs, searching for the old digits beneath the whitewash on the stairwell walls. At the third landing, scratching the lime with a fingernail revealed half the loop of a "4." On the fifth, the lower part of a "6" remained. The technician entered the stop numbers in his register as he went.

After the team went upstairs, the Building Management assistant told Dinbandhu that scratching the wall had not been proper. Dinbandhu asked, "If the numbers cannot be seen, how will the team count the stops?" The assistant said, "Temporary direction boards could have been installed."

The next day direction boards were indeed installed. But they carried no numbers, only arrows and branch names. Beneath the first arrow was written "Payment Scrutiny," beneath the second "Scheme Approval." By the time one reached the fifth landing, one arrow pointed toward an old branch, because after the board had been made the branch had again moved by half a floor. Dinbandhu did not touch the board. According to the order, it was the approved direction.

At two in the afternoon the inspection was completed. Mechanically, the lift was sound. The cable, doors, bell, and braking mechanism all worked. But the certificate contained one line: "Permanent stop identification shall be clearly displayed on each button."

The team leader examined the buttons. There were two marked "Scheme Approval," one "Material Verification," one "Payment Scrutiny," one "Record Preservation," and one whose paper label was half peeled away.

"These are not permanent identifiers," he said.

The Building Management assistant said, "The names will keep changing according to departmental orders."

"Then what stop should I write on the certificate?"

"The branch name."

"My form requires numbers."

"Numbers are prohibited."

The technician remained silent for a few moments. Then on the last line of the certificate he wrote: “Machinery functional; verification of stop identifiers pending.”

The lift door was closed again.

By Monday everyone in the building had learnt to use the stairs. Someone had written small numbers in charcoal over the whitewash. The cleaner wiped them off in the morning; by afternoon someone had written them again. When asked where a branch was, Dinbandhu now said, “Two turns up,” “four turns up,” “right at the top.”

On Tuesday a new order came: small numbers could also be written beside the branch names on the lift buttons, but the numbers would be deemed “for internal technical purposes only.”

Building Management had six small round slips printed—1 through 6. As soon as the slips arrived, another problem arose: which number should be pasted beside which name, because the third phase of branch relocation was to take effect on Wednesday.

It was decided that the number slips would be pasted after the third phase came into force.

On Wednesday the order implementing the third phase was suspended. The suspension order said: “Present position shall continue until further instructions.” But it did not state the date whose position was to be treated as the “present position.”

The lift remained closed.

On Friday evening Dinbandhu was coming downstairs with the last file of the day. On the ground floor, through the narrow gap between the white doors of the closed lift, the buttons inside could be seen. The paper branch labels were peeling away at the edges. Beneath them the old round numerals still shone—1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6.

Dinbandhu looked at the numbers for a few moments. Then he tucked the file under his arm and turned toward the first flight of stairs.

STORY 266

The Blank Seal

...

In the District Small Industries Assistance Office in Madhubani there was a seal on which nothing at all was written.

Its wooden handle was old, worn smooth by use. The rubber underneath was neither round nor square—something close to an oval. Pressed into blue ink and stamped on paper, it produced only a blurred violet outline, with not a single letter inside. The people in the office called it “the blank seal.”

But though the seal was blank, its authority was not.

Any paper bearing that seal moved to the next desk without question. If the seal was missing, someone or other would write in red pencil: “Required seal absent.”

Mukund Mishra had newly joined the office as a clerk. Earlier he had worked in the Cooperative Branch at Benipatti, where every seal bore clear words—Received, Checked, Payment, Copy. During his first week here, nothing surprised him more than the blank seal.

On Monday an application for assistance with sikki craft came to his desk. It was from Champa Devi of a village near Rahika. Five women worked together making baskets, maunis, and small boxes from sikki grass. They had applied for assistance to buy colour, a bamboo platform for drying sikki, and two small tools for the next market fair.

The papers were complete—the group register, bank details, training certificate, village recommendation, and cost estimate. Mukund sent the file to the next desk.

Ten minutes later it came back.

Across the top, in red, was written: “Blank seal required.”

Mukund asked the elderly clerk sitting beside him, Jagdish Babu, “What exactly does this blank seal certify?”

Jagdish Babu pushed up his spectacles. “That the paper is in order.”

“In order in what sense?”

“That it may go forward.”

“And why may it go forward?”

Jagdish Babu looked at Mukund’s face for a few moments. Then he said slowly, “Because the blank seal is on it.”

Mukund thought he was being teased. But Jagdish Babu went back to reading his file.

The blank seal was kept in a small iron box. The box lay in a drawer of the Head Assistant's desk, though the drawer was never locked. Four or five times a day different clerks took the seal, pressed it into the ink pad, stamped a paper, and returned it to the box.

Before stamping Champa Devi's application, Mukund asked again, "What is its official name?"

Head Assistant Ramlochan Thakur said, "It is an old practice."

"Is 'practice' its name?"

"Does the work proceed by the name, or by the seal?"

Mukund fell silent.

He stamped the paper. A violet outline appeared. There was nothing in the middle. The file went to the next desk and this time did not return.

After that Mukund's attention remained fixed on the blank seal. Looking through old files, he found the same blurred outline on papers five years old. On some files ten years old the outline was darker, but the centre had been empty even then. On one old payment order the impression was so clear that even a small crack in the rubber could be seen, yet there was not a single letter.

One day Mukund examined the stores register. Fifteen seals were listed there—Receipt, Dispatch, Payment, Verification, Officer, Branch, Copy. The blank seal was not listed.

"Then how did this become government property?" Mukund asked.

Stores Clerk Harisharan said, "If something has no name, under what name can it be entered in the register?"

"Write 'Blank Seal.'"

"That is not an official name."

"What is the official name?"

Harisharan suppressed a smile. "That is what you are trying to discover."

Mukund wrote a short note: "The purpose and authority of the letterless seal in current office use may kindly be clarified."

The note went to the Head Assistant.

Ramlochan Thakur read it. He picked up his pen, then put it down.

"Why is this question necessary?"

"We stamp papers with it. We ought to know what we are certifying."

"Suppose I write that it means Verification, and later it turns out that this was a Receipt seal. Then what?"

“What about all the old papers?”

“That is exactly why I am asking. Thousands of papers bear this seal. If we assign it the wrong meaning now, the meaning of thousands of papers becomes wrong.”

Mukund said, “But no meaning is written on it at all.”

Ramlochan Babu looked up. “That is why everything is safe.”

The note remained on his desk for three days. On the fourth he wrote above it: “Position may be clarified from old records.”

The Records Branch replied: “Use of this seal is found in old records; order relating to its institution is unavailable.”

The file returned to the Head Assistant. He wrote: “Existing practice may continue while search for the source proceeds.”

Meanwhile the blank seal continued to be used exactly as before.

Champa Devi came to the office a second time. The papers for the first instalment of assistance to her group were in the Accounts Branch. But the Accounts Clerk asked for one further certificate—a confirmation that the group was functioning.

Champa said, “All five of us women are sitting outside in the veranda. You may look if you wish.”

The Accounts Clerk said, “Seeing is one thing. A paper is required.”

The certificate was prepared. Mukund saw that it too required the blank seal.

“What will be certified on this paper?” he asked Jagdish Babu.

This time Jagdish Babu laughed. “You have started again?”

“That the group is functioning?”

“Possibly.”

“That the signature is correct?”

“That too is possible.”

“That the paper has been received?”

“That as well.”

“Then this one seal says all three things at once?”

Jagdish Babu picked up the seal. “When nothing is written on it, what can contradict it?”

Mukund stopped his hand. “I will not stamp this certificate until its meaning is clarified.”

That day the certificate remained on his desk. It stayed there the next day too. On the third day Champa came again. The fair was only four weeks away.

The group needed the advance to buy colour and sikki. Two of the women had already borrowed money.

“How many more days?” Champa asked.

Mukund answered plainly, “The meaning of the seal is not clear.”

Champa remained silent for a few moments. “Will our money come only after the meaning of the seal is understood?”

Mukund gave no answer.

That evening he took the blank seal out of the box and examined it carefully. There was not even a trace suggesting that letters had once existed on the rubber surface. The centre was smooth. Only a thin raised rim ran around the edge, producing the violet boundary on paper.

The next morning Mukund carried the file to Ramlochan Thakur. “I am not stamping this certificate.”

Ramlochan Babu asked, “Why?”

“I do not know what I would be certifying.”

“You will not be certifying the meaning of the seal. You will be certifying the office practice.”

“And the authority for that practice?”

Instead of answering, Ramlochan Babu opened a drawer and took out an old register. He showed an entry from twenty years earlier: “Special Office Seal —I.”

“This may be it,” he said.

“Is any description available?”

“No. No description at all.”

“And is this blank seal the same one?”

“No one here is old enough to say with certainty.”

“Then how do we proceed?”

Ramlochan Babu closed the register. “If you stop this, it will not be only this certificate that stops. Questions will arise over every file bearing this seal. Will you take responsibility for that?”

Mukund looked toward the veranda. Champa and the four women with her were sitting there with small sikki baskets in their cloth bags. To pass the time, one woman was threading red yarn around the rim of a basket.

Mukund picked up the seal.

“What should I write to say that I have seen it?” he asked.

Ramlochan Babu said, “Nothing. That is what the seal is for.”

Mukund pressed it into the ink pad and stamped the certificate. A violet outline appeared. The file went to Accounts. Two days later the first instalment for Champa Devi's group was sanctioned.

But the file containing Mukund's note was not closed.

A month later a reply came from headquarters: "The purpose of the locally used seal shall be determined by the concerned office itself on the basis of records."

The office records had already stated that the order establishing the seal was unavailable.

Below the reply Ramlochan Babu wrote: "Record basis insufficient. Previous practice to continue unchanged."

Mukund asked, "What does this 'unchanged' mean?"

"It will continue as it has been continuing."

"For how long?"

"Until the meaning is found."

"When will the meaning be found?"

Closing the file, Ramlochan Babu said, "When the practice is stopped."

Three months later a district inspection took place. The inspectors examined every desk, register, store item, and pending file. At the end one inspector's eye fell on the iron box.

"What is in this box?"

Ramlochan Babu opened it. The blank seal lay inside.

The inspector took it out and turned it over in his hand. "Why is nothing written on this?"

No one in the room answered.

Mukund thought: this was the question he had been waiting three months to hear. But as soon as it was asked, his own note, Champa Devi's payment, the twenty-year-old register, and thousands of old papers all came to his mind at once.

The inspector asked again, "What does this do?"

Ramlochan Babu said very softly, "It is a seal in established office use."

"For what purpose?"

"The matter of its purpose was under consideration at headquarters."

"What did headquarters say?"

Ramlochan Babu placed the relevant file before him.

The inspector read the entire file: the headquarters reply, the Records Branch note, and then looked again at the blank seal.

After a while he wrote in the inspection register: "History of the letterless seal in current use is unclear. In order that continuity of past records not be disturbed, existing practice may be continued until separate instructions are issued."

He signed beneath it.

Ramlochan Babu pushed the register toward Mukund.

Mukund did not understand.

Ramlochan Babu pointed toward the blank seal. "Office seal on the inspection remark."

For a moment Mukund looked at the inspector. The inspector had already begun reading another file.

Mukund pressed the seal into the ink pad. Beneath the new inspection remark appeared a violet outline. In the middle, as always, there was nothing.

That evening, while closing the iron box, Mukund noticed a fresh stain of ink on the handle of the blank seal. He wiped it away with a cloth. The rubber surface became clean again. The next morning the first file arrived on his desk. Across the top, in red letters, was written: "Required seal absent." Mukund opened the drawer. The blank seal was in its usual place inside the box.

STORY 267

The Night Order

...

At one in the morning, in Belahi Panchayat of Lakhnaur Block, the thak-thak of the watchman's stick was heard. It was a night in Bhadon. After a day of oppressive humidity, a light wind had begun to move around midnight. Most houses in the village had gone to sleep. In one courtyard cattle were chewing cud; elsewhere red embers lay buried in the ash of a half-dead hearth. In that stillness the sound of the stick came first from far away, then nearer, lane by lane.

"Head of the household, come outside," called Ramvriksh Paswan, the watchman. "There is a night order."

Devkant Mishra first thought there must be a fire somewhere. Gathering his dhoti, he came outside. Ramvriksh held a bundle of blue papers. Each was folded in half, with a round government seal at the top. He handed one copy to Devkant and moved toward the next house.

"What does it say?" Devkant called after him.

Without turning, Ramvriksh said, "I do not understand it. I have only been ordered to distribute it."

Devkant opened the paper in the light of a lamp. At the top, in Devanagari numerals, was written: "Night Order 72/A." Beneath it were five lines in a script he had never seen before. The letters were neither rounded nor square; in some places two strokes crossed each other, in others tiny dots appeared in groups of three. At the very bottom there was only one sentence in Devanagari: "Compliance status shall be submitted by 9:00 a.m."

His wife Malti came outside. "What is in the order?"

"That is what I cannot understand."

"Then what are we supposed to comply with?"

Devkant looked again at the paper. "In the morning I will go to the office and find out."

"The compliance status is due by nine. Not the understanding."

At that sentence, both fell silent.

The night order did not go only to Devkant's house; it went to every house in Belahi. Until two in the morning dogs kept barking, doors opened and shut, and the blue papers were turned over again and again in the light of lamps,

lanterns, and torches. Someone said it must be a flood warning. Someone thought it concerned animal vaccination. Someone assumed it was an order for land measurement. No one recognised the script.

At six in the morning five copies of the blue paper lay on one table at Budhan's tea stall. The script was the same on all of them; only the serial numbers differed.

Retired teacher Ramanand Jha put on his spectacles and studied them for a long time. "This is not Maithili, not Hindi, not Nepali, not Urdu."

Budhan asked, "English?"

Ramanand shook his head. "Not even English letters."

"Then in which language is a government order written?"

No one had an answer.

By seven a crowd had gathered in the veranda of the Panchayat building. Panchayat Secretary Prabhakar Jha arrived at eight. The same blue paper lay on his desk. People surrounded him from all sides.

Devkant held out his copy. "Tell us what it means."

Prabhakar Jha first looked at his own paper, then Devkant's. "I received mine during the night too."

"Do you understand it?"

"No."

"Then who sent the order?"

"From above."

"From where above?"

Sitting down in his chair, Prabhakar said, "From the Block Office."

Devkant immediately went to the Block Office. Ramanand Jha, Jagarnath Yadav the milk seller, and Sushila Devi from the self-help group went with him. At the gate of the Block building, fifty or sixty people were already standing with blue papers in their hands. On the notice board inside, a fresh notice had been posted: "Separate instructions awaited for clarification of meaning regarding Night Order."

Reading it, Sushila Devi said, "Instructions explaining the meaning are awaited, but compliance status is required by nine. Which of the two comes first?"

The gate employee shrugged.

At 8:20 the Block Development Officer's assistant came outside and announced, "All citizens shall fill in and submit the compliance-status form. Necessary corrections may be made once clarification of meaning is received."

Ramanand Jha asked, "How can we state compliance without understanding the meaning?"

"The form has three options—full compliance, partial compliance, compliance pending."

"Compliance with what?"

The assistant was silent for a few moments. "With the order."

A low laugh moved through the crowd, but no one laughed openly. The assistant too had a blue paper in his hand.

Forms were distributed. Devkant stared for a long time at the three options. In the end he marked "Compliance Pending." Ramanand Jha left his blank. Jagarnath chose "Partial Compliance."

Devkant asked, "What did you comply with?"

Jagarnath said, "After receiving the order last night, I did not take the cattle outside. If the order concerns livestock, then half of it has been complied with."

Sushila Devi smiled. "And if the order was to take the cattle outside?"

Jagarnath's face became serious. He thought of changing his form to "Compliance Pending," but the ink mark had already been made.

At nine the window closed. A total of three hundred and twenty-seven compliance-status forms had been submitted. The office immediately prepared a register: full compliance 41, partial compliance 93, compliance pending 176, no option selected 17.

"What did the forty-one people claiming full compliance actually do?" Devkant asked.

The clerk said, "That is a separate question. Here we count the status."

At noon the first clarification arrived from the district. It was one page long: "Night Order 72/A has been issued in Standardised Administrative Sign-Script. A local-language translation will be distributed when an authenticated copy becomes available."

Ramanand Jha read the phrase "Standardised Administrative Sign-Script" three times. "Who has been taught this script?"

Secretary Prabhakar said, "Presumably someone in the higher offices."

Instead of telephoning, the Block assistant checked the telegram-message register. There was no translated copy there. Another written reply came from the district office: "The sign-script standard manual had been dispatched separately."

"Where?"

“A dispatch number is given.”

The dispatch number was traced. Three months earlier, a thick file under that number had reached the Block Office. Receipt was entered in the stores register, but where the file had been kept was unclear. Two hours later it was found on top of a cupboard containing old election materials.

Everyone became hopeful. The file was opened. Inside was a booklet titled: “Standardised Administrative Sign System—Part 2.”

Part 1 was missing.

On the first page of Part 2 the instruction read: “For meanings of basic signs, consult the index in Part 1.”

Ramanand Jha leaned back in his chair. “Then what can Part 2 tell us?”

The assistant turned the pages. “It contains the format for compliance reporting.”

Secretary Prabhakar said quietly, “That we already received.”

By three in the afternoon different interpretations of the order had spread through the village. Someone removed hay stacked outside the house. Someone stopped the children from going near the river. Someone did not take livestock to market. One farmer postponed spraying pesticide in his field. Sushila Devi cancelled the self-help group’s meeting for the day.

In the evening the Block Office issued a fresh notice: “Until an authorised translation is received, citizens shall, in their own discretion, refrain from any act that may run contrary to the possible objective of the original order.”

Devkant read the notice and asked, “What is the possible objective of the original order?”

Prabhakar Jha said, “Whatever the objective might possibly be, do not act against it.”

“And what about something that could not possibly be the objective?”

“Nothing has been said about that.”

Devkant returned home. Malti asked, “Did you understand it?”

“Not yet.”

“Then what will we do tonight?”

Devkant hung the blue paper beside a peg. “We will do whatever we normally do. But while doing it, we will keep thinking whether it might be against the order.”

Malti did not laugh. “If we keep thinking that way, will ordinary work remain ordinary?”

By ten that night the village had become unusually quiet. For fear of unknowingly breaking a rule, people postponed small decisions. Budhan closed his tea stall early. Jagarnath tied the cattle inside the cowshed. Two young men returned home instead of sitting at the pond steps. No one knew which, if any, of these acts had anything to do with the order.

At exactly one in the morning, the thak-thak of the stick was heard again.

Watchman Ramvriksh was once more distributing blue papers. This time all the lines were in clear Maithili. Devkant lit the lamp and read: "For verification of compliance status regarding dated Night Order 72/A, citizens shall inform in writing by 9:00 a.m. tomorrow whether the order was understood and complied with, or whether compliance status was submitted without understanding its meaning."

One more line appeared below: "The authorised translation of Night Order 72/A will be dispatched separately."

Malti read over Devkant's shoulder.

"Now what will we write?"

Devkant took down the first blue paper from the peg. Its five lines in the unknown script were still as silent as before.

He hung the second paper beside it. Both bore the same government seal—one could not be understood; the other could be understood, but merely asked about the meaning of the first. Devkant kept looking from one to the other for some time.

"At least this one can be understood," he said.

Outside in the lane, Ramvriksh's stick moved on toward the next house.

STORY 268

The Invisible Tax

...

In Ward Twenty-Four of Madhubani Municipal Council, Shambhunath Sah had a small bicycle-repair shop at a bend in the road. A tin awning projected over the front, two old seats stood inside, circular shadows of tyres marked the wall, and an air hose hung from a bamboo peg. The house was behind the shop. His wife Phoolkumari went to the vegetable market in the mornings, his son Anshu studied at the high school, and his elderly father Ramlochan spent most of the day on the veranda of the house.

One Monday the postman delivered a yellow envelope. On it was written: “Integrated Civic Facilities Tax—Notice of Arrears.”

At first Shambhunath thought it must be the Municipal Council’s property tax. He knew that tax. He paid it once a year and kept the receipt wrapped separately in cloth inside an iron chest.

But when he opened the envelope, the amount stated was one thousand seven hundred and sixty-four rupees. The name of the tax was again the same —“Integrated Civic Facilities Tax.” In the space for basis there was only a thin line. The rate column also had only a thin line. Under period it said: “Current Period of Existence.”

Phoolkumari read the slip twice.

“What is a ‘period of existence’?”

Shambhunath said, “Perhaps it means this year.”

From the veranda Ramlochan said, “My period of existence has been going on for eighty years. Will that be taxed too?”

No one laughed. At the bottom of the slip, in bold letters, was written: “Failure to pay by the prescribed date may result in temporary suspension of civic existence facilities.”

The next day Shambhunath went to the Municipal Council. There was no long queue at the service window of the Tax Branch. Only three people stood ahead of him, each holding a differently coloured slip. When his turn came, the clerk looked at the notice, asked his name, opened a thick register, placed a thumb on one line, and said, “Yes, one thousand seven hundred and sixty-four.”

“Tax on what?”

“Integrated Civic Facilities Tax.”

“On what basis is this tax imposed?”

The clerk looked at the left page of the register, then the right. “The basis comes from the district.”

“It is not written here?”

“The amount is written here.”

“The rate?”

“The rate must be in a separate register.”

“Where is that register?”

The clerk said calmly, “Not with me.”

Shambhunath asked, “Then how am I to know what I am paying for?”

For the first time the clerk raised his eyes fully toward him. “You know the amount. That is enough for payment.”

Shambhunath did not pay. He filled out a form asking for the basis of the tax. The form asked: “Is your objection to the amount of tax or to existence?” There was a small square before each option. Shambhunath held his pen still for some time, then marked “Amount.” The idea of objecting to existence seemed strange to him.

Four days later the Municipal Council’s garbage-collection vehicle stopped near the shop. The worker collected refuse from the lane but left the bamboo basket placed in front of Shambhunath’s house.

Phoolkumari came out and asked, “Why did you leave this?”

The worker held a small list. He found the name. “The facility for your house shows as suspended.”

“Is garbage collection an existence facility?”

The worker shrugged. “I was given a list. If there is a red dot against a name, I do not take that basket.”

That evening, at the ration shop, Phoolkumari’s family card did not get caught in the machine but in the shopkeeper’s newly printed list. The name was written as before, but beside it was printed: “Inactive.” The shopkeeper sat with a sack of rice open.

“I know all of you,” he said, “but the register is not active. If I give you rice, the accounts will not match.”

The next day notice came from Anshu’s school that scholarship verification had been stopped because the family’s civic-facility status was temporarily inactive. The Headmaster knew Shambhunath personally. He said, “There is no restriction on studies. Only the facilities linked to the system will stop.”

“How many facilities?”

The Headmaster returned the slip. “Ask the Municipal Council that.”

Shambhunath went back to the Tax Branch. The reply to his tax-basis application was not ready.

“How long will it take?”

The clerk said, “The basis has been requested from the district.”

“Why are my facilities stopped until then?”

“There are arrears.”

“Why are there arrears?”

“Because tax has been imposed.”

“Why has the tax been imposed?”

The clerk was silent for a few moments. Then he closed the register. “The basis statement will answer that question.”

Shambhunath considered paying. Garbage, ration, scholarship—the trouble was becoming greater than one thousand seven hundred and sixty-four rupees. But when he brought cash to the service window, a new problem appeared. The clerk said the arrears had been recalculated that day.

“How much now?”

“One thousand two hundred and ninety-eight.”

“How did it decrease?”

“The integrated facilities have decreased.”

Shambhunath stared at him. “You suspended the facilities, so the tax went down?”

“I only see the amount.”

“If you suspend every facility, will the tax become zero?”

The clerk did not laugh. “I do not make estimates.”

Shambhunath again did not pay. By now he had become more determined to know the rule of calculation than to know the amount.

Within a week his membership in the municipal library was deactivated, though he hardly went there twice a year. Ramlochan’s name disappeared from the list for elderly travel concessions. When the Municipal Council tap in front of the house broke, a complaint was filed, but the reply came: “Complainant family not on active facilities list.”

Phoolkumari said, “You have not understood the tax, but the tax is understanding all of us.”

Shambhunath said nothing.

At the end of that week another irony arrived at the door. A Municipal Council employee came with the old property-tax register. He saw that the dimensions of the house, the tiled section, the tin awning, and the small courtyard at the back were already recorded, and demanded the ordinary annual property tax.

Shambhunath asked, "My family is inactive. How is this house active?"

The employee laughed. "The house is taxable property. The family's facility status is a separate matter."

"No one is treated as living in the house, yet tax is charged on the house?"

"Who said no one is living there? In my register, you are the owner."

Shambhunath immediately took hold of the slip. "If I show this name to the Civic Facilities Branch, will they treat the family as active?"

The employee shook his head. "This is only a property-tax receipt. It proves that the property is taxable."

"The owner?"

"The owner's name is written."

"Is the owner alive?"

The employee stopped his pen. "That is not my subject."

Shambhunath paid the ordinary property tax. The receipt clearly printed his full name, his father's name, and the house address. That afternoon he took the receipt to the Civic Facilities Branch.

The clerk examined it carefully, turned it around, and handed it back.

"This proves the existence of the property."

"And mine?"

"Your name is associated with the property."

"Then the family?"

"The family is inactive in the facilities list."

Shambhunath did not fold the receipt. He walked out holding the paper flat in his hand.

On the twelfth day the tax amount fell again, to seven hundred and twelve rupees. On the fifteenth, to three hundred and thirty-six. On the twentieth, the clerk at the service window looked at the register and said, "The arrears are now zero."

For the first time relief appeared on Shambhunath's face.

"Then all the facilities will be restored?"

The clerk shook his head. "No. The family is inactive."

"But the arrears are zero."

“Yes, zero.”

“Then why the suspension?”

“Facilities are for active families.”

“Activate us.”

The clerk opened another register. He found Shambhunath’s name. The family number was there, but the status read: “Existence-facility relationship terminated.”

“Reconnect the relationship.”

“For that you need an Active Family Certificate.”

“Where do I get an Active Family Certificate?”

“From the Civic Facilities Branch.”

“What does that branch require?”

The clerk turned the page. “Certificate of zero tax arrears, proof of residence, and an active facility number.”

Shambhunath asked slowly, “And how do I get an active facility number?”

“Once you are active.”

The clerk said this in the ordinary tone one might use to say that water remains on the road after rain.

Shambhunath asked for a certificate showing zero tax arrears. The fee was twenty rupees. The certificate clearly stated: “Integrated Civic Facilities Tax: Zero.” In the line for reason it said: “Tax basis unavailable.”

“Why is the tax basis unavailable?” Shambhunath asked.

The clerk said, “An inactive family does not generate a basis.”

“Was there a basis earlier?”

“There was an amount.”

“The basis?”

The clerk again gestured toward the district.

This time Shambhunath did not go to the district. He returned home.

The house was still there. The tin awning over the shop was still there. Ramlochan was sitting on the veranda. Phoolkumari was sorting masoor in the kitchen. Anshu had his book open. In the evening two people came to have their bicycles repaired. A child pumped air into a tyre and, without being told, hung the hose back on the bamboo peg.

Three days later the reply to his tax-basis application came by post. Shambhunath tore open the envelope. Inside was one sheet:

“The requested basis is unavailable in current records. Since the concerned family’s facilities relationship stands terminated, tax calculation is not applicable.”

Beneath it was a new line: “To ascertain the basis of previous calculation, an active family number is required.”

Shambhunath folded the paper and placed it in the iron chest beside the property-tax receipt.

That evening the garbage vehicle came down the lane again. The workers lifted the baskets from every house. When one reached Shambhunath’s house, he checked the list, searched for the red dot, and stopped. “Your name is not here anymore,” he said. Shambhunath stood holding the basket in his hands. “Then what happens?” The worker folded the list. “If the name is not there, it does not say suspended either.” “Will you take it?” The worker opened the list again. “To take it, there has to be a name.” The vehicle moved on. Shambhunath placed the basket back beside the door. When the night wind rose, the dry leaves lying on top blew into the lane. He caught two and put them back in the basket. A third crossed the road and disappeared into the darkness.

STORY 269

The Wrong Date of Birth

...

The day Ramudit Mandal came to the District Handicrafts Assistance Centre in Jhanjharpur to apply for the Senior Artisan Honorarium, his bag contained three small bamboo objects—a sample winnowing tray, a shallow basket, and a half-finished mauni. There was no rule requiring him to bring such things with his papers, but Ramudit had always preferred to introduce himself less through words than through the work of his hands.

The clerk at the service window read the application, then searched for Ramudit's name in the electronic register. Two minutes later his eyebrows drew together.

"You have applied for the Senior Artisan Honorarium?"

"Yes, the senior honorarium."

"For that, you must be sixty years old."

Ramudit laughed. "Then how old does it show me?"

The clerk turned toward the screen. "Thirty-eight."

Ramudit stopped laughing. "My eldest daughter is forty-five."

The clerk looked at the screen again. "Your date of birth here is 12 July 1988."

Ramudit reached into his bag and took out an old artisan identity card kept inside a plastic cover. The paper had yellowed, but the blue letters were still legible: Name: Ramudit Mandal. Craft: Household articles made of bamboo and cane. Registration date: 12.7.88.

The clerk compared the two dates.

"Look. The date entered in the system as your date of birth is actually the date of your registration."

Ramudit said, "Then the mistake is clear. Correct it."

The clerk immediately shook his head. "Understanding that there is an error and proving the correct date of birth are two different things."

The rules for the Senior Artisan Honorarium required two things: sixty years of age and at least thirty years of craft experience. Ramudit's experience field had filled automatically: thirty-eight years and two months. His age field showed almost the same.

The clerk himself remained silent for a few moments. Then he said, "Your experience is complete. Your age is not."

"If I am thirty-eight years old, how can I have thirty-eight years of experience?"

"They are two separate fields."

"But the date is the same."

"I can see that."

Ramudit's application was sent to the Correction Branch. The branch was at the far end of another veranda. The assistant there first asked his current date of birth, then his actual date of birth. Ramudit said he had been born in the dark fortnight of Bhadon, in a year when the old channel of the Kosi had risen twice. No one in the family had written down the day. He estimated the year from his marriage, the birth of his eldest daughter, and the flood of 1987.

The assistant said, "A date of birth cannot be corrected on an estimate."

Ramudit produced a certified copy of his eldest daughter's birth register. It recorded Shanti's birth in 1981, with Ramudit Mandal named as her father.

The assistant examined it. "This paper proves only that in 1981 you were Shanti's father."

"And that I was born in 1988?"

"This paper does not say that."

Ramudit brought out a second paper: an old copy of the 1995 electoral roll. His age there was recorded as thirty-six.

"By this calculation, I must have been born around 1959."

The assistant examined the list carefully. "It gives an age, not a date of birth."

"The year of birth can be derived from the age."

"An approximate year can. What about the day and month?"

Ramudit fell silent.

The third paper was a flood-relief register. In 1987 Ramudit had been entered as head of the household; his wife, two children, and elderly mother were listed as family members. Seeing this page, the assistant softened a little.

"Looking at all this, the present date of birth does appear to be wrong."

"Then correct it."

"What authenticated date should I enter in its place?"

For the first time Ramudit faced a problem in which removing a falsehood required an entire day, month, and year of truth. He remembered the season of

his birth, the story his mother had told, and the estimates of old people in the village, but no old paper carried a date.

The Correction Branch accepted the application and wrote to the Records Room to trace the “source of the original entry.” Three days later Ramudit was called again.

During those three days his own work had also been held up. He had an order for a wedding in the village: twenty winnowing trays, ten baskets, and five large dauras. Strips of split bamboo were drying in the sun in his small courtyard. On an ordinary day he wove for four hours in the morning, split bamboo in the afternoon, and evened the rims in the evening. Now, with two trips to the office, the strips dried too much and became hard. His wife Devkali sprinkled them with water and covered them with cloth.

Devkali asked, “Will the paper be corrected before the wedding is over?”

Ramudit said, “The paper says I am still young. The work says I am getting late.”

That day someone from the wedding household came to ask about the advance order. Ramudit pushed the delivery date two days forward. The man agreed, but while leaving he looked at a half-finished daura and said, “Your hands are still as quick as ever.”

Ramudit did not reply. The slip certifying thirty-eight years of experience kept turning in his mind.

In the Records Room, a thick register, a grey copy of his old artisan identity card, and a record-conversion list had been placed on the table. Nowhere on the old page was Ramudit’s date of birth recorded. It contained only the registration date, 12.7.88, and his age at registration: “approximately twenty-nine.”

The Records Assistant showed him a line in the conversion list. Years earlier, when the old registers had been transferred into the electronic system, there had been an instruction that the date-of-birth field must not be left blank. Where no date of birth was found in the record, the earliest available date was entered as a “reference date.”

Ramudit’s earliest available date had been his registration date, 12 July 1988. In the first conversion list, the word “reference” had appeared in small letters beside it; in a later system that separate marker had ceased to display, leaving only the date.

Ramudit asked, “So at first this was not a birth date, only a reference?”

“That is what the old list says.”

“And now?”

“Now it is in the date-of-birth field.”

“Then the root of the mistake has been found.”

The Records Assistant said, “The root has been found. The corrected date has not.”

“Then leave the date of birth blank.”

“The field cannot remain blank.”

“Enter the estimated year.”

“Day and month are compulsory.”

“So I am being treated as born on the day I was registered?”

The assistant closed the register. “The system treats it that way. I do not.”

For Ramudit, the difference was very small, because the honorarium would be granted by the system.

A week later a three-member committee sat for correction review. Ramudit was called inside. The first member examined the old papers one by one. The second sat with the electronic register open. The third asked, “What is your actual date of birth?”

Ramudit again said, “The dark fortnight of Bhadon. Around 1959.”

“Around is not acceptable.”

“Then do you accept that my daughter was born in 1981?”

“There is a document. We accept it.”

“That in 1987 I was head of a household?”

“We accept it.”

“That in 1988 I was registered as an artisan?”

“We accept it.”

“And that on that very day I was born?”

None of the three answered at once. The second member kept searching on the screen. At last the first said, “That is what the present entry says.”

“Then the papers are quarrelling with one another.”

“Papers do not quarrel. They record different facts.”

The review committee’s decision ran to two pages. The first page stated that the source of the present date of birth appeared to be the artisan-registration date and that the entry could not be considered reliable. The second page stated that in the absence of acceptable proof of birth, no new date of birth could be entered. The conclusion read: “Present entry to remain unchanged pending correction.”

Ramudit asked, “What does unchanged mean?”

The clerk said, “Until an authenticated date is found, 1988.”

“Then the Senior Honorarium?”

“Your age is not complete.”

“My experience?”

The clerk took out another slip. “Thirty-eight years and two months certified.”

Two sheets lay before Ramudit. On one: age—thirty-eight years. On the other: craft experience—thirty-eight years and two months. Both rested on the same original date—12 July 1988.

Gathering the papers, the clerk said, “Your application cannot proceed under the senior category. But there is a new skill-upgradation camp for registered artisans below forty. You are automatically eligible.”

For a moment Ramudit thought it was a joke. The clerk’s face remained still. He printed a third sheet: “New Artisan Upgradation Camp: Participant—Ramudit Mandal.”

“What will they teach there?” Ramudit asked.

The clerk read from the list. “Selecting bamboo, splitting it, making thin strips, weaving the base of baskets and winnowing trays.”

Ramudit opened his bag. He took out the half-finished mauni and placed it on the desk. The bends of the strips were so fine that the clerk instinctively touched them with a finger.

“You made this?”

“Yes. With my own hands.”

The clerk placed the mauni back in the bag. He handed Ramudit the camp sheet, the experience certificate, and the correction-review decision together, fastening them at the top with a small metal pin.

Back home, Ramudit took the old artisan identity card out of the iron chest. The date 12.7.88 was still clear. Beside it he placed the new camp paper. On the two documents the same date remained alive with two different meanings—on one, the work had begun; on the other, the man. Ramudit did not close the chest. In the evening light he picked up a thin strip of bamboo, split it down the middle with his thumbnail, and resumed weaving the unfinished rim of the mauni.

STORY 270

One Door Less

...

Seen from the road, Nandkishore Sah's house in the old quarter of Benipatti Nagar Panchayat looked quite ordinary. There was a narrow veranda in front, two rooms behind it, a courtyard in the middle, and a small workshop to the west where his wife Manjula made bamboo baskets and winnowing trays. The house had two doors: one opening toward the main road, the other from the courtyard into a narrow lane at the back. Through the rear door passed long bamboo lengths, straw, bicycles, and in the rainy season shoes caked with mud.

Nandkishore had never thought there was anything unusual about having two doors. His grandfather used to say that the rear door had been there since the house was built. At different times wedding parties had gone out through it, sacks of paddy had passed through it, even a sick calf. In the history of the house, the door had simply done its work; it had never asked for a name.

One Monday a yellow paper arrived from the Nagar Panchayat. At the top was written: "Building Record Conformity Campaign." Below it were Nandkishore's house number and one line: "Compared with the approved digital plan, one additional door is visible. Submit an explanation within seven days."

Nandkishore read the paper twice. Then he walked through the courtyard to the rear lane and looked at the door. The wood was old, there was an iron nail in the middle plank from his father's time, and a small stain of soot above it. The door stood where it always had. He could not understand since when it had become additional.

The next day he went to the Building Branch of the Nagar Panchayat. The young man at the service desk opened the house number in the electronic register. A blue-line plan of the house appeared on the screen. There was a small mark at the front. The rear wall was shown as one unbroken straight line.

"Look," the young man said. "There is no door here in the plan."

"But there is one in the house."

"That is the problem."

"When was this plan made?"

The young man checked the date. "Three months ago, during record conversion."

“The house is seventy years old.”

“The digital plan is the currently approved record.”

Nandkishore asked, “What was this plan based on?”

The young man opened another page. “The old property-tax sketch.”

Nandkishore did not laugh. He remembered that tax sketch. Twenty years earlier an employee had stood outside the house and written down its length and width. That paper showed no rooms, windows, or courtyard—only a rectangular boundary and one small mark for the front entrance.

“That was a paper for calculating tax,” Nandkishore said.

“Now it is also the basis of the building record.”

“So whatever was not drawn on that paper has now become illegal?”

The young man thought for a few moments. “I can only tell you what is visible here.”

For the explanation there were three options: close the door, produce the old approved plan, or apply for an amendment. Nandkishore returned home to search for the old approved plan. The iron chest, bamboo box, bundles of clothes, land papers, tax receipts—everything came out. No approved plan from the time the house was built was found. No one could remember with certainty whether, when his grandfather had built the house, approval of plans had even been required in that neighbourhood.

At the bottom of the chest he found an old partition deed. It described the western boundary as: “Along the shared rear passage.” Nandkishore felt a little hope. At least this would prove that passage at the rear had existed from long ago. He took the document back to the Building Branch. The clerk read it, examined the seal and the date.

“This proves there was a passage at the back,” the clerk said.

“If there was a passage, there must have been some way to go out to it.”

“That is an inference.”

“Did we climb over the wall?”

The clerk did not laugh. “The paper does not say door.”

Nandkishore put the document back in his bag. On his way home he entered through the rear lane. Three old houses opened onto that narrow passage. The doors of two had been replaced recently; his own was the oldest. A shallow drain for rainwater also ran in the same direction along the lane. For the first time it occurred to him that what he had regarded all his life as an ordinary passage existed, in the eyes of paper, only as an inference.

Manjula was splitting bamboo beside the rear door. She asked, “If we close it, how will the bamboo come in?”

“Through the front.”

“The front door is only three hands wide. Long bamboo cannot turn there.”

Nandkishore measured it. She was right. Immediately behind the front door there was a turn. The rear passage ran straight to the workshop.

He decided to apply for an amendment. On the third day he went again to the Building Branch. The amendment checklist required proof of ownership, tax receipt, existing plan, proposed plan, structural-safety certificate, and “copy of previously approved plan.”

“There is no previously approved plan. That is why I need an amendment,” Nandkishore said.

The clerk placed a finger on the list. “An amendment is made on the basis of an earlier approval.”

“And if there was no earlier approval?”

“Then first establish the earlier condition.”

“How?”

“Through the previously approved plan.”

Nandkishore turned the list toward himself and read it again. The words remained the same.

At last he was shown the route of a “site inspection.” An inspector would see the house, estimate the age of the construction, and after that special consideration might be possible. Five days later the inspector arrived. He entered through the main door, crossed the courtyard, opened the rear door, and looked into the lane.

He examined the old wood of the shutters, the layers of lime on the wall, and the wear on the frame.

“This is not new,” the inspector said.

Nandkishore felt lighter. “Then write that.”

The inspector opened his measuring tape. “It is old, but it is additional to the plan.”

“Does its age make no difference?”

“Age and legality are different matters.”

The inspection report came: “Door appears to be of old construction; archival approval unavailable; inconsistent with current digital plan.” At the end was the recommendation: “For regularisation, amendment or closure.”

The amendment again got stuck on the same old plan. Tired, Nandkishore asked, “What if I close the door?”

“Then compliance photographs and site verification,” the clerk said.

“And after that the matter ends?”

“From the Building Branch’s side.”

Nandkishore returned home and called a mason. Manjula did not want the whole opening bricked shut. Finally they decided the shutters would be removed and the opening walled up. But when the mason measured it, another fact emerged. The house’s main drainage channel also passed out through that part of the rear wall. If the door were bricked shut, there would be no access from inside to clean the drain.

“Turn the drain another way,” Nandkishore said.

The mason studied the slope of the courtyard. “Then the courtyard water will run toward the front of the house. In the rains the veranda will flood.”

Nandkishore went back to the Nagar Panchayat, this time to the Sanitation Branch. The employee examined the sketch of the house and said, “Access must remain open for inspection of the main drain.”

“The access is through this very door.”

“Then why are you closing it?”

“The Building Branch says I must.”

The employee read the Building Branch order, then opened his own rulebook. “I will say nothing about the door. I need access to the drain.”

“If I leave a small opening in the wall?”

“Large enough for a person to enter and clean it.”

Nandkishore asked, “If the opening is large enough for a person to enter, will it not be called a door?”

The employee suppressed a smile. “The Building Branch will know that.”

The following week the Building Branch and Sanitation Branch conducted a joint site inspection. The two employees stood beside the same rear doorway. The Building Inspector said, “This must be closed.” The Sanitation employee said, “Access to the drain must remain open.”

“Then how much should be closed and how much left open?” Nandkishore asked.

The two looked at each other. The measuring tape came out again. At last a temporary solution was written down: “Shutters shall be removed; permanent use for movement shall cease; service opening for drain inspection shall be retained.”

Nandkishore read the paper. “How large should the service opening be?”

“There is no measurement in the rule,” the Building Inspector said.

“Smaller than a door?”

“Naturally.”

“Large enough for a person to enter?”

The Sanitation employee said, “Essential.”

Two days later the mason removed the shutters. The frame was not taken out, because removing it might break the edge of the wall. Within the frame, bricks were laid to a height of two feet from the bottom; the upper portion was left open, so that a person could bend and reach the drain. Manjula watched.

“And now the bamboo?” she asked.

Nandkishore lifted a long bamboo pole. He tried to raise it over the two-foot wall and pass it through the opening above. The bamboo got stuck. Neither of them laughed.

Three days later the compliance inspection took place. The Building employee took photographs and wrote: “Additional door closed; service opening retained.” The Sanitation employee wrote on the same spot: “Drain access available.” Both signed.

In the Nagar Panchayat’s electronic register, the status of Nandkishore’s building turned green: “Conforms to plan.” In the new digital image, the rear wall was again a straight line. No opening was marked.

That evening Manjula sat in front of the workshop splitting bamboo. Nandkishore went toward the rear wall. There were no shutters. The frame was still there. Two feet of brick rose from the bottom, and above it was a narrow rectangle of open sky. He bent, placed one foot on the brickwork, and climbed through the service opening into the rear lane.

Standing outside, he turned and looked back at the house. The house truly had one door less now. But at the place where the door had been, he could still go in and out—the only difference was that the paper no longer called it a door.

STORY 271

Return

...

Twenty-four years earlier, Devnarayan Mandal had left Belauncha village in Jhanjharpur to earn a living elsewhere. He had been twenty-two then; the roof of the house was tiled, two mango trees stood in the courtyard, and there was more black than grey in his mother Saraswati Devi's hair. He found work in a loom factory in Surat. At first he had thought he would return in two years, but two became five, five became ten, and after ten the measure of time began to run through receipts for money sent home by post, festival leave, and letters arriving from the village.

This time, when the factory closed, he decided that he would now live permanently in the village. He gathered a metal trunk, two bundles, a small sewing machine, and twenty-four years of papers, travelled by passenger vehicle to Darbhanga, from there to Jhanjharpur, and then by shared vehicle to Belauncha. As soon as he got down near the pipal tree outside the village, the first new thing he saw was a yellow board on the wall of the Panchayat building: "Registration of Returning Residents Compulsory. Verification Required Before Permanent Re-entry."

Devnarayan laughed. What verification could be needed to return to one's own village? But the driver said, "Babu, first get your name entered at the Panchayat. Otherwise ration, house number—everything will get stuck."

He left the trunk for safekeeping on the veranda of a familiar tea shop and went to the Panchayat building. A young man sat behind a long table. In front of him was a computer screen; beside it were three registers and a red seal. Devnarayan gave his name. The young man searched.

"Devnarayan Mandal, son of the late Ramparikshan Mandal?"

"Yes, I am Devnarayan."

"Your village-exit serial number?"

Devnarayan did not understand. "What serial number?"

"The exit entry made when you left the village. Its serial number."

"I left twenty-four years ago. There was nothing like that then."

The young man pointed to a field on the screen. "The returning-resident entry will not open without the old exit number."

"I was born here. My house is here. My mother is here."

“That proves residence. For return, it must also be proved that you had previously left the village.”

For the first time Devnarayan thought of an ordinary event in his life as something requiring proof. He had left—the fact was known to him, to his mother, to the entire neighbourhood, to the factory in Surat. But where was the paper proving the sentence: he had left?

He went back to the tea shop and opened the metal trunk. Clothes lay on top; beneath them was a bundle of old receipts. There were money-order receipts, factory wage slips, a worker identity card, and two old rent receipts for his room in Surat. He took them all to the Panchayat.

The young man examined each paper. “All of these prove that you lived in Surat.”

“Then they also prove that I had left.”

“No. Under the rule, ‘previous exit’ is a separate thing.”

“If I lived in Surat, I must have left Belauncha.”

“That is an argument. I need evidence.”

A faint smile replaced the tiredness on Devnarayan’s face. “Then what paper should I bring?”

The young man opened a list. “Exit slip, old Panchayat entry, or statements from two witnesses who directly remember the event of your leaving the village.”

Devnarayan asked, “Will a railway ticket do?”

“If it is the ticket from that day.”

“Who keeps a ticket for twenty-four years?”

The young man did not answer. The list said a ticket was acceptable evidence; whether a ticket could survive twenty-four years was not a matter for the rule.

The first witness he found in the neighbourhood was eighty-year-old Vaidyanath Kaka. “Yes, I remember you leaving,” he said. “Your father went with me as far as the station.” But when asked for the date, he scratched his head. “Was it Sawan or Bhadon? The Kamla rose twice that year. How am I to remember the exact day?”

The second witness was Siyaram Jha, an old schoolteacher. He remembered Devnarayan clearly. “You left school after Class Eight, then worked in the fields for two years, and after that went away for work.” He too could not give a date.

On the Panchayat witness form, the day, month, and year were all compulsory. The young man said, "The event is remembered, but the system will not accept it without a date."

"I do not remember the date either."

"Then search the old records."

The old records were in a back room of the Panchayat building: dusty registers in bamboo cupboards, electoral rolls, tax receipts, family registers. Devnarayan and the young man searched for his name for three hours. In the family register from twenty-four years earlier, his name was present. In the register five years later, the word "away" had been written in pencil beside it.

Devnarayan brightened. "Here is the proof."

The young man examined the register carefully. "This proves that you were away."

"That is what I have been saying."

"But it does not say on what day you left."

"Why do you need the day?"

"Without an exit entry, the return entry cannot be made, and the exit entry requires a date."

In an old electoral roll his name appeared in one year and disappeared from the next. In the ration register his mother, father, and younger brother remained, while Devnarayan's name had been struck out; the reason column was blank. The young man said, "Deletion of a name proves absence, not exit."

Devnarayan remembered the old postman, Bhola Yadav. Bhola Kaka was now retired and lived at home. His signatures appeared on the receipts for money Devnarayan had sent from Surat. Devnarayan sent a young man on a bicycle to fetch him. Bhola Kaka came leaning on a stick, put on his spectacles, examined the old receipts, and laughed. "This is my signature. Once or twice a month money used to come in your mother's name. The whole neighbourhood knew you were earning in Surat."

The Panchayat clerk asked hopefully, "Did you see him leaving the village?"

Bhola Kaka shook his head. "No. When he left, I was posted in another postal area. I came here two years later."

"Then your statement will prove outside residence, not exit."

Bhola Kaka took off his spectacles and looked at Devnarayan. "Shall I write that he lived away for twenty-four years, but I cannot say whether he ever left the village?"

The young man said seriously, "Under the rule, that is all that can be written."

Bhola Kaka remained silent for a while. Then he lifted his stick and said, "Paper can see a very long way, but there is one road it cannot see." He went away.

Devnarayan came outside and sat on the veranda. The afternoon was waning. The village was only half a kos away. The tops of the mango trees were visible. His mother had already been told that her son was returning that day. His young nephew had twice come as far as the Panchayat to ask, "Uncle, when are you coming home?" The first time Devnarayan had said, "Just a little longer. The papers are being made." The second time he had only raised a hand. But in the Panchayat's reckoning the son still could not return, because it had not been recorded clearly enough that he had ever left.

An elderly farmer waiting beside a pillar for a copy of his land record had heard the story. He asked, "Is the village stopping you, or the paper?"

Devnarayan said, "Not the village. The register is stopping me."

The old man laughed. "Then go to the village."

"I can go. But if I reach home without reaching the register, I will have to come back here tomorrow."

After that answer, the old man too fell silent.

A little later the Panchayat Secretary arrived. The young man explained the whole matter. The Secretary examined the old entry marked "away," looked through the papers, and then at Devnarayan's face.

"The only problem is the date of the old exit?"

"Yes. Only that."

"Will the system not accept it without a previous date?"

The young man tried. Red letters appeared on the screen: "Certified date required for historical exit."

"Where will the certified date come from?"

"From the same exit slip that was never made."

The Secretary was silent for a few moments. Then he asked, "Can an exit entry be made with today's date?"

The young man's hand stopped. "It can. But he has returned today."

"Make the exit first. Then the return."

Devnarayan looked at the Secretary. "Where am I supposed to go again now?"

"Nowhere. The paper will go."

The young man opened a new entry. Name, father's name, house number, reason—"Long-term external employment." The system itself filled the current time of exit: 3:17 p.m. The entry was saved. For the first time, Devnarayan's official record stated that he had gone out of Belauncha.

One minute later the "Returning Resident" field opened. The young man checked the same papers again. Arrival time—3:18 p.m. Purpose—permanent residence. Verification—complete.

The machine produced two slips. The first stated that Devnarayan Mandal had left the village at 3:17 p.m. The second stated that he had returned permanently at 3:18 p.m. Between them lay one minute.

Handing over the slips, the young man said quietly, "The old twenty-four years will not appear in the record."

Devnarayan folded both slips and put them in his bag. "I have lived those years. Let the paper keep the one minute it needs."

He carried the trunk himself along the road to the village. He passed the pipal tree, reached the pond, and then his own neighbourhood. His mother stood at the door. Her hair was now almost entirely white.

Devnarayan set down the trunk and touched her feet. Saraswati Devi placed a hand on his head and asked only, "Where were you for so many days, son?"

Instead of answering, Devnarayan put a hand into his bag. The two slips were pressed against each other. The first said 3:17; the second 3:18. He put them back inside.

His mother was counting twenty-four years. The Panchayat, one minute.

STORY 272

Translation

...

At the northern edge of Madhubani district stood an old iron bridge over the Kamla River. On one side was the road toward Harlakhi; on the other, a small market and bus stand. In the rainy months, when the river swelled, orders to reduce the load on the bridge were issued from time to time. The villagers were used to such things. Bullock carts would move slowly, only one brick-laden vehicle would cross at a time, and no vehicle would stop in the middle of the bridge.

In the third week of Sawan that year, two iron plates beneath the bridge were found badly rusted. After inspection, the engineer wrote to the district office that loads needed to be restricted during the evening rush. The district issued an order. It was printed in four languages—Maithili, Hindi, Urdu, and English. Few people in the market read the English lines, and in any case their letters were the smallest, pressed beneath the government emblem at the top.

Block Office clerk Shashibhushan Jha received copies of all four versions together. He first read the Maithili: “After six in the evening, crossing the bridge with a load exceeding five quintals is prohibited.” Then his eye fell on the Hindi version. There the meaning was that vehicles carrying more than five quintals were not to cross the bridge until six in the evening.

Shashibhushan read both again. One prohibited crossing after six; the other prohibited it until six.

He called Accounts Clerk Abdul Sami to read the Urdu translation. Sami read it aloud slowly. In that version, the five-quintal limit applied only to goods vehicles, not to bullock carts. The newly appointed assistant Rashmi was called for the English version. She said the English text mentioned no time at all; it merely prohibited “commercial loads” above five quintals.

All four sheets were copies of the same order. All bore the same number, the same date, and the stamped signature of the same officer. The last line too was identical in all four: a fine of one thousand rupees for violation.

“Then which one applies?” Shashibhushan asked.

Abdul Sami turned the papers over. “Whichever language the original order was written in.”

“And which is the original language?”

None of the four copies answered that question.

That afternoon the order was posted at both ends of the bridge. Maithili and Hindi were fixed to one pillar, Urdu and English to the other. The first dispute arose at five in the evening. Budhan Sadai, a potter from Kaluar, was taking five baskets of earthen pots to market on a bullock cart. The bridge guard, looking at the Maithili copy, stopped him.

“Is it more than five quintals?”

Budhan looked at his oxen. “How would I know? Where is the weighing scale?”

The guard estimated. “Looks heavier.”

Budhan pointed to the Hindi copy. “This says the restriction is until six. It is only ten past five. You tell me to stop; this tells me the restriction lasts only until six. Which one should I obey?”

The guard’s job was not to interpret meaning; it was to record violations. He said, “I will follow the copy I was given.”

“Which language is your copy in?”

Instead of answering, the guard wrote down the cart number. Budhan was given a penalty slip. The slip was in Maithili, but the box for the reason was blank.

The next morning the problem reversed itself. At half past six, a small goods vehicle loaded with bricks reached the bridge. Under the Hindi wording, the time restriction had already ended. Under the Maithili wording, it had just begun. The driver, Suresh Yadav, read the Hindi notice and drove ahead. In the middle of the bridge, the guard from the opposite side stopped him; that guard was holding the Maithili copy. A second fine of one thousand rupees was issued.

On the third day two bullock-cart drivers pointed to the Urdu copy and said that version did not mention bullock carts at all. The guard could not read Urdu. He called Abdul Sami from the office. Sami came to the bridge and read the text aloud.

The guard asked, “Then should I let them go?”

Sami said, “I can read the translation. I have no authority to enforce it.”

Both bullock carts stood at the bridge entrance for half an hour. When the crowd began to grow, the guard let one cart pass and stopped the other, because the first carried paddy and the second bricks. No such distinction appeared anywhere in the order. But the guard had to make some decision.

In four days seven penalty slips were issued. All seven people came to the Block Office with objections. Shashibhushan spread the slips across the desk.

The reasons differed—time, weight, type of vehicle—but the amount was always the same: one thousand rupees.

Budhan Sadai asked, “In which language should I write my appeal?”

Shashibhushan said, “In whichever language you understand.”

“But what if the decision was made according to the meaning in another language?”

Shashibhushan remained silent.

That evening the office sent a letter to the district: “Implementation is difficult because the multilingual versions of the order differ in meaning. Kindly clarify the original authoritative text.” The letter was written in Maithili, because most Block Office employees understood Maithili.

Three days later the district replied in Hindi: “All certified translations shall be regarded as equally valid. Meaning shall be construed according to local circumstances. The penalty provision shall remain unchanged.”

Shashibhushan read the reply four times. Putting “equally valid” and “meaning shall be construed” in the same sentence had not made the problem smaller. It had made it larger.

Rashmi said, “If all meanings are valid, can a citizen choose the meaning most favourable to him?”

Abdul Sami said, “Then the guard can choose the meaning most favourable to him too.”

The following week a new board was placed at the bridge: “Order to remain in force until clarification is received.” This line was not translated. The office was afraid that the clarification itself might acquire four meanings.

But as soon as only one language was displayed, a new objection arose. The market traders’ association asked how people who could not read that language were supposed to understand the rule. Panchayat members pointed out that the whole purpose of issuing a multilingual order had been to make it understandable to everyone.

At last the district office called a “Translation Coordination Meeting.” The engineer, language assistant, legal clerk, Block representative, and bridge guard sat together. All four versions lay on the table.

The first hour was spent discussing “after” and “until.” The second went into “vehicle” and “commercial load.” The third was spent deciding whether the five-quintal limit included the vehicle’s own weight or only the goods it carried.

At last the bridge guard asked, “What are we supposed to do from this evening?”

The chair of the meeting said, "Until a uniform text is prepared, give priority to safety."

"Does safety mean stop everyone?"

"No. Use reasonable discretion."

"What is the written meaning of reasonable discretion?"

The chair looked at him. "Not everything is written down."

The meeting ended. A three-member subcommittee was formed to prepare a uniform text. Its first draft read: "All vehicles with a total load exceeding five quintals shall not cross the bridge after six in the evening."

Rashmi asked, "Who will weigh the total load?"

The word "estimated" was added.

Abdul Sami said that imposing a fine on an estimate would be difficult. Someone proposed adding "visibly." The legal clerk said weight could not be seen directly. The draft was held back again.

Meanwhile the number of penalty slips rose to twelve. Not one appeal had been decided, because it first had to be clarified which text had been violated. But the deadline for depositing a fine was seven days. Five people paid so that interest would not increase. Budhan Sadai did not. His earnings from pottery were less than one thousand rupees.

On the eighth day his name was added to the arrears list. He came to the office. "My appeal has not yet been decided. How can the fine already be in arrears?"

Shashibhushan looked at the register. "The penalty process and the appeal process are separate."

"The meanings of the order are separate, but the penalty is one?"

"There is no translation difference in the penalty line."

That was factually true. In all four languages the amount had been written as the numeral 1000. Numerals did not require translation.

Two weeks later a revised order arrived. This time there was only one sheet. At the top it said: "Original Text: Hindi." Beneath it were Maithili, Urdu, and English translations.

Shashibhushan read the Hindi first, then the Maithili. The Hindi said "after six in the evening." In the Maithili, because of a printing error, "until six in the evening" had appeared again.

For a few moments no one spoke.

Rashmi said quietly, "Should we not put this copy up at the bridge?"

Shashibhushan read the final line of the revised order: "Penalties imposed under the previous order shall remain valid."

He did not fold the sheet. He laid it flat and placed a weight on top of it.

That evening all four old notices were still hanging at the bridge. The Maithili copy lifted at one edge in the wind; the Hindi copy hung straight; rain had spattered the Urdu copy; dust lay on the English one. At the small table below them, the bridge guard was writing out a new penalty slip.

Budhan Sadai was returning that way with an empty bullock cart. He stopped and asked, "Which meaning applies now?"

The guard looked at the four notices, then at the number written on his slip. "The paper about the meaning is still in the office," he said. "The penalty slip is here."

STORY 273

The Order of the Empty Chair

...

The Agriculture Seed Subdivision Office of Madhubani district occupied an old brick building. On one side of the veranda was a service window for farmers; inside stood three desks, two cupboards, and, furthest forward, the chair of the Subdivisional Officer. The back of the chair had a dark-brown cushion, its arms were worn smooth, and a small bell stood to its right. Whenever the bell rang, the peon Manbodh came inside.

On the last Monday of Phagun, Officer Surendranath Mishra was transferred. The farewell took place in the afternoon: garlands, sweets, two speeches. Surendranath rose, patted the arm of the chair once, and said, "The new sahib will arrive in two or four days. Do not let the work stop."

Everyone heard that final sentence. But no one asked what written arrangement would keep the work from stopping.

From the next day, the chair remained empty.

The old practice of the office was that the branches wrote their small proposals on separate slips and placed them on the officer's desk by afternoon. At three, the officer read all the slips, struck out some things, changed others, and wrote "Approved" on some. Head Clerk Ramlochan Jha then combined the approved points into an office order, assigned it a number, the officer signed it, and Manbodh distributed the copies.

On the second day after the transfer, three slips were submitted. The first proposed sending five sacks of paddy seed from the Bisfi storehouse to the Rahika centre. The second proposed keeping the service window open until two in the afternoon. The third listed the employees who were to go on field inspection on Thursday.

At three o'clock Ramlochan looked at the slips, then at the empty chair.

"Will no order be issued today?" Assistant Clerk Chandramohan asked. "Who will sign?"

Ramlochan said nothing at first. Chandramohan added, "The seed has to reach there tomorrow."

Ramlochan picked up the first slip. He remembered what Surendranath had said two days earlier—do not let the work stop. He opened the old order register. The next number was 47. He had all three matters typed. The space for

the signature was left blank. Beneath it the designation was already printed: "Subdivisional Agriculture Officer."

"Without a signature?" Chandramohan asked again.

Ramlochan thought for a while. Then he wrote: "Post vacant—according to previous arrangement." In the right-hand corner he put his small initials.

Order No. 47 was issued. Five sacks of seed reached Rahika. The service window stayed open until two. The employees went to the field on Thursday. Nothing went wrong.

Because of that success, four slips arrived the next day. Seven came the day after that. By the end of the week every branch had understood that the officer's chair might be empty, but there was no reason for the order register to remain empty.

The manner of writing proposals changed too. Earlier people wrote "For consideration." Now they began writing "For orders." There was no person left to consider, but there was still a register from which orders could emerge.

Ramlochan made a rule: any proposal to which no branch raised an objection would go into the routine order. Objections had to be submitted in writing. No branch read another branch's slip in time. As a result, almost every proposal began to be treated as unopposed.

In the first week of Baisakh, Order No. 59 was issued: "Seed distribution hours shall be from 10:00 a.m. to 1:00 p.m." On the same day, Order No. 60 was issued: "All employees shall remain present for field-store verification from 11:00 a.m. to 3:00 p.m."

The next day the service window closed at eleven because all the employees had gone for verification. Outside, Sita Devi of Piprahi sat with samples from two sacks of defective maize seed. The seed had failed to germinate. It was the last day for filing the application.

Manbodh said, "There is an order. Everyone has gone out."

Sita Devi pointed to the other order pasted on the wall. "This one says the window will remain open until one."

Manbodh read both papers. "Both are orders."

"Then which one should I follow?" Sita Devi asked.

Manbodh said, "For you, the window order. For the employees, the verification order."

Sita Devi asked again, "How will the window remain open without employees?"

Manbodh had no answer to that. He looked toward the empty chair. The chair was still in its place that day too.

Sita Devi's application could not be submitted in time. The next day she went to Ramlochan. Ramlochan placed Orders 59 and 60 side by side.

"There is a conflict," he admitted.

"Whose orders are these?" Sita Devi asked.

Ramlochan opened his mouth to give the obvious answer, then stopped. "The office's."

Sita Devi asked again, "Who said it in the office?"

Ramlochan replied, "It is entered in the order register."

Sita Devi said, "Does the register speak?"

Chandramohan lowered his eyes.

After this incident Ramlochan drafted a clarification proposal: "When two orders apply at the same time, work relating to public service shall be given priority." The proposal was placed on the desk of the empty chair. No one wrote an objection for two days. On the third day it became Order No. 62.

But the Stores Branch wrote that on the fixed day for store verification, a district inspection took place, and therefore store verification should receive priority. The next order came: "Work connected with district inspection shall have priority equal to public-service work."

Chandramohan laughed and asked, "If the priority is equal, which comes first?"

Ramlochan said, "According to the circumstances."

Chandramohan asked again, "Who decides the circumstances?"

Ramlochan did not look toward the empty chair.

The chair, which had once been merely a place for one person to sit, gradually became an institution present in the office. Whenever an employee hesitated to take a decision, he would say, "Let an order come from the chair." Anyone wanting to make a proposal seem stronger would write, "Required at officer level." Even farmers began asking, "When will the chair decide?"

No one said that the chair itself did nothing. Everyone knew that the chair itself did nothing. The problem was that the orders issued on paper truly made things happen.

A month later a letter came from the district office. Appointment of the new officer was delayed; "daily work shall continue according to the existing arrangement." Ramlochan placed a copy of the letter on the desk of the empty chair. Those four words—according to the existing arrangement—became the greatest approval of all.

The order numbers kept rising. 71—seed complaints shall not be accepted without a sample. 72—farmers from distant villages may submit the sample

later. 73—no complaint number shall be issued before receipt of the sample. 74—no sample shall be deposited in the store without a complaint number.

Sita Devi came again. This time she carried a small bag of maize seed that had failed to sprout. Chandramohan was sitting at the service window.

“Complaint number first,” he said.

Sita Devi replied, “A sample is needed for the complaint number.”

Chandramohan said, “A complaint number is needed to deposit the sample.”

Sita Devi placed the bag on the table. “Then where will this stay?”

Chandramohan picked up the bag, carried it inside, and placed it on the desk of the empty chair. “Until a clear order comes.”

That evening, beside the bag, Ramlochan found a new proposal: “The sequence of sample receipt and complaint registration may be clarified.” Beneath it were the initials of three branches. No one had objected. It became Order No. 76: “Both processes shall be treated as complementary to each other.”

“The sequence?” Chandramohan asked.

Ramlochan said, “Complementary things do not have a sequence.”

In the last week of Jeth, the new officer finally arrived—Avinash Kumar. At half past ten in the morning Manbodh cleaned the old brown chair. There was no dust on it; because no one had been sitting there, it had become the cleanest object in the office.

Avinash sat down. His first question was, “Who issued office orders during the vacancy?”

Ramlochan placed two thick volumes of the order register before him. “Routine work was not allowed to stop, sir.”

Avinash turned the pages. “Where are the signatures?”

Ramlochan said, “It says ‘post vacant.’ There was a letter from the district directing us to continue work according to the existing arrangement.”

Avinash asked again, “Who approved these orders?”

Ramlochan replied, “Each branch proposed matters within its own subject. If there was no objection, the proposal became an order.”

Avinash read Orders 59, 60, 62, 63, and 71 through 76. He put a hand to his forehead and remained silent for a while. “All of these will have to be reviewed.”

He dictated a new order: “All orders issued during the period of vacancy shall remain in force until individually reviewed. No previous order shall be treated as immediately cancelled.”

Ramlochan asked, “Number?”

Avinash said, “The next one.”

Order No. 81 was issued. This time it bore Avinash’s clear signature.

At noon a message came from the district saying that the new officer was required to attend a three-day orientation in Darbhanga. Avinash left the next morning. As he went, he told Manbodh, “I will return. Let the routine work continue.”

At ten o’clock the first proposal arrived—once again asking for clarity on the sequence between Sita Devi’s sample and complaint. Chandramohan took the paper to Ramlochan.

“Sahib is not here,” he said.

Ramlochan opened Order No. 81. He read the line: previous orders remain effective until review. Then he remembered what Avinash had said while leaving—let the routine work continue.

Manbodh wiped the desk of the empty brown chair and placed the proposal there. By noon four more slips had accumulated on top of it.

At three o’clock Ramlochan opened the order register. The next number was 82. The chair was empty again. This time, however, it also had a signed order on its side.

STORY 274

Entry Pass

...

In front of the emergency building of Jhanjharpur Subdivisional Hospital, a thin red line had been painted across the entrance. Above it, a new board hung on the wall: "ENTRY TO EMERGENCY ROOM PROHIBITED WITHOUT ENTRY PASS." The board was so new that its white paint shone even in the muddy light of evening.

A little before seven that evening, four fellow workers brought Ramji Paswan, a mason's labourer from the Araria-Sangram side, on a bamboo cot. While working all day on the projecting roof of a new house, a bamboo plank had fallen. The weight had come down on Ramji's left leg; he could no longer stand. A folded gamchha had been placed beneath the leg. Sweat covered his forehead, but he was fully conscious.

His wife Phoolkumari came running behind them. In her hand was a small cloth pouch containing the house keys, two hundred rupees, and Ramji's old identity card.

As soon as the cot crossed the hospital gate, guard Vishwanath raised his hand. "Entry pass first."

Panting, Phoolkumari asked, "Where do we get it?"

Vishwanath pointed to the left of the red line. Behind a small window sat clerk Harinath. Before him were a stack of slips, a date stamp, and a thick register.

The cot was stopped two handspans outside the red line. Ramji closed his eyes. One of his co-workers, Bhola, went to the window.

Harinath asked, "Patient's name?"

"Ramji Paswan."

"Age?"

Bhola looked toward Phoolkumari. She said, "Above fifty. Fifty-two or fifty-three, perhaps."

Harinath wrote "Approx. 52" on the slip. "Village?"

"Araria-Sangram."

"Emergency number?"

Bhola asked, "What is that?"

Harinath stopped his pen. “The emergency number is issued after the preliminary examination inside. Without that number the entry pass cannot be completed.”

Bhola turned toward the red line. “Who will examine him inside?”

“The patient must first go inside.”

From where he stood, Vishwanath said, “No entry without a pass.”

For a few moments everyone was silent. Ramji opened his eyes and said, “Look at the leg later. Send my paper inside first.” There was more weariness than pain in his voice.

Inside the emergency room, nurse Malti heard the exchange and came to the door. Seeing the cot stopped across the red line, she grew irritated. “Why have you stopped the patient?”

Vishwanath pointed at the board. “There was an inspection three days ago. Two entry slips were missing from the register. I was given written instructions: no one goes inside without an entry pass.”

Malti stepped outside and examined Ramji. She touched the leg, checked his pulse, and told Bhola, “Keep the cot straight. Do not move the leg.” Then she called to Harinath, “Write emergency number 47.”

Harinath wrote 47 and completed the slip. Phoolkumari let out a breath of relief.

“Now inside?”

Harinath shook his head. “One thing remains. The entry pass must be entered in the arrival register.”

“Then enter it.”

Harinath pointed not to the register before him but to a desk inside. “This one here is the ordinary slip register. The emergency arrival register is inside. After the inspection, the order was that the register must not leave the emergency area.”

Malti said, “Give me the slip. I will enter it inside.”

Harinath reached out to hand it to her, but Vishwanath stopped him again. “Until it is entered in the register, it is not a valid entry pass. How can an invalid pass go inside?”

Malti stared at him. Vishwanath said quietly, “I did not make the rule.”

Harinath read the small order pasted beneath the board. The line was clear: “Only patients carrying a registered entry pass may enter the emergency area.”

Bhola said, “The slip is not the patient. Send the slip inside.”

Harinath replied, "For registration, the time of entry must be written on the slip."

"Write the time."

"The time is written when entry takes place."

"When will entry take place?"

"After registration."

Ramji closed his eyes again. Phoolkumari untied and retied the knot of her cloth pouch. The two hundred rupees were still there. She could no longer tell whether this place required more money or more patience.

Meanwhile the doctor inside, Aniruddh Mishra, came to the door. Malti explained the matter briefly. Aniruddh looked at Ramji and immediately stepped outside to begin first aid. One side of the cot was cleared and a splint was tied to keep the leg still.

"Take him inside," Aniruddh said.

Vishwanath folded his hands. "Sir, if you say so, I will carry him in. But if two slips are missing again tomorrow, my name will be written down."

Aniruddh looked at his face for a few moments. Then he asked Harinath, "Which line is causing the problem?"

Harinath explained: the register required an entry time; the entry time could be written only after the patient entered; but the patient could enter only after registration.

Aniruddh said, "Then leave the time blank."

Harinath showed him the second page of the order. "An incomplete entry is not valid."

"Estimated time?"

"There is no box for 'estimated.'"

Aniruddh did not laugh. "In this hospital, the boxes are always ready before the patient."

Malti brought the arrival register from inside but stopped at the red line. "This register cannot go outside."

Harinath pulled his chair away from the window and brought it up to the red line. He remained outside; Malti remained inside. The line lay between them. The register was in Malti's hands, the slip in Harinath's.

Bhola said, "Write it here itself."

Harinath asked, "Entry time?"

Everyone looked at Ramji again.

Ramji himself said, “Push the head of my cot inside. Half of me will stay outside, half inside. Then write the time.”

For the first time Bhola burst out laughing. Phoolkumari silenced him, but a faint smile appeared on Ramji’s face too.

Aniruddh said, “Do not make a joke of it. But if the rule asks when the body entered, then the time entry began is also a time.”

Vishwanath hesitated. Finally he allowed the front two legs of the bamboo cot, resting on the red line, to be pushed one handspan inside. Ramji’s head and shoulders crossed the line; his legs remained outside.

Harinath looked at the clock. “Seven eighteen.”

Malti placed the register on a table just inside the line. From outside, Harinath leaned forward and passed her the slip. The slip crossed the red line. Malti entered the name, village, and time against serial number 47.

“Now registered,” she said.

Vishwanath immediately moved aside. The cot went fully inside. Phoolkumari followed, but Vishwanath asked, “Attendant pass?”

Malti said sharply, “Let one family member come in.” This time Vishwanath allowed Phoolkumari through without looking at the board.

Ramji’s examination began. The bone in his leg was injured, but his condition was stable. A bandage, medicines, and rest were arranged. His co-workers sat outside on the veranda.

At eight that night Head Clerk Shashibhushan came to the emergency building after hearing about the inspection issue. His greatest concern was not that the patient had been registered while half inside and half outside; it was the time entered in the register.

“When did first aid begin?” he asked Malti.

“Around seven ten.”

Shashibhushan looked at the register. “Entry at seven eighteen. Then how did treatment begin eight minutes before entry?”

Aniruddh said, “The patient was outside, so treatment was given outside.”

“Where is that recorded?”

“On the treatment sheet.”

“But entry-pass number 47 became valid at seven eighteen. At seven ten the number was not yet valid.”

Malti asked, “Was the patient’s pulse supposed to wait eight minutes?”

Shashibhushan immediately said, “I am not talking about stopping treatment. I am only asking about the sequence in the record.”

After that sentence the argument softened, because everyone understood that no one was opposing treatment. The only problem was that the treatment had already happened and the paperwork was still searching for a sequence in which to accept it.

In the end Shashibhushan wrote a new note: "Necessary assistance provided in an emergency before completion of the entry pass shall be treated as 'pre-entry assistance.'"

Harinath asked, "Will there be a separate register for that?"

After thinking, Shashibhushan said, "For now, let the note remain."

The next morning an office meeting was held. The previous evening's incident was treated as an example for procedural improvement. It was decided that the arrival register would remain inside the emergency area, but its table would be placed exactly beside the red line. The slip would be prepared outside, entered in the register inside, and then the patient would enter.

Harinath asked, "And the entry time?"

The meeting was silent for a few moments. Finally it was written: "The time of entry in the register shall be treated as the time of entry."

On paper, the problem was over.

Three days later Ramji was discharged and returned home with the help of crutches. As they were leaving, Phoolkumari stopped near the red line. The table holding the arrival register now stood so close to the line that two of its legs were inside and two outside. Harinath sat on the inner side; people waiting to collect slips stood in a queue outside.

A new small board had also been put up that day: "Provide necessary assistance to emergency patients immediately." Directly beneath it another line read: "Record details of assistance along with the entry-pass number."

Phoolkumari could not read both lines. She merely adjusted Ramji's crutch and said, "Walk slowly."

Ramji crossed the red line. This time he had a discharge slip in his hand. No one asked his entry time.

STORY 275

The Closed Account

...

At half past ten on Tuesday morning, in the cooperative bank branch at Sakri Bazaar, Ramlochan Mahato stared for the first time so long at a page of his passbook. In blue letters across the middle was written: "Account operations suspended for security reasons." Beneath it, the balance was clearly shown: forty-two thousand six hundred and eighteen rupees. The money was still there, but Ramlochan could not withdraw even one rupee of it.

Ramlochan was a bamboo craftsman from a nearby village. He made wedding pavilions, mats for drying makhana, baskets for storing paddy, and bamboo winnowing trays for festivals. All year, his small earnings had gone into this account. This month he had to pay the apprenticeship fee for his younger daughter Sarita. He had therefore come to withdraw five thousand rupees.

When he reached the counter with the withdrawal slip, clerk Shambhunath entered it into the system, looked at the screen, and raised his head.

"The account is closed."

Ramlochan asked, "But the money is there."

"The money is there. Operations are closed."

"Why the security suspension?"

Shambhunath handed him a printed sheet. "Security review."

The sheet said that because of the possibility of unusual transactions, the account had been temporarily secured. Ramlochan thought back over the deposits of the last three months—two thousand, seven hundred, four thousand five hundred, and then once, twelve thousand. The twelve thousand had been payment for a wedding pavilion in Darbhanga.

"What is unusual in this?"

Shambhunath said, "I cannot tell you that. The details of the security reason are also kept secure."

"Then how will it be reopened?"

"Submit a reactivation application."

Ramlochan felt a little relief. The application was only one page: name, account number, address, signature. Shambhunath had him fill everything in and sent the paper to the Branch Manager's desk.

Half an hour later the answer came: the application was acceptable, but a reactivation fee of one hundred and eighteen rupees had to be paid.

Ramlochan took a two-hundred-rupee note from his pocket.

Shambhunath did not reach for it. "Not in cash."

"Then how do I pay the fee?"

"The fee will be deducted from this account."

Ramlochan remained silent for a few moments. "The account is closed."

"Yes. Operations are suspended."

"How will you deduct from a closed account?"

"The account will become active, then it will be deducted."

"When will it become active?"

"After the fee is deducted."

For a few moments the two looked at each other. There was no mockery in Shambhunath's expression. If anything, he too seemed to hear the circular shape of the sentence. He looked again at the printed sheet.

"The rule says only this: 'The reactivation fee shall be automatically deducted from the account holder's concerned account.'"

Ramlochan folded the two-hundred-rupee note and put it back in his pocket. "Then what am I supposed to do?"

"Meet the Manager."

Branch Manager Prabhakar Mishra's room stood behind a half-glass partition. Ramlochan went in. Prabhakar listened carefully to the whole matter. The rule was not new to him, but he had never faced this exact situation before.

He opened the branch procedure manual. The section on reactivation had four lines. The fee was compulsory. Cash was not accepted. Payment from another account was not permitted. The amount had to be automatically deducted from the concerned account.

Prabhakar said, "If you wish, first deposit one hundred and eighteen rupees into this account."

Ramlochan did not laugh. "There is already more than forty-two thousand in the account."

"You are right." Prabhakar turned another page of the manual. "Let us see whether a deposit is accepted."

At the deposit counter a slip for one hundred and eighteen rupees was submitted. The system accepted it. Ramlochan's balance became forty-two thousand seven hundred and thirty-six rupees.

“Now deduct the fee,” Ramlochan said.

Shambhunath tried. A red line appeared on the screen: “Account operations suspended; withdrawal by account holder prohibited.”

“This is not a withdrawal. It is a fee,” Ramlochan said.

“In the system, every amount deducted on behalf of the account holder is treated as a withdrawal.”

“But the deposit went in.”

“Money may enter a security-suspended account. It cannot go out.”

Ramlochan asked, “Can the bank deduct its own fees?”

Before Shambhunath could answer, Prabhakar came out himself. “Regular service charges can be deducted by the bank. Those are institutional deductions.”

Ramlochan’s eyes brightened. “Then treat this one hundred and eighteen as a bank fee and deduct it.”

Prabhakar said slowly, “The reactivation fee is a service-request fee of the account holder. It is not a regular bank charge.”

“The money will leave the same account.”

“The category is different.”

By noon the problem had become a topic of discussion throughout the branch. The Accounts Assistant suggested depositing the fee first into the branch’s interim account and adjusting it later. Prabhakar showed him the manual: interim adjustment was prohibited for reactivation fees.

Another employee suggested that Ramlochan open a new account and pay the fee from that. The form for opening a new account was filled. The registration system replied: “Account holder already has active/suspended account in this branch; opening of second savings account not permitted.”

Ramlochan said, “Does it say this account is active or suspended?”

“Both are in the same category,” Shambhunath said.

“When I want to use it, it is closed. When I want to open another one, it is active?”

Papers kept rustling across the desks. At Ramlochan’s round question, everyone lowered their eyes to their own pages.

The next day Ramlochan returned. This time his daughter Sarita came with him. The final date for paying the training institute’s fee was four days away. Sarita read the bank slips in order. She had passed Class Twelve and understood numerical accounts clearly.

She asked, "Has any amount been deducted from Babu's account this month?"

Shambhunath printed the statement. The previous week eighteen rupees had been deducted as a message-service charge.

Sarita placed her finger on the line. "After the account was closed?"

"Two days after."

"Then the bank can deduct eighteen rupees from a closed account."

"That is a regular service charge."

"The reactivation fee is also called a service charge."

Shambhunath read the papers. The words "service charge" did indeed appear in both places. The only difference was that one was preceded by "regular," the other by "reactivation."

Prabhakar was called again. He decided to send the matter to the district office. The branch wrote: "Institutional fee deduction possible from security-suspended account; account holder's reactivation fee cannot be deducted. Guidance requested."

The district office's reply arrived on the third day. It was brief: "Under the rules, the reactivation fee is payable only from the concerned account. The account shall be activated after payment of the fee."

This time Ramlochan thought of another route. "Do not reopen it. Close it completely and give me my money."

Shambhunath took out the account-closure form. The first two lines were straightforward. The third said: remaining balance to be withdrawn or transferred to another verified account of the account holder.

"I will take cash," Ramlochan said.

Shambhunath shook his head. "With this much balance, cash cannot be withdrawn without removal of the security suspension."

"Then transfer it to another account."

"You do not have another verified account."

"Open a new one."

"Because this account already exists, another savings account cannot be opened."

Ramlochan placed the form back on the desk. "So to close this account, I first have to open it?"

Looking at the form, Shambhunath said, "According to this form—yes."

Sarita read the letter and asked, "It has only written the same thing again."

Prabhakar said, "The district does not change the rule. It clarifies it."

“Has it become clear?”

Prabhakar did not answer.

That day was the final date for Sarita’s training fee. There was not five thousand rupees in cash at home. Ramlochan sold two finished bamboo pavilions to a trader at a lower price and raised the money. Sarita paid the fee. In the bank account remained forty-two thousand seven hundred and eighteen rupees—the message charge had already been deducted.

A week later the annual security inspection began at the branch. An inspector came from the district. Prabhakar placed Ramlochan’s case before him. The inspector read the full details.

“Was there any unauthorised withdrawal from the account?”

“None.”

“After suspension, was there any withdrawal by the account holder?”

“Not one.”

“Then the security control is successful.”

Prabhakar said, “But the account holder cannot use his own money.”

The inspector turned the page. “The purpose of suspension is to prevent unauthorised use.”

“This use is not unauthorised. The account holder himself is asking.”

“The system will recognise that after reactivation.”

Ramlochan was not at the bank that day. In the inspection report, beside his account number, was written: “Security suspension effective; zero unauthorised withdrawals during suspension period.”

At the end of the month twenty-three rupees of savings interest were added to the account. Two days later an annual account-maintenance charge of eighty-four rupees was deducted. The balance fell again.

Seeing the statement, Shambhunath went to Prabhakar. “Sir, the maintenance charge has been deducted.”

Prabhakar looked at the screen for a while. Then he asked, “The reactivation fee?”

“Still not. Withdrawals by the account holder are blocked.”

Prabhakar leaned back in his chair. “What is the account-maintenance fee maintaining?”

Shambhunath had no answer.

The next day Ramlochan came to the bank. Shambhunath gave him the new statement. Ramlochan read the two lines for interest and charges. He saw

that his money could increase inside the account and could decrease inside the account; only it could not reach his own hands.

He folded the receipt for the reactivation application and placed it inside the passbook. Then he asked, "Is my account closed, or is it running?"

Shambhunath thought for a few moments.

"Closed for you," he said, "running for the bank."

Ramlochan nodded and walked outside. On the branch wall a new board for Security Week had been hung: "Your money, our care."

Ramlochan read the board, tucked the passbook under his arm, and walked slowly into the crowd of Sakri Bazaar.

STORY 276

Final Approval

...

On Monday morning, Sumitra Devi arrived at the Disaster Assistance Branch of Madhepur Block with a blue envelope tucked under her arm. Her husband Jagdish Mandal's name was written on the envelope. Jagdish had been dead for seven months. Yet the letter said that his application for compensation for paddy damaged by the Kamla flood had received final approval, and that fourteen thousand eight hundred rupees was ready for payment.

Jagdish had submitted the application in Sawan the previous year. The paddy on two bighas of sharecropped land had remained under water for three days. A Panchayat employee had inspected the field, written down the measurements, and taken Jagdish's thumb impression. Three months later, before winter began, Jagdish died. Sumitra had almost forgotten about the application. Now, seven months later, a letter marked "Final Approval" was in her hands.

At the first window of the branch, clerk Naresh Jha read the letter.

"The amount has been approved," he said.

Sumitra took the death certificate out of the envelope and handed it to him. "But the person in whose name it has been approved is no longer alive."

Naresh read the certificate. "This will have to be added to the file."

He took a grey file from the cupboard behind him. On the cover, in red letters, was written: "Crop Damage—Jagdish Mandal." Inside were the application, field measurements, Panchayat recommendation, copy of the bank account, and approval letter, arranged in order. On the last page was a blue stamp: "Final Approval." Beneath it one line was blank: "Beneficiary appeared and accepted payment."

Naresh placed a finger on that line. "The problem is here."

"I am his wife."

"That can be proved by documents. But the beneficiary's presence at the time of payment is a separate matter."

"The death certificate also proves that he cannot be present."

Naresh was silent for a few moments. "That is true. But there is no place on the screen to write 'deceased.'"

The screen offered three options: “Present,” “Absent,” “Voluntarily declined payment.”

Sumitra could not read all three. Naresh explained them.

“Then he is absent,” Sumitra said.

“If I select absent, another notice will be generated asking him to appear.”

“He will never come now.”

“There ought to have been a fourth option.”

Naresh went to Head Assistant Shashibhushan Mishra. Shashibhushan examined the death certificate, the approval letter, and the screen, then opened the old rulebook. The chapter on payment said that the beneficiary must appear in person, prove identity, verify bank details, and place a thumb impression or signature on the receipt. The next paragraph provided for home verification in the case of an incapacitated beneficiary. There was no mention of a deceased beneficiary.

“Home verification?” Naresh asked.

Shashibhushan shook his head. “For an incapacitated beneficiary. Not for a deceased one.”

“A dead person is more incapable than an incapacitated one.”

Shashibhushan closed the book. “Rules do not work by comparison.”

Sumitra sat at the window listening to both of them. At home she had two daughters, an elderly mother-in-law, and a half-built bamboo cowshed. Fourteen thousand eight hundred rupees was not merely a number on paper to her. In that amount she could already see seed for the next paddy crop, straw for the roof, and the remaining cost of her daughter’s sewing machine.

Shashibhushan suggested one possibility—an application to add the heir’s name. Sumitra immediately agreed to submit it. But the final line of the form was read aloud: “Consent of the original beneficiary shall be attached.”

Naresh said, “Should we strike this line out?”

“It is a printed form,” Shashibhushan said. “The district may return an altered form.”

“Can the death certificate take the place of consent?”

“It proves death, not consent.”

For the first time Sumitra laughed. It was a small laugh. “After a person dies, whom do you ask for his consent?”

For a few moments the three looked at one another. There was no written answer to the question.

That day a clarification letter was sent to the district office. The question was brief: "If a beneficiary who has received final approval dies before payment, what is the procedure for paying the heir?" Naresh gave Sumitra a copy of the letter and told her they would inform her when the reply came.

Thirteen days later the reply arrived. Sumitra was called again. The district had written: "Under the prevailing rules, the approved beneficiary's payment process shall first be completed; after payment fails, provisions relating to heirs may be considered."

"How is payment declared failed?" Sumitra asked.

Shashibhushan opened the rulebook again. If the beneficiary failed to appear three times, payment was treated as "failed." There had to be an interval of at least seven days between each notice.

So the first notice was issued: Jagdish Mandal must appear in person on the twenty-fourth. The notice reached his own house. The postman handed it to Sumitra. On the twenty-fourth, Sumitra went to the office with the death certificate.

"Jagdish Babu?" the new assistant at the window asked.

"He will not come."

"The notice says he must appear in person."

Sumitra held out the death certificate. Naresh saw her from a distance and came over. In the register, against Jagdish's name, was written: "Absent—First Notice."

Seven days later the second notice arrived. Sumitra went again. This time Naresh already had the register open. Without much conversation he wrote: "Absent—Second Notice."

On the way home, Sumitra stopped at the haat. She had earlier told the seed seller that she would repay the old credit for paddy seed as soon as the compensation money came. The shopkeeper asked from a distance, "Did you get the money?"

Sumitra only shook her head. In her bag were two government notices—both proving that Jagdish had not appeared. But not one rupee had come in exchange for that proof.

The second trip to the office had cost Sumitra more than three hundred rupees when bus fare, a tonga from the market to home, and a day's lost wages were added together. When Shashibhushan heard the calculation, he said, "These expenses cannot be added under the rules."

Sumitra said, "I did not ask you to add them. I only want to understand how many times I have to buy proof that he will not come."

Shashibhushan lowered his eyes and closed the rulebook.

The third notice arrived fifteen days later. The rains had begun. Sumitra reached the office protecting the letter under her wet sari end. Mud clung to her sandals. Shashibhushan himself came to the window.

“Today the third absence will be completed,” he said.

“Will I get the money after that?”

“After that, payment will be declared failed. Then the heir application will be considered.”

Sumitra placed the death certificate on the table. “This has been saying for seven months that payment will fail.”

Shashibhushan looked at the certificate. “The rule required it to be said three times.”

The third absence was recorded. The next day a “Payment Failure Report” was prepared. Naresh filled the heir application again. This time, on the line requiring the original beneficiary’s consent, Shashibhushan wrote in red ink: “Beneficiary deceased; consent irrelevant.” The death certificate, marriage confirmation, family register, and all three absence notices were attached.

The file went to the district and returned two weeks later. On top was a note: “Before deciding heir payment, clarify the status of the original approval. After payment has been declared failed, is the approval active or inactive?”

The rulebook was opened again in the branch. It contained no answer to such a question. Shashibhushan wrote to headquarters. The reply came a month later: “Unless the original approval has been cancelled, it shall be treated as valid.”

“Has it been cancelled?” Sumitra asked.

Naresh looked at the screen. “No. It still shows ‘Final Approval—Payment Pending.’”

“Then pay me.”

“The decision on the heir is still pending.”

“Is the approval final?”

“Yes. The final approval is valid.”

“And the payment?”

Before answering, Naresh looked at the screen again. “Pending.”

Meanwhile the end of the financial year drew near. A new instruction came from the district that the presence of all beneficiaries with pending approvals must be verified again. The system automatically generated a fresh list. Jagdish

Mandal's name was on it. In the reason column it said: "Final Approval; Payment Pending."

Naresh tried to remove the name, but the system asked: "Basis for cancellation?" There was still no option for death.

He called Sumitra. This time she came without the death certificate. She had already shown that paper to the office four times.

Naresh said, "The new list is again asking for his presence."

Sumitra sat down on a chair. "What do we do now?"

Naresh looked at the blank line in the register for the reason. He lifted his pen, hesitated for a few moments, and wrote: "Beneficiary cannot appear; death certificate available in file."

There was no field on the screen for that sentence. So in the system, once again, "Absent" was selected.

Immediately a fresh notice was generated: "Shri Jagdish Mandal shall appear in person for final payment."

Naresh printed the paper but did not hand it to Sumitra. He held it for a while.

"Give it to me," Sumitra said.

She took the notice, folded it, and placed it in the blue envelope beside the first approval letter. Jagdish Mandal's name was still written on the envelope.

Outside, the rain had stopped. Sumitra descended the steps and crossed the courtyard. Inside the branch, green letters glowed on the screen: "Final Approval—Payment Pending."

STORY 277

The Forbidden Question

...

On the second Monday of Sawan, the old building of the Minor Irrigation Division in Madhubani had been crowded since morning. Rain had fallen all night and filled the ponds, yet water from the canal was still not reaching the fields. Outside on the veranda, farmers stood wringing out wet gamchhas; inside the Accounts Branch room, Madhukant Mishra was opening file after file tied with red thread and checking payment papers. On the left side of his desk lay a stack of green covers. For three weeks an oral rule had been in force in the office: any file without a green cover would not move forward.

Madhukant did not understand the reason for the rule. The stock of green covers had run out, the new consignment had not yet arrived, and seven bills for canal repairs were held up solely because there were no covers. Among those seven bills were the wages of a group of women labourers from Pipraun. Two days earlier, Kamla Devi had come and said, “Babu, we cut earth, filled sacks, saved the embankment. Now our wages are stopped because of the colour of the paper?”

Madhukant had then said only, “It is the rule.”

Today that sentence sounded hollow even in his own ears.

At ten, Assistant Engineer Shailendra Jha entered the room. Madhukant showed him all seven files.

“There are no green covers,” Shailendra said. “Keep them. They will come from the stores.”

“How many days?”

“Whenever they come.”

Madhukant asked quietly, “Under which order is this rule about green covers?”

At first Shailendra thought the question was ordinary. He nodded. “It is an old instruction.”

“Order number?”

Shailendra’s hand stopped on the file. “The Stores Branch will have the number.”

“Date?”

“Look there.”

Madhukant closed the file. "If we can find the source, we can explain it to the farmers. Perhaps the order provides some alternative when covers are unavailable."

Shailendra stared at him. "Follow the rule. Searching for its source is not your work."

At noon Madhukant went to the Stores Branch. Lakshman Paswan was turning the pages of a register. Green covers had been purchased three times in five years, but none of the entries mentioned an order number.

"Green covers have always been in use," Lakshman said.

"Since when?"

"I have been here eight years. They were already in use when I came."

"Then the source?"

Lakshman closed the register. "Why do you keep asking about the source? What is in practice is in practice."

Madhukant prepared a written application: "Kindly provide the order number, date, and issuing authority of the prevailing rule concerning green covers, so that the pending bills may be disposed of lawfully." He submitted the application to the Establishment Branch and took a receipt number.

The next morning a yellow slip lay on his desk. At the top it said: "Explanation Required." Below was the question: "Why did it become necessary to raise a question regarding the source of a prevailing administrative rule?"

Madhukant read it and smiled. It seemed to him that instead of an answer to his application, another question had arrived.

He wrote: "Because seven payments are held up by the rule and no copy of the order is available."

Two hours later a second slip arrived: "Expressing doubt regarding the validity of a rule is contrary to employee conduct. Under which provision did you raise such a question?"

Madhukant's smile stopped there. He went to the Establishment Branch. Section Assistant Vibhakar Thakur read the slip with his spectacles lowered on his nose.

"I did not question the validity," Madhukant said. "I asked for the source."

"The distinction between asking for the source and questioning validity will have to be shown on paper."

"Then which rule says that asking for a source is forbidden?"

Vibhakar immediately stopped his pen. "That is a second question."

"Yes, but the answer is connected with the first."

On the back of the slip Vibhakar wrote in red pencil: "Employee again raised a question concerning the source of a rule." Then he said, "For now, return to your desk. The Establishment Officer will examine the matter."

By evening the seven bills were still where they had been. Kamla Devi from Pipraun came again. Three women labourers were with her.

"Did the papers move?" she asked.

Madhukant looked at the empty stack where green covers should have been. "Not yet."

"The colour has still not come?"

"Something more than the colour is stuck now."

Kamla Devi did not understand, but she did not ask further. "There is rice for two days in my house. Whatever paper is needed, tell us."

That sentence remained inside Madhukant for a long time.

On the third day an order came from the Establishment Officer that until the inquiry was completed, Madhukant would be kept away from "correspondence concerning interpretation of rules." All seven files were given to another clerk.

But the other clerk too stopped them at the same point because there were no green covers.

Madhukant was given a new task: prepare a list of administrative questions raised by employees during the previous two years. The Establishment Branch believed that such questions were increasing and that there was a need to curb the "tendency toward unnecessary interpretation."

He opened the register. Someone had questioned the calculation of leave, someone the rate of travel allowance, someone the procedure for depositing old equipment. Most had received answers. Some answers merely said: "According to the prevailing rule." Nowhere was the source given.

As Madhukant prepared the list, he also added the receipt number of his own application. Subject of question: "Source of the green-cover rule." Status: "Under inquiry."

On the fifth day an inspection team arrived from the Chief Engineer's Office. Team leader Surendra Rai asked while examining the papers, "How did this dispute begin?"

Shailendra Jha said, "An employee asked for the basis of a prevailing rule."

"Where is the basis?"

The room was silent for a few moments. Shailendra said, "It is an old arrangement."

Surendra Rai examined two or three files with green covers. “Written order?”

The Establishment Officer said, “A search is under way.”

“Then why is there an inquiry against the employee?”

“Because the question was raised directly. Not through the prescribed channel.”

“What is the prescribed channel?”

The Establishment Officer looked toward Vibhakar. Vibhakar opened one old rulebook, then another. At last he said, “I am not finding any clear mention of it in this matter.”

Surendra Rai leaned back in his chair. “Then make a clear procedure. Write down how an employee is to ask a question. And if you find the source of the rule, add that too.”

After this instruction a three-member committee was formed. Madhukant was not on it; his matter was under inquiry. The committee sat for seven days. Old files were searched, retired employees were telephoned, and the stores registers were examined again. No one could say with certainty where the use of green covers had begun. One elderly employee said that canal maps had once been kept in green covers, and perhaps the habit had grown from that. Another said that separate colours had once been used during an accounts inspection. No written order was found.

In the end, the committee created not a source but a procedure. A new circular was drafted: “Before asking for the source of any prevailing office rule, tradition, or instruction, an employee shall obtain permission to question from the head of the branch. Directly asking for a source without permission shall be treated as a violation of administrative discipline.”

At the end of the circular it was written: “In light of the confusion that has recently arisen, this clarification shall take immediate effect.”

Madhukant received a copy. As he read, he stopped at the list of enclosures at the bottom: “Enclosure 1: Dated application of employee Shri Madhukant Mishra, by way of example.”

He went to the Establishment Branch.

“So now the rule has been made?” he asked Vibhakar.

“Yes. The manner of asking questions has been clarified.”

“On the day I asked, this rule did not exist.”

Straightening the paper, Vibhakar said, “This is not a new rule. It is a clarification of prevailing discipline.”

“The source of the prevailing discipline?”

Vibhakar looked at Madhukant. This time his expression was not stern, only tired. He said softly, "You are asking a question again."

Madhukant said nothing.

That evening the new consignment of green covers arrived. The Stores Branch sent fifty covers to Accounts. All seven files were given covers, payment orders were prepared, and three days later the wages of the women labourers from Pipraun reached their accounts. Kamla Devi came to thank him.

"See, once the colour of the paper arrived, the work got done," she said with a laugh.

Madhukant laughed too. "Yes."

"And that other thing that was stuck?"

At that moment the new circular lay on Madhukant's desk. Its heading was: "Question-Permission Procedure." In the enclosure was a copy of his own application.

He said, "That too has now become a rule."

Kamla Devi did not understand. She bowed and left.

At closing time Madhukant stacked the seven old green covers to one side. From his drawer he took out the new question-permission form. The first field said: "Question proposed to be asked." The second: "Reason for asking the question." The third: "Source of the question."

Madhukant lifted his pen and stared at the third field for a long time. Then, without filling in the form, he folded it and put it back in the drawer.

STORY 278

Guarding the Door

...

The old Cooperative Building in Jhanjharpur had four doors in its western wall. People entered and left through the first three; the fourth had a thick iron chain, two locks, and a faded board hanging above it: "Entry 4: Special Verification." Beneath the board, rainwater running down the wall had left green streaks.

When Rameshwar Das first reached that door, it was a Bhadon afternoon. In his hands were the renewal application for a handloom cooperative society, the accounts for the previous year, and the signatures of twelve members. Their society in Belahi village had been running for eighteen years. Because it was registered in the government yarn-distribution register, it received yarn at a subsidised rate; if the renewal stopped, the looms of all twelve families could come to a halt.

The employee sitting at the main gate looked at his papers and took out a slip. Across the middle, in bold letters, it said: "Route: Entry 4."

"Where is Entry 4?" Rameshwar asked.

The employee pointed his thumb toward the western wall. "There."

Rameshwar went around. Beside the fourth door sat guard Harikishore Yadav with a wooden stool, an earthen water pot, and a register. Rameshwar showed him the slip. Harikishore read it, looked at the door, then at Rameshwar.

"Does entry happen through this?"

"The paper says so."

"Who has the key?"

Harikishore smiled. "I have not found the answer to that question in three years."

He opened the register. "Give me your name. Your presence will be recorded now."

Rameshwar frowned. "Once I am marked present, how do I get inside?"

"That is a matter of entry. I guard attendance."

Rameshwar thought it must be a joke. But Harikishore was entirely serious. He wrote the date, time, and application number, and took Rameshwar's signature. Then he said, "Do not try to go through the main entrance. Your

application is on Route Four. If you go in through the main route, it will be entered under another branch.”

Rameshwar returned to the main gate and spoke to the employee there. The employee checked the number on the screen. “Special verification. Entry 4.”

“That door is locked.”

“The Building Branch handles matters concerning the building. My register shows Route Four.”

“Where does the branch sit?”

“On the second floor.”

“Then shall I go to the second floor?”

“An application routed through Entry Four cannot go upstairs without an entry mark.”

Rameshwar came outside. The last bus for home was at three. That day the application did not get inside.

He returned the next day. Harikishore recognised him. “The lock is the same today too.”

“Is there any day on which it opens?”

“My duty order says only ‘guarding.’ It does not say ‘opening.’”

This time Rameshwar searched out the Building Branch. The clerk there explained that Entry 4 had once been a direct door to the Verification Branch. Three years earlier the Verification Branch had moved to the second floor, but the old route number was still in the system. To change the route, they needed a “Service Point Inactivity Certificate.”

“How is that issued?”

“No user must come to that entry for thirty consecutive days.”

For a moment Rameshwar stared at the clerk’s face. “But the system sends me there.”

“Then users are still coming. How can the service point be treated as inactive?”

Rameshwar said nothing.

Over the next ten days he came five times. Each time Harikishore wrote his name in the register. Each time the lock remained in place. Harikishore now left a little space for him on one side of the stool. Sometimes they talked about the price of makhana, sometimes about the rainwater. The corner of the application in Rameshwar’s bag became bent, but the words “Entry 4” on the slip remained clear.

Work at the village looms began to decline. The society had only two weeks of old yarn left. Member Phoolkumari Devi said, “If the renewal does not happen, we will not get the next consignment. If we buy yarn from the private market, our earnings will be cut in half.”

The next time Rameshwar went, he carried a petition signed by all twelve members. The office Superintendent examined it. “I understand the problem. But changing the route is not simple. Entry 4 is showing as active.”

“How is it active?”

The Superintendent showed him the register. “Twenty-seven attendances this month. The highest among all four entrances in the building.”

Rameshwar asked in astonishment, “Did twenty-seven people get inside?”

“There are twenty-seven attendances.”

“Inside?”

The Superintendent removed his spectacles. “Attendance and entry are two separate figures.”

Those twenty-seven attendances included Rameshwar’s five visits, four visits by another member of his society, and people from other villages who had also been assigned special verification. No one had gone inside. Yet for the annual report, the number had become useful.

A new bamboo shelter was erected in front of Entry 4, two benches were brought in, and the earthen water pot was replaced by a metal drinking-water vessel. A second guard was added to Harikishore’s post for a two-hour shift.

“Now the service point has become good,” the new guard said on his first day.

Rameshwar looked at the lock. “Where is the service?”

The new guard laughed. Harikishore did not. He said quietly, “My job is not to open the door. It is to guard the service point.”

Two weeks later an inspection team came from the district. It examined the shelter, benches, water vessel, and register. Seeing the rising attendance figures, one member of the team said, “Demand is high here. The facility should be strengthened further.”

Rameshwar gathered courage and said, “The demand is to get inside.”

The inspector looked at his slip. “Your route is Four?”

“Yes, Route Four.”

“Then you are at the correct place.”

“The door is locked.”

The inspector looked at the lock and had the Building employee write something down. Three days later the lock was replaced with a new, heavier one because the old lock had begun to rust. The inspection note said: "Security at Entry 4 shall be improved."

The society's yarn ran out. First two looms stopped, then four. Phoolkumari bought two bundles of yarn from the private market, but the price was so high that hardly any profit remained in the finished cloth. All twelve members held a meeting. Someone suggested forming a new society under a new name. Someone else said it would be foolish to abandon an eighteen-year-old registration. Rameshwar remained silent.

At last he made a decision. "For thirty days, no one will go to the office."

Phoolkumari asked, "Then the application?"

"It will remain stuck just as it is now. But if we do not go for thirty days, Entry 4 will become inactive."

When Rameshwar told Harikishore, the guard looked uneasy for the first time. "My register will remain empty."

"Let it remain empty."

"They will ask from above."

"Tell them people could not get inside, so they stopped coming."

Harikishore shook his head. "There is no field in the register for that answer."

Even so, Rameshwar did not come. The society members did not come either. Harikishore could not stop other people assigned to special verification from arriving, but he began advising them to file complaints at the main gate. Gradually the Entry 4 register began to empty.

It took forty-two days to complete thirty consecutive days, because in between two people arrived carrying old slips. Then, at last, no name was entered for thirty straight days.

On the forty-first day the Building Branch issued a "Service Point Inactivity Certificate." The next day Route Four was removed from the system. All old applications were shifted to the main-entry route.

Harikishore sent a message to Rameshwar. He came the following Monday. At the main gate, the employee checked his number. "Route One."

Rameshwar went inside. For the first time no guard stopped him. Climbing the stairs, he was surprised to discover that the Verification Branch really was an ordinary room on the second floor; reaching it did not require passing through the locked door in the western wall at all.

The employee examined his application, and this time no objection was raised about its route. A copy of one old certificate was missing; Rameshwar submitted it two days later. Within seven days the society's renewal was completed.

Until the next government yarn consignment arrived, they still had to buy expensive yarn from the private market. Three weeks of earnings were reduced, but the looms began running again. As Phoolkumari opened the first new bundle, she said only, "The road was closed, not the work."

A month later Rameshwar came to the Cooperative Building again for another matter. His eyes went toward the western wall. The board for Entry 4 had been removed. The shelter was still there, and two employees were eating their lunch on the bench. The water vessel was empty. A new lock gleamed on the door.

Harikishore was now on duty at the main gate. Rameshwar asked, "That door is of no use to anyone now?"

Harikishore said, "On paper it is inactive."

"The lock is new."

"It is a security object. Even an inactive object needs guarding."

Both looked toward the west. Rameshwar's old waiting slips were probably lying in some file. The attendances recorded in front of a door that never opened had counted as service statistics for a full year; only when people stopped coming did the way inside finally open.

STORY 279

An Evening in Laheriasarai

...

Arunesh Jha had never before noticed anything distinctive in the way evening descended on Tower Chowk in Laheriasarai. If he was late leaving the office, he would cross the road with his head lowered, dodge the bells of passing rickshaws, thread his way between people carrying bags of vegetables, and walk straight toward his rented room. That day, while reconciling accounts under the flood-relief head at the District Accounts Office, it was half past seven before he could leave. His eyes were tired from the small print on the papers, and only one thought kept circling in his head: as soon as he reached home, Kumud would again ask how much they had managed to save that month.

Arunesh had been married for four years. Kumud taught Maithili and mathematics to children at a nearby private teaching centre, and in the evenings she tutored children from two or three households in their room. Between the two incomes, the household ran, but expenses had increased over the previous six months. Arunesh had to send money for his mother's medicines, the rent had gone up, and Kumud wanted to save for the next course in her teacher training.

Whenever Kumud repeatedly asked about the accounts, Arunesh did not hear a question; he heard supervision.

"Where did three thousand go?"

"I ate out twice with people from the office."

"If you had told me earlier, I would have entered it in the accounts."

Over such small matters their voices would rise. The previous week Kumud had said, "I am not asking you to stop spending. I only want to know which road the two of us are taking together."

Arunesh had replied, "The house is running. Is that not enough?"

That night Kumud had remained silent for a long time. Arunesh had taken that silence as his victory.

As he neared Tower Chowk that evening, his pace slowed by itself. On one side of the road, a middle-aged couple who sold roasted gram and puffed rice were packing up their cart. Arunesh had seen them many times, though he did not know their names. The man had hitched his dhoti up to his knees. Dust

from roasted gram clung to the woman's sari. Both looked tired, and both also seemed irritated with each other.

"I told you to keep the small bowls separately," the woman said sharply.

Counting coins, the man replied, "If I have to keep everything in my head, what will you do?"

She answered at once, "I sat at the cart all day. Was that nothing?"

Without warning Arunesh heard the tone of his own home. The words were different; the bitterness was familiar. He wanted to move on, but just then a fast rickshaw swung onto the road. The man, pushing the cart, stopped abruptly. The woman was behind him. She said nothing. She merely placed her left hand on the rear wooden bar of the cart. Without turning, the man pulled the cart to the right. The rickshaw passed.

Then they began walking again.

Ten steps later the strap of the woman's slipper came loose. She bent down. The man still did not turn, but the cart stopped on its own. His hands remained on the handle, his body faced forward, but he did not take another step. The woman fixed the strap and again placed her hand on the wood at the back. Only then did the cart move.

This time Arunesh stopped at the side of the road.

Nothing extraordinary had happened in those two minutes. The man had not taken the woman's hand, no sweet words had passed between them, and their earlier irritation had not disappeared. Yet Arunesh felt that between them there was some hidden measure that needed no words. The pace of one was made from the steps of the other. Even after the quarrel, that measure had not broken.

Suddenly he began remembering many small things Kumud did.

Kumud no longer put pickle on his plate at night because two years earlier he had suffered burning in his stomach. Arunesh had never mentioned it again, but Kumud's hand had remembered until now. In winter, when he left for the office, she would tell him to fasten the top button of his kurta. Arunesh would get irritated—"I am not a child." But after Kumud stopped saying it, the cold wind had struck his chest many times.

And Arunesh? What small thing about Kumud did he remember like that?

He thought: how much sugar does Kumud take in her tea? The answer did not come at once. On which days did she return late from the teaching centre? He could not remember that properly either. Last month there had been a strip of cloth tied around her right wrist. Had he asked about it? He had only seen it; he had not asked.

The street lamps came on one by one. Dust began to shine in the air. Half the shop shutters were coming down. From a sweet shop came the smell of something frying in ghee. Voices, rickshaw bells, the clatter of utensils—everything was as before, but the figures in the calculation running inside Arunesh had changed.

Why did Kumud ask about the accounts? Until then he had understood the answer to be “money.” For the first time it occurred to him that more than money, Kumud was asking about the road. She wanted to know where the two of them were going.

He remembered his own earlier answer—“The house is running. Is that not enough?”

Now the sentence sounded to his own ears as though the cart was moving, but no one cared about the steps of the two people pushing it.

Arunesh turned from Tower Chowk toward home. On the way he thought of buying something, then decided against it. If he took sweets or flowers home, the moment might become an occasion again. What he had understood today was not an occasion.

When he reached home, Kumud was sitting on a mat on the floor checking exercise books. The lamp was to her right, but she was leaning her body to the left as she wrote. A narrow strip of cloth was again tied around her right wrist.

“You are back?” Kumud asked without looking up.

“Yes, I’m back.”

Arunesh put down his bag. Usually he would first wash his hands and face, then ask about dinner. That day he stood silent for two moments.

“Does your wrist still hurt?”

Kumud’s pen stopped. She looked up. There was surprise on her face, not delight.

“Sometimes,” she said. “When I write too much.”

Arunesh remembered: three weeks earlier Kumud had told him that two new students had joined and that there was more writing to do at night. At the time he had asked only, “How much will they pay per month?”

He pulled his chair over and sat beside the mat.

“Shall we look at this month’s accounts today?” he asked.

Kumud looked at him carefully. “Today?”

“Yes. The money you are saving for the training—let us set that aside separately. The money to send to Mother too. Then whatever remains, we will both see.”

Kumud said nothing. She moved the pile of exercise books to one side and took out an old blue-covered account book whose pages were filled with small figures and dates.

For the first time Arunesh noticed that Kumud had recorded his salary in careful detail, while she had not written her own earnings with the same precision. In some places she had merely written: “three children,” “two children,” “old dues.”

“Why have you not kept your income separate?” Arunesh asked.

Kumud said simply, “How can it be separate? Whatever the house needs, it goes there.”

It was a short sentence. Kumud went back to matching the figures.

Arunesh did not reply. Before his eyes the cart appeared again—one hand in front, one hand behind; between them wood, coins, dust, and a whole day’s exhaustion.

In the account book Kumud placed her thumb on one page and said, “Look here. This much has been saved for the training. This much is still short.”

Arunesh bent over the page. There was a small ink stain near Kumud’s thumb. He kept looking at the figures, but this time he did not see only the shortfall. He saw not two separate incomes, but two lives moving across the same page.

Outside in the lane, some cart passed with a soft wooden rattle. Arunesh heard it without meaning to. Kumud did not.

He pulled the account book toward himself and began writing the date before the next blank line.

STORY 280

Lights on the Bridge

...

Evening light was spreading slowly over the bridge across the Kamla River. In the western sky the redness of the sun had been pressed behind grey clouds, and the yellow lamps fixed to the bridge pillars were coming on one by one. Nilabh, a college student, was walking his bicycle up the bridge with his bag slung over his shoulder. After sitting in the library all day his eyes were tired, but instead of hurrying home, he was thinking of stopping in the middle of the bridge.

An old memory was tied to this bridge. Three years earlier, when he was in the final class of high school, Rashmi had once handed him her exercise book at the eastern end of the bridge. That was all. While giving him the notebook, Rashmi had said, "Return it tomorrow. I still have preparation left to do." For a long time Nilabh had been unable to regard that ordinary sentence as an ordinary sentence. He had felt that the notebook was only a pretext, that there was something more in her voice, some signal in the way her eyes had lingered.

From that day onward, in his memory Rashmi gradually became less a real classmate and more a story of his own making. He kept imagining that she too remembered him while crossing the bridge, that the song she had sung at the school function had been for him, that her turning back on the last day of examinations had been a secret sign of farewell. None of this was ever confirmed, but the absence of confirmation never became an obstacle to Nilabh's imagination.

After school, the two went to different colleges. Nilabh did not know exactly what subject Rashmi had taken. Someone had told him she was studying biology; someone else had said she had taken a nursing entrance examination. Between these incomplete pieces of news, Nilabh preserved the Rashmi in his mind exactly as she had been—quiet, fond of poetry, fond of evening bridges and light on the river.

That day, while leaving the library, his classmate Chandan had casually said, "Rashmi will be going home by this road today with her younger sister. I saw her in the market."

After that one sentence, Nilabh's pace had changed. He kept telling himself that he wanted to stop on the bridge because of the breeze, because he was tired after the whole day, because he wanted to look at the river. But when the first yellow lamp came on, he slowed his bicycle without meaning to.

When he reached the middle of the bridge, he stood by the railing. Below, the broad water left after the rains looked grey. The reflections of the lamps did not form straight lines; because of the wind and the current they flickered in broken fragments. Nilabh remembered the blue cover of the old exercise book. That notebook was not still in his trunk—he had returned it—but later he had bought another notebook with a similar blue cover, merely so that the sight of it would awaken that day's memory.

Two bicycle bells sounded behind him. Nilabh stepped away from the railing. On the first bicycle was a girl of about fourteen; on the second was Rashmi. In the front basket of her bicycle were two thick bundles, a small packet of medicine, and a bunch of green vegetables. As soon as Rashmi saw Nilabh, she stopped.

"Nilabh?"

The voice was the same, but in his memory it had become much softer and more hesitant; the real voice was clearer and more direct.

"Yes," he said. "After a long time."

Rashmi laughed. "A long time? I saw you in the market two months ago. You probably did not notice me."

Nilabh remembered that two months earlier he had been in a crowd submitting an examination form. Someone had called out to him, but he had not turned. Now that unnoticed moment seemed more solid than all his old imaginings.

Rashmi's younger sister had already ridden ahead. Rashmi called, "Neha, stop after the bridge. Do not cross the chowk alone."

Then she turned back to Nilabh. "What are you studying here?"

"History."

"I thought you would take mathematics."

Nilabh was surprised. "Why?"

"At school you were the one who worked out the most calculations."

Nilabh laughed. For the first time he realised that Rashmi too carried a version of him in her memory—and that version was wrong. It was possible that on the other side too there were incomplete lines of memory, but there was no need to call them love.

"Are you studying biology?" he asked.

"No. I am doing laboratory training. From seven in the morning I am at the hospital laboratory, then I have classes. Today I had come to the market to buy Mother's medicine."

The ‘Rashmi who loved poetry’ in Nilabh’s mind did not suddenly shatter at these words; rather, beside her appeared another, clearer human being—someone who examined samples at seven in the morning, bought medicine for her mother, and would not let her younger sister cross the chowk alone.

He asked naturally, “Do you still sing?”

Rashmi shook her head. “I stopped after school. I do not get the time. Neha sings. She sings better than I do.”

Something inside Nilabh became lighter. For three years he had treated a song at a school function as a private signal meant for him; Rashmi herself might have given it no more importance than one small chapter of her life. The surprising thing was that this understanding did not humiliate him. Instead, his mind felt relieved—the story he had carried as a mystery had only been arithmetic of his own making.

Nilabh remembered another incident from school. On the day of the annual function, Rashmi had been waiting backstage for her turn to sing, and from a distance he had once seen her smile. For three years he had treated that smile as a sign directed toward him. Now, listening to the details of Rashmi’s daily life, it occurred to him that amid the dozen students, teachers, harmonium, wires, and hurried movement behind the stage that evening, he had never had any basis for deciding whom that smile had been meant for. Memory had preserved only the fragment that made his story beautiful.

Adjusting the bundles in her basket, Rashmi said, “Do you remember that essay of yours? ‘Evening in My Town?’”

For a moment Nilabh’s heart beat again with the old rhythm. “I remember.”

“That day I thought you wrote far too much about the lamps on the bridge. I do not like these lamps at all. Moths and little insects keep flying near your eyes.”

Nilabh looked at her face, then at the yellow lamp burning above them. In his old imagination he had connected Rashmi with the light of this bridge so many times that it had never occurred to him that Rashmi might not like this light at all.

From a distance Neha called, “Didi!”

“I should go now,” Rashmi said. “Mother has to take her medicine on time.”

“All right. We will meet.”

Rashmi mounted her bicycle, then paused for a moment and said, “We should meet sometime. You are studying history; I need some information

about the old building of our laboratory. They say it used to be an indigo warehouse. You might know.”

Nilabh said, “I will see. I can look for documents.”

“Then good. Goodbye.”

She rode away. The bundles in the basket moved gently. Nilabh watched her descend from the bridge, but now there was no urge in that watching to search for a secret sign. Halfway down, Rashmi stopped to look at the rear wheel of Neha’s bicycle, said something, and the two rode on again.

Nilabh took hold of his bicycle handle. He thought: what had Rashmi really been thinking three years ago when she handed him the exercise book? Perhaps about the examination. Perhaps about getting home quickly. Perhaps about nothing at all. Earlier, such uncertainty had seemed unbearable to him. For the first time today he understood that filling the blank spaces inside another person with one’s own desires was not love.

In that understanding Rashmi did not become smaller, nor did his old affection become false. On the contrary, for the first time she stepped out of the flat shape of imagination in his mind and stood there with the weight of an actual life—with fatigue, sweat, dislikes, responsibilities, and tastes entirely her own. Nilabh felt that for three years he had treasured Rashmi less than he had treasured his own imagination.

He mounted his bicycle. By now all the bridge lamps were fully lit. Below, their reflections on the water broke in the wind, joined, and broke again. Nilabh had once thought that broken light meant incompleteness. Now it seemed to him that perhaps this was the true form of light upon water; the steady line seen from far away was only an illusion.

As he came down from the bridge, he did not turn back even once. He wanted to meet Rashmi again, but this time he knew that at their next meeting he did not have to prove any old story. He only had to speak with a real person—a person whose life was far larger, far busier, and far more her own than his imagination had ever allowed.

STORY 281

The Closed Library

...

A small notice on red paper was pasted to the gate of Darbhanga's old public library: "The library will remain closed today due to the annual book count." Madhavi read the sentence twice. The first time with her eyes; the second, as though against the accounting of her whole day. In her bag were a reference list, two books, questions written on yellow paper, and in her head a complete plan: from ten to one, examine journals from the final decade of the nineteenth century; from one to two, lunch; then notes until four. Inside the gate, the chairs on the veranda had been turned upside down onto the tables. All the windows were shut. The silence within seemed to her as though time itself had taken leave for the day.

Madhavi was doing research at the university. Her subject was women's private writing in old Maithili periodicals. She was in her fifth year. At the beginning of the research she had thought the work would be finished in two years. In the third year she said, "Once this chapter is done." In the fourth: "Nothing can be written without seeing the primary material." By the fifth year, one sentence had become permanent in her speech: "After I submit the thesis."

After she submitted the thesis, she would visit her sister. After she submitted the thesis, she would choose saris from her mother's old trunk. After she submitted the thesis, she would replace the torn curtain in her hostel room. After she submitted the thesis, she would cut her hair, meet old friends, drink tea in the morning without looking at the clock. After she submitted the thesis, she would enter that part of life which, for now, seemed merely a preface.

Today the library was closed.

She stood beneath the shade of the pipal tree beside the gate. Returning to the hostel would have been simple, but the thought of an empty day gave her a strange unease. It was as though someone inside her were asking: if the library does not open, what will you do? The question was ordinary. She had no answer.

Across the road was a small bookbinder's shop: half tin roof, half open sky. Madhavi had seen it many times, but had never paid attention. Today, because she had no work, her gaze settled there. The bookbinder, Brijnandan, was spreading glue along the exposed spine of a thick book. Beside him sat his

daughter Lalita, about twelve years old, with a schoolbook open before her. Sometimes she handed her father thread; sometimes she wrote something in her exercise book.

“Babu, we will go at three, won’t we?” Lalita asked.

Without raising his head, Brijnandan said, “Yes. Once this binding dries, we will go.”

“Do not be late. I have my lesson today.”

“I told you, we will go. The book can be bound tomorrow too.”

Madhavi’s attention caught on that last sentence: the book can be bound tomorrow too. Brijnandan did not say it like a philosophy; he merely bit off the thread with his teeth, closed the glue tin, and picked up another binding. Lalita, reassured, returned to her writing.

Madhavi took her notebook out of her bag. She thought she would sit in front of the closed library and organise the notes from the previous chapter. As soon as she opened it, a folded sheet of paper slipped from the middle. Her sister Meena had written it. It was four months old. There were only two lines: “Didi, come this time. You keep saying after the thesis is finished, but my son knows you only like a name inside a book.”

Madhavi had read the letter before. The first time she had felt annoyed with Meena—she did not understand how difficult research was. The second time she had thought she would go once the next chapter was completed. The third time the letter had been pressed between the pages of her notebook. Today, in front of the closed gate, the sentence looked different.

The city day continued at its own pace across the street. A vegetable seller set down her basket and sat in the shade. A rickshaw puller untangled thread caught in his pedal. Two schoolboys placed bricks across a small puddle left by the rain and jumped over it. The library was closed, but no one else’s day was closed. For the first time Madhavi noticed that her own days had been shaped almost entirely around waiting for institutional doors to open.

She thought of her hostel room. For five years it had held an iron cot, a table, two trunks, and a torn curtain. Two years earlier her mother had given her a curtain with a green border—“Put it up; the room will look brighter.” Madhavi had wrapped it in newspaper and kept it in a trunk. Why? “I am not going to live here permanently.” Five years of temporary living had never struck her as contradictory.

She remembered the way she ate: hurriedly, five minutes before the library closed at noon; turning down friends’ invitations; shortening conversations with her mother because “I have to find a quotation.” The quotations kept increasing, the chapters kept increasing, and the boundary of the research kept

moving backward. The date on which she would begin the life she imagined after the thesis was written in no register anywhere.

Madhavi grew uncomfortable with her own thoughts. It seemed to her that this line of thinking was becoming an argument against research. But she loved her research. The smell of paper when she opened old journals, the name of a forgotten woman writer, a handwritten note in the margin—these genuinely gave her pleasure. The problem was not the research. The problem, she realised, was that she had turned research into a shield: a shield for postponing some meetings, for not taking some decisions, for avoiding the discomfort of some relationships.

Across the road Brijnandan pressed a book under a cloth. Lalita looked at the clock.

“Babu, now?”

“Now.”

“And these two?”

“Tomorrow.”

Brijnandan did not lower the shop curtain. He merely covered the glue, gathered the thread, and told his daughter to put her exercise book in the bag. The work was incomplete, but there was no guilt in his movements. For him, unfinished work was not opposed to life; it was one part within life.

Madhavi folded her paper again. She was still thinking of returning to the hostel. If she wanted, she could sit in her room and write five pages. In her old habit, wasting such a day felt almost like a crime. She looked again at the red notice on the gate. “Closed today.” Only today. The library would reopen the day after tomorrow. The world of her research was not coming to an end.

She kept Meena’s letter not inside the bag but in her hand. Meena lived in a rented house in the southern part of the city, toward Donar. Twenty minutes by rickshaw. For four months Madhavi had stretched that distance until “after I submit the thesis.”

As she crossed the road, for a moment she felt she was being sentimental. Was going to her sister’s house not an escape from research? Then she laughed at herself. How strange it was to measure a twenty-minute distance against a five-year work plan.

She reached the bookbinder’s shop. Brijnandan had not locked it; he only told the neighbouring shopkeeper, “Keep an eye on it. I am going to watch Lalita’s lesson and will be back.”

Madhavi asked, “You are leaving the shop open?”

Brijnandan laughed. “It is only for a little while. The books are not going to run away.”

Lalita pulled her father forward. Madhavi smiled at the sentence. The books are not going to run away. Her research would not run away either. Yes, time runs away—the sentence came to her mind, but she did not complete it. Some thoughts do not need a complete sentence.

She stopped a rickshaw. The driver asked, “Where to?” The name of the hostel almost came out of Madhavi’s mouth first. Five years of habit. She paused for a moment, then said, “Donar. Near the old post office.” The rickshaw moved. The red notice at the library fell behind. Madhavi thought about the reference list in her bag—which journal she would ask for first the day after tomorrow, which pages she would have copied; all of it remained clear in her mind. The research was still there, with all its weight and attraction. The only change was that, for the first time, she could see a little space for life around it. On the road to Donar the rickshaw stopped at a crossing. Outside a cloth shop, a curtain with a green border stirred in the wind. Madhavi remembered the curtain her mother had given her, lying in the trunk. She did not decide that she would return that very day and hang it up. There was no hurry to decide that either. She understood only that a room did not remain temporary merely because she had called it temporary for five years, and life too was not some next chapter titled ‘After I submit the thesis.’ The rickshaw moved on. Madhavi unfolded Meena’s letter in her palm and smoothed it. The crease that had remained for four months did not disappear entirely, but the letters were now clear. For the first time she was not thinking about what answer to write. Reaching there before answering seemed simpler.

STORY 282

The Fair Is Over

...

On the morning after the fair in Janakpur ended, it seemed as though someone had gathered up all the colours of the field during the night. The gate that until yesterday had been covered with strings of electric bulbs, cloth flowers, and coloured letters had already lost half its covering. Its bamboo frame stood exposed. Truck wheels had left deep tracks in the ground, the dust dampened by dew had been churned up, and in the distance the round frame of the Ferris wheel stood against the unlit sky like a black line.

Fifteen-year-old Mihir Jha reached the grounds before sunrise. Under his arm was a small cloth bag containing one change of clothes, a gamchha, and an old school exercise book.

For fifteen days Mihir had been helping at his maternal uncle Raghunath's tea stall. From the day the fair opened, his work had been to fetch water in the morning, scour the brass kettle, wash glasses, watch the milk pot, and wipe the tables during the rush. At the end of each day his uncle put a few rupees into his palm.

More than the money, Mihir was fascinated by the other world that moved behind the fair—the people who assembled and dismantled rides, the young men who laid electric cables, the workers who checked iron frames until midnight, and the trucks that left for another town as soon as one fair ended.

Mihir's father, Harimohan, ran a small bicycle-repair shop near a chowk in Janakpur. After school Mihir would return home, dip tyres in water to find punctures, roughen rubber, and pump in air. His father worried about low earnings in bad weather, but he had never spoken of stopping his son's studies.

Mihir had no complaint against home. His restlessness was of another kind. It seemed to him that every day of his life had already been decided—school in the morning, bicycles in the afternoon, lessons in the evening, then the same lane, the same awning, the same familiar faces. When the fair arrived, for the first time he met people who themselves did not know for certain where they would be the next day.

Mihir took that uncertainty for freedom.

Among the Ferris-wheel crew was eighteen-year-old Shivnath, thin-bodied, with oiled hair and old cut marks across his palms. Mihir often went near him on the pretext of carrying tea. Shivnath would mention the haat at

Madhubani, the grounds at Rajbiraj, or Viratnagar. His descriptions of towns were always brief—"The ground there was soft," "There we had to carry water from far away," "There the rain stopped work for three days"—but Mihir heard whole worlds inside those names.

On the final evening Mihir had asked, "Where are all of you going now?"

"Rajbiraj," Shivnath had said while undoing a knot in a rope. "Two days on the road. We will stop at one place in between."

"Could I get work too?"

Shivnath had not laughed at first. He looked at Mihir's hands, then asked, "Can you lift iron strips? Can you stay awake at night? Can you stretch a tarpaulin in the rain?"

"I can learn."

"Then come at five in the morning. Speak to the owner, Ramnaresh. First see the work. Tell your family before you come."

That night Mihir could not sleep for a long time. At home he said only that he was going early in the morning to help dismantle the fair.

His mother asked, "School?"

"I will be back by ten."

Even as he answered, Mihir knew it was possible that he would not need to return by ten at all. On the last page of his exercise book Shivnath had written three names: Rajbiraj, Viratnagar, Itahari. Mihir read the page three times that night. It seemed to him that if he reached the third name on that list, he would be very far from his old routine.

As soon as he reached the field in the morning, the first difficulty in his imagination appeared before him. The cabins of the Ferris wheel were being taken down, and from underneath each one the packed dust, grease, and scraps of paper had to be cleaned away. Shivnath handed him a sack.

"Shake out all these seat covers and put them in here."

Mihir had imagined he would be given ironwork; shaking seat covers seemed ordinary. But within half an hour dust had filled his nose, his palms were black, and he understood that even dismantling had an order. Which strip came first, which pin belonged with which piece, which rope went into which box—if the order was wrong, half a day would be lost at the next stop.

Shivnath counted every item without appearing hurried.

"Do you remember all this counting?" Mihir asked.

"If we leave it to memory, half the equipment disappears on the road," Shivnath said. "There is a register."

He showed him an oil-stained notebook. The number of every box, the count of bolts, the length of cables, and the colour of each cabin were written in it.

Mihir was surprised. In his imagination, a wandering life existed outside rules; here even a small pin was bound to an account.

As the sun climbed, the field began to grow hot. The mixed smell of sweets, perfume, smoke, and crowds from the previous night had been replaced by the smell of wet rope, diesel, earth, and boiling rice. Under the shade of one tarpaulin, three women were cooking rice on a hearth. Beside them two children sat on a wooden crate and wrote in their exercise books. Whenever the wind turned the pages of one boy's notebook, he placed a small piece of iron on the page to hold it down.

Mihir asked, "Do they travel everywhere with you?"

Shivnath said, "Some members of the family do. Not everyone. That younger boy came this time after his examination."

"And his school?"

"It is in the village. He goes back between seasons. Whatever he misses, he catches up later."

Shivnath did not tell this as a story of sorrow. He continued measuring rope. Mihir too said nothing. He merely became aware of the weight of the exercise book inside his own bag.

By eight o'clock half the fair had disappeared. The target-shooting boards had been loaded onto a truck, the cloth from the toy stalls had become bundles, and the coloured arch that had marked the entrance at night lay separated into cloth, bamboo, and rope.

Mihir felt not disappointment but a kind of curiosity. What until yesterday had appeared to him as a single thing now revealed itself as the joining of many hands.

Ramnaresh, the owner of the Ferris wheel, walked around with a thick register checking the inventory. Seeing Mihir, he asked, "You are Raghunath's nephew?"

"Yes."

"Shivnath says you want to go with the crew."

For a moment Mihir's heart beat hard. The matter was no longer imagination.

Ramnaresh said, "You are young. Not without your family's permission. If they permit it, you can work for two weeks and see. Morning and evening hours will not be fixed. Wages are different on travel days and on days when the

fair is running. You eat with the crew. You need your own clothes and bedding.”

“How many towns do you travel through?”

“Depends on the season. Sometimes five, sometimes eight. If the rains turn bad, we go straight home.”

For fifteen days Mihir had been carrying one question inside him—“How much fun is it?”—but he could not ask it. There was no place for fun in Ramnaresh’s manner of speaking; there was only work, time, wages, weather, and permission.

Ramnaresh moved on. Shivnath looked at Mihir’s bag. “You came prepared?”

Mihir put the bag down. “I have two sets of clothes.”

Shivnath smiled. “The first time I left, I carried five. By the third day I understood that a dry place mattered more than clothes.”

“Do you not miss home?”

“I do.” Shivnath wiped a bolt with a cloth. “But this is the work. If I stayed home, there would be some other work. Travelling is one thing; this work is another.”

After that short sentence, both returned to work. Mihir felt that Shivnath was neither trying to stop his desire nor encourage it. He had only separated two things that Mihir had spent fifteen days treating as the same—travelling, and working while travelling.

At half past eight, while loosening an iron brace beneath one of the cabins, Mihir trapped his finger. The injury was not serious, but a red line appeared beside the nail. Shivnath poured water over it, cleaned away the dust, and tied a narrow strip of cloth around it.

“Enough for the first day,” he said.

Mihir wanted to object, but the strength in his hand had diminished. He sat beneath the tarpaulin.

In front of him there was no longer the circular shadow of last night’s Ferris wheel; half its frame lay broken into long strips on the ground. Four workers, without speaking, were sliding the pieces onto a truck. In the distance, where the tea stalls had stood, only black circles from brick hearths remained. At the place where Uncle Raghunath’s stall had been, three bricks and a small heap of ash were visible.

Mihir remembered himself the previous night—running through the crowd, watching the distant trucks, deciding in his mind that once he got beyond this field his life would open up. Now, inside one of those trucks, he

could see a box in which cables, greasy cloth, tools, half a sack of rice, and bedding for three men were being packed together.

The truck was not wrong. Nor had his imagination been entirely wrong. There was simply a great deal between the two that could not be seen in the lights.

At nine the first truck was full. Ramnaresh came to Mihir again. "Decision?"

In Mihir's bag was the exercise book. In his pocket were the rupees left from the previous five days that his uncle had paid him. In front of him stood the truck going to Rajbiraj. He knew that if he said yes now, the matter would truly move forward; no one was pretending to stop him.

He looked around the field. Until yesterday the crowd had seemed to him like a world outside his ordinary life. The crowd was gone now. On the faces of those who remained were fatigue, calculation, and haste.

Even so, the fair had not been false. The lights at night, the songs, the children's laughter, the steam rising from tea, the city seen from the top of the Ferris wheel—everything had been real. But that reality had lasted fifteen days. To mistake the speed of those fifteen days for the speed of an entire life had been Mihir's own addition.

"I will not go today," he said.

Ramnaresh merely nodded. "All right." Then he turned and called to a worker, "Tighten the rope on the second box." He had no time to ask the reason for the decision.

A little later Shivnath came to Mihir. "Changed your mind?"

Mihir said, "I still want to travel."

"Then travel," Shivnath said. "This truck is not the only road."

Mihir did not reply. He liked the sentence, but he did not want to preserve it as a piece of advice. Shivnath went back to his work.

By ten, the main frame of the Ferris wheel too had left the ground and been loaded onto a truck. Where its four legs had stood, four deep round marks remained in the earth. For the first time Mihir could see the entire field from one end to the other without any curtain, festoon, or crowd.

The empty space was larger than he had expected. A few scraps of paper moved in the wind, two crows fought over a piece of biscuit, and in a hollow near the edge the clear sky was reflected in rainwater left from the night.

Just then Uncle Raghunath arrived on a bicycle. "Ah, you are still here? I forgot the small brass kettle. Did you see it near the heap of ash?"

Mihir stood up. Together they searched near the three bricks. After they moved aside a half-burnt sack, they found the kettle. One side was blackened with soot; on the other fell the morning light.

Wiping it with a cloth, his uncle asked, “Why did you come carrying a bag?”

Mihir was silent for a few moments. “I had thought I might go with Shivrath and the others for a few days.”

His uncle hung the kettle from the bicycle handle. “And now?”

“Now I will go home.”

His uncle only said, “Hmm.” He neither scolded nor laughed. He turned the bicycle around.

Mihir lifted the bag onto his shoulder, but before leaving the field he looked back once more. Last night’s lights did not seem false to him, and today’s emptiness did not seem an opposing truth. They were two times of the same event.

The desire that for fifteen days he had taken to be permanent inside himself had borrowed something of its colour from the fair as well. Knowing this did not make the desire smaller; it only made its shape clearer.

On the way, his uncle talked about calculations for the tea stall in the next fair season. Mihir listened only halfway. On the last page of the exercise book inside his bag, the three names were still written—Rajbiraj, Viratnagar, Itahari.

When he reached home, he did not tear out the page. As he closed the exercise book, he merely pulled it straight from between the folds of the gamchha so that the word “Viratnagar,” written across the crease, could be read clearly.

STORY 283

Outside the Cinema

...

Outside the old cinema hall near Station Chowk in Madhubani, the coloured strip of lights that had been hanging since evening was still glowing at ten at night. In the enormous picture above, the film's hero, wearing black glasses, leaned over a motorcycle; behind him were dust, fire, and people running. As the final show ended inside, the crowd surged toward the gate all at once. The pounding music was still trembling through the walls and spilling outside.

Twenty-two-year-old Navneet Jha came out more slowly than anyone else in the crowd. The final scene of the film kept returning to him—the hero leaving the city alone while people called after him, yet never once turning back. Navneet had liked the scene so much that even after stepping outside, his gait seemed altered.

He worked as a sales assistant in a cloth shop in Madhubani. From nine in the morning until eight at night, his routine was to open bolts of cloth, fold them, cut fabric according to customers' measurements, and prepare account slips. For two months he had felt that this life simply was not made for him. Whenever the owner, Kailash Babu, said, "Work increases toward Dussehra. Do not talk about leave now," Navneet would repeat a film dialogue in his mind: "Who can stop the one who is meant to fly?"

That very day he had told people at home that he would go to Delhi the following month. What work he would do, where he would stay, whom he would go to—he had no answers to any of these questions. But he was certain that the moment he left his town, the pace of his life would change. While buying the cinema ticket, his friend Ranjit had laughed and said, "First save the fare to Delhi, then become a hero." Navneet had replied, "The fare will come later. First you need courage."

As soon as he came out of the cinema, he saw Ranjit ride away on a motorcycle with his maternal cousin. Navneet had to get to his rented room on Rajnagar Road. Two or three electric rickshaws stood on the road, but all the drivers were looking for longer-distance passengers. One asked Navneet for twice the normal fare. Irritated, Navneet shook his head. "At that rate, I could buy half another cinema ticket."

He set off on foot. The cinema's light receded behind him. One by one, the shops around Station Chowk were switching off their glittering bulbs. A tea

cart at the roadside was being packed away. The air carried the smells of roasted makhana, diesel, and the damp earth left by rain.

After walking about half a kos, he heard the faint sound of a bell behind him. An old cycle-rickshaw was approaching slowly. The driver was a thin man around fifty. The back of his kurta was dark with sweat even though a cool night breeze was blowing. The rickshaw's lamp was very dim.

"Rajnagar Road?" Navneet asked.

Without stopping his pedalling, the driver answered, "As far as the railway crossing?"

"Beyond that, near the old dispensary."

"Sit. Sixty rupees."

Again Navneet thought it expensive, but the road was becoming deserted. He sat down.

The rickshaw moved on. For the first few minutes Navneet hummed the film music. Before his eyes were the hero's motorcycle, shining roads, and the lights of a distant city. In his mind he planned that after reaching Delhi he would find work in some clothing warehouse, after a few months change his style of dress, buy a motorcycle, then return to the village and surprise everyone. Labour, rent, food, travel—nothing in the plan was clear; only the picture was clear.

Before the railway crossing, the rise of the rail bridge began. The driver's pedalling became heavy. Navneet did not notice at first. Then he heard that after every two or three breaths a faint rasp came from the driver's throat. The man leaned forward on the seat and put his full weight into the pedals. The back of his right slipper was torn; his heel was exposed.

The rickshaw suddenly slowed. The driver got down and began pulling it by the handle.

Navneet remained seated. After two steps he felt uncomfortable. He got down.

"Stay seated," the driver said. "It is only the incline."

"I can walk."

They began walking side by side with the rickshaw. From the top of the bridge, the red and green railway signals near the station shimmered in the distance. Freight wagons stood beside the tracks below. Holding the handle with one hand, the driver pressed his chest with the other and steadied his breathing.

Navneet asked, "How long have you been driving today?"

"Since six in the morning."

“Until now?”

The driver gave a short answer. “Went home twice in between.”

After they descended from the bridge, he got back on the pedals. Navneet sat down too, but now his eyes were less on the road and more on the driver’s back. White salt marks had dried near the armpits of the kurta. An old cloth bag hung from the left side of the handlebar. The end of a small iron wrench protruded from it.

A little farther on, the chain slipped off. The driver got down immediately. He pulled the rickshaw to the roadside, took the wrench from the bag, and crouched behind the vehicle. Out of habit Navneet put a hand into his pocket, then remembered that his phone battery had died inside the cinema. He simply stood there.

While lifting and setting the chain with his fingers, the driver said, “Second time today.”

“Will it need replacing?”

“Not the chain. The rear sprocket is worn. I will get it repaired tomorrow in the daytime.”

“How much will it cost?”

“The mechanic said two hundred and eighty.”

Without thinking, Navneet touched the inside pocket of his shirt. Four hundred rupees were folded there. He had been planning to buy a pair of black glasses on Saturday—wide-framed ones like the hero’s in the film. He and Ranjit had talked about it all day.

The driver reset the chain and brushed his hands together. Black grease filled the lines of his palms. He pulled out a piece of cloth from the bag, wiped his hands, then drank two gulps of water from a bottle. The bottle was nearly empty.

“What is your name?” Navneet asked.

“Mahendra Sadai.”

“Where is your home?”

“Toward Ranti.”

“That is far from here.”

“I leave the rickshaw in the owner’s courtyard and walk half a kos. Then I have a bicycle.”

Saying this, Mahendra got back on the pedals. There was no complaint in his voice; there was fatigue, but he did not set it apart in his sentences.

When they reached Rajnagar Road, the road widened. The night market was almost closed. In front of a few warehouses, sacks were still being unloaded. Two labourers were lowering bundles from a truck. A watchman sat on a piece of sacking drinking tea.

Navneet suddenly remembered the city he had just seen in the film. In that city, the roads at night had been empty, as though made for the hero. Here the night was not empty. Here the work of people he barely noticed even in daylight was still going on.

Mahendra's rickshaw slowed again. Navneet asked, "Will you still take another passenger?"

"If I get one toward the station, then once more."

"This late?"

"Today the fares were low."

Navneet did not answer. After a while Mahendra himself said, "It rained for two days. Sitting at home does not stop the rickshaw rent."

"How much per day?"

"Ninety. Punctures and small repairs are mine."

That was all. Mahendra fell silent again.

Navneet began doing the arithmetic in his head. Ninety for the rickshaw rent. Two hundred and eighty to replace the sprocket. Even after reaching the rickshaw owner's place, half a kos on foot and then a bicycle ride home. Six in the morning again.

Suddenly his own routine came to mind—standing eight or eight and a half hours in the shop, eating in between, the owner's scolding, bundles of cloth. He wanted to escape the fatigue of all this. Yet in his fantasy of escape, labour itself was absent. As though changing cities would change the rules of work; as though putting on new clothes would make life shine by itself.

The thought did not comfort him. Instead, something inside him tightened.

The old dispensary was now ahead. Navneet got down. Mahendra rang the rickshaw bell once and stopped at the roadside.

"Sixty," he said.

Navneet took out a five-hundred-rupee note. Mahendra shook his head. "No change."

Navneet touched the pocket with the four hundred rupees again. Separately, he had one fifty-rupee note and two ten-rupee notes. He paid sixty. Ten rupees remained.

For a moment he felt like giving something extra. Then it occurred to him that washing away his discomfort immediately with money would itself become another cinema-like scene—a small gesture, a clean ending. He did not want such an ending. Mahendra had named the fare; the fare had been paid. That was all.

Mahendra counted the money and put it into the inside pocket of his kurta. “You know the way from here?”

“Yes.”

The rickshaw turned. Navneet stood by the roadside. Mahendra’s back grew smaller and smaller in the darkness. After two turns, only the dim lamp remained visible; then that too disappeared.

Navneet walked toward his rented room. The cinema ticket was in his pocket. He took it out and looked at it. The hero’s name was printed on the paper in large letters. Because the ticket had been folded, the hero’s name appeared broken through the middle. Navneet did not throw the ticket away. He put it back into his pocket.

When he reached the room, Ranjit, who shared it with him, was still awake. Lying on the cot, he asked, “So, hero sahib! Is the Delhi decision final?” Navneet kept taking off his shoes. “Why are you quiet?” Ranjit laughed. “In the film, did the hero leave the city or not?” “He did.” “Then?” Navneet went to lift the water lota, then corrected himself. “Where is the water?” Ranjit pointed toward the earthen pitcher. Navneet drank and stood by the window. Every now and then a rickshaw bell could still be heard on the road. “Are you going to Delhi or not?” Ranjit asked again. This time Navneet answered, “I may go. But in the calculation I had made so far, some things had not been written down at all.” “What things?”

Navneet did not answer at once. He kept remembering Mahendra’s sweat-darkened kurta, the fallen chain, the two hundred and eighty rupees needed for the sprocket, and his plan to make one more trip toward the station even after eleven at night. He also remembered his own plan for the black glasses. He said, “The real arithmetic of work.” The sentence sounded ordinary to Ranjit. He turned over to sleep. Navneet too did not want to make a declaration out of it.

The next morning, as he left for the shop, the same four hundred rupees were still in his pocket. In the market, the spectacles shop was opening. Navneet looked toward it for a moment, but did not stop. He was thinking that if he went to Delhi, where would he live, how much would the first month’s rent be, how much could he earn in cloth work, and how much money would it be sensible to take from home. There was no glamour in any of these questions.

But for the first time, they seemed to him part of his life—not dull details left over after the film had ended.

STORY 284

The Verandah Bulb

...

In the Benta neighbourhood of Darbhanga, the verandah of Anima Jha's house opened toward the road. An old iron grille, a wooden bench, a sewing machine set against the wall, and a milky-white bulb hanging overhead—these few things gave the verandah its character. By day vegetables were sorted there, clothes were dried, and the children's shoes lay scattered about; when evening fell, Anima would open the cover of the machine and sit down in that same place.

It was half past nine that night. Inside the house Madhukant was adding up the next day's accounts. He had a small grocery shop where he spent the day selling oil, lentils, soap, and spices. Their son Nachiket was in the next room preparing for a technical entrance examination. Their daughter Ragini had finished putting away the kitchen utensils and gone to study. On the verandah Anima was shortening the sleeve of their neighbour Usha's blouse.

"I need it tomorrow morning, Didi," Usha had said that evening when she left the blouse. "I have to go to a wedding. Just shorten these sleeves by two fingers."

Out of habit Anima had said, "Leave it here." There had been no discussion of payment. For years people in the neighbourhood had been leaving small alterations with her. Someone's salwar was loose, someone's petticoat torn, someone's child's kurta too long. Anima kept doing them. Sometimes people brought a spool of thread, sometimes they did not. She herself had never asked for an account.

As she threaded the needle again, the bulb flickered twice. Anima looked up. The yellowish light brightened for a moment, then dimmed.

"Ragini," she called toward the inside, "did you tell Babu about this bulb?"

A voice came from within. "I did. Babu said he would bring one tomorrow."

Madhukant heard too. "I forgot while closing the shop. Remind me in the morning."

Anima started the machine again. She had not made even two stitches when the bulb blinked once and went out. The verandah fell completely dark. The light coming from the inner room grew thin by the time it reached the grille. It was difficult to see the needle of the machine.

Anima took her foot off the pedal.

“Is there a candle?” Madhukant asked from inside.

“There may be one in the kitchen.”

“Then leave it for today. Do it in the morning.”

Anima did not answer. She had promised to return the blouse in the morning. She began feeling under the bench for the small box where extra thread, buttons, measuring tape, and needles were kept. Her hand found two empty spools, then an old measuring tape. No bulb.

Ragini came outside holding a torch. “Ma, take this.”

“Your studies?”

“The battery will not die in ten minutes.”

Ragini held the beam over the machine. Anima began sewing again, but the light would not stay fixed in one place. Her daughter kept changing hands. After five minutes Anima stopped the machine.

“Go and study. I will finish it in the morning.”

When Ragini went back inside, the verandah was dark again. Light from the electric pole on the road cast the square shadow of the grille onto the wall. Anima remained seated in front of the machine. She felt no hurry to go inside.

In that darkness the shape of the machine was not very clear, but her hands knew every part of it. Her mother had given her this machine when she married. Before marriage, Anima had spent two years in Madhubani learning sewing. Her mother had said, “You will do household work anyway, but keep a skill of your own in your hands.”

During the first five or seven years of marriage, Anima had earned a little by sewing clothes for people in the neighbourhood. Then Nachiket was small, her mother-in-law fell ill, and the household work increased. The cover of the machine began to remain closed for months at a time.

After her mother-in-law died, people slowly began bringing clothes again. Even then Anima had thought—this time I will make it regular. She would put up a wooden sign on the verandah, write down fixed hours, keep a separate account for thread and buttons. But that year the roof of the house needed repair. The next year came Nachiket’s examination. Then Ragini had a long fever. Then Madhukant changed shops. Saying “after this time” again and again, seven years passed.

Her sewing had not stopped in the meantime; only it had never acquired the name of work. Clothes for the family, clothes for relatives, small alterations for neighbours—everything kept coming. Asking for payment embarrassed her. When someone voluntarily gave ten or twenty rupees, she put

the money in the thread box. Sometimes she bought needles with it, sometimes coriander and chillies for the house.

Sitting in the darkness, she remembered something from that afternoon. Before leaving the blouse, Usha had been talking about her younger sister-in-law.

“She had the sleeves shortened in the market,” Usha had said. “They charged eighty rupees. I told her Anima Didi would do it.”

Anima had laughed then. The conversation had ended there. Now, in the dark, that figure—eighty rupees—returned to her mind. Shortening sleeves took ten minutes. The thread was hers. The machine was hers. The electricity was from her house. The time was hers.

It was not that she had never understood this arithmetic before. She had. But after doing the calculation she always placed some other thought beside it—Usha is a neighbour; Kusum’s husband knows Madhukant; it is a child’s garment; how can I ask money for such a small job? Each reason seemed right on its own. Put together, all those reasons left her entire work without a name.

From inside Madhukant called, “Anima, are you not coming to sleep?”

“I am coming.”

She stood up but did not cover the machine. Turning the needle wheel by hand, she raised the needle and took out the blouse, folding it carefully. Just then two young women passed outside the grille. Both carried bundles of cloth. One was saying to the other, “Come tomorrow at three. Madam will teach us how to take measurements.”

Their voices moved away.

Anima stood by the grille. Three lanes behind the neighbourhood, a woman taught sewing. Two years earlier Ragini had said that she too would learn during the holidays. Anima had replied, “Learn from me.” But no time was ever fixed. The holidays passed.

The thought did not wound her. It simply raised a straightforward question: if no time is fixed for something, when will it ever happen?

She went inside. Madhukant was closing the account book.

“Bring a bulb tomorrow,” Anima said.

“Yes, first thing in the morning.”

“Bring two. One extra.”

Madhukant looked at her. “All right.”

Anima stood there for a few moments, then said, “And I need a wooden board.”

“What board?”

“To put up on the verandah.”

“Why?”

“I will write the sewing hours on it.”

Madhukant’s hand stopped over the account book. “Hours?”

“Three in the afternoon to six in the evening. Whoever brings clothes should come in that time.”

“All right,” Madhukant said easily. Then, after thinking for a moment, he added, “Will it fit with the housework?”

Earlier, to a question like that, Anima would have said—let us see, if there is time. This time she opened the day inside her mind. Morning cooking, Nachiket’s meal, the tiffin for Madhukant’s shop, the afternoon dishes, evening tea. Not every task had to be done by the same pair of hands. Ragini could make the evening tea. Nachiket could bring milk from the market.

“It will,” Anima said. “Some work will have to be shared.”

Madhukant took a little time before answering. Then he said, “I will tell Ragini. Nachiket can go to the market too.”

That was all. No announcement. No argument. Anima went to sleep, but before sleep came, for the first time she could see the shape of her decision in three hours of the day—three to six. For years she had needed “sometime.” Now she had three numbers.

Usha came very early the next morning. Anima had not yet finished the blouse.

She said plainly, “Sit for ten minutes. The bulb went out last night.”

Usha sat on the bench. On his way to the market, Madhukant had left two bulbs and a narrow wooden board. Nachiket set up a ladder and screwed in the new bulb. It was not particularly needed in daylight, but Anima pressed the switch to test it. Milky-white light fell over the machine.

She finished Usha’s blouse. Usha tried it on and was pleased.

“How much should I give?” she asked naturally.

Earlier Anima would have answered such a question with, “Leave it.” This time she added up the thread and the time in her mind.

“Fifty rupees.”

Without surprise, Usha handed her a fifty-rupee note. “It came out better than the market one. And could you make this neckline a little tighter too?”

Taking the note, Anima said, “Yes. But bring it after three in the evening.”

“Why, are you going somewhere?”

“No. From now on my sewing hours will be three to six.”

Usha looked at her for a moment, then smiled. "Then I will come at three."

After Usha left, Anima did not put the note into the thread box. She took out an old exercise book and wrote the date on the first page: "Sleeves shortened —50." Under it she wrote five rupees as the cost of thread. As she wrote, her handwriting looked slightly awkward to her; after so long, she was keeping a separate account of her sewing.

When Ragini returned from college in the afternoon, the wooden board was lying on the verandah.

"What should I write on this?" she asked.

Anima said, "Write clearly: 'Sewing and Alterations. Hours: Three to Six.' That is all."

"No prices?"

"I will tell the price after seeing the work."

Ragini began painting the letters in black. Nachiket passed by, read the board, and laughed. "Ma's shop!"

Anima kept threading the machine. "Not a shop. Working hours."

There were still twenty minutes before three. The new bulb on the verandah was off; daylight was enough. The old dead bulb lay in one corner of the bench. Ragini picked it up to throw it away.

Anima looked at the dead bulb for a moment and said, "Throw it."

Ragini went toward the rubbish bin outside. Anima lifted the wooden board. The paint was still a little wet. She rested the board inside the grille so that the air could reach it.

At three o'clock, she would hang it up.

STORY 285

The Glass of the Tea Stall

...

South of Laheriasarai Tower, beside the main road, the entire front wall of a newly opened tea stall was glass. As long as the evening light remained, those sitting inside could see the road clearly outside; as darkness deepened, the lights inside came on and the glass became half mirror. Shruti Jha had never paid much attention to this play of light before. That day she had to sit there for nearly forty-five minutes waiting for a bus.

Shruti was in the final year of economics at M.R.M. College. Her father ran a small medicine shop near Sadar Hospital, and her mother taught five or seven children at home. Shruti too taught mathematics to two children in the evenings and earned eighteen hundred rupees a month. For the last six months she had been saving a little from those earnings. Two days earlier she had bought herself a dark-blue cloth bag—a sturdy strap, two compartments inside, and a small zippered pocket outside. It cost eight hundred and fifty rupees. At home her father had said, “Why so expensive?” Shruti had replied with a laugh, “It’s my own earnings.” That sentence had given her a particular pleasure.

Today she had taken the bag to college for the first time. On the way back, at the bus stop, she was told that the bus would be late because a roadside drain was being repaired. Dust was flying, and along one side of the road five women labourers were gathering broken bricks, sand, and mortar. To escape the dust, Shruti went into the tea stall.

Inside there were eight wooden tables. On the wall were written the prices of tea, milk, roasted makhana, and samosas. Jagannath Sah sat at the counter. Shruti ordered a tea and chose a table by the glass. From there she could see the road, and when the bus arrived it would be easy to go out through the entrance.

While she waited for the tea, she hung the bag over the back of the chair and straightened its strap. Her reflection showed faintly in the glass. She adjusted the shoulder of her kurta, pushed a stray lock of hair back with her fingers, then looked to see whether the dull green of her kurta went with the blue of the bag. Dust flew outside the glass, but the reflection half-covered the scene beyond.

“Tea for one here too,” a woman’s voice called from outside.

Jagannath Sah looked out from the counter. “Malti, come inside. There is too much dust.”

“My shoes are smeared with mortar. Just give it to me here.”

Shruti looked outside without meaning to. A woman by the roadside was taking a gamchha from her head and shaking off the dust. She might have been between thirty and thirty-five. Her grey sari was hitched up to her knees, old rubber shoes on her feet, the ash-grey colour of mortar lodged beneath her fingernails. Her name was Malti—Shruti knew that much from the way Jagannath Sah had called her.

The boy from the stall carried tea outside in an earthen kulhad. Malti straightened her back and leaned against the wall. At that moment Shruti’s reflection and Malti’s figure came into the same frame in the glass. Shruti’s blue bag appeared beside Malti’s shoulder, almost as if the bag were hers. Shruti’s hand rested on the table, but in the glass it seemed to lie beside Malti’s cup of tea. The image lasted only two moments; a bicycle passed along the road and the reflection shifted.

Shruti lifted her tea. She found the image interesting. She moved slightly to the right. Again the two figures appeared together. This time her own face was clear, while Malti’s was a little blurred in the light outside. Shruti raised a hand to fix her hair again, then stopped midway.

The munshi overseeing the road repair came toward the workers with a sheet of paper in his hand. He began reading out names and writing something down. “Malti Devi?” he asked.

“I am here,” Malti said.

The munshi wrote something on the sheet. “Half day today.”

Malti moved away from the wall. “How is it half a day? I’ve been here since eight in the morning.”

The munshi looked toward the road. “The gravel didn’t arrive for two hours. Work was stopped.”

Malti asked, “Was I the one who stopped the gravel?”

The munshi said, “I will write the account I have been given.”

Another woman labourer, Shanti, came over. “We were digging out the old mortar during those two hours.”

The munshi folded the sheet. “Half is written from above. Ask tomorrow when the engineer comes.”

Malti said nothing. She drank the tea left in her kulhad in one go. Then she opened a small knot tied in the end of her sari and gave a ten-rupee note to the

stall boy. The boy returned two rupees. Malti looked at the coins and tied them back into the knot of her sari.

More than half of Shruti's tea was still left. She remembered her eighteen hundred rupees a month. Last month, because of two days she had taken off, Vivan's mother had deducted one hundred rupees. Shruti had come home that day very angry. Her mother had said, "People run the accounting for work in their own way." For three days Shruti had thought that from the next month she would stop teaching. But she had not stopped. Even when her income fell, the food at home, her college fees, and her bus fare continued to come from her parents. At the time this had not felt to her like "support"; it had seemed simply the natural arrangement of home.

Outside, Malti returned to the mortar. All five women began lifting broken bricks in a line. The munshi stood on the other side, talking to the driver of a vehicle.

Shruti looked at her bag in the glass. Eight hundred and fifty rupees. She began adding figures in her mind. Tea cost eight rupees; how much Malti earned for half a day, she did not know. Three hundred? Four hundred? It seemed wrong to guess, because she had no facts behind the numbers. But this much was clear: her bag was an object larger in value than some portion of a day's cut wages. As soon as she thought this, she did not feel shame so much as a kind of discomfort—as though, in a familiar room, a new door had suddenly appeared.

She told herself, "I earn too." The sentence was true, but it no longer felt as complete as before. When she said my own earnings, she unknowingly left outside it all the expenses of the household. The rice for meals, the electricity bill, college fees, medicine, the monthly bus fare—these belonged to a world outside her eighteen hundred rupees. Whether Malti's earnings had any such outside world supporting them, Shruti did not know.

Two young men came into the stall and sat at the next table. One said, "Two teas, two samosas." Jagannath Sah called out the order. The lights inside came on. The last daylight outside was thinning. The glass suddenly grew more reflective. Now Shruti could see her own reflection clearly; the road beyond remained like a blurred layer within it.

She took the bag down and placed it in her lap. In the glass the blue strap ran diagonally across her chest. Just then Malti passed behind that frame carrying a basket full of mortar on her head. For a few moments Shruti's face, the blue bag, Malti's raised arms, and the round bottom of the basket joined in the same image. Shruti went still. The light inside made her clear and the

labour outside indistinct. She leaned a little forward and her own reflection deepened; she moved back and the road became slightly clearer.

It seemed to her that the glass hid no one; the light simply altered the measure of the scene according to where the viewer sat. The thought did not form itself into words in her mind. She merely pulled her chair a little farther back. Now she could see less of her own face and more of the road.

Malti emptied the basket and returned again. This time Shanti was with her. They walked slowly, talking. "Will the engineer really come tomorrow?" Shanti asked. Malti laughed. "If he comes, we'll ask. If he doesn't, we'll get it written again."

Shanti asked, "Will the house run on half a day's wage?" Malti replied, "There's rice today. Oil is short. We'll see tomorrow."

Only those words reached inside. No long note of complaint, no heroism. Then both women merged into the noise of the road. Shruti looked at her cup. The tea had gone cold.

The green stripe of the bus appeared in the distance. Shruti got up at once. She gave a twenty-rupee note at the counter. As Jagannath Sah returned the change, he asked, "The bus has come?" Shruti said, "Yes."

She put the bag over her shoulder. At the entrance she looked back once at the glass. From outside, it looked different now. With the lights on inside, the whole stall shone like a bright box. In that light her empty chair was clearly visible, and so was the cup of half-finished tea on the table. From the roadside, there was almost no reflection of her.

The bus stopped. Shruti climbed aboard and sat by the window. As it moved slowly ahead, the workers beside the drain were putting away their tools. Malti was shaking out her gamchha and placing it over her head. The sheet of paper was still in the munshi's hand.

In the bus window, Shruti's reflection appeared again. Ordinarily, as soon as a journey began, she looked at her hair, the bindi on her forehead, or the shoulder of her kurta. This time too the blue bag was clear in the reflection. But her gaze did not settle on it. Beyond the glass, the road was slipping backward.

By the time they reached the turn at the Tower, the light of the tea stall had grown small. For a moment Shruti remembered that frame again in which her bag and Malti's basket had appeared together. The two objects were not alike. The glass had only placed them in the same scene for a moment.

Shruti placed the bag in her lap. Its price was still eight hundred and fifty rupees. The only thing that had changed was that the sum no longer told her a story of her earnings alone.

STORY 286

Railway Announcement

...

On platform number three at Darbhanga Junction, the evening sunlight lay thin across the railway tracks like a blacksmith's tongs. Vinodnath Mahato sat on a wooden bench with his blue bag between his feet. Inside the bag were two bundles of bicycle spokes, brake cables, a small box of bells, and an account slip from a wholesale shop in Samastipur. He was past seventy-two, yet his small bicycle-repair shop in Sakri bazaar still opened each morning by his own hand. His son looked after the fields, his grandson studied, and Vinodnath felt that without the smell of old tyres and grease on his thumb, the day remained somehow incomplete.

The train that would take him home after buying supplies in Samastipur was running an hour late. On the platform, people kept getting up, looking toward the information board, then sitting down again. A tea-selling boy passed with a brass kettle in his hand, calling, "Tea, hot tea." Vinodnath bought a kulhad. The first sip was too hot. He set the cup beneath the bench and touched the knot of his bag once more. The account slip inside listed goods worth twelve thousand four hundred rupees. That was no small sum for him; if sales went badly for two months, his credit would rise.

Just then the loudspeaker above crackled. First came a few indistinct sounds, then a woman's clear voice: "Passengers are requested to pay attention..." Vinodnath usually half-heard such announcements and let the rest pass. But the next three words reached him with perfect clarity—"for Jamalpur..." His hand, bending toward the kulhad, stopped where it was.

Jamalpur.

More than fifty years had passed. The word had not grown old.

A thin young man sitting beside him rose at once. A khaki bag lay in his lap, and the corner of a measuring tape showed from its outer pocket. Nervously he asked, "Kaka, which platform will the Jamalpur train come on? I couldn't understand the announcement properly."

Vinodnath looked up at the board. The red digit 5 was glowing. "Platform five," he said. "Go over the footbridge. There is time."

The young man thanked him and slung the bag over his shoulder. After taking two steps, he turned back. "I'm going for a vocational training course. First time this far."

Vinodnath merely nodded. The young man disappeared into the crowd.

The announcement was repeated over the loudspeaker. “Jamalpur...” This time, as soon as he heard the word, it was not the present platform at Darbhanga that rose before Vinodnath’s eyes, but the earth-mixed surface of the old Sakri station. He had been nineteen then. Thick hair on his head, a light-brown shirt stitched by his father, and a small tin trunk in his hand. Inside the trunk were two pairs of clothes, a gamchha, sattu prepared by his mother, and the address of the training centre at the Jamalpur railway workshop.

The opportunity had not come by any miracle. Ramsevak Babu, his mathematics teacher in high school, had noticed his interest in taking machines apart and putting them together again. At the teacher’s urging, Vinodnath sat the recruitment examination. Five young men from the village went; only Vinodnath was selected. At home there were three bighas of land, two younger brothers, and his father’s bicycle-repair shop. Their income was limited, but his father had borrowed from two customers to arrange the journey and the expenses of the first month.

On the morning of his departure, his father had come with him as far as Sakri station. Not once on the way had he said, “Don’t go.” On the contrary, while placing an old screwdriver from the shop in the trunk, he had said, “Your own tool is the trust of your own hand.” His mother had tied sattu into a bundle. His younger brothers had run all the way to the station.

For years Vinodnath had remembered all this in another way. The family was poor, there was a burden on the household, his father was unwell—all of that was true. But there was one truth he had repeatedly kept away even from himself.

The train had arrived.

It had arrived on time.

There had been an announcement that day too. The sound had broken and crackled, but he had heard both words—“Samastipur” and “Jamalpur”—clearly. The ticket was in the breast pocket of his shirt. His father had come as far as the outside of the platform, not inside. Vinodnath had stood beside the trunk. People kept boarding. Porters lifted luggage and placed it inside. An old man seated his grandson by the window. A newly married woman climbed onto a seat surrounded by red trunks. The train whistled.

Vinodnath’s heart was beating so hard that he thought everyone would hear it the moment he boarded. All at once he was surrounded by the thought of the unknown room in the Jamalpur hostel, unfamiliar people, strict training, and spending month after month far from his village. The familiar

smell of his father's shop, his mother's courtyard, the edge of the pond, evening football—everything became extraordinarily precious in that instant.

He took one step toward the train, then stopped.

The second whistle sounded.

The train left.

His father was waiting outside. Vinodnath came out carrying the trunk. His father asked, "What happened?"

The first sentence he spoke was still perfectly clear in his memory: "The train was too crowded. I couldn't get on."

His father looked at his face for a few moments. Then he picked up the trunk. "Again tomorrow?"

Vinodnath said, "They said admission to the training was only today. What can happen now?"

That second sentence was larger than the first. After it, the story began making itself. Sometimes he said the train had left before time; sometimes that he had been delayed while changing the ticket. In later years, the poverty of the family became a convenient sheet spread over every reason. No one had much time to question him. Two days later his father put him to work full-time in the shop. Vinodnath learned the craft, married, had children, and the shop came into his name. His life did not remain empty.

But whenever some young man left to study or work elsewhere, Vinodnath would say, "I too had a chance to go to Jamalpur, but the condition of the house did not let me go." For years he repeated that story in many forms, and in the end he himself began to accept it as true.

The sound of a train entering platform three brought Vinodnath back to the present. It was not his train. A goods train was passing slowly. One iron wagon after another moved ahead. At every coupling came a knock-knock sound. He picked up the kulhad. The tea had gone cold.

On the footbridge toward platform five, he saw the same young man. He was moving quickly through the crowd but not running. His bag kept slipping from his shoulder, and he kept hitching it back up. The worry caused by changing platforms was clear on his face. For a few moments Vinodnath felt like calling out loudly, "Don't be afraid. Get on." But he remained silent. The young man's fear belonged to the young man; its answer too had to come from him.

With that thought, for the first time Vinodnath felt no anger toward his nineteen-year-old self. Whether that boy had been a coward was not a question with so simple an answer. He had only been afraid. And admitting fear, even

fifty years later, was no easier than keeping a lie standing in the name of poverty.

He remembered that his father had not spoken a single bitter word on the way home that day. He had merely carried the weight of the trunk himself for half the road. Perhaps his father had understood everything. Perhaps he had not. Vinodnath did not want to guess now.

The loudspeaker sounded again. This time it was the announcement for his train to Samastipur. He was told to go to platform two. Vinodnath lifted his bag. The goods worth twelve thousand four hundred rupees, the two bundles of spokes, and the box of bells did not suddenly become heavier; the weight was exactly what it had been. He walked toward the stairs of the footbridge. The first five steps came easily. On the sixth, his knee hurt a little. He held the railing, paused for a moment, then continued upward.

Reaching the middle of the bridge, he looked toward platform five. The Jamalpur train was still standing there. The young man was near a doorway, looking for his seat. Once inside by the window, he placed his bag above him, then looked out. The fear had not vanished from his face. Only now that fear was inside a moving train, not on the platform.

Vinodnath's train came into platform two. He sat by a window. Opposite him were three children from one family, a bundle lay on the luggage rack above, and a basket of vegetables stood in the corner. Before the train started, the ticket examiner came. Vinodnath took the ticket from his pocket and handed it over. The man glanced at it and returned it.

The ticket read "Darbhanga—Samastipur." Vinodnath folded it and put it back in his pocket.

The train began to move slowly. The platform slipped backward. An announcement for some other train began over the loudspeaker, but the words were no longer clear. Vinodnath kept looking out of the window. His old story came back to him again—poverty, the burden of the house, the train that had been missed. This time he made one small correction to the sentence, silently, for himself.

The train had not been missed. He had not boarded it. That was all. After that, the fields, the shop, marriage, children, debt, earnings—the next pages of life remained exactly as they had been. Only one sentence on the first page had been corrected.

Outside the window, evening was deepening. A train bound toward Sakri rushed past in the opposite direction. Its gust shook the window glass. Vinodnath pulled his blue bag closer to his feet and leaned back against the

seat. When the announcement for the next station began, this time he tried to listen to it in full.

STORY 287

A Strip of Sunlight

...

It was a morning in Agahan. East of Rahika market, beside the road to Bisfi, in Tanti Tola, a thin strip of sunlight entered the eastern room of Shivanandan Das's house through a small latticed window. On the mud-plastered floor, the strip first shone near the door, then slowly began to move toward the cot. Shivanandan watched it from his pillow. The high fever had subsided, but his body was still so weak that even going as far as the veranda twice left him breathing hard.

There were two looms in his house. He himself sat at one, his son Naval at the other. They had an order for thirty gamchas with red borders for a cloth merchant in Darbhanga. The yarn had arrived eighteen days earlier; the goods were due in seven days. Before the fever took hold of him, Shivanandan had completed fourteen. Naval was managing the remaining work by running one loom at a time.

The old clock that hung on the wall of the room had been taken to the loom room because Naval needed to watch the time while changing the warp. What remained to tell Shivanandan the hour were the sounds from the courtyard, the school bell, and this strip of sunlight.

On the first day he had paid no particular attention to it. When his wife, Devaki, came to give him medicine, he asked, "What time is it?"

"Half past ten."

Shivanandan saw that the sunlight was about two handspans away from the leg of the cot. He took the medicine and closed his eyes again. A little while later the khat-khat of the loom stopped. His ears became alert at once.

"Naval!" he called loudly.

From the veranda came the reply, "The warp has broken, Babu. I am joining it."

"How many times will it break? You have left the yarn loose."

Naval said nothing. Five or seven minutes later the khat-khat began again. Shivanandan's eyes went to the sunlight. The strip had already crossed half the distance to the cot leg. It seemed to him that time was running very fast even though the loom had stopped.

At noon the school bell sounded. Devaki came with rice and thin moong dal. Shivanandan picked up a small piece of charcoal lying on the floor beside the cot and drew a line along the edge of the sunlight.

Devaki asked, "What are you doing?"

"I will see tomorrow whether the sunlight is here at twelve."

Devaki did not laugh. She merely set down the plate and said, "Eat first. Settle accounts with the sun afterward."

Shivanandan had spent his whole life keeping accounts. A hand of cloth, a yard of yarn, how much thread went into one gamcha, how many pieces could be woven in a day, how much the merchant would deduct, how much the dyer would charge—everything added itself up at once in his mind. When Naval sat at the loom, Shivanandan could look at the hands of the clock and know how much weft had gone in within an hour. The habit irritated Naval, but he never objected.

On the second day, when the school bell rang, Shivanandan was already watching the sunlight. The strip was not on yesterday's charcoal line; it was about two finger-widths to the left.

He called Devaki. "Look. The bell rang at twelve, didn't it?"

Devaki listened toward the courtyard. "Yes. The second shift has been dismissed."

"Then why is the sunlight wrong?"

Devaki smiled. "The sunlight is not wrong. Your line is fixed."

Shivanandan did not like that answer. He drew a second line. On the third day the strip had shifted again. On the fourth as well. Now four short black lines lay on the floor, as though a child had made an unfinished staircase.

During those four days, along with the sunlight, Shivanandan began to notice the work of the household that had earlier escaped his eye. Around half past ten Devaki sorted paddy in the courtyard. At about eleven Naval's wife, Mira, filled the bobbins with yarn. Before twelve Naval would stop the loom to inspect the warp, join broken threads, and load weft into the wooden shuttle. In the afternoon Mira brought down the dried yarn from the roof. Amid all this, the sound of the loom stopped from time to time, but the work did not stop.

On the fifth day Mahesh Sah came. He collected cloth from village to village for the merchant in Darbhanga. Sitting on the veranda, he counted the finished gamchas with Naval.

"Twenty-three?" he asked.

"Twenty-three complete. Two are on the loom."

"I need thirty in seven days. The vehicle leaves on Tuesday."

Shivanandan, lying on the cot, was listening. From inside he called, "Naval, run the loom two extra hours at night."

Mahesh Sah came to the doorway of the room and said, "You rest, Kaka. As long as the goods reach on time."

"They will reach on time," Shivanandan said.

Mahesh left. Naval sat at the loom again. The khat-khat remained brisk until evening. Even after the night meal, the loom went on sounding. Shivanandan kept turning from side to side on the cot. What he had said seemed reasonable to him—if the order did not go on time, the next job might go to another household. But around ten at night, when he heard Naval cough, he fell silent for a moment.

The next morning, when the strip of sunlight appeared near the door, Shivanandan sat up. His body felt lighter than before. He looked at the five black lines on the floor. Each stood a little apart from the next. The differences were so small that one had to bend down to see them, yet taken across five days it was clear that the strip was changing its path.

That day, while working the loom, Naval slowly stopped. Shivanandan waited for the sound to begin again. It did not. Five minutes. Ten minutes. The strip of sunlight moved past the first line and continued toward the second.

At last Shivanandan himself came as far as the veranda. Naval was sitting beside the loom with the warp opened. Two red-border threads had become tangled at a point where forcing them would spoil the entire border.

"How long will it take?" Shivanandan asked.

Without raising his head, Naval said, "As long as it takes. If I cut it and join it again, the mark will show."

Earlier, an answer like that would have made Shivanandan impatient. This time he stood with a hand resting on the wood of the loom. Naval separated the threads one by one. Mira kept filling bobbins and setting them aside. After nearly half an hour the warp was fit to run again.

Shivanandan returned to his room. The strip of sunlight was now touching the leg of his cot. He thought: in this half hour the hands of the clock must have advanced thirty minutes, yet not an inch of cloth had grown on the loom. Even so, the warp had been saved, the border had been saved, two days' labour had been saved. This time had not been empty.

He looked again at his charcoal lines. Until yesterday he had thought the sunlight was telling him the time. Now he understood that the sunlight

showed only that time was passing; what was happening within that passage had to be reckoned separately.

By the evening of the sixth day, twenty-seven gamchas were ready. Mahesh Sah came again. Seeing three still unfinished, his brows tightened.

“Will they be ready by tomorrow afternoon?”

Naval said, “Two will be. For the third, there is a little shortage of dyed yarn. Mira will fill the bobbins tonight, then we will see.”

Mahesh looked toward Shivanandan. “Kaka, if he runs it through the night, everything will be ready by dawn.”

Shivanandan’s habit was to calculate at once. Four hours of night, so much time for each gamcha, a warp change in between—the numbers rose in his mind. Then he looked at Naval’s eyes. They were red from two nights of wakefulness. Near the loom treadle, the skin of his heel had been rubbed raw.

Shivanandan said, “We will give you two by tomorrow afternoon. The third in the evening. If the vehicle leaves, send it with the next consignment.”

Mahesh was silent for a few moments. “If one is short, the account will be different.”

“Make it different,” Shivanandan said. “If the cloth goes wrong, the account will be even worse.”

Mahesh gave no reply. He tied up the finished gamchas and left.

Naval looked at his father’s face but said nothing. Shivanandan too offered no sermon. He returned to the cot and lay down. The evening sunlight had already left the room. Only the black lines remained on the floor.

On the seventh day Shivanandan did not wait for the school bell. At noon, when Devaki came with his medicine, she saw him holding the piece of charcoal and drawing one long mark beside the old lines.

“Another mark for twelve o’clock today?”

“No,” Shivanandan said. “This is how far it has come in seven days.”

Setting down the plate, Devaki asked, “And what does that account tell you?”

Shivanandan placed the piece of charcoal on the window ledge. “Nothing. Just something to look at.”

In the afternoon Naval took the twenty-eighth gamcha off the loom. The twenty-ninth remained on it. The yarn for the thirtieth was not ready even by evening. Shivanandan knew the number, but he did not ask the time.

The next morning the thin strip of sunlight came down near the door again, a little apart from yesterday’s long mark. Half-sitting on the cot, Shivanandan watched it. The strip did not move faster when the loom sounded,

nor did it stop as on a feverish night. Its movement was so slow that one could not notice it in a single moment; but look away and look again, and it had changed its place.

From the veranda the khat-khat began. Naval was running only one loom today. Devaki was spreading paddy in the courtyard. Mira was filling bobbins. Outside on the road, the voices of children going to school rose and then faded into the distance.

Shivanandan looked at the lines of seven days on the floor. For the first time the question did not arise in his mind of how many pieces would be made today. He simply watched—the strip of sunlight crossed the first line, then the second, and moved on at its own pace.

STORY 288

A Fragment of Music

...

It was a cold evening in Magh. In Lakshmisagar, Darbhanga, a pavilion of coloured cloth had been raised in front of Sudhanshu Babu's house. From the gate inward, garlands of marigolds, bamboo poles, and little electric bulbs shone everywhere. There was still time before the bridegroom's procession arrived, but the band players had begun tuning their instruments at one side of the road. A long note rose first from a brass trumpet, then came two beats of the drum, and after that three short notes—high, low, then high.

Sixty-four-year-old Shashikant Chaudhary sat on a chair in a corner of the verandah with an earthen cup of tea in his hand. He did not raise his head at the first note. The second time those same three notes sounded, his fingers stopped on the rim of the cup. The third time, the young trumpeter repeated the exercise. In front of Shashikant, the present wedding pavilion disappeared; all at once, the courtyard of his younger sister's wedding thirty years earlier opened before him.

His nephew Alok came near and asked, "Kaka, has the tea gone cold? Shall I bring another?"

Shashikant looked at the cup. "No, this is fine."

Alok went back inside laughing. Shashikant's ears turned again toward the road. The trumpeter was now testing another tune, but those first three notes had lodged somewhere inside him.

At that time Shashikant had been thirty-one. After the Sakri sugar mill closed, he had taken up accounting work in a fertiliser-and-seed cooperative society in Madhubani. Within the family he was regarded as the educated one, the man who understood accounts and remained steady in his dealings. At his sister Neelam's wedding, the cash expenditure, the workers' payments, and the accounts of the band and the caterer were all his responsibility.

By afternoon on the wedding day, the house was full. The band had come from Madhubani—six musicians and two adolescent assistants. One of the boys was Naseem, sixteen or seventeen, thin-bodied, deep-eyed, with long fingers. He was the nephew of Salim, the principal trumpeter. His work was to carry the instruments, hand things out from the wire box, and, in the intervals when the players grew tired, sometimes take up the small trumpet and practise.

Before evening fell, Naseem had come to Shashikant. "Babuji, the master says it would help if half the wages could be paid now. We need to buy medicine for my mother at home."

A red-bound account register lay open in front of Shashikant. Without looking up, he had said, "The contract is for the whole band. Payment will be made after the bride's departure. The account will not be broken in between."

Naseem remained standing for a few moments. "I'm not asking for my own share. If you tell the master to give half as an advance—"

"I told you, after the departure." Shashikant's voice had hardened, because at that very moment the caterer had come asking about the shortage of ghee. Naseem had gone away quietly.

At ten that night, when the wedding procession arrived, the courtyard became so crowded that it was difficult to recognise even one's own people. Shashikant had slipped a brown envelope containing cash into a fold of a red shawl for safekeeping. The envelope held six thousand four hundred rupees, the combined payments for the band, the tonga, the fish seller, and two labourers. At that time, six thousand four hundred rupees was not merely a sum to him; it was the final accounting of the entire wedding.

Then, as happens on such occasions, five different tasks seemed to call for him at once: the list of items for the kanyadaan, the question of sending milk to the quarters where the groom's party was staying, the priest's dakshina, and fuel for the generator in the outer courtyard. About half an hour later, when Shashikant looked for the envelope, the desk drawer was empty.

At first he searched silently. Then beneath the red-bound register, behind a pillow, beside the box. The envelope was nowhere. His mouth went dry.

"Who all came here?" Mama Raghunath had asked.

Shashikant did not answer at once. He remembered that Naseem had come asking for an advance. He himself had said nothing about it, but no one knew how, within ten minutes, the word spread that a boy from the band had been asking for money.

Naseem was stopped in the outer courtyard. At that moment the band was waiting a little away from the wedding pavilion for the groom's party to enter. Salim lowered the trumpet from his mouth and asked, "What happened?"

"An envelope can't be found," Raghunath had said. "The boy was moving around here."

Naseem's face hardened at once. "I went to ask for money. I did not see any envelope."

Nothing more needed to be said. Two young men opened his bag and searched it. Inside were an old gamchha, a small bottle of oil, two rotis wrapped in cloth, and a medicine prescription. Nothing else. Then the pockets of his kurta were searched.

By the time Shashikant reached there, the search was still going on. The moment Naseem saw him, he said, “Babuji, you tell them. I only came to ask for an advance.”

At that single sentence something flashed within Shashikant. He remembered the red shawl. Before the crowd had thickened, he himself had taken the envelope out of the drawer and tucked it into a fold of the shawl because the drawer key kept sticking. The memory was so clear that he could even see the small knot of black thread on the edge of the shawl.

At that very moment he should have gone into the next room and opened the shawl.

But he remained standing there.

By then four or five people had already voiced suspicion about Naseem. If Shashikant immediately said that perhaps he himself had placed the envelope somewhere else, everyone’s eyes would turn toward him. The household’s “keeper of accounts” had forgotten where he had put the money—there would be laughter, reproach, and questions about his management in the middle of the wedding. He told himself: let me search for two minutes; when the envelope is found, I will say that the money was safe.

Those two minutes became ten.

Naseem’s bag was turned out a second time. Salim’s face burned with humiliation and anger. He said, “I have been playing at weddings for twenty years. Hold back the payment if you wish, but why are you searching the boy’s body?”

Raghunath replied, “Let the money be found. Then everything will be clear.”

Meanwhile the groom’s party was reaching the gate. The bandmaster signalled to Salim; if the music stayed silent, the spectacle would only grow. Salim looked at Naseem, then clenched his teeth and raised the trumpet. The main tune could not begin at once. Naseem, one button of whose kurta had broken during the search, picked up the small trumpet and began to tune it. Three notes—high, low, then high. At that signal Salim caught the main melody.

Listening to those three notes, Shashikant went inside. He opened the fold of the red shawl. The brown envelope was there. Not a single rupee was missing.

He came out and said, "It has been found. It had slipped in among the things." Raghunath asked, "Where?" Shashikant had replied, "It was inside. I couldn't see it in the crowd."

That was all. He did not say that he himself had put the envelope there. Nor did he say that Naseem was innocent, because the very basis of the suspicion had been his own forgetting. No question of apology arose. The groom's procession passed through the gate. The band began to play loudly. Naseem remained with the band throughout the night, because the full wages would only be paid after the bride's departure.

The next morning, at the time of payment, Shashikant counted the money and handed it to Salim. Naseem was not there. Salim had said, "He is by the groom's quarters, gathering the equipment."

Shashikant did not call him. It had seemed to him then that the money had been found, the full wages had been paid, and the matter was over.

For years he did not even remember the incident in this form. Looking through the wedding photographs, he remembered his sister, his parents, the old courtyard, the paag, the garland of makhana—everything. Not Naseem. If that night ever did rise in memory, Shashikant would tell himself, "I never accused anyone. People suspected him on their own. As soon as the envelope was found, I stopped the matter."

Today, hearing those same three notes on the road in Lakshmisagar, the blank space inside that sentence filled itself in. Before "as soon as the envelope was found," there had been ten minutes. In those ten minutes he had understood the truth, yet had not spoken it. He had not beaten anyone, had not abused anyone; he had only remained silent in order to save himself from the small embarrassment of damaged prestige. But for Naseem, that silence had become suspicion laid upon his pockets, his bag, and his body.

On the road, the young musician in the present band played the three notes again. This time Shashikant watched his hands—thin fingers, slightly stiff from the cold. He could not remember whether Naseem's fingers had been like that. He remembered only the broken button.

From inside came the sounds of preparations for a wedding ritual. The women were laughing. Alok came out again. "Kaka, the groom's procession will be here in five minutes. Will you come inside?"

Shashikant rose. His knees were a little stiff. He set the earthen cup with the remaining tea at the edge of the verandah. "I'm coming."

At the gate he turned once more and looked toward the road. The band players had readied their instruments. One assistant was arranging all the empty cases in a row. No one was paying attention to him. For a moment

Shashikant wondered: where might Naseem be now? Would he remember that night or not? Would Salim still be alive? There were no answers. The distance of thirty years had made the questions heavier than any answer.

Alok said, “Kaka?”

Shashikant replied, “Yes.”

He moved inside. Just then, behind him, the trumpet lifted those three notes again—high, low, high. This time they did not sound to him like the tune of an old wedding. They sounded only like the measure of ten minutes: so small that on a clock they were almost nothing, and so long that a boy’s broken button had remained stitched into memory exactly as it was even thirty years later.

STORY 289

The Closed Shop

...

At the warehouse of a wholesale distributor in Madhubani, Aniruddh Karn was opening boxes of brightly coloured toys. A company in Patna had assigned him to assess demand for its goods in the markets of North Bihar. Wooden spinning tops no longer appeared on his list; in their place were shiny plastic spinners, balls that made sounds when squeezed, little cars, whistles, and multicoloured wheels. Aniruddh matched the number of boxes, entered the figures in the register, and told the distributor, "I'll finalise the next consignment by evening."

In the middle of the meeting he found himself with forty-five minutes free. On the old market road that ran from the warehouse toward the station stood the shop he had loved most in childhood—Lalbabu's toy shop. In the twenty-seven years since, he had come to the town many times, but every visit had been swallowed by trains, meetings, and accounts. This time the warehouse was close to the market. He set out on foot.

In his memory Lalbabu's shop was very small, but the world inside it was vast. Wooden spinning tops, glass marbles, rubber balls, coloured kites, bamboo whistles, paper pinwheels, cloth pouches for keeping game pieces—each object was a separate festival to the child Aniruddh. There was a green strip beneath the awning. Inside, a small brass bell hung above the wooden cupboard and rang whenever anyone entered. While showing the goods, Lalbabu would say, "Take it in your hand and look, but don't drop it."

Aniruddh reached the turn. In place of the shop, a grey iron shutter was closed. There was no signboard. Only two old nails and the faint imprint of letters remained. He looked at his watch. It was midday. His first thought was that Lalbabu must have gone to eat.

He asked the young man who ran the photocopy centre next door, "What time does this toy shop open?" The young man looked at the shutter. "It has been closed for a long time." "How long?" "Seven or eight years, perhaps. Even when I took over this centre, it hardly opened regularly."

Aniruddh remained silent for a few moments. Seven or eight years did not feel like a number to him; it felt like a kind of omission. The shop had been closed all those years, and yet in his memory it had kept opening every day.

He went up to the shutter. In one place, beneath the dust, a layer of blue paint had peeled away. Under the blue, a green line showed through. In Aniruddh's memory the shutter itself had always been green. When, then, had the blue been painted over it? He could not remember.

Without stopping his work, the young man said, "Lalbabu used to sit there first. Later his nephew looked after it for some time. The stock kept getting smaller. The rent went up. Then the shutter came down." That was all. The young man had neither the time to tell the history of Lalbabu nor any reason to understand what the memory meant to Aniruddh. A woman arrived to have some copies made, and the young man bent over her papers.

Aniruddh remained standing before the shutter. Three scenes began to rise before his eyes at once. First—the seven-year-old Aniruddh buying a wooden spinning top with a coin his father had given him. Second—choosing glass marbles with his friends in Class Five. Third—buying kite string after his Class Ten examination. In Aniruddh's memory, Lalbabu was almost the same age in all three scenes, the shutter the same green, the cupboard equally full.

But memory had not been so straightforward.

All at once he remembered an evening from Class Nine. A large new toy shop had opened near the station. His friend Subodh had said, "Balls are two rupees cheaper there." The two of them had gone. They had spent a long time looking at bright plastic whistles and shiny balls. They had bought their things there. On the way back they had passed Lalbabu's shop. Lalbabu had raised a hand from inside. Aniruddh too had waved, but had not gone in. Why did that scene never remain inside his memory of the "beloved shop"? By then Aniruddh was no longer a child but an adolescent who had turned toward lower prices and more choice. His share in the history of Lalbabu's dwindling customers had been negligible, but it had not been zero.

Another incident came back to him. Once the iron nail in his favourite spinning top had bent. Aniruddh had reached the shop almost in tears. Lalbabu had not merely been a seller of spinning tops; he had pulled out the nail, straightened it with a small hammer, then rubbed the wooden point a little until the balance was right. Five minutes later the top was spinning again. Aniruddh had held out a coin, but Lalbabu had refused it. "Before buying a new one, first see whether the old one can be made to run," he had said.

Now, almost no one repaired the goods Aniruddh sold. If a plastic spinner went wrong, the buyer returned to the retailer, the retailer reported the number to the wholesale distributor, and the company adjusted the loss in the next consignment. Instead of being opened and made to work again, the object became a figure in an account. This system was Aniruddh's livelihood, and he

did not consider it wrong. But remembering Lalbabu's shop, he understood for the first time that although the words "toy shop" had remained the same across both periods, the trade inside them had become entirely different. Indeed, his own daily work now consisted of expanding the distribution of inexpensive wholesale goods. Objects like the plastic top-shaped spinner he had counted in the warehouse a little while earlier must also, little by little, have displaced the wooden toys of such small shops.

No great wave of guilt rose in Aniruddh. A market does not change because of one person. Lalbabu's shop had not existed merely to preserve Aniruddh's childhood memories; it had rent to pay, stock to buy, earnings to make. But within this ordinary arithmetic he understood something new: the permanence of the shop in his memory had not been created by the strength of its business, but by his own absence. A change he had not witnessed had seemed almost not to have happened at all.

A small flake of blue paint came loose from the shutter and fell. The green beneath showed more clearly. Aniruddh tried to remember whether the shop had already been painted blue when he was in Class Ten. For a few moments he strained to recall. Then he realised that the green awning, the blue shutter, the wooden cupboard, Lalbabu's thick hair, and the white at his temples in later years had all merged into a single picture. The shop preserved inside him had perhaps never existed in exactly that form on any one actual day.

Two boys stopped their bicycles beside the shutter. One leaned his bag against it while the other bent to tie his shoelace. For them, the closed shutter was only a patch of shade. A few moments later they rode away. Aniruddh did not find the sight sad. He understood only this much: the same place acquires different meanings for people of different ages at different times.

He remembered the time of the meeting and turned back toward the warehouse.

Wholesale distributor Rakesh Sah was sitting with the register open. The company's sample goods were spread over the table. Rakesh's son was spinning a plastic toy on the floor. It whirled rapidly, giving off red and yellow light, then after a few moments wobbled and fell.

The boy picked it up and spun it again. This time a small wheel came off and rolled to one side. The child picked it up and held it out to his father. Without concern, Rakesh said, "It's only a sample piece. We'll replace it." He set the wheel at the corner of the table and opened another sample. Aniruddh said nothing. His eyes rested for a moment on that small wheel, then returned to the register. Rakesh said, "Aniruddhji, this item should sell well in the smaller markets. The price is low. Shall I put down one carton?"

Aniruddh took the sample in his hand. It was very light. He remembered the weight of the wooden spinning top from his childhood—the feel of winding the string tight around it, the rasping sound that rose when it struck the earth. The comparison came into his mind, but he said nothing about it. "Not one carton," he said, looking at the register. "Send half a carton first. We'll see the sales and increase the next consignment accordingly." Rakesh wrote down the figure. "All right." The meeting moved on. They discussed the price of balls, the quantity of little cars, transport charges, and the retailer's margin. Aniruddh continued his work just as before. But when he reached the line in the register marked "Old Market," his pen paused for a moment. The new distribution point was a shop that had opened behind the photocopy centre. Lalbabu's name was not on the list.

Rakesh asked, "What happened?" "Nothing," Aniruddh said, and wrote down the name of the new shop.

In the evening, on the way to the station, the rickshaw driver asked, "Where should I turn?" The old landmark rose to Aniruddh's tongue—near Lalbabu's toy shop. But the words did not come out. He said, "Turn left at the bend just beyond the photocopy centre." The rickshaw reached the turn. Aniruddh looked once at the closed shutter. Amid the grey paint, a thin green line remained visible even after the sunlight had faded. Above the green was blue, and above the blue, grey. The rickshaw moved on. The shop did not disappear from Aniruddh's mind; for the first time, he saw its different years in their different colours.

STORY 290

The Eaves

...

At Benta Chowk in Laheriasarai, the rain came down so hard that the road which, ten minutes earlier, had been raising dust suddenly turned into a gleaming black strip. Aniruddha pulled his two-wheeler to the side of the road and ran beneath the eaves of a closed clothing shop. Under his arm was a blue tube in which a building plan had been rolled. The first thing he did was check the tube's cap; the second was brush the sleeve of his white kurta.

An unfamiliar man was already standing beneath the eaves. White stains of dried cement marked the shoulder of his grey shirt, his slippers were caked with mud, and the skin on two fingers of his right hand had turned rough. Beside him lay an old cloth bag and a small measuring tape.

Aniruddha went and stood at the other end of the eaves. He did not set the tube against the wall; he kept it in his hand. The stranger looked once at the tube, then at Aniruddha's face, and remained silent.

The rain thickened. The lettering across the road blurred. Water poured steadily from the front edge of the eaves, but at the left corner a thin stream began to curl back toward the wall. Within moments the limewash there darkened with damp.

Looking up, the stranger said, "There is no groove underneath."

Aniruddha looked up by reflex. "What groove?"

"Under the edge of the eaves. So the water falls forward instead of turning back toward the wall."

The point seemed ordinary to Aniruddha. "What difference can that little thing make?"

With the edge of his palm, the man indicated the thickness of the eaves. "Rain does not come for only one day. Two years from now this stream will have made a mark all the way inside."

Aniruddha smiled inwardly. For the past six months he had been drawing plans at a construction consultancy office. Lines, measurements, sections, and heights were his daily work. Whenever something seemed wrong at a construction site, his first sentence was usually the same: "Where does a mason ever read the plan properly?" He had said exactly that the previous week after seeing cracked plaster on the verandah of a new house.

He looked at the stranger's stained shirt and decided silently that he too must be a labourer returning from some construction site.

The rain kept forcing the two men closer beneath the eaves. When the wind began driving water in from the left, Aniruddha had to move away from his end. Now only a hand's breadth separated them.

The man lifted his bag and set it against the wall, making room for Aniruddha's blue tube. "Put it here. Less water will reach it."

Aniruddha kept the tube in his hand. "If it gets wet, there will be damage."

"Paper?"

"A plan."

"For construction?"

Aniruddha gave a short answer. "Yes."

The man looked up at the eaves again. "Then you can tell whether the plan for these eaves showed a groove underneath or not."

Aniruddha's tone hardened slightly. "I do not draw the plan for every eave."

The man did not laugh. "That is true. I only asked."

For a while both were silent. A rickshaw cut through the water on the road. The splash reached as far as the eaves. The stranger drew his mud-covered slippers slightly back so that the spray would not strike Aniruddha's kurta. Aniruddha noticed this, but said nothing.

After a few moments he himself asked, "Do you work in construction?"

"I am a mason."

"How many years have you been doing this work?"

"Twenty-two years now."

Aniruddha kept running a finger around the round cap of the tube. "Then you must be able to read all the plans?"

The mason looked at him. "I read what I need to read. What I do not understand, I ask. But the people who can answer are not always at the site."

"All the measurements are on the plan."

"They are," he agreed. "But in the middle of the work the owner says, 'Make it two fingers less here; the room will become larger.' Someone else says, 'Pour it by this evening.' A third says, 'Save cement.' Then the rain comes and everyone says the mason ruined it."

Aniruddha's hand stopped on the tube.

The man did not pursue the matter. He kept looking at the edge of the eaves. Water was now drawing a clear line down the wall from the ungrooved underside he had pointed out.

Aniruddha asked, "Masons do make mistakes, don't they?"

"Why wouldn't they?" the man replied easily. "If it happens by my hand, it is my mistake. But if the decision was not mine and the blame is still put on me, that is another matter."

Aniruddha remembered the verandah from the previous week. The plaster had cracked. He had gone there to inspect it. The moment the owner saw him, he had said, "Look how careless these labourers are." Without even touching the wall, Aniruddha had nodded in agreement. Later, after reaching the office, he had remembered that it was the owner himself who had pressed for the plastering to be finished quickly; the instruction to sprinkle it with water for two days had also been brushed aside. But amid the rush of work Aniruddha had pushed that memory away.

Now, standing beneath the eaves, the incident came back sharply.

"Your name?" Aniruddha asked.

"Shivcharan."

"I am Aniruddha."

Shivcharan nodded. That was the whole introduction.

The rain grew lighter, though it did not stop. Drops fell from the edge of the eaves in a steady rhythm. Shivcharan opened his bag and took out a small piece of wood. He held it against the wall beneath the eaves, then said to Aniruddha, "See, the outward slope is too little. The water collects along the edge."

Aniruddha took the wooden piece in his hand. It was an ordinary flat piece, with a tiny water tube sealed in the middle. Shivcharan used it for checking level.

"This is very simple," Aniruddha said.

"A great deal can be understood from simple things."

There was no weight of instruction in the sentence. Shivcharan put the wood back into his bag.

For the first time Aniruddha looked carefully at his hands: the old graininess of cement on the fingers, fine cuts beside the nails, thickened skin in the middle of the palm. He thought of his own hands. His wrist ached after drawing lines all day, but his palms were smooth. The two kinds of labour were different; they were not opposed to one another.

The wind rose again. Shivcharan hoisted the bag onto his shoulder. "I have to catch a bus farther ahead. The rain is lighter now."

"You'll go now?"

"If I am late, I will miss the last bus to the village."

He stepped out from beneath the eaves. Within two steps his shirt was wet again. For a moment Aniruddha wanted to call out and tell him to wait a little longer, but Shivcharan crossed the road and disappeared into the crowd.

Aniruddha was left alone beneath the eaves. Above him the water was still curling back toward the wall.

He felt an urge to open the blue tube. Carefully he removed the cap and took out the plan inside. It was the plan of the new house where construction was to begin the next day. The front verandah and the section through its eaves were drawn on the sheet.

Keeping away from the rain, he spread out the page. The measurement of the outer edge of the eaves was written there, but there was no clear indication of a drip groove underneath. At the office it was assumed that a mason would know such a thing anyway.

A slight discomfort stirred inside Aniruddha. When something was not written on a plan, how many times had he himself said at a construction site, “A mason ought to know this.”

He took out a pencil. Under the section drawing of the eaves he added a small groove and wrote beside it: “Leave a drip groove beneath the outer edge; keep the slope outward.”

After writing it, he looked at the page for a while. The addition to the drawing was very small. It did not change the appearance of the building, nor did it meaningfully change the cost. Only one thin indication had been added.

When the rain stopped, Aniruddha went back to his two-wheeler. Water was flowing along the road. As he rode toward the office, he remembered the cracked plaster from the previous week again. Earlier, he had seen only shoddy work in that scene. Now he saw the orders, the haste, the saving, the labour, and the mistake together.

The next morning at the office, Mahendra Babu, the senior draughtsman, looked at the new sheet and asked, “Why have you shown this groove separately? Masons know these things.”

Aniruddha paused for a moment before answering.

Until yesterday, he too would have said only this: they ought to know.

Today he merely said, “If something is necessary, it is better for it to be on the paper.”

Mahendra Babu said nothing. With a red pencil he began checking a measurement in another corner of the sheet.

Aniruddha sat down at his desk. Before his eyes came the eaves at Benta Chowk—on one side a dry plan, on the other a cement-stained shirt, and

between them the rainwater. It seemed to him that yesterday's rain had not washed away his assumptions. It had only made a thin crack in them, through which the water of another person's experience could enter.

STORY 291

The Bicycle

...

Before leaving for the Monday haat at Benipatti, Deepa opened her small account book once again. On the first page she had written down the expenses for her father's new shop—one month's rent in advance, two wooden planks, a chest for keeping tools, a tin nameboard, wire for the light, and a new screwdriver for opening and putting together old sewing machines. Altogether the amount was running higher than expected.

At the very bottom Deepa had written: "Sale of old bicycle—estimated 900."

That very bicycle was upside down in the courtyard as Basudev Sah spun the rear wheel. The frame was black, though in many places the paint had worn away and the iron showed through. Two repairs on the rear carrier were clearly visible. One pedal looked new; the edge of the other had been worn smooth and round.

For twenty-five years Basudev had travelled from village to village repairing sewing machines. At first he had gone on foot with his tools in a cloth bag. Later he bought this bicycle. After that, twelve or fifteen villages around them became the map of his livelihood—somewhere a foot pedal had jammed, somewhere the thread-tension wheel had gone wrong, somewhere the teeth of an old machine had worn down. He would tie his toolbox to the carrier, leave in the morning, and return in the evening.

Now a narrow shop had become available for rent near the haat. People would bring their machines there, and he would no longer need to carry heavy tools every day. That was why the question of selling the bicycle had arisen.

When the idea of the shop first came up, Deepa had said the bicycle should be kept. It would still be useful for going from home to the haat. Basudev had replied, "Why hold on to something only because it is old when it is no longer useful?" Deepa had not expected that answer. She had assumed her father must be deeply attached to the bicycle. But perhaps Basudev's attachment was less to the object than to its use. As long as it had been a means of earning his living, he had attended to every sound it made; now that the shop was taking over that work, letting it go was not difficult.

"We'll get nine hundred for it at least," Deepa said.

Basudev stopped the wheel and looked at her. "You have already made the account?"

"How can we open a shop without accounts?"

"A bicycle is not a figure on paper."

"For the seller, in the end it becomes a figure."

Basudev smiled and put two drops of oil on the chain. "Come to the haat. We'll see whether your figure turns out to be right."

Deepa had returned home two weeks earlier after completing six months of accounting training in Darbhanga. Household expenses now looked different to her than before. Which thing was capital, which was a daily expense, how many years an item took to lose its value—after studying all this, she had begun making the complete account for her father's new shop herself. Basudev was both proud of this and amused by it.

At the haat, Ramvilas had a thatch-roofed shop that bought old bicycles. Eight or ten bicycles stood outside; inside, tyres, rims, chains, bells, and pedals hung separately. Ramvilas looked over the bicycle once from all four sides.

"The frame is old," he said. "But it is straight."

Deepa opened her account book.

Ramvilas lifted the rear wheel and spun it. "This rim is newer than the frame."

"Yes," Basudev said.

"How many years?"

Basudev scratched his head. "After the year of Deepa's higher-secondary examination."

Deepa's pen stopped on the paper.

Ramvilas said, "If it is that old, how is it new?"

"I said newer than the frame," Basudev laughed.

Deepa counted the years in her mind. In that examination year there had been repeated discussions at home about the examination fee, two guidebooks bought in Darbhanga, and bus fare for the days of the examination. She remembered that at the same time her father had ridden the bicycle slowly for two weeks. The rear wheel had leaned to one side. Deepa had thought he must have had it repaired. Now she understood that perhaps he had been postponing the repair.

Ramvilas pressed the front tyre. "This one is even older."

Basudev said, "I was going to replace it, but that was when Vinod got admission to the Industrial Training Institute."

Vinod was Deepa's younger brother. The whole family had been happy on the day of his admission. That Father had not replaced the tyre was recorded in none of the family's memories.

Deepa did not close the account book, but she stopped writing.

Ramvilas turned the pedal. "The right pedal is new."

"Three years."

"The left?"

"Let it stay as long as it runs."

"It would have been better if you had replaced both together."

Basudev replied easily, "That month the tin on the roof of the house had to be replaced. One pedal was enough to keep things going."

For Ramvilas this was only an answer. He went on turning the pedal. But in Deepa's account book the expenses that sat in separate boxes—education, household, tools, travel—suddenly began joining one another. One pedal had not been replaced, and so a sheet of tin had gone onto the roof; the tyre had been postponed, and so Vinod's admission had happened; the rim had been replaced two weeks late, and so her examination had been managed without borrowing.

There was no common heading for all this on paper.

Ramvilas examined the teeth of the chain. "The chain has been used a long time. If you had changed it on time, the rear sprocket would have worn less."

Basudev said, "It is good when everything can be replaced on time. Money should also be there on time."

Deepa looked up at that sentence. Her father was not looking at her. Ramvilas too heard the answer as an ordinary remark of the haat and moved on to inspect the next part. Deepa remembered an old sentence of her mother's: "This month the bicycle is asking for money again." Her mother had said it not as a complaint but while explaining the household accounts. At the time Deepa had thought the bicycle was a burden on the family. Today, for the first time, she saw the account in reverse—the expenses of the family had come first, and the bicycle had kept waiting for its own turn.

Ramvilas slapped the carrier. "This has been welded twice?"

"Three times," Basudev said.

"Then the price comes down."

Deepa spoke at once. "The joints are strong. It has carried the toolbox all these years."

Ramvilas looked at her and smiled. "I will call it strong when I buy it, and whoever takes it from me will call it old and cut the price. That is how the haat works."

He offered seven hundred and fifty.

Deepa remembered her estimate of nine hundred. Basudev asked for eight hundred and fifty. The bargaining began. What surprised Deepa was that Basudev did not bargain very hard. He only kept stressing that the bicycle was in working condition. "Look at the brakes, listen to the bell, the frame is not bent."

Ramvilas finally stopped at eight hundred and twenty.

Deepa leaned close to her father and said quietly, "Let's go somewhere else. We may get nine hundred."

Basudev asked, "For how much money will we spend half a day going around?"

"Eighty rupees is money too."

"Yes, but the planks for the shop have to be brought today."

Deepa fell silent. They had taught the value of time in her accounting training too. But at home, the value of time was counted differently—when a bus had to be caught, when a machine had been promised for delivery, when the rain might come, when the landlord would ask for the advance.

Ramvilas agreed to eight hundred and forty. Basudev accepted.

Before paying, Ramvilas wrote the details on a small piece of paper. "Old bicycle—one. Sale price—840."

Deepa kept looking at that line without meaning to. She remembered the "estimated 900" in her account book. The difference was only sixty rupees. From the point of view of accounting, her estimate had been almost right.

And yet her account suddenly seemed incomplete.

Ramvilas called a boy to take the bicycle inside. The moment the boy caught hold of it, Basudev said, "Wait."

Deepa thought perhaps he would remove the bell or the pump.

Basudev only untied the old jute cord fastened to the carrier. Black oil stains marked it here and there. He folded the cord and put it into his bag.

"Why that?" Deepa asked.

"The toolbox will have to be tied up in the new shop too."

That was all. He neither ran a hand over the bicycle nor looked back at it. Ramvilas's boy took it inside.

Basudev handed the eight hundred and forty rupees to Deepa and said, “Add it to the account.”

Deepa counted the money. She opened the account book. Beside “Sale of old bicycle” she struck out 900 and wrote 840. The account was complete.

Still, she could not close the page.

“What now?” Basudev asked.

Deepa opened the next page, where the items to be bought for the shop were listed: wooden planks, chest, wire, light, nameboard, small tools. There was no chair on the list. Deepa had deliberately not written one. She had thought they should save money in the first month; Father could sit on a plank while examining a customer’s machine, or stand and work if necessary.

She picked up the pen and wrote at the very top: “Sturdy chair with arms—
1.”

Basudev looked at the page and said, “That isn’t necessary yet. We’ll take the old mora from home.”

“No,” Deepa said. “We will buy this in the first month itself.”

“The expense will go up.”

“I have put it in the account.”

Basudev looked at her face, then did not argue.

The two of them walked through the haat toward the carpenter who would make the planks. Earlier, when Basudev walked beside the bicycle, his right hand rested on the handlebar. Now the hand was empty. For some distance he walked with his right palm unconsciously held a little forward, then adjusted the bag on his shoulder.

Deepa matched her steps to his walking pace. The account book was in her bag. Inside it, the value of the bicycle was written as eight hundred and forty rupees—a clean, correct, verifiable figure.

For all the things that remained outside the page, there was no column.

STORY 292

A Glass of Water

...

Afternoon light was falling through a gap in the heavy curtains of the auditorium in Madhubani Town Hall. On the pale grey backdrop behind the stage, blue letters read: "Mithila Small Enterprise Conference: Systems, Labour and Trust." Nearly two hundred chairs stood in ordered rows. Entrepreneurs, representatives of cooperatives, and trainees occupied the first three rows; farther back, latecomers were quietly finding places to sit.

The keynote speaker, Aniruddha Chaudhary, stood at the left of the stage gathering his papers. For the past ten years he had advised small factories, milk-collection centres, and handicraft groups on improving the organisation of work. His particular strength was putting complicated things into clear sentences. He rarely felt nervous before a speech. The words, pauses, and examples would already be arranged in order in his mind.

Half an hour before the programme began, Aniruddha had told the auditorium manager, Meghnath Sah, three things: no voices should come from behind the stage, the wheeled water trolley should not move during the speech, and the clatter of metal utensils should not enter the recording. Meghnath had nodded at once.

"Don't worry," he had said. "There will be complete silence during the speech."

Aniruddha had been pleased. He wanted clean sound. His assistant had told him that morning that the conference speech would later be used as training material.

Once on stage, he spoke for the first five minutes without looking at his papers. "It is not enough for a system to look polished from the outside. The real question is how the work flows within it. Which hands bear how much weight, which steps are unnecessary, and which small obstruction turns into major fatigue over the course of a day—these are things we must learn to see."

The auditorium was quiet. Aniruddha's voice was steady. In his next example, he described a milk-collection centre where removing a duplicate entry of the same figure had saved an employee's time. People were taking notes. On a table at the right corner of the stage, his glass had become empty. He glanced at it once and continued speaking.

A few moments later an attendant emerged beside the curtain. Aniruddha did not know his name. He looked somewhere between fifty-five and sixty: grey kurta, dark trousers, a thin line of sweat behind his ear. In his left hand he carried a full glass of water; his right hand was empty. He came to the edge of the stage and held the glass out.

Just as the rim reached Aniruddha's fingers, it made a faint sound. The attendant's hand was trembling. The water moved in circles inside the glass, and one drop spilled over and fell on his finger.

Aniruddha took the glass.

The attendant said softly, "Forgive me."

"It's all right," Aniruddha replied easily.

The attendant stepped back at once.

Aniruddha turned again to the audience. The next sentence was written clearly on his paper: "An efficient system is created where unnecessary human labour is reduced."

He could have read the sentence. But when his eyes stopped on the words "unnecessary human labour," he saw the attendant's trembling hand again.

He took a sip of water. When he set the glass down on the table, it made a soft tick.

"I want to say one more thing," he began, but the example he had meant to give suddenly seemed contrived. He fell silent for two seconds. In the hush of the auditorium, the sound of a chair being moved somewhere at the back was distinctly audible. Aniruddha opened the next page of his notes and returned to the planned sequence.

The speech continued, but another calculation had begun inside him. Why had the attendant's hand trembled? Age? Heat? Fatigue? He did not know the answer. Even so, that trembling hand kept entering between the sentences he had prepared.

Twenty minutes later, the question-and-answer session began. The head of a Madhubani painting group asked how the burden of work could be measured in a small organisation. Aniruddha normally answered such a question in five points. Today he stopped after three. The fourth point on his paper was: "Do not first interfere with a process that is running without complaint." He did not read it. All at once he understood that the absence of complaint and the absence of burden were not the same thing.

When the programme ended, people came up to the stage to meet him. One person handed him a card; another asked for a date for consultation with

his organisation. Aniruddha spoke briefly with each of them. Again and again his eyes went toward the curtain. The attendant did not appear.

When the crowd had thinned, Aniruddha asked Meghnath Sah, "Who was the elderly gentleman serving water?"

Meghnath thought for a moment. "Raghunath Paswan. He has worked at the Town Hall for many years. Today he was stationed at the back."

"His hand was trembling."

"Yes. He must be more tired than usual today," Meghnath said casually. "He has been going up and down since morning."

"Why up and down?"

Meghnath's answer was entirely ordinary. "The water trolley comes through the back corridor. But today the camera and cables were in that passage. And you had said you didn't want the sound of the wheels during the speech. So the trolley was left downstairs. The glasses had to be carried up two at a time by hand."

Aniruddha said nothing. He remembered his own words from the morning exactly: "I don't want any clatter at all; the recording must be clean." At the time the instruction had seemed like a small technical matter. He had thought only that the sound would disappear. He had not thought about who would do the work of removing that sound, which route would change, or how many times someone would climb the stairs.

"How many steps are there?" Aniruddha asked.

"Thirty-six," Meghnath said. "If you count from the store below, thirty-six."

Aniruddha looked involuntarily at his glass. Half the water remained. His fingerprints marked the outside of the glass. The drop that had spilled from Raghunath's hand had already dried.

"Where is Raghunathji?"

"At the back, collecting the utensils."

Aniruddha went behind the curtain. Behind the bright face of the stage was a narrow corridor. Cables, empty cases, folded cloth, and two large water containers lay there. Against the wall stood the wheeled trolley, with four empty jugs and the drinking glasses placed upside down on top. When the trolley moved, one wheel made a faint squeaking sound.

Raghunath was wiping two glasses with a cloth. On seeing Aniruddha, he began to rise.

"Please stay seated," Aniruddha said.

Raghunath sat back down but stopped his hands.

Aniruddha asked, “Did you have to climb the stairs many times today?”

Raghunath smiled. “When there is a gathering, it is like this. Today the trolley didn’t go upstairs, so it took more trips.”

“Does your hand tremble already?”

“A little. The right hand is fine. There is an old strain in the left. If I carry weight too many times, it begins to tremble.”

Raghunath did not say this as a complaint. He began wiping the glass again. The thought turned over inside Aniruddha: what he had been calling “human burden” on the stage was not a theory for Raghunath; it was simply the repeated climb of thirty-six steps.

Aniruddha could have apologised at that moment. But even saying “This happened because of me” seemed to him another way of placing himself at the centre. He remained silent. Bending beside the trolley, he turned its wheel. The squeak came again.

“The sound isn’t very loud,” he said.

Raghunath smiled. “When the hall is quiet, you can hear it.”

That brief answer lodged inside Aniruddha. When there is quiet, you can hear it. On stage he had treated silence as a sign of quality; behind the stage, the cost of that same silence was being counted in stairs.

That evening at the guest house, Aniruddha opened the papers of his speech. He had a habit of making corrections in red ink. On the first page was written: “See which hands bear how much weight.” He did not cross out the line. Beside it, in small letters, he wrote only: “And who designed the system by which that burden is seen?”

The next day he had another session. Before it began, his assistant asked, “Should I tell them to keep the sound completely clean like yesterday?”

Aniruddha thought for a moment. From behind the auditorium came the faint squeak of the trolley’s wheel.

“No,” he said. “Let the natural sounds of the work continue.”

During the session the wheeled water trolley passed once at the back. The glasses clinked softly. Two or four people looked that way, then turned back toward him. Aniruddha did not stop his sentence.

The water in the glass on the table was still. But when he lifted it, he remembered the trembling hand from the day before. This time he imagined not the water in the glass, but the route by which it had reached him.

His speech continued, but it no longer had the unquestioning hardness it had carried the day before. He did not feel that as a loss.

STORY 293

The Procession

...

Near the Tower in Laheriasarai, the evening air held the mingled smells of marigolds, dust, and hot oil. On the right side of the road, at a small flower cart, thirteen-year-old Abhay was stringing garlands with his mother, Sarita. In front of them lay a heap of yellow flowers, a box of thread, and, in one corner, a bucket full of water in which the flower stems had been dipped to keep them from wilting. Threading flowers quickly, Sarita said, "We need twenty more garlands by this evening. The procession people have sent word again."

Abhay's fingers began moving faster. Since afternoon, people in the market had been saying that a large procession bound for an election meeting in town would pass this way. No political party had been discussed by name at home. Sarita's calculation was simple: if the garlands sold, the day's earnings would rise. Abhay's calculation was different. He was drawn to the beat of drums, the echo of loudspeakers, the flutter of flags printed with symbols, and the sight of so many people walking together.

By sunset the drums were heard first from far away. Then came slogans, followed by the heavy sound of amplified voices. Shopkeepers along the road began pulling their goods inward, while people came to stand at gates and verandahs. Abhay's hands stayed on the garland, but his eyes were on the road.

Cloth tied to the first vehicle fluttered in the air. Behind it walked young men carrying flags. Some wore paper caps; some carried placards marked with a round symbol. Now and then small pieces of glossy printed paper were tossed into the air. Children ran to catch them. Abhay too left the cart and took two steps forward, but Sarita called out, "Finish this garland first."

Abhay sat down again, though the movement of the procession continued inside him. After a while a young man stopped at the cart. "Are ten garlands ready?"

Sarita counted them out. The young man handed her the money, slung the garlands over his shoulder, and disappeared into the crowd. Abhay saw the fold of the notes. Their ordinary day's sales never brought in so much at once. In that moment the procession seemed not only a spectacle but also a lucky day for their cart.

Sarita had brought the marigolds from the wholesale market at five in the morning. She had paid two hundred rupees in advance, and from the sale of the flowers had to come the household oil and spices as well as Abhay's monthly school fee. Because of the procession order, fewer flowers would remain unsold today—Abhay understood what that calculation meant. So the young men running up for garlands seemed to him not merely part of the noise, but part of the earnings too.

At that moment the road filled as if with a rain of glossy leaflets. One leaflet fell near Abhay's foot. He picked it up. There were bold letters, a round symbol, the photograph of a candidate, and smaller lines of text below. Abhay did not read it all. He liked the smoothness of the paper. He folded it and slipped it into his pocket.

At the heart of the procession the noise was so great that Abhay had to bend toward Sarita to hear what she said. On both sides of the road people laughed, waved, and sometimes clapped. Some simply watched. Abhay thought that when so many people moved in the same direction at the same time, the road itself seemed to grow larger. His own little cart looked very small to him.

About half an hour later, the last vehicle too had gone past. The noise slowly moved eastward. The evening returned to the road much as before, but the road itself was no longer as it had been. Torn paper caps, plastic cups, empty water sachets, wilted flowers, bits of thread, and leaflets lay scattered everywhere. A few flags had been trampled underfoot and stuck in the mud.

Abhay stepped down from the cart and picked up a shiny strip. "I'll keep this," he said.

Gathering the flowers, Sarita replied, "Keep it. But first pull the cart back. Can't you see those clouds?"

As he pulled the cart backward, Abhay saw a few broken flowers at the bottom of the basket emptied by the garland sales. Sarita did not throw them away; she set them aside, intending to take them home for worship. Abhay was used to seeing his mother save even flower stems. For a moment, therefore, the sight of whole garlands lying scattered on the road seemed strange to him, but the lingering beat of drums was still in his ears, and the thought did not stay.

The western sky had grown dark. The air turned cool. People in the market began hurriedly gathering their goods. Abhay pushed the cart beneath a verandah. Just then the first heavy drops fell. Within five minutes the rain became hard.

The drain opening on the right side of the road normally swallowed the rainwater at once. Today the water began backing up and spreading across the

road. At first Abhay watched the rain with excitement, but soon the water reached the cart. Sarita lifted the flower basket higher.

“The drain is blocked,” she said.

Holding an umbrella, Abhay ran toward the drain. Leaflets, plastic cups, and a thick knot of flowers had collected over the iron grating. Rainwater pressed down from above, but the holes in the grate were sealed. Abhay tried to clear the rubbish with a stick. The first time he pushed it in, a cup spun around and lodged itself in the same place again.

Sarita called from behind, “Don’t use your hand. There may be glass in there too.”

Abhay brought a thin piece of old bamboo lying beside a shop. Slowly he began pulling the leaflets away. The wet paper had stuck together into a thick layer. When one layer came off, the water rushed strongly inward, but at once another piece of plastic clung to the grating.

In the rain Abhay’s kurta stuck to his body. He remembered how bright those same leaflets had looked half an hour earlier as they flew through the air. Now he even felt disgust as he lifted the glossy layers with the tip of the bamboo.

Jamuna, the fruit seller nearby, raised her basket and called, “Quickly, child, clear it, or all the water will rise here.”

Abhay pulled harder. When two cups, a knot of flowers, and three soaked leaflets came away together, the drain gave a gurgle. The water on the road swirled and began going down through the grating. It fell, though not completely. Abhay cleared the other side as well.

When the rain weakened, the signs of the procession on the road had changed. The paper that had leapt through the air now lay dark and pasted to the edge of the drain. Flowers that had hung around necks had mixed into the mud. Abhay felt his pocket. The glossy leaflet he had saved had also become wet and half dissolved. The letters had blurred. Only part of the candidate’s photograph remained clear.

He did not throw the leaflet away. He placed it on the cart.

Sarita was calculating the day’s takings. Sales had indeed been good. Almost all the garlands were gone. The cost of two baskets of flowers had been recovered. She said, “See? Today our earnings increased.”

Abhay nodded. “Yes.”

Sarita separated a small heap of wet flowers. “These won’t sell tomorrow,” she said to herself. Abhay calculated: ten more garlands had sold, but some

flowers had been lost in the rain. There was still a profit, yet the evening of the procession no longer seemed to him as straightforward as before.

He said only that much. He could not tell whether increased earnings and a dirty road were opposite things or merely two different parts of the same evening. He understood only that the scene which had seemed finished half an hour earlier was still doing its work.

At home that night he emptied his pockets. A shiny strip, the wet leaflet, and a small round paper symbol. He placed the strip by the window to dry. When he tried to open the leaflet, one corner tore. He carefully flattened it. Half the printed sentence could still be read; the other half had washed away in the rain.

The next morning Abhay went to school. On the way, near the Tower, municipal sanitation workers were sweeping. The road was dry, but shreds of wet paper still clung beside the drain. Abhay stood for a while and watched. There were no drums from yesterday's procession, no slogans. Only the scrape of brooms and the sound of an iron basket.

At school there was a drawing class. The teacher said, "Draw any scene you saw in town yesterday."

Several children began drawing flags, vehicles, and crowds. Abhay too first drew a large vehicle in the middle of the page, and behind it people carrying flags. His hand naturally drew the same scene for which he had wanted to leave the cart and run the day before.

Then, in the right-hand corner of the page, he drew the drain grating. On the grating he drew two cups, a soaked leaflet, and beside it a small boy holding a bamboo stick. At the far edge he added two figures with brooms.

His friend Neel, sitting beside him, asked, "Why are you drawing all this? The procession is here."

Abhay looked at the crowd in the middle of the page, then at the drain in the corner. "This happened yesterday too," he said.

"But this isn't the procession."

Abhay was silent for a moment. It seemed he could hear yesterday's drums again, then the gurgling of the drain in the rain.

"I didn't really see yesterday where the procession ended," he said softly.

He began colouring again. The flags on the vehicle remained bright, but he did not leave the water in the drain blank.

STORY 294

The Small Mirror

...

Turning in from Station Road in Madhubani town, in a narrow lane of the old market, stood “Ramsevak Barber Shop.” In front of the shop was a half-raised tin awning; inside were two iron-framed chairs, a long mirror on the wall, and in one corner a small mirror with a red back. The morning sun had only reached the top of the lane; inside the shop, in the pale light of a bulb, only the flash of the scissors was clear.

Seventy-two-year-old Harinarayan Mishra entered slowly. Behind him came his son Nachiket, managing a notebook, two bills, and a cloth bag.

Ramsevak rose when he saw him. “Come, Kaka. After a long time.”

Harinarayan laughed. “Hair does not count the days. I was the one putting it off.”

Nachiket sat on the bench by the wall. His cloth shop was in the main market. Before Dussehra, it was the season for ordering stock, settling old credit, and paying the warehouse rent. He opened the notebook and began adding figures on a page. When Harinarayan sat in the chair, Ramsevak tied a white cloth around his neck. In the long mirror on the wall, the old man’s face, Ramsevak’s raised hand, and Nachiket bent over in the background appeared together.

“Not too short,” Harinarayan said. “Keep it clean around the ears. Just set the top in order.”

Ramsevak laughed. “You say the same thing every time, and in the end you’ll say—two more snips.”

Harinarayan looked at Nachiket in the mirror. Whether the remark had reached him or not, Harinarayan could not tell. Nachiket folded the corner of one bill and turned to another page.

This shop was not new to Harinarayan. Thirty years earlier, when Nachiket was five or seven years old, he used to bring him here for haircuts. The child would never sit still in the chair; Harinarayan would stand behind him with a hand on his shoulder. Ramsevak’s father, Jeevachh, had been the barber then. After the haircut, Jeevachh would hold this small red-backed mirror behind the child’s head, and Nachiket would look at the back of his neck in the wall mirror and laugh. Harinarayan would ask, “Are both sides by the ears even?”

Nachiket would inspect himself gravely, as though the decision rested with him.

Harinarayan also saw his working years as tied to this lane. For thirty-four years he had kept accounts at the Madhubani Textile Cooperative Store. On the last day of each month, evening would come while he matched totals for cotton dhotis, gamchhas, saris, and bundles of loom yarn. The day after receiving his salary, he would get his hair cut at Jeevachh's, buy mustard oil for the house, and notebooks for the children.

When Nachiket opened his cloth shop, Harinarayan had helped a great deal in choosing the first stock—which cotton cloth would sell during the rains, which gamchha would move in the villages, how much credit could safely be allowed. For the first five years, Nachiket brought his account book to his father at night. Harinarayan checked the additions with a red pencil. Later Nachiket began managing his accounts himself. At first the notebook came home once a week, then once a month, and then only on days when some total would not match.

Harinarayan had accepted this change as natural. A son learning his work was a relief to a father. But today, seeing Nachiket bent over in the mirror, he understood that relief and distance sometimes grow at the same pace.

Ramsevak's scissors clicked around his ears. Harinarayan's white hair kept falling onto the cloth. Figures kept accumulating in Nachiket's notebook. In between, he asked, "Babuji, will it take much longer?"

Harinarayan said, "If you have work, go. I'll return by rickshaw."

"No, we'll go together. I just need to reach the shop by half past ten."

Ramsevak glanced once at Nachiket in the mirror, then went on cutting silently.

Harinarayan calculated in his mind: it was twenty past nine. The shop was ten minutes away. Nachiket had time. Even so, there was an impatience in his voice, as though even five minutes were an amount owed on credit.

He remembered that over the past three months Nachiket had repeatedly said, "Babuji, if you have to go to the market, keep all your errands for the same day." It was practical. It saved petrol for the motorcycle and reduced the time the shop had to be left unattended. Harinarayan agreed too. He began grouping the bank, post office, medicine shop, and clothes to be given for stitching into a single day. But slowly, going out of the house became a list of tasks; stepping out without a list began to feel like a wasteful expense.

While cutting the right side of his head, Ramsevak asked, "Nachiket Babu, will there be a crowd in the market for the puja this time?"

Without raising his eyes from the notebook, Nachiket said, “There will be a crowd, but more will be on credit. Less cash.”

“Harinarayan Kaka used to say people always bought clothes for the puja in the old days.”

“Warehouse rent wasn’t this high in the old days,” Nachiket replied briefly.

The answer did not seem harsh to Harinarayan. He knew that running a shop was not easy. Last year, when water leaked through the roof, twenty bundles of saris had to be moved elsewhere. This year one trader had failed to send goods on time. Nachiket often sat over the accounts late into the night. But seeing his son’s bent head in the mirror, Harinarayan wondered for the first time: he knew the shape of his son’s difficulties—but how much did the son know of the shape of his days?

Ramsevak switched on the electric trimmer. A buzzing rose. The short hairs at the back of Harinarayan’s neck began to disappear. He closed his eyes. Into the buzzing merged sounds from an older time—Jeevachh’s scissors, little Nachiket’s laughter, bullock carts in the market, his mother’s voice after he reached home: “Did he leave hair at the back of your neck?” Time had changed so many things, yet this small ritual of the barber shop had survived almost unchanged.

The trimmer stopped. Ramsevak brushed hair from his shoulder. “Kaka, look at the back.”

He picked up the small red-backed mirror from the corner and held it behind Harinarayan’s head. The long wall mirror and the little hand mirror fell into one another. In the first frame was Harinarayan’s white neck, behind it Ramsevak’s hand, and farther within, in a smaller frame, Nachiket.

Nachiket had now closed the notebook. He looked at his watch, straightened the bills, then bent to pick up the bag kept beside the bench. For a moment his eyes rose toward the wall mirror, but instead of resting on his father, he brushed dust from the shoulder of his kurta. Then he looked out toward the lane.

Ramsevak asked, “Is the back all right?”

Harinarayan kept looking at half of his son’s face in the small mirror. “It’s all right,” he said.

Ramsevak lowered the mirror. Now, in front of Harinarayan, there was again only his own face. His white hair was neat, the fine line above his brows had deepened, his cheeks were slightly hollow. He understood that he read his age less from the mirror than from the duration of Nachiket’s gaze. As a child, if one strand of hair had been left uneven, Nachiket would stare for ten

moments; today, through the entire haircut, he had perhaps not looked at his father for even ten moments.

Along with this thought, another rose immediately. Harinarayan remembered that the previous week Nachiket had asked him to sit at the shop. “Babuji, stay for half an hour while I go and check the warehouse.” Harinarayan had refused. He did not like the dust of the market, and sitting in a crowd felt difficult. Nachiket had not asked again. It was too easy to say that distance had been made from only one side. But the small frame in the mirror had made one thing clear: distance had now become part of their daily routine, and both of them had stopped measuring it.

Ramsevak untied the cloth from his neck. The white hair slid onto the floor. Nachiket stood up at once. “How much?”

Ramsevak named the amount. Nachiket took a note from the small pocket of the bag. Harinarayan had started to reach toward his own pocket, but stopped. Nachiket paid, took the change, then asked, “Shall we go, Babuji?”

Harinarayan rose. Ramsevak ran a brush over his shoulder. Outside, sunlight had now crossed the tin awning and reached the threshold of the shop.

Nachiket moved ahead. Harinarayan paused for a moment at the threshold. “Will the shop be very crowded today?”

“Not now. It will pick up after noon.”

“Then I’ll sit there for a while.”

Nachiket turned and looked at him. “At the shop?”

“Yes. You had to go and check the warehouse, didn’t you?”

The surprise on Nachiket’s face was so slight that it vanished at once. “Yes, but I thought I wouldn’t go today.”

“Go. I’ll sit there.”

Nachiket said nothing. He merely shifted the bag to his left hand, leaving his right hand free. On the way from the lane toward the main road there was a patch of mud. He extended his right hand toward Harinarayan’s arm. Harinarayan did not take his hand; he only rested his forearm in Nachiket’s palm for a moment and crossed the mud.

As he left the shop, Harinarayan did not look back. Inside, Ramsevak had put the small red mirror back in the corner. In the long mirror on the wall there was now an empty chair, white hair on the floor, and the light from the open doorway.

STORY 295

Pigeons on the Roof

...

It was a June morning in Balbhadrapur, Laheriasarai, and the sunlight had not yet spread across the whole roof. The shadows of the earthen flowerpots lay long, and Kanak, with an exercise book resting on her knees, was solving physics problems. Her scholarship entrance examination was three days away. The farther the hand of her wristwatch moved, the tighter her handwriting became.

Seven pigeons sat on the parapet. Now one turned its neck, now another shook out its wings. Kanak did not want to look at them. In front of her was a timetable drawn in red pencil—mathematics from five to seven, physics from seven to eight, breakfast from eight to half past eight, then chemistry. In the right-hand corner of the page she had written in bold letters: “Three days. No help.”

No teacher had written that last sentence. Kanak had written it herself.

Her father, Navalkishore Jha, ran a small bookbinding and photocopy shop near the Tower. If Kanak won the scholarship, a large part of her fees for the next two years could be saved. Navalkishore had calculated that sum many times, but he rarely spoke of the amount in front of her. He only said, “The examination is yours; the accounts are mine.”

Kanak both liked that sentence and felt stung by it. She thought that if she won the scholarship, she herself would lighten the burden of her education expenses. Gradually another stubbornness attached itself to that thought—preparation by herself, the journey by herself, difficult questions by herself. Taking anyone’s help seemed to reduce some part of the achievement.

That was why, the previous evening, when her classmate Ruchi had brought her own summary notes for two chapters, Kanak had returned them.

“You were having trouble with the electricity section, weren’t you?” Ruchi had asked.

“Not now.”

“Look at this. I’ve put all the formulas on one page.”

“I don’t need it. I’ll make my own.”

Ruchi had looked at her for a few moments, then folded the sheet and put it back in her bag. “All right.”

Kanak was now stuck on a problem from that very chapter. Her own summary sheet had not been made. The sign in one formula kept coming out wrong. She used the eraser again; the paper had grown thin.

Her mother Janki called from downstairs, “Kanak, I’ve left your tea.”

“Not now!” Kanak called back sharply.

Her voice came out louder than she had intended. She herself was startled, but at once bent over the problem again.

Just then sacks began to be unloaded on the roof of the grain warehouse opposite. At the sound of grain being shaken out, the pigeons on the parapet all rose together. Kanak lifted her head without meaning to.

The seven pigeons first made a small circle. Five more joined them from the roof behind. Twelve pairs of wings flashed at once, yet within moments the shape of the flock changed. Two went ahead, three wheeled behind the water tank, four dipped lower, and then all of them came together again in one wide circle.

Kanak looked at the time. Two minutes had passed. Irritated, she returned to the problem.

At nine in the morning her father came up. He had a small piece of paper in his hand. “I’ve written down the route to the examination centre,” he said. “If you take the first bus, get down at Station Chowk and—”

Kanak cut him off. “I’ll work it out.”

“You’ve never been there before.”

“I’ll still get there.”

Navalkishore kept holding the paper. “I can come with you. I’ll open the shop two hours late—”

“No. Why should you keep the shop closed? I’m not a child.”

Navalkishore’s hand slowly dropped. “All right. At least keep this paper with the route.”

“No, I don’t need it now.”

He folded the paper and put it into the pocket of his kurta. “All right.”

For a moment Kanak felt that her tone had been harsh, but another voice inside her immediately said: this is what it means to be independent. Do everything yourself.

By noon she had returned to the same physics chapter three times. She solved the problem, but it was not clear to her why the solution worked. Her head began to ache. While they sat down to eat, Janki said, “Lie down for half an hour.”

Kanak replied, "There's no time."

After the meal she went back up to the roof. The June sun was now fierce. The pigeons had drawn into the shade of the parapet. Not one of them was flying. Kanak found it strange—the wings that had moved so quickly in the morning were silent now. She opened her book, but the letters began to swim before her eyes.

After a while one pigeon came to the earthen water bowl in a rear corner of the roof. It drank, puffed out its wings, and remained sitting there. Two more came as well. Kanak thought: they could fly if they wanted to, but they were not flying. No one was stopping them.

At that moment her eyes went to the timetable in red pencil. "No help." The words no longer looked as firm as before; they looked somewhat harsh.

In the evening Ruchi came again. This time she carried no summary notes. She had come to leave a piece of cloth with Janki for measurements before stitching. Kanak met her on the verandah.

"Will you do the practice test tomorrow?" Ruchi asked.

Kanak could have said, "Yes, I will," but instead she remained silent. Then she asked, "Why does the negative sign come in the third formula in the electricity section?"

Ruchi did not laugh. She sat down on the bench by the wall. "Up to which step do you understand it?"

Kanak brought her notebook. For ten minutes the two of them looked at only one problem. Ruchi did not give her the answer; she drew a diagram and asked, "If the direction changes, what happens to the sign?" Kanak worked the answer out herself.

"That's all?" Kanak said.

"That was all."

After Ruchi left, Kanak opened her red timetable. She drew a thin line through "No help." Beneath it she wrote, "Understand what needs to be understood—from anyone." As soon as she wrote it, the sentence seemed somewhat artificial. She crossed that out too. In the end she wrote only: "Ask questions."

The next morning Navalkishore was getting ready to go to the shop. Kanak stopped him near the stairs.

"Do you still have the paper on which you wrote the route yesterday?"

Navalkishore looked at her face. "Yes."

He took the folded paper from his pocket. Kanak opened and read it. The bus stop, where to get down, two turns, the name of the examination centre. At

the bottom, in his own handwriting, Navalkishore had added: "If you miss the first bus, the second is at 6:40."

"I'll keep this," Kanak said.

"I can come with—"

"No, I'll go myself. But if I have the route written down, you won't have to keep the shop closed."

Navalkishore nodded. This time there was neither disappointment nor any special pleasure on his face. "All right. Just leave on time."

Kanak put the paper with her admit card. She did not feel that she had lost anything. On the contrary, the journey now felt more her own than before, because she was no longer spending energy proving that she would not accept this or that.

On the evening before the examination, she was doing her final revision on the roof. There were clouds to the east. The flock of pigeons rose again. This time Kanak watched carefully. The flock took one direction, then broke apart, then formed again. No pigeon was tied to another's wing. Sometimes five flew together, sometimes two apart, sometimes one trailed behind all the others. Even so, their flight was not diminished by one another's presence.

Until then, the picture of independence in Kanak's mind had been a single wing—far from everyone, separate from everyone, without anyone's support. Now, on the roof before her, there was another picture: wings flying together, for whom being separate did not require leaving the flock, and being together did not require giving up one's own direction.

She did not close the book. She only stood by the parapet for five minutes. The anxiety about the examination was still inside her; whether the paper would be easy or difficult, whether she would win the scholarship or not—nothing was certain. Only one thing now seemed clear: she had unnecessarily given loneliness the name of independence.

Janki called from below, "Kanak, food!"

"I'm coming now."

Kanak looked at the time. According to the timetable, she still had twenty more minutes to study. She picked up the red pencil, drew a small line through the twenty-minute slot, and gathered her books. The questions would still be there tomorrow. Her mother and father would also be at the dining table. Freedom did not mean choosing one of the two; deciding when to be with which was more difficult.

She moved toward the stairs. Behind her, the pigeons were still in the sky—together, but not in a single line.

STORY 296

The Hand of the Clock

...

In the waiting room on the third floor of a private finance company on Station Road in Laheriasarai, Apurva Jha sat with the slip bearing token number 17 crumpled in his fist. The round clock on the wall showed ten forty-two. There were twelve chairs before him, but the attention of those seated there was divided among the clock, their papers, and the closed door inside.

For the third time, Apurva looked at his wristwatch. It was one minute behind the wall clock. A thin scratch crossed the glass, the strap had been stitched twice, and the brass colour showed through on the winding crown at the right. Twenty years earlier, his father, Devanarayan Jha, had rescued the watch from a watchmaker's discarded parts, replaced its components, made it run again, and given it to Apurva on the day of his final college examination.

"Keep an eye on the time," his father had said then, "but do not live by what the clock tells you."

For years Apurva had taken the sentence merely as a joke. Today, in the waiting room, he remembered it again.

Token number 14 went inside. A thin young man named Neeraj, seated beside him, rearranged his file of certificates once more. He asked quietly, "Where are you from?" "From the Benipur side." "Are you working now?" "I keep accounts at a wholesale agricultural-supplies shop." "The salary here could be double." Neeraj smiled. "As for me, wherever they post me, I'll go. In five years I want to be a branch manager."

Apurva nodded without thinking much about it. Five years. The same question was in his interview practice book: "Where do you see yourself five years from now?" He had memorised the answer: "Growing with the organisation, taking on greater responsibility, and moving into a leadership role." The words were committed to memory, but as the wait lengthened, the sentences began to feel less and less like his own.

He looked at the clock. Ten forty-nine. The thin second hand of the wall clock paused for a moment near the mark for eight, then moved ahead in two small jumps. Apurva's mind immediately began calculating: the clock could not simply be weak, or the hand would drag everywhere. If it was sticking at the same point each time, perhaps there was dust or a slight bend in one section of the gear train.

He was startled by himself. For the past half hour he had been thinking about salary, position, answers, clothes, and certificates; for the first time, his attention had entered the inside of something without effort.

He remembered Devanarayan's shop—a space in an old Laheriasarai lane, seven hand-spans long and four wide. A narrow tin sign hung above it, bearing the words: “Samay Watch Repair Centre.” Inside were three glass boxes, two rows of tiny screwdrivers, fine tweezers beside them, and one yellow bulb. As a child, Apurva would sit there after returning from school. When his father opened a watch, he would lay the parts out in order on a sheet of paper.

But after Class Twelve, Devanarayan had said plainly one day, “You are not to get stuck in this shop. Study. Do work with paper and pen. You should not have to spend the life I have spent.”

From that day on, Apurva had turned the sentence into an instruction. He studied commerce. He bought guides for competitive examinations. Twice he sat for bank examinations. Once he missed the cooperative institution's list by three marks. Meanwhile, to meet household expenses, he took the accounts job at the wholesale agricultural-supplies shop—thirteen thousand five hundred rupees a month, accounts late into the evening in season, and extra work when sacks of seed arrived before the rains.

Devanarayan never told him to leave the job. He only asked, “Does your heart take to it?” Apurva always gave the same answer: “It's temporary for now.” The word temporary had been running for three years.

Token number 15 went inside. A woman employee came out and said, “The interviews are running late. We may not be able to call everyone before the lunch break.”

A mild murmur of dissatisfaction moved through the room. Someone spoke of going downstairs for tea; someone else began calculating travel time. Apurva looked at his wristwatch again. Eleven-oh-five. At that moment he remembered that his father had two old visitors' wall clocks to work on today, their hands needing to be straightened.

The previous evening his father had said, “When you come back, if you aren't tired, have a look at one. Your hand is still quicker than mine at fine work.”

Apurva had laughed it away. “I'll see after the interview.”

So much had been pushed into that word after—the watches, the shop, time sitting with his father, his own interest, and the question of whether a paper-and-pen job was truly what he wanted or merely a safe, respectable name.

Neeraj spoke again. “Where did you prepare?” Apurva named a coaching centre. “They guide you even after you get a job, don't they?” “Yes.” “At home,

everyone only wants one thing—that I get a steady income once. What I myself want can be looked at later.”

Neeraj had said it simply; there was neither sorrow nor complaint in his voice. The sentence gave Apurva no answer of his own. Instead it brought him a new question: since when had he been keeping what he himself wanted for “later”?

The second hand on the wall clock stuck near eight again. This time Apurva felt an urge to open the clock and look inside. He imagined the back cover, the tiny wheel, the spindle of the hand. Without meaning to, his fingers touched the winding crown of his wristwatch.

Then a conversation with his father from five years earlier returned with complete clarity. Apurva had come back dejected after his first bank examination. Handing him tea, Devanarayan had said, “If it didn’t happen, try again. But don’t do it only because people say that when a watchmaker’s son sits behind a desk, that means he has risen in life. Your own heart will know what progress means.”

Irritated, Apurva had replied, “You were the one who first said I shouldn’t sit in the shop.” Devanarayan had answered, “I said you should not get stuck. How can I decide where you are to go?”

Apurva had not forgotten that conversation. He had only given the second sentence less importance than the first. His father had not chosen the dream of a job for him. He had only wanted to prevent his own hardships from becoming his son’s fate. The form of the job, the name of the position, the five-year target—Apurva himself had added much of that later: some from practice books, some from relatives’ questions, some from his own embarrassment.

Token number 16 went inside. A slight tightening came into Apurva’s stomach. His turn was next. He opened his file. The résumé was on top, then the mark sheets and experience certificate. On the back of the last page he had written five questions for practice. The third was: “Where do you see yourself five years from now?”

He did not run his pen over the memorised answer. He simply closed the page.

“Number 17,” the employee called. Apurva stood up. Three people were seated inside the door. Looking at his experience certificate, the person in the middle asked, “You have been doing accounts work for three years. Why do you want to come here?”

Apurva’s prepared answer was: “For broader opportunities and institutional growth.” But the words came as far as his mouth and stopped. He could no

longer see the hand of the wall clock, though its faint ticking came from outside.

He said, "The income will be higher. That is one reason, and it matters for my family. But I am also beginning to understand that I should not change my work merely because of the name of a post. I like numbers, accounts, and fine mechanical work—all three. I have come here to understand the nature of this work. If I am here only to give the answer I have memorised, that answer will not describe all of me."

For a few moments, all three interviewers were silent. The woman seated on the left asked, "Then where do you see yourself five years from now?"

A faint laugh rose inside Apurva. "I have a prepared answer to that question," he said, "but right now I can only say that five years from now I want to be doing work that makes use of the way I pay attention. I cannot yet name the position."

The interview did not last very long. When Apurva came out, he did not know whether his answers had been right for selection or not. He felt no certainty either. He understood only this much: for the first time, he himself had been present inside his answers.

As he went down the stairs, he looked at his wristwatch. Twelve twenty-seven. It was still one minute behind the wall clock. He pulled the crown out to set the time, then stopped. One minute's difference would do no harm.

On the way home, he went straight to his father's shop. Devanarayan, thick-lensed spectacles over his eyes, had opened a small alarm clock. Without raising his head when Apurva entered, he asked, "How did it go?" "I don't know." "Did you answer?" "I did. But not the answers from the practice book." Now Devanarayan looked up. "Then?"

Apurva pulled over a chair and sat down. Two old wall clocks were kept in a glass box. The hand of one was bent. He took it in his hand. "Will you let me look at this one?"

His father held out the tweezers toward him. "Immediately after the interview?" "Yes. If I get the job, I'll decide about that later. First I want to understand whether I am running away from this work or actually moving toward some other work." Devanarayan said nothing. He only turned the small table lamp toward Apurva.

Apurva opened the back cover of the clock. There was fine dust inside. The spindle of the hand was slightly bent. His own hand became steady without effort. Outside, the sounds of handcarts, bicycles, and buses continued along the road.

His wristwatch kept ticking. Apurva did not look at it again. Time had not stopped; but for the first time he did not feel compelled to run in whichever direction all the hands were pointing.

STORY 297

The Last Page

...

By half past eight in the evening, the last machine in the sewing unit on Ranti Road in Madhubani had also fallen silent. Rajni Chaudhary closed the day's wage register, placed a bundle of red thread in a box, and bolted the outer gate from inside. The rain had stopped, but water still fell now and then from one corner of the tin roof. Small scraps of thread clung to the floor.

Eighteen women worked in the unit. That month they had received a large order for uniforms from three private schools. The bundles of cloth had arrived on time, but the belts of two machines had snapped, the son of one sewing worker had fallen ill, and the distributor had delayed the advance payment by three days. Rajni's days passed among these calculations—how many metres of cloth, how many pairs of kurtas, whose wages, whose advance, whose work was to be sent home.

That night, while putting away the register, her eyes fell on a book kept at the corner of the table. Her colleague Shabnam had lent it to her. The title on the cover was *The Other Side of the River*, a novel by some new writer. For the past two weeks Rajni had been reading one or two chapters at night. Now only eighteen pages remained.

"Finish it tonight," Shabnam had said in the evening. "My brother will take it tomorrow."

Rajni had laughed. "Should I finish the book or the wage accounts?"

"The accounts will be there every day. The story will not be here tomorrow."

At the time, Shabnam's sentence had seemed like a joke. When Rajni reached home that night and picked up the book after dinner, the clock showed half past ten. Her husband Manoj was in the next room adding up outstanding cloth bills. Their daughter Ira was at her study table working through entrance-examination questions.

Ira had completed her graduation that year. She had been selected for a one-year course at a textile-conservation training centre in Patna. The fee was not very high, but once the cost of living there was added, it would weigh on the household budget. Rajni wanted Ira to take teacher training in Darbhanga instead—closer to home, cheaper, with a future that seemed easier to

understand. For three weeks Ira had been saying, “I want to study textile work, not only sewing—old cloth, dyes, conservation.”

Rajni always said the same thing: “Look first at the work that is solid. You can pursue your interest later too.”

Ira had gradually begun arguing less.

Rajni opened the book. In the story there was an old boatman whose grandson wanted to go to the city to study after a flood. The story moved among boats, river, fields, and debt. Rajni felt the boatman’s life was very far from her own. Yet its small details of work drew her in—the knotting of rope, sand gathered in the belly of a boat, bargaining over fares, the loss from returning empty during the rains.

Manoj, adding the bills, asked, “Still reading?”

“Only the last eighteen pages.” “You have to get up at five tomorrow.” “I know.” Manoj went back to his papers. Rajni kept reading. In the final chapter of the novel, the grandson set out to catch the first bus across the river. The old boatman went with him as far as the ghat. He gave no long advice; he merely handed him an old gamchha and said that if he drank too little water on the road, his head would ache. Rajni liked that detail. Her mother, Shail Devi, too used to say such ordinary things while seeing someone off: “Eat something before you get hungry,” “Keep the papers in the inner pocket,” “Don’t rush while changing buses.”

The pages diminished. Five. Three. Two.

On the last page the bus had already gone far from the ghat. The old boatman remained standing on the riverbank. The writer gave no long explanation. The last sentence read:

“He had not sent the boy across; for the first time he watched someone cross the current that he himself had never been able to cross in his life.”

Rajni read the sentence again.

At once there was no boat, river, or old boatman in her mind. She heard her own mother’s voice—twenty-two years earlier, on the verandah of the old house in Sakri.

Rajni had been nineteen then. She had received an opportunity to study commerce at a women’s college in Darbhanga. Her father had said that if daily bus fare and the cost of books were added up, it would be difficult. Her uncle had suggested that she learn sewing near home; within two years she could begin earning. Rajni herself had been uncertain.

That night, while folding her clothes, Shail Devi had said, “Go. Home will still remain home. The road of the heart does not open again and again.”

At the time Rajni had understood the sentence as her mother's sacrifice. It was not that her mother sold jewellery; she reduced household expenses, took on sewing for two more homes, and sent her daughter to study. In Rajni's memory, the meaning of the sentence had been only this: Mother endured difficulty for her daughter.

But as soon as she read the sentence on the last page, an old, almost neglected fact rose inside her. Shail Devi herself had been selected for teacher training at the age of sixteen. Rajni had known this since childhood. Her maternal grandmother fell ill, there were three younger brothers and sisters at home, and Shail Devi could not go for the training. Later came marriage, the household, sewing, children. She never turned this into a sorrowful story. Only once, on Rajni's first day at college, while she was getting onto the bus, Shail Devi had said, "In my time the bus did not leave without me; I simply could not get on."

Rajni had laughed then. To her it had seemed only one of her mother's old anecdotes.

Now two sentences came and stood beside each other—"The road of the heart does not open again and again" and "I simply could not get on."

For the first time Rajni understood that her mother's "Go" had not been merely a sentence of sacrifice for her daughter. It may also have carried the memory of a road she herself had never travelled. By pushing her daughter forward, her mother was not only protecting her future; in some form, she was also watching an old unfinished movement inside herself go on.

This understanding did not give Rajni any pleasant sense of completion. Instead, it unsettled her. Because at that very moment her thoughts turned to Ira.

Ira was still studying in the next room. Rajni remembered her own sentences from the past three weeks: "Training close to home is more sensible," "Why spend so much to live far away?" "Teaching is stable work," "What will you do by preserving old textile samples?"

She understood that these sentences had not been only practical concerns. Her own life had been speaking through them as well. Rajni had built the sewing unit from nothing. At first there had been four women, two machines, and cloth bought on credit. In fifteen years the unit had grown to eighteen women. She was proud of that work. Somewhere inside her there was also a wish that Ira should carry it forward in a new way—accounts, patterns, marketing, colour, all of it.

That wish was not wrong. But was Ira's road the same?

Rajni did not close the book. The last page remained open. Her left hand rested on it. The edge of the paper felt thin against her finger.

Ira came out to drink water. "You're still awake?"

"Yes." "Finished the book?" "Yes." Ira filled a glass. Rajni kept watching her. Her daughter looked tired; the hair at the front of her head had loosened. Rajni asked, "What exactly is the part in that training about preserving old cloth?"

Ira stopped with the glass in her hand. "Textile conservation. Old saris, paags, embroidery, dyes—the science of keeping cloth from being destroyed." "Where does one get work?" Ira did not answer at once. She suspected the same argument was about to begin again. "Museums, archives, design houses, sometimes independent work. Nothing is certain." Rajni said, "Tomorrow make the complete expense calculation again. Fees, lodging, travel, everything. Make one for teacher training too. We'll look at both together."

Ira's face changed, though she did not leap up in excitement. She only asked, "Then you won't refuse?" Rajni was silent for a few moments. "I am not saying yes yet either. I only want to see whether I am pushing you toward my road or trying to understand yours." Ira placed the glass on the table. "All right." That was all. No embrace, no grand decision. Ira returned to her room. Manoj looked up from his papers. "What happened?"

"Tomorrow we'll make two budgets." "All right." "Not one." Manoj looked at Rajni's face but could not understand why the sentence mattered. "Fine, two." Rajni looked again at the last page of the book. She was surprised that on the second reading the sentence did not shine as it had before. Now it was ordinary ink on ordinary paper. Whatever had changed was not on the page, but in her old memory.

She remembered her mother's verandah—the folded clothes, coins for bus fare, the tiny needle mark on Shail Devi's palm. "Go. Home will still remain home."

For all these years Rajni had understood that sentence only as her mother's generosity toward her. Now she could hear another voice within it too—the voice of a young woman who had never been able to leave home for training herself, but who, watching her daughter depart, had recognised the sound of her own abandoned road.

Rajni closed the book. She ran a hand over the cover and put it into the bag for Shabnam. The clock showed eleven twenty-seven. Tomorrow there would again be the wage register, bundles of cloth, machine belts, and unpaid bills. Ira's decision would not be made in one night either.

Before turning off the light, Rajni took out a blank sheet and wrote two headings: “Teacher Training” and “Textile Conservation.” Beneath each she left the same amount of space.

She still did not understand her mother’s sentence completely. Perhaps the meaning of old things is never complete; life keeps adding new pages inside them. But that night Rajni understood for the first time that her mother had not merely sent her forward. She had also sent along with her a part of the road she herself had never travelled.

STORY 298

The First Morning Bus

...

At the small bus stand east of Jhanjharpur, the morning mist had not yet fully lifted. Smoke rose from the stoves of tea-and-pakora stalls, but Krishnamohan Paswan's eyes were so heavy from a sleepless night that it was hard to tell smoke from fog. An old cloth bag was tucked under his arm. Inside were two pairs of clothes, a gamchha, two small tools for pump repair, and the receipt for the advance Sahuji had given him.

All night he and Mala had kept returning to the same argument. Krishnamohan had found three months' work at an irrigation-pump repair centre in Saharsa. The wages were nearly twice what he earned in the village. The previous evening he had decided that he would catch the first bus in the morning. Mala had said, "The question isn't whether you are going or not. The question is why a decision for three months was made in three minutes."

As the night deepened, Krishnamohan's replies had grown harder. "A household runs by accounts. Wherever the earnings are higher in the account, that is where one should go."

Mala had not fallen silent. "You write the earnings in your accounts. Where do you write the cost of your absence?"

At that sentence Krishnamohan had laughed. The laugh carried both weariness and the stubbornness of defending a decision already made. "The cost of absence! Is that a new item in the ledger now?"

Now, sitting at the bus stand at dawn, he could hear that sentence again. But he had not left home in order to turn back. As he joined the ticket queue, he placed the bag between his feet.

The first bus to Saharsa left at seven. It was half past six. Five or six children in school uniform came along in front of the stand. One had a heavy schoolbag on his back, another carried a tiffin box, another had drawing sheets tucked under an arm. The eldest girl, about thirteen, was tying the shoelace of a small boy. The boy kept pulling his foot away.

"Keep still, Amar," the girl said irritably. "We're getting late." The little boy pouted. "If Babuji were here, he would tie it quickly." The girl did not answer. She tightened the lace, stood up, and settled her own schoolbag on her back again. Krishnamohan found himself looking at them. His daughter Kavita was fifteen now, his son Neeraj ten. In the middle of the previous night's

quarrel, Mala had said once, “Kavita gets Neeraj ready in the morning, but her examination is near too.” Krishnamohan had heard the words; he had not understood them.

Another child carried a thin bamboo stick with four round paper discs tied to it. It looked like something he had made for school. When the breeze touched them, the discs began to spin. Delighted, the boy said, “Look, it’s moving!”

The girl beside him said, “It isn’t moving. The wind is turning it.”

For a moment a smile came to Krishnamohan’s face. Then he took out the receipt and read it again. Sahuji had written: three months; monthly wages eighteen thousand; lodging behind the centre; food at one’s own expense. Five thousand had already been paid in advance. Of that, two thousand had gone toward household debt, fifteen hundred toward Neeraj’s books and uniform, and Mala had kept the rest for grain. The decision was no longer merely a matter of desire. The advance was pushing him toward Saharsa.

The queue moved slowly. The ticket window opened. Krishnamohan said, “One to Saharsa.” The moment the ticket came into his hand, something inside him grew strangely still. This was the paper form of the decision over which so many words had been spent through the night. He folded the ticket and put it into the pocket of his kurta. The children were standing at the edge of the bus stand. Their school vehicle had not arrived yet. The thirteen-year-old girl said to her little brother, “After school, wait at the gate. I’ll be late because of science practice.”

“Then who will come for me?” “Ma.” “Ma has to go to the market.” The girl thought for a moment. “Then I’ll ask the teacher to keep you for five minutes.” She said it so ordinarily that it struck Krishnamohan all the more strongly. How many small pieces of time had to be joined together for a household to keep running—who would drop whom, who would fetch whom, who would untie the goat, who would watch the midday stove, who would bring the medicine, who would lift the sack of rations. He had never written these tasks down in one place. He had looked only at the figure for earnings.

Mala’s “cost of absence” now sounded to him like the language of accounts, not an emotional phrase.

He remembered his own house in the morning. On ordinary days he rose at five, filled water from the courtyard hand pump, cleaned and set out his pump-repair tools, checked the air in Neeraj’s bicycle tyres. None of these had ever seemed like “work” to him; they were simply part of being at home. After he went to Saharsa, these small tasks would be divided among other hands. Mala would fill the water, Kavita would look after her brother, Neeraj would have to

get someone else to check his bicycle. Alongside three months of double wages would run three months of this redistribution.

He remembered a moment from the previous night. While clearing the plates, Mala had said, "I am not trying to stop your earnings. But don't assume that the rest of the household's time will run by itself." At the time Krishnamohan had stopped listening. Now, in the noise of the bus stand, he heard the sentence more clearly.

Even so, he did not tear up the ticket.

He knew that if he did not go this time, another mechanic would take the job at the centre. Pump-repair work in the village was seasonal. In the previous two months, three customers had had repairs done on credit, and two payments were still outstanding. Money would be needed for Kavita's studies the following year. Part of the roof also needed repairs. The economic reasons for going to Saharsa were real.

The difficulty was that until the previous night he had believed that the real reason was the only reason.

An elderly man sat on a nearby bench with a small milk can in his hand. Seeing Krishnamohan's bag, he asked, "Going away for work?" "Yes." "Far?" "To Saharsa for three months." The old man only said, "Three months is not a short time." Then he pressed down the lid of the milk can and tightened it. Krishnamohan felt no need to answer.

A little before seven, the bus appeared in the distance. A thin layer of dust lay over its front windscreen. The driver sounded the horn twice. People at the stand picked up their bags. Krishnamohan stood as well. At that same moment the school vehicle came from the opposite direction. The children stirred. The thirteen-year-old girl first helped her brother climb in, then pushed her own schoolbag up. As she climbed, she turned once toward the road to see whether her mother was coming. No one was there. She got in without complaint. Krishnamohan placed one foot on the first step of his bus.

The argument from the night became clear inside him again. Mala had not really been trying to stop him. She had only wanted the work of those who would remain behind to be counted in the decision as well. For the first time Krishnamohan understood that "I am going to earn" was not a complete sentence. Behind it was another half: "and so someone else at home will have to carry my share."

Inside the bus he found a seat by the window. He put the bag under his feet and looked outside. The school vehicle had already gone. A faint cloud of dust rose behind it on the road. The fire in the stove at the bus stand had grown brighter. The tea seller was washing glasses.

Krishnamohan took the receipt from his pocket. He felt an urge to write something in his own hand on the blank back of it, but he had no pen. He folded the receipt again. The bus started.

Jhanjharpur market began slipping behind. At one turn, three children were walking along the roadside toward school. Two of them were taking turns carrying one schoolbag. Krishnamohan watched until the bus rounded the bend.

He was going to Saharsa—the decision had not changed. But now the decision no longer looked like a straight line. On one side were wages, on the other time; on one side the money sent home, on the other the work divided at home; on one side his absence, on the other the daily routines of Mala and the children.

He remembered his own sentence from the previous night: “Wherever the account shows more earnings, that is where one should go.”

Resting his head against the bus window, he saw in his mind the empty columns in that account. For the first time he understood that the numbers had not been too few; the ledger had been incomplete.

STORY 299

The Endless Register

...

In the southern quarter of Saurath, two houses beyond an old mango tree, Vachaspati Jha had a small workroom. From outside it looked like no remarkable place—earth-coloured walls, two wooden cupboards, a low cot, and a low table against the wall. Yet because of the panji books wrapped in red cloth and kept on the table, people stepped more softly when they entered the room.

Vachaspati had learned to read the panjis from his father. His father used to say, “Reading the names is easy. Reading the blank spaces between the names is difficult.” As a child Vachaspati had not understood this. Now, at fifty-two, when people came during the marriage season to check genealogical lines, trace old relationships, and have certified copies made, he understood that a panji carried not only the weight of written lines, but of missing lines as well.

That year, continuous rain through Sawan had made the roof of the old storeroom leak. The edges of five panji volumes had become wet, and some pages had stuck together. Members of the local conservation committee asked Vachaspati to prepare a clean copy of whatever could still be read. He would be paid by the page. For the household accounts, the work was not insignificant. His wife, Sharda, was already adding and subtracting the costs of medicine, oil, grain, and their little granddaughter’s school fees.

For three days Vachaspati did nothing but dry the pages. To press wet paper meant lifting the letters off with it. He placed thin cotton cloth between pages, raised corners with slender bamboo tweezers, and carried the books indoors whenever the sunlight grew harsh. On the fourth day one thick panji opened. The year written on its outer strip was almost erased, but the writing inside was clear.

The first pages followed the familiar pattern—lineage, branch, village, father, son, marriage link. Vachaspati recognised some names from memory. Beside some were small marks his father used to point out in older copies. He went on making the copy. In his mind he counted the payment: if he finished this many pages, it would cover two months of oil and salt for the household.

Near midday, his hand stopped on one page.

That page contained his own branch of the lineage.

Grandfather, father, Vachaspati—the three names appeared in the correct order. Beneath Vachaspati was the name of his son, Nachiketa. That was not

impossible; the entry could have been made sometime after Nachiketa's birth. But beneath Nachiketa was another name: "Ishan."

Nachiketa had no child. He had married three years earlier, and his wife Mrinal was now pregnant. No name had yet been settled upon in the household.

Vachaspati brought the page close to his nose. The smell of the ink did not reveal its age. The lettering resembled the same hand that had written the lines above. After Ishan came three more names—"Vedika," "Neel," "Archis." After that, the branch divided in two directions.

He closed the page again.

"Won't you eat?" Sharda asked from the doorway.

"Not now. A little later."

"You've been sitting since morning."

"One page is stuck."

Sharda laughed. "Is the page stuck, or are you?"

Vachaspati did not answer.

In the afternoon he opened the panji again. This time he left his own branch and looked three pages farther ahead. There was the line of a family from Belahi. Vachaspati knew the names up to the present generation because he had checked that household's marriage link the previous year. But beneath the current names were five more names. Beside one of them was written the name of a village with which that family had no connection at present.

For the first time Vachaspati felt not fear but anger. Someone had inserted later writing into an old book—that was his first conclusion. He took a magnifying glass and examined the ink. The stroke, pressure, the slant of the letters—all matched the older lines. The yellowing of the paper had settled over the writing in exactly the same way.

That evening Nachiketa returned from his shop. He sold bicycle parts, and after a day's fatigue went straight into the courtyard to wash his hands and face. Vachaspati could have called him. He could have uttered the name "Ishan" just once and asked, "Do you like this name?" But he remained silent.

At night Mrinal was talking with Sharda about measurements for the baby's clothes. She said, "We'll make the list of names later. First let us decide whether Dadi's suggestions will prevail or Babuji's."

Sharda burst out laughing. The glass in Vachaspati's hand became still.

The next day he copied only up to the present from the old panji. He left out the lines containing future names. But the thought that the copy for the

committee would remain incomplete unsettled him. The rule of the work was: copy whatever can be read; omit nothing for your own convenience.

At midday a visitor came. His name was Sudhanshu Thakur. He had come to have his daughter's marriage-line genealogy checked. Vachaspati matched the older entries. The work was ordinary. At the end Sudhanshu said softly, "They say a very old panji has come into your hands. How many generations of names does it contain?"

Vachaspati started. "As many as are written."

"And those ahead?"

"What do you mean, ahead?"

Sudhanshu smiled. "Does news take long to fly through a village?"

Vachaspati understood that some young man from the committee who had helped open the wet volumes must have seen something.

"A panji is an account of relationships that have already taken place," Vachaspati said.

"But what if the names ahead are truly written there?"

"Then they are names. Not events."

Sudhanshu remained silent for a few moments. Then he asked, "May I see the names ahead in my own family?"

For the first time Vachaspati answered plainly, "No."

After that one word, an unusual silence filled the room. Sudhanshu was dissatisfied, but he did not argue. He paid the fee and left.

All day Vachaspati thought about his answer. It seemed to him that perhaps he was not protecting the book, but protecting his own fear. If people saw names from the future, they would build stories around them. Marriages would be arranged, marriages would be broken, unborn children would be named in advance, families would treat a future line as a command governing present decisions. A few letters could become causes in people's lives.

That evening he tried an experiment. The first future name written in the Belahi branch was "Raghav." On a separate sheet he wrote only the name—Raghav. Then he remembered three families in the village where children had been given that name within the past five years. A name by itself was not the future. It became the future only when people attached it to the person they thought it belonged to.

But the name "Ishan" in his own branch would not leave him.

Three weeks later Mrinal gave birth to a son. Joyful bustle filled the household. Nachiketa returned from the hospital and came into his father's

room. His eyes were red from a night without sleep, but the happiness in his voice could not be hidden.

“Have you thought of a name?” Vachaspati asked.

“Mrinal says let the child come home first. Then we’ll all think together.”

“Anything in your own mind?”

Nachiketa laughed. “For now we are just calling him Chhotu.”

For the first time Vachaspati breathed easily. The name “Ishan” in the book was still only in the book.

That night he opened the panji. Ishan, Vedika, Neel, Archis—all the names were exactly as before. No letter had increased or disappeared. The page was ordinary. Its endlessness lay not in the number of pages but in people’s hunger to give them meaning—the thought came to him, but he did not write it down as a sentence.

The next morning, while completing the copy for the conservation committee, he copied the future lines too, but above them he added a note: “The date and period of the entries beyond this point are unverified; they are not valid as evidence for present decisions.”

A young man from the committee asked, “Then are all these wrong?”

Vachaspati said, “I did not say that.”

“Then they are right?”

“I cannot say that either, not yet.”

The young man kept looking at his face.

Vachaspati closed the panji. “Why this hurry to call something right or wrong when it has not even happened yet?”

When he returned home, Sharda raised the question of the baby’s name. Dadi’s list had Govind, Nachiketa’s had Arya, and Mrinal’s list had two other names. In the end everyone looked at Vachaspati.

“Your suggestion?” Nachiketa asked.

“Ishan” rose clearly in Vachaspati’s mind. He saw the panji page, the ink, the slant of the old handwriting. Then he looked at the newborn’s fist, which was complete even without any name.

“Let us watch him for a few days first,” he said. “We can name him later.”

In the courtyard everyone began repeating their suggestions again. Vachaspati quietly went into his room. He wrapped the panji in red cloth and placed it in the cupboard. He made no attempt to look for the book’s last page. For now it was enough to know this much: the next name might already be written, but the next life had not yet been written.

STORY 300

The Library of Mithila

...

For three days in Darbhanga's old book market, Ishan Mishra had been searching for the same title—North Mithila's Ponds and Village Memories. The title belonged to his own proposed book, but where had the book been written yet? For seven months he had travelled from district to district, taking down the accounts of ponds, ahars, old ghats, boatmen, fishers, potters, and cultivators. The publisher wanted the manuscript by Paush. Half of the advance had already gone into household expenses, and the remaining half was dissolving into travel fares, copies, and photocopies of old papers.

Then an elderly bookseller—no, seller of pothis—Binod Chaudhary, pointed him toward the end of a narrow lane and said, "What you are looking for may perhaps be found there."

There was no signboard at the end of the lane. Only a wooden door on which someone had written in ink: "The Library of Mithila." The letters were neither very old nor entirely new. Ishan pushed the door open.

Inside there was no smell of dust, but rather of dried paper, hemp cord, and a faint trace of mustard oil. Cupboards lined the walls, and behind the cupboards were more cupboards. In the middle, a thin old man was wiping the edges of books with a cloth.

"Membership?" Ishan asked. Without raising his head, the old man said, "There is no membership here. There are questions." Ishan laughed. "Then the question is this—I need some material on the ponds of North Mithila and the memories of its villages." For the first time the old man looked at him. "Material, not books?" "Both." "How much?" "As much as is useful." An expression came over the old man's face as though the question itself were not quite right. He rang no bell and opened no register. He merely pointed with his right hand toward a corridor at the back. "Come."

At the first turn was written "Ponds." At the second, "Memory." At the third, Ishan rubbed his eyes. On the cupboard in front of him was written the title he himself had proposed—North Mithila's Ponds and Village Memories. Beneath it were not one but hundreds of volumes. Some thick, some thin, some bound in red, some in black, some wrapped in hemp cloth.

"This is impossible," Ishan said. "The meaning of the word possible is different here from what it is outside," the old man replied.

Ishan opened the first book. Author: Ishan Mishra. Publication year: the following year. The first chapter began with the same village he had visited two months earlier. The first five lines matched his notes. The sixth line was entirely unfamiliar: the western ghat of the pond had been built in the 1950s by a widow who had sold her jewellery. Nothing like this was in Ishan's notes.

He opened a second volume. The same chapter, the same village, but the builder of the western ghat was a wealthy moneylender. In a third, the ghat had never been completed at all. In a fourth, the pond itself was declared imaginary. In a fifth, the same pond was described as the centre of a state archive. All the writing was smooth, plausible, and furnished with references.

Ishan's palms grew damp. "Which of these is true?" The old man shrugged. "Your question is small again." "Small?" "Ask instead—what is the basis by which you recognise truth?"

Ishan grew irritated. He needed sources, not riddles. Time was short. Two days earlier the publisher had sent a message: "Send the final draft soon." At home his wife Neelima had told him to look at the creditors' accounts before extending this journey again. He had no leisure for the library's philosophical games.

He picked up one volume and placed it in front of the old man. "Here there is a reference—Madhubani District Records, File Number Eighteen." "Then check it." "The records are here too?" "Every possible book written about Mithila is here. Possible copies of the records as well."

The old man pointed to another corridor. There, indeed, were dozens of versions of File Number Eighteen. In one, the ghat was mentioned; in another, it was not. In a third, the page was torn. In a fourth, the official's signature was different. In a fifth, the entire file concerned a subject that had nothing to do with the pond.

Ishan slowly closed the volume. Anger now rose in him more than fear. "Then nothing here is evidence." "I did not say that." "To keep every possible version and then say that something among them must be true—this is not evidence. It is noise." The old man smiled faintly. "There are many versions of that sentence here." Ishan's anger rose further. "I did not come here to hear jokes." "Nor did I."

They moved on. One room contained only titles: "Books That Could Have Been Written but Were Not." Another: "Books That Were Written but Did Not Survive." A third: "Things People Kept Saying but Never Wrote Down." Ishan stopped. On the last cupboard, in small letters, was written: "Authors Who Were More Certain Than Their Sources."

The old man said, "There are many of your books in this section."

Ishan did not reply. He pulled out a volume. Chapter Seven—"The Southern Quarter of Bisfi." In that chapter an elderly woman, Sharda Devi, said that her father had given thirty days of unpaid labour in the digging of a pond. Ishan remembered the statement. In the actual interview Sharda Devi had said, "I have heard that my father went too, but for how many days, I do not know." In his draft Ishan had written: "According to Sharda Devi, her father was forced into thirty consecutive days of unpaid labour." Where had the figure of thirty days come from? Perhaps from an interview in another village. Perhaps while combining his notes.

He turned the page. In the next version it was fifteen days. In the third, seven. In the fourth there was no mention of unpaid labour at all. In the fifth, Sharda Devi's name had become Saraswati.

Ishan's anger suddenly gave way to fatigue. The library was not giving him wrong answers; it was enlarging the weakness in his certainty until he could see it.

"Do you make all these?" he asked the old man. "I wipe the dust from the bindings." "Then who makes them?" "The one who asks the question, perhaps. The one who writes, perhaps. The one who reads, perhaps. There are separate books here for all three answers."

Ishan fell silent. Somewhere in the distance came the sound of paper sliding. There was no clock, but he remembered his own time: Paush. The publisher. The advance. The creditors. The unfinished chapter.

"Show me my finished book," he said. The old man asked, "Which finished book?" "The one I will actually send." "That is still your work. Not the library's." For the first time Ishan laughed, though there was weariness in the laugh. "Then what use is there in all these possible books being here?"

The old man lifted one volume, then put it back. "Perhaps to understand that possibility and evidence are not the same thing." Ishan wanted to keep that sentence in his mind, then immediately grew wary—what if this too was only a beautiful sentence from one of the endless books? He looked at the old man. The old man was again wiping a binding with his cloth. As Ishan left, he turned to look back. The corridor did not seem as long as before. Perhaps the light had changed. Perhaps he himself was in a hurry. Before closing the door, his eyes fell on a thin volume: *The Library of Mithila: A Story*. He pulled the door shut before reading the author's name. The next day he sat in the ordinary reading room of the district archive. A fan rattled on the wall. An employee brought him three real files—one incomplete, one faded, and one without the information he wanted. For the first time Ishan was not irritated by these deficiencies. He listened again to the original recording of Sharda Devi's

interview. Her sentence was clear: “For how many days, I do not know.” Ishan crossed out “thirty days” in his draft. Then he rewrote the entire sentence: “Sharda Devi recalled a family memory connecting her father with labour in the digging of the pond, but she could not state the duration with certainty.”

The sentence seemed less vivid than the earlier version. But on paper it felt more durable. By evening he had cut five pages. He marked off three beautiful episodes whose basis was only one person’s retelling of another person’s account. Returning home, he told Neelima, “The manuscript may not be finished by Paush.” Neelima looked up from the account notebook. “Then?” “Then it will be late. I may have to return part of the advance.” “And the book?”

Ishan thought for a moment. “It may be thinner.” Neelima bent back over the accounts. “A thinner book is lighter to carry.” Ishan smiled. He made no attempt to draw any philosophical meaning from the sentence. That night, at the end of his manuscript, he added a new page: “Where Sources Do Not Agree.” On that page he gave no verdict; he only recorded the differing statements, dates, memories, and the limits of the records. After that, for a long while, he did not think of the extraordinary library. Before him there were only three files, four audio notes, two old maps, and one unfinished question. For the first time, the insufficiency seemed enough.

“A story remains alive for as long as people and language remain alive.”

GAJENDRA THAKUR

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